Spanish, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one commute at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Spanish one word at a time — and it teaches each word by taking it apart. A huge fraction of Spanish vocabulary is not arbitrary: it is Latin, lightly worn by a thousand years of use, and English borrowed from the same Latin so often that the two languages are full of hidden cousins. So no word here is a fresh thing to memorize. *gracias* arrives next to *grace*, *gratitude*, *gratuity*, *ingrate*, and *congratulate* — a family you have owned your whole life. The bet is simple and, as far as we can tell, how the brain actually works: you learn the new by welding it to the known.

Three things follow from that, and shape every lesson:

- **One word per lesson, gone deep.** Not "the ten greetings" — *hola* is a lesson, *buenos días* is a lesson. A few minutes each, the size of a single errand or commute.
- **The widest honest web of cousins.** Every word reaches for all the English relatives it can *truthfully* claim — because the more live connections a word has, the more places it sticks. False cousins are flagged, not smuggled in.
- **The reason, not the rule.** Why is it *buenos días*, plural? Because it is the fossil of a blessing, *"may God give you good days."* We learn the culture and the idiom hiding inside the grammar — the things Spanish 101 skips.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Spanish out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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366.1 la caja 1595
366.2 la lámpara 1597
366.3 la almohada 1598
366.4 la escalera 1600
366.5 el armario 1601

367 Breakfast, Fruit And Something Sweet 1605
367.1 el desayuno 1605
367.2 la fruta 1607
367.3 la naranja 1608

367.4 la patata 1610
367.5 el azúcar 1611

368 Five Animals, Two Of Them Small 1615
368.1 la abeja 1615
368.2 la mosca 1617
368.3 el cerdo 1618
368.4 el lobo 1620
368.5 el toro 1621

369 The River, The Sand And The Ash 1625
369.1 el río 1625
369.2 la arena 1627
369.3 el polvo 1628
369.4 el humo 1630
369.5 la ceniza 1631

370 Storm, Thunder And Ice 1635
370.1 la tormenta 1635
370.2 el trueno 1637
370.3 el hielo 1638
370.4 la cueva 1640
370.5 la costa 1641

371 Small, Fat, Young, Slow, Sweet 1645
371.1 pequeño 1645
371.2 gordo 1647
371.3 joven 1648
371.4 lento 1649
371.5 dulce 1651

372 Grey, Pink And Dark 1653
372.1 gris 1653
372.2 rosa 1655
372.3 oscuro 1656
372.4 pálido 1658
372.5 suave 1659

373 Five Things You Can Pick Up 1661
373.1 el oro . . . 1661
373.2 la botella . . . 1663
373.3 la alfombra . . . 1664
373.4 la falda . . . 1665
373.5 el peine . . . 1667

374 Five Things You Hold 1669
374.1 el lápiz . . . 1669
374.2 el cepillo . . . 1670
374.3 el guante . . . 1672
374.4 la vela . . . 1673
374.5 el nudo . . . 1675

375 Five Things a Person Has 1677
375.1 la uña . . . 1677
375.2 el labio . . . 1678
375.3 el pulgar . . . 1680
375.4 el beso . . . 1681
375.5 el sobrino . . . 1682

376 Five Things on a Plate 1685
376.1 la harina . . . 1685
376.2 la uva . . . 1687
376.3 el maíz . . . 1688
376.4 el chocolate . . . 1689
376.5 el pimiento . . . 1691

377 Five Things You Can Learn 1693
377.1 la letra . . . 1693
377.2 la frase . . . 1695
377.3 el idioma . . . 1696
377.4 la historia . . . 1697
377.5 el baile . . . 1699

378 Five Places You Can Ask About 1701
378.1 la selva . . . 1701
378.2 el prado . . . 1702
378.3 el volcán . . . 1704
378.4 la cumbre . . . 1705

378.5 el edificio 1707

379 Five Words for How Something Feels 1709
379.1 seco 1709
379.2 mojado 1711
379.3 fresco 1712
379.4 tibio 1713
379.5 grueso 1715

380 Five Words for What Something Is Like 1717
380.1 simpático 1717
380.2 alegre 1719
380.3 feo 1720
380.4 último 1721
380.5 necesario 1723

381 Four Everyday Actions English Kept 1725
381.1 lavar 1725
381.2 romper 1727
381.3 saltar 1728
381.4 soñar 1729

382 Four Verbs Two Languages Built Twice 1731
382.1 empezar 1731
382.2 acabar 1733
382.3 pagar 1734
382.4 quedar 1735

383 Two Words From Outside, and Two Nobody Can Place 1739
383.1 guardar 1739
383.2 dejar 1741
383.3 sacar 1742
383.4 buscar 1744

384 Four Roads, and Where the Trail Stops 1747
384.1 enviar 1747
384.2 subir 1749
384.3 morir 1750
384.4 olvidar 1751

385 Four Things the Hands Do **1755**
385.1 usar . . . 1755
385.2 tocar . . . 1757
385.3 mezclar . . . 1758
385.4 colgar . . . 1760

386 Selling, Serving, Spending, Growing **1763**
386.1 vender . . . 1763
386.2 servir . . . 1765
386.3 gastar . . . 1766
386.4 crecer . . . 1768

387 Fire, Crossings, and Things That Turn **1771**
387.1 quemar . . . 1771
387.2 cruzar . . . 1773
387.3 volar . . . 1774
387.4 girar . . . 1776

388 Push, Throw, Rub Out, Shout **1779**
388.1 empujar . . . 1779
388.2 lanzar . . . 1781
388.3 borrar . . . 1782
388.4 gritar . . . 1784
388.5 (review) . . . 1785

389 Knowing How — the Verb That Once Meant Taste **1789**
389.1 saber . . . 1789
389.2 (review) . . . 1791

390 Five Parts of a Building **1793**
390.1 la terraza . . . 1793
390.2 la sala . . . 1795
390.3 la planta . . . 1797
390.4 el ascensor . . . 1799
390.5 la piscina . . . 1800

391 Five Words for Eating Out **1803**
391.1 el menú . . . 1803
391.2 el camarero . . . 1805
391.3 el postre . . . 1807
391.4 el supermercado . . . 1808

391.5 el euro 1810

392 Five Words for a Journey 1813
392.1 el aeropuerto 1813
392.2 las vacaciones 1815
392.3 el destino 1816
392.4 el pasajero 1818
392.5 agosto 1820

393 Five Things a Form Asks For 1823
393.1 el ordenador 1823
393.2 internet 1825
393.3 el correo electrónico 1827
393.4 la dirección 1828
393.5 la nacionalidad 1830

394 Five Places and Things in a Week 1833
394.1 la universidad 1833
394.2 el trabajo 1835
394.3 la actividad 1837
394.4 la guitarra 1839
394.5 el médico 1840

395 Five Everyday Actions 1843
395.1 entrar 1843
395.2 volver 1845
395.3 llegar 1846
395.4 perder 1848
395.5 necesitar 1850

396 Five More Everyday Actions 1853
396.1 aprender 1853
396.2 cocinar 1855
396.3 preferir 1856
396.4 funcionar 1858
396.5 reparar 1860

397 Five Words for Weighing One Thing Against Another 1863
397.1 barato 1863
397.2 caro 1865
397.3 gratis 1867

397.4 mayor 1868
397.5 menor 1870

398 Five Words for What a Thing Is Worth 1873
398.1 importante 1873
398.2 interesante 1875
398.3 favorito 1876
398.4 fácil 1878
398.5 difícil 1879

399 Two Words for How Something Looks 1883
399.1 bonito 1883
399.2 guapo 1885

400 Five Words for Making a Journey 1887
400.1 el tren 1887
400.2 el vuelo 1888
400.3 el aparcamiento 1890
400.4 el abono 1891
400.5 la playa 1892

401 Four Words for Following Directions 1895
401.1 seguir 1895
401.2 cambiar 1896
401.3 la avenida 1898
401.4 recto 1899
401.5 (review) 1900
401.6 (review) 1901

402 Five Words in a Clothes Shop 1903
402.1 costar 1903
402.2 la camisa 1904
402.3 la camiseta 1905
402.4 la talla 1905
402.5 el gorro 1906
402.6 (review) 1907
402.7 (review) 1908

403 Chicken, Vegetables and Paella **1909**
403.1 el pollo . . . 1909
403.2 la verdura . . . 1910
403.3 la paella . . . 1911
403.4 (review) . . . 1911
403.5 (review) . . . 1912

404 Wi-Fi, Mobile Phones and Films **1913**
404.1 apagar . . . 1913
404.2 el wifi . . . 1914
404.3 el móvil . . . 1915
404.4 la película . . . 1915
404.5 (review) . . . 1916
404.6 (review) . . . 1917

405 Photography, Photos and Permission **1919**
405.1 la fotografía . . . 1919
405.2 la foto . . . 1920
405.3 permitir . . . 1921
405.4 (review) . . . 1922
405.5 (review) . . . 1922

406 Clients, Documents and Data **1923**
406.1 el cliente, la cliente . . . 1923
406.2 el documento . . . 1924
406.3 el dato . . . 1925
406.4 el impreso . . . 1926
406.5 rellenar . . . 1927
406.6 (review) . . . 1928
406.7 (review) . . . 1928

407 Middle, Below, Outside and Beside **1931**
407.1 en medio . . . 1931
407.2 debajo . . . 1932
407.3 fuera . . . 1932
407.4 el lado . . . 1933
407.5 (review) . . . 1934
407.6 (review) . . . 1934

408 Doctor, Pills and Tiredness 1937
408.1 el doctor / la doctora 1937
408.2 la pastilla 1938
408.3 (review) 1939
408.4 (review) 1939

409 Finish, Prepare and Plan the Weekend 1941
409.1 terminar 1941
409.2 preparar 1942
409.3 el fin de semana 1943
409.4 reservar 1943
409.5 incluir 1944
409.6 (review) 1945
409.7 (review) 1946

410 Academy, French, Student and Exam 1947
410.1 la academia 1947
410.2 francés / francesa 1948
410.3 el examen 1949
410.4 (review) 1950
410.5 (review) 1950

411 Ice Cream 1953
411.1 el helado 1953
411.2 (review) 1954
411.3 (review) 1954

412 Gym and Sport 1957
412.1 el gimnasio 1957
412.2 el deporte 1958
412.3 (review) 1959
412.4 (review) 1959

413 Music and Concert 1961
413.1 la música 1961
413.2 el concierto 1962
413.3 (review) 1963
413.4 (review) 1963

414 Sign Up at Reception **1965**
414.1 apuntarse . . . 1965
414.2 la recepción . . . 1966
414.3 (review) . . . 1967
414.4 (review) . . . 1967

415 A Package Abroad **1969**
415.1 el paquete . . . 1969
415.2 el extranjero . . . 1970
415.3 (review) . . . 1971
415.4 (review) . . . 1971

416 Stay in May **1973**
416.1 quedarse . . . 1973
416.2 mayo . . . 1974
416.3 (review) . . . 1975
416.4 (review) . . . 1975

417 An Adult Swimming Course **1977**
417.1 el curso . . . 1977
417.2 nadar . . . 1978
417.3 adulto, adulta . . . 1979
417.4 (review) . . . 1979
417.5 (review) . . . 1980

418 Writing — Four Lines That Hold Together **1981**
418.1 ayer . . . 1981

419 Dancing, and the Article You Drop **1983**
419.1 bailar . . . 1983

420 Theatre, Exhibition, Circus **1987**
420.1 el teatro . . . 1987
420.2 la exposición . . . 1989
420.3 el circo . . . 1990
420.4 cinco lugares . . . 1992
420.5 ¿Vamos al teatro o al circo? . . . 1993

421 The Actor and the Actress 1995
421.1 el actor . . . 1995
421.2 la actriz . . . 1997
421.3 la escena completa . . . 1999
421.4 ¿Quién está en la película? . . . 2000

422 The Web Page 2003
422.1 la página web . . . 2003
422.2 cuatro palabras de internet . . . 2005
422.3 ¿Cuál es la página web? . . . 2006

423 Character, Not Mood 2009
423.1 antipático . . . 2009
423.2 inteligente . . . 2011
423.3 trabajador . . . 2013
423.4 serio . . . 2014
423.5 tímido . . . 2016
423.6 sociable . . . 2018
423.7 ocho palabras de carácter . . . 2019
423.8 ¿Cómo es? . . . 2021

424 The Marks Themselves 2023
424.1 el punto . . . 2023
424.2 la coma . . . 2025
424.3 los dos puntos . . . 2026
424.4 la raya . . . 2027
424.5 las comillas . . . 2028
424.6 los paréntesis . . . 2030
424.7 el guion . . . 2031
424.8 la barra . . . 2032
424.9 ocho signos . . . 2033
424.10 una nota con todos los signos . . . 2035

425 The Letters Themselves 2037
425.1 el abecedario . . . 2037
425.2 be larga o be corta . . . 2039
425.3 las cinco vocales . . . 2040
425.4 los dígrafos . . . 2042
425.5 la sílaba . . . 2043
425.6 veintisiete letras . . . 2044

425.7 ¿Cómo se escribe? 2046

426 Capitals, Short Forms And Symbols 2049
426.1 las mayúsculas 2049
426.2 la minúscula inicial 2051
426.3 las abreviaturas 2052
426.4 las letras voladitas 2053
426.5 las siglas 2054
426.6 los símbolos 2056
426.7 tres formas cortas 2057
426.8 un formulario completo 2058

427 People Named By What They Do 2061
427.1 el vendedor 2061
427.2 el comprador 2062
427.3 el policía 2063
427.4 el bombero 2065
427.5 el abogado 2066
427.6 la empresa 2067
427.7 cinco personas y un lugar 2069
427.8 ¿A qué se dedica? 2070

428 Five Last Pieces 2073
428.1 la arroba 2073
428.2 el guion bajo 2074
428.3 ¡Felicidades! 2076
428.4 ¡Salud! 2077
428.5 el animal 2078
428.6 cinco piezas sueltas 2080
428.7 una invitación 2081

429 The Instituto, And What A Mark Is Called 2083
429.1 el instituto 2083
429.2 la nota 2085
429.3 la calificación 2086
429.4 aprobar 2088
429.5 suspender 2089
429.6 el curso entero 2091
429.7 Practice 2092

430 The Wardrobe, And The Word For Having No Work 2095
430.1 estar en paro 2095
430.2 los vaqueros 2097
430.3 el jersey 2098
430.4 el bolso 2100
430.5 cuatro que cierran dos listas 2101
430.6 Practice 2103

431 El Pedido Y La Devolución 2105
431.1 el pedido 2105
431.2 devolver 2106
431.3 el retraso 2107
431.4 el proveedor 2108
431.5 cobrar 2109
431.6 (pedido, devolver, retraso, proveedor … 2110
431.7 Practice 2112

432 La Casa Por Dentro 2113
432.1 la lavadora 2113
432.2 el contador 2114
432.3 la estantería 2115
432.4 la tubería 2116
432.5 el sofá 2117
432.6 (lavadora, contador, estantería … 2118
432.7 Practice 2120

433 El Edificio Y Sus Normas 2123
433.1 el portal 2123
433.2 la portera 2124
433.3 el garaje 2125
433.4 la norma 2126
433.5 junto 2127
433.6 (portal, portera, garaje, norma, junto) 2128
433.7 Practice 2129

434 El Taller Y La Máquina 2131
434.1 el taller 2131
434.2 la máquina 2132
434.3 la pieza 2133
434.4 la batería 2134

434.5 el cargador 2135
434.6 (taller, máquina, pieza, batería … 2136
434.7 Practice 2137

435 Los Papeles Del Trabajo 2139
435.1 el currículum 2139
435.2 la documentación 2140
435.3 la experiencia 2141
435.4 previo 2143
435.5 jubilado 2144
435.6 (currículum, documentación … 2145
435.7 Practice 2146

436 Gente Y Trato 2149
436.1 el compañero 2149
436.2 el grupo 2150
436.3 ofrecer 2151
436.4 prestar 2152
436.5 recoger 2153
436.6 (compañero, grupo, ofrecer, prestar … 2155
436.7 Practice 2156

437 Decidir, Coincidir, Equivocarse 2159
437.1 decidir 2159
437.2 coincidir 2160
437.3 equivocarse 2161
437.4 tardar 2162
437.5 cenar 2163
437.6 (decidir, coincidir, equivocarse … 2164
437.7 Practice 2166

438 El Cuerpo Y El Descanso 2167
438.1 el polideportivo 2167
438.2 la natación 2168
438.3 torcerse 2170
438.4 descansar 2171
438.5 reír 2172
438.6 (polideportivo, natación, torcerse … 2174
438.7 Practice 2175

439 Andenes Y Cierres **2177**
439.1 el andén . . . 2177
439.2 trasladar . . . 2178
439.3 cerrado . . . 2180
439.4 cortar . . . 2181
439.5 tirar . . . 2182
439.6 (andén, trasladar, cerrado, cortar … . . . 2184
439.7 Practice . . . 2185

440 La Fiesta Y El Año **2187**
440.1 la boda . . . 2187
440.2 el cumpleaños . . . 2189
440.3 celebrar . . . 2190
440.4 disfrutar . . . 2191
440.5 el humor . . . 2193
440.6 (boda, cumpleaños, celebrar … . . . 2194
440.7 Practice . . . 2195

441 El Contrato **2197**
441.1 el contrato . . . 2197
441.2 firmar . . . 2198
441.3 fijo . . . 2199
441.4 la factura . . . 2201
441.5 el préstamo . . . 2202
441.6 (contrato, firmar, fijo, factura … . . . 2204
441.7 Practice . . . 2205

442 La Gestion **2207**
442.1 la administración . . . 2207
442.2 el envío . . . 2209
442.3 concertar . . . 2210
442.4 la reunión . . . 2211
442.5 la pantalla . . . 2213
442.6 (administración, envío, concertar … . . . 2214
442.7 Practice . . . 2215

443 El Animo **2217**
443.1 doler . . . 2217
443.2 interesar . . . 2219
443.3 acercarse . . . 2220

443.4 concentrarse 2221
443.5 arrepentirse 2223
443.6 (doler, interesar, acercarse … 2224
443.7 Practice 2226

444 La Casa Por Fuera **2229**
444.1 la calefacción 2229
444.2 la madera 2230
444.3 plantar 2232
444.4 cubrir 2233
444.5 el carrito 2235
444.6 (calefacción, madera, plantar, cubrir … 2236
444.7 Practice 2237

445 El Puesto **2241**
445.1 jubilarse 2241
445.2 la responsabilidad 2242
445.3 exigente 2244
445.4 enseñar 2245
445.5 repetir 2247
445.6 (jubilarse, responsabilidad, exigente … 2248
445.7 Practice 2249

446 Mirar Y Moverse **2251**
446.1 mirar 2251
446.2 mover 2253
446.3 acompañar 2254
446.4 directo 2255
446.5 el partido 2257
446.6 (mirar, mover, acompañar, directo … 2258
446.7 Practice 2260

447 Juzgar **2263**
447.1 el análisis 2263
447.2 comentar 2265
447.3 la urgencia 2266
447.4 torpe 2267
447.5 (análisis, comentar, urgencia, torpe) 2269
447.6 Practice 2270

448 La mudanza **2273**
448.1 mudarse . . . 2273
448.2 la mudanza . . . 2275
448.3 duro . . . 2276
448.4 estropear / estropeado . . . 2277
448.5 roto . . . 2279
448.6 (mudarse, la mudanza, duro … . . . 2280
448.7 Practice . . . 2281

449 El taller **2285**
449.1 arreglar . . . 2285
449.2 el freno . . . 2287
449.3 la rueda . . . 2288
449.4 el taladro . . . 2289
449.5 acercar . . . 2291
449.6 (arreglar, el freno, la rueda, el … . . . 2292
449.7 Practice . . . 2293

450 El césped y el patio **2295**
450.1 el patio . . . 2295
450.2 la hierba . . . 2297
450.3 la piedra . . . 2298
450.4 el césped . . . 2299
450.5 el entrenamiento . . . 2301
450.6 (el patio, la hierba, la piedra, el … . . . 2302
450.7 Practice . . . 2304

451 La cola y el carné **2307**
451.1 la cola . . . 2307
451.2 apuntar . . . 2309
451.3 el carné . . . 2310
451.4 mostrar . . . 2312
451.5 el ticket . . . 2313
451.6 revisar . . . 2315
451.7 (la cola, apuntar, el carné, mostrar … . . . 2316
451.8 Practice . . . 2317

452 El reparto **2319**
452.1 el almacén . . . 2319
452.2 la ruta . . . 2321

452.3 el seguimiento 2322
452.4 cómodo 2323
452.5 (el almacén, la ruta, el seguimiento … 2325
452.6 Practice 2326

453 El turno **2329**
453.1 la limpieza 2329
453.2 la instalación 2331
453.3 rotativo 2332
453.4 consultar 2333
453.5 (la limpieza, la instalación … 2335
453.6 Practice 2336

454 La vía cortada **2339**
454.1 la obra 2339
454.2 la vía 2341
454.3 el accidente 2342
454.4 el servicio 2343
454.5 (la obra, la vía, el accidente, el … 2345
454.6 Practice 2346

455 La habitación **2349**
455.1 pintar 2349
455.2 el dormitorio 2351
455.3 claro 2352
455.4 tender 2354
455.5 meter 2355
455.6 (pintar, el dormitorio, claro, tender … 2356
455.7 Practice 2358

456 La cuenta **2361**
456.1 la ensalada 2361
456.2 el cargo 2363
456.3 aceptar 2364
456.4 el coste 2365
456.5 la agencia 2367
456.6 (la ensalada, el cargo, aceptar, el … 2368
456.7 Practice 2369

457 La farmacia de guardia **2371**
457.1 el medicamento . . . 2371
457.2 encargar . . . 2373
457.3 la guardia . . . 2374
457.4 (el medicamento, encargar, la guardia) . . . 2375
457.5 Practice . . . 2377

458 El plazo **2379**
458.1 el plazo . . . 2379
458.2 entregar . . . 2381
458.3 admitir . . . 2382
458.4 (el plazo, entregar, admitir) . . . 2383
458.5 Practice . . . 2385

459 El inventario **2387**
459.1 la sección . . . 2387
459.2 el inventario . . . 2389
459.3 habitual . . . 2390
459.4 (la sección, el inventario, habitual) . . . 2392
459.5 Practice . . . 2393

460 La herramienta **2395**
460.1 la herramienta . . . 2395
460.2 solicitar . . . 2397
460.3 la espera . . . 2398
460.4 (la herramienta, solicitar, la espera) . . . 2400
460.5 Practice . . . 2401

461 El donativo **2403**
461.1 donar . . . 2403
461.2 peligroso . . . 2405
461.3 rechazar . . . 2406
461.4 (donar, peligroso, rechazar) . . . 2408
461.5 Practice . . . 2409

462 La reunión **2411**
462.1 reducir . . . 2411
462.2 decidirse . . . 2413
462.3 el jefe . . . 2414
462.4 (reducir, decidirse, el jefe) . . . 2416

462.5 Practice 2417

463 El viaje guiado **2419**
463.1 organizar 2419
463.2 el guía / la guía 2421
463.3 importar 2422
463.4 (organizar, el guía, importar) 2424
463.5 Practice 2425

464 La cita perdida **2427**
464.1 recordar 2427
464.2 el dentista / la dentista 2429
464.3 fallar 2430
464.4 (recordar, el dentista, fallar) 2431
464.5 Practice 2433

465 El cuaderno de campo **2435**
465.1 el cuaderno 2435
465.2 anotar 2437
465.3 la temperatura 2438
465.4 la lluvia 2440
465.5 (el cuaderno, anotar, la temperatura … 2442
465.6 Practice 2443

466 Una carta del colegio **2447**
466.1 el director / la directora 2447
466.2 visible 2448
466.3 el comportamiento 2450
466.4 discutir 2452
466.5 (el director, visible, el … 2453
466.6 Practice 2454

467 El huerto comunitario **2457**
467.1 producir 2457
467.2 suficiente 2459
467.3 alimentar 2460
467.4 el objetivo 2462
467.5 (producir, suficiente, alimentar, el … 2463
467.6 Practice 2465

468 Dos grados **2467**
468.1 la chaqueta . . . 2467
468.2 el grado . . . 2469
468.3 el abrigo . . . 2470
468.4 la bufanda . . . 2471
468.5 (la chaqueta, el grado, el abrigo, la … . . . 2473
468.6 Practice . . . 2474

469 La impresora de la sala 2 **2477**
469.1 imprimir . . . 2477
469.2 la impresora . . . 2479
469.3 conectar . . . 2480
469.4 la llamada . . . 2482
469.5 (imprimir, la impresora, conectar, la … . . . 2483
469.6 Practice . . . 2485

470 Un paraguas azul **2487**
470.1 el paraguas . . . 2487
470.2 el mango . . . 2489
470.3 encontrar . . . 2490
470.4 avisar . . . 2492
470.5 (el paraguas, el mango, encontrar … . . . 2493
470.6 Practice . . . 2495

471 El curso de cocina **2497**
471.1 demasiado . . . 2497
471.2 el nivel . . . 2499
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Chapter 1

Hola and Buenos Días

Modes: **voice** (7) **pen** (4) **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 11 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in Spanish, say how I am, and wish them a good day.

A short doorway greeting: hola, an answer to how you are, and buenos días on the way in.

1.1 hola — hello

The very first word, and the easiest to say — but there's already one trap hiding in it, and one small mystery.

Sounds you'll need

- `silent-h` — the **h is silent**. *hola* is said *OH-la*, never *HOH-la*. The letter is written but makes no sound at all. This is true of every Spanish *h* you'll ever meet. → pronunciation reference
- `vowel-o`, `vowel-a` — two pure vowels: *OH*, *AH*. No glide, no drift.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hola — hello / hi.
This one is a genuine mystery, and honesty matters more than a tidy story: *hola*'s origin is **not settled**. It's an old interjection — a hailing call — and that's about as far as the evidence firmly goes. You'll see it confidently linked to English *hello*, or to Arabic *wallāh* ("by God"), or

to a nautical shout. Treat all of those as **folk etymology**: plausible-sounding, not established.
In particular, the resemblance to English *hello* is a **false friend**. English *hello* comes from a Germanic hailing root (*hail*, *holler*, *hollo*) — a completely different family from anything Spanish. The two words sound alike by pure coincidence, not shared ancestry.

> Why flag this so hard? Because the whole method of this book is building on real family resemblances between Spanish and English. A *fake* one is worse than none — it teaches a connection your brain then has to unlearn. So: enjoy *hola*, but don't file it next to *hello* in your head. They're strangers who happen to look alike.

Why it's said this way

hola is **informal**. It's the "hi" you'd say to a friend, a kid, a shopkeeper you know. It carries no time of day and no deference — which is exactly why, in more formal or first-meeting situations, Spanish speakers reach past it for *buenos días* and its siblings (the next lessons). Knowing *when not* to use *hola* is as much the lesson as the word itself.
Note the written form: an exclamation gets an **upside-down mark** at the front — *¡hola!* — so you know the tone before you start reading it aloud.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hola" — *OH-la*, silent h
- "¡hola!" to an imagined friend — light, informal

Before you move on

Two things to lock in: what sound does the *h* make? (None.) And is *hola* actually related to English *hello*? (No — a coincidence, a false friend.)

1.2 *hola* — let your eye and your hand meet the word

Say the greeting you already know: *hola*, *OH-la*. Today adds no new Spanish at all. You will only look at how that one familiar word sits on a page, and let your hand follow it.

What you've built — one written word

h o l a → hola

Count them: **four** written letters.
Now count what your mouth does: *OH-la* — **three** sounds.
The extra letter is the one at the front. You met it in the very first lesson: the **h** is written and says nothing. Here is the same fact seen from the other side — when you *listen*, the **h** is missing; when you *write*, it must be there.
Point to each letter from left to right, once: **h**, **o**, **l**, **a**.

Writing — trace with the model visible

Keep **hola** visible in front of you the whole time.

Slowly finger-trace the four letters once, left to right. Then trace the word once more in the air.

Say *OH-la* only after your finger has passed the silent **h** and reached the final **a**.

This is noticing, not a handwriting test. Use the letter shapes you already write. There is no new alphabet here — Spanish uses the letters you have written all your life.

Before you move on

Touch the silent letter. Stop here — copying comes in the next tiny lesson.

1.3 *hola* — one supported copy

Point to the first letter in **hola**. It is written **h** and it is said as silence.

Keep the model on the page for the whole of this lesson. You are not being asked to remember anything today.

Writing — guided copy

Copy **hola** once. You may look back at the model after every single letter — that is what "guided" means here.

When you finish, touch your own **h-o-l-a** and say *OH-la*.

Your eye checks four letters. Your voice makes three sounds. The hand writes one letter the mouth never says.

Before you move on

Compare only the order of the four letters and whether the **h** is there. Repair one letter if you need to, then stop. The model stays visible today.

1.4 *hola* — look, hide, write, compare

Look at **hola** for five seconds. Touch the silent **h** at the front. Do not copy it yet.

Writing — delayed copy

1. cover **hola**
2. wait five seconds
3. write the word once from memory
4. uncover the model and compare **h-o-l-a**

The place to check first is the front of the word. When the model disappears, the letter your voice never says is the one most likely to go with it.

If one letter differs, circle that place and repair only that letter. A repair is part of the exercise, not a failure.

Before you move on

Read your repaired word aloud as *OH-la*. Stop after one memory attempt.

1.5 One heard greeting — write what you know

Cover the answer line lower on this page. You will hear one familiar greeting. No new Spanish is hiding in this lesson.

Writing — short dictation

Hear: OH-la

Write the Spanish greeting from that sound alone.

Three sounds reached your ear. Four letters belong on your page. Your pen has to supply a letter that the sound never gave you — and it goes first.

Now uncover and compare: **hola**. Check the four letters and the **h** at the front. Repair one place if you need to.

Before you move on

Writing from sound is the last step of this four-step runway. It is not a DELE task yet; later lessons grow this from one known word to names, numbers, forms, and short practical messages.

1.6 bien — "well," a whole answer in one word

You have *hola*. Now the word that carries half of everyday small talk: *bien*. It answers "how are you," it agrees to a plan, it stands completely on its own — and it opens a family of English words you already use.

What to know first

- hola — your first word; *bien* is what you say back when someone asks how you are.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ie` — **ie** is a quick *YEH*: *bien* is said *byen*, one syllable. → reference
- `v-b` — the **b** is soft, halfway to a *v*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bien — "well." Root: Latin **bene** ("well"). That *bene* is the piece hiding in a shelf of English words, every one about something being *good* or *well*:

- **bene**fit — literally "to do **well**" (*bene* + *facere*).
- **bene**volent — "wishing **well**" (*bene* + *volens*).
- **bene**diction — "speaking **well**," a blessing (*bene* + *dicere*).
- **bene**factor, **bene**ficial, be**nign**.

So *bien* is the Spanish member of the *bene-* family you've owned in English your whole life.
Using it on its own. This is the useful part: *bien* is a complete answer.

- "*¿Cómo estás?*" (how are you?) → "**Bien.**" — "Well." / "I'm good." Done.
- As agreement, when someone suggests something → "**Bien.**" — "Okay / fine."

The adjective sibling: *bueno / buena*

bien is an **adverb** — it describes *how* something is done ("you speak *well*"). When you want the **adjective** — to describe a *thing* as "good" — Spanish uses **bueno** (for a masculine word) or **buena** (for a feminine word). These come from Latin **bonus** ("good"), *bene*'s sibling: Latin split the idea of "good" into an adverb (*bene*) and an adjective (*bonus*), and Spanish kept both. The Latin-descended English cousins of *bueno* are *bonus*, *bonanza*, and *bounty*.

> **English does the exact same split**: *well* (adverb) vs. *good* (adjective) — "you did *well*" but "a *good* job." English's pair happens to be Germanic, not Latin, so *well/good* aren't blood cousins of *bien/bueno* — but the *structure* is identical, and that parallel is your handle: **bien = well, bueno/buena = good.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "bien" as the answer to "how are you"
- "bueno" then "buena" — the adjective, masculine then feminine

Before you move on

Which is the adverb ("well") and which is the adjective ("good")? (*bien / bueno–buena.*) And name an English *bene-* cousin of *bien.* (benefit, benevolent, benediction…)

1.7 el and la — "the," and the gender it carries

Before your first noun, meet two of the smallest, most frequent words in Spanish: *el* and *la.* Both mean "the." Your job here is simply to recognize the pair and connect each form to its label.

What to know first

- bien / bueno — you saw *bueno* change to *buena*; this lesson explains the gender that made it happen.

Sounds you'll need

- `vowel-e`, `vowel-a` — two clean vowels: *el* (*ehl*), *la* (*lah*). → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el — "the" (masculine). **la** — "the" (feminine). English has one word, "the"; Spanish makes this two-way distinction.
Where they come from. Both are worn-down Latin **demonstratives** — words that meant "**that one (over there)**":

- **el** ← Latin **ille** ("that one," masculine).
- **la** ← Latin **illa** ("that one," feminine).

Over centuries the pointing force faded and the initial *i-* dropped: *ille* → *el*, *illa* → *la.* What began as "that one" softened into a plain "the."

The same *ille/illa* spread across the whole family — French *le/la*, Italian *il/la* — every Romance "the" is eroded Latin "that."
The twin thread. Those *same* Latin words, *ille/illa*, also became Spanish **él** ("he") and **ella** ("she"). So the article *el* ("the") and the pronoun *él* ("he") are twins from one Latin parent — told apart only by the accent. (English "the," by contrast, is Germanic and *unrelated* — a shared job, not a shared root.)

What you've built

el and *la* are **articles**: little words that mark "the." Keep them apart from their accented relatives *él* and *ella*, the pronouns "he" and "she." The next micro-lesson explains why Spanish needs two article forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el" then "la" — the two "the"s
- which article goes with a masculine noun? with a feminine one?

Before you move on

Which form is labelled masculine? (*el.*) Which is labelled feminine? (*la.*) Both come from Latin words meaning what? ("That one" — *ille* / *illa.*)

1.8 Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind *el* and *la*

You know that *el* and *la* both mean "the." Now give their two labels: *el* is masculine; *la* is feminine.

What to know first

- el / la — the two definite articles.

Grammar Lens: grammatical gender

Every Spanish noun belongs to one of two **grammatical classes**, traditionally called masculine and feminine. This is not a claim about biological sex. It is a matching system: a masculine noun uses *el*; a feminine noun uses *la*.
Latin had masculine, feminine, and neuter classes. Spanish reduced that three-way system to two, with most old neuter nouns joining the masculine class. The word *gender* itself comes through Latin *genus*, "kind" or "class."
You cannot always predict a noun's class from its ending. Learn each new noun with its article, as one small unit: *el + noun* or *la + noun*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the article for a noun labelled masculine
- the article for a noun labelled feminine
- what grammatical gender classifies — nouns, not people

Before you move on

How many noun classes did Latin have? (Three.) How many does Spanish keep? (Two.) What should travel with every new noun you learn? (Its article, *el* or *la*.)

1.9 día — your first noun

You just learned how Spanish tags gender with *el* / *la*. Now put it to work on your very first noun — *día*, "day."

What to know first

- el / la — grammatical gender and the two "the"s; *día* is where you apply them.

Sounds you'll need

- `accent-i` — the accent sits on the **í**: *día* is *DEE-a*, two beats. → reference
- `d-soft` — the **d** between vowels is soft, toward the *th* in *this*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el día — "the day." Root: Latin **dies** ("day"). The family fans across English, mostly through French:

- **di**ary, **di**urnal ("of the day").
- **jour**nal, **jour**ney — French *jour*, "a day" (a *journey* was once "a day's travel").
- quoti**di**an ("every-day"), meri**di**an ("mid-day"), and *dismal* (*dies mali*, "evil days").

Its two tags: gender and number

You already know gender from the last lesson; here's how *día* wears it.
Gender. *día* is **masculine** — *el día* — which is a small surprise, because it ends in *-a*, the ending that usually signals feminine. Why the exception? Because Latin *dies* was masculine, and *día* inherited that gender whole, spelling be damned. (This is exactly why gender must be learned *with* the word, not guessed from the ending — and it's the first of several "*-a*-but-masculine" nouns you'll meet.)
Number. One rule for now: a noun ending in a vowel adds **-s**. *día* → *días* ("days"). (Consonant endings take *-es* — later.)

Grammar Lens: why the gender matters next

Gender isn't a passive label — it *forces* the words around the noun to match. The very next lesson, *buenos días*, turns *bueno* ("good") into *buen**os*** precisely because *día* is masculine and plural. So the gender you just attached to *día* is about to earn its keep.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el día" — with its masculine "the"
- "días" — plural, vowel + *-s*
- is *día* masculine or feminine, and why? (masculine — from Latin *dies*, despite the *-a*)

Before you move on

Which "the" goes with *día*, and why? (*el* — masculine, inherited from Latin *dies*, despite the *-a* ending.) How do you make it plural? (*días* — vowel + *-s*.)

1.10 buenos días — the greeting you say before noon

You can already greet someone at any hour with *hola*. Now the one you use in the morning — the greeting everyone knows.

What to know first

- día — the word *day*, which you have already met.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ue` — **ue** is a quick *WEH*: *bueno* is *BWEH-no*.
- `accent-i` — *días* keeps its stress on the *í*: *DEE-as*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenos días is, word for word, **"good days"** — plural, and nobody knows quite why the plural stuck. Spanish says it in the plural and always has.
Take it whole. It is one thing you say, not two things you assemble: *buenos días*, said as a single run, the way English says *good morning* without stopping to think about *good* or *morning*.

> The shape of it — why *buenos* and not *bueno* — is a real rule, and a useful one. It is also not the rule you need in order to say hello before lunch. It comes later, once you have enough words for it to be worth explaining.

Why it's said this way

So why "good **days**," plural at all? Because *buenos días* is a **fossil** — the worn-down stub of a blessing: **"Buenos días os dé Dios,"** *"may God give you good days."* You weren't wishing one good morning; you were asking heaven for many good days ahead. The plural is the last bone of that prayer — and it's why *buenos días* feels warm and a little formal, where *hola* is casual. It is, almost literally, a small *bene*diction (the *bien* lesson's word). *(A widely-accepted account; exact history debated.)*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- build it slowly — "bueno" … "días" … "buenos días"
- "hola, buenos días" — casual + warm, stacked
- why is it *buenos*, not *bueno*? (out loud, in your own words)

Before you move on

Two things: why is it *buenos* and not *bueno*? (Agreement — *días* is masculine plural.) And what blessing was *buenos días* shortened from? ("May God give you good days.")

1.11 Practice — hola and buenos días

End of the chapter. No new words — just the four you have, turned over until they're automatic.

What you've built

In four short lessons you went from nothing to two full greetings and the first two rules of Spanish grammar:

- **hola** — the casual "hi."
- **bien** — "well/good," a complete answer on its own; and its adjective sibling **bueno / buena**.

- **día → días** — a noun, and the plural rule (vowel + *-s*).
- **buenos días** — assembled from *bueno* + *días*, with **agreement** turning *bueno* into *buenos* to match.

Your turn

Say each out loud; don't just read.

Say these aloud:

- greet a friend casually — *hola*
- greet someone warmly in the morning — *buenos días*
- stack them — *hola, buenos días*
- answer "how are you" with one word — *bien*
- the four shapes of "good" — *bueno, buena, buenos, buenas* — and for each, is it masculine/feminine, singular/plural?

Twice through: Build *buenos días* from scratch, out loud: *bueno* → agree with masculine-plural *días* → *buenos días*. Do it until the "why" feels obvious, not memorized.

Before you move on

You can now greet two ways and give a one-word positive answer. The very next question is the one that opens a real conversation: when *someone else* says *buenos días* to you — **what do you say back?** That's the whole next chapter, and it's where these words start turning into an exchange.

Chapter 2

The Rest of the Greetings

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can greet someone correctly at any hour — morning, afternoon or night — and say why the greeting changes shape.
>
> *The same greeting exchange run three times across the day, choosing the right form for each hour.*

2.1 tarde — "afternoon," and the "late" hiding inside it

> You built *buenos días*. The afternoon greeting is coming, but first its key word on its own — *tarde* — and it's secretly a word you already know from English.

What to know first

- buenos días — you'll pair *tarde* with *buena* the same way you paired *días* with *bueno*.

Sounds you'll need

- Regular stress: *TAR-de* — ends in a vowel, so the stress falls on the second-to-last syllable. → reference

la tarde (feminine) — "afternoon." Root: Latin **tardus** — which did *not* mean afternoon. It meant **"slow, late."** And *that* is the meaning English kept:

- **tard**y — late.
- re**tard** — to slow down (literally "to make late").
- **tard**igrade — "slow-stepper," the real name of the little water-bear that plods under a microscope.

How did "late" become "afternoon"? Naturally — the afternoon *is* the late part of the day, the day growing old. Spanish took the Latin word for "late" and let it drift to name the lateness itself. Say *tarde* and you're calling it "the late hours."
Its gender: *tarde* is **feminine** — *la tarde*, not *el tarde*. (Contrast *el día* from the last lesson: your first masculine and feminine nouns, side by side.) Learn each noun *with* its *el*/*la*, because gender isn't reliably guessable — and it will decide the shape of every word that describes the noun, starting next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "tarde" — *TAR-de*
- "tarde" then English "tardy" — hear the shared root
- "tardes" — plural, add *-s* (vowel ending), just like *día* → *días*

Before you move on

What did Latin *tardus* originally mean, before "afternoon"? (Slow, late — as in *tardy*, *retard*.) And how do you make *tarde* plural? (*tardes* — vowel + *-s*.)

2.2 buenas tardes — assembled, and now the *feminine* side of agreement

Same move as *buenos días*: take "good" and "afternoon" and snap them together. But watch the ending — this time it comes out *buen**as***, and that difference teaches you the other half of the agreement rule.

What to know first

- bien / bueno — the adjective *bueno* and its four shapes.
- tarde — the noun *tardes*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas tardes = **buena** ("good") + **tardes** ("afternoons") = literally "good afternoons."

Why it's said this way

Buenos días in the morning; **buenas tardes** in the afternoon. The ending changes, and there is a reason for it — the same reason that comes later, with the rest of the pattern. For now: two greetings, two shapes, both said whole.

Why it's said this way

Same fossil blessing as the morning greeting: *buenas tardes* is short for *"Buenas tardes os dé Dios."* One cultural note on timing — *tardes* runs from after the midday meal until it's genuinely dark, which in much of the Spanish-speaking world is late. Spanish follows the daylight, not the clock; there's no fixed "12:00 = afternoon" line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "buenas tardes" — *BWEH-nas TAR-des*
- "buenos días" then "buenas tardes" — hear the *o* flip to *a*
- why *buenas* and not *buenos*? (out loud, your own words)

Before you move on

Why is it *buenas tardes* but *buenos días*? (*tarde* is feminine, *día* is masculine — the adjective agrees with each.)

2.3 noche — "night," and a Latin sound-change you can now spot

The last time-of-day word before the evening greeting. *noche* — "night" — and it shows off a spelling pattern that will help you decode dozens of Spanish words later.

What to know first

- tarde — same build ahead: word first, then *buenas* + it.

Sounds you'll need

- `soft-c` — the **ch** in *noche* is the *ch* of English *church*: *NO-cheh*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la noche (feminine) — "night / evening." Root: Latin **nox**, stem **noct-** — which was itself *feminine* in Latin, and *la noche* inherited that gender straight down (just as *el día* inherited its masculine from Latin). That *noct-* runs all through English:

- **noct**urnal — active at night.
- **noct**urne — a piece of night-music.
- equi**nox** — *equi* ("equal") + *nox*, the day when night and day are equal length.

A pattern worth banking: Latin *noctem* → Spanish *noche*. The Latin **-ct-** softened into Spanish **-ch-**. This happened again and again: *factum* → *hecho* ("done"), *lactem* → *leche* ("milk"), *octo* → *ocho* ("eight"). Once you know *-ct-* → *-ch-*, you can often guess the Latin root (and its English cousins) behind a Spanish *-ch-* word on sight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "noche" — *NO-cheh*
- "noche" then "nocturnal" then "equinox"

- "noches" — plural, vowel + *-s*

Before you move on

What English word is *equi-* + *noche*'s root? (*Equinox*, "equal night.") And what Latin sound did the *-ch-* in *noche* come from? (*-ct-*, as in *noctem* → *noche*.)

2.4 buenas noches — good evening *and* good night

The fourth greeting, assembled the way you now expect — and it has one quirk the others don't: it works both coming and going.

What to know first

- buenas tardes — feminine agreement (*buenas*); *noche* is feminine too, so the same shape applies.
- noche — the noun *noches*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas noches = **buena** ("good") + **noches** ("nights"). *noche* is **feminine** (*la noche*), plural here, so — exactly like *tardes* — the adjective is **buenas**. No new rule; you're now just *fluent* in the agreement you learned two lessons ago: masculine *días* → *buenos*, feminine *tardes*/*noches* → *buenas*.

Why it's said this way

The same amputated blessing (*"Buenas noches os dé Dios"*) — but with a twist. *buenas noches* is both a **greeting** and a **farewell**:

- Arriving at a dinner at 9pm → *buenas noches* ("good evening").
- Leaving that same dinner at midnight → *buenas noches* ("goodnight").

English splits these into two phrases; Spanish uses one and lets context tell you the direction. The blessing doesn't care which way you're going — you're wishing good hours either way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "buenas noches" arriving somewhere
- "buenas noches" leaving somewhere
- all four times of day — "buenos días, buenas tardes, buenas noches" — and notice which take *buenos* vs *buenas* and why

Before you move on

What's unusual about when you can use *buenas noches*? (Both hello and goodbye.) And why *buenas*, not *buenos*? (*noche* is feminine.)

2.5 buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along

Say all three greetings, in order through the day: *buenos días*, *buenas tardes*, *buenas noches*.

You have been saying them for two chapters without being told why the first one differs. Now it is worth knowing.

What to know first

Two things you already have:

- Every Spanish noun is **masculine or feminine**. *Día* is masculine; *tarde* and *noche* are feminine.
- Adding **-s** makes a noun plural: *días*, *tardes*, *noches*.

Grammar Lens: the describing word copies the noun

In Spanish a describing word **copies** the noun it sits next to — it matches both the masculine-or-feminine and the one-or-many. *Bueno* is the describing word in all three greetings. It copies:

- *días* is masculine and plural, so *bueno* becomes **buenos**.
- *tardes* is feminine and plural, so *bueno* becomes **buenas**.

- *noches* is feminine and plural, so again **buenas**.

That is the whole rule. One word changing its last letter to agree with the word beside it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-o** and the **-a** are old. Latin marked masculine with *-us* and feminine with *-a*: *bonus* and *bona*, "good." Spanish wore *bonus* down to *bueno* and kept *bona* as *buena*, and the two endings have been doing this same job for two thousand years.
English lost this entirely. *Good* is *good*, whatever it sits beside.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "buenos días" — and say why it is *buenos*: *días* is masculine.
- "buenas tardes" — and why *buenas*: *tardes* is feminine.
- all three in order, morning to night.

Before you move on

Why *buenos días* but *buenas tardes*? (*Día* is masculine, *tarde* is feminine, and the describing word copies the noun.) Which Latin endings are hiding in *-o* and *-a*? (*-us* and *-a*.) Does English do this? (No — *good* never changes.)

2.6 Practice — the four greetings

You can now greet at any hour of the day. Let's make the choice — and the grammar behind it — automatic.

What you've built

- **hola** — any time, casual.
- **buenos días** — morning (*días* masculine → *buenos*).
- **buenas tardes** — afternoon (*tarde* feminine → *buenas*).

- **buenas noches** — evening *and* goodnight (*noche* feminine → *buenas*).

The one grammar thread running through all of them: **agreement**. The "good" word copies the gender of the time-of-day word. That's why it's *buen**os** días* but *buen**as** tardes* and *buen**as** noches*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- greet for the actual current time of day, correctly
- all three "buenos/buenas" greetings in a row; for each, say whether the noun is masculine or feminine and why the ending fits
- "hola, buenas tardes" — casual + timed, stacked

Twice through: Run morning → afternoon → night, out loud, without hesitating on *buenos* vs *buenas*.

Before you move on

Quick: is it *buenos* or *buenas* noches, and why? (*buenas* — *noche* is feminine.) Next chapter, someone finally greets *you* back — and you learn to say your name and ask for theirs.

Chapter 3

Un and Una — the Other Article

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say a day, an afternoon and a night, choosing the article by the noun's gender.
>
> *un is the number one, and English a is the same word worn down.*

3.1 un — "a," and the number hiding in it

How do you say "the day"? (*El día.*) Which word is doing the work of *the*? (*El.*)

Grammar Lens: the other article

El día is **the** day — a particular one, the one we both know about. For **a** day, any day, not one we have settled on, Spanish swaps the article:

un día — *a day.*

That is the second article, and Spanish has only these two kinds. *El* points at something known; **un** does not.
Like *el*, it carries the noun's gender — so *un* is the masculine one, and its partner is coming in the next lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is the part worth keeping.
Un is the number one. Latin *ūnus*, "one", and Spanish never really separated the two — *un día* is *a day* and *one day* at once, and context decides which you meant.
English did exactly the same thing and hid it better. Our *a* and *an* are the word **one**, worn down over centuries of being unstressed. That is why *an hour* and *one hour* start with the same sound, and why *a* feels like almost nothing when you say it: it has been eroded from a whole number down to a single vowel.
So the two languages made the same move. Spanish just left the seam visible.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el día" then "un día" — the known one, then any one
- "un día", and hear the number *one* still sitting in it

Before you move on

How do you say "a day"? (**Un día**.) What is the difference between *el* and *un*? (*El* points at something known; *un* does not.) And what number is *un*? (**One** — and English *a* is the same word.) Next: the feminine partner.

3.2 una — the feminine one

Say "a day." (*Un día.*) And what is the word for "the afternoon"? (*La tarde.*)

Grammar Lens: the partner

Tarde and *noche* are feminine, so they take the feminine article:

una tarde — *an afternoon.* **una noche** — *a night.*

You now have both, and they behave exactly as *el* and *la* do — the article takes the gender of the noun standing next to it. Nothing new

is being asked of you; the rule you learned for *el* and *la* simply applies again.

	masculine	**feminine**
the	*el* día	*la* tarde
a	**un** día	**una** tarde

This table is allowed here because every box in it is something you can already say.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

One detail, because it runs against what you might expect.
Una is not *un* with something added. It is the other way round: Latin had *ūnus* and *ūna*, and **una kept the whole word while un lost a syllable.**
That is the ordinary direction of travel. The forms said most often wear down fastest, and *un* — standing in front of masculine nouns, which are the default for anything unspecified — got said more.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "un día, una tarde, una noche"
- each noun twice — once with *the*, once with *a*

Before you move on

Say "a night." (**Una noche**.) Which article goes with *día*, and why? (**Un** — *día* is masculine.) And which of the pair is the worn-down one? (**Un** — *una* kept the whole Latin word.)

3.3 Review — the four little words

Nothing new here. Say "the day," then "a day."

What you've built

Four words, and they cover every noun you will ever meet in this book:

- **el** · **la** — *the*, pointing at something we both know.
- **un** · **una** — *a*, pointing at no one in particular.

Two jobs, two genders, and the gender is never the article's own — it is borrowed from the noun beside it, exactly as *bueno* borrowed it from *día*.
That is one rule doing all four jobs, and you have now seen it three times: on the greeting, on the definite article, and here.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "el día, un día" · "la tarde, una tarde" · "la noche, una noche"

Twice through: Until the article arrives with the noun rather than after it.

Before you move on

Name all four articles. (*El*, *la*, *un*, *una*.) Which two point at something known? (*El* and *la*.) And where does an article's gender come from? (**The noun beside it** — never from itself.)

Chapter 4

Saying Your Name

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say my own name in Spanish.
>
> *Saying Your Name — the chapter run end to end.*

4.1 me — your first pronoun, and a *real* English twin

A tiny word doing big work. *me* is your first **pronoun** — and unlike *hola*, its English look-alike is the real thing: a true cousin, not a coincidence.

Sounds you'll need

- `vowel-e` — one clean syllable, *meh* (the *e* of *bed*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me — "me / myself." Root: Latin **me** (the object form of *ego*, "I"). Here's the satisfying part: English **me** is a **genuine cousin**, not a false friend. Spanish *me* comes from Latin *me*; English *me* comes from Proto-Germanic — but both trace back to the *same* ancient ancestor (the Proto-Indo-European root *me-*, "me"). So do English **my** and **mine**. This is the opposite of the *hola*/*hello* trap you saw earlier: here the resemblance is real, and you can lean on it hard. Spanish *me* = English *me*, all the way down.

Grammar Lens: what a pronoun is

A **pronoun** is a stand-in word that points to a person or thing without naming them — *I, you, he, me, it. me* specifically is an **object** pronoun: it marks the person the action lands on ("call *me*", "give *me*"). In Spanish it usually sits **right before the verb** — you'll see it next lesson in *me llamo*, literally "myself I-call." For now, just hold *me* = "me / myself."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "me" — *meh*
- "me" then English "me", "my", "mine" — all one family

Before you move on

Is Spanish *me* a true cousin of English *me*, or a coincidence like *hola*/*hello*? (A true cousin — both from the same ancient root.) What part of speech is it? (A pronoun.)

4.2 llamo — "I call," from a root that shouts

The verb inside "my name is." On its own it means "to call" — and its Latin root literally means *to shout*, which is why it echoes through a whole family of English words.

What to know first

- me — you'll bolt *me* onto *llamo* next lesson.

Sounds you'll need

- `ll-y` — **ll** sounds like English **y**: *llamo* is *YA-mo*, not *LA-mo*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llamo — "I call." The dictionary form (the infinitive) is **llamar**, "to call." Root: Latin **clamare**, "to cry out, to shout." That *clam-* shouts all through English:

- ex**claim**, ex**clam**ation — *ex-* ("out") + *clamare*: to shout **out**.
- pro**claim**, pro**clam**ation — *pro-* ("forth"): to call **forth**.
- ac**claim** — *ad-* ("toward"): to shout praise toward.
- **claim**, re**claim**, dis**claim**; and **clam**or, borrowed whole.

A sound-pattern to bank: Latin *cl-* became Spanish *ll-*. *clamare* → *llamar*. It happened repeatedly: *clavem* → *llave* ("key"), *flamma* → *llama* ("flame"), *plovere* → *llover* ("to rain"). A Spanish word starting *ll-* is very often a Latin *cl-*/*fl-*/*pl-* word in disguise — and its English cousin usually kept the original cluster (*clamor*, *flame*, *pluvial*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "llamo" — *YA-mo*
- "llamo" then "exclaim", "proclaim", "clamor" — the shouting root
- "llamar" (to call), "llave" (key) — both from Latin *cl-*

Before you move on

What does the root *clamare* mean? (To shout / cry out.) Latin *cl-* becomes which two letters in Spanish? (*ll-* — *clamare* → *llamar*.)

4.3 me llamo — "I call myself"

Snap the last two lessons together — *me* + *llamo* — and you can introduce yourself. But notice Spanish doesn't say "my name is" at all.

What to know first

- me · llamo

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me llamo = **me** ("myself") + **llamo** ("I call") = literally **"I call myself."** Then the name: *Me llamo Susana* — "I call myself Susan."

Grammar Lens: reflexive verbs

When the action loops back onto the person doing it — you call *yourself* — the verb is **reflexive**, and Spanish marks it with that little pronoun in front: *me* ("myself"). *llamo* alone is "I call [someone else]"; *me llamo* is "I call **myself**." English can do this ("I call myself Sam") but usually doesn't bother, flattening it to "my name is." Spanish keeps the reflexive loop visible.
This matters because the pronoun **changes with the person**: *me* llamo (I call myself) → *te* llamas (you-informal call yourself) → *se* llama (he/she/you-formal calls himself). You'll meet *te* and *se* in a few lessons; for now, lock in *me llamo* for yourself.

Why it's said this way

Spanish presents your name not as a thing you *have* ("my name is") but as what you *do* — what you call yourself. It's subtly more active, and it's the completely standard, neutral way to introduce yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "me llamo" + your own name
- "hola, me llamo _____" — greeting + introduction
- what does *me llamo* literally mean, word for word?

Before you move on

Literally, what is *me llamo*? ("I call myself.") What makes it reflexive? (The *me* — the action loops back on you.)

4.4 Saying your name — putting it together

Three lessons became one sentence. Say it to a stranger. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Hola. **Me llamo** Susana. — Me llamo David.

What you've built

You can now put your own name into Spanish, which is the first thing anyone will ask you for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 5

The Three Words for You

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can choose between tú and usted, and recognise vos.
>
> *The Three Words for You — the chapter run end to end.*

5.1 tú and usted — two of the three words Spanish says to one person

English has one word for "you." Spanish has three for speaking to one person, and today you get two of them — the two you will use yourself. What the choice *means* socially, and the odd grammar *usted* drags along with it, comes next. The third word comes shortly after, and you will only ever need to recognise it.

The two words

tú — "you," **informal**. For friends, family, children, peers, anyone you are on easy terms with.

> Root: Latin **tū**. This is a **true cousin** of English **thou** — the word English used to have for exactly this job, the intimate "you" (*thou/thee/thy*), before it faded out around 400 years ago. Both *tú* and *thou* come straight from the same ancient root (*tu-*). So Spanish still uses, every day, the pronoun English quietly retired.

usted — "you," **formal**. For strangers, elders, officials, customers, anyone you are showing respect or keeping distance with.

Both are the "doer" word — the one that says who is acting, like *yo* ("I"). Say them enough times that they come out without hunting: *tú*, one syllable with the accent; *usted*, stress on the second, with a very soft final *d*.

> **Not the whole story, and you should know that now.** Across Argentina, Uruguay, Paraguay, most of Central America and parts of Colombia, the everyday informal "you" is a *third* word — not *tú* at all. That is well over a hundred million people. You are learning *tú* because it is understood everywhere, and you will meet the third word shortly, only to recognise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "tú" — for a close friend
- "usted" — for someone you'd address respectfully
- "tú" then English "thou" — the retired twin

Before you move on

Which is formal, *tú* or *usted*? (*Usted.*) What English pronoun is the lost twin of *tú*, and what happened to it? (*Thou* — it faded out of English around 400 years ago.) How many words does Spanish have for "you," and how many will you say yourself? (*Three, for one person; two.*) Next: what picking one of them tells your listener.

5.2 tú *or* usted — a choice you have to make every time

You have both words. Now the hard part: Spanish makes you **choose** one every time you speak to someone, and the choice is never neutral.

What to know first

- tú / usted — the two words themselves.

Why it's said this way

Tú and *usted* do not differ in **meaning** — both are "you," singular, one person. They differ in **register**: the social distance you are claiming.

you say	you are signalling
tú	closeness, equality, ease
usted	respect, deference, distance

English used to carry this too, with *thou* against *you* — and when *thou* died, English lost the ability to say it at all. One-size-fits-all "you" means an English speaker never has to decide. A Spanish speaker decides every single time, and getting it wrong is not a grammar mistake but a **social** one: *tú* to a stranger can read as presumptuous, *usted* to a friend as cold.

The safe default when you cannot tell: **usted**. Over-formal is recoverable; over-familiar is awkward.

Grammar Lens: usted takes he/she forms

One structural surprise, because it shapes every lesson after this: ***usted* takes the *he/she* verb forms, not the informal "you" forms.** That is why "what's your name?" formally is *¿cómo* ***se llama*** *usted?* — using the *se llama* you would otherwise use for "he calls himself" — and not *te llamas*. Grammatically, *usted* behaves as though you were talking **about** the person rather than **to** them. That is a fossil of where the word came from, and the next lesson digs it up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "tú" and name someone you would use it with
- "usted" and name someone you would use it with
- which verb pattern *usted* takes — the he/she one

Before you move on

Do *tú* and *usted* differ in meaning or in register? (**Register** — both mean "you"; they signal closeness versus respect.) Which do you pick when unsure? (**Usted**.) Which verb forms does *usted* take?

(The same forms used with **he** or **she**.)

5.3 vos — the third "you," and you only have to recognise it

Two words so far. Which one do you use with a friend? (*Tú*.) Which one keeps a respectful distance? (*Usted*.)

What to know first

vos — "you," informal. It does the same job as *tú*.

Where it lives, in part: Argentina, Uruguay and Paraguay, and most of Central America. It is also alive in Chile, and in parts of Colombia and Bolivia — this list is not the whole map. Counting only the places named, that is **well over a hundred million people** for whom *vos*, not *tú*, is the ordinary word to a friend.

You are learning *tú* because it is understood everywhere, those places included. But a course that never mentioned *vos* would be teaching you a Spanish nobody speaks in Buenos Aires.

What you owe this word. Recognition, nothing more. Hear **vos**, think *tú*. Its endings differ a little, and you will meet that where you meet the endings themselves — not before.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Vos is Latin **vōs** — and Latin **vōs** was the **plural** "you." The word Romans used for a group.

How does a plural become the word for one friend? By politeness. Addressing someone as though they were several made them bigger. The courtesy wore off, and across much of the Americas the word slid into *tú*'s place.

English began the same way and ended in the opposite place. You met *thou* earlier in this chapter. What retired it was **you** — a *plural*, used to one person out of politeness, exactly as Spanish used *vos*. But English's polite plural won and spread until it was the only word left; standard English now has no separate singular at all. Spanish's *vos* went the other way — it *lost* the polite job and dropped into the intimate one.

Same start, opposite ends. And what took the polite job away from *vos* is the very next lesson.

Your turn

Recognition only — nothing to produce here.

- [YOU HEAR: "vos"] → think: *tú*. A friend, an equal, someone at ease with you.
- [YOU HEAR: "usted"] → think: distance, or respect.
- [YOU SAY: "tú"] — still your word, everywhere you go.

Before you move on

How many words does Spanish have for "you" when speaking to **one** person? (*Three.*) Which do you say? (*Tú* — and *usted* for distance.) Name a country where *vos* is the everyday word. (*Argentina, Uruguay, Nicaragua…*) What was Latin *vōs* originally? (*The plural "you."*)

5.4 *vuestra merced* → *usted* — respect compressed into one word

You use *usted* for respectful "you," and it takes the same verb form as "he" or "she." That surprising grammar preserves the word's history.

What to know first

- tú / usted — the informal and formal choices.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

usted wore down from **vuestra merced**, "your grace" or "your mercy." *Vuestra* comes from Latin *vestra*, "your." *Merced* comes from Latin *merces, mercedem*, "wages, reward, favor."
The *merc-* root links **mercy**, **mercenary**, **commerce**, **merchant**, and **merchandise**. A respectful title was repeated so often that two

words compressed into one pronoun. Its older abbreviation **Vd.** still preserves the *v* of *vuestra*.

Why it's said this way

A title like "your grace" refers to a respected person in the third person. That is why modern *usted* still takes the he/she verb form even while it means "you." The social history remains visible in the grammar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two-word title that became *usted*
- "usted" followed by "mercy" and "merchant" — the *merc-* family
- which verb pattern *usted* takes

Before you move on

What did *vuestra merced* mean? ("Your grace" or "your mercy.") Why does *usted* take the he/she verb form? (It began as a third-person title.) And the third "you" you met last lesson — which is it, and do you say it or just know it? (*Vos*; you recognise it, and keep saying *tú*.)

5.5 quién — "who?" in one gentle step

You can choose **tú** or **usted** for the person in front of you. Now add one tiny question about a person: **¿Quién?** — "Who?"

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Say **quién** like *kyen*, one smooth beat. It asks for a **person**:

— **¿Quién?** — Who? — **Ana.**

Hear the word as one piece for now. The next micro-lesson slows down and explains the written accent that Spanish question words carry.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **¿Quién?** — then answer with one name
- **tú**, **usted** — you; **¿Quién?** — who

Before you move on

Which two words mean "you"? (**Tú, usted**.) Which word asks "who"? (**Quién**.) Say it once more, slowly. Stop there.

5.6 Choosing your "you" — putting it together

Three words for "you," plus **quién** for "who." Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

To a friend: **tú**. To a stranger, an elder, an official: **usted**. Heard across the Southern Cone and Central America: **vos** — understand it, keep saying *tú*.

What you've built

You know which word to reach for, and why *usted* takes the shape it does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- point to one person, ask **¿Quién?**, and answer with a name
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 6

Asking Someone's Name

Modes: **voice** (6) **eyes** (1) **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask someone's name in either register and say it was a pleasure.
>
> *Asking Someone's Name — the chapter run end to end.*

6.1 cómo — "how," your first question word

To ask someone's name or how they are, you need this word first. *Cómo* — "how" — and hiding inside it is a little Latin word for "manner" that you already own a dozen English versions of.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cómo — "how." Root: Latin **quo modo** — not a word but a **two-word phrase**, "in what **manner**."
The two halves, and their English cousins:

- *modo* ("manner, measure") → English **mode**, **modal**, **model**, **moderate**, **modify**, com**mod**ity.
- *quo* ("in what") is the Latin question-stem **qu-**, the seed of nearly every Spanish question word.

How the phrase became one word — the wearing-down.
Spanish did not borrow *cómo* ready-made; it **eroded** out of *quo modo*

over centuries of everyday speech. The final *-do* fell off and the middle collapsed:

quomodo → *quomo* → **como**

The *qu-* (a *kw* sound) flattened to a plain *k*, written *c* before *o*. What is left is a whole Latin phrase worn smooth — the way a pebble loses its edges in a river. The same erosion gave Italian *come*, Portuguese *como*, French *comme*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "cómo" — *CÓ-mo*, stress on the first syllable
- "cómo" then English "mode", "model" — the *modo* root
- the erosion — "quo modo, quomo, como"

Before you move on

What does *cómo* mean? ("How.") Walk the erosion: *quo modo* → ? → *cómo*. (*Quomo* → *como*.) What did the two Latin halves mean? (*Quo*, "in what"; *modo*, "manner" — the root of English *mode* and *model*.) Next: the two marks Spanish puts on a question.

6.2 ¿cómo? — the two marks that say "this is a question"

You have the word *cómo*. Written down, it wears **two** marks that English has no equivalent for — and neither of them is decoration. Both do a job English leaves to word order and guesswork.

What to know first

- cómo — the word itself, and where it came from.

Script — the upside-down opener

Spanish questions open with an upside-down **¿** and close with a normal **?**: *¿cómo?*

Why? Spanish word order often does not change in a question — *cómo estás* looks the same whether you are asking or reporting. A reader coming to a long sentence would not know to raise their pitch until they hit the mark at the very end, by which time it is too late. The **¿** is a piece of engineering: it tells your voice, in advance, what shape the sentence has. Only the **question part** gets bracketed, not necessarily the whole line.

Grammar Lens: the accent that marks a question

Now watch the accent mark do real work:

written	**means**
cómo	"how?" — the question word
como	"like / as" — or "I eat"

Same letters, same sound. The written accent is the **only** thing marking the difference:

- *¿**Cómo** estás?* — "**How** are you?"
- ***Como** tú.* — "Like you." / *Yo **como**.* — "I eat."

Every question word you will meet — *qué, dónde, cuándo, quién* — carries this accent for exactly this reason. It is not about stress (the stress is the same either way); it is a flag that says **"asking."**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿cómo?" — with question intonation, opening high
- the pair — "cómo" (how?) then "como" (like / I eat)

Before you move on

Why does Spanish open a question with **¿**? (Word order often does not change, so the reader needs the warning **before** the sentence, not after.) What changes when the accent disappears from *cómo*? (It stops being the question word — *como* means "like / as," or "I

eat.") Which word asks for a person? (*Quién.*)

6.3 The *qu-* question family — one ancient pattern, many clues

You traced *cómo* back to Latin *quomodo*. Focus now on its first piece, *qu-*, without trying to use a whole set of new question words yet.

What to know first

- cómo — "how," from Latin *quomodo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin used a recurring *qu-* stem in questions. Spanish preserves that family, although centuries of sound change gave the modern forms different shapes:

Spanish clue	← Latin	future meaning
qué	*quid*	what
quién	*quem*	who
cuál	*qualis*	which
cuándo	*quando*	when
cuánto	*quantus*	how much
cómo	*quomodo*	how

These are previews, not vocabulary to produce today. For now, use the family only as an etymological clue: a question form beginning *qu-* or *cu-* may continue the same Latin pattern. *Dónde*, "where," is an exception from Latin *de unde*, "from where."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the Latin source of *cómo*
- the recurring Latin question stem
- which word in the family asks for a person

- whether the table is today's production list or a preview

Before you move on

Which old stem connects *qué, quién, cuándo,* and *cómo*? (*qu-*.)
Which word in the preview is the exception? (*Dónde.*)

6.4 se llama — the reflexive that fits *usted*

You can say *me llamo* ("I call myself"). To ask someone *else* their name — especially formally, with *usted* — you need the version that loops back on *them*: *se llama.*

What to know first

- me llamo — the reflexive "I call myself."
- tú / usted — and the key fact that *usted* takes *he/she* verb forms.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

se llama = **se** ("himself / herself / yourself-formal") + **llama** ("calls"). So *se llama* = "he/she calls himself," or — because *usted* uses third-person forms — "**you** (formal) call yourself."
se — the reflexive pronoun for the third person (and for *usted*). Root: Latin **sē** ("himself, herself, itself"). That same *se-* — carrying the sense of "self / apart / aside" — is bolted onto a shelf of English words:

- **se**cede — *se* + *cedere* ("go apart").
- **se**clude, **se**gregate ("apart from the flock"), **se**parate.
- **se**duce — *se* + *ducere* ("lead aside").
- **se**cure — *se* + *cura* ("free from care"), **se**cret ("set apart").

Every one is something turned in on itself or set apart — the same idea as a reflexive looping the action back on the doer.

Grammar Lens: the reflexive pronoun changes with the person

The verb *llamar* stays, but the little reflexive word in front shifts to match *who* is doing the calling:

- **me** llamo — *I* call myself
- **te** llamas — *you (informal, tú)* call yourself
- **se** llama — *he / she / you (formal, usted)* calls himself/yourself

Three persons, three pronouns: *me / te / se*. That *se* is exactly why the formal "what's your name?" is *¿cómo **se** llama usted?* — *usted*, born from "your grace," politely takes the *he/she* shape.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "se llama" — *seh YA-ma*
- the set — "me llamo, te llamas, se llama"
- "se" then "secede", "seclude", "separate" — the set-apart root

Before you move on

Which reflexive goes with *usted* — *te* or *se*? (*se* — because *usted* takes third-person forms.) What's the "self/apart" root inside *secede* and *separate*? (Latin *se-*.)

6.5 ¿cómo se llama usted? — assembling the question, and answering it

Everything you built this chapter clicks into one sentence: how to ask a stranger their name, and how to answer back. This is your first real two-way exchange.

What to know first

- cómo · se llama · usted

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo se llama usted? = *cómo* ("how") + *se llama* ("do you-formal call yourself") + *usted* ("you," formal).
Literally: **"How do you call yourself?"** Spanish asks *how*, not *what*, for a name — you're asking by what name a person goes, the manner they're called.
The informal version, for a friend, swaps the reflexive and drops the formal pronoun: **¿Cómo te llamas?** (*te llamas*, from *tú*). Same question, two registers — exactly the *tú*/*usted* choice from earlier, now live in a real sentence:

- To a stranger, an elder, a customer → *¿Cómo se llama usted?*
- To a friend, a child, a peer → *¿Cómo te llamas?*

How to answer

You already have the answer from the *me llamo* lesson: **Me llamo _____.**

— ¿Cómo se llama usted? — **Me llamo David.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ask a stranger their name — *¿cómo se llama usted?*
- ask a friend the same — *¿cómo te llamas?*
- the whole mini-exchange — ask, then answer with *me llamo* _____

Before you move on

Formal vs. informal "what's your name"? (*¿Cómo se llama usted?* / *¿Cómo te llamas?*) Does Spanish literally ask "what" or "how" is your name? ("How" — *cómo*.)

6.6 mucho — "much," and a sound-change you've already seen

One more word before "pleased to meet you." *mucho* — "much, a lot" — and it hides the same Latin-to-Spanish sound trick you spotted in *noche*.

Sounds you'll need

- `soft-c` — the **ch** is the *ch* of *church*: *MOO-cho*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mucho — "much, a lot." Root: Latin **multus** ("much, many"). The English cousins keep the original *-lt-*:

- **mult**iple, **mult**itude, **mult**iply, **mult**i-purpose, **mult**imedia.

The sound-change, again: Latin *multum* → Spanish *mucho*. The Latin **-lt-** softened into Spanish **-ch-** — the very same move as *noctem* → *noche* (*-ct-* → *-ch-*, as in the *noche* lesson). Spanish has a habit of melting these consonant clusters into *ch*. So a Spanish *-ch-* word very often points back to a Latin *-ct-* or *-lt-* root — and the English cousin usually preserves it (*noct*urnal, *mult*iple).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "mucho" — *MOO-cho*
- "mucho" then "multiple", "multitude" — the *mult-* family
- "noche" and "mucho" — two words, same *-ch-* from a melted Latin cluster

Before you move on

mucho comes from Latin *multus* — what English words keep the *-lt-*? (multiple, multitude, multiply.) What Latin cluster melted into the *-ch-*? (*-lt-*, like *-ct-* did in *noche*.)

6.7 gusto → mucho gusto — "much pleasure"

The line you say when you shake someone's hand. First the noun *gusto*, then snap *mucho* onto it, and you've got it.

What to know first

- mucho — "much," about to modify *gusto*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el gusto (masculine) — "taste; pleasure, liking." Root: Latin **gustus** ("a tasting, a taste"). The English cousins:

- **gust**atory — to do with the sense of taste.
- dis**gust** — *dis-* ("not, opposite") + *gust*: literally "**dis**taste."
- **gusto** — borrowed whole into English, meaning zest, relish, enjoyment.

  False friend to flag: a *gust* of wind is **not** related — that one's from Old Norse *gustr*. Same spelling, different root. Resemblance isn't proof.

mucho gusto = *mucho* ("much") + *gusto* ("pleasure") = literally **"much pleasure"** — short for "it's a great pleasure [to meet you]." *gusto* is masculine (*el gusto*), and *mucho* is in its plain masculine form to match it: another quiet piece of the agreement you've been building.

Why it's said this way

Spanish greets a new acquaintance by naming the *pleasure* of it — "much pleasure" — where English names the *person* ("pleased to meet **you**"). The phrase works by itself, so this first exchange needs no extra reply formula.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "gusto" then "gusto" (English), "disgust", "gustatory"

- "mucho gusto" — on meeting someone

Before you move on

What does *mucho gusto* literally mean? ("Much pleasure.") Is *el gusto* masculine or feminine? (Masculine.) And the English cousin of *gusto* built from *dis-*? (*Disgust* — "distaste.")

6.8 Practice — introducing yourself

Ten lessons of atoms now assemble into a real conversation. No new words — just the exchange, run both formally and informally until the *tú* / *usted* choice is automatic.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

— Buenos días. Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo se llama usted?**
— Me llamo David. **Mucho gusto.**

Informal (a friend, a peer): only two words change, and they're the ones that carry the whole social difference:

— ¡Hola! Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo te llamas?** — Me llamo David. Mucho gusto.

What you've built

- **me llamo** — introduce yourself ("I call myself").
- **tú / usted** — the informal vs. formal "you," and *why* (the retired *thou*; *usted* from "your grace").
- **¿cómo te llamas? / ¿cómo se llama usted?** — ask a name, in either register, the pronoun (*te* / *se*) tracking the choice.
- **mucho gusto** — "much pleasure," pleased to meet you.

And one from two chapters back, because it is worth keeping warm: *buenos días* but *buenas tardes* — the describing word copies its noun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both parts
- the same exchange *informally* — catch yourself on *se llama* → *te llamas*
- for a police officer, then your best friend — which "you" for each, and why?
- point to either speaker and ask **¿Quién?** — answer with the name

Twice through: Run the formal version start to finish without stopping.

Before you move on

Which two words change between the formal and informal introduction? (*se llama usted* → *te llamas*.) Next chapter, you will learn how to ask how someone is doing.

Chapter 7

Thank You, Yes, and No

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can thank someone, answer when I am thanked, and say yes or no.
>
> *Thanks, the answer to thanks, and the two words that let you accept or decline.*

7.1 sí — yes

The smallest useful word — and the accent on it is doing real work.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí = yes. One syllable, said *see*.
The written accent is not decoration — it is the **whole difference** between two words:

- **sí** (with the accent) = **yes**
- **si** (no accent) = **if**

They sound almost identical, so Spanish uses the mark to tell them apart on the page: *Sí, si quieres* = "Yes, if you want." Miss the accent and you've written "if" where you meant "yes."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí is Latin **sīc**, "thus, so" — answering a question with "just so," exactly the move Latin also made with **ita** ("thus" = yes, from the Latin yes/no lesson). Its Romance cousins kept the same root:

Latin *sīc*	→
Spanish	**sí**
Italian	**sì**
Portuguese	**sim**

French is the odd one out — it went a completely different way for "yes" (*oui*), which its own lesson tells. But say *sí, sì, sim* in a row and you hear one Latin word answering across three countries.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "sí" — *see*, and picture the accent
- the pair — "sí" (yes) vs "si" (if)
- the cousins — "sí, sì, sim" — all from Latin *sīc*

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Spanish? (**sí**.) What is the *only* difference between **sí** "yes" and **si** "if"? (The **written accent**.) What Latin word is *sí* from, and what did it mean? (**sīc** — "thus, so".)

7.2 no — no / not

The easiest word yet — and it quietly does two jobs Spanish never splits apart.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

no = **no**. Said *noh*, a clean single vowel.
It is Latin **nōn** with almost nothing worn off — just the final consonant gone. Compare the family, all from the same *nōn*:

Latin *nōn*	→
Spanish	**no**
Italian	**no**
French	**non**

Why it's said this way

Here's the thing English splits and Spanish doesn't. English has **"no"** (the answer) and **"not"** (inside a sentence) — two different words. Spanish uses **no** for **both**:

- as the **answer**. Someone asks you something — anything at all — and this one syllable declines it. You do not need to understand the question to answer it, which is exactly why this word comes early.
- and later, as the word that turns a sentence around — but that needs a sentence first, so it waits until you have one. For now: ***no*** is how you decline, refuse, and disagree, which is most of what a beginner needs it for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "no" — *noh*
- "No." — flat, once, the way you would decline a second coffee
- "Sí." then "No." — the two shortest complete answers in Spanish

Before you move on

How do you say no in Spanish? (**no**.) What Latin word is it from? (**nōn**.) Spanish *no* does the work of which **two** English words? (**"no"** the answer, and later the word for "not.") Where does *no* go to negate a sentence? (**Right before the verb**.)

7.3 gracias — "thank you," and a whole family of English words

You can now introduce yourself. The next exchange is *how are you?* — but every answer ends the same polite way, so we learn the courtesy word first: **gracias**.

Sounds you'll need

- `vowel-a` — the clean *ah* of *father*, twice.
- `r-tap` — a single flicked *r* (not the English one, and not yet the rolled *rr*): the tongue taps once, like the middle of American *butter*.
- `ci-th-s` — the *ci* is a soft *s* in Latin America (**GRAH-syahs**) and a soft *th* in most of Spain (**GRAH-thyahs**). Either is correct — pick one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gracias is the plural of **gracia** ("grace, favour"), from Latin **grātia** — *favour freely given*. Saying *gracias* literally offers someone "graces," i.e. good will in return for theirs.
That one Latin root **grātia** fans out across English — once you see it, you get a fistful of words for free:

- **grace**, **gracious**, **graceful** — the direct borrowings.
- **grateful**, **gratitude** — being *full of* grātia.
- **gratis**, **gratuity** — something given as a *favour* (for free, or a tip).
- **congratulate** — literally "to wish grace *together with* someone."
- Italian **grazie**, French *grâces*, Portuguese *graças* — the whole Romance family kept grātia, even where everyday thanks went elsewhere (French says *merci*, Portuguese *obrigado*).

So *gracias* is not a word to memorize cold: it is **grace**, made plural and handed to another person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "gracias" — *GRAH-syahs*, one soft tap on the *r*
- "gracias" then English "grace, grateful, gratitude" — one family

Before you move on

What everyday English word is *gracias* the plural of, at the root? (*Grace.*) So when you thank someone in Spanish, you are literally handing them — what? (Graces / favours.) Next: the little reply that closes the exchange, **de nada**.

7.4 de nada — "you're welcome," or "it was nothing"

Someone says **gracias**. You need the reply that closes the loop: **de nada** — literally *"of nothing."* You're waving the favour off as no trouble at all — the same move English makes with *"it's nothing"* / *"no problem."*

Sounds you'll need

- `d-soft` — the *d* in *nada* is soft, almost the *th* of *this* (**NAH-thah**), not a hard English *d*. Spanish *d* between vowels always softens.
- `vowel-a` — three clean *ah* sounds: *deh NAH-thah.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **de** = "of / from" (Latin **dē**) — the same *de* hiding in English **de**part, **de**duct, **de**scend.
- **nada** = "nothing." And this is the beautiful part.

nada comes from Latin **(rēs) nāta** — "(a thing) *born.*" From *nāscī*, "to be born," the same root as English **nat**ive, **nat**ure, **nat**al, **re-nais-sance** (re-birth). Latin speakers said *nōn est rēs nāta*, "there is not a born thing" — *not a single thing that ever came into being* —

and over centuries the emphatic *nāta* ("born thing") wore down until **the word for 'born thing' became the word for 'nothing' itself.** So the reply *de nada* literally says **"of [a] born-thing"** → "of nothing at all." French did the identical trick with **rien** ("nothing") — which is Latin **rem**, "a thing." Two languages, same move: the word for *thing* collapses into the word for *nothing*.

Grammar Lens: the courtesy pair

gracias → *de nada* is a fixed **adjacency pair**: one turn expects the other. Learn them as a unit, the way English glues *thank you* → *you're welcome*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "gracias" … "de nada" — the full exchange, both voices
- "de nada" then English "native, nature, natal" — nada's true family

Before you move on

nada ("nothing") started life as the Latin word for a *born* — what? (A *thing* — *rēs nāta*, a born thing.) What English words share that "born" root? (Native, nature, natal, renaissance.) Next: the verb the whole "how are you?" question turns on — **estar**.

7.5 Thank you, yes, and no — putting it together

Two words that travel everywhere together. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— **Gracias.** — **De nada.**

And the two words that let you answer anything at all:

— ¿…? — **Sí.** / — **No.**

What you've built

You can thank someone, answer when you are thanked, and — for the first time — accept or decline. Until you have *sí* and *no*, every question anyone asks you is unanswerable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 8

How Are You

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask a stranger how they are.
> *Greeting plus the question that opens almost every conversation.*

8.1 estar — "to be," the *standing* kind

To ask *how are you?* Spanish needs a verb for **being**. Today just the verb itself and where it came from; how to use it, and its two forms, come next.

Sounds you'll need

- `st-no-e` — Spanish never starts a word with a bare *st-*; it props it up with an *e*: *es-TAR*. (That reflex is why Spanish speakers say *e-Spain*, *e-student* — the same *e* that Latin *stāre* grew to become *estar*.)
- `r-tap` — the final *r* is one soft tap: *es-TAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estar comes straight from Latin **stāre**, *"to stand."* Hold onto that picture: it is the whole reason this verb behaves the way it does. How you are **standing** at this moment — well, tired, here, there — is a snapshot, not a permanent fact.
That root **stā-/sta-** is one of the most productive in English. *Estar*

hands you a large family for free:

- **stay**, **stand**, **stance**, **station**, **stable**, **stationary** — to stand or stay put.
- **state**, **status**, **statue**, **estate** — a way of *standing* (your state is how you stand).
- **constant**, **circumstance**, **substance** — "standing with / around / under."

So *¿cómo estás?* is, at the root, **"how are you standing?"**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "estar" — *es-TAR*, with the little propping *e*
- "estar" then English "stay, state, status, stable" — all *standing*

Before you move on

Which Latin verb is *estar* — "to be" or "to stand"? (To **stand** — *stāre.*) Why does Spanish put an *e* on the front? (It never begins a word with bare *st-*.) Name two English cousins. (*Stay, state, status, stable, estate…*) Next: the two forms you will actually ask with.

8.2 estás / está — the two forms, and what they are for

Estar is "to stand." Now put it to work. Two forms, one job: saying how somebody is **right now**.

What to know first

- estar — the verb and its Latin "to stand" root.
- tú *or* usted — why *usted* takes he/she forms.

Grammar Lens: state and location use estar

Use **estar** for a **current state** or a **location** — the two things that can change without changing what something *is*:

- a state: *estoy bien* — "I'm well" (today; maybe not tomorrow).
- a location: *está aquí* — "it's here" (for now).

"How are you?" asks about a current state, so it takes *estar*. Spanish has a second be-verb for identity, and it arrives in its own later lesson; keeping it out of today's drill lets one contrast settle at a time.

Grammar Lens: the two forms you need

you're addressing	form	reads as
tú (informal)	**estás**	"you are"
usted (formal)	**está**	"you are"

Notice that **está** is also "he is / she is." That is not a coincidence and not something extra to learn — it is the *usted*-takes-he/she-forms rule you already met, showing up for the first time in a real verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "estás" … "está" — the two forms you'll ask with
- which one goes with *tú*, which with *usted*
- a state, then a location — "estás bien", "está aquí"

Before you move on

What two kinds of thing does *estar* cover? (**Current state** and **location**.) Which form goes with *tú*, and which with *usted*? (*Estás*; *está*.) Why is *está* also "he/she is"? (Because *usted* takes the **he/she** verb forms.) Next lesson, you finally ask it: **¿cómo está usted?**

8.3 ¿cómo está usted? — "how are you?"

Everything you've built this chapter now snaps together into one question. You already met **cómo** ("how") and the **tú / usted** choice back in when you first met them; you just learned **estar**. Assemble them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo está usted? = "How are you?" (formal) literally: **"In what manner are you standing?"**

- **cómo** = "how / in what manner"
- **está** = "you are" (the *usted*/he-she form of **estar** — state, not identity)
- **usted** = the formal "you"

Note the **¿** — Spanish opens a question with an upside-down mark so you know the melody is coming before you start reading aloud. (We take that mark apart in a dedicated writing lesson.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Cómo está usted?" — formal, for a stranger
- the pieces — "cómo + está + usted"

Before you move on

Which be-verb does "how are you?" use — *ser* or *estar*, and why? (*estar* — it's about your current state.) What changes between formal and informal? (**The next step changes the ending and pronoun.**) Next: choosing the register.

8.4 How are you — putting the question together

You have a second "to be" and the question it carries. Nothing new here — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Buenos días. **¿Cómo está usted?**

The answer is the next chapter. Asking is this one.

What you've built

You can ask a stranger how they are, which is the question that opens almost every conversation you will ever have in Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Cómo está usted?" — to someone you have just met
- the greeting and the question together, as one breath

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which "to be" carries how someone is, and why? (*Estar* — a state, not an identity.) Ask the question once more from memory.

Chapter 9

Answering, and Handing It Back

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can answer how I am, choose my register, and return the question.
>
> *The answer, the register choice inside it, and handing the question back.*

9.1 ¿cómo está usted? / ¿cómo estás? — choose the register

You can already ask a stranger **¿Cómo está usted?** Now change only the relationship: ask the same question of a friend.

Grammar Lens: one question, two relationships

register	question
formal (stranger, elder, customer)	**¿Cómo está usted?**
informal (friend, peer, child)	**¿Cómo estás?**

The formal version uses the third-person ending **está** plus **usted**. The informal version uses second-person **estás** and normally omits **tú**. This is the same relationship contrast you drilled with **se llama / te llamas**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a doctor you just met — "¿Cómo está usted?"
- to your cousin — "¿Cómo estás?"
- swap back and forth — "está usted / estás"

Twice through: Ask both versions until the ending swap is automatic.

Before you move on

Which version fits a stranger? (**¿Cómo está usted?**) Which fits a friend? (**¿Cómo estás?**) What two things change? (**The verb ending and the pronoun.**)

9.2 regular / más o menos — the honest "so-so"

You asked *¿cómo estás?* Now you can answer three ways: great, middling, or a wave of the hand. You already have **bien** ("well"). Today, the *middling* answers — because nobody is *bien* every day.

What to know first

Recall **bien** — "well." Root? (Latin *bene*, "well" — same as *bene*fit, *bene*volent.) So *estoy bien* = "I'm well." Now the answer for when you're *not* quite bien.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

regular — as an answer to "how are you?", it means **"so-so, average, not great."** (A famous false-friend trap: it does **not** mean English "regular / normal / usual" here.) From Latin **rēgula**, a *straight rod* a builder used to check a line — the **ruler**. So *regular* is "on the rule, on the average line" → middling.
That *rēgula* rod is everywhere in English: **rule**, **ruler**, **regulate**, **regular**, **regiment**, and even **rail** (a straight rod). All the same straight stick.
más o menos — "more or less," the shrug-answer:

- **más** = "more," from Latin **magis** ("more") — cousin of *major*, *master*, *maximum*.

- **menos** = "less," from Latin **minus** — the very word English borrowed for *minus*, *minor*, *minimum*, *minus*cule.

So *más o menos* is literally **"more or less"** — the exact phrase, root for root, that English uses for the same shrug.

Grammar Lens: a small answer set

You now have a scale to answer *¿cómo estás?*:

answer	sense
(muy) bien	(very) well
regular	so-so
más o menos	more or less / meh

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "regular" — *reh-goo-LAR*, soft tap on both *r*'s
- "más o menos" — a little shrug in the voice
- answer "¿cómo estás?" three ways — bien / regular / más o menos

Before you move on

As an answer, does *regular* mean "normal" or "so-so"? (So-so — the false-friend trap.) What straight-rod Latin word is it from, and what English "rod" words share it? (*rēgula* → rule, ruler, regulate, rail.) Next: put the whole exchange together.

9.3 y / ¿y tú? — pass the question back

You can ask how someone is and answer. One tiny connector turns that exchange around so the other person gets a turn too.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Y means **and** and sounds like Spanish **i**: *ee*. It continues Latin **et**, also "and." English borrowed that Latin word intact inside **et cetera**,

literally “and the rest.”

Grammar Lens: the shortest return question

Put **y** before a person you already know:

- **¿Y tú?** — And you? *(informal)*
- **¿Y usted?** — And you? *(formal)*

Nothing else needs repeating. The little question hands the previous topic back to the other person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Bien. ¿Y tú?” to a friend
- “Regular. ¿Y usted?” to a stranger
- “y” — one clear *ee* sound

Before you move on

What does **y** mean? (**And.**) How do you hand a question back to a friend? (**¿Y tú?**) To a stranger? (**¿Y usted?**) Which Latin word survives inside English **et cetera**? (**Et**, “and.”)

9.4 Asking how someone is — putting it together

Now the question, its answer, and the register choice inside it. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— ¿**Cómo está usted**? — **Bien**, gracias. ¿**Y** usted? — **Regular**.

What you've built

You can ask how someone is, formally or not, answer honestly, and hand the question back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 10

The Written Accent

Modes: **voice** (1) **pen** (2) **Hands-free start:** none of the 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can hear where a Spanish word is stressed and see why the accent is written.
>
> *The Written Accent — the chapter run end to end.*

10.1 á é í ó ú — the acute accent, and the two jobs it does

You've been reading accented words since your very first noun — **día**, **có**mo, es**tá**, **má**s. Time to make that little stroke make sense. Spanish uses one mark to write exceptional stress — the *acute* accent, ´, leaning right — and it does two jobs in the words you know. Learn the stress job now; the next lesson adds its grammar-label job.

Script — shape and stroke

A short stroke rising **left-to-right**, sitting on top of a vowel: **á é í ó ú**. (On the *í*, it replaces the dot.) One clean up-stroke — the opposite lean from the French *grave* accent à. Spanish never uses grave or circumflex; if it leans the wrong way, it isn't Spanish.

Grammar Lens: the mark records exceptional stress

Spanish stress is regular, so most words need **no** mark. The default:

- word ends in a **vowel, -n, or -s** → stress the **second-to-last** syllable (*ho-la*, *lla-mo*, *gus-to*).
- word ends in **any other consonant** → stress the **last** syllable (*us-**ted***, *re-gu-**lar***, *es-**tar***).

The accent appears **only when a word breaks that rule** — it marks the exception. *está* ends in a vowel, so the rule wants *ES-ta*; the accent overrides it to *es-**TÁ***. *cómo* ends in a vowel (rule wants *co-**MO***) but is stressed *CÓ-mo*, so it gets the mark. The accent is a **spoken stress you can see** — it never changes the vowel's sound, only which syllable you hit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hola, llamo, gusto" — second-to-last stress
- "usted, regular, estar" — final stress
- "está, cómo" — the accent overrides the default

Before you move on

How many accent marks does Spanish have, and which way does it lean? (One — the acute, ´, rising left-to-right.) Its two jobs? (Mark irregular stress; the next step covers its look-alike job.) When does a word ending in a vowel, **-n**, or **-s** need an accent? (**When its stress breaks the second-to-last default.**)

10.2 el or él? — the accent as a meaning label

You know **el** as the article "the." Add one acute accent and the same two letters do a different job.

Grammar Lens: one mark, two grammatical jobs

The **tilde diacrítica** separates words that otherwise look alike:

no accent	with accent
el = the	**él** = he

The two words are pronounced alike. Here the accent does not move stress; it labels meaning and grammar. Other pairs will arrive only when you know both words, so this lesson asks you to hold one contrast, not memorize a list.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "el" — the
- *Say it:* "él" — he
- *Write it:* **el / él**, adding the meaning-label accent only to the pronoun

Before you move on

What is the accent's second job? (**Separate look-alike words.**) Which means "the"? (**El**, no accent.) Which means "he"? (**Él**, with the accent.) Does this mark change their stress? (**No — it labels the job.**)

10.3 The written accent — putting it together

Two lessons on one small mark that changes both sound and meaning. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

está is not *esta*. *él* is not *el*.

What you've built

You can hear where the stress falls and see why the mark is there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 11

Enye and the Upside-Down Marks

Modes: **voice** (1) **pen** (4) **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read and write ñ and the upside-down question and exclamation marks.
>
> *Enye and the Upside-Down Marks — the chapter run end to end.*

11.1 ñ — the letter that remembers a doubled n

> **ñ** is the one letter English does not have — and it has the best origin story in the alphabet. That wavy hat (**~**, a *tilde*) is not decoration. It is **a tiny second *n*, written on top to save space.** Once you know that, you know both how to write it *and* why it sounds as it does.

Sounds you'll need

ñ = the *ny* in "ca**ny**on" or "o**ni**on" — one squished sound, tongue flat against the roof of the mouth. English *canyon* is, in fact, Spanish **cañón** with the *ñ* spelled out as *ny*. Say "onion," freeze on the middle: that is ñ.

Script — how to write it

Write a normal **n**, then a small wavy ~ floating above it. Two strokes, one letter.

Careful: ñ is its own letter, not "n with an accent." *año* ("year") and *ano* (a rather different word) are completely different words — the tilde is not an optional flourish, it is a distinct letter of the alphabet, with its own slot in the dictionary.

Why it's said this way

That wave is a **medieval shorthand**. Scribes copying Latin were forever writing double letters, so they saved a stroke: write the letter **once**, and put a little mark above meaning *"…and one more of these."* A bar over a vowel meant a dropped *n* or *m* (Latin *tantum* → *tãtum*); a wave over an *n* meant **nn**.
Spanish is full of words where a Latin **-nn-** did exactly this:

- Latin **annus** ("year") → *anno* → **año**. (That same *annus* gives English **ann**ual, **ann**iversary, bi-**enn**ial.)
- Latin **canna** ("reed") → **caña**; Latin *domina* → *donna* → **doña**.

So the tilde on **ñ** is a **frozen abbreviation** — a thousand-year-old note saying "there used to be two *n*'s here." You are writing a scribe's shortcut.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "año" — *AH-nyo*, one squished *ny*; then English "annual"
- the doubled-n words — "año, caña, doña"

Before you move on

What is the tilde on *ñ*, really? (A tiny second *n* — a scribe's shorthand for a doubled *nn*.) What Latin word gives *año*, and what English words share it? (*Annus* → annual, anniversary.) Is *ñ* a separate letter or an accented *n*? (A **separate letter**.) Next: the two everyday words you will be writing it in.

11.2 mañana, español — the ñ in the words you are about to need

You can write **ñ** and you can say it. Two of the next words in this book carry it, and both are worth a minute on their own — because neither of them got its *ñ* from a doubled *n*.

What to know first

- ñ — the letter, the sound, and the scribe's shorthand.

Script — the two forms

- **mañana** — "tomorrow," and also "morning." *ma-NYA-na*: the *ñ* is in the **middle**, and it is the stressed syllable.
- **español** — "Spanish." *es-pa-NYOL*: the *ñ* is at the **end**, right before the *-ol*.

Now the honest footnote. The scribe's doubled *nn* is **one** road to *ñ*, the one you met with *año*. These two words took a **different** road: Latin's **-ni-** before a vowel. *Mañana* traces back through *maneana* to **mānе** ("morning" — the root of English **matinée**); *español* comes from **Hispaniolus**, built on **Hispania**. In both, a *ni* sequence squeezed together into the same single palatal sound.

So *ñ* is where **two** separate Latin sequences ended up — *-nn-* and *-ni-*. One letter, one sound, two histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "año, mañana, español" — the ñ in three positions
- the two roads — "año, from -nn-" then "mañana, from -ni-"

Before you move on

Where does the *ñ* sit in *mañana*, and where in *español*? (Middle; end.) Did those two get their *ñ* from a doubled *n*? (**No** — from Latin **-ni-** before a vowel, a second road to the same letter.) What was the first road? (**-nn-**, the scribe's shorthand, as in *año*.)

11.3 ¿ ¡ — the marks that open a question

You've been writing them since *¿cómo está usted?* Spanish is the one major language that puts an **upside-down** question or exclamation mark at the **start** of the sentence, as well as the normal one at the end. It looks exotic; the reason is purely practical.

Script — the two opening marks

- **¿ … ?** wraps a question: *¿Cómo estás?*
- **¡ … !** wraps an exclamation: *¡Hola! ¡Gracias!*

The opening mark is just the closing mark **flipped 180°** — turned upside down *and* left-right. To write **¿**, draw a normal *?* and rotate it half a turn: the hook ends up at the bottom, the dot on top.

Why it's said this way

English lets you read most of a sentence before the final **?** reveals it was a question — fine, because English usually flags a question early with word order ("*Are* you…", "*Do* you…"). Spanish often **doesn't reorder words**: *Tienes hambre.* ("You're hungry.") and *¿Tienes hambre?* ("Are you hungry?") are the **same words** — only punctuation and the spoken rising tone tell them apart.
So the Spanish Royal Academy, in **1754**, made the opening **¿** official: it warns the reader *"a question is starting — read this with rising intonation from the very first word."* It's a **melody cue placed before the melody**, the exact same instinct as the written accent marking stress you can't otherwise see. For a language read aloud, it's genuinely useful.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read "¿Cómo estás?" — start the rising *question* melody from the very first word, the way the ¿ tells you to
- "¡Hola!" — the ¡ warns you to begin with exclamation energy

Before you move on

Why does Spanish open a question with **¿**? (Because word order often doesn't change, so the reader needs an early warning to use question intonation.) How do you write it? (A normal *?* rotated 180°.) Does it always sit at the sentence's start? (**The next step places it around a question inside a larger sentence.**)

11.4 Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span

You can open a whole question with **¿**. Now place that mark inside a larger sentence, exactly where the questioning voice begins.

Script — bracket the spoken span

The opening mark goes where the **question** begins, even if the sentence started earlier:

Roberto, **¿cómo estás?**

The name **Roberto** is outside the question. The marks bracket the words that need question intonation. The same principle works for an exclamation:

Roberto, **¡buenos días!**

This is why the opening mark is more than decoration. It tells the reader exactly where to begin and end a change in spoken melody.

Your turn

- *Write it:* "María, ¿cómo estás?"
- *Write it:* "María, ¡buenos días!"
- *Say it:* begin the new melody at ¿ or ¡, not at the first capital

Before you move on

In **Roberto, ¿cómo estás?**, is **Roberto** inside the question? (**No.**) Where does the inverted mark go? (**At the start of the question or exclamation span.**) What does that placement tell a reader? (**Where to change the spoken melody.**)

11.5 Practice — "how are you?", start to finish

No new words. This chapter's atoms — *gracias, de nada, estar, ¿cómo está?, regular* — now assemble into a real exchange, run formally and informally until the register swap is automatic. It picks up right where the introduction left off.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

— Buenos días. ¿**Cómo está usted**? — **Bien, gracias.** ¿Y usted? — **Más o menos.** — [reply to a thanks, later in the chat] **De nada.**

Informal (a friend, a peer) — only the verb + pronoun change:

— ¡Hola! ¿**Cómo estás**? — **Regular.** ¿Y tú? — Bien, gracias.

The glue pattern you just secured is **¿y usted? / ¿y tú?** — "and you?" It bounces the question back without repeating the whole sentence.

What you've built this chapter

- **gracias** — thank you (← *grātia*, "grace").
- **de nada** — you're welcome (← "of a born-thing" → "of nothing").
- **estar** — the state/location be-verb (← *stāre*, "to stand").
- **¿cómo está usted? / ¿cómo estás?** — how are you, formal / informal.
- **bien / regular / más o menos** — well / so-so / more-or-less.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both voices
- the same exchange *informally* — catch *está* → *estás*, *usted* → *tú*
- chain the two — introduce yourself *and* ask how they are: "Me llamo … ¿Cómo está usted?"

Twice through: Run the formal exchange, greeting to answer, without stopping.

Before you move on

Which be-verb carries "how are you?" and why? (*estar* — current state.) Two words swap between formal and informal — which? (*está* → *estás*, and *usted* → *tú*.) What does *de nada* literally say? ("Of nothing.") And if the person answering you says **vos** instead of *tú* — do you switch? (*No. You understand it and keep saying tú.*) Next chapter: **farewells** — hasta luego, hasta mañana, adiós.

Chapter 12

Goodbye

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can end a conversation, and I know the word every softer goodbye is built from.
>
> *Goodbye — the chapter run end to end.*

12.1 adiós — "goodbye," or "to God"

You can greet, introduce yourself, and ask how someone is. Time to leave gracefully. The final, plainest parting is **adiós** — and, like the English *goodbye*, it's a tiny prayer worn smooth.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-io` — the *-iós* is one glide, *ee-OHS*: *ah-DYOHS*, stress on the end (that's what the accent on *ó* marks — remember the acute-accent lesson).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

adiós is **a** + **Dios** — "**to God**." It's the front half of an old blessing, *a Dios te encomiendo*, "I commend you **to God**" — said to someone setting off, when a journey was dangerous and you left them in God's keeping.
Every Romance sister kept the same farewell-prayer:

language	goodbye	literally
Spanish	*adiós*	"to God"
French	*adieu*	"to God" (*à Dieu*)
Italian	*addio*	"to God"
Portuguese	*adeus*	"to God"

And English is doing the **exact same thing** without telling you: **goodbye** is a crushed-down *"God be with ye."* So *adiós* and *goodbye* are, at heart, the same sentence — a blessing for the road.

- **Dios** ("God") ← Latin **Deus** — the *Deus* of English *deity*, *divine*, *adieu*, and (via Greek *Zeus*, same root) the whole sky-god family.

Grammar Lens: adiós is a *final* goodbye

adiós leans toward a **longer** parting — you won't see them soon, or it's the end of the day. For "see you later / tomorrow," Spanish reaches for **hasta ...**, which the rest of this chapter is about — and *hasta* has a surprising origin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "adiós" — *ah-DYOHS*, stress the end
- adiós / adieu / addio / adeus — four "to God" farewells
- English "goodbye" = "God be with ye" — the same prayer

Before you move on

What two words hide inside *adiós*? (*a* + *Dios* — "to God.") What English goodbye is built the same way? (*Goodbye* ← "God be with ye.") Is *adiós* for a quick "see you soon"? (No — it's the longer/final parting; *hasta …* comes next.) Next: **hasta**, and a word Spain borrowed from Arabic.

12.2 hasta — "until," and Spain's Arabic centuries

Spanish says "see you later" as **hasta luego** — literally "**until** later." So the key word is **hasta**, "until." And *hasta* carries the single most important fact about Spanish's history: **for nearly 800 years, much of Spain spoke Arabic.**

Sounds you'll need

- `silent-h` — Spanish **h is always silent**: **hasta** = *AHS-tah* (no breath on the *h* at all). Stress the front.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta comes from Arabic **ḥattā**, "until, up to." From **711 CE**, Muslim armies ruled much of the Iberian Peninsula — *al-Andalus* — and Arabic was the language of government, science, and poetry there for **centuries**, until

1. Spanish absorbed roughly **four thousand** Arabic words in that time — more

of its vocabulary than from any source except Latin itself.
Most of those loans are **nouns**, and you can spot a huge number by the frozen Arabic article **al-** ("the") fused onto the front:

- **almohada** (pillow), **alcázar** (fortress), **alcalde** (mayor), **alfombra** (rug), **aduana** (customs), **álgebra**, **alcohol**.
- **azúcar** (sugar), **aceite** (oil), **naranja** (orange).

But **hasta** is rare and special: it is a **function word** — a preposition, part of the grammatical skeleton. Languages borrow nouns easily and grammar words almost never — so an Arabic *preposition* surviving in everyday Spanish shows how deep, how *intimate*, those centuries of contact were. (Its Latin rival *ad* "to"/*usque* "up to" simply lost.) You say a piece of al-Andalus every time you say goodbye.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hasta" — *AHS-tah*, silent h
- "hasta" then Arabic *ḥattā* — the same word, 1,300 years apart

Before you move on

What language is *hasta* from, and what does it mean? (Arabic *ḥattā* — "until.") Why is it remarkable that Spanish borrowed it? (It's a *function word* / preposition — languages almost never borrow those; it shows how deep the Arabic centuries went.) How do you spot many Arabic nouns in Spanish? (The frozen *al-* article: *almohada, azúcar, álgebra.*)

12.3 hasta aquí / hasta la noche — point to the limit

You know **hasta** means "until" or "up to." Give that small word one spatial endpoint and one temporal endpoint, using only one new word.

Grammar Lens: endpoints in space and time

Aquí means **here**. Put it after **hasta**:

hasta aquí — up to here

For a time endpoint, reuse **la noche**, "the night," which you already have:

hasta la noche — until the night / until tonight

The same preposition points to a place or the end of a stretch of time. The next lessons will place new time words after it one at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "aquí" — here
- "hasta aquí" — up to here

- "hasta la noche" — until tonight

Before you move on

What does **hasta** point to? (**An endpoint.**) Give one spatial and one temporal example. (**Hasta aquí; hasta la noche.**) What is the only new lexical item? (**Aquí**, "here.")

12.4 Leaving — putting it together

One farewell that is final, and one word that opens all the others. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

Adiós — meant, and a little final. **Hasta** — "until," and it is waiting for what comes next.

What you've built

You can close a conversation, and you have the word every softer goodbye is built from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 13

Until When

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can pick the farewell that matches when I will next see someone.
>
> *Until When — the chapter run end to end.*

13.1 hasta luego — the everyday "see you later"

This is the goodbye you'll actually use most — friendly, casual, open-ended. **hasta luego**: "until later." You already own **hasta** ("until"); today you add **luego** ("later"), and it has a very Latin backstory.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ue` — **luego** = *LWEH-goh*: the *ue* is a *w*-glide, *lweh-*.
- The whole phrase: *AHS-tah LWEH-goh.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta luego = "until later" → "see you later."

- **hasta** = "until" (last lesson — Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **luego** = "later / then / soon," from Latin **loco**, "at the place / at that point." The idea slid from *place* → *point in time* → "then, next, soon." So its cousins in English are all about **place**:

local, **locus**, **loc**ation, **loc**ate, **al-loc-ate**. Spanish moved *loco* from *where* to *when*.

A nice contrast: **hasta luego** fuses an **Arabic** word and a **Latin** word in three syllables — the two great layers of Spanish, shaking hands as you leave.

Grammar Lens: the "hasta ..." family

hasta + a time word is Spanish's whole toolkit of soft goodbyes. You'll build the other two this chapter:

phrase	"until ..."	when
hasta luego	later	the default "see you"
hasta mañana	tomorrow	leaving for the day
hasta pronto	soon	you expect to meet again shortly

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hasta luego" — *AHS-tah LWEH-goh*
- "luego" then English "local, location" — the *loco* "place" family
- "¡Adiós! … no — ¡hasta luego!" — feel the difference: final vs. soon

Before you move on

What does *hasta luego* literally mean? ("Until later.") What did *luego*'s Latin root *loco* first mean, and what English words keep it? (Place — *local, location, locus.*) Which two language layers meet in *hasta luego*? (Arabic *hasta* + Latin *luego.*) Next: **hasta mañana**.

13.2 hasta mañana — "see you tomorrow" (and the ñ returns)

Leaving for the day? **hasta mañana** — "until tomorrow." It brings back a letter you studied in the writing lessons: the **ñ**. Here it is, living in a word you'll say every evening.

Sounds you'll need

- `enye-ny` — **mañana** = *mah-NYAH-nah*: the **ñ** is the squished *ny* of "canyon" (your ñ writing lesson — the tilde is a tiny second *n*, remember). Three soft *ah*'s: *ma-**ÑA**-na*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta mañana = "until tomorrow" → "see you tomorrow."

- **hasta** = "until" (Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **mañana** = "tomorrow" — **and** "morning." One word for both, from Latin **(hōra) maneana**, "the **early** hour" (from *māne*, "in the morning"). The logic: the next "early hour" you'll see is *tomorrow morning* → *mañana* came to mean both **morning** and **tomorrow**.

The ñ, in the wild. Recall the writing lesson: *ñ* is a frozen *nn* — a scribe's shorthand for a doubled *n*. *mañana* comes from Latin *maneana*, whose *n*+*ea* palatalized (softened) into that single *ñ* sound. So the tilde is a little historical fossil sitting in the middle of "tomorrow."

Grammar Lens: same word, two meanings — context decides

mañana means "morning" **or** "tomorrow"; the sentence tells you which. Paired with *hasta*, it's always **tomorrow**: *hasta mañana*, "until tomorrow."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "mañana" — *mah-NYAH-nah*, squished *ñ*
- "hasta mañana" — until tomorrow
- "mañana" once as "morning," then once as "tomorrow" — context decides

Before you move on

What two meanings does *mañana* carry? (Morning; tomorrow.) With *hasta*, which one? (Tomorrow.) What sound is the *ñ*, and what is its tilde, historically? (The *ny* of "canyon"; a frozen doubled-*n*.) Next: **hasta pronto**.

13.3 hasta pronto — "see you soon"

The last of the "hasta …" trio: **hasta pronto**, "until soon" — for when you genuinely expect to meet again shortly. One new word, **pronto**, and it's hiding in plain sight in English.

Sounds you'll need

- **hasta pronto** = *AHS-tah PRON-toh* — a clean *pr*, a pure *o*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta pronto = "until soon" → "see you soon."

- **hasta** = "until" (Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **pronto** = "soon / quickly / ready," from Latin **promptus**, "brought forth, ready at hand" (from *prōmere*, "to bring out"). Something *prompt* is brought out **without delay** — so *pronto* slid to "soon."

You already know its English twin: **prompt** (on time; to bring out a response), plus **prompt**er, **prompt**ly, and the computer **prompt** (the cursor "ready" for input). Italian borrowed *pronto* too — it's what Italians say when they pick up the phone (*"Pronto!"* = "Ready!").

Grammar Lens: the "hasta …" trio, complete

You now have Spanish's three soft goodbyes, sharpest to vaguest in time:

phrase	until...	nuance
hasta pronto	soon	you'll meet again shortly
hasta luego	later	the neutral default "see you"
hasta mañana	tomorrow	you're parting for the day

...and **adiós** for the long or final goodbye.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hasta pronto" — *AHS-tah PRON-toh*
- "pronto" then English "prompt, promptly" — one family
- the trio — hasta pronto / hasta luego / hasta mañana

Before you move on

What does *hasta pronto* mean, and *pronto*'s English twin? ("Until soon"; *prompt.*) What Latin word is it from, and its literal sense? (*promptus*, "brought forth / ready.") Order the three *hasta* goodbyes by time. (pronto → luego → mañana.) Next: put the whole farewell set together.

13.4 Practice — saying goodbye

No new words. This chapter's farewells — *adiós* and the three *hasta …* goodbyes — now close a real conversation, and fold back into the whole arc you've built since *hola*.

Grammar Lens: choosing the right goodbye

The choice is about **when you'll meet again**:

you're...	say
parting for good / a long time	**Adiós.**
expecting to meet again shortly	**Hasta pronto.**
just "see you" (neutral default)	**Hasta luego.**
leaving for the day	**Hasta mañana.**

The exchange — start to finish

Everything from Chapters 1–5, in one conversation:

> — ¡Hola! Buenos días. Me llamo Ana. ¿Cómo se llama usted? — Me llamo Luis. Mucho gusto. — ¿Cómo está usted? — Bien, gracias. ¿Y usted? — Bien. **Hasta mañana**, Luis. — **Hasta mañana**, Ana. **¡Adiós!**

What you've built this chapter

- **adiós** — the plain/final goodbye ("to God"; twin of *goodbye*).
- **hasta** — "until," Spain's everyday Arabic word (← *ḥattā*).
- **hasta luego / mañana / pronto** — see you later / tomorrow / soon, each an Arabic + Latin handshake.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full conversation above, both voices — greeting to goodbye
- pick the goodbye — for a friend you'll see tomorrow? (hasta mañana); for someone moving away? (adiós)

Twice through: Run the whole exchange, *hola* to *adiós*, without stopping.

Before you move on

Which goodbye for someone you won't see for a long time? (*Adiós.*) Which everyday word for "until" did Spanish take from Arabic? (*hasta.*) You can now open *and* close a conversation in Spanish. Next chapter: **por favor** and **gracias**' partner courtesies, then into

everyday verbs.

Chapter 14

A Coffee, Please

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for something politely.

A Coffee, Please — the chapter run end to end.

14.1 café — coffee, and a place to drink it

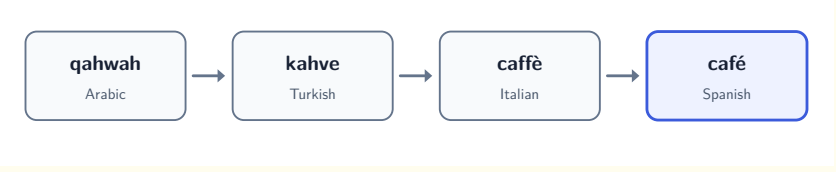
Before you can make a polite request, you need one small thing to request. **Café** gives you a useful noun and lets the written accent do a job you already understand.

Sounds you'll need

Say **ca-FÉ**. A vowel-final word would normally stress the second-to-last syllable, so the acute accent records the unexpected final stress.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **café** came through Italian **caffè** and Turkish **kahve** from Arabic **qahwah**. English **coffee** reached the same travelling word by a different European route. The drink and the word both crossed languages.



The route from Arabic qahwah through Turkish kahve and Italian caffè to Spanish café

Café can name the drink or the place, just as English **coffee** and **café** divide those jobs. It is masculine: **el café**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "café" — final stress
- "el café"
- the route — "qahwah → kahve → caffè → café"

Before you move on

Where does the stress fall? (**On the final é.**) Why is the accent written? (**It overrides the usual vowel-final stress.**) What route carried the word into Spanish? (**Arabic qahwah → Turkish kahve → Italian caffè → Spanish café.**)

14.2 por favor — "please," i.e. "for a favour"

You can already thank (*gracias*) and reply (*de nada*). The third courtesy completes the set: **por favor**, "please" — literally *"for [a] favour."* You're asking someone to do you a kindness.

Sounds you'll need

- `r-tap` — one soft tapped *r* in *por* and *favor*.
- `v-b` — Spanish *v* and *b* sound **identical** (a soft *b*): *favor* ≈ *fah-BOR*. (So *favor* and English *favour* look alike *and* the *v* even sounds like the *b* you'd hear in "harbour.")

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **por** = "for / through / by," from Latin **prō** ("for, on behalf of") — the same *pro-* in English **pro**noun, **pro**pose, **pro**tect.

- **favor** = "a favour, goodwill," from Latin **favēre**, *"to be favourable to, to support."* It's the very word English borrowed: **favour**, **favorite**, **favorable**, **favouritism**.

So *por favor* literally says **"for a favour"** — *[do this] as a kindness to me.* English **favour**, **favorite**, and **favorable** keep the same Latin family visible without asking you to learn another language's formula.

Grammar Lens: the courtesy set is complete

You now hold the three pillars of politeness:

- **por favor** — please (asking).
- **gracias** — thank you (receiving).
- **de nada** — you're welcome (replying).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "por favor" — *por fah-BOR*, soft *v/b*
- "Café, por favor" — "Coffee, please"
- "favor" then English "favour, favorite" — one family

Before you move on

What does *por favor* literally mean? ("For a favour.") What Latin verb is *favor* from, and its English cousins? (*favēre* — favour, favorite, favorable.) Which three-word courtesy loop do you now own? (*Por favor* → *gracias* → *de nada.*) Next: your first regular **verb** — *hablar*, "to speak."

14.3 Ordering — putting it together

Your first transaction: a thing you want, and the word that makes it a request. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Un **café**, **por favor**. — Gracias.

What you've built

You can ask for something and stay polite doing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 15

When You Don't Understand

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that I did not understand, and ask for it more slowly.
>
> *The two sentences that rescue a conversation, and the thanks that closes it.*

15.1 no entiendo — the most useful sentence a beginner owns

Everything so far assumed you understood what was said to you. This chapter is for when you did not.

What to know first

No entiendo. — "I don't understand."

Say it whole. You already have **no**; the rest comes with it for now, and the piece you are not yet meant to take apart will come apart later.

This is not an admission of failure. It is the sentence that keeps a conversation alive — the alternative is nodding at something you did not catch.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The word hiding inside *entiendo* comes from Latin **intendere** — literally *to stretch toward*. To understand something was to lean into it. English took the same word and kept it in several places: **intend** (to stretch your mind toward a thing), **intense**, and — through the same

family — **attention**, which is what you are stretching when you listen hard.
So *no entiendo* is, underneath, "I am not managing to stretch that far yet." Which is exactly true, and much kinder than "I failed."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "No entiendo." — calmly, not apologetically
- it again, to someone speaking too fast

Before you move on

Say it once from memory. Which English word shares its root?

15.2 más despacio — the request that makes the last sentence solvable

Everything so far assumed you understood what was said to you. This chapter is for when you did not.

What to know first

Más despacio, por favor. — "More slowly, please."

No entiendo stops the conversation. This restarts it. Together they are the whole repair kit: say what went wrong, then say what would fix it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Despacio comes from **de spatio** — "of space." Latin **spatium** is English **space**, and also **spatial**.
Doing something *de spatio* meant doing it with room around it, unhurried. The sense drifted from space into time, which is a journey English made too: we still say we need *space* when we mean we need *time*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Más despacio." — calmly, not apologetically
- it again, to someone speaking too fast

Before you move on

Say it once from memory. Which English word shares its root?

15.3 When you don't understand — putting it together

Two sentences. Between them they rescue almost any conversation.

The exchange

— *(something too fast to follow)* — **No entiendo. Más despacio, por favor.** — *(again, slower)* — **Gracias.**

What you've built

Until now, a sentence you missed was the end of the conversation. It is not any more. You can say what went wrong and what would fix it, and then thank someone for doing it — which is the difference between speaking a language badly and not speaking it at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both sentences, one after the other, without a pause between them
- them again, then "Gracias." — the whole repair, start to finish

Twice through:

Before you move on

What do you say when you did not follow? And what do you ask for next? Which English words hide inside *entiendo* and *despacio*? (*Intend, intense, attention* — and *space.*)

Chapter 16

Your First Verb, and the Form That Means I

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I do, in one word, with no pronoun at all.
>
> *One word, one whole sentence — and why English cannot do the same.*

16.1 hablar — "to speak," which used to mean "to tell tales"

Fixed phrases got you this far. **Hablar** ("to speak") is the first verb you will take apart and put back together. Today: the word itself. Next lesson: one ending, and it becomes about you.

Sounds you'll need

- `silent-h` — the **h is completely silent**: *hablar* = *ah-BLAR*. (Spanish *h* never makes a sound.)
- `v-b` — the *b* is a soft *b*; *hablo* = *AH-bloh*.

That silent *h* is not an accident of spelling. Latin's initial **f-** weakened in a whole set of Spanish words and eventually fell silent altogether, but the scribes kept writing a letter where it used to be — and that letter is **h**. You are looking at the gravestone of an *f*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hablar comes from Latin **fābulārī**, *"to chat, to tell tales"* — from **fābula**, "a story." So *to speak*, in Spanish, is at root *to tell stories*. Notice Latin had a plainer verb available (*loquī*, "to speak," which English keeps in **eloquent** and **loquacious**) — and Spanish chose the chattier, more colourful one.
That **fābula** is thoroughly English: **fable**, **fabulous** ("story-like"), **confabulate**, and **ineffable** ("un-speak-able").
The single path you need today is **fābulārī** → **hablar**; later words will let you test how broadly that *f-* → *h-* pattern reaches.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablar" — *ah-BLAR*, silent *h*
- "hablar" then English "fable, fabulous, ineffable" — the *fābula* root
- the sound law — "fābulārī" then "hablar"

Before you move on

What Latin word is *hablar* from, and what English word shares it? (*Fābulārī* ← *fābula* — **fable**.) What happened to its initial Latin *f-*? (It weakened away, leaving the written but **silent** Spanish *h-*.)
Next: swap the *-ar* for one letter, and *hablar* becomes *I speak*.

16.2 hablo — "I speak"

What is the word for "to speak"? (*Hablar.*) Say it once.

What to know first

- hablar — the verb, and the *fābula* behind it.

Grammar Lens: change the ending, change who is speaking

Hablar is the naming form — "to speak." It is not yet about anybody. To make it about **you**, take off the **-ar** and put **-o** in its place:

hablar → **hablo** — *I speak.*

That is the whole operation. One ending, swapped.
And notice what you did not have to do: you did not add a word for *I*. The **-o** is already carrying it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-o** is old and it is nearly untouched. Latin marked "I" on a verb with **-ō**, a long *o*: *amō*, "I love." Two thousand years later Spanish still marks "I" with exactly that letter.
Most of Latin's endings wore down on the way to Spanish. This one did not. When you say *hablo*, the last sound in your mouth is the same one a Roman used to say *I*.

> **Worth noticing.** English gave up. *Speak* is *speak* whoever is doing it, which is why English cannot let go of its pronouns. You will meet that difference properly in the very next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablo"
- "hablo" again, and hear that the *-o* is the part meaning *I*

Before you move on

How do you turn *hablar* into "I speak"? (Drop **-ar**, add **-o**.) Which Latin ending is that **-o**? (*-ō* — the same one.) Next: why *hablo* is already a complete sentence.

16.3 hablo — one word, one whole sentence

Say "I speak" in Spanish. (*Hablo.*) Now count the words you said.

Grammar Lens: the pronoun you never needed

One word. And it is a complete, ordinary, grammatical Spanish sentence.
English needs two — *I* and *speak* — because English's ending is doing no work. Spanish needs one, because the **-o** already said *I* in the previous lesson.
Spanish does have a word for *I*. You will meet it. But putting it in front of *hablo* is a little like saying **"I, I speak"** — the information is already there, and repeating it is something Spanish does only when it wants to make a point.

> **The habit to build now.** When you want to say *I speak*, say **hablo**. Not two words. One.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

This is not Spanish being clever. It is English having lost something. Old English marked its verbs properly — *ic sprece*, *þū sprecest*, *hē spricþ*. Those endings were as distinct as Spanish's are. Then English wore them down until almost nothing was left: today *speak, speak, speak, speak, speaks*. Four of the five are identical.
Once the endings stopped telling you who was speaking, the pronoun had to, and English could never put it down again.
Spanish kept its endings. So Spanish kept the choice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablo" — one word, and stop there
- it as an answer to a real question, as if someone just asked whether you speak

Before you move on

How many words is "I speak"? (**One** — *hablo*.) What is the name for leaving the pronoun out? (**Pro-drop**.) Why can't English do it? (Its endings wore away, so only the pronoun is left to carry the person.) Next chapter: the same verb, aimed at somebody else.

Chapter 17

Talking to a Friend

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what a friend does, using the tu form of an -ar verb.
>
> *The -as ending, and the one English ending that survives beside it.*

17.1 hablas — "you speak," to someone you know

Say "I speak." (*Hablo.*) How many words? (One.)

What to know first

- tú — the "you" for a friend, a peer, someone at ease with you.

Grammar Lens: one more letter, and it is about the other person

Last chapter the ending was **-o**, and it meant *I.*
Swap it for **-as** and the sentence turns around to face the person you are talking to:

hablar → **hablas** — *you speak.*

Same verb. Same operation — drop the **-ar**, add an ending. Only the ending changed, and with it, who the sentence is about.
This is *tú*'s form: a friend, a peer. And as before, you need no separate word for *you.* **Hablas** on its own is the whole sentence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin marked *you* with **-ās**, and Spanish kept it whole: *hablās* → **hablas**.
Here is the piece worth holding on to. English has almost no verb endings left — but it does have one. **He speak*s*.** That lonely **-s**, the last ending standing in English, comes from the very same Latin-and-Germanic habit of putting an *s* sound on a verb to mark the person.
English kept one *s* and lost the rest. Spanish kept the whole set. When you learn *hablas*, you are learning the system English is down to its last piece of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablas"
- "hablo" then "hablas," and feel the sentence turn from you to the other person

Before you move on

What is "you speak," to a friend? (**Hablas**.) Which ending means *I*, and which means *you*? (**-o** and **-as**.) Which English ending is the last survivor of this system? (The **-s** in *he speaks*.) Next chapter: the same verb again, for *usted* — and for *he* and *she*.

Chapter 18

He, She, and the Polite You

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what someone else does, and address someone respectfully, with one form.
>
> *One form doing three jobs, and the vuestra merced fossil behind it.*

18.1 habla — "he speaks," and the polite "you speak"

Two forms so far. Which means *I speak*? (*Hablo.*) Which is *you speak*, to a friend? (*Hablas.*)

Grammar Lens: take the -s away again

Drop the **-ar**, add just **-a**:

hablar → **habla** — *he speaks*, *she speaks*.

That is the third form, and the third ending: **-o**, **-as**, **-a**.

Grammar Lens: the same form does a second job

Back when you met *usted*, you were told it takes the *he/she* form of the verb. Here is the first verb where you can actually see it happen.

usted habla — *you speak*, politely.

The same word, **habla**, covers *he speaks*, *she speaks*, **and** the respectful

you speak. Nothing extra to learn — it is one form doing three jobs, and that is a gift, not a complication.
Why? Because *usted* was never a word for *you* to begin with. It grew out of *vuestra merced*, "your grace" — and *your grace* is a **thing you talk about**, not a person you talk to. You would say "your grace **speaks**," not "your grace speak." The verb form is a fossil of that politeness.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's ending here was **-at**: *hablat*, "he speaks." Spanish let the final **-t** fall away, as it let most final consonants fall away, and the bare **-a** is what was left standing.
French did the same thing and went further — it writes *parle* but the ending is now silent. Italian kept more: *parla*. Three languages, one Latin ending, three degrees of wear.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "habla"
- it for a friend's brother, then for a stranger you are being polite to — same word both times

Before you move on

What is "he speaks"? (**Habla**.) Which form does *usted* take, and why? (**Habla** — because *usted* began as *vuestra merced*, "your grace," something you talk *about*.) What did Latin's *-at* lose? (Its **-t**.) Next chapter is a review — no new words at all.

Chapter 19

Review — The Three Forms Side by Side

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can hold all three singular -ar forms at once and choose between them without stopping.
>
> *The first paradigm table in the book, arriving only after all three of its cells are owned.*

19.1 Review — the three forms, side by side

Nothing new in this chapter. Not one word. Say the three forms you already have, in any order they come.

Grammar Lens: the table you have earned

Three chapters, one form each. Now — and only now — they are worth seeing together:

who	**ending**	***hablar*** →	**meaning**
I	**-o**	**hablo**	I speak
tú	**-as**	**hablas**	you speak (a friend)
él · ella · usted	**-a**	**habla**	he/she speaks · you speak (polite)

A table like this one at the *start* would have been three things at once

and you would have memorised it. Arriving here, it is a picture of something you can already do.
This is the whole engine. Every regular **-ar** verb in Spanish — and there are thousands — runs on these three endings. You have not learned one verb. You have learned the pattern that fits all of them.

What you've built

- Say what **you** do — *hablo*.
- Ask or state what a **friend** does — *hablas*.
- Say what **someone else** does, or address someone **politely** — *habla*.
- Do all three **without a pronoun**, because the ending carries it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all three in order — "hablo, hablas, habla"
- them out of order, as prompted: *she* · *I* · *a friend* · *politely*

Twice through: Until the ending arrives before you have to think about it.

Before you move on

Three endings — name them. (**-o**, **-as**, **-a**.) How many regular *-ar* verbs does this pattern fit? (**All of them**.) Next chapter you will not learn anything either — you will *use* this to say something you actually mean.

Chapter 20

Trabajar — Work, and the Torture Device Behind It

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I do for work with a second regular -ar verb.

tripalium, a three-stake device, is why work and travail are the same word.

20.1 trabajar — "to work," and it once meant *torture*

A second **-ar** verb — snap it into the exact template you just learned. And *trabajar* has the darkest, best etymology in this chapter: it began as a word for **torture**, and it's the secret origin of English **travel**.

Sounds you'll need

- `j-jota` — the **j** is a raspy *h*-from-the-throat (the *jota*): *trabajar* = *tra-ba-**HAR***.
- `r-tap`, `b-soft` — tapped *r*, soft *b*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

trabajar comes from Vulgar Latin **tripaliāre**, *"to torture"* — from **tripalium**, a Roman instrument of torture made of **three stakes** (*tri-* "three" + *pālus* "stake," the root of English **pale** and **impale**).
The chain of meaning is grimly logical: *torture* → *torment / suffering* → *hard toil* → just **work**. And English took the very same word down a parallel road:

- **travail** — painful, laborious effort (and the pains of childbirth).
- **travel** — yes: journeying was once such an *ordeal* that "travail" (toil) became **travel** (to make a journey). Every time you *travel*, you're etymologically being *tortured*.

So even plain **trabajo**, "I work," hides the old idea of toil as torment — a dark little joke inside an everyday verb.

Grammar Lens: same -ar template

Drop **-ar**, add the ending — identical to *hablar*:

person	form	meaning
I (ending carries the subject)	**trabajo**	I work
tú	**trabajas**	you work
usted	**trabaja**	you (formal) work

Notice you didn't learn a new ending — that's the point. **One template, every regular -ar verb.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "trabajar" — *tra-ba-HAR*, raspy *j*
- "trabajo, trabajas, trabaja" — same endings as *hablo/hablas/habla*
- "trabajar" → travail → travel — torture became a journey

Before you move on

What did *trabajar* originally mean, and from what device? ("To torture," ← *tripalium*, a three-stake tool.) What two English words come from the same root? (*Travail* and *travel*.) How do you say "I work"? (*Trabajo* — same *-o* ending.) Next: **estudiar**, "to study."

Chapter 21

Estudiar — Studying Is Being Eager

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I study, with a third regular -ar verb and no new pattern.

studere, to be eager - the root under student, studio and studious.

21.1 estudiar — "to study," and the eagerness inside it

Your third **-ar** verb. By now the pattern should feel automatic — that's exactly what we want. *estudiar* also hides a nicer feeling than the classroom suggests: at root it means **eagerness.**

Sounds you'll need

- `st-no-e` — Spanish props up *st-* with an *e*: **es-tudiar** (the same reflex behind *estar*, *España*, *escuela*). *es-too-DYAR.*
- `diphthong-io` — the *-iar* glides: *es-too-**DYAR**.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estudiar comes from Latin **studēre**, *"to be eager, to apply oneself zealously."* A *studium* was **zeal, enthusiasm, devotion** — only later "study." So to *study* is, at heart, to *throw yourself eagerly* at something.

That **studēre** is everywhere in English:

- **student** — literally "one who is *eager*."
- **studio**, **studious**, **study** — the place, the trait, the act.
- Italian **studio** and the musical *studio* keep the "devoted practice" sense.

So *Estudio español* is "I *devote myself eagerly* to Spanish" — a nicer picture than mere schoolwork.

Grammar Lens: the template holds

Drop **-ar**, add the ending — for the third time:

person	form	meaning
I (ending carries the subject)	**estudio**	I study
tú	**estudias**	you study
usted	**estudia**	you (formal) study

Three verbs, one pattern: *hablo, trabajo, estudio.* The singular regular **-ar** present is now reusable rather than memorized verb by verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "estudiar" — *es-too-DYAR*
- "estudio, estudias, estudia" — the now-familiar endings
- "estudiar" then English "student, studio" — the *studēre* "eagerness"

Before you move on

What did *studēre* originally mean? ("To be eager / apply oneself.") Its English cousins? (Student, studio, studious.) Say "I study" — and notice it uses the same *-o* as *hablo* and *trabajo.* (*Estudio.*) Next: put a verb and a noun together into your **first real sentence**.

Chapter 22

Espanol, and Your First Built Sentence

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the language and build a whole sentence from parts I chose myself.
>
> *Hispania to espanol, and the first sentence assembled rather than memorised.*

22.1 español — the word for the language

You have practised writing this word's **ñ**. Now find out what is inside it — because *español* is not a Spanish-made word at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

español = "Spanish" — both the language and a Spaniard — from **Hispania**, the **Roman** name for the Iberian peninsula. The path *Hispania* → *hispaniolus* → *español* wore the word down, and there is the **ñ** again, exactly the *-ni-* squeeze you met in the writing lesson (*Hispaniolus* → *españ-ol*). Say it *es-pa-**NYOL***.
Two footnotes worth having:

- English **Spanish**, **Hispanic** and **Hispania** are all the same root, so the English and Spanish names for the language are cousins, not translations of each other.
- *Hispania* itself may go back through Latin to a **Phoenician**

name for the coast, often read as "land of hyraxes" (or rabbits) — the Phoenicians having met an unfamiliar animal and reached for the nearest word they had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "español" — *es-pa-NYOL*
- the path — "Hispania, hispaniolus, español"
- "español" then English "Hispanic" — same root

Before you move on

Where does *español* come from? (**Hispania**, the Roman name for Iberia.) What letter does its ending bring back, and from what Latin sequence? (**ñ**, from **-ni-** in *Hispaniolus*.) Next: put it behind a verb and build your first sentence.

22.2 Hablo español — your first real sentence

This is the moment this book has been building to. You take a **verb** you conjugated yourself and a **noun** you took apart yourself, and make a sentence **nobody handed you pre-assembled**.

What you've built — the sentence assembled

Snap two things you already own together:

> **Hablo** (I speak, from *hablar*) + **español** (Spanish) = **Hablo español.**

That is a complete, grammatical Spanish sentence, and notice what is **not** in it: no separate subject word. The *-o* of *hablo* already says "I" — the pro-drop you just learned, doing real work in a real sentence. Now swap the pieces and watch it generate:

- **Estudio español.** — "I study Spanish."

- **Trabajo.** — "I work."
- **¿Hablas español?** — "Do you speak Spanish?" (the **¿ ?** pair opening and closing the question, as in the writing lesson).

Grammar Lens: languages go bare

One more thing missing from *hablo español*: **no "the," no "a."** After a verb like *hablar* or *estudiar*, a language name takes **no article** — *hablo español*, never *hablo el español*.
This matters because Spanish otherwise loves its articles far more than English does (*me gusta* ***el*** *café*, "I like coffee"). So this is a genuine exception you have to hold onto, and the rule of thumb is narrow: right after *hablar*, the language goes bare.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Hablo español" — *AH-bloh es-pa-NYOL*
- swap the verb — "Estudio español", "Trabajo"
- ask it — "¿Hablas español?" (raise the pitch; ¿ opens it)

Why it's said this way

You met **no** long ago as the answer. It has a second job, and now you have a sentence to try it on: put *no* directly in front of the verb and the whole thing flips.
Hablo español → No hablo español.
That is all there is to it. English needs a helper — *do not* — and Spanish needs nothing: one small word, in front, and the sentence means its opposite.

Before you move on

Say "I speak Spanish," then "I study Spanish." (*Hablo español; estudio español.*) Why is there no separate subject word? (The *-o* ending carries "I.") Why no "the" before *español*? (**Languages take no article** after a verb like *hablar*.) You just built a sentence from parts — that is the whole game from here.

Chapter 23

-cion — About Two Thousand Words, At Once

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can turn an English -tion word into Spanish and know its gender without being told.
>
> *Complete ES-C56-cion: convert an English -tion word, give the gender, and say why the correspondence is a rule.*

23.1 -ción — about two thousand words, at once

You have learned roughly twenty Spanish words so far. This chapter is going to hand you about two thousand more, and it is not a trick.

Sounds you'll need

- `ci-th-s` — *ci* is a soft sound: *th* in most of Spain, *s* across Latin America. *Nación* is *na-SYON* or *na-THYON*, never *na-KYON*.

Grammar Lens: an ending that translates itself

Spanish *-ción* is English *-tion*.

Not "often." Not "sometimes." As a rule:

nación → nation · *información* → information · *educación* → education *conversación* → conversation · *nación* → nation · *atención* → attention

Read those without the English column and you can still read them. **And every single one is feminine**, without exception — *la nación*, *la información*. One ending, one gender, no decision to make. That alone is worth the chapter: gender is the thing this book will otherwise ask you to learn word by word.
So: take almost any English word ending in *-tion*, swap the ending for *-ción*, and you have said something real. You will be right far more often than you are wrong, and when you are wrong you will still be understood.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The reason this works is not luck, and it is worth knowing so you trust the rule rather than half-trusting it.
Latin had an ending **-tiōnem** that turned a verb into a noun for the act of doing it. Spanish **inherited** it directly, wearing it down to *-ción*. English **borrowed** it — first from French after 1066, then straight from Latin for centuries afterwards — and kept it as *-tion*.
Same ending, two routes, and the routes did not change it much. That is why the correspondence is a rule and not a resemblance: these are not similar words, they are **the same word**, arriving from two directions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "nación, información, educación" — hear the ending stay put
- an English *-tion* word of your own, converted

Before you move on

English *-tion* becomes? (***-ción***.) What gender? (**Feminine**, always.) And roughly how many words did that just give you? (About **two thousand**.) Next: another ending, and another twelve hundred.

Chapter 24

-dad — Twelve Hundred More

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read a -dad word I have never met, and say why it looks less like its English partner.

Complete ES-C56-dad: convert university, read realidad unseen, and explain the uneven erosion.

24.1 -dad — twelve hundred more

-ción is *-tion*. Here is a second ending, and this one is harder to spot because the two languages wore it down by different amounts.

Sounds you'll need

- `d-soft` — the *d* between vowels is soft, close to English *th* in *this*: *ciudad* ends nearer *-dath* than *-dad*.

Grammar Lens: -dad is -ty

Spanish *-dad* (or *-tad*) is English *-ty*.

ciudad → city · *libertad* → liberty · *universidad* → university *realidad* → reality · *dificultad* → difficulty · *sociedad* → society

This one does not announce itself the way *-ción* does. *Ciudad* and *city* do not look alike at a glance — but line the endings up and the rule is exact, and once you have seen it you cannot unsee it.

Feminine again, every time: *la ciudad*, *la libertad*. That is now two endings that carry their own gender, which between them cover a large slice of the abstract nouns in the language.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **-tātem** made a noun meaning *the quality of being* something. Spanish inherited it and wore it to **-dad**: the *t* softened to *d* between vowels, exactly as it does in the middle of *ciudad* today. English took it through French, where it had already worn much further — *-tātem* to *-té* to **-ty**.

So English is holding a shorter stub of the same ending. That is why this pair looks less alike than *-ción*/*-tion*: not a different relationship, just more erosion on the English side.

Which gives you a way to read the ones you have not met. See a Spanish word ending in *-dad* and you are looking at an abstract quality, and English almost certainly has the same word with a smaller tail.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ciudad, libertad, universidad" — the same tail three times
- "city, liberty, university" straight after, and hear the shorter tail

Before you move on

English *-ty* becomes? (***-dad***.) Gender? (**Feminine**.) And what does a *-dad* word always name? (**A quality** — the state of being something.) Next: an ending you can put on almost any adjective.

Chapter 25

-mente — With No Upper Limit

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build an adverb from any adjective, and say why the adjective goes feminine first.
>
> *Complete ES-C56-mente: build rapidamente, explain the feminine step, and say what the word literally means.*

25.1 -mente — with no upper limit

Two endings so far, and each was worth a fixed number of words. This one has **no number**, because you can make it yourself.

Grammar Lens: -mente is -ly

Spanish *-mente* is English *-ly*.

rápidamente → rapidly · *claramente* → clearly · *perfectamente* → perfectly · *naturalmente* → naturally

And unlike the last two endings, this one is a **machine** rather than a list: take an adjective, put it in its **feminine** form, add *-mente*.

rápido → *rápida* → **rápidamente** *claro* → *clara* → **claramente**

That feminine step looks arbitrary and is not — the next section says why. But the practical effect is that every adjective you ever learn comes with a free adverb, which is why this ending has no count attached. Its reach is however many adjectives you end up knowing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

-mente is not an ending at all, historically. It is the Latin noun **mente**, "with a mind" — and *mente* is **feminine**, which is the whole explanation for that feminine adjective.

Latin said *clārā mente*, "with a clear mind," and the adjective agreed with the noun because that is what adjectives do. Then the phrase fused, the noun stopped being a noun, and the agreement was left behind as a rule nobody could explain any more.

So *rápidamente* is, at the bottom, **"with a rapid mind."** Every Spanish adverb in *-mente* is quietly a phrase about somebody's state of mind.

English does exactly the same thing with a different body part. **-ly** is Old English *-līce*, from *līc*, "body, form" — so *clearly* is "in a clear form." Two languages, two fused nouns, the same idea.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "rápido, rápida, rápidamente" — watch the feminine step
- "claramente" and hear "with a clear mind" underneath it

Before you move on

English *-ly* becomes? (***-mente***.) What do you do to the adjective first? (Make it **feminine**.) And why? (Because ***mente*** was a **feminine noun** meaning *mind*.) Next: the three of them together.

Chapter 26

Review — Three Endings

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the three endings, their partners, and which give gender for free.
>
> *Complete ES-C56-repaso-amigos: give the three pairs and distinguish a decoder from a machine.*

26.1 Review — three endings

Nothing new here. Say the three endings and their English partners before you look.

What you've built

Spanish	English	gender	roughly how many
-ción	-tion	feminine	~2,000
-dad / -tad	-ty	feminine	~1,200
-mente	-ly	(adverb)	no limit

Three chapters. Between them they reach further than every vocabulary lesson in this book put together, and they will keep reaching for as long as you keep learning adjectives.

That is worth stating plainly, because it changes what you should expect from the rest of the book. **A Spanish course is not mostly a list of words.** A large part of it is a small number of rules that turn words you already own into words you can use — and you have just

been handed three of the biggest.

Grammar Lens: two kinds of ending

The three are not the same kind of thing, and the difference matters:

- ***-ción*** and ***-dad*** are **decoders**. They let you *read* a word you have never met. They have a fixed reach, because there are only so many English words with those endings.
- ***-mente*** is a **machine**. It lets you *build* a word nobody taught you, from any adjective you hold. Its reach is whatever your adjective vocabulary turns out to be.

Both kinds are worth having, and neither is a substitute for the other. A decoder gets you through a page; a machine gets you through a sentence you have to say yourself.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "nación, ciudad, rápidamente" — one of each

Twice through:

Before you move on

Three endings — name them. (***-ción, -dad, -mente***.) Which two are always feminine? (***-ción*** and ***-dad***.) Which one has no upper limit? (***-mente***.) Next: reading a sentence nobody taught you.

Chapter 27

Synthesis — Reading What You Were Never Taught

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a sentence containing words no lesson has taught me.
>
> *Complete ES-C56-sintesis-leer: read a four-new-word sentence and say what let you read it.*

27.1 Synthesis — reading what you were never taught

> You are about to read a sentence with four words in it that this book has never shown you. Read it before you read the explanation.

The exchange

> *La* ***universidad*** *tiene una* ***reputación internacional****,* ***naturalmente****.*

Say it aloud. Then say what it means.

The university has an international reputation, naturally.

Now count what you were given. **Four of those words are new**, and you read all four:

- *universidad* — *-dad* is *-ty.*

- *reputación* — *-ción* is *-tion*.
- *internacional* — a plain friend; it needed no rule at all.
- *naturalmente* — *-mente* is *-ly*.

Three chapters of endings, and a sentence of adult Spanish came free.

Grammar Lens: what has actually changed

Something is different about this chapter and it is worth naming. Every other lesson so far has taught you a word or a form and then asked you to use it. This one asked you to read words **nobody taught you**, and you could, because a rule reaches further than a word. That is the shape of the rest of your Spanish, and it is worth expecting. You will keep learning individual words — there is no way around *casa* or *comer* — but the reading you can do will run far ahead of the words you were handed, as long as you keep collecting rules alongside them. **A warning that costs nothing.** These endings are reliable, not perfect. A few words wearing a familiar ending have drifted somewhere unexpected, and you will meet them later as **false friends** — memorable precisely because the rule is otherwise so dependable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole sentence, twice
- the four new words alone, and name the rule that gave you each

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many words in that sentence were new? (**Four**.) What let you read them? (**Three endings**.) And what does that tell you about the rest of the book? (That **rules reach further than words** — collect both.)

Chapter 28

F to H — Why the H Says Nothing

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can decode an unfamiliar h- word by putting an f back, and say why the h is silent.
>
> *Complete ES-C57-f-a-h: say why the h is silent, name hablar's English friend, and decode hierro unseen.*

28.1 f → h — why the h says nothing

Since your first chapter you have known that the Spanish *h* is silent. You were told it as a fact. Here is the reason, and it turns the fact into a tool.

Grammar Lens: a letter standing on a grave

> **Where Spanish has a silent *h-*, Latin very often had an *f-*.**

You already hold the proof. *Hablar* comes from Latin **fabulārī** — and English took the same root and kept the *f*: **fable**, **fabulous**.

> *hablar* ← *fabulārī* → **fable**

The sound did not vanish overnight. Latin *f-* weakened to a breathy *h*, the breath faded, and eventually nothing was left — but the spelling had already settled, so Spanish went on writing a letter it had stopped saying. **The silent *h* is a gravestone.** It marks where a sound used to be.

Which makes it a decoder. Meet an unfamiliar Spanish word beginning with *h-*, put an *f* back, and look for the English:

Spanish	**put the f back**	**English friend**
hijo	*fijo* ← *fīlium*	**filial**, **affiliate**
hierro	*fierro* ← *ferrum*	**ferrous**, **ferric**
harina	*farina*	**farinaceous**
higo	*figo* ← *fīcus*	**fig**
hoja	*foja* ← *folia*	**foliage**, **portfolio**

Not one of those five words has been taught in this book, and you can read all five.

Why it's said this way

Two honest limits, because a decoder you trust too far will mislead you. **Not every *h* is a dead *f*.** *Hola* is not, and *hasta* came from Arabic. **And not every Latin *f* became *h*.** *Fácil*, *fuerte* and *forma* kept theirs; the change left *f* alone before *ue* and *r*.
So this is a **lead**, not a guarantee. Put the *f* back and believe it when an English word appears.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablar" then "fable" — the same word, one letter apart
- "hijo, hierro, hoja" and put the *f* back on each

Before you move on

Why is the *h* silent? (It stands where an ***f*** used to be.) What do you do with an unfamiliar *h-* word? (**Put the *f* back** and look for the English.) Is it always right? (**No** — a lead, not a guarantee.)

Chapter 29

Cl-, Pl-, Fl- to Ll-

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can try three Latin clusters on an unfamiliar ll- word and find the English cousin.
>
> *Complete ES-C57-ll: name llamar's cousins, give the three clusters, and decode llave.*

29.1 cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-

Say "my name is." (*Me llamo.*) That *ll-* is the second sound law of this book, and you have been using it since your third chapter without being told.

Grammar Lens: three clusters, one destination

Latin *cl-*, *pl-* and *fl-* all became Spanish *ll-*.

Llamar is Latin **clāmāre**, "to cry out." English took the same root untouched: **claim**, **clamour**, **proclaim**, **exclaim**.

llamar ← *clāmāre* → **claim**, **clamour**

And it happened to all three clusters, which is what makes it a law rather than a one-off:

Spanish	from	English cousin
llamar	*clāmāre*	**claim**, **clamour**
llave	*clāvem*	**clavicle**, **clef**, **conclave**
llover	*plovere*	**pluvial**
lleno	*plēnum*	**plenty**, **plenary**
llano	*plānum*	**plain**, **plane**
llama	*flamma*	**flame**, **inflammable**

Three different starting points arriving at one sound is unusual, and it is useful precisely because it is untidy: an unfamiliar Spanish word in *ll-* has **three** English shapes to try, and one of them is very often right.

Why it's said this way

You now hold three sound laws, and they are not three facts. They are three instances of the same thing.

- *-ct-* → *-ch-* — *noctem* → *noche*, and English kept **nocturnal**.
- *f-* → *h-* — *fabulārī* → *hablar*, and English kept **fable**.
- *cl-*, *pl-*, *fl-* → *ll-* — *clāmāre* → *llamar*, and English kept **clamour**.

Every one has the same shape: **Spanish inherited the word and wore it down; English borrowed it later and left it closer to the Latin.** That is why the English cousin so often looks more Latin than the Spanish does, which feels backwards until you see why.
So the laws are not trivia about the past. They are a **conversion table** between the Spanish in front of you and the English already in your head, and they will keep working on words no course will ever teach you.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "llamar" then "clamour"; "llave" then "clavicle"; "llama" then "flame"

Before you move on

Which three clusters became *ll*-? (***cl-***, ***pl-***, ***fl-***.) What is *llamar*'s English cousin? (**Claim**.) And why does the English usually look more Latin? (Spanish **inherited and wore it down**; English **borrowed it later**.)

Chapter 30

Es- — the Vowel Spanish Put in Front

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can strip the e- from a Spanish word beginning es- plus a consonant and recognise the English word underneath.
>
> *Decode estacion, estudiante and espacio by taking the e- off the front.*

30.1 es- + consonant

Say "to be" — the one about how and where. (*Estar.*) Now say "to study." (*Estudiar.*)

You have known both since your first chapters. Today they explain each other.

Grammar Lens: a word cannot start like that

Latin words beginning *s* + a consonant grew an *e-* in front.

Latin was happy to start a word with *st-*, *sp-* or *sc-*. Spanish was not — the mouth wants a vowel there — so it put one in.

stāre → **es**tar · *studēre* → **es**tudiar

Nothing was added to the meaning. A vowel was added to the *front*, because the alternative was a beginning Spanish could not say.

English borrowed the very same Latin words and never needed the vowel:

Spanish	**from**	**English kept it bare**
estar	*stāre*	**state**, **stay**, **status**
estudiar	*studēre*	**study**, **student**, **studio**
escuela	*schola*	**school**, **scholar**
especial	*speciālis*	**special**, **species**
espíritu	*spīritus*	**spirit**

So the rule runs in both directions, and the backwards one is the useful one: **take the *e-* off the front, and an English word is often standing there.**

Your turn

Take the *e-* off and say what you see.

Say these aloud:

- *estación* → **st**ación → **station**
- *estudiante* → **st**udiante → **student**
- *espacio* → **sp**acio → **space**

Estación took two rules at once: the *e-* came off the front, and the *-ción* you learned seven chapters ago became *-tion* at the back. That is what these rules are for — they stack.

Why it's said this way

A word you would expect to fit, and it does not.
Español looks like a perfect example. It is not. Its *Es-* is not an added vowel — it is what is left of Latin ***Hispānia***, whose *H* was already silent. *España* is *Hispania* with the *h* gone, not *spaña* with an *e* glued on.
So check before you claim one. The rule is about words that *began* with two consonants in Latin. When the *e* was there all along, there is nothing to take off.

Before you move on

Say the rule in your own words.
Then take the *e-* off *estilo* and say the English word you find.
(*Style.*)

Chapter 31

Synthesis — The Decoder

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can decode unfamiliar Spanish with three sound laws and three endings.
>
> *Complete ES-C57-sintesis-descifrar: decode hoja and lleno, read a two-ending phrase, and say what a word that resists every rule suggests.*

31.1 Synthesis — the decoder

Four sound laws and three endings. Before the practice: what do you do with an unfamiliar word starting *h-*? One starting *ll-*? One starting *es-*?

What you've built

what you see	what to try	example
-ch-	Latin *-ct-*	*noche* → **nocturnal**
h-	put an *f* back	*hijo* → **filial**
ll-	try *cl-*, *pl-*, *fl-*	*llave* → **clavicle**
es- + consonant	take the *e-* off	*escuela* → **school**
-ción	*-tion*	*nación* → **nation**
-dad	*-ty*	*ciudad* → **city**
-mente	*-ly*	*claramente* → **clearly**

Seven rules, and between them they will get you through a great deal of written Spanish this book has no room to teach. They also **stack**:

estación gives up both ends at once.

Grammar Lens: what a decoder is not

Be exact about what you have, because overclaiming it will disappoint you at the worst moment. This is a **reading** tool, and mostly a first-guess one: it will not tell you how to say something, will not give you gender or conjugation, and will sometimes point at the wrong English word.

What it does is remove the feeling that an unfamiliar Spanish word is a wall. Usually it is not — it is a word you already know, wearing clothes you have learned to recognise. That change of expectation is worth more than any word in this chapter: it is what lets you read above your level and get most of it.

And when the decoder fails, that is information too. A word that resists every rule is usually from one of Spanish's non-Latin layers — Arabic, Basque, or the Americas — worth noticing precisely because it breaks a rule you hold.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the seven rules, in order
- "hoja, lleno, noche" and name the law behind each

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many rules do you now hold? (**Seven** — four laws and three endings.) What are they for? (**Reading**, mostly first guesses.) And what has really changed? (An unfamiliar word is **no longer a wall**.)

Chapter 32

Synthesis — The Same Conversation, Twice

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can hold one short conversation both warmly and respectfully, changing only the verb ending.

The register choice carried entirely by one letter - and now with something real to say.

32.1 Synthesis — the same conversation, twice

Nothing new in this chapter either. This one is for **using** what you have — because knowing three endings is not the same as choosing the right one while a real person waits for you to finish.

Grammar Lens: what the ending is really saying

You are going to hold one short conversation twice — once with someone your own age, once with someone you want to show respect to. The **words** barely change. What changes is **one letter on the end of one verb**.
That letter is the whole message. *Hablas* says *I am at ease with you.* *Habla* says *I am being careful with you.* English would need a change of tone, or a "sir." Spanish does it with an **-s**.

The exchange — with a friend

> — ¡Hola! Me llamo Ana. — Me llamo David. Mucho gusto. — ¿**Hablas** español? — Sí, **hablo** español. ¡Gracias!

The exchange, again — being polite

> — Buenos días. Me llamo Ana. — Me llamo David. Mucho gusto. — ¿**Habla** usted español? — Sí, **hablo** español. Gracias.

One letter. *Hablas* became *habla*, and the whole exchange changed its temperature. Your own line — *hablo* — never moved, because *you* are still you in both conversations.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- version one, both parts, start to finish
- version two — and catch the single letter that moved

Twice through: Run whichever version is harder.

Before you move on

What is the *only* thing that changed between the two conversations? (**One letter** — *hablas* → *habla*.) Why did *hablo* stay the same? (Because it is about **you**, and you did not change.) What does choosing *habla* over *hablas* actually tell the other person? (That you are being **respectful** — the grammar is carrying the manners.)

Chapter 33

Putting the -ar Verbs to Work

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use several -ar verbs in real sentences.

The -ar present tense in action across the verbs of the last chapters.

33.1 Practice — making sentences with -ar verbs

A milestone chapter: for the first time you're not reciting fixed phrases, you're **building sentences from a pattern**. Drill the three verbs through the endings until *hablo / hablas / habla* is automatic.

Grammar Lens: conjugate on command

Run each verb through the three singular jobs you know: the ending alone for **I** → **tú** → **usted**:

- **hablar**: hablo · hablas · habla
- **trabajar**: trabajo · trabajas · trabaja
- **estudiar**: estudio · estudias · estudia

Same three endings (**-o / -as / -a**) every time — that's the whole regular **-ar** present, singular.

The exchange — say something real

— ¿**Hablas** español? — **Hablo español.** — ¿**Estudias** español? — **Estudio español.** — **Café, por favor.** — ¡Gracias! — De nada.

What you've built this chapter

- **por favor** — please (← "for a favour"), completing gracias / de nada / por favor.
- **the singular regular -ar pattern** — drop *-ar*, add **-o / -as / -a**: the template behind *hablar, trabajar,* and *estudiar.*
- **hablar** (← *fābula*, fable; the f→h law), **trabajar** (← *tripalium*, torture → travail/travel), **estudiar** (← *studēre*, eagerness → student).
- **Hablo español** — your first self-assembled sentence (pro-drop, no article).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three verbs for I / tú / usted, without stopping
- answer "¿Hablas español?" and "¿Estudias español?" about yourself
- request "Café, por favor" and run the full gracias/de nada loop

Twice through: Ask and answer "¿Hablas español? — Hablo español."

Before you move on

What are the three singular *-ar* endings? (*-o / -as / -a.*) Give the "I" form of all three verbs. (*Hablo, trabajo, estudio.*) Why does *Hablo español* need no separate subject word? (The *-o* carries "I.") You can now generate sentences — this book stops handing you phrases and starts handing you *rules.* Next chapter adds the *-er/-ir* verb families.

Chapter 34

Comer — the Second Verb Family, One Slot at a Time

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 4 of 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use all three singular forms of a regular -er verb, having built each one separately.
>
> *The -er singular, earned a slot at a time - and the yo ending that never changed.*

34.1 comer — "to eat," and the second verb family

Last chapter you learned the **-ar** verbs. Spanish has two more families — **-er** and **-ir** — and here's the good news: they're **almost the same**. Meet **comer** ("to eat"), your first **-er** verb.

Sounds you'll need

- `r-tap` — one soft tap: *ko-**MER**.*
- The *c* before *o* is a hard *k*: *comer* = *ko-MER.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comer derives from Latin **comedere**, *"to eat up"* — **com-** (intensifier, "completely") + **edere**, "to eat." That **edere** is the twin of English **eat** (both from the same ancient root), and it feeds a small English family:

- **edible** — fit to be eaten.
- **comestible** — a fancy word for food (straight from *comedere*).
- English **eat** itself — the Germanic cousin of Latin *edere*.

Grammar Lens: one family over, and one ending already yours

Hablar ended in **-ar**. *Comer* ends in **-er**, and that single letter is what makes it a different family.
Here is the good news, and it is worth having before you meet a single new form: **the *yo* ending does not change.** *Hablar* gave *habl**o***. *Comer* will give *com**o***. The ending you already own works untouched. Only two slots in this family behave differently from the one you know, and you will meet them one at a time over the next three chapters — not here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "comer" — *ko-MER*
- "comer" then English "edible, comestible, eat" — the *edere* family

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *comer* from, and its English cousins? (*Comedere* ← *edere* — edible, eat.) Which ending is the same in both families? (The **yo** ending, **-o**.) Next: the *yo* form — and it will cost you nothing.

34.2 como — "I eat," and you already knew how

How do you say "I speak"? (*Hablo.*) And what is the verb for "to eat"? (*Comer.*)

Grammar Lens: the ending that did not change

Drop the **-er**, add **-o**:

comer → **como** — *I eat.*

That is the same operation and the same ending you used on *hablar*. A new verb family, and the *yo* slot cost you nothing at all.
This is worth pausing on, because it is how most of the rest will go. Spanish's three families differ in **two** of their singular slots, never in the first one. Whatever the verb, "I" is **-o**.
And as before, one word is the whole sentence: **como**. No pronoun.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

One warning, because this word is busy. **Como** is three things:

- **como** — *I eat*, the form you just built.
- **como** — *like*, *as*. (*Como tú* — "like you.")
- **cómo**, with the accent — *how?*, which you have used since your first conversations.

Same four letters, three jobs. The accent marks the question word; context sorts the other two. This is not a trap so much as a reminder that the accent in Spanish is doing real work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablo" then "como" — the same ending, twice
- "como" alone, as a complete sentence

Before you move on

How do you say "I eat"? (**Como**.) Which slot never changes between verb families? (The **yo** slot — always **-o**.) What does *cómo* with an accent mean? (**How?**) Next: the slot that *does* change.

34.3 comes — "you eat," and the first real difference

Say "I eat." (*Como*.) Now say "you speak," to a friend. (*Hablas*.)

Grammar Lens: one vowel moves

In the *-ar* family, *tú* took **-as**. Here it takes **-es**:

comer → **comes** — *you eat.*

That is the whole difference. The **-s** that means *you* is still there, doing the same job it does in *hablas*. Only the vowel in front of it has moved from **a** to **e** — and it moved because the verb's own family vowel is **e**. The ending is agreeing with the family it belongs to.
So you are not learning a new ending so much as watching a familiar one take on the colour of its surroundings.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin had *amās* for "you love" and *comedis* for "you eat" — different vowels in the ending, exactly as Spanish has now. The split is not a Spanish invention; it is inherited, and it is why the families exist at all. What every one of them kept, across two thousand years, is the **-s**. If a Spanish verb form ends in *-s*, it is talking to *tú*. That single rule will carry you through every tense in this book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablas" then "comes" — the same *-s*, a different vowel
- "como" then "comes" — and feel the sentence turn toward the other person

Before you move on

What is "you eat," to a friend? (**Comes**.) What part of the ending is the same as in *hablas*? (The **-s**.) What changed, and why? (The vowel, to match the verb's own family.) Next: the last of the three.

34.4 come — "he eats," and the polite "you eat"

Say "you eat," to a friend. (*Comes.*) And what was the *usted* form of *hablar*? (*Habla.*)

Grammar Lens: take the -s off again

Drop the **-er**, add **-e**:

> **comer** → **come** — *he eats*, *she eats*, and **usted come**, *you eat*, politely.

The relationship is the one you already know. In the *-ar* family, *hablas* became *habla* by losing its **-s**. Here *comes* becomes *come* the same way. And exactly as before, this one form does three jobs — *he*, *she*, and the respectful *you* — for the same reason it did last time: *usted* began life as *vuestra merced*, a thing you talk **about**.
Three slots, three chapters, and the shape of the family is now yours.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's form here was *comedit*. Spanish let the final **-t** fall, precisely as it let it fall from *hablat* to give *habla*.
That is the useful part: the two families were not worn down by different forces. The same weather hit both. Which is why, once you know what happened to one, the other holds no surprises.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "habla" then "come" — the same move, one family over
- "come" for a friend's sister, then for a stranger you are being polite to

Before you move on

What is "she eats"? (**Come**.) How did it come from *comes*? (By losing the **-s**, exactly as *hablas* → *habla*.) What did Latin's *comedit* lose? (Its **-t**.) A short review closes this chapter; the third and last family follows.

34.5 Review — the -er family, all three

Nothing new. Say the three forms of *comer* you have built, in any order they come to you.

Grammar Lens: the table you have earned

Three slots, three lessons. Now they are worth seeing beside the family you already had:

who	***-ar***	***-er***	
I	-o	**-o**	*hablo* · **como**
tú	-as	**-es**	*hablas* · **comes**
él · ella · usted	-a	**-e**	*habla* · **come**

Read the middle two columns down and the whole *-er* family is one observation: **the *yo* slot is shared, and the other two swap a for e.**
That is the entire cost of a second verb family. Every regular *-er* verb in Spanish runs on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "como, comes, come" straight through
- "hablo, como" · "hablas, comes" · "habla, come" — the two families in step

Twice through:

Before you move on

Give the three *-er* endings. (**-o, -es, -e**.) Which one matches *-ar* exactly? (The **yo** ending.) How many regular *-er* verbs does this fit? (**All of them**.) Next chapter: the third family, and it is the smallest change yet.

Chapter 35

Vivir — the Family That Costs Nothing

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the singular of a regular -ir verb, and say why it asked me to learn no new form.
>
> *In the singular the -ir endings ARE the -er endings; the families part company only in the plural.*

35.1 vivir — "to live," and the third family (that's barely new)

The third and last verb family: **-ir**, and **vivir** ("to live") is your first. Here's the punchline — in the present tense, **-ir is almost identical to -er**. You've nearly finished learning the whole regular present.

Sounds you'll need

- `v-b` — Spanish *v* = a soft *b*: *vivir* ≈ *bee-BEER*.
- `r-tap` — one tap on the final *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vivir comes from Latin **vīvere**, *"to live"* — one of the most alive roots in English:

- **vivid** — "full of life."
- **survive** (*super-vīvere*, "to live beyond"), **revive** ("live again").
- **vivacious**, **convivial** ("living together" — sociable), **viva!**, **vivarium**. (And *vīta*, "life," gives **vital**, **vitamin**.)

Grammar Lens: the family that costs nothing

The third family is the shortest lesson in this book, and it is short because of a fact rather than a shortcut.
In the singular, the *-ir* endings are the *-er* endings. Not similar. The same three:

> **vivo** · **vives** · **vive** — *-o*, *-es*, *-e*, exactly as *como*, *comes*, *come*.

So the third family asks you to learn no new form at all. You already built these three endings one at a time in the last chapter; here they are, doing the same work on a different verb.
The two families do part company later, in the plural — and when they do, you will meet that difference on its own. It is not needed now, and mentioning it here would be borrowing trouble.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "vivir" — *bee-BEER*
- "como, comes, come" then "vivo, vives, vive" — identical endings
- "vivir" then English "vivid, survive, revive" — the *vīvere* family

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *vivir* from, and two English cousins? (*vīvere* — vivid, survive.) In the singular, how do *-er* and *-ir* endings compare? (They are **identical**: *-o* / *-es* / *-e*.) Say "I live." (*Vivo*.) Next: a second verb in this family, and two words for asking questions.

Chapter 36

Beber, and Two Ways to Ask

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I drink, and ask what and where with que and donde.
>
> *A second -er verb that needs no new pattern, and the two question words that turn the forms outward.*

36.1 beber — "to drink," and the pattern is yours

One more **-er** verb to make the pattern automatic — **beber**, "to drink." Pair it with *comer* and you can talk about eating and drinking, the heart of any café or restaurant.

Sounds you'll need

- `v-b` — both *b*'s are the soft Spanish *b*: *be-**BER***.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

beber comes from Latin **bibere**, *"to drink"* — a thirsty little root that soaked into English:

- **beverage** — a drink (via Old French *bevrage*, from *bibere*).
- **imbibe** — to drink in (*in-* + *bibere*).
- **bibulous** — fond of drinking; **bib** — the cloth that catches drips; even **beer**'s cousins hover nearby.

Grammar Lens: no new grammar — that's the point

beber is a regular **-er** verb, so it takes the endings you already own:
yo	**bebo**	I drink
tú	**bebes**	you drink
él/ella/usted	**bebe**	he/she drinks / you (formal) drink
Nothing new to learn — you're just *reusing the machine*. With the word *café* from the previous chapter, you can already say:

> **Bebo café.** — "I drink coffee."

One new verb, one known noun, one sentence you built yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "beber" — *be-BER*
- "bebo, bebes, bebe" — the familiar *-o/-es/-e*
- "Bebo café" — "I drink coffee"

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *beber* from, and its English cousins? (*bibere* — beverage, imbibe.) Did *beber* need any new endings? (No — it's a regular *-er* verb.) Say "I drink." (*Bebo.*) Next: start **asking** — *qué*, "what?"

36.2 qué — "what", a new question word

You already know the question word *cómo*; now ask about a thing. The new question word is **qué**, "what" — and it puts to work two things from your writing chapter: the **accent** and the **¿ ?**.

Sounds you'll need

- `k-hard` — **qu** is a plain hard **k** (the *u* is silent): *qué* = *keh.*
- `accent-mark` — the **accent on *é*** marks this as the *question*

word (recall the diacrítica: *qué* = "what?"; *que* = "that"). Question words wear the accent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

qué comes from Latin **quid**, *"what"* — the neuter of *quis*, "who." It's a small function word with a few learned English descendants:

- **quiddity** — the "what-ness," the essence of a thing.
- **quid pro quo** — "*what* for *what*," this for that.
- the *qu-* question family it heads in Spanish: *qué, quién* (who), *cuál* (which) — Latin's *qu-* interrogatives, the same *wh-* instinct as English (Latin *qu-* and English *wh-* are ancient cousins).

Grammar Lens: asking with a verb you know

Put **qué** in front of a verb, wrap it in **¿ ?**, and you have a real question:

> **¿Qué comes?** — "What are you eating? / What do you eat?" **¿Qué bebes?** — "What are you drinking?"

Remember the opening **¿** (from the writing lesson) warns the reader a question is coming; the accent on *qué* marks it as the question word. Answer with the verb you already conjugate and a noun you already know: *Bebo café.* ("I drink coffee.")

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "qué" — *keh*, silent *u*
- "¿Qué comes?" / "¿Qué bebes?" — ask with verbs you know
- "qué" vs "que" — the accent marks the *question*

Before you move on

What Latin word is *qué* from? (*quid* — quiddity, quid pro quo.) Why does *qué* carry an accent? (It's the *question* word; *que* without

= "that.") Ask "what are you eating?" (*¿Qué comes?*) Next: asking **where** — *dónde*.

36.3 dónde — "where?"

One more question word, and one more real question you can build: **dónde**, "where?" Pair it with *vivir* and you can ask the single most common getting-to-know-you question: *where do you live?*

Sounds you'll need

- `d-soft` — the middle *d* is soft, near the *th* of *this*: *DON-deh*.
- `accent-mark` — like *qué*, the **accent on *ó*** marks the question word (*dónde* = "where?"; *donde* without = "where," a relative — "the place *where*").

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dónde comes from Latin **de unde**, literally *"from whence." unde* meant "from where," and Spanish glued *de* onto the front and wore the pair down to *dónde*. (English once had the matching set *whence / where / whither* — "from where / at where / to where"; Spanish keeps that flavour in *de dónde* "from where", *dónde* "where", *adónde* "to where".)

Grammar Lens: your first getting-to-know-you questions

Two question words + verbs you own = real conversation:

> **¿Dónde vives?** — "Where do you live?" → *Vivo en Madrid.* **¿Dónde trabajas?** — "Where do you work?"
> **¿Qué estudias?** — "What do you study?"

Notice the little **en** ("in," ← Latin *in*) in the answer — the first preposition, slipping in exactly where you need it. You're now trading real questions and answers, not fixed phrases.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "dónde" — *DON-deh*, soft *d*
- "¿Dónde vives?" — "Where do you live?"
- answer — "Vivo en …" with your city

Before you move on

What Latin phrase is *dónde* from, and what did it mean? (*De unde* — "from whence.") Why the accent? (It marks the *question* word.) Ask "where do you live?" and answer it. (*¿Dónde vives? — Vivo en …*) Next: put the questions and verbs together in practice.

36.4 Practice — asking real questions

You now have all three verb families **and** two question words. This is where it becomes a conversation: you can **ask** and **answer**, not just recite. Drill until the questions come without thinking.

Grammar Lens: three singular patterns

Conjugate *yo* → *tú* → *él/ella* — feel how little differs:

- **-ar** *hablar*: hablo · hablas · habla
- **-er** *comer*: como · comes · come
- **-ir** *vivir*: vivo · vives · vive

Endings: *-ar* → -o/-as/-a; *-er* and *-ir* → **-o/-es/-e** in these three singular forms. The plural forms can wait.

The exchange — use only what you know

— ¿**Dónde vives**? — **Vivo** en Sevilla. ¿Y tú? — **Vivo** en México. — ¿**Qué estudias**? — **Estudio** español. ¿**Qué bebes**? — **Bebo** café.

What you've built this chapter

- **comer / beber** (-er), **vivir** (-ir) — the two remaining verb families; singular endings **-o / -es / -e**.
- **qué** (← *quid*) and **dónde** (← *de unde*) — your first question words, each wearing the **accent** and opening with **¿**.
- **Real questions**: *¿Qué comes? ¿Dónde vives? ¿Dónde trabajas?* — and the first preposition, **en** ("in"), in the answers.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three families, yo/tú/él, back to back
- ask a friend where they live and what they drink; answer both
- ask what they study; answer "Estudio español"

Twice through: "¿Dónde vives? — Vivo en … ¿Y tú?"

Before you move on

What are the singular endings for *-er/-ir* verbs? (*-o / -es / -e.*) Give the "I" forms of *comer, vivir, beber.* (*Como, vivo, bebo.*) Ask "what do you study?" and "where do you live?" (*¿Qué estudias? ¿Dónde vives?*) You can now hold a simple back-and-forth — this book is fully in sentence territory. Next: **numbers** (uno, dos, tres) and telling someone your age and phone.

Chapter 37

Synthesis — Asking, and Answering

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can hold a short exchange about what someone drinks and where they live, using all three verb families.
>
> *Three families and two question words, and every word in the dialogue self-built.*

37.1 Synthesis — asking, and answering

Nothing new in this chapter. Say "I eat" and "I live." (*Como. Vivo.*)

What you've built

Something quietly enormous happened over the last four chapters, and it is worth saying out loud before you use it.
Spanish has **three** verb families. You now hold the singular of all three. That is not three facts — it is a machine: hand it any regular verb you meet for the rest of your life, and you can already say what you do with it, what a friend does, and what somebody else does.
Two question words turn that machine outward. **¿Qué?** asks *what*. **¿Dónde?** asks *where*. With them, the forms stop being an exercise and start being a conversation.

The exchange

> — ¿**Qué** bebes? — **Bebo** café. ¿Y tú? — Yo también. ¿**Dónde** vives? — **Vivo en** Madrid.

Four lines, and every single word in them is something you built yourself. No new vocabulary was needed to get here — only the endings, one slot at a time.

Notice what the questions cost: nothing. You did not learn a question *form*. You put **¿qué?** or **¿dónde?** in front of a verb you already had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the exchange above, both parts, without stopping
- it again, swapping in *comes* for *bebes*

Twice through: Run it until the question and the answer arrive together.

Before you move on

How many verb families do you hold? (**Three** — and that is all of them.) What did the question words cost you? (**Nothing** — they sit in front of forms you already had.) Ask where somebody lives. (*¿Dónde vives?*)

Chapter 38

Hablamos — the First Form That Is Not About One Person

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what we do, with the -amos ending.

-mos is Latin's -mus, barely changed in two thousand years.

38.1 hablamos — "we speak"

Say "I speak", then "you speak" to a friend. (*Hablo. Hablas.*)

Grammar Lens: the first form that is not about one person

Every verb form you have met so far — in every tense — has been about **one** person. That changes here.
Drop the **-ar**, add **-amos**:

hablamos — *we speak.*

One word again, no pronoun, and now it covers you and somebody else. This is the form you will reach for constantly and have not had: *we speak*, *we work*, *we study*. Everything you could say about yourself, you can now say about a group you belong to.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-mos** is remarkable for how little happened to it.
Latin marked *we* with **-mus**: *amāmus*, "we love". Spanish says *-mos*.
One vowel changed in two thousand years, and nothing else — no consonant lost, no syllable worn away, no analogy pulling it out of shape.
Compare what became of the third person, which lost its **-t** entirely (*hablat* → *habla*). Endings do not decay at the same rate, and this one barely decayed at all.
And Portuguese and Italian kept it too — *falamos*, *parliamo*. If you ever meet another Romance language, *-mos* or *-mo* will be waiting for you, doing the same job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablo" then "hablamos" — one person, then a group
- "hablamos" alone, and notice it is still a whole sentence

Before you move on

How do you say "we speak"? (**Hablamos**.) Which Latin ending is that? (**-mus**, almost unchanged.) How many words? (**One** — still no pronoun.) Next: the form for *them*.

Chapter 39

Hablan — They, and Ustedes

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what they do, and address any group as ustedes.
>
> *ustedes is vuestras mercedes - so it takes the they form for the same reason usted takes the he form.*

39.1 hablan — "they speak," and "you all speak"

Say "we speak." (*Hablamos.*) And what was the form for *he speaks*? (*Habla.*)

Grammar Lens: add the plural -n

Take *habla*, the form for one other person, and add **-n**:

hablan — *they speak.*

That is the whole operation, and it is the same one Spanish uses everywhere: a final **-n** on a verb means the subject is plural and is not you.

Grammar Lens: the form does a second job, exactly as habla did

ustedes — *you all.* And it takes **hablan**, the *they* form.
You have seen this exact move before. *Usted* takes the *he/she* form because it grew out of *vuestra merced*, "your grace" — a thing you talk

about. **Ustedes** is simply that phrase made plural, *vuestras mercedes*, "your graces". Same origin, same consequence.

> **Where this is the ordinary word.** Across all of Latin America, and in the Canary Islands and parts of Andalusia, **ustedes** is how you address *any* group — friends, family, strangers alike. There is no separate familiar plural. For most Spanish speakers alive, this lesson is the complete answer to "how do I talk to more than one person?"

Spain uses a different word for friends, and it has the next chapter to itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "habla" then "hablan" — one other person, then several
- "ustedes hablan", addressing a group you have just met

Before you move on

What is "they speak"? (**Hablan**.) What does a final **-n** on a verb tell you? (The subject is **plural**, and not you.) And who does *ustedes* address in Latin America? (**Any** group at all.) Next: the word Spain uses instead, for friends.

Chapter 40

Hablais — the Form Spain Keeps

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can recognise the vosotros form and say where it is used.
>
> *vos + otros, added in Spain to keep the plural apart from a singular vos the Americas kept instead.*

40.1 habláis — the form Spain keeps

How do you say "you all speak" to a group in Mexico? (*Ustedes hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: a second plural you

In Spain, addressing a group of **friends** uses a different word and a different verb form:

vosotros habláis — *you all speak*, informally.

vosotros — *you all*, familiar. Its ending is **-áis**, and it is the last of the six.
This is not an ornament. In Spain it is the ordinary, everyday way to speak to more than one friend, and a Spaniard hears *ustedes* to a group of friends as oddly formal — roughly as an English speaker hears *sir* from someone they know well.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You met **vos** long ago: Latin's *plural* you, which drifted into the singular across much of the Americas.
That drift left Spain with a problem. If *vos* was being used for one polite person, what was left for an actual group? Spaniards added a word to disambiguate: **vos + otros**, "you **others**" — hence *vosotros*, and its feminine *vosotras*.
The Americas never needed the repair, because *ustedes* had already taken the plural job. So the split is not a difference of taste. **Two regions solved the same problem in two different ways**, and both solutions are still in use.

> **What you owe this form.** Recognition, at minimum — you will meet it in every book, film and song from Spain. Produce it if you are learning for Spain; otherwise *ustedes* will carry you anywhere.

Your turn

- [YOU HEAR: "habláis"] → a Spaniard, talking to friends.
- *Say it:* "ustedes hablan" then "vosotros habláis" — the same sentence, two continents

Before you move on

What is *vosotros* built from? (**Vos + otros** — "you others".) Why did Spain need it and the Americas not? (Because *vos* had drifted singular in the Americas, where *ustedes* already covered the plural.) Which will carry you anywhere? (**Ustedes**.)

Chapter 41

Review — the Whole Present Tense

Modes: 👁 **eyes** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can produce all six present-tense forms of a regular -ar verb.
>
> *The first complete paradigm in the book - withheld for thirty-two chapters until every box in it was earned.*

41.1 Review — the whole thing, at last

Nothing new in this chapter. Say "we speak", then "they speak."

Grammar Lens: the table this book has been withholding

Six forms. Every one of them built separately, on its own, in its own lesson.

who	***hablar*** →
yo	**hablo**
tú	**hablas**
él · ella · usted	**habla**
nosotros	**hablamos**
vosotros *(Spain)*	**habláis**
ellos · ellas · ustedes	**hablan**

Most Spanish courses open with this table. This one has spent thirty-two chapters refusing to show it, because a table you cannot yet

fill is a picture of work still to do, and a table you can fill is a picture of ground you hold.
Read it now and there should be no surprises in it. That is the point. **And it is not one verb.** Every regular *-ar* verb in Spanish — thousands of them — runs on these six endings, so this table is the present tense of a large part of the language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six in order, top to bottom
- them out of order, as prompted: *they* · *we* · *I* · *a friend*

Twice through: Until the whole set runs without a gap in it.

Before you move on

Give all six endings. (**-o, -as, -a, -amos, -áis, -an**.) How many regular *-ar* verbs does this fit? (**All of them**.) And why did the table wait until now? (Because every box in it had to be yours first.)

Chapter 42

Synthesis — the Same Sentence, Two Continents

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can choose between vosotros and ustedes by where I am, and say that neither corrects the other.
>
> *The first choice in this book decided by geography rather than meaning.*

42.1 Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents

Nothing new here. Say *hablan*, then *habláis*.

Grammar Lens: a choice that is not about grammar

Every other choice this book has asked you to make has been about **meaning**. *Tú* or *usted* — how close are you to this person? *El* or *un* — does your listener already know which one you mean?
This one is different. It is about **where you are**.

> — ¿**Habláis** español? — *asked in Madrid, to friends.* — ¿**Hablan** ustedes español? — *asked in Bogotá, to the same friends.*

Identical meaning. Identical register. The speaker chose by geography, and nothing else.

What you've built

This matters more than a regional footnote, because it settles what "correct Spanish" means in this book.
Neither of those sentences is the correction of the other.
Roughly 40 million people use *vosotros* daily; several hundred million have never used it in their lives and never will. A course that taught only *ustedes* would leave you unable to follow a Spanish film. One that taught only *vosotros* would leave you sounding strange in nineteen countries.
So you learn both, and you learn *which is which* — which is exactly what you have just done across four chapters.

> If you must pick one to produce: **ustedes**. It is understood everywhere, Spain included, and in the Americas it is the only option.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the Madrid version, then the Bogotá version
- the one you would actually use, and say why

Twice through:

Before you move on

What decides between *habláis* and *hablan*? (**Where you are** — not what you mean.) Which is correct? (**Both.**) And which one will carry you everywhere? (**Ustedes hablan**.)

Chapter 43

Where -er and -ir Part Company

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what we eat and what we live, and explain why the singular hid the difference.
>
> *comemos and vivimos: one vowel apart, audible only because the ending is stressed.*

43.1 comemos — "we eat"

Say "we speak." (*Hablamos.*) And "I eat." (*Como.*)

Grammar Lens: the same -mos, a different vowel

Drop the **-er**, add **-emos**:

> **comemos** — *we eat.*

The **-mos** is the one you already have from *hablamos*. Only the vowel in front of it changed, from **a** to **e** — and it changed for the reason it always does: the ending takes the colour of its family.
That is the pattern for every plural ending you will meet. **-mos** and **-n** never change. The vowel before them does.

> **Something is about to happen that has not happened before.** In the singular, *-er* and *-ir* were **identical** — *como/comes/come* and *vivo/vives/vive*, the same three endings twice over. That was a genuine saving,

and it is about to stop. The next lesson is where the two families finally part.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "hablamos" then "comemos" — the same *-mos*, a different vowel

Before you move on

What is "we eat"? (**Comemos**.) Which part of a plural ending never changes? (The **-mos**.) And what has been true of *-er* and *-ir* until now? (They were **identical** — which the next lesson ends.)

43.2 vivimos — where the two families part

Say "we eat." (*Comemos.*) And "I live." (*Vivo.*)

Grammar Lens: the saving ends here

Drop the **-ir**, add **-imos**:

vivimos — *we live.*

Not *vivemos.* **Vivimos**.
This is the first form in the whole book where *-er* and *-ir* do not match. For every singular form you learned, the two families shared endings exactly — and you were told that saving would end in the plural. This is where.

comemos — we eat. · **vivimos** — we live.

One vowel apart, and it is each family's own vowel: the **e** of *comer*, the **i** of *vivir*. The families were never really the same; the singular endings simply happened to fall out identically.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Why did the singular hide the difference and the plural expose it? Stress. In *vivo*, *vives*, *vive*, the stress is on the **stem** and the ending is unstressed — and unstressed vowels wear toward each other until they

are indistinguishable. In *vivimos*, the stress lands on the **ending itself**, and a stressed vowel keeps its own quality.
So the families did not diverge here. They were always distinct, and the plural is simply the place where the stress lets you hear it.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "comemos" then "vivimos" — and hear the one vowel that separates them

Before you move on

What is "we live"? (**Vivimos**.) Why was the difference invisible in the singular? (The ending was **unstressed**, so the vowels wore together.) And what makes it audible here? (The **stress** falls on the ending.)

Chapter 44

Comeis and Vivis

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can recognise both vosotros forms and say that they are the second and last difference.
>
> *Latin's -tis, collapsed two ways: -eis for one family, -is for the other.*

44.1 coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last

Which form goes with *vosotros* for *hablar*? (*Habláis.*) And where is that word used? (*Spain.*)

Grammar Lens: two families, two endings, one lesson

coméis — *you all eat.* · **vivís** — *you all live.*

These two are taught together, and it is worth saying why, because this book has otherwise insisted on one form per lesson.
You already know the fact they demonstrate. The *-er* and *-ir* families differ in exactly **two** slots — *nosotros*, which you met last chapter, and *vosotros*, which is this one. Learning them apart would teach the same single fact twice and hide the pattern that makes it easy.
And after this, the two families agree again. *They eat* and *they live* take the same ending, as every singular form did.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Both descend from Latin's **-tis**: *comeditis*, *vīvitis*. Spanish lost the **-t-** between vowels — as it lost most of them — and what was left collapsed differently in each family. The *-er* line kept two vowels, **-éis**. The *-ir* line kept one, **-ís**.
Same ending, same erosion, two outcomes. That is most of what sound change looks like.

Your turn

- [YOU HEAR: "coméis", "vivís"] → a Spaniard, addressing friends.
- *Say it:* "comemos, coméis" then "vivimos, vivís" — the two differing slots, side by side

Before you move on

Give both *vosotros* forms. (**Coméis**, **vivís**.) In how many slots do the two families differ? (**Two** — and you have now met both.) What Latin ending is behind them? (**-tis**.)

Chapter 45

Comen and Viven — Agreeing Again

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what they eat and what they live, with one ending shared by both families.
>
> *After two chapters apart the families fall back into step and stay there.*

45.1 comen and viven — agreeing again

What is "they speak"? (*Hablan.*) And who else does that form address? (*Ustedes.*)

Grammar Lens: one ending for both

Both families take **-en**:

> **comen** — *they eat*, *ustedes* eat. **viven** — *they live*, *ustedes* live.

No split here. After two chapters of divergence the families fall back into step, and they stay there.
That is the shape of the whole system, and it is worth holding as one sentence:

> ***-er* and *-ir* are identical in four of the six slots.**
> **They differ only in *nosotros* and *vosotros*.**

Two exceptions in a system of twelve forms. You have now met both, and everything else you already knew.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "comen, viven" — one ending, both families
- "ustedes comen", addressing a group

Before you move on

Give *they eat* and *they live*. (**Comen**, **viven**.) In how many of the six slots do the two families agree? (**Four**.) Next chapter: all three families, whole.

Chapter 46

Review — the Present Tense, Whole

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can conjugate any regular Spanish verb in the present, in any of the three families.
>
> *Eighteen forms, every one built separately before it appeared in the grid.*

46.1 Review — the present tense, whole

Nothing new in this chapter. Say "we eat" and "we live."

Grammar Lens: eighteen forms, and you built each one

who	*-ar*	*-er*	*-ir*
yo	habl**o**	com**o**	viv**o**
tú	habl**as**	com**es**	viv**es**
él · ella · usted	habl**a**	com**e**	viv**e**
nosotros	habl**amos**	com**emos**	viv**imos**
vosotros	habl**áis**	com**éis**	viv**ís**
ellos · ustedes	habl**an**	com**en**	viv**en**

This is the present tense of the Spanish language. Not a summary of it, not the regular part of it with exceptions pending — every regular verb in Spanish sits in that grid, and there are thousands

of them.
Two things are worth reading off it before you close the chapter:

- **The *yo* row is the same in all three families.** It always was. That is why the second and third families cost so little when they arrived.
- **-*er* and -*ir* differ in exactly two boxes — *nosotros* and *vosotros*. Four of their six forms are identical.**

So the whole grid is really one set of endings with a family vowel, plus two exceptions. That is the shape you have actually learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- one column straight down — *hablar*, all six
- one row straight across — *nosotros*, all three families

Twice through: Down a column, then across a row, until neither direction stalls.

Before you move on

How many forms are in the grid? (**Eighteen** — three families, six each.) Which row never varies? (***Yo***.) And how many boxes separate *-er* from *-ir*? (**Two**.)

Chapter 47

Numbers, and How Old You Are

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can count from one through ten and use singular forms of tener to ask and answer age with a number I know.
>
> *Count from one through ten, move among tengo, tienes, and tiene, then ask and answer age with the number frame taught in the chapter.*

47.1 uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five

Numbers are among the most reusable words in any language. Spanish keeps them close enough to Latin that English cousins can help you remember them. This lesson asks for only **five**: **uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco**.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ue` — **cuatro** begins *KWA-*.
- `r-tap` — give *tres* and *cuatro* one light tap, not an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	English memory hook
uno (1)	*ūnus*	**unit**, unique
dos (2)	*duo*	**duo**, dual
tres (3)	*trēs*	**trio**, triple
cuatro (4)	*quattuor*	**quart**, quarter
cinco (5)	*quīnque*	**quintet**, quintuplet

The spellings changed, but the family resemblance remains. *Cinco* and *quintet* both descend from *quīnque*; Spanish changed the opening sound while English borrowed a more visibly Latin form.

Grammar Lens: uno becomes un or una

When **uno** stands alone, it means "one." Before a noun it shortens:

- **un** before a masculine noun: **un café** — one coffee / a coffee.
- **una** before a feminine noun: **una noche** — one night / a night.

This shortening is called **apocope**: the end drops away. Spanish uses the same forms for "one" and "a/an"; context supplies the difference.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco" — once up, once down
- "uno/unit, dos/duo, tres/trio, cuatro/quart, cinco/quintet"
- "un café, una noche" — hear *uno* shorten

Before you move on

Give 1–5 in Spanish. (*Uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco.*) Which English word helps you remember *cinco*? (*Quintet*, through Latin *quīnque.*) What happens to *uno* before a noun? (It becomes **un** or **una**.) Next: **six through ten**.

47.2 seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count

You can count to five. Add one small set and you reach ten: **seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**. Four English month names will help hold the last four in memory.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ie` — **siete** begins *SYE-*.
- `diphthong-ue` — **nueve** begins *NWE-*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	English memory hook
seis (6)	*sex*	**sextet**
siete (7)	*septem*	**September**, septet
ocho (8)	*octō*	**October**, octave
nueve (9)	*novem*	**November**
diez (10)	*decem*	**December**, decimal

Say the chain aloud: *siete–September, ocho–October, nueve–November, diez–December*. It is a memory path, not a second list to memorize.

Why it's said this way

The month names preserve an old Roman count in which **March was first**: September through December occupied positions seven through ten. When January and February stood before March, those names shifted to positions nine through twelve but kept their old numbers.
One tempting story is wrong: July and August were not new months inserted into the middle. The existing months **Quintilis** and **Sextilis** were later **renamed** for Julius Caesar and Augustus. The calendar moved; the numbered names stayed.
Numbers above ten belong to a later chapter. For now, stop cleanly at **diez**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- count from *uno* through *diez*
- "siete/September, ocho/October, nueve/November, diez/December"

Before you move on

Give 6–10. (*Seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez.*) Why does *December* carry the old word for ten? (The month names preserve a March-first count.) What happened to Quintilis and Sextilis? (They were renamed July and August.) Next: the verb **tener**, "to have."

47.3 tener — "to have," with two visible changes

Regular *comer* gave you *como, comes, come.* The common verb **tener**, "to have," belongs to the same **-er** family, but its three singular forms change in two places. Learn only those three today.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ie` — **tienes** begins *TYE-*.
- `r-tap` — one light tap at the end of **tener**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tener descends from Latin **tenēre**, "to hold or keep." Having is, at root, holding. English borrowed the same root many times:

- **tenant**, **tenure**, **tenacious** — holding land, office, or position.
- **contain**, **retain**, **maintain**, **sustain** — holding together, back, in hand, or up.

When you see *-tain* in English, think of Spanish **tener**.

Grammar Lens: the three singular forms

person	regular *comer*	irregular *tener*
yo	como	**tengo**
tú	comes	**tienes**
él / ella / usted	come	**tiene**

Two small changes do all the work:

1. **yo** adds **g**: *tengo*, not *teno*.
2. The other two singular forms change **e** → **ie**: *tienes, tiene*.

Later chapters will expand both patterns. For now, hold only **tengo, tienes, tiene** — the same three-person frame you already use for regular verbs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "tener — tengo, tienes, tiene"
- "tener / tenant / retain" — the shared idea is *hold*
- compare "como, comes, come" with "tengo, tienes, tiene"

Before you move on

What did Latin *tenēre* mean? ("To hold.") Give the three singular forms. (*Tengo, tienes, tiene.*) What are the two changes? (*g* appears in *tengo*; *e* becomes *ie* in *tienes/tiene.*) Next: use them to ask and answer about **age**.

47.4 ¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age

You now have *tengo, tienes, tiene* and the numbers one through ten. Put them together and you can ask or answer age. Spanish frames age as something you **have**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cuántos años tienes? "How old are you?" — literally, "How many years do you have?"

- **cuántos** means "how many." Latin **quantus**, "how much," also gives English **quantity, quantum, quantify**.
- **años** means "years." Latin **annus** also gives **annual** and **anniversary**. Its doubled *nn* became Spanish **ñ**, exactly as your script lesson showed.
- **tienes** is the *tú* form of **tener**.

Keep the marks visible: opening **¿**, the accent in **cuántos**, and the letter **ñ** in **años** each carries information.

Grammar Lens: Spanish "has" years

English says "I **am** ten years old." Spanish says:

— ¿Cuántos años **tienes**? — **Tengo diez años.**

The reusable frame is **Tengo + number + años**. Use a number you already know: *Tengo ocho años*, *Tengo nueve años*, *Tengo diez años.* Larger numbers wait until their own lesson; the grammar does not change.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Cuántos años tienes?"
- "Tengo ocho años. Tengo nueve años. Tengo diez años."

Before you move on

What does the question literally ask? ("How many years do you have?") Which verb carries age? (*Tener.*) How do *cuántos* and *años* connect to English? (*Quantus* → quantity; *annus* → annual.) Next: combine counting, *tener*, and age in one short exchange.

47.5 Practice — counting, having, and age

This checkpoint asks for three small moves: count to ten, choose the right singular form of *tener*, and use the age frame. Everything here has already appeared.

Grammar Lens: count and conjugate

- Count: **uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco, seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**.
- Change person: **tengo · tienes · tiene**.
- Remember the roots: *quīnque* helps with *cinco*; *decem* helps with *diez*; *tenēre*, "hold," helps with *tener*.
- Keep the calendar correction: July and August were **renamed**, not inserted.

The exchange — use only what you know

— Hola. ¿Cómo te llamas? — Me llamo Ana. ¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo diez años. ¿Y tú? — Tengo nueve años.

The exchange reuses the name question you already know, then adds exactly one new capability: age with **tener**.

What you've built this chapter

- **uno through diez**, with Latin and English hooks instead of an isolated list.
- **un / una** before a noun, where standalone *uno* shortens.
- **tengo, tienes, tiene**, the three singular forms of **tener**.
- **¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo ... años**, with *quantus/quantity* and *annus/annual* showing where the words came from.

Numbers above ten and the plural forms of *tener* remain deliberately deferred.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- count 1–10 up, then down
- "tengo, tienes, tiene"
- ask and answer age with a number from 1–10

Twice through: "¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo nueve años."

Before you move on

Count to ten. Give the three singular forms of *tener*. Ask "How old are you?" and answer with a number you learned. You can now move from a name exchange into one concrete personal detail. Next: the two Spanish ways to say "to be," introduced one contrast at a time.

Chapter 48

Ser and Estar — Two Ways to Be

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can identify someone, state origin, check wellbeing, and give a location by choosing a learned singular form of ser or estar.
>
> *Identify Ana, state an origin with soy de, check a current state, and locate Ana with está en using only previously introduced vocabulary and singular forms.*

48.1 ser — another way to say "to be"

You already use **estar** for a current state or location. Spanish also has **ser**. This chapter adds one job at a time; today, learn the verb and the three singular forms that match the person frame you already know.

Sounds you'll need

- `vowel-e` — **ser** begins with the clear vowel in *mesa*.
- `r-tap` — the final **r** is one light tap: *SER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Modern **ser** grew from a historical merger. Latin **esse** meant "to be," while **sedēre** meant "to sit." The infinitive and the present forms do not all come down the same path, so the modern verb cannot be predicted from one neat stem.

The **esse** family is still visible in English **essence**, **essential**, **entity**, **present**, and **absent**. That makes *essence* a useful memory hook for one major use of *ser*: identifying what someone or something **is**.

Grammar Lens: only three forms today

person	form	a small identifying frame
yo	**soy**	**Soy Ana.** — "I am Ana."
tú	**eres**	**Eres Ana.** — "You are Ana."
él / ella / usted	**es**	**Usted es Ana.** — "You are Ana."

Say the set as **soy · eres · es**. These forms are **irregular**: do not try to remove *-er* and attach the regular endings from *comer*. A later lesson will build the plural-person frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ser — soy, eres, es"
- "Soy Ana. Eres Ana. Usted es Ana."
- "esse — essence — ser"

Before you move on

Which two Latin verbs fed *ser*? (*Esse* and *sedēre*.) Give the three forms learned today. (*Soy, eres, es*.) Why not predict them from the infinitive? (The verb is historically mixed and irregular.) Next: set *ser* beside *estar* using only identity and state frames you already have.

48.2 ser vs estar — identity or current state?

You now have two small sets: **soy, eres, es** and **estás, está**. Do not memorize a long rule list. Make one contrast: **ser identifies**; **estar places someone in a current state or location**.

Grammar Lens: the first contrast, from known material

question	what it asks	verb
¿Es usted Ana? — "Are you Ana?"	identity	**ser**
¿Está usted bien? — "Are you well?"	current state	**estar**

Only the verb and the job change. The first question identifies the person; the second checks how that person is now. Both **Ana**, **usted**, and **bien** are already part of your course, so the contrast adds no hidden vocabulary.

Grammar Lens: a memory hook, not a law

- **ser** recalls Latin *esse* and English **essence**: use it here to say who someone **is**.
- **estar** comes from Latin *stāre*, "to stand," the family behind **state**: use it for the state or location in which someone stands.

"Permanent versus temporary" is only a rough beginner shortcut, not the rule. A location may last for centuries and still use *estar*; an identification may last one minute and still use *ser*. Ask instead: **am I identifying, or am I giving a state or location?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Es usted Ana?" — identity, *ser*
- "¿Está usted bien?" — state, *estar*
- "identify: ser; state or location: estar"

Twice through: "¿Es usted Ana? ¿Está usted bien?"

Before you move on

Which verb identifies? (*Ser.*) Which gives a current state or location? (*Estar.*) Why is "permanent versus temporary"

incomplete? (The choice follows the kind of claim, not its duration.)
Next: use *ser* for one specific identity fact — origin.

48.3 soy de... — saying where you are from

You can identify yourself with **Soy Ana**. Add one short word and you can state another identity fact: **Soy de...**, "I am from…".

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de means "from" or "of." It comes from Latin **dē**, "down from, away from." English keeps that direction in **de**part and **de**scend.
You already learned that *dónde* grew from Latin *de unde*, "from where." Spanish can put the still-living word **de** before **dónde** to ask explicitly about origin.

Grammar Lens: ser + de for origin

¿De dónde eres? — "Where are you from?" **Soy de Madrid.** — "I am from Madrid."

The place name **Madrid** already appeared with *vivir*. Here, the new piece is the frame around it. Use **ser**, because this sentence states origin; it does not say where someone is located now.
Keep the two known questions separate:

question	asks about
¿De dónde eres?	origin — where you are from
¿Dónde vives?	residence — where you live

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿De dónde eres?"
- "Soy de Madrid."
- "de — depart — descend": the shared direction is *from*

Before you move on

What does *de* mean? ("From" or "of.") Ask where one friend is from. (*¿De dónde eres?*) Answer with Madrid. (*Soy de Madrid.*) Next: reuse *dónde* and *en* to say where someone is located now.

48.4 está en... — saying where someone is

You have already asked **¿Dónde vives?** — **Vivo en Madrid** about where someone lives. Now use the same **dónde** and **en** with *estar* to ask about a current location.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en already means "in," "on," or "at." It descends from Latin **in** and is a cognate of English **in**. No new preposition is needed; only the surrounding verb changes.

Grammar Lens: dónde + estar, then estar + en

¿Dónde está usted? — "Where are you?" (formal)
Usted está en Madrid. — "You are in Madrid." **Ana está en Madrid.** — "Ana is in Madrid."

The form **está** is already familiar from *¿Cómo está usted?* The phrase **está en...** simply gives that form a place. Location uses *estar* even when a place seems stable; the choice marks the kind of claim, not how long it lasts.
Compare origin and location without adding any new form:

sentence	meaning	verb
Ana es de Madrid.	origin	*ser*
Ana está en Madrid.	location	*estar*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Dónde está usted?"

- "Ana está en Madrid."
- "en / in" — two cognates

Before you move on

Which verb locates someone? (*Estar.*) What already-known word introduces the place? (*En.*) Ask formal "Where are you?" (*¿Dónde está usted?*) Next: combine identity, origin, state, and location without adding another word or verb form.

48.5 Practice — identity, origin, state, and location

This checkpoint adds nothing. Use **ser** for identity and origin; use **estar** for a current state or location.

Grammar Lens: retrieve the two small form sets

- **ser**: **soy** · **eres** · **es**
- **estar** in the questions used here: **estás** · **está**

Plural forms remain deliberately deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **ser**: *esse* + *sedēre*.
- **estar**: *stāre*, "stand."
- **de**: Latin *dē*, "from."
- **en**: Latin *in*, English *in*.

Grammar Lens: sort by the kind of claim

prompt	answer	why
¿Es usted Ana?	*ser*	identity
¿De dónde eres?	*ser*	origin
¿Está usted bien?	*estar*	current state
¿Dónde está Ana?	*estar*	location

The exchange — only known pieces

> — Hola. ¿**Es usted Ana**? — Sí. **Soy Ana**. — ¿**De dónde es usted**? — **Soy de Madrid**. — ¿**Dónde está Ana**? — **Está en Madrid**. — ¿**Está usted bien**? — **Bien, gracias**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "soy, eres, es"
- the four questions, naming each job
- the exchange once

Twice through: "¿Es usted Ana? ¿Está usted bien?"

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms of *ser*. (*Soy, eres, es.*) Which verb identifies and states origin? (*Ser.*) Which gives a state or location? (*Estar.*) Ask where one friend is from, then locate Ana in Madrid. Next: **ir**, "to go," introduced in the same small-step frame.

Chapter 49

Going, and the Future You Can Already Say

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask where someone is going, say what a singular person is going to do, and mark a known singular noun with mi, tu, or su.

Complete ES-C10-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise with singular ir, ir a plus a known infinitive, and mi, tu, or su before café.

49.1 ir — "to go," from more than one historical stem

You already match different verb forms with **tú** and **usted**, and you can ask **¿Dónde...?**, "Where…?" Today, add one new verb and only its three singular-person forms.

Sounds you'll need

- `vowel-i` — **ir** is one clear syllable, like *ear* without a glide.
- `diphthong-oy` — **voy** ends with the sound in English *boy*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ir means "to go." Its infinitive descends from Latin **īre**, also "to go." The present forms below followed a different Latin verb, **vādere**, "to go forward" or "advance." English **invade** and **evade** preserve that *vad-* family.

One modern verb built from historically different stems is called **suppletive**. English does the same thing when *go* changes to *went*, an old form borrowed from *wend*.

Grammar Lens: only three forms today

person	present of ir
yo	**voy**
tú	**vas**
él / ella / usted	**va**

Say the small set as **voy** · **vas** · **va**. The plural forms are deliberately left for a later lesson.

The known question word now gives you a useful prompt:

¿Dónde va usted? — "Where are you going?"

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ir — voy, vas, va"
- "¿Dónde va usted?"
- "īre gives ir; vādere gives the present set"

Before you move on

What does *ir* mean? ("To go.") Give the three forms learned today. (*Voy, vas, va.*) Why do they look unlike *ir*? (The infinitive and present set come through different Latin stems.) Next: place **a** and a known infinitive after this small set to talk about what is coming.

49.2 voy a + infinitive — moving toward the near future

You know **voy, vas, va** and the infinitives **hablar, comer, vivir**. This lesson joins those owned pieces with one short new word.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **a** means "to" or "toward." It descends from Latin **ad**, "toward," which English keeps in words such as **advance**. Movement toward a place easily becomes movement toward a future event. English uses the same picture in "I am **going to** speak." Spanish keeps **a** visible: **voy a hablar**.

Grammar Lens: ir + a + an unchanged infinitive

person	near-future frame	meaning
yo	**voy a hablar**	I am going to speak
tú	**vas a comer**	you are going to eat
usted	**va a vivir**	you are going to live

Only **ir** changes for the person. The second verb stays in its known dictionary form: **hablar**, **comer**, or **vivir**. No new plural person or infinitive is hidden in the pattern.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "voy a hablar"
- "vas a comer"
- "va a vivir"

Before you move on

What is the frame? (*Ir* in the present + **a** + an infinitive.) Does the second verb change for the person? (No.) What idea connects physical going with future time? (Motion toward a destination becomes motion toward an event.) Next: say whose already-known

café it is.

49.3 hablaré — the future in one word

You can already say *voy a hablar* — "I am going to speak." Spanish has a second way to say the same thing, and it is shorter: one word instead of three. Your job here is to recognize it and to see where it came from.

What to know first

- voy a + infinitive — the future you already have.
- hablar — the infinitive this is built on.

Sounds you'll need

- `vowel-e` — the ending is stressed: *hablarÉ* (*ah-blah-REH*). The written accent is doing real work; it tells you where your voice lifts. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hablaré — "I will speak." Look closely and you will see a word you already know sitting inside it, whole and unchanged:
`hablar + é → hablaré (to speak) (ending) (I will speak)`
This is the one Spanish tense built on the **complete infinitive**. Nothing is chopped off. Every other tense you have met removes the *-ar* first; this one leaves it alone and simply adds to the end.
Where the ending comes from. It is a verb in its own right, worn down. Latin speakers said *hablare habeo* — literally "**I have** to speak," in the sense of "I am to speak," a thing still ahead of me. Said often enough, the *habeo* shrank onto the back of the infinitive and stopped being a separate word:
`hablare habeo → hablar é → hablaré "I have to speak" "I will speak"`
So the Spanish future is an obligation that turned into a prediction — the same drift English made when "I **shall** speak" softened out of a word that once meant "I owe."

What you've built

The singular endings ride on the full infinitive, and they are the **same for all three verb families** — *-ar*, *-er* and *-ir* alike. This is the most regular tense in the language:

	speak	**eat**	**live**
I will	hablaré	comeré	viviré
you will	hablarás	comerás	vivirás
he/she will	hablará	comerá	vivirá

Both futures are correct. *Voy a hablar* is what you will hear most in conversation; *hablaré* is a little more formal, and is what you will meet in writing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablaré* — stress the last syllable
- the same idea the long way — *voy a hablar*
- "I will eat" and "I will live," using the table

Before you move on

What whole word can you still see inside *hablaré*? (*hablar.*) Which syllable carries the stress? (The last — the accent says so.) The ending began life as which Latin verb? (*Habeo*, "I have.")

49.4 mi, tu, su — whose café?

You already know **café**, and you distinguish informal **tú** from formal **usted**. Now put one small ownership word before that one known noun.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	meaning in today's frame
mi	*meus*	my
tu	*tuus*	your, to one informal **tú**
su	*suus*	your, to formal **usted**; also his or her

English **my** helps recall **mi**. Older English **thy**, "your," helps recall Latin *tuus* and Spanish **tu**. The ownership word **tu** has no written accent; the person word **tú** that you already know keeps its accent.

Grammar Lens: put the ownership word before the noun

phrase	meaning
mi café	my coffee
tu café	your coffee, informal
su café	your coffee, formal; or his or her coffee

The situation tells you which person **su** points to. Every noun phrase in this lesson is singular. Forms used before plural things are left for a later step, so there is no new number pattern to learn here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "mi café"
- "tu café" to *tú*
- "su café" to *usted*

Before you move on

Give the three ownership words. (*Mi, tu, su.*) Where do they go? (Before the noun.) Which one addresses *usted*? (*Su.*) Which Latin sources sit behind them? (*Meus, tuus, suus.*) Next: retrieve the chapter without adding a new word, form, or noun.

49.5 Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve **voy, vas, va**; build the near future with **a** and a known infinitive; then put **mi, tu,** or **su** before the known noun **café**.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- **ir**, singular: **voy · vas · va**.
- near future: **voy a hablar · vas a comer · va a vivir**.
- ownership before one singular known noun: **mi café · tu café · su café**.

Plural person forms of *ir* and possessives before plural nouns remain deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **ir** continues Latin *īre*, while **voy, vas, va** continue *vādere*.
- **a** continues Latin *ad*, "toward"; motion toward a goal became motion toward a coming event.
- **mi, tu, su** continue Latin *meus, tuus, suus*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "voy, vas, va"
- "voy a hablar, vas a comer, va a vivir"
- "mi café, tu café, su café"

Twice through: "Voy a hablar. Su café."

Before you move on

Give the singular *ir* set. (*Voy, vas, va.*) Build "You are going to eat" for one friend. (*Vas a comer.*) Say "my coffee" and formal

"your coffee." (*Mi café; su café.*) The next chapter can now extend the grammar from this small, closed frontier.

Chapter 50

Ser in the Plural

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use all six present forms of ser, and say why no two of them look alike.
>
> *Two Latin verbs in one paradigm - and the seam between them is visible at eres.*

50.1 somos — "we are"

Say "I am." (*Soy.*) And "we speak." (*Hablamos.*)

Grammar Lens: the -mos survives even here

somos — *we are.*

Look at what survived. *Ser* is the most irregular verb in Spanish — *soy*, *eres*, *es* share almost nothing — and yet the plural still ends in **-mos**, exactly as *hablamos* and *comemos* do.
That ending is the single most stable thing in the language. Even a verb that has thrown away everything else kept it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

And here is why *ser*'s forms refuse to resemble each other: **it is not one verb.** It is two Latin verbs fused into a single paradigm.

- Latin **esse**, "to be", gave *soy* and *somos* — the *s-* forms, and the rest of that family arrives over the next two lessons.

- Latin **sedēre**, "to sit", gave *ser* itself, and the future and conditional.

So *somos* and *ser* are not irregular versions of each other. They are descendants of **different words**, brought together because Spanish needed one verb where Latin had two.
English did something very similar. *Am*, *is*, *are*, *was*, *be* — no two of those look related, because they are not: they come from three separate Old English verbs. Every language seems to build "to be" out of spare parts.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "hablamos, comemos, somos" — the same ending, three times

Before you move on

What is "we are"? (**Somos**.) Which ending did even this verb keep? (**-mos**.) And why do *soy* and *ser* look unrelated? (They **are** unrelated — two Latin verbs in one paradigm.)

50.2 son — "they are"

Say "we are." (*Somos.*) And "they speak." (*Hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: the final -n, again

son — *they are*, and **ustedes son**, *you all are*.

Three letters, and it is one of the two or three commonest words in the whole language. The rule you know holds even here: a final **-n** means the subject is plural and is not you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's form was **sunt**. Spanish dropped the final **-t**, exactly as it dropped it from *hablat* to give *habla*, and *sunt* became *son*.
That is worth noticing because it is the same erosion you have already watched happen twice. Irregular verbs are not exempt from sound change; they are simply verbs where sound change ran on material that

had already been strange.

> **A word you may already know.** English *sonata*, *sonnet* and *sound* have nothing to do with this — they come from Latin *sonāre*, "to sound". *Son* the verb and *son* the noun in English are unrelated to each other and to both. Spanish is full of these collisions, and the way through is always the same: the root, not the spelling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "somos, son" — the two plural forms you now hold
- "ustedes son", addressing a group

Before you move on

What is "they are"? (**Son**.) What did Latin's *sunt* lose? (Its **-t**, like every other final *-t*.) Who else does *son* address? (**Ustedes**.)

50.3 sois — the last of the six

Say "they are." (*Son*.) And which region uses *vosotros*? (*Spain*.)

Grammar Lens: one syllable, and the paradigm closes

> **vosotros sois** — *you all are*, in Spain.

One syllable, and with it the six forms of *ser* are complete: *soy*, *eres*, *es*, *somos*, *sois*, *son*.
As before, this is the form you need in order to **follow** Spain rather than to speak everywhere. In the Americas, *ustedes son* does the same job.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin had **estis**. Spanish wore away the *e-* at the front and the *-t-* in the middle, and *sois* is what was left — a word reduced almost to nothing but still doing its whole job.

That is the pattern with this verb throughout. *Ser* is short everywhere because it is said constantly, and constant use grinds words down. The commonest verb in a language is almost always its most eroded one.

Your turn

- [YOU HEAR: "sois"] → Spain, addressing friends.
- *Say it:* "ustedes son" then "vosotros sois" — the same sentence, two continents

Before you move on

What is the *vosotros* form of *ser*? (**Sois**.) What Latin word is it worn from? (**Estis**.) And why is this verb so short everywhere? (Because it is said **constantly**, and constant use grinds words down.)

50.4 Review — all of ser

Nothing new. Say "we are", then "they are."

Grammar Lens: the table, and why it looks like that

who	***ser*** **→**
yo	**soy**
tú	**eres**
él · ella · usted	**es**
nosotros	**somos**
vosotros	**sois**
ellos · ustedes	**son**

Most books present this as a table to memorise. You have built it a form at a time, and you can now read something off it that memorisation would never give you.

Five of the six begin with *s*-. One does not. *Eres* is the outlier, and it is the outlier because it comes from somewhere else — Latin *eris*, from *esse*'s own future stem, pulled in to fill a gap. The rest are the *s*- family: *sum*, *sumus*, *sunt*.

So the "irregularity" is not chaos. It is a seam between two verbs, and

you can see exactly where it runs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six, top to bottom
- the five *s-* forms, then *eres* on its own

Twice through:

Before you move on

Give all six forms of *ser.* (*Soy, eres, es, somos, sois, son.*) How many begin with *s-*? (**Five**.) And why does the sixth not? (It came from a **different Latin verb** — the seam is visible.)

Chapter 51

Profesor — and the Article Spanish Leaves Out

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what someone does for a living with ser and no article.
>
> *I can say what someone does for a living with ser and no article.*

51.1 profesor

Say "I am." (*Soy.*) You learned *ser* three chapters ago as the verb for saying **what someone is**.

And then you had nothing to put after it. Today you do.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

profesor — a teacher

Latin **profitērī** meant to *declare something publicly.* A *profesor* is someone who has declared what they know — which is also why in English you **profess** a faith, and why the work you declare yourself trained in is a **profession**.

profesor ← *profitērī* → **professor**, **profess**, **profession**

Say it: *profesor.* And for a woman, *profesora.*

Grammar Lens: the missing "a"

After *ser*, a job takes no *un* or *una*.

You learned *un* and *una* early, and you have been right to use them. Here is the one place Spanish leaves them out.

Spanish	English
Soy profesor.	I am **a** teacher.
Es profesora.	She is **a** teacher.

English needs the *a*. Spanish does not — because it is not counting one teacher, it is naming what kind of person you are.
Soy un profesor is not wrong so much as **different**: it makes the teacher into one item out of several, the way English does with *I'm a teacher, not the teacher*. Say the bare one and you will sound like everyone else.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Soy profesor*
- *Trabajo* — and now say what you are

Twice through:

Before you move on

What word does English need here that Spanish leaves out? (***a***.)
Now say what you are, out loud, even if it is not *profesor* yet.

Chapter 52

Estudiante — a Word You Can Build

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build a person-word from a verb with -ante, and read it as English -ant.
>
> *I can build a person-word from a verb with -ante, and read it as English -ant.*

52.1 estudiante

Say "to study." (*Estudiar.*) You have had it since your first handful of verbs.

Say "I am a teacher." (*Soy profesor* — no *un.*)

Grammar Lens: the one who is doing it

Verb + *-ante* = the person doing it.

Take *estudiar*, cut the *-ar*, add *-ante*:

*estudi**ar*** → *estudi**ante*** — **the one who is studying**

You did not memorise that word. You **built** it, from a verb you already had.
English uses the same ending, worn down to *-ant*: a **particip*ant*** takes part, an **assist*ant*** assists, an **inhabit*ant*** inhabits. So *-ante* and *-ant* are one more pair for your decoder.

Spanish	English
estudiante	**student**
importante	**important**
elegante	**elegant**

And *estudiante* also begins *es-* + consonant. Take the *e-* off: **st**udiante. **Student**. Two of your rules on one word.

Grammar Lens: one word, either person

Profesor changed to *profesora* for a woman. *Estudiante* does not change at all:

Él es estudiante. · *Ella es estudiante.*

The article moves instead — *el estudiante*, *la estudiante* — but the word itself stays put. Words ending in *-ante* almost never shift.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Soy estudiante*
- *Somos estudiantes*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What does *-ante* do to a verb? (Makes **the one doing it**.)
And does *estudiante* change for a woman? (**No** — only the article does.)

Chapter 53

-ista — Jobs You Can Already Read

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read an -ista word as English -ist without being taught it.
>
> *I can read an -ista word as English -ist without being taught it.*

53.1 -ista

What does *-ante* make? (**The one doing it**.) Say "I am a student." (*Soy estudiante*.)

Grammar Lens: a job you can already read

Spanish *-ista* is English *-ist*.

Greek ***-istēs*** named the doer of an action. Latin borrowed it, and Spanish and English both still use it — so this ending needs almost no learning.

Spanish	English
artista	**artist**
dentista	**dentist**
turista	**tourist**
periodista	**journalist**

Three of those four you could read before this chapter opened. That is the point: **the ending is doing the work, not your memory.**

The fourth is the interesting one. *Periodista* is not *periodist* — it is built on *periódico*, a **newspaper**, which is a **periodical**, something that comes round at a *period*. The ending is regular; the root is the surprise.

Grammar Lens: -ista never changes

Like *-ante*, an *-ista* word is the same for a man or a woman — and it keeps its *-a* either way:

Él es artista. · *Ella es artista.*

The *-a* is not feminine here. It is just how the word ends. Only the article moves: *el artista*, *la artista*.
And still no *un*: *Soy artista*, not *Soy un artista*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *artista, dentista, turista*
- *Soy* — and one of them

Twice through:

Before you move on

What is *-ista* in English? (***-ist***.)
Does it change for a woman? (**No.**)

Chapter 54

Synthesis — Saying What People Do

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I and others do, and turn the question back.

I can say what I and others do, and turn the question back.

54.1 Synthesis — saying what people do

One word English needs after *is* and Spanish leaves out. Which? (***a.***)

What you've built

Three chapters ago *ser* was a verb with nothing to sit in front of. Now:

Soy profesor.	I am a teacher.
Ella es estudiante.	She is a student.
Somos artistas.	We are artists.

And two of those words you did not memorise. You **built** *estudiante* from *estudiar*, and you **read** *artista* off English.

Grammar Lens: what the two endings are worth

Neither ending is a word. Each is a **machine** that makes words, which is why they outrun any vocabulary list:

-ante ↔ **-ant** · *-ista* ↔ **-ist**

Both are also invariant — one form for a man or a woman — so you never have to choose. Only the article moves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Soy* — and what you actually are
- *¿Y tú?*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Two endings that name a person. (***-ante*** and ***-ista***.) What do both skip after *ser*? (***un*/*una***.) And which of them changes for a woman? (**Neither**.)

Chapter 55

Estar in the Plural

Modes: **voice** (3) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 3 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use all six present forms of estar, and say why its plural is regular where ser's is not.

One Latin verb against two - which is the whole reason one paradigm is plain and the other is not.

55.1 estamos — the other "we are"

Say "we are" with *ser*. (*Somos.*) And how do you ask a friend how they are? (*¿Cómo estás?*)

Grammar Lens: this one behaves

estamos — *we are.*

Drop the **-ar**, add **-amos**. That is the plain *-ar* ending you learned on *hablamos*, applied without alteration.
And that is the point of this lesson. You have just spent a chapter on *ser*, whose six forms come from two different Latin verbs and refuse to resemble each other. **Estar is not like that at all.** In the plural it is an ordinary *-ar* verb.

hablamos · *estamos* — the same ending, and no surprises.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The reason is simple, and it is the reason for almost every irregularity you have met: **estar is one verb.** Latin *stāre*, "to stand" — and that is the whole ancestry. Nothing was fused into it, so nothing in it has a seam.
Ser is irregular because two verbs were welded together. *Estar* is regular because it never was.
That is worth carrying, because it predicts the rest. Where a Spanish verb looks chaotic, the usual explanation is not that it decayed strangely but that it is **more than one word wearing a single name**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablamos, estamos" — the same ending
- "somos, estamos" — two verbs for *we are*, and only one of them is strange

Before you move on

What is "we are" with *estar*? (**Estamos**.) Which Latin verb is it from? (***Stāre***, "to stand".) And why is it regular where *ser* is not? (Because it is **one** verb, not two.)

55.2 están — "they are"

Say "we are" with *estar*. (*Estamos.*) And "they speak." (*Hablan.*)

Grammar Lens: the ending is regular, the accent is the clue

están — *they are*, and **ustedes están**, *you all are*.

The ending is **-an**, exactly as in *hablan*. But there is a written accent, and it is not decoration.
Estar is unusual in one specific way: it puts its stress on the **ending** rather than the stem, in every singular and plural form except

estamos. You have already seen this without being told — *estás*, *está*, and now *están*. The accent is simply Spanish writing that stress down, by the rule for written accents you learned long ago.

> **hablan** — stress on the stem, no accent. **están** — stress on the ending, so an accent.

Same ending, different stress, and the spelling records it faithfully.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablan" then "están" — same ending, and hear the stress move
- "ustedes están", addressing a group

Before you move on

What is "they are" with *estar*? (**Están**.) Why the accent? (The stress falls on the **ending**.) Which form of *estar* does not do that? (***Estamos***.)

55.3 estáis — and nothing surprises you

> Say "they are" with *estar*. (*Están*.) And the *vosotros* form of *hablar*? (*Habláis*.)

Grammar Lens: predictable, and that is the news

> **vosotros estáis** — *you all are*, in Spain.

If you guessed that before reading it, you have understood the chapter. The ending is *-áis*, the plain *-ar* one from *habláis*, and the accent is there for the reason it is always there with this verb: the stress sits on the ending.
That is now three forms in a row where knowing *estar* meant knowing nothing new. In the Americas, *ustedes están* does this job.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "habláis" then "estáis" — the same ending, twice

Before you move on

What is the *vosotros* form of *estar*? (**Estáis**.) Why the accent? (*Estar* stresses its **ending**.) And in Argentina? (***Ustedes están***.)

55.4 Review — both verbs for "to be"

Nothing new. Say *somos*, then *estamos*.

Grammar Lens: side by side, and the difference is history

who	***ser***	***estar***
yo	**soy**	**estoy**
tú	**eres**	**estás**
él · ella · usted	**es**	**está**
nosotros	**somos**	**estamos**
vosotros	**sois**	**estáis**
ellos · ustedes	**son**	**están**

Read the two columns down and the difference is not a matter of difficulty. It is a matter of **history**.

- ***Ser*** is two Latin verbs fused — *esse* and *sedēre* — so its forms have no common shape. Five begin with *s*-; *eres* does not, and that is the seam.
- ***Estar*** is one Latin verb, *stāre*. Its plural is a plain *-ar* paradigm, and the only oddity in the whole column is where the stress falls, which the written accent records honestly.

So the two hardest-looking verbs in Spanish are hard for opposite reasons: one because it is two words, and the other not really at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- one column down, then the other
- each row across — *soy, estoy* · *somos, estamos* — and hear which column surprises you

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the two verbs is regular in the plural? (***Estar***.) Why? (It is **one** Latin verb; *ser* is two.) And what is the only oddity in *estar*'s column? (Where the **stress** falls — which the accent records.)

Chapter 56

La Casa — Your First Everyday Noun

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say la casa and tengo una casa, using the article and gender rules I already hold.

Complete ES-C43-casa: produce la casa and tengo una casa, and say what casa meant in Latin.

56.1 la casa — "house," and "home"

You have spent a long time learning what to **do** with nouns — their gender, their articles, their agreement. This chapter and the next few hand you some nouns to do it with.

Sounds you'll need

- `s-sound` — the *s* in *casa* is a plain, unvoiced *s*. Spanish has no *z* buzz here: *KAH-sah*, never *KAH-zah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la casa — *the house*, and just as often *home*.

Latin **casa** meant something humbler than a house: a **hut**, a cottage, the small shelter a farm worker lived in. The grand Latin word for a proper house was *domus* — which is where **domestic** and **dome** come from. And *domus* lost. Across the whole west of the Roman world the

humble word won and the grand one faded: Spanish *casa*, Italian *casa*, Portuguese *casa*.
French took the same word somewhere stranger. *Casa* wore down until it stopped being a noun at all and became the little word **chez** — so *chez moi* is, underneath, "at the house of me."
Italian kept a small one too: *casino* is *casa* plus a diminutive ending — literally "little house."

Grammar Lens: a feminine noun, behaving exactly as promised

Casa ends in *-a* and is feminine, so it takes **la**. That is the common case, and it is worth having one plain example on hand before you meet the awkward ones.

la casa — the house. *Tengo una casa.* — I have a house.

Nothing new is happening here. That is the point: the machinery has been ready for a long time, and this is the first ordinary thing to run through it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la casa" — *KAH-sah*, a clean *s*
- "Tengo una casa"

Before you move on

What is "the house"? (***La casa***.) What did *casa* mean in Latin? (A **hut** — the humble word that outlived the grand one.) Next: a masculine noun whose Latin ancestor was a piece of a tree.

Chapter 57

El Libro — And a Word Made of Tree Bark

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say el libro and tengo un libro, and contrast it with la casa as a gender pair.

Complete ES-C43-libro: produce el libro and tengo un libro, and say what Latin liber originally named.

57.1 el libro — "book"

Say "the house." (*La casa.*) Why *la* and not *el*? (*Casa* is feminine.) Here is one that goes the other way.

Sounds you'll need

- `r-tap` — a single flick of the tongue: *LEE-broh*. One tap, not a roll.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el libro — *the book.*

Latin **liber** did not mean "book." It meant the **inner bark of a tree** — the thin, pale layer just under the rough outside, which is what Romans wrote on before they had anything better.
So the word travelled the way these words usually do: from the **material**, to the **thing made of it**, to the thing itself long after the

material is gone. Nobody has written on bark for two thousand years, and the word has not noticed.
English took the same root and kept it in the places books live:

- **library** — and French *livre*, Italian *libro*.
- **libretto** — Italian for "little book," the words of an opera.

English's own word went the same route from a different tree: **book** is related to **beech**, whose bark the Germanic peoples wrote on. Two languages, two trees, the same idea.

Grammar Lens: a masculine noun to sit beside the feminine one

Libro ends in *-o* and is masculine, so it takes **el**.

> *el libro* — the book. *Tengo un libro.* — I have a book. *la casa* — the house. *Tengo una casa.* — I have a house.

Two nouns, one of each gender, side by side. That pairing is worth more than either noun alone: from here on, when something in Spanish depends on gender, you have a plain example of both to test it against.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el libro" — one tap on the *r*
- "Tengo un libro" then "Tengo una casa" — hear the article follow the noun

Before you move on

"The book"? (***El libro.***) "The house"? (***La casa.***) What was *liber* before it was a book? (Tree **bark**.) Next: a noun you can build yourself, out of a verb you already have.

Chapter 58

Grande — the First Word for What a Thing Is Like

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can describe a thing with an adjective after the noun.
>
> *I can describe a thing with an adjective after the noun.*

58.1 grande

Say "she is." (*Es.*) You can say who someone **is** and what they **do**.

You still cannot say what anything is **like**. That starts here.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

grande — big

Latin **grandis** meant *full-grown*. English took it whole and never changed it: a **grand** piano is the big one, a **grandiose** plan is oversized, and a **grandmother** is — literally — the full-grown mother.

grande ← *grandis* → **grand**, **grandiose**, **aggrandise**

Say it: *grande*.

Grammar Lens: where it goes, and what it does not do

A describing word usually comes *after* the noun in Spanish.

English puts it in front — *a big house*. Spanish puts it behind:

una casa ***grande*** — a big house

And *grande* does not change for a man or a woman:

el libro grande	the big book
la casa grande	the big house

You have met that already. *Estudiante* and *artista* do not shift either. Some Spanish words agree with gender and some simply do not, and the ending tells you which: *-o/-a* words like *bueno/buena* shift, *-e* words like *grande* sit still.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *una casa grande*
- *el libro grande*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does a describing word go? (**After** the noun.)
And which endings sit still? (**-e** ones, like *grande*.)

Chapter 59

Cansado — a State, Not a Quality

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say how I am right now with estar and an adjective.
>
> *I can say how I am right now with estar and an adjective.*

59.1 cansado

Say "a big house." (*Una casa grande.*) That is what the house **is**.

Now for something that is only true today.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cansado — tired

Cansado comes from *cansar*, to tire, and behind that is Latin **campsāre**: *to turn aside off the road.* The tiredness is what made you turn off.

And your decoder cannot help you here. There is no English cousin to find — no *cansate*, no *campsation.* English took its word for this from an entirely different place.

That is worth meeting on purpose. The rules you built are a **lead**, not a guarantee, and a word that gives nothing back is not a failure of the method. It is simply one of the words you learn the ordinary way.

Grammar Lens: the state, not the quality

Estoy cansado. — not *soy cansado.*

You learned two verbs for *to be*. Here is the first describing word that shows you why:

Estoy cansado.	I am tired — **today**.
Es grande.	It is big — **that is what it is**.

Ser is for what a thing is. *Estar* is for how it is right now. Being tired is a state you are passing through, so it takes *estar*, always.
And unlike *grande*, this one **does** shift, because it ends in *-o*:

*Estoy cansad**o**.* · *Estoy cansad**a**.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Estoy cansado*
- *La casa es grande, pero estoy cansado*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which verb for tired? (***Estar***.) Why? (It is a **state**.)
And does *cansado* shift for a woman? (**Yes** — *cansada*, because it ends in *-o*.)

Chapter 60

Synthesis — Describing Things

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can choose ser or estar with an adjective and make it agree.
>
> *I can choose ser or estar with an adjective and make it agree.*

60.1 Synthesis — describing things

Two verbs for *to be*. Which is for what a thing **is**? (*Ser.*) Which is for how it **is right now**? (*Estar.*)

What you've built

You met *ser* and *estar* as a pair long before this book had a single word to put after them. Now it does, and the pair finally does its job:

La casa es grande.	The house is big — that is what it is.
Estoy cansado.	I am tired — today.
Soy profesor.	I am a teacher — and no *un*.

Three sentences, three different jobs for *to be*, and nothing memorised as a phrase.

Grammar Lens: which words shift

The ending tells you, and you now have one of each:

ending	shifts?	example
-o	**yes**	*cansado* → *cansada*
-e	no	*grande* stays *grande*
-ista, *-ante*	no	*artista*, *estudiante*

So you never have to guess. Look at the last letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *La casa es grande*
- *Estoy cansado* — and mean it

Twice through:

Before you move on

Ser or *estar* for tired? (***Estar***.) Where does the describing word go? (**After** the noun.) And what tells you whether it shifts? (Its **last letter**.)

Chapter 61

-oso — a Shelf of Words You Were Never Taught

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read an -oso word as English -ous, make it agree, and choose ser or estar for it.
>
> *Read misterioso, make comida deliciosa agree, and pick estar for nervioso.*

61.1 -oso

Name your two describing words. (*Grande*, *cansado*.)

Two is a short shelf. You are about to have a long one.

Grammar Lens: full of

Spanish *-oso* is English *-ous*.

Latin **-ōsus** meant *full of*. Stick it on a noun and you get an adjective: *fāma* is fame or report, so *famōsus* is **full of fame**.
English holds the same suffix, worn down through French to *-ous*. Not a resemblance — the **same ending**, arriving by two roads, exactly like *-ción* and *-tion*.

Spanish	English
famoso	**famous**
delicioso	**delicious**
curioso	**curious**
precioso	**precious**
nervioso	**nervous**

You were taught none of those. You can read all of them.

Grammar Lens: and you already know what to do with it

An *-oso* word is an ordinary describing word, so every rule you just learned applies without being restated:

- it goes **after** the noun — *un profesor famoso*
- it ends in *-o*, so it **shifts** — *famoso* / *famosa*
- and the verb depends on what you mean:

Es famoso.	He is famous — that is what he is.
Estoy nervioso.	I am nervous — right now.

That last pair is the whole *ser*/*estar* contrast again, and you did not have to be told which verb to use. You worked it out from the meaning.

Why it's said this way

The ending is reliable. The root still has to be shared.
Hermoso is *beautiful*, not *hermous* — because the root is *formōsus*, from *forma*, and English simply never borrowed that one.
So *-oso* tells you the word is an adjective and roughly how it is built. It only hands you the meaning when English took the same root. That is the same deal every rule in this book has offered: a **lead**, not a guarantee.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *famoso, delicioso, curioso*

- *Estoy nervioso*

Twice through:

Before you move on

-oso in English? (***-ous***.) Does it shift for a woman? (**Yes** — it ends in *-o*.)
And what does the ending *not* promise? (That English **took the same root**.)

Chapter 62

-ncia — Turning a Quality into a Thing

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read an -ncia word as English -nce, know it is feminine, and describe it.

Read preferencia, choose la for distancia, and say una diferencia grande.

62.1 -ncia

-oso in English? (***-ous***.) And *-ción*? (***-tion***.)

One more, and it is the one that makes ideas into things.

Grammar Lens: a quality, made into a thing

Spanish *-ncia* is English *-nce*.

Latin **-entia** turned a quality into a noun. If something *differs*, the state of differing is *differentia*. Spanish kept the ending nearly whole; English took it through French, where it wore down to *-nce*.

Spanish	English
diferencia	**difference**
importancia	**importance**
experiencia	**experience**
distancia	**distance**
paciencia	**patience**

One word wearing two coats, five times over. This is the same shape as *-ción* and *-tion*: not a resemblance, the **same ending** arriving by two roads.

Grammar Lens: what you do with it

Every *-ncia* word is a **noun**, and every one is **feminine** — so the article never surprises you:

la diferencia · *la importancia* · *una experiencia*

And you already know what goes after a noun:

una diferencia ***grande*** — a big difference

That sentence uses three things you were taught separately: a noun built by an ending, an article chosen by gender, and a describing word in its Spanish position. None of it was memorised as a phrase.

Why it's said this way

One that will look wrong, and is not.
Ciencia is **science**, not *cience*. The ending behaved exactly as promised — it is the *root* that English spells differently, because *scientia* came into English through a French spelling that kept the *sc-*. So when a decoded word looks almost right, trust the ending and check the root. Almost right is usually right.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la diferencia, la importancia, la experiencia*
- *una diferencia grande*

Twice through:

Before you move on

-*ncia* in English? (***-nce***.) What gender, always? (**Feminine**.) And when a decoded word looks *almost* right? (Trust the ending, **check the root**.)

Chapter 63

-ario — the Eighth and Last Ending

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can read an -ario word as English -ary and tell noun from adjective.

I can read an -ario word as English -ary and tell noun from adjective.

63.1 -ario

-ncia? (***-nce***.) *-oso*? (***-ous***.)

One more, and the set is complete.

Grammar Lens: belonging to, or the place for

Spanish *-ario* is English *-ary*.

Latin **-ārius** meant *belonging to* — and then, by an easy step, *the place where that thing is kept*.

diccionario — the place the **words** are kept

Which is exactly what an English **dictionary** is, and neither language ever said so out loud.

Spanish	English
necesario	**necessary**
ordinario	**ordinary**
primario	**primary**
diccionario	**dictionary**
aniversario	**anniversary**

Grammar Lens: it does two jobs

Unlike the other seven, *-ario* makes **both** nouns and adjectives, and the sentence tells you which:

un diccionario	a dictionary — a **thing**
es necesario	it is necessary — a **quality**

When it is an adjective it ends in *-o*, so it shifts the way you already expect: *necesario / necesaria*. When it is a noun it is masculine, and takes *el* or *un*.
You do not have to decide in advance. The sentence decides.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *necesario, ordinario, primario*
- *un diccionario*

Twice through:

Before you move on

-ario in English? (***-ary***.) Noun or adjective? (**Either** — the sentence decides.)

Chapter 64

Review — the Eight Endings

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can sort the eight endings by what they make and know which decide gender.
>
> *I can sort the eight endings by what they make and know which decide gender.*

64.1 Review — the eight endings

The first one you ever learned? (*-ción* → *-tion.*) The last? (*-ario* → *-ary.*)

What you've built

Sorted by **what they make**, which is more useful than the order you met them:

makes a thing	**makes a person**
-ción → **-tion** *-dad* → **-ty** *-ncia* → **-nce**	*-ante* → **-ant** *-ista* → **-ist**
makes a describing word	**makes either**
-oso → **-ous** *-mente* → **-ly**	*-ario* → **-ary**

Eight endings. Not one of them had to be memorised as vocabulary,

because each is the **same suffix** arriving in Spanish and English by different roads.

Grammar Lens: what each one costs you

Two things worth holding, because they save you a decision every time:
Gender is decided by the ending, not by you. *-ncia* is always feminine. *-ista* and *-ante* never change at all. *-oso* and *-ario* end in *-o*, so they shift when they are adjectives.
Reach differs enormously. *-mente* is unbounded — it attaches to adjectives you have not met yet. *-ción* reaches about two thousand words. *-ario* reaches far fewer. They are all worth having; they are not all worth the same.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the eight endings, and what each one makes

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which ending has no upper limit? (***-mente***.) Which reaches about two thousand words? (***-ción***.) And what did you memorise to get them? (**Nothing.**)

Chapter 65

Synthesis — Reading a Paragraph

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a paragraph of Spanish I was never taught.
>
> *I can read a paragraph of Spanish I was never taught.*

65.1 Synthesis — reading a paragraph

Decode *estación*. (**Station** — the *e-* off the front, the *-ción* to *-tion* at the back.)

Now a whole paragraph.

What you've built

Read it slowly. **Not one of these words appears anywhere else in this book.**

> *La comunidad literaria tiene una tradición extraordinaria. Su estructura es voluntaria, evidentemente, pero la actividad es enorme.*

Now check yourself:

what you saw	how you got it
comunidad	*-dad* → **-ty**
literaria	*-ario*, agreeing → **-ary**
tradición	*-ción* → **-tion**
extraordinaria	*-ario*, agreeing → **-ary**
estructura	take the *e-* off → **structure**
voluntaria	*-ario*, agreeing → **-ary**
evidentemente	*-mente* → **-ly**
actividad	*-dad* → **-ty**

The literary community has an extraordinary tradition. Its structure is voluntary, evidently, but the activity is enormous.

Nine words. Eight fell to rules you hold, and the ninth is below.

Grammar Lens: what actually changed

The endings were never the point. This is:

A paragraph of unfamiliar Spanish is no longer a wall. Most of it is words you already know, wearing clothes you have learned to recognise. That change of expectation is worth more than any single word, because it is what lets you read above your level and get most of it — which is how the rest of the language arrives.

Enorme is the ninth, and no ending gives it to you. You guessed it anyway, from **enormous**, and the guess was right. That is what the rules are really for: they do not decode every word, they make the guessing **safe**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the paragraph, out loud, all of it

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many of those words appear anywhere else in this book? (**None.**) How many did you read? (**All of them.**) And what is the real change? (An unfamiliar paragraph is **no longer a wall**.)

Chapter 66

Falsos Amigos — the Words That Obey and Lie

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can spot a false friend by checking a decoded word against the sentence.
>
> *Recognise exito, actualmente and libreria as words that obey the rules and mean something else.*

66.1 falsos amigos

Every rule in this book has come with the same warning: a **lead**, not a guarantee.

Today is the chapter where the lead is wrong, on purpose.

Grammar Lens: the words that answer and lie

> **A false friend is not a word that breaks your rules. It is a word that obeys them and still means something else.**

A word that resists every rule just looks foreign, and you look it up. A false friend hands you an answer with a straight face.

Spanish	your rule says	it actually means
éxito	exit	**success**
actualmente	actually	**currently**
librería	library	**bookshop**
embarazada	embarrassed	**pregnant**
ropa	rope	**clothes**

Most are not coincidences. They are roots the two languages shared and then walked away from:

- *exitus* was **a going out**. English kept the door — *exit*. Spanish kept the outcome: the way a thing *came out*, then a good one. **Success.**
- Latin *actuālis* was about **action**. Through Old French it came to mean *now existing*; Spanish kept that time sense, and English kept going, to *real*. Both moved — in different directions.
- A *librería* is where *libros* are: a **bookshop**. The building that lends them is a *biblioteca*.

One of the five is a genuine accident. *Ropa* is Germanic, from a word for *plunder*; *rope* is a different Germanic word. They did not drift apart — they collided. Both kinds exist.

Why it's said this way

The rule is not "distrust the rules." Your endings are still right about two thousand *-ción* words. What this adds is a second question, asked **after** the ending answers:

> Does the meaning fit what is being said?

Estoy embarazada, from someone apologising, is not *I am embarrassed* — the sentence would be strange. The ending offered a candidate; the **context** rejected it. Five false friends is not a list to memorise. It is a **habit**.

Your turn

- *Say it: éxito, actualmente, librería* — and what each really means

Twice through:

Before you move on

What makes a false friend dangerous rather than merely hard? (It **obeys** your rules.) And what is the second question, after the ending answers? (**Does the meaning fit the sentence?**)

Chapter 67

Tener in the Plural, and the Stem-Change Rule

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use tener in every person, and state when a stem changes and when it does not.
>
> *The stem breaks exactly where it is stressed - so nosotros and vosotros never break, in any verb.*

67.1 tenemos — and the stem change disappears

Say "I have" and "you have." (*Tengo, tienes.*) And "we eat." (*Comemos.*)

Grammar Lens: the break is gone

tenemos — *we have.* · **tenéis** — *you all have.*

Not *tienemos*. Look at what happened: *tienes* had the broken stem **ie**, and here it is plain **e** again — the ordinary *-er* endings, on the ordinary stem.

You already know why. It is the same reason `-er` and `-ir` looked identical in the singular and parted in the plural: **stress**.

Tienes stresses the stem, and a stressed **e** in that position breaks into **ie**. *Tenemos* stresses the *ending*, so the stem is unstressed and its vowel stays whole.

The stem change was never a property of the verb. It is a property of

where the stress lands, and these two forms are where the stress lands elsewhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "tienes" then "tenemos" — and hear the stress move off the stem
- "comemos, tenemos" — the same endings

Before you move on

What is "we have"? (**Tenemos**.) Where did the **ie** go? (Nowhere — it only ever appears when the **stem** is stressed.) Next: the form where the stress comes back.

67.2 tienen — the break comes back

Say "we have", then "you have" to a friend. (*Tenemos, tienes.*) Which one has the broken stem?

Grammar Lens: the rule, stated once and for all

tienen — *they have*, and **ustedes tienen**, *you all have*.

The **ie** is back. And now you have seen it appear, vanish and return, which is enough to state the rule outright:

> **A stem change happens exactly where the stem is stressed, and nowhere else.**

That is four forms with the break — setting aside the *yo* form, which has an oddity of its own — and two without: *nosotros* and *vosotros*. Always those two. In every stem-changing verb in the language. Learners are usually told to memorise a shape called "the boot" — the four stressed forms drawn as an outline around a table. **You do not need the boot.** You need to know where Spanish puts its stress, which you already do.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "tienes, tenemos, tienen" — break, no break, break
- the two forms that never break, for any verb

Before you move on

What is "they have"? (**Tienen**.) State the stem-change rule. (**The stem breaks exactly where it is stressed.**) Which two forms never break? (*Nosotros* and *vosotros*.)

Chapter 68

Ir in the Plural — a Verb That Is Not Ir

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use ir in every person, and say why its present belongs to a different verb.
>
> *The present of ir is regular for vadere - and the four commonest verbs are now complete.*

68.1 vamos — from a verb that is not *ir*

Say "I go." (*Voy.*) And "we speak." (*Hablamos.*)

Grammar Lens: -amos and -áis, on a stem you have not seen

vamos — *we go.* · **vais** — *you all go.*

The endings are ordinary. **-amos** and **-áis** are the plain *-ar* endings from *hablamos* and *habláis*.
What is strange is the stem. The infinitive is *ir*, and there is no *v* in it anywhere — yet every one of these forms begins with one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You met this shape two chapters ago and now you can use it as a tool. **Ir is not one verb.** Latin had **īre**, "to go", which gives the infinitive *ir* and little else. It also had **vādere**, "to advance, to make one's way",

which gives *voy*, *vas*, *va*, *vamos*, *vais* and one more — the entire present tense.
So the present of *ir* is not irregular. It is **regular for a different verb**, one whose infinitive Spanish stopped using. The endings behave perfectly; they are simply attached to a stem the dictionary form does not show you.
That is the third time this pattern has explained something: *ser* from *esse* and *sedēre*, and now *ir* from *īre* and *vādere*. **English does it too** — *go* and *went*, where *went* is really the past of *wend*.

> The commonest verbs in a language are the likeliest to be made of more than one, because they are used so much that no single word's forms survive intact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablamos, vamos" — the same ending, an unexpected stem
- "voy, vas, va, vamos, vais" — all one verb, and it is not *ir*

Before you move on

What is "we go"? (**Vamos**.) Which Latin verb do these forms come from? (***Vādere***.) And what does that make *ir*? (**Two verbs**, like *ser* — and like English *go* and *went*.)

68.2 van — and the four are done

Say "we go." (*Vamos*.) And "they speak." (*Hablan*.)

Grammar Lens: the last form

van — *they go*, and **ustedes van**, *you all go*.

Latin's form was *vadunt*. Spanish wore it down to three letters, and the rule still holds visibly: a final **-n**, and the subject is plural and not you.

What you've built

Four chapters ago you could conjugate any *regular* verb in the present, and none of the irregular ones. Now the four commonest verbs in Spanish are complete in every person:
ser · **estar** · **tener** · **ir** — *to be*, *to be*, *to have*, *to go*.
And each one taught something that outlives it:

- ***ser*** — two Latin verbs fused, so the seam shows at *eres*.
- ***estar*** — one verb, so it is regular; the accent only marks stress.
- ***tener*** — the stem breaks exactly where it is stressed, in **every** stem-changing verb, which is why *nosotros* and *vosotros* never break.
- ***ir*** — its present belongs to a different verb entirely.

Three of those four are about the same underlying thing: **a verb that looks chaotic is usually more than one word**, and the places it looks regular are the places one word survived intact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "somos, estamos, tenemos, vamos" — the four, in the *we* form
- "son, están, tienen, van" — the four, in the *they* form

Twice through: Until all four run without a gap.

Before you move on

What is "they go"? (**Van**.) Name the four verbs you have just completed. (*Ser, estar, tener, ir.*) And what do three of them have in common? (Each is **more than one Latin verb**, or its stem change follows the stress.)

Chapter 69

Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can express singular wanting and ability, compare the learned e-to-ie and o-to-ue changes, and say our with a known singular noun.

Complete ES-C11-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate singular querer and poder, the learned vowel-change contrast, and nuestro or nuestra before a known singular noun.

69.1 querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change

You already say **tienes** and **tiene**, where the middle **e** opens into **ie**. Today, reuse that visible change in one useful verb and keep the same three-person frame you already own.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ie — begin **quiero** with one smooth *kye-* syllable.
- r-tap — end the infinitive **querer** with one light tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

querer means "to want." With a person as its object, it can also express love, but wanting is the meaning used in this lesson.
It descends from Latin **quaerere**, "to seek or ask." English keeps the same searching idea in **query**, **quest**, **inquire**, and **require**. Wanting something begins as seeking it.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of querer
yo	**quiero**
tú	**quieres**
él / ella / usted	**quiere**

Say the small set as **quiero · quieres · quiere**. The **e → ie** that you saw in **tienes, tiene** is visible again. The plural persons are deliberately left for a later step.
Place one known infinitive after the form of **querer**:

- **Quiero hablar.** — "I want to speak."
- **Quieres comer.** — "You want to eat."
- **Quiere vivir.** — "He, she, or formal you wants to live."

The second verb stays in its known infinitive form.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "querer — quiero, quieres, quiere"
- "Quiero hablar"
- "quaerere — query — querer"

Before you move on

What does *querer* mean? ("To want.") Give the three learned forms. (*Quiero, quieres, quiere.*) Which Latin verb and English cousin help explain it? (*Quaerere*, "seek"; *query* or *quest.*) Next: add the other

singular vowel change with **poder**.

69.2 poder — ability with the o → ue change

Quiero hablar says what you want to do. Now change the first verb to say what you are able to do. The second verb will remain a known infinitive.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — **puedo** begins *pwe-* with one smooth glide.
- r-tap — end **poder** with one light tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poder means "to be able"; in a sentence it often translates as "can." It descends through Latin **potere** from **posse**, "to be able." English **power**, **potent**, **potential**, and **possible** belong to the same family. Ability is the power to do something.

Grammar Lens: the three singular forms

person	present of poder
yo	**puedo**
tú	**puedes**
él / ella / usted	**puede**

Say **puedo** · **puedes** · **puede**. In these three learned forms, the stem **o** opens into **ue**. Plural persons wait.
Follow the form of **poder** with one unchanged infinitive:

- **Puedo hablar.** — "I can speak."
- **Puedes comer.** — "You can eat."
- **Puede vivir.** — "He, she, or formal you can live."

Compare **Quiero hablar** with **Puedo hablar**: only the first verb changes the meaning from want to ability.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "poder — puedo, puedes, puede"
- "Puedo hablar"
- "poder — power — possible"

Before you move on

What does *poder* mean? ("To be able; can.") Give the three learned forms. (*Puedo, puedes, puede.*) What English word is its close cousin? (*Power.*) Next: compare only the singular forms you have actually learned.

69.3 e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms

You now own three small singular sets: **tengo, tienes, tiene**; **quiero, quieres, quiere**; and **puedo, puedes, puede**. Compare only those learned forms before extending the pattern later.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

On the road from Latin to Spanish, many short **e** and **o** vowels opened when stressed: **e → ie** and **o → ue**. That history helps explain why a verb's stem can look different across its forms.
It is a clue, not a machine that predicts every form. Learn each verb's small set, then use the shared history to organize what you remember.

Grammar Lens: two changes, one learned frame

person	**tener / querer, e → ie family**	**poder, o → ue**
yo	**tengo / quiero**	**puedo**
tú	**tienes / quieres**	**puedes**
él / ella / usted	**tiene / quiere**	**puede**

The comparison says exactly this:

- **querer** shows **ie** in all three forms learned here.
- **poder** shows **ue** in all three forms learned here.
- **tener** reminds you that a common verb may combine more than one change: **tengo** has its known **g**, while **tienes** and **tiene** show **ie**.

No plural form and no new verb is part of today's generalization.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "quiero, quieres, quiere"
- "puedo, puedes, puede"
- "stressed e and o often opened to ie and ue"

Before you move on

Which change appears in *querer*? (**e** → **ie**.) In *poder*? (**o** → **ue**.) Why is the history useful but not a complete prediction rule? (It organizes learned forms, but individual verbs can combine or resist changes.) Next: one possessive that agrees with a known noun's gender.

69.4 nuestro, nuestra — "our" with singular gender agreement

You put **mi, tu,** or **su** before the known noun **café**. Now add "our" and let it match one contrast you learned much earlier: masculine **día** beside feminine **noche**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nuestro and **nuestra** mean "our." They descend from Latin **noster**, also "our." **Paternoster** means "Our Father," and English **nostrum** originally meant "our thing."
The change from *noster* to **nuestro** also displays the historical **o** →

ue opening you just used to organize **poder**.

Grammar Lens: match singular gender

known noun	**"our" phrase**
el día, masculine	**nuestro día**
la noche, feminine	**nuestra noche**

Like **mi, tu,** and **su**, the new word goes before the noun. Unlike those earlier forms, it shows the noun's gender: **nuestro** before a masculine singular noun, **nuestra** before a feminine singular noun.
Only these two singular forms belong to this lesson. Plural agreement and the separate word for "your" to a group wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "nuestro día"
- "nuestra noche"
- "noster — nuestro — Paternoster"

Before you move on

Which form goes before masculine *día*? (*Nuestro.*) Before feminine *noche*? (*Nuestra.*) What Latin source explains the pair? (*Noster*, "our.") Next: retrieve the whole chapter without adding a form.

69.5 Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve two three-form verbs, compare their two vowel changes, and choose **nuestro** or **nuestra** before one known singular noun.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- wanting: **quiero** · **quieres** · **quiere** plus a known infinitive.
- ability: **puedo** · **puedes** · **puede** plus a known infinitive.
- the contrast: **e** → **ie** in the learned *querer* set; **o** → **ue** in the learned *poder* set.
- singular "our": **nuestro día** · **nuestra noche**.

Plural persons and plural possessive agreement remain deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **querer** continues Latin *quaerere*, "seek," the family of **query**.
- **poder** continues the Latin ability family behind **power** and **possible**.
- stressed Latin **e** and **o** often opened into Spanish **ie** and **ue**.
- **nuestro, nuestra** continue Latin *noster*, "our."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "quiero hablar; puedo hablar"
- "quieres comer; puedes comer"
- "nuestro día; nuestra noche"

Before you move on

Give the two singular sets. (*Quiero, quieres, quiere; puedo, puedes, puede.*) Which vowel contrast organizes them? (**e** → **ie** beside **o** → **ue**.) Say "our day" and "our night." (*Nuestro día; nuestra noche.*) The next chapter can now build from this closed singular frontier.

Chapter 70

Hacer, Decir, and the -go Verb Club

Modes: **voice** (3) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the three learned singular forms of hacer and decir and compare tengo, hago, and digo without predicting unseen verbs.
>
> *Complete ES-C12-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise with known words and only the learned singular person frame.*

70.1 hacer — doing or making with three singular forms

You already use **tengo, tienes, tiene**, and you already know **café** and the question word **qué**. Reuse that small frontier for one verb that covers both English "do" and "make."

Sounds you'll need

The **h** in **hacer** is silent, just as it is in **hola**. In **hago**, the written **g** has the hard sound heard before **a**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hacer means "to do" or "to make." It descends from Latin **facere**, with the same making root preserved in English **fact**, **factory**, and **manufacture**. Much of early Castilian changed word-initial Latin **f**

into an **h** sound that later became silent, leaving the spelling as a historical trace.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of hacer
yo	**hago**
tú	**haces**
él / ella / usted	**hace**

Say the bounded set as **hago · haces · hace**. Only the learned **yo** form contains **g**. Compare it with the familiar **tengo**, but do not extend the comparison beyond forms you already own.
Use the forms with one known object:

- **Hago café.** — "I make coffee."
- **Haces café.** — "You make coffee."
- **Hace café.** — "He, she, or formal you makes coffee."

You can also ask **¿Qué haces?** — "What are you doing?" Plural persons and weather expressions wait for later lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hacer — hago, haces, hace"
- "¿Qué haces? Hago café."
- "facere — fact — factory — hacer"

Before you move on

What two English verbs does *hacer* cover? ("Do" and "make.") Give the three learned forms. (*Hago, haces, hace.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Facere*; *fact* or *factory.*) Next: add **decir** without widening the person frame.

70.2 decir — saying with the same small person frame

You can ask **cómo**, say **hola**, and retrieve **hago, haces, hace**. Keep those three persons fixed while adding the verb "to say."

Sounds you'll need

In **digo**, the **g** before **o** is hard. Keep the **i** in all three learned forms short and clear: **digo, dices, dice**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

decir means "to say" or "to tell." It descends from Latin **dīcere**, "to say." English keeps the same root in **diction**, **dictionary**, **predict** ("say beforehand"), and **verdict** ("a true saying").

Grammar Lens: one more three-form set

person	present of decir
yo	**digo**
tú	**dices**
él / ella / usted	**dice**

Say **digo** · **dices** · **dice**. The **yo** form has **g**, while the other two learned forms do not. Do not build a full table or a general vowel-change rule from this small set yet.
Now combine it only with known language:

- **Digo hola.** — "I say hello."
- **Dices hola.** — "You say hello."
- **Dice hola.** — "He, she, or formal you says hello."
- **¿Cómo dices "hola"?** — "How do you say 'hello'?"

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "decir — digo, dices, dice"

- "Digo hola. ¿Cómo dices hola?"
- "dīcere — diction — decir"

Before you move on

What does *decir* mean? ("To say" or "to tell.") Give the three learned forms. (*Digo, dices, dice.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Dīcere*; *diction*, *dictionary*, or *predict.*)
Next: compare only the three **yo** forms you have actually learned.

70.3 tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know

Three learned verbs now place **g** in the **yo** form: **tengo, hago, digo**. Compare those three without guessing the form of any unseen verb.

Grammar Lens: one visible corner

infinitive	meaning	learned yo form	learned tú form
tener	to have	**tengo**	**tienes**
hacer	to do / make	**hago**	**haces**
decir	to say / tell	**digo**	**dices**

The shared observation is narrow: each learned **yo** form ends in **-go**, while each learned **tú** form does not. This is a memory organizer for three known forms, not permission to manufacture new ones.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The three modern forms did not arise by attaching one productive Latin **-go** ending. Older stem sounds changed in different ways, and analogy helped common verbs converge on a familiar shape. That mixed history explains why the group is useful to remember but unsafe as a prediction rule.
Later lessons can introduce other verbs on their own evidence. For now, the complete comparison is exactly **tengo · hago · digo**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "tengo — hago — digo"
- "tienes — haces — dices"
- "a memory organizer, not a prediction machine"

Before you move on

Which three learned **yo** forms end in **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo.*) May this comparison predict an unseen verb? (No.) Why not? (Different sound histories and analogy converged on the same shape.) Next: retrieve the whole chapter without adding any word or form.

70.4 Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve two bounded three-form sets, use them with known words, and compare only **tengo, hago, digo**.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- doing or making: **hago** · **haces** · **hace**.
- saying or telling: **digo** · **dices** · **dice**.
- the learned **yo** comparison: **tengo** · **hago** · **digo**.
- known-word use: **Hago café. Digo hola. ¿Cómo dices "hola"?**

Plural persons, weather nouns, homework vocabulary, and unseen verbs remain outside this checkpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **hacer** continues Latin *facere*, the making family of **fact** and **factory**.

- **decir** continues Latin *dīcere*, the saying family of **diction** and **predict**.
- inherited sound changes and analogy made three known **yo** forms converge on **-go**; the resemblance does not predict forms you have not learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hago, haces, hace"
- "digo, dices, dice"
- "tengo, hago, digo"
- "Hago café. Digo hola."

Before you move on

Give both three-form sets. (*Hago, haces, hace; digo, dices, dice.*) Which three learned **yo** forms share **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo.*) Why is that comparison a memory aid rather than a prediction rule? (Its mixed history does not license unseen forms.) The next chapter may now introduce its own verbs one at a time.

Chapter 71

Poner — Putting, and the Root Under Position

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I put, with the -go yo form and regular forms elsewhere.
>
> *pongo in the yo slot, pones and pone everywhere else.*

71.1 poner — putting or placing with three singular forms

You already know **hago, haces, hace** and the careful comparison **tengo · hago · digo**. Add one verb on its own evidence: **poner**, "to put" or "to place."

Sounds you'll need

The **g** in **pongo** has the familiar hard sound. Tap the final **r** of **poner** lightly; do not turn it into the stronger written **rr** sound.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poner descends from Latin **pōnere**, "to put or place." English keeps the same placing family in **position**, **compose** ("place together"), and **deposit** ("place down"). The two shapes **pon-** and **pos-** are historical relatives, so *poner* and *position* are cousins even though their endings differ.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of poner
yo	**pongo**
tú	**pones**
él / ella / usted	**pone**

Say the bounded set as **pongo · pones · pone**. The learned **yo** form joins the known comparison because it ends in **-go**. That resemblance helps memory; it still does not predict an unseen verb. For now, practise the forms and their meaning without importing a new object. Later lessons can add the nouns needed for expressions such as setting a table or putting on clothing. Plural persons and reflexive **ponerse** also wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "poner — pongo, pones, pone"
- "pōnere — position — poner"
- "a learned comparison, not a prediction rule"

Before you move on

What does *poner* mean? ("To put" or "to place.") Give its three learned forms. (*Pongo, pones, pone.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Pōnere*; *position*, *compose*, or *deposit.*) Next: learn **salir** inside the same three-person frame.

Chapter 72

Salir — Leaving

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that I leave, and use the regular forms for anyone else.
>
> *salgo in the yo slot; sales and sale behave normally.*

72.1 salir — leaving with three singular forms

You can retrieve **pongo, pones, pone**, and you already use **de** with a place name. Keep that frontier while adding **salir**, "to leave" or "to go out."

Sounds you'll need

The **g** in **salgo** is hard. Keep the **l** clear in every form: **salgo, sales, sale**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

salir descends from Latin **salīre**, "to leap" or "to jump." The older image of leaping outward developed into the everyday meaning "to go out." English **salient** first carried the sense "leaping" or "springing," and a **sally** is a sudden movement outward. Those cousins preserve the same motion without requiring a long list of uncertain relatives.

Grammar Lens: one more singular set

person	present of salir
yo	**salgo**
tú	**sales**
él / ella / usted	**sale**

Say **salgo** · **sales** · **sale**. Only the learned **yo** form contains **g**. Compare it with **pongo** because both forms are now known, not because one form could have predicted the other.
Reuse the known word **de** and the familiar place name Madrid:

- **Salgo de Madrid.** — "I leave Madrid."
- **Sales de Madrid.** — "You leave Madrid."
- **Sale de Madrid.** — "He, she, or formal you leaves Madrid."

Plural persons, dating expressions, house vocabulary, and the noun for "exit" wait until their own lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "salir — salgo, sales, sale"
- "Salgo de Madrid."
- "salīre — salient — salir"

Before you move on

What does *salir* mean? ("To leave" or "to go out.") Give the three learned forms. (*Salgo, sales, sale.*) What did Latin *salīre* mean? ("To leap" or "to jump.") Name one English cousin. (*Salient* or *sally.*) Next: add **venir** and compare it only with already-learned **tener**.

Chapter 73

Venir — Coming

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that I come, and hear the stem break in the other two forms.
>
> *vengo, then vienes and viene with the ie break.*

73.1 venir — coming with three singular forms

You can say **salgo de Madrid**, and you already know **tengo, tienes, tiene**. Now learn **venir**, "to come," inside exactly the same three singular persons.

Sounds you'll need

The **g** in **vengo** is hard. In **vienes** and **viene**, let **ie** move as one smooth vowel sequence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

venir descends from Latin **venīre**, "to come." English **convene** means "come together"; an **event** is something that "comes out"; and **adventure** passed through the idea of what may "come to" a person. The recurring **ven-** or **vent-** shape marks this old coming family.

Grammar Lens: one known comparison, still singular

person	present of venir	known tener comparison
yo	**vengo**	**tengo**
tú	**vienes**	**tienes**
él / ella / usted	**viene**	**tiene**

Say **vengo** · **vienes** · **viene**. The learned singular forms line up closely with **tengo** · **tienes** · **tiene**: the **yo** form ends in **-go**, while the other two show **ie**. This comparison describes two complete learned sets; it does not introduce a plural "boot" table or license guesses about other verbs.
Now contrast leaving and coming with known **de** and Madrid:

- **Salgo de Madrid.** — "I leave Madrid."
- **Vengo de Madrid.** — "I come from Madrid."
- **Vienes de Madrid.** — "You come from Madrid."

Plural persons and free-standing arrival vocabulary wait for later lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "venir — vengo, vienes, viene"
- "Vengo de Madrid."
- "vengo / tengo — vienes / tienes"

Before you move on

What does *venir* mean? ("To come.") Give its three learned forms. (*Vengo, vienes, viene.*) Which learned verb provides the close comparison? (*Tener*: *tengo, tienes, tiene.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Venīre*; *convene*, *event*, or *adventure*.) Next: compare all six learned **yo** forms only after retrieving this chapter's three verbs.

Chapter 74

Review — Six Verbs, One Ending

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name all six -go verbs and say why the list is closed.
>
> *The club is complete at six - and it was never a club, only six unrelated verbs that converged.*

74.1 Review — six verbs, one ending

Nothing new in this chapter. Say the *yo* forms of the three verbs you have just met: *poner*, *salir*, *venir*.

What you've built

The set is closed. Six of the commonest verbs in Spanish put an unexpected **-go** on the *yo* form and nowhere else:

verb	*yo*	and the rest behaves
tener	**tengo**	normally
hacer	**hago**	normally
decir	**digo**	normally
poner	**pongo**	normally
salir	**salgo**	normally
venir	**vengo**	normally

Six verbs, one oddity, and it lives in exactly one slot. That is a much smaller thing to carry than "six irregular verbs."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is what the six chapters could not show you separately.
They are not a family. Nobody decided these six belonged together. They came from different Latin verbs, by different routes, and arrived at the same ending by accident — a *g* that was already in some of the stems, and a sound change that pulled the others into line behind them.
The club is a result, not a rule. Spanish learners are taught "the *-go* verbs" as though someone had drawn up a membership list; what actually happened is that six unrelated words drifted into the same shape and then reinforced each other.
That is worth knowing for a practical reason: it tells you the list is **closed**. A pattern with a cause keeps recruiting. A pattern that is an accident stops.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six *yo* forms in one breath — tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo
- for each, the plain infinitive it came from

Twice through: Until the six run together as one list.

Before you move on

How many verbs take *-go*? (**Six**.) In how many slots? (**One** — the *yo* form.) And why does the list not grow? (Because it was never a rule — six unrelated verbs happened to converge.)

74.2 Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve the three bounded singular sets first. Only then widen the memory comparison from three learned **yo** forms to six.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

- putting or placing: **pongo · pones · pone**.
- leaving or going out: **salgo · sales · sale**.
- coming: **vengo · vienes · viene**.
- known-word contrast: **Salgo de Madrid. Vengo de Madrid.**
- known singular comparison: **vengo / tengo · vienes / tienes · viene / tiene**.

Now that all three new verbs have been taught, the learned **yo** comparison can grow to exactly **tengo · hago · digo · pongo · salgo · vengo**. It remains a retrieval aid, not a rule for predicting any unseen verb.
Plural persons, full boot diagrams, reflexive clothing expressions, house and table nouns, clock times, dinner vocabulary, and other unseen contexts remain outside this checkpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **poner** continues Latin *pōnere*, the placing family of **position**.
- **salir** continues Latin *salīre*, the leaping family of **salient**.
- **venir** continues Latin *venīre*, the coming family of **convene**.
- different inherited histories and analogy let the six known **yo** forms converge on **-go**; the shared shape does not make a productive prediction rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "pongo, pones, pone"
- "salgo, sales, sale"
- "vengo, vienes, viene"
- "tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo"

Before you move on

Give all three new singular sets. (*Pongo, pones, pone; salgo, sales, sale; vengo, vienes, viene.*) Which six learned **yo** forms now share **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo.*) Why is the list a memory aid rather than a prediction rule? (Different histories converged on one shape.) The next chapter may now introduce a new time frame without borrowing any plural form from this chapter.

Chapter 75

Synthesis — You, and Somebody Else

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say the same thing about myself and about someone else, and know which of the two is irregular.
>
> *The oddity lives only in the yo slot - the form a beginner says most.*

75.1 Synthesis — you, and somebody else

Nothing new here. Say three of the six *-go* forms, whichever come first.

Grammar Lens: the odd slot is the one about you

Here is the practical shape of what you have, and it is worth noticing before you use it.
These six verbs are irregular **only when you talk about yourself.** Every one of them behaves normally the moment the sentence is about anybody else:

> **salgo** — but *sales*, *sale*. **pongo** — but *pones*, *pone*. **vengo** — but *vienes*, *viene*.

So the cost of the whole set is one form each, and it is the form you will use most, because most of what a beginner says is about themselves. That is a good trade, and it is not an accident of teaching order: the verbs that wore down oddly are the ones people said constantly.

The exchange

The same two sentences, once about you and once about a friend. Watch which word changes shape and which does not:

Salgo. — *I'm leaving.* **Sales.** — *You're leaving.*

Vengo. — *I'm coming.* **Viene.** — *He's coming.*

One word each time, no pronoun, and the only surprise is in the first line of each pair.

What you've built

Six of the most common verbs in the language, in the person you speak in most. You can now say that you have, do, say, put, leave and come — about yourself, in one word, with no pronoun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- each pair above — first about yourself, then about someone else
- all six *yo* forms, then all six *tú* forms, and hear the difference vanish

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which slot in these six verbs is irregular? (**Only** the *yo* form.) How many words does "I'm leaving" take? (**One** — *salgo.*) Why is that one form worth the trouble? (Because it is the one you will say most.)

Chapter 76

Deriving the Rest

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can produce the plural of any irregular verb in this book from rules, and conjugate a verb I was never shown.
>
> *Three rules generate the whole present tense - and a system, unlike a table, works on words it has never seen.*

76.1 queremos, quieren — work them out first

> Before you read on: you have the singular of *querer*, and you have the stem-change rule. **What is "we want"?** Say your answer out loud, then continue.

Grammar Lens: you were right

> **queremos** — *we want.* · **quieren** — *they want.*
> **podemos** — *we can.* · **pueden** — *they can.*

If you said *queremos* rather than *quieremos*, you did not remember it. You **derived** it, from a rule you were given one chapter ago: the stem breaks exactly where it is stressed, so *nosotros* never breaks.
And *quieren* breaks, because there the stress is back on the stem.
That is the difference between a course that hands you tables and one that hands you rules. Four forms you had never seen, and none of them needed teaching.

> **A test you can run yourself.** You have *puedo* and

puedes. Without being told, what are *we can* and *they can*?

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the *yo*, *nosotros* and *ellos* forms of *querer* — break, no break, break
- the same three for *poder*

Before you move on

What is "we want"? (**Queremos**.) Why no break? (The stress is on the **ending**.) And could you have produced these without this lesson? (**Yes** — which is the point of it.)

76.2 hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all

Name the six *-go* verbs. And say where in each one the *-go* appears.

Grammar Lens: an oddity that was only ever in one slot

You were told, when the club closed, that the **-go** lives in the *yo* form and nowhere else. Here is what that is worth:

hacemos · **hacéis** · **hacen** — plain *-er* endings.
ponemos · **ponéis** · **ponen** — plain *-er* endings.
salimos · **salís** · **salen** — plain *-ir* endings.

Nothing to learn. The *-go* club has no plural forms of its own, because the thing that made it a club was never in the plural to begin with. Two of the six do something in the plural, and it is **not** the *-go*:

decimos but **dicen** · **venimos** but **vienen**

Those are stem changes, and they follow the rule you already have — the stem breaks where it is stressed, and *nosotros* is never stressed on the stem. So even the exceptions are not exceptions.

What you've built

Two rules — **the *-go* is yo-only**, and **stems break under stress** — now generate the entire present tense of every irregular verb in this book, in every person.
That is what a rule buys that a table does not: the table stops at the forms printed on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six *-go* verbs in the *we* form — and hear that none is odd
- "decimos, dicen" and "venimos, vienen" — the two that break, and why

Before you move on

How many special plural forms does the *-go* club have? (**None** — the *-go* was only ever in *yo*.) Which two do something in the plural, and what? (*Decir* and *venir* — a **stem change**, following the stress.) How many rules now generate every irregular present in this book? (**Two**.)

76.3 Synthesis — a verb you have never met

Nothing new in this chapter, and nothing to memorise. Say the six endings of a regular *-er* verb.

What you've built

Everything you hold about the present tense now fits in three lines:

1. **Three families**, six endings each; `-er` and `-ir` differ only in *nosotros* and *vosotros*.
2. **A stem breaks exactly where it is stressed** — so *nosotros* and *vosotros* never break.
3. **A `-go` sits in the *yo* form and nowhere else.**

That is the whole system. Not a summary of it — the system.

And a system, unlike a table, works on words it has never seen.

The exchange

Here is a verb this book has not taught you: **beber**, "to drink" — you have met the word, but never its full set.

Do not look anything up. It is a regular `-er` verb, so:

bebo · bebes · bebe · bebemos · bebéis · beben

Six forms, and the only thing you needed was rule 1.

Now one that uses all three rules. **Salir** is an `-ir` verb, and it is in the `-go` club. Rules 1 and 3 give you every form, and you can produce them before reading on:

salgo · sales · sale · salimos · salís · salen

One odd form, in the one slot rule 3 names. The other five are plain `-ir`.

Four broken, two whole, and the two whole ones are the two the stress leaves alone. Every time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all six of *beber*, without looking
- all six of *salir*, and name the only odd one

Twice through: Until deriving is faster than remembering.

Before you move on

State the three rules. (**Three families · stems break under stress · the -go is yo-only**.) Which two forms never break? (*Nosotros*, *vosotros*.) And what can you do now that a table could not give you? (**Conjugate a verb nobody taught me**.)

Chapter 77

La Comida — A Noun You Can Build

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build comida from comer with -ida, and know that nouns made this way are feminine.
>
> *Complete ES-C43-comida: derive comida from comer and say what gender the -ida ending guarantees.*

77.1 la comida — "food," built from a verb you have

Say "to eat." (*Comer.*) Keep it in mind — this chapter's noun is made out of it, in front of you.

Sounds you'll need

- `d-soft` — the *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* in English *this*: *ko-MEE-thah*, not a hard *d*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la comida — *food*, and also *a meal*.

Take *comer*, drop the ending, add **-ida**:

comer → **com**ida — literally *the eaten thing*.

That ending is not decoration. It is a working tool: it takes a verb and

hands you back a noun for the **result** of that verb. You will meet it again and recognise it when you do.
This is the first Spanish noun you did not have to be given. You could have built it. That is a different kind of possession from memorising a list, and it is the reason the ending is worth more here than the word.
Comer itself comes from Latin **comedere** — *ed-* is "eat," the same ancient root as English **eat**, with *com-* ("thoroughly") in front. So *comida* is, at the bottom, "the thoroughly-eaten thing."

Grammar Lens: -ida nouns are feminine

Nouns built this way end in *-a* and are **feminine**, every time. So the ending gives you two things at once: the word, and its gender.

la comida — the food. *Hago la comida.* — I make the meal.

Set your three nouns side by side and the pattern is doing all the work:

noun	gender	article
libro	masculine	**el**
casa	feminine	**la**
comida	feminine	**la**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "comer" then "comida" — hear the verb inside the noun
- "Hago la comida"

Before you move on

What verb is hiding inside *comida*? (***Comer***.) What does the *-ida* ending give you besides the word? (Its **gender** — always feminine.) Next: what happens to these three nouns, and to their articles, when there is more than one of something.

Chapter 78

Las — The Plural Article That Behaves

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say las casas and las comidas, putting the plural -s on both the article and the noun.
>
> *Complete ES-C44-las: produce las casas and las comidas and say how many new rules the chapter added.*

78.1 las casas — "the houses"

You learned this in your first chapter: a noun ending in a vowel adds **-s**. So what is "houses"? (*Casas.*) Now — what is "**the** houses"?

Grammar Lens: the article does what the noun does

las — *the*, for more than one feminine thing.

la casa → ***las*** *casa**s*** — the houses. *la comida* → ***las*** *comida**s*** — the meals.

The *-s* lands on **both** words. That is not two rules; it is one rule applied where it belongs. You have already seen Spanish do this — *buenas noches* is *buena* copying *noche*'s number — and it is the same instinct throughout the language: **the words around a noun agree with it**, so when the noun goes plural, they follow.
So *las* is not a word to memorise. It is *la* obeying the rule you already hold.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la casa" then "las casas" — hear the *-s* twice
- "las comidas"

Before you move on

"The houses"? (***Las casas***.) Where did the *-s* go? (**Both** words.) Next: the masculine one, which does not do the obvious thing — and the reason will be familiar.

Chapter 79

Los — The One That Does Not Add -s

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say los libros and explain why the masculine plural article is not els.
>
> *Complete ES-C44-los: produce los libros, give all four articles, and say why el does not simply take an -s.*

79.1 los libros — "the books"

Last chapter: *la casa* → *las casas*. Apply the same move to *el libro* and say what you get, out loud, before reading on.

Grammar Lens: not els

If you said *els libros*, you did exactly the right thing and Spanish did not.

> **los** — *the*, for more than one masculine thing.
>
> *el libro* → ***los*** *libro**s*** — the books.

The noun behaved. The article did not: *el* became **los**, not *els*. Out of four articles this is the only one that changes more than its ending, and it is worth two minutes rather than a shrug.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You have met this exact story before, three chapters ago, wearing different clothes.

El is not a whole word that lost its way. It is a **worn-down** one: Latin *illum* gave *elo*, and *elo* lost its final vowel to become *el*. The plural came from *illos* — and it did **not** lose that vowel. It kept it, dropped the front instead, and arrived as **los**.

So the pair is not *el* + *s*. It is two forms of one Latin word that wore down in two different directions:

	singular	**plural**
masculine	*elo* → **el**	*illos* → **los**
feminine	*illam* → **la**	*illas* → **las**

This is the same shape as *el* and *lo*, which you met when the object pronouns started: the masculine forms lost a vowel where the feminine ones had none to lose. One sound change, showing up for the third time.

An "irregular" article turns out to be a regular word that was worn down twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el libro" then "los libros"
- "el, la, los, las" — the whole set, in order

Before you move on

"The books"? (***Los libros***.) Why not *els*? (*El* is worn down from *elo*; the **plural kept the vowel**.) Next: the plural rule your first chapter promised and did not give you.

Chapter 80

-es — The Plural Chapter One Promised

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can form the plural of a word ending in a consonant, and say why the extra vowel is there.
>
> *Complete ES-C44-plural-es: pluralise espanol, name the word that has carried this rule since long before the chapter, and say why -s alone will not do.*

80.1 -es — the plural your first chapter owed you

Say "you," formally. (*Usted.*) Now say it to a group. (*Ustedes.*) Hold both of those in your mouth for a moment.

Grammar Lens: you have been doing this for fifty chapters

Your first chapter gave you half a rule and said the rest was for later. This is later.

> **A word ending in a vowel adds *-s*. A word ending in a consonant adds *-es*.**

And you already know the second half, because you have been saying it since the day you learned to address a group:

> *usted* → *usted**es***.

That is not a special word. That is the consonant rule, and nobody told you. Here it is again on something you also hold:

> *español* → *español**es*** — Spanish people, Spanish speakers.
> *los españoles* — with the plural article from last chapter.

Why it's said this way

The extra *e* is not decoration and not an exception. Try saying *usteds* out loud. Then *españols*.
Spanish does not let a word end in that pile of consonants. So when the plural *-s* would land somewhere unsayable, the language puts in the vowel it needs to get the *-s* out — and that vowel is *e*.
Which means the rule is really **one** rule with a repair attached: *add -s; if you cannot say it, make room.* That is a better thing to hold than two rules, because it will keep explaining things long after this chapter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "usted" then "ustedes" — the rule you already had
- "los españoles"
- try "usteds" and hear why the *e* exists

Before you move on

Vowel ending — which plural? (**-s**.) Consonant ending? (**-es**.) And why? (A bare *-s* there would be **unsayable**.) Next: the four articles in one place, now that every one of them has been earned.

Chapter 81

Review — All Four Words for The

Modes: **voice** (1) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give el, la, los and las and state the plural rule including its consonant repair.
>
> *Complete ES-C44-repaso-articulos: give the four articles in order and state the plural rule in one sentence.*

81.1 Review — all four words for "the"

Nothing new here. Before the table: how many words does Spanish have for "the"?

What you've built

Four. And you have now met every one of them separately, which is why they are allowed to appear together.

	singular	**plural**
masculine	**el** libro	**los** libros
feminine	**la** casa	**las** casas

English has one word here and Spanish has four, so it is easy to read this table as three extra things to carry. It is not. It is **two** questions you were already answering — *which gender?* and *how many?* — laid out in a grid.

The first chapter of this book taught the top row. The last two chapters taught the bottom one. Nothing in this table arrived without being built.

Grammar Lens: the two plural rules

And underneath the grid, one rule with a repair:

> **Add *-s*. If the word ends in a consonant and the *-s* would be unsayable, add *-es* instead.**

- *casa* → *casas*, *libro* → *libros*, *comida* → *comidas* — vowels, plain *-s*.
- *usted* → *ustedes*, *español* → *españoles* — consonants, *-es*.

You held the first half from chapter one and the second half from *ustedes* without knowing it had a name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el, la, los, las" until the order is automatic
- "el libro, los libros, la casa, las casas"

Twice through: Until the grid is a reflex rather than a lookup.

Before you move on

Four articles — say them. (***El, la, los, las***.) Two questions decide which? (**Gender** and **number**.) Next: what happens to *a* when there is more than one — and the answer is not what you would expect.

81.2 Review — the half of *ir* you never say out loud

"We go." (*Vamos.*) "They go." (*Van.*)

What you've built

Three plural forms, and a *v* in every one of them.
We. *Vamos.* · **You all.** *Vais.* · **They.** *Van.*

Now say the infinitive after them: *ir*. No *v* anywhere in it.
That gap is the whole point. The forms you speak descend from **vādere**, "to make one's way." The name on the dictionary entry descends from **īre**. Two Latin verbs, one Spanish label — so the present tense is not irregular at all. It is perfectly regular, for a verb whose own infinitive Spanish stopped saying.

Why it's said this way

So what is left of *īre*? Almost nothing. The infinitive *ir*, and one door you already know how to open.
Remember what *comer* did when you took its ending off and put **-ida** on instead:

*com*er → la *com*ida — the eaten thing.

Do the same to *ir* and you get **la ida** — the going, the outward journey. Nobody had to teach you that word. The ending built it, and it built it on the one syllable *vādere* never took over.
That is worth more than either word. An ending that turns a verb into the result of the verb keeps working on stems the spoken language has abandoned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vamos*, *vais*, *van* — then *ir*, and hear the letter go missing
- *la comida*, *la ida* — one ending, two verbs

Twice through:

Before you move on

"You all go"? (***Vais***.) Which Latin verb do *vamos*, *vais* and *van* belong to? (***Vādere***.) And which one does *la ida* reach? (***Īre*** — the half of *ir* that stopped being spoken.)

Chapter 82

Synthesis — More Than One

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can contrast a bare plural with a definite plural, and know that the indefinite article is dropped rather than pluralised.
>
> *Complete ES-C44-sintesis-mas-de-uno: say tengo libros and tengo los libros and explain what separates them.*

82.1 Synthesis — more than one

Say "I have a book." (*Tengo un libro.*) Now say "I have books," and notice where you hesitate.

Grammar Lens: the article that leaves

The hesitation is the right instinct. *The* pluralised neatly — *el* became *los*. *A* cannot, because "a" and "more than one" disagree by definition. English solves this by swapping in another word: *a book* → *some books*, or just *books*. Spanish takes the shorter road:

> *Tengo* ***un*** *libro.* — I have a book. *Tengo libro****s****.* — I have books.

The article simply goes. Not replaced, not pluralised — dropped. A bare plural noun is a complete, ordinary Spanish phrase.
This is the mirror image of everything you have been doing. For fifty chapters Spanish has made you say *more* than English: two genders, four articles, six verb endings. Here, for once, it says less.

The exchange

Read this aloud and watch the two plurals doing different jobs.

> *— ¿Tienes libros? — Sí, tengo libros. — ¿Y los libros de la casa? — Los libros de la casa, no.*

Bare *libros* means "books, some books, books in general." *Los libros* means "**the** books" — particular ones, already known to both of you.

That is the same distinction English makes and never explains: *do you have books?* is a different question from *do you have the books?* You have simply never had to choose it deliberately before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Tengo un libro" then "Tengo libros" — hear the article vanish
- "libros" then "los libros", twice, until the two feel like different questions

Before you move on

"I have books"? (***Tengo libros*** — no article.) "I have the books"? (***Tengo los libros***.) Which article pluralises and which one leaves? (**The** pluralises; **a** leaves.) Next: the small words that let you stop naming a thing you have already named.

Chapter 83

Lo — Saying It Without Naming It

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can replace a masculine noun already named with lo, in front of the verb.
>
> *Complete ES-C42-lo: turn Tengo el libro into Lo tengo, and name the article that shares lo's Latin ancestor.*

83.1 lo — "it"

Say "my name is" in Spanish. (*Me llamo.*) Where does that little *me* sit — before the verb, or after it?

Grammar Lens: a slot you have been using all along

Before the verb. You have known that since your fourth chapter, and you have been doing it every time you say your name.
Here is a second word for that same slot.

> **lo** — *it*, standing in for something masculine.

Watch what it does:

> *Tengo* ***el libro.*** — I have the book. ***Lo*** *tengo.* — I have it.

The noun leaves; *lo* takes its place; and it goes where *me* goes — in front of the verb. Not one new rule. One new word for a slot you already own.

Notice that this only became possible last chapter. A pronoun replaces a noun, so it needs a noun to replace — which is why these three ordinary words came first.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Lo should look faintly familiar, and it should also look wrong. It is almost *el*, but not quite. That is not a coincidence, and the near-miss has a cause.

Latin *ille*, "that one," changed shape depending on the job it was doing. As the **object** of a verb it was **illum**. Spanish got both its article and its object pronoun out of that one word — and then wore it down twice, differently, because the two jobs put the stress in different places:

- Leaning on a noun, unstressed, it lost its vowel: *illum* → *elo* → ***el***.
- Standing alone in the verb's slot, it kept the vowel: *illum* → ***lo***.

So *el* and *lo* are the same ancient word, split by the work it was asked to do. English did something similar with *he* and *him*: one word, two shapes, and the shape tells you the job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Tengo el libro" then "Lo tengo" — hear the noun disappear
- "me llamo" then "lo tengo" — the same slot, twice

Before you move on

What does *lo* mean? (**It** — for something masculine.) Where does it go? (**Before** the verb.) Next: the same job, done by a word that never changed its shape at all.

Chapter 84

La — The Pronoun Carries What Left

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can replace a feminine noun with la, and explain that the pronoun carries a gender the sentence no longer states.
>
> *Complete ES-C42-la: turn Hago la comida into La hago and say what decides between lo and la.*

84.1 la — "it," for a feminine noun

Say "I have it," about the book. (*Lo tengo.*) Now guess the feminine version before you read on.

Grammar Lens: the form you probably guessed

> **la** — *it*, standing in for something feminine.
>
> *Hago* ***la comida.*** — I make the meal. ***La*** *hago.* — I make it.

If you guessed *la*, you were not lucky. You were doing what the shape of Spanish invites you to do: *el* and *la* mark the two genders everywhere else, so the object pronouns mark them the same way. The pronoun agrees with the **noun it replaces** — not with you, and not with the verb. *El libro* is masculine, so *lo*. *La comida* and *la casa* are feminine, so *la*.

That last point is worth pausing on. *La* here is not agreeing with anything present in the sentence. The noun is **gone**; the pronoun is carrying its gender on its behalf. This is the first time in Spanish that a word has had to remember something that is no longer being said.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Last chapter had a small mystery: why *lo* and not *el*, when both come from the same Latin word? Here that mystery quietly disappears.
The feminine object form in Latin was **illam**. Worn down as an article it gave *la*. Worn down as a pronoun it gave — *la*. Both routes arrived at the same place, because the vowel that got lost on the masculine side (*elo* → *el*) was never at risk on the feminine side.
So the masculine pair split into two shapes and the feminine pair did not. Not an exception to memorise: a single sound change that happened to bite one word and not the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Hago la comida" then "La hago"
- "lo tengo" then "la hago" — one syllable carries the whole difference

Before you move on

Which pronoun replaces a feminine noun? (**La**.) What decides it — you, the verb, or the noun? (The **noun**, even though it is no longer there.) Next: the same slot, for the two people actually talking.

Chapter 85

Me and Te — The Two People Talking

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say te quiero and me quieres, and tell the doer form apart from the object form.
>
> *Complete ES-C42-te: produce te quiero and me quieres, and name the English pair that matches tu and te.*

85.1 me quieres — "you love me"

Say "my name is." (*Me llamo.*) That *me* has been in your mouth for more than fifty chapters. This chapter gives it nothing new to look like — only something new to do.

Grammar Lens: the same word, a simpler job

In *me llamo*, the *me* points back at the speaker: *I call* ***myself***. That is a special use, and it was the one you needed first.
Here is the ordinary one:

> ***Me*** *quieres.* — You love **me**.

Now *me* is not pointing back at anybody. It is simply the person the verb lands on — the same job *lo* does for a book and *la* does for a meal.

> *Lo tengo.* — I have it. *Me quieres.* — You love me.

Same slot, in front of the verb. Same kind of work. The only difference is that *me* is a person and *lo* is a thing, which is a fact about the world rather than a fact about Spanish.
Notice what this chapter did **not** ask you to learn: a form. You already had it. Some of the ground you gain in a language is like this — not new material, but an old piece turning out to reach further than you were told.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Me comes from Latin **mē**, and Latin got it from something far older. English **me** is not a translation of it and not a borrowing from it — the two are the **same inherited word**, sitting in two languages that split thousands of years ago and never bothered to change it.
Words this short and this used are the ones that survive intact. That is why your very first Spanish pronoun was also the easiest one you will ever meet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "me llamo" then "me quieres" — the same syllable, two jobs
- "lo tengo" then "me quieres" — hear that the slot never moves

Before you move on

Say "you love me." (***Me quieres.***) Where did the pronoun go? (**Before** the verb, as always.) Next: the answering half of that sentence.

85.2 te quiero — "I love you"

Say "you love me." (*Me quieres.*) Now turn it around in your head: what would "I love you" need?

Grammar Lens: the partner of tú

te — *you*, when you are the one it happens to.

Te quiero. — I love you.

Tú is for the one doing; *te* is for the one it lands on. Spanish keeps those apart with two different shapes, the same way it keeps *el* and *lo* apart, and the same way English keeps *I* and *me* apart.

Me quieres. — You love me. *Te quiero.* — I love you.

Two words each, and a complete exchange. Read them aloud one after the other: the pair is a conversation.
One thing worth knowing before you use it. *Querer* means *to want*, and you have been using it that way for a long time. But *querer* pointed at a **person** does not mean wanting them — it means **loving** them. *Quiero un libro* is "I want a book"; *te quiero* is "I love you."
So the sentence is built entirely out of pieces you already had. What is new is not a form — it is that the verb changes its meaning depending on whether its object is a thing or a person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Te quiero" then "Me quieres" — a whole exchange in four words
- "tú" then "te", and hear which one is doing

Before you move on

Say "I love you." (***Te quiero.***) And "you love me." (***Me quieres.***)
Next: where *te* came from, and the English word that is the very same one.

85.3 te — the pair English used to have

Two shapes for one person: *tú* when they act, *te* when it lands on them.

English once had exactly the same two shapes, and they are the same two words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Te is Latin **tē** — the object form of **tū**, which you already have. Old English had **thou** for the doer and **thee** for the one it happened to. Here is the striking part: *tú*/*te* and *thou*/*thee* are not merely similar. They are **one ancient pair, inherited twice** — once down the Latin line into Spanish, once down the Germanic line into English. English later dropped both and let *you* cover the two jobs. Spanish kept them apart, which is why you have two words to learn where a speaker of English feels there should be one.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "tú" then "te", and "thou" then "thee" — the same split twice

Before you move on

Which English pair matches *tú* and *te*? (**Thou** and **thee**.) And which of the two means "the one it happened to"? (***Te*** — and *thee*.) Next: all four object pronouns in one place, for the first time.

Chapter 86

Review — Four Pronouns, One Slot

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name me, te, lo and la and say which of them a noun decides.
>
> *Complete ES-C42-repaso-objeto: give all four pronouns and identify the single question that chooses between them.*

86.1 Review — four pronouns, one slot

Nothing new in this chapter. Before the table: where does an object pronoun go?

What you've built

Four chapters, four words, and now they can stand together — because you built each one separately and none of them is new here.

the one it happens to	pronoun	example
me	**me**	*me quieres* — you love me
you	**te**	*te quiero* — I love you
it (masculine)	**lo**	*lo tengo* — I have it
it (feminine)	**la**	*la hago* — I make it

Read down the last column. The verb never moved. The pronoun

never moved. Only the first word changed, and it changed for one reason at a time.

Grammar Lens: the single question

Choosing between these looks like four decisions. It is one:
Who or what is the verb landing on?

- If it is you speaking → *me*.
- If it is the person you are speaking to → *te*.
- If it is a thing or somebody else → *lo* or *la*, and the **noun** decides which, not you.

That last clause is the whole of the difficulty. *Me* and *te* are about the conversation, so you always know them. *Lo* and *la* are about the noun, so they are only as reliable as your grip on its gender. That is why the three nouns came first: *el libro* and *la comida* are not vocabulary here so much as the two test cases you run every new pronoun against.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four in order, then the four examples
- "Te quiero" and "Me quieres" back to back, as if two people were speaking

Twice through: Until the choice arrives before the sentence does.

Before you move on

Four pronouns — say them. (***Me, te, lo, la.***) Which two are decided by a noun rather than by you? (***Lo*** and ***la.***) Next chapter has no new forms either — it asks what these words are actually **for**.

Chapter 87

Synthesis — Saying It Once

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can answer a yes/no question about a thing already named without naming it again.
>
> *Complete ES-C42-sintesis-decirlo-una-vez: answer Tienes el libro and Haces la comida with lo tengo and la hago, and say what was wrong with the grammatically correct version.*

87.1 Synthesis — saying it once

> Answer out loud: *¿Tienes el libro?* Say yes, and do not use the word *libro*.

The exchange

Here are the same two exchanges, twice. Read both versions aloud.

Version one:

> *— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí, tengo el libro. — ¿Haces la comida? — Sí, hago la comida.*

Version two:

> *— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí, lo tengo. — ¿Haces la comida? — Sí, la hago.*

Every sentence in version one is correct. Not one of them is a mistake. And no speaker of Spanish would say them.

Grammar Lens: what the pronoun is actually for

These four words do not make you more **correct**. They make you sound like somebody having a conversation instead of somebody completing an exercise.
A conversation carries what has already been said. English does the same thing and you have never noticed: you would not answer *do you have the book?* with *yes, I have the book.*
So this is the first place where knowing the form is not the skill. **The skill is noticing that the thing has already been named** — and no table can drill that.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both versions of the book exchange, and hear the difference
- "Sí, lo tengo" and "Sí, la hago" until no decision is needed

Before you move on

¿Tienes el libro? (***Sí, lo tengo.***) *¿Haces la comida?* (***Sí, la hago.***) And what were these four words for? (**Not** repeating what has already been said.) Next: the past tense — and you will find these four words sit in exactly the same place there.

Chapter 88

Nos — Us, and the Word Inside -mos

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say nos quieren, and say what nosotros is made of.
>
> *Complete ES-C45-nos: produce nos quieren and name the verb ending that is the same ancient word.*

88.1 nos — "us"

Say "you love me." (*Me quieres.*) And "I love you." (*Te quiero.*) Both of those are about **one** person on the receiving end. Here is more than one.

Grammar Lens: the third person in the room

nos — *us.*

Nos *quieren.* — They love **us**.

Same slot as always, in front of the verb. *Me* is one person speaking; *nos* is that person and somebody else.

> *Me quieren.* — They love me. *Nos quieren.* — They love us.

One letter of difference, and the difference is how many people you are speaking for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Me quieren" then "Nos quieren"
- "Te quiero" then "Nos quieren" — one person, then a group

Before you move on

Say "they love us." (***Nos quieren.***) And which slot did *nos* take? (The one in **front of the verb**.) Next: where *nos* came from, and the verb ending that has been carrying it all along.

88.2 nosotros — the word inside -mos

Say "they love us." (*Nos quieren.*)

That little *nos* has been somewhere else in your Spanish for a very long time, and nobody has pointed at it yet.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Nos is Latin **nōs**, which meant both *we* and *us* — the language had not yet split them into two words.
You have been carrying it without being shown. The *-mos* ending on *hablamos*, *comemos*, *tenemos* is that same **nōs**, worn down and glued to the back of the verb. Every time you said "we speak," you were saying *nos* twice: once in the ending, and once by not needing to say it at all.
And the word for "we" itself:

nosotros — *we*, literally **nos** + **otros**, "we **others**."

Spanish added *otros* to the plain *nos* somewhere in the Middle Ages, to make clear the speaker meant *this* group and not the person being addressed. Nothing else in the family did it quite this way, and the seam is still visible in the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablamos" and hear the *nos* at the end of it
- "nosotros hablamos" and hear it twice

Before you move on

What is *nosotros* made of? (***Nos*** + ***otros*** — "we others.") And which ending is the same word worn down? (***-mos***.) Next: the plural of *lo* and *la*, and you will not need to be told what they are.

Chapter 89

Los and Las — Them, Derived

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can make any direct object pronoun plural, and say why the pronoun is tidier than the article.
>
> *Complete ES-C45-los-las: produce los tengo and las hago, and explain why lo needed no repair in the plural when el did.*

89.1 los and las — "them"

Tengo el libro becomes *lo tengo*. Now: *Tengo los libros*. Say the short version out loud **before** reading on.

Grammar Lens: you were right

> **los** — *them*, masculine. **las** — *them*, feminine.
>
> *Tengo los libros.* → ***Los*** *tengo.* — I have them. *Hago las comidas.* → ***Las*** *hago.* — I make them.

Add *-s*. That is the whole lesson, and you did it yourself in the warm-up.

Two chapters have now asked you for a plural and this is the first one that behaved exactly as you would guess. That is worth noticing rather than passing over: most of what is ahead of you in Spanish is like this, and the memorable exceptions are memorable because they are rare.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

There is one genuinely satisfying thing here.
The **article** could not do this. *El* did not become *els*; it became *los*, because *el* is a worn-down *elo* that had lost its vowel and the plural had kept it.
The **pronoun** never lost that vowel. *Lo* is *illum* with the vowel intact — which is exactly why it was not *el* in the first place. So when the plural came, *lo* had nothing to repair:

	singular	**plural**
article	**el** (worn down)	**los**
pronoun	**lo** (vowel kept)	**los**

The two arrive at the same place from different directions, and the pronoun takes the plain road. An irregularity in one column and none in the other, from one Latin word, decided entirely by which one got leaned on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "lo tengo" then "los tengo"; "la hago" then "las hago"
- "el / los" then "lo / los" — one pair changed shape, one did not

Before you move on

"I have them," about books? (***Los tengo***.) About meals? (***Las hago***.) How do you make an object pronoun plural? (Add ***-s***.)
Next: one more form, and it belongs to one part of the world.

Chapter 90

Os — You All, in Spain

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use os for a group in Spain and los or las everywhere else.
>
> *Complete ES-C45-os: say os quiero and its non-peninsular equivalent, and name the older word os is worn down from.*

90.1 os — "you all," in Spain

Which word for "you all" is used in Spain, and which everywhere else? (*Vosotros* in Spain; *ustedes* everywhere.) That split is about to appear one last time.

Grammar Lens: the object form of vosotros

> **os** — *you all*, as the one it happens to.
>
> ***Os** quiero.* — I love you all.

Two letters, the shortest word in the set. It pairs with *vosotros*, so it lives exactly where *vosotros* lives: Spain, and nowhere else in daily speech.
Across the Atlantic, "you all" as an object is **los** or **las** — the same forms you learned last chapter, because *ustedes* is grammatically a *they*-word:

> *Os quiero.* — I love you all. **(Spain)** *Los quiero.* — I love you all. **(everywhere else)**

Neither is a mistake for the other. Several hundred million speakers will never say *os* in their lives, and forty million say it every day.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Os was **vos**, and the *v* simply fell off in the object slot — a word this small, said this often, and never stressed, wears faster than the rest of the language.
That same *vos* is still visible in two places you have met. It is the front of **vosotros** (*vos* + *otros*, "you others," built exactly like *nosotros*). And it survives **whole** as a subject pronoun in Argentina and much of Central America, where *vos* replaces *tú*.
So one Latin word left three descendants alive in three different conditions: worn to *os* in Spain, glued into *vosotros* in Spain, and standing intact as *vos* across the Río de la Plata. Same word, three fates, decided by geography.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Os quiero" then "Los quiero" — the same sentence, two continents
- "vos", "os", "vosotros" and hear one word in three states

Before you move on

"I love you all," in Spain? (***Os quiero***.) Elsewhere? (***Los quiero***.) What is *os* worn down from? (***Vos***.) Next: all eight of these in one place.

Chapter 91

Review — All Eight

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give all eight direct object pronouns and say which four depend on a noun.
>
> *Complete ES-C45-repaso-ocho: give the eight pronouns and identify the four that a noun decides.*

91.1 Review — all eight

Nothing new here. Before the grid: where does an object pronoun sit, and has that ever changed?

What you've built

Never, in nine chapters. Here is the complete set:

	singular	plural
me	**me**	**nos**
you	**te**	**os** *(Spain)*
it / them — masculine	**lo**	**los**
it / them — feminine	**la**	**las**

Eight cells, built one at a time, and this is the first page on which they have all appeared together. That is deliberate. A grid handed to you on the day you met the first one would have been eight things to memorise; here it is a picture of ground you already hold.

Count the genuinely new **shapes** you had to learn across those chapters: *me* was already yours from chapter four, *te* was one, *nos* one, *os* one, *lo* one, *la* one — and *los* and *las* were free, because you produced them yourself from an *-s*.

Grammar Lens: two questions

Reading the grid as eight decisions is the hard way. It is two:

1. **Who is on the receiving end** — me, you, or something else?
2. **How many, and if it is a thing, which gender?**

The second question only bites in the bottom two rows, because only there does a noun decide. *Me*, *te*, *nos* and *os* are settled by the conversation itself: you always know who is talking.
So the difficulty is not eight-eighths of this table. It is one quarter of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the eight in grid order, twice
- "me quieres, te quiero, nos quieren, os quiero"

Twice through: Until the grid is a reflex rather than a lookup.

Before you move on

How many direct object pronouns are there? (**Eight**.) How many of them depend on a noun? (**Four**.) Next: what all eight are for, in a conversation that would be unbearable without them.

Chapter 92

Synthesis — The Conversation Without Them

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can carry a four-turn exchange using pronouns, and say what a pronoun promises the listener.
>
> *Complete ES-C45-sintesis-sin-repetir: run the exchange with pronouns and say what goes wrong when the gender points at nothing.*

92.1 Synthesis — the conversation without them

¿Tienes los libros? Answer yes without saying *libros*.

The exchange

Four turns, with the pronouns:

> *— ¿Tienes los libros? — Sí, los tengo. — ¿Y las comidas? — Las hago hoy.*

Now the same four turns without them:

> *— ¿Tienes los libros? — Sí, tengo los libros. — ¿Y las comidas? — Hago las comidas hoy.*

Read the second version aloud, all four lines. It is not wrong anywhere. It is exhausting, and by the fourth line it sounds like somebody being careful with a stranger rather than talking.

Grammar Lens: what a pronoun buys, and what it costs

The pronoun buys speed, and it is paid for with **attention**.
Los tengo is only clear because both of you remember what *los* points at. If the last three sentences were about meals and you say *los tengo*, your listener hunts for a masculine thing and finds none. A pronoun is a promise that the thing is still in the room.
That is the real skill, and it is not on the grid: **hold what has been said, and point back at it accurately.** English asks the same of you and you have done it since you were three, which is why nobody taught it to you. Here the pointer must also agree in gender and number — which is why *lo* and *la* were the hard quarter of that table.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both versions of the four-turn exchange, and hear the second one tire
- "los tengo" and "las hago" until the gender arrives with the noun, not after it

Before you move on

¿Tienes los libros? (***Sí, los tengo.***) *¿Y las comidas?* (***Las hago.***) What does a pronoun promise? (That the thing it points at is **still in the room**.) Next: the past tense.

Chapter 93

Le — To Him, To Her, To You

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say le digo, and know that le does not mark gender.
>
> *Complete ES-C46-le: produce le digo, say how many genders le has, and name the Latin case it comes from.*

93.1 le — "to him," "to her," "to you"

Lo and *la* answer the question **what**. This chapter answers a different one: **to whom**.

Grammar Lens: the other question

> **le** — *to him*, *to her*, *to you* (with *usted*).
>
> ***Le** digo.* — I tell **him**. Or her. Or you.

Some verbs land on a thing: you have it, you make it, you want it. Others land on a **person you are aiming at** — you tell them, you speak to them, you give them something. Spanish uses a different pronoun for the second kind, and *le* is it.
Same slot. Still in front of the verb. Nothing about the shape of a sentence has changed in eleven chapters.
And here is the relief: *le* does **not** mark gender.

> *Le digo.* — I tell him. **and** I tell her. **and** I tell you.

After four chapters of choosing between *lo* and *la* by the gender of a noun, this one asks you for nothing. One form covers three people. If you need to say which, you add it in words — but the pronoun itself does not care.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Lo and *le* are the same Latin word again — and this time the difference is not wear, it is **grammar**.
Latin changed a word's ending to show its job in the sentence. *Ille*, "that one," had one form for the thing an action hit and another for the person it was aimed at:

- **illum** — the one the verb acts on → Spanish **lo**.
- **illī** — the one it is aimed at → Spanish **le**.

Latin called these the accusative and the dative. Almost all of that system collapsed on the way to Spanish; nouns lost their endings entirely. But in these small, constantly-used pronouns, **two of the cases survived**, and you are looking at them.
English had the same distinction and lost it more completely. It survives in a word order rather than a shape: *I told **him** the story* — *him* is doing exactly what *le* does, and English simply stopped marking it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Lo tengo" then "Le digo" — what, then to whom
- "Le digo" three times, meaning him, then her, then usted

Before you move on

Say "I tell him." (***Le digo***.) And "I tell her." (***Le digo*** — the same.) Which Latin case is *le*? (The **dative**, *illī*.) Next: its plural, and a discovery about how little of this system is actually new.

Chapter 94

Les — And What the Second System Costs

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say les digo and name the four pronouns that are identical in both object systems.
>
> *Complete ES-C46-les: produce les digo and say how many genuinely new words the indirect set adds.*

94.1 les — "to them," and what this system really costs

Lo became *los*. So what does *le* become? Say it before you read on.

Grammar Lens: right again, and then something better

les — *to them, to you all.*

Le digo. — I tell him. → ***Les*** *digo.* — I tell them.

Add *-s*. That is the second time an object pronoun has pluralised without argument, and it will not be the last.
Now the part worth the chapter. You have just met the sixth and last indirect object pronoun — and you have only ever been **taught two of them**.

What you've built

Here are the two sets, side by side:

	direct (*what*)	**indirect (*to whom*)**
me	**me**	**me**
you	**te**	**te**
him / her / you	**lo**, **la**	**le**
us	**nos**	**nos**
you all *(Spain)*	**os**	**os**
them / you all	**los**, **las**	**les**

Look down the two columns. **Four of the six rows are identical.** *Me*, *te*, *nos* and *os* do not change at all — the same word does both jobs, and Spanish never asks you to choose.

So a "whole second system" turns out to cost exactly **two new words**: *le* and *les*. Everything else you already owned, and you owned it before you knew there were two systems to own it in.

This is worth holding onto beyond this chapter. A grammar book will show you two complete tables and it will look like twelve things. Count what is actually **different** and it is two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "le digo" then "les digo"
- "me, te, nos, os" and note that this list is finished for both systems at once

Before you move on

"I tell them"? (***Les digo***.) How many new words did the whole indirect system cost you? (**Two**.) Next: how to know which of the two a verb is asking for.

Chapter 95

Which One Is the Verb Asking For?

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can decide between the direct and indirect pronoun by asking one question of the verb.
>
> *Complete ES-C46-cual-pide: state the test, apply it to hablar and tener, and say why le veo is not an error in Madrid.*

95.1 Which one is the verb asking for?

You have two sets now. The obvious worry is that you will have to learn, verb by verb, which set each one wants. You do not.

Grammar Lens: ask the verb one question

> **Does the verb do something *to* this, or aim something *at* this?**

That is the whole test.

> *Tengo el libro* → ***Lo*** *tengo.* The having lands **on** the book. Direct. *Hablo a Ana* → ***Le*** *hablo.* The speaking is aimed **at** Ana. Indirect.

Say the sentence in English with the little word *to* in front of the person. If it fits, Spanish wants the indirect one:

- I speak **to** her → *le hablo.* **Fits.**

- I have **to** the book → nonsense. So *lo tengo*.

English hides this by dropping the *to*: you say *I told him*, not *I told to him*. Put it back, and if it survives, the pronoun is *le*.

Why it's said this way

One thing the test will not settle, said now rather than met later as a shock.
In much of Spain, speakers use *le* for a **male person** even where the grammar calls for *lo*: *le veo* rather than *lo veo*. It has a name, *leísmo*, it is old, it is accepted for people, and roughly a fifth of the Spanish-speaking world does it.
So if you hear *le* where this chapter predicts *lo*, neither of you has misunderstood. The test above is right everywhere.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "Lo tengo" then "Le hablo" — which question does each answer?

Before you move on

What one question tells you which set to use? (Does the verb act **on** it, or aim **at** it?) What is it called when Spain uses *le* for a man where the rule says *lo*? (***Leísmo*** — and it is fine.) Next: both sets in one place.

Chapter 96

Review — Two Systems, Two New Words

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give both object pronoun sets and say which row is the only one where they differ in shape.
>
> *Complete ES-C46-repaso-dos-sistemas: give the six indirect pronouns and count the distinct shapes across both tables.*

96.1 Review — two systems, two new words

Nothing new. Two questions before the tables: where does an object pronoun go, and what single question chooses between the two sets?

What you've built

	direct — *what*	**indirect — *to whom***
me	**me**	**me**
you	**te**	**te**
him / her / usted	**lo**, **la**	**le**
us	**nos**	**nos**
you all *(Spain)*	**os**	**os**
them / ustedes	**los**, **las**	**les**

Twelve cells. **Two of them are new since the last review**, and you

produced one of those yourself by adding an *-s*.
Do the arithmetic once and it will stay done. Fourteen chapters of object pronouns have asked you to learn, as shapes: *te*, *lo*, *la*, *nos*, *os*, *le*. Six words. *Me* you had from chapter four; *los*, *las* and *les* you derived. Six words, spread across fourteen chapters, with a review and a synthesis at each joint — that is what a gentle ramp costs and what it buys.

Grammar Lens: the one asymmetry

Read the third row again, because it is the only place the two columns disagree in shape rather than spelling:

> direct: **lo / la** — two forms, gender marked. indirect: **le** — one form, gender not marked.

Spanish cares about the gender of a thing being acted on and does not care about the gender of a person being aimed at. There is no deep reason for it; Latin's dative simply had one form where its accusative had two, and Spanish inherited the asymmetry whole.
It is good news. The row that carries all the difficulty in one column carries none in the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the direct six, then the indirect six, and hear how much is the same
- "lo tengo, le hablo, los tengo, les hablo"

Twice through: Until the shared four stop feeling like two separate lists.

Before you move on

How many pronouns are shared between the two sets? (**Four**.)
Which row differs? (**Him / her / usted** — *lo* and *la* against *le*.)
Next: both sets in one conversation, where you have to choose fast.

Chapter 97

Synthesis — The Thing and the Person

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use both sets in one exchange and say what decides between them.
>
> *Complete ES-C46-sintesis-dar-y-decir: run the four-turn exchange and say what separates lo from le.*

97.1 Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence

Two pronouns, one question. *Lo* or *le* — what decides?

The exchange

Read this aloud and watch the two sets take turns.

> *— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí,* ***lo*** *tengo. — ¿Y Ana? —* ***Le*** *digo hoy.*

Four turns. The book gets *lo*, because the having lands on it. Ana gets *le*, because the telling is aimed at her.

Nothing in the sentence shape tells you which. Same slot, two letters each, one Latin ancestor. **The only thing separating them is what you mean.**

That is new. Every choice so far could be settled by looking at something — a noun's ending, its article, where the stress falls. This one cannot.

Grammar Lens: choosing at speed

In a real conversation you do not have time to run a test. So do not aim for the test — aim for the **feeling** of the two verbs:

- Verbs that **hold, make, want, see** land on a thing. Those take *lo*, *la*, *los*, *las*.
- Verbs that **tell, speak, give, ask** are aimed at a person. Those take *le*, *les*.

Say enough sentences and the verb starts arriving with its pronoun attached, which is what fluency here actually is. The test is scaffolding for when you are unsure, not the method.
And when you get it wrong you will be understood: *lo digo* and *le digo* are both ordinary sentences. You will have said something slightly other than you meant, and the person will ask.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "lo tengo, le digo, los tengo, les hablo" until each verb brings its own pronoun

Before you move on

¿Tienes el libro? (***Sí, lo tengo***.) "I tell her today"? (***Le digo hoy***.) What decides between *lo* and *le*? (**What you mean** — nothing on the page.) Next: what happens when a sentence needs **both** at once.

Chapter 98

Me Lo — Both at Once

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can put two object pronouns in front of one verb, in the right order.
>
> *Complete ES-C47-me-lo: produce te lo digo and me la haces, and say which pronoun leads.*

98.1 me lo — both at once

You have a pronoun for the **thing** and a pronoun for the **person**. A sentence often needs both. What happens then?

Grammar Lens: they stand together, in one order

They queue up in the same slot, both still in front of the verb:

> ***Me lo*** *dices.* — You tell **it to me**. ***Te lo*** *digo.* — I tell **it to you**.

Two small words, one after the other, and then the verb. Nothing has moved.
The order never varies. The person comes first, then the thing:

> **indirect, then direct.** *Me lo*, never *lo me*.

That is the entire rule, and it is worth noticing what it saves you. English lets you choose — *give it to me* or *give me it* — and the choice carries a faint difference in emphasis you have to feel your way into.

Spanish took the choice away. There is one order, it is always right, and you never have to decide.
A fixed order is a smaller thing to learn than a free one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Me lo dices" then "Te lo digo" — hear the pair stay glued
- "me la haces"

Before you move on

"I tell it to you"? (***Te lo digo.***) Which pronoun leads? (The **person** — indirect first.) Next: the one combination Spanish refuses to say, and what it says instead.

Chapter 99

Se Lo — The Pair That Does Not Exist

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can turn le or les into se in front of lo, la, los or las.
>
> *Complete ES-C47-se-lo: produce se lo digo, name the four words that trigger the change, and count the readings se lo digo allows.*

99.1 se lo — the pair that does not exist

Person first, then thing. So "I tell it to him" should be *le* plus *lo* plus *digo*. Say that out loud: ***le lo digo***.

Grammar Lens: nobody says that

Your mouth probably objected before your grammar did. *Le lo* is two nearly identical syllables in a row, and Spanish will not say it.

> **In front of *lo*, *la*, *los* or *las*, the pronouns *le* and *les* become *se*.**
>
> ~~*Le lo digo.*~~ → ***Se lo*** *digo.* — I tell it to him. ~~*Les la hago.*~~ → ***Se la*** *hago.* — I make it for them.

Everything else about the sentence is unchanged. The order is still person then thing. The slot is still in front of the verb. **Only the first word's shape changes**, and it changes for one reason: what follows it.

Note what *se* does **not** tell you. *Le* already refused to mark gender, and *se* goes further — it does not mark number either:

Se lo digo — to him. To her. To you. To them. To you all.

Five readings, one word. Context does all the work, and if you need to be precise you add it in words rather than in the pronoun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "le lo digo" once, badly, and then "se lo digo" — feel why
- "Se lo digo" and "Se la hago"

Before you move on

"I tell it to him"? (***Se lo digo***.) What happened to *le*? (It became ***se*** in front of *lo*.) Next: **why** it became *se* — and it is not the reason almost everyone assumes.

Chapter 100

Why Se? — Gelo, and a Collision

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say why le becomes se, and that this se is not the reflexive one.
>
> *Complete ES-C47-por-que-se: name the Old Spanish form, and say whether the se of se lo digo is the se of se llama.*

100.1 Why se? — and why it is not the se you know

You have known a word *se* since almost the beginning: *se llama*, "he calls **himself**." Now you have met a second *se*, in *se lo digo*. The obvious conclusion is that they are the same word doing a second job.

They are not. They are two different words that arrived at the same spelling, and knowing that removes a confusion most learners carry for years.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Old Spanish did not say *se lo*. It said **gelo**.
That came from the two Latin pronouns you already know, run together and worn down: *illī* (the dative, giving *le*) plus *illum* (the accusative, giving *lo*) → **gelo**. One squeezed word for "to-him it."
So the medieval sentence was *gelo digo*, and it was regular. There was no substitution and no rule to learn.

Then two things happened:

1. **The word split back into two** — *gelo* was re-analysed as *ge* + *lo*, matching the two-pronoun pattern everywhere else in the language.
2. **The sound *ge* drifted** until it was pronounced exactly like *se* — and once two words sound identical, spelling follows.

By the sixteenth century *ge lo* had become *se lo*, and the trail was cold.

Why it's said this way

This matters for a practical reason, not a historical one.
The reflexive *se* in *se llama* means **himself**. If the *se* in *se lo digo* were that word, the sentence would have to mean something reflexive — and learners who assume it do spend years trying to make "he tells it to himself" fit sentences where it plainly does not.
It does not fit because it is not that word. One *se* is Latin *sē*, "himself"; the other is *illī*, "to him." Unrelated, and collided by accident of sound.
Two words wearing one shape is something this language does often — *ser* is built from two Latin verbs, *ir* borrows its present from a third. Here it happens to two of the smallest words in Spanish, which is where it is hardest to notice.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "se llama" then "se lo digo" — two different words, one sound

Before you move on

What was *se lo* before it was *se lo*? (***Gelo.***) Is it the reflexive *se*? (**No** — a different word that came to sound the same.) Next: all of it together.

Chapter 101

Review — The Pairs

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can generate every permitted pair of object pronouns from two facts.
>
> *Complete ES-C47-repaso-dobles: state the two facts that generate the table and say how many new pronouns the arc added.*

101.1 Review — the pairs

Nothing new. Two facts before the table: which pronoun leads, and what happens to *le* in front of *lo*?

What you've built

Every pair Spanish permits, in one place:

person	**+ thing**	**gives**
me	lo / la / los / las	**me lo**, **me la**, **me los**, **me las**
te	”	**te lo**, **te la**, …
le / les	”	**se lo**, **se la**, **se los**, **se las**
nos	”	**nos lo**, **nos la**, …
os	”	**os lo**, **os la**, …

Read the whole table as **two facts**, because that is all it is:

1. The person comes first. Always.

2. *Le* and *les* turn into *se* in front of the thing. Only there.

Every other row is just the two pronouns you already had, standing next to each other with nothing done to either of them.

Grammar Lens: how little is actually new

Count the new material in this whole arc: **one order, and one substitution.** No new pronoun, no new form, no new position in the sentence. Four chapters, two facts, and one of the two turned out to be an accident of medieval pronunciation rather than a rule at all.
That is worth saying plainly, because *se lo* has a reputation. It is usually taught as the moment Spanish object pronouns become genuinely hard. It is instead the moment they stop growing: this is the last new thing the system does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "me lo, te lo, se lo, nos lo, os lo" — the whole first column
- "se lo digo, se la hago" and notice that only the middle row changed

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which row is the only one that changes? (***Le*** and ***les*** → ***se***.) How many new pronouns did you learn here? (**None**.) Next: all of it in a conversation, at speed.

Chapter 102

Synthesis — Two at a Time

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can carry a four-turn exchange in which almost no noun appears.
>
> *Complete ES-C47-sintesis-dos-a-la-vez: produce se la hago and say how many words in it name anything.*

102.1 Synthesis — two at a time

"I tell it to him," in three words. (*Se lo digo.*)

The exchange

> *— ¿Tienes el libro? — Sí. ¿**Te lo** digo? — Sí, y **se lo** dices a Ana. — Y la comida — **se la** hago hoy.*

Look at the last three lines. After the first sentence names the book, **not one noun does any work.** *Te lo*, *se lo*, *se la* — six words that name nothing, and the conversation is perfectly clear to both speakers.

That is what all of this has been for. Fifteen chapters of object pronouns exist so that a conversation can stop repeating itself, and this is the point where the machinery is complete enough to see it happen.

Grammar Lens: two words carrying a whole sentence

Se la hago is three words and it means "I make **the meal** for **her**, today." Two of the three are pronouns; between them they carry a

person and a thing, neither of which is named anywhere in the sentence.
English cannot compress like this. *I'll make it for her* needs five words and still spells out *for*. Spanish puts both jobs in front of the verb, in a fixed order, and gets on with it.
The cost is the one you already know, doubled. Two pronouns are two promises that both things are still in the room. When you lose track of one of them, the sentence does not become wrong — it becomes about somebody else, and nobody will notice until it matters.
So the practice that pays here is not conjugation. It is keeping a conversation's furniture in mind while you talk.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four-turn exchange straight through
- "te lo digo, se lo dices, se la hago" until the pairs feel like single words

Twice through:

Before you move on

"I make it for her"? (***Se la hago***.) How many nouns are in that sentence? (**None**.) And what does each pronoun promise? (That its thing is **still in the room**.) Next: the past tense.

Chapter 103

The Preterite — Your First Past Tense

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the singular completed past of ser or ir and the known regular -ar verb hablar.
>
> *Complete ES-C14-practice and distinguish fui/fuiste/fue from hablé/ hablaste/habló using known words, context, and written stress.*

103.1 ayer — the word that opens the past

> Everything you have said so far happens now or later. This lesson gives you the one word that points the other way — backwards — and warns you what the verbs in this chapter are about to do.

What to know first

- voy a + infinitive — you can already point forwards; this points back.

Sounds you'll need

- `vowel-a`, `vowel-e` — two syllables, stress on the last: *a-YÉR* (*ah-YEHR*). → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ayer — "yesterday." It is two Latin words that fused:
`ad + heri → ayer (to) (yesterday) (yesterday)`
Latin *heri* is the same ancient word as English **yester**day and German *gestern*. The *h-* fell silent and then fell away, the *-ri* softened to a *-y-* sound, and *ad heri* — "to yesterday" — packed down into one short word.

What you've built

Ayer is a **time frame**: a word that tells the listener *when*, before the verb ever gets a chance to. That matters more than it looks, because Spanish will not let a past time frame sit beside a present verb. Say *ayer* and the verb must follow you backwards.
That is what the rest of this chapter is for. Spanish has **two** past tenses, and they split the past between them:

	what it says	**met in**
preterite	it happened, and it finished	this chapter
imperfect	it was going on, or it used to happen	a later chapter

English blurs this — "I spoke" covers both. Spanish makes you choose, every time. You do not have to choose yet; you only need to know that the choice is coming, so the next few lessons do not look like arbitrary endings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ayer* — stress the second syllable
- which of the two past tenses is for something finished?

Before you move on

Which two Latin words gave us *ayer*? (*Ad* and *heri*.) English keeps *heri* inside which word? (**Yester**day.) How many past tenses does Spanish have? (Two — one for finished, one for ongoing.)

103.2 fui — one past set shared by ser and ir

You already use **ser** for identity and **ir** for going. Spanish now gives both verbs one completed-past set. This lesson keeps the same three singular persons you know: **fui, fuiste, fue**.

Grammar Lens: three singular forms, two verbs

person	completed past of ser or ir
yo	**fui**
tú	**fuiste**
él / ella / usted	**fue**

Say **fui** · **fuiste** · **fue**. Each form can belong to either verb. The surrounding words decide which meaning is possible:

- **Fui a Madrid.** — "I went to Madrid." The known **a** plus a destination points to **ir**.
- **Fue Roberto.** — "It was Roberto." Identification points to **ser**.

Fui and **fue** are one-syllable words, so standard Spanish spelling gives them no written accent. Plural forms wait until a later lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The shared set continues the Latin perfect family of "be," including Latin **fuī**, "I have been." Sound change and analogy reshaped the inherited forms. Spanish **ir** then came to share this past family with **ser**: a case of **suppletion**, where one verb draws forms from more than one historical root. English **go / went** uses the same broad strategy, although not the same words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "fui, fuiste, fue"
- "Fui a Madrid."
- "Fue Roberto — identification, so ser."

Before you move on

Give the three shared forms. (*Fui, fuiste, fue.*) Which two verbs share them? (*Ser* and *ir.*) What decides the meaning? (Context.) What older family supplied the forms? (The Latin perfect family of "be.") Next, reuse the known verb **hablar** to build a regular singular past.

103.3 hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb

You know **hablar** and its present singular **hablo, hablas, habla**. To say that the speaking was completed, keep **habl-** and learn three new endings: **hablé, hablaste, habló**.

Grammar Lens: present beside completed past

person	present	completed past
yo	**hablo**	**hablé**
tú	**hablas**	**hablaste**
él / ella / usted	**habla**	**habló**

Say **hablé · hablaste · habló**. This is a complete singular pattern, not a preview of plural forms. Notice the exact changes:

- **hablo** → **hablé** changes the final vowel and moves stress to the end.
- **hablas** → **hablaste** adds the past ending **-aste**.
- **habla** → **habló** changes the final vowel and moves stress to the end.

Grammar Lens: two accents, one natural stress pattern

The written accents in **hablé** and **habló** show final stress. Without those marks, words ending in a vowel normally stress the next-to-last syllable. **Hablaste** already follows that ordinary pattern — **blas** is next to last — so it needs no written accent. The mark records the stress; it is not the only change that makes a form past.
Now reuse known words:

- **Hablé español.** — "I spoke Spanish."
- **¿Hablaste español?** — "Did you speak Spanish?"
- **Habló español.** — "He, she, or you-formal spoke Spanish."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The regular **-ar** past continues material from the Latin first-conjugation perfect, visible in forms such as **amāvī, amāvistī, amāvit**. Centuries of sound change and analogy produced the Spanish family **-é, -aste, -ó**. The history explains a family resemblance; it is not one tidy letter-by-letter erosion for every modern ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablé, hablaste, habló"
- "Hablo español. Hablé español."
- "hablé and habló carry written accents; hablaste does not"

Before you move on

Give the three learned past forms. (*Hablé, hablaste, habló.*) Which two carry written accents, and why? (*Hablé* and *habló*; the marks show final stress.) What older family lies behind the endings? (The Latin first-conjugation perfect.) Next: choose between the two past patterns using only known words.

103.4 Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve the shared singular set and the regular **hablar** set, then use context and spelling to keep them apart.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

- shared past of **ser** and **ir**: **fui** · **fuiste** · **fue**.
- regular past of **hablar**: **hablé** · **hablaste** · **habló**.
- context: **Fui a Madrid** expresses **ir**; **Fue Roberto** expresses **ser**.
- time contrast: **Hablo español** is present; **Hablé español** is completed past.
- spelling: **hablé** and **habló** show final stress with a written accent; **hablaste** needs none.

Plural persons, additional past-tense verb classes, new time words, and new place or person vocabulary wait for later lessons.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **fui** family continues Latin perfect "be" material and became shared by **ser** and **ir**. The regular **-ar** endings continue Latin first-conjugation perfect material, reshaped by sound change and analogy.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "fui, fuiste, fue"
- "hablé, hablaste, habló"
- "Fui a Madrid. Fue Roberto."
- "Hablo español. Hablé español."

Before you move on

Give both singular sets. (*Fui, fuiste, fue; hablé, hablaste, habló.*) How does context separate **ser** from **ir**? (A destination points to going; identification points to being.) Which regular forms carry written accents? (*Hablé* and *habló.*) The next chapter can add another past family without borrowing plural forms or unseen

vocabulary from this checkpoint.

Chapter 104

The Regular Preterite

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I did with a regular -er or -ir verb, and place the written accent correctly.

-er and -ir agree again, and the accent marks the stressed final vowel.

104.1 comí — one regular -er singular past

You know present **como, comes, come** and the singular **-ar** past. To make a completed past from **comer**, keep **com-** and learn three forms: **comí, comiste, comió**.

Grammar Lens: present beside completed past

person	present	completed past
yo	**como**	**comí**
tú	**comes**	**comiste**
él / ella / usted	**come**	**comió**

Say **comí** · **comiste** · **comió**. Keep the limit visible: these are the same three familiar singular persons. Plural forms wait.

Grammar Lens: final stress in two forms

Comí and **comió** carry written accents because their stress falls on the final vowel. **Comiste** follows ordinary next-to-last stress, so it needs no mark. The three forms by themselves make complete utterances:

- **Comí.** — "I ate."
- **¿Comiste?** — "Did you eat?"
- **Comió.** — "He, she, or you-formal ate."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **comer** continues Latin **comedere**. Its regular past endings also continue Latin perfect material, including forms with **-ī, -istī, -it**. Sound change and analogy reshaped that material across Romance into Spanish **-í, -iste, -ió**. The resemblance is real, but it is not one tidy chain in which every modern ending merely drops a letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "comí, comiste, comió"
- "Como. Comí."
- "comí and comió carry final-stress accents"

Before you move on

Give the three learned **comer** forms. (*Comí, comiste, comió.*) Which carry written accents? (*Comí* and *comió.*) What shaped the modern endings? (Latin perfect material, sound change, and analogy.) Next: reuse the same endings with a known **-ir** verb.

104.2 viví — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

You know present **vivo, vives, vive**, and you just learned past **comí, comiste, comió**. Keep **viv-** and reuse those three past endings: **viví, viviste, vivió**.

Grammar Lens: one -ir singular past

person	present	completed past
yo	**vivo**	**viví**
tú	**vives**	**viviste**
él / ella / usted	**vive**	**vivió**

Say **viví** · **viviste** · **vivió**. Reuse known **en** for a small contrast:

- **Vivo en Madrid.** — "I live in Madrid."
- **Viví en Madrid.** — "I lived in Madrid."
- **¿Viviste en Madrid?** — "Did you live in Madrid?"
- **Vivió en Madrid.** — "He, she, or you-formal lived in Madrid."

The written accents in **viví** and **vivió** show final stress. **Viviste** already has ordinary next-to-last stress and needs no mark.

Grammar Lens: -er and -ir meet in this past

person	comer	vivir
yo	com**í**	viv**í**
tú	com**iste**	viv**iste**
él / ella / usted	com**ió**	viv**ió**

The shared endings are **-í** in the first row, **-iste** in the second, and **-ió** in the third. The presents differ, but these two singular past rows converge on one ending set. That is a fact about the forms you have learned, not permission to guess plural forms; those wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **vivir** continues Latin **vīvere**. Its modern past endings belong to the same Romance history as the **comer** endings: Latin perfect material was reshaped by sound change and analogy. The shared **-iste** is a useful family resemblance, not proof of one simple letter-by-letter erosion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "viví, viviste, vivió"
- "Vivo en Madrid. Viví en Madrid."
- "comí and viví share -í; comió and vivió share -ió"

Before you move on

Give the three learned **vivir** forms. (*Viví, viviste, vivió.*) Which past endings do **comer** and **vivir** share? (*-í, -iste, -ió.*) Which two carry written accents? (*Viví* and *vivió.*) Next, keep the singular limit but let the stem change.

Chapter 105

The Strong Preterites

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use tuve, hice and estuve, and hear that their stress sits on the stem.
>
> *Latin's own perfect, carried through on verbs too heavily used to be rebuilt.*

105.1 tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress

You know present **tengo, tienes, tiene**. Its completed past changes the stem to **tuv-** and uses **tuve, tuviste, tuvo**. Unlike **comí** and **comió**, none of these three forms carries a written accent.

Grammar Lens: one strong singular pattern

person	present	completed past
yo	**tengo**	**tuve**
tú	**tienes**	**tuviste**
él / ella / usted	**tiene**	**tuvo**

The strong stem **tuv-** takes **-e, -iste, -o**. Say **tuve** · **tuviste** · **tuvo**. Stress remains in the stem, so normal spelling needs no accent mark. Reuse known **café**:

- **Tuve café.** — "I had coffee."
- **¿Tuviste café?** — "Did you have coffee?"

- **Tuvo café.** — "He, she, or you-formal had coffee."

"Strong" describes the stem-stressed historical pattern. It does not mean that the meaning is forceful. Plural endings wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tener continues Latin **tenēre**. Its past also belongs to an older strong history associated with Latin **tenuī**. Spanish sound change and analogy reshaped that material into the **tuv-** family. **Tenuī** → **tuve** is therefore a historical relationship, not a promise that every letter passed across intact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "tuve, tuviste, tuvo"
- "Tuve café."
- "comí has final stress; tuve has stem stress"

Before you move on

Give the three learned **tener** forms. (*Tuve, tuviste, tuvo.*) Which endings attach to **tuv-**? (*-e, -iste, -o.*) Why are there no written accents? (The strong stem carries the stress.) What shaped **tuve** historically? (Older strong-perfect material, sound change, and analogy.) Next: reuse the strong endings with **hacer**.

105.2 hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

You know present **hago, haces, hace** and strong past **tuve, tuviste, tuvo**. **Hacer** reuses the strong endings: **hice, hiciste, hizo**. Watch the third form: the stem is **hiz-** there, not **hic-**.

Grammar Lens: hacer in the completed past

person	completed past	stem plus ending
yo	**hice**	**hic- + -e**
tú	**hiciste**	**hic- + -iste**
él / ella / usted	**hizo**	**hiz- + -o**

Say **hice** · **hiciste** · **hizo**. These are strong, stem-stressed forms with no written accents. **Hizo** is an irregular stem alternation inside this family; it is not a general rule that **c** must become **z** before **o**. Reuse known **café**:

- **Hice café.** — "I made coffee."
- **¿Hiciste café?** — "Did you make coffee?"
- **Hizo café.** — "He, she, or you-formal made coffee."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hacer continues Latin **facere**, and **hice** continues the history of its strong perfect **fēcī**. Long sound changes help explain Spanish **h-** and the changed vowel and consonant; this is not a direct spelling recipe. The pattern links **hice** historically to strong **tuve**, while each verb keeps its own stem.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hice, hiciste, hizo"
- "Hice café."
- "hizo is a learned hiz- alternation, not a general c-before-o rule"

Before you move on

Give the three learned **hacer** forms. (*Hice, hiciste, hizo.*) What changes in the third form? (**Hic-** becomes **hiz-**.) Is that a general **c-before-o** spelling rule? (No; learn it inside this irregular family.) What older form lies behind **hice**? (Latin **fēcī**, through substantial historical change.) Next: add strong **estar** without adding plural

forms.

105.3 estuve — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

You know present **estoy, estás, está** and the strong past pairs **tuve, tuviste, tuvo** and **hice, hiciste, hizo**. Now use the same strong endings with **estuv-**: **estuve, estuviste, estuvo**.

Grammar Lens: estar in the completed past

person	completed past
yo	**estuve**
tú	**estuviste**
él / ella / usted	**estuvo**

Say **estuve** · **estuviste** · **estuvo**. The strong stem **estuv-** takes **-e, -iste, -o**. These forms carry no written accents. Reuse known **bien**:

- **Estuve bien.** — "I was well."
- **¿Estuviste bien?** — "Were you well?"
- **Estuvo bien.** — "He, she, or you-formal was well."

Grammar Lens: three strong singular rows

- yo: **tuve** · **hice** · **estuve**.
- tú: **tuviste** · **hiciste** · **estuviste**.
- él / ella / usted: **tuvo** · **hizo** · **estuvo**.

All three rows use the learned strong endings. Only **hacer** changes its stem shape from **hic-** to **hiz-** before third-person **-o**. Plural forms and other irregular verbs still wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Estar grew from a Romance verb related to Latin **stāre**, "stand." But modern **estuve** is not a direct, tidy wearing-down of Latin **stetī**.

Historical analogy helped reshape its past beside other strong forms, including the **-uv-** pattern visible in **tuve**. This explains the family resemblance without pretending that each modern letter came straight from one Latin form.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "estuve, estuviste, estuvo"
- "Estuve bien."
- "tuve and estuve share -uv- through historical analogy"

Before you move on

Give the three learned **estar** forms. (*Estuve, estuviste, estuvo.*) Which known strong verb shares their **-uv-** shape? (*Tener: tuve.*) Why should **estuve** not be shown as a direct wearing-down of **stetī**? (Analogy reshaped the Spanish family.) Next: retrieve all six bounded patterns.

Chapter 106

Synthesis — You Can Hear Which Past It Is

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can tell a regular preterite from a strong one by ear, and say why only one of them carries an accent.
>
> *The accent is the stress written down: ending-stressed regular, stem-stressed strong.*

106.1 Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve only the three singular persons of each learned row. Every word in the short sentences is already known.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

Regular rows:

- **yo: hablé · comí · viví.**
- **tú: hablaste · comiste · viviste.**
- **él / ella / usted: habló · comió · vivió.**

Strong rows:

- **yo: tuve · hice · estuve.**

- **tú: tuviste · hiciste · estuviste**.
- **él / ella / usted: tuvo · hizo · estuvo**.

The **-er** and **-ir** rows share **-í, -iste, -ió**. The three strong rows share **-e, -iste, -o**, but their stems must be learned: **tuv-, hic-/hiz-, estuv-**. Plural persons, more strong verbs, and new time or setting vocabulary remain outside this checkpoint.

Grammar Lens: let spelling show the stress

- Regular **comí, comió, viví, vivió** carry written accents for final stress.
- Strong **tuve, tuvo, hice, hizo, estuve, estuvo** carry no written accents; stress remains in the strong stem.
- **Comiste** and **viviste** need no accent because their ordinary stress is already next to last.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The regular **-er/-ir** endings continue Latin perfect material reshaped across Romance. **Tuve** and **hice** continue older strong-perfect histories, also reshaped rather than copied letter for letter. **Estuve** shows especially clear analogical remodeling beside the **-uv-** family of **tuve**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé, comí, viví”
- “tuve, hice, estuve”
- “Hice café. Viví en Madrid. Estuve bien.”
- “comí and comió have accents; tuve and tuvo do not”

Before you move on

Give the regular **comer** and **vivir** sets. (*Comí, comiste, comió; viví, viviste, vivió.*) Give the three strong sets. (*Tuve, tuviste, tuvo; hice, hiciste, hizo; estuve, estuviste, estuvo.*) Which rows share endings? (**-er/-ir** share one regular set; the strong rows share another.) The next chapter can add a new past contrast without borrowing any plural form here.

106.2 Synthesis — you can hear which past it is

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *comí*, then *tuve*.

Grammar Lens: the stress tells you everything

Say those two again and listen to where your voice lifts.

> com**í** — the stress lands on the **ending**. **tu**ve — the stress lands on the **stem**.

That is not a detail. It is the whole difference between the two kinds of past in this chapter, and it is audible before you know anything else about the verb.

- **Endings stressed** → the regular preterite. It needs a written accent, because Spanish marks a stressed final vowel: *comí*, *viví*.
- **Stem stressed** → a strong preterite. It needs **no accent at all**: *tuve*, *hice*, *estuve*.

So the accent is not extra spelling to remember. It is the stress, written down. If a preterite has no accent, the stress moved back onto the stem, and you are looking at one of the strong ones.

What you've built

The two kinds have two histories.
The regular preterite is Spanish doing what Spanish does: one set of endings, and — as in the present and the imperfect — **-er** and **-ir** agreeing with each other rather than going separate ways.
The strong preterites are older. They are Latin's own perfect, carried

through with the stress where Latin had put it, on verbs used too heavily ever to be rebuilt. Which is the same reason the imperfect has only three irregulars: the words people say constantly are the ones that keep their odd shapes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comí*, *viví* — and feel the lift on the last syllable
- *tuve*, *hice*, *estuve* — and feel it move back

Twice through: Until you can place a preterite by ear before you place it by rule.

Before you move on

Where does the stress fall in a strong preterite? (**On the stem.**) What does a missing accent tell you? (That it is one of the strong ones.) And why do the strong ones exist at all? (They are Latin's own perfect, kept intact on verbs used too much to be rebuilt.)

Chapter 107

The Imperfect — What Used to Happen

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can describe an ongoing or habitual past with a regular verb from any family.

-aba and -ia, and -er and -ir agreeing once again.

107.1 hablaba — let a past action stay open

Hablé español presents speaking as a completed past event. A different past, the **imperfect**, can leave the action open: **Hablaba español** — "I was speaking Spanish" or "I used to speak Spanish." The sentence does not say where the action ended.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

person	open or habitual past
yo	habl**aba**
tú	habl**abas**
él / ella / usted	habl**aba**

Say **hablaba** · **hablabas** · **hablaba**. The first and third forms are identical; the surrounding conversation or an explicit person tells you who is speaking. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **-aba** continues the Latin imperfect family in **-ābam**. Historical sound change reshaped the complete Latin forms, but the **b** remains a useful audible bridge between **-ābam** and Spanish **-aba**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablaba, hablabas, hablaba"
- "Hablé español. Hablaba español."
- "-ābam and -aba share b"

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaba, hablabas, hablaba.*) What can the imperfect do? (Leave a past action ongoing or habitual.) Which Latin family stands behind **-aba**? (**-ābam**.) Next: build the same gentle frame with **comer**.

107.2 comía — hear both vowels

Comí presents eating as completed. **Comía** leaves it open or habitual: "I was eating" or "I used to eat." One accent separates the two forms in writing and in sound.

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	open or habitual past
yo	com**ía**
tú	com**ías**
él / ella / usted	com**ía**

Say **comía** · **comías** · **comía**. As with **hablaba**, the first and third forms match. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: co-mí-a

The accent in **-ía** keeps **i** and **a** in separate syllables: **co-mí-a**, three beats. It appears in every form learned here. Compare final stress in **comí** with the middle stress and extra syllable in **comía**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-er** imperfect continues a Romance reshaping of Latin **-ēbam** material. Among the changes, an intervocalic **b** was lost; later Spanish spelling marks the stressed **í** that keeps **i-a** apart. This is a layered history, not a single instruction to delete one letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "comía, comías, comía"
- "Comí. Comía."
- "co-mí-a"

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comía, comías, comía.*) What does the accent do? (Keeps **i** and **a** apart.) Which Latin family lies behind the ending? (**-ēbam**, reshaped through Romance.) Next: test whether **vivir** can reuse this row.

107.3 vivía — reuse the complete -er row

An earlier chapter let **comer** and **vivir** share one completed-past row. They converge again here. Replace **com-** in **comía, comías, comía** with **viv-**.

Grammar Lens: one row reused

person	comer	vivir
yo	comía	vivía
tú	comías	vivías
él / ella / usted	comía	vivía

Say **vivía · vivías · vivía**. **-er** and **-ir** share **-ía, -ías, -ía**. The accent still keeps **i-a** apart. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: one known contrast

- **Viví en Madrid.** — presents living there as a completed stretch.
- **Vivía en Madrid.** — puts us inside that past stretch or treats it as background.

Both are past. The speaker chooses how to frame the event.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Vivir continues Latin **vīvere**. Its infinitive belongs to the Spanish **-ir** class, but the imperfect has converged with **-er**. That shared row is a reliable fact about these learned forms, not a claim that the two conjugations are identical everywhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "vivía, vivías, vivía"
- "comía and vivía share -ía"
- "Viví en Madrid. Vivía en Madrid."

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Vivía, vivías, vivía.*) Which class shares them? (**-er**.) What contrast can **viví / vivía** make? (Completed stretch versus an open or background past.) Next: learn **ver** before asking it to enter this tense.

Chapter 108

Ver — Seeing

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I see, with a verb whose stem keeps a letter Latin had.
>
> *videre, and the e that other verbs dropped but ver kept.*

108.1 ver — learn the verb before its past

Ver means "to see." Its written **v** uses the Spanish sound you already know: it is not contrasted with a separate English-style **v** sound. Say **ver**.

Grammar Lens: three present forms

person	present
yo	**veo**
tú	**ves**
él / ella / usted	**ve**

The **tú** and third-person forms resemble the familiar **-er** row. The **yo** form keeps an extra vowel: **veo**. Reuse known **café**: **Veo café** — "I see coffee."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **ver** continues Latin **vidēre**, "to see," through Old Spanish **veer**. Loss of the consonant between vowels helps explain the shorter

shape; the two adjacent vowels later contracted in the infinitive. English **video** belongs to the same Latin family, a memory bridge rather than a new Spanish word for this lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ver — to see"
- "veo, ves, ve"
- "ver comes through veer from vidēre"

Before you move on

What does **ver** mean? ("To see.") Give its three learned present forms. (*Veo, ves, ve.*) Which Latin verb stands behind it? (**Vidēre**.) Next: add **ser** to the open past.

Chapter 109

The Only Three Irregulars

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use era, iba and veia, and know that no fourth irregular imperfect exists.
>
> *erat and ibat worn straight through from Latin, never tidied up.*

109.1 era — an old root in an open past

You know present **soy, eres, es** and completed-past **fui, fuiste, fue**. The open or background past of **ser** uses a different short stem: **era**.

Grammar Lens: the singular ser row

person	open or background past
yo	**era**
tú	**eras**
él / ella / usted	**era**

Say **era** · **eras** · **era**. The first and third forms match, just as they did in the regular imperfect rows. **¿Era usted?** asks "Was it you?" without adding a new noun. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Era continues Latin **eram**, an old form in the **esse** family. That is the family already connected to Spanish **ser** and English **essence**. The

preterite **fue** comes from another historical set, so **era / fue** is a real contrast inside one modern verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "era, eras, era"
- "¿Era usted?"
- "era comes from Latin eram"

Before you move on

Give the three learned **ser** forms. (*Era, eras, era.*) Which past form supplies background, **era** or **fue**? (**Era**.) Which Latin form stands behind it? (**Eram**.) Next: follow **ir** back toward its own older verb.

109.2 iba — ir returns to its inherited past

Present **voy** and completed-past **fui** came from different historical sets. For an open or habitual past, **ir** gives you **iba** — "I was going" or "I used to go."

Grammar Lens: the singular ir row

person	open or habitual past
yo	**iba**
tú	**ibas**
él / ella / usted	**iba**

Say **iba · ibas · iba**. Reuse the destination frame: **Iba a Madrid** — "I was going to Madrid" or "I used to go to Madrid." Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Iba continues Latin **ībam**, from **īre**, the inherited verb behind the Spanish infinitive **ir**. Present **voy** contains material associated with **vādere**, while preterite **fui** comes from the Latin "be" perfect family.

These sources help explain the three learned sets; they do not mean that every form in every tense can be assigned to one source by a three-box rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "iba, ibas, iba"
- "Fui a Madrid. Iba a Madrid."
- "iba continues ībam from īre"

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Iba, ibas, iba.*) Say "I was going to Madrid." (*Iba a Madrid.*) Which Latin form stands behind **iba**? (**Ībam**, from **īre**.) Next: put newly learned **ver** into the same past.

109.3 veía — keep the extra e you already met

You learned **ver** before its past: **veo, ves, ve**. Its imperfect keeps **ve-** and adds the familiar **-ía** row. That gives **veía** — "I was seeing" or "I used to see."

Grammar Lens: the singular ver row

person	open or habitual past
yo	**veía**
tú	**veías**
él / ella / usted	**veía**

Say **veía** · **veías** · **veía**. Keep **í-a** in separate syllables. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Old Spanish **veer** displays the **ve-** shape clearly. The imperfect **veía** preserves that vowel before the familiar **-ía** material. It is useful to call this an exceptional learned row, but not to pretend that **ver** was

already known before this chapter or that the history is merely "regular plus one letter."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "veía, veías, veía"
- "Veo café. Veía café."
- "veer helps explain ve-"

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Veía, veías, veía.*) Which vowel stays before **-ía**? (**e**.) Which earlier form displays it? (**Veer**.) Next: retrieve every row of this chapter and make a few bounded contrasts.

Chapter 110

Synthesis — Three Exceptions, and No Others

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the imperfect freely, knowing its complete irregular inventory is three verbs.
>
> *The exceptions are the words you use most - which is the reason they are exceptions.*

110.1 Practice — keep the past open or close it

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary and no plural persons. Retrieve the seven learned singular rows, then choose whether a known sentence presents the past as completed or leaves it open as background, progress, or habit.

Grammar Lens: the complete frame for this chapter

Regular rows:

- **yo: hablaba · comía · vivía**.
- **tú: hablabas · comías · vivías**.
- **él / ella / usted: hablaba · comía · vivía**.

The three special rows:

- **yo: era · iba · veía**.

- **tú: eras · ibas · veías**.
- **él / ella / usted: era · iba · veía**.

The first and third forms match in every learned row. **Comer** and **vivir** share **-ía, -ías, -ía**. **Ver** keeps **ve-** before that material. Plural persons remain outside this checkpoint.

Grammar Lens: one scene, two frames

- **Hablé español.** — completed event. **Hablaba español.** — open, background, or habitual speaking.
- **Viví en Madrid.** — completed stretch. **Vivía en Madrid.** — we stand inside that past stretch.
- **Fui a Madrid.** — completed trip. **Iba a Madrid.** — motion was in progress or habitual.

The tense does not mechanically report how long something lasted. It frames the past from a different viewpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

-aba continues the Latin **-ābam** family. **-ía** continues material from the **-ēbam** family after several Romance changes. **Era** continues **eram**; **iba** continues **ībam** from **īre**; and **veía** keeps the **ve-** shape also visible in Old Spanish **veer**. These are historical bridges, not recipes for generating unlearned forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaba, comía, vivía”
- “era, iba, veía”
- “Hablé / hablaba · viví / vivía · fui / iba”

Before you move on

Give the six **yo** forms. (*Hablaba, comía, vivía, era, iba, veía.*) Which two regular classes share a row? (**-er** and **-ir**.) What is the core contrast? (The preterite presents a completed event; the imperfect leaves past action open, habitual, in progress, or in the background.) Chapter 17 can now build on **-ía** without borrowing a plural form here.

110.2 Synthesis — three exceptions, and no others

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *hablaba*, then *comía*.

What you've built

Here is the fact that no single lesson of this chapter could give you, and it is worth more than any of them.

The imperfect has exactly three irregular verbs in the entire language. *Ser*, *ir*, *ver*. That is the complete list — not "the common ones", not "to start with". Three.

Every other Spanish verb, without exception, takes **-aba** or **-ía** and behaves. After the preterite, which has a strong stem for what feels like every verb worth using, this is a tense that simply lets you get on with it.

So the honest instruction for the imperfect is short: learn *era*, *iba* and *veía*, and stop worrying.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

And the three are not random. They are the *most used verbs in the language* — to be, to go, to see — worn straight through from Latin *erat* and *ibat* without ever being tidied up.

That is how irregularity works everywhere: a form survives unchanged because it is said constantly, and speakers never have to reach for a rule to rebuild it. Rare verbs get regularised precisely because nobody remembers them well enough to keep the odd shape alive.

> The exceptions are the words you use most. That is not bad luck — it is the reason they are exceptions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *era*, *iba*, *veía* — the whole irregular inventory, in one breath
- *hablaba*, *comía*, *vivía* — and notice nothing surprises you

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many irregular imperfects are there? (**Three** — and that is all.) Which verbs? (*Ser*, *ir*, *ver*.) And why those three? (Because they are the ones people say constantly, so the old forms were never worn into a rule.)

Chapter 111

Hablaba and Hablo — Two Ways of Looking

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that the two past tenses differ in viewpoint rather than in time.
>
> *Complete ES-C48-dos-miradas: say whether the two pasts differ in when, and identify which one views an event from outside.*

111.1 hablaba and habló — two ways of looking

You hold two past tenses. Say "I spoke" in both. (*Hablé. Hablaba.*)

Grammar Lens: not two times — two viewpoints

The obvious guess is that one is further back than the other. It is not. Both describe the same afternoon.

> *Ayer* ***hablé*** *con Ana.* — Yesterday I spoke with Ana. *Ayer* ***hablaba*** *con Ana.* — Yesterday I was speaking with Ana.

Same day, same conversation, same two people. What changes is **where you are standing**.

- ***Hablé*** looks at the conversation from outside, finished, as one thing with edges. It happened, it is over, next.

- ***Hablaba*** puts you inside it, while it is still going on. No edges. It is the scenery, not the event.

This is why the choice cannot be made by a rule about time. It is made by what you are doing with the sentence: **reporting something that happened**, or **setting a scene where something else can happen**.
Grammar books call this *aspect*. The word is not important. The habit is: when you reach for a past tense, you are being asked a question about your own point of view, and you answer it every time whether you notice or not.

Why it's said this way

English asks you the same question and lets you dodge it.

> I spoke. I was speaking. I used to speak.

Those are three different viewpoints, and English marks them with extra words rather than with the verb itself. Because they are optional, you can say "I spoke" for almost anything and be understood.
Spanish put the choice **inside the verb**, so it is not optional. Every past sentence commits to a viewpoint before it commits to anything else. That is why this is the piece of Spanish that stays difficult longest for English speakers: not because it is complicated, but because it asks a question your first language let you leave unanswered.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablé" then "hablaba" — outside, then inside
- "estudié" then "estudiaba"

Before you move on

Do the two pasts differ in **when**? (**No** — in how you look at it.) Which one has edges? (The **preterite**.) Next: the word that lets both of them stand in one sentence.

Chapter 112

Cuando — Both Pasts in One Sentence

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can join a scene and an event with cuando, using the right tense for each.

Complete ES-C48-cuando: build estudiaba cuando hablo Ana and say which tense sets the room.

112.1 cuando — putting both pasts in one sentence

One tense is the scenery and one is the event. So far you have only been able to use one at a time. This chapter's word lets them share a sentence.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ua` — *cua* is one syllable, not two: *KWAN-doh.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cuando — *when.*

From Latin **quandō**, and the *qu-* at the front is not decoration. It is the same question-marker sitting inside *qué*, *quién* and *cómo* — a family you have been collecting since your very first questions. Latin built its question words from one root and Spanish kept the

whole set, so *cuándo* with an accent asks a question and *cuando* without one simply joins two things. Same word, and the accent is doing the same job it always does: marking the stressed, questioning one.

Grammar Lens: the scene and the thing that interrupts it

Now the two tenses can do their jobs side by side:

> ***Estudiaba cuando habló*** *Ana.* — I **was studying** when Ana **spoke**.

Read what each tense is doing:

- *Estudiaba* — imperfect. The **scene**. Already going, no edges, and it does not stop being true when something else happens.
- *Habló* — preterite. The **event**. One thing, with edges, dropped into that scene.

This is the shape most Spanish stories are built from, and it is worth hearing the pattern rather than memorising a rule: **the imperfect sets the room, the preterite is what walks into it.**
Turn it around and the sentence changes meaning, not just style:

> *Estudié cuando hablaba Ana.* — I studied while Ana was talking.

Now the talking is the room and the studying is the event. Neither version is more correct. They are about different things.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Estudiaba cuando habló Ana"
- the reversed version, and notice the story changed

Before you move on

Which tense is the room? (The **imperfect**.) Which one walks into it? (The **preterite**.) Next: two verbs where the choice does not change the picture — it changes the **meaning**.

Chapter 113

Tenia and Tuve — When the Tense Changes the Meaning

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say why tuve una casa means I got one, and predict what a state verb's preterite will mean.

Complete ES-C48-tenia-tuve: contrast tenia and tuve, and say what any state verb's preterite will mean.

113.1 tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning

So far the two pasts have shown you the same event from two places. With one very common verb, they show you two **different** events.

Grammar Lens: having, and getting

Tenía *una casa.* — I **had** a house. ***Tuve*** *una casa.* — I **got** a house.

Read those twice. The second one is not "I had a house, viewed as finished." It is a different verb in English altogether.
The reason follows from everything you already know. *Tener* means a **state** — having something is not an event, it is a condition that simply continues. So the imperfect, which has no edges, fits it perfectly: *tenía* is the ordinary way to say you had something.

Force that state into the preterite and you are demanding edges for something that does not have any. Spanish resolves the clash the only way it can: **it gives you the moment the state began.** The edge of *having* is *getting*.
Nothing irregular is happening. It is the same aspect rule you met two chapters ago, applied to a verb where the result is a new word in English.

Why it's said this way

This is worth more than one verb, because the same thing happens to every verb that names a state rather than an action. When you meet those verbs later, you will not need a list — you will already know what their preterite is going to mean: **the moment the state started.**
It also explains a frustration you may already have had. English "I had" covers both sentences above, so an English speaker reaching for *tuve* is often reaching for the wrong one. The fix is not to memorise which is which. It is to notice that you are describing a **state**, and states live in the imperfect unless you specifically mean the moment they began.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Tenía una casa" then "Tuve una casa" — hear the English change
- the rule aloud — a state in the preterite gives you its beginning

Before you move on

Tenía una casa? (I **had** one.) *Tuve una casa*? (I **got** one.) And why? (A state forced into the preterite gives you the **moment it began**.) Next: all of it in one place.

Chapter 114

Review — One Question, Three Answers

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can state the single question that chooses between the two past tenses.

Complete ES-C48-repaso-dos-pasados: state the question, identify the scene verb, and name the pair that changes meaning.

114.1 Review — one question, three answers

Nothing new. Before the table: do the two past tenses differ in **when**?

What you've built

Three chapters, one question, three ways it gets answered.

what you are doing	tense	example
reporting an event, with edges	**preterite**	*hablé* — I spoke
setting a scene, no edges	**imperfect**	*hablaba* — I was speaking
naming a state	**imperfect**	*tenía* — I had
naming the moment a state began	**preterite**	*tuve* — I got

Rows one and two are the same event seen from two places. Rows

three and four are not: there the tense changes what happened.

Grammar Lens: the question to actually ask

Not *"which tense is this?"* — that has no answer without you.

> **Am I telling you what happened, or what things were like?**

What happened has edges: preterite. *What things were like* does not: imperfect. A story is mostly the second with the first dropped into it, which is what *cuando* let you build:

> *Estudiaba cuando habló Ana.*

And when the verb names a state rather than an action, the same question still works — you are simply more likely to be describing what things were like, so the imperfect is the ordinary case and the preterite is the special one.
There is no list to memorise here, and that is deliberate. Lists of "preterite trigger words" exist in most courses and they fail exactly where the choice is interesting, because the same word can sit in either sentence. The question does not fail, because the question is the thing the language is actually asking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablé / hablaba", then "tenía / tuve", and name the difference in each pair
- the question aloud before each one

Twice through: Until the question arrives before the verb does.

Before you move on

The one question? (**What happened**, or **what things were like**?) Which pair changes meaning rather than viewpoint? (***Tenía*** and ***tuve***.) Next: a whole small story, which is what all of this was for.

Chapter 115

Synthesis — A Small Story

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can narrate four sentences using both past tenses, with a background and a foreground.
>
> *Complete ES-C48-sintesis-una-historia: identify the two layers of the story and say why tuve belongs to the foreground.*

115.1 Synthesis — a small story

> Everything in this book so far has been sentences. A story is different: it needs a background and a foreground at the same time.

The exchange

Four sentences. Watch the tenses take turns.

> *Yo* ***estudiaba*** *español. No* ***tenía*** *un libro.* ***Tuve*** *un libro en marzo. Y* ***cuando tuve*** *el libro,* ***hablé*** *con Ana.*

Now read only the imperfects: *estudiaba*, *tenía*. Those two sentences tell you **what things were like** — the situation, with no edges, going on for as long as it needed to.

Now read only the preterites: *tuve*, *hablé*. Those tell you **what happened** — two events, each with edges, in order.

The story is the two layers together. Neither layer is a story on its own: the imperfects alone are a description that never moves, and the preterites alone are a list of events with no world around them.

Grammar Lens: what you can now do

Notice the third sentence. *Tuve un libro* is not "I had a book" — it is the moment you **got** one, which is why it belongs in the foreground with *hablé* rather than in the background with *tenía*. The same verb appears in both layers of this story, doing two different jobs, and nothing about it is irregular.
That is the whole rung. From here you can narrate: not just report that something happened, but say what the world was like while it did. It is worth naming the cost. Two tenses learned separately, then three chapters on nothing but the choice between them — because the forms were never the difficulty. English lets you leave this question unanswered; Spanish does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four sentences straight through
- only the imperfects, then only the preterites, and hear the two layers

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which layer says what things were like? (The **imperfect**.) Which says what happened? (The **preterite**.) And what can you do now that you could not before? (**Tell a story** — not just report events, but say what the world was like while they happened.)

Chapter 116

Hablado, Comido, Vivido — The Participle

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the participle of any regular verb, and know it never changes for person.

Complete ES-C49-participio: form the three participles and say whether the form changes with the speaker.

116.1 hablado, comido, vivido — the participle

Your three verb families, once more: *hablar*, *comer*, *vivir*. This chapter gives each of them one new form, and two of the three get the same one.

Grammar Lens: two endings, not three

hablar → **hablado** · **com**er → **comido** · **viv**ir → **vivido**

- **-ar** verbs take **-ado**.
- **-er** and **-ir** verbs both take **-ido**.

You have seen those two families collapse into one before: in the preterite, where *comí* and *viví* have identical endings. It happens here for the same reason it happened there — the difference between *-er* and *-ir* was never deep, and outside the present tense it mostly stops existing.

So this is one new ending and one you can predict.
The word itself does not change for who is speaking. *Hablado* is *hablado* whether you, I, or a hundred people did the speaking. That is unusual enough to notice: every other verb form you hold has been carrying a person on its back.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Grammarians call this a **participle**, from Latin **participium** — "the form that **takes part**." It was named for doing two jobs at once: it is built from a verb, and it behaves like an adjective.
You can see the adjective half immediately. *Cansado* ("tired") is the participle of *cansar*, and it agrees like any adjective: *cansada*, *cansados*. The same shape, doing adjective work.
Next chapter puts it to its verb work instead — and there, held in place by another word, it stops agreeing with anything at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablado, comido, vivido" — one ending, then the shared one
- "comí, viví" then "comido, vivido" — the same merger, twice

Before you move on

Participle of *hablar*? (***Hablado***.) Of *comer* and *vivir*? (***Comido***, ***vivido*** — the same ending.) What does *participium* mean? (The form that **takes part** — verb and adjective at once.) Next: the word that turns it into a tense.

Chapter 117

He Hablado — A Verb With No Meaning Left

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say he hablado, and say what haber contributes to it.

Complete ES-C49-he-hablado: produce he hablado espanol and say what haber means there.

117.1 he hablado — "I have spoken"

You have *hablado*, and it cannot stand alone — it names no person and no time. It needs a word in front of it. Here is that word.

Sounds you'll need

- `silent-h` — the *h* in *he* is silent, as every Spanish *h* is. It is one sound: *eh*.

Grammar Lens: the emptied verb

he + participle — *I have* done something.

***He hablado** español.* — I have spoken Spanish.

Two words, and the work is split cleanly between them. *He* carries the person and the tense. *Hablado* carries the meaning. Neither does the

other's job, and that division is why the participle never had to agree with anybody.
He is a form of **haber** — and here is the thing worth the chapter: **haber does not mean anything here.** It is not "I hold spoken." You cannot translate it on its own. It is a word whose entire remaining purpose is to hold a participle in place.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Haber comes from Latin **habēre**, "to hold, to have" — a completely ordinary verb with a completely ordinary meaning.
Then Spanish did something drastic. It handed the *meaning* to **tener** (which had been the narrower "hold, grip"), and kept *haber* for this one grammatical job. The verb was hollowed out: the meaning left, the machinery stayed.
English did exactly the same thing to *have*, and you never noticed. When you say *I have eaten*, nobody is holding anything. Two languages, independently, took their word for "hold" and wore it down into a tense marker — because the step from *I have a thing that is done* to *I have done a thing* is a very short one, and everybody takes it eventually.
So when *haber* feels meaningless, that is not a gap in your understanding. It is an accurate perception of what happened to the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "He hablado español"
- "I have eaten" in English, and notice that nothing is being held

Before you move on

"I have spoken"? (***He hablado***.) Which word carries the meaning? (***Hablado***.) And what does *haber* contribute? (**A person and a tense** — and no meaning at all.) Next: the rest of it.

Chapter 118

Has, Ha, Hemos, Habeis, Han

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use every form of haber with a participle.
>
> *Complete ES-C49-haber-completo: give all six forms and say why haber is shorter than an ordinary verb.*

118.1 has, ha, hemos, habéis, han

Say "I have eaten." (*He comido.*) Now the other five people need their word.

Grammar Lens: the whole of it

	haber	**with a participle**
I	**he**	*he comido*
you	**has**	*has comido*
he / she / usted	**ha**	*ha comido*
we	**hemos**	*hemos comido*
you all *(Spain)*	**habéis**	*habéis comido*
they / ustedes	**han**	*han comido*

Six forms, and five of them are one syllable. Only *hemos* and *habéis* are longer, and they are the two you say least often.

That is not a coincidence, and it is the same principle you met with *ser* and *ir*: **the most-used words wear down the most.** *Haber* is said in every perfect sentence in the language, so it has been ground shorter

than any ordinary verb — down to *he*, *has*, *ha*, which barely have room to be irregular in.
Notice also what does **not** change. *Comido* is *comido* in all six rows. One word does all the person-work and the other never moves, which is why this tense, unlike every other you have learned, costs six little words rather than six endings on every verb you know.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "he, has, ha, hemos, habéis, han" until the list is one breath
- "he comido, has comido, ha comido…" through all six

Twice through:

Before you move on

"They have eaten"? (***Han comido.***) "We have eaten"? (***Hemos comido.***) How many times does the participle change? (**Never.**) Next: four participles that refused to follow the rule.

Chapter 119

Hecho, Dicho, Visto, Puesto

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the four irregular participles and say why those four.

Complete ES-C49-participios-irregulares: give the four forms, name the English noun that is hecho, and say why these four break the rule.

119.1 hecho, dicho, visto, puesto

By the rule, the participle of *hacer* should be *hacido*. Say it. Now be told that nobody has ever said it.

Grammar Lens: four, and you could have guessed which

verb	participle	in use
hacer	**hecho**	*he hecho* — I have done
decir	**dicho**	*he dicho* — I have said
ver	**visto**	*he visto* — I have seen
poner	**puesto**	*he puesto* — I have put

Look at that list of verbs before you look at the forms. *Do*, *say*, *see*, *put* — four of the commonest verbs in any language, and the same four that have been irregular in every tense you have met. The verbs that break rules are not a random selection: **they are always the ones**

said most often, because frequent words are the only ones used enough to survive being irregular.
You already know this in English. *Go/went*, *see/saw*, *do/did*, *put/put* — and nobody struggles with them, because you meet them a hundred times a day. The same will happen here.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

These four are not broken. They are **older than the rule**.

- *hecho* ← Latin **factum** — the thing done. English **fact** is that same word: a fact is literally *a thing that has been done*.
- *dicho* ← Latin **dictum** — the thing said. English keeps *dictum* whole, and *dictation*, *verdict* ("a true saying"), *contradict*.
- *visto* ← Latin **vīsum** — the thing seen. English **vision**, **visible**.
- *puesto* ← Latin **positum** — the thing placed. English **position**, **deposit**, **compose**.

Latin already had participles for these verbs, and Spanish inherited them intact instead of rebuilding them from the stem. The regular *-ado* / *-ido* forms are the newer machinery; these four are what was there before it.
So an irregular participle is not a form that went wrong. It is a form that was never replaced.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hecho, dicho, visto, puesto"
- each with English beside it — "hecho / fact", "dicho / dictum", "visto / vision", "puesto / position"

Before you move on

The four? (***Hecho, dicho, visto, puesto***.) Are they broken forms? (**No** — they are **older than the rule**, inherited whole from Latin.) Next: all of it together.

Chapter 120

Review — A Tense You Build

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the two pieces of the perfect and say which carries the person.
>
> *Complete ES-C49-repaso-perfecto: name the two pieces and say why this tense cost less than the present or preterite.*

120.1 Review — a tense you build

Nothing new. Two questions: how many words is this tense, and which of them carries the person?

What you've built

Piece one — the person: *he, has, ha, hemos, habéis, han.*
Piece two — the meaning: the participle, which never changes.

	regular	
-ar	**-ado**	*hablado*
-er / -ir	**-ido**	*comido*, *vivido*
	irregular	
hacer	**hecho**	*decir* → **dicho**
ver	**visto**	*poner* → **puesto**

Six little words times any participle you can form. That is the whole tense.

Grammar Lens: why this one was cheap

Every other tense you have learned made you attach endings to **every verb**. The present has six endings per family; the preterite has its own set; the imperfect has another.
This one does not work like that. You learn **six words once**, and then any verb you ever meet joins the tense by forming a single participle.
A tense that is *built* rather than *conjugated* costs a fixed amount instead of a per-verb amount.
That is worth recognising as a shape, because Spanish does it again. Once you have *haber* plus a participle, the same two pieces will give you more tenses later by changing only the little word — and each of those will cost you almost nothing, for the same reason this one did.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "he hablado, has comido, ha vivido, hemos hecho, habéis dicho, han visto"

Twice through: Until the little word arrives without thought.

Before you move on

Two pieces — name them. (A form of ***haber***, plus a **participle**.) The four irregulars? (***Hecho, dicho, visto, puesto***.) Next: when to reach for this tense instead of the preterite — and the answer depends on where you are standing on the map.

Chapter 121

Synthesis — Two Shores, Two Answers

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what the perfect does that the preterite does not, and that today takes different tenses in Spain and Latin America.
>
> *Complete ES-C49-sintesis-dos-orillas: contrast he comido with comi, and say which tense Madrid and Mexico City choose for today.*

121.1 Synthesis — two shores, two answers

You can now say "I spoke" two ways: *hablé* and *he hablado*. The obvious question is which one to use, and it has an unusual answer.

Grammar Lens: what the perfect is for

Start with the part everybody agrees on. The perfect reaches into **now**:

> *He comido.* — I have eaten. *(so I am not hungry) Comí.* — I ate. *(a finished event, back there)*

The preterite puts an event in the past and leaves it there. The perfect drags it forward and makes it matter now — the tense is telling your listener what to do with the information, not when it happened. English agrees: *I have eaten* and *I ate* are not interchangeable for you either.

Why it's said this way

Now the part nobody agrees on, and it is worth having straight before you are corrected by two people who contradict each other.
For something that happened **today**, Spain and most of Latin America choose differently:

> *Hoy* ***he hablado*** *con Ana.* — **Spain.** *Hoy* ***hablé*** *con Ana.* — **most of Latin America.**

Same day, same conversation, both entirely correct. Spain uses the perfect for anything inside the current stretch of time; much of Latin America uses the preterite and saves the perfect for things whose relevance is still open.
Third split in this book decided by **geography rather than meaning**, after *vosotros* and *os*. There is no version of Spanish that is the real one, and no choice here that will make you wrong.
A default, if you want one: the Latin American pattern is understood everywhere and is what most learners meet first, so leaning on the preterite for finished events is a safe habit. In Spain you will hear the perfect constantly and pick it up in a week.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "He comido" then "Comí" — one reaches into now, one does not
- "Hoy he hablado con Ana" then "Hoy hablé con Ana" — two shores

Twice through:

Before you move on

What does the perfect do that the preterite does not? (**Reaches into now.**) And for something that happened today? (**Spain** says *he hablado*; **much of Latin America** says *hablé* — and both are right.)

Chapter 122

The Future — Saying What Will Happen

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I will do, in the singular, across all three verb families.

The future endings ride on the whole infinitive, one family at a time.

122.1 hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future

Voy a hablar español uses the near-future frame you already know. Spanish also has a one-word future: **Hablaré español** — "I will speak Spanish." It can present a future prediction or intention without adding a new subject or object.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

Keep the whole infinitive **hablar**, then add one ending:

person	simple future
yo	hablar**é**
tú	hablar**ás**
él / ella / usted	hablar**á**

Say **hablaré** · **hablarás** · **hablará**. Each form has final stress, marked by an accent. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Late Latin and early Romance used more than one way to speak about the future. One influential construction placed an infinitive beside present forms of Latin **habēre**, "to have." Through repeated use and sound change, descendants of those pieces became the endings in forms such as **hablaré**.
That history explains why the infinitive remains visible. It does **not** mean that a modern learner should attach the full modern verb **haber**, and it does not require the claim that every older future vanished at one moment.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablaré, hablarás, hablará"
- "Voy a hablar español. Hablaré español."
- "infinitive plus historical habēre material"

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaré, hablarás, hablará.*) What stays visible? (The whole infinitive.) What older verb contributed to the endings? (Latin **habēre**.) Next: test the same endings on **comer**.

122.2 comeré — the same endings keep -er

You built **hablaré** without removing **-ar**. Keep **comer** just as intact: **comeré** — "I will eat."

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	simple future
yo	comer**é**
tú	comer**ás**
él / ella / usted	comer**á**

Say **comeré** · **comerás** · **comerá**. Compare **hablaré** / **comeré**:

the infinitives differ, but the future endings do not. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The historical infinitive-plus-**habēre** construction helps explain the shared endings: the verb-family vowel remains inside **hablar** or **comer**, rather than selecting a different ending set.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "comeré, comerás, comerá"
- "Hablaré. Comeré."
- "Beberé café."

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comeré, comerás, comerá.*) Did the **-er** disappear? (No.) Which endings match **hablar**? (**-é, -ás, -á**.) Next: let **vivir** test the pattern once more.

122.3 viviré — one future row for three verb families

Hablaré kept **-ar**. **Comeré** kept **-er**. Predict the yo future of **vivir** before reading on. It is **viviré**.

Grammar Lens: the singular -ir row

person	simple future
yo	vivir**é**
tú	vivir**ás**
él / ella / usted	vivir**á**

Say **viviré** · **vivirás** · **vivirá**. Now the bounded pattern is complete: **hablaré, comeré, viviré**. The same three endings attach to all three whole infinitives. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: meaning with known words

Viviré en Madrid says "I will live in Madrid." Every lexical piece was available before this lesson; only the future form is new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "viviré, vivirás, vivirá"
- "hablaré, comeré, viviré"
- "Viviré en Madrid."

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Viviré, vivirás, vivirá.*) Which verb families share the learned endings? (All three: **-ar, -er, -ir**.) Next: reuse the whole-infinitive frame for "would."

Chapter 123

The Conditional — Saying What Would Happen

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I would do, in the singular, across all three verb families.
>
> *The same infinitive, a different auxiliary tense on the end.*

123.1 hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía

Hablaré español places speaking in the future. **Hablaría español** means "I would speak Spanish" in an imagined or conditional situation. Today the situation can remain unstated; learn the form and its core "would" meaning first.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

Keep **hablar** whole, then add the learned singular conditional endings:

person	conditional
yo	hablar**ía**
tú	hablar**ías**
él / ella / usted	hablar**ía**

Say **hablaría** · **hablarías** · **hablaría**. The first and third forms match. The accent keeps **í-a** in separate syllables, just as it did in **comía**. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The conditional developed from an infinitive beside past or imperfect forms of the same "have" verb that helped form the Romance future. That is why the whole infinitive remains visible again and why the endings resemble the **-ía** row. The history passes through older Romance forms; modern **hablaría** is not made by attaching the complete modern word **había**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablaría, hablarías, hablaría"
- "Hablaré español. Hablaría español."
- "ha-bla-rí-a"

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaría, hablarías, hablaría.*) What is the core meaning? ("Would speak.") Which older construction stands behind the row? (An infinitive plus past forms of **haber**.) Next: give **comer** the same ending set.

123.2 comería — keep -er before "would"

Comeré means "I will eat." Keep **comer** whole and exchange the future ending for **-ía**: **comería** — "I would eat."

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	conditional
yo	comer**ía**
tú	comer**ías**
él / ella / usted	comer**ía**

Say **comería** · **comerías** · **comería**. Compare **hablaría** / **comería**: one bounded ending set serves both complete infinitives. Plural persons wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "comería, comerías, comería"
- "comeré, comería"
- "hablaría, comería"

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comería, comerías, comería.*) Which piece stays whole? (**Comer**.) Which endings match **hablaría**? (**-ía, -ías, -ía**.) Next: complete the regular pattern with **vivir**.

123.3 viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame

You can move from **comeré** to **comería**. Apply the same move to **viviré**: **viviría** — "I would live."

Grammar Lens: the singular -ir row

person	conditional
yo	vivir**ía**
tú	vivir**ías**
él / ella / usted	vivir**ía**

Say **viviría · vivirías · viviría**. The complete regular frame is now **hablaría, comería, viviría**. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: meaning with known words

Viviría en Madrid says "I would live in Madrid." The lesson adds no new place or preposition.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "viviría, vivirías, viviría"

- “hablaría, comería, viviría”
- “Viviría en Madrid.”

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Viviría, vivirías, viviría.*) Which regular verb families share the ending row? (All three.) Next: three already-known verbs change the stem but keep both sets of endings.

Chapter 124

One Stem, Two Tenses

Modes: **voice** (1) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the irregular stems that serve the future and the conditional alike.

hare, tendre, podre - stems shared by both tenses, so learning one buys the other.

124.1 haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets

Regular verbs keep the whole infinitive. Three common verbs you already know use a shorter or reshaped stem. Learn only these three today. In each row, the **same** stem serves the future and the conditional.

Grammar Lens: hacer becomes har-

person	future	conditional
yo	**haré**	**haría**
tú	**harás**	**harías**
él / ella / usted	**hará**	**haría**

Use the known noun in **Haré café** — "I will make coffee" — and **Haría café** — "I would make coffee."

Grammar Lens: tener becomes tendr-

person	future	conditional
yo	**tendré**	**tendría**
tú	**tendrás**	**tendrías**
él / ella / usted	**tendrá**	**tendría**

The **d** in **tendr-** arose during the history of the compact future and conditional. Treat **tendr-** as the learned stem, not as permission to insert **d** into a new verb.

Grammar Lens: poder becomes podr-

person	future	conditional
yo	**podré**	**podría**
tú	**podrás**	**podrías**
él / ella / usted	**podrá**	**podría**

Podré hablar español says "I will be able to speak Spanish." **Podría hablar español** says "I could / would be able to speak Spanish." These stems reflect inherited reductions and sound changes. The useful modern fact is bounded: **har-** · **tendr-** · **podr-**, each followed by the same endings you already learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "haré, haría"
- "tendré, tendría"
- "podré, podría"

Before you move on

Give the three learned stems. (**Har-, tendr-, podr-.**) Does each verb need separate future and conditional stems? (No; one stem serves both.) Do the endings change? (No.) Next: retrieve the complete twelve-atom chapter.

124.2 Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary and no plural persons. Retrieve the six regular singular rows, then the three learned irregular stems. Use the future for "will" and the conditional for the bounded core meaning "would."

Grammar Lens: the regular frame

person	hablar	comer	vivir
yo future	hablaré	comeré	viviré
tú future	hablarás	comerás	vivirás
él / ella / usted future	hablará	comerá	vivirá
yo conditional	hablaría	comería	viviría
tú conditional	hablarías	comerías	vivirías
él / ella / usted conditional	hablaría	comería	viviría

All three regular infinitives remain whole. Future endings are **-é, -ás, -á**; conditional endings are **-ía, -ías, -ía**. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: three learned stems

verb	learned stem	future yo	conditional yo
hacer	har-	haré	haría
tener	tendr-	tendré	tendría
poder	podr-	podré	podría

The stems change; the ending sets do not. Other irregular stems remain outside this chapter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Romance future and conditional forms grew from constructions pairing an infinitive with forms of Latin **habēre**. Present material contributed to the future; past or imperfect material contributed to the conditional. Many paths and competing forms existed during the change, so this is a bridge for memory, not a one-step story or a recipe

using modern **haber**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hablaré, comeré, viviré"
- "hablaría, comería, viviría"
- "haré/haría · tendré/tendría · podré/podría"

Before you move on

Give the three regular future yo forms. (*Hablaré, comeré, viviré.*) Give the three regular conditional yo forms. (*Hablaría, comería, viviría.*) Which three learned stems replace a whole infinitive? (**Har-, tendr-, podr-.**) What is the careful historical bridge? (Infinitive plus forms of Latin **habēre**, reshaped through Romance.) The next chapter can now begin without borrowing plural persons, new auxiliaries, or clock-time vocabulary.

Chapter 125

Synthesis — Promising, and Supposing

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can choose between a promise and a supposition, and say why the endings differ.
>
> *Haber glued on twice - present for the promise, past for the guess.*

125.1 Synthesis — promising, and supposing

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *hablaré*, then *hablaría*.

Grammar Lens: the two endings are one word, twice

Three chapters ago you were told where these endings came from. Now it is worth seeing what that fact *buys* you.
Both are the verb **haber** — Latin *habēre*, "to have" — glued onto the back of the infinitive. Romance speakers stopped saying "I have to speak" as two words and fused it into one:

> *hablar* + **he** (I have) → **hablaré** — I will speak. *hablar* + **había** (I had) → **hablaría** — I would speak.

That is the entire difference between the two tenses: **the same auxiliary, once in the present and once in the past.** Not two systems to learn — one system, looked at from two moments.

What you've built

And the meaning follows from the grammar rather than being extra to it.
Having to do something **now** is a commitment: **hablaré** is a promise, or a prediction you are standing behind. *Having had to* do it is a supposition — the obligation sits in a past that never arrived, so **hablaría** is hypothetical.

Promise from the present. Suppose from the past.

English hides the same move: *will* is the present of an old verb meaning *to want*, and *would* is its past. **Will/would** is the same pair as **-é/-ía**.

The exchange

— ¿**Hablarás** español en Madrid? — Sí, **hablaré** español.

— ¿Y sin práctica? — **Hablaría** español, pero no bien.

One letter-run apart, and the second speaker has moved from a commitment to a guess without changing a single other word.

Your turn

- *Say it: hablaré* then *hablaría*, and hear a promise turn into a guess

Twice through: Until the choice is about what you mean, not which ending it was.

Before you move on

What is glued onto the infinitive in both tenses? (**Haber** — the verb *to have*.) Which one is a promise, and which a supposition? (*-é* the promise, *-ía* the supposition.) And what is the English pair that works the same way? (**Will** and **would** — a present and a past of one old verb.)

Chapter 126

Wanting, Not Asserting

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can tell an asserted event apart from a wanted one, and say why the verb changes.
>
> *Hablas espanol asserts; quiero que hables asserts nothing at all.*

126.1 Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?

Hablas español can assert "You speak Spanish." Now compare **Quiero que hables español** — "I want you to speak Spanish." **Hables** does not report what is true. It presents the speaking as wanted and not yet asserted. That meaning contrast is the first small doorway into the **subjunctive**.

Grammar Lens: count the doers

meaning	Spanish	doers
I want to speak Spanish.	**Quiero hablar español.**	one: I want; I speak
I want you to speak Spanish.	**Quiero que hables español.**	two: I want; you speak

With one doer, keep the known infinitive **hablar**. With a different doer for the wanted event, use **que** and the new form **hables**. This is a bounded pattern for **querer**, not a rule for every clause in Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hablas español.”
- “Quiero hablar español.”
- “Quiero que hables español.”

Before you move on

Which form asserts the event? (**Hablas.**) Which presents it as wanted? (**Hables**, after **quiero que**.) What happens when the wanter and the speaker are the same? (Use the infinitive: **Quiero hablar**.) Next, build the three singular **-ar** forms one piece at a time.

Chapter 127

The Subjunctive, Regular

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can form the singular present subjunctive of a regular verb in any of the three families.
>
> *hable, coma, viva - the vowels swap sides, and -er and -ir agree again.*

127.1 hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row

You already used **hables** for one friend. Today add only the other two singular slots:

person	present subjunctive
yo	habl**e**
tú	habl**es**
él / ella / usted	habl**e**

Plural forms wait. Say the small row: **hable · hables · hable**.

Grammar Lens: the yo stem, then a vowel swap

Start from present **hablo**. Remove **-o** to reveal **habl-**. Regular **-ar** verbs then use **e** in these subjunctive endings: **-e, -es, -e**. The family vowel has swapped from the familiar **a** to **e**. This recipe will matter later because a verb's special present **yo** stem can travel with it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **subjuntivo** descends from Latin **subiūnctīvus**, "subjoined," from **sub-** "under" plus **iungere** "join." English **join**, **junction**, and **conjunction** belong to the same word family; **yoke** is a more distant cousin. The name helps you picture the wanted clause joined under **quiero que**. It is history, not a complete usage rule.

Your turn

Build each answer only from the learned singular row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Hable, hables, hable.**) Which present form supplies the stem? (**Hablo.**) What did the family vowel do? (**a** → **e**.) What does the name remember? (A clause **subjoined**, or joined under another.)

127.2 coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a

Start from **como**, remove **-o**, and keep **com-**. A regular **-er** verb crosses to the **a** family:

person	present subjunctive
yo	com**a**
tú	com**as**
él / ella / usted	com**a**

Say only the singular row: **coma · comas · coma**.

Grammar Lens: meaning before machinery

Comes can assert "you eat." **Quiero que comas** presents your eating as what I want. The **e** → **a** contrast helps you hear the two meanings. It does not mean that every **a** form is subjunctive; use the learned frame as a whole.

Your turn

Keep **comer** inside the learned singular frame.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Coma, comas, coma.**) Which form asserts "you eat"? (**Comes.**) Which belongs after **quiero que**? (**Comas.**) Next, test whether regular **-ir** behaves differently.

127.3 viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er

Start from **vivo**, remove **-o**, then add the same **a** endings you just used with **comer**:

person	present subjunctive
yo	viv**a**
tú	viv**as**
él / ella / usted	viv**a**

Regular **-er** and **-ir** match in this singular row:

- **comer: coma · comas · coma**.
- **vivir: viva · vivas · viva**.

Plural differences wait.

Grammar Lens: meaning in a known frame

Vives en Madrid asserts where one friend lives. **Quiero que vivas en Madrid** makes that living a wanted event. Nothing new is being smuggled into the sentence: **en** and **Madrid** have appeared in the earlier location frame.

Your turn

Keep **vivir** inside the learned singular frame.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Viva, vivas, viva.**) Which regular family matches **-ir** here? (**-er.**) Which form fits one friend after **quiero que**? (**Vivas.**)

Chapter 128

The Subjunctive Built From the Yo Form

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build the subjunctive of an irregular verb from its yo form.
>
> *quiera, pueda, haga - each one is its own yo form with the vowel swapped.*

128.1 quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know

Present **quiero** already carries the stressed **e** → **ie** change. Remove **-o** to get **quier-**, then add the **-er/-ir** subjunctive endings:

person	present subjunctive
yo	quier**a**
tú	quier**as**
él / ella / usted	quier**a**

Say only this bounded singular row: **quiera · quieras · quiera**.

Grammar Lens: one known verb, one inherited stem

You are not learning a new list of stem-changing verbs. You are carrying one known change into one known row. **Quiero que quieras**

hablar español means "I want you to want to speak Spanish." The sentence is deliberately narrow: no new person noun, object, or plural form.

Your turn

Carry only the known **quier-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Quiera, quieras, quiera.**) Which old change stays visible? (**e → ie.**) Where did the stem come from? (Known **quiero**, minus **-o**.)

128.2 pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change

Present **puedo** already carries **o → ue**. Remove **-o** to get **pued-**, then add the same **a** row:

person	present subjunctive
yo	pued**a**
tú	pued**as**
él / ella / usted	pued**a**

Say **pueda · puedas · pueda**. No other **poder** forms enter today.

Grammar Lens: use it immediately

Quiero que puedas hablar español means "I want you to be able to speak Spanish." Every word was already known except the single form **puedas**. This is the gentle pattern: learn one row, then spend it in the next sentence.

Your turn

Carry only the known **pued-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Pueda, puedas, pueda.**) Which old change stays visible? (**o → ue.**) Which form addresses one friend after **quiero que**? (**Puedas.**)

128.3 haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem

The known present **yo** form is **hago**. Remove **-o** and keep **hag-**:

person	present subjunctive
yo	hag**a**
tú	hag**as**
él / ella / usted	hag**a**

Say **haga · hagas · haga**. Only **hacer** enters this lesson; other special stems wait for later chapters.

Grammar Lens: spend the new form

Haces café can assert "you make coffee." **Quiero que hagas café** says "I want you to make coffee." The **g** is not a fresh exception: it was already in **hago**, the present form that supplied the stem.

Your turn

Carry only the known **hag-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Haga, hagas, haga.**) Where does **hag-** come from? (Known **hago**, minus **-o**.) Say the wanted event. (**Quiero que hagas café.**)

Chapter 129

Ojala — a Prayer That Outlived Its Religion

Modes: **voice** (2) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish for something with ojala, and say where the word came from.

wa-sha' allah, carried through al-Andalus and kept long after.

129.1 ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic

Ojalá hables español means "I hope you speak Spanish" or "May you speak Spanish." **Ojalá** expresses the wish by itself. It needs neither a main verb nor **que** before the subjunctive. Keep the first frame tiny:

Ojalá + subjunctive

That is a usable modern pattern. It does not make the Arabic source phrase new Spanish vocabulary.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The Real Academia Española records **ojalá** from Hispanic Arabic **wa šá lláh**, "and God has willed." Long contact in al-Andalus carried the expression into Spanish, where its sound and grammatical life changed. You met another Arabic-derived function word in **hasta**. The

historical phrase explains a route; only modern **ojalá** is available for your Spanish sentences.

Your turn

Use only modern **ojalá** as the Spanish trigger.

Before you move on

What follows **ojalá** in the learned frame? (The **subjunctive**.) Does it need **que**? (**No.**) Which historical language variety carried the word into Spanish? (**Hispanic Arabic.**) Is the older Arabic phrase usable as new Spanish vocabulary here? (**No.**)

129.2 Practice — assert the event or want it

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary, plural person, object pronoun, or new clause frame. First decide whether the event is asserted or wanted. Then retrieve only the singular rows you learned.

Grammar Lens: the bounded map

verb	yo / él / ella / usted	tú
hablar	hable	hables
comer	coma	comas
vivir	viva	vivas
querer	quiera	quieras
poder	pueda	puedas
hacer	haga	hagas

The repeated outer form is not a missing row: first- and third-person singular match. Every plural form waits.

Grammar Lens: two safe triggers

- Same doer: **Quiero hablar español.**
- Different doer: **Quiero que hables español.**

- Wish by itself: **Ojalá hables español.**

Do not extend these two frames to every emotion, doubt, command, or conjunction yet. More triggers belong in later micro-lessons.

Your turn

Decide the meaning first; then retrieve only the learned form.

Before you move on

What is the first meaning choice? (**Asserted event or wanted event.**) Give the three regular tú forms. (**Hables, comas, vivas.**) Give the three bounded special tú forms. (**Quieras, puedas, hagas.**) Name the two safe triggers. (**Quiero que** for a different doer; **ojalá** for a wish.) What still waits? (Plural persons, additional irregular verbs, and additional subjunctive triggers.)

129.3 Review — you never learned a new stem

"I want you to want." (*Quiero que quieras.*)

What you've built

Four verbs came at you one after another, and each looked like a fresh thing to memorise. Put them in a column and the memorising disappears.

you already said	so you say
vivo	*viva*
quiero	*quiera*
puedo	*pueda*
hago	*haga*

One move, four times: **take the *yo* form, drop the *-o*, put *-a* on instead.**

Why it's said this way

Look at what rode across with the stem.
Quiero carries *ie*, and *quiera* keeps it. *Puedo* carries *ue*, and *pueda*

keeps it. *Hago* carries a *g* that *hacer* has nowhere else, and *haga* keeps that too.
None of those was a new irregular form. Each was an old one, already paid for, travelling into a new place on the back of the *yo* you had been saying for weeks. That is why the four lessons felt repetitive: they were.
The *-a* is worth one more look. *Vivir* ends in *-ir* and *querer*, *poder* and *hacer* end in *-er*, and all four still land on *-a*, *-as*, *-a*. The two families that stay apart in the present tense stop being two families here.

Your turn

- *Say it: vivo, viva · quiero, quiera · puedo, pueda · hago, haga*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which form do you start from? (**The *yo* form of the present**.) Where did the *ie* in *quiera* come from? (***Quiero*** — it was already there.) How many new stems did these four lessons ask you to learn? (**None**.)

Chapter 130

Synthesis — Claiming, and Not Claiming

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can choose the mood by deciding whether I am willing to assert the thing at all.
>
> *Indicative: this is so. Subjunctive: I am not saying this is so.*

130.1 Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming

Nothing new in this chapter. Say *hablas*, then *hables*.

Grammar Lens: what the second one is actually doing

Those two forms are not two tenses. They are two **stances**.

> **Hablas español.** — I am telling you this is so. **Quiero que hables español.** — I am not telling you anything is so.

In the first, you put a fact on the table and stood behind it. In the second, nothing has been claimed at all: the speaking has not happened, and might not. The mood is the difference, and the difference is about **what you are willing to assert**.
That is the whole of it, and it is worth holding onto, because every remaining use of this mood — and there are many — is a version of the same move. Wishing, doubting, denying, hoping: none of them puts a fact on the table.

Indicative: *this is so.* Subjunctive: *I am not saying this is so.*

The exchange

— ¿**Hablas** español? — Ana quiere que **hable** español. — **Ojalá hables** mucho.

Three lines, three stances. The first asks about a fact. The second reports somebody's wish, so nothing is asserted. The third wishes it outright.

What you've built

Ojalá deserves a last look, because it explains itself.
It is Arabic — *wa-šā' allāh*, "and may God will it" — carried into Spanish over eight centuries of al-Andalus and kept long after the religion behind it stopped being the speaker's. A Spanish speaker saying *ojalá* today is uttering a prayer in a language they do not speak, to a God the sentence no longer names.
And it can only ever take this mood. Of course it can: a thing God has yet to will is, by definition, not a fact you can assert.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the three-line exchange, and name the stance of each line

Twice through: Until choosing the mood feels like choosing what you mean.

Before you move on

What does the indicative do that the subjunctive does not? (**Claim that something is so.**) Why can *ojalá* never take the indicative? (Because a thing not yet willed is not a fact.) And what language is *ojalá*? (**Arabic** — a prayer that outlived the religion behind it.)

Chapter 131

Habla — Telling Somebody To Do Something

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give an informal positive command using a form I already hold.
>
> *Complete ES-C50-habla: give a tu command and name the form it reuses.*

131.1 habla — telling somebody to do something

Say "he speaks." (*Habla.*) Hold that word. You are about to be told it does a second job you have never been shown.

Grammar Lens: you already have it

To tell somebody you address as *tú* to do something, use the **he/she** form of the present.

Habla. — Speak. *Come.* — Eat. *Vive.* — Live.

That is the whole rule, and it costs you nothing. *Habla* was already in your mouth as "he speaks"; the same two syllables, said to somebody, are an order.

verb	he/she does	you, do it
hablar	habla	**habla**
comer	come	**come**
vivir	vive	**vive**

The column repeats. That is not an oversight in the table. Spanish does this often enough that it is worth naming as a habit: rather than inventing a new form for every job, it **reuses one and lets context sort it out.** *Habla* said about somebody is a statement; *habla* said to somebody is a command, and nobody has ever confused the two.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The name for this form is the **imperative**, from Latin **imperāre**, "to command."
That *imper-* is a word you already know in English clothes. An **emperor** is literally *one who commands*; an **empire** is the thing he commands. The grammar term and the political ones are the same root, which is a fair description of what the form does: it is the sentence shape that expects to be obeyed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "habla" as a statement, then "¡Habla!" as an order — same word, different job
- "come", "vive"

Before you move on

Tell somebody to speak. (***Habla.***) Which form is that? (The **he/she** present — nothing new.) What does *imperāre* mean? (**To command** — as in *emperor*.) Next: eight verbs that refused, and every one of them is a single syllable.

Chapter 132

Di, Haz, Ve, Pon, Ten, Sal, Se, Ven

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the eight irregular informal commands and say why they are all one syllable.
>
> *Complete ES-C50-ocho-cortos: give the eight forms and say why they are so short.*

132.1 di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven

By last chapter's rule, "say it" should be *dice*. It is not. There are exactly eight of these, and once you see them together you will not need to memorise the list.

Grammar Lens: eight, all one syllable

verb	command	
decir	**di**	say
hacer	**haz**	do, make
ir	**ve**	go
poner	**pon**	put
tener	**ten**	have, hold
salir	**sal**	leave
ser	**sé**	be
venir	**ven**	come

Read the middle column down. **Every single one is one syllable**, and most are two or three letters. No other set of forms in Spanish is

this short.
That is the fact worth carrying, and it has a cause. A command is the sentence you shout, the sentence you say in a hurry, the sentence you interrupt somebody with. Words used that way get worn down harder than words used calmly — and these eight are the commonest verbs in the language, so they had the most use to be worn by.
So the list is not eight arbitrary exceptions. It is **what the eight most-shouted verbs look like after two thousand years of being shouted.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all eight in one breath — "di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven"
- each one as if calling across a room

Twice through: Until the list is a rhythm rather than eight facts.

Before you move on

How many irregular *tú* commands are there? (**Eight**.) What do they all have in common besides being irregular? (**One syllable each**.) Next: how to tell somebody **not** to do something — and you already have that form too.

Chapter 133

No Hables — Telling Somebody Not To

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give a negative informal command, and say why it takes the subjunctive.
>
> *Complete ES-C50-no-hables: produce no hables and say why the subjunctive is the right form.*

133.1 no hables — telling somebody not to

"Speak" is *habla*. So "don't speak" should be *no habla*. Say it, and then be told it is wrong.

Grammar Lens: the form you already learned for wanting

A **negative** command uses the **subjunctive**.

no ***hables*** — don't speak. *no* ***comas*** — don't eat.

Those are not new forms. You built them chapters ago, when you learned to say *quiero que hables* — "I want you to speak."
And the connection is not an accident of grammar. Think about what the subjunctive was **for**: the form for something **not asserted** — wanted, feared, hoped for, but not claimed to be happening.
A negative command is exactly that. *No hables* does not describe any speaking. There is no speaking; the whole point of the sentence is that you want there to be none. Spanish reaches for the non-asserting form

because nothing is being asserted.
So this is not "the negative command borrows the subjunctive." It is the subjunctive doing the thing it has always done.

Why it's said this way

There is a lopsidedness here worth naming, because it looks like untidiness and is not.

> **habla** — an ordinary present form. **no hables** — a subjunctive form.

Two different shapes for one verb, depending only on whether there is a *no* in front. Most languages would use one form for both.
The reason Spanish does not is that the two sentences are doing genuinely different things. *Habla* points at an action and hands it to you. *No hables* points at an action **and refuses it** — and the refusal, not the action, is the sentence's content. The form follows the content, as it did in every subjunctive sentence you have already met.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "habla" then "no hables" — hear the form change with the no
- "quiero que hables" then "no hables" — the same form, twice

Before you move on

"Don't speak"? (***No hables***.) Which form is that? (The **subjunctive** — the one for what is not asserted.) Next: the same form again, this time for politeness rather than negation.

Chapter 134

Hable Usted — The Polite Command

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can give a formal command and say why the usted form is the polite one.

Complete ES-C50-hable-usted: produce hable por favor and explain why the usted command is polite.

134.1 hable usted — the polite command

Usted takes the **he/she** form of every verb. You have known that since you learned it. Watch what that does to a command.

Grammar Lens: the subjunctive, a third time

A command to *usted* — positive or negative — uses the **subjunctive**.

Hable**, por favor.* — Speak, please. ***Coma**, por favor.* — Eat, please. ***No hable. — Don't speak.

So the subjunctive now covers three of the four boxes:

	tú	***usted***
do it	*habla* — ordinary present	***hable*** — subjunctive
don't	*no hables* — subjunctive	*no hable* — subjunctive

One box out of four uses an ordinary form, and it is the informal, positive one. Everything else reaches for the subjunctive.

Why it's said this way

Here is why the formal command is the polite one, and it is not because the subjunctive is a fancy form.

Remember what *usted* is: a worn-down **vuestra merced**, "your grace" — a **title**, and titles are third person. That is why *usted* takes he/she endings. So a command to *usted* is not grammatically aimed at the person in front of you at all. It is aimed at *your grace*, spoken about rather than to.

That indirectness **is** the politeness. Every polite language does some version of it: you soften an order by not pointing it straight at somebody. English does it with extra words — *could you possibly*, *would you mind* — where Spanish does it with a verb form and a fossil of a title.

Which means that if the *usted* command ever feels stiff to you, you are hearing it correctly. It is supposed to hold somebody at a small distance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Habla" then "Hable, por favor" — hear the distance open up
- all four boxes: "habla, no hables, hable, no hable"

Before you move on

"Speak, please," to *usted*? (***Hable, por favor.***) Which form? (The **subjunctive** again.) Why is it polite? (Because *usted* is a **title** — the order is aimed past the person, not at them.) Next: all four in one place.

Chapter 135

Review — Four Boxes

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give all four command forms of a regular verb.
>
> *Complete ES-C50-repaso-mandatos: give all four boxes for comer and say what the rung genuinely cost.*

135.1 Review — four boxes

Nothing new. Before the grid: which single box does **not** use the subjunctive?

What you've built

	tú	***usted***
do it	*habla · come*	*hable · coma*
don't	*no hables · no comas*	*no hable · no coma*

Three of the four boxes are the **subjunctive**, which you built chapters ago for wanting and hoping. The fourth is the ordinary **he/she present**, which you built long before that.

Now count what this rung actually cost you. A whole grammatical mood — the one every phrasebook opens with — and the only genuinely new material in it was **eight one-syllable words**: *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven.*

Everything else was a form you already owned, doing one more job.

Grammar Lens: why the odd box is the odd one

It is worth asking why the informal positive command is the exception. Because it is the one that is said most. *Come*, *ven*, *habla*, *ten* — said to children, friends, dogs, and across kitchens, thousands of times a day for two thousand years. That is the box under the most pressure, and heavy use keeps old short forms alive rather than letting them be replaced by tidier ones.

The same pressure explains the eight irregulars, which live in exactly that box and nowhere else. There are no irregular *negative* commands to learn, because negatives are said less and had time to be regularised. **The messiest corner of this grid is the most-used corner.** That has been true of every irregularity in this book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four boxes for *hablar*, then for *comer*
- the eight irregulars once more

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many of the four boxes use the subjunctive? (**Three**.) What did this rung genuinely cost? (**Eight one-syllable words**.) Next: what a command sounds like to the person receiving it.

Chapter 136

Synthesis — Asking Without Sounding Rude

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can pick the command form that matches my relationship to the listener.
>
> *Complete ES-C50-sintesis-pedir-bien: command a friend and a stranger, and say where a Spanish command's politeness lives.*

136.1 Synthesis — asking without sounding rude

> Say "eat" to a friend. (*Come.*) In English, saying "Eat." to somebody lands hard. You are about to learn that it does not land the same way here.

Why it's said this way

English has almost no polite imperative. *Eat. Sit.* Bare, they sound like orders to a dog, so English speakers pad them: *could you*, *would you mind*.
Spanish needs no padding, because it spends its politeness elsewhere — **on the choice of person**.

> *Come.* — to a friend. Perfectly warm. *Coma, por favor.* — to a stranger. Perfectly polite.

The *tú* command is not blunt; it is **intimate**. Using it says *we are on those terms*, which between friends is friendly rather than bossy. The

usted command is not cold; it is **respectful**, for the same reason. So an English speaker's mistake here is not tone. It is picking the wrong person: *usted* with a friend sounds stiff, *tú* with a stranger presumptuous. **The politeness lives in the pronoun you chose before the command left your mouth.** *Por favor* helps and costs nothing, but here it is a garnish rather than the structure.

The exchange

The same four things said twice — once to a friend, once to a stranger.

> **To a friend:** *Ven. Come. No hables. Ten.* **To a stranger:** *Venga. Coma, por favor. No hable. Tenga.*

Read both aloud. The first is not ruder; it is closer. Say the second to somebody you have known for years and you have not been polite — you have put a small distance between you, and they will hear it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Ven" then "Venga" — hear the distance, not the rudeness
- the friend row, then the stranger row, straight through

Twice through:

Before you move on

Is *Come* rude to a friend? (**No** — it is **close**.) Where does the politeness of a Spanish command live? (In the **person you chose**.) And what does *usted* with an old friend sound like? (**Distance**, not courtesy.)

Chapter 137

Lo Siento

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can apologise in Spanish and choose between lo siento and perdón.
>
> *Say lo siento for regret and perdón for fault or for catching someone's attention, hearing sentir — I feel it — inside the first and dōnāre — to give completely — inside the second.*

137.1 lo siento — "I'm sorry," i.e. "I feel it"

You already know **por favor**, "please." The next courtesy phrase is **lo siento**. Spanish does not say "I *am* sorry" as an adjective; it says something closer to **"I feel this."**

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **lo** = "it" — a **neuter** pronoun. It does not point at any noun; it points at the **situation itself**. Spanish keeps this one leftover neuter slot precisely for "the whole business, unnamed."
- **siento** = "I feel," from **sentir**, "to feel," from Latin **sentīre**. That root gave English a whole family: **sentiment**, **sense**, **consent** ("feel together"), **resent** ("feel back at"), and **sentence** (originally an *opinion*, something felt).

So **lo siento** is literally *"I feel it."* You are naming a feeling — regret, sympathy — rather than declaring a state about yourself. That is why it stretches so easily: *lo siento mucho*, "I feel it a lot," works both for

stepping on someone's foot and for hearing that their father died.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "siento" — I feel — then "lo siento," I feel it / I'm sorry
- "lo siento mucho" — I'm so sorry
- "siento" then English "sentiment, sense, consent"

Before you move on

What does **lo siento** literally mean? (**"I feel it"** — *siento*, "I feel," from Latin *sentīre*.) What is the *lo* pointing at? (The **situation**, not a noun — it is the neuter "it.") Next: Spanish's *other* word for sorry, and when it is the right one.

137.2 perdón — the sorry that asks for something back

Lo siento names a feeling. Spanish keeps a **second** word for a different job — one that is not about your feelings at all, but about something you want from the other person.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perdón ("pardon"), from the verb **perdonar** — Latin **per-** ("thoroughly") + **dōnāre** ("to give"). Literally: **"to give completely."**
That *dōnāre* is English's **donate**, **donor**, and **condone**; the *per-* is the same intensifier in **perfect** ("thoroughly made") and **perturb**. So forgiveness, in Latin's picture of it, is a **gift given all the way** — you hand over the debt rather than keeping a share of it.

Why it's said this way

The two are not interchangeable, and the difference follows straight from the etymologies:

	lo siento	**perdón**
literally	"I feel it"	"give [it] completely"
points at	**your** feeling	**their** forgiveness
use for	regret, sympathy	fault, or getting past someone

So **perdón** is what you say to squeeze through a crowd or catch a waiter's eye (English "excuse me"), and to ask forgiveness for something **you did** — often stronger than *lo siento*. **Lo siento** leans toward "I'm sorry that happened," including things that are nobody's fault at all.

Be honest about the edges: native speakers use whichever fits, the boundary is soft, and mixing them is not a real mistake — just a shade off.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "perdón" — pardon / excuse me
- the pair — "lo siento" for regret, "perdón" for fault
- "perdón" then English "donate, condone" — the *dōnāre* root

Before you move on

What do the two halves of **perdonar** mean? (**Per-**, "thoroughly," plus **dōnāre**, "to give" — to give completely.) Which word do you use to get past someone in a corridor? (**Perdón**.) Which leans toward sympathy rather than fault? (**Lo siento** — "I feel it.")

Chapter 138

Days of the Week

Modes: **eyes** (2) **Hands-free start:** none of the 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name all seven days of the week in Spanish and say why the last two broke away from the planet names.
>
> *Run lunes to domingo straight through, then pair each weekend day against its English twin — sábado against Saturn's day, domingo against the Sun's.*

138.1 lunes to viernes — the planets of the week, worn down

The Romans mapped the seven-day week onto the seven visible "wandering stars" — the planet-gods. Spanish kept that map, but handled the word "day" differently from its Romance cousins: where French still spells out "**-di**" (day) on every weekday, Spanish mostly just **dropped it**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Each weekday began life as **"[planet-god]'s** diēs **(day)."** In Vulgar Latin, *diēs* was simply **dropped as a separate word** in most of these — what survived is just the planet's own Latin genitive form. That's why **martes, jueves, viernes** already end in **-s**: not because *diēs* wore down into one, but because **Martis, Iovis, Veneris** — the planets' own genitive forms — end in *-s* in Latin already. **Lunes** has no such *-s* to inherit (*lūnae* doesn't end in one), so it likely picked up

the ending by **analogy** with its four siblings:

Spanish	← **Latin**	**planet-god**	**English echo**
lunes	*lūnae diēs*	the **Moon** (*luna*)	*Mon*day = Moon-day
martes	*Martis diēs*	**Mars**	*Tues*day (Tiw, the Germanic war-god = Mars)
miércoles	*Mercuriī diēs*	**Mercury**	*Wednes*day (Woden = Mercury)
jueves	*Jovis diēs*	**Jupiter** (*Jove*)	*Thurs*day (**Thor** = Jupiter)
viernes	*Veneris diēs*	**Venus**	*Fri*day (Frigg/ Freya = Venus)

Compare **French**, which keeps *diēs* as its own visible syllable on every day — **lundi**, **mardi**, **jeudi** — while Spanish dropped it from four of its five weekdays. **miércoles** is the odd one out: some historians of the language think its extra "**-coles**" is a genuine surviving trace of *diēs* itself (fused in and reshaped) — though the exact sound changes are debated, unlike the plainer, better-understood story for its four siblings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes" — the work week
- each as "[planet]'s day, worn down" — "lunes = Moon, jueves = Jupiter"
- the bridge — "martes / Tuesday, both the war-god's day (Mars / Tiw)"

Before you move on

Recall the weekday family:

- What did every Spanish weekday begin life as? (**"[Planet-god]'s diēs (day)"** — the same Latin phrase French keeps more visibly with *-di.*)
- Why do **martes, jueves, viernes** end in *-s*, and where does **lunes** get its *-s* from? (**From the planet's own Latin genitive** — Martis/Iovis/ Veneris already end in *-s*; *lunes* likely picked it up **by analogy**, since *lūnae* has no *-s* of its own.)
- What's debated about **miércoles**? (**Whether its "-coles" is a genuine surviving trace of diēs** — unlike the plainer, better-understood story for its four siblings.)
- Why do *martes* and *Tuesday* line up? (They name the same day for the war-god: *Mars* in Latin, *Tiw* in Germanic.)

138.2 sábado and domingo — the week's religious edge

Five days named for planets — then two that broke the pattern entirely. The weekend is where **religion overwrote astronomy**, and Spanish keeps both rewrites in plain view.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	**← Latin**	**meaning**	**note**
sábado	*sabbatum*	"**Sabbath**"	the planet-god (Saturn) is gone — replaced by the Hebrew *shabbāt*, "to rest"
domingo	*diēs Dominica*	"the **Lord's** day"	*Dominica* ← *Dominus*, "lord/master" — Spanish kept this one much less worn-down than French's *dimanche*

Two different rewrites:

- **sábado** would have been "Saturn's day" (as English **Satur**day still is — the one weekday English kept a Roman god for). Instead, Latin Christians borrowed the Jewish **Sabbath** (*Sabbatum* ← Hebrew *shabbāt*), and it became *sábado*. So English **Saturday** and Spanish **sábado** are the **same day, two different names** — the planet vs. the Sabbath.
- **domingo** drops Sun-worship entirely: where English keeps **Sun**day, Spanish made it *diēs Dominica*, "the Lord's day" (*Dominus* → English **dominion**, **dominate**, **dame**). Spanish kept **domingo** recognizably close to *Dominica* — compare French's more worn-down **dimanche**, where the *di-* (day) fossil jumped to the front of the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full week — "lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes, sábado, domingo"

- "sábado = Sabbath, domingo = the Lord's day" — religion, not planets
- the pair-ups — "sábado / Saturday (Sabbath vs. Saturn)", "domingo / Sunday (Lord vs. Sun)"

Before you move on

Give all seven Spanish days. (*Lunes … domingo.*) Where does **sábado** come from, and its English contrast? (The **Sabbath**, *Sabbatum*; English kept *Saturday* = Saturn's day.) What does **domingo** mean literally? ("The **Lord's** day," *diēs Dominica.*)

Chapter 139

Black, White, Red, and Blue

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name black, white, red and blue in Spanish and say which of them Spanish borrowed rather than inherited.
>
> *Say negro, blanco, rojo and azul, then sort them by origin: negro inherited from Latin, blanco traditionally linked to the Germanic Visigoths, rojo a cousin of English red by a different Latin branch, and azul carried in from Arabic lāzaward.*

139.1 negro, blanco — two colours, and one of their histories

Two colours you can put to work immediately. One of them has the most ordinary history imaginable. The other does not — which is why it gets its own lesson next.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

negro ("black") ← Latin **niger**. Nothing surprising: the same Latin root gives English **denigrate** ("to blacken someone's name") and the rest of the Romance family's words for black — French *noir*, Italian *nero*, Portuguese *negro*. Latin's word for black stayed put, in every daughter language.
Hold that in mind as the baseline. It is what a colour word normally does.

The two words in use

blanco ("white") is the pair to it: *el gato negro*, *el gato blanco*. Both behave like any Spanish adjective — they follow the noun and agree with it (*la casa blanca*).

But hear what you would have expected and did not get. Latin's word for white was **albus**, and by the *negro* pattern Spanish "white" should be something like *albo*. It is not. Where **blanco** actually came from — and what became of *albus* — is the next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "negro, blanco"
- with a noun — "el gato negro, la casa blanca"
- "negro" then English "denigrate" — the *niger* root

Before you move on

Say black and white. (*Negro, blanco.*) Where does *negro* come from, and what English word shares it? (Latin **niger** — *denigrate.*) What would you have expected Spanish's "white" to be, given Latin *albus*? (Something like *albo* — and it isn't. That is next lesson's puzzle.)

139.2 blanco — the colour Spanish did not inherit

Negro came straight down from Latin, like almost every other everyday word you have met. **Blanco** did not come down at all. It walked in.

What to know first

- negro, blanco — the two colour words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blanco comes from **Germanic *blank** — "**shining, gleaming**." It is a **loan**, traditionally attributed to contact with the **Visigoths**, the Germanic people who ruled Spain for centuries after Rome collapsed. Be careful how firmly you hold that last part: no surviving Gothic text actually preserves this word, so the Visigothic route is a **plausible traditional account**, not a documented one. What *is* well attested is the parallel case next door — **French** took the very same Germanic word (*blanc*) from a **different** Germanic people, the **Franks**. Two Romance sisters, the same borrowed word for white, two separate borrowings.

Why would a borrowed word beat Latin's own? Because **blank* was not a pale word: it meant **bright, gleaming**. Colour terms lose out to vivid ones all the time — English's own *bright* is doing the same job in "bright white."

Why it's said this way

Latin's white did not vanish. It stopped being the **everyday** word and survived in corners:

word	**meaning**	**the white inside**
alba	dawn	the sky going *white*
albo (rare, poetic)	white, pale	a fossil, mostly literary now
álbum (Eng. *album*)	album	a *blank white* tablet
albino	albino	white-skinned

That is the normal fate of a displaced word: not death, but retreat into technical and poetic corners. *El alba* is still every Spanish speaker's word for dawn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pairing — "negro from Latin, blanco from Germanic"
- "el alba" — dawn — and hear the old Latin white inside it
- "blanco" then French "blanc" — the same loan, twice over

Before you move on

Where does **blanco** come from, and what did it mean? (**Germanic *blank**, "shining" — traditionally linked to the Visigoths, though not directly attested.) Which other language borrowed the same word, from whom? (**French** *blanc*, from the **Franks**.) Where did Latin's *albus* end up? (In **alba** "dawn," *álbum*, *albino* — no longer the everyday colour word.)

139.3 rojo — the same family as *red*, by a different branch

So far the sorting has been simple: *negro* inherited, *blanco* borrowed. **Rojo** needs a third box — inherited, yes, but not from the word you would guess.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rojo ("red") ← Latin **russus**, an everyday, expressive Latin word for red. That is a **different specific Latin word** from the one behind French *rouge* (← **rubeus**). Latin had several reds and the daughter languages did not all pick the same one.
Both *russus* and *rubeus*, though, descend from the very same ancient root: PIE ***h₁rewdʰ-*** — which is also the root of English **red**, **rust**, **ruddy**, and of Latin *ruber* itself (English **rubric**, once written in red ink).
So *rojo*, *rouge* and *red* are **cousins**, not copies: three descendants of one very old family, arriving by three different branches. Nobody borrowed this one from anybody.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "rojo"
- the cousins — "rojo · rouge · red", three branches, one root
- the three so far — "negro inherited, blanco borrowed, rojo cousin"

Before you move on

Is **rojo** from the same Latin word as French *rouge*? (**No** — *rojo* ← *russus*, *rouge* ← *rubeus*.) Are they related at all? (**Yes** — cousins, via the shared PIE root *h₁rewdʰ-*, which also gives English **red**.) Next: the one colour in this chapter that came from outside Europe entirely.

139.4 azul — a stone from Afghanistan, in your everyday vocabulary

Three colours in, three different histories: inherited, borrowed from a neighbour, inherited by a different branch. The fourth comes from outside the Indo-European family altogether.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

azul ("blue") ← Arabic لازورد (*lāzaward*), "**lapis lazuli**" — the deep blue stone, mined for centuries in what is now Afghanistan and ground into the most expensive pigment in the medieval world. Spanish picked the word up during the centuries of Arabic-speaking rule in Iberia (**al-Andalus**). English has the same source at one more remove, in **azure**, and the stone keeps its own name: **lazuli**.
So Spanish's word for blue is, underneath, the name of a **rock** — which is common for blue. Blue is the last basic colour term most languages acquire, and when they do, they usually name it after the thing that was reliably that colour.

Why it's said this way

Here is the contrast worth keeping. **French** has *azur* too — but only as a **secondary, poetic** word (the sky's blue, the *Côte d'Azur*); its everyday blue is the Germanic loan *bleu*. In **Spanish** it is the reverse: **azul is the plain, unremarkable, everyday word**, with no Germanic rival competing for the job at all.
Same borrowed word, two languages, opposite outcomes — a reminder that where a word came from tells you nothing about how ordinary it now feels.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all four — “negro, blanco, rojo, azul”
- sort them — “negro inherited, blanco Germanic, rojo cousin of red, azul Arabic”
- “azul” then English “azure” — the same lapis lazuli

Before you move on

Name the four colours and sort them by origin. (*Negro* — Latin *niger*; *blanco* — Germanic **blank*; *rojo* — Latin *russus*, cousin of *red*; *azul* — Arabic *lāzaward*.) What did *lāzaward* actually name? (**Lapis lazuli**, the stone.) How does *azul*’s role differ from French *azur*’s? (**Azul is Spanish’s everyday blue**; French’s *azur* is only poetic, with *bleu* doing the daily work.)

Chapter 140

Parents and Siblings

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name my parents and my siblings in Spanish and explain why hermano is not built on Latin's word for brother.
>
> *Give el padre, la madre, el hermano and la hermana, trace hermano back through germānus to germen, the seed, rather than to frāter, and separate its silent h from the once-spoken h of hijo and hacer.*

140.1 el padre, la madre — among the oldest words there are

"Father" and "mother" are some of the **oldest reconstructible words in human language** — older than Latin, older than Rome. Spanish kept them close to the Latin original, and they are secretly the *same words* as English **father** and **mother**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **el padre** ("father") ← Latin **pater** ← PIE ***ph₂tḗr***.
- **la madre** ("mother") ← Latin **māter** ← PIE ***méh₂tēr***.

Why it's said this way

Padre and English *father* both descend independently from the **same** PIE word — they're siblings, not parent and child. Latin (and Spanish

after it) kept the original *p* and *t* largely intact; the Germanic branch that gave English took a separate road through **Grimm's Law**, which shifted the **inherited p → f** and **t → th**:

PIE ancestor	**Latin → Spanish**	**Germanic → English**
ph₂tḗr	*pater* → **padre**	**f**a**th**er
méh₂tēr	*māter* → **madre**	**m**o**th**er

So *padre* and *father* aren't lookalikes borrowed late, and neither one comes *from* the other — they're the **same inherited PIE word**, one branch keeping the *p*, the other shifting it to *f*. The Latin root also gives Spanish and English their "of a parent" adjectives: **paternal, paternidad, patrón** and **maternal, maternidad**. (A further Latin-only offshoot, *māter* → *māteria*, "the stuff a tree-mother produces," gives Spanish *materia* and, separately, *matriz* — "womb" — via Latin *mātrix*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el padre, la madre"
- the sound-law — "padre keeps p; father shifts to f — same word"
- "padre → paternal; madre → maternal"

Before you move on

Give "father" and "mother" with their articles. (**el padre, la madre**.) Does *padre* turn into English *father* directly? (**No** — both descend independently from the same PIE word; the Germanic branch shifted p → f and t → th via **Grimm's Law**, while Latin/Spanish kept the original sounds.) Name an English cousin of each. (*padre* → paternal; *madre* → maternal.)

140.2 el hermano, la hermana — brother and sister, from a different word entirely

You might expect Spanish "brother" to come from Latin **frāter**, the way French's *frère* does. It does not. Spanish's siblings took a completely different word — one about **seeds**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Classical Latin could say **frāter germānus**, literally "a brother **of the same stock/blood**" — distinguishing a *full* brother from a half-brother, or from a "brother" in some looser sense.
Then something ordinary and strange happened: in everyday Latin the **adjective** took over the whole job and the **noun quietly dropped out**. (English does this all the time — a *mobile phone* becomes a *mobile*, a *cellular telephone* becomes a *cell*.) What survived is the modifier:

- **el hermano** ("brother") ← Latin **germānus**.
- **la hermana** ("sister") ← Latin **germāna**.

So Spanish's everyday word for brother is, grammatically, a leftover adjective.

Why it's said this way

Germānus traces back to **germen**, "**sprout, bud, seed**" — the same root that gives English **germ**, **germinate**, and **germane** (originally "closely related," from the same seed, before it loosened into just "relevant").
So calling someone your *hermano* is, at the etymological root, calling them "**sprung from the same seed**." (And no, this has nothing to do with *Germany* — that name is a separate, unrelated puzzle.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el hermano, la hermana" — brother, sister

- the root chain — "germen, seed" → "germānus, of the same seed" → "hermano"
- "hermano" then English "germinate, germane"

Before you move on

Does Spanish *hermano* come from Latin *frāter*? (**No** — from **germānus**, "of the same stock/seed," an adjective that swallowed the noun *frāter* it used to modify.) What does its root *germen* mean, and what English words share it? (**Seed, sprout** — *germ*, *germinate*, *germane*.) Next: the silent *h* on the front, which is not the *h* you think it is.

140.3 the *h* in hermano — a letter that was never spoken

Germānus starts with a **g**. *Hermano* starts with an **h**. Something has to explain that — and the obvious explanation is the wrong one.

What to know first

- el hermano, la hermana — the words and the *germen* root.

Why it's said this way

You may already know that Spanish often turns a Latin initial **f** into a silent **h** — *filius* → **hijo** ("son"), *facere* → **hacer** ("to do"). **Hermano is not that**, and the difference is worth getting right.

Germānus is stressed on its **third** syllable (*ger-MĀ-nus*), which leaves the opening *ger-* **unstressed**. Latin's **g** before a front vowel had already softened toward a *y*-like sound in everyday speech — and in that unstressed position it simply **fell away entirely**, giving Old Spanish ***ermano***, with **no *h* at all**. That is the form actually recorded centuries ago.

The **h** you see today was added **later, in spelling only**, to mark the word's old link to Latin *g-*. Compare:

word	**what happened to the sound**	**was the *h* ever spoken?**
hijo, **hacer**	Latin *f-* → a real breathy *h*	**yes**, for centuries
hermano	Latin *g-* simply **dropped**	**no**, never

Same silent letter today; two completely different backstories, only one of which involves a sound at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "germānus" then "ermano" then "hermano" — the three stages
- the honest distinction — hijo/hacer's *h* was once truly spoken; hermano's *h* never was

Before you move on

Is *hermano*'s *h* the same kind of change as *hijo*'s or *hacer*'s? (**No.**) What actually happened to *germānus*'s opening? (Its **g** dropped away in an **unstressed** syllable, giving Old Spanish *ermano*.) So where did the *h* come from? (**Spelling** — added later to mark the Latin link, never pronounced.)

Chapter 141

Head and Hand

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the head and the hand in Spanish and get la mano's gender right despite its -o ending.
>
> *Say la cabeza and la mano, use me duele la mano, and explain the feminine article on a word that ends in -o by way of Latin's fourth declension.*

141.1 la cabeza — "the head"

Spanish's word for "head" is the boring, expected one — and that's exactly what makes it interesting, once you see what French did instead.

You'll want to know: la cabeza

la cabeza — the head. Feminine, so **la**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin's word for "head" was **caput**. Spanish's *cabeza* comes straight from it (by way of Vulgar Latin *capitia*), and *caput* shows up all over English too:

English	literally
captain	the "head" of a ship/unit
capital	the "head" city, or "head" sum of money
de**cap**itate	to remove the head
capitulate	to arrange under "headings" — hence, to yield

Why it's said this way

French had the exact same Latin word available — and **dropped it**. French *tête* ("head") comes instead from **testa**, Latin for an **earthenware pot**: Roman soldiers joked about the skull the way English speakers say "noggin" (a small mug), and in Gaul that joke eventually **replaced** the real word entirely. Spanish never made that swap — *cabeza* is *caput*, plain and simple, still standing after two thousand years.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la cabeza" — the head
- "me duele la cabeza" — "my head hurts"
- the English family — "captain, capital, decapitate"
- the contrast — Spanish kept caput; French swapped it for a pot joke

Before you move on

Say "the head." (*La cabeza* — feminine.) What Latin word is it from? (**Caput**.) Give an English word from the same root. (**Captain, capital, decapitate**...) What did French do instead? (**Replaced caput with *testa*, "pot"** — soldiers' slang for the skull that took over completely.)

141.2 la mano — "the hand"

You've been trusting "-o words are masculine, -a words are feminine" since your first chapters. Here's the word that breaks it — and everyone learning Spanish has to memorize this one by name.

Grammar Lens: la mano and its gender

la mano — the hand. **Feminine**, despite ending in **-o**.

Almost every Spanish noun ending in *-o* is masculine (*el libro, el gato...*). *Mano* is the single most common exception, and it's actually **doubly** irregular. Latin **manus** ("hand") belonged to the **4th declension** — a group of *-us* nouns that were mostly **masculine** (*frūctus* "fruit," *exercitus* "army," *senātus* "senate"). *Manus* was one of a small handful of exceptions that were **feminine** instead (alongside *domus* "house" and *anus* "old woman"). So *mano* broke the rule **twice over**: an exception within Latin's own mostly-masculine 4th declension, and then an exception again against Spanish's usual *-o* = masculine pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Mano comes from Latin **manus**, "hand" — and that root is buried inside an enormous number of English words:

English	literally
manual	done by hand
manufacture	made by hand (*manus* + *facere*, "to make")
manuscript	written by hand (*manus* + *scrībere*)
maintain	hold in the hand (*manū tenēre*)
manage	to handle

Manufacture is worth pausing on: it literally means "made by hand" — and today it names precisely the opposite.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la mano" — feminine, despite the -o
- "me duele la mano" — "my hand hurts"
- the family — "manual, manufacture, maintain — all a hand"
- the irony — "manufacture = made by hand"

Before you move on

Say "the hand," and name its gender. (*La mano* — **feminine**, despite ending in *-o*.) Why is *mano* feminine when most *-o* words aren't? (**It's doubly irregular** — Latin's 4th declension, where *manus* belongs, was mostly **masculine**; *manus* was one of a few feminine exceptions there, and then an exception again against Spanish's usual -o=masculine rule.) Give an English word built on *manus*. (**Manual, manufacture, manuscript, maintain, manage**.)

Chapter 142

The Seasons

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four seasons in Spanish and explain how verano moved from spring to summer.

Run primavera, verano, otoño, invierno, unpack primavera as prīma vēra, and show verano growing out of that same vēr before its meaning slid across to summer.

142.1 la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno — three plain, one surprising

Three of Spanish's four seasons are exactly what you'd expect from Latin. The fourth hides a genuine surprise: its **meaning itself** drifted from one season to another.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **la primavera** ("spring") ← Latin ***prīma vēra***, literally "**first spring**" (*vēr*, "spring," + *prīma*, "first"). Italian still says the identical phrase, *primavera*, unchanged. (Old French once said *primevère* too, before switching to *printemps*.)
- **el otoño** ("autumn") ← Latin ***autumnus*** — the same root behind French *automne* and English *autumn* itself.
- **el invierno** ("winter") ← Latin ***hībernum*** (*tempus*), "the **wintry** [season]" — the same root as French *hiver* and English **hibernate**, "to spend the winter."

Why it's said this way

You might expect *verano* ("summer") to come from Latin **aestas**, "heat" — the way French *été* does. It doesn't. The standard account (per Spanish etymological dictionaries) traces **verano** to Latin ***vērānum*** (*tempus*), "**of spring**" — built on the very same *vēr*, "spring," behind *primavera*.
So how did a word meaning "spring-ish" end up naming **summer**? The honest answer is a **shift in meaning over time**, not a sound change — though the exact story is murkier than a tidy one-line explanation. The traditional, simplified account says that as *primavera* ("first spring") rose to become the standard word for spring, *verano*'s meaning drifted forward into the season right after, summer; the fuller picture likely also involves Vulgar Latin agricultural usage (a "vernal" grazing or working period that stretched from late spring into early summer), so the drift may not be purely a case of one word simply vacating a job for the other. Either way, two Spanish words both rooted in *vēr*, "spring," ended up naming two different seasons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "primavera, verano, otoño, invierno" — the four seasons
- "primavera = prima vera, first spring"
- the surprise — "verano ALSO comes from vēr, 'spring' — but its meaning moved to summer"
- "invierno ~ hibernate"

Before you move on

What does **primavera** literally mean? (**"First spring"** — *prīma vēra*.) Does **verano** come from Latin *aestas*, like French *été*? (**No** — from *vērānum*, "of spring," the same *vēr* root as *primavera*; its meaning **shifted** toward summer over time — traditionally linked to *primavera* taking over the job of naming spring, though the fuller history is murkier than that alone.) What English word is **invierno** the cousin of? (**Hibernate**.)

Chapter 143

Water, Wine, and Bread

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name water, wine and bread in Spanish and say why a compañero is someone who shares bread with me.
>
> *Say el agua, el vino and el pan, then open compañero into com- plus pānis and follow the root out to panadería and panadero.*

143.1 el agua — water, and an article that is not what it looks like

One of the least changed words in Spanish, carrying one of its most misunderstood rules. The "masculine" article on this feminine noun is not a mistake and not an exception to gender.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

agua ("water") ← Latin **aqua** — almost unchanged in two thousand years. Compare French, where the *very same word* was worn all the way down to a bare **"eau,"** just the sound "oh." Same starting point, same span of time, wildly different amounts of erosion: how fast a language wears its words down is not fixed.
English kept the whole Latin word too, but as a **learned borrowing** rather than an inherited everyday one: **aquatic, aquarium, aqueduct, aqualung**.

Grammar Lens: el agua's article and gender

Notice: **el agua**, not *la agua* — yet *agua* is genuinely **feminine**. You can prove it: *el agua **fría**, "the cold water," keeps the feminine adjective ending, and the plural is* las aguas*, never* los aguas*.*
The rule is **phonological**, not grammatical. Spanish swaps *la* for *el* directly before a **singular** feminine noun beginning with a **stressed *a*-sound**, to avoid running two identical vowels together (*la agua*). It is the same instinct that makes English pick "an apple" over "a apple."

	singular	**plural**
the water	**el** agua	**las** aguas
the eagle	**el** águila	**las** águilas
the axe	**el** hacha	**las** hachas

Only the article changes. The noun's gender never moves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el agua" — water, feminine, but takes *el*
- the proof — "el agua fría" and "las aguas"
- the contrast — "agua" barely changed; French's "eau" wore all the way down

Before you move on

Is **agua** masculine or feminine? (**Feminine** — *el* replaces *la* only because *agua* begins with a **stressed a**.) How would you prove it? (*El agua **fría***; *las aguas*.) How does Spanish's erosion of *aqua* compare with French's? (**Much less** — Spanish kept nearly the whole word; French wore it to "eau.")

143.2 el vino — one word, three separate arrivals in English

The second drink is grammatically boring — plain masculine, plain *el vino*, no stressed-*a* trick. Its history makes up for that.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vino ("wine") ← Latin **vīnum** — which held its shape well, as French's *vin* did too.
English shares the very same root by **more than one road**, and the roads are worth separating, because they show three different ways a word can travel:

English word	how it got there
wine	*vīnum* borrowed **directly** into old Germanic, very early
vine, **vinegar**	borrowed centuries later, **secondhand via French** (*vin + aigre*, "sour wine")
vineyard	**not borrowed at all** — English built it at home from the already-borrowed *wine* plus native *yard*

So *wine* and *vine* are the same Latin word twice, arriving a thousand years apart by different routes, and *vineyard* is a homemade compound made out of the first arrival. One Latin noun; three English histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el agua, el vino" — the two drinks
- "vino" then English "wine, vine, vinegar" — one root, three roads

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *vino*? (**Vīnum**.) Name three English cousins and say how each arrived. (**Wine** — direct, early, into Germanic; **vine/vinegar** — later, via French; **vineyard** — built at home from *wine* plus *yard*.) And why is it *el agua* but *las aguas*? (The *el* is a sound rule for a stressed *a*, singular only.)

143.3 el pan — bread, and the friend who shares it

Spanish's word for bread hides the same lovely word-story you'd find in English's "companion" — except Spanish kept **both halves**, the bread and the friendship.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pan ("bread") ← Latin **pānis**. Masculine: *el pan*.

Why it's said this way

The Latin root **pān-** ("bread") gives Spanish its own word for a close friend:

- **compañero / compañera** ("companion, friend, partner") ← *com-* ("with") + *pānis* — literally "**one you share bread with**." Spanish built this word from the very same recipe as English **companion** and **company** (which come from the identical Latin pieces) — but where English only kept the *friendship* sense, Spanish still visibly uses the **same root** for the actual **bread** (*pan*) too.
- **panadería** ("bakery") and **panadero** ("baker") — both transparently built on *pan*.

So *pan* and *compañero* are the same word-family doing double duty in Spanish: name the food, and name the friend you'd share it with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el pan" — bread
- "compañero" — literally, one you share bread with
- "panadería, panadero" — bakery, baker

Before you move on

Give "bread" with its article. (**El pan**.) What does *compañero* literally mean, and what's it built from? ("**One you share bread with**" — *com-* + *pānis*.) Does English keep this same double meaning? (**No** — English's *companion* only kept the friendship sense; Spanish still uses the same root for the actual bread, *pan*, too.)

Chapter 144

La Bebo — The Pronoun Tells the Truth

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use an object pronoun to reveal a gender the article hides.
>
> *Complete ES-C55-la-bebo: say la bebo for el agua and explain why the pronoun can report a gender the article hides.*

144.1 la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth

Which article does *agua* take? (*El.*) And what gender is *agua* really? (**Feminine** — the article is a sound rule, not a gender.)

Grammar Lens: a third witness

When you met *el agua* you were given two proofs that the word is feminine underneath: the adjective it takes and the plural it forms. Here is a third, and it costs you nothing new.

Bebo ***el agua****.* — I drink the water. ***La*** *bebo.* — I drink it.

Not *lo bebo.* **La** bebo.
The article had to say *el* for a reason that has nothing to do with gender — two *a* sounds colliding. The pronoun is under no such pressure. Nothing sits in front of it, no vowels collide, so it reports the gender straight.
This is worth more than one word. **When an article looks**

suspicious, the object pronoun is a witness that cannot be leaned on. You now have a test you can run yourself, rather than a list to trust.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el agua" then "la bebo" — until the clash stops feeling like an error
- "lo bebo" then "la bebo", and notice which one is about water

Before you move on

El agua — which pronoun replaces it? (**La**.) And why does that not contradict the article? (The article changed for **sound**, not gender.)

Chapter 145

The Months

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the twelve months in Spanish and explain why diciembre carries the Latin word for ten.
>
> *Recite enero through diciembre, tie marzo back to martes through Mars, and place septiembre and diciembre against the Roman year that started in March.*

145.1 los meses — the calendar's gods and Caesars

Spanish's twelve months are a **procession of Roman gods and emperors**, barely changed from Latin. Two things you already know pay off immediately: *marzo* is the war-god you met in *martes*, and *septiembre–diciembre* are the Latin numbers 7–10 from the counting chapters.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← **Latin**	**who / what**
enero	*Iānuārius*	**Janus**, the two-faced god of doors & beginnings
febrero	*Februārius*	*Februa*, the Roman **purification** festival
marzo	*Martius*	**Mars**, the war-god — *the same Mars as* **martes** (Tuesday)!
abril	*Aprīlis*	perhaps *aperīre*, "to **open**" (buds opening)
mayo	*Māius*	**Maia**, goddess of growth
junio	*Iūnius*	**Juno**, queen of the gods
julio	*Iūlius*	originally *Quīntīlis*, "the 5th [month]" — **renamed** for **Julius Caesar** after his death
agosto	*Augustus*	originally *Sextīlis*, "the 6th [month]" — **renamed** for the emperor **Augustus**
septiembre	*september*	"**7th**" (*septem*)
octubre	*octōber*	"**8th**" (*octō*)
noviembre	*november*	"**9th**" (*novem*)
diciembre	*december*	"**10th**" (*decem*)

Two payoffs land at once:

- **marzo = Mars = martes.** The month and the weekday honor the *same* war-god — *Martius* (his month) and *Martis diēs* (his day). Spot one, you know the other.
- **The 7–10 months.** *Septiembre* through *diciembre* still carry *septem, octō, novem, decem* — because the old Roman year

originally began in **March**, with September genuinely the 7th month. Centuries before Caesar, two new months (Januarius, Februarius) were added at the front to cover the winter, which pushed every later month's number out of step with its name — September became the *9th* month while still being *named* "7th." **Julius** and **Augustus** had nothing to do with that shift: they simply got two already-existing months — *Quintilis* and *Sextilis*, literally "5th" and "6th" — **renamed** in their honor after the fact. The names stuck; the months themselves were never new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — "enero, febrero, marzo, abril, mayo, junio, julio, agosto, septiembre, octubre, noviembre, diciembre"
- the tie-back — "marzo / martes — both Mars, the war-god"
- "septiembre = 7, diciembre = 10" — the old March-start year

Before you move on

Which god links *marzo* and *martes*? (**Mars**, the war-god — his month and his day.) Why is *diciembre* Latin for "ten"? (**The Roman year began in March**, and adding January/February at the front later pushed every month's number out of step with its name.) Did Julius Caesar and Augustus **add** new months to the calendar? (**No** — *julio* and *agosto* were already-existing months, *Quintilis* and *Sextilis* ("5th"/"6th"), simply **renamed** in their honor.)

Chapter 146

Noon and Midnight

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that it is noon or midnight in Spanish and break both words into their two living halves.
>
> *Say es mediodía and es medianoche, split each into medio/media plus día/noche, and set them against French's worn-down midi and minuit.*

146.1 mediodía, medianoche — noon and midnight, spelled out in full

Two hours that don't get a number — they get a name. And Spanish keeps that name far more transparent than its French cousin does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	literally
mediodía	*medius diēs*	"**mid-day**" (*medio* "middle" + *día* "day")
medianoche	*media nox*	"**mid-night**" (*media* "middle" + *noche* "night")

Both halves are **fully alive, ordinary Spanish words on their own**: **medio/media** ("middle" — cousin of English *medium, mid,*

middle) and **día/noche** ("day/night," words you already know). Compare French, which took the same Latin phrase down a bumpier road: *minuit*'s second half, **-nuit**, is still the plain, everyday French word for "night" — just as recognizable as Spanish's *noche*. But *midi*'s second half, **-di**, wore down into an opaque fragment: the ordinary French word for "day" is *jour*, not *di* — that piece survives only as a fossil, tucked inside weekday names like *lundi* and *mardi*. So the erosion split unevenly: French kept "night" transparent and lost "day," while Spanish kept both.
They don't need *horas* the way a normal Spanish time (*son las tres*) never does either — they simply stand in for the hour on their own:

> **Es mediodía.** — "It is noon." **Es medianoche.** — "It is midnight."

(Fun aside: English **noon** comes from Latin *nōna hōra*, "the **ninth** hour" — originally mid-afternoon, it drifted earlier over the centuries to mean midday. Spanish kept the tidier, transparent "mid-day" instead.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "mediodía" (noon), "medianoche" (midnight)
- break them — "medio + día", "media + noche" — both halves still ordinary words
- "Es mediodía. Es medianoche." — they stand in for the hour
- the contrast — French kept "night" (nuit) but wore "day" down to a fossil (-di)

Before you move on

What do *mediodía* and *medianoche* literally mean, and from what Latin? ("Mid-day" ← *medius diēs*; "mid-night" ← *media nox*.) Are both halves still recognizable, ordinary Spanish words? (**Yes** — *medio/ media* "middle," *día/noche* "day/night.") Did French erode its phrase evenly? (**No** — French's *-nuit* stayed just as transparent

as Spanish's *noche*, but its *-di* wore down to an opaque fossil, since the everyday French word for "day" is actually *jour*.) How do you say "it is noon"? (*Es mediodía*.)

Chapter 147

Telling Time

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell the time in Spanish and choose correctly between es la una and son las dos.

Say es la una, son las dos, son las diez, and explain why one o'clock takes a singular verb while every other hour takes a plural one.

147.1 la hora — Spanish's barely-changed Latin hour

You've now seen this Latin word take three different paths: French wore it down to *heure*, German borrowed it centuries later as *Uhr*. Spanish's path is the simplest of all — it barely changed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hora ← Latin **hōra** ← Greek **hṓrā**, "a season, a time of day" (the Greek goddesses of the seasons were the *Hōrai*). Spanish kept the word almost exactly as Latin had it — just a silent **h** in spelling, a fossil of a Latin *h* that was already weak and barely pronounced by the time Spanish inherited the word (the same non-story as French *heure* or English *hour*'s silent *h*). Be careful not to confuse this with *hijo* and *hacer*'s silent *h* — those come from a completely different, later Spanish sound change (Latin **f-** → Old Spanish aspirated *h-* → eventual silence), not from an already-weak Latin *h* the way *hora*'s is.

Two different roads to the same "silent letter" result. Compare its cousins: French wore *hōra* down further to *heure*; German didn't inherit the word at all, but borrowed it later as *Uhr*; English took the same Latin *hōra* and made *hour*.

language	word	what happened
Spanish	**hora**	inherited almost unchanged, just a silent *h*
French	*heure*	inherited, but worn down further
German	*Uhr*	not inherited — borrowed later, separately
English	*hour*	inherited via French, silent *h*

Grammar Lens: Son las and telling time

Spanish uses **ser** ("to be") plus the **feminine plural article** (agreeing with the unspoken *horas*) to tell time — and famously switches number for "one":

> **Es la una.** — "It is one o'clock." (singular — *la una*, "the one") **Son las dos.** — "It is two o'clock." (plural — *las dos*, "the two") **Son las diez.** — "It is ten o'clock."

Literally "**it is the one**" / "**they are the two/ten**" — the hour count itself is implied by the article and number, without needing to say *hora(s)* at all in everyday speech (unlike French's *il est deux heures*, which spells out "hours" every time).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hora" — silent h, a fossil of an already-weak Latin h
- "Es la una. Son las dos. Son las diez."
- "hora / heure / hour" — one Latin root, three different fates

Before you move on

What Latin (and Greek) word is *hora* from? (*hōra* ← Greek *hṓrā*.) How did Spanish's path differ from French's and German's? (**Spanish** inherited it almost unchanged; **French** wore it down further to *heure*; **German** didn't inherit it at all and borrowed *Uhr* separately, much later.) How do you say "it is one o'clock" vs. "it is two o'clock"? (*Es la una* — singular; *Son las dos* — plural.)

Chapter 148

The Weather

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about the weather in Spanish and know why llueve refuses to join hace.
>
> *Ask about el tiempo, answer hace calor, hace frío, hace sol, then switch to llueve — a verb of its own, whose ll- is the same sound change that gave llamar.*

148.1 el tiempo — one word doing two jobs

Ask a Spanish speaker *¿qué tiempo hace?* and you are literally asking "**what time does it make?**" — because *tiempo* does not split "time" from "weather" the way English does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tiempo = both "**time**" and "**weather**" — from Latin **tempus**, which already carried this same double sense. Nothing was merged in Spanish; the two meanings simply arrived together and stayed.
English inherited the word too, through borrowing, but kept **only the time half**: **temporal**, **contemporary**, **tempo**, **temporary**. So the double meaning is not a Spanish oddity — it is the older state of affairs, and English is the one that narrowed.
How does a Spanish speaker know which is meant? **Context alone**, and it is never ambiguous in practice: *no tengo tiempo* is "I have no time," *¿qué tiempo hace?* is "what's the weather like?"

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el tiempo" — time, or weather, depending on context
- "¿qué tiempo hace?" — what's the weather like?
- "tiempo" then English "tempo, temporal" — the *tempus* family

Before you move on

What two things does **el tiempo** mean? (**Time** and **weather**.) Which Latin word gives it, and did it already mean both? (**Tempus** — yes, both.) Which language narrowed the meaning, Spanish or English? (**English** — it kept only "time.") Next: how to actually answer *¿qué tiempo hace?*

148.2 hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — the weather Spanish *makes*

You can ask *¿qué tiempo hace?* Now answer it. Three of Spanish's commonest weather answers all take the same verb you already know — *hacer*, "to make."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **calor** ← Latin **calor**, "heat, warmth" → English **calorie**, **caloric**, **cauldron**.
- **frío** ← Latin **frigidus**, "cold" (the middle syllable syncopated away) → English **frigid**, **refrigerate**.
- **sol** ← Latin **sol**, "sun," unchanged → English **solar**, **solstice**, **parasol**.

Here is the part worth noticing: all three are **nouns**, not adjectives. *Calor* is "heat," not "hot." That is exactly why Spanish reaches for **hacer**: you cannot *be* a noun, but the world can **make** one.

hace calor — "it's hot," literally "**it makes heat**" **hace frío** — "it's cold," literally "**it makes cold**" **hace sol** — "it's sunny," literally "**it makes sun**"

French does the same thing with the same logic (*il fait chaud*); English is the outlier, forcing weather into "it **is** hot" with an adjective.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hace calor. hace frío. hace sol."
- the literal reading — "it makes heat, it makes cold, it makes sun"
- "calor" then English "calorie"; "frío" then "refrigerate"

Before you move on

Say "it's hot," "it's cold," "it's sunny." (*Hace calor, hace frío, hace sol.*) Why does Spanish use *hacer* rather than a "to be" verb? (Because *calor*, *frío* and *sol* are **nouns** — the weather **makes** heat, it does not *be* hot.) Give an English cousin of *frío*. (**Frigid**, **refrigerate**.)

148.3 llueve — the one weather word that will not join *hacer*

Hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — three answers, one pattern. Now try rain, and the pattern breaks. Rain does not get made in Spanish; rain has a verb of its own.

Grammar Lens: rain brings its own verb

llueve = "it's raining." Not *hace lluvia*, not "it makes rain" — just **llueve**, a single word that is a complete sentence.
It comes from **llover**, "to rain," and *llover* is **impersonal**: it has no subject at all, not even a "it" you could point to. Compare the two shapes side by side:

pattern	example	what carries the weather
hacer + noun	*hace calor*	the **noun** (*calor*, heat)
dedicated verb	*llueve*	the **verb itself**

English does exactly the same split, which makes it easy to feel: you say "it **is** hot" with an adjective, but "it **rains**" with a verb built for the job. Spanish just draws the line in the same place.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llover ← Latin **pluere**, "to rain." Recognise that **pl-** → **ll-** shift? It is the **same regular sound change** that gave you **llamar** (← *clamāre*), **llave** (← *clāvem*, "key") and **llama** (← *flamma*, "flame"). Latin's *cl-*, *fl-* and *pl-* clusters all became Spanish *ll-*.
So *llueve* is not an exception you have to memorise twice: it is a predictable descendant of *pluere* (the same root English keeps in **pluvial** and the **pluviometer**, a rain gauge), and it is the one weather word with enough of its own life to refuse the *hacer* frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿qué tiempo hace?" then "hace calor. hace frío. hace sol."
- "llueve" — one word, a whole sentence, no *hacer*
- the family — "llamar, llave, llama, llover" — four Latin clusters, one Spanish *ll-*

Before you move on

Which weather word does **not** use *hacer*, and why? (**Llueve** — rain has its own impersonal verb, *llover*.) What Latin word is *llover* from? (**Pluere**.) What sound change turned its *pl-* into *ll-*, and what other words show it? (Latin *cl-/fl-/pl-* → Spanish *ll-* — *llamar*, *llave*, *llama*.) And what does *el tiempo* mean? (**Time** and **weather**, from *tempus*.)

Chapter 149

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

Modes: **voice** (4) **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can count from eleven to twenty in Spanish and say where the fused Latin teens stop and the ten-and-X ones begin.
>
> *Run once to quince as fused Latin compounds, then dieciséis to diecinueve as a ten-and-X template, say why Latin's own subtractive 18 and 19 did not survive, and close on veinte.*

149.1 once — quince: five words with a seam you can no longer see

Spanish counts past ten in **two completely different ways**, and the join between them is a real boundary in the language, not a place someone drew a line. Today: the first five, which you simply have to learn as words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin
once	*undecim* ("one-ten")
doce	*duodecim* ("two-ten")
trece	*tredecim* ("three-ten")
catorce	*quattuordecim* ("four-ten")
quince	*quindecim* ("five-ten")

Every one of these *was* a compound — a number plus **-decim** ("ten,"

the same root as *diez*). But these five are the numbers people say most often, and heavy use wears words smooth. Centuries of everyday speech fused each pair into a single, **opaque** word: no Spanish speaker hears "one-ten" in *once* any more than an English speaker hears "two-ten" in *twelve*.
Listen for the ghost, though. The **-ce** ending on *doce, trece, catorce, quince* is all that survives of Latin's *-decim*. It is the same "ten" you already say in **diez**, ground down to two letters.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "once, doce, trece, catorce, quince"
- just the endings — "-ce, -ce, -ce, -ce" — the worn-down *ten*

Before you move on

Count eleven to fifteen. (*Once, doce, trece, catorce, quince.*) What are these five, structurally? (**Fused Latin compounds** — number plus *-decim*, "ten.") Which piece of each word is the old "ten"? (The **-ce** ending — *diez* worn down.) Next: the numbers where the seam is still wide open.

149.2 dieciséis — diecinueve: where the seam reopens

You just learned five numbers whose insides had been ground smooth. Now say **fifteen** and then **sixteen** — *quince*, *dieciséis* — and hear the language change gear. From here you are not memorising words; you are following a rule.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	literally
dieciséis	*diez y seis*, "ten and six"
diecisiete	*diez y siete*, "ten and seven"
dieciocho	*diez y ocho*, "ten and eight"
diecinueve	*diez y nueve*, "ten and nine"

No fusion. You can hear **diez** plainly at the front of every one, and the number you already know sitting right behind it.

Grammar Lens: a formula, not a list

This is the structural difference that makes 15/16 a real boundary in Spanish rather than a convenient place to pause:

	11-15	16-19
how you get the word	**remember** it	**build** it
the "ten" inside	worn to *-ce*	still spelled *dieci-*
can you hear the parts?	no	yes

So *once* through *quince* are **vocabulary**, and *dieciséis* through *diecinueve* are **grammar**: one template, *dieci- + digit*, filled four times. Learn the template once and all four are already yours.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve"
- the seam out loud — "diez y seis" then "dieciséis"
- the boundary — "quince" (remembered), "dieciséis" (built)

Before you move on

Count sixteen to nineteen. (*Dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve.*) Are these fused or transparent? (**Transparent** — plain "ten and X.") Which of the two groups do you have to memorise, and which can you generate? (**Memorise 11-15**; **generate 16-19** from *dieci-* plus the digit.)

149.3 duodēvīgintī — the quirk Spanish threw away

Dieciocho and *diecinueve* look like the least interesting words in the chapter — just two more ten-and-X compounds. They are actually the most interesting, because of what Latin said instead.

What to know first

- dieciséis — diecinueve — the *dieci-* plus digit template.

Why it's said this way

You would expect *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* to carry on whatever Latin did for 18 and 19. Latin did something else entirely. Its everyday words for those two numbers were **subtractive** — counted *down* from twenty:

number	Latin	literally
18	**duodēvīgintī**	"**two from** twenty"
19	**ūndēvīgintī**	"**one from** twenty"

(You still meet this habit in English clock-talk: "ten **to** four.")
Spanish did not inherit either word. It built *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* fresh, on exactly the same simple template as 16 and 17 — quietly **regularising away** an irregularity that existed in its own parent language. Languages are usually described as wearing down and getting messier; here is a clean case of one tidying up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- Latin's way — "two from twenty" — then Spanish's — "dieciocho"
- "dieciocho, diecinueve" — addition, not subtraction

Before you move on

How did Latin say 18 and 19? (**Subtractively** — *duodēvīgintī*, "two from twenty," and *ūndēvīgintī*, "one from twenty.") Did Spanish keep that? (**No** — it built *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* on the

regular ten-and-X template.) So which language is the irregular one here? (**Latin** — Spanish simplified.)

149.4 veinte — the number the teens were counting toward

Latin's own 18 and 19 were counted *down from twenty*. So it is worth meeting twenty itself — the number the whole run has been aiming at.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

veinte ("twenty") ← Latin **vīgintī**. It was worn down by ordinary sound change — the *g* softened away, the vowels shifted — but notice what did **not** happen to it: it was never **fused** out of two separate words the way *once* through *quince* were. *Vīgintī* was already a single word for a single round number, so there is no seam inside *veinte* to look for.

Three different histories, then, in one short chapter:

words	**what happened**
once - *quince*	two words **fused** into one
dieciséis - *diecinueve*	two words **built** into one, seam visible
veinte	one word, simply **worn**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "once, doce, trece, catorce, quince" — the five fused Latins
- "dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve" — built, not fused
- "veinte" — twenty, worn but never fused

Before you move on

Count eleven to twenty. Where is the boundary between remembering and building, and why is it there? (**After *quince*** — 11-15 are fused Latin compounds, 16-19 are *dieci-* plus a digit.) Did Spanish inherit Latin's subtractive 18 and 19? (**No** — it regularised them.) Was *veinte* fused from two words? (**No** — Latin *vīgintī* was already one word; it was only worn down.)

Chapter 150

Dog and Cat

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name a dog and a cat in Spanish and say which of the two words still has no agreed origin.
>
> *Say gato and perro, trace cattus back toward Egypt, then admit that perro — which pushed out the older can — has no settled etymology at all.*

150.1 gato — the word that travelled with the animal

Some etymologies can be followed all the way home. This one runs from your mouth back to ancient Egypt, and every step of it is documented.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gato ("**cat**") ← Latin **cattus**. But *cattus* was **not** Classical Latin's word for cat. That was **fēlēs**, which survives today only in the scientific name *Felis catus* and in English **feline**.
Cattus entered Latin **later**, arriving with the animal itself as domestic cats spread along **Roman trade routes** from where they were domesticated — **Egypt**, around 2000 BCE. The word is most likely **Afro-Asiatic** in origin (compare Nubian **kadis**, "cat").
So word and creature travelled together, out of Africa into Europe, and the newcomer pushed *fēlēs* out almost everywhere: Spanish *gato*, Italian *gatto*, French *chat*, Old Irish *cat*, Welsh *cath*, English *cat*. When

a thing arrives from abroad, its name usually arrives with it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el gato" — the cat
- the trail — "kadis, cattus, gato"
- the word it replaced — "fēlēs," now only in "feline"

Before you move on

What was Classical Latin's actual word for cat, and where does it survive? (**Fēlēs** — in *Felis catus* and English *feline*.) Where did *cattus* most likely come from? (An **Afro-Asiatic** word, travelling with the domesticated cat out of **Egypt**.) Next: the other animal in this chapter, whose history nobody can trace at all.

150.2 perro — the word nobody can explain

Gato could be traced all the way to Egypt. **Perro** is the opposite kind of word, and it is worth knowing that such words exist: completely ordinary, used a thousand times a day, and **nobody knows where it came from**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perro ("**dog**"). Roll the *rr*: *PEH-rro*.
The word Spanish **should** have inherited is **canis** — the same root as English **canine**, French *chien*, Italian *cane*. And it did survive, as the now-archaic Spanish **can** (still readable in old poetry and in *canino*). But at some point *perro* pushed *can* almost entirely out of everyday use — and *perro* itself has no agreed origin.

Why it's said this way

Three serious proposals, none confirmed:

proposal	the case for it	the problem
onomatopoeia — a growl, or a shepherd's call *"perr, perr"*	matches how herding calls become names elsewhere	no early written evidence
pre-Roman Iberian substrate	the *-rro* ending is a known marker of likely pre-Latin words in Spanish	the substrate languages are barely recorded
Persian *persus*, a hunting-dog breed	such breeds did spread in the late Empire	the sound match is loose

Notice what makes this a **good** open question rather than a shrug: each proposal predicts different evidence, and the evidence needed simply has not survived. *Perro* remains one of Spanish's genuinely unsolved puzzles, and a useful reminder that "we don't know" is a real answer in etymology, not a gap in your notes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el perro, el gato" — dog and cat
- "can" — the archaic word *perro* replaced, from Latin *canis*
- the contrast — "gato, traced to Egypt; perro, unsolved"

Before you move on

What archaic Spanish word did *perro* replace, and what is its Latin source? (**Can**, from **canis** — the root of English *canine*.) Does *perro* have a confirmed etymology? (**No** — onomatopoeic, pre-Latin substrate and Persian proposals all remain unconfirmed.) And *gato*'s origin, by contrast? (**Traceable** — Latin *cattus*, probably Afro-Asiatic, travelling out of Egypt.)

Chapter 151

Green and Yellow

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name green and yellow in Spanish and explain why amarillo is built on the word for bitter.
>
> *Say verde and amarillo, tie verde to virēre, to flourish, and amarillo to amarellus, a little bitter — the same root as everyday amargo.*

151.1 verde — the colour named after being alive

After *azul*'s long journey from Afghanistan, here is a colour that stayed exactly where it started. It is also the one that names a **process** rather than a thing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

verde ("**green**") ← Latin **viridis** (worn down through *virdis*), which comes from the verb **virēre**, "**to be green, to flourish, to be vigorous**."
So the adjective is built on a **verb of thriving**. Latin did not name the colour of leaves; it named what leaves are *doing*, and let the colour follow. The same root gives *vigour* its neighbours in English: **verdant**, **verdure**, and the green-tinged **verdigris** ("green of Greece").
One careful non-connection: **verde is not a cousin of English *green***. *Green* comes from a completely separate **Germanic** root, tied to *grow* and *grass* — which, funnily enough, is the same idea arrived at independently. Two families, two words, one metaphor: green is the colour of things that are growing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "verde" — green
- the root — "virēre, to flourish" → "verde"
- "verde" then English "verdant" — and *not* "green"

Before you move on

What Latin verb gives **verde**, and what does it mean? (**Virēre**, "to be green, to flourish.") Is *verde* related to English *green*? (**No** — *green* is Germanic, from the same family as *grow* and *grass*; the two languages reached the same metaphor separately.) Next: a colour that is not named after a colour at all.

151.2 amarillo — the colour that started as a taste

Verde was exactly what you would expect from Latin. This one is not. Latin had three perfectly good words for yellow, and Spanish took none of them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

amarillo ("**yellow**") does **not** trace to *flāvus*, *gilvus* or *lūteus* — Latin's actual yellow words. It comes from Late Latin **amarellus**, "**a little bitter**," a diminutive of **amarus**, "**bitter**."
A colour named after a **taste**. The bridge is medicine: yellow was the colour of **bile** and of **jaundice** (which Spanish still calls *ictericia*, but which folk speech long tied to bitterness), and of a great many bitter-tasting plants. A word meaning "somewhat bitter" came to mean "the yellowish look of a bitter thing," then simply "yellowish," and by Spanish's Golden Age it had dropped the taste entirely and kept only the colour.
You can still check the family in a living word: **amargo** ("bitter") is *amarillo*'s cousin, straight from the same *amarus*. Say them together and the shared *amar-* is right there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "verde, amarillo" — green and yellow
- "amarillo, amargo" — hear the shared *amar-*
- the path — "a little bitter" → "yellowish" → "yellow"

Before you move on

Does **amarillo** come from a Latin word for yellow? (**No** — from *amarellus*, "a little bitter," a diminutive of *amarus*.) What everyday Spanish word is its cousin? (**Amargo**, "bitter.") And *verde*? (From **virēre**, "to flourish" — a colour named after being alive, as this one is named after a taste.)

Chapter 152

Synthesis — Saying Something About Your Own Life

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can describe things around me with the nouns and colours I hold, choosing un rather than el.
>
> *Fourteen chapters of nouns and colours, combined for the first time - and the article that makes it possible.*

152.1 Synthesis — saying something about your own life

Nothing new in this chapter. Say the words for *dog* and for *black*.

What you've built

Something has been accumulating quietly for fourteen chapters and has never once been put to work.
You have six colours. Parents and brothers and sisters. A head and a hand. Water, wine and bread. The seasons, the months, the hours. Hot weather and cold. Numbers to twenty. A dog and a cat.
That is not a vocabulary list any more. It is **enough to describe the room you are sitting in**, and this chapter is the first that asks you to.

Grammar Lens: the word that made this possible

Notice which article you need here, because it is not the one you have used most.

> **el perro** — *the* dog. A particular one. The one we were talking about. **un perro** — *a* dog. Any dog. One you are mentioning for the first time.

Describing your own life means introducing things your listener does not know about yet — and that is exactly the job **un** does. Almost every sentence below needs it.

The exchange

— ¿**Tienes un perro**? — Sí, **tengo un perro negro**. ¿Y tú?
— **Tengo un gato blanco.**

Every word in those three lines is one you built yourself, across fourteen chapters that never asked you to combine them. Nothing here is new. What is new is that it is a **conversation** rather than a list.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the exchange above, both parts
- it again about a real animal you know, with a real colour

Twice through: Until you are describing rather than translating.

Before you move on

Which article introduces something your listener does not yet know about? (**Un**.) And which points at something you have both already mentioned? (**El**.) Say one true sentence about an animal, with its colour.

152.2 Review — the same question, asked of eleven words

The two days of the weekend. (*Sábado, domingo.*) The four seasons. (*Primavera, verano, otoño, invierno.*)

What you've built

You can now say when something happens.
The hour: *Son las dos.* Add the minutes: *Son las dos y* **veinte**. The two hinges of the day: *el mediodía*, *la medianoche*. And the weather, which needs no subject at all — *llueve*.
The months, in order, from *enero* to *diciembre*.

Why it's said this way

Ask one question of all of them — *where did you come from?* — and no two give the same answer.

- ***la hora*** came through from Latin nearly untouched.
- ***veinte*** came through worn thin, but in one piece.
- ***sábado*** and ***domingo*** were **overwritten**: the other five days are named after planets, and a religion renamed these two.
- ***azul*** was **borrowed**, from Arabic, and then beat the inherited word.
- ***verde*** was a verb before it was a colour — "to flourish."
- ***amarillo*** meant **"a little bitter."** It has no ancestor that meant yellow at all.
- ***rojo*** is a **cousin** of French *rouge*, not a copy of it.

Inherited, worn, overwritten, borrowed, repurposed, drifted, related. Every new word you meet from here on has one of those behind it, and asking which is how a vocabulary stops being a list.

Your turn

- *Say it: sábado*, *domingo* — then *lunes*, and hear the planet come back

Before you move on

Name the season after *el verano*. (*El otoño.*) The month after *noviembre*. (*Diciembre.*) And which of your colour words was borrowed rather than inherited? (***Azul***.)

152.3 Review — one Saturday, from morning to midnight

The first day of the weekend. (*El sábado.*) The month before *noviembre*. (*Octubre.*)

What you've built

Every piece below has been a separate chapter. Here they are as one day.

> *Es* ***sábado****. Es* ***octubre****, y es* ***otoño****. Son las nueve y* ***veinte****.* ***Llueve****. Al* ***mediodía*** *el cielo está* ***amarillo****. A* ***medianoche****, todavía* ***llueve****.*

Read it again and count what it took: a day name, a month, a season, an hour, the minutes, a weather verb with nothing in front of it, two halves of the day, and a colour. Nine chapters, four lines.

Why it's said this way

One thing in that story is quietly wrong, and it has been wrong for two thousand years.
Octubre carries *ocho* inside it. Eight. And it is the **tenth** month.
The Roman year opened in March, so the counting started there: *septiembre* seventh, *octubre* eighth, *noviembre* ninth, *diciembre* tenth.
Then the year was moved to January, everything slid by two, and nobody renamed anything.
So four of your months are still counting from a new year that stopped happening — which is why you can read them without being told what they mean.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the four lines of the story, straight through, without stopping

Twice through:

Before you move on

What day was it? (***Sábado***.) What colour was the sky at noon? (***Amarillo***.) And what number is hiding in *diciembre*? (***Diez*** — ten, in the tenth month's old position.)

Chapter 153

Pensar — Thinking Is Weighing

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I think, and break pensar's stem the way a stem-changer requires.
>
> *Run pensar through the e→ie boot, and find the scales still inside pensive and peso.*

153.1 pensar — "to think", and it started out meaning "to weigh"

You can already run an *-ar* verb: *hablo, hablas, habla.* Here is one that takes those same endings and then cracks its stem in the middle, the way *querer* did.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ie` — under stress the *e* breaks open: **pienso** = *PYEN-so.*
- The *s* is always a clear hissing *s*, never an English *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pensar ("**to think**") ← Latin **pēnsāre**, "**to weigh**" — the repeating form of *pendere*, "to hang, to weigh out". A Roman hung goods on a balance; the same verb slid across to weighing an idea.
English kept the whole family, and most of it still smells of money and

scales:

- **pensive** — turning something over on the balance.
- **compensate** — *com-* "together" + weigh: settle one weight against another.
- **expense**, **dispense**, **pension** — payments were literally *weighed out*.
- **peso** — a coin whose name simply means "a weight".
- **pansy** — from French *pensée*, "a thought".

English reaches for the same picture without noticing it: you *weigh your options*, and an argument *carries weight*.

Grammar Lens: the same endings, a broken stem

The endings are the ordinary *-ar* set. Only the stressed *e* changes:

person	form	stem
yo	**pienso**	broken
tú	**piensas**	broken
él/ella/usted	**piensa**	broken
nosotros	**pensamos**	plain
ellos/ustedes	**piensan**	broken

Pensamos keeps the plain *e* because there the stress lands on the ending, not the stem — exactly the rule *querer* taught you.
Two small habits come with the verb: *pensar* **en** something means "think about" it (*pienso en ti*), and *pensar* followed by a bare infinitive means "plan to" (*pienso hablar* — I mean to speak).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "pensar" then the set — "pienso, piensas, piensa, pensamos, piensan"
- "Pienso en ti" — I am thinking of you
- "pensar" then English "pensive, compensate, peso" — the weighing family

Before you move on

What did *pēnsāre* mean literally, and name two English cousins. (**To weigh**; *pensive, compensate, expense, peso.*) Which form keeps the plain *e*, and why? (*Pensamos* — the stress falls on the ending.) Which little word follows *pensar* for "think about"? (**En**.) Next: **entender**, which cracks the same way.

Chapter 154

Entender — Understanding Is Stretching Toward

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I understand, and see the verb inside the no entiendo I have used since chapter 14.
>
> *The second e→ie stem-changer, and the moment a chapter-14 formula turns out to have parts.*

154.1 entender — "to understand", built out of stretching

Pensar broke its stem under stress. So does this one — and you have already been using it. **No entiendo** has been in your mouth since the repair kit, where you learned it as one frozen block. This is the verb it came from.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ie` — **entiendo** = *en-TYEN-do.*
- `d-soft` — the *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* of English *this.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

entender ("**to understand**") ← Latin **intendere**: **in-** ("toward") + **tendere** ("**to stretch**"). Understanding something was *stretching*

your attention toward it — leaning in.
tendere stretches right across English:

- **intend**, **intent**, **intense**, **intention** — the very same *in-* + stretch.
- **attend**, **attention** — *ad-* "toward", stretch that way.
- **extend**, **contend**, **pretend**, **tension**, **tendon**, and **tent**, which is stretched cloth.

So *entiendo* and *I intend* are the same two Latin pieces landing in different places: Spanish went to "I grasp it", English to "I mean to".

> **Careful with a false friend.** Spanish **pretender** is *not* English *pretend*. It means "to aim at, to be after" — *pretende ser médico*, "he means to become a doctor". Same pieces, different landing.

Grammar Lens: an -er verb that cracks, and a calmer twin

Ordinary *-er* endings, stressed *e* broken to *ie*:

person	form	stem
yo	**entiendo**	broken
tú	**entiendes**	broken
nosotros	**entendemos**	plain
ellos/ustedes	**entienden**	broken

Spanish has a second verb for this job: **comprender** ← Latin *comprehendere*, "to seize together" (→ English **comprehend**, **apprehend**, **comprehensive**). It is a plain *-er* verb with no crack at all: *comprendo, comprendes, comprende*. Both mean "understand". *Entender* is the everyday one; *comprender* leans a little more formal, and more toward grasping a whole thing than catching a word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "No entiendo" — I don't understand
- "entiendo, entiendes, entendemos, entienden"

- "pienso" then "entiendo" — the same crack, twice
- "entender" then English "intend, intense, attention" — the stretching family

Before you move on

What does *tendere* mean, and what does *in-* add? (**To stretch**; "toward".) Give the *yo* and *nosotros* forms. (*Entiendo, entendemos.*) Of *entender* and *comprender*, which one breaks its stem? (**Entender**.) And what does Spanish *pretender* mean? (**To aim at**, not to pretend.) Next: **leer**.

Chapter 155

Leer — Reading Is Gathering

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I read, with a verb whose stem does not break.
>
> *legere, the root that gathers: collect, select, elect, and intellect.*

155.1 leer — "to read", and before that, "to gather"

Two cracked verbs down. Here is a calm one — nothing breaks in the middle. The only difficulty is in your mouth: two *e*'s in a row that must stay two.

Sounds you'll need

- `hiatus-ee` — **leer** is two syllables, *le-ER*, never one long English *ee*.
- **leo** is likewise two beats, *LE-o*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

leer ("**to read**") ← Latin **legere**, "**to gather, to pick out, to choose**" — and only afterwards "to read". A reader picks letters out of a row the way a farmhand picks olives off a branch.
That gathering root runs through an enormous amount of English:

- **legible**, **legend** ("things to be read"), **lecture**, **lectern**, and

worn right down, **lesson**.

- built with prefixes: **collect** (*col-* "together"), **select** (*se-* "apart"), **elect** (*e-* "out"), **intellect** (*inter-* "between" — choosing between things).
- **diligent** and **elegant**, both of which meant "picking carefully".

One honest limit: Greek *légein* ("to speak, to gather") — which gives English *logic*, *dialogue*, *catalogue* — is a **cousin** of *legere* from the same ancient root, not its parent. Same family, separate journeys.

Grammar Lens: a plain -er verb, with a mouthful

Nothing irregular happens. Drop *-er*, add the ordinary endings:

person	form	said
yo	**leo**	LE-o
tú	**lees**	LE-es
él/ella/usted	**lee**	LE-e
nosotros	**leemos**	le-E-mos
ellos/ustedes	**leen**	LE-en

Every one of those is a syllable longer than an English speaker expects. Give each *e* its own beat and the word comes out right.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "leer" — *le-ER*, two beats
- "Leo un libro" — I read a book
- "No entiendo" then "Leo, pero no entiendo" — I read, but I don't understand
- "leer" then English "legible, collect, select, elect"

Before you move on

What did *legere* mean before it meant "to read"? (**To gather, to pick out**.) Give two English words built on it with a prefix.

(*Collect, select, elect, intellect.*) How many syllables in *leo*? (**Two** — *LE-o.*) Next: **escribir**, the other half of literacy.

Chapter 156

Escribir — Writing Is Scratching

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I write, and explain the propped-up e- in front of it.
>
> *scrībere, to scratch, and Spanish refusing to begin a word with sc-.*

156.1 escribir — "to write", which once meant "to scratch"

Leer gathers letters off a page. This is the other half of the same skill — and its root remembers a time when writing was done with a sharp point in wax.

Sounds you'll need

- `st-no-e` — Spanish will not begin a word with *sc-*, *sp-*, *st-*, so it props one up with an **e-**: *es-cri-BIR*.
- `b-soft` — between vowels the *b* is soft, lips barely touching.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

escribir ("**to write**") ← Latin **scrībere**, whose first sense was "**to scratch, to incise**". Writing was cutting a line into wax or stone before it was ever ink on paper.
The English family is huge, and every member still works with a pen:

- **scribe**, **scribble**, **script**, **scripture**.

- **describe** (*de-* "down") and **description**; **prescribe** (*prae-* "before") and **prescription**; **subscribe** (*sub-* "under" — you signed at the bottom); **inscription**; **transcript**; **postscript**.
- **manuscript** — *manus* "hand" + *scriptum*: written by hand.
- **conscription** — being *written into* an army.

The Spanish past participle is **escrito** ("written"), which is English **script** wearing different clothes.

Grammar Lens: an -ir verb, and a productive spelling rule

Escribir is a plain *-ir* verb, the family *vivir* opened:

person	form	ending
yo	**escribo**	-o
tú	**escribes**	-es
él/ella/usted	**escribe**	-e
nosotros	**escribimos**	-imos
ellos/ustedes	**escriben**	-en

That propped-up **e-** is a rule you can run yourself, not a quirk of one word: Latin *schola* became **escuela**, *spatha* became **espada** (sword), *stāre* became **estar**, *Hispānia* became **España**. It is also why a Spanish speaker learning English says *eh-Spain*.
Now you can state a plan out loud: *Pienso escribir* — "I mean to write."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "escribo, escribes, escribe, escribimos, escriben"
- "Leo y escribo español" — I read and write Spanish
- "Pienso escribir" — I mean to write
- "escribir" then English "scribe, describe, manuscript" — the scratching family

Before you move on

What did *scrībere* mean first? (**To scratch, to incise**.) Why does Spanish say *escuela* and *España*? (It refuses to open a word with *sc-* or *sp-*, so it props an **e-** in front.) Say "I read and write Spanish". (*Leo y escribo español.*) And what does *legere* mean, from the lesson before? (**To gather, to pick out**.) Next chapter: taking, asking, helping — and a verb that runs backwards.

Chapter 157

Review — Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can hold all four mind-verbs at once and name the physical act inside each one.
>
> *Four abstractions, four labourers: weighing, stretching, gathering, scratching.*

157.1 Review — four verbs of the mind

Nothing new in this chapter. Name the four verbs of the last four chapters: to think, to understand, to read, to write.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is the thing none of the four chapters could show you on its own. Every one of these four "mental" verbs began as something you do with your **body**:

- **pensar** — Latin *pēnsāre*, to **weigh**. Thinking is putting things on a balance. English kept the scales in *weigh your options*, and in *pensive*.
- **entender** — Latin *intendere*, to **stretch toward**. Understanding is reaching. English kept the reach in *attention*.
- **leer** — Latin *legere*, to **gather, pick out**. Reading is picking grain from a field. English kept the gathering in *collect*, *select*, *elect*.

- **escribir** — Latin *scrībere*, to **scratch**. Writing is scratching a surface, which is exactly what it was.

Four abstractions, four labourers. No language invents a word for thinking; it borrows one from the hands and lets the meaning drift indoors.

> **And a hidden joint.** *Intellect* is Latin *inter* + *legere* — "to gather **between**." The root of **leer** is sitting inside the English word for the mind itself.

What you've built

Four verbs, and with them the four things you do with a language: take it in (*leer*), work on it (*pensar*), get it (*entender*), put it back out (*escribir*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four verbs in order — to read, to think, to understand, to write
- for each one, the body word underneath it

Twice through:

Before you move on

What did *entender* physically mean? (**To stretch toward**.) What do all four have in common? (Each was a **body** word before it was a mind word.) Next chapter you will use them to say something you actually think.

Chapter 158

Synthesis — What You Understand, and What You Don't

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can report which part of what I heard landed and which did not, instead of only signalling that I am lost.
>
> *The chapter-14 distress signal becomes a sentence with moving parts.*

158.1 Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't

Say the sentence you learned in the repair kit, the one that rescues a conversation. (*No entiendo.*)

Grammar Lens: the formula was a verb all along

You have been saying **no entiendo** since the repair kit, and until four chapters ago it was a single frozen block — two sounds that meant *I'm lost*, with no moving parts.
It has parts now. **Entiendo** is *entender*, and *entender* is Latin *intendere*, "to stretch toward." Which means the sentence you have been using to admit defeat has never actually said *I failed*. It says:

> **I am not managing to stretch that far.**

That was true the whole time. You just could not see it yet.

And the moment a formula has parts, it turns. *No entiendo* stops being the only thing you can say and becomes one option among several.

The exchange

Back in the repair kit, all you could do:

> — No entiendo. Más despacio, por favor.

Now, the same moment, with the parts working:

> — Perdón — **leo** un poco, pero **no entiendo**. — Más despacio, por favor. **Ahora entiendo.** Gracias.

Same trouble. But the second speaker is no longer only failing — they are reporting **which** part works and which does not. That is the difference between a distress signal and a conversation.

What you've built

Four verbs is not four words. It is the ability to say **where** you are in a language: what you take in, what you work on, what lands, what you can produce.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the repair-kit version — the distress signal on its own
- the version above, where you say what *does* work before what doesn't

Twice through: Run the second one until it sounds like a person, not a repair kit.

Before you move on

Which verb was hiding inside *no entiendo*? (*Entender.*) What did it physically mean? (**To stretch toward**.) What can you say now that you could not say back then? (Not just that you are lost — **which part** is lost.)

Chapter 159

Tomar — Taking, and a Word With No Past

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I take, and explain why this everyday verb has no agreed origin.

tomar, the honest gap — and coger, the verb Latin actually left.

159.1 tomar — "to take", and nobody knows where it came from

Every verb so far ran straight back to a Latin root you could name. Here is one that does not — and the gap is the useful part.

Sounds you'll need

- `r-tap` — one soft tap of the tongue: *to-MAR*.
- `vowel-o` — a short, pure *o*, with no English glide toward *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tomar ("**to take**") is a plain *-ar* verb: **tomo, tomas, toma, tomamos, toman**. It is one of the most common verbs in the language, and its origin is **genuinely unsettled**.
The leading proposal derives it from Latin *autumāre*, "to take as, to

assert", worn down through an intermediate *tumar*; a rival one points to a pre-Roman Iberian word Latin never recorded. Neither is proved, and careful dictionaries say so. "We don't know" is a real answer in etymology.
It carries a second everyday sense across Latin America: **to drink**. A waiter asking *¿Qué vas a tomar?* is asking what you would like.

Why it's said this way

Latin's own "gather up" verb survived perfectly well: **coger** ← **colligere**, which is *com-* ("together") + *legere* — the very root you met in *leer*. English took that same Latin word twice: **collect** straight from the Latin, and **coil** by way of French.
In Spain *coger* is the plain everyday word: *coger el autobús*, catch the bus. In much of Latin America — Argentina, Mexico and well beyond — it is **coarse slang for sex**, and using it innocently will derail a conversation. *Tomar* is safe on both sides of the Atlantic, which is a large part of why it won.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "tomo, tomas, toma, tomamos, toman"
- "Tomo un café" — I'll have a coffee
- "Tomo el autobús" — the safe way to say it anywhere
- "coger" then English "collect, coil" — one root, and one place to be careful

Before you move on

Does *tomar* have a confirmed etymology? (**No** — *autumāre* and a pre-Roman source are both unproved.) What Latin verb gives *coger*, and which root sits inside it? (*Colligere*, holding *legere*, "to gather", from *leer*.) Why reach for *tomar* instead? (*Coger* is coarse slang across much of Latin America.) Next: **preguntar**, and the two different asks.

Chapter 160

Preguntar — Asking, and Sounding a Depth

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask a question with preguntar, and choose it over pedir.

percontari, to sound a depth with a pole; and why English's one ask becomes two Spanish verbs.

160.1 preguntar — "to ask", by sounding the water with a pole

English gets by with one verb, *ask*. Spanish splits the job in two, and picking the wrong half is a reliable beginner mistake. Here is the first half.

Sounds you'll need

- `pr-cluster` — *pre-* is one crisp beat, *preh*, with a tapped *r*.
- `g-hard` — the *g* before *u* is hard, as in English *gun*: *pre-goon-TAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

preguntar ("**to ask a question**") ← Vulgar Latin **praecunctāre**, itself a reshaping of classical **percontārī**, "to inquire". And *percontārī* was built on **contus**, "**a punting pole**": to *percontor* was to push a

pole down through water and find out how deep it was.
Asking is taking a sounding. Unlike almost every other word here, *preguntar* left English nothing — the pole word died out — yet English rebuilt the same metaphor on its own: you *sound someone out*, you *probe*.
The verb is a plain *-ar* one: **pregunto, preguntas, pregunta, preguntamos, preguntan**. Its noun is **la pregunta** (fem.), and note that Spanish *makes* a question rather than asking one: *hacer una pregunta*.

Grammar Lens: one English "ask", two Spanish verbs

Spanish sorts asking by **what you are after**:

what you want	verb	example
information	**preguntar**	*Te pregunto la hora* — I'm asking you the time
a thing or a favour	**pedir**	*Pido un café* — I'm asking for a coffee

Ask for a coffee with *preguntar* and you have said "I question a coffee". The line is simple: a question takes *preguntar*, a request takes *pedir*. **pedir** ← Latin **petere**, "to make for, to aim at" — and *that* root stocked English generously: **petition**, **appetite**, **compete**, **impetus**, **perpetual**, **centripetal**. It cracks a third way, $e \rightarrow i$: **pido, pides, pide, pedimos, piden**. Recognise *pido* for now; the pattern gets its own lesson later.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "pregunto, preguntas, pregunta, preguntamos, preguntan"
- "Te pregunto la hora" — I'm asking you the time
- "Pido un café" then "Tomo un café" — I ask for one, I have one
- "pedir" then English "petition, appetite, compete" — the aiming family

Before you move on

What did *percontārī* picture literally? (**Sounding water with a pole**.) Which verb asks for a coffee, and which asks the time? (*Pedir* for the coffee; *preguntar* for the time.) What Latin root is *pedir* from, and one English cousin? (*Petere*, "to aim at" — *petition, appetite, compete.*) Next: **ayudar**, which is the same word as English *aid*.

Chapter 161

Ayudar — the Same Word as Aid

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that I help, and hear English aid inside the Spanish word.
>
> *adiutare straight through to aid, and the -di- that also gave hodie -> hoy.*

161.1 ayudar — "to help", and it is English "aid" in disguise

You can ask a question now. The next thing to ask for is a hand — and this verb is one you already own in English without knowing it.

Sounds you'll need

- `vowel-a` — a clean, open *a*: *a-yoo-DAR*.
- `r-tap` — one tap at the end, not an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ayudar ("**to help**") ← Latin **adiūtāre**, the repeating form of **adiuvāre**: **ad-** ("toward") + **iuvāre** ("to help, to delight"). To help was to move toward someone.
English borrowed that identical verb through Old French *aidier* and calls it **aid**. So *ayudar* and *aid* are not merely cousins — they are the

same word by two different roads. The family came with it:

- **aide**, and **aide-de-camp**, an officer who helps.
- **adjutant** — the officer whose whole job is assisting.
- **adjuvant** — a substance that helps another drug work.
- **coadjutor** — one who helps alongside.

The shape change is a rule, not an accident. Latin **-di-** before a vowel turned into Spanish **y**: *adiūtāre* → **ayudar**, *hodiē* → **hoy** ("today"), *podium* → *poyo*. Once you have that, the word stops looking arbitrary.

Grammar Lens: a plain -ar verb, and how to ask for a hand

Nothing breaks; the endings are the ones you started with:

person	form	meaning
yo	**ayudo**	I help
tú	**ayudas**	you help
nosotros	**ayudamos**	we help
ellos/ustedes	**ayudan**	they help

Its noun is **la ayuda** (fem.), "help" — the word on relief packages worldwide. Two sentences worth owning: ***¿Me ayudas?*** ("will you help me?" — Spanish uses the plain present where English needs *will*) and, politely, ***¿Puedo ayudarle?***

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ayudo, ayudas, ayudamos, ayudan"
- "¿Me ayudas?" — will you help me?
- "Te pregunto" then "Me ayudas" — I ask you, you help me
- "ayudar" then English "aid, adjutant, adjuvant" — one word, two roads

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces build *adiuvāre*? (**Ad-** "toward" + **iuvāre** "to help".) What everyday English word is *ayudar*, arriving by French? (**Aid**.) What sound-law turned *adiūtāre* into *ayudar*, and which other word shows it? (Latin **-di-** became Spanish **y**; *hodiē* → *hoy*.) Next: **gustar**, the verb that runs backwards.

Chapter 162

Review — Three Verbs That Behave

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use all three verbs and say what they have in common: the sentence is about the one doing it.
>
> *Three origins - tidy, reshaped, and genuinely unknown - and the shared shape about to be broken.*

162.1 Review — three verbs that behave

Nothing new here. Name the three verbs of the last three chapters: to take, to ask, to help.

What you've built

All three work the way you expect, and it is worth naming that out loud **before** the next chapter, where one does not.
In each of them, **you** are the one doing it. You take. You ask. You help. The person doing the verb is the person the sentence is about — exactly as in English, and exactly as in every verb you have met since *hablo*.
Hold on to that. It is about to be worth money.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Three origins, three very different kinds of story:

- **ayudar** is the tidy one. Latin *adiūtāre* → English **aid**. Same word, two roads, and you can still hear it.
- **preguntar** is the reshaped one — *percontārī*, to sound a depth with a pole. Asking as measuring how deep something goes.
- **tomar** is the honest gap. It has **no agreed origin at all.** The verb Latin actually handed down for "take" was *coger*, and *coger* turned coarse across much of Latin America — so an everyday word had to come from somewhere, and nobody is sure where.

Not every word has a clean story. A course that pretended otherwise would be inventing them.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the three verbs, then one sentence with each

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which one has no settled origin? (*Tomar.*) In all three, who is the sentence about? (**The one doing it**.) Next chapter: a verb where that stops being true.

Chapter 163

Gustar — the Verb Built the Other Way Round

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build a gustar sentence the way Spanish builds it, with the thing liked as the subject.
>
> *me gusta el libro is the book pleasing me, so the verb agrees with the book.*

163.1 gustar — the verb that runs backwards

Back in the introductions you learned **mucho gusto** — "much pleasure". Here is the verb that noun belongs to, assembled the opposite way round from English. It is the single thing in Spanish that trips English speakers up hardest.

Sounds you'll need

- `g-hard` — a hard *g* before *u*: *goos-TAR*.
- `s-clear` — a clean hissing *s*, never a *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gustar ← Latin **gustāre**, "**to taste**". English kept the root and stayed close to the tongue:

- **gusto** — doing something with relish, that is, with a taste for it.

- **gustatory** — of the sense of taste.
- **disgust** — *dis-* "away" + taste: what you spit back out.
- **degustation**, a tasting menu; and through French, **ragout**.

Spanish's own **el gusto** — the *gusto* of *mucho gusto* — still holds both senses: taste on the tongue, and pleasure taken in a thing. The verb followed the second: *gustar* means "**to please**".

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

English says **I** like the book: the liker is the subject. Spanish has no such sentence. It says **Me gusta el libro** — "the book is pleasing **to me**".
Everything follows from that:

- *el libro* is the **subject**, which is why the verb is *gusta*, third person.
- *me* is the person it happens **to**, not the one doing anything.

So the verb agrees with the **thing**, never with you:

what you mean	Spanish	why
I like the book	**Me gusta el libro**	one book, so *gusta*
I like books	**Me gustan los libros**	many books, so *gustan*
I like reading	**Me gusta leer**	one action, so *gusta*

To change who is pleased, change the little word in front, not the verb: **me** (to me), **te** (to you), **le** (to him, her, *usted*), **nos** (to us), **les** (to them).

> **Careful.** There is no *yo gusto el libro*. *Yo gusto* is a real sentence — it means "**I** am pleasing" — just not the one you were reaching for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Me gusta el café" then "Me gustan los libros" — the verb follows

the thing

- "Te gusta tomar café" — you like drinking coffee
- "Me gusta ayudar" — I like helping
- "gustar" then English "gusto, disgust, gustatory" — the tasting family

Before you move on

In *me gusta el libro*, what is the subject? (**El libro**.) Why is it *me gustan los libros*? (The verb agrees with *los libros*, which is plural.) What did *gustāre* mean, and name an English cousin. (**To taste**; *gusto, disgust.*) And what would *yo gusto* actually mean? (**I** am pleasing.)

Chapter 164

Synthesis — What You Like, and Who Does the Liking

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I like without translating I like word by word, and hear mucho gusto as the same word.
>
> *Liking started at the tongue; and the chapter-5 phrase turns out to be gustar's noun.*

164.1 Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking

Say "I like coffee" in Spanish. Then answer this: in that sentence, which word is the **subject**?

Grammar Lens: the sentence that will not let you be the subject

Me gusta el café. The coffee is the subject. The coffee does the pleasing. You are the one it happens *to*.
English puts you in charge: *I like coffee* — I am the subject, the coffee just sits there. Spanish reverses it.

> Two chapters ago, all three verbs were about **the one doing it**. That is why this chapter had to sit next to them.

Translate *I like* word by word and you build a sentence Spanish does

not have — which is why this is a chapter about saying an idea, not a word.

The exchange

> — ¿Te gusta el café? — Sí, **me gusta** mucho. ¿Y a ti? — A mí también. **Mucho gusto.**

That last line is a joke you can now get. *Mucho gusto* — the phrase you learned long ago for "pleased to meet you" — is the **same word**. It has always meant *much pleasure*. You have been saying *gustar*'s noun since your third conversation in this book.

What you've built

Gustar is Latin *gustāre*, **to taste** — English *gusto*, *disgust*. Liking, in Spanish, started at the tongue.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the exchange above, both parts
- it again, and as you say *me gusta*, notice that you are **not** the subject

Twice through: Until *me gusta* arrives without translating *I like* first.

Before you move on

Who is the subject of *me gusta el café*? (**El café**.) What did *gustar* mean first? (**To taste**.) And what has *mucho gusto* meant all along? (**Much pleasure** — the same word.)

Chapter 165

Hearing, Sleeping, Walking, Running

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say I hear, sleep, walk and run in Spanish, write oír's y where the spelling demands it, and break dormir's o to ue the way a boot verb does.
>
> *Run the chapter's four verbs together and sort them by what they do to their stems: correr, caminar and andar leave theirs alone, dormir breaks o to ue, oír grows a g in oigo and writes y in oyes. Then name each verb's source in turn — audīre, dormīre, Gaulish camminus, currere — and set the two words with no settled origin, andar and perro, against them.*

165.1 oír — "to hear", and the y that appears from nowhere

Say *Me gusta el café* once — the coffee is pleasing to me, and the coffee is the subject. Now a verb about the ears, and one of the most bent-out-of-shape words in the language.

Sounds you'll need

- `accent-i` — the accent on **í** keeps the vowels apart: *o-EER*, two beats.
- `y-glide` — the **y** in *oyes* is the consonant of English *yes*: *O-yes*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

oír ("**to hear**") ← Latin **audīre**, "to hear". Spanish wore it right down: the *d* between vowels dropped away and *au-* collapsed to *o-*. English never inherited it but borrowed it repeatedly, and the family keeps the *aud-* Spanish threw away: **audio**, **audible**, **audition**, **auditorium**, **audit**, **audience** — the people doing the hearing.
Then the surprise. **Obey** is Latin **oboedīre**, *ob-* ("toward") + *audīre*: obeying is literally **listening toward** someone. **Obedient** comes with it.

Why it's said this way

Spanish splits what English leaves joined. **Oír** is what your ears do whether you meant it or not. **Escuchar** is on purpose.
Escuchar has its own root: Latin **auscultāre**, "to listen to", built on *auris*, "ear". A doctor **auscultates** a chest; and when Old French wore *auscultāre* down to *escouter*, English borrowed it as **scout** — one sent out to listen. English can draw the line when it wants. Spanish makes you.

Grammar Lens: the -go yo-form, and a spelling rule

person	form
yo	**oigo**
tú	**oyes**
él/ella/usted	**oye**
nosotros	**oímos**
ellos/ustedes	**oyen**

Two separate things. The *yo*-form grows the hard **-g-** you know from *tengo*, *hago* and *digo*; *oír* joins that club.
The rest is **spelling**, not sound. Spanish will not write an unstressed **i** stranded between two vowels, so *oi-es* is impossible and the letter becomes **y**: *oyes*, *oye*, *oyen*. *Oímos* keeps its accent because there the *i* is stressed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "oigo, oyes, oye, oímos, oyen"

- "¿Me oyes?" — can you hear me?
- "Me gusta oír" — hearing is pleasing to me
- "oír" then English "audio, audience, obey"

Before you move on

Which Latin verb is behind *oír*, and what has *obey* to do with it? (**Audīre**; *oboedīre* is "to listen toward".) Why *oyes* and not *oies*? (Spanish will not leave an unstressed *i* between two vowels.) Which of *oír* and *escuchar* do you choose to do? (**Escuchar**.) And in *me gusta el café*, what is the subject? (**El café**.)

165.2 dormir — "to sleep", and the boot's other vowel

Run *oír* once more: *oigo, oyes, oye, oímos, oyen* — and remember that the **y** in *oyes* is a spelling rule, not a new sound. Now a verb whose stem cracks the way *pensar*'s did, but on a different vowel.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ue` — under stress the *o* breaks open: **duermo** = *DWER-mo*.
- `r-tap` — one soft flick of the tongue in *dormir*, nothing like an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dormir ("**to sleep**") ← Latin **dormīre**, "to sleep" — one of the rare verbs Spanish inherited almost untouched. English took the root only through French and Latin, and every borrowing still points at a bed:

- **dormitory**, and its clipped **dorm** — the room where sleeping is done.
- **dormant** — from the French participle *dormant*, "sleeping". A dormant volcano is a sleeping one.
- **dormer** — the window let into a roof, named for the

sleeping-loft behind it.

Spanish keeps its own branch: **el dormitorio** for the bedroom, and *la bella durmiente* for Sleeping Beauty.

The **dormouse** looks like the obvious member of this family, and careful dictionaries will not commit. An Anglo-Norman *dormeus*, "sleepy", is the best guess, but the trail goes cold. Treat it as likely rather than proved.

Grammar Lens: the boot again, with o→ue

person	form	stem
yo	**duermo**	broken
tú	**duermes**	broken
él/ella/usted	**duerme**	broken
nosotros	**dormimos**	plain
ellos/ustedes	**duermen**	broken

Pensar broke **e→ie** under stress. *Dormir* breaks **o→ue** under exactly the same condition, and for exactly the same reason: the stress falls on the stem in four of these forms and on the ending in *dormimos*, so only *dormimos* keeps its plain *o*.
That is the whole of the rule. Spanish has two stressed vowels that will not sit still — *e* becomes *ie*, *o* becomes *ue* — and once you can hear where the stress lands, you can predict which forms crack without memorising a list.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "duermo, duermes, duerme, dormimos, duermen"
- "pienso" then "duermo" — e to ie, o to ue, one rule
- "No duermo bien" — I don't sleep well
- "dormir" then English "dormitory, dormant, dormer" — the sleeping family

Before you move on

Which form of *dormir* keeps its plain *o*, and why? (*Dormimos* — the stress lands on the ending.) Name two English cousins of *dormīre*. (*Dormitory, dormant, dormer.*) What did *pēnsāre*, behind *pensar*, mean literally? (**To weigh**.) And what is the *yo*-form of *oír*? (**Oigo**.)

165.3 caminar — "to walk", from a word Rome borrowed from the Celts

Duermo, duermes, duerme — the *o* cracking to *ue*. Relax: the two verbs here do nothing of the kind. The interest is in where they came from.

Sounds you'll need

- `k-hard` — the *c* before *a* is a hard *k*: *ka-mi-NAR*.
- `vowel-a` — a short clean *a*, the same in every syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

caminar ("**to walk**") was built on the noun **el camino**, "the road" — and *camino* is not a Latin word at all. Latin **camminus** was a loan from **Gaulish**, the Celtic language of pre-Roman France, from a word for a step or a way. It stocked the roads of every Romance language: *camino*, Portuguese *caminho*, Italian *cammino*, French *chemin*.
Here the cousin web runs out, and that is worth saying plainly: this root reached English only inside borrowed French phrases. The Celtic layer did reach English by other doors — Latin also took Gaulish *carrus*, a wagon, behind **car** and **cargo**. *Camminus* never crossed.

> **A false friend that looks certain.** Latin also had **camīnus**, "hearth", from Greek *kaminos* — and *that* gave English **chimney**. Two nearly identical Latin words, no relation.

Grammar Lens: two plain verbs, and which to reach for

Spanish has a second everyday verb here, **andar**. Both take ordinary *-ar* endings and neither breaks its stem.

person	caminar	andar
yo	**camino**	**ando**
tú	**caminas**	**andas**
él/ella/usted	**camina**	**anda**
nosotros	**caminamos**	**andamos**
ellos/ustedes	**caminan**	**andan**

Caminar is walking as the thing you are doing. **Andar** is wider: to go about, and by extension to work at all — *no anda*, of a machine, means "it isn't running". Either serves for a walk.

Why it's said this way

Camino has a clean history. *Andar* does not. It comes down from Medieval Latin **andāre**, and where *andāre* came from is **genuinely disputed**: *ambulāre* ("to walk about") and *ambitāre* ("to go around") are both proposed and neither is proved. If *ambulāre* is right, **amble** and **ambulance** are cousins — but that "if" carries real weight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "camino, caminas, camina, caminamos, caminan"
- "ando, andas, anda, andamos, andan"
- "Camino una hora" — I walk for an hour
- "el camino" then "camino" — the road, and I walk it

Before you move on

Which language did Latin borrow *camminus* from? (**Gaulish**.) Which English word comes from the *other* Latin *camīnus*, the hearth? (**Chimney** — unrelated.) Is *andar*'s origin settled? (**No**.) Say "I walk for an hour". (*Camino una hora.*) And the *nosotros* form of *dormir*? (*Dormimos.*)

165.4 correr — "to run", and the root that runs through half of English

You can walk two ways now — *camino* and *ando*. Speed it up. This last verb of the chapter is the plainest to conjugate and the richest to trace.

Sounds you'll need

- `rolled-rr` — the double *r* is a full trill: *ko-RRER*. It is a different letter from a single *r*, and swapping them swaps words.
- `vowel-o` — a short pure *o*, no glide toward English *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

correr ("**to run**") ← Latin **currere**, "to run". English borrowed this root harder than almost any other, and the descendants have spread so far from running that they no longer look related:

- **current** — water that runs; **currency**, money running hand to hand.
- **curriculum** — a *running*, a racecourse. A course of study is a track you run.
- **courier**, a runner; **course**, **cursor**, **cursive** — writing that runs.
- **corridor** — a place for running along, by way of Italian.
- with prefixes: **occur** (*ob-*, to run up against), **recur**, **incur**, **precursor**, **excursion**.

And a cousin from the lesson before: Gaulish *carrus*, behind English **car** and **cargo**, comes from the very same Proto-Indo-European root ***kers-***, "to run". Latin took one road and Celtic another; English holds both ends.

Grammar Lens: a plain -er verb, and four verbs together

Correr breaks nothing and grows nothing: **corro, corres, corre, corremos, corren**. That makes it the clean case the chapter's others stand out against:

verb	what it does to its stem
correr	nothing — *corro, corres, corre*
caminar, **andar**	nothing — *camino, ando*
dormir	breaks *o* to *ue* under stress — *duermo*, but *dormimos*
oír	grows *-g-* in *oigo*, and writes *y* in *oyes*, *oye*, *oyen*

Only two of the four misbehave, and each misbehaves by a rule you can state.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "corro, corres, corre, corremos, corren"
- "El perro corre" — the dog runs
- "Camino, no corro" — I walk, I don't run
- "Corro el sábado" — I run on Saturday; Spanish uses the bare article where English says *on*
- "Oigo, duermo, camino, corro" — the whole chapter in four words
- "correr" then English "current, curriculum, corridor" — the running family

Before you move on

Name each verb's source in turn: *oír*, *dormir*, *caminar*, *correr*. (**Audīre**; **dormīre**; Gaulish *camminus*, by way of *el camino*; **currere**.) Which of the four leave their stems alone? (*Caminar*, *andar* and *correr*.) Say "the dog runs". (*El perro corre*.) Two words here have no settled origin — which? (*Andar*, and *perro*, whose three proposals all lack the evidence to decide between them.) And which English everyday word is a cousin of *correr* through Celtic? (**Car**.)

Chapter 166

Opening, Closing, Sitting Down, Standing Up

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I open, close, sit down and stand up in Spanish, and use the reflexive pronoun that makes sentarse and levantarse land the action back on me.

Say the chapter in one breath — abro el libro, me siento, cierro el libro, me levanto — then separate the two features it taught: sentarse is reflexive and a stem-changer, levantarse is reflexive only. Name the shared recipe behind both body-position verbs (a Latin present participle, sedēns and levāns), pick abierto out as the one irregular participle, and reach back to la mano for why the article stays feminine.

166.1 abrir — "to open", and the one part of it that misbehaves

Say *corro* and *camino* once — two verbs that gave you no trouble. This one is nearly as easy, and its one misbehaving piece is a word you will read on a shop door before you ever say it.

Sounds you'll need

- `b-soft` — between vowels the *b* barely closes the lips: *a-BREER*.
- `r-tap` — a single flick for the final *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

abrir ("**to open**") ← Latin **aperīre**, "to open, to uncover". The *p* softened to *b* between vowels on the way into Spanish — the slide that turned *sapere* into *saber* and *lupus* into *lobo*.
English took the root through two doors and does not notice they are one word:

- straight from Latin *apertūra*: **aperture**, the opening a lens makes.
- through French *ovrir* and its participle *overt*: **overt** ("out in the open") and **overture**, an opera's opening.
- **aperitif**, a drink that *opens* the appetite; Spanish, **el aperitivo**.

The cousin that is not one. *April* looks like it belongs here — the opening month. That is old folk etymology and is not accepted: the better proposals point at an Etruscan *Apru*, borrowed from Aphrodite, or at an Italic word meaning "the next one". A hook this pretty is the kind to check.

Grammar Lens: regular everywhere but the participle

In the present, *abrir* is a plain *-ir* verb, the family *escribir* belongs to: **abro, abres, abre, abrimos, abren**. Nothing breaks, nothing grows.
The **past participle** is where the irregularity lives. A regular *-ir* verb would give *abrido*. Spanish says **abierto**, straight down from Latin *apertum*, keeping the *e* that broke to *ie* under stress long ago.
You will meet that participle long before the tense it belongs to, because it is a word on doors: **ABIERTO** on the sign, **está abierto** for "it is open now". *Escribir* does the same with **escrito**. Both refuse the regular ending because both inherited a Latin participle whole.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "abro, abres, abre, abrimos, abren"
- "Abro el libro" then "Está abierto"

- "abrir" then English "aperture, overt, overture"
- "correr" then English "current, curriculum" — still there from before

Before you move on

What is the past participle of *abrir*, and what would a regular verb have given? (**Abierto**; *abrido*.) Name two English words from *aperīre*. (*Aperture, overt, overture, aperitif.*) Is *April* one? (**No** — folk etymology.) Which other verb keeps an inherited Latin participle? (*Escribir* → *escrito*.) And which Latin verb is behind *correr*? (**Currere**.)

166.2 cerrar — "to close", from the bar across the door

Abro, abres, abre — and the sign saying **ABIERTO**. Here is the sign on the other side of the day, and a verb that cracks its stem.

Sounds you'll need

- `soft-c` — *c* before *e* is soft: a *th* across most of Spain, an *s* across Latin America.
- `rolled-rr` — the double *r* is fully trilled: *se-RRAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cerrar ("**to close**") ← Late Latin **serāre**, "to bolt, to fasten", from the noun **sera**: the **bar you drop across a door**. Closing here is a physical object being put in place, not an abstraction.
Its Romance siblings kept the pressure: Italian *serrare*, French *serrer*, "to squeeze, to tighten". English holds one of that branch, **serried**, as in ranks pressed shut against each other. Reference works generally connect *sera* to Latin **serere**, "to join in a row", which would make **series** and **insert** distant relatives — usual, but not certain.

Why it's said this way

Latin had a perfectly good verb for closing: **claudere**. English is full of it — **close**, **closet**, **closure**, **clause**, **cloister**, **include**, **exclude**,

conclude, **recluse**.
Spanish let it go. For shutting a door it took *serāre* instead, and kept *claudere* only in words scholars borrowed back much later: **incluir**, **excluir**, **concluir**, **clausura**. That inversion is worth sitting with: the bigger English family belongs to the verb Spanish gave up. A cousin web maps what each language kept, and these two kept opposite halves.

Grammar Lens: e→ie, and the sign on the door

person	form
yo	**cierro**
tú	**cierras**
él/ella/usted	**cierra**
nosotros	**cerramos**
ellos/ustedes	**cierran**

Dormir broke **o→ue**. *Cerrar* breaks **e→ie** — the same boot, the other vowel, the same trigger: stress on the stem. *Cerramos* is plain because there the stress moves to the ending.
Its participle, unlike *abierto*, is regular: **cerrado**. The two signs on one door are built differently — *abierto* inherited whole from Latin, *cerrado* made by rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "cierro, cierras, cierra, cerramos, cierran"
- "Abro el libro" then "Cierro el libro"
- "ABIERTO" then "CERRADO" — the two signs
- "aperīre, aperture" then "serāre, serried" — the two doors' roots

Before you move on

What was a *sera*, and does *cerrar* come from *claudere*? (**The bar dropped across a door**; and **no** — Spanish kept *claudere* only in *incluir*, *excluir*, *concluir*.) Which form of *cerrar* keeps its plain *e*,

and why? (*Cerramos* — the stress moves to the ending, as in *dormimos*.) Which participle is irregular, *abierto* or *cerrado*? (*Abierto*.) And what did *intendere*, behind *entender*, mean literally? (**To stretch toward**.)

166.3 sentarse — "to seat oneself", which is how Spanish thinks about sitting down

Two things in hand. *Cierro* — the *e* cracking to *ie*. And *me llamo*, "I call **myself**", where the little *me* bounced the action back onto you. This verb needs both at once.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ie` — the stressed *e* breaks: **me siento** = *me SYEN-to*.
- `s-clear` — a clean hissing *s*, never a *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sentar ← Vulgar Latin ***sedentāre**, built not on the Latin verb but on its **present participle**:* sedēns, *"sitting", from **sedēre**, "to sit". Spanish made a new verb out of being in a sitting state.*
Sedēre is one of the great English suppliers, and hardly any descendant still looks like sitting: **sedentary**, **sediment**, **sedate**; **session** and **siege** (an army sitting down outside a city); **preside**, **reside**; **assess**, **obsess**, **possess**. By way of Greek *hedra*, "seat", it also gives **cathedral** and **chair**.
Then the other branch. English **sit**, **seat**, **settle**, **saddle** and **nest** come down from the very same root, ***sed-***, through Germanic rather than Latin. Neither borrowed from the other: they are siblings, exactly as *padre* and *father* are, each branch reshaping the sounds its own way.

Grammar Lens: seating someone, and seating yourself

Plain **sentar** means to seat somebody *else*. To sit down yourself, you send the action back with the pronoun that made *me llamo* "I call myself":

person	form
yo	**me siento**
tú	**te sientas**
él/ella/usted	**se sienta**
nosotros	**nos sentamos**
ellos/ustedes	**se sientan**

Two patterns run at once, and you have both. The pronoun changes with the person — *me, te, se, nos, se* — and the stem breaks *e→ie* wherever the stress lands on it, leaving *nos sentamos* plain. The pronoun stands before a conjugated verb and clips onto an infinitive, hence the name **sentarse**.

> **Two verbs, one shape.** *Me siento* is also the *yo*-form of *sentirse*, "to feel": *me siento bien* is "I feel fine". Only what follows tells them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "me siento, te sientas, se sienta, nos sentamos, se sientan"
- "me llamo" then "me siento" — the same little me, twice
- "Cierro el libro y me siento" — I close the book and sit down
- "sentarse" then English "session, sedentary, preside"

Before you move on

What does *sentarse* say literally, and which Latin form was it built on? (**To seat oneself**; the participle *sedēns*.) Are English *sit* and Latin *sedēre* parent and child, or siblings? (**Siblings** — separate branches of one root, like *father* and *padre*.) Which form keeps its plain *e*, and what was a *sera*? (*Nos sentamos*; **the bar across a door**.)

166.4 levantarse — "to raise oneself", and how Spanish says "stand"

Me siento put you in the chair, the little *me* bouncing the action back onto you. Now get out of it. The pronoun works the same way; this time the stem does not crack at all.

Sounds you'll need

- `v-b` — Spanish *v* and *b* are one sound: *le-ban-TAR*.
- `nasal-n` — a clean *n* before the *t*, not swallowed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

levantar ← Vulgar Latin ***levantāre**, from **levāns**, the present participle of **levāre**, "to raise, to lighten" — itself from **levis**, "light, not heavy".*
Notice the shape: a Latin **present participle**, made into a new verb — the identical recipe that gave *sentar* from *sedēns*. Spanish built both of its body-position verbs out of a word for the state rather than the act.
Levāre is everywhere in English: **lever**, **elevate**, **elevator** for raising; **levity**, **levitate**, **alleviate**, **relieve** for lightening; **leaven**, what raises the bread, and **levy**, a tax *raised*. And **the Levant**, from French *levant*, "rising": from western Europe it lay where the sun came up. English **light**, the opposite of heavy, is the Germanic cousin of *levis*, as *sit* is of *sedēre*.

Grammar Lens: raising a thing, raising yourself, standing still

Levantar on its own raises something else. **Levantarse** raises *you*:

Spanish	what it means
Levanto la mano	I raise my hand
Levanto la cabeza	I lift my head
Me levanto	I get up, I stand up

The endings are ordinary *-ar* throughout — **me levanto, te levantas, se levanta, nos levantamos, se levantan** — and nothing breaks. So the chapter has now shown its two features apart: *sentarse* is reflexive **and** a stem-changer; *levantarse* is reflexive **only**.

For standing as a *state*, Spanish uses no verb. It says **estar de pie** — "to be on foot", *el pie* being the foot. English's single "stand" splits in two: *me levanto* for getting up, *estoy de pie* for being up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "me levanto, te levantas, se levanta, nos levantamos, se levantan"
- "Levanto la mano" then "Levanto la cabeza" then "Me levanto"
- "Estoy de pie" — I am standing
- "Abro el libro, me siento, cierro el libro, me levanto"
- "levantar" then English "lever, elevate, Levant"

Before you move on

Say the chapter's four verbs, then say how you are standing. (*Abro, cierro, me siento, me levanto*; *estoy de pie.*) What do *sentar* and *levantar* share in their making, and which also breaks its stem? (Both from a Latin **present participle**, *sedēns* and *levāns*; *sentarse* breaks *e→ie.*) Name the two roots on that door, and which participle is irregular. (**Aperīre** and **serāre** — *not claudere*; *abierto.*) Why *la* mano? (*Manus* was feminine in Latin.)

166.5 Review — down, up, and away

"I sit down." (*Me siento.*) "I get up." (*Me levanto.*)

What you've built

Four verbs, and between them a whole body's worth of positions. *Me siento* puts you down. *Me levanto* brings you up. And once you are up, there is a phrase for staying there: **de pie** — on foot, standing. Notice that *de pie* is not a verb at all. Spanish says the posture with a noun and a preposition where English reaches for *standing.*

Why it's said this way

Sentarse and *levantarse* look unrelated. They were made by the same move.

Latin had *sedēre*, "to sit," and its participle *sedēns*, "sitting." Someone built a new verb straight off that participle — *sedentāre* — and Spanish inherited it as *sentar*. Then Latin had *levāre*, "to raise," participle *levāns*, and the same thing happened: *levantāre*, Spanish *levantar*.

Two verbs, one recipe: take the part of the verb that means *doing it right now*, and build a fresh verb on top.

Now walk, and the tidiness ends. *Caminar* comes off *el camino*, which Latin took from Gaulish — a clean, traceable borrowing. *Andar* comes from Medieval Latin *andāre*, and where *andāre* came from is **genuinely disputed**. Two candidates, neither proved.

So these four sit at opposite ends of what can be known. Two you can take apart on the page; one you can trace to the people it was borrowed from; one nobody has settled.

Your turn

- *Say it: me siento · me levanto · de pie · camino · ando*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What did Latin build *sentar* and *levantar* out of? (**A participle** — *sedēns* and *levāns*.) What does *de pie* mean literally? (**On foot**.) Which of the four verbs has no agreed origin? (***Andar***.)

Chapter 167

Telling What Happened

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can tell a short connected story about something that happened — ordering the events with luego, giving a reason with porque, and choosing the imperfect for the scene and the preterite for the events.
>
> *Tell a four-sentence story out loud: Llovía. Me levanté, luego bebí café. No corrí, porque llovía mucho. Me senté y leí. Every word in it has been taught in this book, and the two pasts divide the work between scene and event.*

167.1 luego — a word you already have, doing a job you have not seen it do

Nothing new to learn here — you have said **luego** every time you said *hasta luego*. What is new is that it can stand alone, between two events, and put them in order.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ue` — *ue* is one glide, not two syllables.
- `g-soft-gw` — between vowels the *g* softens; **luego** is *LWEH-gho*, not the hard stop English puts in *go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You already know where it comes from: Latin **locō**, the ablative of ***locus***, "place" — "in that place", a word about *where* that slid into a word about *when*. That is why *hasta luego* is "until later".
What you have not been shown is how much else *locus* is holding up. It gives **local**, **locate**, **location**, **locus**, **allocate**, **dislocate**. And through French *lieu*, "place", it gives **lieutenant** — literally the officer *holding the place* of another.

> **A leftover worth knowing. *Desde luego*** means "of course". It was built on an older sense of *luego*, "**immediately**", so its literal force was nearer "from this moment on". The bare word has since drifted to "later"; the phrase kept the old sense.

Grammar Lens: luego between two events

Out of the farewell, *luego* is not glued to a verb. It marks the join between two events and sits at the front of the second:

Me siento. **Luego** leo.	I sit down. **Then** I read.
Bebo café y **luego** escribo.	I drink coffee and **then** I write.
Me levanto **y luego** corro.	I get up **and then** I run.

Two events, in order, with one word doing the ordering — and it is a word you have been saying since chapter five.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "hasta luego" then just "luego" — same word, standing alone
- "Me siento. Luego leo."
- "Me levanto y luego corro."
- "luego" then English "local, locate, lieutenant"

Before you move on

What job does *luego* do here that it does not do in *hasta luego*? (It **joins two events in order**, instead of sitting inside a fixed farewell.) Which English officer's title hides the same *locus*? (**Lieutenant** — the one holding another's place.) Which older sense of *luego* is frozen inside *desde luego*? (**Immediately** — not "later".)

167.2 porque — "because", and the reason a sequence turns into a story

With *luego* you can put two events in order. But order is not yet a story. *I sat down, then I read* tells nobody **why**. One more word closes that gap, and it is two words wearing a single coat.

Sounds you'll need

- `k-hard` — *qu* before *e* is a plain *k*; the *u* is silent. **porque** = *POR-keh.*
- `r-tap` — a single flick of the tongue, not the rolled *rr*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

porque = **por** + **que**, fused.
por descends from Latin ***prō***, "for, in front of, on behalf of" — the same *prō* standing at the front of **pro**vide, **pro**ceed, **pro**tect, **pro**pose, and surviving whole in the English phrase *quid* ***pro*** *quo*.
que descends from Latin ***quid***, "what" — and then quietly took over every job Latin had given ***quod***, without taking its form.
And this is the good part. That Latin *qu-* is one branch of the Proto-Indo-European interrogative root ****k^{w}o-***. The other branch went into Germanic, where **k^{w}-* softened to *hw-* — Grimm's Law turning a stop into a breath — and came out as English **who**, **what**, **when**, **where**, **why**.
So Spanish *que* and English *what* are not borrowed from one another. They are **siblings** — the same ancient question-word, walked down two different roads. *Quid pro quo* puts both Latin halves of *porque* side by side in an English sentence.

Grammar Lens: porque, por qué, el porqué

Three spellings, three jobs, and they are genuinely distinct in writing:

written	stress	job
porque	one word, no accent	**because** — gives the reason
por qué	two words, accent on *qué*	**why** — asks for the reason
el porqué	one word, accent, with *el*	**the reason** — a noun

*¿**Por qué** te levantas?* — **Why** do you get up? *Me levanto **porque** corro.* — I get up **because** I run. *No entiendo **el porqué**.* — I don't understand **the reason**.

The accent is not decoration. It marks *qué* as the questioning one, exactly as it does on other question words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "porque" — *POR-keh*, silent *u*
- "Me siento porque leo." — I sit down because I read.
- "Me levanto y luego corro, porque hace sol."
- the three shapes — "porque, por qué, el porqué"

Before you move on

What two Latin words are fused inside *porque*? (***prō*** and ***quid***.) Are Spanish *que* and English *what* parent and child, or siblings? (**Siblings** — Latin *qu-* and Germanic *wh-* from one root, ****k^{w}o-***.) Which of the three spellings asks a question? (***Por qué*** — two words, accent on *qué*.)

167.3 Review — the accent is doing the work

"I get up because I run." (*Me levanto porque corro.*)

What you've built

Three spellings that a listener cannot tell apart, and a reader always can.

written	job
porque	**because** — gives the reason
por qué	**why** — asks for it
el porqué	**the reason** — a thing you can own

*¿**Por qué** te levantas? — Me levanto **porque** corro. — No entiendo **el porqué**.*
Ask, answer, and then name the answer.

Why it's said this way

The accent on *qué* is not there to look nice, and it is not there at random. It is the same mark that sits on every question word: *qué*, *quién*, *dónde*, *cuándo*, *cómo*. Spanish uses one mark, consistently, for one job — **this word is the one doing the asking**.
So *por qué* is two words because it is literally *for what*, with the accent marking *what* as the question. And *porque*, fused into one word with no accent, has nothing left to ask with.
El porqué is the odd one, and it is odd in a way that makes sense: put *el* in front of anything in Spanish and it becomes a thing. It keeps the accent because the question word is still inside it — the reason is, after all, the answer to a *why*.

Your turn

- *Say it: ¿por qué? · porque · el porqué*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which one carries an accent and a space? (***Por qué*** — the one that asks.) What job does the accent do everywhere in Spanish? (**Marks the word that does the asking**.) Which one takes *el*? (***El porqué***, the reason itself.)

167.4 llovía / llovió — the same rain, told two ways

You already have both past tenses. The imperfect — *hablaba*, *comía* — came in chapter sixteen, with its three irregulars. Nothing here is a new form. What is new is **which one to reach for**, and that turns out to be the whole trick of telling a story.

Sounds you'll need

- `double-l-y` — *ll* is a *y* glide: **llovía** = *yo-VEE-a*.
- `accent-i` — the accent splits the vowels: *llo-VÍ-a*, three beats.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The name is the lesson, and it is worth having.
Imperfecto is Latin ***imperfectus***: ***in-*** ("not") plus ***perfectus***, "carried all the way through" — itself ***per-*** ("through") plus ***facere*** ("to do, to make"). That *facere* is everywhere in English: **fact**, **factory**, **effect**, **manufacture**, and **perfect** itself, which still means *finished through*.
So the imperfect is the **not-carried-through** tense. Not unfinished in quality — unfinished in *time*. It shows an action still running, with no edge on it. That is not a label bolted on afterwards; it is a description of the job.

Grammar Lens: the scene and the events

Take one fact — it rained — and watch the tense decide what *kind* of fact it is:

Llovía.	It was raining. *(no edge — the weather that day)*
Llovió.	It rained. *(edged — a thing that happened)*

Neither is more correct. They answer different questions. A told story needs both, in a division of labour that never varies:

> The **imperfect paints the scene** — what was going on, what things were like. The **preterite drops the events**

into it — what then happened.

Llovía. Luego me levanté. — It was raining *(scene)*. Then I got up *(event)*.
English has no separate form for this, which is the only reason it feels hard. English leans on *was -ing* and *used to* and lets context carry the rest. Spanish decided it once, in the ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — "llovía" then "llovió"
- scene, then event — "Llovía. Luego me levanté."
- "No corrí, porque llovía." — the reason is a scene, the running an event
- "Comía pan porque llovía."

Before you move on

What does *imperfectus* literally say, and which English word shares its second half? (**Not carried through**; **perfect** — and *fact*, *factory*.) In a story, which tense paints the background and which drops in the events? (**Imperfect** paints; **preterite** drops in.) Which of *llovía* and *llovió* has an edge on it? (***Llovió*** — a thing that happened.)

167.5 contar — to tell a story, which is also to count it up

Three pieces are in your hands: *luego* to order events, *porque* to explain them, the imperfect to hold the background still. This lesson adds no fourth piece — it puts the three together, under the verb that names the act.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ue` — the stem breaks under stress: **cuento** = *KWEN-to*, but **contamos** stays plain.
- `k-hard` — *c* before *o* is a hard *k*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

contar means **to count** — and **to tell a story**. One verb, both jobs, and not a pun.

It descends from Latin ***computāre***, "to reckon up": ***com-*** ("together") plus ***putāre***, which meant "to prune", then "to settle an account", then simply "to reckon". *Putāre* gives **amputate**, **dispute**, **deputy**; *computāre* gives **count**, **compute**, **account**.

English carries the same double sense — to **recount** an event, to give an **account** of yourself — but those are the very same word, borrowed through Old French from *computāre*. Spanish's relatives, not an independent echo.

The independent echo is **tell**: Germanic, unrelated, and it *also* once meant "to count" — hence a bank **teller**, and *all told*. Two unrelated languages, one thought: **a story is a reckoning-up of events in order.**

Grammar Lens: the backbone of a told story

Contar breaks *o* to *ue* under stress:

person	form
yo	**cuento**
tú	**cuentas**
él/ella/usted	**cuenta**
nosotros	**contamos**
ellos/ustedes	**cuentan**

Here is the shape of a told story:

> **Llovía**. Me **levanté**, **luego bebí** café. No **corrí**, **porque llovía** mucho. Me **senté** y **leí**.
>
> *It was raining. I got up, then I drank coffee. I didn't run, because it was raining hard. I sat down and read.*

Watch the two pasts divide the work. ***Llovía*** — imperfect, holding the

scene still. ***Me levanté, bebí, me senté, leí*** — preterite, dropping events in. *Luego* orders them; *porque* explains one.
That is a narration, and every word in it is one this book has taught you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "cuento, cuentas, cuenta, contamos, cuentan"
- "Cuento hasta cinco." — I count to five. Same verb.
- the scene, then the event — "Llovía. Luego me levanté."
- the whole thing — "Llovía. Me levanté, luego bebí café. No corrí, porque llovía mucho."
- "contar" then English "count, account, recount, teller"

Before you move on

Contar does two jobs — which two, and what Latin verb explains both? (**Count** and **tell**; ***computāre***, "to reckon up".) Which English word carries the same double sense? (**Recount** — or *an account*; and *tell* itself, as in a bank *teller*.) In your story, which tense held the rain and which one poured the coffee? (**Imperfect** *llovía*; **preterite** *bebí*.) Name the two joining words you used. (***Luego*** for order, ***porque*** for reason.)

Chapter 168

Traer — Bringing, and Latin for Dragging

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I bring, and choose traer over llevar by where I am standing.
>
> *trahere, to drag - the root under tractor, attract and abstract.*

168.1 traer — "to bring", and the direction baked into it

Me levanto, and now *estoy de pie*. Up, and carrying something. The verb for that has a direction inside it that English leaves open.

Sounds you'll need

- `r-tap` — one flick of the tongue: *tra-ER*, two beats.
- `g-hard` — the *g* of *traigo* is hard, as in English *go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

traer ("**to bring**") ← Latin **trahere**, "**to drag, to pull**". Bringing started out as hauling.
Latin built a second stem, *tract-*, and English helped itself to both: **tractor**, **traction**, **attract**, **contract**, **subtract**, **extract**, **distract**,

retract — and **abstract**, *abs-* + *trahere*, something "dragged away" from anything particular.
Then the worn-down half, through French: **trace**, **train** (what is dragged along behind), **trail**, **portray** ← *prōtrahere*, "to draw forth", and **retreat** ← *retrahere*, "to draw back".

Grammar Lens: the hard g, for the second time

person	form
yo	**traigo**
tú	**traes**
él/ella/usted	**trae**
nosotros	**traemos**
ellos/ustedes	**traen**

Oír grew a hard **-g-** in *oigo* and nowhere else in its present. *Traer* does the identical thing: **traigo**, and then four ordinary *-er* endings. One club, two members so far, and neither one announces itself.

Why it's said this way

English lets one verb wander: *bring me the bread*, *bring it to the café* — same word, opposite journeys. Spanish will not.
Traer moves a thing **toward you**. **Llevar** moves it **away**. *Traigo el pan* is the bread arriving here; *llevo el pan* is the bread leaving with me. You choose by where you are standing, never by what you are carrying.
And **llevar** ← Latin **levāre**, "to raise" — the verb already behind *levantarse*. To carry a load was first to lift it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "traigo, traes, trae, traemos, traen"
- "Traigo el pan" then "Llevo el pan" — here, then away
- "oigo" then "traigo" — the same hard g
- "traer" then English "tractor, attract, abstract"

Before you move on

Which way does *traer* carry a thing, and which verb goes the other way? (**Toward you**; *llevar*.) What did *trahere* mean, and name two English words from it. (**To drag**; *tractor, attract, abstract, retreat*.) Which form of *traer* misbehaves, and which verb showed you that same misbehaviour first? (**Traigo**; *oigo*.) And say you are standing. (*Estoy de pie*.)

Chapter 169

Conseguir — Getting Is Following Until You Have It

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I get, and make the e-to-i stem change.
>
> *consequi, to follow after - the root of sequence and consequence.*

169.1 conseguir — "to get", by following a thing until you have it

Traigo carries a thing that is already yours. *Coger* grabs what is in front of you. This verb is for the getting that took some work.

Sounds you'll need

- `g-hard` — the *gu* in *conseguir* is one hard *g*; the *u* is silent.
- `s-clear` — a clean hissing *s*: *con-se-GEER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

conseguir ("**to get, to obtain, to manage to**") ← Latin **cōnsequī**: *com-* ("along with") + **sequī**, "**to follow**". You got a thing by following it until it was yours.
Sequī is one of Latin's great English suppliers: **sequence**, **sequel**, **consequence**, **subsequent**, **consecutive**; **second**, from *secundus*,

"the one following"; **execute** and **prosecute**; **obsequious**, following someone about; and through French, **pursue**, **ensue** and **suit**. Spanish also keeps the formal partner **obtener** ← *obtinēre*, "to hold onto" — English **obtain**. It behaves exactly like *tener*, so its *yo*-form is *obtengo*. *Conseguir* is the everyday one.

Grammar Lens: the third crack, and a silent u that leaves

person	form
yo	**consigo**
tú	**consigues**
él/ella/usted	**consigue**
nosotros	**conseguimos**
ellos/ustedes	**consiguen**

You have met *dormir* breaking **o→ue** and *pido* quietly breaking **e→i**. Here is that third pattern in full: stress on the stem turns *e* into *i*, and *conseguimos* stays plain because the stress moved to the ending.
Now the spelling. Spanish writes *gu* only to keep a *g* hard in front of *e* and *i*. Once the *e* becomes *i*, there is nothing in front to guard against, so the *u* has no job and goes: **consigo**, not *consiguo*. Two changes, one form, and only one of them is a sound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "consigo, consigues, consigue, conseguimos, consiguen"
- "Traigo el café" then "Consigo el café" — carried, then obtained
- "sequī, sequence, second" then "conseguir"

Before you move on

What did *sequī* mean, and name two English words from it. (**To follow**; *sequence, second, consequence, pursue.*) Why is it *consigo* and not *consiguo*? (The *u* only guards a hard *g* before *e* and *i*.) Name the three stem cracks you now have, with a verb for each. (*Cerrar* **e→ie**, *dormir* **o→ue**, *conseguir* **e→i**.) And which Latin verb is behind *traer*? (**Trahere**.)

Chapter 170

Jugar — Playing Was Joking

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I play, with the only u-to-ue verb in Spanish.
>
> *iocari, to joke - and Latin's own play-verb ludere left Spanish entirely.*

170.1 jugar — "to play", and the only verb of its kind

Consigo cracked its *e* to *i*. Here is a verb that cracks a vowel no other verb in Spanish cracks — and it started life as a joke.

Sounds you'll need

- `j-jota` — the *j* is scraped at the back of the throat: *khoo-GAR*.
- `diphthong-ue` — *juego* is three beats, *KHWE-go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jugar ("**to play**") ← Latin **iocārī**, "**to joke, to jest**", built on the noun **iocus**, "a joke". Playing and joking were one word, and Spanish kept the joking one for both.
English holds *iocus* in several shapes: **joke**; through French **jocular**; **juggler**, from *ioculātor*, an entertainer; and **jeopardy**, from Old French *jeu parti*, "an evenly divided game" — a position so balanced that either side might lose. The Spanish family stays close: **el juego**, a

game; **el juguete**, a toy.

Why it's said this way

Latin's ordinary word for playing was **lūdere**, and Spanish dropped it exactly as it dropped *claudere* for shutting doors. English kept the whole family instead: **illusion**, **allude**, **elude**, **delude**, **collude**, **prelude**, **interlude**, **ludicrous**.
Claudere and *lūdere* tell one story: the large English family belongs to the Latin verb Spanish walked away from.

Grammar Lens: the fourth crack, with one member

person	form
yo	**juego**
tú	**juegas**
él/ella/usted	**juega**
nosotros	**jugamos**
ellos/ustedes	**juegan**

Dormir breaks **o→ue**. *Jugar* breaks **u→ue**, and it is the **only verb in Spanish that does**: the *o* of *iocārī* had already slid irregularly to *u*, so the crack landed on a vowel no other verb offers. *Jugamos* stays plain, because the stress moves to the ending.
One more habit: Spanish plays **at** a thing rather than simply playing it. *El fútbol* is football, and you say *juego* ***al*** *fútbol*, with *a* + *el* fused into *al*. With a companion rather than a game it is *con*: *juego con el perro*, I play with the dog.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "juego, juegas, juega, jugamos, juegan"
- "Juego con el perro"
- "duermo" then "juego" — o to ue, then u to ue
- "iocus, joke, jocular, juggler"

Before you move on

What did *iocārī* mean, and which English words carry it? (**To joke**; *joke, jocular, juggler, jeopardy.*) What is unusual about *juego* among Spanish verbs? (**U→ue**, and no other verb does it.) Which two Latin verbs did Spanish drop while English kept their families? (*Claudere* and *lūdere.*) And which vowel does *conseguir* break? (**E to i**.)

Chapter 171

Conocer — Coming to Know

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say who and what I am acquainted with, and choose conocer over saber.
>
> *cognoscere, whose -sc- means BEGIN to know; English know is its Germanic sibling.*

171.1 conocer — "to meet", because knowing has a first moment

Juego — the one *u→ue* in the language. Now the chapter's last verb, and its oddity is not in the vowel but in what the word means.

Sounds you'll need

- `soft-c` — *conoces* has a soft second *c*: a *th* in Spain, an *s* elsewhere.
- `k-hard` — but *conozco* is *ko-NOTH-ko*, soft then hard, back to back.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

conocer ← Latin **cognōscere**, *com-* + *(g)nōscere*. Its *-sc-* is Latin's **"begin to" marker**, so *nōscere* was never "to know" — it was "**to come to know**". Latin said *nōvī*, "I have come to know", for actually knowing a thing.

Spanish built its verb from the *beginning* half. That is the whole lesson: *conocer a alguien* is **to meet** someone, and Spanish puts a small **a** before a person who is the object — *conozco a María*.
The root fills English: **cognition**, **recognize**, **incognito**, and through French **notice**, **notion**, **notorious** and **noble**, "the knowable one". English **know** and **ken** are its Germanic siblings — the same standing that *padre* has beside English *father*, neither one borrowed from the other.

Grammar Lens: conocer and saber

what you know	verb
a person, a city, a book	**conocer**
a fact, or how to do something	**saber**

English says *know* for both. Spanish will not: **conocer** is being **acquainted** — you have met the thing. **Saber** is having the information. *Conozco Madrid* means I have been there; *sé dónde está* means I have the fact.
The *yo*-form keeps a hard cluster the rest lost: **conozco, conoces, conoce, conocemos, conocen**. Every *-cer* verb after a vowel does the same, and it is a third kind of odd *yo*-form beside *traigo* and *oigo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "conozco, conoces, conoce, conocemos, conocen"
- "Conozco a María" then "Conozco Madrid"
- "traigo, consigo, juego, conozco" — the chapter's four *yo*-forms
- "padre, father" then "conocer, know" — siblings, not borrowings

Before you move on

Say the chapter's four verbs in the *yo*, then say what each one does to itself. (*Traigo* grows a hard *g*; *consigo* breaks *e*→*i* and loses a silent *u*; *juego* breaks *u*→*ue*, alone in the language; *conozco* keeps a hard cluster.) Name their four Latin roots and what each meant. (**Trahere** to drag, **cōnsequī** to follow, **iocārī** to joke, **cognōscere**

to begin to know.) Which verb do you use for a person, and which for a fact? (*Conocer*; *saber*.) And which of the four moves a thing toward you? (*Traer* — *llevar* goes away.)

Chapter 172

Review — All Four Stem Changes

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name all four stem-change patterns and the single verb that owns one of them.
>
> *The system closes at four - and u-to-ue has exactly one member.*

172.1 Review — the four stem changes, all of them

Nothing new in this chapter. Say a verb whose stem breaks under stress — any one you have met.

What you've built

Something finished in the last two chapters and it is worth stopping for. Spanish has **four** stem-change patterns. Not five, not a dozen — four. You met the first two long ago with *querer* and *poder*, and the last two in the chapters you have just finished. That is the whole system, and you now hold all of it:

the change	the verb that taught it	what breaks
e → ie	*querer*	→ *quiero*
o → ue	*poder*	→ *puedo*
e → i	*conseguir*	→ *consigo*
u → ue	*jugar*	→ *juego*

This table is allowed here because every row in it is something you can

already do. It is a picture of the ground you hold, not a list to memorise.

Grammar Lens: the pattern with one member

The fourth row is strange, and worth knowing precisely.
u → ue happens in exactly one verb in the entire language: *jugar*.
Not "mostly one." One. Every other Spanish verb with a *u* in its stem leaves it alone. So you are not learning a pattern here so much as a single fact with a pattern's shape — which is easier, not harder, and is the kind of thing a course should tell you instead of letting you brace for more.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- one verb from each of the four rows
- the four changes themselves, as sounds — *e-ie, o-ue, e-i, u-ue*

Twice through: Until naming the pattern is faster than working it out.

Before you move on

How many stem-change patterns are there? (**Four** — and that is all of them.) Which one has a single member? (**u → ue**, only *jugar*.) Next chapter is not about forms at all — it is about three places where English gives you one word and Spanish makes you choose.

Chapter 173

Synthesis — The Choices English Never Makes You Make

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose correctly between three verb pairs where English offers only one word.

preguntar/pedir, traer/llevar, conocer/saber - the decision carries the meaning.

173.1 Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make

Nothing new here. Two verbs to say aloud first: *traer*, *conocer*.

Grammar Lens: one English word, two Spanish verbs

Three times now you have met a pair of verbs where English makes do with one. They arrived chapters apart and have never been put side by side:

English gives you	Spanish makes you choose	the question you must answer
to ask	*preguntar* · *pedir*	asking a **question**, or asking **for a thing**?
to bring / take	*traer* · *llevar*	toward the speaker, or away?
to know	*conocer* · *saber*	a **person or place**, or a **fact**?

None of these is a vocabulary problem. In each one, the word is easy and the **decision** is the work — and the decision is information English speakers are simply never required to supply.

What you've built

When you pick *traer* over *llevar*, you have told your listener **where you are standing**. When you pick *conocer* over *saber*, you have told them whether you have *met* the thing or only heard of it. The grammar is carrying meaning that English would need a whole clause to add. You are not translating any more. You are choosing.

The exchange

> — ¿**Conoces** Madrid? — Sí, **conozco** Madrid. Pero no **sé** dónde está el café.

Two "knows" in two lines, and not interchangeable. The first is acquaintance — *I have been there.* The second is a fact. English uses **know** for both and loses the difference.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the exchange above, both parts

Twice through: Until the choice happens before you notice making it.

Before you move on

What does choosing *traer* tell your listener? (**Where you are standing.**) What does choosing *conocer* tell them? (That you have **met** it, not just heard of it.) And which of the three pairs did you

learn first? (*Preguntar* and *pedir* — long before the other two.)

Chapter 174

Waiting, Answering, Buying

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say I wait, answer and buy in Spanish — three verbs whose endings never surprise me — and I know that esperar alone carries wait, hope and expect, so context does the work English hands to three separate verbs.
>
> *Run espero, contesto and compro — three verbs that break nothing, whose whole difficulty is meaning — and give each root and its sense: spērāre to hope, contestārī to call witnesses, comparāre to procure. Refuse the lookalike: English compare descends from a different Latin comparāre built on compār, so it is not a relative. Then buy — compro el pan, el vino y un café, por favor — and reach back for what pānis gave compañero, which English words vīnum reached, why café is masculine, and what por favor says word for word.*

174.1 esperar — one verb for waiting, hoping and expecting

Four verbs that each did something odd to themselves — *juego* the strangest of them. Here is one that does nothing odd at all, and is still the hardest word in these two chapters.

Sounds you'll need

- `st-no-e` — the *e-* is a run-up: *es-pe-RAR*, never *spe-*.
- `r-tap` — one flick for the *r* in the middle.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

esperar ← Latin **spērāre**, "**to hope**", from **spēs**, "hope". That front *e-* is the same run-up that turned *scrībere* into *escribir* and *studēre* into *estudiar*: Spanish will not start a word with *s* plus a consonant. English took the root by its negative: **despair** ← **dēspērāre**, *dē-* + *spērāre* — literally **to un-hope** — and with it **desperate**, and **desperado**, which English shaped from Spanish *desesperado*.
Prosper is traditionally read as *prō* + *spēs*, "according to one's hope", though that reading is the traditional one rather than a settled one.
Spanish keeps the hope in plain sight: **la esperanza**. So does **Esperanto** — its inventor published as *Doktoro Esperanto*, "Doctor One-Who-Hopes".

Grammar Lens: three English verbs, one Spanish word

Spanish	what it means
Espero a María	I am **waiting** for María
Espero el pan	I am **expecting** the bread
Espero que sí	I **hope** so

One verb, three English words, and nothing in the Spanish tells them apart. Context does all of it, and a learner has to stop translating and start reading the situation. *Hope* and *expect* were never far from waiting: to wait for a thing is to think it is coming.
Note the small **a** before a person, the same one that stands in *conozco a María*. And after three chapters of cracking stems, *esperar* is perfectly regular: **espero, esperas, espera, esperamos, esperan**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "espero, esperas, espera, esperamos, esperan"
- "Espero a María" then "Espero el pan" then "Espero que sí"
- "spērāre, esperanza" then English "despair, desperate"

Before you move on

Give the three English verbs *esperar* covers. (**Wait**, **hope**, **expect**.) What does *dēspērāre* take apart into? (*Dē-* + *spērāre*, **to un-hope**.) Name two other Spanish verbs whose *e-* is a run-up, with their Latin roots. (*Escribir* ← *scrībere*, *estudiar* ← *studēre*.) Would you use *conocer* or *saber* for a city? (*Conocer*.) And what did the *-sc-* inside *cognōscere* mark? (**Beginning** — to *come* to know.)

174.2 contestar — "to answer", from a Roman courtroom

Pregunto pushes the pole down to sound the water. *Espero* waits. Now the other half of a conversation — and a word that began as an oath.

Sounds you'll need

- `s-clear` — a clean *s* in the middle: *con-tes-TAR*.
- `stress-final` — the beat lands on the last syllable, with no written accent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

contestar ("**to answer**") ← Latin **contestārī**, "**to call witnesses**": *com-* + *testārī*, from **testis**, "a witness". In Roman law, *contestārī lītem* was the formal opening of a lawsuit — both sides calling their witnesses so the argument could begin.
From that one act the two languages walked in opposite directions. **English kept the fight**: to *contest* a thing is to dispute it. **Spanish kept the reply** — first "say back what the other side said", then simply *answer*.
The *testis* family is shared: **testify**, **testimony**, **testament**, **attest**, **protest**, **detest**.

Grammar Lens: contestar and responder

Spanish has a second answering verb, and it is built on a different promise.
responder ← Latin **respondēre**, *re-* + **spondēre**, "to pledge

solemnly". Answering is pledging *back*. English holds that whole branch: **respond**, **response**, **responsible**, **sponsor**, and **spouse**, from *spōnsus*, "one who has been pledged".

verb	**where it lives**
contestar	the everyday one: a question, the phone, a letter
responder	weightier — responding *to* something

Both are regular, one *-ar* and one *-er*: **contesto, contestas, contesta, contestamos, contestan**; **respondo, respondes, responde**. The noun is the odd part: the answer is **la respuesta**, borrowed from *responder*, never from *contestar*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "contesto, contestas, contesta, contestamos, contestan"
- "Te pregunto la hora y me contestas"
- "testis, testify, contest" then "contestar"

Before you move on

What did *contestārī* mean literally, and what did English make of it? (**To call witnesses**; *contest.*) What does *respondēre* take apart into? (*Re-* + *spondēre*, **to pledge back**.) Which verb asks for information and which asks for a thing? (*Preguntar*; *pedir.*) And name the three English verbs inside *esperar*. (**Wait, hope, expect**.)

174.3 comprar — "to buy", and a cousin that is not one

You can ask, answer and wait. Now pay for the bread, with a verb whose obvious English relative turns out to be a stranger.

Sounds you'll need

- `pr-cluster` — *-pr-* is one beat: *kom-PRAR*, never *kom-pe-rar*.
- `vowel-o` — a short pure *o*, with no glide toward *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comprar ("**to buy**") ← Latin **comparāre**: *com-* + **parāre**, "**to make ready, to furnish, to procure**". Latin already used it for buying — you procured a thing — and the middle syllable wore away, *comparāre* to *comprar*.
Parāre stocked English well: **prepare**, **repair**, **apparatus**, **apparel**, **separate**, **parade**, and **emperor**, from *imperāre*, "to give orders". Spanish keeps *preparar*, and *parar*, "to stop".
That *com-* is the same one already inside *compañero* — "the one you share bread with" — and inside *conseguir*, *conocer* and *contestar*.

Why it's said this way

English **compare** looks like the obvious relative. It is not one.
Latin had **two** verbs spelled *comparāre*. One is *com-* + *parāre*, "procure", and Spanish *comprar* comes from it. The other is built on **compār**, "equal, matched", and means "to set side by side" — that is the one English *compare* comes from. Two different words that fell together in spelling.
Comprender is a stranger too: it is *comprehendere*, "to seize together". Same prefix, unrelated second halves. A resemblance is a question, never an answer.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "compro, compras, compra, compramos, compran"
- "Compro el pan y el vino"
- "Un café, por favor"
- "parāre, prepare, repair" then "comprar"

Before you move on

Run the chapter: *espero*, *contesto*, *compro* — three verbs that break nothing, whose difficulty is meaning. Give each root and what it meant. (**Spērāre** to hope, **contestārī** to call witnesses, **comparāre** to procure.) Is English *compare* a relative of *comprar*? (**No** — a different Latin *comparāre*, built on *compār*, "equal".) Now buy: *compro el pan, el vino y un café, por favor* — then say what *pānis* gave *compañero*, which English words *vīnum* reached, why *café* is masculine, and what *por favor* is word for word. (**One who shares bread**; *wine, vine, vinegar*; *café* arrived as a masculine loan out of Arabic *qahwa*; "for a favour".) And which verb gets a thing by following it? (*Conseguir*.)

Chapter 175

Saying Why

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give a reason for what I think and what I plan — stating an opinion with creo que, running forward to its consequence with así que, and naming an obligation with debo.
>
> *Answer ¿Por qué no corres? in four moves — Creo que llueve. No corro porque llueve, así que leo. Debo estudiar. Opinion, cause, consequence, obligation, each with its own word, and every word in it taught by this book.*

175.1 creer — to put your heart somewhere

You have **pensar** — to think, and underneath it *pēnsāre*, "to weigh". Spanish has a second verb for the inside of your head, and it does a different job. Where *pensar* weighs, this one commits.

Sounds you'll need

- `hiatus-ee` — the two *e*'s do not merge: **creer** = *kreh-EHR*, two beats.
- `r-tap` — a single flick, not the rolled *rr*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

creer = "to believe", and in everyday use "to think" in the sense of *hold an opinion*.

It comes from Latin ***crēdere***, "to entrust, to believe" — and *crēdere* is a compound so old that Latin had already forgotten it was one. It is PIE ****ḱred-dʰeh₁-***: "**to put **ḱred-***".
What is that first half? Traditionally, the **heart** word — the root of Latin ***cor***, ***cordis*** and of English **heart**. Be honest that the step is **disputed**: that root normally appears as **ḱḗr*, never **ḱred-*. The compound is not in doubt; only what it was built on.
Taking the traditional reading:

from *crēdere*	**from *cor, cordis***
credit, **creed**, **credo**	**cordial**, **courage**
credential, **incredible**	**record**, **accord**, **discord**

To **record** is to bring something back to the *cor* — for a Roman the seat of **memory**, not of feeling. To have **courage** is to have heart.

Grammar Lens: creer que

Creer almost always drags a **que** behind it, and then a whole clause:

Creo que llueve.	I think it's raining.
Creo que hace frío.	I think it's cold.
No creo que llueva.	I don't think it's raining.

Look hard at that third row. *Creo que* **llueve** — but *no creo que* **llueva**. Negating *creer* flips the clause into the **subjunctive** from chapter eighteen: stop vouching for something and Spanish stops using the tense that states facts.
Pienso is the weighing; ***creo*** is where it landed. Treat that as a way to feel the difference, not a rule — both take *que* and a clause, and a speaker may use either. But *creo que* is the ordinary opening for an opinion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "creer" — *kreh-EHR*, two beats, not one
- "Creo que llueve."
- the pair — "pienso" (I weigh) then "creo" (I hold)

- "creer" then English "credit, creed, cordial, record"

Before you move on

What shape is *crēdere*, under the surface? (**A compound** — **ḱred-* + $d^{h}eh_1$-, "to put **ḱred-*".) What is the traditional reading of that first half, and why hedge it? (**Heart** — but the heart root is **ḱḗr*, never **ḱred-*, so the step is disputed.) *Pensar* weighs; what does *creer* do? (It **lands** — it holds the opinion the weighing produced.)

175.2 así que — "so", and a word you have been saying since yes

Porque runs from a claim back to its reason. This runs the other way — from the reason forward to what follows. Same two facts, opposite arrow, and you need both to explain anything.

Sounds you'll need

- `s-clear` — a clean hiss in **así**, never a *z* buzz.
- `k-hard` — *qu* is a plain *k*; the *u* is silent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

así = "so, thus, in that way". **así que** = "so, and therefore".
Así is Latin ***sīc***, "thus" — with an *a-* that Spanish added later, the same one it put on *apenas* and *afuera*. And you have met *sīc* before: it is the whole of Spanish **sí**, "yes". Latin *sīc* meant "thus, in this way", and saying *thus* in answer to a question is how a language gets a word for yes.
So *sí* and *así* are the same Latin adverb, one bare and one with the *a-* attached. English borrowed it raw and never translated it: ***sic***, the mark an editor puts after a quoted mistake — "thus it stood".

Grammar Lens: the two arrows

The pair is worth drilling as a pair, because they carry the same two facts in opposite orders:

No corro **porque** llueve.	I'm not running **because** it's raining.
Llueve, **así que** no corro.	It's raining, **so** I'm not running.

Porque points **backwards** to the cause. *Así que* points **forwards** to the consequence. Which you reach for depends only on which fact you want to say first — and that is a choice about emphasis, not about grammar.

Hace frío, **así que** bebo café.	It's cold, so I drink coffee.
Creo que llueve, **así que** leo.	I think it's raining, so I read.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "sí" then "así" — the same Latin word, one with an *a-* on the front
- "Llueve, así que no corro."
- the same two facts the other way — "No corro porque llueve."
- "Creo que hace frío, así que bebo café."

Before you move on

Which Latin adverb is hiding in both *sí* and *así*? (***Sīc***, "thus".) Which way does *porque* point, and which way *así que*? (*Porque* **backwards** to the cause; *así que* **forwards** to the consequence.) What does an editor's *sic* mean? (**Thus it stood** — the same word, borrowed whole.)

175.3 deber — to owe, and therefore to ought

You can now say what you think and what follows from it. This verb adds the third move in any explanation: what somebody **ought** to do about it. It gets there from an unexpected direction — money.

Sounds you'll need

- `b-soft` — between vowels the *b* softens: **deber** = *deh-BEHR*.
- `r-tap` — one flick at the end, not a roll.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

deber does two jobs: "**to owe**", and "**ought to, should**".
Latin ***dēbēre*** explains both, because it is a compound: ***dē-*** ("from") plus ***habēre*** ("to have"). To *dēbēre* something is **to have it from someone** — which is exactly what owing is. You are holding what is theirs.
English helped itself to this verb four times over — three of them from the participle *dēbitum* rather than the verb — and the spellings record each route:

English	how it came
debt	through French, then re-spelled to show the Latin *b*
debit	straight from Latin bookkeeping
due	through French *deü*, the *b* worn away
duty	built on *due*

One more came the long way round, and not by borrowing. French turned *dēbēre* into *devoir*, "duty". English **translated** the phrase *mettre en devoir* — to put oneself under an obligation — half-way, as *put in dever*, and the last two words later fused into **endeavour**.

Grammar Lens: debo + infinitive

Deber is regular, and for "ought to" it takes a bare infinitive straight after it — no *que*, no preposition:

person	form
yo	**debo**
tú	**debes**
él/ella/usted	**debe**
nosotros	**debemos**
ellos/ustedes	**deben**

Debo estudiar. — I ought to study. **Llueve, así que debo leer.** —

It's raining, so I ought to read.
The obligation is softer than a command and firmer than a wish, which is the register an explanation usually wants.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "debo, debes, debe, debemos, deben"
- "Debo trabajar."
- "Hace frío, así que debo beber café."
- "Creo que llueve, así que debo leer."
- "deber" then English "debt, debit, due, duty"

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces build *dēbēre*, and what do they say together? (***Dē-* + *habēre*** — "to have **from** someone", which is owing.) Name two of the four English words it became. (Any of **debt**, **debit**, **due**, **duty**.) What follows *debo* — a *que*, or a bare infinitive? (**A bare infinitive**: *debo estudiar*.)

175.4 explicar — to unfold

Three pieces are in your hands: *creo que* to state an opinion, *así que* to run forward to what follows, *debo* to say what ought to happen. This lesson puts all three in a row, under the verb that names the act.

Sounds you'll need

- `k-hard` — *c* before *a* is a hard *k*: **explicar** = *eks-plee-KAR*.
- `l-clear` — a clean *l* in the *pl*, no vowel slipped in between.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

explicar = Latin ***explicāre***: ***ex-*** ("out") + ***plicāre*** ("to fold"). **To explain is to unfold** — something was folded shut, and you open it. *Plicāre* is one of the great suppliers of English. Some came from Latin directly, some through French, and the sound changed on the way:

straight from Latin	**through French**
explicate	**explicit**, **application**
complicated (*com-* + fold)	**employ**, **deploy**
duplicate	**display** — a doublet of *deploy*

And **simple** is *sim-plex* — "**one**-fold". Something simple has been folded only once. Something **complicated** has been folded *together*, over and over, which is why it needs unfolding. The metaphor is consistent all the way down, and Spanish keeps it in the plainest verb of the set.

Grammar Lens: the shape of an explanation

Explicar is regular — it takes the plain *-ar* endings of *hablar*, with no stem change at all: **explico**, **explicas**, **explica**, **explicamos**, **explican**. (*Contar*, which you met earlier, breaks its *o* to *ue*; this one does not, and there is nothing to remember.)
Here is a whole explanation, with every piece something this book has taught:

> — ¿Por qué no corres? — **Creo que** llueve. No corro **porque** llueve, **así que** leo. **Debo** estudiar.
>
> — *Why aren't you running? — I think it's raining. I'm not running because it's raining, so I read. I ought to study.*

Four moves, four words: an **opinion** (*creo que*), a **cause** (*porque*), a **consequence** (*así que*), an **obligation** (*debo*). That is what an explanation is made of, and you can now build one in either direction — cause first or claim first — because *porque* and *así que* let you choose.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "explico, explicas, explica, explicamos, explican"
- "Explico bien." — I explain well.
- the four moves — "Creo que llueve, porque hace frío, así que debo leer."
- "explicar" then English "explicit, complicated, simple, display"

Before you move on

What does *explicāre* literally say? (**To fold out** — *ex-* + *plicāre*.) What is *simple*, folded? (**Once** — *sim-plex*; *complicated* is folded together, again and again.) Name the four moves of an explanation and the word for each. (Opinion ***creo que***, cause ***porque***, consequence ***así que***, obligation ***debo***.)

Chapter 176

Para — For, Pointing Forward

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use para for a destination, a deadline, a recipient or a purpose.
>
> *Complete ES-C51-para: produce para ti and para manana, and name the Latin piece inside para that means toward.*

176.1 para — "for," pointing forward

English has one word, *for*, doing about ten jobs. Spanish splits them between two words, and most courses hand you a list of twelve rules. You are getting one idea instead, and this chapter is half of it.

Grammar Lens: the arrow points away from you

para — *for*, when something is **aimed at** something else.

*Es **para** ti.* — It's for you. *(aimed at a person)* ***Para** mañana.* — By tomorrow. *(aimed at a moment) Hago la comida **para** la casa.* — I make the meal for the house. *(aimed at a purpose)*

Destination, deadline, recipient, purpose. They look like four different rules and they are one: **something is heading toward something else.** Draw an arrow from the thing to its target, and if the arrow makes sense, the word is *para*.
That is the whole of this chapter. Not four uses — one direction.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The direction is not a mnemonic somebody invented. It is **inside the word**.

Para was Latin **per** + **ad**, squeezed into one word. And *ad* means **"toward"** — it is the same *ad* sitting at the front of English **advance**, **admit**, **adhere**, **address**, all of which are about moving or pointing at something.

So *para* is, at the bottom, "through-toward." A word that is literally made of an arrow.

Once you have that, you do not have to remember which of the twelve textbook uses of *para* is which. You have to ask one question: **is this pointing at something?**

Your turn

- *Say it:* "para ti", "para mañana", "para la casa" — draw the arrow each time

Before you move on

What one question decides *para*? (**Is it pointing at something?**) What is inside the word? (***Ad*** — "toward.") Next: the other half — and you have been saying it since your first chapter.

Chapter 177

Por — And Three Phrases You Already Owned

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use por for a cause, a route or an exchange, and say what por favor literally means.

Complete ES-C51-por: say what por favor literally means and name the English word that is the per inside por.

177.1 por — and you already know three of these

Say "please." (*Por favor.*) Say "why." (*¿Por qué?*) Say "because." (*Porque.*) You have been carrying this word since your first page and nobody has told you what it means.

Grammar Lens: the arrow points back, or through

por — *for*, when something is the **cause**, the **route**, or what is given **in exchange**.

Gracias ***por*** *la comida.* — Thanks **for** the meal. *(the cause)* ***Por*** *ti.* — Because of you. *(the cause)*

Where *para* pointed forward at a target, *por* points **back at a reason** or **through a middle** — what something came through, not what it heads toward.
Now look again at the three phrases you already own:

- ***por favor*** — literally *by way of a favour*. You are not aiming at a favour; you are asking **through** one.
- ***¿por qué?*** — literally *through what?* — that is, **caused by what?**
- ***porque*** — the same two words fused into an answer: *because*.

Three of your oldest phrases turn out to be the same preposition, doing exactly what this chapter says it does. You knew *por* before you knew *hola* meant anything.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Por is two Latin words run together: **pro** ("in front of, on behalf of") and **per** ("through").
The *per* half is still alive and unchanged in English, in the least poetic corner of the language:

- **per hour**, **per person**, **per cent** — *cent* being *hundred*, so literally **through each hundred**.
- **percolate**, **permeate**, **perforate** — all piercing *through*.

English kept *per* meaning "through" and Spanish kept it inside *por*. Saying *por favor*, you are using the same word as *miles per hour*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "por favor", "¿por qué?", "porque" — three old friends, one word
- "Gracias por la comida"

Before you move on

Which direction does *por* point? (**Back at a cause**, or **through** something.) What is *por favor* literally? (**By way of a favour**.) Which English word is the *per* inside it? (***Per***, as in *per hour*.) Next: the two side by side.

Chapter 178

Which Way Is the Arrow Pointing?

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can choose between por and para with one question instead of a list of rules.
>
> *Complete ES-C51-la-flecha: contrast para ti with por ti and state the arrow test.*

178.1 Which way is the arrow pointing?

One points forward at a target. One points back at a cause. Say which is which before you read on.

Grammar Lens: the same sentence, twice

The pair that makes the difference visible:

> *Lo hago **para** ti.* — I'm doing it **for** you. *(you receive it)*
> *Lo hago **por** ti.* — I'm doing it **because of** you. *(you are the reason)*

Two letters apart, and two different sentences about your relationship with somebody. The first is a gift; the second is a motive.
English says *for* in both and lets context carry the rest. Spanish makes you choose, and once you hear the choice you notice English was hiding it.
The test:

> **Draw an arrow. Does it point at the thing (*para*),**

or come from it (*por*)?

- *Es para ti* — arrow **at** you. You get it.
- *Es por ti* — arrow **from** you. You caused it.

That is the whole rung: one arrow, two directions.

Why it's said this way

The test works because it is not a trick. It is what the two words are made of: *para* contains **ad** ("toward"), *por* contains **per** ("through"). You are not memorising which preposition suits which situation. You are reading a direction built into each word before Spanish existed. That keeps working on uses this book never showed you: meeting *por* in an unfamiliar sentence, ask what it comes **through** or **because of**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "Lo hago para ti" then "Lo hago por ti" — two letters, two relationships

Twice through: Until the arrow arrives before the word does.

Before you move on

Para ti — who gets it? (**You do**.) *Por ti* — who caused it? (**You did**.) And why does the test keep working on sentences this book never showed you? (Because the directions are **inside the words**.) Next: both in one place.

Chapter 179

Review — One Arrow

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can state both directions and place my old por phrases under them.
>
> *Complete ES-C51-repaso-flecha: give both directions, name three old phrases containing por, and say what it means when a sentence takes either.*

179.1 Review — one arrow

Nothing new. One question before the table: which way does each preposition point?

What you've built

	para — toward	**por — through, because**
built from	*ad*, "toward"	*per*, "through"
the arrow	points **at** it	comes **from** it
a person	*para ti* — you get it	*por ti* — you caused it
a time	*para mañana* — by then	—
thanks	—	*gracias por* — for what caused it
asking	—	*por favor* — through a favour
asking why	—	*¿por qué?* — through what?

Look at the right-hand column. Four of those six *por* entries are phrases you have owned since the opening chapters. This review is not mostly teaching you new Spanish — it is **re-filing old Spanish under a heading that explains it**.

That happens more than a course usually admits. A great deal of what looks like new grammar late in a book is a name for something you have been doing correctly and blindly for a long time.

Grammar Lens: what to do when you are unsure

You will still hesitate sometimes. Two things help, in this order:

1. **Ask what the sentence is about.** A destination, a deadline, a recipient, a purpose — *para*. A cause, a route, a swap, a duration — *por*.

2. **If it is genuinely both, it is genuinely both.** *Lo hago para ti* and *lo hago por ti* are both good Spanish; you are not choosing right from wrong, you are choosing which thing to say.

That second point matters more than it looks. Most *por*/*para* anxiety comes from believing every sentence has one correct answer waiting to be found. Plenty of sentences take either, and the choice is the meaning.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “para ti / por ti”, “para mañana”, “gracias por la comida”

Twice through:

Before you move on

Para — which way? (**At** it.) *Por* — which way? (**From** it.) And when a sentence takes either? (**Both are right** — the choice is the meaning.) Next: the two of them in a conversation, where the choice does real work.

Chapter 180

Synthesis — The Gift and the Motive

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can change the meaning of a sentence by choosing between por and para.
>
> *Complete ES-C51-sintesis-regalo-motivo: say the dinner sentence both ways and say what a wrong choice actually produces.*

180.1 Synthesis — the gift and the motive

> *Para ti* or *por ti* — one of them is a present and one of them is a reason. Which is which?

The exchange

Read this twice, changing only one word.

> — *Hago la comida* ***para*** *ti.* — *Gracias.*
>
> — *Hago la comida* ***por*** *ti.* — *…gracias.*

The first is somebody cooking you dinner. The second is somebody telling you they are cooking **because of** you — which, depending on the day, is an act of love or a small complaint.

Two letters. Nothing else in the sentence moved.

Grammar Lens: a preposition carrying the feeling

This is the first place in the book where **the smallest word in the sentence carries its emotional content**.
Nouns and verbs have been doing the meaning until now. Here the noun is the same, the verb is the same, the person is the same — and the sentence changes completely on a preposition. That is worth meeting deliberately, because English speakers arrive expecting the little words to be plumbing.
They are not plumbing here. *Por* and *para* are the difference between *I made this for you* and *I made this because of you*, and no amount of context repairs the wrong one: your listener will simply hear the thing you did not mean.
Which is also the reassuring part. If you pick the wrong one, you have not produced nonsense or bad grammar — you have said something true about a different situation. Somebody will look faintly puzzled, and you will notice, and that is how this stops being difficult.

Your turn

- *Say it:* both versions of the dinner sentence, and hear the second one land differently

Twice through:

Before you move on

Para ti — a gift or a reason? (A **gift**.) *Por ti*? (A **reason**.) And what happens if you choose wrong? (You say something **true about a different situation** — and somebody will look puzzled, which is how you learn it.)

Chapter 181

Se Habla Espanol — Nobody in Particular

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read and use the impersonal se, where no person is named.
>
> *Complete ES-C52-se-habla: write the sign and say who is doing the speaking.*

181.1 se habla español — nobody in particular

Se llama — "he calls himself." You have had that *se* since your third chapter. Here it is doing something you have seen on signs and never been able to parse.

Grammar Lens: a sentence with nobody in it

> ***Se habla*** *español.* — Spanish is spoken here. ***Se come*** *bien.* — One eats well here. / The food is good.

Look for the person doing it. There is not one, and there is not meant to be. *Se habla español* does not tell you **who** speaks Spanish — it tells you that Spanish gets spoken, and that is the entire content. English has to work harder to be that vague. It reaches for a passive ("Spanish is spoken"), or a fake subject ("**they** speak Spanish here", "**you** eat well there"), and neither is quite honest, because there is no *they* and no *you*.

Spanish just... leaves the person out. **The *se* is the mark that says**

nobody is being named.
This is why it is the natural voice of signs, notices and rules: *se habla español*, *se prohíbe fumar*, *no se aceptan tarjetas*. A sign is not addressed by anyone to anyone. It simply reports that something is the case.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Se habla español" as if reading it off a window
- "Se come bien"

Before you move on

Se habla español — who is speaking? (**Nobody named** — that is the point.) What does the *se* mark? (That **no person is being named**.) Next: why this form grew out of the one you already knew.

Chapter 182

Se Compran Libros — The Verb Tells On Itself

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can make the verb agree with the thing, and say why it does.
>
> *Complete ES-C52-se-venden: produce se compran libros and read it as if se still meant themselves.*

182.1 se compran libros — the verb tells on itself

> *Se habla español* — one thing, singular verb. Now guess what happens with more than one thing.

Grammar Lens: it agrees, and that is strange

> *Se* ***compra*** *el libro.* — The book is bought. *Se* ***compran*** *libros.* — Books are bought.

The verb changed. *Compra* for one book, *compran* for several — the verb is agreeing with **the thing being bought**.
Stop and notice how odd that is. In *se habla español* there is nobody doing the speaking, so what is the verb agreeing **with**? If this were simply "one buys books," the verb would stay singular, because *one* is one person. It does not stay singular.
The thing is behaving like the subject. And that is the clue to where this construction came from.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Read *se compran libros* with the *se* meaning what it meant in *se llama*:

Books buy themselves.

That is nonsense as a description of the world, and it is exactly the sentence Spanish is using. The reflexive was stretched: first *the door closes itself* (true enough of doors), then *the books sell themselves*, and finally any verb at all with the doer quietly dropped.
Once you see that, the agreement stops being strange. *Libros* is the subject of *se compran* in the same way *él* is the subject of *se llama*. The verb has been agreeing with its subject all along; it is just that the subject is a thing, and the thing is not really doing anything.
So this *se* **is** the reflexive *se* — grown, not borrowed. Unlike the *se* of *se lo digo*, which only looks like it.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "Se compra el libro" then "Se compran libros" — hear the verb follow the thing

Before you move on

Why does the verb go plural? (Because it agrees with **the thing**.) And why does it agree with the thing? (Because underneath, the thing is **doing it to itself**.) Next: the one you will use every day.

Chapter 183

Como Se Dice — The Sentence That Unlocks the Rest

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask how something is said, and say which se that is.
>
> *Complete ES-C52-como-se-dice: ask the question politely and say why it is impersonal rather than aimed at the listener.*

183.1 ¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest

You know *cómo*. You know the impersonal *se*. Put them in front of *dice* and you have the sentence that will teach you more Spanish than this book will.

The two words

¿Cómo se dice? — How do you say it? / How is it said?

Take it apart with what this chapter gave you. *Se dice* is the impersonal: it asks how a thing **gets said**, without asking who says it. Not *how do **you** say it*, though that is the natural English — Spanish is not pointing at the person you are talking to. It is asking about the language itself.

Which is exactly right, because you are not asking for their personal opinion. You are asking what the word is.

¿Cómo se dice "book" en español? — How do you say "book" in Spanish? *¿Cómo se dice, por favor?*

This is the most valuable sentence in the book, and it is worth saying why. Every other sentence you have learned lets you say something you already know. This one gets you the thing you **do not** know, from the person in front of you, mid-conversation. A learner with this sentence and some patience out-learns one with twice the vocabulary and no way to ask.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Cómo se dice?" until it is one word
- "¿Cómo se dice en español, por favor?"

Twice through: This is the one to over-practise.

Before you move on

Ask how something is said. (***¿Cómo se dice?***) Which *se* is that? (The **impersonal** one — asking about the language, not the person.) Next: the three *se*s, side by side, for the first time.

Chapter 184

Review — The Three Se's

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can tell the three se's apart and say which two are really one word.
>
> *Complete ES-C52-tres-ses: say which two se's are one word and what marks the impostor.*

184.1 Review — the three se's

Nothing new. Say *se llama*, then *se habla español*, then *se lo digo*. Three sentences, three *se*s, learned about a hundred chapters apart.

What you've built

	example	what the *se* is
reflexive	*se llama*	himself
impersonal	*se habla español*	nobody named
the impostor	*se lo digo*	*le*, in disguise

And here is the fact that makes this a review rather than a fourth thing to learn:

The first two are the same word. The third is not.

The impersonal grew out of the reflexive — *the books sell themselves* becoming *books are sold* — which is why the verb still agrees with the thing. Same word, stretched.

The third only looks like them. It is Latin *illī* — the *le* you already know — which arrived at this spelling by an accident of medieval pronunciation, as you saw when *gelo* became *se lo*.
So Spanish does not have three *se*s. It has **two, and a coincidence**.

Grammar Lens: how to tell them apart in the wild

You will not have to work this out consciously for long, but while you do:

1. **Is there a *lo*, *la*, *los* or *las* right after it?** Then it is the impostor: *se lo*, *se la*. It means *to him / to her / to them*.
2. **Otherwise, is anybody named as the doer?** If not, it is the impersonal: *se habla*, *se dice*, *se come bien*.
3. **Otherwise it is the reflexive**, pointing back at whoever the sentence is about: *se llama*, *se levanta*.

The first test is nearly free, because that direct object pronoun is sitting right there in the open.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "se llama", "se habla español", "se lo digo" — two of these are relatives

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many *se*s does Spanish really have? (**Two, and a coincidence**.) Which one is the impostor? (The one in ***se lo*** — it is *le*.) Next: all of it in a place you would actually meet it.

Chapter 185

Synthesis — Reading the Window

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read impersonal signs and ask my way past the words I do not have.
>
> *Complete ES-C52-sintesis-el-letrero: read the signs, ask for an unknown word, and say what the missing person buys a notice.*

185.1 Synthesis — reading the window

> Almost nobody will say *se habla español* to you. It will be **written**, on a window, and you will be walking past it.

The exchange

Four things on four windows, in one street:

> *SE HABLA ESPAÑOL SE COMPRAN LIBROS AQUÍ SE COME BIEN SE PROHÍBE FUMAR*

Three you can read completely. The fourth has words you have never met — and you can still read its shape: something is forbidden, by nobody in particular.

That is what this rung buys. Not producing these sentences, but **reading them off the world**, and knowing the missing person is missing **on purpose**.

And for the two unknown words, you already have the tool:

¿Cómo se dice "fumar", por favor?

Which is itself the same construction, asked out loud.

Grammar Lens: what it means that nobody is named

A sentence with nobody in it is not just vague — it is **doing something with the vagueness**. *Se prohíbe fumar* does not say who forbids it, and that is what gives a sign its authority: nobody is claiming anything, so there is nobody to argue with. English does the same when a report says *mistakes were made*.
So when you meet a *se* with no doer, ask who is being left out. Sometimes the answer is interesting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four signs aloud as if walking past them
- "¿Cómo se dice, por favor?" — the way out of any of them

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does this grammar mostly live? (**Written on things.**) What does the missing person buy a sign? (**Authority** — nobody to argue with.) And what do you say when a sign has a word you do not have? (***¿Cómo se dice, por favor?***)

Chapter 186

El Libro Que Compro — One Sentence Out of Two

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can join two sentences with que so a noun carries a clause.
>
> *Complete ES-C53-que-relativo: join two sentences with que and name the question words that share its root.*

186.1 el libro que compro — one sentence out of two

Say "I want you to speak." (*Quiero que hables.*) That *que* is about to do a second job — and it is the job that lets your sentences stop being short.

Grammar Lens: stapling two sentences together

You have two sentences about one book:

> *Tengo el libro.* — I have the book. *Compro el libro.* — I buy the book.

Que joins them, and the repeated noun disappears:

> *Tengo el libro* ***que*** *compro.* — I have the book **that** I buy.

That is the whole mechanism. **Name the thing once, then use *que***

to hang a second sentence off it. Everything you can already say can now be attached to a noun instead of standing alone.
This is the point where a language stops being a list of statements. Up to now your sentences have had one verb each. From here a sentence can contain another sentence, and then another — which is what allows description, explanation and storytelling of any length.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Que comes from the Latin **qui / quem / quid** family — the same *qu-* question-root sitting inside *qué*, *quién*, *cómo* and *cuándo*, which you have been collecting since your very first questions.
That is not a coincidence of spelling. A question and a relative clause are doing related work: *¿qué compras?* asks you to fill a gap, and *el libro que compro* fills one. Latin used the same word family for both, and Spanish kept the arrangement.
So the busiest structural word in the language is a worn-down question word. English did the identical thing: *what*, *which*, *who* and *that* all serve twice, as questions and as joints.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two short sentences, then the joined one
- “el libro que compro”, “la casa que tengo”

Before you move on

Join “I have the book” and “I buy the book.” (***Tengo el libro que compro.***) What does *que* let a sentence do that it could not before? (**Contain another sentence.**) Next: the one place English is lazier than Spanish, and it trips every learner.

Chapter 187

El Libro Que Compre — The Word You Cannot Leave Out

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can supply the que that English deletes.
>
> *Complete ES-C53-que-no-se-cae: produce el libro que compre and name the English pattern that always needs a que.*

187.1 el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out

Say this English sentence out loud: **"the book I bought."** Notice that you did not say *that*. Now try to translate it.

Grammar Lens: English drops it, Spanish never does

> *el libro* ***que*** *compré* — the book I bought. *la casa* ***que*** *tengo* — the house I have.

English lets you delete the joint. *The book that I bought* and *the book I bought* are both fine, and in speech you almost always drop it. **Spanish cannot.** There is no version of these without *que*. Leaving it out does not sound casual or fast — it sounds like a sentence that broke.

This is worth a chapter of its own because of what it does to a learner. You will build the sentence in English first, silently, with the *that*

already missing — and then translate the version you thought of. The gap is invisible precisely because your own language put it there.
So the habit to build is: whenever an English noun is followed straight by a new subject and verb, a *que* belongs in the Spanish.

- the book **I** bought → *el libro* ***que*** *compré*
- the house **we** have → *la casa* ***que*** *tenemos*
- the meal **she** makes → *la comida* ***que*** *hace*

Why it's said this way

English can afford to drop it because its word order is rigid: *the book I bought* can only be read one way.
Spanish word order is looser — subjects vanish under pro-drop, objects move in front of verbs. Where the pieces can sit in several places, a deletable joint would make sentences ambiguous. So it is never deleted. Not arbitrary strictness: the price of the freedom Spanish gives you elsewhere.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "the book I bought" then "el libro que compré" — hear the extra word

Twice through: Until the missing English *that* stops being invisible.

Before you move on

"The house I have"? (***La casa que tengo.***) Can *que* ever be left out? (**No** — never.) And why not? (Because Spanish **moves its pieces around**, so the joint has to stay.)

Chapter 188

Lo Que — What, Out of Two Old Words

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use lo que for a thing that is never named.

Complete ES-C53-lo-que: produce lo que digo and contrast it with lo digo.

188.1 lo que — "what," out of two old words

You have *lo*. You have *que*. This chapter puts them next to each other and adds nothing.

Grammar Lens: a noun-shaped hole

lo que — *what*, in the sense of *the thing that*.

Lo que *digo* — what I say. *(= the thing that I say)* ***Lo que*** *compro* — what I buy.

Every relative clause so far has hung off a noun: *el libro que compro*. But sometimes there is no noun, because you do not know or do not care what the thing is. *Lo* stands in for it — a placeholder with no gender and nothing behind it — and *que* does its usual job of joining. So *lo que* is a **noun-shaped hole with a sentence attached**. That is why it translates as English *what*, which is doing exactly the same thing: *what I say* is *the thing that I say* with the word *thing* taken out.

Now compare it to the *lo* you already know:

> *Lo digo.* — I say **it**. *(a specific thing, already named) Lo que digo* — **what** I say. *(no specific thing at all)*

Same word. In the first it points at something known; in the second it points at a gap the following clause will fill.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "lo digo" then "lo que digo" — pointing at a thing, then at a gap
- "lo que compro"

Before you move on

Say "what I buy." (***Lo que compro.***) What is *lo* doing there? (**Standing in for a thing that is never named.**) How many new words was that? (**None**.) Next: all of it in one place.

Chapter 189

Review — Three Jobs, No New Words

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use all three relative patterns and name the error that outlives the others.
>
> *Complete ES-C53-repaso-que: say how many new words the rung added and name the trap.*

189.1 Review — three jobs, no new words

Nothing new. One question first: how many new words did this rung teach you?

What you've built

None. Here is the whole rung:

	Spanish	English
joining to a noun	*el libro* ***que*** *compro*	the book that I buy
the same, with English's *that* dropped	*la casa* ***que*** *tengo*	the house I have
no noun to join to	***lo que*** *digo*	what I say

Que you have held since *quiero que hables*. *Lo* you have held since the object pronouns. This rung put them to work and added nothing. That is worth pausing on, because it is the last big structural piece a

beginner's course owes you, and it turned out to cost **no vocabulary at all**. Almost everything in a language is like this eventually: the pieces stop being new and start being rearranged.

Grammar Lens: what to actually watch for

One error will outlive the others, so it gets the last word here.

English deletes its joint. Spanish never does.

You will think *the book I bought*, translate what you thought, and produce *el libro compré*. It will feel complete because your English was complete.
The check is mechanical and takes a second: **a noun, then a new subject and verb, with nothing in between** — that gap needs a *que*.
And when there is no noun to begin with, *lo* supplies one so that *que* has something to hang from. Which means both chapters were about the same thing: **Spanish will not let the joint go missing.**

Your turn

- *Say it:* all three rows of the table

Twice through: Until the missing English *that* is loud.

Before you move on

New words this rung? (**None**.) The error that outlives the others? (**Dropping *que***, because English drops *that*.) Next: sentences long enough to be worth saying.

Chapter 190

Synthesis — Sentences Worth Saying

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build a sentence containing other sentences.
>
> *Complete ES-C53-sintesis-frases-largas: build a three-verb sentence and say why length is not difficulty.*

190.1 Synthesis — sentences worth saying

Until this rung, every sentence you could build had one verb in it. Count the verbs in the next one.

The exchange

> *— ¿Tienes el libro **que** compré? — Sí. **Lo que** no tengo es la comida **que** haces.*

Read the second line again. It has three verbs in it, and you can build every piece of it:

- *lo que no tengo* — the thing I do not have *(a noun-shaped hole)*
- *es* — is
- *la comida que haces* — the meal you make *(a noun with a sentence hung off it)*

Nothing in that sentence is new. What is new is that the pieces are allowed to sit **inside** each other.

Grammar Lens: length is not difficulty

Long sentences look like an increase in difficulty and are not.
A relative clause does not add grammar. It adds a **slot** where a whole sentence can go, and you fill it with the same Spanish you were already making. Two short sentences become one long one, and the only new thing is the joint.
That is why this is the last structural rung a beginner's course owes you. Not because nothing is left, but because from here the growth is **more of what you have**, arranged more deeply. What remains genuinely hard is vocabulary and hearing speed, and both are time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full two-line exchange
- the long sentence broken into its three pieces, then whole

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many verbs can one sentence hold now? (**As many as you can join.**) What does a relative clause actually add? (A **slot**, not new grammar.) And what is genuinely hard from here?
(**Vocabulary and hearing speed** — both of which are time.)

Chapter 191

Hay — There Is, There Are, Same Word

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say there is and there are with one form that never changes.
>
> *Complete ES-C54-hay: produce hay una casa and hay libros, and say what hay agrees with.*

191.1 hay — "there is," "there are," same word

Say "I have eaten." (*He comido.*) You met *haber* as the verb with no meaning left. It kept one more job, and this is it.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ai` — *hay* is one syllable, rhyming with English *eye*. The *h* is silent, as always.

Grammar Lens: one form, and it does not count

> **hay** — *there is*, and *there are*.
>
> ***Hay** una casa.* — There is a house. ***Hay** libros.* — There are books. ***Hay** una casa aquí.* — There's a house here.

Read those twice. One book or a hundred, *hay* does not move. **That is remarkable**, and you are now in a position to see why. Every verb form in this book has agreed with something: with the

person speaking, with the thing being replaced, with the noun being described. In the impersonal *se* chapter, even a sentence with nobody in it still made the verb agree with the thing — *se compran libros*. *Hay* does not. It is the one common Spanish verb form that counts nothing at all, and it is a small gift: no decision to make, ever.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "Hay una casa" then "Hay libros" — the same word, twice

Before you move on

"There is a house"? (***Hay una casa.***) "There are books"? (***Hay libros*** — the same word.) What does *hay* agree with? (**Nothing.**) Next: what it is actually made of, and the fossil hiding in it.

Chapter 192

Ha + Y — The Fossil in a Three-Letter Word

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what hay is made of and name the French phrase built from the same pieces.
>
> *Complete ES-C54-ha-mas-y: name the two pieces, say where else the y appears, and name the French equivalent.*

192.1 ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word

Hay looks like nothing. Say the *haber* form for he/she. (*Ha.*) Now look at *hay* again with that in mind.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hay is two words fused:

ha + y

The *ha* you already hold: it is *haber*, third person. The **y** is the interesting half. It is Latin **ibi**, meaning **"there"** — and Spanish otherwise **lost that word completely.**
There is no *y* meaning "there" anywhere else in modern Spanish. It survives in exactly one place, welded to the front of a verb, because words that get glued to something else stop being available to be replaced. *Hay* is a museum case with one object in it.

So the literal reading is: **"it has there."** Which is a strange way to say something exists, until you notice that the neighbours do the same:

- **French: *il y a*** — "it there has." Same *haber* verb, same *ibi*, same order, three words instead of one. French kept its *y* separate, so its fossil is still visible on the surface.
- **English: *there is*** — which also starts with a place-word doing a job that has nothing to do with place. Nobody is pointing anywhere when they say *there is a problem.*

Three languages, three different verbs, and all of them reached for a word meaning **"there"** to announce that something exists. That is not borrowing; it is the same instinct arriving three times.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "ha" then "hay" — hear the extra piece
- "hay", "il y a", "there is" — three languages, one instinct

Before you move on

What is *hay* made of? (***Ha*** + ***y***.) What does the *y* mean, and where else is it? (**"There"** — and **nowhere else** in Spanish.) What did French do with the same pieces? (Kept them apart: ***il y a***.) Next: *hay* with a verb after it.

Chapter 193

Hay Que — Somebody Has To, and Nobody in Particular

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can express an obligation without naming who is obliged.

Complete ES-C54-hay-que: produce hay que hablar espanol and name the other construction that leaves the person out.

193.1 hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular

Se habla español left the person out. So did every sign you read. Here is the other way Spanish does that — and this one is about obligation.

Grammar Lens: an obligation with nobody in it

hay que + a plain infinitive — *one must*, *you have to*, *it is necessary to*.

Hay que *hablar español.* — You have to speak Spanish.
Hay que *comer.* — One must eat.

Three words you already own, and no new grammar: *hay*, *que*, and a verb in its dictionary form.
What it produces is an obligation with **nobody obliged**. *Hay que hablar español* does not say who has to — not you, not me, not them.

It says the requirement exists, the way a sign says a thing is forbidden without saying who forbids it.
That is the same move as the impersonal *se*, and now you have both:

	Spanish	**leaves out**
something happens	*se habla español*	who does it
something must happen	*hay que hablar español*	who must

Two constructions, one habit: **Spanish is comfortable saying that something is the case without saying who is behind it.** English needs a vague *you* or *they* or a passive to manage the same thing, and always sounds slightly like it is avoiding the question.

Your turn

- *Say it:* "Hay que hablar español" then "Se habla español" — both with nobody in them

Before you move on

"One must eat"? (***Hay que comer.***) Who must? (**Nobody named.**) And which other construction does the same? (The **impersonal *se*.**) Next: all of it in one place.

Chapter 194

Review — Three Letters

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use all three jobs of hay and say what it never does.
>
> *Complete ES-C54-repaso-hay: give the three uses and say why a three-letter word needed four chapters.*

194.1 Review — three letters

Nothing new. What does *hay* agree with?

What you've built

one thing	*Hay una casa.*	There is a house.
many things	*Hay libros.*	There are books.
an obligation	*Hay que comer.*	One must eat.
what it is made of	*ha + y*	"it has there"

Three letters, and everything above came out of them.

Notice the shape of this arc, because it is the shape of a lot of language learning: **the smallest words need the most explaining.** *Hay* is shorter than any noun you have learned and it took four chapters, while *comida* took one. Short words are short because they are used constantly, and constant use is what wears them into fossils that no longer explain themselves.

Grammar Lens: what it does not do

Two things *hay* never does, and both save you work:

1. **It never agrees.** Not with number, not with anything. One form.
2. **It never names anybody.** Neither does *hay que*.

So of everything you have learned about making Spanish verbs match their surroundings — six endings a tense, gender on the pronouns, number on the articles — none of it applies here. After a hundred and seventy chapters of agreement, the last word is the one that opted out.

Your turn

- *Say it:* all four rows of the table

Twice through:

Before you move on

Three uses of *hay* — say them. (*There is*, *there are*, and ***hay que*** for must.) What does it agree with? (**Nothing at all.**) Next: the last synthesis.

Chapter 195

Synthesis — Describing Where You Are

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can describe a place using existence, relative clauses and impersonal obligation together.
>
> *Complete ES-C54-sintesis-lo-que-hay: build lo que hay, hay que comerlo and say what remains to be learned.*

195.1 Synthesis — describing where you are

> *Hay* is the word you reach for to describe a place. Look around the room you are in and say what is there.

The exchange

> *— ¿Qué hay aquí? — **Hay** una casa. **Hay** libros — **los que** compré. — ¿Y **la comida que** haces? — **Lo que** hay, **hay que** comerlo.*

The last line is four words of grammar stacked on each other, and every piece came from a different chapter:

- *lo que hay* — the noun-shaped hole, filled by *hay*
- *hay que* — obligation with nobody obliged
- *comerlo* — the object pronoun, riding on the end of an infinitive

You have not been taught that last one, and you can still read it: *comer* plus *lo*. That is what it feels like when a language starts assembling itself.

Grammar Lens: what you can do now

Describing a place is a small thing that needs a surprising amount: an existence word, articles that count, nouns, relative clauses to pick things out, and a way to say what has to happen. This chapter needed all of them, and you supplied them without any of it being new.
That is the honest end of a beginner's course. Not "you are finished" — nobody is — but **the machinery is assembled**. Every remaining thing in Spanish is either a word you have not met yet or a familiar structure standing somewhere you have not seen it stand.
The eleven gaps found in the original audit are now closed. What is left is not a gap. It is the ordinary, unbounded work of using the thing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole four-line exchange
- "Lo que hay, hay que comerlo" — and hear four chapters at once

Twice through:

Before you move on

Ask what there is here. (***¿Qué hay aquí?***) Say what there is, one must eat. (***Lo que hay, hay que comerlo.***) And what is left after this? (**Words, and practice** — the machinery is assembled.)

Chapter 196

Si — If, and the Word Yes Is Made Of

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can make a real condition with si and the present.

I can make a real condition with si and the present.

196.1 si

Say "yes." (*Sí.*) Now the pair from the accent chapter: *el* and *él*. Same letters, one accent, two words.

Today you meet the third member of that family — and it is *sí* with the accent taken off.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

si — if

Latin **sī** meant *if*. Spanish kept it unchanged.
And the *sí* you already know — **yes** — is that same word with a **pointing particle** stuck on the end: Latin **sīc** is *sī* + *-ce*, roughly *if-so*, which came to mean *thus*, *that way*, and finally **yes**.

si ← *sī* — **if** · *sí* ← *sī* + *-ce* — **thus** → **yes**

So *yes* is literally *if*, pointed at. The accent is the only thing keeping them apart on the page, and it is doing the same job it did for *el* and *él*.

Grammar Lens: the real condition

For something that really might happen: *si* + present, then present.

No new verb form. You already have every piece:

Si tengo tiempo, hablo español.	If I have time, I speak Spanish.
Si llueve, no voy.	If it rains, I don't go.

Both halves sit in the present, and the sentence is about something genuinely possible — today, tomorrow, whenever.
The order can flip, and the comma simply goes away:

Hablo español si tengo tiempo.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Si tengo tiempo, hablo español*
- *Si llueve, no voy*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which tense goes on each side of a real condition? (**Present**, both.) And what separates *if* from *yes*? (One **accent** — and a pointing particle, two thousand years ago.)

Chapter 197

Si + Futuro — What Will Happen If

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can put the result of a condition in the future, and keep si in the present.
>
> *I can put the result of a condition in the future, and keep si in the present.*

197.1 si + futuro

Say "if I have time, I speak Spanish." (*Si tengo tiempo, hablo español.*) Two presents.

Now move the second half into the future, where most real conditions actually live.

Grammar Lens: the present stays put

si + *present*, then *future*.

Si tengo tiempo, hablaré español.	If I have time, I **will** speak Spanish.
Si llueve, comeré en casa.	If it rains, I **will** eat at home.

The result half moves to the future. **The *si* half does not.** Spanish will not put a future tense after a *si* that sets a condition — *si tendré*

tiempo… is simply not said.
(The other *si*, the one meaning *whether*, is a different word doing a different job, and it takes the future quite happily. You will meet it later.)
And you already obey that rule in English without having been taught it. Nobody says *if it will rain, I won't go.* English keeps the present after *if* too, and neither language explains why.

Why it's said this way

A condition is not a prediction.
The *si* half is not claiming the thing will happen — it is setting it aside as a supposition, and a supposition has no tense to be right or wrong about. Only the **result** half makes a claim about the future, so only the result half gets the future tense.
That is why the rule feels arbitrary and is not: the two halves of the sentence are doing different jobs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Si tengo tiempo, hablaré español*
- *Si llueve, comeré en casa*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which half takes the future? (The **result** half, after the comma.)
And what never follows *si*? (The **future tense**.)

Chapter 198

Synthesis — Real Conditions

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what happens, or will happen, if something else does.

I can say what happens, or will happen, if something else does.

198.1 Synthesis — real conditions

Which tense after *si*? (**Present**, always.) Which after the comma? (**Present or future** — your choice of meaning.)

What you've built

Two chapters, one word, and a sentence shape you did not have before:

Si tengo tiempo, hablo español.	a habit — whenever it happens
Si tengo tiempo, hablaré español.	a plan — this once
Si llueve, comeré en casa.	a decision waiting on the weather

This is the first thing in the book that needs two clauses to say. Every sentence before it was one thought. A condition is two, hooked together — and the hook cost you no new grammar at all, only a word and a rule about where the future may stand.

Grammar Lens: what a condition is for

A condition lets you talk about a world you are not claiming is real yet. That is a genuinely new power, and it is the doorway to the rest of this book: once you can suppose, you can also suppose things that are **not** true — *if I had time* — and that needs a verb form you do not have yet.
You will meet it soon. For now the supposing is real, and real supposing is most of what anyone says all day.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a real condition about your own day
- the same one, moved into the future

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many clauses does a condition need? (**Two**.) What new verb form did it cost you? (**None**.) And what is still missing? (A way to suppose something **untrue** — that comes next.)

Chapter 199

Hablaron — They Spoke

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what a group of people did, with -ar verbs in the past.
>
> *I can say what a group of people did, with -ar verbs in the past.*

199.1 hablaron

Give the three past forms you have. (*Hablé, hablaste, habló.*) Now the present for *they*. (*Hablan.*)

You have had a past tense for one person only. Today it grows.

Grammar Lens: they, in the past

hablaron — they spoke

	present	past
ellos / ellas / ustedes	**hablan**	**hablaron**

The present ending is *-an*. The past ending is **-aron**, and the stress lands on that **-a-**: *ha-BLA-ron*. No written accent this time — the word already ends in *-n*, and a word ending in *-n* is stressed on the second-to-last syllable by default, which is exactly where the stress is. So *habló* needed its accent and *hablaron* does not. The rule you learned for reading accents is doing the work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablan* · *hablaron*
- *trabajaron* · *estudiaron*

Twice through:

Before you move on

The past *they* ending for *-ar* verbs? (**-aron**.)
Does it take a written accent? (**No** — it ends in *-n*, so the default stress is already correct.)

Chapter 200

Hablamos — We Speak, and We Spoke

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use one form for both tenses and let context decide.
>
> *I can use one form for both tenses and let context decide.*

200.1 hablamos

Say "we speak." (*Hablamos.*) Say "they spoke." (*Hablaron.*)

Now say "we spoke."

Grammar Lens: the form you already own

hablamos — we speak **and** we spoke.

There is nothing to learn. For every **regular** *-ar* verb the *we* form is **identical** in the present and the past:

	present	**past**
nosotros	**hablamos**	**hablamos**

Latin kept them apart — *-āmus* for now, *-āvimus* for then — and the second one wore down until it landed on top of the first. Spanish noticed, and did nothing about it.

Context does the work instead, exactly as it does in English *I put it there*, where *put* is present or past and nobody is ever confused.

Why it's said this way

A gap that costs nothing is a gap a language keeps.
Spanish could have invented a new ending. It did not, because the two meanings almost never compete: whatever else is in the sentence — a time word, the verb before it, the conversation you are already in — settles which one you meant.
And when it genuinely matters, a speaker just says when. That is cheaper than a new tense form for every verb in the language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablamos* — meaning now
- *hablamos* — meaning then

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many new forms did this chapter cost you? (**None**.)
What tells a listener which tense you meant? (**Context** — and if it matters, you say when.)

Chapter 201

Comieron — One Ending, Two Families

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can put -er and -ir verbs into the plural past with one set of endings.

I can put -er and -ir verbs into the plural past with one set of endings.

201.1 comieron

In the past singular, how many ending sets do *-er* and *-ir* verbs need between them? (**One** — *comí* and *viví* take the same endings.)

The plural keeps that bargain.

Grammar Lens: one ending, two families

comieron · ***vivieron*** — they ate · they lived

	present	past
comer	**comen**	**comieron**
vivir	**viven**	**vivieron**

The past ending is **-ieron** for both families, exactly as *-í* served both in the singular. And *we* follows the same shape:

comimos · *vivimos*

Now the interesting part, and it is not the one you would guess.

	present	**past**
hablar	*hablamos*	*hablamos* — **the same**
comer	*comemos*	*comimos* — **different**
vivir	*vivimos*	*vivimos* — **the same**

Two families out of three collapse. *Vivimos* is *we live* and *we lived*, exactly as *hablamos* is both. Only ***-er*** keeps the two apart — and only because its past borrowed *-imos* from the *-ir* family and so moved away from its own present *-emos*.
You met *comemos* and *vivimos* together as the first place *-er* and *-ir* stop agreeing. This is the second place, and it goes the other way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comieron* · *vivieron*
- *comemos* · *comimos* — and *vivimos*, which is both

Twice through:

Before you move on

The past *they* ending for *-er* and *-ir*? (**-ieron**, for both.)
Which families lose the present-past distinction in the *we* form? (***-ar* and *-ir*** — only *-er* keeps it.)

Chapter 202

Tuvieron — the Strong Stems, Made Plural

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can put the strong preterite stems into the plural.

I can put the strong preterite stems into the plural.

202.1 tuvieron

Say the three strong pasts you know. (*Tuve, hice, estuve.*) Where does the stress fall? (On the **stem** — *TU-ve*, *HI-ce.*)

That is what makes them strong. Now watch what the plural does to it.

Grammar Lens: the stem gives the stress back

Strong stem + *-ieron.*

singular	plural
tuve	**tuvieron**
hice	**hicieron**
estuve	**estuvieron**

The ending is the same *-ieron* you learned for *comer* and *vivir.* The strong stem does not change — *tuv-*, *hic-*, *estuv-* — it simply takes the ordinary plural ending.

And the stress moves: *TU-ve*, but *tu-VIE-ron*. The stem holds it in *tuve* and *tuvo* and hands it back here, because *-ieron* is two syllables and takes it.
Note that *tuviste* never had it — *tu-VIS-te* is stressed on the ending like any ordinary past. **The stem only ever held the stress in two of the forms**, which is exactly how much irregularity Spanish was willing to pay for.
No written accent on any of them — they end in *-n*, so the default is already right, exactly as with *hablaron*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tuve* · *tuvieron*
- *hice* · *hicieron* · *estuvieron*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What ending do the strong stems take in the plural? (**-ieron** — the ordinary one.)
And what changes besides the ending? (The **stress**, back onto it.)

Chapter 203

Fueron — They Were, and They Went

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the one plural past that serves both ser and ir.
>
> *I can use the one plural past that serves both ser and ir.*

203.1 fueron

> *Fui* — how many verbs does it belong to? (**Two**: *ser* and *ir*.) So *fui* is both *I was* and *I went*.
>
> The plural keeps that bargain, and breaks a different one.

Grammar Lens: the form that refuses the ending

> ***fueron*** — they were **and** they went

Every other past plural you have takes *-aron* or *-ieron*. This one takes neither:

tener	*tuv-* + *-ieron* → *tuvieron*
ser / *ir*	— → **fueron**

Not *fuieron*. The stem simply becomes *fue-* and the *-ron* is stuck on. And *fuimos* is *we were* and *we went*, with the same double duty.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish borrowed its whole past for *to be* from a different verb.
Latin **fuī** and **fuērunt** are the past of a root meaning *to grow, to become* — not of *esse, to be*. When a verb is used constantly its past tends to wear away, and languages patch the hole from whatever is nearby.
English did exactly the same thing. *Was* and *were* do not come from *be* either; they come from a root meaning *to dwell, to remain*. Two languages, the same hole, the same repair.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *fui* · *fuimos* · *fueron*
- *fueron* — meaning they were, then meaning they went

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which two verbs does *fueron* serve? (***Ser*** and ***ir***.)
And why is the past of *to be* built from another verb entirely? (Because a constantly used past **wears away**, and the hole gets patched — in Spanish and in English both.)

Chapter 204

Review — the Whole Preterite

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give the whole preterite, six people and three families.
>
> *I can give the whole preterite, six people and three families.*

204.1 Review — the whole preterite

The past *they* ending for *-ar*? (**-aron**.) For *-er* and *-ir*? (**-ieron**.) That is the whole plural, in two syllables each.

What you've built

Say each family's own line, one at a time. There is no table here on purpose — a paradigm is easier to hold as three short chants than as a grid.

-ar: **hablé · hablaste · habló · hablamos · hablaron**

-er: **comí · comiste · comió · comimos · comieron**

-ir: **viví · viviste · vivió · vivimos · vivieron**

Two ending sets, not three. *-er* and *-ir* have shared this tense from the first chapter of it, and go on sharing it here.

And one person is still missing. The *vosotros* form — *hablasteis*, *comisteis* — has not been taught, so this is five of the six the present tense gave you. The strong verbs are shorter still: you have *tuve* and *tuvieron*, but not *tuvimos*. Both are owed, and it is better to know that than to think the tense is finished.

Grammar Lens: the two quiet overlaps

Worth holding, because neither is a mistake:
1. *hablamos* and *vivimos* are each two tenses. Present and past, identical. Only *comer* keeps them apart — *comemos* against *comimos* — and only because its past borrowed *-imos* from the *-ir* family.
2. The strong stems are four words, not a rule. *Tuv-*, *hic-*, *estuv-*, and *fue-*. Everything else about them is ordinary: they take *-ieron* like any *-er* verb, except *fueron*, which takes nothing at all and just adds *-ron*.
So the only memorising this tense ever asked of you was four stems.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the *ellos* form of *hablar*, *comer*, *vivir*, *tener*, *ser*

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many ending sets does the plural need? (**Two**.) How many stems had to be learned by heart? (**Four**.) And is the tense finished? (**Not quite** — *vosotros* is still owed, and so are the strong *nosotros* forms.)

Chapter 205

Synthesis — Telling What Happened

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can tell a short past story about other people.
>
> *I can tell a short past story about other people.*

205.1 Synthesis — telling what happened

Hablaron. Fueron. Two plurals, two different bargains — one regular, one refusing every ending in the language.

What you've built

Three chapters ago your past tense could still only talk about **one person at a time**. Now it can talk about a group:

Hablaron español.	They spoke Spanish.
Comimos en casa.	We ate at home.
Tuvieron tiempo.	They had time.
Fueron profesores.	They were teachers.

That is the difference between keeping a diary and **telling a story**. A story needs other people in it, and other people need a plural.

Grammar Lens: the form that pays twice

One of the five forms you just learned is about to do a second job.

hablaron · *comieron* · *tuvieron* · *fueron*

Swap the *-ron* for *-ra* and something appears that Spanish uses for supposing: *hablara*, *comiera*, *tuviera*, *fuera*. That is the form the next chapters need — the one that lets you say *if I had time* rather than *if I have time*.
You are not learning it yet. You are being told that **you already own the raw material**, which is why the plural had to come first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Hablaron español y tuvieron tiempo*
- *Fueron profesores*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What can this tense do now that it could not before? (Talk about **other people** — tell a story rather than keep a diary.)
And which form is about to be used twice? (The ***they*** form.)

Chapter 206

Hablara — the Form for Supposing

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build the supposing form of any verb from its they-past.
>
> *I can build the supposing form of any verb from its they-past.*

206.1 hablara

Give the *they* past of *hablar*, *comer* and *vivir*. (*Hablaron, comieron, vivieron.*)

You were told those would be used twice. This is the second time.

Grammar Lens: swap the ending

Take the *they* past. Swap *-ron* for *-ra*.

they past	supposing
hablaron	**hablara**
comieron	**comiera**
vivieron	**viviera**

No verb in Spanish changes its stem here — a stronger guarantee than almost anything else in the language. The one thing the swap does not carry is an accent: *habl**á**ramos*, *tuvi**é**ramos*. The stem is untouched; only the mark moves.

The reason is worth a moment: every irregularity these verbs had was

already spent in the preterite. Because this form is carved out of that one, it **inherits the irregularity instead of inventing new irregularity**. A tense built on a broken form comes out perfectly regular.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

***Hablara* did not start out as supposing.**
In Latin this ending was a plain statement about the past: *amāveram*, **I had loved**. It slid from *what had happened* to *what did not*, which is a short journey — both sit outside the present, and only one is real. (*Hablar*'s Latin ancestor was **deponent**, so Spanish built *hablara* on the pattern rather than inheriting it. The ending carried over, not the word.)
Spanish also has a second form for exactly this job — *hablase* — and that one **did** come from a Latin subjunctive. Two different Latin tenses walked into the same modern meaning. You will meet *-se* in reading; you never have to produce it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablaron* → *hablara*
- *comieron* → *comiera*, *vivieron* → *viviera*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What do you start from? (The ***they* past**.) What do you swap? (***-ron*** for ***-ra***.)
How many verbs change their stem? (**None** — the breaking already happened somewhere else.) And what does move? (The **accent**, in the *nosotros* form.)

Chapter 207

Tuviera — the Hard Stems, Collected Free

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build the supposing form of the strong verbs without learning a new stem.
>
> *I can build the supposing form of the strong verbs without learning a new stem.*

207.1 tuviera

The rule, again. (Take the *they* past, swap *-ron* for *-ra*.)

Now try it on the verbs that gave you the most trouble.

Grammar Lens: the hard ones cost nothing

they past	supposing
tuvieron	**tuviera**
hicieron	**hiciera**
estuvieron	**estuviera**
fueron	**fuera**

Nothing new was learned here. The same swap, applied to stems you already had. The four words you memorised for the preterite have now paid for themselves twice.

And *fuera* keeps the double duty *fui* and *fueron* had: it is the supposing form of ***ser*** **and** of ***ir***. *Si fuera* can begin *if I were* or *if I*

went, and only the rest of the sentence decides.

Why it's said this way

This is what a well-shaped irregularity looks like.
Spanish could have given the supposing form its own set of broken verbs. Instead it built the form out of one that was already broken, so the damage is paid for once and reused. Learn *tuvieron* and you have *tuviera* for nothing.
Which is why the plural had to come first. It was never only about saying *they had*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tuvieron* → *tuviera*, *fueron* → *fuera*
- *hicieron* → *hiciera*, *estuvieron* → *estuviera*

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many new stems? (**None**.) Which form serves two verbs? (***Fuera***.)
And why did the preterite plural have to come first? (Because **this form is cut out of it**.)

Chapter 208

Si Tuviera — Supposing What Is Not So

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what would happen if something untrue were true.
>
> *I can say what would happen if something untrue were true.*

208.1 si tuviera

Say the real one. (*Si tengo tiempo, hablo español.*) Now the supposing form of *tener*. (*Tuviera.*)

Put them together and you can talk about a day you are not having.

Grammar Lens: the world that is not the case

si + supposing form, then the *-ría* form.

Si tengo tiempo, hablo español.	and I might well have it
Si tuviera tiempo, hablaría español.	**but I do not**

The second sentence says two things at once: what would happen, **and** that it is not happening. That is carried entirely by the verb forms — no extra word is needed to say *but I don't*.

Both halves change together. *Si* takes the supposing form; the result half takes the *-ría* form you learned for *would*. Neither half can be left in the present.

Why it's said this way

And *si* never takes the present subjunctive. Not *si tenga* — that combination simply does not occur in Spanish. The supposing form after *si* is always the *-ra* one.
It is worth knowing why the pairing feels lopsided. The *si* half is not asserting anything, so it uses the form Spanish reserves for the unasserted — and the result half **is** making a claim, just a claim about a world that does not exist, which is what *-ría* is for. Two different jobs, two different forms, in one sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Si tuviera tiempo, hablaría español*
- the real version, then the unreal one, back to back

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which form follows *si* here? (The **supposing** form — *tuviera*.)
Which follows the comma? (The ***-ría*** form.)
And what does the sentence say besides its words? (That the thing **is not true**.)

Chapter 209

Review — the Two Conditions

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can choose between a real and an unreal condition and get both halves right.
>
> *I can choose between a real and an unreal condition and get both halves right.*

209.1 Review — the two conditions

Which follows *si* in a real condition? (The **present**.) In an unreal one? (The **supposing** form.)

What you've built

Say each one aloud, one after another. They are three sentences about the same afternoon, and only the verbs differ.

Si tengo tiempo, hablo español. — whenever it happens

Si tengo tiempo, hablaré español. — a plan for today

Si tuviera tiempo, hablaría español. — but I do not have it

Notice what *si* itself contributes: **nothing**. The same three letters open all three. Everything that tells the worlds apart is carried by the verbs standing on either side of it.

Grammar Lens: the two rules that never bend

The future never follows *si*. *Si tendré* is not said. If the result is in the future, the *si* half stays in the present.
The present subjunctive never follows *si* either. *Si tenga* is not said. Supposing after *si* is always the *-ra* form.
Two prohibitions, one word. Everything else about *si* is free.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the three sentences, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many worlds can you now describe? (**Three** — habitual, planned, and not the case.) What does *si* change between them? (**Nothing**.) And which two forms may never follow it? (The **future** and the **present subjunctive**.)

Chapter 210

Synthesis — Supposing Out Loud

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can speak about a world that does not exist.
>
> *I can speak about a world that does not exist.*

210.1 Synthesis — supposing out loud

Build the supposing form of *ser*. (*Fuera*.) Of *hacer*. (*Hiciera*.)

Now use one.

What you've built

Say these, and hear how much each one carries:

> **Si fuera profesor, hablaría español todos los días.**
>
> **Si tuviera tiempo, comería en casa.**

Each says what would happen **and** that it is not happening, in one breath and with no extra words. English needs *but I'm not* to be quite that clear; Spanish puts it in the verb endings.
This is the first thing in this book you can say about a world that does not exist. Everything before it described what is, was, or will be.

Grammar Lens: what the climb cost

Look back at what this one sentence needed.
It needed *si*, which cost one chapter. It needed the *-ría* form, which you had already. And it needed the supposing form — which needed the **preterite plural**, a gap nobody would have named as the thing standing between you and hypothetical speech.
That is worth remembering the next time something in this language looks arbitrary. The order things must be learned in is rarely the order they look important in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Si fuera profesor, hablaría español todos los días*
- an unreal condition of your own

Twice through:

Before you move on

What can you now say that you could not before? (Something about a world that **is not the case**.) And what had to be built first? (The **preterite plural** — and nobody would have guessed it.)

210.2 depende — the condition you do not have to finish

You have spent two chapters building conditions with both halves: *si* plus a situation, then what follows. This is the word for when you want the condition without saying what it is.

What to know first

- supposing out loud — the real and unreal conditions this word stands in for.

Sounds you'll need

- Three syllables, stress in the middle: *de-PEN-de.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

depende — "it depends." Latin *de-* ("down from") plus *pendere* ("to hang"). To depend on something is to **hang from** it, and the metaphor is still doing work: the answer is suspended from a condition, and until the condition settles the answer swings.
That *pendere* is a generous root. It gave English **pendant** (a thing that hangs), **pending** (still hanging), **suspend**, and — by way of a hanging scale pan — **pensive** and even **pound**, because things were weighed by hanging them.

What you've built

Every condition you have built so far names its own *si*. *Depende* is the one that does not: it asserts that a condition exists and declines to state it, which is why it is such a useful answer to a question you are not ready to answer.
Add *de* and you can name it after all — *depende de ti*, "it depends on you." The condition stops being a mystery and becomes a thing you point at.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *depende* — stress the middle
- name the condition — *depende de ti*
- the same answer the long way, with a full *si* sentence

Before you move on

What does *pendere* mean, and what is hanging? (To hang — the answer hangs from the condition.) Which English words share the root? (**Pendant**, **pending**, **suspend**.) What do you add to name the condition? (*De.*)

Chapter 211

Dice Que — Someone Else's Sentence, Inside Yours

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can report what someone says right now.

I can report what someone says right now.

211.1 dice que

Decir, in the present, for one person. (*Digo*, *dices*, *dice*.)

And one thing you can say about someone. (*Está cansado.*)

Grammar Lens: one sentence inside another

You already have two whole sentences:

Dice. — he says. *Está cansado.* — he is tired.

Reporting is nothing more than putting the second one **inside** the first, and the joint between them is *que*:

Dice que está cansado.

Notice what did **not** happen. The inner sentence was not taken apart. *Está cansado* went in whole, exactly as it would be said on its own.

Why it's said this way

English lets the joint vanish. *He says he's tired* is ordinary English, and so is *He says that he's tired* — both are available.
Spanish has only one of those. *Dice que está cansado* is the sentence; the version without *que* is not a shorter way of saying it, it is not a sentence at all.
This is the second time you have met that refusal. When *que* joined a noun to a clause — *el libro que compré* — it could not be dropped either, while English happily says *the book I bought*. Same word, same job description: *que* is the piece that tells you a clause is arriving. Spanish will not begin a clause without announcing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Dice que está cansado*
- the same thing about yourself

Twice through:

Before you move on

What sits at the joint between the two sentences? (***Que***.)
And may it be left out, as English leaves out *that*? (**No** — and you have now seen *que* refuse to vanish twice.)

Chapter 212

Dijo — The Stem That Breaks Its Own Rule

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what someone said, and say it in the plural without inventing a syllable.

I can say what someone said, and say it in the plural without inventing a syllable.

212.1 dijo

The strong pattern, once more: a stem that changed shape, and then endings that carry no stress. (*Tuve*, *tuvo*.)

One more stem is about to join them.

Grammar Lens: the stem is dij-

Decir builds its past on **dij-**, and in the singular nothing is new at all:

tuve · *tuvo*	the stem you know
dije · ***dijo***	the same endings, on a new stem

Unstressed at the end, exactly like the others. *Dijo*, not *dijó*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin said ***dīxit***. That *x* stood for a [ks] — the sound at the end of English *box*.
Old Spanish kept the letter and softened the sound: *dixo*, with the *x* said roughly like English *sh*. Centuries later that sound hardened at the back of the mouth into the one *j* spells today, and the spelling followed the sound. **dīxit → dixo → dijo.**
So the *j* in *dijo* is not a decoration. It is a Latin *x*, wearing modern clothes.

Grammar Lens: where it breaks the pattern

You learned the strong plural as stem plus *-ieron*: *tuvieron*, *hicieron*, *estuvieron*. Apply that here and you would get *dijieron*.
It is *dijeron*. The *i* is gone.
The *i* in *-ieron* is not a full vowel — it is a glide, the *y* sound of English *yes*, leaning on the vowel after it. And Spanish does not keep a glide next to a sound already made in that part of the mouth. The *j* was there first, so the glide goes.
This is not a fact about *decir*. **Any strong stem ending in *j* does it**, and you will meet more of them; when you do, the ending will already be familiar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dije*, *dijo*, *dijeron*
- *tuvieron*, then *dijeron*, and hear the difference

Twice through:

Before you move on

The stem? (***Dij-***.) The *they* form? (***Dijeron*** — no *i*.)
And is that an exception you must memorise for this one verb, or a rule? (A **rule**, for every strong stem that ends in *j*.)

Chapter 213

Dijo Que — Both Verbs Step Back

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can report what someone said, with the tense the report actually needs.
>
> *I can report what someone said, with the tense the report actually needs.*

213.1 dijo que

Report it in the present. (*Dice que está cansado.*)

Now move only the first verb into the past. (*Dijo...*)

Grammar Lens: both verbs move

Dice *que* ***está*** *cansado.* ***Dijo*** *que* ***estaba*** *cansado.*

The inner sentence cannot stay in the present once the reporting has moved back. It steps back too — into the **imperfect**.
Two more, so the shape is unmistakable:

now	**reported later**
Dice que trabaja.	*Dijo que* ***trabajaba****.*
Dice que hace calor.	*Dijo que* ***hacía*** *calor.*

Why it's said this way

Of the two pasts you own, why this one?
Because of what the imperfect was always for: **what was going on**, rather than what happened and finished. And that is precisely what a report describes. He was tired *at the moment he spoke* — not for an instant, and with no news about when it started or stopped.
The preterite would say something else entirely. It would package his tiredness as one completed event, which is not what he told you.
So the backshift is not a rule about reporting at all. It is the imperfect doing the job it has always done, in a place you had not needed it yet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Dijo que estaba cansado*
- the present version, then the reported one, back to back

Twice through:

Before you move on

When *dice* becomes *dijo*, what happens to the verb after *que*? (It moves into the **imperfect**.)
And why that past and not the other one? (Because the report is about **what was going on** when he spoke.)

Chapter 214

Preguntó Si — A Question That Stops Being One

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can report a yes-or-no question somebody asked.

I can report a yes-or-no question somebody asked.

214.1 preguntó si

Report a statement. (*Dijo que trabajaba.*)

Now the past of *preguntar*, which is perfectly ordinary. (*Preguntó.*)

Grammar Lens: a question, reported

¿Trabaja? — the question, as asked. ***Preguntó si trabajaba.*** — the question, reported.

Two things changed, and both are worth naming.
The joint is *si*, not *que*. A statement goes in on *que*; a yes-or-no question goes in on *si*. The verb still steps back into the imperfect, exactly as before — that part has not changed at all.

Why it's said this way

And the question marks are gone. Not forgotten — *not allowed*. Look at what the reported sentence actually does: it tells you something. It is a statement about an act of asking, and nobody is being asked anything. The marks belong to a question being put, and no question is being put here.
So *¿Preguntó si trabajaba?* is a real sentence, but it means something else — it asks whether he asked.
Now the *si* itself. It is the same *si* that opens a condition, and that is not a coincidence dressed up as one. Both uses hold something open that has not been settled: *si tengo tiempo* leaves the time unsettled, *si trabajaba* leaves the answer unsettled. English splits the job between *whether* and *if*. Spanish never needed to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Preguntó si trabajaba*
- the question as asked, then the report

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which word joins a reported yes-or-no question? (***Si***.)
And what happened to the question marks? (They **went**, because the sentence no longer asks anything.)

Chapter 215

Preguntó Dónde — What the Accent Was Always For

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can report a question that begins with an asking word, accent intact.

I can report a question that begins with an asking word, accent intact.

215.1 preguntó dónde

Report a yes-or-no question. (*Preguntó si trabajaba.*)

Now one that cannot be answered with yes or no: *¿Dónde trabaja?*

Grammar Lens: the asking word is the joint

¿Dónde trabaja? ***Preguntó dónde trabajaba.***

No *que*. No *si*. The asking word **is** the joint — it was already at the front of the question, and it stays there.
The rest is what you already do: question marks gone, verb stepped back into the imperfect.

Why it's said this way

Now look at *dónde* in that reported sentence. **The accent is still there** — in a sentence with no question marks at all.

This is the answer to a question you may have been carrying since the sixth chapter. The accent was never a partner to the question marks. It marks the word as an **asking** word, and the asking is still inside the report: he wanted to know something, and *dónde* is the something. Compare the two jobs the same letters can do:

donde	plain — it just points at a place
dónde	asking — it wants the place named

The marks around a sentence tell you the *sentence* is a question. The accent on a word tells you the *word* is doing the asking. Those are different facts, and only now do you have a sentence where one is true and the other is not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Preguntó dónde trabajaba*
- *Preguntó si trabajaba*, then *Preguntó dónde trabajaba*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What joins the report when the question starts with an asking word? (**The asking word itself** — no *que*, no *si*.)
And what does the accent on *dónde* mark? (That the **word** is asking — not that the sentence is a question.)

Chapter 216

Review — Three Joints, Two Constants

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can choose the right joint for anything I am reporting.
>
> *I can choose the right joint for anything I am reporting.*

216.1 (review)

Two forms first, because the rest is built on them. *He said.* (*Dijo.*) *They said.* (*Dijeron* — no *i.*)

What you've built

Three chants. Say each one, then say what it is for.
First. *Dijo que trabajaba.* — a statement goes in on ***que***, and *que* may never be dropped.
Second. *Preguntó si trabajaba.* — a yes-or-no question goes in on ***si***, the same *si* that opens a condition.
Third. *Preguntó dónde trabajaba.* — a question that starts with an asking word brings **its own joint**, accent and all.

Grammar Lens: the two things that never change

Whatever the joint, two things are true of all three chants.
One. The inner verb steps back into the imperfect — because a report

says what was going on when somebody spoke.
Two. The question marks go. A report tells; it does not ask. And yet the accent on *dónde* stays, because that accent was never marking the sentence — it marks the word that does the asking.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the three chants, in order, without looking

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which tense does the inner verb land in, every time? (The **imperfect**.)
And one word to keep, for the pleasure of it: what is the *j* of *dijo*, historically? (A Latin ***x***. *Dīxit*, *dixo*, *dijo*.)

Chapter 217

Synthesis — Carrying a Conversation

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can report a whole exchange to somebody who was not there.
>
> *I can report a whole exchange to somebody who was not there.*

217.1 (synthesis)

Here is a very short conversation. Two people, four lines.

> *— ¿Dónde trabajas? — Trabajo en casa. — ¿Estás cansado? — Sí.*

You were there. Somebody else was not.

What you've built

Carry it across, line by line. Every line needs a joint, and the joint is different every time.
The first line was a question with an asking word. (*Preguntó dónde trabajaba.*)
The second was a statement. (*Dijo que trabajaba en casa.*)
The third was a yes-or-no question. (*Preguntó si estaba cansado.*)

Your turn

- *Say it:* all three reports, one after another, without stopping

Twice through:

Before you move on

Read your three sentences back and name what is **not** in them. (No question marks — and not one verb left in the present.)
Four lines of live speech went in; one steady account came out.
What is new is not that you said something in Spanish — it is that you **carried** somebody else's words to a person who was not there, and marked every seam where they stopped being your own.

Chapter 218

Pero — Two True Things at Once

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can hold two facts against each other without denying either.
>
> *I can hold two facts against each other without denying either.*

218.1 pero — the word that lets two true things stand together

With *porque* you can give a reason: one thing **because of** another. That word makes two facts agree.

Now you need the opposite tool — the one for two facts that **do not** agree, and are both true anyway.

Sounds you'll need

- `r-tap` — one flick of the tongue, not the rolled *rr*. **pero** = *PEH-ro*. (The rolled version is a different word entirely, so this flick is worth getting right.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pero was **two** Latin words: **per hoc** — *by this*, *through this*.
You can still feel the route it took. *By this* became *for all that*, and *for all that* is already a contrast: I grant you the first thing, and here is the second anyway. The phrase wore down into one short word and kept only the contrast.

Estoy cansado, ***pero*** *estudio.*

Why it's said this way

Notice what *pero* does **not** do. It does not deny the first half. *Estoy cansado* stays true — tiredness is not cancelled by studying.
That is the whole job: two things that pull in opposite directions, both standing. *Porque* fuses two facts into one reason; *pero* keeps two facts apart and admits both. Between them you can say almost anything. And it is the first word of every argument you will ever make. Nobody argues by listing things they agree with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Estoy cansado, pero estudio*
- something true about today, then *pero*, then something that pulls the other way

Twice through:

Before you move on

Porque joins two facts into one reason. What does *pero* do with two facts? (**Keeps them apart, and admits both.**)
And what were its two Latin words? (***Per hoc*** — *by this.*)

Chapter 219

También — Your First Word, Hidden Inside

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can agree with what somebody just said, in two words.
>
> *I can agree with what somebody just said, in two words.*

219.1 también — a word with your very first word inside it

Pero sets two things against each other. Now the opposite move: adding one thing **to** another.

And say *bien*, from your first chapter. You will need it in a moment, in a place you would not expect.

Sounds you'll need

- `accent-mark` — the accent on **también** puts the stress on the last syllable: *tam-BYEN*.
- `b-soft` — the *b* here is gentle, the lips barely closing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

también = tan + bien.
Tan means *so*, *as* — it is the word Spanish uses to say how much of

something there is. And ***bien*** you have had since chapter one.
So *también* is, literally, **"so well"**. Somebody says a thing; you say *and that goes so well for me too.* Say it enough times and it stops being a comment about how well anything is going, and becomes the plain word for *also.*

Estudio español. Trabajo ***también.***

Why it's said this way

The most useful shape it takes is the shortest one:

— *Estoy cansado.* — ***Yo también.***

Two words, and you have agreed with somebody. That is worth more in a real conversation than most of the grammar in this book, and it costs nothing to remember, because you already knew half of it.
Notice the accent, too. It is there because *también* is stressed on its last syllable, which is where the *bien* sits — the borrowed half kept the stress it had when it was a word of its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Yo también*
- *Estudio español. Trabajo también.*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What is *también*, taken apart? (***Tan*** **+** ***bien*** — *so well.*)
And which half have you known since the very beginning? (***Bien.***)

Chapter 220

Tampoco — The Same Frame, the Other Half

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can agree with a no as easily as with a yes.

I can agree with a no as easily as with a yes.

220.1 tampoco — the same frame, the other half

Yo también agrees with somebody who said a **yes**.

But what do you say to somebody who said a **no**? English changes word there too — *me too* becomes *me neither*.

Sounds you'll need

- `k-hard` — the *c* before *o* is a plain *k*. **tampoco** = *tam-PO-ko*, with no accent to write, because the stress already falls where Spanish expects it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tampoco = **tan** + **poco**.
The same *tan* you met yesterday. The new half is ***poco***, which means *little* — a small amount of something.

también	tan + **bien**	so **well**
tampoco	tan + **poco**	so **little**

One frame, two fillings. You are not learning a second word here so much as turning the first one over.

Why it's said this way

— *No estoy cansado.* — ***Yo tampoco.***

The rule is simple and it is about the **other** person's sentence, not yours. If what they said was positive, you answer *yo también*. If it had a *no* in it, you answer *yo tampoco*.
Getting this wrong is one of the most audible mistakes a learner can make, and it is entirely avoidable: listen for the *no*. If you heard one, use the *poco* word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Yo también*, then *Yo tampoco*
- *No estoy cansado.* — *Yo tampoco.*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Tan + bien is *so well*. What is *tan + poco*? (**So little** — ***tampoco***.) And what in the other person's sentence decides between the two? (A ***no***.)

Chapter 221

Este — Pointing at What Is in Your Hand

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something next to me.

I can point at something next to me.

221.1 este — pointing at what is in your hand

El libro names a book. But which one?

If it is in your hand, you need a word that **points**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

este libro — *this book*, the one right here.
It agrees like any other word that leans on a noun:

este *libro*	this book
esta *casa*	this house
estos *libros*	these books
estas *casas*	these houses

Latin's word was ***iste***, and it did not mean *this*. It meant **that of yours** — it pointed at the person being spoken to. Spanish walked it one step closer, off the listener and onto the speaker's own hand, and it has stayed there ever since.

Why it's said this way

Now the part English speakers get wrong, and it is a rule rather than a habit.

este libro — never *el este libro*.

The pointing word goes **in front** of the noun, and it takes the article's place. It does not stand beside it. You cannot have both, because both are doing the same job — saying *which one* — and Spanish only lets one word do that job at a time.
So the moment you reach for *este*, the *el* you were about to say is already spoken for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *este libro*, *esta casa*
- *estos libros*, *estas casas*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does *este* stand, and what does it push out? (**Before** the noun, in the ***article's*** place.)
And who did Latin's *iste* originally point at? (**You** — the person being spoken to. Spanish moved it closer.)

Chapter 222

Ese — Pointing at What Is by You

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can point at something on my listener's side.
>
> *I can point at something on my listener's side.*

222.1 ese — pointing at what is by you

Este libro is the one in my hand.

Remember where *este* came from: it used to point at **you**. So when it moved to me, something had to take over the job it left behind.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ese libro — *that book*, the one near **you**.

ese *libro*	that book, by you
esa *casa*	that house, by you
esos *libros*	those books
esas *casas*	those houses

The word that stepped in was Latin ***ipse***, which meant **self** — the same *ipse* in the Latin phrase *ipso facto*, "by the fact itself".
You can feel how it got the job. *That very one*, *that one itself* — an emphasiser that keeps insisting on a particular thing eventually stops emphasising and simply **points**.

Why it's said this way

So the difference between *este* and *ese* is not distance in metres. It is **whose side the thing is on**.

> *Este libro* — mine, here. *Ese libro* — yours, there.

Two people sitting at one small table will still say *este* and *ese* about books a hand's width apart, because the question was never how far away the book is. It is which of us it belongs to in this moment.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *este libro*, then *ese libro*
- *esa casa*, *esos libros*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Whose side is *ese* on? (**Yours** — the listener's.)
And what filled the slot when *iste* moved closer? (***Ipse***, the word for *self*.)

Chapter 223

Aquel — The Far One, and an Old Friend

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something away from us both.

I can point at something away from us both.

223.1 aquel — the far one, and an old friend in disguise

Mine, here: *este libro*. Yours, there: *ese libro*.

Now the one across the room, belonging to neither of us.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

aquel libro — *that book over there.*

aquel *libro*	that book, over there
aquella *casa*	that house, over there
aquellos *libros*	those books, over there
aquellas *casas*	those houses, over there

Look at the middle of that word. ***-el-***. You have met it before, in your **first chapter**.

Latin ***ille*** went two ways at once. Said quickly and without stress,

leaning on the noun after it, it wore down to ***el*** — the article. Said with stress, and propped up in front with **accu-** (roughly *look, there*), it stayed a pointing word: **accu + ille → aquel**.
So *el* and *aquel* are the same Latin word, and the difference between them is two thousand years of one being emphasised and the other not.

Why it's said this way

That leaves Spanish with **three**, where English has two:

este	by me
ese	by you
aquel	by neither of us

English collapses the last two into *that* and then patches the difference back on when it matters — *that one over there*. Spanish keeps the three apart in the word itself, so it never needs the patch.
And the middle one is the one to watch. If you find yourself reaching for *aquel* because the thing is a few steps away, stop and ask the real question: is it near the person you are talking to? If it is, it is *ese*, however far it is from you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *este libro*, *ese libro*, *aquel libro*
- *aquella casa*, *aquellos libros*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Three words, three places. Which one is by the person you are talking to? (***Ese***.)
And what did *el* and *aquel* both start out as? (Latin ***ille*** — one worn down, one propped up.)

Chapter 224

Esto, Eso, Aquello — Pointing at What Has No Name

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something I cannot name, or at a whole situation.

I can point at something I cannot name, or at a whole situation.

224.1 esto · eso · aquello — pointing at what has no name yet

Este libro, *esa casa*. Both pointing words agreed with a noun.

But what do you say when there **is** no noun — when you do not know what the thing is, or when the thing is not a thing at all?

Grammar Lens: the third set

There is one more form of each, ending in **-o**:

esto	this, here, whatever it is
eso	that, by you, whatever it is
aquello	that, over there, whatever it is

These never sit in front of a noun. They **are** the noun.

*¿Qué es **esto**?* — What is this?

Este could not ask that: it needs a word to lean on, and the whole

point of the question is that you have not got one.

Why it's said this way

Spanish nouns are masculine or feminine — you learned that in chapter one, and it has held ever since. So what gender is *esto*? **Neither.** It is the one leftover of a third gender Latin had and Spanish otherwise abandoned, kept for exactly this job: pointing at what has not been sorted into a gender, **because it has not been named**. Which is also how you point at a whole situation — *Eso está bien.* Not a book, not a house; the thing just said. Nothing there has a gender, so the form that agrees with nothing fits.
Name it, and agreement returns: *¿Qué es esto? — Es un libro. — Ah, ese libro.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¿Qué es esto?*
- *esto*, *eso*, *aquello*

Twice through:

Before you move on

When do you use the *-o* form? (When there is **no noun** — you cannot name it, or it is a whole situation.)
And can *esto* stand in front of a noun? (**No.** It *is* the noun.)

Chapter 225

Review — Three Places, One Question

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose the right pointing word without stopping to think.

I can choose the right pointing word without stopping to think.

225.1 (review)

Three words, three places, in order. (*Este*, *ese*, *aquel*.)

What you've built

Three chants. Say each one, then say who it belongs to.
First. *Este libro* — **by me**. The word Latin used to point at you, walked one step closer.
Second. *Ese libro* — **by you**. The word that used to mean *self*, moved in when the first one left.
Third. *Aquel libro* — **by neither**. The word that also became *el*, kept stressed and propped up so it could go on pointing.

Grammar Lens: one question, asked twice

Everything else here is two questions, in this order.
Do I have a noun? If no, use the *-o* form and stop: *esto*, *eso*, *aquello*. Nothing to agree with, so nothing agrees.

If yes — whose side is it on? Then pick from the three, agree it with the noun, and put it **in front**, in the article's place. Never *el este libro*; the pointing word already did the article's job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three chants, in order, without looking
- *¿Qué es esto?*, then answer it and point again with a noun

Twice through:

Before you move on

Two origins worth keeping. What did *ese* mean in Latin? (***Self***.) And which everyday word is *aquel* related to? (***El*** — both from *ille*, one worn down, one propped up.)

Chapter 226

Muy — The Same Word, Bitten Short

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that something is very something.

I can say that something is very something.

226.1 muy — the same word, bitten short

You have said *mucho* since chapter six — *mucho gusto*.

Now you want to say that something is **very** something. *Cansado* is tired; how do you say *very tired*?

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Estoy ***muy*** *cansado.*

muy is not a new word to learn. It is ***mucho***, with its ending bitten off. Both are Latin ***multum***, *much* — one kept whole, one worn short. Spanish does this a lot: a long form for standing alone, a short form for leaning on the word after it. You will meet the same trick again in this chapter's neighbours.

Why it's said this way

The two shapes are not interchangeable, and the rule is easy because the word tells you itself.

mucho *café*	in front of a **noun** — the long form
muy *grande*	in front of an **adjective** — the short one
muy *bien*	in front of an **adverb** — the short one

So *muy* never stands alone. If somebody asks how you are and you want to say *very*, you cannot answer *muy* — there is nothing for it to lean on. You would answer *muy bien*.
And this is the strongest *very* Spanish has in one word. *Muy grande* is as big as *grande* gets without reaching for another sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *muy bien*, *muy grande*, *muy cansado*
- *mucho café*, then *muy grande*, and hear which is which

Twice through:

Before you move on

Long form or short form in front of an adjective? (**Short** — *muy.*)
And how many Latin words are *muy* and *mucho* between them? (**One** — *multum.*)

Chapter 227

Bastante — An Ending You Can Already Read

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that something is enough, or quite so.

I can say that something is enough, or quite so.

227.1 bastante — an ending you can already read

The ending ***-ante***, from chapter fifty-two. *Estudiante* — the one who studies. It turns a verb into *the one doing it.*

Keep that in mind; it is about to hand you a word for free.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

There is a verb ***bastar***, *to be enough.* Put your ending on it:

bast- + **-ante** → ***bastante***, "sufficing".

So *bastante* does not mean *a lot.* It means **enough** — and from there, *quite*, *fairly.* It is the amount that suffices, not the amount that impresses.

Estoy ***bastante*** *cansado.* — I'm quite tired.

Why it's said this way

You now hold a scale, and it is worth saying out loud in order:

poco	little
bastante	enough, quite
muy	very

Notice where *bastante* sits. English speakers reach for it thinking *quite a lot*, and land higher than they meant. It is the middle of the scale, not the top — the top is *muy*.
And unlike *muy*, it is not fussy about what follows: *bastante café*, *bastante grande*. Only *muy* insists on leaning on an adjective or an adverb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *poco*, *bastante*, *muy*, in order
- *Estoy bastante cansado*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does *bastante* sit on the scale? (In the **middle** — enough, not very.)
And which of the three refuses to sit in front of a noun? (***Muy***.)

Chapter 228

Mal — Bien Finally Gets Its Opposite

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that something is bad, or going badly.
>
> *I can say that something is bad, or going badly.*

228.1 mal — bien finally gets its opposite

Bien has been with you since chapter one, and so has *bueno*.

Both have an opposite, and the pair works exactly the same way.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Malo is the adjective — *bad*. ***Mal*** is what is left of it when it goes in front of a masculine noun, and it is also the adverb — *badly*.

bien / ***mal***	well / badly
bueno / ***malo***	good / bad

Estoy ***mal***. — I'm not well.

Both come straight from Latin: *bene* and ***malus***, which you can still hear in English *malady* and *malice*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bien*, then *mal*
- *bueno*, then *malo*

Twice through:

Before you move on

How do you say you are not well? (*Estoy* ***mal***.)
And which English words still carry Latin *malus*? (*Malady*, *malice*.)
Next: the short form and the long form turn out to be a habit, not a quirk.

228.2 a word in a hurry — the short form and the long one

Muy — very. *Mal* — badly.

Each of those arrived beside a longer word, and the pairing was not a coincidence either time.

Why it's said this way

Set the two pairs beside each other.

long form	short form	short one appears
mucho	***muy***	before an adjective or adverb
malo	***mal***	before a masculine noun, and as the adverb

This is not two exceptions. It is one habit of the language: Spanish **bites the ending off a word that is leaning on another word**, and keeps it whole when that word stands on its own.
Once you have heard it twice you start noticing it everywhere, and it stops being something to memorise. A short form is a word in a hurry to get to the next one.

Your turn

- *Say it: mucho / muy*, then *malo / mal*, and hear the same trick twice

Twice through:

Before you move on

When does Spanish bite the ending off? (When the word is **leaning on** another word.)
And what was *muy* before it was in a hurry? (Latin ***multum***.)

Chapter 229

Review — One Scale, One Habit

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can place a thing on a scale, and recognise a shortened word.
>
> *I can place a thing on a scale, and recognise a shortened word.*

229.1 (review)

The scale, least to most. (*Poco*, *bastante*, *muy*.)

What you've built

Three chants. Say each, then say what it is for.
First. *Estoy muy cansado.* — ***Muy*** is the top of the scale, and it is *mucho* with its ending bitten off.
Second. *Estoy bastante cansado.* — ***Bastante*** is the middle, and it means *sufficing*: *bastar* plus the *-ante* you could already read.
Third. *Estoy mal.* — ***Mal*** is the opposite of *bien*, and it is *malo* with its ending bitten off.

Grammar Lens: the habit underneath

Two of those three came in a long form and a short one, and that is the thing worth carrying out of this chapter.
Mucho keeps its ending in front of a noun and loses it in front of an adjective. *Malo* keeps its ending standing alone and loses it in front of a masculine noun. Different words, one habit: **the ending goes**

when the word is leaning on the next one.
So when you meet a short Spanish word that looks like a longer one you already know, that is usually what has happened — not a new word to learn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three chants, in order
- *mucho* / *muy*, then *malo* / *mal*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the three refuses to stand in front of a noun? (***Muy***.)
And which one refuses to stand alone as an answer? (***Muy*** again — *muy bien*, never just *muy*.)

Chapter 230

Al — Two Words Spanish Will Not Keep Apart

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say where I am going, with the article fused on.

I can say where I am going, with the article fused on.

230.1 al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart

You have *a* — *to, towards*. And you have *el*.

Put them together and say it quickly. *A el... a el...* Hear what your mouth wants to do.

Grammar Lens: the squeeze

a + *el* → ***al***

Voy ***al*** *café.* — I'm going to the café.

This is not an option and not a shortcut for speaking fast. It is how the language is **written**. *A el café* is not a more careful version of *al café*; it is simply wrong.

Why it's said this way

You met this instinct two chapters ago, when *mucho* lost its ending in front of an adjective. Spanish does not like a word standing about doing nothing while another word waits: **when one word leans on the next, something gives.** Here the two words simply fuse.
And there is one exception worth knowing, because it looks like a mistake and is not. When *El* is part of a **name**, it keeps its distance:

> *Voy a El Salvador.* — not *al Salvador.*

What contracts is the little article — not every word that happens to be spelled *el*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *al café*, *al profesor*
- *Voy al café*

Twice through:

Before you move on

A plus *el* makes what? (***Al*** — always.)
And when does it not happen? (When ***El*** is part of a **name**.)

Chapter 231

Del — And Then the List Stops

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say whose something is, and I know both contractions exist.
>
> *I can say whose something is, and I know both contractions exist.*

231.1 del — and then the list stops

A + *el* gave you *al*. Now take *de*, which you have had since chapter forty-eight.

Say *de el* quickly, and let the same thing happen.

Grammar Lens: the second squeeze

de + *el* → ***del***

el libro ***del*** *profesor* — the teacher's book

Same rule, same force. And notice what *del* is doing in that phrase: Spanish has no apostrophe-s, so *of the* is how it says whose something is. *Del profesor* — of the teacher.

Why it's said this way

Now the part worth celebrating.
That is the complete list. Spanish has exactly **two** obligatory contractions — *al* and *del* — and no others. Not *de la*, not *a la*, not *de*

los. Those stay two words forever.

a + *el*	***al***
de + *el*	***del***
a la, *de la*, *a los*, *de las*	unchanged

It is rare to be handed a grammar rule and told the exceptions are finished. Learn these two and you will never wonder about a third.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *al café*, *del café*
- *el libro del profesor*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Name both contractions. (***Al*** and ***del***.)
And how many more are there to learn? (**None.** That is the whole list.)

Chapter 232

Quién — The Asking Word for People

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask who somebody is.

I can ask who somebody is.

232.1 quién — the asking word reserved for people

¿Qué es esto? asks about a **thing**.

But you cannot ask *¿Qué es* about a person and expect a name. For people, Spanish keeps a different word entirely.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

*¿**Quién** es?* — Who is it?

It carries the accent, like every asking word, and it sits between the two marks.

Latin had ***quis*** for *who* — but the form Spanish kept is ***quem***, the shape the word took when it was the **object** of the sentence. Latin marked that job with an ending; Spanish threw the endings away and was left holding this one form, which then had to do every job. So *quién* is an old object-form doing subject work, and has been since before anyone noticed.

Why it's said this way

The division is simple and it does not bend:

qué	things, ideas, anything not a person
quién	people, and only people

English blurs this — *what is that person to you?* is fine English. Spanish will not: if the answer is a person, the question takes *quién*. And it has a plural, which English does not. If you expect more than one person in the answer, you ask ***quiénes***.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¿Quién es?*
- *¿Qué es esto?*, then *¿Quién es?*, and hear the split

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which asking word is reserved for people? (***Quién***.)
And what do you ask when you expect several? (***Quiénes***.)

Chapter 233

O — One Letter, One Catch

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can offer a choice between two things.
>
> *I can offer a choice between two things.*

233.1 o — one letter, one catch

Y joins two things: *café* ***y*** *agua*.

Now the other one — not both, but a choice between them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Café ***o*** *agua?* — Coffee or water?

o is the whole word. Latin's was ***aut***, and it wore all the way down to a single letter — which is about as far as a word can go without disappearing.

Why it's said this way

And that is the problem. A word one letter long is easy to lose. Say *siete o ocho* — *seven or eight* — quickly, and the *o* is swallowed by the *o* of *ocho*. So Spanish swaps it for a shape that cannot be swallowed:

siete ***u*** *ocho*

Nothing here is about meaning. *O* becomes ***u*** in front of a word that **begins with the *o* sound** — including one spelled with a silent *h*, because the *h* is not there to be heard.
It is the same instinct you have now seen three times: *mucho* into *muy*, *a el* into *al*, and now *o* into *u*. Spanish keeps rearranging small words so the next one stays audible.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¿Café o agua?*
- *siete u ocho*

Twice through:

Before you move on

When does *o* become *u*? (Before a word that **starts with the *o* sound**.)
And is a silent *h* an obstacle? (**No** — the rule listens, it does not read.)

Chapter 234

Ni — Joining Two Absences

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say I want neither of two things.
> *I can say I want neither of two things.*

234.1 ni — joining two absences

Y joins two things you have. *O* offers a choice between them.

Now: neither one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

No quiero café ***ni*** *agua.* — I don't want coffee or water.

ni is Latin ***nec***, and the important thing about it is that the *no* is **inside** the word. It does not mean *or*; it means *and not*.
So it is not the negative twin of *y*. It is a word that carries its own refusal, which is why it can start a phrase on its own: ***Ni*** *café.* — *Not even coffee.*

Why it's said this way

Look again at that sentence and count the negatives.

No *quiero café* ***ni*** *agua.*

Two — and it is correct. English was taught to treat two negatives as cancelling out; Spanish never agreed. Here they **agree with each**

other instead: the sentence is negative, so every part of it that can be negative, is.
This is worth holding on to, because it will keep happening. Once a Spanish sentence turns negative, the negativity spreads rather than doubling back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *No quiero café ni agua*
- *Ni café* — not even coffee

Twice through:

Before you move on

Two negatives in one Spanish sentence — right or wrong? (**Right.** They agree rather than cancel.)
And what is hiding inside *ni*? (A ***no*** — it means *and not*.)

Chapter 235

Review — Four Small Words, One Instinct

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the small joining words without hesitating.
>
> *I can use the small joining words without hesitating.*

235.1 (review)

The two contractions, and nothing else on the list. (*Al*, *del*.)

What you've built

Four chants. Say each, then say what it does.
First. *Voy al café.* — *A* and *el* fuse, always, and *de* and *el* do the same. Those two, and no third.
Second. *¿Quién es?* — the asking word kept for **people**, where *qué* would ask about a thing.
Third. *Siete u ocho.* — *O* steps aside as ***u*** so it is not swallowed by the word after it.
Fourth. *No quiero café ni agua.* — *Ni* carries its own *no*, and two negatives in one Spanish sentence agree rather than cancel.

Grammar Lens: one instinct underneath

Three of those four are the same instinct wearing different clothes. *A el* fuses. *De el* fuses. *O* changes shape. In each case a **small word leaning on a bigger one gives ground**, so that the bigger one stays audible. You saw it first when *mucho* became *muy*.
The fourth is different, and it is the one to keep separate in your head: *ni* is not about sound at all. It is about agreement — once the sentence is negative, its parts stay negative too.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four chants, in order
- *al*, *del*, and then stop — there is no third

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the four is **not** about sound? (***Ni*** — it is about negatives agreeing.)
And what do the other three have in common? (A small word **gives ground** so the next one stays audible.)

Chapter 236

Hablando — An Action Caught in the Middle

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the -ando shape of an -ar verb.

I can form the -ando shape of an -ar verb.

236.1 hablando — an action caught in the middle

Hablo says that I speak. It does not say I am speaking **right now**, this minute, with my mouth open.

Spanish has a separate form for that, and it is built from the infinitive.

Grammar Lens: swap the ending

habl- **ar** → *habl-* ***ando***

hablar	***hablando***
trabajar	***trabajando***
estudiar	***estudiando***

Take the *-ar* off, put *-ando* on. There is nothing to agree with and nothing to conjugate: **one form, for everybody**. After all the endings this book has asked you to learn, that is a holiday.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin had a form for an action thought of as a **thing being done** — the *gerund*, ending in *-ndum*. Spanish kept the ending almost untouched and threw away everything else about it: Latin's gerund had case endings, and Spanish's has none at all.
What survives is the meaning: not *to speak*, not *I speak*, but **speaking** — the action underway, with no beginning and no end attached.
English built its *-ing* separately and lands in almost the same place, which is why *hablando* feels immediately familiar. Almost. The two part company later, and this book will show you where.

Your turn

- *Say it: hablando, trabajando, estudiando*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What replaces the *-ar*? (***-ando***.)
And how many endings does this form have? (**One.** It agrees with nothing.)

Chapter 237

Comiendo, Viviendo — Two Families, One Ending

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the gerund of any regular verb.

I can form the gerund of any regular verb.

237.1 comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending

Hablar gave *hablando*. Now the other two families.

Grammar Lens: -iendo, for both

comer	***comiendo***
beber	***bebiendo***
vivir	***viviendo***
escribir	***escribiendo***

One ending for both. Not *-endo* for *-er* and something else for *-ir* — the same *-iendo*, every time.

Why it's said this way

You have watched this happen before. In the preterite, the *-er* and *-ir* endings turned out to be identical, and the two families you had learned separately quietly became one.
Here it happens again, and more completely: there is not even a difference to notice. So the whole gerund is **two endings for three verb families**:

-ar verbs	***-ando***
everything else	***-iendo***

Two endings, no agreement, no persons. It is the smallest thing this book has asked you to learn, and it unlocks the next chapter entirely.

Your turn

- *Say it: hablando, comiendo, viviendo*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which ending do *-er* and *-ir* verbs share? (***-iendo***.)
And how many endings in total? (**Two**, for three families.)

Chapter 238

Estoy Hablando — The Payoff

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I am doing right now.

I can say what I am doing right now.

238.1 estoy hablando — the payoff

Estar, all the way through: *estoy*, *estás*, *está*, *estamos*, *están*.

And one gerund. Put them side by side.

Grammar Lens: standing in the middle of doing

Estoy hablando. — I am speaking, right now.

Estoy ***comiendo***.	I'm eating
Está ***trabajando***.	he's working
Estamos ***estudiando***.	we're studying

Only *estar* changes. The gerund sits there, the same shape for everybody, which is why the whole construction costs you one verb you already knew and one ending.

Why it's said this way

It had to be *estar* rather than *ser*, and you already know why. *Estar* is the verb for how something **temporarily stands**. An action caught

mid-stride is as temporary as things get.
Now the difference from English, and it is worth having straight. English uses *I'm* + *-ing* for the **future** all the time: *I'm eating with her tomorrow.* Spanish will not.

> *Estoy comiendo* — I am eating, **at this moment**, food in hand.

For tomorrow, Spanish reaches for the form you learned at chapter 49: *voy a comer*. So the two languages look identical here and are not: the Spanish progressive means *now*, and only *now*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Estoy hablando*, *Estoy comiendo*
- *Estoy comiendo* for now, then *Voy a comer* for tomorrow

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which verb carries the person — *estar* or the gerund? (***Estar***.)
And what can the Spanish progressive **not** do that the English one can? (Talk about the **future**.)

Chapter 239

Veo a María — The Little A That Guards People

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can mark the person on the receiving end of a verb.
>
> *I can mark the person on the receiving end of a verb.*

239.1 veo a María — the little a that guards people

Veo — I see. And *a*, which you know as *to*, *towards*.

Watch what happens when what I see is a **person**.

Grammar Lens: it appears, then vanishes

Veo la casa.	I see the house
Veo ***a*** *María.*	I see María

Nothing in the English moved. In the Spanish, a preposition appeared out of nowhere — and it is not optional. *Veo María* is wrong.
It is not doing its usual job either. Nobody is going *towards* María.
The *a* is there purely because the thing being seen is a person.

Why it's said this way

Remember what happened to *quién*: Latin marked the object of a sentence with an **ending**, and Spanish threw those endings away. That was cheap for things — a house is unlikely to be seeing anybody — but expensive for people, because with two people in a sentence, word order alone has to carry who did what.
So Spanish grew a replacement. The little *a* marks the person on the **receiving** end, doing by hand the job the lost ending used to do for free.
Which is why it guards people and ignores houses. The ambiguity it protects against only ever arises with people.

Your turn

- *Say it: Veo la casa*, then *Veo a María*

Twice through:

Before you move on

When does the little *a* appear? (When the thing on the receiving end is a **person**.)
And is it optional? (**No.** *Veo María* is simply wrong.)

Chapter 240

Review — Two Endings and One Little A

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what is happening now, and mark a person correctly.
>
> *I can say what is happening now, and mark a person correctly.*

240.1 (review)

Two endings, three families. (*-ando* for *-ar*; *-iendo* for everything else.)

What you've built

Three chants.
First. *Hablando, comiendo, viviendo.* — one form each, no agreement, no persons. The smallest thing this book has asked of you.
Second. *Estoy comiendo.* — *estar* carries the person, the gerund never moves. And it means **now**: for tomorrow you still say *voy a comer*.
Third. *Veo a María*, but *veo la casa.* — the little *a* in front of a person, and nothing in front of a house.

Grammar Lens: both of these are Latin's absence

The gerund is what is left of a Latin form after its case endings fell off — which is why it has exactly one shape and agrees with nothing.
The personal *a* is what grew back **because** case endings fell off. Latin marked the receiving end with an ending; Spanish marks it with a preposition, but only where it matters, which is people.
One rule is a leftover and the other is a repair. Same cause.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the three chants, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many gerund endings? (**Two.**)
And which of this chapter's two rules is a **repair** rather than a leftover? (The **personal *a*** — it grew to replace a lost ending.)

Chapter 241

Hablasteis — The Form You Were Promised

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use every person of the -ar preterite.

I can use every person of the -ar preterite.

241.1 hablasteis — the form you were promised

The *-ar* past, as far as you have it: *hablé*, *hablaste*, *habló*, *hablamos*, *hablaron*.

Five of six. The review that closed the preterite told you the sixth was still owed. Here it is.

Grammar Lens: -steis

vosotros ***hablasteis*** — you all spoke

Look at it beside the *you* form you already know:

tú	*habla* ***ste***
vosotros	*habla* ***steis***

The same *-ste*, with *-is* stacked on the end. That *-is* is the plural marker you met back in the present, in *habláis*. Nothing here is new; it is two pieces you own, in a row.

Why it's said this way

And with that, the *-ar* preterite is **complete**:
hablé · hablaste · habló · hablamos · hablasteis · hablaron
Six forms, no gaps. It is the first tense in this book you can say straight through without a promissory note at the end.
As with every *vosotros* form, you will hear it in Spain and rarely elsewhere — but you will **read** it everywhere, which is reason enough to know it on sight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablaste*, then *hablasteis*
- all six, straight through

Twice through:

Before you move on

What is stacked on *-ste* to make *-steis*? (The plural ***-is***.)
And how many gaps are left in the *-ar* past? (**None.**)

Chapter 242

Comisteis, Tuvisteis — The Last Gap Closes

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the whole preterite, regular and strong.
>
> *I can use the whole preterite, regular and strong.*

242.1 comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes

Hablasteis. Now the other two families, and then the hard stems.

Grammar Lens: -isteis, for everything else

comer	***comisteis***
vivir	***vivisteis***

One ending for both, exactly as everywhere else in the preterite. The *-er* and *-ir* families stopped being two families the first time you met this tense.

Grammar Lens: and the strong stems take it too

The stems that gave you trouble — *tuv-*, *hic-*, *estuv-*, *dij-* — take the same *-isteis*, with no surprises left in them:
tuvisteis · *hicisteis* · *estuvisteis* · *dijisteis*
And *ser*/*ir*, which share one past: ***fuisteis***.

Why it's said this way

That was the last hole. **The preterite is finished** — every family, every person, regular and strong alike, with nothing outstanding. It has taken a long stretch of this book to build, and it is the largest single structure in it. The review that named this debt out loud can now be read without a caveat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comisteis*, *vivisteis*, *tuvisteis*
- *fuisteis*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which ending do the strong stems take? (The **same** *-isteis*.) And what is still missing from the preterite? (**Nothing.**)

Chapter 243

Hablábamos — The Imperfect Gets Its Plural

Modes: **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use every person of the -aba imperfect.

I can use every person of the -aba imperfect.

243.1 hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural

Hablaba — I used to speak, or I was speaking. The tense for what was going on.

Until now you have had only its singular.

Grammar Lens: the three that were missing

Say them: *nosotros* ***hablábamos***. *Vosotros* ***hablabais***. *Ellos* ***hablaban***.
The *-aba-* runs all the way through. The endings on top of it are the ordinary plural ones you have used since the present tense: *-mos*, *-is*, *-n*.

Why it's said this way

Now look at the accent on ***hablábamos***, because it is the only one in the set and it is doing real work.
The word ends in *-s*, so Spanish's default would put the stress on the

next-to-last syllable: *habla-BA-mos*. But the stress actually falls a syllable earlier, on the *-BA-...* which is not where the default lands, so the accent has to say so.
Without it you would read *hablabamos* with the wrong beat. The mark is not decoration; it is the difference between the word being a past tense and being nothing at all.
None of the other five needs one, because in each of those the default already lands where the stress is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablábamos*, *hablabais*, *hablaban*
- all six, straight through

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the six carries a written accent? (Only ***hablábamos***.)
And what would go wrong without it? (The **stress** would land in the wrong place.)

Chapter 244

Comíamos, Éramos, Íbamos — Every One With an Accent

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the whole imperfect, including all three irregulars.

I can use the whole imperfect, including all three irregulars.

244.1 comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent

The *-ar* imperfect is whole. Now *comía*, which has had only its singular until now.

Grammar Lens: the -ía plural

Say them: *nosotros* ***comíamos***. *Vosotros* ***comíais***. *Ellos* ***comían***.
And here the accent is on **every** form, not just one. The *-ía* puts an *i* and an *a* next to each other, and Spanish would ordinarily run two such vowels together into a single beat. The accent keeps them apart, so *comía* stays three syllables rather than collapsing into two.
So the two imperfect sets are mirror images: in *-aba* only one form needs a mark, and in *-ía* they all do.

Grammar Lens: and the three irregulars

Spanish has exactly **three** irregular imperfects, and you have had their singulars for a long time. Their plurals:

ser	***éramos*** · *erais* · *eran*
ir	***íbamos*** · *ibais* · *iban*
ver	***veíamos*** · *veíais* · *veían*

That is the whole irregular list for this tense — three verbs, and now every form of all three. **The imperfect is complete.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comíamos*, *comíais*, *comían*
- *éramos*, *íbamos*, *veíamos*

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many *-ía* forms carry an accent? (**All** of them.)
And how many irregular imperfects are there in the language? (**Three** — and you have them all.)

Chapter 245

Review — Two Tenses Finished

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say both past tenses straight through, with no gaps.
>
> *I can say both past tenses straight through, with no gaps.*

245.1 (review)

The form the book owed you longest. (*Hablasteis.*)

What you've built

Two chants, and each is a whole tense.
The preterite. *Hablé · hablaste · habló · hablamos · hablasteis · hablaron.* Six of six, and the same for *-er*, for *-ir*, and for every strong stem.
The imperfect. *Hablaba · hablabas · hablaba · hablábamos · hablabais · hablaban.* Six of six, with exactly three irregular verbs in the whole language — *ser*, *ir*, *ver* — and you hold all of them.
Neither of those sentences has a note at the end saying the rest is coming later. That is new.

Grammar Lens: where the accents fall

The one thing worth keeping separate is the accents, because the two imperfect sets behave in opposite ways.
In the *-aba* set, **one** form carries a mark: *hablábamos*, and only

because the stress falls where the default would not put it.
In the *-ía* set, **every** form carries one, and for a different reason entirely: the *i* and the *a* would otherwise run together into a single beat, and the accent holds them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the preterite, all six
- the imperfect, all six

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many irregular imperfects? (**Three.**)
And how many gaps are left in either past tense? (**None.**)

Chapter 246

Para Mí — The Pronouns That Stand on Their Own

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use a pronoun after a preposition.

I can use a pronoun after a preposition.

246.1 para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own

You have *me* and *te* — the little object pronouns that lean on a verb: *me llamo*, *te quiero*.

Put a preposition in front and they change shape.

Grammar Lens: after a preposition

El café es ***para mí***. — The coffee is for me.

Say them: *para* ***mí***. *Para* ***ti***. *Para* ***él***, *para* ***ella***.
Only the first two persons actually change. From *él* onward the form is the same one you already use as a subject — which is why this list is shorter to learn than it looks.

Why it's said this way

Now the accent on ***mí***, and it is the kind you have met before: one that tells two identical words apart.

mi	**my** — *mi café*
mí	**me**, after a preposition — *para mí*

Same letters, same sound, different jobs — so Spanish marks the stressed one, exactly as it marks *tú* against *tu* and *él* against *el*.
And *ti* has **no** accent, which looks inconsistent and is not: there is no other *ti* to confuse it with. The mark is only ever spent where something needs separating.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *para mí*, *para ti*, *para él*
- *mi café*, then *para mí*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which *mi* carries the accent? (The one meaning **me**, after a preposition.)
And why has *ti* none? (Nothing to **separate** it from.)

Chapter 247

Conmigo, Contigo — The Word That Says With Twice

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say with me and with you.

I can say with me and with you.

247.1 conmigo · contigo — the word that says "with" twice

Para mí, *para ti*. The pattern is steady: preposition, then the stressed pronoun.

One preposition refuses to follow it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Con means *with*. But *with me* is not *con mí*:

> *¿Vienes* ***conmigo****?* — Are you coming with me?

Here is where it came from, and it is one of the best stories in the language. Latin did not put *cum* in front of a pronoun; it stuck it on the **end**: ***mecum***, literally *me-with*.
Spanish inherited that as *-migo* — and by then nobody could hear a preposition in it any more. It had become a meaningless tail. So Spanish put *con* back on the **front**, where prepositions belong.
Which means ***conmigo*** contains *with* **twice**: once at each end, in two

different languages, fifteen centuries apart. And *contigo* does exactly the same.

Why it's said this way

This is the same instinct you saw turn *mucho* into *muy* and *a el* into *al*, running the other way. Spanish reshapes small words to keep them audible — usually by wearing them down, and here, once, by **doubling** one that had worn away to nothing.
There are only two of these. From *él* onward the ordinary pattern returns: *con él*, *con ella*.

Your turn

- *Say it: conmigo*, *contigo*, then *con él*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Why does *conmigo* begin with *con* when it already ends in one? (Because the **old one stopped being audible**.)
How many pronouns do this? (**Two** — *conmigo*, *contigo*.)

Chapter 248

¡Qué Grande! — The Same Word, Exclaiming

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can react to something with force, in two words.

I can react to something with force, in two words.

248.1 ¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming

¿Qué es esto? asks. And you have had the upside-down exclamation mark since the writing chapters, with nothing much to put between the pair.

Here is what goes there.

Grammar Lens: qué in front of an adjective

¡Qué grande! — How big! ***¡Qué bien!*** — How good! / Great!

No verb needed, nothing else needed. *Qué* plus an adjective or an adverb, between the two marks, and you have said something with force.
¡Qué bien! in particular is worth having on the tip of your tongue. It is what Spanish says when English says *nice!* or *great!*, and it costs two words.

Why it's said this way

Notice the accent. It is there in *¿qué?* and it is here in *¡qué!*, and by now you know why: that mark has never been about questions. It marks the word **carrying the force** of the sentence.
You saw the same thing when a reported question kept its accent inside a sentence with no question marks at all. Asking and exclaiming are two jobs, and the accent is the one thing they share.
Plain *que* — no accent — is the joint you use for reporting and for relative clauses. It carries nothing, so it is marked with nothing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¡Qué grande!*, *¡Qué bien!*
- *¿qué?* then *¡qué!*, and hear that only the frame changed

Twice through:

Before you move on

What follows *qué* in an exclamation? (An **adjective** or an adverb — no verb needed.)
And does it keep its accent? (**Yes** — it is still the word doing the work.)

Chapter 249

María, Ven — Naming Who You Are Talking To

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can address somebody by name.

I can address somebody by name.

249.1 María, ven — naming who you are talking to

Ven — come. *¿Cómo estás?* — how are you.

Both are aimed at somebody. Now say **who**.

Grammar Lens: the comma is the grammar

***María**, ven. ¿Cómo estás, **María**? **Profesor**, ¿puedo hablar?*

The name can go at the front or at the end, and either way it is fenced off by a **comma**. That comma is not decoration — it is the entire grammatical marking. There is nothing else to learn here.

Why it's said this way

Latin had a whole **case** for this — a set of endings whose only job was addressing somebody. Spanish replaced all of it with a pause.
That is the shortest possible summary of what became of Latin's

endings. Twice now you have watched the same thing: the endings went, and something small and audible took over the work — a preposition for the personal *a*, and here a comma.
And notice the person you address takes **no** *a*. *Veo a María* has María on the receiving end of the seeing; *María, ven* has her doing the coming. Same name, opposite roles, and the comma is what tells them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *María, ven*
- *Veo a María*, then *María, ven*, and hear the difference

Twice through:

Before you move on

What did Spanish replace Latin's addressing case with? (A **comma**.)
And does the addressed person take an *a*? (**No.**)

Chapter 250

Review — Four Small Things

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the stressed pronouns, exclaim, and address somebody.
>
> *I can use the stressed pronouns, exclaim, and address somebody.*

250.1 (review)

After a preposition: *para* ***mí***, *para* ***ti***, *para* ***él***.

What you've built

Four chants.
First. *El café es para mí.* — the stressed pronouns, and only the first two persons change shape at all.
Second. *¿Vienes conmigo?* — the two that fuse, each carrying *with* at both ends.
Third. *¡Qué bien!* — the asking word exclaiming, accent intact.
Fourth. *María, ven.* — a comma, and that is the whole grammar of addressing somebody.

Grammar Lens: the accent has never been about questions

Two accents in this chapter, doing two different jobs, and neither is about questions.
On ***mí*** it separates twins: *mi* is *my*, *mí* is *me*. On ***qué*** it marks the word carrying the force, which is why it survives into an exclamation

and into a reported question that has no marks at all.
And three of this chapter's four rules exist for one reason: Latin's endings fell away, and something audible had to take over. A stressed pronoun, a preposition doubled at both ends, and a comma.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the four chants, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which *mí* takes the accent? (The one meaning **me**.)
And what do three of this chapter's four rules have in common? (Latin's **endings fell away**, and something audible replaced them.)

Chapter 251

Ahí, Allí — The Other Two Places

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say where something is, on any of the three sides.
>
> *I can say where something is, on any of the three sides.*

251.1 ahí · allí — the other two places

Aquí — here. You have had it a long time, on its own.

And you know three pointing words: *este*, *ese*, *aquel*. The places work the same way, and they have been waiting for their other two.

Grammar Lens: one for one

Say them: ***aquí***, by me. ***Ahí***, by you. ***Allí***, away from us both. They line up with the pointing words exactly:

este libro	***aquí***	by me
ese libro	***ahí***	by you
aquel libro	***allí***	by neither

So this is not a new system to learn. It is the **same** system, answering the same question — whose side is it on — with a word for the place instead of a word for the thing.

Why it's said this way

All three carry a written accent, and all three carry it for the same reason: each is stressed on its **last** syllable, and each ends in a vowel, where Spanish would otherwise stress the one before.
A-QUÍ. A-HÍ. A-LLÍ. Say them and you can hear the beat landing at the end every time.
English gets by with two — *here* and *there* — and patches the third on when it must: *over there*. Spanish keeps all three separate, exactly as it does with the pointing words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aquí*, *ahí*, *allí*
- *este libro aquí*, *ese libro ahí*, *aquel libro allí*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which place word sits on the listener's side? (***Ahí.***)
And why do all three take an accent? (Each is stressed on its **last** syllable.)

Chapter 252

Ahora, Hoy — Now and Today

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can place what I am saying in time.

I can place what I am saying in time.

252.1 ahora — now

Mañana — tomorrow. *La hora* — the hour.

One more time word, and it is hiding something you already know.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Ahora — *now*. Look at what is sitting in the middle of it: ***hora***, the word for *hour* you learned long ago.
Latin said ***hac hora*** — *at this hour*. Two words, worn together into one, and the *h* in the middle went silent along the way. *Now* is literally **this hour**. Spanish is full of these — phrases that stopped being phrases.

Why it's said this way

And now you can put a time on the tense you learned for the moment:

Ahora *estoy comiendo.* — Right now, I'm eating.

Notice which tense it takes. *Ahora* goes with the progressive, because both mean *at this instant* — the word and the tense are saying the

same thing about the clock, which is why they sit together so comfortably.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ahora*, then *mañana*
- *Ahora estoy comiendo*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Ahora was which two Latin words? (***Hac hora*** — *this hour.*) And how do you say "right now I am eating"? (*Ahora estoy comiendo.*) Next: the same trick, worn down even further, in a word of three letters.

252.2 hoy — today

Ahora was *hac hora* — *at this hour*, two Latin words worn into one.

Here is the same wearing-down, gone further.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hoy — *today.* Latin said ***hodie***, which was itself *hoc die*, *this day.* So the pair is symmetrical, and neither has parts any more: *this hour* wore down to *ahora*, *this day* wore down to three letters. A phrase became a word, and then the word became short enough that nobody hears the phrase in it.

Set the three against each other and your day has a shape: *hoy*, the day you are in; *ahora*, the instant inside it; *mañana*, the one that has not come.

Why it's said this way

Ahora pulls the progressive, because both mean *at this instant. Hoy* covers a whole day, so it takes the ordinary forms:

> ***Hoy*** *voy a comer con ella.* — Today I'm going to eat with her.

That is the going-to future, which is how Spanish says the thing English says with *I'm eating.* A day is wide enough to hold something that has not happened yet, and an instant is not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ahora*, *hoy*, *mañana*
- *Hoy voy a comer con ella*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Hoy was which Latin word? (***Hodie***, which was *this day.*)
And which of your three time words is the widest? (***Hoy*** — a whole day, with *ahora* somewhere inside it.)

Chapter 253

Unos, Unas — The Plural of One

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say some of a thing, as against the thing in general.
>
> *I can say some of a thing, as against the thing in general.*

253.1 unos · unas — the plural of "one"

Un libro, *una casa*. And you know where they came from: Latin ***unus***, the number **one**.

Which raises a question. What could a plural of *one* possibly mean?

Grammar Lens: it stops meaning one

> ***unos*** *libros* — some books, a few books ***unas*** *casas* — some houses

The moment it goes plural it stops being a number and becomes a **vague quantity**: a handful, several, a few. Not one, and not counted. English does the same trick with *a* and *some* and never notices, because it changes the word. Spanish keeps the word and changes only the ending.

Why it's said this way

Now the useful part, because you already know the alternative.

Compro ***libros****.*	I buy books — books in general
Compro ***unos*** *libros.*	I buy **some** books — a few, this once

The bare plural you learned long ago talks about the **kind** of thing.
Unos picks out a small, unspecified number of them.
So they are not interchangeable, and the difference is one you can hear in English too — *I buy books* is a habit, *I buy some books* is an occasion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *un libro*, then *unos libros*
- *Compro libros*, then *Compro unos libros*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What does *unos* mean, given that *un* means one? (**Some** — a few, uncounted.)
And what does the **bare** plural mean instead? (The **kind** of thing, in general.)

Chapter 254

Vuestro — The Last Possessive

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use every possessive in the set.

I can use every possessive in the set.

254.1 vuestro — the last possessive

Nuestra casa — our house. And *vosotros* — you all.

One possessive is still missing, and the pair you just said gives it away.

Grammar Lens: the pair

nosotros →	***nuestro*** *libro*, ***nuestra*** *casa*
vosotros →	***vuestro*** *libro*, ***vuestra*** *casa*

Same ending, same agreement, same position in front of the noun. Once you have seen it beside *nuestro* there is nothing left to learn — which is why it has been safe to leave until last.

Why it's said this way

And that completes the set. Say them in order:
mi · *tu* · *su* · *nuestro* · *vuestro* · *su*
Six, and only two of them — *nuestro* and *vuestro* — change for gender. *Mi*, *tu* and *su* do not care whether the thing is masculine or feminine;

they only change for **number**.
As with every *vosotros* form, you will meet *vuestro* mainly in Spain, and you will read it everywhere. It costs one word to know it and it closes the set.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nuestra casa*, then *vuestra casa*
- all six, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which possessive goes with *vosotros*? (***Vuestro***.)
And how many of the six change for gender? (**Two.**)

Chapter 255

Vi, Di — The Shortest Pasts

Modes: **voice** (1) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the preterite of ver and dar.
>
> *I can use the preterite of ver and dar.*

255.1 vi — the shortest past in the language

The *-er* past, first person: *comí*, with an accent, because the stress lands at the end.

Now do the same to *ver*, whose stem is a single letter.

Grammar Lens: nothing left to accent

ver → ***vi***, ***viste***, ***vio***

Look at *vi* and *vio*: **no accent**, where *comí* and *comió* both had one. And the reason is not an exception. A written accent exists to say *the beat is here, not where you would expect.* A word of **one syllable** has nowhere else the beat could be, so there is nothing to correct. Spanish does not spend a mark on a choice that does not exist.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comí*, then *vi*, and hear which one needs the mark

- *vi*, *viste*, *vio*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Why does *vi* carry no accent? (**One syllable** — the beat has nowhere else to fall.)
And what is "I saw"? (***Vi***.) Next: a second verb that does the same thing, and it is one you have never met.

255.2 di — the verb that changed families in the past

Vi, *viste*, *vio* — bare, because one syllable has nowhere else to put the beat.

A second verb does the same, and it is one you have never met.

Grammar Lens: dar, which behaves like an -er verb

Dar means *to give*. It is an *-ar* verb — and in the preterite it flatly refuses to behave like one:

dar → ***di***, ***diste***, ***dio***, ***dimos***, ***disteis***, ***dieron***

Those are the *-er* endings, on an *-ar* verb, with the same one-syllable forms going bare. *Ver* does the same in the plural: *vimos*, *visteis*, *vieron*.
Two verbs, one shared oddity, and now the last two named irregulars of the preterite are yours.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *di*, *diste*, *dio*
- *vi*, *viste*, *vio*, then *di*, *diste*, *dio*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which endings does *dar* take in the past? (The ***-er*** ones, though it is an *-ar* verb.)
And what does *dar* mean? (*To give.*)

Chapter 256

Review — Five Sets, Finished

Modes: **voice** (2) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use every one of the sets the book had left half-taught.
>
> *I can use every one of the sets the book had left half-taught.*

256.1 (review)

Three places, in order. (*Aquí*, *ahí*, *allí*.)

What you've built

Five chants, and each one finishes something.
Places. *Aquí*, ***ahí***, ***allí*** — one for each of *este*, *ese*, *aquel*.
Times. ***Ahora***, ***hoy***, *mañana* — now, today, tomorrow.
Articles. *Un libro*, ***unos*** *libros* — one, then a few.
Possessives. *Nuestra casa*, ***vuestra*** *casa* — and with that the set of six is closed.
Two verbs. ***Vi***, ***di*** — the shortest pasts in the language.

Grammar Lens: a gap in a set is hard to see

Every one of these was a set you already partly had. You had *aquí* without *ahí*. You had *mañana* without *hoy*. You had *un* without *unos*, and *nuestro* without *vuestro*.
That is a particular kind of gap, and it is harder to notice than a missing subject, because nothing feels absent — you simply use the

half you have and route around the rest.
And two small rules came out of it worth keeping. *Vi* and *di* take **no accent**, because a one-syllable word has nowhere else the beat could fall. And *dar*, though an *-ar* verb, takes the *-er* endings in the past.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the five chants, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many possessives are in the closed set? (**Six.**)
And which place word matches *ese*? (***Ahí*** — the listener's side.)

256.2 Review — two pasts, both finished

"You all ate." (*Comisteis.*) "We used to eat." (*Comíamos.*)

What you've built

Two whole tenses closed, and each closed on one small thing.
The preterite ran out of gaps when a single ending, **-isteis**, turned out to cover every verb that is not an *-ar* verb — and the strong stems with it. *Comisteis. Tuvisteis.* One syllable, and the last hole was filled.
The imperfect closed on *comíamos*, and on the only three verbs that refuse the pattern: *éramos*, *íbamos*, *veíamos*.

Why it's said this way

Set the two imperfect sets side by side and one of them is covered in accents.

> *hablábamos* — one accent, in one form. *comíamos* — an accent on **every** form of the set.

That is not a spelling habit. In *comíamos* the *í* and the *a* are two separate syllables, and Spanish would otherwise run them together into one. The accent is what keeps them apart — take it off and the word stops being a past tense.

And one verb sits across the line. ***Dar*** is an *-ar* verb, yet in the preterite it took the *-er* endings and went as bare as *vi*: **di**. I gave.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablamos, hablasteis, hablaron* — then *comimos, comisteis, comieron*
- *hablábamos*, *comíamos* — and hear where the stress lands

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which ending closed the preterite for everything that is not an *-ar* verb? (**-isteis**, strong stems included.) And how many verbs break the imperfect? (**Three** — *ser*, *ir*, *ver*.)

256.3 Review — the column that belongs to *vosotros*

The pronoun for "you all," in Spain. (*Vosotros.*) "You all go." (*Vais.*)

What you've built

These arrived one tense at a time, chapters apart. Collected, they are one column.
Present. *Vais.* **Preterite, ordinary stem.** *Comisteis.* **Preterite, strong stem.** *Tuvisteis.* **And what belongs to you all.** *Vuestro.*
Four forms, four different chapters, one addressee.

Why it's said this way

The pairing is what makes this cheap to hold.

nosotros → *nuestro.* · *vosotros* → *vuestro.*

Same shape, same ending, same job. Once you see the first pair the second costs nothing — and with *vuestro* in place, the possessives have no gaps left.

Worth saying plainly: most Spanish speakers, across the Americas, do not use this column at all. They say *ustedes* and reach for the *they* forms. You are learning it because you will **read** and **hear** it constantly, not because you will be required to produce it.

Your turn

- *Say it: vais*, *comisteis*, *tuvisteis*, *vuestro* — one addressee, four forms

Twice through:

Before you move on

What belongs to *vosotros*? (***Vuestro***.) "You all had"? (***Tuvisteis***.) And who says these forms? (**Spain** — elsewhere *ustedes* takes the work.)

Chapter 257

Hablo — One Form, Two Readings

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the plain present for both a habit and this moment.
>
> *I can use the plain present for both a habit and this moment.*

257.1 hablo — one form, two readings

Somebody phones and asks what you are doing. Answer with *comer*, in the present, without using the *-iendo* form.

You said *como*. Now think about what that sentence actually claimed.

Grammar Lens: it was doing both all along

> *Como.* — I eat. **And also**: I'm eating, right now, this minute.

One form, two readings. The **durative** one is the habit — *I eat at eight.* The **actual** one is this moment — *I'm eating, don't ring back.*
English keeps two shapes; Spanish keeps one.
You have been using both since the very first verb, without anybody naming either.

Why it's said this way

Which raises the obvious question about the form you learned nineteen chapters ago. If *como* already means *I'm eating*, what is *estoy comiendo* for?
Insistence. The progressive is not the ordinary way to say what you are doing now — it is the way to say it when the *now* is the point.

> — *¿Qué haces?* — *Como.* (perfectly normal) — *¡Estoy comiendo!* — I'm **in the middle of eating**, leave me alone.

So the progressive is **optional** where English's is compulsory. An English speaker reaches for *estoy comiendo* every time and sounds oddly emphatic; a Spanish speaker uses the plain present and saves the long form for when it means something.
This is worth more than it looks. It means you already had a complete present tense before that chapter, and the progressive was an addition rather than a repair.

Your turn

- *Say it: Como* as an answer, then *Estoy comiendo* as a protest

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many readings does the plain present carry? (**Two** — the habit and this moment.)
And is the progressive required for *right now*? (**No.** It is for insisting.)

Chapter 258

Hablo, Hablas, Habla — The Ending Says Who

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can state why Spanish verbs change their endings, and why the pronoun can go.
>
> *I can state why Spanish verbs change their endings, and why the pronoun can go.*

258.1 hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who

Say *hablar* through, all six. (*Hablo, hablas, habla, hablamos, habláis, hablan.*)

You have done that hundreds of times. Now here is the question nobody has asked you: **why is the ending different every time?**

Grammar Lens: naming what you already do

Because the verb **agrees with its subject**. Whoever is doing the action decides the ending, every time, in every tense you have learned.

> *Nosotros hablamos* — the *-mos* is there **because** the subject is *we*.

That is the rule, stated plainly for the first time, and you have obeyed it perfectly for two hundred chapters. Being able to say it matters,

because an examiner can ask, and because it explains something you were told long ago without a reason.

Why it's said this way

At the very beginning you learned you could drop the pronoun — *hablo*, not *yo hablo*. It was presented as a habit of the language.
It is not a habit. It is a **consequence**. The ending already carries the subject, so the pronoun would be saying a second time what the verb has already said. Spanish drops it because it is genuinely redundant.

> *Hablo* — the *-o* IS the *yo*.

Which is why the pronoun comes back exactly when the ending stops being enough: *habla* could be *he*, *she*, or *usted*, so a speaker who needs to be clear says *ella habla*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablo*, and name what the *-o* is doing
- *ella habla*, and say why the pronoun is needed there

Twice through:

Before you move on

What does a Spanish verb agree with? (Its **subject**.)
And is dropping the pronoun a habit or a consequence? (A **consequence** — the ending already said it.)

Chapter 259

Mucha Agua — When the Quantity Word Agrees

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can decide whether a quantity word agrees or freezes.

I can decide whether a quantity word agrees or freezes.

259.1 mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees

Mucho café. And *muy grande*, where the short form appeared because an adjective followed.

Now try *mucho* in front of a **feminine** noun and listen to what your mouth wants.

Grammar Lens: in front of a noun, it agrees

mucha *agua* · ***muchos*** *libros* · ***pocas*** *casas*

When *mucho* or *poco* sits in front of a noun it is behaving like an adjective, so it does what every adjective does: it takes the gender and the number of the noun.
And *agua* is the test case you already own. It takes *el* for a sound reason while being feminine underneath — so it is ***mucha*** *agua*, never *mucho agua*. The quantity word reports the real gender, exactly as the object pronoun did.

Grammar Lens: after a verb, it freezes

Now move it behind a verb, where there is no noun for it to lean on:

> *Ella trabaja* ***mucho****.* — She works a lot. *Ella come* ***poco****.* — She eats little.

No agreement. Not *mucha* because *ella* is feminine — the word is not describing *her*, it is describing the working. A verb has no gender and no number, so there is nothing to agree with, and the word freezes in its plain masculine-singular shape.
So one test decides it: **is it leaning on a noun, or on a verb?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mucha agua*, *muchos libros*, *pocas casas*
- *Ella trabaja mucho* — and notice nothing agreed

Twice through:

Before you move on

In front of a noun, does *mucho* agree? (**Yes** — gender and number.) And after a verb? (**No.** There is nothing there to agree with.)

Chapter 260

María, España — The Nouns That Need No Article

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can use names and titles with the right article, or none.

I can use names and titles with the right article, or none.

260.1 María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article

El libro, *la casa*. The article's job is to say **which one**.

Now try putting one in front of a person's name and hear how wrong it sounds.

Grammar Lens: nothing left for the article to do

*Veo a **María**.* — not *a la María. Vivo en **España**.* — not *en la España.*

A **proper noun** — a name, a country, a city — already points at exactly one thing in the world. The article exists to narrow a noun down to one, and here there is nothing left to narrow. So it goes. That is the rule you have been following since the first time you said *Me llamo…*, and it has never been stated.

Why it's said this way

Now the part that catches people, and it follows from the same logic.

Hablo con ***el profesor*** *García.*	talking **about** him — article
Profesor *García, ¿puedo hablar?*	talking **to** him — none

A title is not a name. *Profesor* is an ordinary noun, so it takes an article like any other — until you turn and address the person, at which point you are not identifying them for anybody. You are calling them. And a vocative takes no article, exactly as it takes no personal *a*. Same rule underneath: the article says which one, and it appears precisely when that job needs doing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Veo a María*, *Vivo en España*
- *el profesor García*, then *Profesor García, …*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Why do names take no article? (They already point at **one** thing.) And when does a title lose its article? (When you are **addressing** the person.)

Chapter 261

Review — Four Rules You Already Obeyed

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can state four rules I had been following without knowing.
>
> *I can state four rules I had been following without knowing.*

261.1 (review)

What decides the ending on a Spanish verb? (Its **subject**.)

What you've built

Four chants, and not one of them taught you anything you could not already do.
First. *Como* means *I eat* **and** *I'm eating.* One form, two readings, and the long form is for insisting.
Second. The ending agrees with the subject — which is *why* the pronoun can go, rather than a separate habit.
Third. *Mucha agua*, but *trabaja mucho.* It agrees on a noun and freezes on a verb.
Fourth. *Veo a María*, not *a la María.* A name already points at one thing, so the article has no work to do.

Grammar Lens: why naming it was worth a chapter

You have obeyed all four of these for hundreds of chapters without being told any of them. So what changed?
Two things. A rule you can state is a rule you can **check** when you are unsure — and doing something correctly by reflex is no help at all when somebody asks you directly why.
And naming one rule often explains another. Once *the ending agrees with the subject* is said out loud, dropping the pronoun stops being a quirk to memorise and becomes an obvious consequence. Three of this book's earliest lessons quietly make more sense than they did yesterday.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the four chants, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many readings does the plain present carry? (**Two**.)
And what did any of these four chapters teach you to *do* that you could not do before? (**Nothing** — they taught you to **say** what you were already doing.)

Chapter 262

Primero, Segundo, Tercero — Counting in Order

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say which one in a line something is.
>
> *I can say which one in a line something is.*

262.1 primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order

Uno, dos, tres — how many.

Now the other kind of counting: not how many, but **which one in the line**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Say them: ***primero***, ***segundo***, ***tercero***, ***cuarto***, ***quinto***.
And the second one has a story. Latin ***secundus*** did not mean *two*. It meant **following**, from the verb *sequi*, *to follow* — so second place is literally *the one that comes after*. English *second* is the very same word, and *sequence* and *consequence* are its cousins.
They behave as adjectives: *la* ***segunda*** *casa*, *los* ***primeros*** *libros*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *primero*, *segundo*, *tercero*, *cuarto*, *quinto*
- *la segunda casa*, *los primeros libros*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Give the first three in order. (***Primero***, ***segundo***, ***tercero***.) And what did *secundus* mean before it meant *second*? (**Following** — the one that comes after.) Next: where these words stand, and what happens to two of them when they get there.

262.2 el primer libro — where an ordinal stands

Primero, *segundo*, *tercero*. And the rule you have carried for a long time: a Spanish adjective follows its noun.

These do not.

Why it's said this way

Two things set them apart from ordinary adjectives.
They go in front. Where *grande* follows its noun, an ordinal leads: *el* ***primer*** *libro*, not *el libro primero*.
And there — did you catch it? ***Primer***, not *primero*. In front of a masculine singular noun, *primero* and *tercero* drop their final *o*.

el ***primer*** *libro*	but *la* ***primera*** *casa*
el ***tercer*** *libro*	but *la* ***tercera*** *casa*

You have met this exact habit twice already: *mucho* to *muy*, and *malo* to *mal*. Three times now, so it is not a set of exceptions — it is what Spanish does to a word leaning on a masculine noun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el primer libro*, *la primera casa*
- *muy*, *mal*, *primer* — one habit, three sightings

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does an ordinal stand? (**Before** the noun, unlike other adjectives.)
And which two lose their *o*? (***Primero*** and ***tercero***, in front of a masculine noun.)

Chapter 263

Uno... Otro — Splitting a Pair

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say something different about each of two things.
>
> *I can say something different about each of two things.*

263.1 uno... otro — splitting a pair

Un libro — one book. *Unos libros* — some books.

Now: two books, and you want to say something different about each.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Otro — *the other*. Latin ***alter***, which did not mean *any other*: it meant **the other of two**, the second of a pair.
English keeps that sense in *alternative* and *alternate* — one, then the other, back and forth.
And it takes no article. *Otro libro*, never *un otro libro*.

Grammar Lens: one at each end

> ***Uno*** *es grande,* ***otro*** *es bueno.* — One is big, the other is good.

The pattern splits a pair across the two halves of the sentence: *uno* takes the first, *otro* takes the second. Neither needs a noun after it, because the noun was already named or is obvious.

It agrees, like everything else: *una… otra* for two feminine things, *unos… otros* for two groups.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Uno es grande, otro es pequeño*
- *una… otra*, *unos… otros*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What goes at the first half, and what at the second? (***Uno***, then ***otro***.)
And does *otro* take an article? (**No.**)

263.2 Review — picking one, pairing two, refusing both

"There," near you. (*Ahí.*) "Over there," away from us both. (*Allí.*)

What you've built

Here is a whole conversation, and it uses everything in this review.

> *— ¿Cuál quieres? ¿Este de **aquí** o ese de **ahí**? — **Ni** uno **ni** otro. Quiero aquel de **allí**.*

Take it apart.
By distance. *Aquí*, *ahí*, *allí* — my side, your side, neither side. They line up one for one with *este*, *ese*, *aquel*, because both sets answer the same question: whose side is it on?
By pairing. ***Uno** … **otro***. Not "one and any other" — *otro* is Latin *alter*, the other of **two**. It always implies a partner, which is why the pattern splits a pair across the two halves of a sentence.

Why it's said this way

By refusing both. *Ni uno ni otro.*
Count the negatives in the full sentence and English would object: *No quiero ni uno ni otro* has two. Spanish wants both, because ***ni*** is Latin *nec* and carries its *no* inside it. The *no* on the verb and the *ni* on each item are not fighting; they are agreeing.
That is the same instinct as the pointing words. Spanish would rather mark a thing in every place it can be marked than mark it once and hope. The double negative is not a sloppy extra — it is the language being consistent with itself.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the whole exchange, both turns, at speed

Twice through:

Before you move on

Otro is the other of how many? (**Two**.) Which word carries a *no* already inside it? (***Ni.***) And which place word goes with *aquel*? (***Allí.***)

Chapter 264

Comer Es Bueno — The Infinitive as Subject

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name an activity and say something about it.

I can name an activity and say something about it.

264.1 comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject

El libro es grande. A noun, then *es*, then what it is.

Now put an **action** in the noun's place.

Grammar Lens: the infinitive stands there

Comer *es bueno.* — Eating is good. ***Hablar*** *español es bueno.* — Speaking Spanish is good.

The infinitive — the plain dictionary form — simply occupies the subject slot, and the sentence carries on as normal. Nothing is added and nothing changes shape.
Note the verb after it: ***es***, singular. An action counts as one thing, however many words are wrapped around it.

Why it's said this way

Here is the trap, and it is entirely an English one.
English uses *-ing* for this — *eating is good* — and you have an *-ing* form now. So it is tempting to reach for ***comiendo***.

Comiendo es bueno. — **wrong.**

The gerund never does this job in Spanish. It is for an action **underway**, leaning on *estar*; it is not a name for the activity. The infinitive is the name.
So the two languages divide the work differently, and Spanish's division is the simpler one: English argues about *to eat* against *eating*, and Spanish uses one form for both.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Comer es bueno*
- *Hablar español es bueno*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which form names an activity — the infinitive or the gerund? (The **infinitive**.)
And what is the gerund for? (An action **underway**, with *estar*.)

264.2 Review — what happens where two words touch

"One book." (*Un libro.*) "The first book." (*El primer libro.*) Neither word is whole.

What you've built

One: the word bites itself short.
Uno → *un libro. Primero* → *primer libro. Mucho* → *muy. Malo* → *mal.*

And the biting has a condition: it happens **in front of the noun** and nowhere else. Say *el libro primero* and the *o* comes straight back. That position is also where an ordinal lives in the first place — *el primer libro*, not *el libro primer*.
Your scale of degree is built out of exactly this. *Poco*, ***bastante***, *muy* — and the top of it, *muy*, is *mucho* with the end chewed off.

Why it's said this way

Two: the two words fuse.

a + *el* → ***al***. · *de* + *el* → ***del***.

And then the list stops. Two obligatory contractions, no others — a rare thing to be able to say about any grammar.
Three: the word changes shape to stay audible. *O* is a single letter, and in front of a word starting with *o-* a single letter would vanish. So it becomes *u*: *siete* ***u*** *ocho*.
And the one that went furthest. Latin put *cum* on the **end** of the pronoun — *mēcum*, "with me." Spanish stopped hearing that ending as a word and put ***con*** back on the front. **Conmigo** therefore says *with* twice, and it has been getting away with it for a thousand years.

Your turn

- *Say it: uno → un libro, primero → primer libro, mucho → muy*

Before you move on

How many obligatory contractions does Spanish have? (**Two** — *al*, *del*.) Where does *primero* lose its *o*? (**In front of** a masculine noun.) And what does *conmigo* say twice? (***With***.)

Chapter 265

Hoy Como en Casa — The Pieces That Move

Modes: **voice** (2) **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can move when and where around a sentence, and use the front for emphasis.

I can move when and where around a sentence, and use the front for emphasis.

265.1 hoy como en casa — the pieces that move

Como en casa. — I eat at home. Now add *hoy*, and put it wherever sounds right to you.

Whatever you chose was probably correct, and that is the lesson.

Grammar Lens: three placements, one meaning

Hoy *como en casa. Como* ***hoy*** *en casa. Como en casa* ***hoy****.*

All three are Spanish, and all three mean the same thing. The pieces that say **when** and **where** are not pinned to a position the way the subject and the verb are.
You can stack them, too: *Hoy como en casa con María.* When, where, with whom — and the order among them is yours.

Why it's said this way

The freedom is not free, and it is not decoration. **The front of the sentence is the emphatic position.** Putting *hoy* first says *today*, as against some other day. Leaving it at the end mentions it and moves on.
So the choice is not stylistic. It is how a Spanish speaker does what an English speaker does by stressing a word out loud.
And notice why this is possible at all. The verb ending already says who is acting, and the personal *a* already marks who is on the receiving end — so nothing depends on position to keep the roles straight. Latin's endings paid for word order when they fell; the pieces Spanish kept are what let the rest move.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all three placements of *hoy*
- *Hoy como en casa* as though correcting somebody about the day

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which position is the emphatic one? (The **front**.)
And what makes the freedom safe? (The **endings** already say who is doing what.)

265.2 Review — what the ending carries, and what happens when it carries nothing

"We go." (*Vamos.*) "They go." (*Van.*) No pronoun needed for either.

What you've built

The ending says who. That one fact has been paying for two things at once.
It pays for the missing pronoun. *Van* is three letters and it still

tells you the subject is plural and is not you. Nothing was lost when *ellos* went; the information was never in *ellos*.
And it pays for a second reading. *Hablo* is "I speak" and also "I am speaking." The progressive was never required — *estoy hablando* is available, not obligatory.
So *vamos*, *vais*, *van* each do the same double duty: a person, and a right-now.

Why it's said this way

Now turn it around. What happens to a verb form that names **no** person at all?
It stops being a verb and starts behaving like a noun.

> *Comer es bueno.* — Eating is good.

Comer has no ending saying who, so nothing anchors it to a subject, and it can sit in the subject slot itself. English needs two forms here and argues about which; Spanish sends the infinitive and has never needed the argument.
And one step further along the same road:

> *comer* → *la* ***comida***.

Take the ending off and put *-ida* on, and the verb becomes a noun outright — with a gender, an article, and a plural. The further a form gets from saying who, the more like a noun it behaves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hablo, hablas, habla* — and drop every pronoun as you go
- *comer*, *la comida* — a verb, then the same verb as a thing

Twice through:

Before you move on

Why can Spanish drop the subject pronoun? (The **ending** says who.) And what can the infinitive do that a conjugated form cannot? (**Stand where a noun stands** — *comer es bueno.*)

Chapter 266

Review — Four Last Pieces, and the Thread

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can use the last of the A1 structures, and name the thread that runs through them.
>
> *I can use the last of the A1 structures, and name the thread that runs through them.*

266.1 (review)

The first five in order. (*Primero, segundo, tercero, cuarto, quinto.*)

What you've built

Four chants.
First. *El primer libro*, *la primera casa* — ordinals go in front, and two of them drop their *o* before a masculine noun.
Second. *Uno es grande, otro es bueno* — a pair split across the sentence. *Otro libro*, with no article in front of it.
Third. *Comer es bueno* — the infinitive naming an activity, where English would reach for *-ing* and Spanish will not.
Fourth. *Hoy como en casa* — the when and the where can move, and the front is where the emphasis lives.

Grammar Lens: the thread

Primer is the **third** time you have watched Spanish bite the ending off a word leaning on another — after *muy* and *mal*. Three sightings make a habit, not a list of exceptions, and you will meet a fourth without being surprised.

And the moving pieces close a thread that has run through this whole level. Latin marked who did what with **endings**. Those endings fell away, and Spanish built replacements out of small audible things: an article to say which one, a preposition to mark the person on the receiving end, a comma to address somebody, and a fixed front position to carry emphasis.

Every one of those was a chapter of its own. Together they are one story, and you now have all of it.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the four chants, in order

Twice through:

Before you move on

Where does emphasis live in a Spanish sentence? (At the **front**.) And what one event explains the article, the personal *a*, the vocative comma and that emphatic position? (Latin's **endings falling away**.)

266.2 Review — one name, four different jobs

"I see María." (*Veo a María.*) "María, come." (*María, ven.*)

What you've built

The name does not change. *María* is *María* in both. Everything that distinguishes them sits **outside** the word.

> *Veo* ***a*** *María.* — she is what the seeing lands on. *María****,*** *ven.* — she is the one being spoken to.

A preposition in the first, a comma in the second. Latin did both with endings on *María* herself, and had a whole case for each.

The article does a third job: a name points at one person already, so *el* has nothing left to do — *María*, not *la María*. Give her a **title** and it comes back: *la señora García*.

Why it's said this way

The fourth job went to **position**, which decides form as well as meaning.

> *Mucha agua.* — leaning on a noun, so it agrees. *Come mucho.* — leaning on a verb, so it freezes.

Same word, two shapes, and the only difference is what it stands next to. The ordinal does this one slot over: *el primer libro*, in front, shortened.
And because the verb's ending already says who did what, the pieces that say **when** and **where** can move:

> *Hoy como en casa.* · *Como en casa hoy.* · *En casa como hoy.*

Three placements, one meaning — and the front slot is the emphatic one. Latin bought that freedom with case endings; Spanish lost them and bought it back with word order. Same trade in ***¡Qué*** *grande!*: the force sits at the front.

Your turn

- *Say it: hoy como en casa, como en casa hoy, en casa como hoy*

Before you move on

What replaced Latin's ending for the person on the receiving end? (A little ***a***.) Which slot carries emphasis? (The **front** one.) And why does *mucho* refuse to agree in *come mucho*? (It leans on a **verb**.)

266.3 (reading) — the first paragraph

Everything you are about to read, you already know. Not one word in it is new.

What **is** new is that there are forty-seven of them in a row.

Read this

María vive en una casa grande con su hermano. Hoy no trabaja, porque es domingo. Por la mañana come pan. Luego va a leer un libro. El libro es muy bueno, pero es bastante grande. Ahora está cansada. Va a dormir. Mañana habla español con su estudiante.

Read it once without stopping. Do not translate as you go — let the sentences arrive.
Now read it again, and notice how little work it took.

Why it's said this way

Look at what is holding it together, because it is not vocabulary. ***Porque*** joins a fact to its reason. ***Pero*** holds two true things apart. ***Luego*** puts one thing after another. ***Va a*** reaches forward into tomorrow. Each of those was a chapter, and each was small.
Eight sentences across six lines is not much. But the longest run of Spanish anywhere in this book so far was a single line of about fifteen words, and nearly every one of those was a drill — a list of verb forms, or one phrase set against another — rather than something a person would actually say.
This is the first time the book has asked you to hold a whole paragraph in your head at once — and the reason it can is that everything in it was paid for, one chapter at a time.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the paragraph aloud, once, without stopping

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many words in that paragraph were new to you? (**None.**) And what made it readable? (Everything in it had already been **paid for**, one chapter at a time.)

266.4 (reading) — the second paragraph

The last paragraph was about María. This one is about her brother, on a different day.

Same rule as before: not one word in it is new.

Read this

El lunes María trabaja. Su hermano no. Está en casa con el perro. Por la tarde bebe café y escribe a su madre. No hay pan, pero hay agua. Luego va a salir, porque quiere ver a su padre. Por la noche los dos comen en casa.

Once through, without stopping.
Again — and this time notice that you did not have to work out who *Está* refers to. Spanish left the name out and you kept it anyway.

Why it's said this way

Su hermano no. Two words, and the verb is gone. Spanish drops what the sentence before it already said, and the reader carries it forward.
That is the thing a paragraph can do that a sentence cannot. A sentence has to say everything. A paragraph gets to lean on the one before it.
It is also why reading gets *easier* as it gets longer, which is the opposite of what most people expect.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the paragraph aloud, once, without stopping

Twice through:

Before you move on

In *Su hermano no*, what word is missing? (**Trabaja** — and you supplied it without being asked.)
How many new words were in the paragraph? (**None**, again.)

266.5 (reading) — the third paragraph

This one is longer than both of the others. You are not going to notice.

Read this

El sábado María y su hermana van a casa de su madre. Su madre es profesora y habla español muy bien. Por la mañana comen pan y beben café. Luego María lee un libro y su hermana escribe. Por la tarde caminan hasta la casa de su hermano. Ahora es tarde, pero están bien. Mañana es domingo, y María no trabaja.

Once through, without stopping.
Now answer this before you read it again: how many people are in it?

Why it's said this way

Four people, and Spanish named each one once. After that they are *su madre*, *su hermana*, *su hermano* — held in place by a single small word you learned a long time ago.
Count what you actually did here. Sixty-one words. Four people. Two days. One page of grammar you already had.
The first paragraph in this chapter was forty-seven words and felt like a wall. This one is longer and did not. Nothing was added in between except two more paragraphs — which is the only thing that ever fixes this.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the paragraph aloud, once, without stopping

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the three paragraphs was hardest? (**The first** — and it was the shortest.)
What changed? (**Nothing was added.** You simply read three of them.)

Chapter 267

Saying No, and Asking

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that something is not so, and ask a question that can be answered yes or no.
>
> *Hold a four-line exchange that denies something and then asks the other person to agree.*

267.1 no + verb — putting *no* in front of the verb — the whole of Spanish negation

One rule, and it is shorter than the English one.

Grammar lens: putting *no* in front of the verb — the whole of Spanish negation

You already know **no**. You met it already as an answer: *¿Hablas español? — No.*
Here is the part nobody has told you yet, and it is the entire rule:

> **Put *no* immediately before the verb. That is negation. There is nothing else.**

Hablo español — I speak Spanish. **No** *hablo español* — I do **not** speak Spanish.
English needs a helper — *I do not speak* — and that *do* is doing no work except carrying the negation. Spanish never borrowed the habit. The word goes in front of the verb and the sentence is finished.

That means every sentence you can already say, you can now also unsay.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three sentences you already know, then say each one again negated
- the same three as yes-or-no questions, letting your voice rise

Before you move on

What goes in front of the verb to negate it? (***no***.) Does Spanish need a helper word like English's *do*? (**No — nothing else changes.**)

267.2 no ... nada — the double negative — where Spanish stacks what English forbids

One rule, and it is shorter than the English one.

Grammar lens: the double negative — where Spanish stacks what English forbids

English teachers spend years stamping out *I don't see nothing.* Spanish requires it.
No veo **nada** — literally *I don't see nothing*, and it means **I see nothing**.
The rule: when a negative word comes AFTER the verb, *no* still has to sit in front of it. Both halves stay.

No veo **nada**. · *No* hablo con **nadie**. · *No* voy **nunca**.

Move the negative word to the front and the *no* disappears, because the sentence already has its negation:

Nada veo. · **Nadie** habla. · **Nunca** voy.

Both are correct. The first is what people say.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three sentences you already know, then say each one again negated
- the same three as yes-or-no questions, letting your voice rise

Before you move on

In *no veo nada*, how many negative words are there? (**Two**, and both are required.) What happens to *no* if *nada* moves to the front? (**It goes away** — the sentence is already negative.)

267.3 ¿Hablas español? — the yes-or-no question — and why Spanish barely has to do anything

One rule, and it is shorter than the English one.

Grammar lens: the yes-or-no question — and why Spanish barely has to do anything

English rebuilds the sentence to ask a yes-or-no question. *You speak Spanish* becomes *Do you speak Spanish?* — a word appears from nowhere and the order changes.
Spanish does neither. **The words stay exactly where they are.** Only your voice goes up, and the writing marks it:

Hablas español. → **¿Hablas español?**

Same three words, same order. The **¿** at the front is the instruction: *this is a question, start lifting your voice now.* That is why Spanish opens it — English readers do not find out until the final *?*, by which time the sentence has been read flat.
You may also put the subject after the verb — *¿Habla usted español?* — and with *usted* that is the more usual shape. But it is a preference, not a rule. The rising voice is the question.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three sentences you already know, then say each one again negated
- the same three as yes-or-no questions, letting your voice rise

Before you move on

What has to change to turn a Spanish statement into a yes-or-no question? (**Nothing but the voice** — and the ¿ ? marks.) Why does Spanish open with ¿? (**So the reader lifts their voice from the first word**, not the last.)

267.4 ¿verdad? — the tag question — asking someone to agree

One rule, and it is shorter than the English one.

Grammar lens: the tag question — asking someone to agree

There is a second kind of yes-or-no question: the one where you already think you know the answer and want the other person to agree. English has a whole machine for this — *isn't it, doesn't he, haven't you, aren't they* — and it changes with every verb. Spanish has two words.

> *Hablas español,* **¿verdad?** — *You speak Spanish, right? No hablas español,* **¿no?** — *You don't speak Spanish, do you?*

¿verdad? is *truth?* and works everywhere. **¿no?** is quicker and slightly more casual. Neither one changes for the verb, the person, or the tense.
One tidy convention: after a negative sentence people prefer **¿verdad?**, since *¿no?* after *no* sounds like a stutter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three sentences you already know, then say each one again negated

- the same three as yes-or-no questions, letting your voice rise

Before you move on

What does Spanish use instead of English's *isn't it / doesn't he / haven't you*? (***¿verdad?*** and ***¿no?***.) Do they change with the verb? (**Never.**)

267.5 negar y preguntar — saying something is not so, and asking whether it is

Everything in this chapter, in one place.

Grammar lens: saying something is not so, and asking whether it is

This chapter gave you two things that go together more often than not.

you can now	how
say something is not so	*no* in front of the verb
say it with a negative word after	*no* stays, both halves
ask a yes-or-no question	nothing changes but your voice
ask someone to agree	*¿verdad?* or *¿no?*

Put them together and you have the shape most real conversations run on:

> — *¿Hablas español? — No, no hablo español. Hablo inglés.*
> — *Pero entiendes un poco,* **¿verdad?** — *Sí, un poco.*

Every word there is one you already had. What is new is that you can now **deny** and **ask**, which between them cover most of what a beginner needs to survive a conversation they did not start.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three sentences you already know, then say each one again negated
- the same three as yes-or-no questions, letting your voice rise

Before you move on

How do you negate a verb? (***no*** in front of it.) How do you ask a yes-or-no question? (**Voice up, ¿ ?** — nothing else moves.) How do you ask someone to agree? (***¿verdad?*** or ***¿no?***.)

Chapter 268

Travelling — Asking, Boarding, Staying, and When It Goes Wrong

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask where something is, ask for a ticket and a room, and say that there is a problem.
>
> *Complete ES-C268-problema: put each of the chapter's three nouns into the donde esta frame, ask for a ticket and a room outright, and report a problem with the correct article.*

268.1 ¿dónde está? — the question that unsticks you

You know *dónde*, and you know *está*. Put them together and you have the single most useful sentence a traveller owns — the one that works when you are lost, when you cannot find the door, when the platform is not where the sign said it was.

What to know first

- dónde — the asking word, with its written accent.
- estar — the *being* that is about **place**, not essence.

Sounds you'll need

- Two stressed syllables: *DÓN-de es-TÁ*. Both accents are written, and both are telling you the truth about your voice. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿dónde está? — "where is it?" Two known words, no new grammar: *dónde* ("where") + *está* ("it is, located"). Spanish has two verbs for "to be," and this question takes *estar*, the one that answers *where* rather than *what*. A thing's location can change; *estar* is the verb for what changes.

Say the name of what you want after it and the question is finished: *¿dónde está el hotel?*, *¿dónde está el tren?* You do not need to build a sentence — you need one frame and a noun.

Where it comes from. *Dónde* is Latin *unde*, "from where," with a *de-* welded on the front; *está* is Latin *stare*, "to stand" — the same root inside English **stand**, **state** and **stay**. Spanish asks, quite literally, *where does it stand?*

What you've built

This is a **frame**: a fixed opening you finish with whatever you need. The next three lessons give you three nouns worth putting in it.

Two courtesies make it land better, and you already have both. Open with *perdón* and the stranger knows a question is coming. Close with *gracias* whether or not you understood the answer.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¿dónde está?* — stress DÓN and TÁ
- the same question about the hotel — *¿dónde está el hotel?*
- it again, opening with *perdón*

Before you move on

Which of the two "to be" verbs does this question use, and why? (*Estar* — it is about place, and place changes.) What Latin verb is

está? (*Stare*, "to stand.")

268.2 billete — the ticket, and the note in your pocket

One word gets you onto the train. It also, confusingly and usefully, means the paper money you pay for it with.

What to know first

- ¿dónde está? — the frame this noun drops into.

Sounds you'll need

- Three syllables, stress in the middle: *bi-YE-te*. The *ll* is a *y* sound in most of the Spanish-speaking world. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

billete — "ticket," and also "banknote." One word, two things you carry, and the overlap is not an accident: both are a small official paper that entitles you to something.

Where it comes from. Latin *bulla* was a **seal** — the blob of wax stamped onto a document to prove it was genuine. The sealed document took the seal's name, shrank through French *billet* ("a short note"), and arrived in Spanish as *billete*. The same *bulla* is still sitting inside English **bulletin** and the papal **bull**: all of them are documents that were once literally sealed.

Worth knowing before you travel. Much of Latin America says **boleto** or **pasaje** for a travel ticket and keeps *billete* for money. Both are correct Spanish; which one you hear depends on where you are standing.

What you've built

Drop it into the frame — *¿dónde está el billete?* — or ask for one outright: *un billete, por favor*. Two words and a courtesy is a complete transaction.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *billete* — stress the middle, *bi-YE-te*
- ask for one — *un billete, por favor*
- the Latin American word for a travel ticket (*boleto*)

Before you move on

What did Latin *bulla* mean? (A seal.) What two things does *billete* name? (A ticket, and a banknote.) Which English words still carry *bulla*? (**Bulletin**, and a papal **bull**.)

268.3 habitación — a room, from a verb meaning to live somewhere

The word you need at a hotel desk. It is long, but it is built out of a verb you can almost read already.

What to know first

- billete — the previous thing you had to ask for.

Sounds you'll need

- Five syllables, stress at the very end: *a-bi-ta-SYON*. The written accent on *ó* is the whole reason you know that. The *h* is silent — it always is. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

habitación — "room." Take it apart and the meaning is transparent: *habitar* ("to live in, to dwell") + *-ción* (the ending that turns a verb into the noun for its result). So a *habitación* is, literally, **a place lived in**.

That *-ción* is one of the most profitable endings in the language, and it is English *-tion* wearing different clothes: *nación* / nation, *estación* / station, *información* / information. Meet it once and hundreds of words open up.

Where it comes from. Latin *habitare*, "to dwell" — a frequentative of *habere*, "to have," so it once meant something like "to keep on having a place." English **inhabit** and **habitat** are the same root, undisguised.

What you've built

Una habitación, por favor books you a room. And the *-ción* ending you just met is a key you will use far outside this chapter: these nouns are feminine, and they are very often an English *-tion* word you already know with its ending swapped.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *habitación* — silent *h*, stress the last syllable
- ask for a room — *una habitación, por favor*
- two more *-ción* words and their English twins

Before you move on

What does the verb *habitar* mean? (To dwell, to live in.) What does *-ción* do? (Turns a verb into the noun for its result.) Which article do *-ción* nouns take? (*La* — they are feminine.)

268.4 Review — three phrases, in the order you need them

The first thing you say anywhere new. (*¿Dónde está?*)

What you've built

These three arrived one after another, and they are not a list. They are a sequence.
¿Dónde está? — you find the thing. **Un billete** — you buy your way onto it. **Una habitación** — you stop, and sleep.
Find, travel, rest. Said in any other order they still work, but said in that order they are a day.

Why it's said this way

Habitación is the long one, and it is the one that pays you back. Take it apart: *habitar*, "to live in," plus **-ción**, the ending that turns a doing word into the noun for its result. A *habitación* is, with no metaphor at all, **a place lived in**.

That ending is the profitable part. It does the same job every time it appears, it makes the noun feminine every time, and it is very often an English word you already own wearing different clothes — the English ending is *-tion*.

And *habitar* has a story of its own. It is Latin *habitāre*, built off *habēre*, "to have," in a form that means doing something over and over. To dwell somewhere is to **keep on having** a place. English **inhabit** and **habitat** are the same root, barely disguised.

Your turn

- *Say it: ¿dónde está? · un billete · una habitación*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What is a *habitación*, taken literally? (**A place lived in**.) What did *habitar* grow out of? (***Habēre***, to have.) And what do you ask for before you ever need the room? (**Un *billete***.)

268.5 problema — the word for when it goes wrong (and the -a that is masculine)

Travel goes wrong. This is the word that starts the conversation about it — and it hides a grammatical surprise you should meet on purpose rather than by accident.

What to know first

- habitación — and the gender rule it followed.

Sounds you'll need

- Four syllables, stress in the middle: *pro-BLE-ma*. No written accent, because that is where a word ending in a vowel is stressed by default. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

problema — "problem." A near-twin of the English word, and you will be understood the moment you say it.
Where it comes from. Greek *próblēma*, "a thing thrown forward" — *pro-* ("forward") plus *bállein* ("to throw"). A problem is something pitched into your path. That same *bállein* is inside English **ballistic** and **symbol**.

What you've built

Here is the surprise, and it is worth more than the word itself. You learned that nouns ending in *-a* are usually feminine. *Problema* is **masculine**: *el problema*, *un problema*. Never *la problema*.
It is not an exception you have to memorise blindly — it is a whole family with a shared history. Greek nouns ending in *-ma* were neuter, and when Latin borrowed them the neuter words landed on the masculine side. Every one of them came into Spanish the same way: *el problema*, *el sistema*, *el tema*, *el programa*, *el idioma*, *el clima*. If a noun ends in *-ma* and sounds Greek and academic, guess *el* and you will usually be right.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *un problema* — and notice you did not say *una*
- report one — *perdón, hay un problema*
- three more *-ma* words that take *el*

Before you move on

Which article does *problema* take, and why? (*El* — Greek *-ma* nouns were neuter and became masculine.) What did *próblēma*

mean literally? (A thing thrown forward.) Name two more of the family. (*El sistema*, *el tema*, *el programa*, *el idioma*, *el clima*.)

268.6 Review — when the ending tells the truth, and when it lies

La habitación. El problema.

What you've built

Two words from the same chapter, and they disagree about the most basic question you can ask a Spanish noun.

word	ending	article
habitación	*-ción*	**la**
problema	*-ma*	**el**

One of those two endings predicts the article. The other does the opposite of what you were taught to expect.

-ción is one of the most reliable signals in the language: it is feminine, every time, without exception you will meet. And *-a*, the ending you were taught to read as feminine, hands you *el problema*.

Why it's said this way

The useful part is that neither of these is arbitrary, so neither has to be memorised as a bare fact.

-ción is feminine because the Latin ending it descends from was feminine, and nothing since has disturbed it. The ending kept its gender the whole way down.

Problema is masculine because it did not come through Latin from the start. It came from **Greek**, where nouns ending in *-ma* were neither masculine nor feminine but a third thing — neuter. Latin had no comfortable place to put them and handed them to the masculine, and Spanish inherited that decision.

So *-ma* is not an exception to the *-a* rule. It is a **passport stamp**: it tells you the word came in from Greek, and the gender came with it. When you meet another noun in *-ma* that names an idea, expect *el*.

Your turn

- *Say it: la habitación · el problema*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which ending always tells you *la*? (***-ción***.) Why is *problema* masculine? (**It is Greek — *-ma* nouns were neuter, and Latin made them masculine**.) Is that an exception or a family? (**A family**.)

Chapter 269

Describing an Experience — How It Felt, How Long, How It Compared

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say how something felt, what I hope for, how it compared with something else, and how long it lasted.

Complete ES-C269-durante: describe one experience using a feeling adjective, an espero ambition, a mas que comparison, and a durante length.

269.1 feliz — happy, and an adjective that refuses to pick a gender

You can say where things are and what has gone wrong. This chapter is about saying how it *felt*. It starts with the most useful feeling word, which also happens to be conveniently lazy.

What to know first

- problema — and the gender surprise it carried.

Sounds you'll need

- Two syllables, stress on the last: *fe-LIZ*. No written accent is needed — words ending in *-z* are stressed on the final syllable by default. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

feliz — "happy." Latin *felix*, which first meant **fruitful** — of soil that bore a crop, of a tree heavy with fruit. Happiness, to a Roman farmer, was the field doing what it was supposed to do. The same *felix* is the name **Felix**, and it is inside English **felicity**.
You already meet it once a year without translating it: *¡feliz cumpleaños!*

What you've built

Feliz does something the adjectives you have met do not. *Bueno* becomes *buena* for a feminine noun; *cansado* becomes *cansada*. *Feliz* does neither — it is *feliz* for everyone. Adjectives ending in a consonant simply do not carry gender, so *un niño feliz* and *una niña feliz* use the identical word.
That is a saving, not an exception: every adjective you meet ending in *-z*, *-l* or *-e* is one fewer form to remember.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *feliz* — stress the last syllable
- it about a man, then about a woman, and notice nothing changed
- *¡feliz cumpleaños!*

Before you move on

What did Latin *felix* first describe? (Fruitful soil, a fruiting tree.)
Why does *feliz* not change for a feminine noun? (It ends in a consonant, and consonant-final adjectives do not carry gender.)

269.2 espero viajar — saying what you are reaching for

Ambitions are things you have not got yet. Spanish says them with a verb you have already met wearing a different coat.

What to know first

- feliz — the feeling this chapter opened with.
- esperar — where you first met this verb, meaning *wait*.

Sounds you'll need

- Three syllables, stress in the middle: *es-PE-ro.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

espero — "I hope." The same *esperar* you learned as "to wait," and Spanish sees no reason to separate them. To wait for something and to hope for it are one act: you are standing in the present with your attention on a future you cannot reach yet.
Where it comes from. Latin *sperare*, "to hope" — the root of English **prosper** ("to hope forward") and, negated, **desperate**, which is literally *de-sperare*, to have hope taken away. Spanish keeps the plain form; English kept the compounds.

What you've built

This is your ambition frame. *Espero* plus an infinitive says what you are reaching for: *espero viajar*, *espero aprender*, *espero vivir en España*. Every one of those infinitives is a verb you already own, so the frame costs you nothing new and turns your whole verb list into statements about your future.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *espero* — stress the middle
- an ambition — *espero viajar*

- another, using any verb you know

Before you move on

What two English meanings does *esperar* carry? (To wait, and to hope.) What is *desperate*, taken apart? (*De-sperare* — hope taken away.)

269.3 más que — comparing two things, with no new endings to learn

English changes the adjective to compare: big, *bigg-er*. Spanish refuses to. It puts one small word in front and leaves the adjective alone.

What to know first

- espero — the ambition frame just before this.
- más — the degree word you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *más* carries a written accent, and it earns it: there is an older word spelled the same way without one. Two words, one sound, and the accent is the only thing telling them apart on the page. You meet the other at the end of the book. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

más que — "more than." *Más* ("more") plus *que* ("than," and also "that").
Where it comes from. Latin *magis*, "more" — the same root as English **magnitude** and **major**. Latin *did* have *-ior* endings for comparison (*maior*, *melior*), exactly like English *-er*. Spanish threw nearly all of them away and rebuilt comparison out of one adverb, which is why there is so little to learn here.

What you've built

The pattern is fixed and takes any adjective you own, unchanged: *más* + adjective + *que*. *Más grande que*, *más feliz que*, *más cansado que*. Swap *más* for *menos* and you have "less than" for free.
Two words sit outside it, kept from Latin because they are used constantly: *mejor* and *peor*, "better" and "worse" — as English says *better*, not *more good*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *más feliz que* — the adjective did not change
- the same idea downwards, with *menos*
- "better" without using *más* (*mejor*)

Before you move on

What is the fixed pattern? (*Más* + adjective + *que*.) Why does *más* carry an accent? (To separate it in writing from an older word spelled the same way without it — you will meet that one at the end of the book.) Which two comparatives kept their Latin endings? (*Mejor* and *peor*.)

269.4 durante — how long it lasted

An experience has a length. This is the word that gives it one, and it closes the chapter: you can now say how it felt, what you hope for, how it compared, and how long it went on.

What to know first

- más que — the comparison just before this.

Sounds you'll need

- Three syllables, stress in the middle: *du-RAN-te*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

durante — "during," and often English "for" when you are talking about a stretch of time: *durante dos horas*, "for two hours."
Where it comes from. It is not really a preposition. It is the old present participle of *durar*, "to last" — so it once meant "lasting." *Durante dos horas* was "two hours lasting," an absolute phrase that hardened into a fixed word once speakers stopped hearing the verb inside it.
Latin *durare* is **hard** — *durus* — and it is still visible in English **durable**, **duration** and **endure**. To last is to be hard enough to.

What you've built

Durante answers *how long*, where *cuándo* answers *when*. Worth a moment's care: English "for" stretches over both a length of time and a recipient, and *durante* only ever covers the length.
That completes the chapter's four moves. You can describe an experience now: how it felt, what you hope for next, how it measured against something else, and how long it lasted.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *durante dos horas*
- which question it answers — *how long*, not *when*
- an experience of yours with a length attached

Before you move on

What was *durante* before it was a preposition? (The present participle of *durar* — "lasting.") What does Latin *durus* mean, and which English words carry it? (Hard; **durable**, **duration**, **endure**.)

Chapter 270

Making a Case — Claim, Example, However, Although

Modes: **voice** (4) **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can state an opinion in Spanish, back it with an example, turn against an objection, and grant one before I turn it.
>
> *Complete ES-C270-aunque: run the four moves in order on one claim of your own.*

270.1 en mi opinión — marking a claim as yours

You can say what happened and how it felt. This chapter is for saying what you THINK, and defending it.

What to know first

- durante — the last word of the experience chapter.
- creer — you can already say *creo*, "I believe."

Sounds you'll need

- Five syllables, and the accent on *opinión* is doing the usual work: *en-mi-o-pi-NIÓN*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en mi opinión — "in my opinion."
Opinión is Latin **opinari**, "to suppose, to think" — and the *-ión* ending is the same one you met in *habitación*, turning a verb into the noun for its result. An opinion is *a supposing*, made into a thing you can hand someone.
English took the identical word from the identical place, which is why you can read it before you can say it.

What you've built

There is a difference between saying something and **marking it as a claim**, and this phrase does the marking. *Es difícil* asserts that a thing is hard. *En mi opinión, es difícil* says the same and hands the listener a place to disagree.
That is what makes it the opening move of an argument rather than a statement of fact — you are inviting the reply.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en mi opinión*
- a claim with it — *en mi opinión, es difícil*
- the same claim WITHOUT it, and hear the difference

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *opinión* built on? (*Opinari*, "to suppose.") What does marking a claim as an opinion invite? (Disagreement — a reply.)

270.2 por ejemplo — the claim, and then the reason to believe it

A claim on its own is just an assertion. This is how you back it.

What to know first

- en mi opinión — the claim this supports.

Sounds you'll need

- *por e-JEM-plo.* The *j* is the throat-sound you have met in *trabajo.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

por ejemplo — "for example."
Ejemplo is Latin **exemplum**, and *exemplum* is worth taking apart: *ex-* ("out of") plus a root meaning "to take." An example is **a thing taken out** — one item lifted from a pile so the pile can be understood through it.
English **exemplary**, **sample** and **example** are all the same word arriving by different routes; *sample* is the most worn-down of the three.

What you've built

This is the second move of an argument, and the order matters: claim first, example second. *En mi opinión, es difícil. Por ejemplo, …*
An example is not proof — it is one thing taken out of the pile, which is exactly what the word says. That is worth knowing in both languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *por ejemplo*
- a claim, then an example — two sentences
- what *exemplum* means literally (a thing taken out)

Before you move on

What does *exemplum* mean, taken apart? (A thing taken *out* of a pile.) Which comes first, the claim or the example? (The claim.)

270.3 sin embargo — however, and why it is not pero

You have *pero*, "but." This is its heavier cousin, and the difference is real.

What to know first

- por ejemplo — the evidence move.
- pero — the ordinary "but" you already own.

Sounds you'll need

- *sin em-BAR-go.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sin embargo — "however, nevertheless."
Literally **"without hindrance."** *Embargo* is a hindrance, a seizure, an impediment — the same word English borrowed whole for a trade **embargo**, and it traces to a Latin-derived *imbarricare*, "to bar in."
So the phrase says: *that obstacle notwithstanding.* Whatever was just conceded, it does not stop what comes next.

What you've built

Pero joins two things inside one breath: *es difícil pero me gusta.*
Sin embargo stands at the head of its own sentence and turns against everything before it: *Es difícil. Sin embargo, me gusta.*
The second is what an argument needs, because you have to grant the other side's point in full before you turn it. *Pero* is too light to carry that weight, which is why one is not a translation of the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sin embargo*
- the light version — *es difícil pero me gusta*

- the heavy version — two sentences, the second opening with *sin embargo*

Before you move on

What does *sin embargo* mean literally? (Without hindrance.) What English word is *embargo*? (The same one — a trade embargo.) Which of the two turns against a whole sentence rather than half of one? (*Sin embargo.*)

270.4 aunque — conceding first, and arguing after

The last move: granting the other side's point BEFORE you make yours.

What to know first

- sin embargo — conceding after the fact.

Sounds you'll need

- *AUN-que*, two syllables. The *au-* is one glide, not two vowels. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

aunque — "although, even though."
It is *aun* ("even, still") welded to *que* ("that"), and *aun* descends from Latin **adhuc**, "up to this point, still." So *aunque* is, at root, **"even that"** — even granting that.
You have watched this fusion happen twice already: *ayer* out of *ad heri*, and *hablaré* out of *hablar habeo*. Spanish builds most of its small words this way, by saying two words often enough that they become one.

What you've built

Sin embargo concedes after: *Es difícil. Sin embargo, me gusta. Aunque* concedes first: *Aunque es difícil, me gusta.*
Same two ideas, opposite order — and the order chooses what the

listener remembers, because the sentence lands on whatever comes last. Leading with *aunque* puts your own point in the emphatic position. With that, you have the four moves: state a claim, support it, turn against an objection, and grant one before you turn it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aunque*
- the concession first — *aunque es difícil, me gusta*
- all four moves in order — claim, example, however, although

Before you move on

What two words is *aunque* built from? (*Aun* and *que*.) Which Latin word is *aun*? (*Adhuc*, "still.") Which of *aunque* and *sin embargo* concedes first? (*Aunque*.)

Chapter 271

Talking About Ideas — Hedging From Doubt, and From Inference

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (3) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can put an idea forward in Spanish while marking how sure I am of it, and tell an admission of ignorance from a claimed inference.

Complete ES-C271-supongo-que: state one idea three ways – bare, hedged with quizas, and hedged with supongo que – and say what each does to your commitment.

271.1 quizás — saying it without claiming it

An argument needs one more thing: a way to put an idea forward while admitting you might be wrong.

What to know first

- aunque — the concession that closed the last chapter.
- en mi opinión — marking a claim as yours.

Sounds you'll need

- *ki-ZÁS*, stress on the last syllable, and the accent says so. You will also see **quizá**, without the *-s*; both are standard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

quizás — "maybe, perhaps."
It is a fossilised question. Latin **qui sapit** — *"who knows?"* — said often enough that it stopped being a question and became a word meaning *perhaps*. The *sapit* is the same root as **savoir**, **sapient** and, at some distance, **sage**: knowing.
English did the identical thing twice over. *Perhaps* is *per* + *hap*, "by chance"; *maybe* is *may be*. Every language seems to build its hedges by wearing down a phrase that once admitted ignorance out loud.

What you've built

This is a **hedge**: it lowers your commitment without lowering your meaning. *Es difícil* claims. *Quizás es difícil* offers.
Set beside what you already have, you now hold three settings on the same dial — *en mi opinión* marks a claim as yours, *quizás* marks it as uncertain, and a bare statement claims outright.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *quizás* — stress the end
- a claim, then the same claim hedged
- what Latin *qui sapit* asked (*who knows?*)

Before you move on

What question is hidden inside *quizás*? (*Qui sapit* — "who knows?")
What does a hedge lower — your meaning, or your commitment? (Your commitment.)

271.2 supongo que — the hedge that shows its reasoning

The second hedge, and it is not the same as the first.

What to know first

- quizás — the hedge that admits uncertainty.

Sounds you'll need

- *su-PON-go ke.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

supongo que — "I suppose that."
Take it apart and it is beautifully literal: Latin **sub-** ("under") plus **ponere** ("to place"). To suppose is to **place something underneath** — to slide an assumption under an argument so the argument can stand on it.
That *ponere* is everywhere in English once you see it: **compose** (place together), **impose** (place upon), **depose**, **postpone**, **position**. And *supongo* is exactly English **suppose**, arrived by the same road.

What you've built

Quizás and *supongo que* hedge differently, and the difference is worth keeping.
Quizás says: I do not know. *Supongo que* says: I have not been told, but it follows.
The first admits ignorance; the second claims an inference. In an argument they do opposite work — one steps back from a claim, the other quietly offers a reason for it.
With this the chapter's four moves are complete: name an abstract thing, name a whole idea, hedge from uncertainty, and hedge from inference.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *supongo que* …, finishing it however you like
- the same idea with *quizás* instead, and hear what changed
- three English words built on *ponere*

Before you move on

What does *sub-* + *ponere* mean literally? (To place underneath.) Which hedge admits ignorance, and which claims an inference? (*Quizás*; *supongo que.*)

271.3 Three settings on one dial

Two hedges, and a bare statement between them. This is where you feel the difference rather than read it.

Your turn

Take one idea of your own — anything you could argue about — and say it three times.

Say these aloud:

- the bare claim. No hedge. Hear how much you have committed to.
- the same claim with *quizás* in front. You have not changed the idea; you have changed how far you will defend it.
- the same claim again with *supongo que.* Now you are not admitting ignorance — you are offering an inference, and inviting the listener to check your reasoning rather than your confidence.

Say these aloud:

- which of the three you would use with a stranger, and why
- which one an argument is hardest to answer with, and why

Before you move on

Which hedge admits you do not know? (*Quizás.*) Which one claims a reason you have not been given? (*Supongo que.*) What did the Latin behind each one mean — "who knows?", and "to place underneath"?

Chapter 272

Reading Between the Lines — Imply, Invert, Look It Up, Re-tune

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 3 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell the four ways a Spanish sentence means more than it says, and say which strategy each one asks of the listener.

Complete ES-C272-practice: name the listener strategy each of the four devices requires, and which one a written text hides.

272.1 es que... — the refusal that never says no

Everything so far has meant what it said. This chapter is about Spanish that means MORE than it says, and this is the commonest case.

What to know first

- supongo que — the hedge that claims an inference.

Sounds you'll need

- *es ke*, run together, and usually trailing off rather than finishing. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

es que... — literally "it is that…", and functionally almost never that. Asked to do something you cannot do, a Spanish speaker very often begins *es que…* and then gives a circumstance rather than an answer. *¿Vienes? — Es que mañana trabajo.* Nothing in that sentence is a refusal. Every listener hears one.
The words supply a reason; the **refusal is left for you to work out**. That gap between what is said and what is meant has a name in linguistics — an **implicature** — and Spanish leans on it harder than English does.

What you've built

This is the first thing in the book you cannot translate word by word and still understand. *It is that tomorrow I work* is not English, and even repaired to *it's just that I work tomorrow* it loses the refusal.
Two consequences worth carrying. When you hear *es que*, expect the sentence after it to be a reason for a "no" that will not be spoken. And when you need to decline something yourself, this is the polite instrument for it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *es que…* and finish it with a reason
- what a listener would understand from it, in one word (*no*)
- the bare refusal instead, and notice how much blunter it lands

Before you move on

What is the gap between what a sentence says and what it means called? (An implicature.) What does *es que* usually introduce? (A reason standing in for a refusal.)

272.2 sí, claro — when the words say yes and the speaker means no

Harder than an implicature: a sentence whose meaning is the OPPOSITE of its words.

What to know first

- es que… — meaning more than you say.

Sounds you'll need

- Everything here is in the delivery. Said briskly and warmly, *sí, claro* is plain agreement. Said slowly, flatly, with the *claro* dragged out, it is the opposite. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí, claro — "yes, of course" — or "yeah, right", depending entirely on how it is said.
Claro is Latin **clarus**, "bright, clear" — the same word as English **clear** and the name **Clara**. To say *claro* is to say *that is obvious.* Which is exactly what makes it available for irony. A word meaning "obviously" is the perfect thing to say about something you find not obvious at all, and the gap between the word and the tone is where the sarcasm lives.

What you've built

Irony is not a Spanish trick; English does the same with *sure* and *of course*. What is worth knowing is that **the marker is carried in the voice, not in the words** — so a written *sí, claro* is genuinely ambiguous, and Spanish readers resolve it from context exactly as you do in English.
If you are not certain which one you are hearing, you are not failing at Spanish. The sentence is ambiguous by design.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sí, claro* meaning it — brisk and warm

- *sí, claro* not meaning it — slow and flat
- which of the two a written text cannot tell you

Before you move on

What does *claro* mean literally, and which English word is it? (Bright, clear — *clear*.) Where is the irony carried? (In the voice, not the words.)

272.3 tomar el pelo — four words you know, meaning something else entirely

You know every word in this phrase. That will not help you.

What to know first

- tomar — "to take", which you already own.
- sí, claro — the irony marker just before this.

Sounds you'll need

- *to-MAR el PE-lo.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tomar el pelo — "to tease someone, to have someone on."
Word by word it is *to take the hair*, and word by word it tells you nothing. *Pelo* is Latin **pilus**, "a hair" — the same root inside English **pile** (the raised surface of a fabric) and **depilate**.
Where the phrase comes from is genuinely uncertain, and the tidy stories you will find online are folk etymology. What is certain is that its meaning cannot be reached from its parts, and that is the definition of an **idiom**.
English does the same to Spanish learners with *pull someone's leg*, which has no better-attested origin.

What you've built

An idiom is the limit case of this chapter. An implicature asks you to infer; irony asks you to invert; an idiom asks you to **look it up**, because there is nothing in the words to work with.
That is worth stating plainly rather than leaving you to discover it: some Spanish cannot be decoded, only learned. Recognising which is which is the skill this chapter is really teaching.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tomar el pelo*
- what it says word by word (*to take the hair*)
- whether the origin story you may have heard is reliable (it is not)

Before you move on

What does *tomar el pelo* mean? (To tease, to have someone on.)
Can its meaning be worked out from its words? (No — that is what makes it an idiom.)

272.4 mira — a word that changes the temperature of what follows

The last of the four, and the smallest: one word that tells the listener how to take the next sentence.

What to know first

- tomar el pelo — the idiom before this.

Sounds you'll need

- *MI-ra*, stress the first syllable. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mira — "look."
It is the command form of *mirar*, "to look" — Latin **mirari**, "to wonder at, to marry at", which also gave English **miracle**, **admire** and **mirror**.
But dropped at the start of a sentence it has stopped being a command. Nobody is being asked to look at anything. *Mira, no es así* — "look, it isn't like that" — uses it to mark what follows as a correction, an intimacy, or an impatience, depending on the voice. Spanish is full of these: *oye*, *venga*, *bueno*, *hombre*. Every one of them started as a word with a meaning and became a **signal about the sentence around it**.

What you've built

This is a **discourse marker**, and it does not translate — it *positions*. The literal meaning is spent; what is left is a change in temperature. That completes the chapter's four ways a Spanish sentence can mean more than it says: it can imply (*es que*), it can invert (*sí, claro*), it can be opaque (*tomar el pelo*), or it can be re-tuned by a word that carries no content at all (*mira*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mira* as a real command — look at something
- *mira* as a marker — *mira, no es así*
- two more markers Spanish uses this way

Before you move on

What is *mira* literally? (The command "look", from *mirar*.) What does a discourse marker do instead of meaning something? (It positions the sentence — it changes how you are meant to take it.)

272.5 Four ways to mean more than you say

Four devices, and the useful skill is telling them apart fast enough to keep up with a speaker.

Your turn

For each of the four, say which strategy the listener has to use.

Say these aloud:

- *es que mañana trabajo* — and then say what the listener must do (**infer** — supply the refusal that was not spoken)
- *sí, claro*, flat and slow — and what the listener must do (**invert** — take the opposite of the words)
- *me estás tomando el pelo* — and what the listener must do (**know it already** — nothing in the words will help)
- *mira, no es así* — and what the listener must do (**re-tune** — the marker says how to take what follows, not what it means)

Say these aloud:

- which of the four a written text hides from you, and why (*sí, claro* — the irony is in the voice)
- which of the four you could not have guessed without being taught

Before you move on

Name the four strategies a listener uses: infer, invert, look it up, re-tune. Which one is carried in the voice rather than the words? (Irony.) Which one cannot be worked out at all? (The idiom.)

Chapter 273

Building a Paragraph — Plan, Add, Join, Refer Back

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can build a paragraph in Spanish whose sentences signal how they relate to one another, and say what is lost when the signals are removed.
>
> *Complete ES-C273-practice: build a four-sentence paragraph with each join, then say it again with the joins removed and describe what changed.*

273.1 en primer lugar — telling the reader the shape before you fill it

You can build a sentence that means more than it says. This chapter is about building something longer than a sentence.

What to know first

- mira — the marker that re-tunes what follows.
- por ejemplo — the evidence move.

Sounds you'll need

- *en pri-MER lu-GAR.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en primer lugar — "in the first place, firstly."
Primer is Latin **primarius**, "of the first rank" — English **primary**, **prime**. *Lugar* is **locus**, "place" — English **local**, **locate**. Literally: *in the first place*, and English kept the phrase intact.
Its partners are *en segundo lugar* and *por último*, "lastly."

What you've built

This is not a connective. It does not join two ideas — it tells the listener **how many are coming**.
That is a different job, and it is what makes extended text followable. A reader who hears *en primer lugar* knows to expect a second point and holds a slot open for it. Take the phrase away and the same three points arrive as an undifferentiated list.
Signposting is most of what separates a paragraph from a pile of sentences.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en primer lugar* and make a point
- *en segundo lugar* and make another
- *por último* and close

Before you move on

What Latin words are inside *primer* and *lugar*? (*Primarius* and *locus*.) What does the phrase tell a listener that a connective does not? (How many points are coming.)

273.2 además — adding a point, not adding an item

You have *también*, "also." This is not the same word, and the difference is the same one *pero* and *sin embargo* had.

What to know first

- en primer lugar — the signpost before this.
- también — the "also" you already own.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-de-MÁS*, and the accent tells you so. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

además — "furthermore, moreover, besides."
Take it apart: *a* + *de* + *más* — "to, of, more." It is built out of three words you already have, and *más* is the comparison word from the experience chapter.
So it means, quite literally, **"in addition to more."** Spanish built its heaviest additive connector out of its lightest pieces.

What you've built

También adds an **item**: *hablo español; también hablo francés. Además* adds a **point**: *es difícil. Además, es caro.*
The first says *one more of the same kind.* The second says *and here is a further reason*, and it is what an argument uses when the reasons are not interchangeable.
That is the same distinction you met with *pero* and *sin embargo*: the light word joins inside a breath, the heavy one opens a new sentence and carries argumentative weight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- two like items with *también*
- two separate reasons with *además*
- which of the two an argument needs, and why

Before you move on

What three words is *además* built from? (*A*, *de*, *más*.) What does *también* add, and what does *además* add? (An item; a point.)

273.3 por lo tanto — the word that makes a text hold together

Signpost, addition — and now the join that turns a list of points into an argument.

What to know first

- además — adding a further point.
- así que — the everyday "so" you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *por lo TAN-to.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

por lo tanto — "therefore, consequently."
Tanto is Latin **tantus**, "so much, so great." The phrase is *for so much — given all that*, therefore.
You already have *así que*, which does the same job in conversation. *Por lo tanto* is its written, weight-bearing form: the one that appears in an argument where the conclusion has to look earned.

What you've built

Here is the thing this chapter is really about. The English word for what these connectives create is **cohesion** — the property that makes a text feel like one thing rather than several.
Cohesion is not achieved by the sentences being about the same topic. It is achieved by each sentence carrying an explicit signal of **how it relates to the last one**: another point (*además*), a consequence (*por lo tanto*), a concession (*sin embargo*), an example (*por ejemplo*). Remove those signals and a paragraph does not become wrong. It becomes work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a claim, then *por lo tanto*, then its consequence
- the same pair with *así que*, and hear the register drop
- what cohesion is, in your own words

Before you move on

What does *tanto* mean, and which Latin word is it? (So much — *tantus*.) What is cohesion? (Each sentence signalling how it relates to the last.)

273.4 lo cual — pointing back at everything you just said

The last piece: a way to refer to a whole idea rather than a thing.

What to know first

- por lo tanto — the cohesion join.
- lo que — naming a thing you cannot name.

Sounds you'll need

- *lo KUAL.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lo cual — "which", where the *which* points at an entire preceding clause.
Cual is Latin **qualis**, "of what kind" — English **quality** and the *-al* of **equal**. The neuter *lo* in front is what widens its target: not a noun, but everything just said.
Llegó tarde, lo cual me sorprendió. — "He arrived late, **which** surprised me." What surprised me is not *he*, and not *late*. It is the whole fact.

What you've built

Pointing back at something already said is called **anaphora**, and it is the other half of cohesion. Connectives say how sentences relate; anaphora lets a sentence pick up what came before without repeating it.

Spanish is precise here in a way English is not. English *which* can point at a noun or a clause and leaves you to work out which. Spanish splits the job: *que* and *el cual* take a noun, *lo cual* takes the whole idea. The neuter *lo* is the marker that says "what follows refers to no single thing."

With that, the chapter's four pieces are complete: plan the text, add to it, join it, and refer back within it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a sentence, then *lo cual*, then your reaction to the whole of it
- what *lo cual* points at that *que* cannot
- the word for pointing back (*anaphora*)

Before you move on

What Latin word is *cual*? (*Qualis*, "of what kind.") What does the neuter *lo* do to its target? (Widens it from a noun to a whole idea.) What is the name for pointing back? (Anaphora.)

273.5 One paragraph, four joins

Four pieces, and the point of them is that they only show their value at length. A single sentence never needed any of this.

Your turn

Build one paragraph out loud, on any opinion you hold. Four sentences, each with its join.

Say these aloud:

- *en primer lugar*, and your first reason. The listener now knows more is coming.
- *además*, and a second reason that is **not** the same kind as the first. If it could have taken *también*, choose a different reason.
- *por lo tanto*, and the conclusion those two reasons earn.
- one more sentence ending in *lo cual* plus your reaction to the whole of it.

Say these aloud:

- the same four sentences again with every join REMOVED. Same content, same order.
- what changed. Nothing became wrong — it became work.

Before you move on

Which of the four tells the listener how many points are coming? (*En primer lugar.*) Which one points back at a whole idea? (*Lo cual.*) What is the name for a text whose sentences signal how they relate? (Cohesive.)

Chapter 274

What a Phrase Carries — Authority, a Story, a Silence, a Sense of Charm

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the cultural weight a Spanish phrase carries beyond its meaning, and tell a proverb from an idiom, an allusion from a word, and a euphemism from politeness.
>
> *Complete ES-C274-practice: name the weight each of the four phrases borrows, and say which one can be used correctly without knowing its source.*

274.1 más vale pájaro en mano — a sentence the language finished for you

This chapter is about Spanish that carries more than its meaning: it carries where it came from.

What to know first

- lo cual — the last piece of the paragraph chapter.
- tomar el pelo — the idiom you cannot decode.

Sounds you'll need

- *más VA-le PÁ-ja-ro en MA-no.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

más vale pájaro en mano — "a bird in the hand is worth more."
Every word is one you have. *Más* from the comparison chapter, *vale* from Latin **valere** ("to be worth" — English **value**, **valid**), *mano* from **manus**.
And Spanish speakers do not finish it. The full form is *más vale pájaro en mano que ciento volando* — "than a hundred flying" — but the second half is so well known that saying it marks you as explaining rather than quoting.
English does the same. Nobody says *a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush*; they say **a bird in the hand** and stop.

What you've built

A **proverb** is not an idiom. An idiom's meaning cannot be worked out from its words; a proverb's can — *a bird in the hand is worth more* is transparent.
What a proverb carries instead is **communal authority**. Using one is a claim that the point is not yours but everybody's, already settled, not up for argument. That is why proverbs close conversations and arguments open them.
The half-sentence is the tell. A phrase you are expected to leave unfinished is a phrase the room already knows.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the half everyone says
- the full form, and notice it sounds like explaining
- what a proverb claims that an argument does not (that it is settled)

Before you move on

What is the difference between a proverb and an idiom? (A proverb's meaning is transparent; an idiom's is not.) Why do speakers stop halfway? (Finishing it marks you as explaining rather than quoting.)

274.2 ser un quijote — when a book becomes a common noun

A proverb comes from everyone. This comes from one book, and behaves like a word.

What to know first

- más vale pájaro en mano — the proverb.

Sounds you'll need

- *ser un ki-JO-te*. The *j* is the throat sound. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ser un quijote — to be idealistic to the point of impracticality; to fight for a lost cause because it is right.
It is Don Quixote, from Cervantes' novel of 1605 — and the word has stopped being a name. Written lowercase, *quijote* is an ordinary Spanish noun in the dictionary, and so is the adjective *quijotesco*.
English took the same journey to **quixotic**.
Notice what that means: you can use the word correctly without having read the book. Most speakers have not. The allusion has been absorbed into the language and no longer requires its source.

What you've built

This is a **cultural allusion**, and it is the hardest kind of meaning for a learner, because a dictionary will give you the gloss and not the weight. The practical consequence is worth stating plainly: when a Spanish text uses a name as though it were a word — *un quijote*, *un donjuán*, *una celestina* — it is pointing at a story its readers are assumed to share. You are not expected to know all of them. You are expected to **notice that a name is doing work**, and look it up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ser un quijote*

- what it means, without mentioning the novel
- the English word that made the same journey (*quixotic*)

Before you move on

What is *quijote* in the dictionary — a name or a noun? (A noun; the name was absorbed.) What are you expected to notice, rather than already know? (That a name is doing the work of a word.)

274.3 pasar a mejor vida — the words a language uses to avoid a word

Some meanings a language will not say directly. This is how Spanish says one of them.

What to know first

- ser un quijote — the allusion.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-SAR a me-JOR VI-da.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pasar a mejor vida — literally "to pass to a better life": to die. Spanish has the plain verb, *morir*, and uses it. But alongside it sits a whole shelf of ways not to: *pasar a mejor vida*, *fallecer* (the formal one), *irse*, *descansar*.
English has exactly the same shelf — *pass away*, *pass on*, *depart*, *rest* — and for the same reason. A **euphemism** is not politeness for its own sake. It is a language routing around a subject its speakers find hard to name.

What you've built

Where the euphemisms cluster tells you what a culture treats as difficult, and the clusters are largely shared: death, illness, money, the body, dismissal from a job.
Two practical consequences. First, **you will meet these before you**

meet the plain word, because speakers reach for them by default with strangers. Second, choosing the plain word when a euphemism was expected is not a neutral act — it is a choice the listener will hear, the same way *sí, claro* said flatly is a choice.
The euphemism is not the polite version of the sentence. It is a different sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pasar a mejor vida*
- the plain verb it avoids (*morir*)
- one English euphemism for the same thing

Before you move on

What is a euphemism doing? (Routing around a subject speakers find hard to name.) Name two areas where euphemisms cluster. (Death, illness, money, the body, losing a job.)

274.4 tener gracia — the last thing a learner gets, and why

The final piece of the chapter, and the one that stays difficult longest.

What to know first

- pasar a mejor vida — the euphemism.
- gracias — one of the first words of this book, and the same root.

Sounds you'll need

- *te-NER GRA-cia.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tener gracia — "to be funny", and rather more than that.
Gracia is Latin **gratia** — favour, charm, grace, and the thing you give thanks for. It is the same word inside *gracias*, which you learned on the first page of this book, and inside English **grace**, **gracious** and **gratitude**.
So *tener gracia* is not quite "to be funny." It is closer to *to have charm* — and a joke that fails is *no tiene gracia*, which says less that it failed to amuse than that it lacked a quality it should have had.

What you've built

Humour is the last thing a learner acquires, and the reason is structural rather than a matter of vocabulary. Every device in the previous two chapters converges here: a joke can turn on an implicature, an inversion, an idiom, a proverb bent out of shape, an allusion, or a euphemism deployed too plainly.
To find something funny in Spanish you have to hold all of them at once and notice which one is being played with — which is why it comes last, and why not getting a joke is a poor measure of your Spanish and a good measure of how much of the culture you have absorbed.
That closes the chapter. Four kinds of weight a phrase can carry beyond its meaning: the community's authority, a shared story, a subject avoided, and a sense of what is charming.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tener gracia*, and *no tiene gracia*
- the first word of this book that shares its root (*gracias*)
- why humour comes last, in one sentence

Before you move on

What Latin word is *gracia*, and which word from page one shares it? (*Gratia*; *gracias*.) Why is humour the last thing acquired? (It requires holding every other implicit device at once.)

274.5 Four kinds of weight

> Each of these four says something plain and carries something else. The skill is naming what the something else is.

Your turn

For each, say the phrase and then name the weight it carries.

Say these aloud:

- *más vale pájaro en mano* — and what it borrows (**the community's authority**: the point is not mine, it is settled)
- *ser un quijote* — and what it borrows (**a shared story**, which you may use without having read)
- *pasar a mejor vida* — and what it borrows (**a silence**: the subject the language is routing around)
- *no tiene gracia* — and what it borrows (**a sense of what is charming**, which is not the same as what is amusing)

Say these aloud:

- which of the four you could use correctly without knowing its source (*un quijote* — the allusion has been absorbed)
- which one tells you what a culture finds hard to say (the euphemism)

Before you move on

Name the four weights: the community's authority, a shared story, a subject avoided, a sense of charm. Which one is transparent in its words but borrowed in its force? (The proverb.) Which is the last a learner acquires, and why? (Humour — it needs all the others at once.)

Chapter 275

Fine Shades — Four Differences a Translation Loses

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can hear four Spanish distinctions that English translates identically, and say which of them no rule can teach me.
>
> *Complete ES-C275-practice: say each pair and what English does with the difference.*

275.1 deber de — one preposition, two entirely different claims

This chapter is about differences too small to be called mistakes and too large to ignore. The first one is a single word.

What to know first

- deber — "should, must", which you already own.
- supongo que — the hedge that claims an inference.

Sounds you'll need

- *de-BER de.* The *de* is unstressed and easy to miss, which is exactly the problem. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

deber and **deber de** — and English uses one word, *must*, for both. *Debe estar en casa.* — He **must** be at home. (Obligation: it is his duty.) *Debe de estar en casa.* — He **must** be at home. (Inference: I conclude it.)
English hides this. *He must be at home* is ambiguous in exactly the same way, and only context resolves it. Spanish has a marker available, and the marker is one unstressed syllable.
Deber is Latin **debere**, "to owe" — English **debt**, **debit**, **due**. The obligation sense is the original; the guessing sense is the borrowed one, which is why the plain form keeps it.

What you've built

Two honest notes, because a rule stated too confidently here would mislead you.
First, this distinction is prescribed more consistently than it is observed. Many educated speakers use plain *deber* for both, and the Real Academia accepts that while recommending the split. **You will hear it collapsed.** Knowing the distinction is for reading carefully and writing precisely, not for correcting anybody.
Second, it belongs beside *supongo que*: both are ways of marking that a statement is reasoned rather than known. *Deber de* puts that marking inside the verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the obligation — *debe estar en casa*
- the inference — *debe de estar en casa*
- which one English cannot mark at all

Before you move on

What does *deber de* claim that *deber* does not? (An inference rather than an obligation.) Is the distinction reliably observed in speech? (No — it is prescribed more than practised.)

275.2 cometer un error — the verb the noun demands

Nothing is wrong with the sentence you would build from first principles. It is simply not what anybody says.

What to know first

- deber de — the modal shade.
- hacer — "to do, to make", the verb you would reach for.

Sounds you'll need

- *co-me-TER un e-RROR*. The double *rr* is trilled. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cometer un error — "to make a mistake."
Not *hacer un error*. That is grammatical, comprehensible, and wrong in the way that matters: no one says it. Spanish **commits** an error, as English commits a crime.
Cometer is Latin **committere** — *com-* ("together") plus *mittere* ("to send"), the root inside English **mission**, **transmit** and **commit**. English kept the verb for offences; Spanish extended it to mistakes.
The pairings are not deducible and have to be met one at a time: *cometer un error*, *tomar una decisión* (not *hacer*), *prestar atención* (to *lend* attention), *hacer una pregunta* (to *make* a question, where English *asks*).

What you've built

A pairing of words that a language habitually uses together is a **collocation**, and it is the last thing to come right in a learner's output. It is worth understanding why it feels so unfair. Grammar is a system you can learn, and vocabulary is a list you can study. Collocation is neither: it is **usage**, and the only source is having met the pair before. This is why reading widely does something no amount of grammar study does, and why a sentence can be flawless and still sound foreign.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cometer un error*
- the version you would have built, and why it is wrong (*hacer* — no one says it)
- one more pair from the list above

Before you move on

What is a collocation? (Words a language habitually uses together.) Why is it the last thing to come right? (It is usage — there is no rule to learn, only exposure.)

275.3 sí que — the yes that answers an accusation nobody made

English does this with the voice. Spanish does it with two words, and they leave a trace on the page.

What to know first

- sí, claro — the ironic yes.
- cometer un error — the collocation.

Sounds you'll need

- *sí ke*, and the *sí* keeps its accent because it is the affirming *sí*, not the conditional *si*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí que — the emphatic affirmative.
Habla español. — He speaks Spanish. *Sí que habla español.* — He **does** speak Spanish.
English marks this with stress alone — *he DOES speak Spanish* — and in writing must resort to italics or the inserted *do*. Spanish has a phrase for it, which means the emphasis **survives being written**

down.
Sí is Latin **sic**, "thus, so" — the same *sic* you meet in an English quotation meaning *thus it stood*.

What you've built

What makes this a fine shade rather than a loud one is what it implies. *Sí que habla español* does not simply assert. It **contradicts** — it answers a doubt, and if nobody voiced one, it invents one to answer. That is a real risk in use: saying *sí que* when no doubt existed tells your listener you thought they doubted you. Emphasis is never only volume; it always implies something about what the other person was thinking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the plain statement
- the emphatic one with *sí que*
- what the emphatic version implies about your listener

Before you move on

What Latin word is *sí*? (*Sic*, "thus".) What does *sí que* do beyond asserting? (It contradicts a doubt — and implies one if none was voiced.)

275.4 delgado / flaco — two words for one fact, and the choice is the message

The last shade, and the one with consequences: two words that describe the same person and say different things about the speaker.

What to know first

- sí que — the emphasis device.

- cansado — an adjective you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *del-GA-do*, *FLA-co.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

delgado and **flaco** both mean "thin."
Delgado is Latin **delicatus** — the same word as English **delicate**. It is the neutral-to-complimentary one: slim.
Flaco is Latin **flaccus**, "flabby, drooping" — English **flaccid**. It is blunter, and depending on where you are and who you are talking to it ranges from plainly descriptive to unkind.
Regional warning, and it matters more than the etymology. In much of Latin America *flaco* is affectionate — a common term of address to a friend, regardless of their build. In parts of Spain it lands harder. This is one of the places where a single word's warmth genuinely does not travel.

What you've built

Two words with the same **denotation** — the fact they point at — and different **connotation** — what choosing one says about you.
This is where a dictionary stops being enough. It will give you both words and the same gloss for each, and the gloss is where the information you need has been removed.
That completes the four shades: a modal that marks a guess, a verb the noun insists on, an emphasis that implies a doubt, and a synonym that is not one. Every one of them is invisible to a translation and audible to a native speaker.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both words
- which you would use about someone you had just met
- why a dictionary cannot tell you that

Before you move on

What is the difference between denotation and connotation? (The fact a word points at; what choosing it says about you.) Which of the two thin-words travels worst between regions? (*Flaco* — affectionate in much of Latin America, harder elsewhere.)

275.5 Four differences a translation loses

Each of these four survives translation into English as the *same sentence*. That is what makes them the last things you learn.

Your turn

For each pair, say both and then say what English does with the difference.

Say these aloud:

- *debe estar* and *debe de estar* — English gives both **must**, and leaves you to guess which
- *cometer un error* and the *hacer* version — English cannot even see the error; both translate to *make a mistake*
- *habla español* and *sí que habla español* — English needs the voice, or italics, and loses it in plain text
- *delgado* and *flaco* — English gives **thin** for both, and the dictionary removes exactly the information you needed

Say these aloud:

- which of the four could get you into trouble socially, and where (*flaco* — warm in much of Latin America, harder elsewhere)
- which one no rule can teach you (the collocation — only having met it)

Before you move on

Name the four: a guess marked in the verb, a verb the noun insists on, an emphasis that implies a doubt, and a synonym that is not

one. What do all four have in common? (English translates them identically.)

Chapter 276

Reading Older Spanish — Register, Date, and Form

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell from small details whether a Spanish text is literary and whether its verse is rhymed.

Complete ES-C276-practice: say what each detail tells you about a text before you have read it.

276.1 mas — a word you will only ever read

The last chapter is about Spanish written before you were born, and Spanish written to be read rather than said. This word is both.

What to know first

- pero — the everyday "but".
- más que — the comparison, WITH an accent.

Sounds you'll need

- *mas*, one syllable, unstressed in the sentence — and note it has **no written accent**, which is the whole point. *Más* with the accent is "more." → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mas — "but." The same job as *pero*, and almost nobody says it aloud. It is Latin **magis**, "more" — the same word that gave you *más*. The two split: *más* kept the quantity, *mas* took a contrastive sense and then retreated into books.
The accent is doing real work here, and this is the pair the written accent exists for: *mas* (but) against *más* (more). Two words, one sound, and only the page tells them apart.

What you've built

A word that survives **only in writing** is a marker of **literary register**, and a reader needs to recognise it for two reasons.
First, practically: meeting *mas* in a poem and reading it as *más* turns the sentence inside out.
Second, and more usefully: its presence tells you what kind of text you are in before you have understood a word of it. Register is information carried by **which** words appear, independently of what they say — and a text signals it in the first line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mas* and *más*, and name the difference on the page
- the everyday word it replaces (*pero*)
- what its presence tells you about a text

Before you move on

What is the difference between *mas* and *más*? (But; more — only the accent separates them.) What does meeting *mas* tell you before you have read the sentence? (That the text is literary.)

276.2 asonancia — why Spanish poems do not rhyme the way you expect

The last piece. If Spanish verse has ever sounded to you like it nearly rhymes, this is why.

What to know first

- mas — the literary register marker.
- vuestra merced → usted — the archaic form, taught long ago.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-so-NAN-cia.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

asonancia — assonance: rhyme on the **vowels only**, ignoring the consonants after them.
Luna and *cuna* rhyme fully — English would call that a rhyme too. But *luna* and *musa* are also a rhyme in Spanish verse: stressed *u*, final *a*, and the *n* against the *s* simply does not count.
Asonancia is Latin **assonare**, "to sound towards" — *ad* plus *sonare*, the root of **sound**, **sonorous** and **unison**.
This is not a loose or lazy rhyme. It is the organising principle of the **romance**, the ballad form, which runs from medieval oral poetry through Lorca in the twentieth century.

What you've built

Two things follow for a reader.
An English-trained ear hears assonance as *failure to rhyme* and concludes the poem is unrhymed. It is rhymed — by a rule your ear was not trained on, and the rule is easier than the English one, not harder.
And it explains why Spanish verse can sustain a single rhyme for hundreds of lines where English cannot. Rhyming on vowels alone leaves far more words available. The form is shaped by what the language makes cheap.
That closes the chapter, and with it the last thing this book can teach you about reading: a text carries its date, its register, and its form in details that look like noise until you know what they are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *asonancia*

- whether *luna* and *musa* rhyme in Spanish (yes)
- why a Spanish ballad can keep one rhyme for hundreds of lines

Before you move on

What does assonance rhyme on? (The vowels only.) Which form is built on it? (The *romance*, the ballad.) Why can it run so long? (Vowel-only rhyme leaves far more words available.)

276.3 What a text tells you before you read it

Three details that look like noise until you know what they are — and each one dates or places a text before you have understood a sentence of it.

Your turn

For each, say what the detail tells you.

Say these aloud:

- you meet *mas* with no accent — what do you now know about the text? (**Literary**, and almost certainly not transcribed speech.)
- you meet *vuestra merced* — what do you now know? (**Old**, and you were told long ago what it became: *usted*.)
- the lines end *luna … musa … cuna* — is this rhymed? (**Yes** — assonance, and an English-trained ear will say no.)

Say these aloud:

- which of the three explains something still in use today (*vuestra merced* — it is why *usted* takes the he/she verb)
- what all three have in common (each carries information that has nothing to do with what the sentence means)

Before you move on

Name what each signals: register, date, form. Which one is a fossil that still governs living grammar? (*Vuestra merced*, behind *usted*.) Which is a rhyme your ear may not hear as one? (Assonance.)

Chapter 277

Working From Sources — Credit It, Restate It, Hold Both, Compress

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can attribute a claim in Spanish, restate it in my own words, hold two disagreeing sources in one structure, and compress both into a sentence.

Complete ES-C277-practice: run all four moves on two sources that disagree, then say what the summary left out.

277.1 según — the word that says this is not mine

The last chapter of the book. It is about handling what other people have said, and it starts with the smallest and most important move: saying whose it is.

What to know first

- en mi opinión — marking a claim as yours.
- dijo que — reporting what someone said.

Sounds you'll need

- *se-GÚN*, and the accent is written because the stress is on the last syllable. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

según — "according to."
Latin **secundum**, "following, next along" — the same word as English **second** and, through it, **sequence**. To say *según* is literally to say *following — following García, the number is higher.*
You already have the opposite move: *en mi opinión* marks a claim as **yours**. *Según* marks it as **someone else's**, and the two together are the whole apparatus of attribution.

What you've built

This is the smallest honest unit of scholarship, and it does two jobs at once.
It **credits** — the idea belongs to somebody. And it **distances** — you are reporting the claim, not endorsing it. *Según él, es fácil* leaves entirely open whether you agree.
That second job is why *según* is common in journalism and argument, not only in citation. It lets you put a claim on the table without picking it up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *según* plus a name plus a claim
- the same claim as your own, with *en mi opinión*
- which of the two commits you to it

Before you move on

What Latin word is *según*, and which English word shares it? (*Secundum — second.*) What two jobs does it do at once? (Credits the source, and distances you from the claim.)

277.2 es decir — saying it again, differently, on purpose

You have the source. Now the harder half: putting what it said into words that are yours.

What to know first

- según — marking whose claim it is.
- es que… — a different *es* phrase entirely.

Sounds you'll need

- *es de-CIR*. Note how close this is to *es que* and how different its job is. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

es decir — "that is to say, in other words."
Literally *it is to say*: the infinitive *decir* from Latin **dicere**, the root inside English **diction**, **dictate**, **verdict** and **contradict**.
It marks what follows as **the same content in different words** — and that is the definition of a **paraphrase**. Not a summary, which is shorter, and not a quotation, which is identical. The same, said again, deliberately.

What you've built

Why a language needs a marker for this at all is worth a moment. Without *es decir*, a restatement looks like a second, separate claim. The listener counts two points where you made one. The marker tells them: **this is the same point, arriving again in a form you may find easier.**
That is also the honest test of whether you have understood a source. If you can only repeat its words, you have not understood it; if you can say it another way, you have. Paraphrase is comprehension made visible, which is why it is asked for in every examination ever set.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a claim, then *es decir*, then the same claim differently
- why the marker matters (without it, it reads as a second point)
- the difference between a paraphrase and a summary

Before you move on

What does *es decir* mark? (The same content in different words.) How does a paraphrase differ from a summary? (A summary is shorter; a paraphrase is the same length, said differently.) Which English words share *dicere*? (*Diction*, *verdict*, *contradict*.)

277.3 por un lado... por otro — two sources in one sentence

One source you can report. Two that disagree is a different problem, and this is the frame for it.

What to know first

- es decir — restating a source.
- sin embargo — turning against a point.

Sounds you'll need

- *por un LA-do … por O-tro.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

por un lado... por otro (lado) — "on one hand… on the other."
Lado is Latin **latus**, "side, flank" — English **lateral**, **bilateral**. The image is spatial in both languages: two sides of a thing, held apart so both can be seen.
Spanish, like English, usually drops the second *lado*: *por un lado… por otro.*

What you've built

This is the frame that makes **synthesis** possible, and synthesis is not the same as reporting twice.

Reporting twice: *Según García, sube. Según López, baja.* Two facts, no relation. Synthesising: *Por un lado García dice que sube; por otro, López lo niega.* Now the two are **held in one structure**, and the reader can see that they conflict rather than having to notice it themselves.
The frame does the analytical work. Announcing two sides commits you to producing both, which is exactly the discipline that stops a summary from quietly becoming an argument for one of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- two conflicting claims, reported flatly, one after the other
- the same two inside the *por un lado… por otro* frame
- what the frame made visible that the flat version did not

Before you move on

What Latin word is *lado*? (*Latus*, "side" — English *lateral*.) What does the frame do that reporting twice does not? (It holds the two in one structure, so the relation between them is visible.)

277.4 en resumen — the hardest thing to do with a text

The last phrase in the book, and the hardest skill in it.

What to know first

- por un lado… por otro — holding two sources.
- por lo tanto — the cohesion join.

Sounds you'll need

- *en re-su-MEN.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en resumen — "in short, in summary."
Resumen is Latin **resumere** — *re-* ("again") plus *sumere* ("to take up"). To summarise is to **take it up again**, and English **resume** kept the taking-up while Spanish kept the shortening.
Note the false friend, because it will catch you: Spanish *resumen* is a **summary**, not a curriculum vitae. The English *résumé* took the same French word in a different direction.

What you've built

Summarising is harder than paraphrasing, and the difference is **decision**.
A paraphrase keeps everything and changes the words. A summary **throws things away**, and every omission is a judgement about what mattered. That is why two honest summaries of one text can differ, and why summarising is the last skill on this ladder rather than the first.
It also closes the loop this book opened. It began by giving you a word for *hello*. It ends by giving you the means to read what other people have written, decide what is load-bearing in it, and say that much in your own words — which is most of what it means to *use* a language rather than to know one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en resumen*, and compress the last thing you read into one sentence
- what you left out, and why
- the false friend to avoid (*resumen* is not a CV)

Before you move on

What does *resumere* mean, taken apart? (To take up again.) What separates a summary from a paraphrase? (A summary throws things away, and every omission is a judgement.)

277.5 Read two, say one

The last exercise in the book, and it uses all four moves in the order you would actually need them.

Your turn

Find two things that disagree — two people, two articles, two friends. Then run the four moves.

Say these aloud:

- *según* the first one, what it claims. You have credited it and not agreed with it.
- *es decir*, and the same claim in words the first source did not use. If you cannot, you have not understood it yet.
- *por un lado… por otro*, putting both inside one sentence so the disagreement is visible rather than merely present.
- *en resumen*, and one sentence that covers both.

Say these aloud:

- what you left out of the summary, and why it was safe to lose
- whether your summary favours one of the two. Check honestly — this is where a summary quietly becomes an argument.

Before you move on

Name the four moves: credit it, restate it, hold both, compress.
Which one proves you understood the source? (The paraphrase.)
Which one requires you to throw something away? (The summary.)

Chapter 278

Four Things Outdoors — Wind, Snow, Tree, Flower

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the wind, the snow, a tree and a flower in Spanish, and say for each whether its English relative is an inherited cousin or a later borrowing.
>
> *Complete ES-C278-flor: say all four words, then sort their English relatives into cousins and loans.*

278.1 el viento — a word English happens to own twice

You have just spent a long run of lessons on words for arguing, citing and summarising. What follows is the opposite kind of material: plain, solid things you can point at.

What to know first

- el tiempo — the weather, and the word for it.
- hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — saying what the weather is doing today.

Sounds you'll need

- *VIEN-to*, stress on the first syllable. The *ie* is the same opening-out you have met before in *quiero* and *tiene*: one Latin vowel arriving in Spanish as two. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el viento — "the wind."
Latin **ventus**, with its short stressed *e* opening into *ie* on the road into Spanish. That single change is why the vowel you say is not the vowel Latin wrote.
The interesting part is on the English side. **Wind** was not taken from *ventus*. The two words go back to one much older ancestor and came down two separate family lines, which is why they resemble each other only faintly. **Ventilate** and **vent**, by contrast, *are* Latin *ventus*, carried into English out of books long after English already had a perfectly good word for moving air.

What you've built

A cousin and a loan leave different marks, and you can often see which you are holding.
An inherited word has been in the mouth for two thousand years, and each language has worn it down its own way — one ancestor came out as *viento* here and as *wind* there. A borrowed word arrives late, in writing, and stays tidy: *ventilate* still looks Latin because it has had almost no time to stop looking Latin.
Keep that test. It will pay off in nearly every word ahead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el viento*
- which English word is the cousin and which is the loan (*wind*; *ventilate*)
- one sentence about the weather with *hace*, and one with *el viento*

Before you move on

What Latin word stands behind *viento*? (*Ventus.*) Is English *wind* borrowed from it? (No — a cousin, down a separate line from the same ancestor.) Which English word is the actual loan? (*Ventilate*, or *vent.*)

278.2 la nieve — the same vowel trick, and a missing s

You have one weather word already. Here is a second, and it repeats the sound change you just met — which is how you will start to recognise it on your own.

What to know first

- el viento — the wind, and the *ie* that came out of a Latin *e*.
- llueve — saying that it is raining.

Sounds you'll need

- *NIE-ve*, stress on the first syllable, and the *v* said with the lips barely meeting — the soft *b* sound you already use in *vino*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la nieve — "the snow."
Latin's word was **nix**, but its other forms carry the stem *niv-*, and it is that stem — through the form *nivem* — that Spanish grew from. The short stressed *e* opened into *ie*, exactly as it did a moment ago, and *nivem* came out as *nieve*.
English **snow** is the cousin. The shared ancestor began with an *s* that Latin dropped and the Germanic side kept, so the two words differ at the front and agree behind it. Latin's own form does reach English, but only in cold technical corners: **niveous** for snow-white, and the *nival* zone near the top of a mountain.

What you've built

Twice now, a Latin *e* under stress has arrived in Spanish as *ie*. That is no longer a fact about one word; it is a pattern you can carry.
When you meet a Spanish word with *ie* whose Latin or English relative shows a plain *e*, you are almost certainly looking at this same event, two thousand years old, still visible in the spelling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la nieve*, then *el viento*
- the Latin stem behind it (*niv-*)
- what English kept at the front of *snow* that Latin threw away

Before you move on

Which sound change turned *nivem* into *nieve*? (Stressed *e* opening into *ie* — the same one behind *viento*.) What separates *nieve* from English *snow* at the very front? (An *s* the Latin line lost.)

278.3 el árbol — one letter away from Latin

Some words changed a great deal on the way from Latin. This one changed by a single letter, and the letter it changed tells you something about mouths rather than about Spanish.

What to know first

- verde — green, from a Latin verb meaning to flourish.
- á é í ó ú — what a written accent does to the stress.

Sounds you'll need

- *ÁR-bol*. The accent is written because the stress falls on the first syllable while the word ends in *l*, which is not where the default would put it. The *r* is a single tap, not a roll. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el árbol — "the tree."
Latin **arbor**, and Spanish kept nearly all of it. What moved is the second *r*, which became *l*.
Two *r* sounds a syllable apart are awkward to keep distinct, and a tongue that says the word ten thousand times will look for a way out. Spanish took it. Portuguese, next door, did not: its tree is *árvore*, both *r* sounds intact. The escape route was available, not compulsory, and that is worth knowing before you start expecting sound changes to be laws.
English holds the Latin word too, untouched: **arbor**, **arboreal**, **arboretum**. Both *r* sounds still there, because a word borrowed out of a book escapes everything an inherited word lives through.

What you've built

This is the cousin-and-loan test again, from the other direction. *Árbol* is the inherited form, and it carries a scar: one sound gave way to another for no reason except ease. *Arboretum* is the loan, and it carries no scar at all. When two English words look like a Spanish one but only the tidy one matches it letter for letter, the tidy one is usually the late arrival.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el árbol*, stressing the first syllable
- the Latin word, and which of its letters moved (*arbor*; the second *r*)
- *el viento, la nieve, el árbol* — the three you now have

Before you move on

What single change separates *árbol* from *arbor*? (The second *r* became *l*.) Did every Romance language make it? (No — Portuguese kept *árvore*.) Why does English *arboretum* look more Latin than the Spanish word does? (It was borrowed late, not inherited.)

278.4 la flor — and the English word hiding inside your bread

The last of the four outdoor words, and the one with the best surprise waiting on the English side.

What to know first

- el árbol — the tree, one letter from Latin.
- el pan — bread, which this lesson comes back to.

Sounds you'll need

- *flor*, one syllable, ending in a single tapped *r*. Spanish does not put a vowel into the *fl-* cluster, so it starts cleanly. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la flor — "the flower."
Latin's bare form was **flos**, but its other forms show the stem *flor-*, and Spanish built on the stem, as it did with *nieve*. Feminine, so *la flor*, even though the ending gives you no help at all.
English took the same stem twice. Once through French, as **flower**. And once — this is the surprise — as **flour**. The finest part of ground grain, sifted out from the rest, was called the *flower* of the meal, in the sense of *the best of it*. For centuries English wrote both senses the same way, and only later split the spelling so that a baker and a gardener could stop confusing each other.
Flourish, **floral** and **flora** are the same root again, arriving in more obviously Latin clothes.

What you've built

You now have four ordinary outdoor words, and each one taught a different way a word can travel.
Viento showed a cousin beside a loan. *Nieve* showed a sound change repeating, so you could recognise it rather than memorise it. *Árbol* showed a change that one language made and its neighbour did not. And *flor* shows a single word splitting in two inside English, until the two halves no longer look related.
That is four kinds of movement, and none of them is Spanish being

irregular. It is what happens to any word that stays in use long enough.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la flor*, with a clean *fl-*
- what *flour* originally meant (the flower, the finest part, of the ground grain)
- all four — *el viento, la nieve, el árbol, la flor*

Before you move on

Which Latin stem gave *flor*? (*Flor-*, from *flos.*) Which everyday English word is the same word as *flower*? (*Flour.*) Is *la flor* masculine or feminine? (Feminine, and its ending tells you nothing.)

Chapter 279

Four Things in a Room — Door, Window, Chair, Bed

Modes: **voice** (4) **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the door, the window, the chair and the bed in Spanish, and say which of the four has no settled origin.
>
> *Complete ES-C279-cama: name the four things around you, and say which one nobody has managed to trace.*

279.1 la puerta — a city gate, shrunk to fit a house

Come indoors. The next four words are things in the room you are probably sitting in, and the first of them started life very much larger.

What to know first

- la casa — the house these things are inside.
- e → ie and o → ue — the two vowels that open under stress.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUER-ta*, stress on the first syllable. The *ue* is one glide, not two separate vowels. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la puerta — "the door."
Latin **porta**, with the short stressed *o* opening into *ue* — the partner of the change that gave you *viento*. Same event, other vowel.
But *porta* did not mean a door in a house. It meant a **gate**: the opening in a city wall, the thing guarded and shut at night. Spanish took the grand word and let it shrink until it would fit a bedroom.
English holds *porta* in several shapes. A **portal** is a doorway that still sounds like a gate. A **porch** came through French from *porticus*, the covered way at the entrance. And one of English's two **porter**s — the one who keeps the door of a college or a hotel — is the gate-keeper of *porta*, while the porter who carries your luggage comes from a different Latin verb entirely. Two unrelated words, spelled identically, sitting in the same hotel lobby.

What you've built

Words shrink. A gate in a wall becomes a door in a wall becomes a door in a room, and nothing marks the moment it happened.
This matters for reading older Spanish, where a word you know may still be carrying more weight than it does today. When a text seems to make a small thing sound grand, check whether the word was once grand.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la puerta*, one glide in the middle
- what *porta* meant to a Roman (a city gate)
- which English *porter* belongs here (the one who keeps the door)

Before you move on

Which vowel change turned *porta* into *puerta*? (Stressed *o* opening into *ue*.) What did the Latin word name? (A gate in a city wall.) Which English word keeps that sense most plainly? (*Portal*.)

279.2 la ventana — two languages, one idea, no contact

You met the wind a few lessons ago. It is about to come back indoors, and so is English, by a completely separate road.

What to know first

- el viento — the wind, from Latin *ventus*.
- la puerta — the other opening in the wall.

Sounds you'll need

- *ven-TA-na*, stress in the middle. Three even syllables, no written accent needed because the stress lands where the default puts it. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la ventana — "the window."
Take Latin **ventus**, the wind, and add an ending. That is the whole word: a *ventana* is the wind's opening. Notice that the *e* stayed put here — it does not open into *ie*, because in this longer word the stress moved off it and onto the *a*. The change you learned needs a stressed vowel to work on.
Now the good part. English **window** has nothing to do with Latin. It came from Old Norse *vindauga*, which is *vindr* plus *auga*: **wind-eye**. Two languages, no contact between them on this point, both looked at a hole in a wall and named it after the draught coming through.
Latin had its own word, **fenestra**, and Spanish let it go. French and Italian kept it — *fenêtre*, *finestra* — and English borrowed it for one splendid purpose only: **defenestration**, throwing somebody out of a window.

What you've built

Two things worth carrying out of this one.
First, the sound change has a condition attached. *Ventus* gave *viento* when the *e* was stressed and *ventana* when it was not, and the same vowel behaved differently in the same century for that reason alone.
Second, unrelated languages reach the same metaphor often enough

that a shared idea is weak evidence of a shared word. *Ventana* and *window* agree on meaning and share no ancestor at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la ventana*, stress in the middle
- *el viento*, then *la ventana* — the same Latin word, stressed and unstressed
- what *vindauga* meant, part by part (wind, eye)

Before you move on

Why does *ventana* keep a plain *e* where *viento* has *ie*? (The stress moved off the vowel.) Which Latin word for a window did Spanish drop? (*Fenestra.*) Where does English still keep it? (*Defenestration.*)

279.3 la silla — a word you are sitting on

Two openings in the wall, and now the furniture. This word turns out to be a close relative of several English words you would never have guessed.

What to know first

- sentarse — to sit down, the action this object exists for.
- cl-, pl-, fl- → ll- — the *ll* sound, and where Spanish gets it.

Sounds you'll need

- *SI-ya* in most of the Spanish-speaking world, *SI-zha* or *SI-sha* around the River Plate. The *ll* is one sound, never two *l* sounds in a row. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la silla — "the chair."
Latin **sella**, a seat, and behind *sella* the verb **sedere**, to sit. The object is named after the posture, which is so obvious once said that most people never notice it.
Sedere is generous. English **sedentary** is a life spent sitting. A **session** is a sitting, which is why parliaments and courts still have them. A **resident** is somebody sitting back down in a place. The Holy **See** is a seat, from Latin *sedes*, and a bishop's **cathedral** is named for his *cathedra*, the chair he speaks from.
And **saddle** belongs here too, by the cousin route rather than the loan: it comes down the Germanic line from the same ancient root for sitting, without ever passing through Latin.

What you've built

One root, and you can now recognise it in half a dozen English words you already knew separately.
That is what makes etymology worth the time. You are not memorising trivia about *silla*; you are getting a hook that catches *sedentary*, *session*, *resident* and *cathedral* on the way past — and, next time you meet an unfamiliar Spanish word starting *sed-* or *sen-*, a first guess worth testing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la silla*, with one *ll* sound
- the Latin verb behind it (*sedere*, to sit)
- three English words from that verb

Before you move on

What Latin noun is *silla*? (*Sella*, a seat.) What verb lies behind it? (*Sedere*, to sit.) Is English *saddle* a loan from Latin or a cousin? (A cousin, down the Germanic line.)

279.4 la cama — the second word nobody can explain

You have already met one everyday Spanish word with no agreed origin. Here is the other one, and it is even harder to avoid using.

What to know first

- perro — the dog, and the honest shrug that came with it.
- dormir — to sleep.

Sounds you'll need

- *CA-ma*, two short even syllables, the *c* hard as in *casa*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cama — "the bed."
Latin's word was **lectum**, and Spanish did keep it: *lecho* survives, but it has gone literary, the sort of bed a character dies in. What you actually sleep in is *cama*, and *cama* is not Latin.
The earliest witness is Isidore of Seville, writing in the 600s, who glosses it as a bed low to the ground and treats it as a local word rather than a Latin one. After that the trail forks. One proposal takes it from Greek *khamai*, "on the ground", which fits Isidore's own definition suspiciously well. Another puts it in the pre-Roman languages of the peninsula, which are barely recorded and so can neither be confirmed nor ruled out.

What you've built

Two of the plainest words in the language — the dog and the bed — have no settled history, and that is not a gap in your notes.
It is worth being clear about why. Both proposals for *cama* predict evidence that would decide the matter, and in both cases the evidence would have had to be written down by people who mostly did not write. The question is open because the record is thin, not because nobody has thought about it.
Meanwhile the word itself is completely secure. You can sleep in a *cama* every night of your life without the etymology ever coming up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cama*
- the Latin word Spanish half-kept, and what became of it (*lectum*, now the literary *lecho*)
- the two proposals, and why neither is settled

Before you move on

Is *cama* inherited from Latin? (No.) Who is the earliest witness for it? (Isidore of Seville, in the 600s.) Which other everyday word you have already met has the same unsettled status? (*Perro*.)

Chapter 280

Four Things You Buy — Cheese, Egg, Apple, Money

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name cheese, an egg, an apple and money in Spanish, and say which of them is named after a Roman gardener and which after a Roman coin.
>
> *Complete ES-C280-dinero: name the four, then say which two carry a proper name and a coin inside them.*

280.1 el queso — the same word as cheese, honestly

Four things you might buy. The first of them looks nothing like its English translation, and is nevertheless the identical word.

What to know first

- la comida — food, and the meal.
- el pan — bread, which you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *KE-so.* The *qu-* before *e* is a plain hard *k*; the *u* is written but never said. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el queso — "the cheese."
Latin **caseus**. Spanish inherited it and wore it down to *queso*.
Now consider English. **Cheese** is *caseus* as well. Germanic speakers along the Roman frontier took the word — with the thing, which the Romans were better at — some time before the year 500, and it went through the Germanic sound changes until *caseus* had become Old English *cyse*. German did the same and got *Käse*.
So *queso* and *cheese* are one Latin noun that spent fifteen centuries in two different mouths. They no longer share a single sound in the same position, and they are still the same word. **Casein**, the protein, is the modern loan, taken straight from the book and untouched.

What you've built

Resemblance is a poor guide to relatedness, in both directions. *Queso* and *cheese* look unrelated and are the same word. Meanwhile Spanish is full of words that look reassuringly like an English one and mean something else entirely — you have already met a few of those. Sound alone decides nothing; the history has to be traced.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el queso*, with a silent *u*
- the Latin word behind both languages (*caseus*)
- *el pan y el queso*

Before you move on

Are *queso* and *cheese* related? (They are the same Latin word, *caseus*.) Which one is the loan and which the inheritance? (English borrowed it; Spanish inherited it.) Is the *u* in *queso* pronounced? (No.)

280.2 el huevo — a letter put there for the reader

A short word with a letter in front of it that does nothing at all — and the reason it is there is one of the more human facts in Spanish spelling.

What to know first

- el queso — the cheese, from *caseus*.
- f → h — the other place an *h* turns up unpronounced.

Sounds you'll need

- *WE-bo*. The *h* is silent, the *ue* is one glide, and the *v* is that soft lips-barely-touching sound again. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el huevo — "the egg."
Latin **ovum**, with the stressed *o* opening into *ue* — the change you already know from *puerta*. That gives *uevo*, which is exactly what the word sounds like.
So where did the *h* come from? Not from Latin, and not from the sound. It came from scribes. In medieval handwriting *u* and *v* were the same letter, so a word beginning *ue-* could be read as *ve-* by anyone in a hurry. Putting a silent *h* in front made the following letter unmistakably a vowel. The *h* of *huevo* is a reading aid, frozen into the spelling centuries after the fact.
English took *ovum* straight from Latin and left the sense alone: **oval**, **ovary**, **ovulate**. English **egg** itself is Norse, and it displaced the older native *ey* — one more everyday word the Vikings left behind.

What you've built

Not every letter in a word records a sound. Some record a problem somebody had while reading.
That is a useful thing to hold on to, because it stops silent letters from looking like arbitrary cruelty. *Huevo*, *hueso*, *huerto* — the *h* appears before *ue* right across the language, always for the same reason, and once you know the reason you can predict it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el huevo*, starting on the *w* sound
- the Latin word (*ovum*) and the change that gave *ue*
- why the *h* is written

Before you move on

Does the *h* of *huevo* come from Latin? (No.) What is it doing there? (Marking the *u* as a vowel, for readers of handwriting.) Which Latin word is underneath? (*Ovum*, the source of English *oval*.)

280.3 la manzana — a variety name that ate the fruit

This one is a person's name, worn down for two thousand years until nobody notices the person inside it any more.

What to know first

- María · España · profesor — how Spanish handles proper names.
- el huevo — the egg, and its silent *h*.

Sounds you'll need

- *man-ZA-na*, stress in the middle. The *z* is a soft *th* in most of Spain and an *s* almost everywhere else; both are standard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la manzana — "the apple."
Latin's general word for apple was **malum**, and Spanish did not keep it. What it kept was a variety.
Gaius Matius was a Roman of the first century before our era, a friend of Julius Caesar, and a writer on cooking and gardening. A kind of apple carried his name: **mala Mattiana**, the Matian apples. That

phrase wore down — *mattiana* into *manzana* — and along the way the adjective swallowed the noun. The variety name became the word for the fruit, and the man vanished inside it.
English does this too, and recently enough that the joins are still obvious. A **satsuma** is named after a Japanese province, a **greengage** after Sir William Gage, a **boysenberry** after Rudolph Boysen. Give any of them another fifteen centuries of ordinary use and they will look as opaque as *manzana* does.

What you've built

An ordinary word can have a proper name inside it, completely invisible.
This is worth holding because it explains a shape you will keep meeting: a word whose Latin ancestor looks like an adjective rather than a noun. *Mattiana* was an adjective agreeing with *mala*. The noun dropped out, the adjective stayed, and the ending it still carries is the feminine ending it needed in order to agree with a fruit that is no longer in the sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la manzana*, stress in the middle
- whose apples they were (*Matius*)
- *el queso, el huevo, la manzana*

Before you move on

What was *mala Mattiana*? (The apples of Matius, a Roman variety.) Which half of that phrase survived? (The adjective.) What was Latin's ordinary word for an apple? (*Malum* — and Spanish let it go.)

280.4 el dinero — one coin, three survivals

You have just seen a person's name inside a fruit. Here is a coin inside the word for money — and this one left tracks in three

languages.

What to know first

- comprar — to buy, which this word makes possible.
- uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting, for prices.

Sounds you'll need

- *di-NE-ro*, stress in the middle. The *d* between vowels is soft, closer to the *th* of English *the* than to a hard *d*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el dinero — "the money."
Latin **denarius**, a silver coin. The name means "by tens": at its introduction it was reckoned as ten of the smaller bronze coins, and the coin kept the arithmetic in its name long after the exchange rate had moved.
That coin outlived its empire three separate times. Spanish turned it into *dinero*, the general word for money — a particular coin generalised into all money, the same move you have just watched a particular apple make. Arabic borrowed it as **dinar**, which is still the name of the currency in several countries. And in Britain the penny was abbreviated **d** — for *denarius* — right up until decimalisation in 1971, so that a price written *3d* was quoting a Roman coin to a shopper who had never heard of one.

What you've built

Twice in two lessons, a specific thing has become a general one: Matius's apples became all apples, and one silver coin became all money.
That widening is one of the commonest ways a word changes meaning, and it is worth watching for, because it runs the other way too. When an old text uses a word you know, ask whether it was still the narrow version. A medieval *dinero* might be an actual coin in somebody's hand rather than money in the abstract.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el dinero*, with a soft *d*
- what *denarius* meant (by tens — ten of the smaller coins)
- the three places the coin survives (*dinero*, *dinar*, British *d*)

Before you move on

Which Roman coin is *dinero*? (The *denarius*.) What did its name count? (Tens.) What did *d* stand for on a British price tag? (*Denarius* — the penny.)

Chapter 281

Four Ordinary Adjectives — New, Old, Clean, Dirty

Modes: **voice** (4) **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say new, old, clean and dirty in Spanish, and say what each of them meant in Latin before it meant what it means now.

Complete ES-C281-sucio: say each adjective with its four endings, and give the Latin sense it started from.

281.1 nuevo — the cousin test, one last time

Four adjectives to finish with, in two pairs. Each of them meant something slightly different in Latin from what it means to you now.

What to know first

- grande — an adjective you already use.
- la puerta — where you first met stressed *o* opening into *ue*.

Sounds you'll need

- *NUE-vo*, stress on the first syllable, the *ue* one glide. Four forms to keep straight: *nuevo, nueva, nuevos, nuevas.* → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nuevo — "new."
Latin **novus**, with the stressed *o* opening into *ue* exactly as it did in *puerta*. Third time you have seen that change, and by now you should be able to run it backwards: give a Spanish *ue*, guess a Latin *o*.
English **new** is the cousin. It comes down the Germanic line from the same ancient root, never passing through Latin — which is why it is short, plain and worn, the way inherited words are.
The loans came later and stayed longer: a **novel** is a new thing, a **novice** is a new arrival, to **renovate** is to make new again, and a **nova** in the sky is a star that was not there last year. Every one of them is *novus*, taken out of a book rather than out of a mouth.

What you've built

You now have the cousin-and-loan test in a form you can apply without being told.
Short, irregular, everyday English words are usually the cousins. Long, tidy, bookish ones are usually the loans. *New* against *renovate*; *wind* against *ventilate*. When a Spanish word has two English relatives, the plain one tells you how old the family is and the fancy one tells you the Latin spelling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nuevo, nueva, nuevos, nuevas*
- the Latin word, and the change that gave *ue* (*novus*; stressed *o*)
- *una casa nueva*

Before you move on

What Latin adjective is *nuevo*? (*Novus.*) Is English *new* a loan from it? (No — a cousin.) Which English words are the loans? (*Novel*, *novice*, *renovate*, *nova.*)

281.2 viejo — the word Spanish kept was the affectionate one

The opposite of the word you just learned — and Spanish did not inherit the ordinary Latin adjective for it. It inherited a nickname.

What to know first

- nuevo — its opposite, from *novus*.
- trabajar — where you first met the throat sound written *j*.

Sounds you'll need

- *VIE-jo*, stress on the first syllable. The *j* is the same throat sound you have in *trabajo*, not an English *j*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

viejo — "old."
Latin's plain adjective was **vetus**. Spanish does not descend from it. It descends from **vetulus**, the diminutive — *little old one*, the form you would use warmly about a grandparent or a well-worn coat. Spoken Latin shortened *vetulus* to *veclus*, and *veclus* came out as *viejo*, with the stressed *e* opening into *ie* along the way.
This happened more than once. Late spoken Latin liked diminutives the way a family likes nicknames, and several Spanish words are the affectionate form that outlived the neutral one. The plain *vetus* did not vanish; it went into English instead, as **veteran** — someone grown old in a trade — and as **inveterate**, a habit that has aged into place.

What you've built

Spanish inherited spoken Latin, not written Latin, and the two made different choices.
That is why the dictionary word so often ends up in English while the everyday word ends up in Spanish: the books preserved *vetus*, the streets preserved *vetulus*, and English later raided the books. When a Spanish word and its English relative feel different in tone, this is usually why.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viejo, vieja, viejos, viejas*
- *nuevo* and *viejo*, one after the other
- which Latin word English kept, and where (*vetus*, in *veteran*)

Before you move on

Which Latin form gave *viejo* — the plain adjective or the diminutive? (The diminutive, *vetulus*.) What did the diminutive add? (Warmth — *little old one*.) Where did plain *vetus* end up? (In English *veteran*.)

281.3 limpio — clear water, and what became of it

The last pair. Both of these adjectives started out describing water, and only one of them stayed there.

What to know first

- el agua — water, which this word first described.
- viejo — the adjective before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *LIM-pio*, stress on the first syllable, and *-pio* is one syllable, not two. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

limpio — "clean."
Latin **limpidus**, which meant clear, transparent, see-through. It was said of water and of air, and it was about what you could see through rather than about what had been washed.
English borrowed it and left the meaning exactly where it found it: **limpid** is still a word for a clear pool or a clear prose style, and it has

nothing to do with housework. Spanish, using the word every day rather than only in poetry, let it drift the short distance from *clear* to *clean*, and then handed the job of describing water to other words. The verb followed the adjective: *limpiar*, to clean, is built on *limpio* and did not exist in Latin at all.

What you've built

The same Latin word can sit still in one language and move in another, and the one that moved is usually the one that got used more. There is a rough test in that. A word a language uses constantly drifts, narrows and widens; a word it reserves for books stays put. *Limpid* is rare in English and has not changed in centuries. *Limpio* is said a hundred times a day and has already travelled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *limpio, limpia, limpios, limpias*
- what *limpidus* meant (clear, see-through)
- *el agua limpia*

Before you move on

What did *limpidus* mean in Latin? (Clear, transparent.) Which English word still holds that sense? (*Limpid*.) Which language moved the meaning, and why? (Spanish, because it used the word constantly.)

281.4 sucio — wool straight off the sheep

The opposite of the last word, and its history is far more specific than you would expect from something this ordinary.

What to know first

- limpio — its opposite, from *limpidus*.
- la mano — a body word, handy for practising this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *SU-cio*, stress on the first syllable. The *c* before *i* is a soft *th* in much of Spain and an *s* elsewhere, like the *z* you met before. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sucio — "dirty."
Latin **sucidus**, from **sucus**, juice or sap. *Sucidus* meant juicy, sappy, greasy — and its most ordinary use was for **wool that had not been washed**, still heavy with the natural grease it came off the animal with.
From there the road is short. Ungreased wool is unwashed wool; unwashed becomes unclean; unclean becomes dirty in general, including dirty in the moral sense that *sucio* also carries. The word never described mud. It described a fleece.
English keeps *sucus* in **succulent**, a plant full of juice, and the connection to *suck* is real but ancient — both go back to a root about drawing liquid.

What you've built

That is sixteen plain words, and every one of them turned out to have somewhere it came from.
Look back at what the pair you just finished has in common. *Limpio* began at clear water and moved to clean; *sucio* began at greasy wool and moved to dirty. Neither started life as an opposite of the other. They were pulled into a pair later, by speakers who needed two words and had these two lying about — which is how most of the neat oppositions in any language got built.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sucio, sucia, sucios, sucias*
- what *sucidus* described (unwashed wool, still greasy)
- *la mano sucia*, then *la mano limpia*

Before you move on

What did *sucidus* mean? (Juicy or greasy — said of unwashed wool.) What is the noun behind it? (*Sucus*, juice.) Were *limpio* and *sucio* ever a pair in Latin? (No — they were made into one later.)

Chapter 282

Meeting Someone — Welcome, Greeting, Hug, Smile, Guest

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can welcome someone in Spanish and name the greeting, the hug, the smile and the guest that go with it.
>
> *Complete ES-C282-invitado: say all five words in order, and say which two of them are participles.*

282.1 bienvenido — well come, in two words you already have

> What did *sucidus* describe before it meant dirty? (Unwashed wool, still greasy.) Now a word with nothing new in it but the joining.

What to know first

- bien — well, and the first half of this word.
- hola — the greeting you have opened with since the start.

Sounds you'll need

- *bien-ve-NI-do*, stress on the *ni*. The *v* is the same soft sound you give *b* — two letters, one sound. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bienvenido — "welcome."
Two pieces, both of them plain. **bien**, well, which you have; and **venido**, come, the participle of *venir*. Latin put it the same way round: *bene venutus*, well come.
English **welcome** looks like the identical build and is not one. Old English had **wilcuma**, from *willa*, desire, and *cuma*, a comer: the person you wanted to arrive. Norse and French pressure then bent *wil-* into *wel-*, and the word ended up resembling "well" plus "come" by accident.
So two languages reached the same shape from opposite directions. Spanish means it literally. English only appears to.

What you've built

Nothing here was new except the joining.
Bien you had already, and *venido* has *venir* audible inside it. A compound you can take apart is a word you do not have to memorise — and Spanish builds a great many of its politest words this way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bienvenido*, then *bienvenida*
- the two pieces on their own — *bien*, *venido*
- *hola*, then *bienvenido*, as you would at a door

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *bienvenido*? (*Bien* and *venido*.) Is English *welcome* built the same way? (No — it was *wilcuma*, a desired comer.)

282.2 el saludo — a wish for your health, worn smooth

Before the new one: what are the two pieces of *bienvenido*? (*Bien* and *venido*.)

What to know first

- bienvenido — what you say; this is what you are doing.
- hola — one particular instance of it.

Sounds you'll need

- *sa-LU-do*, stress on the *lu*. The *d* between two vowels is soft, closer to the *th* of English *this* than to a hard *d*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el saludo — "a greeting."
From **saludar**, to greet, and behind that Latin **salutem**, health — the accusative of *salus*, soundness and safety. To greet a Roman was to wish him his health, and Spanish still raises a glass with *salud* and answers a sneeze with it.
English took the same Latin word more than once. **Salute** is the soldier's version, borrowed whole. **Salutary** and **salubrious** kept the health and dropped the greeting altogether.
So a *saludo* is not really a word. It is a wish, repeated until nobody hears it any more — which is what centuries do to every polite formula, in every language.

What you've built

You have been greeting people since your first lesson without a name for the act.
This is the name. Having one lets you talk about the thing rather than only do it — and that is a step up in what you can say.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el saludo*
- *un saludo*, then *el saludo*
- *bienvenido* and then *el saludo* — the word, then the act

Before you move on

What is behind *saludo*? (*Salutem*, health.) Which English word is the soldier's version of it? (*Salute*.)

282.3 el abrazo — the arm is still inside the word

Before the new one: what did *saludo* wish you? (Your health.)

What to know first

- la mano — a part of the body you already have.
- el saludo — the greeting this one belongs to.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-BRA-zo*, stress in the middle. The *r* is a single tap, and the *z* is the *th* of *think* in much of Spain and an *s* elsewhere. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el abrazo — "a hug."
From **abrazar**, and inside it Latin **bracchium**, the arm: *ad-bracchiare*, to put your arms around. The word says exactly what the body does, and Spanish never hid it — *brazo* is still the word for the arm itself.
English **embrace** is the same build through French, *in* plus *bracchium*. A **bracelet** is a little arm-band. A **brace** holds a thing the way an arm holds it.
Latin took *bracchium* from Greek *brakhion*, which meant the shorter upper arm — from *brakhys*, short, the same *brachy-* that turns up in a scientist's vocabulary. The hug goes back to a word for shortness.

What you've built

Three words now, and each of them is something you could point at. A welcome, a greeting, an embrace. None of the three needed grammar to be useful — which is worth remembering when a language starts to feel like rules.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el abrazo*
- *un abrazo*, which is how a letter ends
- *el saludo* and *el abrazo* one after the other

Before you move on

What is inside *abrazo*? (*Bracchium*, the arm.) Which English word is the same build? (*Embrace.*)

282.4 la sonrisa — a laugh with the volume down

Before the new one: what is inside *abrazo*? (*Bracchium*, the arm.)

What to know first

- el abrazo — the last one, and another thing a face or a body does.
- bien — well, which you have had since the beginning.

Sounds you'll need

- *son-RI-sa*, stress on the *ri*. The *s* is clear and never buzzes into a *z* sound the way an English *s* between vowels does. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sonrisa — "a smile."
From **sonreír**, and that is Latin **subridere**: *sub-*, under or slightly, plus **ridere**, to laugh. A smile is a laugh with the volume turned down. The *sub-* wore to *son-* on the way in.
English keeps *ridere* only at the loud end, and only in loans: to **deride** is to laugh at, **ridicule** is the laughing itself, and something **risible** is worth a laugh.
So Spanish built its quiet word out of the noisy one by putting *sub-* in front. English never built it at all — *smile* is Germanic and has no Latin in it.

What you've built

Sub- is a dial, not a word.
Under, slightly, a little less than the whole thing. Once you can hear it, a long Latin word stops being one item to memorise and becomes two smaller ones you can already handle.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sonrisa*
- *una sonrisa*, then *la sonrisa*
- *el abrazo* and *la sonrisa*, one after the other

Before you move on

What does *sub-* do to *ridere*? (Turns the laugh down to a smile.)
Which English words kept the laughing? (*Deride*, *ridicule*, *risible*.)

282.5 el invitado — named by what was done to him

Before the last of the five: what does *sub-* do to *ridere*? (Turns the laugh down to a smile.) And what is inside *abrazo*? (The arm.)

What to know first

- el abrazo — what you might give this person.
- la sonrisa — and what you would give with it.

Sounds you'll need

- *in-vi-TA-do*, stress on the *ta*. Four syllables, all of them short and even; Spanish does not swallow the unstressed ones the way English does. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el invitado — "a guest."
From **invitar**, Latin **invitare**, to invite. *Invitado* is its participle, "invited" — so Spanish names the guest by what was done to him, exactly as *bienvenido* names a welcome by what is wished.
Put the two side by side. **venido** in the first of these five and **invitado** in the last are the same piece of grammar doing the same job: an action turned into a description of a person.
English **guest** is a different word altogether, Germanic *gastiz* — which is also the source of Latin *hostis*, a stranger and then an enemy. Two peoples had one word for the man at the door and could not agree whether he was a visitor or a threat.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: *bienvenido*, *el saludo*, *el abrazo*, *la sonrisa*, *el invitado*.
Two of the five are participles, and that is the pattern worth carrying forward. Spanish is unusually willing to name a person or a thing by an action already finished — the one invited, the one welcomed — and once you notice it you will find it everywhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el invitado*, then *la invitada*
- all five in order — *bienvenido*, *el saludo*, *el abrazo*, *la sonrisa*, *el invitado*
- the two participles on their own — *bienvenido*, *invitado*

Before you move on

What is an *invitado*, literally? (One who has been invited.) Which other word in this run is a participle? (*Bienvenido* — well come.) And what did *saludo* wish you? (Your health.)

Chapter 283

Courtesy Past Thank You — Excuse Me, With Permission, Kind, A Thousand Thanks

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise, ask to pass, call someone kind and thank them at more than one weight in Spanish.

Complete ES-C283-no-hay-de-que: say all five, and take the last one apart into the words you already had.

283.1 disculpe — take the fault off me

Before a new run: what is an *invitado*? (One who has been invited.) And what was *la sonrisa* built from? (*Ridere*, to laugh, turned down by *sub-*.)

What to know first

- perdón — the apology you already have.
- por favor — the politeness you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *dis-CUL-pe*, stress in the middle. The *c* before *u* is a hard *k*, as in *casa*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

disculpe — "excuse me."
From **disculpar**: *dis-*, which undoes, plus **culpa**, fault. To *disculpar* is to take the fault off someone. Said to a person — *disculpe* — it asks them to un-fault you.
Latin *culpa* stands intact in English **culpable** and in **mea culpa**, my fault, and worn down in **culprit**. The *dis-* is the reversing prefix of *disappear* and *disarm*: it does not merely deny a thing, it undoes it. *Disculpe* is the *usted* form, so it is the one for a stranger. To a friend you would say *disculpa* — the same choice you have been making since you met *tú* and *usted*.

What you've built

You now have two apologies, and they are not the same size.
Perdón asks for pardon, which is a thing granted. *Disculpe* asks for the fault to be lifted, which is a thing undone. Spanish gives you both, and a language with two words for one moment is telling you the moment has two parts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *disculpe*
- *disculpe*, then *disculpa*, and hear which is the stranger's
- *perdón*, then *disculpe*

Before you move on

What is inside *disculpe*? (*Culpa*, fault.) What does the *dis-* do? (Undoes it.) Which form would you use with a stranger? (*Disculpe.*)

283.2 con permiso — the one you say before, not after

Before the new one: what does the *dis-* do to *culpa*? (Undoes it.)

What to know first

- disculpe — the other “excuse me”, for something done.
- por favor — the politeness you attach to a request.

Sounds you’ll need

- *con per-MI-so*, stress on the *mi*. The *r* is one tap of the tongue, not the long English glide. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

con permiso — “excuse me,” said as you pass in front of someone. **Permiso** is Latin **permissum**, from *permittere*: *per-*, through, plus **mittere**, to send. To permit is to let a thing through.
Mittere was one of the most productive words Latin had, and English is full of it. A **mission** is a sending. A **missile** is a thing sent. To **dismiss** is to send away, and to **permit** is this very word, borrowed unchanged.
The two courtesies are not interchangeable, and the difference is time. *Disculpe* is for something you have done. *Con permiso* is for something you are about to do.

What you’ve built

Politeness in Spanish is often a matter of tense rather than of warmth. One formula looks backwards at a fault, the other forwards at an intrusion. Get the direction right and you will sound careful even when your grammar is not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *con permiso*
- *disculpe*, then *con permiso*, and place each one in time
- *con permiso, por favor*

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *permiso*? (*Per*, through, and *mittere*, to send.) Which courtesy comes before the act? (*Con permiso.*)

283.3 amable — loveable, before it meant kind

Before the new one: which courtesy comes before the act? (*Con permiso.*)

What to know first

- gracias — what you say to someone who is this.
- disculpe — and what you say when you are not.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-MA-ble*, stress in the middle. The *b* between vowels is soft — the lips barely close. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

amable — "kind."
Latin **amabilis**, from **amare**, to love: loveable, a person it is easy to be fond of. Spanish moved the word from what you feel about the person to what the person does.
English has it twice over. **Amiable** came through French and kept the sense. **Amorous** kept the love, and an **amateur** is one who does a thing for love rather than for money — which is praise in the original and faint praise now.
The **-able** on the end is the same ending English writes on its own words. It arrived from the same Latin *-abilis*, and it means then what it means now: able to have this done to it.

What you've built

Muy amable is the reply you have been missing.
You could thank someone; you could not say anything about them. One adjective closes that gap, and it costs you nothing new — *muy* has been yours for a long while.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *amable*, then *muy amable*
- *gracias, muy amable*
- *amable* and *amiable*, and hear the same word twice

Before you move on

What did *amabilis* mean in Latin? (Loveable.) Which Latin root is under it? (*Amare*, to love.)

283.4 mil gracias — a number that stopped counting

Before the new one: what did *amabilis* mean? (Loveable.)

What to know first

- gracias — the half of this you already have.
- amable — what you say about the person you are thanking.

Sounds you'll need

- *mil GRA-cias.* The *l* stays clear and forward, never darkening the way an English *l* does at the end of a word. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mil gracias — "a thousand thanks."
Gracias has been yours since near the beginning. **Mil** is Latin **mille**, a thousand, and it is the same *mille* buried in English **mile**: the Roman **mille passuum**, a thousand paces, which is why a mile is the awkward length it is and not a round number of anything.
Notice what the phrase is doing. Spanish is not measuring gratitude here; it is reaching for a large number and stopping. Every language keeps a few numbers that have given up counting — English says thanks a million and means the same nothing-in-particular.

Millimetre, **million** and **millennium** are the honest arithmetic uses of *mille*, and they arrived from the book rather than from the mouth.

What you've built

Four courtesies, and not one of them is a new idea.
Each is a word you had, or a number you had, put to a use you did not know about. Vocabulary grows fastest at the joins.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mil gracias*
- *gracias*, then *mil gracias*, and hear the weight change
- *mil gracias, muy amable*

Before you move on

What is *mil* in Latin? (*Mille*, a thousand.) What has a mile got to do with it? (It was a thousand paces.)

283.5 no hay de qué — four words you already own

Before the last of the five: what is *mil* in Latin? (*Mille*, a thousand.) And what did *amabilis* mean? (Loveable.)

What to know first

- de nada — the other reply to thanks, and the same idea.
- mil gracias — what this answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *no ay de KE*, four quick syllables run together. The written accent on *qué* marks the question word, not a change of stress. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

no hay de qué — "not at all," the reply when someone thanks you. Every piece is already yours. **No**, **hay**, **de**, **qué** — nothing new in the list. What is new is the assembly: literally "there is nothing of which," with the thing not worth mentioning left out of the sentence entirely. Spanish already gave you **de nada**, "of nothing," for the same moment. The two are one idea built twice: whatever you are thanking me for, there was nothing in it.

That is worth more than a fifth word. A courtesy formula is rarely new vocabulary. It is old vocabulary frozen in an order nobody parses any more — and once you have taken one apart, the rest stop being phrases to memorise.

What you've built

Five ways to be polite: *disculpe*, *con permiso*, *amable*, *mil gracias*, *no hay de qué*.

Two of them look backwards and two look forwards; the fifth is made of scraps. And the fifth is the one that shows you what the others are — sentences that stopped being sentences.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *no hay de qué*
- its four pieces slowly — *no*, *hay*, *de*, *qué*
- all five in order — *disculpe*, *con permiso*, *amable*, *mil gracias*, *no hay de qué*

Before you move on

How many new words are in *no hay de qué*? (None — only the assembly is new.) Which reply to thanks did you already have? (*De nada.*) And what is inside *disculpe*? (*Culpa*, fault.)

Chapter 284

Five Short Answers — Agreed, Sure, True, Exactly, Of Course

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can answer someone in Spanish with a single short phrase, and say what is inside each one.
>
> *Complete ES-C284-por-supuesto: give all five answers in order, and name the Latin verb inside each.*

284.1 de acuerdo — hearts brought together

Before a new run: how many new words were in *no hay de qué*? (None.) And what does *mil* mean? (A thousand.)

What to know first

- sí — the shortest answer of all, which you have.
- no hay de qué — another formula assembled from small pieces.

Sounds you'll need

- *de a-CUER-do*, stress on the *cuer*. The *ue* is one glide, not two vowels taken in turn. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de acuerdo — "agreed."
From **acordar**, and inside it Latin **cor**, **cordis**, the heart. To *acordar* is to bring hearts together.
English has the whole family and rarely notices the organ in it. An **accord** is this word. **Concord** is hearts together and **discord** hearts apart. To **record** is to bring back to the heart — because the Romans located memory there, so recording was memorising long before it was writing anything down. Even **courage** is *cor* with a French ending on it.
The stressed *o* of *cordis* opens into *ue*, the change you have watched happen again and again: *cor* to *cuerdo*, as *portam* went to *puerta*.

What you've built

You can now agree without saying *sí*.
That matters more than it sounds. *Sí* answers a question; *de acuerdo* accepts a proposal. Conversations run on the second one far more than on the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *de acuerdo*
- *sí*, then *de acuerdo*, and hear the difference in what each answers
- *de acuerdo, gracias*

Before you move on

What is inside *acuerdo*? (*Cor*, the heart.) Why does *record* belong to it? (To bring back to the heart — where memory was thought to sit.)

284.2 seguro — without a care, which came to mean reliable

Before the new one: what is inside *acuerdo*? (*Cor*, the heart.)

What to know first

- de acuerdo — the answer before this one.
- bien — another one-word answer you already give.

Sounds you'll need

- *se-GU-ro*, stress in the middle. The *gu* before *r* is a hard *g*; the *u* here is fully pronounced. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

seguro — "sure," and also "safe."
Latin **securus**: *se-*, without, plus **cura**, care. Free of care. The Romans meant untroubled; Spanish and English both dragged it towards reliable, which is a different thing.
English took it twice, and the two arrivals do not look alike. **Secure** came late and whole, out of a book. **Sure** came early through French, worn down to one syllable, having lost the *c* on the road. The same Latin word walked in through two doors.
Cura itself is in English **cure**, **curator** and **curious** — all of them about taking care of something, or taking rather too much.

What you've built

Se- is another dial worth keeping.
It means without or apart, and it is doing the same job in *seguro* that *sub-* did in *sonrisa*: a small piece in front changing the whole. You are collecting prefixes now, not only words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *seguro*
- *seguro* and *secure*, and hear one word twice
- *de acuerdo*, then *seguro*

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *securus*? (*Se-*, without, and *cura*, care.) Which English word is the worn-down one? (*Sure.*)

284.3 cierto — what has been sifted out

Before the new one: what are the two pieces of *securus*? (*Se-*, without, and *cura*, care.)

What to know first

- seguro — the answer before this one, and a near neighbour in meaning.
- la puerta — where you first watched a stressed *o* open into *ue*.

Sounds you'll need

- *CIER-to*, stress on the first syllable. The *c* before *i* is the *th* of *think* in much of Spain and an *s* elsewhere. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cierto — "true," "certain."
Latin **certus**, and it is a participle: from **cernere**, to sift, to separate, to decide. What is *certus* is what has been sifted out from everything it was mixed up with.
The English family is large and the sieve is invisible in all of it. **Certain** is this word. To **discern** is to sift apart. To be **concerned** is to be sifted together with something. And a **secret** is *se-cernere*, a thing sifted aside — the same *se-* you met in *seguro*, one word ago.
The stressed *e* opens into *ie* here, as it did in *puerta* with an *o*: *certus* to *cierto*. Two vowels, one habit.

What you've built

Certainty is a metaphor, and a physical one.
Sifting, separating, deciding: the Romans had one word for all three, and every English word about being sure still has grain and a sieve at the bottom of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cierto*
- *es cierto*
- *seguro*, then *cierto*, and hear which agrees with a person and which with a fact

Before you move on

What did *cernere* mean? (To sift.) What is a *secret*, taken apart? (Something sifted aside.)

284.4 exacto — driven out, then weighed out

Before the new one: what did *cernere* mean? (To sift.)

What to know first

- cierto — the answer before this one.
- sí — the plain agreement these are all sharpening.

Sounds you'll need

- *e-XAC-to*, stress in the middle. The *x* here is *ks*, said fully: *ek-SAK-to*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

exacto — "exactly," used on its own as an answer.
Latin **exactus**, the participle of **exigere**: *ex-*, out, plus **agere**, to drive. To drive out; then to demand; then to weigh out precisely, because a Roman checking a coin was driving the true amount out of the metal.
Agere is everywhere in English: an **act**, an **agent**, an **agenda** — things to be driven along. **Exigent** kept the demanding sense unchanged.
As an answer, *exacto* is the one that agrees with a detail rather than with a person. Somebody has got a number or a name right, and you

are confirming the number, not backing the speaker.

What you've built

Four answers, and each agrees with something different. *De acuerdo* accepts a plan, *seguro* backs a person, *cierto* confirms a fact, *exacto* confirms a detail. English leans on one word for all four and lets the tone carry it; Spanish would rather you chose.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *exacto*
- *cierto*, then *exacto*
- the four in order — *de acuerdo*, *seguro*, *cierto*, *exacto*

Before you move on

What are the pieces of *exigere*? (*Ex-*, out, and *agere*, to drive.) What does *exacto* agree with? (A detail, not a person.)

284.5 por supuesto — it was under the conversation already

Before the last of the five: what does *exacto* agree with? (A detail.) And what did *cernere* mean? (To sift.)

What to know first

- exacto — the answer before this one.
- la sonrisa — where you first met *sub-* doing its work.

Sounds you'll need

- *por su-PUES-to*, stress on the *pues*. Another *ue* glide, and the *s* stays clear throughout. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

por supuesto — "of course."
Supuesto is the participle of **suponer**, Latin **supponere**: *sub-*, under, plus **ponere**, to place. Something *supuesto* has been placed underneath — assumed, taken as given, sitting under the conversation without ever being said out loud.
English **suppose**, **supposition** and **presuppose** are that same placing. And English's own "of course" is doing something similar with a different picture: the thing runs along the expected course, so nobody had to steer it.
There is *sub-* again, and you met it turning a laugh into a smile. Prefixes are worth more than words. One of them unlocks dozens.

What you've built

Five answers: *de acuerdo*, *seguro*, *cierto*, *exacto*, *por supuesto*.
Three of the five are participles — *acuerdo* aside, they name a state something has been put into. Spanish keeps reaching for the finished action when it wants a short answer, and now you have five examples instead of one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *por supuesto*
- *sub-* and *supuesto*, and hear the prefix
- all five in order — *de acuerdo*, *seguro*, *cierto*, *exacto*, *por supuesto*

Before you move on

What are the pieces of *supponere*? (*Sub-*, under, and *ponere*, to place.) Where did you meet *sub-* before? (Inside *sonrisa*, turning a laugh down.) And what is inside *acuerdo*? (*Cor*, the heart.)

Chapter 285

Who Someone Is — Neighbour, Friend, Teacher, Nurse, Cook

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say who someone is in Spanish — the neighbour, a friend, the teacher, the nurse, the cook.
>
> *Complete ES-C285-cocinero: name all five people, and say what each name is really describing.*

285.1 el vecino — the man from your own street

> Before a new run: what does *por supuesto* say has happened to the thing? (It was placed underneath — assumed.) And what is inside *acuerdo*? (The heart.)

What to know first

- la casa — the house this person lives near.
- hola — what you say to him over the fence.

Sounds you'll need

- *ve-CI-no*, stress in the middle. The *c* before *i* is the *th* of *think* in much of Spain and an *s* elsewhere. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el vecino — "the neighbour."
Latin **vicinus**, from **vicus**: a village, a row of houses, a block of a town. A *vicinus* is a person off your own street, and the word names the street rather than the person.
English has the abstract end of it. **Vicinity** is nearness — the quality of sharing a *vicus*. And *vicus* itself was borrowed into Old English early as *wic*, a settlement, which is the *-wich* still sitting on the end of Norwich and Ipswich.
English **neighbour** describes the same man quite differently: *neah*, near, plus *gebur*, a dweller. A near-dweller. Two languages, one person, and two pictures — a street against a distance.

What you've built

Every name for a person is a description that stopped being one. Hold on to that for the next four. None of them will name the human being directly; each names a place, a feeling, a comparison or an act, and lets the ending turn it into somebody.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el vecino*, then *la vecina*
- *mi vecino*
- *el vecino* and *la casa*, and hear the street inside the first

Before you move on

What is a *vicus*? (A village or a row of houses.) What does English *neighbour* describe instead? (A near-dweller — distance, not a street.)

285.2 la amiga — the same root as amable, a short way back

Before the new one: what does *vecino* actually name? (The street, not the man.)

What to know first

- amable — the same Latin root, met a short while ago.
- el vecino — the person before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *la a-MI-ga*, stress on the *mi*. The two *a* sounds at the join run together in ordinary speech. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la amiga — "a friend," of a woman.
Latin **amica**, and underneath it is **amare**, to love — the very *amare* that gave you *amable* not long ago. Latin made the kind person and the friend out of one root, and Spanish inherited both without noticing the family resemblance.
English **amicable** is *amicabilis*, friend-like, and an **amicus curiae** in a courtroom is a friend of the court. But English **friend** is Germanic, from a word for loving that has otherwise disappeared — so both languages built the friend out of a love word, and then lost the source in one case and kept it in the other.
Note the article: *la amiga*, and not the *el* that *agua* takes. That swap needs the stress on the first *a*, and here it falls on the *i*.

What you've built

A root you have already spent is cheaper than a new one.
Amable and *amiga* cost you one Latin root between them. When two words share a root, learning the second is mostly remembering the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la amiga*, then *el amigo*
- *amable* and *amiga*, and hear *amare* in both
- *mi amiga*

Before you move on

Which root is under *amiga*? (*Amare*, to love.) Which other word of yours is built on it? (*Amable*.)

285.3 el maestro — the one who is more

Before the new one: which root is under *amiga*? (*Amare*, to love.)

What to know first

- el estudiante — the person this one stands in front of.
- la amiga — the person before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *ma-ES-tro*, stress on the *es*. The *a* and the *e* stay separate — three syllables, not two. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el maestro — "the teacher."
Latin **magister**, built on **magis**, more. Beside it Latin kept **minister**, built on **minus**, less. The two were made as a matched pair: the one who is more and the one who is less, a master and a servant.
Both reached English and drifted so far apart that the pairing is invisible. On one side a **master**, a **mister** (the same word worn down), a **magistrate** and a **magnate**. On the other a **minister** and to **administer** — which is to serve towards something.
Spanish kept *maestro* for the schoolteacher and has *profesor* as well, which you already have. The two are not rivals: one teaches children and the other teaches a subject.

What you've built

A comparison can harden into a job.
Magis and *minus* are not people; they are more and less. Latin turned both into titles, and two thousand years later one of them signs your school report and the other runs a government.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el maestro*, then *la maestra*
- *maestro* and *master*, and hear the *magis* in both
- *el maestro* and *el estudiante* together

Before you move on

What is *magis*? (More.) What was *minister* built on? (*Minus*, less.)

285.4 la enfermera — named after the patient

Before the new one: what is *magis*? (More.)

What to know first

- el maestro — the person before this one.
- la cabeza — a body word, useful when you say what is wrong.

Sounds you'll need

- *en-fer-ME-ra*, stress on the *me*. Both *r* sounds are single taps, neither rolled. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la enfermera — "the nurse."
From **enfermo**, ill, and that is Latin **infirmus**: *in-*, not, plus **firmus**, firm. The ill person is the one who is no longer steady on his feet. And the nurse is named after the patient rather than after the work.
English kept *infirmus* twice over — **infirm** for the person, an **infirmary** for the room they are put in. **Firm** itself is the same *firmus*, and to **confirm** is to make a thing firm along with somebody else.
English **nurse** went the other way entirely. It is *nutrire*, to feed: the wet-nurse came first and the hospital a long time afterwards. One language named the helper after the illness, the other after the milk.

What you've built

Four people, and four different things being described.
A street, a word for loving, a comparison, and a condition. Not one of the four names a human being outright — and that is the ordinary state of affairs in every language, once you start pulling the words open.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la enfermera*, then *el enfermero*
- *enfermo* and *enfermera*, and hear the patient inside the nurse
- *la enfermera* and *el maestro*

Before you move on

What are the pieces of *infirmus*? (*In-*, not, and *firmus*, firm.) Who is the nurse named after? (The patient.)

285.5 el cocinero — the root that got everywhere

Before the last of the five: who is the nurse named after? (The patient.) And what is *magis*? (More.)

What to know first

- la comida — what this person makes.
- la enfermera — the person before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *co-ci-NE-ro*, stress on the *ne*. The first *c* is a hard *k* and the second, before *i*, is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cocinero — "the cook."
From **la cocina**, the kitchen — Latin **coquina** — and under that **coquere**, to cook.
This root travelled further than any other in the run. English **kitchen** is *coquina*, borrowed into Germanic early and worn right down. A **biscuit** is *bis-coctus*, twice-cooked. To **concoct** is to cook things together. And a **precocious** child is *prae-coquus*, cooked early — a word used first of fruit that ripened before its season, and moved onto children only much later.
So the same Latin root gave English a room, a snack, a metaphor for scheming and a word for a clever eight-year-old, and gave Spanish the person who does the cooking.

What you've built

Five people: *el vecino*, *la amiga*, *el maestro*, *la enfermera*, *el cocinero*. Set the five descriptions side by side. *Vecino* is a place. *Amiga* is a feeling. *Maestro* is a comparison. *Enfermera* is a condition. *Cocinero* is an action. Five ways of pointing at a person without ever saying what a person is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cocinero*, then *la cocinera*
- *la cocina* and *el cocinero*, the room and the person
- all five in order — *el vecino*, *la amiga*, *el maestro*, *la enfermera*, *el cocinero*

Before you move on

What is a *biscuit*, taken apart? (Twice-cooked.) What does *precocious* literally mean? (Cooked early.) And who is the *enfermera* named after? (The patient.)

Chapter 286

Where It Hurts — Eye, Mouth, Throat, Pain, Fever

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the eye, the mouth and the throat in Spanish, and say that there is a pain or a fever.
>
> *Complete ES-C286-fiebre: name all five, and separate the three places from the two things that are wrong.*

286.1 el ojo — the same eye as English, from far enough back

Before a new run: what does *precocious* literally mean? (Cooked early.) And who is the *enfermera* named after? (The patient.)

What to know first

- la cabeza — where this one is.
- la mano — the other body word you have.

Sounds you'll need

- *O-jo*, stress on the first syllable. The *j* is a hard rasp at the back of the mouth, the *jota*, with no English equivalent. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el ojo — "the eye."
Latin **oculus**, and the road from *oculus* to *ojo* runs through a change Spanish made and its neighbours made differently: the *cl* left in *oc'lu*, once the unstressed vowel dropped, hardened into the *jota* you are now saying — a sound Latin never had at all.
English has the loans, and they are unmistakable: **ocular**, **binocular**, a **monocle**, and to **inoculate**, which was a gardener's word first, for setting an eye — a bud — into another plant.
And English **eye** is the cousin, not a borrowing. *Oculus* and *eye* come down from one ancient root by two different roads, one through Latin and one through Germanic, which is why they share almost no letters and mean precisely the same thing.

What you've built

The *jota* is a Spanish invention.
It is not in Latin, and it is not in Italian or French, which had the same material to work with. When a word has one, you are hearing something that happened in Spain and nowhere else.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el ojo*, then *los ojos*
- *oculus* and *ojo*, slowly, and hear the *cl* harden
- *la cabeza* and *el ojo*

Before you move on

What is the Latin behind *ojo*? (*Oculus.*) Is English *eye* borrowed from it? (No — it is the cousin, down the Germanic road.)

286.2 la boca — the cheek that took the mouth's job

Before the new one: is English *eye* borrowed from *oculus*? (No — it is the cousin.)

What to know first

- el ojo — the last one, and its neighbour on the face.
- la cabeza — which Spanish did not replace, unlike this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *BO-ca*, stress on the first syllable. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la boca — "the mouth."
Latin had **os**, **oris** for the mouth, and that is the word English borrowed for **oral** and **orifice**. Spanish does not use it. Spanish uses **bucca**, which in Latin meant the cheek — specifically a cheek puffed out, the one a trumpeter uses.
So the lively word from the street pushed the official one out of the job. That is a swap Spanish declined to make for the head, where *cabeza* is still *caput* plain and simple, and made without hesitation for the mouth. Which words get replaced is not predictable; it only ever looks obvious afterwards.
English kept both ends of the Latin. **Buccal** is the medical adjective for the cheek. To **debouch** is to come out of a mouth — said of rivers, and of armies leaving a narrow pass.

What you've built

Two body words, and two completely different histories.
Ojo is the inherited word doing the job it always did. *Boca* is an upstart that took the job from another word. Both are ordinary, and only one of them is quiet about where it came from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la boca*
- *el ojo* and *la boca*
- *oris* and *bucca*, the word that lost and the word that won

Before you move on

What did *bucca* mean in Latin? (The cheek.) Which Latin word did it push out? (*Os*, *oris* — which English kept in *oral*.)

286.3 la garganta — a word made out of a noise

Before the new one: what did *bucca* mean in Latin? (The cheek.)

What to know first

- la boca — the opening this one sits behind.
- el agua — what goes down it.

Sounds you'll need

- *gar-GAN-ta*, stress in the middle. Both *g* sounds are hard, and both *r* sounds are single taps. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la garganta — "the throat."
This one is not inherited from a tidy Latin word so much as assembled out of a noise. Latin had **gurgulio** for the windpipe and **gargarizare** for gargling, and both are the sound itself, said twice: *gar-gar*.
English does the same imitation over and over. To **gargle**. To **gurgle**. To **regurgitate**. A **gorge**, which is a throat first and a narrow valley second, because a valley of that shape looks like one.
Words like this are worth noticing because they escape the usual account. Almost all of your vocabulary is either inherited or borrowed. A few words are simply what the thing sounds like — and those can turn up in unrelated languages with no contact between them whatsoever.

What you've built

Three places on the body, and now you can say where.
El ojo, *la boca*, *la garganta*. What is still missing is the other half of the sentence: what is actually wrong. That is the next two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la garganta*
- *gar-gar*, then *garganta*, and hear where the word came from
- *el ojo*, *la boca*, *la garganta*

Before you move on

Where does *garganta* come from? (The noise of gargling.) Which English words are the same imitation? (*Gargle*, *gurgle*, *gorge*.)

286.4 el dolor — and the word that stopped hurting

Before the new one: where does *garganta* come from? (The noise of gargling.)

What to know first

- la garganta — one of the places this can be.
- ¿cómo está usted? — the question this answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *do-LOR*, stress on the second syllable, as the lack of a written accent tells you for a word ending in *r*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el dolor — "the pain."
Latin **dolor**, arriving with almost nothing worn off it, from **dolere**, to hurt. This is the word that turns a body part into a complaint: a pain of the head, a pain of the throat.
English has it in the mournful register only: **doleful**, **dolorous**, and **condolence** — to hurt together with somebody.
And **indolent**, which is the surprise of the family. *In-dolens* is feeling no pain, and it began as a medical word: an indolent sore is one that

does not hurt. From there it slid to feeling no effort, and finally to lazy. The pain fell out of the word altogether.

What you've built

You can now answer with more than *bien* or *regular*.
A place and a trouble is a whole sentence in any language. You have three places and, from here, two troubles.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el dolor*
- *dolor de cabeza*
- *dolor de garganta*

Before you move on

What does *dolere* mean? (To hurt.) What did *indolent* mean first? (Feeling no pain.)

286.5 la fiebre — one Latin word, borrowed twice, centuries apart

Before the last of the five: what does *dolere* mean? (To hurt.) And where does *garganta* come from? (The noise of gargling.)

What to know first

- el dolor — the other thing that can be wrong.
- cierto — where you last watched a stressed *e* open into *ie*.

Sounds you'll need

- *FIE-bre*, stress on the first syllable. The *ie* is one glide, and the *b* between vowels is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la fiebre — "the fever."
Latin **febris**, with the stressed *e* opening into *ie* once again — *febris* to *fiebre*, the change you have now watched in *cierto* and in *puerta*, and can predict without being told.
English **fever** is that same *febris*, borrowed into Old English long before the Normans arrived, at a time when a Latin medical word was worth having and an English one did not exist. Then the doctors borrowed it a second time, unworn, as **febrile**.
Two borrowings of one word, a thousand years apart: the early one goes to the sickroom and the late one to the textbook. That split is so regular in English that you can often date a word by how ordinary it sounds.

What you've built

Five: *el ojo*, *la boca*, *la garganta*, *el dolor*, *la fiebre*.
Three of them are places and two are troubles, and the two halves fit together. *Dolor de garganta*, *dolor de cabeza* — a place and a trouble joined by a word you have had since the beginning. That is a real sentence, built entirely out of five new words and one small old one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la fiebre*
- *tengo fiebre*
- all five in order — *el ojo*, *la boca*, *la garganta*, *el dolor*, *la fiebre*

Before you move on

Which vowel change turned *febris* into *fiebre*? (Stressed *e* into *ie*.) How many times did English borrow this word? (Twice — *fever*, then *febrile*.) And what did *indolent* mean first? (Feeling no pain.)

Chapter 287

Five Things You Ask For — Soap, Towel, Glass, Spoon, Plate

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask for soap, a towel, a glass, a spoon and a plate in Spanish, politely.
>
> *Complete ES-C287-plato: ask for all five in turn, with por favor on the end of each.*

287.1 el jabón — a word that went abroad and came home

Before a new run: how many times did English borrow *febris*? (Twice.) And what does *dolere* mean? (To hurt.)

What to know first

- el agua — what you use this with.
- por favor — what you put on the end when you ask.

Sounds you'll need

- *ja-BON*, stress on the second syllable, which the written accent marks. The *j* is the *jota* again, the rasp at the back. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el jabón — "soap."
Latin **sapo**, **saponem** — and Latin did not make this word. It borrowed it from the Germanic peoples on its northern frontier, who used the stuff on their hair before anybody in Rome used it for washing.
So English **soap** and *jabón* are one word, and the English one is the one that stayed at home. Spanish has it back after a long detour: Germanic into Latin, Latin into Spanish. **Saponify** and **saponification** are the late loans, taken straight from the Latin form. Words move with things. Rome had better roads and better law; the north had better soap. Trade decides vocabulary far more often than conquest does.

What you've built

Not every Latin word is Roman.
Latin was borrowing from its neighbours the whole time, and a word can be perfectly good Latin and still be an import. *Jabón* has been abroad and come back, and nothing in the sound of it says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el jabón*
- *el jabón, por favor*
- *jabón* and *soap*, and hear one word twice

Before you move on

Where did Latin get *sapo*? (From its Germanic neighbours.) Is English *soap* borrowed from Spanish? (No — it never left; it is the same word at home.)

287.2 la toalla — the Germanic layer, still in the bathroom

Before the new one: where did Latin get *sapo*? (From its Germanic neighbours.)

What to know first

- el jabón — what you use before you need this.
- el agua — and what you are drying off.

Sounds you'll need

- *to-A-lla*, stress on the *a*. The *ll* is a *y* sound for most speakers, and something closer to a *j* in the River Plate. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la toalla — "a towel."
Another Germanic word, and this time both languages took it. Frankish **thwahlja**, a cloth for washing, became Old French *toaille*, and out of that Spanish has *toalla* and English has **towel**.
Two words in a row now that are not Latin at the bottom. Spanish is a Latin language with a Germanic layer laid over the top, and that layer sits mostly in the house and the wardrobe — the words the settlers brought along with the things themselves.
The *-alla* ending is the giveaway. A Latin word would not have arrived in that shape; a French one would. Spanish borrowed this from its neighbour, not from its parent.

What you've built

Two Germanic words, side by side, in the plainest room of the house. That is not an accident. The most domestic vocabulary in a Romance language is often the least Roman, because that is where the incomers actually lived.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la toalla*
- *la toalla, por favor*
- *el jabón y la toalla*

Before you move on

Is *toalla* a Latin word? (No — Frankish, through French.) Which English word is the same one? (*Towel.*)

287.3 el vaso — named for the job, not the material

Before the new one: is *toalla* a Latin word? (No — Frankish, through French.)

What to know first

- el agua — what goes in it.
- la toalla — the thing before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *VA-so*, stress on the first syllable. The *v* is the same soft sound as *b* — the letters differ and the sound does not. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el vaso — "a glass," the thing you drink out of.
Latin **vas**, **vasis**: a vessel, a container of any sort. Spanish names the object by what it does rather than by what it is made of, which is why a plastic one is still a *vaso* and an English glass made of plastic is a small embarrassment.
English has three of them at three different weights. A **vase** holds flowers. A **vessel** holds wine, or cargo, or blood. The **vascular** system is the body's plumbing, named by anatomists reaching for the same Latin.
And notice the letter. *Vaso* begins with the sound you have been giving to *b*. Spanish writes *v* and says something very close to *b*, and

that was true long before the spelling settled down.

What you've built

Three things you can ask for, and three different sources. Germanic, Frankish, Latin. A tray of ordinary objects in a Spanish kitchen is a small map of who passed through.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el vaso*
- *un vaso de agua, por favor*
- *vaso* and *vase*, and hear the container in both

Before you move on

What did *vas* mean in Latin? (A vessel or container.) Why is a plastic one still a *vaso*? (Because the word names the job, not the material.)

287.4 la cuchara — a snail shell with a handle

Before the new one: what did *vas* mean in Latin? (A vessel.)

What to know first

- el vaso — the thing before this one.
- la comida — what you need this for.

Sounds you'll need

- *cu-CHA-ra*, stress in the middle. The *ch* is one sound, as in English *church*, and never a *k*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cuchara — "a spoon."
Latin **cochlear**, a spoon, from **cochlea**, a snail shell. The Romans ate snails and used the shell to get them out, and the tool kept the name of the shell long after it had stopped being one.
Cochlea is still in English, unchanged, for the spiral inside your ear — named by an anatomist who thought it looked like the shell. So the spoon and the inner ear are the same Latin snail, arriving a thousand years apart by two completely different routes.
A tool named after the thing it replaced is one of the commonest patterns in any vocabulary. The name outlives the object, and nobody notices until somebody pulls the word open.

What you've built

Four things, and each one is a small piece of history you can hold. Soap from the north, a towel from the Franks, a vessel from Rome, and a snail shell with a handle on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cuchara*
- *la cuchara, por favor*
- *cochlea* and *cuchara*, the shell and the spoon

Before you move on

What is a *cochlea*? (A snail shell.) What else in English carries the name? (The spiral of the inner ear.)

287.5 el plato — flat, in Greek, before anything else

Before the last of the five: what is a *cochlea*? (A snail shell.) And what did *vas* mean? (A vessel.)

What to know first

- la cuchara — what you put beside it.
- por favor — what closes every one of these requests.

Sounds you'll need

- *PLA-to*, stress on the first syllable. The *l* stays clear and forward, and the *pl* is said cleanly with no vowel slipped in. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el plato — "a plate."
Not Latin at the bottom: Greek **platys**, flat or broad. Latin took it in as *plattus*, and out of that Spanish has *plato* and English has **plate**. The same Greek flatness turns up all over. A **plaza** is a flat open space — Latin *platea*, a broad street. A **plateau** is a flat high place. A **platypus** is a flat-foot. And English **flat** itself is the Germanic cousin of *platys*, from the same ancient root by the other road.
Five things you can now ask for. The asking itself you have had for a long while: *por favor* on the end of any of them, and the sentence is finished.

What you've built

Five: *el jabón*, *la toalla*, *el vaso*, *la cuchara*, *el plato*.
Germanic, Frankish, Latin, Latin, Greek. Five ordinary objects and five different origins — which is the honest answer to the question of where Spanish words come from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el plato*
- *el plato, por favor*
- all five in order — *el jabón*, *la toalla*, *el vaso*, *la cuchara*, *el plato*

Before you move on

What does *platys* mean? (Flat.) What is a *platypus*, taken apart? (A flat-foot.) And where did Latin get *sapo*? (From its Germanic neighbours.)

Chapter 288

Setting Off — The Way Out, the Journey, the Return, the Arrival, the Farewell

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the way out, the journey, the return, the arrival and the farewell in Spanish.
>
> *Complete ES-C288-despedida: name all five stages of a departure in order, from the way out to the goodbye.*

288.1 la salida — the Romans jumped out of rooms

Before a new run: what does *platys* mean? (Flat.) And what is a *cochlea*? (A snail shell.)

What to know first

- salir — the word this one is made from.
- la puerta — where the way out generally is.

Sounds you'll need

- *sa-LI-da*, stress on the *li*. The *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* of *this*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la salida — "the exit," "the way out."
From **salir**, which you have, and behind *salir* is Latin **salire**, to jump. A Roman did not leave a room; he jumped out of it. It calmed down on its way into Spanish and kept only the departing.
The jumping survives in the English loans. Something **salient** is jumping out at you. An **assault** is a jumping-at. A **somersault** is a jump over the top. And to **sally** out of a fort is the same word once more, arriving through French.
The ending is worth as much as the root. *-ida* on an action gives you the act or the result of it, and it is going to give you three of the next four words.

What you've built

You have had *salir* for a long time; now you have the name of what it does.
That is a cheap way to grow a vocabulary, and Spanish is unusually generous with it. A word you know plus an ending you know is a word you did not have to learn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la salida*
- *salir*, then *la salida*, and hear the first one inside the second
- *la puerta de salida*

Before you move on

What did *salire* mean? (To jump.) What does the *-ida* ending do? (Turns an action into the act or the result.)

288.2 el viaje — the packed lunch that became the journey

Before the new one: what did *salire* mean? (To jump.)

What to know first

- la salida — how this one begins.
- caminar — the walking you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *VIA-je*, stress on the first syllable. The *j* is the *jota*, and the *ia* is one glide. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el viaje — "the journey."
Latin **viaticum**, from **via**, a road: not the journey at all, but the money and food you packed for one. Spanish moved the word off the supplies and onto the trip.
English took the same *viaticum* through French and got **voyage**. It also has *via* on its own: a **viaduct** carries a road; something **trivial** is *tri-via*, the place where three roads meet, and what gets said at a crossroads is not important.
The shift is the interesting part. A word for the preparation became the word for the thing prepared for. That happens constantly, and it is why so many ordinary words look sideways at their own meaning.

What you've built

Two of the five, and both were something else first.
A jump became a way out; a packed bag became a journey. Neither word describes what it now names.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el viaje*
- *buen viaje*
- *la salida* and *el viaje*

Before you move on

What was a *viaticum*? (The provisions for a road.) Which English word is the same one? (*Voyage*.)

288.3 la vuelta — everything here is rolling

Before the new one: what was a *viaticum*? (The provisions for a road.)

What to know first

- el viaje — what this one ends.
- la puerta — where you first met the *o* opening into *ue*.

Sounds you'll need

- *VUEL-ta*, stress on the first syllable. The *ue* is one glide and the *l* stays clear. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la vuelta — "the return," and also a turn.
From **volver**, Latin **volvere**, to roll or turn. The stressed *o* opens into *ue* exactly as you now expect it to: *volta* to *vuelta*, as *portam* went to *puerta*.
Volvere rolled a long way into English. To **revolve** is to roll again. A **revolution** is one full turn — of a wheel first and of a state a great deal later. And a **volume** is a rolled-up scroll, which is why a book carries the same name as a quantity of space.
Vuelta is not only a return. It is a lap of a track, a turn of a key, and change handed back in a shop. All of them are the same rolling, and Spanish did not bother to invent separate words.

What you've built

You can now predict this vowel rather than memorise it.
Puerta, *cierto*, *fiebre*, *vuelta*: stressed *o* to *ue*, stressed *e* to *ie*. Given a Latin word you have never seen, you can guess the Spanish — and be right more often than not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la vuelta*
- *volver*, then *la vuelta*
- *la salida*, *el viaje*, *la vuelta*

Before you move on

What does *volvere* mean? (To roll or turn.) Why is a book a *volume*? (Because it was a rolled scroll.)

288.4 la llegada — the sails are folded, so you have arrived

Before the new one: what does *volvere* mean? (To roll or turn.)

What to know first

- la vuelta — the return this one completes.
- cl-, pl-, fl- → ll- — the change you are about to see happen.

Sounds you'll need

- *lle-GA-da*, stress on the *ga*. The *ll* is a *y* sound for most speakers, and the *g* before *a* is hard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la llegada — "the arrival."
From **llegar**, to arrive, and this is the best story of the five. Latin **plicare** means to fold. A ship coming in to shore folded its sails — *plicare vela* — and the phrase wore down until the folding meant the arriving and the sails were gone from the sentence entirely.
Now the beginning of the word. *Plicare* to *llegar*: the *pl-* has become *ll-*, which is the change you have already met by name and can now watch doing real work.
Ply, **apply**, **complicate**, and a **plait** are the English relatives, every

one of them still folding something. *Complicate* is to fold together, which is a fair description of what it does to a plan.

What you've built

A sound change you learned as a rule has just paid for itself. You did not have to be told that *llegar* comes from *plicare*; the *ll-* at the front told you it came from something with *pl-*. Rules about sound are worth more than lists of words, because they work on words you have never met.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la llegada*
- *plicare*, then *llegar*, and hear the *pl-* collapse
- *la salida* and *la llegada*, the two ends of a trip

Before you move on

What did *plicare* mean? (To fold.) What was being folded? (The sails of a ship coming in.) What happened to the *pl-*? (It became *ll-*.)

288.5 la despedida — taking your leave was asking for it

Before the last of the five: what did *plicare* mean? (To fold.) And what did *salire* mean? (To jump.)

What to know first

- adiós — one thing you say at this moment.
- hasta luego — and another.

Sounds you'll need

- *des-pe-DI-da*, stress on the *di*. Both *d* sounds between vowels are soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la despedida — "the farewell," the act of saying goodbye.
From **despedir**, and behind it Latin **expetere**: *ex-*, out, plus **petere**, to seek or to ask. To take your leave was to ask for it — which is still what a leave-taking is, underneath the politeness.
Petere is a large family in English. A **petition** asks. To **compete** is to seek alongside somebody. An **appetite** seeks towards. And to **repeat** is to seek a thing again.
Adiós, *hasta luego* and *hasta mañana* have been yours since near the start, and you have been saying them without a word for the act itself. This is that word.

What you've built

Five: *la salida*, *el viaje*, *la vuelta*, *la llegada*, *la despedida*.
Set out in order they trace a whole departure — the way out, the journey, the return, the arrival, and the goodbye that opens the whole thing. Four of the five are words you already had, wearing an ending. Only the endings were new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la despedida*
- *adiós*, then *la despedida* — the word and the act
- all five in order — *la salida*, *el viaje*, *la vuelta*, *la llegada*, *la despedida*

Before you move on

What are the pieces of *expetere*? (*Ex-*, out, and *petere*, to ask.)
Which English words still ask? (*Petition*, *compete*, *appetite*, *repeat*.)
And what did *plicare* mean? (To fold.)

Chapter 289

Overhead — Daybreak, Sky, Cloud, Star, Shade

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the daybreak, the sky, a cloud, a star and the shade in Spanish.
>
> *Complete ES-C289-sombra: name all five overhead in order, from first light to the shade under a tree.*

289.1 el amanecer — the piece hiding inside mañana

Before a new run: what are the pieces of *expetere*? (*Ex-*, out, and *petere*, to ask.) And what does *la llegada* name? (The arrival.)

What to know first

- hasta mañana — a word you have been saying for a long time, with a piece of this one inside it.
- el día — what this is the beginning of.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-ma-ne-CER*, stress on the very end. The *c* before *e* is the soft one. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el amanecer — "the daybreak," the moment it gets light.
Take it apart and Latin **mane** falls out, meaning "in the morning." Around it sit *a-*, towards, and *-ecer*, an ending that means a thing beginning to happen. So: moving towards morning, and not yet arrived.
You already own that middle piece. *Mañana* is *mane* too, worn down through **hora maneana**, "the morning hour," until only the *mañ-* was left. Two words you would never have paired, and the same Latin sits in both.
The cousins in English arrive by a different road. **Matins** is the morning office. A **matinee** is the showing early enough to still count as morning, at least when somebody named it.

What you've built

A word for the moment a day starts, and a piece you can now hear in a word you already had.
That is worth more than one word. Once *mane* is visible inside *mañana*, the two stop being separate things to remember and become one thing wearing two coats.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el amanecer*
- *mañana*, then *el amanecer*, and hear *man-* in both
- *hasta mañana*, then *el amanecer*

Before you move on

What did *mane* mean? (In the morning.) Which word you already had carries the same piece? (*Mañana*.) And what does *-ecer* add? (That a thing is beginning to happen.)

289.2 el cielo — the ceiling over everything

> Two back: what does *la despedida* name? (The farewell.) And what did *mane* mean? (In the morning.)

What to know first

- el amanecer — what happens up there first.
- azul — what it usually is.

Sounds you'll need

- *CIE-lo*, stress on the first part. The *ie* is one slide, not two beats, and the *l* stays bright to the end. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cielo — "the sky."
Latin **caelum**, and the Romans used it for the sky and for the vault of heaven without much worrying which they meant. Spanish kept both senses in the one word.
The English relatives came in by two doors. Through French *ciel* you get **ceiling** — the sky of a room, which is a nicer thought than the word usually gets credit for. Straight from Latin you get **cerulean**, the deep blue in a paint box, from **caeruleus**, "sky-coloured."
Notice what the *ie* is doing. Latin had a short *e* in *caelum*, and Spanish broke it into *ie* the way it did in *bien* and *tiene*. Once you hear that, a whole set of words stops looking irregular.

What you've built

Two words, and both of them are about what is over your head. *El amanecer* is a moment; *el cielo* is a place. Between them you can already say when and where without any of the machinery a sentence usually needs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cielo*

- *el cielo azul*
- *el amanecer*, then *el cielo*

Before you move on

What was *caelum*? (The sky.) Which English word for the top of a room is the same one? (*Ceiling.*) And what colour is *cerulean*? (Sky blue.)

289.3 la nube — where nuance comes from

Before the new one: what was *caelum*? (The sky.) And which piece of *amanecer* means "in the morning"? (*Mane.*)

What to know first

- el cielo — where these are.
- blanco — what colour they usually are.

Sounds you'll need

- *NU-be*, stress on the first part. The *u* is the pure one, and the *b* between vowels is soft, the lips barely meeting. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la nube — "the cloud."
Latin **nubes**, and it has come down almost untouched: four letters in, four letters out.
The good English relative is not obvious. French took *nubes* and made **nue**, a cloud, and from *nue* built **nuance** — which meant the shading of one cloud into another before it ever meant a shade of meaning. When you say a distinction has nuance, you are borrowing a description of the sky.
Nebulous looks like a relative and is a slightly different one: Latin **nebula** was mist rather than cloud. Close cousins, different words, and the pair is worth keeping apart in your head.

What you've built

Three, and they stack: a moment, the place above you, and the things crossing it.
El amanecer, *el cielo*, *la nube*. Notice that none of the three has needed a new ending or a new pattern — they are ordinary words, and you can already hang *azul* or *blanco* on the last two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la nube*
- *la nube blanca*
- *el amanecer*, *el cielo*, *la nube*

Before you move on

What English word for a fine distinction began as a shading of cloud? (*Nuance*.) What did *nebula* mean, as against *nubes*? (Mist, not cloud.)

289.4 la estrella — stella, with a running start

Quick pass: what was *nubes*? (A cloud.) What was *caelum*? (The sky.) And what does *el amanecer* name? (The daybreak.)

What to know first

- el cielo — where you find them.
- la noche — when you find them.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-TRE-lla*, stress in the middle. The *rr* is not here — this is a single *r* after a *t*, one tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la estrella — "the star."
Underneath it is Latin **stella**, and English took that one bare: something **stellar** is of the stars, and a **constellation** is a set of them standing together.
So where did the *e-* come from? Spanish does not care for a word that opens with *s* and another consonant, and it puts an *e* in front to give the tongue somewhere to start. You have seen it without being told: *escuela*, *estudiante*, *España*. Each one is a Latin word with a step built in front of it.
That is why an English speaker learning Spanish and a Spanish speaker learning English trip over the same threshold from opposite sides.

What you've built

Four, and one small piece of machinery that costs nothing and pays constantly.
El amanecer, *el cielo*, *la nube*, *la estrella*. The last of them handed you a way to guess at words you have not met: strip the *e-*, and a Latin or English relative is often sitting underneath.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la estrella*
- *estudiante*, *España*, *estrella* — the same step three times
- *el cielo*, *la nube*, *la estrella*

Before you move on

What is *estrella* without its *e-*? (*Stella.*) Why is the *e-* there? (Spanish wants a vowel before *s* plus a consonant.) Name two more words that do it. (*Escuela*, *estudiante*, *España.*)

289.5 la sombra — what an umbrella is little of

Before the last of the five: what was *stella*? (A star.) What was *nubes*? (A cloud.) And why does *estrella* begin with an *e*?

(Spanish wants a vowel before *s* and a consonant.)

What to know first

- el árbol — a reliable source of one.
- el cielo — what has to be clear for there to be any.

Sounds you'll need

- *SOM-bra*, stress on the first part. The *m* closes the lips and the *b* opens them again, so the two run together. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sombra — "the shade," "the shadow."
Two Latin words squeezed into one: **sub**, under, and **umbra**, shadow. To be *sub umbra* was to be under the shadow, and Spanish ran the phrase together until it named the thing itself.
Umbra is generous in English. An **umbrella** is a little shadow you carry — built for sun before it was ever built for rain, which the name still admits. To take **umbrage** is to be put in the shade by somebody. And a **sombrero** is Spanish handing the word back: a shadow-maker for your head.
The *-ero* on *sombrero* makes a thing that does a job, the way *cocinero* names somebody who cooks. A hat that shades is a *sombrero*, and now the hat is not a word you have to memorise.

What you've built

Five: *el amanecer*, *el cielo*, *la nube*, *la estrella*, *la sombra*.
Read them in order and they run from first light to the dark shape under a tree — a whole day's worth of overhead, in five words and no new grammar at all. Three of the five handed you something extra on the way out: a piece of *mañana*, the *e-* step, and now an ending you had already met wearing a different hat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sombra*

- *sombra*, then *sombrero* — the shade and the thing that makes it
- all five in order — *el amanecer*, *el cielo*, *la nube*, *la estrella*, *la sombra*

Before you move on

What two Latin words are inside *sombra*? (*Sub*, under, and *umbra*, shadow.) Which English words still carry *umbra*? (*Umbrella*, *umbrage*.) And what does *-ero* do? (Names somebody or something that does the job.)

Chapter 290

What Is Eaten — Wheat, Rice, Onion, Tomato, Honey

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name wheat, rice, an onion, a tomato and honey in Spanish, and thank somebody for them.
>
> *Complete ES-C290-miel: name all five foods in turn and thank somebody for each.*

290.1 el trigo — the grain that got rubbed

> Before a new run: what two Latin words hide in *sombra*? (*Sub* and *umbra*.) And what was *stella*? (A star.)

What to know first

- el pan — what this becomes.
- el agua — the other half of what bread needs.

Sounds you'll need

- *TRI-go*, stress on the first part. One tap for the *r*, and the *g* is hard before *o*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el trigo — "the wheat."
Latin **triticum**, and that is built on **terere**, to rub or to wear away. Wheat was named for what you had to do to it: rub the grain out of the husk. The crop is named after the threshing, not the plant.
Terere wore a path through English too. Something **trite** has been rubbed smooth by overuse. **Attrition** is wearing down. **Detritus** is what has been rubbed off. Even **detriment** is a wearing-away, though it has gone abstract and stopped admitting it.
A useful habit, this: when a Latin food word looks odd, ask what was done to the food. The answer is often the whole etymology.

What you've built

One word, and a small piece of the ancient working day.
You have had *el pan* for a long time. Now you have what it is made of, which means you can name a thing and the stuff it came from — a step up from naming things one at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el trigo*
- *el trigo*, then *el pan* — the stuff, then the thing
- *el pan de trigo*

Before you move on

What did *terere* mean? (To rub.) Which English words still rub? (*Trite*, *attrition*, *detritus*.) And what is *el trigo*? (The wheat.)

290.2 el arroz — a word that brought its own article

Two back: what does *la sombra* name? (The shade.) And what did *terere* mean? (To rub.)

What to know first

- el trigo — the grain before this one.
- el agua — what you cook it in.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-RROZ*, stress on the end. The *rr* at the start of the second part is the rolled one, held. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el arroz — "the rice."
This one did not come from Latin. Arabic **ar-ruzz** crossed into Spain with the crop itself, and Spanish took the phrase whole, article and all. *Ar-* was already "the." So *el arroz* says it twice, in two languages, and nobody minds.
Once you know to watch for it, that stuck-on *a-* is everywhere in the Arabic layer of Spanish: *azúcar*, *aceite*, *almohada*, *aduana*. Each one is still wearing an Arabic *al-* that Spanish stopped being able to see.
English got the same grain by a different road — Greek **oryza**, then Latin, then Italian, then French, arriving as **rice**. Same plant, two routes, and the words no longer look like relatives.

What you've built

Two grains, and two completely different histories sitting side by side. *El trigo* came down from Rome. *El arroz* came in from the south with farmers. That is Spanish in miniature: a Latin skeleton with a large Arabic vocabulary laid over the top, and the joins still visible when you know where to look.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el arroz*
- *el trigo*, then *el arroz* — Rome, then the south
- *arroz*, *azúcar*, *aceite* — three words carrying an Arabic *al-*

Before you move on

What does the *ar-* in *arroz* already mean? (The.) Name two more Spanish words carrying an Arabic article. (*Azúcar*, *aceite*, *almohada*.) And which English word is the same grain? (*Rice*.)

290.3 la cebolla — a little something, permanently

Before the new one: what does the *ar-* of *arroz* already mean? (The.) And what was *triticum* named for? (The rubbing, the threshing.)

What to know first

- comer — what you eventually do with it.
- el arroz — what it usually goes into.

Sounds you'll need

- *ce-BO-lla*, stress in the middle. The *c* before *e* is soft, and the *ll* is close to an English *y*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cebolla — "the onion."
Latin had **caepa** for an onion, and **caepulla** for a small one. Spanish kept the small one and quietly dropped the full-sized word, so the language now calls every onion a little onion, however large.
That happens more than you would expect. A word with a diminutive on it gets used so often that the ending stops meaning anything, and the plain form falls away. You will meet the same *-illa* and *-illo* again shortly, still doing the job in words where it has not yet worn out.
English kept the other half. **Chive** came through French *cive* from that same **caepa**, and a chive really is a small one — so between the two languages the pair got split down the middle.

What you've built

Three things you can put in a pot, and a piece of machinery worth more than the three.
El trigo, *el arroz*, *la cebolla*. Hearing a small ending as "a little one of these" will unlock words you have not been taught, which is the whole point of taking them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cebolla*
- *el arroz con cebolla*
- *el trigo*, *el arroz*, *la cebolla*

Before you move on

What was *caepa*? (An onion.) What did *caepulla* add? (Smallness.) Which English plant is the same root? (*Chive*.)

290.4 el tomate — a word that came the other way

Quick pass: what was *caepa*? (An onion.) What does *ar-* mean in *arroz*? (The.) And what is *el trigo*? (The wheat.)

What to know first

- la cebolla — what it is usually cooked with.
- rojo — what colour it goes.

Sounds you'll need

- *to-MA-te*, stress in the middle. Three clean vowels, none of them swallowed. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tomate — "the tomato."
Take this one apart and nothing Latin falls out, because there is nothing Latin in it. **Tomatl** is Nahuatl, the language of the Mexica, and the plant and its name travelled to Spain together in the sixteenth century.
Spanish shaved the *-tl* into *-te*, which is what it did to the whole set: **chocolatl** became *chocolate*, **ahuacatl** became *aguacate*, **coyotl** became *coyote*. Then English took them from Spanish, which is why an English speaker already owns three Nahuatl words without knowing it. So the traffic ran both ways. Spanish handed *sombrero* to English and took *tomate* from Mexico, and both words now sit in the same everyday vocabulary with no label saying where they have been.

What you've built

Four foods, and three separate continents behind them.
El trigo is Roman. *El arroz* is Arabic. *El tomate* is American. One short set of words, and the history of who fed whom is sitting inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tomate*
- *tomate*, *chocolate*, *aguacate* — the same ending three times
- *el arroz con tomate y cebolla*

Before you move on

What language is *tomate* from? (Nahuatl.) What happened to the *-tl* ending? (It became *-te*.) Name two more words that did it. (*Chocolate*, *aguacate*, *coyote*.)

290.5 la miel — the sweetness inside three English words

Before the last of the five: what language gave us *tomate*? (Nahuatl.) What was *caepa*? (An onion.) And what does *ar-*

mean? (The.)

What to know first

- el pan — what you put it on.
- la flor — where it starts.

Sounds you'll need

- *MIEL*, one beat. The *ie* is a single slide, and the *l* is bright, never the dark English one at the end of a word. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la miel — "the honey."
Latin **mel**, four letters shorter than most of what we have taken apart, and Spanish did little to it beyond breaking the *e* into *ie* — the same break you met in *cielo*.
Mel is sweeter in English than it looks. Something **mellifluous** flows with honey, which is what *fluere* is doing on the end of it. **Molasses** came through Portuguese *melaço*, the honey-like leavings of sugar.
And **marmalade** carries the Greek form **meli**, stuck to *melon*, quince — a quince-honey, which is exactly what marmalade is.
There is a lesson hidden in that last one. A word can be perfectly transparent in its own language and completely opaque once it has crossed two borders.

What you've built

Five: *el trigo*, *el arroz*, *la cebolla*, *el tomate*, *la miel*.
Set out together they are a shopping list, and they are also four separate histories — Rome, Arabia, Mexico, and Rome again. Every one of the five arrived with an English relative attached, which is the quiet argument this whole approach rests on: you know more of this language than you have been taught.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la miel*

- *el pan con miel*
- all five — *el trigo*, *el arroz*, *la cebolla*, *el tomate*, *la miel*

Before you move on

What was *mel*? (Honey.) What does *mellifluous* say, taken apart? (Flowing with honey.) And which breakfast preserve is a quince-honey? (*Marmalade.*)

Chapter 291

From the Seed Up — Seed, Root, Trunk, Branch, Wood

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the seed, the root, the trunk, the branch and the wood in Spanish.
>
> *Complete ES-C291-bosque: name all five from the ground upwards, seed to forest.*

291.1 la semilla — where a seminar gets its name

> Before a new run: what was *mel*? (Honey.) And what language gave Spanish *tomate*? (Nahuatl.)

What to know first

- la flor — what this one is left behind by.
- el trigo — a crop that is nothing but these.

Sounds you'll need

- *se-MI-lla*, stress in the middle. The *ll* is the *y* sound again, the same as in *cebolla*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la semilla — "the seed."
Behind it sits Latin **seminalia**, "the things for sowing," and behind that **semen**, which meant a seed long before it meant anything narrower.
The English family is unusually respectable. A **seminar** is a seed-bed, a place where ideas are started rather than finished. A **seminary** is a nursery for people. To **disseminate** is to scatter seed in every direction, which is what *dis-* is doing there. And something **seminal** is the thing everything later grew out of.
Hear the *-illa* on the end again. This is the second time it has turned up in two chapters' worth of words, and it will keep turning up — a small ending doing quiet work in words nobody thinks of as small any more.

What you've built

One word, and the beginning of a shape.
The next few belong together: this is a tree taken from the ground upwards, and you are standing at the bottom of it. Learning words in a set like that is worth more than learning five unrelated ones, because the set itself is a hook.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la semilla*
- *la semilla*, then *seminar* — the seed and the seed-bed
- *la semilla del trigo*

Before you move on

What did *seminalia* mean? (Things for sowing.) What is a *seminar*, taken apart? (A seed-bed.) And what does *dis-* add to *disseminate*? (Scattering in all directions.)

291.2 la raíz — the word this book keeps using about words

Two back: what was *mel*? (Honey.) And what is a *seminar*, taken apart? (A seed-bed.)

What to know first

- la semilla — what this comes out of first.
- el árbol — what is standing on top of it.

Sounds you'll need

- *ra-ÍZ*, two beats, stress on the second. The written accent is doing real work: it splits *a* and *i* apart instead of letting them slide together. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la raíz — "the root."
Latin **radix**, and this is the one word in the set you have already been using in English without noticing, because it is what we say about words themselves. When a lesson says a Spanish word and an English word share a root, *radix* is the metaphor underneath.
A **radish** is a *radix* that got eaten. A **radical** goes to the root of the matter, which is why the word means both "fundamental" and "extreme" — it depends whether you approve. To **eradicate** is to pull up by the roots, *e-* out plus *radix*. And a square **root** in mathematics is a translation of the same Latin.
The accent on the *í* is not decoration. Without it, *ai* would slide into one sound; with it, the two vowels stay separate and the stress lands on the second.

What you've built

Two, and they are in the right order: the seed, then what comes out of it first.
You also have the etymology of the word *root* itself, which is a small thing until you notice that half of what this approach does is claim two words share one. Now you can say that claim in Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la raíz*
- *la semilla*, then *la raíz* — in that order
- *ra-íz*, two beats, and keep the vowels apart

Before you move on

What was *radix*? (A root.) What does *eradicate* say, taken apart? (To pull out by the roots.) And what is the accent on *raíz* doing? (Keeping the two vowels in separate beats.)

291.3 el tronco — a word that means "cut short"

Before the new one: what was *radix*? (A root.) And what did *seminalia* mean? (Things for sowing.)

What to know first

- la raíz — what holds this up.
- el árbol — the whole of which this is the middle.

Sounds you'll need

- *TRON-co*, stress on the first part. The *c* before *o* is the hard one, and the *n* closes the first beat. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tronco — "the trunk."
Latin **truncus**, and its first meaning was not a tree at all. *Truncus* meant lopped, maimed, cut short — a thing with its ends taken off. A tree stripped of branches is a *truncus*, and the name stuck to the part that was left.
English took the whole family. A **trunk** is the same word. To **truncate** is to cut short deliberately. A **truncheon** is a stick that is a cut-off piece of something longer. Even the elephant's trunk and the traveller's trunk are the same word wandering off in two directions

from one idea of a thick stump.
That first meaning explains something odd about *tronco* in Spanish: it is used of a body as well as a tree, for the part left when you set aside the head and the limbs. It has never really stopped meaning "what remains."

What you've built

Three, going upward: *la semilla*, *la raíz*, *el tronco*.
The set is doing the work of a story. You are not holding three separate items in mind, you are holding one tree, and the order of the words is the order of the thing itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tronco*
- *la semilla*, *la raíz*, *el tronco* — bottom to middle
- *el tronco del árbol*

Before you move on

What did *truncus* mean first? (Lopped, cut short.) What does *truncate* do? (Cuts something short.) And what are the first three of the set? (*La semilla*, *la raíz*, *el tronco*.)

291.4 la rama — what a ramification actually is

Quick pass: what did *truncus* mean? (Lopped short.) What was *radix*? (A root.) And what is *la semilla*? (The seed.)

What to know first

- el tronco — what these come out of.
- el árbol — the whole thing they belong to.

Sounds you'll need

- *RA-ma*, stress on the first part. The opening *r* at the start of a word is rolled, not tapped. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la rama — "the branch."
Latin **ramus**, and it has barely moved: drop the ending, soften nothing, and there it is.
English kept *ramus* only in its abstract clothes, which makes the connection easy to miss. When a problem **ramifies**, it is growing branches. A **ramification** is one branch of a consequence. Both words are used almost entirely about arguments and lawsuits, and both are describing a tree.
This is a pattern worth naming. Spanish very often keeps a Latin word for the physical thing while English keeps it only for the metaphor. *Rama* is a branch you can snap; **ramification** is a branch nobody can point at. Same word, and the two languages divided the labour between them.

What you've built

Four, and the tree is nearly whole: *la semilla*, *la raíz*, *el tronco*, *la rama*.
Four words, and not one of them needed a rule you did not already have. They are ordinary things with ordinary endings, and the only work you have done is hearing what was already inside them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la rama*
- *la rama del árbol*
- *la semilla*, *la raíz*, *el tronco*, *la rama*

Before you move on

What was *ramus*? (A branch.) What is a *ramification*, underneath? (A branch of a consequence.) And which four do you have so far? (*La semilla*, *la raíz*, *el tronco*, *la rama*.)

291.5 el bosque — the one in the set that is not Roman

Before the last of the five: what was *ramus*? (A branch.) What was *truncus*? (Lopped short.) And what was *radix*? (A root.)

What to know first

- el árbol — one of these, many times over.
- la rama — the word before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *BOS-que*, stress on the first part. The *qu* is a plain hard *k* and the *u* is silent, as it is in *qué*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el bosque — "the wood," "the forest."
Take this one apart and Latin does not answer. *Bosque* is Germanic — from a root like **busk**, a thicket — and it walked into Spanish with the Visigoths, who ruled the peninsula for three centuries between Rome and the Arabic arrival.
Which means its English relative is a native one. A **bush** is the same word. A **bosky** wood is a thicketed one. To **ambush** is to lie in the bushes, *in* the *busk*, waiting. And a **bouquet** is French for a little wood, a small stand of stems, which is a fair description of what is in the vase.
Spanish is often described as Latin plus Arabic, and that is most of the truth, but there is a Germanic layer underneath. You have already met *blanco*, which is Germanic too. *Bosque* is that layer showing again.

What you've built

Five: *la semilla*, *la raíz*, *el tronco*, *la rama*, *el bosque*.
Said in order they build one tree and then step back to show a thousand of them. Four came from Rome and the fifth from the north, so this short set has quietly handed you the three sources Spanish draws on — Latin, Arabic in the chapter before, and now Germanic.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el bosque*
- *bosque*, then *bush* — the same thicket twice
- all five — *la semilla*, *la raíz*, *el tronco*, *la rama*, *el bosque*

Before you move on

Where does *bosque* come from? (Germanic, not Latin.) Which English words are its cousins? (*Bush*, *bosky*, *ambush*.) And which other Germanic word do you already have? (*Blanco*.)

Chapter 292

Naming the Land — Village, Hill, Valley, Lake, Mountain

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the village, a hill, a valley, a lake and a mountain in Spanish, and say where I am from.
>
> *Complete ES-C292-montana: name all five features of a landscape and place a village among them.*

292.1 el pueblo — the place and the people, one word

Before a new run: where does *bosque* come from? (Germanic, not Latin.) And what was *ramus*? (A branch.)

What to know first

- la casa — what a small one is mostly made of.
- el vecino — who lives in it.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUE-blo*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide, and the *b* between vowels is the soft one. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pueblo — "the village," and also "the people."
Latin **populus** meant the people, the citizen body. Spanish kept that sense and added the other one, so *el pueblo* is both the settlement and everybody in it, and Spanish does not usually feel the need to say which.
Populus is generous in English. Something **popular** belongs to the people. A **population** is the whole of them counted. Anything **public** is theirs rather than private — *publicus* is *populus* worn down. And **people** itself came through French from the same Latin, so the English and the Spanish word are the same word, three roads apart.
Watch the *ue*. Latin's short *o* in *populus* broke into *ue* in Spanish, the same way the short *e* broke into *ie* in *cielo*. Once you can hear those two breaks, a very large number of Spanish words stop being surprises.

What you've built

One word doing two jobs, which is a bargain.
You can now name where somebody is from, and the answer is also a claim about who they are. That is a genuinely useful thing to be able to say when you are meeting people, and it costs one word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pueblo*
- *mi pueblo*
- *pueblo*, *popular*, *público* — the same Latin three times

Before you move on

What did *populus* mean? (The people.) What two things does *pueblo* name? (The village and the people in it.) And what did Latin's short *o* become? (*Ue*.)

292.2 la colina — the same rising that is in excel

Two back: which of the tree words was Germanic? (*El bosque.*)
And what does *pueblo* name besides the village? (The people.)

What to know first

- el pueblo — often sitting on one of these.
- el bosque — what is often growing on it.

Sounds you'll need

- *co-LI-na*, stress in the middle. Both *l* sounds are bright and forward. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la colina — "the hill."
Latin **collis**, a hill, and behind it an old root that simply meant to rise or to stand up. That root went everywhere.
To **excel** is *ex-* plus *cellere*, to rise out above the rest. To **culminate** is to reach the **culmen**, the summit. And the plain English **hill** is a cousin too, arriving through Germanic rather than Latin — the same ancient rising, split between the two halves of your vocabulary.
The *-ina* on the end is a softening, the same shape as in *cocina*. Spanish tends to take a blunt Latin word and hand it a warmer ending, and *collis* to *colina* is that habit in one step.

What you've built

Two, and between them you can place a settlement in a landscape. *El pueblo* and *la colina* are the beginning of being able to answer "where are you from?" with something more than a name — which is exactly what you do when you meet somebody and the name alone is not enough.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la colina*

- *el pueblo en la colina*
- *colina*, then *excel* — both of them rising

Before you move on

What was *collis*? (A hill.) What does the old root behind it mean? (To rise.) And which two English words still rise? (*Excel*, *culminate*.)

292.3 el valle — the low half of the pair

Before the new one: what was *collis*? (A hill.) And what two things does *el pueblo* name? (The village and its people.)

What to know first

- la colina — the opposite shape.
- la nieve — what comes down into one.

Sounds you'll need

- *VA-lle*, stress on the first part. The *v* is said with both lips, close to a soft *b*, and the *ll* is the *y* sound. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el valle — "the valley."
Latin **vallis**, and English has it twice over. **Valley** came through French, carrying the extra syllable. **Vale** is the same word arriving earlier and shorter, which is why it survives mostly in place names and poetry.
Avalanche belongs here too, though it took a detour: it is from a dialect of the Alps, built on the idea of descending — *a val*, to the valley. What an avalanche is named for is not the snow, but where the snow ends up.
The *v* is worth a moment. In Spanish it is not the English *v* made with teeth and lip; it is made with both lips, and in most positions it is barely distinguishable from *b*. Spanish speakers who have not been taught spelling mix the two up in writing for exactly that reason.

What you've built

Three, and they are starting to describe a place rather than list things. *El pueblo*, *la colina*, *el valle*. High ground, low ground, and somewhere for people to live between them. That is a landscape, and you can now put a name to one when somebody asks where you grew up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el valle*
- *la colina*, then *el valle* — up, then down
- *el pueblo del valle*

Before you move on

What was *vallis*? (A valley.) Which two English words are both from it? (*Valley* and *vale*.) And how is the Spanish *v* made? (With both lips, near a soft *b*.)

292.4 el lago — and the gap it leaves in a page

> Quick pass: what was *vallis*? (A valley.) What was *collis*? (A hill.) And what was *populus*? (The people.)

What to know first

- el agua — what one is made of.
- el valle — where one usually sits.

Sounds you'll need

- *LA-go*, stress on the first part. The *g* before *o* is hard, and softens a little between vowels. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el lago — "the lake."
Latin **lacus**, standing water. English **lake** is the same word through French, and **lagoon** arrived later through Italian *laguna*, which is *lacuna* worn smooth.
That last one is the interesting turn. A **lacuna** in Latin is a pool or a pit, and scholars borrowed it for a hole in a manuscript — a place where the text has gone missing. So the word for a small lake became the word for a gap in a page, because both are an absence with an edge round it.
Lacus also went north on its own and turned up in English as **loch** and **lough** through the Celtic languages, which is why the map of Scotland and Ireland is covered in a Spanish word nobody there would recognise as one.

What you've built

Four, and the landscape now has water in it.
El pueblo, *la colina*, *el valle*, *el lago*. You could describe most of the places people are actually from with these four and nothing else, which is not bad for four words that each came with an English relative attached.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el lago*
- *el lago del valle*
- *el pueblo*, *la colina*, *el valle*, *el lago*

Before you move on

What was *lacus*? (Standing water.) What is a *lacuna* in a text? (A gap where something is missing.) And why is it called that? (It was a pool first.)

292.5 la montaña — the hill inside amount

> Before the last of the five: what was *lacus*? (Standing water.) What was *vallis*? (A valley.) And what was *collis*? (A hill.)

What to know first

- la colina — the smaller version.
- la nieve — what is on top of one.

Sounds you'll need

- *mon-TA-ña*, stress in the middle. The *ñ* is one sound, not two: the tongue flat against the roof of the mouth. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la montaña — "the mountain."
Latin **mons**, and in its other forms **montem**, a hill. Spanish built *montaña* on it; English took **mountain** through French from the same place.
Then *mons* went quietly into a set of English words that have stopped looking like hills at all. Something **paramount** is *par a mont*, up above. To **surmount** is to get over the top. To **amount** to something is to climb to it — which is why a bill amounts to a figure, as though the total were a summit. A **montage** is things mounted, stacked up.
The *ñ* is the one letter here that Latin did not have. It began as a scribe's shortcut for a doubled *n*: rather than write the second one in full, they set a tiny *n* over the first to save space, and that tiny mark hardened into the tilde. *Montanea* to *montaña* is that shortcut, frozen.

What you've built

Five: *el pueblo*, *la colina*, *el valle*, *el lago*, *la montaña*.
Together they are a place, and a place is what most people mean when they tell you where they are from. You started this run able to give a name; you can now give a landscape as well, which is the difference between an introduction and a conversation.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la montaña*
- *la colina*, then *la montaña* — small, then large
- all five — *el pueblo*, *la colina*, *el valle*, *el lago*, *la montaña*

Before you move on

What was *mons*? (A hill.) What does *paramount* say, taken apart? (Up above.) And where did the *ñ* come from? (A scribe's tiny second *n*, set over the first.)

Chapter 293

Further Down — Neck, Shoulder, Back, Knee, Ankle

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the neck, the shoulder, the back, the knee and the ankle in Spanish, and say which one hurts.
>
> *Complete ES-C293-tobillo: name all five places in order and say that each one hurts.*

293.1 el cuello — what an accolade was thrown around

Before a new run: what was *mons*? (A hill.) And what was *lacus*? (Standing water.)

What to know first

- la cabeza — what sits on top of it.
- la garganta — what runs down inside it.

Sounds you'll need

- *CUE-llo*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide, and the *ll* is the *y* sound you have had since *cebolla*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cuello — "the neck."
Latin **collum**, and there is that *o*-to-*ue* break again, the one you met in *pueblo*. Spanish did it here for exactly the same reason.
Collum is all over English clothing and ceremony. A **collar** is the thing that goes round it. An **accolade** is *ad collum*, "to the neck" — originally the embrace, or the sword laid on the shoulder, that made somebody a knight. The word now means any honour, and has forgotten it used to be a gesture.
El cuello does double duty in Spanish, as it does in English: the neck of a person and the neck of a shirt are the same word, and so is the neck of a bottle.

What you've built

One more place on the body, and you already had the ones above it. *La cabeza*, *la garganta*, and now *el cuello*. Being able to say precisely where something hurts is one of the few pieces of vocabulary that is genuinely urgent, which is why this ground is worth going over twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cuello*
- *me duele el cuello*
- *la cabeza*, *el cuello* — top down

Before you move on

What was *collum*? (The neck.) What does *accolade* say, taken apart? (To the neck.) And what break turned *collum* into *cuello*? (Short *o* into *ue*.)

293.2 el hombro — the bone a doctor still names in Latin

Two back: what was *mons*? (A hill.) And what does *accolade* mean, taken apart? (To the neck.)

What to know first

- el cuello — what this sits either side of.
- la mano — the far end of the same arm.

Sounds you'll need

- *OM-bro*, stress on the first part. The *h* is silent — begin on the vowel and the word is right. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el hombro — "the shoulder."
Latin **umerus**, with no *h* at all. Spanish added the letter later, purely as spelling, and it has been silent from the day it arrived. If you say *ombro* you have said the word correctly.
The Latin survives untouched in English medicine: the **humerus** is the long bone of the upper arm, running from this joint to the elbow. It is one of those words English kept in a white coat while Spanish wore it every day.
Do not confuse *umerus* with **humor**, the old bodily fluid — nor with **humus**, the ground. Three similar Latin words, three unrelated families, and the *h* that Spanish sprinkled on *hombro* makes the confusion easier rather than harder. Spelling is not always your friend.

What you've built

Two, and they are next to each other on the body.
El cuello and *el hombro*. You are working downward, and the run will keep going down — which is a better way to hold a set of body words than any list, because the body supplies the order for you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el hombro*
- *me duele el hombro*
- *el cuello*, then *el hombro*

Before you move on

What was *umerus*? (The shoulder.) What do doctors call that bone today? (The humerus.) And what is the *h* in *hombro* doing? (Nothing — it is silent.)

293.3 la espalda — a broad blade, worn on the body

Before the new one: what was *umerus*? (The shoulder.) And what was *collum*? (The neck.)

What to know first

- el hombro — the corner of it.
- el dolor — what it is famous for.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-PAL-da*, stress in the middle. There is the *e-* step again, in front of *sp*, exactly as in *estrella*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la espalda — "the back."
Underneath is Latin **spatula**, a broad flat blade, itself a small **spatha**, a broad sword. The shoulder blade was named after the tool it resembles, and in Spanish the name spread out from the blade to cover the whole back.
Strip the Spanish *e-* and the English relatives line up. A **spatula** is still a broad flat blade in a kitchen. A **spade** is a bigger one. An **epaulette** is the ornament on a shoulder, through French *épaule* — and French put an *é* on the front for the same reason Spanish put an *e*, so the two languages solved one problem twice.
This is the second word in this run where the *e-* is the only thing standing between you and a word you already know. It is worth making that a habit: meet an unfamiliar *es-* word, take the *e* off, and see what is left.

What you've built

Three, still working downward: *el cuello*, *el hombro*, *la espalda*. The *e-* trick has now paid twice — once on a star and once on a back — which is about the point at which a pattern stops being a curiosity and starts being a tool.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la espalda*
- *me duele la espalda*
- *el cuello*, *el hombro*, *la espalda*

Before you move on

What was *spatula* in Latin? (A broad blade.) Which English kitchen tool is the same word? (A spatula.) And what happens if you take the *e-* off an *es-* word? (A familiar word is often underneath.)

293.4 la rodilla — a little wheel, which is exactly right

Quick pass: what was *spatula*? (A broad blade.) What was *umerus*? (The shoulder.) And what was *collum*? (The neck.)

What to know first

- la espalda — the word before this one.
- el dolor — what this joint tends to produce.

Sounds you'll need

- *ro-DI-lla*, stress in the middle. The opening *r* is rolled; the *d* between vowels is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la rodilla — "the knee."
Latin **rota** was a wheel, and **rotella** a little one. That is what the knee was called: the small wheel in the middle of the leg. Anyone who has watched a kneecap turn will grant that it is a fair description.
Rota is busy in English. To **rotate** is to wheel. A **rotary** is a wheel of traffic. **Roulette** is a little wheel through French — the same diminutive as *rotella*, built in a different language. And something **rotund** is wheel-shaped.
There is that *-illa* again, and this is the fourth time it has appeared. Once in an onion, once in a seed, and now in a knee. When an ending shows up in words that have nothing to do with one another, it has stopped being decoration and become part of how the language builds things.

What you've built

Four, from the neck down to the leg: *el cuello*, *el hombro*, *la espalda*, *la rodilla*.
Each one arrived with a picture attached — a collar, a bone, a blade, a wheel. Words with a picture behind them survive in the memory much longer than words with only a translation.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la rodilla*
- *me duele la rodilla*
- *el cuello*, *el hombro*, *la espalda*, *la rodilla*

Before you move on

What was *rota*? (A wheel.) What did *rotella* add? (Smallness.) And which English gambling wheel is the same diminutive? (*Roulette*.)

293.5 el tobillo — a small lump, honestly named

> Before the last of the five: what was *rota*? (A wheel.) What was *spatula*? (A broad blade.) And what was *umerus*? (The shoulder.)

What to know first

- la rodilla — the joint above this one.
- el dolor — what a twisted one gives you.

Sounds you'll need

- *to-BI-llo*, stress in the middle. The *b* between vowels is soft, lips barely touching. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tobillo — "the ankle."
Behind it is Latin **tuber**, a swelling or a lump, with the small ending on it. The ankle is the little lump at the bottom of the leg, and the Romans saw no reason to be more poetic about it than that.
Tuber kept its lumpiness in English. A **tuber** is the swelling on a root that we eat as a potato. **Tuberculosis** is named for the small lumps the disease leaves in the lungs. A **protuberance** is a lump sticking forward, which is *pro-* doing the sticking.
That is the fifth *-illo* or *-illa* in this stretch of the book, and by now it should not need pointing out. A seed, an onion, a knee, an ankle: none of them related, all of them small.

What you've built

Five, and a whole side of the body: *el cuello*, *el hombro*, *la espalda*, *la rodilla*, *el tobillo*.
Said in that order they run from the top of the spine to the bottom of the leg, and each of them fits straight into *me duele* — which you have had for a long time and which now has five more places to point at.
The vocabulary is new; the sentence around it is not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tobillo*
- *me duele el tobillo*
- all five — *el cuello*, *el hombro*, *la espalda*, *la rodilla*, *el tobillo*

Before you move on

What was *tuber*? (A swelling, a lump.) Which vegetable part is still called one? (A tuber.) And what do *-illo* and *-illa* add? (Smallness.)

Chapter 294

Five More Things You Ask For — Knife, Cup, Pot, Blanket, Broom

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask for a knife, a cup, a pot, a blanket and a broom in Spanish, politely.
>
> *Complete ES-C294-escoba: ask for all five in turn, with por favor on the end of each.*

294.1 el cuchillo — the little blade behind cutlery

Before a new run: what was *tuber*? (A swelling.) And what was *rota*? (A wheel.)

What to know first

- la cuchara — the one that does not cut.
- por favor — what you put on the end when you ask.

Sounds you'll need

- *cu-CHI-llo*, stress in the middle. The *ch* is one sound, as in English *church*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cuchillo — "the knife."
Latin **culter** was a blade; **cultellus** was a small one. Spanish took the small one and forgot the big one, exactly as it did with the onion. English took *culter* by several roads at once. **Cutlery** came through French *coutel*. A **cutlass** is *coutelas*, an oversized one. And the **coulter** on a plough — the blade that cuts the soil ahead of the share — is the bare Latin word, still doing farm work.
You already have *la cuchara*. It looks like a relative of *cuchillo* and is not one: *cuchara* is from **cochlearium**, a snail-shell spoon. Two kitchen words that begin with the same three letters and come from opposite places, which is a useful reminder that resemblance is not evidence.

What you've built

One more thing you can ask for at a meal.
You had *la cuchara* and *el plato* already. Adding *el cuchillo* means you can now ask for the two halves of the job — the thing that cuts and the thing that lifts — with nothing but *por favor* on the end.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cuchillo*
- *un cuchillo, por favor*
- *la cuchara* and *el cuchillo* — near neighbours, unrelated

Before you move on

What was *culter*? (A blade.) What did *cultellus* add? (Smallness.) And is *cuchara* from the same word? (No — it is a snail shell.)

294.2 la taza — a cup that came a very long way

Two back: what was *tuber*? (A swelling.) And what was *cultellus*? (A little blade.)

What to know first

- el vaso — the one you drink cold things from.
- el agua — what goes in either.

Sounds you'll need

- *TA-za*, stress on the first part. The *z* is the *s* sound across most of the Spanish-speaking world. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la taza — "the cup."
Another one with no Latin behind it. Arabic **tassa** brought it into Spain, and Arabic had it from Persian **tašt**, a bowl or a basin. So the word crossed two languages and most of a continent before it reached a Spanish kitchen.
French took the same Arabic word and made **tasse**, which is why a small strong coffee is served in a **demitasse** — a half-cup — in English restaurants that would not otherwise admit to speaking Persian.
Set this beside *el vaso*, which you already have. *Vaso* is Latin **vas**, a vessel, and gives English **vase** and **vascular**. Two drinking containers, sitting side by side in the same cupboard, from two completely different worlds.

What you've built

Two of the five, and both of them ask well.
Un cuchillo, por favor. Una taza, por favor. The polite frame has not changed since you first learned it — you are simply dropping new words into a shape you already trust, which is the cheapest kind of progress there is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la taza*
- *una taza, por favor*
- *el vaso* and *la taza* — Rome and Persia in one cupboard

Before you move on

Which language handed *taza* to Spanish? (Arabic.) And before that? (Persian.) What is a *demitasse*? (A half-cup.)

294.3 la olla — the word that never changed

Before the new one: which language handed *taza* to Spanish? (Arabic.) And what was *culter*? (A blade.)

What to know first

- el arroz — what goes in it.
- la cebolla — and what goes in with it.

Sounds you'll need

- *O-lla*, two beats, stress on the first. The *ll* is the *y* sound; do not let the English *l* creep in. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la olla — "the pot."
There is nothing to take apart. Latin **olla** meant a cooking pot, and two thousand years later Spanish says *olla* and means a cooking pot. Every letter is where the Romans left it.
That is rarer than it sounds, and it tends to happen to the humblest words. Grand Latin words get replaced, borrowed over, or refined into something abstract. A pot stays a pot because people keep needing one.
English does have it, at one remove. The Spanish dish **olla podrida** — literally a rotted pot, meaning a stew of everything — was borrowed into English as **olio**, a mixture. The French translated the name rather than borrowing it, and got **pot pourri**, which is the same two words again and now means a bowl of dried petals.

What you've built

Three, and a small point about how languages age.
El cuchillo shrank, *la taza* travelled, *la olla* sat still. Three words from

one kitchen, and three completely different fates — which is most of what etymology has to teach, in one cupboard.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la olla*
- *el arroz en la olla*
- *el cuchillo*, *la taza*, *la olla*

Before you move on

How much has *olla* changed since Latin? (Nothing at all.) What does *olla podrida* mean literally? (A rotted pot.) And what did French make of it? (*Pot pourri*.)

294.4 la manta — a cloak that lay down

Quick pass: how much has *olla* changed? (Nothing.) Which language gave *taza*? (Arabic.) And what was *cultellus*? (A little blade.)

What to know first

- la cama — where one lives.
- la toalla — the other useful cloth.

Sounds you'll need

- *MAN-ta*, stress on the first part. Two clean beats, and the *n* closes the first. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la manta — "the blanket."
Latin **mantum** was a cloak — something you wore. Spanish kept the cloth and dropped the wearing, so a *manta* is now what goes over a bed rather than over your shoulders.

The cloak is still visible in English. A **mantle** is a cloak, literal or inherited: a bishop's, or a champion's. A **mantelpiece** is the shelf over a fire, named because the hood above the hearth was thought of as its cloak. A **mantilla** is a Spanish lace veil, and there is the small ending again. And a **manta ray** is named for its shape — a swimming cloak, which is the best description of one anybody has managed. Spanish also has *manto* for the cloak proper. So the language kept both: the masculine one stayed a garment, the feminine one lay down on a bed.

What you've built

Four things to ask for, and a whole room implied by them. *El cuchillo*, *la taza*, *la olla*, *la manta*. A kitchen and a bed between them. These are the words you actually need when you are a guest in somebody's house and do not want to rummage.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la manta*
- *una manta, por favor*
- *el cuchillo*, *la taza*, *la olla*, *la manta*

Before you move on

What was *mantum*? (A cloak.) Why is a mantelpiece called that? (The hood over the fire was its cloak.) And why is the manta ray called one? (It is shaped like a swimming cloak.)

294.5 la escoba — the one with no English cousin

Before the last of the five: what was *mantum*? (A cloak.) How much has *olla* changed? (Nothing.) And what was *culter*? (A blade.)

What to know first

- limpio — what this makes a room.
- sucio — what a room is before you use it.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-CO-ba*, stress in the middle. The *e-* step in front of *sc*, and the *b* between vowels is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la escoba — "the broom."
Latin **scopa** was a twig, and **scopae** in the plural was a bundle of them tied to a stick. That is what a broom was, and in much of the world still is.
Take the *e-* off and *scopa* is showing. That is the third time the step has earned its keep in this stretch — a star, a back, and now a broom.
Here is the honest part: this one has no everyday English relative. *Scopa* stayed in Latin and in botany, and English built its own word from the broom plant instead. Most of the words in this book have arrived with a cousin attached, and it is worth meeting one that has not, so that the method does not start to look like magic. Sometimes a word is simply a word, and you learn it.

What you've built

Five: *el cuchillo*, *la taza*, *la olla*, *la manta*, *la escoba*.
Every one of them fits the asking-frame you already had, so the five cost you no grammar whatever. Four came with an English relative and the fifth came without one, which is a fair sample of how the vocabulary of a language is actually distributed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la escoba*
- *una escoba, por favor*
- all five — *el cuchillo*, *la taza*, *la olla*, *la manta*, *la escoba*

Before you move on

What was *scopa*? (A twig, and a bundle of them.) What is the *e-* doing on the front? (Giving the tongue a start before *sc.*) And does this one have an English cousin? (No — and that is worth knowing.)

Chapter 295

The Way Out — Path, Bridge, Shore, Island, Mist

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the path, the bridge, the shore, the island and the mist in Spanish.

Complete ES-C295-niebla: name all five of the way out, from the path to the mist behind you.

295.1 el sendero — a half-sized road

Before a new run: what was *scopa*? (A twig, and a bundle of them.) And what was *mantum*? (A cloak.)

What to know first

- la salida — where one of these begins.
- el bosque — what it usually runs through.

Sounds you'll need

- *sen-DE-ro*, stress in the middle. The *d* between vowels is soft, and the *r* is a single tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el sendero — "the path," "the trail."
Behind it is Latin **semita**, a footpath, and *semita* looks to have been built from **semi-**, half, and a piece meaning going. A footpath was a half-road: narrower than the paved thing the legions marched on, and going somewhere less official.
That *semi-* is the one you already know from **semicircle** and **semifinal**. It is doing exactly the same job here as it does there — halving something — and what it halves in *sendero* is the road itself. Spanish also has *camino* for the larger sort of road. So the language kept the Roman distinction: one word for the way everybody takes, another for the way through the trees.

What you've built

One word, and the start of a way out.
You have had *la salida* since the departure words. A *salida* is where you leave; a *sendero* is what you leave along. The two fit together, and this run is going to keep fitting things onto the end of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el sendero*
- *el sendero del bosque*
- *la salida*, then *el sendero*

Before you move on

What was *semita*? (A footpath.) What does the *semi-* in it mean? (Half.) And what is *el sendero*? (The path.)

295.2 el puente — why the pope is a bridge-builder

Two back: what was *scopa*? (A twig.) And what does the *semi-* in *sendero* mean? (Half.)

What to know first

- el sendero — what this carries across.
- el lago — the sort of thing it goes over.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUEN-te*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide, the same as in *pueblo* and *cuello*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el puente — "the bridge."
Latin **pons**, and in its other form **pontem**. There is the *o*-to-*ue* break for the third time — *pueblo*, *cuello*, and now *puente*. By this point you should be able to predict it.
The English relatives are worth the detour. A **pontoon** is a floating bridge. To **pontificate** is to speak as a **pontiff** does — and *pontifex*, the Roman priestly title the popes inherited, is *pons* plus *facere*: a bridge-maker. Nobody is certain whether the Roman priests literally maintained the bridge over the Tiber or whether the bridge was always a metaphor for the link between people and gods. Both stories have been told for two thousand years.
Spanish also uses *puente* for a long weekend — the days that bridge a holiday to the nearest Saturday. It is the same idea, doing modern work.

What you've built

Two, and the way out now crosses something.
El sendero and *el puente*. You also have the *ue* break confirmed three times over, which means the next unfamiliar Spanish word with *ue* in the middle is probably a Latin *o* you already know in English.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el puente*
- *el sendero y el puente*
- *pueblo*, *cuello*, *puente* — the same break three times

Before you move on

What was *pontem*? (A bridge.) What does *pontifex* mean, taken apart? (Bridge-maker.) And which Latin vowel became *ue*? (Short *o*.)

295.3 la orilla — the sixth little one

Before the new one: what was *pontem*? (A bridge.) And what was *semita*? (A footpath.)

What to know first

- el lago — one thing that has one.
- el puente — what joins two of them.

Sounds you'll need

- *o-RI-lla*, stress in the middle. The *r* between vowels is a single tap, not rolled. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la orilla — "the shore," "the bank," "the edge."
Latin **ora** meant a border or an edge — of a country, of a garment, of the sea. Spanish added the small ending and got *orilla*, "the little edge," and then used it for all three of those things at once.
That breadth is the useful part. The bank of a river is *la orilla*. The shore of a lake is *la orilla*. The hem of a cloth is *la orilla*. One word covers every place where a thing stops being itself, which is a lot of ground for four syllables.
And there is the small ending for the sixth time — an onion, a seed, a knee, an ankle, a knife, and now an edge. Six words with nothing in common except the way they were built. When you meet a new Spanish word ending in *-illa* or *-illo*, take the ending off and look underneath: the plain word is often waiting there, and is often one you already have.

What you've built

Three, and the route now reaches water: *el sendero*, *el puente*, *la orilla*. The diminutive has become a genuine tool rather than a piece of trivia. That is worth more than any single one of the six words that taught it to you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la orilla*
- *la orilla del lago*
- *el sendero*, *el puente*, *la orilla*

Before you move on

What did *ora* mean? (An edge, a border.) Name three things that have *una orilla*. (A river, a lake, a cloth.) And what does *-illa* add? (Smallness.)

295.4 la isla — and the silent letter English added by mistake

Quick pass: what did *ora* mean? (An edge.) What was *pontem*? (A bridge.) And what was *semita*? (A footpath.)

What to know first

- la orilla — what one is entirely made of.
- el agua — what is round it.

Sounds you'll need

- *IS-la*, two beats, stress on the first. The *s* is clean and unvoiced, never a *z* sound. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la isla — "the island."
Latin **insula**, and Spanish simply let the *n* go: *insula*, *isla*. The English words kept it. Something **insular** has an island's outlook. To **isolate** is to make an island of somebody — that one came back through Italian *isolato*. A **peninsula** is *paene insula*, "almost an island." And **insulin** was named for the little islands of cells in the pancreas that produce it.
English **isle** has a stranger history. It came from French *ile*, with no *s* in it and none pronounced. Scholars later inserted the *s* to make the word look more like *insula*, and it has sat there silently ever since. Then the same scholars put an *s* into **island**, which is not from Latin at all and never had one.
So *isla* dropped a letter honestly and *isle* gained one dishonestly, and the two words now look almost the same for opposite reasons.

What you've built

Four, and the way out has run as far as it can go: *el sendero*, *el puente*, *la orilla*, *la isla*.
Path, crossing, edge, and the thing past the edge. Four words that put you somewhere, and the last of them arrived with four English relatives and a spelling scandal attached.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la isla*
- *la orilla de la isla*
- *el sendero*, *el puente*, *la orilla*, *la isla*

Before you move on

What was *insula*? (An island.) What does *peninsula* say, taken apart? (Almost an island.) And why does *isle* have an *s*? (Scholars put it there to imitate Latin.)

295.5 la niebla — the word that was promised

> Before the last of the five: what was *insula*? (An island.) What did *ora* mean? (An edge.) And what was *pontem*? (A bridge.)

What to know first

- la nube — the near-cousin, set aside earlier for this.
- la orilla — where it sits thickest.

Sounds you'll need

- *NIE-bla*, stress on the first part. The *ie* is one slide, and the *b* is soft between the vowel and the *l*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la niebla — "the mist," "the fog."
When *la nube* was taken apart, one word was deliberately left on the shelf: **nebula**, which Latin used for mist as against *nubes* for cloud. This is that word, arrived at last.
The road from *nebula* to *niebla* is short. The short *e* broke into *ie*, as it did in *cielo* and *miel*. The *-bul-* in the middle collapsed to *-bl-*, which Spanish does whenever an unstressed vowel finds itself between two consonants it can be spared from.
English kept *nebula* whole and gave it to astronomy, for the faint clouds between the stars. Something **nebulous** is misty in the figurative sense — an idea you cannot get an edge on. Which is a good word to end a run on, since the whole point of taking words apart is to make them less nebulous than they were.

What you've built

Five: *el sendero*, *el puente*, *la orilla*, *la isla*, *la niebla*.
Read in order they are a way out of a place — the path, the crossing, the water's edge, the land beyond it, and the weather closing in behind you.
This run also shuts a circle. It opened with a cloud and closes with the mist that Latin kept carefully separate from it, and the two words have been waiting for each other since. That is the argument for taking a word apart rather than memorising it: the pieces you find keep turning

up, and they keep paying.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la niebla*
- *la nube*, then *la niebla* — the cloud and the mist
- all five — *el sendero*, *el puente*, *la orilla*, *la isla*, *la niebla*

Before you move on

What was *nebula*, as against *nubes*? (Mist, not cloud.) What did the short *e* become? (*Ie.*) And what does *nebulous* mean? (Misty — an idea with no clear edge.)

Chapter 296

Animals About the House — Horse, Cow, Sheep, Hen, Donkey

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the horse, the cow, the sheep, the hen and the donkey in Spanish.
>
> *Complete ES-C296-burro: name all five animals in order, and say which one English took back off Spanish.*

296.1 el caballo — the plodder that won

> Before a new run: what was *insula*? (An island.) And what did *nebula* mean, as against *nubes*? (Mist, not cloud.)

What to know first

- perro — an animal you have had for a long time.
- gato — the other one.

Sounds you'll need

- *ca-BA-llo*, stress in the middle. The *b* is soft between vowels, and the *ll* is the *y* of *llueve*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el caballo — "the horse."
Latin had two words for the animal. **Equus** was the horse of poetry and of the cavalry parade. **Caballus** was the other one: a plodding, thick-legged work-horse, close to "nag." Educated Romans wrote *equus*. And *caballus* is the one that survived. Not just in Spanish — French *cheval*, Italian *cavallo*, Portuguese *cavalo*. The polite word went into the museum and the stable word went into every mouth in western Europe.
English is full of the plodder without knowing it. **Cavalry** is soldiers on *caballi*. A **cavalier** was one of them. And **chivalry** is the same word again, worn down through French — so the most elevated idea the Middle Ages had is named after a nag.

What you've built

One animal, and a rule of thumb worth more than the animal. When Latin had a grand word and a plain word for the same thing, bet on the plain one. That is what people actually said, and what people actually said is what became Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el caballo*
- *el caballo* and *el perro*, one after the other
- *el caballo del pueblo*

Before you move on

Which Latin word won, *equus* or *caballus*? (*Caballus.*) What kind of horse was it? (A plain work-horse.) And which English word for soldiers on horseback holds it? (*Cavalry.*)

296.2 la vaca — the animal inside a medical word

Two back: what did *nebula* name? (The mist.) And which Latin horse won, the grand one or the plain one? (The plain

one, *caballus*.)

What to know first

- el caballo — the animal before this one.
- el queso — what this one is behind.

Sounds you'll need

- *VA-ca*, stress on the first part. The *v* is the same sound as *b*, and the *c* before *a* is hard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la vaca — "the cow."
There is almost nothing to take apart. Latin **vacca**, Spanish *vaca*: one consonant thinned and the rest left alone. Some words travel two thousand years and arrive with their hat still on.
The interesting part is in English. In the seventeen-nineties Edward Jenner noticed that dairymaids who had caught cowpox did not catch smallpox, and he built a treatment on it. He named it from **vaccinus**, Latin for "of the cow" — so **vaccine**, and every vaccine since, is named after this animal.
Nothing about a modern vaccine involves a cow. The name is a fossil of the first one, in the way *la salida* is a fossil of somebody actually going out.

What you've built

Two animals, and a word English uses every day without knowing whose it is.
El caballo is the plodder who beat the parade horse. *La vaca* is the one who arrived unchanged and lent her name to medicine.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la vaca*
- *el caballo*, then *la vaca*
- *la vaca del valle*

Before you move on

What was *vacca*? (A cow.) What does *vaccinus* mean? (Of the cow.) And why is a vaccine called that? (The first one came from cowpox.)

296.3 la oveja — the small one that ate the big one

What kind of horse was a *caballus*? (A plain work-horse.) And what is *vaccinus*? (Of the cow.)

What to know first

- la vaca — the animal before this one.
- la manta — often made of what this animal grows.

Sounds you'll need

- *o-VE-ja*, stress in the middle. The *j* is the scrape at the back of the mouth, the *jota*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la oveja — "the sheep."
Latin's word was **ovis**. Alongside it people used **ovicula**, with the ending that makes a thing small and fond — the ancestor of the *-illo* and *-ito* you can hear all over Spanish. *Ovicula* meant something like "little sheep."
Then the odd thing. *Ovis* died out completely, and the small fond version took over the whole job. Spanish has no word left that means "sheep, full size, unsentimentally." Every sheep is a little one now.
That happens more often than you would think. Latin **auricula**, a little ear, gave French *oreille* and Spanish *oreja* by exactly the same road — which is why *oveja* and *oreja* rhyme. The plain word for ear went the way of *ovis*.
The English cousin stayed formal: **ovine** means "of sheep," and it comes straight from *ovis*, the word Spanish threw away.

What you've built

Three animals, and a second rule to sit beside the first.
The plain word does not always win by staying plain. Sometimes it wins by shrinking: the affectionate version gets said so often that it stops sounding affectionate and simply becomes the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la oveja*
- *la vaca*, then *la oveja*
- all three — *el caballo*, *la vaca*, *la oveja*

Before you move on

What was *ovis*? (A sheep.) What did the *-icula* ending do to it? (Made it small and fond.) And which of the two survived into Spanish? (The small one.)

296.4 la gallina — the bird that is also an insult

> Three questions. Which horse won? (The plain one.) What is *vaccinus*? (Of the cow.) And what did *-icula* do to *ovis*? (Made it small.)

What to know first

- la oveja — the animal before this one.
- el huevo — what this one leaves you.

Sounds you'll need

- *ga-LLI-na*, stress in the middle. The *g* before *a* is hard, and the *ll* is a *y*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la gallina — "the hen."
Latin **gallus** was the cock, and **gallina** was made from it with the ending that marks the female. The pair came through intact: Spanish still has *gallo* for the one and *gallina* for the other.
English keeps *gallina* only in its Sunday clothes. **Gallinaceous** is what a zoologist calls the whole family of birds that scratch about on the ground — hens, pheasants, turkeys. Nobody says it at breakfast.
The part worth having is not the bird. In Spanish, *ser un gallina* — to be a hen — means to be a coward. English says **chicken** for exactly the same thing, and neither language borrowed the idea from the other. Two peoples watched the same animal and reached the same unkind conclusion.

What you've built

Four animals, and the first of them that carries an opinion.
El caballo, *la vaca* and *la oveja* are only themselves. *La gallina* is also a judgement about somebody, which makes it the first of the four you could be insulted with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la gallina*
- *la oveja*, then *la gallina*
- all four — *el caballo*, *la vaca*, *la oveja*, *la gallina*

Before you move on

What was *gallus*? (The cock.) What does *gallinaceous* describe? (The whole ground-scratching family of birds.) And what does calling somebody *un gallina* mean? (That they are a coward.)

296.5 el burro — the one English took whole

Before the last of the five: which horse won, the grand one or the plain one? (The plain one.) What was *ovis*? (A sheep.) And

what does *un gallina* call somebody? (A coward.)

What to know first

- el caballo — what this one is the small, stubborn version of.
- la gallina — the animal before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *BU-rro*, stress on the first part. The *rr* is a full roll, not a single tap — the difference is real and it is the only difference here. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el burro — "the donkey."
Behind it is late Latin **burricus**, a small horse, and behind that **burrus**, "reddish" — the colour of the animal, borrowed by Latin from Greek. So a donkey is, quite literally, a little red horse. Which puts it in the same family as *el caballo*, at a distance and going downhill.
Now the direction reverses. English did not inherit this word; it **borrowed** it, from Spanish speakers in the American southwest, and it borrowed it whole: **burro**, spelled and said the Spanish way. And then it borrowed the small version too. A **burrito** is a little donkey — nobody is certain why the food took the name, but the name is not a mystery at all once you have *burro*.
That *-ito* is the same ending you met flattening *ovis* into *oveja*, still at work and still making things small.

What you've built

Five: *el caballo*, *la vaca*, *la oveja*, *la gallina*, *el burro*.
Read in order they are a farmyard, and they arrived by four different routes: a word that beat its own posh rival, a word that barely changed, a word that only survived by shrinking, a pair kept together, and a word English took back off Spanish long after Latin had finished with it.
Traffic in words is not one-way, and this run ends on the one going the other direction.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el burro*
- *el caballo*, then *el burro* — the horse and the little red one
- all five — *el caballo*, *la vaca*, *la oveja*, *la gallina*, *el burro*

Before you move on

What did *burrus* mean? (Reddish.) Which language took *burro* from which? (English took it from Spanish.) And what is a *burrito*, taken literally? (A little donkey.)

Chapter 297

More of the Kitchen — Pan, Oven, Fork, Garlic, Soup

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the pan, the oven, the fork, the garlic and the soup in Spanish, and thank somebody for the meal.

Complete ES-C297-sopa: name all five of the kitchen in order and thank somebody for what came out of it.

297.1 la sartén — the accent that is a receipt

Before a new run: what does *un gallina* call somebody? (A coward.) And what did *burrus* mean? (Reddish.)

What to know first

- la olla — the deep one you already have.
- el plato — where the food ends up.

Sounds you'll need

- *sar-TÉN*, stress on the very end, which is what the written accent is telling you. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sartén — "the frying pan," the shallow one you fry in.
Latin **sartago** was already exactly that, and the Romans already fried in it. The word came down through the sideways form *sartaginem*, which is where the *-n* on the end comes from.
The accent is the part worth stopping on. Spanish only writes one when the stress falls somewhere the default rules would not put it, so an accent is never decoration — it is a receipt. A word ending in *-n* is expected to be stressed on the part before last. *Sartén* is not, so it must say so.
Now make it plural and watch the receipt get handed back: *sartenes* ends in *-s* and is stressed on the part before last, which is exactly what the rules already predict. No accent needed, so no accent written. The mark did not move; the reason for it disappeared.

What you've built

A pan, and a small piece of proof that the accents are not arbitrary. If you can say why *sartén* wears one and *sartenes* does not, you can predict the mark on most words you meet rather than memorising it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sartén*
- *la sartén*, then *las sartenes* — hear the stress stay put
- *la olla*, then *la sartén*

Before you move on

What was *sartago*? (A frying pan.) Why does *sartén* wear an accent? (Because the stress is final and a word ending in *-n* would not be.) And why does *sartenes* not? (The rules already predict its stress.)

297.2 el horno — an f buried under an h

Two back: what is a *burrito*, taken literally? (A little donkey.) And why does *sartén* carry an accent? (Its stress is final, against the rule.)

What to know first

- f → h — the change this word is a specimen of.
- la sartén — the shallow one, from just before.

Sounds you'll need

- *OR-no*, stress on the first part. The *h* is written and not said, which is the whole point of it. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el horno — "the oven."
Latin **furnus**, an oven or a bakehouse. You already know what happened to the *f-*: it thinned to a breathy sound, the breath faded, and Spanish went on writing the letter over the empty space. *Furnus* to *forno* to *horno*.
So the *h* is a headstone. Say *OR-no* and you are saying the word correctly; the letter is there to tell you what used to be.
English took the same Latin word later and by a different door, straight out of the books, so it never got worn down: a **furnace** still has its *f*, and so does the older sense of **furnish** — to supply, as a bakehouse supplies bread.
One more thing you can now do. Meet an unfamiliar Spanish word beginning with a silent *h*, put an *f* back on the front, and see whether a Latin or English word falls out. It works often enough to be worth trying every time.

What you've built

Two of the kitchen, and a decoder you can run on strangers.
La sartén explained a mark you can see. *El horno* explains a letter you cannot hear. Both are the same lesson: written Spanish keeps records, and the records are readable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el horno*
- *la sartén*, then *el horno*
- *el pan del horno*

Before you move on

What was *furnus*? (An oven.) What is the *h* in *horno* marking? (An *f* that wore away.) And which English word kept the *f*? (*Furnace.*)

297.3 el tenedor — a word you can build yourself

What was *sartago*? (A frying pan.) And what letter is hiding under the *h* of *horno*? (An *f*.)

What to know first

- tener — the word this one is built out of.
- la cuchara — the one you already ask for.

Sounds you'll need

- *te-ne-DOR*, stress on the very end. No accent is written, because a word ending in *-r* is expected to be stressed there. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tenedor — "the fork."
This one you can almost assemble from parts you own. Take *tener*, to hold. Add **-dor**, the ending that names whoever or whatever does the thing. A *tenedor* is "a holder" — which is a very level-headed description of the object, once you stop seeing a fork and start seeing four prongs gripping a piece of meat.
The ending is everywhere once you look. A *comedor* is where the eating is done. A *mirador* is a place for looking out. English has the very same ending twice over — **-or** in *inventor*, *conductor*, and its

plainer cousin **-er** in *holder* itself — because both descend from the same Latin.
Notice what that buys you. *Tenedor* is not a word to memorise; it is a word to work out, and so is the next one built the same way.

What you've built

Three of the kitchen, and the first of them you could have predicted. A pan is a pan and an oven is an oven. A *tenedor* is a machine for holding, named by exactly that, and *la cuchara* lying next to it is now the one word of the pair that has to be remembered rather than deduced.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tenedor*
- *la cuchara* and *el tenedor*, one after the other
- *el tenedor, por favor*

Before you move on

What does *tener* mean? (To hold, to have.) What does the ending *-dor* add? (The one who does it.) So what is a *tenedor*, literally? (A holder.)

297.4 el ajo — two letters, a long history

Three questions. Why does *sartén* wear an accent? (Final stress, against the rule.) What is under the *h* of *horno*? (An *f*.) And what is a *tenedor*, literally? (A holder.)

What to know first

- la cebolla — what it usually goes in the pan with.
- la sartén — the pan in question.

Sounds you'll need

- *A-jo*, two beats and no more. The *j* is the scrape at the back, the *jota*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el ajo — "the garlic."
Latin **allium**. Three syllables have been squeezed down to two letters and a scrape, and yet the road is short: *allium* to *aljo* to *ajo*, with the doubled *l* hardening into the *jota* on the way, exactly as it did in *hijo* from *filium*.
English kept *allium* whole and handed it to the botanists, so the family that holds garlic, onions and leeks is the **allium** family on any seed packet.
The best cousin is on a menu. **Aioli** is Provençal *ai* plus *oli*: garlic and oil, which is the entire recipe stated in the name. Say *ajo* and you are saying the first half of a sauce you already know.

What you've built

Four of the kitchen, and the shortest word of the run carrying the longest history.
La cebolla and *el ajo* go into *la sartén* together in more Spanish cooking than any two other things. You can now name the pan, the fire, the tool and half the contents.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el ajo*
- *el ajo y la cebolla*
- all four — *la sartén*, *el horno*, *el tenedor*, *el ajo*

Before you move on

What was *allium*? (Garlic.) Where does English still use the whole word? (As the botanical family name.) And what two things is *aioli* named after? (Garlic and oil.)

297.5 la sopa — the bread, not the liquid

> Before the last of the five: what does the ending *-dor* add? (The one who does it.) What letter hides under an *h*? (An *f*.) And what was *allium*? (Garlic.)

What to know first

- el pan — what this word originally meant.
- la cuchara — what you eat it with.

Sounds you'll need

- *SO-pa*, stress on the first part. The *s* is clean and never buzzes. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sopa — "the soup."
This one is not Latin. It came from the Germanic speakers who arrived as Rome went out, and their **suppa** did not mean the liquid at all. It meant the piece of bread you dropped into the liquid.
That is the older meal, and the honest one: broth was cheap and bread was the food. The name travelled with the bread and only later slid across to what the bread was floating in.
English has the whole family, and the same slide. A **sop** is still a bit of bread dipped in something. To **sup** is to take it, and **supper** is the meal where you did. **Soup** itself came back into English through French — the same Germanic word, one lap later.
So *el pan* is not merely something you eat with *la sopa*. It is what *la sopa* used to be.

What you've built

Five: *la sartén*, *el horno*, *el tenedor*, *el ajo*, *la sopa*.
A pan, a fire, a tool, a flavour and a dish — enough to describe most of what happens in a kitchen before anybody sits down. And when somebody puts it in front of you, *mil gracias* is the size of thanks it deserves.
The five arrived by five different roads: a Latin pan, a Latin oven with its letter worn off, a word Spanish built for itself, a Latin plant, and a

Germanic crust. That is the mix Spanish is actually made of, in one meal.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sopa*
- *la sopa, mil gracias*
- all five — *la sartén*, *el horno*, *el tenedor*, *el ajo*, *la sopa*

Before you move on

What did *suppa* mean first — the bread or the broth? (The bread.) Which English meal is named from it? (*Supper.*) And what is *la sopa*? (The soup.)

Chapter 298

Five More Short Answers — Maybe, Could Be, Indeed, No Doubt, Out of the Question

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can answer someone in Spanish anywhere from maybe to out of the question, and say how strong each answer is.
>
> *Complete ES-C298-ni-hablar: give all five answers in order, from the weakest to the flattest.*

298.1 tal vez — such a turn

> Before a new run: what was *allium*? (Garlic.) And did *suppa* mean the bread or the broth? (The bread.)

What to know first

- quizás — the other way to say this, which you already have.
- de acuerdo — the answer at the opposite end.

Sounds you'll need

- *tal VEZ*, with the weight on the second word. The *v* is a *b*, and the *z* is a plain *s* in most of the Spanish-speaking world. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tal vez — "maybe," "perhaps."
Two pieces. *Tal* means "such," and *vez* is Latin **vicem**: a turn, a going round, one occasion out of several. So *tal vez* is "such a turn" — this time it might fall this way, another time it might not.
Vicem is generous to English. **Vice versa** is "the turn having been turned." A **vicar** stands in someone's turn, and so does a **vice-president**. **Vicissitude** is life doing the turning without asking you.
You already have *quizás* for the same job. The difference is small but real: *quizás* leans on not knowing, and *tal vez* leans on it happening to fall out that way. Either answers a question you cannot answer.

What you've built

The first of five answers, and the least committed of them.
The run ahead is a dial. It starts here, at "possibly," and ends somewhere you would not want to point at a stranger.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tal vez*
- *quizás*, then *tal vez*
- *tal vez mañana*

Before you move on

What did *vicem* mean? (A turn, an occasion.) What is *vice versa*, taken literally? (The turn turned round.) And what does *tal vez* answer? (Maybe.)

298.2 puede ser — nothing new in it

Two back: what did *suppa* mean? (The soaked bread.) And what does *vicem* mean inside *tal vez*? (A turn, an occasion.)

What to know first

- poder — the first half.
- ser — the second.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUE-de SER*, two beats then one. The *ue* is a single slide, not two steps. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

puede ser — "could be," "it may be so."
There is nothing here you do not already own. *Poder*, to be able, with its stressed *o* cracking open into *ue* the way it always does. *Ser*, to be. Put them together and you have said "it is able to be," which is a very exact description of what "maybe" actually claims.
That is worth noticing on its own. Some of the most useful things you can say in a language are not new material at all — they are two familiar pieces standing in the right order, and the only thing you were missing was permission to put them there.
Against *tal vez*, this one is warmer. *Tal vez* is a shrug at the odds. *Puede ser* concedes that the other person might be right, which is why it so often comes just before somebody changes their mind.

What you've built

Two answers, and a way of getting more of them free.
Every time you learn a piece, you also learn every combination that piece can stand in. *Puede ser* costs you nothing but the knowledge that Spanish speakers say it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *puede ser*
- *tal vez*, then *puede ser*
- *puede ser, no sé*

Before you move on

Which two pieces make *puede ser*? (*Poder* and *ser*.) What happens to the *o* of *poder* under stress? (It breaks into *ue*.) And which of the two answers so far concedes the most? (*Puede ser*.)

298.3 en efecto — a false friend with a warning on it

What does *tal vez* answer? (Maybe.) And which two pieces make *puede ser*? (*Poder* and *ser*.)

What to know first

- exacto — the answer this one stands next to.
- hacer — the doing that sits inside it.

Sounds you'll need

- *en e-FEC-to*, stress on the third beat. The *c* before *t* is a hard *k*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en efecto — "indeed," "quite so."
Efecto is Latin **effectus**: *ex*, out, and *facere*, to do — a thing carried out and finished. The same *facere* you have been meeting inside *hacer* since early on.
Now the warning. English **in effect** looks like the same phrase letter for letter, and it is not. *In effect* means "for practical purposes, though not formally" — it softens a claim. *En efecto* hardens one: it says the thing someone just told you is so.
That is what makes it worth having. *Exacto* agrees with a statement's precision. *En efecto* agrees with the fact of it, and it is the one you will hear from somebody reading a document out loud and finding it says what you claimed.
Two words that look identical and pull in opposite directions is the most expensive kind of pair there is, because nothing warns you. This one is warned.

What you've built

Three answers, and the dial has turned. *Tal vez* is a shrug, *puede ser* is a concession, and *en efecto* is agreement with the evidence in hand.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en efecto*
- *exacto*, then *en efecto*
- all three — *tal vez*, *puede ser*, *en efecto*

Before you move on

What two pieces are in *effectus*? (*Ex*, out, and *facere*, to do.) Does *en efecto* soften a claim or confirm one? (It confirms it.) And what does English *in effect* do instead? (It softens.)

298.4 sin duda — caught between two

Three answers so far. Which is the shrug? (*Tal vez.*) Which concedes? (*Puede ser.*) And which confirms? (*En efecto.*)

What to know first

- seguro — the answer nearest to this one.
- en efecto — the answer just before it.

Sounds you'll need

- *sin DU-da*, weight on the second word. Both *d* sounds are soft, the tongue barely touching. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sin duda — "no doubt," "certainly."
Duda comes from Latin **dubitare**, to waver, and *dubitare* is built on **duo**, two. To doubt is to have two answers in front of you and no way

to pick. That is a much better picture of the state than the English word gives you.
The same *duo* is all over English. **Dubious**, obviously. **Double**, less obviously. And **doubt** itself, which came through French as *doute* with no *b* in it at all — the *b* was inserted centuries later by scholars who wanted the Latin visible. English still writes it and still does not say it, which is exactly what Spanish does with the *h* of *horno*.
So *sin duda* is "without the two": there is only one answer available, and this is it.

What you've built

Four answers, and the dial is near its top. *Sin duda* is stronger than *en efecto*, because *en efecto* agrees with what was said and *sin duda* says there was never anything else to agree with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sin duda*
- *seguro*, then *sin duda*
- all four — *tal vez*, *puede ser*, *en efecto*, *sin duda*

Before you move on

What number is inside *dubitare*? (Two.) Why does English write a *b* in *doubt*? (Scholars put it back to show the Latin.) And how strong is *sin duda*? (Very — there is no second answer.)

298.5 ni hablar — not even that

Before the last of the five: which answer is the shrug? (*Tal vez.*) What is inside *dubitare*? (*Duo*, two.) And does *en efecto* soften or confirm? (It confirms.)

What to know first

- ni — the first half, which you have had for a long time.
- hablar — the second.

Sounds you'll need

- *ni a-BLAR*, and the *h* is silent, so the two words run straight into each other. The *r* at the end is one tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ni hablar — "out of the question," "no chance."
Again, nothing new. *Ni* is "nor, not even." *Hablar* is to speak. Together: "not even speaking of it." The refusal is not of the request — it is of the conversation about the request, which is a good deal more final.
English has the same manoeuvre in **out of the question** and in **don't even**. None of these say no to the thing; they say the thing is not eligible to be discussed, and that is why they close a subject where a plain no would only invite another round.
A caution. This is flat, and among strangers it can be rude. With friends it is ordinary, and often affectionate — the way English *don't even* can be. Keep *no, gracias* for people you have just met.

What you've built

Five: *tal vez*, *puede ser*, *en efecto*, *sin duda*, *ni hablar*.
Read in order they are a dial that runs from "possibly" through "yes, evidently" to "we are not discussing this." Two of the five you built out of pieces you already owned, and one of them warned you about a word that looks like English and is not.
Answers are cheap to learn and dear to get wrong. Knowing which end of this dial you are standing on matters more than any single one of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ni hablar*

- *sin duda*, then *ni hablar* — the two ends
- all five — *tal vez*, *puede ser*, *en efecto*, *sin duda*, *ni hablar*

Before you move on

What does *ni hablar* refuse — the request, or the conversation? (The conversation.) Which two words is it made of? (*Ni* and *hablar*.) And which of the five would you use with somebody you had just met? (Not this one.)

Chapter 299

The Field and the Farm — Field, Farm, Livestock, Harvest, Shepherd

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the field, the farm, the livestock, the harvest and the shepherd in Spanish, and say I am from the country.
>
> *Complete ES-C299-pastor: name all five of a holding in order, and say what three of them were named after.*

299.1 el campo — flat ground, and everything pitched on it

> Before a new run: what is inside *dubitare*? (*Duo*, two.) And what does *ni hablar* refuse? (The conversation, not just the request.)

What to know first

- el pueblo — what usually sits in the middle of it.
- el valle — the shape of the land it lies in.

Sounds you'll need

- *CAM-po*, stress on the first part. The *c* before *a* is hard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el campo — "the field," and also "the countryside," everything that is not the town.
Latin **campus** meant flat open ground — not a farmer's field particularly, just level land with nothing on it. Which is precisely why so much got pitched there.
An army stopped on flat ground, so a **camp** is one. A season of fighting was spent out on it, so a **campaign** is one. Whoever fought for a village in single combat was its *campio*, the man of the field, which is English **champion**. And when American colleges wanted a word for their grounds, they took **campus** back whole and unchanged. So the same flat ground gave English a tent, a war, a hero and a university. And it gave Spanish the word for everywhere that is not a town: *vivo en el campo* means you live out there, among the fields, whether or not you farm.

What you've built

The ground itself, before anything is put on it.
El pueblo is where people are; *el campo* is what surrounds it. Between them you can already say roughly where somebody is from, which is most of what that question ever wants.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el campo*
- *el pueblo*, then *el campo*
- *soy del campo*

Before you move on

What did *campus* mean? (Flat open ground.) What was a *campio*? (The man who fought on it — a champion.) And what does *el campo* mean besides a field? (The countryside.)

299.2 la granja — a building named after what is in it

Two back: what does *ni hablar* refuse? (The conversation.) And what did *campus* mean? (Flat open ground.)

What to know first

- el trigo — what this building was built to hold.
- el campo — the ground it stands on.

Sounds you'll need

- *GRAN-ja*, stress on the first part. The *g* is hard, and the *j* is the scrape. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la granja — "the farm."
Behind it is Latin **granum**, the grain — the same grain you met being rubbed out of its husk in *el trigo*. A *granja* began as the building where that grain was kept, and then the name spread outwards over the yard, the animals and the whole holding.
English has the identical building twice. A **granary** is where the grain goes. A **grange** is the farmhouse that grew up around one, which is why so many English villages have a Grange in them and nobody remembers why.
This is a common way for names to work. The store gives its name to the farm, the way *la sopa* took its name from the bread rather than the broth. The thing you kept was more worth naming than the place you kept it.

What you've built

The ground and now the buildings on it.
You have had *el trigo* for a while as something that grows. *La granja* is where it stops being a crop and starts being a store, and *el campo* is the flat land both of them sit on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la granja*
- *el campo*, then *la granja*
- *el trigo de la granja*

Before you move on

What is *granum*? (The grain.) What was a *granja* before it was a farm? (The place the grain was stored.) And which English farmhouse is the same word? (A grange.)

299.3 el ganado — the animals as a bank account

What did *campus* mean? (Flat open ground.) And what was a *granja* before it was a farm? (Where the grain was stored.)

What to know first

- la vaca — one of these, counted singly.
- el dinero — what this word is really about.

Sounds you'll need

- *ga-NA-do*, stress in the middle. The *g* is hard and the *d* between vowels is soft, almost a *th*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el ganado — "the livestock," the animals of a farm taken together. It is built on *ganar*, to gain or to win, and it means, quite plainly, "what has been gained." Not the beasts as creatures. The beasts as the thing you have got.

English did exactly the same and hid it better. **Cattle** and **chattel** are one word split in two, both from Latin *capitalis*, "of the head" — property counted by the head. And *capitalis* also gave **capital**, the money sense. So in English, as in Spanish, the herd and the fortune are the same idea.

That is why *el ganado* covers cows and sheep and pigs without distinction. It is not a word about animals at all. It is a word about wealth that happens to walk around.

What you've built

Ground, buildings, and now the animals — and the animals turn out to be an account.

La vaca is one cow. *El ganado* is the whole herd seen from the ledger, which is how a farmer in any century has actually seen it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el ganado*
- *la granja*, then *el ganado*
- *el ganado del campo*

Before you move on

What does *ganar* mean? (To gain, to win.) So what is *el ganado* literally? (What has been gained.) And which English word for money comes from counting animals by the head? (*Capital.*)

299.4 la cosecha — a root you have met before

Three questions. What did *campus* mean? (Flat open ground.) What is *granum*? (Grain.) And what is *el ganado*, literally?

(What has been gained.)

What to know first

- tomar — where you first took *colligere* apart.
- la semilla — where this ends up starting again.

Sounds you'll need

- *co-SE-cha*, stress in the middle. The *ch* is one sound, as in English *church*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cosecha — "the harvest," both the gathering and the crop gathered.
You have already done the hard part of this one. When *tomar* was taken apart, the word Latin actually left behind turned out to be *coger*, from **colligere** — *com-*, together, and *legere*, to pick. That is where **collect** comes from, and **coil**, and the *leer* you read with.
Cosecha is the same word wearing its finished-and-done form: **collecta**, "the gathered-in." So the harvest is not named for cutting or for work. It is named for the picking-up afterwards, which is the part that counts.
One use worth knowing. On a wine label, *una buena cosecha* is a good vintage — English does the same thing, since a **vintage** is only a harvest with a year attached to it.

What you've built

Four of the farm, and one of them cost you almost nothing.
Colligere was already in your hands. All that was new here was which shape it takes when the picking is over, and now the same root is doing work in three places at once.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cosecha*
- *la granja* and *la cosecha*, one after the other

- all four — *el campo*, *la granja*, *el ganado*, *la cosecha*

Before you move on

Which two pieces are in *colligere*? (*Com-*, together, and *legere*, to pick.) Which English word is it most plainly? (*Collect.*) And what does *una buena cosecha* mean on a bottle? (A good vintage.)

299.5 el pastor — the one who feeds

Before the last of the five: what did *campus* mean? (Flat open ground.) What is *el ganado* literally? (What has been gained.) And which two pieces are in *colligere*? (*Com-* and *legere.*)

What to know first

- la oveja — what this person walks behind.
- el maestro — another person named for what they do.

Sounds you'll need

- *pas-TOR*, stress on the end, and no accent needed because a word ending in *-r* is expected there. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pastor — "the shepherd."
Latin **pascere** meant to put animals out to feed, and *pastor* was the one who did it. Note what is not in the word: nothing about sheep, nothing about walking, nothing about a crook. Only the feeding.
That single idea fans out a long way in English. A **pasture** is the ground the animals are fed on. A **repast** is a meal — a feeding, taken again. And a **pastor** in a church is a shepherd of people, a metaphor so old it has stopped sounding like one.
The ending is the *-or* you met on *el tenedor*: the one who does the thing. So *pastor* parses as neatly as *tenedor* did, once you know that the thing being done is feeding.

What you've built

Five: *el campo*, *la granja*, *el ganado*, *la cosecha*, *el pastor*.
Read in order they are a whole holding: the ground, the buildings, the animals, what comes off the land, and the person who keeps it moving.
Say *soy del campo* and every one of them is behind the sentence.
And three of the five were named for something other than themselves — a farm for its grain, a herd for its value, a harvest for the gathering.
Spanish names things by what they are for. Once you expect that, half the words explain themselves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pastor*
- *el pastor y la oveja*
- all five — *el campo*, *la granja*, *el ganado*, *la cosecha*, *el pastor*

Before you move on

What did *pascere* mean? (To put out to feed.) What is a *repast*, at root? (A feeding again — a meal.) And why is a churchman called a pastor? (He is a shepherd of people.)

Chapter 300

What the Body Says — Thirst, Sleep, Skin, Blood, Remedy

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say in Spanish that I am thirsty or sleepy, name the skin and the blood, and say there is no remedy.

Complete ES-C300-remedio: name all five, and put three of them into a sentence with tengo or no hay.

300.1 la sed — something you hold, not something you are

Before a new run: what does *una buena cosecha* mean on a bottle? (A good vintage.) And what did *pascere* mean? (To put out to feed.)

What to know first

- beber — what this sends you to do.
- tener — the word Spanish uses to report it.

Sounds you'll need

- *SED*, one beat, and the final *d* is barely there — closer to a soft *th* than to an English *d*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sed — "the thirst."
Latin **sitis**, worn short. English inherited nothing usable from it, which is rarer than it sounds — most of the body words you have met arrived with a cousin in tow, and this one comes empty-handed.
The interesting part is not where it came from but how Spanish uses it. English says *I am thirsty*, as though thirst were a description of you. Spanish says **tengo sed** — "I have thirst," as though it were a thing in your hands that you could put down.
Once you notice, it is everywhere: *tengo hambre*, *tengo frío*, *tengo miedo*. Spanish keeps handing you the sensation as an object. English keeps turning it into a description of the person, which quietly makes it more permanent than it is.
Neither is right. But if you say *estoy sed*, a Spanish speaker will hear something ungrammatical, and this is the reason.

What you've built

One word, and a habit that will serve you for a dozen more.
When you want to report how your body is, reach for *tengo* first and look for the thing you are holding. That is the Spanish shape.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sed*
- *tengo sed*
- *tengo sed, agua por favor*

Before you move on

What was *sitis*? (Thirst.) Does Spanish say you are thirsty or that you have thirst? (That you have it.) And what is the whole sentence? (*Tengo sed.*)

300.2 el sueño — one word for two things

> Two back: what did *pascere* mean? (To put out to feed.) And does Spanish say you are thirsty, or that you have thirst? (That you have it.)

What to know first

- dormir — the doing; this is the having.
- la cama — where both happen.

Sounds you'll need

- *SUE-ño*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide, and the *ñ* is the *n* with a *y* leaning on it. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el sueño — "sleep," and also "a dream."
Latin **somnus**, sleep. The stressed *o* cracked open into *ue*, exactly as it did turning *dormir* into *duermo* and *porta* into *puerta*. Once that crack is familiar you can run it backwards: see *ue* in a Spanish word, put an *o* back, and look for the Latin.
Do it here and *somnus* appears — and with it **insomnia**, which is *in-*, not, plus sleep; **somnolent**, heavy with it; and a **somnambulist**, who walks in it.
The double meaning is worth a moment. *El sueño* is the sleep and the dream at once, and Spanish is content to leave them together. *Tengo sueño* is "I am sleepy" — you are holding sleep, in the way you hold thirst. *Tuve un sueño* is "I had a dream." Same word, and the difference sits in everything around it.

What you've built

Two of the body, both of them things you hold rather than things you are.
You have had *dormir* for the act since early on. *El sueño* is what the act is made of, and what it leaves behind in the morning.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el sueño*
- *tengo sueño*
- *tengo sed*, then *tengo sueño*

Before you move on

What was *somnus*? (Sleep.) What happened to its stressed *o*? (It broke into *ue*.) And what two things does *el sueño* name? (Sleep and a dream.)

300.3 la piel — the hide you are wearing

What is the Spanish shape for thirst? (*Tengo sed* — you have it.) And what happened to the *o* of *somnus*? (It broke into *ue*.)

What to know first

- la mano — one of the places you can see it best.
- la oveja — an animal people keep partly for hers.

Sounds you'll need

- *PIEL*, one beat. The *ie* is a single slide and the *l* stays bright at the end. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la piel — "the skin."
Latin **pellis** was a hide — an animal's, taken off. The stressed *e* broke into *ie*, the same crack you have watched in *cielo* and *miel*, and the word came out meaning the skin you are still standing in.
That is worth sitting with. Spanish uses one word for the skin on your arm and the skin a coat is made of. *Una chaqueta de piel* is a leather jacket. Latin drew no line there either, and English mostly does: **skin** for the living one, **hide** and **pelt** for the dead.
Pelt is *pellis* itself, arrived through French. And the strangest cousin is in a church: a **surplice** is *super-pellicium*, the white linen worn **over** the fur coat, because medieval choirs were cold. The garment is named entirely for what is underneath it.

What you've built

Three of the body, and the second one whose *ie* you could have predicted.
Cielo, *miel*, *piel*: three words, one crack, and it always runs the same way. Put an *e* back where the *ie* is and the Latin will usually show itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la piel*
- *la piel de la mano*
- *el sueño*, then *la piel*

Before you move on

What was *pellis*? (A hide.) Which English word is it, almost untouched? (*Pelt.*) And what is a surplice worn over? (A fur coat.)

300.4 la sangre — a word that used to be a diagnosis

Three questions. What was *sitis*? (Thirst.) What was *somnus*? (Sleep.) And what was *pellis*? (A hide.)

What to know first

- el vaso — the word for a vessel, which the body has its own set of.
- la piel — what keeps this one where it belongs.

Sounds you'll need

- *SAN-gre*, stress on the first part. The *g* is hard and the *r* is a single tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sangre — "the blood."
Latin **sanguis**, and through its sideways form **sanguinem**, which is where the *-re* on the end comes from. The road is short and the meaning never moved.
English took the same word and did something odd with it. Medieval medicine held that a person's temper came from whichever of four fluids ran strongest in them, and somebody with plenty of blood was ruddy, warm and hopeful. That is why **sanguine** still means optimistic — a medical theory abandoned four hundred years ago, fossilised in an ordinary English word.
The plainer cousins are easier. **Consanguinity** is shared blood, which is what a family is. And French gave English **sangfroid**, "cold blood": the calm of somebody whose blood has not risen.
When you met *el vaso*, you met the word for a vessel, and the body's own vessels are what this runs through. The two words have been waiting for each other.

What you've built

Four of the body: two you hold, one you wear, one that runs underneath.
La sed and *el sueño* are sensations. *La piel* and *la sangre* are the body itself, and between them they are the outside and the inside.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sangre*
- *la piel*, then *la sangre*
- all four — *la sed*, *el sueño*, *la piel*, *la sangre*

Before you move on

What was *sanguis*? (Blood.) Why does *sanguine* mean cheerful? (An old theory that blood made you ruddy and hopeful.) And what is *sangfroid*, taken literally? (Cold blood.)

300.5 el remedio — healing, taken again

Before the last of the five: what was *sitis*? (Thirst.) What broke into *ue* in *sueño*? (The stressed *o* of *somnus*.) And why does *sanguine* mean cheerful? (An old theory about blood.)

What to know first

- la fiebre — one of the things this is for.
- la enfermera — who is likely to bring it.

Sounds you'll need

- *re-ME-dio*, stress in the middle. The *r* at the start is a single tap, and the *io* at the end is one slide. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el remedio — "the remedy," the cure, the way out of a trouble.
Two pieces. **Re-**, again or back, which you have seen doing this work before. And **mederi**, Latin for to heal or to look after. A *remedium* is a putting-back of health.
Mederi is one of the more productive roots English has. **Medicine** is the healing art. A **medic** is the person practising it. Something **remedial** is meant to put a thing back. All of them come off the same short word.
The phrase to take away is **no hay remedio** — "there is no remedy," said about a thing that cannot be helped. You already have *hay* and you already have *no*, so the sentence is finished the moment you have this word. It is what a Spanish speaker says with a shrug where English says *it can't be helped*, and it is useful far outside a sickroom.

What you've built

Five: *la sed*, *el sueño*, *la piel*, *la sangre*, *el remedio*.
Read in order they are a body reporting on itself and then being attended to: two things it wants, two things it is made of, one thing that mends it.
And four of the five you can put into a sentence with words you already had — *tengo sed*, *tengo sueño*, *no hay remedio*. That is the difference between a list of words and a run you can speak from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el remedio*
- *no hay remedio*
- all five — *la sed*, *el sueño*, *la piel*, *la sangre*, *el remedio*

Before you move on

What does *mederi* mean? (To heal.) Which everyday English word is the same root? (*Medicine*.) And what does *no hay remedio* say? (There is nothing to be done.)

Chapter 301

Five More Things You Ask For — Rope, Needle, Thread, Basket, Paper

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask for a rope, a needle, thread, a basket and paper in Spanish, politely.
>
> *Complete ES-C301-papel: ask for all five in turn, with por favor on the end of each.*

301.1 la cuerda — a string made of gut

> Before a new run: what does *sangfroid* mean, taken literally? (Cold blood.) And what does *no hay remedio* say? (There is nothing to be done.)

What to know first

- por favor — what goes on the end of every ask in this run.
- el puente — a thing that has been made out of these.

Sounds you'll need

- *CUER-da*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide and the *d* is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cuerda — "the rope," "the cord," "the string."
Greek **khordē** meant a gut — an intestine — and then the string made out of one, because that is what strings were made of. Latin borrowed it as **chorda**, and the stressed *o* did what it always does under stress in Spanish: it cracked open into *ue*. So *chorda* became *cuerda*, by the same road as *somnus* to *sueño*.
English kept the gut in a whole shelf of words. A **cord** is the plain rope. A **chord** is what several strings sound together. A **cordon** is a rope drawn round a place to keep people out. And a **harpsichord** is, quite literally, a harp made of gut strings.
So this is not a rough word for a rough object. It is a musical instrument's word that ended up in the shed.

What you've built

The first of five things to ask for, and the *ue* crack has now paid twice in two runs.
Sueño and *cuerda* are the same event happening to two unrelated words. That is what makes it a rule rather than a coincidence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cuerda*
- *la cuerda, por favor*
- *el sueño*, then *la cuerda* — the same crack twice

Before you move on

What did *khordē* mean first? (A gut, then a string made of one.)
Which English instrument is a gut-stringed harp? (A harpsichord.)
And what did the stressed *o* do? (Broke into *ue*.)

301.2 la aguja — the sharp you already write

Two back: what does *no hay remedio* say? (There is nothing to be done.) And what did *khordē* mean? (A gut, then a string

made from one.)

What to know first

- la cuerda — the thick one, from just before.
- la oveja — the word this one rhymes with, and for the same reason.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-GU-ja*, stress in the middle. The *gu* is a hard *g*, and the *j* is the scrape. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la aguja — "the needle."
Latin **acus** was a needle, and behind it lay a much older idea: sharpness. Add the small-and-fond ending and you get **acucula**, a little sharp thing — which came down to Spanish as *aguja*, by the very road that turned *ovicula* into *oveja*. That is why the two words rhyme.
Now the useful part. That *acus* is standing in the corner of every page you have read. The accent you write on *sartén* is called **acute**, and *acute* is just Latin for sharp — a sharp accent, as against the grave one that leans the other way. You have been writing the same root for a long time without being told.
The rest of the family is easy once you have it. **Acupuncture** is puncturing with sharps. **Acumen** is a sharp mind. **Acid** is a sharp taste. All of them are this needle.

What you've built

Two of the five, and a root you were already using in silence.
La cuerda and *la aguja* also belong together in the hand: the thick one and the one that pulls the thin one through.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la aguja*
- *la aguja, por favor*
- *la oveja*, then *la aguja* — the same ending, twice

Before you move on

What did *acus* mean? (A needle — a sharp.) Why is the acute accent called that? (*Acute* is Latin for sharp.) And which word does *aguja* rhyme with, and why? (*Oveja* — both came from the same small ending.)

301.3 el hilo — the second h with an f under it

What did *khordē* mean? (A gut, then a string.) And why is the acute accent called acute? (Because *acute* is Latin for sharp.)

What to know first

- el horno — the first word this run gave you with a buried *f*.
- la aguja — what pulls this through the cloth.

Sounds you'll need

- *I-lo*, two beats, and the *h* is silent. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el hilo — "the thread."
Run the decoder. Silent *h* at the front: put an *f* back and see what falls out. **Filum** — Latin for a thread. It works, and it works for the same reason it worked on *horno*.
English took *filum* the bookish way and kept every letter. A **filament** is a fine thread in a lamp. **Filigree** is metal worked into threads. A **profile** is a line drawn round something. And soldiers walking in **single file** are walking in one thread, which is a much older picture than the parade ground.
There is also a phrase worth carrying: *perder el hilo*, to lose the thread — of an argument, of a conversation. English says exactly the same thing about exactly the same object, and neither borrowed it. Everybody who has ever talked too long has felt the thread go.

What you've built

Three of the five, and the *f*-to-*h* decoder has now paid twice. *Horno* and *hilo* are both Latin words with a letter worn off the front. When you meet the next silent *h*, try the same trick before you look anything up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el hilo*
- *el hilo, por favor*
- *la aguja y el hilo*

Before you move on

What was *filum*? (A thread.) What is a *filament*? (A fine thread.) And what does *perder el hilo* mean? (To lose the thread of something.)

301.4 la cesta — one box, two English words

> Three questions. What was *chorda*? (A gut string.) What was *acus*? (A needle.) And what was *filum*? (A thread.)

What to know first

- la manzana — what people carry in one.
- el hilo — the thing before this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *CES-ta*, stress on the first part. The *c* before *e* is the soft one. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cesta — "the basket."
Greek **kistē** was a box. Latin took it as **cista**, and Spanish wore it down to *cesta*, keeping the shape and losing nothing important.
English got the same box twice, by two different doors, and the pair is a good demonstration of what those doors do. Through Germanic mouths, early and worn: a **chest**, which is a box you can sit on.
Straight out of the books, late and tidy: a **cistern**, which is a tank for water and still sounds like an engineer's word.
That is the general pattern, and once you have seen it here you will see it everywhere. Words that came the long way, through everyday speech, sound plain. Words that came the short way, through writing, sound learned. Same origin, different mileage.

What you've built

Four of the five, and a rule about English that keeps explaining Spanish.
When a Spanish word looks like a plain English word and a fancy one at once, that is usually not a coincidence. It is one Latin word that took two routes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cesta*
- *la cesta, por favor*
- all four — *la cuerda*, *la aguja*, *el hilo*, *la cesta*

Before you move on

What was *cista*? (A box.) Which English word for it came the worn, everyday way? (*Chest.*) And which came straight out of the books? (*Cistern.*)

301.5 el papel — a reed, and a part in a play

> Before the last of the five: what was *acus*? (A needle.) What was *filum*? (A thread.) And which English word is *cista*, worn down? (*Chest.*)

What to know first

- el libro — named after what people wrote on before this arrived.
- escribir — what you do on it.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-PEL*, stress on the end, and no accent needed for a word ending in *-l*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el papel — "the paper."
Behind it is **papyrus**, the Egyptian reed whose pith was beaten flat and written on for three thousand years. English **paper** is the same reed. So is the **papyrus** in a museum case, which is the word arriving a second time, unworn, to name the original thing.
Put that beside *el libro*. A *libro* is named after the inner bark of a tree, which is what people wrote on when there was no papyrus to hand. Two writing surfaces, two words, and neither of them has anything to do with writing — both are named after a plant.
Then *papel* did something Latin never asked it to. It also means the **part** an actor plays, because the part used to be handed to the actor written out on a sheet. *Hacer el papel de* — to play the part of.
English keeps the same idea in **role**, which was a little roll of paper.

What you've built

Five: *la cuerda*, *la aguja*, *el hilo*, *la cesta*, *el papel*.
Ask for any of them with *por favor* on the end and you have a complete, polite request — the same shape you have been using since the soap and the towel.
And every one of the five is named after a material rather than a use: a gut, a sharp, a thread, a box, a reed. Objects get their names from what they are made of far more often than from what they are for,

which is the opposite of the rule the farm gave you. Both are true; that is why you need to have met both.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el papel*
- *el papel, por favor*
- all five with *por favor* — *la cuerda*, *la aguja*, *el hilo*, *la cesta*, *el papel*

Before you move on

What plant is *papel* named after? (The papyrus reed.) What is *el libro* named after? (The inner bark of a tree.) And what else does *papel* mean? (The part an actor plays.)

Chapter 302

Out and Away — Street, Corner, Footprint, Harbour, Lighthouse

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the street, the corner, the footprint, the harbour and the lighthouse in Spanish.

Complete ES-C302-faro: name all five of a leaving in order, from the street to the light behind you.

302.1 la calle — a cattle track that reached the town

Before a new run: which English word is *cista*, worn down? (*Chest.*) And what plant is *papel* named after? (The papyrus reed.)

What to know first

- el sendero — the way through the trees.
- el ganado — what wore this one flat in the first place.

Sounds you'll need

- *CA-lle*, stress on the first part. The *c* is hard and the *ll* is a *y*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la calle — "the street."
Latin **callis** was not urban at all. It was the narrow hard track that animals beat through rough country when they were driven from one grazing ground to another — a hoof-path, made by use rather than by anybody's decision.
Then towns grew, and the word walked in with the herds. Spanish now uses *calle* for the most built thing there is: a paved street with houses down both sides. The stones are new; the word underneath them was made by *el ganado*.
You have three words for a way through now, and they do not overlap. *El sendero* is the path through the trees, narrow and unpaved. *El camino* is the road anybody would take. *La calle* has walls on both sides.
Ask *¿en qué calle vives?* and you are asking which street somebody lives on.

What you've built

The first step of a leaving, and it starts at the door.
Everything that follows in this run is further out than the last: a street, then its corner, then what you leave in the dirt beyond it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la calle*
- *el sendero*, then *la calle*
- *¿en qué calle vives?*

Before you move on

What was a *callis*? (A track beaten by driven animals.) What is *la calle* now? (A street.) And which of your three ways through has walls on both sides? (*La calle*.)

302.2 la esquina — named after a shinbone

> Two back: what does *papel* also mean, besides paper? (The part an actor plays.) And what was a *callis*? (A track beaten by animals.)

What to know first

- la calle — what this is the end of.
- la escoba — another word wearing the same *e-* step.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-QUI-na*, stress in the middle. The *qui* is a hard *k* with the *u* silent. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la esquina — "the corner," the outside one, where two walls meet. This one is not Latin. It came from the Germanic speakers, whose **skina** meant a shinbone, or a thin splinter of bone or wood — a long hard edge. A corner is exactly that shape, and the language borrowed the bone to name it.

English kept the bone and did not lend it to the corner: your **shin** is *skina*, the same word, and anybody who has met a table corner in the dark can confirm that the two ideas belong together.

Notice the front of the Spanish word. *Skina* could not stand as it was, because Spanish does not begin a word with *s* and another consonant — so it put an *e* on the front, exactly as it did to make *escoba* and *estar*. The *e-* is not part of the word. It is a step Spanish takes to get onto it.

What you've built

Two of the leaving, and a step you can now recognise on sight.

Any Spanish word starting *es-* with a consonant after it is worth checking: strip the *e*, and a Latin or Germanic word is often standing underneath.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la esquina*
- *la esquina de la calle*
- *la escoba*, then *la esquina* — the same step twice

Before you move on

What did *skina* mean? (A shinbone, or a splinter.) Which English word is it still? (*Shin.*) And why does *esquina* start with an *e*? (Spanish will not begin a word with *s* plus a consonant.)

302.3 la huella — what the treading leaves

What was a *callis*? (A track beaten by driven animals.) And what did *skina* mean? (A shinbone.)

What to know first

- el hilo — the last word this run gave you with a buried *f*.
- el sendero — a thing made entirely out of these.

Sounds you'll need

- *UE-lla*, and the *h* is silent, so the word opens straight onto the *ue* slide. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la huella — "the footprint," "the track," the mark a thing leaves by pressing on something.
Third time for the decoder, and it still works. Silent *h*, so put the *f* back: behind *huella* is *hollar*, to tread, and behind that Latin **fullare**. *Fullare* was a specific job. Newly woven wool had to be cleaned and thickened, and the way to do it was to put it in a vat with water and earth and **tread on it**, for hours. The man who did it was a *fullo*. English still carries him: to **full** cloth is a real word, a **fulling mill** did it with hammers once water power arrived, and the surname **Fuller** belonged to whoever did it by foot.
So a footprint in Spanish is named after a day's work in a vat of wet wool. And the word has gone abstract in both languages the same way:

la huella is also the mark somebody leaves behind them in general, exactly as English uses **footprint** for something that never had a foot.

What you've built

Three of the leaving, and three uses of one decoder in two runs. *Horno*, *hilo*, *huella*. Each of them was an *f* once, and each of them gave the letter up in the same century. A silent *h* is now a piece of evidence, not a spelling to memorise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la huella*
- *el hilo*, then *la huella* — two buried *f* sounds
- *la huella en el sendero*

Before you move on

What letter is under the *h* of *huella*? (An *f*.) What was *fullare*? (Treading cloth in a vat.) And what does *la huella* mean? (A footprint, or a mark left behind.)

302.4 el puerto — the other half of a pair

Three questions. What was a *callis*? (A beaten track.) Which English word is *skina*? (*Shin*.) And what was *fullare*? (Treading cloth in a vat.)

What to know first

- la puerta — the twin of this word, met long ago.
- la orilla — the edge this is built on.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUER-to*, stress on the first part. The *ue* is one slide and the *r* is a single tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el puerto — "the harbour," "the port."
When you took *la puerta* apart, the Latin behind it was **porta**, a city gate. Latin had a second word beside it, built on the same idea of a way through: **portus**, the place a ship gets in. Both broke their stressed *o* into *ue*, and Spanish ended up with a matched pair — *puerta* for the gate on land, *puerto* for the gate off the sea.
English took *portus* and never stopped using it. A **port** is the harbour. To **import** is to carry in through one; to **export**, out. **Portugal** is *Portus Cale*, the harbour at Cale, which is where the whole country got its name.
And the best of them: **opportunity**. Latin *ob portum* described a wind standing toward the harbour — the wind that lets you get in. An opportunity is not luck. It is the wind being in the right quarter, and somebody having a ship.

What you've built

Four of the leaving, and a word you half owned already.
Puerta and *puerto* differ by one letter and by which side of the water you are standing on. Pairs like that are cheap to hold and easy to hear, and Spanish has more of them than any list would suggest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el puerto*
- *la puerta*, then *el puerto* — the gate and the harbour
- all four — *la calle*, *la esquina*, *la huella*, *el puerto*

Before you move on

What was *portus*? (A harbour.) What is *Portugal* named after? (The harbour at Cale.) And what does *ob portum* describe? (A wind standing toward harbour — an opportunity.)

302.5 el faro — an island that became a word

Before the last of the five: what was a *callis*? (A beaten track.) What is under the *h* of *huella*? (An *f*.) And what does *ob portum* describe? (A wind standing toward harbour.)

What to know first

- el puerto — what this stands at the mouth of.
- la isla — what the original one was built on.

Sounds you'll need

- *FA-ro*, stress on the first part. The *r* is one tap, not a roll. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el faro — "the lighthouse."
There is no root to take apart, because this word was a place. **Pharos** was a small island off Alexandria, and on it the Ptolemies built a tower with a fire at the top that stood for some sixteen hundred years.
Sailors called any such tower a *pharos* after it, and the name swallowed the object: French *phare*, Italian *faro*, Spanish *faro*.
The tower fell in an earthquake and the island is now joined to the mainland. Nothing of it is left except the word — which is also, in modern Spanish, what you call a car's headlights. The last of the great wonders is switched on every evening in every car park in Spain.

What you've built

Five: *la calle*, *la esquina*, *la huella*, *el puerto*, *el faro*.
Read in order they are a leaving that gets further out at every step — the street, its corner, the mark left in the dirt, the water's edge, and the light still visible when the town is not.
The five came from five different quarries: a cattle track, a shinbone, a day spent treading wool, a Roman harbour, and an island with a fire on it. That is why taking words apart keeps paying — you never know which one will turn out to be a building you have heard of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el faro*
- *el puerto*, then *el faro*
- all five — *la calle*, *la esquina*, *la huella*, *el puerto*, *el faro*

Before you move on

What was Pharos? (An island off Alexandria with a great lighthouse on it.) How did it become the word? (Sailors called every such tower after it.) And what else is a *faro* today? (A car's headlight.)

Chapter 303

When the Words Run Out — Help, a Moment, Again, I Don't Know, What Does It Mean

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask for help, ask for a moment, ask for another go, admit I do not know, and ask what a word means in Spanish.
>
> *Complete ES-C303-que-significa: repair a stalled exchange five ways, ending with the question that earns a meaning.*

303.1 la ayuda — the word that stands beside you

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la ayuda — "help."
Latin **adiutare** was built from *iuvare*, "to give strength," with *ad-*, "toward." To help was to bring your strength **toward** somebody. Not to take over, not to fix — to stand beside and add what you have.

English took the same stem twice. *Aid* is the plain one. An *adjutant* is the officer who stands beside a commander and adds capacity.
Said alone — *ayuda* — it is a call. Said with *por favor*, it is a request.

What you've built

Your first repair word that asks for a person, not a repetition.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la ayuda*
- *ayuda, por favor*
- *disculpe — ayuda, por favor*

Before you move on

What did *adiutare* mean, literally? (To bring strength toward.)
Which English word is it, worn down? (*Aid.*)

303.2 el momento — the tilt of a balance

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el momento — "a moment."
Latin **momentum** came from *movere*, "to move," and it did not mean time at all. It meant the **smallest movement that tips a balance** — the last grain that makes one pan drop.
That is a weight, not a duration. But the tipping happens in an instant, and the word slid from the movement to the instant. English kept the original sense in *momentum* and the borrowed sense in *moment.*

Un momento, por favor buys you that instant — and it is the politest thing you can say when you need to think.

What you've built

Two repair words now: one asks for a person, one asks for time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el momento*
- *un momento, por favor*
- *un momento — no entiendo*

Before you move on

What did *momentum* weigh? (The last grain that tips a balance.)
What do you say to buy an instant? (*Un momento, por favor.*)

303.3 otra vez — another turn round

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

otra vez — "again."
Word by word it is "another turn." **Vez** is Latin *vicem*, and *vicem* meant a **turn taken in rotation** — your go, coming round again. English holds that exact word in several places. *Vice versa* is "the turn having been changed." A *vicar* stands in somebody else's turn. A *vice*-president takes the turn of the president.
So *otra vez* does not say "repeat." It says **another go round** — a kinder thing to ask of a stranger, and it pairs with what you already have.

What you've built

Three ways to repair now — ask for a person, for time, or for another go.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *otra vez*
- *otra vez, por favor*
- *más despacio, otra vez, por favor*

Before you move on

What is a *vez*? (A turn, coming round.) Which English phrase hides the same word? (*Vice versa.*)

303.4 no sé — what you have not tasted

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

no sé — "I do not know."
Sé comes from Latin **sapere**, and *sapere* meant **to taste** — to have flavour, and then to have the discernment that tasting implies.
Follow it into English and the metaphor is still warm. *Savour* is the taste itself. *Insipid* is *in-* plus *sapidus*: without flavour. *Sapient* — and *Homo sapiens* — is "the one that has tasted," a far more modest name for our species than it usually sounds.
So *no sé* is not a failure. It is "I have not tasted that." Note the written mark: *sé* with an accent is "I know"; *se* without one is a different word.

What you've built

The fourth repair: the honest one, when there is nothing to ask for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *no sé*
- *no sé, lo siento*
- *no sé — más despacio, por favor*

Before you move on

What did *sapere* mean first? (To taste.) What is *Homo sapiens*, literally? (The one that has tasted.)

303.5 ¿qué significa? — asking for the meaning, not the word

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿qué significa? — "what does it mean?"
Significar is Latin *significare*, and it takes apart cleanly: *signum*, "a sign," plus *facere*, "to make." To mean something was **to make a sign** of it.
English took the whole family: *sign*, *signal*, *signify*, *significant*, and *design* — *de-* plus *signare*, to mark something out.
This is the twin of the question you cannot ask yet. One asks for a word you do not have; this one asks for the **meaning** of a word you have just heard and did not follow. Between them they cover both directions, and either one turns a stranger into a source.
Point at the written word, or say it back, and ask.

What you've built

Five repairs, and the last one gets you meanings rather than words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¿qué significa?*
- *disculpe, ¿qué significa?*
- *no entiendo. ¿qué significa?*

Before you move on

Take *significare* apart. (*Signum* a sign, *facere* to make.) Which English word is *de-* plus *signare*? (*Design.*)

Chapter 304

When Bien Is Not True — Calm, Ill, Content, Busy, Sad

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can answer how I am honestly in Spanish: calm, ill, content, busy or sad, in the right form for who is speaking.
>
> *Complete ES-C304-triste: give all five answers, switching the four that take -o/-a and leaving the one that ends in -e alone.*

304.1 tranquilo — a sea with no wind on it

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tranquilo — "calm."
Latin **tranquillus** was, before anything else, a word for **water**: a sea or a lake with no wind moving across it. Flat, and therefore safe to cross.
English borrowed it whole and kept the picture, whether or not anybody notices it: *tranquil*, *tranquillity*.
It is the most-used answer in this chapter after *bien*, and it does something the others do not — said to somebody else, *tranquilo* means

"take it easy," a whole sentence in one word.
A man says *tranquilo*; a woman says *tranquila*. You met that *-o/-a* switch in *bueno* and *buena*.

What you've built

You can answer the wellbeing question with something other than *bien*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tranquilo*
- *tranquila*
- *tranquilo, gracias*

Before you move on

What did *tranquillus* describe first? (Water with no wind on it.)
And what does a woman say? (*Tranquila.*)

304.2 enfermo — not firm

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

enfermo — "ill."
Latin **infirmus** is *in-* ("not") plus *firmus* ("firm, steady"). Illness named as **the loss of steadiness** — not pain, not fever, just the going of the thing that held you up.
English borrowed it twice and kept the shape both times: *infirm*, and the *infirmary* where the not-firm are put.
Enfermo is the strong one in this chapter. You already have *la fiebre* and *el dolor*; this is the word for the state they belong to. And *la*

enfermera — the nurse — is built straight off it: the one who attends the not-firm.

What you've built

Two honest answers now, and one of them explains a word you already had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *enfermo*
- *enferma*
- *enfermo — la enfermera, por favor*

Before you move on

Take *infirmus* apart. (*In-* not, *firmus* firm.) Which word you already knew is built on it? (*La enfermera.*)

304.3 contento — held together

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

contento — "happy," "content."
Latin **contentus** is the past participle of *continere*, "to hold together" — *con-* plus *tenere*, "to hold." So *contento* is literally **held together**. English took the verb as *contain* and the participle as *content*, and kept the double life: a *container* holds things; a *contented* person is held. That is a quieter word than "happy." It does not claim delight. It claims that nothing is falling apart — which, next to *tranquilo* and *enfermo*, is exactly the right register for answering a stranger.

What you've built

Three answers: worn out, not firm, and held together.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *contento*
- *contenta*
- *contento, gracias*

Before you move on

What does *continere* mean? (To hold together.) So what is a *contento* person, literally? (Held together.)

304.4 ocupado — seized

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ocupado — "busy."
Latin **occupare** meant **to seize**, to take possession of — an army occupies ground. English kept it exactly: to *occupy*, and an *occupation*.
So *ocupado* does not say "I have a lot on." It says **something has taken hold of me**. The work is the one doing the grabbing.
It is also the word on a lavatory door, and what a Spanish phone line is when it is busy — the seat and the line are both *seized*.

What you've built

Four honest answers, and one of them is written on doors.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ocupado*
- *ocupada*
- *lo siento — ocupado*

Before you move on

What did *occupare* mean? (To seize.) So who is doing the seizing when you are *ocupado*? (The work.)

304.5 triste — the one word that does not change

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

triste — "sad."
Latin **tristis** was wider than the English word. It covered *grim*, *harsh*, *severe* — a *tristis* judge was a stern one — and only later settled onto sorrow. French carried the softer end into *tristesse*, which English borrowed without translating.
Here is the thing worth noticing, and it is a rule you have been shown four times now without it being named: *tranquilo* becomes *tranquila*, *contento* becomes *contenta*, *ocupado* becomes *ocupada*. **Triste does not move.**
Words ending in *-e* have one form for everybody. That is not an exception to the *-o*/*-a* switch; it is the other half of it, and it costs you nothing to learn because there is nothing to change.

What you've built

Five answers — and the fifth quietly teaches the limit of the *-o*/*-a* rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *triste*
- *triste, gracias*
- *contento — contenta — triste*

Before you move on

Did *tristis* only mean sad? (No — grim and harsh too.) And why does *triste* not change for a woman? (It ends in *-e*.)

Chapter 305

Naming, Properly — Name, Surname, Sir, Madam, Delighted

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can ask for and give a first name and a surname in Spanish, address a stranger as senor or senora, and answer an introduction.
>
> *Complete ES-C305-encantado: give both names, address the other person correctly, and answer the introduction.*

305.1 el nombre — the word that is also English

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el nombre — "the name."
Latin **nomen**. English *name*. These are not borrowings in either direction — they are **cousins**, both descended from the same ancient word, which is why they still agree in sense after several thousand years apart.
Latin lent the borrowed forms too: a *noun* is a naming word, to *nominate* is to name somebody for a post, and *renown* is being re-named, over and over, by people who were never there.

You already say *me llamo* — "I call myself." *El nombre* is the thing you call yourself **with**.

What you've built

A word for the thing your first sentence was already handing over.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el nombre*
- *el nombre, por favor*
- *me llamo… ¿y el nombre de usted?*

Before you move on

Are *nombre* and *name* borrowed from each other? (No — cousins, from the same ancient word.) What is *renown*? (Being named again and again.)

305.2 el apellido — the name you are called by

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el apellido — "the surname," the family name.
It comes from Latin **appellitare**, the repeating form of *appellare*, "to call on." Not the name you are given — the name you are **called by**, again and again, by everybody.
English has the same verb in *appeal* (to call on someone) and *appellation* (what a thing is called).
Worth knowing before anyone asks for it: Spanish speakers usually carry **two** *apellidos*, the father's then the mother's. A form with one

box for “surname” is a form built for a different country.

What you’ve built

Two halves of a full name now, and a warning about forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el apellido*
- *el nombre y el apellido*
- *el apellido, por favor*

Before you move on

What does *appellitare* mean? (To call on again and again.) How many *apellidos* does a Spanish speaker usually have? (Two.)

305.3 señor — respect made out of age

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you’ll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

señor — “sir,” “Mr.”
Latin **senior** meant “older,” the comparative of *senex*, “old.” English took it raw as *senior*, and took the French descendant *sieur* — which is inside *monsieur*, “my lord,” and worn all the way down to English *sir*. So *señor*, *sir*, *senior* and *monsieur* are one word, spread out.
The **ñ** is the letter you met in the writing chapter. And this is what you say to get a stranger’s attention politely, ahead of any of last chapter’s repairs.

What you've built

A way to address the person before you ask them anything.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *señor*
- *señor, por favor*
- *señor — ¿qué significa?*

Before you move on

What did *senior* mean? (Older.) Which English one-syllable word is the same root, worn down? (*Sir.*)

305.4 señora — the same word, turned

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

señora — "madam," "Mrs."
The same *senior*, turned by the *-o/-a* switch you have now met three times: *bueno/buena*, *tranquilo/tranquila*, and here.
That switch is the single most useful pattern in the language, and you have been collecting it since chapter one without being asked to memorise a rule.
One caution worth having early: *señorita* exists and marks an unmarried woman. It is going out of use, and *señora* is the safe address for an adult woman you do not know.

What you've built

Both forms of address, and the *-o/-a* switch confirmed a third time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *señora*
- *señora, por favor*
- *señor — señora*

Before you move on

What turns *señor* into *señora*? (The *-o/-a* switch.) Which is the safe address for an adult woman you do not know? (*Señora.*)

305.5 encantado — sung a spell over

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

encantado — what you say on being introduced.
Latin **incantare** is *in-* plus *cantare*, "to sing" — to **sing a spell onto** something. English took it as *enchanted*, and kept the raw noun as *incantation*.
So the polite thing a Spanish speaker says on meeting you is, literally, "I have been put under a spell." English does the identical thing and nobody notices: *charmed*, and *delighted* — *de-* plus *lacere*, "to lure."
A man says *encantado*; a woman says *encantada*. You already have *mucho gusto*, which does the same job more plainly — either is right.

What you've built

A full introduction now: greet, give both names, address them properly, and be charmed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *encantado*
- *encantada*
- *me llamo… encantado*

Before you move on

Take *incantare* apart. (To sing a spell onto.) Which English word is it exactly? (*Enchanted.*) Which word you already had does the same job? (*Mucho gusto.*)

Chapter 306

Blood and Household — Son, Daughter, Grandfather, Grandmother, Husband

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 4 of 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the closest members of a family in Spanish — son, daughter, grandfather, grandmother and husband — and switch the ending to say which one I mean.
>
> *Complete ES-C306-esposo: name all five relatives, taking the -o/-a switch in both directions.*

306.1 el hijo — the f that turned into a silent h

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el hijo — "the son."
Latin **filius**. English kept it in the borrowed words rather than the everyday one: *filial* duty is the duty owed by a son or a daughter, and to *affiliate* is to take something in as a son.
Spanish did something to it that English never did. A Latin **f-** at the front of a word became Spanish **h-**, and then that h- fell silent. *Filius*

became *hijo*: the letter is written and never said.
Once you have seen the rule it keeps paying out — *facere* became *hacer*, *ferrum* became *hierro*, *fumus* became *humo*. The h you do not pronounce is the fossil of an f.

What you've built

The first person most people name after they have given their own name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el hijo*
- *el nombre del hijo*
- *mi hijo, señor*

Before you move on

What was *hijo* in Latin? (*Filius.*) Which English words still show that f? (*Filial*, *affiliate.*) Do you say the h? (No — never.)

306.2 la hija — the same root, the other ending

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la hija — "the daughter."
Same Latin root, feminine end: **filia** beside **filius**. Spanish did not need a second word, only a second vowel. You have met this machinery already with *contento* and *contenta* — here it does the work of a whole separate noun.
English has no everyday cousin either, so it leans on the same

borrowed *filial*, which quietly covers sons and daughters at once.
There is one more place the root is hiding. A Spanish **hidalgo** — the minor nobleman — is a worn-down *hijo de algo*, "son of something," meaning son of somebody with property. The rank is a description of a parent.

What you've built

A pair: change the last vowel, change who you are talking about.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la hija*
- *el hijo y la hija*
- *el nombre de la hija, por favor*

Before you move on

What is the only difference between *hijo* and *hija*? (The last vowel.)
What is an *hidalgo* literally? (*Hijo de algo* — son of something.)

306.3 el abuelo — the little grandfather

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el abuelo — "the grandfather."
Latin **avus** was the grandfather. Spanish did not inherit *avus* plainly; it inherited the fond diminutive **aviolus**, "the little grandfather," and wore it down to *abuelo*. The affection is baked into the word.
English holds the same root in two long words. *Avuncular* — warm in the way an uncle is warm — comes from *avunculus*, which is itself

"little grandfather" and drifted to mean the mother's brother. And *atavistic*, a trait surfacing from far back, is *atavus*, an ancestor several grandfathers deep.
Notice what that means: English *uncle* is a worn-down *avunculus*. Your word for grandfather and their word for uncle are the same Latin word, pulled two ways.

What you've built

A root that runs through two English words most people never connect.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el abuelo*
- *el abuelo y el hijo*
- *el apellido del abuelo*

Before you move on

What was *avus*? (Grandfather.) Why is *avuncular* about uncles? (*Avunculus*, little grandfather, drifted to mother's brother.) What does *atavistic* reach back to? (A distant ancestor.)

306.4 la abuela — twice over, and again

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la abuela — "the grandmother."
The switch you have now done twice: *abuelo* to *abuela*. Third time you have met this ending doing the work of a separate word, and it will not be the last.

Spanish then does something tidy that English handles with a hyphen. Stack the Latin **bis**, "twice," on the front and you get *bisabuela* — the great-grandmother, the grandmother twice over. English took that same *bis* in *biscuit*, which is *bis coctus*, "twice cooked," and in *bicycle* and *binary*.
So the word for the oldest person in the room is built out of the number two.

What you've built

Four kinship words, and the -o/-a switch is starting to feel automatic.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la abuela*
- *el abuelo y la abuela*
- *la abuela y la hija*

Before you move on

What does *bis* mean? (Twice.) So what is a *bisabuela*? (A great-grandmother.) What is a *biscuit* literally? (Twice cooked.)

306.5 el esposo — the one who promised

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el esposo — "the husband."
Latin **spondere** meant to pledge, to promise in a way that binds. The pledged person was the **sponsus**. English took the same word twice: once quietly as *spouse*, and once openly as *sponsor* — somebody who

makes a promise on your behalf.
The verb went further than that. To *respond* is to pledge back. To be *despondent* is to have pledged away, given up. All of it is one Latin verb about promises.
And look at the front of the Spanish word. Latin *sponsus* began with s- plus a consonant, and Spanish cannot start a word that way, so it glued an **e-** on the front: *esposo*. That is the same e- you already have in *España* and *escuela*. The husband is, in the plainest possible terms, the one who promised.

What you've built

A word for a person that is really a word for a promise — and the chapter's last.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el esposo*
- *el esposo y el hijo*
- *el nombre del esposo, por favor*

Before you move on

What did *spondere* mean? (To pledge.) Name two English words from it. (*Spouse*, *sponsor*, *respond*, *despondent*.) Why the e- on the front? (Spanish will not start a word with s- plus a consonant.)

Chapter 307

The Wider Circle — Wife, Uncle, Aunt, Cousin

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name a wife, an uncle, an aunt and a cousin in Spanish, in either gender, and I know why Spanish and English chose different ancient words for the same relatives.
>
> *Complete ES-C307-prima: name the wider circle of relatives and pair each -o form with its -a form.*

307.1 la esposa — the pledge that binds

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la esposa — "the wife."
The same pledge, the same ending switch. English *spouse* does not bother to mark who it means; Spanish always does.
Now the strange part, and it is worth knowing because it is unmistakable once you have heard it. In the plural, **las esposas** also means *handcuffs*. The metaphor is not a joke about marriage — it runs straight out of the root. A pledge is a thing that binds you, so the binding thing takes the pledge's name.

English does the identical move and nobody blinks: you are *bound* by a promise, you enter into *bonds*, and a *wedlock* is a lock. Spanish has aimed the word at the object, English at the feeling.

What you've built

Six words in, and the -o/-a switch has done the work of six separate nouns.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la esposa*
- *el esposo y la esposa*
- *la esposa y la hija*

Before you move on

What does *las esposas* mean besides wives? (Handcuffs.) Why is that not a joke? (A pledge binds — the root means to pledge.) Which English word does the same thing? (*Bound*, or *wedlock*.)

307.2 el tío — the Greek one

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tío — "the uncle."
This one is not Latin at its source. Greek **theîos** meant uncle, Late Latin borrowed it as **thius**, and Spanish carried it down to *tío*.
Here is why that matters to you. Two lessons ago you learned that English *uncle* comes from Latin *avunculus*, the "little grandfather" inside *abuelo*. So the two languages had both words available and each

kept the other one. English went Latin; Spanish went Greek. Same relative, two different ancestries, and neither word looks anything like the other.
The written accent on the **í** is doing real work. It splits *tí-o* into two beats and keeps the stress on the first. Without it the word would collapse into one syllable.

What you've built

A relative English and Spanish named from opposite ends of the ancient world.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tío*
- *el tío y el abuelo*
- *el tío, señor*

Before you move on

Where does *tío* come from? (Greek *theîos*.) Where does English *uncle* come from? (Latin *avunculus* — the *abuelo* root.) What is the accent on the í doing? (Splitting two beats, holding the stress.)

307.3 la tía — a third word for the same relative

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la tía — "the aunt."
Spanish swings the Greek word feminine and is done. English could not: *aunt* comes from Latin **amita**, the father's sister, which is neither

thius nor *avunculus*. That is three separate ancient words in play for two relatives, and the two languages picked differently every time.
The accent works exactly as it did in *tío* — *tí-a*, two beats, stress on the first.
One thing to be ready for. In everyday speech across much of the Spanish-speaking world, *tío* and *tía* get used for people who are not relatives at all, the way English uses *dude* or *mate*. That is casual, not neutral; you will hear it long before you need it.

What you've built

Eight words, and a clear picture of two languages choosing different ancestors.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la tía*
- *el tío y la tía*
- *la tía y la abuela*

Before you move on

Where does English *aunt* come from? (Latin *amita*.) How many ancient words are in play for uncle and aunt? (Three — *thius*, *avunculus*, *amita*.) Is calling a stranger *tía* neutral? (No — casual.)

307.4 el primo — the relative whose name means first

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el primo — "the cousin."
You have met **primus** before, in *primero*. It means "first," and it is the root under English *prime*, *primary*, *premier* and *primitive*.
So why is a cousin called "first"? Because Latin said **consobrinus primus** — "first cousin," exactly as English still does. Spanish dropped the long word and kept the adjective. What is left is a relative whose entire name is a ranking: first.
English did the reverse and kept the long word. *Cousin* is worn down from *consobrinus*, which is *con-* plus *sobrinus*, "sister's child." Both languages took half of the same Latin phrase — and they took different halves.

What you've built

An old root paying off again: *primero* and *primo* are the same word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el primo*
- *el primo y el tío*
- *el nombre del primo*

Before you move on

What does *primus* mean? (First.) Which word did you already have from it? (*Primero.*) Which half of *consobrinus primus* did English keep? (*Consobrinus*, which became *cousin.*)

307.5 la prima — first lady, first face

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la prima — "the cousin," of a girl or woman.
The ending switch again. What makes this one easy is that English already says *prima* out loud without translating it.
A **prima donna** is the "first lady" of an opera company — the leading singer. The phrase turned into an insult later, but the words are plain: first woman.
Prima facie evidence is evidence that holds up "at first face," on first look. Same *prima*, same meaning, borrowed whole out of Latin and never naturalised.
So you already knew this word. You knew it as a label for opera singers and legal arguments, and it is the same word you now use for your cousin.

What you've built

Ten words — and the chapter's last. Two families of relatives, named.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la prima*
- *el primo y la prima*
- *la prima y la tía*

Before you move on

What is a *prima donna* literally? (First lady.) What is *prima facie*? (At first face.) What is a *prima* to you now? (A cousin.)

Chapter 308

Children and Everybody — Boy, Girl, Lad, Lass, People

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about children and about people in general in Spanish, and I can tell a real cousin word from a false friend.
>
> *Complete ES-C308-gente: name children in both genders and move from one child to people in general.*

308.1 el niño — the word with no ancestors

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el niño — "the boy," or a child of either sex when you do not need to say which.
Every word so far in this chapter has had a Latin pedigree. This one has none. *Niño* comes from **ninno**, which is nursery babble — the noise adults make at small children, frozen into a word.
That is not a failure of the word. English does exactly the same thing: *baby* and *babe* are *bab-* babbling sounds, *papa* and *mama* are the two easiest noises a mouth can make. Languages build their most intimate

words out of the sounds infants produce, which is why those words rarely resemble their neighbours.
English does know this one, though, and untranslated. **El Niño** — the Pacific warming named by Peruvian fishermen because it arrives near Christmas — is "the boy," meaning the Christ child. You have been saying *niño* on weather forecasts your whole life.
The **ñ** is its own letter, not an n with decoration.

What you've built

A word you already knew from the weather report.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el niño*
- *el niño y el hijo*
- *el nombre del niño, por favor*

Before you move on

Does *niño* come from Latin? (No — nursery babble.) What is *El Niño* literally? (The boy — the Christ child.) Which English words are built the same way? (*Baby*, *mama*, *papa*.)

308.2 la niña — the little figure in the eye

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la niña — "the girl."
The ending switch, on a word with no Latin behind it. **La Niña** is the cold counterpart to *El Niño*, named afterwards to match.

Now the good one. In Spanish, **la niña del ojo** is the *pupil* of the eye — "the little girl of the eye." Lean close to somebody's eye and you see a tiny figure of yourself reflected in the dark centre. Spanish named the pupil after that little person.
English named it the same way and hid the fact behind Latin. *Pupil* is Latin **pupilla**, "little doll" — the same tiny reflected figure, the same observation, made independently. And that is why *pupil* also means a schoolchild: *pupilla* was a small girl first.
Two languages looked into an eye, saw a child, and both named it that.

What you've built

Twelve words, and proof that two languages can invent the same metaphor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la niña*
- *el niño y la niña*
- *la niña y la prima*

Before you move on

What is *la niña del ojo*? (The pupil.) Why? (The tiny figure reflected in it.) What is English *pupil* in Latin? (*Pupilla*, little doll — the same idea.)

308.3 el chico — small first, boy second

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el chico — "the boy," "the lad."
Latin **ciccum** was the thin membrane inside a pomegranate — the Roman byword for something worth nothing at all, the way English says *not worth a fig*. From "a trifle" it slid to "tiny," and from "tiny" to "a small person."
This word has no English descendant, and that absence is worth a moment: not every Spanish word has a cousin waiting in English. The method works because so many do, not because all of them must.
Two things to keep straight. First, *chico* still means *small* before it means *boy*, and you will meet it as an adjective constantly. Second, English *chick* for a young bird looks like a match and is not — that is a Germanic word, and the resemblance is an accident. A look-alike with no shared ancestor is called a false friend, and this is your first one. Meanwhile American English has borrowed the feminine, *chica*, outright.

What you've built

A word that arrived by meaning small — and your first false friend.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el chico*
- *el chico y el niño*
- *el chico, por favor*

Before you move on

What was *ciccum*? (The papery skin in a pomegranate — a trifle.) What does *chico* mean before it means boy? (Small.) Is English *chick* related? (No — a false friend.)

308.4 la chica — the loan running backwards

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la chica — "the girl."
Same root, same switch. What is different is the direction of travel. Nearly every word so far has come *to* Spanish and *to* English out of Latin, or has been borrowed by English from somewhere older. *Chica* went the other way. American English took it directly from Spanish, in living memory, without translating it — and it is now printed in English dictionaries.
That happens far more than the Latin story suggests. English also took *plaza*, *patio*, *cargo*, *canyon* and *ranch* straight from Spanish. When you learn Spanish you are not only meeting new words; you are meeting the source of words you already own.
The **ch** is a single letter's worth of sound, exactly as in English *chair*.

What you've built

Fourteen words — and one that English got from Spanish, not the reverse.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la chica*
- *el chico y la chica*
- *la chica y la niña*

Before you move on

Which way did *chica* travel? (Spanish into English.) Name another word English took from Spanish. (*Plaza*, *patio*, *canyon*, *ranch*.) How is *ch* pronounced? (As in *chair*.)

308.5 la gente — everybody, from one clan

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la gente — "people."
Latin **gens** was a clan: everyone descended from a single ancestor. It is the word Rome used to sort its families, and it has been extremely busy in English.
Gentle meant "of good family" long before it meant "soft" — a *gentleman* was a man with a *gens* worth naming, and the softness is a later assumption about how such men behaved. *Genteel* is the same word borrowed a second time, through French. A *Gentile* is somebody of the other nations, the other clans. And *general* is what applies to the whole kind rather than one case.
Two things about using it. The **g** before an **e** is not the g of *gato* — it is the throat sound, the same as the j in *jota*. And *la gente* is grammatically singular even though it means many people, the way English treats *the public*.
So the word for everybody started as the word for one family.

What you've built

Fifteen words, and a root that has been hiding in English manners all along.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la gente*
- *la gente y la familia*
- *mucha gente, señora*

Before you move on

What was a *gens*? (A clan from one ancestor.) What did *gentle* originally mean? (Of good family.) How is the g in *gente* pronounced? (As a jota, not as in *gato*.)

Chapter 309

Naming the Whole — Family, Nickname, Relative, Partner, Baby

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a family, a partner, a relative and a baby in Spanish, and I can say what somebody is called by nickname as well as by name and surname.

Complete ES-C309-bebe: gather the whole household into one word, add the third kind of name, and close on the youngest person in the room.

309.1 la familia — the household, servants included

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la familia — "the family."
Latin **familia** did not mean what you think. It meant the whole household — the people, the servants, the property, everything under one roof and one authority. The root is **famulus**, "a servant." Blood was not the point; belonging to the house was.

English took the word and narrowed it to relatives. But the older sense survives in *familiar*: to be familiar with something is to be at home with it, and a *familiar* — in the old sense — was a spirit attached to a household.
The stress lands on the **i**: *fa-MI-lia*. The **-lia** at the end is one syllable, not two.
You now have a word that gathers up everything in the chapter before it.

What you've built

One word that holds all fifteen of the people you have named.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la familia*
- *la familia y la gente*
- *el apellido de la familia*

Before you move on

Who was in a Latin *familia*? (Everyone in the household, servants included.) What is a *famulus*? (A servant.) What does *familiar* really mean? (At home with something.)

309.2 el apodo — the name somebody reckoned for you

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el apodo — "the nickname."
It comes from *apodar*, "to nickname," and behind that sits Latin **putare**. *Putare* first meant to **prune** a tree — to cut it back into shape. From trimming a tree it moved to trimming a problem, and so to *reckon*, *judge*, *consider*.
English is full of the pruned version. To *compute* is to reckon together. To *dispute* is to reckon apart. Your *reputation* is what people reckon about you over and over. And to *amputate* is the oldest sense back again, cutting off.
So an *apodo* is a name somebody reckoned up for you — a judgement, trimmed to one word. Which is exactly what a nickname is.
Set it beside what you already have. Your *nombre* was given to you, your *apellido* was inherited, and your *apodo* was decided by other people.

What you've built

The third kind of name — and the only one you do not choose.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el apodo*
- *el nombre y el apodo*
- *el apodo del niño*

Before you move on

What did *putare* mean first? (To prune a tree.) How did it get to *compute*? (Pruning to reckoning.) Which of your three names do other people decide? (The *apodo*.)

309.3 el pariente — not the parent

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pariente — "the relative."
Latin **parere** meant to bring forth, to give birth. The one giving birth was a **parens**, and that is English *parent*. It is also *postpartum*, "after the bringing forth," and it is hiding inside *viper* — *vivipara*, the creature that bears its young alive.
Now the warning, and it matters more than the etymology. *Pariente* does **not** mean parent. It means any relative at all — the cousin, the aunt, the grandmother. This is your second false friend, and a sharper one than *chico*, because here the words really are related and the meanings still drifted apart.
One more caution, because the resemblance is very convincing. English *apparent* looks like it belongs here and does not: that is Latin *apparēre*, "to appear," a different verb that happens to look almost identical. Two Latin verbs, nearly the same shape, unrelated in sense. Related words can mislead you exactly because they are related.

What you've built

A word that means more than it looks like — and a caution about trusting resemblance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pariente*
- *el pariente y la familia*
- *un pariente, señor*

Before you move on

What did *parere* mean? (To bring forth.) Does *pariente* mean parent? (No — any relative.) Is *apparent* from the same verb? (No — a different Latin verb that looks alike.)

309.4 la pareja — two of equal weight

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la pareja — "the couple," or "the partner."
Latin **par** meant equal. *Pareja* is **paricula**, "a little equal" — two things matched in weight.
English is thick with it. A *pair* is two equals. *Par* in golf is the equal score. Your *peers* are your equals. *Parity* is the state of being equal. To *compare* is to set things side by side as equals.
The best one is *umpire*. It was **noumpere** in Middle English — *non par*, "not equal," the third person who is not on either side and can therefore decide. English then misheard *a noumpere* as *an oumpere*, and the n moved house. The word for the one who is not equal is built out of the word for equal.
So *pareja* says something specific about a couple: not one and one, but two of matching weight.

What you've built

Nineteen words, and a root that runs from golf to refereeing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la pareja*
- *la pareja y la familia*
- *mi pareja, encantado*

Before you move on

What does *par* mean? (Equal.) What is an *umpire* literally? (*Non par* — not equal, so able to decide.) What does *pareja* say about a

couple? (Two of matching weight.)

309.5 el bebé — the sound, not the word

Two from last time, before anything new is added.

Sounds you'll need

- Say it once slowly, then at speed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el bebé — "the baby."
Spanish took this from French **bébé**, and French did not take it from anywhere. It is echoic: the *b*-noise infants actually make, repeated. English *baby*, *babe* and *babble* are the same act of listening, done separately.
This closes the loop the chapter opened. *Niño* was babble too. The oldest and most careful words here — *esposo* from a Roman legal pledge, *gente* from a Roman clan register — are the formal ones. The words for the smallest people are noises.
Two points of form. The written accent on the final **é** pulls the stress to the last syllable: *be-BÉ*. Without it Spanish would stress the first. And *el bebé* stays masculine whoever the baby is; the word has a gender, the child need not match it.
You began this stretch able to give your own name. You can now name everyone else in the room.

What you've built

Twenty people named — and the last of them arrived as a sound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el bebé*
- *el bebé y la niña*
- *el nombre del bebé, por favor*

Before you move on

Where did *bebé* come from? (French, and before that nowhere — it is babble.) What does the accent do? (Pulls the stress to the last syllable.) Is *bebé* masculine for a girl too? (Yes — the word has a gender, the child need not match.)

Chapter 310

El Cuarto Y La Mesa — Key, Shower, Table, Light, Bathroom

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask a stranger in Spanish for the five things a room and a table make me ask for: the key, the shower, the table, the light and the bathroom.

Complete ES-C310-bano: ask for all five, ending with the question every traveller needs first — donde esta el bano.

310.1 la llave — the little key, and the three English words hiding it

Two repairs from last time, before anything new is added. Which one admits you have no answer? (*No sé.*) Which one asks a stranger for a meaning? (*¿Qué significa?*)

Sounds you'll need

- *LLA-ve*, stress on the first part. The *ll* is a *y*, so this begins the way *yes* begins. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la llave — "the key."
Latin **clavis** was the key. Spanish softened the *cl-* into that *ll-*, the same way *clamare* became *llamar*, and the shape of the old word all

but disappeared. English never softened it, so English is where you can still see it.
Look at your collarbone. It is the **clavicle** — the *little key* — because a Roman anatomist thought it turned like one where it meets the shoulder. Look at the start of a line of music: that is the **clef**, the key that unlocks which note each line means. And when cardinals are shut in a room to choose a pope, they are *cum clave*, **with a key** — in **conclave**.
Three English words, one Spanish word, one Latin key. You have carried *clavis* around in your own shoulder your whole life.
Say *la llave, por favor* at a hotel desk and you will be handed one.

What you've built

The first of the things you have to ask a stranger for.
Everything in this run is an object that somebody else is holding, and the only way to it is a question. That is why these words sit with your repair kit rather than apart from it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la llave*
- *la llave, por favor*
- *disculpe — la llave, por favor*
- *no sé. ¿qué significa?*

Before you move on

Which bone is named "the little key"? (The *clavicle*.) What is *la llave*? (The key.) And which two repairs opened this lesson? (*No sé* and *¿qué significa?*)

310.2 la ducha — a thing that leads water

Two from last time. Which English bone is the *little key*? (The *clavicle*, from the same *clavis* as *llave*.) And which question earns you a meaning from a stranger? (*¿Qué significa?*)

Sounds you'll need

- *DU-cha*, stress on the first part. The *d* is soft, closer to the *th* of *this* than to an English *d*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la ducha — "the shower."
Spanish borrowed this one from Italian *doccia*, a pipe or a spout, and Italian had it from Latin **ducere**: **to lead**.
That is the whole idea. A shower is not named for water and not named for washing. It is named for the fact that something **leads** the water to where you are standing.
Ducere is one of the busiest roots English owns. A **duct** leads air. An **aqueduct** leads water — *aqua* plus *ducere*, and the Romans built them for five hundred years. To **conduct** is to lead together; to **introduce** is to lead somebody in; to **produce** is to lead a thing forward into the world. And a **duke** is a *dux*, the one who leads.
A duke and a shower head, doing the same job.

What you've built

Two objects now, and both of them belong to somebody else.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la ducha*
- *la llave*, then *la ducha*
- *disculpe, ¿dónde está la ducha?*
- *¿qué significa?*

Before you move on

What did *ducere* mean? (To lead.) So what does an aqueduct do to water? (Leads it.) Which English title is the plain *dux*? (*Duke.*) And what is *la llave*? (The key.)

310.3 la mesa — the one word English took without changing a letter

Two from last time. What is *la llave*? (The key.) And what does a *ducha* do, going by its root? (It leads the water to you.)

Sounds you'll need

- *ME-sa*, stress on the first part. The *s* stays clear and hissed; it never buzzes into a *z*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la mesa — "the table."
Latin **mensa** was the table, and it sits next to *metiri*, "to measure." A *mensa* was a board **cut to a measure** — flat, level, and made so on purpose. Flatness is the whole of the word.
Which is why English has this one twice, and one of the two came the long way round. When English speakers reached the American southwest they found hills whose tops were sheared level, and they took the local Spanish word for it. A **mesa** in English is a flat-topped hill. It is *la mesa* with nothing changed — not the spelling, not the sound, not the idea. A table is a small flat top; a mesa is an enormous one.
The Latin sense survives too, in **commensal**: creatures that are *commensal* eat at one table.
Una mesa, por favor gets you seated.

What you've built

The key got you in, and the table is where the asking really starts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la mesa*
- *la mesa, por favor*
- *la llave*, then *la ducha*, then *la mesa*
- *disculpe, ¿dónde está la mesa?*

Before you move on

What is a *mesa* in English? (A flat-topped hill — the same word, untouched.) What did *mensa* have to do with measuring? (It was a board cut to a measure.) And which of your three words leads water? (*La ducha.*)

310.4 la luz — the word that clears things up

Two from last time. What does a *ducha* lead? (Water.) And which English word is *la mesa*, borrowed whole? (*Mesa*, the flat-topped hill.)

Sounds you'll need

- One syllable: *luz*. The final *z* is an *s* across the Americas and a *th* in much of Spain, and both are correct where they are said. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la luz — "the light."
Latin **lux** shows its fuller shape in the form *lucem*, and that *luc-* is what English borrowed, over and over.
Something **lucid** is lit from inside — clear enough to see through. Something **translucent** lets light *across* it. To **elucidate** is to bring light *out of* a thing, which is what a good explanation does. And the morning star was **Lucifer**, the *light-bearer*, before the name was given to anybody else.
There is a second, older link that is easy to miss. English **light** is not borrowed from Latin at all — it came down the Germanic side of the family. But go back far enough and *lux* and *light* meet at one ancient root meaning brightness. The two words have been apart for thousands of years and still mean the same thing.
No hay luz is what you say when the bulb is dead.

What you've built

Four objects, and this is the first one you ask about when it is missing rather than when you want it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la luz*
- *no hay luz*
- *disculpe — no hay luz. ayuda, por favor*
- *la ducha*, then *la mesa*, then *la luz*

Before you move on

What does *elucidate* do, literally? (Brings light out of something.) Is English *light* borrowed from *lux*? (No — it is a distant cousin, not a loan.) And what is *la mesa*? (The table.)

310.5 el baño — the question every traveller asks first

Two from last time. What is *la mesa*? (The table.) And what does *elucidate* do to a thing? (Brings light out of it, from the same *luc-* as *luz*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *BA-ño*, stress on the first part. The *ñ* is one sound, the *ny* in *canyon* — which is itself Spanish *cañón*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el baño — "the bathroom."
Latin **balneum** was the bath, and Latin had taken it from Greek *balaneion*, the bath house. Spanish wore *balneum* down to *baño*: the *l* fell out and the *-ne-* folded into that single *ñ*.
Now the trap, because it is worth naming. English **bath** looks like family. It is not. *Bath* came down the Germanic side and never met *balneum* at all. The honest English relative is the rare one: **balneology**, the study of baths and bathing waters, which is exactly *balneum* with a Greek ending stuck on.

Two words for the same room, sitting side by side for centuries, unrelated. When a pair looks obvious, that is precisely when it pays to check.
¿Dónde está el baño? is the sentence you will need before any other in this run, and you already have every piece of it.

What you've built

Five things a room and a table make you ask for: the key, the shower, the table, the light, the bathroom. None of them are yours until somebody tells you where they are.
That is the chapter. Next comes the shop, where the asking costs money.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el baño*
- *¿dónde está el baño?*
- *disculpe, ¿dónde está el baño?*
- *la mesa*, then *la luz*, then *el baño*
- *gracias*

Before you move on

Is English *bath* related to *baño*? (No — it only looks like it.) Which English word is the real relative? (*Balneology.*) And say the whole question one more time. (*¿Dónde está el baño?*)

Chapter 311

La Tienda Y La Cuenta — Shop, Bill, Price, Bag, Seat

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can carry out a transaction in Spanish: find the shop, ask the price, ask for the bill, ask for a bag and ask for a seat.
>
> *Complete ES-C311-asiento: walk in, ask the price, ask for the bill, take the bag and ask for a seat.*

311.1 la tienda — a shop that is really a stretched cloth

Two from last time. What is *la luz*? (The light.) And is English *bath* a relative of *baño*? (No — the real one is *balneology*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *TIEN-da*, stress on the first part. The *ie* is one glide, not two beats. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la tienda — "the shop."
Latin **tendere** meant **to stretch**, and a *tienda* is named for the cloth that was stretched over it. Before a shop was a building it was an awning in a market: a piece of canvas pulled tight over poles, with

goods laid out underneath. Spanish still uses *tienda* for the camping kind as well, which is the older sense showing through.
English holds the same root in a wide spread. A **tent** is the plain one — the stretched cloth itself. Something **tense** is pulled tight. To **extend** is to stretch out; to **intend** is to stretch your mind *toward* a thing; to **attend** is to stretch toward it and stay. And a **tendon** is the cord in your ankle that is stretched taut every time you take a step.
So a shop, a tent, an intention and an ankle are all one act: something pulled tight.

What you've built

The first word of the run where money changes hands.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la tienda*
- *¿dónde está la tienda?*
- *disculpe, ¿dónde está la tienda?*
- *la luz*, then *el baño*, then *la tienda*

Before you move on

What did *tendere* mean? (To stretch.) Which English word is the plain stretched cloth? (*Tent.*) And what is *el baño*? (The bathroom.)

311.2 la cuenta — one Latin verb, arriving in English twice

Two from last time. What is *el baño*? (The bathroom.) And what was a *tienda* before it was a shop? (A stretched cloth.)

Sounds you'll need

- *CUEN-ta*, stress on the first part. The *c* is hard, and *ue* is one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cuenta — "the bill."
Latin **computare** comes apart into *com-*, "together," and *putare*, "to reckon." To *computare* was to **reckon things up together** — to bring separate amounts into one number.
Here is the good part. English received this word **twice**, by two different roads, and did not notice they were the same.
Straight from Latin, late and in one piece, it arrived as **compute** — and from there, **computer**. Down through spoken Latin into French and then into English, worn smaller at every step, the same verb arrived as **count**, and with the prefix still attached, as **account** and **accountant**.
Compute and *count* are one word wearing different amounts of wear. A **computer** and an **accountant** have the same job description in Latin. Spanish kept the road that wears words down, which is how *computare* ends up as *cuenta*. Ask for it after a meal: *la cuenta, por favor.*

What you've built

A shop and a bill: the two halves of any transaction.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cuenta*
- *la cuenta, por favor*
- *disculpe — la cuenta, por favor*
- *el baño*, then *la tienda*, then *la cuenta*

Before you move on

Take *computare* apart. (*Com-* together, *putare* to reckon.) Which two English words are it, one worn and one not? (*Count* and *compute*.) And what is *la tienda*? (The shop.)

311.3 el precio — why praising somebody is pricing them

Two from last time. What was a *tienda* made of? (Stretched cloth.) And which two English words are both *computare*? (*Count* and *compute*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *PRE-cio*, stress on the first part. The *pr* runs together with no vowel between, and the *-cio* ending is one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el precio — "the price."
Latin **pretium** was **what a thing is worth**. Not the number on a tag: the worth itself, which the number is only a report of.
English carries the family in every register at once. **Price** is the plain transaction. A **prize** is a thing of worth handed over. Something **precious** has worth in it. To **appraise** is to set a worth on a thing, and to **appreciate** is to *raise* its worth — which is why a house appreciates and why appreciating a friend is a real compliment rather than a soft one.
And then the one that surprises people: **praise**. To praise somebody is *pretiare*, to put a value on them out loud. Praise is not decoration. It is an appraisal, said where the person can hear it.

What you've built

Shop, bill, price. You can now ask what a transaction costs before it happens rather than after.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el precio*
- *el precio, por favor*
- *disculpe — el precio, por favor*
- *la tienda*, then *la cuenta*, then *el precio*

Before you move on

What did *pretium* mean? (What a thing is worth.) What are you doing to somebody when you *praise* them, going by the root? (Putting a value on them.) And what is *la cuenta*? (The bill.)

311.4 la bolsa — a bag made of skin, and a word made of it too

Two from last time. What is *la cuenta*? (The bill.) And what are you really doing when you *praise* somebody? (Putting a value on them — *pretium*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *BOL-sa*, stress on the first part. The *b* between vowels is soft, with the lips barely closing. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la bolsa — "the bag."
Latin **bursa** was a leather bag, and Latin had taken it from Greek *byrsa*, a stripped **hide**. Before a bag was cloth or paper it was skin, because skin was what came off the animal already waterproof and already the right size.
English took *bursa* through French and made **purse** of it. Then it took the Latin form again, unworn, for the offices that handle money: a **bursar** keeps a college's purse, and a **bursary** is what the purse pays out. To **disburse** is to pay *out of* the bag; to **reimburse** is to put back *into* it. Every one of those words is a hide.

Spanish uses *bolsa* for the shopping bag you are handed at a counter, and — in exactly the same logic English used for *purse* — for the stock exchange, the place where the money bag of a whole country is opened.

What you've built

You can be given the bag as well as the bill now.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la bolsa*
- *la bolsa, por favor*
- *disculpe — la bolsa, por favor*
- *la cuenta*, then *el precio*, then *la bolsa*

Before you move on

What was a *byrsa*? (A stripped hide.) What does a *bursar* look after? (The purse.) And what is *el precio*? (The price.)

311.5 el asiento — everything that settles

Two from last time. What is *el precio*? (The price.) And what was a *bolsa* made of, at the start? (A hide.)

Sounds you'll need

- *a-SIEN-to*, stress on the middle. Four letters do the middle syllable and it is still one beat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el asiento — "the seat."
Under it is Latin **sedere**, **to sit**, with *ad-* in front: to sit down *to* something. Spanish built the verb *asentar* and then this noun off it. *Sedere* has settled into English everywhere. Work that keeps you in a chair is **sedentary**. What settles to the bottom of a river is **sediment**.

A **session** is a sitting — of a court, a parliament, a band. To **reside** is to sit *back*, to stay put in a place. A bishop's **see** is his seat, which is why the Vatican is the Holy See rather than the Holy Anything Else. And **assess**: *ad-* plus *sedere* again, the same build as *asiento*. An assessor was the official who **sat beside** the judge and set the tax. To assess is not to look from above. It is to sit next to a thing and reckon it.
Un asiento, por favor is how you ask for a place on a bus.

What you've built

Five words for a transaction: the shop, the bill, the price, the bag, the seat. Between them they cover walking in, paying, carrying it out and sitting down.
Next comes what you are carrying while you do it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el asiento*
- *un asiento, por favor*
- *disculpe — un asiento, por favor*
- *el precio*, then *la bolsa*, then *el asiento*
- *gracias*

Before you move on

What does an assessor do, literally? (Sits beside.) Which English word means work done in a chair? (*Sedentary.*) And what is *la bolsa*? (The bag.)

Chapter 312

Lo Que Llevas — Clock, Phone, Suitcase, Map, Letter

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name and ask for the five things I travel with in Spanish: the clock, the phone, the suitcase, the map and the letter.
>
> *Complete ES-C312-carta: ask for each of the five carried things, and ask for the menu by the same word.*

312.1 el reloj — the hour-teller, squeezed down to two syllables

Two from last time. What is *la bolsa*? (The bag.) And what does an assessor do, going by the root? (Sits beside.)

Sounds you'll need

- *re-LOJ*, stress on the end. The initial *r* is rolled, and the final *j* is that scraped sound at the back of the throat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el reloj — "the clock," and also the watch on your wrist.
Behind it is **horologium**, which Latin had from Greek: *hōra*, the **hour**, plus a stem meaning **to tell**. A clock is an **hour-teller**. That is

the entire description, and it is still accurate.
Spanish reached *reloj* by way of Catalan *relotge*, and you can watch the word lose weight at every step. *Horologium* has five syllables. *Relotge* has three. *Reloj* has two. The *h-* went, the *-ium* went, the middle collapsed. What is left is barely recognisable — until you know what to look for.
The *hōra* half is easy to find in English. An **hour** is one. **Horology** is the study of timekeeping, and a **horologist** repairs watches. A **horoscope** is an *hour-watcher*: the reading of which sky stood over the hour you were born.

What you've built

The first of the things already in your pocket rather than behind a counter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el reloj*
- *el reloj, por favor*
- *disculpe, ¿dónde está el reloj?*
- *la bolsa*, then *el asiento*, then *el reloj*

Before you move on

What does *horologium* mean, taken apart? (Hour-teller.) What is a horoscope watching? (The hour.) And what is *el asiento*? (The seat.)

312.2 el teléfono — a far-voice, and where both halves went

Two from last time. What is *el asiento*? (The seat.) And what does a *reloj* tell, going by its root? (The hour.)

Sounds you'll need

- *te-LÉ-fo-no*. The written accent is doing real work: it tells you the stress lands three syllables from the end, which Spanish always marks. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el teléfono — "the telephone."
Two Greek pieces, and neither is old in this combination. **Tele** means **far**. **Phone** means **voice** or **sound**. A telephone is a **far-voice**, and the word was built in the nineteenth century by people who needed a name for a thing that had never existed.
That is what makes it useful: both halves are still productive, so knowing them unlocks a shelf of words rather than one.
Tele- puts distance in front of anything. A **telescope** looks far. A **telegram** writes far. **Television** sees far. **Telepathy** feels far.
-Phone puts sound at the end. **Phonetics** is the study of speech sounds. A **megaphone** is a big sound. A **microphone** is a small one made large. A **symphony** is sounds *together*. **Cacophony** is sounds gone wrong.
Spanish and English built this word out of the same two bricks at almost the same moment, which is why it needs no translation at all.

What you've built

Two pocket objects, and a pair of Greek pieces that will keep paying.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el teléfono*
- *el teléfono, por favor*
- *disculpe — el teléfono, por favor*
- *el asiento*, then *el reloj*, then *el teléfono*

Before you move on

What do *tele* and *phone* each mean? (Far, and voice.) What is a symphony, taken apart? (Sounds together.) And what is *el reloj*? (The clock.)

312.3 la maleta — the bag that gave its name to the post

Two from last time. What is *el reloj*? (The clock.) And what does *tele-* mean in front of a word? (Far.)

Sounds you'll need

- *ma-LE-ta*, stress on the middle. The single *l* is clear and light, made at the front of the mouth. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la maleta — "the suitcase."
The *-eta* on the end is a diminutive: a *maleta* is a **little mala**. So what was a *mala*?
Not a Latin word at all. **Mala** was Gaulish — the language spoken across France before Latin arrived — and it meant a bag or a sack. Latin borrowed it from the people it had conquered, French kept it as *male*, and Spanish took the small version.
Now follow the same bag into English. A rider carrying letters between towns carried them in a *male* — a leather sack strapped behind the saddle. The sack was the visible thing, so people named the service after it. The letters became **the mail**.
English *mail*, then, is not about letters and never was. It is a bag. Your suitcase and your inbox are the same Gaulish sack, and one of them still admits it.

What you've built

Three things you carry, and one of them just explained a word you use every day in English.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la maleta*
- *la maleta, por favor*
- *disculpe — la maleta, por favor*
- *el reloj*, then *el teléfono*, then *la maleta*

Before you move on

What was a *mala*? (A Gaulish bag.) Why is the post called *mail*? (Because the letters rode in that bag.) And what is *el teléfono*, taken apart? (A far-voice.)

312.4 el mapa — the world, drawn on a napkin

Two from last time. What is a *teléfono*, in its two Greek pieces? (A far-voice.) And why is the post called *mail*? (It is named after the bag.)

Sounds you'll need

- *MA-pa*, stress on the first part. It ends in *-a* and takes *el*, which is worth noticing rather than fighting. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el mapa — "the map."
Latin **mappa** meant a **cloth** — a napkin, a signalling flag, a sheet of fabric. The Romans had probably taken the word from Punic, the language of Carthage.
A medieval world map was called a *mappa mundi*: the **cloth of the world**. Not because the drawing was clever but because the surface was linen. Paper was scarce and small; cloth came in sheets big enough to hold an ocean. English then kept only the first half of the phrase, and *mappa* alone came to mean the drawing rather than the fabric.
The other half of *mappa* went into the kitchen. French turned it into *nappe*, a tablecloth, with the *m* worn down to *n* — and English

borrowed the little version as **napkin**. It even got a second one by accident: *a napron* was misheard as *an apron*, and English has said *apron* ever since.
A map, a napkin and an apron. One Latin cloth, three jobs.

What you've built

Four carried things, and two of them turned out to be bags and cloths rather than the objects you thought.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el mapa*
- *el mapa, por favor*
- *disculpe — el mapa, por favor*
- *el teléfono*, then *la maleta*, then *el mapa*

Before you move on

What did *mappa* mean? (A cloth.) Which two kitchen words come off it? (*Napkin* and *apron*.) And what is *la maleta*? (The suitcase.)

312.5 la carta — one sheet of papyrus, six English words

Two from last time. What is *la maleta*? (The suitcase.) And what was a *mappa*? (A cloth.)

Sounds you'll need

- *CAR-ta*, stress on the first part. The *r* is a single tap of the tongue, not a roll. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la carta — "the letter," and on a table, "the menu."
Latin **charta** came from Greek *khartēs*: a **sheet of papyrus**. The word named the material, and everything since has been named after the material.
English has the sheet six ways over. A **chart** is a sheet with information on it. A **charter** is a sheet with rights on it, which is why a town could be granted one. **Cartography** is sheet-drawing. A **carton** is a stiffened sheet folded into a box. A **cartoon** was originally the full-size drawing on a sheet that a painter worked out before touching the wall. And a **card** is a small stiff one.
You have met this sheet's cousin already. *El papel* is named after the papyrus plant; *la carta* is named after the sheet cut from it. The plant and the sheet became two different words, and Spanish uses both.
On a menu the logic is unchanged. *La carta* is the sheet the dishes are written on, and *a la carta* means chosen off that sheet.

What you've built

Five things you carry: the clock, the phone, the suitcase, the map, the letter. Four of the five turned out to be named after the stuff they were made of rather than the job they do.
Next comes the counter, where you hand these over.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la carta*
- *la carta, por favor*
- *disculpe — la carta, por favor*
- *la maleta*, then *el mapa*, then *la carta*
- *gracias*

Before you move on

What was a *khartēs*? (A sheet of papyrus.) What was a *cartoon* before it was funny? (A full-size drawing on a sheet.) And what is *el mapa*? (The map.)

Chapter 313

El Mostrador — Ticket, Coin, Passport, Entrance, Change

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can get through a counter in Spanish: ask for the ticket, hand over the passport, find the entrance and ask for my change.

Complete ES-C313-cambio: ask for a ticket, produce the passport, find the entrance and ask for the change owed.

313.1 el boleto — a little seal, and what it authorises

Two from last time. What was a *mappa*? (A cloth.) And what is *la carta*, on a table? (The menu — the sheet the dishes are on.)

Sounds you'll need

- *bo-LE-to*, stress on the middle. Every vowel is short and clean; none of them drift. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el boleto — "the ticket."
Latin **bulla** started as a bubble or a round boss, and then became the thing that mattered: the **lead seal** hung on a document to prove it

was genuine. The seal was the authority. The words were only what the seal was vouching for.
Italian made *bulletta*, a little sealed slip, and Spanish took it as *boleto*. A ticket is a small document with something official pressed into it. That is still exactly what it is.
English kept the seal in two places. A **bulletin** is a *little bulla* — a short notice issued with authority. And a papal **bull** is named after the lead seal swinging from its ribbon, not after anything in the text.
One note on geography, since you will meet both. Spain mostly says *billete*; most of Latin America says *boleto*. They are the same *bulla*, borrowed at different times down different roads. Either will be understood; *boleto* is the one to carry across the Americas.

What you've built

The first word at the counter, and it is a seal rather than a slip of paper.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el boleto*
- *el boleto, por favor*
- *disculpe — el boleto, por favor*
- *el mapa*, then *la carta*, then *el boleto*

Before you move on

What was a *bulla*? (A lead seal on a document.) Why is a papal bull called that? (For its seal.) And what is *la carta*? (The letter, or the menu.)

313.2 la moneda — money is named after a goddess who gave warnings

Two from last time. What is *la carta*? (The letter, or the menu.) And what was a *bulla*? (A lead seal.)

Sounds you'll need

- *mo-NE-da*, stress on the middle. The *d* between vowels is soft, the tongue barely touching. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la moneda — "the coin."
This one is a place, and the place is named after a goddess.
Latin *monere* meant **to warn**. One of Juno's titles was **Moneta**, "she who warns" — the story is that her sacred geese warned Rome of an attack in the night. Rome built her a temple on the Capitoline hill, and in that temple, for reasons of security rather than religion, the city set up its coin works.
So the coins came out of the *Moneta*. And the name of the building became the name of what the building produced.
English got it twice again, by the two familiar roads. Through French, worn down: **money**. Through Germanic mouths, worn differently: **mint**, the place coins are struck. Money and a mint are one goddess. Her verb is still in English too, unchanged in sense. A **monitor** warns you. To **admonish** is to warn somebody toward something. A **monument** is a warning left standing so nobody forgets.

What you've built

A ticket and a coin: the two things that cross a counter in opposite directions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la moneda*
- *una moneda, por favor*
- *disculpe — una moneda, por favor*
- *la carta*, then *el boleto*, then *la moneda*

Before you move on

What did *monere* mean? (To warn.) Which two English words are both *moneta*? (*Money* and *mint*.) And what is *el boleto*? (The ticket.)

313.3 el pasaporte — a word that is its own instructions

Two from last time. What was a *bulla*? (A lead seal.) And which two English words are the goddess *Moneta*? (*Money* and *mint*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-sa-POR-te*, stress on the third of four. Every *s* stays clear and hissed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pasaporte — "the passport."
Two pieces, both of which you can see without help. *Pasar*, **to pass**, and *porte*, from Latin **porta**, a **gate**. A passport is the paper that lets you **pass the gate**. It was originally permission to leave through a city's walls, not permission to enter a country.
Passus was a **step** in Latin — the pace of a marching legion, and the unit Roman roads were measured in. English keeps the step in **pace**, in **pass**, and in a **passage**, which is the place stepping happens.
Porta you have met before, standing in the harbour. A **port** is a gate for ships. A **portal** is a grand one. A **porch** is the little roofed gate of a house, and a **portico** its columned cousin.
Put the two back together and the word tells you its own job: step, gate, permission. Very few words are this honest.

What you've built

Ticket, coin, passport. The counter is nearly complete.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pasaporte*
- *el pasaporte, por favor*
- *un momento — el pasaporte*
- *el boleto*, then *la moneda*, then *el pasaporte*

Before you move on

Take *pasaporte* apart. (Pass, plus gate.) What was a *passus*? (A step.) And what is *la moneda*? (The coin.)

313.4 la entrada — the way in, and the paper that buys it

Two from last time. Which two English words are the goddess *Moneta*? (*Money* and *mint*.) And what does *pasaporte* say it does? (Lets you pass the gate.)

Sounds you'll need

- *en-TRA-da*, stress on the middle. The *r* in *tra* is a single tap, quick and light. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la entrada — "the entrance," and also the ticket that gets you in. Latin **intrare**, to go in, was built on *intra*, **within**. Everything here is the idea of being inside a boundary rather than outside it.

English took the verb through French and softened it: **enter**. The noun kept more of the shape — an **entrance**, an **entry**. And the raw Latin *intra-* stayed raw wherever precision mattered: **intramural** means within the walls, **intravenous** within the vein, **interior** the inside itself.

Spanish does something neat with *entrada* that English splits into two words. The place you go in is *la entrada*. The ticket that permits it is also *la entrada*. One word for the door and the right to use the door, which saves you learning a second.

Notice how it sits beside the last two. *El boleto* rides you somewhere. *La entrada* lets you in. *El pasaporte* gets you past a border. Three

permissions, three different edges.

What you've built

Four at the counter, and three of them are permissions rather than objects.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la entrada*
- *una entrada, por favor*
- *disculpe, ¿dónde está la entrada?*
- *la moneda*, then *el pasaporte*, then *la entrada*

Before you move on

What does *intra* mean? (Within.) What does *intramural* mean, literally? (Within the walls.) And what is *el pasaporte* made of, in two pieces? (Pass, and gate.)

313.5 el cambio — a Gaulish word that outlived Gaulish

Two from last time. What does *pasaporte* say it does? (Lets you pass the gate.) And what does *la entrada* name, besides the door? (The ticket that lets you through it.)

Sounds you'll need

- *CAM-bio*, stress on the first part. The *-bio* ending is one glide, and the *b* after *m* closes the lips fully. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cambio — "the change."
Late Latin had the verb **cambiare**, to exchange one thing for another.

But Latin did not build it. Latin **borrowed** it, from Gaulish — the Celtic language spoken across what is now France before the legions arrived.
That is worth sitting with. Gaulish died, and what survives of it is a handful of inscriptions. Yet Rome took this one verb, and Rome's daughters carried it everywhere: Spanish *cambiar*, French *changer*, Italian *cambiare*. English took the French form and made **change** of it, then **exchange** and **changeling**.
Every time an English speaker says *change*, a dead language is being spoken.
Spanish uses *el cambio* for the act and for the result: the rate at a bank window, and the coins pressed back into your hand at a till.

What you've built

Twenty words across four runs, and every one is something a stranger is holding.
The repairs kept an exchange alive; these give it something to be about. A noun after *por favor* is a request in Spanish, and that is what this node is for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cambio*
- *¿y el cambio?*
- *disculpe — el cambio, por favor*
- *el pasaporte*, then *la entrada*, then *el cambio*
- *gracias*

Before you move on

Which dead language gave Latin *cambiare*? (Gaulish.) What two things does *el cambio* name? (The exchange, and the coins handed back.) And what is *la entrada*? (The entrance, or the ticket in.)

Chapter 314

The Body, Further Down — Arm, Leg, Foot, Tooth, Ear

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the arm, the leg, the foot, the tooth and the hearing in Spanish.
>
> *Complete ES-C314-oido: name all five in order, from the arm at the top to the hearing you cannot point at.*

314.1 el brazo — the arm that was only ever the shorter one

Two from last time, before a new run starts. Which of your five answers refuses to change for a woman? (*Triste* — it ends in *-e*.) And which one means your hands are full? (*Ocupado*.)

What to know first

- la mano — one end of it.
- el hombro — the other end.

Sounds you'll need

- *BRA-zo*, two beats, stress on the first. The *r* is a single tap against the ridge behind your teeth. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el brazo — "the arm."
Greek **brakhion** was a comparative. It meant "the shorter one." Greek anatomists used it for the upper arm — the shorter half of the limb — and the name stuck to a body part for a reason nobody feels any more. Latin borrowed it as **bracchium** and dropped the comparison entirely. By the time Spanish had it, *brazo* was the whole arm, shoulder to hand.
English holds three pieces of it. A **brace** was armour for the arm before it was anything that holds a thing steady. A **bracelet** is a little *brace*. And to **embrace** somebody is to put them *in* your arms: *em-* is *in*, and *brace* is this word.
So *el hombro*, then *el brazo*, then *la mano*. You have the whole limb now, top to bottom.

What you've built

Five more of the body begin here.
The first three walk you from the shoulder to the ground; the last two are smaller and harder to point at.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el brazo*
- *el brazo y la mano*
- *el hombro*, then *el brazo*

Before you move on

What did *brakhion* mean before it meant an arm? (The shorter one.) And what are you doing when you *embrace* somebody? (Putting them in your arms.)

314.2 la pierna — a ham, put back on the body

Which English word is *bracchium*, worn down and put on a wrist? (*Bracelet.*) And why does *triste* not change for a woman? (It ends in *-e.*)

What to know first

- el brazo — the same idea, upper storey.
- la rodilla — the hinge in the middle of this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *PIER-na*, two beats. The *ie* is one slide, not two vowels. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la pierna — "the leg."
Latin **perna** was a ham. Not a leg: a *cut*. The haunch of a pig, salted and hung from a beam. Spanish took the butcher's word and put it back on the living body — which is the opposite of the usual direction, where a piece of an animal gets named after the human part it resembles.
Watch the *e* break to *ie* on the way: *perna* becomes *pierna*. That is the same crack you tracked through *cielo*, *miel* and *piel*. A stressed *e* in Latin, an *ie* in Spanish, every time.
Spanish is nearly alone in using this word. Italian says *gamba* and French says *jambe*, both from Late Latin **camba**, a hock. English quietly holds that one instead: the **jamb** of a door is its leg, and to **gambol** is to kick yours about.

What you've built

Two of the limb, and a second sighting of the *ie* crack.
Piel, *pierna*: put an *e* back where the *ie* is and the Latin usually shows itself. It will happen twice more before this chapter is out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la pierna*
- *la pierna y la rodilla*
- *el brazo*, then *la pierna*

Before you move on

What was a *perna*? (A ham — the cut.) What happened to its *e*? (It broke into *ie*.) And which English door-part is the other Latin word for a leg? (The *jamb*.)

314.3 el pie — one syllable, and half the world says it

Which body part is a ham? (*La pierna*.) And what is *em-brace* doing, literally? (Putting somebody in your arms.)

What to know first

- la pierna — what this one is on the end of.
- el tobillo — the joint just above it.

Sounds you'll need

- *PIE*, one beat. Two letters of vowel, one slide, no second syllable. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pie — "the foot."
Latin **pedem** — and *pedem* goes back a very long way before Latin. The root under it is *ped-*, and it is one of the oldest things anybody can reconstruct: old enough that it survives, recognisably, across most of Europe and a good part of Asia.
English took it three separate times.
Through Latin: **pedal**, **pedestrian**, **pedestal**, and **pedigree**, which is French *pied de grue*, "a crane's foot" — the three-line mark that shows descent on a family tree.
Through Greek, where *ped-* had become *pod-*: **podium**, **tripod**, **octopus**.
And through Germanic, where an old sound shift turned every *p* into an *f*: **foot**.
So *pie*, *foot*, *podium* and *pedal* are four faces of one word.
It reaches further than Europe. Hindi says *pair*. Persian says *pa*.

Those are not borrowings from anybody — they are cousins, descended in parallel from the same root, and they have been apart for perhaps five thousand years.
Latin *pedem* lost its ending and broke its *e*, exactly as *perna* did.

What you've built

The bottom of the body, and the widest-travelled word you have met. Most words here connect Spanish to English. This one connects Spanish to Hindi and Persian as well.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pie*
- *el tobillo y el pie*
- *la pierna*, then *el pie*

Before you move on

Which English word is *ped-* after the Germanic *p* turned to *f*? (*Foot.*) What is a *pedigree* named after? (A crane's foot.) And name one language outside Europe that kept the root. (Hindi *pair*, or Persian *pa.*)

314.4 el diente — the tooth in the dandelion

Which one word is Spanish, Hindi and Persian all at once? (*Pie.*) And what was a *perna*? (A ham.)

What to know first

- la boca — where these live.
- el dolor — what sends you to somebody about one.

Sounds you'll need

- *DIEN-te*, two beats. The *d* is soft, tongue against the very teeth it names. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el diente — "the tooth."
Latin **dentem**, and the *e* breaks to *ie* one more time. That is the fourth time in two chapters. It is not a coincidence and it is not a list to memorise — it is one rule, doing its work.
English has the Latin form wherever teeth are being discussed carefully: **dental**, **dentist**, **denture**. It also has it where nobody notices. To **indent** a line is to put a *tooth* in the margin. A **dent** in a car door is a tooth-mark.
And then there is the flower. French called it *dent de lion*, "lion's tooth", for the row of jagged points down each leaf. English heard the French and wrote it down the way it sounded: **dandelion**.
Meanwhile Germanic did to *dent-* exactly what it did to *ped-*. The *d* softened, the ending wore away, and out came **tooth**. *Diente* and *tooth* are the same word, two sound shifts apart — the same trick you saw one lesson ago with *pie* and *foot*.

What you've built

Four of the body, and a second matched pair.
Pie and *foot*. *Diente* and *tooth*. Once you can hear that shift, the Germanic half of English stops looking unrelated to the Latin half.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el diente*
- *la boca y el diente*
- *el pie*, then *el diente*

Before you move on

What is a dandelion named for? (A lion's tooth — the jagged leaf.) What does *indent* put in the margin? (A tooth.) And which English word is *diente* after the Germanic shift? (*Tooth.*)

314.5 el oído — the hearing, made into a thing

What is a dandelion? (A lion's tooth.) And which Spanish word do Hindi and Persian also say? (*Pie.*)

What to know first

- oír — the verb this is the past participle of.
- la garganta — another part you cannot see.

Sounds you'll need

- *o-Í-do*, three beats. The accent on the *í* holds the *o* and the *í* apart, so this is not a diphthong. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el oído — "the ear," or more exactly, "the hearing."
You already have the verb *oír*, "to hear." *Oído* is its past participle — "heard" — and Spanish has taken that participle and stood it up as a noun.
So *el oído* is not the flap on the side of your head. Spanish has a separate word for that. *El oído* is the inner ear and the sense itself: the hearing, the thing that works or does not.
Under both of them sits Latin **audire**, one of the most productive roots English owns. **Audio** is "I hear." An **audience** is a hearing. An **audition** is a hearing. An **auditorium** is a room for hearing in. An **auditor** checks accounts by *listening* to them read aloud, which is how it was done before most people could read.
The best of them is **obedient**. It is *ob-audire*: to listen *toward* somebody. Obedience, in Latin, was never more than paying close attention.

What you've built

Five of the body, and the chapter closes.
Four of them you can point at. The fifth is a faculty — and it is the one carrying the largest family in English.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el oído*
- *el diente*, then *el oído*
- *el brazo, la pierna, el pie, el diente, el oído*

Before you move on

What part of speech was *oído* before it was a noun? (A past participle — "heard".) What is an *auditor* doing, in the old sense? (Listening to the accounts read aloud.) And what is *obedient*, taken apart? (Listening toward somebody.)

Chapter 315

What the Body Feels — Chest, Strength, Rest, Fear, Laughter

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the chest, and say strength, rest, fear and laughter in Spanish.
>
> *Complete ES-C315-risa: name all five, and say which two of them are opposites.*

315.1 el pecho — the chest you can run backwards

What is an *audience*, literally? (A hearing.) And what flower is a lion's tooth? (The dandelion.)

What to know first

- la noche — took the same road out of Latin.
- la espalda — the other side of this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *PE-cho*, two beats. The *ch* is the *ch* of English *church*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pecho — "the chest."
Latin **pectus**. The thing to watch is the middle of it: a Latin *ct* comes out as a Spanish *ch*, and it does so with almost no exceptions.
You have already met the result without being handed the rule. Latin *noctem* is *la noche*. Latin *octo* is *ocho*. Latin *factum* is *hecho*. Latin *lactem* is *leche*. And Latin *pectus* is *el pecho*.
So when a Spanish word has *ch* in the middle, there is usually a Latin *ct* underneath it — and usually an English word sitting on that *ct*: *nocturnal*, *octave*, *fact*, *lactose*, **pectoral**.
The strangest survivor is medical. To **expectorate** is to cough something up: *ex-pectore*, "out of the chest." It is a very long word for a very short act, and it is built on this one.

What you've built

The chest, and a rule you can run in either direction.
Ch in the middle of a Spanish word, *ct* in the Latin behind it, and an English word usually waiting on the far side.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pecho*
- *el pecho y la espalda*
- *el oído*, then *el pecho*

Before you move on

What does Latin *ct* become in Spanish? (*Ch.*) Which word for a time of day proves it? (*La noche*, from *noctem.*) And what does *expectorate* mean, taken apart? (Out of the chest.)

315.2 la fuerza — the strength inside comfort

What does Latin *ct* turn into? (*Ch.*) And what is an *audition*? (A hearing.)

What to know first

- el sueño — its *o* broke the same way.
- enfermo — the state where this runs short.

Sounds you'll need

- *FUER-za*, two beats. One slide through the middle, not two vowels. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la fuerza — "the strength," "the force."
Latin **fortis** meant strong. Its abstract noun **fortia** meant strength. Spanish broke the stressed *o* into *ue*, exactly as *somnus* became *el sueño*: *fortia* becomes *fuerza*.
That is the other crack, and now you have both of them.
A stressed *e* goes to *ie*: *piel*, *pierna*, *pie*, *diente*. A stressed *o* goes to *ue*: *sueño*, *fuerza*. Two vowels, two breaks, and between them they account for a very large share of the Spanish dictionary.
English has *fortis* lying in the open. A **fort** is a strong place. To **fortify** is to make strong. **Force** is *fortia* itself, arrived through French. An **effort** is strength put *out*.
And then **comfort**. It is *com-fortare*: to strengthen thoroughly. To comfort somebody was not originally to soothe them — it was to put strength into them. The soft modern sense is a late arrival, and *la fuerza* is the word still sitting underneath it.

What you've built

Both cracks, fully stated.
E breaks to *ie*. *O* breaks to *ue*. Every word in these two chapters that could take one has taken it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la fuerza*
- *no tengo fuerza*
- *el pecho*, then *la fuerza*

Before you move on

What did *fortis* mean? (Strong.) What is *comfort*, taken apart? (To strengthen thoroughly.) And which break turned *fortia* into *fuerza*? (*O* to *ue*.)

315.3 el descanso — the undoing of tiredness

What is *comfort* built on? (*Fortis* — strong.) And what does a Spanish *ch* usually sit on in Latin? (A *ct*.)

What to know first

- la fuerza — what this gives back.
- el sueño — a deeper version of the same thing.

Sounds you'll need

- *des-CAN-so*, three beats, stress in the middle. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el descanso — "the rest," "the break."
This one is assembled in front of you. *Cansar* is "to tire." *Des-* undoes a verb. *Descansar* is "to un-tire," and *el descanso* is the noun: the pause in which the un-tiring happens.
Spanish does not name rest as a thing in its own right. It names it by what it reverses. Rest is the taking-back-off of tiredness.
Cansar has a stranger history than it looks. It is Latin **campsare**, "to turn about, to double back" — a sailor's word for rounding a headland — and Latin had it from Greek **kamptein**, to bend. A ship that had rounded the cape had done the hard part of the voyage. From "turned the corner" to "worn out by turning it" is a short walk, and Spanish walked it.
English has no everyday descendant of *kamptein*, so there is no cognate to collect here. What there is instead is the seam. *Des-* is the same prefix as English **dis-**, so *descanso* is built exactly like *disarm*, *disband* and *dislodge*: a verb with its work run backwards.

What you've built

A word you could have assembled yourself.
Des- is English *dis-*. Once you can see that seam, a large family of Spanish verbs comes apart in your hands.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el descanso*
- *un descanso, por favor*
- *la fuerza*, then *el descanso*

Before you move on

What does *des-* do to a verb? (Undoes it.) What is *cansar*? (To tire.) And what was *campsare*, at sea? (To round a headland.)

315.4 el miedo — the fear inside meticulous

What does *des-* do? (Undoes the verb.) And what is an *effort*? (Strength put out.)

What to know first

- tranquilo — its opposite.
- triste — its neighbour.

Sounds you'll need

- *MIE-do*, two beats. The *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* of *this*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el miedo — "the fear."
Latin **metus**, and the *e* breaks to *ie* once more. That is the fifth time. By now you should expect it before you are told.

English has one descendant of *metus* and it is well hidden: **meticulous**. It is *metus* plus *-culosus*, "full of fear." A meticulous person was, in Latin, a frightened one — somebody so afraid of getting it wrong that they checked everything twice, and then checked it again. English kept the checking and let the fear go. *Meticulous* is now a compliment. But the dread is still down in the word, and *el miedo* is the part that got left behind.
It sits neatly among what you already have. *Tranquilo* is its opposite. *Triste* is its neighbour.

What you've built

The fifth *ie*, and the darker half of this chapter.
One more feeling closes it out — and it is the opposite of this one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el miedo*
- *tengo miedo*
- *el descanso*, then *el miedo*

Before you move on

What did *meticulous* mean in Latin? (Full of fear.) What is the Latin behind *miedo*? (*Metus.*) And which of your five answers is its opposite? (*Tranquilo.*)

315.5 la risa — the laugh under ridicule

What is *meticulous*, in Latin? (Full of fear.) And what does *des-* do to *cansar*? (Undoes the tiring.)

What to know first

- contento — the state this comes out of.
- el miedo — what it is furthest from.

Sounds you'll need

- *RI-sa*, two beats. An *r* at the start of a word is rolled, not tapped. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la risa — "the laughter."
Latin **ridere** was "to laugh," and **risus** was the laugh itself. Spanish kept both halves cleanly: *reír* to laugh, *la risa* the laughter.
English took the root, and took it badly. Every descendant it kept is unkind. To **ridicule** somebody is to laugh at them. To **deride** is *de-ridere*, to laugh *down* at them. **Derision** is the noun for doing it. **Risible** means laughable, and it has never once been a compliment.
So English has four words from *ridere* and not one of them is a happy laugh. Spanish has *la risa*, which is the ordinary, warm, unloaded word — the sound a room makes when something is funny.
That is worth noticing about borrowing generally. A language rarely takes a whole word. It takes one *use* of the word, and the use it takes is very often the sharp one.

What you've built

Ten of the body and what it feels.
And a hinge. The next chapter opens on the other side of this word — what the face does when the laughing stops.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la risa*
- *la risa y el miedo*
- *el pecho, la fuerza, el descanso, el miedo, la risa*

Before you move on

What was *risus*? (The laugh.) Name an English word from *ridere*. (*Ridicule*, *deride*, *derision* or *risible*.) And what do all of them have in common? (Not one is kind.)

Chapter 316

Never, Always, All, Nothing

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can answer with never, always, all and nothing in Spanish.
>
> *Complete ES-C316-nada: put nunca and siempre against la risa and el llanto, then close the line with todo and nada.*

316.1 el llanto — the beating of the chest

> Which English words come from *ridere*? (*Ridicule*, *deride*, *risible*.) And what was a *meticulous* Roman? (A frightened one.)

What to know first

- la risa — the other half of this pair.
- el pecho — what the Latin says you are striking.

Sounds you'll need

- *LLAN-to*, two beats. The *ll* is a *y*, as in *calle*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el llanto — "the weeping."
Latin **plangere** meant "to strike, to beat." **Planctus** was the noun: a beating. And Roman mourning was a physical performance — you struck your own chest, hard, in public, where people could see you do

it. The word for the grief is the word for the blow.
So *el llanto* is built on *el pecho*, which you learned five lessons ago. The chest is inside the etymology.
Two things happened on the way into Spanish. The ending wore off, and the *pl-* turned into *ll-*. That second change is a Spanish specialty and it is very regular. Latin *pluvia* is *la lluvia*. Latin *plenus* is *lleno*. Latin *plorare* is *llorar*. Latin *flamma* is *la llama*. Any Spanish word beginning *ll-* is worth testing for a Latin *pl-* or *fl-* underneath it.
English kept *plangere* twice. To **complain** is *com-plangere*, to beat the breast thoroughly — which tells you how seriously the Romans took complaining. And **plangent**, said of a sound, means it strikes: a bell, a wave, something that hits and rings after.
Now set the pair side by side. *La risa* and *el llanto* are the two things a face does when it stops being neutral, and Spanish names them as a pair constantly.

What you've built

The other half of the face, and the first word of a new chapter.
What follows is a set of very small words — the ones that say how often, how much, and whether at all. They are what you reach for when you answer. And the first two of them are exactly what anybody would say about laughing and weeping.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el llanto*
- *la risa y el llanto*
- *el miedo*, then *el llanto*

Before you move on

What did *plangere* mean? (To strike.) What were Roman mourners beating? (Their own chest.) And what does a Spanish *ll-* usually sit on in Latin? (A *pl-* or an *fl-*.)

316.2 nunca — not ever, in one word

> What is a *planctus*? (A beating.) And which English words come from *ridere*? (*Ridicule*, *deride*.)

What to know first

- no — the *n* at the front of this one.
- el llanto — one of the things you can say this about.

Sounds you'll need

- *NUN-ca*, two beats. The *c* is hard, as in *cat*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nunca — "never."
Latin **numquam** is two words fused together: *ne* "not" and *umquam* "ever." Not-ever.
English **never** is also two words fused together: Old English *ne* "not" and *æfre* "ever." Not-ever.
These two are not related. Latin and Germanic built them separately, out of their own parts, in the same order, to the same shape. When two languages reach the same construction by the same route without either copying the other, it usually means the route was the obvious one — and "not ever" is about as obvious as an idea gets.
Nunca does not change. No *-o*, no *-a*, nothing to agree with. It sits in front of a verb and negates it, and that is the whole of its job.

What you've built

The first of the measuring words.
Nunca is one end of a line. The next word is the other end.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nunca*
- *no, nunca*
- *el llanto*, then *nunca*

Before you move on

What two Latin words are inside *numquam*? (*Ne* and *umquam* — not ever.) What two words are inside *never*? (*Ne* and *ever*.) And does *nunca* change for a woman? (No — it does not change at all.)

316.3 siempre — the other end of the line

What two pieces are inside *numquam*? (*Ne* and *umquam*.) And what were Roman mourners striking? (Their chest.)

What to know first

- nunca — the opposite end.
- la risa — something to measure with these two.

Sounds you'll need

- *SIEM-pre*, two beats. The *ie* slides, and *pr* runs together with no vowel between. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

siempre — "always."
Latin **semper**, and this time almost nothing happened to it. The stressed *e* broke to *ie*, as it always does, and the ending softened. The meaning did not move at all.
English has no plain everyday word from it, but it has two showy ones. **Sempiternal** is *semper* plus *aeternus* — everlasting plus eternal, the same idea said twice, which is what a language does when one word is not emphatic enough. And **semper fidelis**, "always faithful," is the United States Marine Corps motto; most people who say *semper fi* have never once thought about the first word.
Siempre, like *nunca*, refuses to change. *Siempre* ends in *-e*, which is the reason *triste* already gave you. *Nunca* ends in *-a* and still does not move — because it is not describing a person at all. It is describing *when*, and *when* has no gender.

What you've built

Both ends of the line.
Nunca and *siempre* between them cover the whole range. What comes next starts dividing up the middle.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *siempre*
- *sí, siempre*
- *nunca*, then *siempre*

Before you move on

What is *sempiternal* made of? (*Semper* and *aeternus* — everlasting twice.) What does *semper fi* mean? (Always faithful.) And why does *nunca* not change, even ending in *-a*? (It describes when, not a person.)

316.4 todo — all of it, and this one does change

What is the first word of the Marine Corps motto? (*Semper* — always.) And what two pieces are in *never*? (*Ne* and *ever*.)

What to know first

- mucho — a smaller helping than this.
- siempre — the same idea, applied to time.

Sounds you'll need

- *TO-do*, two beats. The *d* between vowels is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

todo — "all," "everything."
Latin **totus** meant whole, entire. English has it undisguised: a **total** is

the whole of something, and **totally** means wholly. There is no sound change to unpick here. The word walked into Spanish and dropped one *t* on the way.
Portuguese took the same Latin word down its own road and arrived at *tudo*. Spanish *todo* and Portuguese *tudo* are siblings, not borrowings — each is *totus*, worn down by its own language's habits.
Now the useful part. *Nunca* and *siempre* do not change. **Todo does.** *Todo* is describing a thing, and in Spanish anything that describes a thing has to agree with it. *Todo* in front of a masculine word; *toda la noche* — all the night — in front of a feminine one. The *-o* becomes *-a* because *noche* is feminine.
That is the rule *triste* held out on. Words ending in *-o* switch to *-a*. Words ending in *-e* do not move. *Todo* ends in *-o*, so it switches.

What you've built

The first word in this chapter that agrees.
Nunca and *siempre* measure time and stay put. *Todo* measures a thing, so it has to match the thing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *todo*
- *toda la noche*
- *todo*, then *toda*

Before you move on

What did *totus* mean? (Whole.) Which English word is it, barely changed? (*Total.*) And what does *todo* become in front of *la noche*? (*Toda.*)

316.5 nada — a thing born, worn down to nothing

What does *todo* become before *la noche*? (*Toda.*) And what is *sempiternal* made of? (*Semper* and *aeternus.*)

What to know first

- de nada — you have been saying this word since chapter four.
- todo — its exact opposite.

Sounds you'll need

- *NA-da*, two beats. Both *a*s are open and the *d* is soft. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nada — "nothing."
This is the best story in the chapter.
Latin had a phrase: **res nata**, "a thing born." To say there was nothing at all, you said *non res nata* — not a thing born, not one single thing that has come into being. Perfectly ordinary emphatic negation, the kind English still does with "not a living soul."
Then the phrase wore down. *Res* fell off the middle. *Non* drifted away and became the separate *no*. What was left standing was **nata** — the participle meaning *born* — carrying, entirely on its own, the meaning "nothing."
So the Spanish word for nothing is, historically, the word for a thing that exists. It means its own opposite, because the negative that made it negative has fallen off the front of it.
Nata is the feminine of *natus*, born, and that root is everywhere in English: **natal**, **native**, **nativity**, **nature**, **nascent**, **innate**, **renaissance**. Every one of them is about coming into being. And *nada* is the same word.
You have been saying it since chapter four. *De nada* — "it's nothing" — is *of nothing*, and now you know what the nothing was made of.
Keep one thing for the next chapter: *nada* has a twin, and the twin is about people.

What you've built

Fifteen words, and this chapter closes on its best etymology.
Todo and *nada* are the two ends of it. Everything, and not a thing born.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nada*
- *de nada*
- *todo*, then *nada*

Before you move on

What was *res nata*? (A thing born.) Which part of the phrase survived as *nada*? (*Nata* — the word for born.) And name an English word from the same root. (*Native*, *nature*, *natal* — any of them.)

Chapter 317

Something, Somebody, Nobody

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can answer with something, somebody, nobody, another and a little in Spanish.
>
> *Complete ES-C317-poco: run algo/nada and alguien/nadie as matched pairs, then add otro and poco with both endings.*

317.1 algo — some, built out of other

> What was *res nata*? (A thing born.) And what does *todo* do in front of a feminine word? (It becomes *toda*.)

What to know first

- nada — the answer when there is none.
- todo — a great deal more than this.

Sounds you'll need

- *AL-go*, two beats. The *g* is hard, as in *goat*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

algo — "something."
Latin **aliquod**: *ali-* plus *quod*. *Quod* is "what." *Ali-* is "other."
Together: some other what — a thing not yet specified.
That *ali-* is worth collecting, because English has taken it repeatedly.

An **alias** is an other name. An **alien** is from another place. To **alienate** somebody is to make them other. **Altruism** is caring about the other one.
So Spanish builds "something" out of "other." That is not obvious at first, but it is sound. To say *something* is to say: not this particular thing — some other one, unnamed.
Algo has one shape and keeps it. It stands for a thing nobody has named yet, and a thing with no name has no gender to agree with.

What you've built

The first of four indefinites.
Algo is a thing. The next one is a person, and it is built from exactly the same piece.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *algo*
- *sí, algo*
- *algo*, then *nada*

Before you move on

What does *ali-* mean? (Other.) What is an *alias*? (An other name.) And why does *algo* have only one form? (The thing it stands for has no name yet, so no gender.)

317.2 alguien — the same piece, now a person

> What does *ali-* mean? (Other.) And which part of *res nata* survived? (*Nata*, the born part.)

What to know first

- algo — the same word, for things.
- la enfermera — one somebody you can already name.

Sounds you'll need

- *AL-guien*, two beats. The *gu* is a hard *g*; the *u* is silent and only there to keep it hard. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

alguien — "somebody."
Take *algo* apart once more: *ali-* "other" plus *quod* "what." Now swap the second half. *Quem* is "whom" — the person form. *Ali-* plus *quem* is **aliquem**: some other whom.
Algo and *alguien* are the same construction built twice, once for things and once for people. Latin drew that line and Spanish kept it exactly. *Algo* is about a thing. *Alguien* is about a person. They are never swapped.
The spelling holds one trap. *Gu* before *e* or *i* is a hard *g*, and the *u* is doing no work of its own — it is a spacer, put there to stop the *g* going soft. You meet the same spacer in *guitarra* and *guerra*. So this word is "AL-gyen," not "AL-gwyen."
Like *algo*, it does not change. One shape for a man and the same shape for a woman, because the whole point of the word is that you do not yet know which.

What you've built

The pair is complete.
Two words for *some*: one for what, one for who, both built on *other*. And each of them has an opposite waiting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *alguien*
- *alguien, por favor*
- *algo*, then *alguien*

Before you move on

What is the *quem* in *aliquem*? (Whom — the person form.) What does the *u* do in *alguien*? (Keeps the *g* hard; it is silent.) And which of the pair is for things? (*Algo.*)

317.3 nadie — nada's twin, and this one is about people

Which of *algo* and *alguien* is for people? (*Alguien.*) And what does *ali-* mean? (Other.)

What to know first

- nada — its twin.
- alguien — what this answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *NA-die*, two beats. The *ie* at the end is one slide. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nadie — "nobody."
Here is the twin that was promised.
Nada came from **res nata**, "a thing born." *Nadie* came from **homines nati**, "people born." Same participle, same construction, same collapse. Latin said *non homines nati*, "not people born," meaning not a soul. The *non* and the *homines* fell away. What was left was **nati** — the born ones — meaning nobody.
So Spanish has two words for nothingness and both of them are, underneath, the word *born*. One is singular and neuter, for things. One is plural and human, for people. The negation that made them negative has evaporated out of both.
Put all four together and the shape of the chapter appears. For things: *algo* and *nada*. For people: *alguien* and *nadie*. Some and none, twice over, one line each.
English has *nati* all over it and never once negatively: **native**, **natal**, **nation** (a people *born* in one place), **nature**, **innate**. Spanish is the

language that took that root and made it mean absence.

What you've built

Four indefinites, in two matched pairs.
Algo and *nada* for things. *Alguien* and *nadie* for people. And both of the negatives are the Latin word for *born*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nadie*
- *nada*, then *nadie*
- *alguien*, then *nadie*

Before you move on

What was *homines nati*? (People born.) What does *nadie* share with *nada*? (Both are the Latin word for born.) And which one is for people? (*Nadie*.)

317.4 otro — the other of exactly two

What was *homines nati*? (People born.) And what does the *u* do in *alguien*? (Keeps the *g* hard.)

What to know first

- uno... otro — the pattern this word gets built into.
- algo — built on Latin's *other* word for other.

Sounds you'll need

- *O-tro*, two beats. The *tr* runs together and the *r* is a single tap. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

otro — "other," "another."
Latin had two words where English has one. **Alius** was "some other, any other, one out of many." **Alter** was "the other one" — of a pair, specifically, when there are exactly two and you mean the one that is not this one.
Spanish kept *alter*. *Otro* is *alter* with the *l* absorbed and the ending trimmed off.
And you have already met the *alius* side of the family. *Algo* and *alguien* are built on *ali-*, which is *alius*. So this one chapter contains both of Latin's words for *other*: one of them turned into "something" and "somebody," the other turned into "another."
English keeps *alter* in the open. To **alter** something is to make it other. **Alternate** things take turns at being the other one. An **alter ego** is your other self. And an **altercation** is a quarrel — two people, each being the other's problem.
Otro changes: *otro* for a masculine thing, *otra* for a feminine one, because it is describing the thing. Same rule as *todo*. An *-o* ending has to agree.

What you've built

Both of Latin's *others*, inside one chapter.
Ali- gave you *algo* and *alguien*. *Alter* gave you *otro*. One word left.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *otro*
- *otra vez*
- *otro*, then *otra*

Before you move on

What was the difference between *alius* and *alter*? (*Alius* is any other; *alter* is the other of two.) Which one is *otro*? (*Alter*.) And what is an *alter ego*? (An other self.)

317.5 poco — a little, and the circle closes

> What did *alter* mean? (The other of two.) And what does *nadie* share with *nada*? (The Latin word for born.)

What to know first

- tampoco — this word is already inside it.
- mucho — its opposite.

Sounds you'll need

- *PO-co*, two beats. The *c* is hard, as in *cat*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poco — "little," "few."
Latin **paucus**, "few." The *au* flattened to *o* and the ending came off.
You have been carrying it for a long time without opening it. *Tampoco* — "neither, not either" — is *tan* plus *poco*: "so little." Every time you have said *tampoco* you have been saying *just as little*, and *poco* is the second half of it.
English has the Latin form in **paucity**, which means a shortage. It is a formal word and not common, but it is exactly this one.
And English **few** is the same root arriving down the Germanic road, after the *p* turned to *f*. That is the third time you have seen that shift in these four chapters. *Pie* and *foot*. *Diente* and *tooth*. *Poco* and *few*. Once you can hear a *p* becoming an *f*, a large part of English stops looking foreign.
Poco agrees, like *todo* and *otro*: *poco* and *poca*. It is measuring a thing, so it matches the thing.

What you've built

Twenty words, and the last one closes a circle.
You opened this run with *el pie* and a *p* turning into an *f*. You finish it with *poco* and the same shift. Between the two: the body, what it feels, and the small words that measure both.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *poco*
- *poco*, then *poca*
- *mucho*, then *poco*

Before you move on

What is inside *tampoco*? (*Tan* and *poco* — so little.) Which English word is *paucus* through Latin? (*Paucity.*) And which is it through Germanic? (*Few.*)

Chapter 318

Review — Four Things Worth Saying Twice

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say goodbye for the short term, pick the right sorry, and say which noun's ending is lying to me.
>
> *Complete ES-C318-repaso-genero: place la cabeza, el vino and la mano by gender, then use the object pronoun to settle el agua.*

318.1 Review — hasta pronto, and the word inside it

Two words, and you have had both for a long time. What does *hasta* mean? (**Until**.) And *pronto*? (**Soon** — and also "quickly", and "ready".)

What you've built

Say it once, slowly: **hasta pronto**, *AHS-tah PRON-toh*. "Until soon." Now take the second half on its own. **Pronto** came from Latin **promptus**, "brought forth, ready at hand". Something *prompt* is brought out without delay — and that is the whole distance between "ready" and "soon".

English has the same word, unchanged in the root: **prompt**, **promptly**, and the computer **prompt** that sits there ready for you to type. Italian took it too, and says ***Pronto!*** — "Ready!" — when it answers the phone.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hasta pronto*, then *pronto* on its own
- *pronto*, then English *prompt*, *promptly* — one word, two languages

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of your goodbyes says you expect to meet again shortly? (***Hasta pronto***.) And what is *pronto* on its own? (**Soon**, and "ready" — the sense English kept in *prompt*.)

318.2 Review — two sorries, and how to tell them apart

What does **lo siento** say, word for word? (**"I feel it"** — *siento* from Latin *sentīre*, "to feel".)

What you've built

English has one word where Spanish has two, and the split follows the etymologies you already hold.

phrase	word for word	points at
lo siento	"I feel it"	**your** feeling
perdón	"give [it] completely"	**their** forgiveness

Lo siento names a feeling — regret, sympathy — and stretches from stepping on a foot to hearing that someone has died. *Perdón* asks for something back, which is why it is also what you say squeezing past a stranger in a corridor.

Be honest about the edges, as the first pass was: speakers reach for whichever fits, the boundary is soft, and mixing them is a shade off rather than a mistake.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lo siento*, then *perdón* — feeling, then request
- *lo siento mucho* — I feel it a lot

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which one leans toward sympathy rather than fault? (***Lo siento.***) Which one is asking the other person for something? (***Perdón*** — a pardon is a thing granted.)

318.3 Review — four nouns, easiest gender to hardest

Two you can answer without thinking. Say "the head." (***La cabeza.***) Say "the wine." (***El vino.***) The ending told you both times.

What you've built

Line up four nouns you already own, in order of how much the ending can be trusted.

noun	ending	gender
la cabeza	*-a*	feminine, as expected
el vino	*-o*	masculine, as expected
la mano	*-o*	**feminine** anyway

Cabeza and *vino* are the ordinary case, and they are worth saying out loud precisely because nothing about them is interesting: the ending points one way and the article agrees.

La mano is the famous one. Latin **manus** sat in the fourth declension, whose *-us* nouns were mostly masculine — and *manus* was one of the handful that were feminine instead. So it broke the pattern twice: once inside Latin, and once again against Spanish's usual *-o*.

Grammar Lens: when the ending will not tell you

The fourth noun is the one where even the **article** is unhelpful.

Bebo ***el agua.*** — I drink the water. ***La*** *bebo.* — I drink it.

The article said *el* to keep two *a* sounds from colliding, which is a fact about sound and not about gender. The object pronoun is under no such pressure, so it reports the gender straight — and it reports **la**. That is a test you can run on any noun whose article looks suspicious: listen for which pronoun a speaker reaches for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cabeza*, *el vino*, *la mano* — two obedient, one not
- *el agua*, then *la bebo* — the article, then the witness

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the four nouns ends in *-o* and is feminine anyway? (***La mano***.) *El agua* — which pronoun replaces it? (***La***.) And why does that not contradict the article? (The article changed for **sound**, not gender.)

318.4 Review — two marks that were added, and when

Why does Spanish open a question with **¿**? (Because the **words do not move** — so the reader needs an early warning to lift their voice.)

What you've built

The **¿** is younger than the language, and it has a date.
The Spanish Royal Academy made the opening mark official in **1754**. English can usually tell you a question is coming by reordering the words — *Are* you…, *Do* you… — so its final **?** arrives late and costs nothing. Spanish does not reorder: *Tienes hambre* and *¿Tienes hambre?* are the same words. Something had to carry the warning, and the Academy put it at the front.
A melody cue placed **before** the melody. That is the whole idea, and

it is the same instinct as the written accent showing a stress you could not otherwise see.

Why it's said this way

Now the second mark, and it is quieter.
Latin **germānus** is stressed on its third syllable, which leaves the opening *ger-* unstressed — and there the **g** simply fell away, giving Old Spanish ***ermano***, with no *h* at all. The *h* on today's **hermano** was added later, in spelling only, to point back at the Latin *g-*.
Keep it apart from the other silent *h*. In **hijo** and **hacer** the *h* stands where Latin had an *f*, and that *h* really was breathed aloud for centuries. *Hermano*'s never was. Same silent letter, two histories, and only one of them ever involved a sound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *germānus*, then *ermano*, then *hermano* — the three stages
- a question of your own, and start lifting your voice where the ¿ sits

Twice through:

Before you move on

What year did the Academy make **¿** official? (**1754**.) And what happened to *germānus*'s opening letter? (Its **g** dropped away in an unstressed syllable — the *h* was put on the page afterwards, and never spoken.)

Chapter 319

Review — Second Looks

Modes: **voice** (6) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 5 of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can check a Spanish surface against better evidence, name the five stages of a leaving, run an introduction start to finish, and use the five answering words.
>
> *Complete ES-C319-repaso-la-superficie: name the honest witness to a noun's gender, choose between the two sorries, and date the opening question mark.*

319.1 Review — what the surface does not tell you

What does **pronto** mean on its own? (**Soon** — and "ready", the sense English kept in *prompt*.)

What you've built

Four things you met separately, gathered because they share a shape: the part you can see is not the part to trust.
First. *Pronto* is about **readiness**, from *promptus*; "soon" is where readiness ended up.
Second. *Lo siento* and *perdón* both come out as English "sorry". The English does not divide them; the Latin does. One names **your** feeling, the other asks for **their** pardon.
Third. *El agua* looks masculine and is not. The article moved for **sound**; the object pronoun did not, and says ***la***.
Fourth. The *h* on *hermano* looks like the *h* on *hijo*. One stood where

a Latin *f* was breathed aloud for centuries; the other went on the page long after the sound had gone.

Grammar Lens: the mark that was designed, not inherited

The **¿** belongs on that list from the other side. It is not a survival: the Spanish Royal Academy made it official in **1754**, because Spanish leaves the words of a question where they were and something had to warn the reader.
Four inherited surfaces that mislead, and one deliberate surface that helps.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pronto*, then English *prompt*
- *el agua*, then *la bebo*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which is the honest witness to a noun's gender? (The **object pronoun**.) When was **¿** made official? (**1754**.) Was *hermano*'s *h* ever a sound? (**No**.)

319.2 Review — the five words of a leaving

Two to start. Say "the street." (***La calle.***) Say "the corner." (***La esquina.***)

What you've built

Say the five in order and hear the distance grow at every step: **la calle**, **la esquina**, **la huella**, **el puerto**, **el faro** — the street, its corner, the mark left in the dirt, the water's edge, and the light still visible when the town is not.
Now the part worth a second visit. Not one of the five was built for this list. *Calle* was a **cattle track**, *callis*. *Esquina* is a **shinbone**,

Germanic *skina*. *Huella* comes from a day spent **treading wool**, *fullāre*. *Puerto* is the Roman **harbour**, *portus*, twin to the *puerta* on land. And *faro* was an **island**, Pharos, with a fire on top of a tower. Five ordinary nouns out of five unrelated quarries. That is the ratio you should expect from here on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all five in order — *la calle*, *la esquina*, *la huella*, *el puerto*, *el faro*
- *la puerta*, then *el puerto* — the gate on land, the gate off the sea

Twice through:

Before you move on

What was *fullāre*? (**Treading cloth in a vat** — the trampling that gave *huella* its footprint.) What does *ob portum* describe? (**A wind standing toward harbour** — an opportunity.) And what is a *faro* in a car park today? (A **headlight**.)

319.3 Review — the harbour, the light, and see you soon

The last two nouns of the run. Say "the harbour." (***El puerto***.) Say "the lighthouse." (***El faro***.)

What you've built

A leaving needs a **place** and a **time**, and you have both.
The place: **el puerto**, the gate off the sea, and **el faro**, the light standing at its mouth. The time: **hasta pronto** — *hasta*, "until", and *pronto*, "soon".
Say the whole thing once, slowly, as one leaving:

El puerto. El faro. Hasta pronto.

Three words out of three different centuries and two different languages — a Roman harbour, a Greek island, and an Arabic

preposition holding a Latin adjective. You can hear all of that now, which you could not at the start.

Your turn

- *Say it: el puerto, el faro, hasta pronto*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which of the two is the light, and which is the water? (***El faro***; ***el puerto***.) And what does *pronto* promise? (**Soon** — you will be back shortly.)

319.4 Review — an introduction, start to finish

Two to open. Which word is the **first** name? (***El nombre***.) And which is the family one? (***El apellido***.)

What you've built

Five words, and between them a complete first meeting.
You can name yourself both ways: **el nombre** and **el apellido**. You can address the other person: **señor** or **señora**, the same Latin *senior* wearing the *-o/-a* switch you have used since *bueno* and *buena*. And you can answer the introduction: **encantado** if you are a man, **encantada** if you are a woman.
Run it once as one exchange, in your own voice:

> — Buenos días. Me llamo Ana Ruiz. ¿Cómo se llama usted, **señor**? — Mi **nombre** es Luis, y mi **apellido** es Vargas. **Encantado**. — **Encantada**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el nombre*, then *el apellido*
- *señor*, then *señora*

- the whole exchange above, both voices

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which Latin word is under *señor* and *señora*? (***Senior***.) Which ending does a woman use to answer an introduction? (**-a** — *encantada*.)

319.5 Review — two ways to answer an introduction

What does **mucho gusto** say, word for word? (**"Much pleasure"** — *gusto* is a taste, and from there a liking.)

What you've built

Somebody has just told you their name. Spanish gives you two answers, and they were minted centuries apart.

you say	it literally means
mucho gusto	much pleasure
encantado / encantada	put under a spell

Mucho gusto is the plain one, and it names a **feeling**: *gusto* is Latin *gustus*, a taste. *Encantado* is Latin *incantāre*, to sing a spell onto something — English kept it as **enchanted**, and the raw noun as **incantation**.

Notice what neither of them does: **mention the other person**. English says "pleased to meet **you**". Spanish names the pleasure, or names the spell, and leaves you out of it. Either answer is right, and *mucho gusto* never changes its ending while *encantado* agrees with whoever is speaking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mucho gusto*, then *encantado*
- *encantada*, and hear the ending follow the speaker

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which answer changes its ending for the speaker? (***Encantado** / **encantada***.) And which one names a pleasure instead of a spell? (***Mucho gusto***.)

319.6 Review — five answering words, and where they came from

Two to open. Which word answers for a **thing**? (***Algo***.) And which for a **person**? (***Alguien***.)

What you've built

Say the five: **algo**, **alguien**, **nadie**, **otro**, **poco**.
Now the part worth a second look. Four of them are built out of two Latin pieces, and once you see the seams the list stops being a list.
The *ali-* pair. *Algo* is *aliquod*, "some other what". *Alguien* is *aliquem*, "some other whom". One for things, one for people — a line Latin drew and Spanish kept exactly. And *otro* is *alter*, the same neighbourhood: Latin's word for the other of **two**, which is why English *alter*, *alternate* and *alter ego* all carry a pair inside them.
The born ones. *Nadie* is *nati*, "people born", out of *homines nati*. Its twin *nada* was "a thing born". One Latin participle, collapsed twice, into two words for absence.
And the fifth. *Poco* is *paucus*, "few" — English **paucity** straight from the Latin, and English **few** the same root down the Germanic road after *p* turned to *f*. You already carried *poco* inside *tampoco*, which is *tan* plus *poco*: "so little."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all five — *algo*, *alguien*, *nadie*, *otro*, *poco*
- *otro*, then *otra*; *poco*, then *poca* — both agree

Twice through:

Before you move on

How many did *alter* mean? (**Two**.) What is inside *tampoco*? (***Tan*** and ***poco***.) And what were the *nati* of *nadie*? (**People born**.)

319.7 Review — the two that agree, and the p that becomes an f

Say "another book," then "another house." (***Otro*** libro; ***otra*** casa.)

What you've built

Of the five answering words, exactly two change their ending: **otro** and **poco**. Both are measuring a thing, so both match the thing.

otro / *otra* — another *poco* / *poca* — a little

Algo, *alguien* and *nadie* never move, because none of them is describing a noun. They **are** the noun.

Why it's said this way

Poco is Latin **paucus**, and English **few** is the same root arriving by the Germanic road, after *p* turned to *f*.
That shift is not a one-off. *Pie* and **foot**. *Diente* and **tooth**. *Poco* and **few**. Three pairs, one sound law — and once you can hear a Spanish *p* behind an English *f*, a large part of English stops looking foreign.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *otro*, *otra*, *poco*, *poca*
- *poco* and *few*, then *pie* and *foot*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Why do *otro* and *poco* change while *nadie* does not? (They **describe a noun**; *nadie* is one.) And name the three *p*-to-*f* pairs. (*Pie*/foot, *diente*/tooth, *poco*/few.)

Chapter 320

The Words Behind Please and Sorry

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the favour, the trouble, the shame, the luck and the fault behind a Spanish courtesy.
>
> *Complete ES-C320-culpa: open por favor into el favor, answer thanks with no es molestia, and place a fault with es mi culpa.*

320.1 el favor — the word you have been saying for a long time

Say *another book*, then *a little water*. (***Otro*** libro; ***poca*** agua.)

What to know first

- por favor — this word is already inside it.

Sounds you'll need

- *fa-VOR*, the stress on the second beat. The *v* is soft, closer to a *b* made without closing the lips. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el favor — "a favour," a good turn done for somebody.
Latin **favēre** meant *to be well disposed toward* — to be on someone's

side. The noun **favor** was what that goodwill looked like when it did something.
You have been carrying it without opening it. ***Por favor*** is *por* plus *favor*: **for a favour**. Every time you have said *please* in Spanish you have been saying *as a good turn to me*. Now the second half stands on its own: *un favor* is a thing you ask for, and *el favor* is the one being asked.
English has it three ways over: a **favour** is the good turn, your **favourite** is what your goodwill lands on, and **favourable** weather is weather on your side.

What you've built

The first of five courtesy words that name what politeness is actually made of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el favor*
- *un favor, por favor*
- *otro favor*

Before you move on

What did *favēre* mean? (To be well disposed toward somebody.)
And what is hiding inside *por favor*? (*Favor* — a good turn.)

320.2 la molestia — the weight you are asked to carry

What is the second half of *por favor*? (*Favor.*) And what does *poco* measure? (A little of something.)

Sounds you'll need

- *mo-LES-tia*, the stress in the middle. The *s* and *t* run together with no vowel between them. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la molestia — "the trouble," "the bother."
Underneath it is Latin **mōlēs**: a mass, a heavy bulk, the word Romans used for a breakwater or a great pile of stone. Something **molestus** was something with that weight on it. **Molestia** is the weight itself. So a bother in Spanish is not an irritation. It is a load — a thing somebody has to carry for you. That is why *no es molestia*, "it is no trouble," is the warm answer to thanks: you are saying *nothing was carried*.
English kept the mass and shrank it. A **molecule** is *mōlēs* with a little-ending on the end: a tiny mass. The pile of stone and the smallest piece of matter are the same Latin word at two sizes.
Molestia ends in *-a* and takes *la*, like *la casa* and *la mesa*.

What you've built

The word that lets you tell somebody they cost you nothing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la molestia*
- *no es molestia*
- *un favor — no es molestia*

Before you move on

What was a *mōlēs*? (A heavy mass, a pile of stone.) Which English word is that same mass made tiny? (*Molecule*.)

320.3 la pena — the price a feeling costs

Say *a favour*, then *it is no trouble*. (*Un favor*; *no es molestia*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *PE-na*, two beats, stress on the first. A plain *n*, not the *ñ*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la pena — "sorrow," and also "a shame," and also "a penalty."
Latin **poena** was a price: the payment a wrongdoer owed. Greek lent it to Latin, where it had meant the blood-price paid to a dead man's family. It has been about paying from the beginning.
Spanish kept both ends. *La pena* is still the legal penalty, and it is also the ache — because sorrow is what a loss costs you.
English took it three separate times. **Pain** came the long way through French and softened into feeling. **Penal** and **penalty** came straight off the Latin and stayed legal. And a **subpoena** is *sub poena*, *under penalty*: a summons that names the price of not coming.
¡Qué pena! — "what a shame" — is the everyday one. You will hear it for a cancelled plan and for a real grief, and the word does not change size.

What you've built

One word that reaches from a courtroom to a friend's bad news.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la pena*
- *¡Qué pena!*
- *no es molestia — es una pena*

Before you move on

What did *poena* mean first? (A price paid, a penalty.) What does *sub poena* mean, word for word? (Under penalty.)

320.4 la suerte — the token you drew

What is a *molestia*? (A trouble, a weight carried.) And what did *poena* mean before it meant sorrow? (A penalty, a price.)

Sounds you'll need

- *SUER-te.* The *ue* is one gliding sound, as in *bueno*, and the *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la suerte — "luck."
Latin **sors**, and in its other form **sortem**, was a physical object: a marked token dropped into a jar and shaken out. Rome settled questions that way. Your *sors* was the token that came out for you, and from there it became your lot, your share, your fate.
English built a surprising amount on that jar. To **sort** things is to put each into the pile its token names. A **sorcerer** is a *sortiarius*, one who works by casting lots. Your **consort** is *con* plus *sors*: the person whose lot is drawn with yours. A soldier's **sortie** is a going-out on whatever lot fell.
The *o* in *sortem* broke into *ue* on the way to Spanish, the same break that turns *bueno* and *puerta* out of *bonus* and *porta*.
¡Buena suerte! is the wish. It agrees: *buena*, because *suerte* takes *la*.

What you've built

A wish you can hand somebody at the door.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la suerte*
- *¡buena suerte!*
- *qué pena — buena suerte*

Before you move on

What was a *sors*, as an object? (A token drawn from a jar.) Why is it *buena suerte* and not *bueno*? (*Suerte* takes *la*.)

320.5 la culpa — five words for what politeness is made of

Say *what a shame*, then *good luck*. (*¡Qué pena!*; *¡buena suerte!*)

Sounds you'll need

- *CUL-pa.* The *c* is hard, as in *cat*, and the *u* is a full round vowel. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la culpa — "the fault," "the blame."
Latin **culpa** meant exactly this, and it came into Spanish unchanged — five letters carried two thousand years without losing one.
English never quite translated it. **Mea culpa**, *my fault*, is still said in Latin. A **culprit** is the one the fault attaches to. Something **culpable** is something the fault can be laid on, and to **exculpate** is to carry the fault back out of somebody.
Spanish does not say *I am at fault.* It says *la culpa es mía* — the fault is mine — or shorter, *es mi culpa.* The fault is a thing that belongs to somebody, and you name whose. That is why the answer that clears a person is *no es tu culpa*: not a denial of the trouble, a return of the object.
Set beside *lo siento* and *perdón*, which you already have: those two say what you feel and what you ask for. *Culpa* says where the thing sits.

What you've built

Five words that name the parts of courtesy: the good turn, the weight, the cost, the token drawn, and the fault. None of them is a phrase you repeat. Each one is a thing you can put in a sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la culpa*
- *es mi culpa*
- *no es tu culpa — buena suerte*

Before you move on

How does Spanish say *it is my fault*? (*Es mi culpa* — the fault is mine.) Which English word is *culpa* with a person attached? (*Culprit.*)

Chapter 321

Pleasure, Reason, Respect

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can answer a first meeting with un placer, agree with tienes razon, and ask for patience, respect or advice in Spanish.
>
> *Complete ES-C321-consejo: answer mucho gusto with un placer, hand somebody razon, and ask for paciencia and un consejo.*

321.1 el placer — the answer to a first meeting

Say *good luck*, then *it is my fault.* (*¡Buena suerte!*; *es mi culpa.*)

What to know first

- mucho gusto — this word answers it.

Sounds you'll need

- *pla-CER*, stress on the last beat. The *pl* runs straight together. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el placer — "pleasure."
Latin **placēre** meant *to please*, and it is one of the most productive words Latin ever handed on. Watch how far it reaches in English. **Please** and **pleasure** came the long way through French and kept the plain meaning. **Placid** came straight off the Latin and means *pleasing*,

which turned into *calm*, because what does not disturb you pleases you. A **plea** in a court is what you set down hoping it will please. And a **placebo** is the Latin sentence *I shall please* — a thing given because it will satisfy, not because it will cure.
Placer is also the doing-word: *me place* is an old, formal way to say *it pleases me*. But the piece you want is the naming one.
When somebody says *mucho gusto* on meeting you, the reply you will hear over and over is ***un placer*** — *a pleasure*. Three syllables that do the whole job.

What you've built

A second thing to say when you meet somebody, so the exchange is not one line repeated back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el placer*
- *un placer*
- *un placer — buena suerte*

Before you move on

What does *placebo* mean, word for word? (*I shall please.*) What do you answer when somebody says *mucho gusto*? (*Un placer.*)

321.2 la razón — being right is having something

Say *it is my fault*, then *a pleasure*. (*Es mi culpa*; *un placer.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *ra-ZÓN*, stress on the last beat — and the written accent is there to say so. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la razón — "reason."
Latin **ratio**, in its other form **rationem**, was a reckoning: a count, a calculation, the running of an account. Only afterwards did it come to mean the faculty that does the counting.
English holds both ends at once. A **ratio** is still a bare reckoning of one number against another. A **ration** is an amount reckoned out to you. **Rational** and **reason** are the thinking end — and *reason* is that same Latin word after a long walk through French.
Spanish did the same thing to itself. *Rationem* worn down slowly through speech became ***razón***. The very same word picked up later out of a book became **ración**, a portion. Two Spanish words, one Latin ancestor, one of them weathered and one of them fresh.
Then comes the useful part. Spanish does not say *you are right*. It says ***tienes razón*** — *you have reason*. Being right is holding something, the way a fault is something you hold. And *no tienes razón* hands it back.

What you've built

A way to agree with somebody that is stronger than *sí*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la razón*
- *tienes razón*
- *tienes razón — es mi culpa*

Before you move on

What did *ratio* mean before it meant thinking? (A reckoning, a count.) How does Spanish say *you are right*? (*Tienes razón* — you have reason.)

321.3 el respeto — turning to look again

Say *a pleasure*, then *you are right*. (*Un placer*; *tienes razón*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *res-PE-to*, stress on the middle beat. The *s* and *p* meet with no vowel between. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el respeto — "respect."
Take it apart and it is a movement of the eyes. Latin **specere** was *to look*. Put **re-** in front, *back* or *again*, and **respicere** is *to look back at*. A **respectus** was that second look: you had walked past, and you turned.
That is what the word still carries. To respect somebody is to give them the look you do not give to furniture.
Specere is everywhere in English once you can see it. A **spectacle** is a thing to be looked at. **Spectacles** are what you look through. To **inspect** is to look into, to **suspect** is to look from underneath, and a **spectator** does nothing but look. English also has **respite** — a pause — which is the same *respectus* down a different road: a moment when you get to look back.
Spanish keeps a near-twin, *respecto*, for *with regard to*. The one you want here is *respeto*, with no second *c*.

What you've built

A word whose shape tells you what to do with your attention.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el respeto*
- *con respeto*
- *con respeto — tienes razón*

Before you move on

What does *respicere* mean, piece by piece? (To look back at.) Name two English words built on *specere*. (*Spectacle*, *inspect*, *spectator*,

suspect.)

321.4 la paciencia — the word for going through it

Say *you are right*, then *with respect.* (*Tienes razón*; *con respeto.*)

What to know first

- -ncia — the ending on the end of this one.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-CIEN-cia*, stress on the middle. The *c* before *i* is a plain *s* across the Americas. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la paciencia — "patience."
Latin **patī** meant *to undergo*, *to have something happen to you.* Not to wait pleasantly — to be on the receiving end. **Patientia** was the capacity to take it.
Which explains a word you have used all your life without hearing it. In a hospital, a **patient** is not somebody being calm. A patient is the one the treatment is happening *to*. Everyone else in the room is doing; one person is undergoing, and that person is named for it.
The same *patī* went into Church Latin and came out as **passion** — which originally meant *suffering*, not enthusiasm. **Compassion** is *undergoing with*: standing in it beside somebody. And something **passive** is a thing things are done to.
The ending is the *-ncia* you already know, the one that turns a way of being into a thing you can name and hand over. *Paciencia, por favor* asks somebody for it.

What you've built

A word you can ask for out loud when you need another minute.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la paciencia*
- *paciencia, por favor*
- *con respeto — paciencia*

Before you move on

What does *patī* mean? (To undergo.) Why is a hospital patient called that? (They are the one the treatment happens to.)

321.5 el consejo — ten words, and a road you have walked before

Say *with respect*, then *patience, please.* (*Con respeto*; *paciencia, por favor.*)

What to know first

- el ajo — the same sound change made this word too.

Sounds you'll need

- *con-SE-jo.* The *j* is the jota, a breath scraped at the back of the mouth. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el consejo — "advice." And also "a council."
Latin **consilium** was a sitting-together to decide: both the deliberation and the body of people doing it. Spanish kept the pair. *Un consejo* is a piece of advice; *el consejo* can be the board that meets. Advice, in Spanish, still sounds faintly like a committee.
English split them and then mixed them up. **Counsel** is the advising — *counsel for the defence.* A **council** is the body. Two spellings, one Latin word, and speakers have been confusing them ever since.
Now the ending, because you have walked this road once. *Allium* became *ajo*: the *-lium* collapsed into a jota. **Consilium** did the same

thing — *consilium*, *consejo*. Once a Latin *l* stood before an *i* and another vowel, Spanish pulled it back into the throat.

What you've built

Ten courtesy words. The first five name what politeness handles: the good turn, the weight, the cost, the token drawn and the fault. These five name what you offer back: the pleasure, the reckoning, the second look, the undergoing, and the sitting-down-together.
Not one of them is a set phrase. Each is a thing you can put where you need it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el consejo*
- *un consejo, por favor*
- *paciencia y respeto*

Before you move on

What two things does *consejo* name? (Advice, and a council.)
Which earlier word took the same *-lium* road to a jota? (*Ajo*, from *allium*.)

Chapter 322

Five Sizes of When

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say last night, the week, early, right away and still in Spanish, and say why an -o on the end of temprano never becomes an -a.
>
> *Complete ES-C322-todavia: place a thing at anoche, count in semanas, arrive temprano, answer enseguida, and say todavia no.*

322.1 anoche — a word with another word inside it

> Say *patience, please*, then *a piece of advice.* (*Paciencia, por favor*; *un consejo.*)

What to know first

- la noche — you can hear it inside this word.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-NO-che*, stress on the middle. The *ch* is one sound, as in *church*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

anoche — "last night."
Say it slowly and the seam shows: *a* plus *noche*. Latin said **ad**

noctem, *toward night.* Two words, spoken together for centuries, until the *d* fell out and nobody heard a join any more.
That *noctem* is one of the easiest Latin words to spot in English. Something **nocturnal** happens at night. A **nocturne** is a night piece of music. An **equinox** is *aequi-nox*, the day when night is equal to the light.
Here is the thing to hold on to. *Anoche* has no other form. It does not become *anocha* for a woman or *anoches* for two nights. Words like *contento* and *ocupado* switch their last letter because they are describing somebody. *Anoche* is not describing anybody — it is saying *when* — so there is nothing for it to agree with, and it never moves.

What you've built

The first of five words that place a thing in time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *anoche*
- *anoche, en casa*
- *un consejo — anoche*

Before you move on

What two Latin words are inside *anoche*? (*Ad* and *noctem* — toward night.) Why does *anoche* never change its ending? (It says when, not what somebody is like.)

322.2 la semana — a number wearing a different coat

Say *a piece of advice*, then *last night.* (*Un consejo*; *anoche.*)

What to know first

- seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — one of these is hiding here.

Sounds you'll need

- *se-MA-na*, three even beats with the stress in the middle. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la semana — "the week."
Latin **septimāna** meant *the set of seven*, from **septem**, seven. A week is not named for anything it does. It is named for how many days are in it.
Spanish already shows you the seven: *siete*. Put *siete* and *semana* side by side and you can watch the same Latin *septem* go two ways — the *p* holding on in one word and dropping out of the other.
English got the seven three times over. **September** was the seventh month back when the year began in March, and the name stayed on after the count moved. A **septet** is seven players. And English **seven** itself is the very same root coming down the Germanic road instead of the Latin one.
Semana takes *la*, and for more than one you add the ending you know: *semanas*.

What you've built

A stretch of time you can count in, sitting next to a night you can point at.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la semana*
- *dos semanas*
- *anoche — esta semana*

Before you move on

What number is inside *semana*? (Seven — *septem*, *siete*.) Why is *September* not the ninth month by name? (The year once began in March.)

322.3 temprano — an -o that stays put

Say *last night*, then *two weeks*. (*Anoche*; *dos semanas*.)

What to know first

- el tiempo — the same Latin word, differently worn.

Sounds you'll need

- *tem-PRA-no*, stress on the middle. The *pr* runs straight together. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

temprano — "early."
Latin **tempus**, in its longer form **tempor-**, was *time*. **Temporānus** meant *in good time*, *in season* — said of fruit that ripened when it should.
You already have that root once. *El tiempo* is *tempus* after the *-por-* fell out and the *e* broke into *ie*. *Temprano* is the same *tempus* with the *-por-* still there, squeezed down to *-pr-*. One Latin word, two Spanish shapes, and you can hear the middle of it in only one of them.
English keeps it plainly: a **tempo** is a rate of time, something **temporary** lasts only a while, **temporal** means belonging to time, and a **contemporary** shares your time.
Now the ending, which is a trap worth walking into on purpose. *Temprano* ends in *-o*. You have seen *-o* switch to *-a*: *contento* and *contenta*, *ocupado* and *ocupada*. **This one does not switch.** A woman does not arrive *temprana*. She arrives *temprano*, because the word is not saying what she is like — it is saying when she got there. The *-o*/*-a* switch belongs to words that describe somebody. This word describes when a thing happened, and a *when* is not a *he* or a *she*.

What you've built

Proof that an *-o* on the end is not a promise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *temprano*
- *María come temprano*
- *anoche — esta semana — temprano*

Before you move on

Which everyday word shares *tempus* with *temprano*? (*El tiempo.*) And does *temprano* become *temprana* for a woman? (No — it says when, not what she is like.)

322.4 enseguida — the next thing, and nothing between

Say *two weeks*, then *early*. (*Dos semanas*; *temprano.*)

What to know first

- conseguir — the same following is inside it.

Sounds you'll need

- *en-se-GUI-da.* The *u* after *g* is silent: it is there to keep the *g* hard. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

enseguida — "right away."
It is *en* plus *seguida*: **in what follows**. Not *soon* — *next*. Whatever comes after this comes with nothing in between, and that is why it means immediately.
Underneath is Latin **sequī**, *to follow*, one of the great root verbs. You have it already in *conseguir*, to get something by following after it, and in *según*, which is *secundum* — *following along*.
English is thick with it. A **sequence** is one thing following another. A **sequel** follows a story. A **consequence** is what follows from a cause. To **pursue** is to follow forward. And **second** is *secundus*, *the following one* — the number two is named for coming after the one.
The spelling carries a silent passenger. In *gui*, the *u* makes no sound at all. Without it the *g* would soften before that *i*, and the word would

not be *seguida* any more.
Like *anoche* and *temprano*, *enseguida* never changes.

What you've built

The answer somebody gives you when they mean *now*, not *later*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *enseguida*
- *enseguida, por favor*
- *temprano — enseguida*

Before you move on

What does *en seguida* mean, piece by piece? (In what follows.) Why is the *u* in *seguida* written at all? (To keep the *g* hard before the *i*.)

322.5 todavía — all the road, and still going

Say *early*, then *right away*. (*Temprano*; *enseguida*.)

What to know first

- todo — the first half of this word is yours already.

Sounds you'll need

- *to-da-VÍ-a*, four beats. The accent on the *í* pulls the *i* and the *a* apart, so they are two beats and not one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

todavía — "still," and with *no* in front of it, "not yet."
Break it where it wants to break: ***toda vía***. *Toda* is the *todo* you have, in its *-a* shape. *Vía* is Latin **via**, a road.
All the road. That was the whole sense once: the thing has gone the

entire way and is going still. Old Spanish used it for *always*, and it narrowed into *still* — which is what *always* becomes when you point it at one moment.
The *via* is easy to find in English. You travel **via** somewhere. A **viaduct** carries a road. To **deviate** is to go off the road. **Trivial** comes from *tri-via*, a place where three roads meet — the kind of gossip exchanged at a crossroads. And **obvious** is *ob viam*, *lying in the road*: what you cannot help meeting.
Todavía no is the pair you will need most. *No* comes first: *todavía no*.

What you've built

Five ways to place a thing in time: a night behind you, a stretch you can count, a position in the day, the very next moment, and a thing that has not stopped. Only one of the five ends in *-o*, and even that one refuses to change.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *todavía*
- *todavía no*
- *temprano* — *enseguida* — *todavía*

Before you move on

What are the two words inside *todavía*? (*Toda* and *vía* — all the road.) What does *obvious* mean, word for word? (Lying in the road.)

Chapter 323

Before, After, and While

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can put two events in order with antes, despues, entonces and mientras, and say that a thing is already done with ya.
>
> *Complete ES-C323-mientras: close todavia no with ya, order two events with antes de and despues de, and join them with mientras.*

323.1 ya — two letters, and the opposite of todavía

Say *right away*, then *not yet*. (*Enseguida*; *todavía no.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *YA*, one beat. The *y* is the same sound that opens *ayuda*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ya — "already," and sometimes "now."
Latin **iam** meant *already*. Its *i* was said like a *y*, so *iam* was close to *yam*, and the *m* dropped. Two letters left.
An English speaker has been carrying this word without knowing it. French wore *iam* down to *ja* and put *de* in front of it: **déjà** — *already*. English borrowed the phrase whole and never translated it. Every time somebody says **déjà vu**, *already seen*, the *jà* in the middle is *ya*.

Now set it against the word from last time. *Todavía* says the thing has not stopped. *Ya* says the thing has arrived. *Todavía no* is *not yet*; *ya* is *it's done*. They are the two ends of one line, and Spanish speakers swap between them constantly.
Ya also does a job English needs a whole tone of voice for. Said alone — *¡ya!* — it means *that's enough, stop there*. Two letters, and the timing is the whole message.

What you've built

The shortest word in the run, and the one that closes a door.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ya*
- *ya está*
- *todavía no — ya*

Before you move on

Which borrowed French phrase hides *ya* inside it? (*Déjà vu* — already seen.) And what is the opposite of *todavía no*? (*Ya.*)

323.2 entonces — pointing at a time the way you point at a chair

Say *still*, then *already*. (*Todavía*; *ya.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *en-TON-ces*, stress in the middle, and a clear *s* on the end. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

entonces — "then."
Inside it are two pieces you can nearly see. *En* is the *en* you know, from

Latin **in**. **Tunc** was Latin for *at that time*. *In tunc* — *at that time* — ran together, and Spanish added an *-s* on the end, the way it likes to. *Tunc* was itself built out of something older and much shorter: the pointing stem that English still runs on. **That**, **there**, **then**, **the** — all of them are that one small sound, put to work in different directions.
So Spanish *entonces* and English *then* are cousins, arriving by different roads from a word whose only job was to point away from here.
That is what *entonces* does. It points at a time the way *ese* points at a chair. It is also the word that carries an argument along — *entonces, ¿qué?*, *so, what then?* — because *and at that time* is how a story keeps moving.
Two other jobs, one word: *entonces* is a *then* on a clock, and a *so* in a sentence.

What you've built

A word that can push a conversation forward when you have run out of others.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *entonces*
- *entonces, ¿qué?*
- *ya — entonces*

Before you move on

What two Latin words are inside *entonces*? (*In* and *tunc* — at that time.) Which English words share that old pointing sound? (*That*, *there*, *then*, *the*.)

323.3 antes — the one that goes in front

Say *already*, then *then*. (*Ya*; *entonces*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *AN-tes*, stress on the first beat, and the *s* on the end is not swallowed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

antes — "before."
Latin **ante** meant *in front of*, in space first and in time afterwards. The *-s* on the end is Spanish, not Latin: it is the ending Spanish keeps hanging on words that say *when*. You saw it on *entonces*, and it is coming again.
English took *ante* and mostly left it alone. An **antechamber** is the room in front of the room. To **antedate** is to be earlier than. In a card game you **ante up** — you put in before you play. **Antique** and **ancient** are both *ante* grown old, which is what they mean.
The best one is **ancestor**. Latin **antecessor** is *ante* plus *cedere*, *to go*: **one who went before**. Not an old relative — a walker who was on the road first.
To say *before something*, Spanish puts *de* after it: *antes de*. The word by itself means only *earlier*: *antes, no — not before now.*

What you've built

Half of a pair. The other half arrives next.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *antes*
- *antes de comer*
- *entonces — antes*

Before you move on

What is an *antecessor*, word for word? (One who went before.)
Which other *when* word carries the same *-s* on the end? (*Entonces.*)

323.4 después — three words that stopped being three

Say *then*, then *before*. (*Entonces*; *antes*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *des-PUÉS*, stress on the last beat — the written accent says so, and the *ué* is one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

después — "after," "afterwards."
This one is a pile-up. Latin had **post**, *after*. Speakers put **ex** in front of it for emphasis, then **de** in front of that, and *de ex post* was said so often it fused: *despost*, *depués*, *después*. Three words to say one thing, and now nobody hears the seams.
The **post** is the piece English kept. To **postpone** is to place after. A **postscript** is written after. Something **posterior** is at the back. **Post-war** is after the war. And **preposterous** is *prae* plus *posterus* — *before-after* — a thing with its front where its back should be, which is a very exact way of saying *absurd*.
Set the pair together now. *Antes* and *después*. Both are Latin place-words that learned to talk about time; both end in that same Spanish *-s*, like *entonces*. To hang either on a thing, you use *de*: *antes de*, *después de*.

What you've built

A pair that can put two events in order without a clock.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *después*
- *después de comer*
- *antes — después*

Before you move on

How many Latin words are inside *después*? (Three — *de*, *ex*, *post*.) What does *preposterous* mean, piece by piece? (Before-after, back to front.)

323.5 mientras — twenty words, and one ending they share

Say *before eating*, then *after eating*. (*Antes de comer*; *después de comer*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *MIEN-tras*, stress on the first beat. The *ie* is one glide, as in *tiempo*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mientras — "while."
Latin said **dum interim**: *while, in the meantime*. **Interim** is *inter*, *between*, with an ending — the time in between. Old Spanish had it as *demientre*; the pieces slid, the *-s* arrived, and *mientras* was left.
That *inter* is one of the most visible Latin pieces in English. An **interim** report covers the time between. An **interval** is the gap between. Something **interior** is between the walls. **International** is between nations. And **meanwhile** is English building the same idea out of its own bricks.
Now the ending, because it is the point of this chapter. Take the four together: *entonces*, *antes*, *después*, *mientras*. Every one of them ends in *-s*, and not one of them is more than one thing. That *-s* is not a plural. Spanish grew a habit of finishing its *when*-words that way, and once you hear it you will spot the next one before anyone explains it.
Mientras joins two things happening at once: *mientras como* — while I eat.

What you've built

Twenty words. Ten name what courtesy is made of; ten put things in time — a night behind you, a week to count in, a place in the day, the

next instant, a thing not finished, a thing already done, a *then*, a *before*, an *after*, and a *while*. Between them you can say a good deal more at a door than *hasta luego*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mientras*
- *mientras como*
- *antes — después — mientras*

Before you move on

What does *inter* mean? (Between.) What do *entonces*, *antes*, *después* and *mientras* all share on the end? (An *-s* that is not a plural.)

Chapter 324

True, False, and Not Even

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can weigh what somebody has told me with verdad, falso, acaso, menos and ni siquiera, and say which two Latin twins gave mas and menos.
>
> *Complete ES-C324-siquiera: call a claim la verdad or falso, hedge it with acaso, size it with mas o menos, and empty it out with ni siquiera.*

324.1 la verdad — the noun inside a question you already ask

Say *afterwards*, then *while*. (*Después*; *mientras*.)

What to know first

- ¿verdad? — the tag you already hang on the end of a sentence.
- -dad — the ending that answers to English *-ty*.

Sounds you'll need

- *ver-DAD*, the weight on the second beat. The *v* is soft, made without closing the lips, and the final *-d* is softer still — closer to the *th* of *this*, and in much of the Spanish-speaking world it fades away entirely. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la verdad — "the truth."
Latin **vērus** meant *true*, and **vēritās** was the state of being so. The *-tās* ending is the one you have met wearing Spanish clothes as *-dad*: Latin *-tātem* became Spanish *-dad* and English *-ty* out of the same starting point, which is why *veritas* lands as both **verdad** and **verity**. English carries the root in more places than it admits. To **verify** is to make true. **Veracity** is truthfulness. A **verdict** is *vērē dictum* — *truly said*, two Latin words a jury still hands over as one. And *very* began as an adjective meaning *true*: a *very* fool once meant a *true* fool, and only later did it drift into meaning *extremely*.
You have been saying the Spanish word for a while without unpacking it. When you end a sentence with **¿verdad?** you are asking *truth? — is that the truth?* Now the noun stands on its own: **la verdad** is the thing itself, and **de verdad** means *for real*.

What you've built

The first of five words for weighing what somebody has told you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la verdad*
- *de verdad*
- *es la verdad, ¿verdad?*

Before you move on

What did *vērus* mean? (True.) And what two Latin words are folded into English *verdict*? (*Vērē dictum* — truly said.)

324.2 falso — the opposite, and a word you have already met in the plural

Say *while*, then *the truth*. (*Mientras*; *la verdad*.)

What to know first

- falsos amigos — you have already carried this word around in its plural.

Sounds you'll need

- *FAL-so*, the weight on the first beat. The *l* stays bright and forward, not swallowed the way an English *l* goes dark before a consonant. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

falso — "false," and often "fake."
Latin **fallere** meant *to trip somebody up* — to make a foot go where the ground was not. **Falsus** was its past participle: *tripped up*, and so *deceived*, and so *untrue*.
English collected the whole family and kept the pieces in different rooms. **False** is the participle, borrowed whole. To **fail** is *fallere* through French — the ground giving way under you. A **fault** is where the ground did give way, in a person or in rock. A **fallacy** is an argument that trips you. Something **fallible** can be tripped.
Spanish kept the verb too, worn down to **faltar** — *to be lacking* — so a thing that *falta* is a thing that has let you down by not being there. The ending moves, because *falso* describes somebody or something: *un billete falso*, *una moneda falsa*. And you have met the plural already, in the name for words that look like English and lie about it — **falsos amigos**.

What you've built

Two words, and between them a scale you can put any sentence on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *falso*
- *verdad o falso*
- *una moneda falsa*

Before you move on

What did *fallere* do to you? (Tripped you up.) And which everyday English verb is the same word through French? (*Fail.*)

324.3 acaso — the third answer, when neither of the first two fits

Say *the truth*, then *false*. (*La verdad*; *falso*.)

What to know first

- quizás and tal vez — two words for *maybe* that you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-CA-so*, three beats, the weight in the middle. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*, the same *c* as in *casa*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

acaso — "perhaps," and underneath that, *by chance*.
Break it and there are two pieces: *a* and *caso*. Latin **cāsus** was *a falling*, from **cadere**, *to fall* — and what falls, in Latin as in English, is dice. A *cāsus* was how the dice landed. So *a caso* is *at the fall*, and to say something happens *acaso* is to say it happens the way dice land.
The fall is everywhere in English. A **case** is how a matter has fallen out. A **casualty** is somebody the fall came down on. Something **casual** happens as it falls, without arrangement. A **cadence** is a falling line of sound. To **decay** is to fall away. An **accident** is *ad-cadere*, a falling toward you. Even *chance* is Latin *cadentia*, *a falling*, worn down through French.
Spanish already gave you *quizás* and *tal vez*. **Acaso** is the third, and it leans differently: dropped into a question — *¿acaso no es verdad?* — it stops being *maybe* and turns into a challenge, closer to English *surely* said with a raised eyebrow.

What you've built

True, false, and the wide space between them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *acaso*
- *acaso es verdad*
- *¿acaso es falso?*

Before you move on

What did Latin *cāsus* mean before it meant *case*? (A falling — how the dice came down.) And what does *acaso* do to a question? (Turns it into a challenge.)

324.4 menos — the other half of a pair you have been using one side of

Say *false*, then *perhaps*. (*Falso*; *acaso*.)

What to know first

- más que — the comparison you can already make in one direction.
- regular — the middling answer, built on this same root.

Sounds you'll need

- *ME-nos*, the weight on the first beat. The final *-s* is pronounced clearly across most of Latin America, and softens toward a breath in the Caribbean and southern Spain. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

menos — "less," or "fewer."
Latin had a matched pair, and Spanish kept both: **magis** for the more of a thing and **minus** for the less. *Magis* wore down into *más*. *Minus* barely moved at all — say *minus* quickly and you have *menos*.
English took the smaller twin without changing it either. **Minus** is the arithmetic. A **minor** matter is a smaller one. A **minimum** is the least. A **minute** was a *pars minuta*, a made-small part of an hour, and

the adjective **minute** meaning *tiny* is the same word with its old stress. To **diminish** is to make less. And a **minister** was once *minus*-plus-an-ending: the lesser one, the servant — the opposite number of a *magister*, the greater one, who becomes the English *master*.
Two everyday phrases carry it. **Más o menos** is *more or less*, and it is the most common answer to *¿cómo estás?* there is. **Por lo menos** is *at least*. And *menos* has a second job with no English echo: after a list, it means *except*.

What you've built

A dial you can turn both ways, and the safest answer in the language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *menos*
- *más o menos*
- *por lo menos, es verdad*

Before you move on

Which Latin word gave *más*, and which gave *menos*? (*Magis* and *minus*.) And what was a *minister* before it was a government job? (The lesser one — the servant.)

324.5 siquiera — a word made of two words you already own

Say *perhaps*, then *more or less*. (*Acaso*; *más o menos*.)

What to know first

- si — *if*, without an accent.
- quiera · quieras · quiera — the *wanting* form used for things that are not settled.

- ni — *nor*, the word that will stand in front of it.

Sounds you'll need

- *si-KYE-ra*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *qu* is a plain *k* with a silent *u*, and *ie* rides through as one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

siquiera — "even," or "at least."
Nothing new arrived. Spanish took *si* and *quiera* — both of them already yours — and pushed them together until they stopped being two words. *Si quiera* meant *if he should want it*, the shrug you make when the smallest version of something would do. Said often enough, the seam closed and the meaning thinned into *even*.
The Latin underneath *quiera* is **quaerere**, *to seek*, and English kept the seeking rather than the wanting: to **query** is to seek an answer, to **acquire** is to seek toward, an **inquest** is a seeking-into, and a **quest** is the bare verb standing alone.
Two uses carry almost all of the weight. On its own, **siquiera** softens a request down to the smallest acceptable size: *siquiera un poco — at least a little*. With **ni** in front, it does the opposite and empties the sentence out: **ni siquiera** is *not even*.

What you've built

Five words for weighing a claim: true, false, perhaps, less — and not even.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *siquiera*
- *ni siquiera*
- *siquiera un poco*

Before you move on

Which two words are welded together inside *siquiera*? (*Si* and *quiera*.) And what does *ni* in front of it do? (Makes it *not even*.)

Chapter 325

Country, City, Neighbourhood

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name five nested places in Spanish — el pais, la ciudad, el barrio, la plaza and el lugar — and say which one of them is Arabic rather than Latin.
>
> *Complete ES-C325-lugar: say where you are from with pais and ciudad, place yourself in a barrio and a plaza, and name a spot with lugar.*

325.1 el país — the widest circle you can be from

Say *more or less*, then *not even*. (*Más o menos*; *ni siquiera*.)

What to know first

- soy de… — the sentence this word finishes.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-ÍS*, two beats, not one. The written accent on the *í* is doing real work: without it, *ai* would glide together into a single sound. The accent prises the two vowels apart and puts the weight on the second. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el país — "the country," meaning a nation.
Latin **pāgus** was a country district — a stretch of land with a village in it, far from any city. Somebody who lived there was a **pāgānus**. Late Latin built **pāgēnsis**, *belonging to the district*, and that word travelled north into French as *pays* and came back over the mountains into Spanish as **país**.
English took *pāgānus* twice, by two different roads, and never noticed. Through Church Latin it arrived as **pagan**: when the cities had changed religion the country districts had not, so *country-dweller* and *unconverted* became the same word. Through French *paisant* — from that same *pays* — it arrived as **peasant**. A pagan and a peasant are one Latin word wearing two English coats.
Spanish keeps the *pays* family alive: **el paisaje** is the landscape, and **el paisano** is a fellow countryman.

What you've built

The first of five circles, from a whole country down to a single spot.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el país*
- *mi país*
- *soy de otro país*

Before you move on

What was a *pāgus*? (A country district.) And which two English words both come from the person who lived in one? (*Pagan* and *peasant*.)

325.2 la ciudad — a place named after the people in it

Say *not even*, then *my country*. (*Ni siquiera*; *mi país*.)

What to know first

- -dad — the ending, met once already with *la verdad*.

Sounds you'll need

- *syu-DAD*, the weight on the last beat. The *c* before *i* is soft — an *s* in Latin America, a *th* in most of Spain — and *ciu* runs through as one glide rather than three separate vowels. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la ciudad — "the city."
Latin had two ideas and kept them separate. **Urbs** was the buildings: walls, streets, stone. **Cīvitās** was the people: the body of **cīvēs**, citizens, who belonged to each other. Spanish let *urbs* go except in bookish words like *urbano*, and built its everyday word on the people instead. **Cīvitātem**, worn down through *cibdad*, gives **ciudad**.
That is the second time you have watched Latin *-tātem* land as Spanish **-dad**. *Vēritātem* gave *verdad*; *cīvitātem* gives *ciudad*. English took the same ending as **-ty**, so *verity* and *city* are the exact same road, walked twice.
The root is loud in English. A **citizen** is a *cīvis*. **Civic** duty, **civil** war, a **civilian** rather than a soldier, and **civilization** itself are all the people-word rather than the building-word. Rome decided a city was who lived there, and both languages have carried that decision ever since.

What you've built

The circle inside the country, and a Latin ending you can now spot on sight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la ciudad*
- *una ciudad grande*
- *la ciudad y el país*

Before you move on

Did Latin name the city after its walls or after its people? (Its people — *cīvēs*.) And which English ending answers to Spanish *-dad*? (*-ty*.)

325.3 el barrio — an Arabic word for the part of town past the wall

Say *the country*, then *the city*. (*El país*; *la ciudad*.)

What to know first

- hasta, azul and café — three words Spanish took from Arabic, already yours.

Sounds you'll need

- *BA-rryo*, the weight on the first beat. The double *rr* is a rolled trill, held long enough to buzz; *io* at the end runs through as one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el barrio — "the neighbourhood," the quarter of a town you live in. This one is not Latin. Arabic **barr** was the open land — dry ground, the country outside. Andalusi Arabic made **barrī**, *of the outside*, and in the walled towns of al-Andalus a *barrī* was the district that had spilled past the wall and kept growing. Spanish took the word and lost the wall, so a *barrio* became any quarter of any town.

You already carry three Arabic words in Spanish without having marked them as a set: **hasta**, from *ḥattā*; **azul**, from *lāzaward*, the blue stone; and **café**, from *qahwah*. Nearly eight centuries of al-Andalus left something over a thousand words in Spanish, and they cluster where daily life is — buildings, water, farming, trade.

English then borrowed *barrio* back out of Spanish without translating it, the way it took *plaza* and *patio*. The word has now crossed three languages and is still the same four sounds it started as.

What you've built

The circle inside the city — and a reminder that Spanish is not only Latin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el barrio*
- *mi barrio*
- *un barrio de la ciudad*

Before you move on

What did Arabic *barr* mean? (The open land outside.) And which three Arabic words in Spanish do you already say? (*Hasta*, *azul*, *café*.)

325.4 la plaza — a word that means broad, and went everywhere

Say *the city*, then *my neighbourhood*. (*La ciudad*; *mi barrio*.)

What to know first

- la calle — the street that runs into it.

Sounds you'll need

- *PLA-sa*, the weight on the first beat. The *pl* stays a clean cluster with no vowel pushed in between, and the *z* is an *s* across Latin America and a *th* in most of Spain. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la plaza — "the square," the open space a town gathers in.
Greek **platýs** meant *broad*. Greek speakers called a wide street a **plateîa hodós**, a *broad way*, and dropped the *way* until only *plateîa* was left. Latin borrowed it as **platea**, and every Romance language

then wore it down its own way: Spanish to **plaza**, Italian to *piazza*, French to *place* — and English took *place* from French and *plaza* from Spanish, so it is holding the same word twice without noticing.
Platýs is broad in English too, once you hear it. A **plate** is a flat broad dish. A **plateau** is broad flat ground. A **platitude** is a flattened remark. And a **platypus** is *platýs* plus *poús*, foot — the broad-footed animal.
There is a thing worth marking about the Spanish town. The *plaza* is not decoration; it is the centre a *barrio* is arranged around, with the church on one side and the market on another. English-speaking towns tend to grow along a main street; Spanish-speaking ones grow around a middle, and **la plaza del pueblo** is where everybody ends up in the evening.

What you've built

The middle of the neighbourhood, and a Greek word that reached English twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la plaza*
- *la plaza del pueblo*
- *la plaza del barrio*

Before you move on

What did Greek *platýs* mean? (Broad.) And which English word is the same Latin *platea* arriving through French? (*Place.*)

325.5 el lugar — the same Latin word as luego, gone the other way

Say *my neighbourhood*, then *the town square.* (*Mi barrio*; *la plaza del pueblo.*)

What to know first

- luego — the same Latin root, already yours.
- en primer lugar — this noun, already inside a phrase you can say.

Sounds you'll need

- *lu-GAR*, the weight on the second beat. The *g* before *a* is hard, and the final *r* is a single flick of the tongue rather than a roll. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el lugar — "the place," a spot rather than a town.
Latin **locus** was a place. Spanish took it twice and let the two copies drift apart until they stopped sounding related.
One copy stayed about space. *Locālis*, *belonging to a place*, wore through Old Spanish *logar* into **lugar** — a spot, a position, somewhere something goes. The other copy turned into time. *In locō*, *in that place*, became *luego*, and what began as *there* slid into *then* — which is why you have been saying **hasta luego** since almost the beginning without meeting the place inside it.
You have also been carrying the noun whole. **En primer lugar** — *in the first place* — is this word, holding the same job it holds in English. English kept *locus* untranslated for a point in space, and built **local**, **locate**, **location**, **allocate** and **dislocate** on it. It also has the French version: *lieu* is *locus* worn down, so a **lieutenant** is a *place-holder*, the officer who stands in somebody else's spot — and *in lieu of* is *in the place of*, still doing its Latin job in an English sentence.

What you've built

Five circles: country, city, neighbourhood, square, spot. You can now say where you are from and where you are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el lugar*
- *otro lugar*

- *un lugar en el barrio*

Before you move on

Which everyday farewell has *locus* hiding inside it? (*Hasta luego.*) And what does a **lieutenant** hold? (Somebody else's place.)

Chapter 326

Five Ways to Be

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say I am nervous, brave, alone, free or ready in Spanish, and say why ser listo and estar listo mean two different things.
>
> *Complete ES-C326-listo: answer with nervioso or valiente, say estoy solo and estoy libre, and split ser listo from estar listo.*

326.1 nervioso — an ending you already own, on a fibre you already have

Say *the square*, then *another place*. (*La plaza*; *otro lugar*.)

What to know first

- -oso — the ending that answers to English *-ous*.
- estar — the verb this word takes.

Sounds you'll need

- *ner-BYO-so*, the weight on the third-from-last beat. The *v* is soft, made without the lips quite meeting, and *io* glides through as one. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nervioso — "nervous."
Latin **nervus** was not a nerve. It was a *sinew* — a tendon, a bowstring, the tough cord that makes a thing pull. Its Greek twin is **neûron**, the same word on the other side of the sea, which is why English ended up with **nerve** from the Latin and **neuron**, **neurology** and **neurotic** from the Greek.
Nervōsus therefore meant *full of sinew* — strong, tough, wiry. English kept that older sense a long while: *nervous* prose is still prose with muscle in it. Only when doctors began calling the body's signalling cords *nerves* did the adjective turn inward and start meaning *anxious* in both languages at once.
The build is one you can already take apart. *Nervus* plus the Latin **-ōsus** gives Spanish **-oso**, which is the English **-ous** — the ending behind *famoso* and *famous*, *curioso* and *curious*. And the *-o* switches for a woman: **nerviosa**.
One thing to fix now. Being nervous is a state you are in, not a thing you are, so it takes *estar*: **estoy nervioso**, not *soy nervioso*.

What you've built

The first of five ways to answer *¿cómo estás?* with something other than *bien*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nervioso*
- *estoy nervioso*
- *nervioso — nerviosa*

Before you move on

What was a *nervus* before it was a nerve? (A sinew — a bowstring.) And which Spanish verb does *nervioso* take? (*Estar*.)

326.2 valiente — the opposite of nervioso, and a verb you already say

Say *another place*, then *I am nervous.* (*Otro lugar*; *estoy nervioso.*)

What to know first

- más vale pájaro en mano — the *vale* in it is this verb.
- triste — the word that showed why an *-e* ending never switches.

Sounds you'll need

- *ba-LYEN-te*, the weight on the middle beat. The *v* is soft again, and *ie* rides through as one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

valiente — "brave."
Latin **valēre** meant *to be strong*, and from there *to be worth* — because what is strong is what holds up, and what holds up is what is worth having. Both meanings survived. Spanish **valer** is *to be worth*, and its old present participle, *the one being strong*, hardened into the adjective **valiente**.
You have been saying the verb already. In the proverb about the bird in the hand, *más vale* is *is worth more.* And the everyday Spanish **vale** — *okay*, *fine*, *agreed* — is the same form: *it holds*, *it stands.*
English took the whole family. **Valiant** is *valiente* through French. **Valour** is the strength. **Value** is the worth. Something **valid** stands up; something **invalid** does not, and an *invalid* person was once somebody whose strength had gone. To **prevail** is to be stronger in front. To **convalesce** is to grow strong together with your body again. Even the Latin farewell **valē** — *be strong* — is the same word, and it is what the Spanish *vale* is descended from.
It ends in *-e*, so there is nothing to switch: *un chico valiente*, *una chica valiente.*

What you've built

Two states that face each other, and a root you can hear in *vale* all day.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *valiente*
- *nervioso — valiente*
- *una chica valiente*

Before you move on

What were the two meanings of *valēre*? (To be strong, and to be worth.) And why does *valiente* stay the same for a woman? (It ends in *-e*.)

326.3 solo — one word, two meanings, and an accent that no longer exists

Say *I am nervous*, then *brave*. (*Estoy nervioso*; *valiente*.)

Sounds you'll need

- *SO-lo*, two even beats, the weight on the first. Both *o* sounds stay short and pure — Spanish never lets an *o* slide off into a second vowel the way English *go* does. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

solo — "alone." And also "only."
Latin **sōlus** meant *alone*, and English is full of it. Your **sole** purpose is your only one. A musician plays a **solo**, alone. A **solitary** person keeps to **solitude**. **Desolate** ground has been left all alone. A **soliloquy** is speaking alone on a stage.
Spanish put the one word to two jobs. *Estoy solo* is *I am alone*. *Solo quiero agua* is *I only want water*. Same five letters, two meanings, and for most of the twentieth century Spanish separated them in writing: the *only* one was spelled **sólo**, with an accent, and the *alone* one was not.
That accent is gone. In 2010 the Royal Spanish Academy ruled it unnecessary, because the sentence around the word already tells you

which meaning is running. You will still see *sólo* in older books and from writers who kept the habit, and neither spelling is a mistake to read — but the rule now is that both are written **solo**.
There is one difference the spelling never showed anyway. *Alone* describes a person, so it switches: a woman says **estoy sola**. *Only* describes the sentence, not a person, so it never moves: *solo* stays *solo* for everybody.

What you've built

A word that does two jobs, and the reason the accent it used to carry was dropped.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *estoy solo*
- *estoy sola*
- *solo quiero agua*

Before you move on

What two things can *solo* mean? (Alone, and only.) And which of the two changes to *sola* for a woman? (*Alone* — the *only* one never moves.)

326.4 libre — not the same word as libro, and Spanish keeps them apart

Say *brave*, then *I only want water.* (*Valiente*; *solo quiero agua.*)

What to know first

- el libro — close enough to trip you, and a different word underneath.

Sounds you'll need

- *LEE-bre*, the weight on the first beat. The *b* is soft between vowels, and the *r* is one flick — hold it any longer and you have said *libre* with a roll it does not want. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

libre — "free."
Latin had two words spelled **liber** and they had nothing to do with each other. One was the inner bark of a tree, the surface people wrote on before paper, and it became the word for a book — Spanish **libro**, English *library*. The other meant *not owned by anybody*: a free person rather than a slave.
Spanish inherited both and kept them clearly apart: **libro** for the object, **libre** for the condition. English inherited both too, but sent them to different shelves — *library* from the bark, **liberty** from the free person — so the collision is invisible until somebody points at it. The free *liber* is a large family in English. **Liberty** and **liberate** are plain. A **liberal** was originally a free person's education, the kind a citizen rather than a labourer received. And to **deliver** is *dē-līberāre*, to set free *from* something — which is why a delivery is a parcel released to you.
Libre ends in *-e*, so it never switches. And it does one thing English cannot: English *free* covers both *unowned* and *costing nothing*, while Spanish splits them — **libre** is the first, **gratis** is the second.

What you've built

Four states, and a pair of look-alikes you will never confuse again.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *libre*
- *el libro — libre*
- *estoy libre*

Before you move on

Are *libro* and *libre* the same Latin word? (No — one was tree bark, the other meant unowned.) And which Spanish word means *free of charge*? (*Gratis.*)

326.5 listo — the word where ser and estar change the meaning outright

Say *I am alone*, then *free*. (*Estoy solo*; *libre.*)

What to know first

- ser vs estar — the split this word finally pays off.
- blanco ← *blank — the Germanic layer of Spanish, already met.

Sounds you'll need

- *LEES-to*, the weight on the first beat. No vowel goes in front of the *st* — Spanish usually refuses that cluster at the start of a word, but in the middle it runs clean. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

listo — "clever," or "ready," and which one depends entirely on the verb.

Ser listo is *to be clever*. That is what somebody is: a standing fact about them. **Estar listo** is *to be ready*. That is what somebody is right now, and in ten minutes it may have changed.

You were taught the *ser/estar* split a long way back as a rule about permanent and temporary. Here is where the rule stops being an abstraction and starts paying rent. With most adjectives, choosing the wrong verb sounds odd. With *listo*, it says something else entirely. *Es lista* praises her mind. *Está lista* means she has her coat on.

The word's own history is a smaller surprise. The Royal Spanish Academy traces *listo* to Gothic **lists**, *cunning* — Spanish has a Germanic layer left by the Visigoths, and you have met it already in *blanco*, which came from a Germanic *blank* rather than from Latin. German still uses the word: **List** is a clever trick, and *listig* means

crafty. English once had it too, as Old English *list*, *skill* or *craft*, and then let it go — one of the places where Spanish kept a Germanic word that English dropped.
The *-o* switches: **listo**, **lista**.

What you've built

Five states of mind — and proof that *ser* and *estar* are not decoration.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *estoy listo*
- *es listo*
- *soy lista, pero no estoy lista*

Before you move on

Which verb makes *listo* mean *clever*? (*Ser.*) And which makes it mean *ready*? (*Estar.*)

Chapter 327

Awake, Asleep, Strong, Weak

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can report on my body with despierto, dormido, fuerte, debil and sano, and say why a vowel breaks in duermo but not in dormido.
>
> *Complete ES-C327-sano: say estoy despierto and estoy dormido, put fuerte against debil, and close with sano y salvo.*

327.1 despierto — the e that breaks, and where it breaks

Say *free*, then *I am ready.* (*Libre*; *estoy listo.*)

What to know first

- e → ie and o → ue — the break this word walks.
- regular — a distant relative, further down.

Sounds you'll need

- *des-PYER-to*, the weight on the middle beat. The *ie* is one glide, not two vowels, and the *r* is a single flick. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

despierto — "awake."
Start with the verb behind it, **despertar**, *to wake*. Latin **expergīscī** meant *to wake up*, and it is built from *ex-*, *out of*, plus **pergere**, *to press onward* — waking as setting out again. *Pergere* is itself *per-* plus **regere**, *to steer*, and that one is loud in English: to **direct**, to **correct**, a **region**, a **regent**, a **rule**, and the *regula* behind *regular*.
Now the sound. The infinitive is *despertar*, with an *e*. The form you say about yourself is *despierto*, with an *ie*. This is the break you were shown long ago, and it obeys one condition: the *e* splits into *ie* only where the stress falls on it. In *despertar* the weight is on the last beat, so the *e* stays whole. In *despierto* the weight moves onto the stem, and the vowel cracks.
Then the useful accident. **Despierto** is both *I wake up* and the adjective *awake* — the same six letters. *Estoy despierto* is *I am awake*, and the *-o* switches for a woman: **despierta**.

What you've built

The first of five reports from the body rather than the mind.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *despierto*
- *estoy despierto*
- *despertar* — *despierto*

Before you move on

Why does *despertar* keep its *e* while *despierto* breaks it? (The break happens only where the stress lands.) And what did *expergīscī* picture waking as? (Setting out again.)

327.2 dormido — a verb you have and an ending you have

Say *I am ready*, then *I am awake*. (*Estoy listo*; *estoy despierto*.)

What to know first

- dormir — the verb this is built from.
- hablado / comido / vivido — the ending being put on it.

Sounds you'll need

- *dor-MEE-do*, the weight on the middle beat. The *r* is one flick, and the *d* between vowels softens toward the *th* of *this*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dormido — "asleep."
Nothing is new here. You have the verb **dormir** and you have the *-ido* ending, so *dormir* plus *-ido* gives **dormido**, and a participle used as an adjective is *asleep*: **estoy dormido**.
Latin **dormīre** stayed close to the surface in English, always in places where sleep is the point. A **dormitory** is a sleeping-room. A **dormant** seed is sleeping. A **dormer** window began as the window of a sleeping-room in the roof. And a **dormouse** is not a door-mouse — the first half is *dormīre* arriving through French, the mouse that sleeps all winter.
Here is the sound point, and it closes the one from last time. *Dormir* breaks its *o* into *ue* when you say *duermo* — but *dormido* does not break at all. Same rule, applied honestly: the vowel cracks only under stress. In *duermo* the weight is on the stem; in *dormido* it has moved onto the *-i-*, so the *o* stays whole. Awake and asleep both turn out to be lessons about where the stress is standing.
The *-o* switches: **dormida**.

What you've built

The pair — awake and asleep — and one sound rule proved twice in a row.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dormido*

- *estoy dormido*
- *despierto — dormido*

Before you move on

Why does *duermo* break its *o* while *dormido* does not? (The break needs the stress, and in *dormido* the stress has moved.) And what is sleeping inside the English *dormouse*? (*Dormīre.*)

327.3 fuerte — the adjective under a noun you already carry

Say *I am awake*, then *asleep.* (*Estoy despierto*; *dormido.*)

What to know first

- la fuerza — the noun; this is the adjective it was built from.

Sounds you'll need

- *FWER-te*, two beats, the weight on the first. The *ue* is one glide starting with a *w*, and the *r* is a single flick. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

fuerte — "strong." And, said about a sound, "loud."
Latin **fortis** meant *strong*, and Spanish already handed you the noun: *la fuerza*, from *fortia*, is the strength. This is the adjective standing behind it, and it walked the same road — the stressed *o* of *fortis* cracked into *ue*, the way it did in *fuerza* and *sueño*, so a Latin *o* under stress became a Spanish *ue* one more time.
English hoarded this family without merging any of it. A **fort** is a strong place, and so is a **fortress**. **Force** is *fortia*, the same noun as *fuerza*, arriving through French. An **effort** is strength pushed *out.* To **fortify** is to make strong. **Fortitude** is strength held over time. And **comfort** is *com-fortāre, to strengthen thoroughly* — being comforted was once being made stronger, not being made softer.
Fuerte ends in *-e*, so it never switches: *un café fuerte*, *una chica fuerte.* And the second meaning is genuinely everyday — *habla más fuerte* is

speak louder, not *speak more strongly.*

What you've built

The adjective under *la fuerza*, and a vowel break you can now predict.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *fuerte*
- *la fuerza — fuerte*
- *un café fuerte*

Before you move on

What happened to the *o* of *fortis*? (Stressed, it broke into *ue*.) And what did *comfort* originally do to somebody? (Made them stronger.)

327.4 débil — the opposite of fuerte, and an accent that explains itself

Say *asleep*, then *strong.* (*Dormido*; *fuerte.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *DÉ-bil*, the weight on the first beat. The *b* is soft between vowels, and the *l* stays bright rather than going dark at the end. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

débil — "weak."
Latin **dēbilis** meant *weak*, *crippled*, *without strength.* English took the long forms and left the short one: to **debilitate** is to weaken, a **debilitating** illness is one that takes your strength, and **debility** is the state of having none. English never adopted the plain adjective, so this is a word where Spanish keeps the simple version and English keeps only the dressed-up ones.

The written accent is not decoration and it is not random. Spanish has a default: a word ending in a vowel, in *-n* or in *-s* is stressed on the second-to-last beat, and any other ending pushes the stress onto the last beat. *Débil* ends in *-l*, so the default would make it *de-BIL*. It is not *de-BIL*; it is *DÉ-bil*. The word breaks the rule, so it must carry an accent to say so. Every written accent in Spanish is that same announcement.
The ending never switches, because *-l* is not *-o*: *un niño débil*, *una niña débil*. And it pairs cleanly with the word before it — *fuerte* and *débil* are the two ends of one line.

What you've built

The second pair, and the reason an accent mark appears where it does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *débil*
- *fuerte — débil*
- *estoy débil*

Before you move on

Where would the stress fall without the accent? (On *-bil*, because the word ends in *-l*.) And which English verb is *dēbilis* in a longer coat? (*Debilitate*.)

327.5 sano — one Latin word that English split down the middle

Say *strong*, then *weak*. (*Fuerte*; *débil*.)

What to know first

- enfermo — the word this one answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *SA-no*, two even beats, the weight on the first. The *a* is open and short, and the *n* is a clean tap with no nasal colour bleeding into the vowel. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sano — "healthy."
Latin **sānus** covered the whole person: healthy in the body *and* sound in the mind, with no line drawn between them. Spanish kept the word whole. English took it apart and put the halves in separate rooms.
The mind half went one way. **Sane** is *sānus*, and so are **sanity** and **insane** — all of them now strictly about the mind, so that calling somebody *sane* says nothing at all about their health. The body half went the other: **sanitary**, **sanitation** and a **sanatorium** are about physical health and never about the mind. One Latin word, and English speakers use both halves daily without hearing that they rhyme for a reason.
Spanish also kept the verb, **sanar**, *to heal*, and a set phrase worth having: **sano y salvo** — *safe and sound*, and both languages reached for a doubled expression to say the same thing.
The *-o* switches: **sana**. And the pairing is the one you would expect — *sano* answers *enfermo*, the way *fuerte* answers *débil*.

What you've built

Five reports from the body: awake, asleep, strong, weak, well. Between this chapter and the one before it you can now answer *¿cómo estás?* ten ways.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sano*
- *estoy sano*
- *sano — enfermo*

Before you move on

Which half of *sānus* did English keep in *sane*? (The mind half.)
And which half is in *sanitary*? (The body half.)

Chapter 328

Never, Barely, Almost, Even

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can size a claim with asi, jamas, apenas, casi and incluso, and say which two Latin words are fused inside jamas.
>
> *Complete ES-C328-incluso: set the manner with asi, then run the scale from jamas through apenas and casi up to incluso.*

328.1 así — the word that is *yes* with a run-up

Say *weak*, then *healthy*. (*Débil*; *sano*.)

What to know first

- así que — the connector you already use. This is its first half, standing alone.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-SÍ*, two beats with the weight on the second, which is what the written accent is there to tell you. The *s* is clean and hissed, never buzzed like the *s* in English *rose*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

así — "thus," "like this," "that way."
Latin had **sīc**, meaning *thus, in this manner*. Spanish took it twice. Once with a small preposition glued on the front: **ad sīc**, *to thus*, wore down to **así**. That is the word here — the one that points at a manner and says *that one, that way*.
And once bare. **Sīc** all by itself became Spanish **sí**, *yes*. A Roman answering a question affirmatively said *thus — that is how it is* — and after enough centuries of saying it, *thus* stopped meaning *thus* and started meaning *yes*. So every *sí* you have said is a worn-down *so it is*, and **así es** is the full sentence it came from: *that is how it is*.
English never made that leap, but it did keep the Latin word raw. When a writer quotes a mistake and puts [**sic**] after it, they are writing *thus — this is how it stood, and the error is not mine*.

What you've built

The first of five words for saying *how much* and *how*. This one sets the manner; the next four set the amount.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *así*
- *así es*
- *así que no*

Before you move on

What did Latin *sīc* mean? (Thus, in this manner.) And which one-letter Spanish word is *sīc* with nothing added? (*Sí* — yes.)

328.2 jamás — two Latin words that add up to *never*

Say *healthy*, then *like this*. (*Sano*; *así*.)

What to know first

- mas — the second half of this word, which you already have on its own.

Sounds you'll need

- *ja-MÁS*, the weight on the second beat. The *j* is the raspy sound made at the back of the throat, nothing like an English *j*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jamás — "never," and in some sentences "ever."
Two Latin words are fused in here, and Spanish has kept both of them alive separately, so you can watch the seam.
Iam meant *already, by now*. **Magis** meant *more*. Put them together — **iam magis**, *already more* — and you have a phrase about time stretching onward: *ever after this, at any point from here*.
You have met the second half. Latin *magis* is the ancestor of Spanish **más**, and of the older **mas**. So *jamás* is, letter by letter, *already-more*.
Now the twist that makes it useful. *Iam magis* originally meant **ever**, not *never*. It turned negative by keeping the company of negatives: it was used so often after *no* that the *no* became optional and the negative meaning stuck to the word itself. French did exactly the same thing with the same two Latin words, and got **jamais**.
Both meanings survive in Spanish. After a negative it is *never*: **no lo hace jamás**. On its own in a question it can still be the old *ever*.

What you've built

Two of five. You have the manner word and the floor of the scale — the point where an amount is nothing at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *jamás*
- *no, jamás*
- *jamás así*

Before you move on

Which two Latin words are fused into *jamás*? (*Iam* and *magis* — already more.) And which Spanish word is that second half on its own? (*Más.*)

328.3 apenas — *barely*, and the pain that is hiding in it

Say *like this*, then *never*. (*Así*; *jamás.*)

What to know first

- la pena — the noun sitting inside this word.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-PE-nas*, three beats with the weight in the middle. No written accent, because a word ending in *-s* takes its stress on the second-to-last beat by default. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

apenas — "barely," "hardly," "scarcely."
Take it apart and you find a word you already own. **A** + **penas** — *at pains*, *with difficulty.* To do something *apenas* is to do it only by paying for it.
Latin **poena** was a *penalty*, the price exacted for a wrong. Greek **poinē** before it meant a blood-price. The word travelled into every corner of English and kept its bill attached: a **penalty** is a poena, **penal** law is the law of poenas, a **penitent** pays one willingly, and a **subpoena** is a court order that names the fine you incur *under* it — *sub poena*, "under penalty."
English **pain** is the same word too, worn down through French. What started as a fine ended as the feeling of one.
Spanish kept the noun straight — **la pena**, the trouble or the sorrow — and then built this adverb on top of it. So *apenas* is not a vague *hardly.* It says the thing happened, and that it cost something to happen.

What you've built

Three of five. *Jamás* is none of it at all; *apenas* is the first sliver above none.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *apenas*
- *apenas un poco*
- *apenas así*

Before you move on

What did Latin *poena* mean? (A penalty, a price paid.) And what does *sub poena* mean word for word? (Under penalty.)

328.4 casi — a Latin word English borrowed without changing a letter

Say *never*, then *barely*. (*Jamás*; *apenas*.)

What to know first

- nada — the word this one likes to stand in front of.

Sounds you'll need

- *CA-si*, two even beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*, and the *s* stays crisp. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

casi — "almost," "nearly."
Latin **quasi** meant *as if*, built from **quam** (*as*) and **sī** (*if*). It was the word a Roman reached for when a thing resembled another without being it.
Spanish wore the *qu-* down to a *c-* and shortened the vowel, and **quasi** became **casi**. The meaning barely moved: *as if* and *almost* are the

same thought from two angles.
Here is the part worth noticing. English did not inherit this word — it **borrowed** it, spelling and all, and never dressed it up. A **quasi-**official statement is one that is *as if* official. A **quasi-**legal arrangement is nearly but not actually legal. English speakers hyphenate a raw Latin word onto the front of nouns every day.
So *casi* and *quasi-* are the same five letters rearranged by time. Spanish kept it as an everyday adverb; English kept it as a formal prefix and left it looking Roman.
Pair it with what you already have: **casi nada** is *almost nothing*, and it is a very common way to say *hardly any*.

What you've built

Four of five. The scale now runs *jamás*, *apenas*, *casi* — none, a sliver, nearly all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *casi*
- *casi nada*
- *casi todo*

Before you move on

What did Latin *quasi* mean? (As if.) And how does English still use that exact word? (As the prefix *quasi-*, on anything nearly a thing.)

328.5 incluso — *even*, and the door that shuts inside it

Say *barely*, then *almost*. (*Apenas*; *casi*.)

What to know first

- todo — the word this one quietly stretches.

Sounds you'll need

- *in-CLU-so*, three beats with the weight in the middle. The *c* before *l* is a hard *k*, and the two letters run together with no vowel between them. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

incluso — "even," and also "including."
Latin **claudere** meant *to shut*. Put **in-** on the front and you get **inclūdere**, *to shut in*, whose past participle is **inclūsus** — *shut inside*. Spanish took that participle whole.
That is the whole idea of the word. When you say *incluso*, you are naming something and shutting it inside the group, especially when the listener would have expected it left out. *Even that one is in here.*
The Latin door swings in every direction in English, and you can hear the same four letters each time. To **include** is to shut in. To **enclose** is to shut around. To **exclude** is to shut out. To **seclude** is to shut apart. A **recluse** has shut himself away. To **conclude** is to shut a matter completely, which is why a **conclusion** ends things. And plain **close** is the same verb, worn smooth by French.
So a word that now means *even* is, underneath, a door being pulled shut with one more thing on the inside.

What you've built

Five words for how much: *jamás*, *apenas*, *casi*, *incluso*, and *así* for how. Between them you can size almost any claim somebody makes to you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *incluso*
- *incluso hoy*
- *incluso así*

Before you move on

What did Latin *claudere* mean? (To shut.) And what is a **recluse**, taken literally? (Somebody shut away.)

Chapter 329

Such, Which, Then, But Rather

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can join and correct two thoughts with tal, cual, pues, sino and salvo, and say why sino needs a no earlier in the sentence.
>
> *Complete ES-C329-salvo: pair tal with cual, conclude with pues, correct a negative with sino, and make an exception with salvo.*

329.1 tal — the *such* you have been saying inside *tal vez*

Say *almost*, then *even*. (*Casi*; *incluso*.)

What to know first

- tal vez — the hedge you already use. This is its first word.

Sounds you'll need

- *TAL*, one beat, and the *l* is made with the tongue tip forward and the back of the tongue flat — never the dark, swallowed *l* that ends English *tall*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tal — "such," "such a," "of that kind."
Latin **tālis** meant *of that kind*. It is the answering half of a pair: *qualis*

asked *of what kind?* and *talis* replied *of that kind*. You will meet its partner in the very next lesson.
You have been saying it for a long time without opening it. **Tal vez** is *tal* plus *vez* — *such a turn*, *a turn of that kind* — which is how Spanish says *maybe*. Every time you hedged with *tal vez* you were saying *in a case like that*.
English lost the word as a word, but kept it in two places worth knowing.
To **retaliate** is **re-** plus **tālis**: *to give back the like*. Not merely to strike back, but to return something *of that same kind* — the word carries its own measure of proportion.
And lawyers still say **lex talionis**, the *law of the like*, which is the formal name for the rule that an eye should answer an eye. That is *tālis* doing the work it was born for: matching a thing to its kind.
Spanish also uses *tal* in a question you will hear constantly — **¿qué tal?**, roughly *what kind of?*, which has settled into meaning *how's it going?*

What you've built

The first of five small joining words. These are the pieces that let two thoughts lean on each other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tal*
- *tal vez*
- *tal vez no*

Before you move on

What did Latin *tālis* mean? (Of that kind.) And what does **retaliate** mean piece by piece? (To give back the like.)

329.2 cual — the question *tal* was answering

Say *even*, then *such*. (*Incluso*; *tal*.)

What to know first

- lo cual — the connector this word already lives in.

Sounds you'll need

- *KWAL*, one beat. The *cu-* is a *k* followed straight by a *w* glide, and the *a* stays open. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cual — "which," "as," "of what kind."
Latin **quālis** asked the question that **tālis** answered. *Quālis? — of what kind? Tālis. — of that kind.* The two words were built to be used together, and Spanish still pairs them: **tal cual** means *exactly as it is*, literally *such as which.*
You already carry it in **lo cual**, the connector for referring back to a whole clause.
Now the English payoff, and it is a good one. Cicero needed a Latin word for a Greek philosophical idea — the *what-kind-ness* of a thing, as opposed to its *how-much-ness.* He built one out of *quālis*: **quālitās**. That word came into English as **quality**.
So *quality* does not originally mean *goodness* at all. It means *the kind of thing something is.* That older sense is still visible when a chemist speaks of **qualitative** analysis, which asks *what is in it?* rather than *how much?* — and its partner **quantitative** is built the same way on *quantus*, *how much.*
A **qualification** is likewise a statement of what kind, which is why qualifying a claim narrows what kind of claim it is.

What you've built

Two of five. *Tal* and *cual* are a matched pair, and Spanish uses them as one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cual*
- *lo cual*

- *tal cual*

Before you move on

What did Latin *quālis* ask? (Of what kind?) And which everyday English noun did Cicero build on it? (*Quality.*)

329.3 pues — the word already hiding in *después*

Say *such*, then *which*. (*Tal*; *cual*.)

What to know first

- después — this word is inside it.

Sounds you'll need

- *PWES*, one beat. The *ue* is a single glide, *w* into *e*, not two separate vowels. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pues — "well," "then," "since."
Latin **post** meant *after*. Spanish softened it into **pues**, and in doing so let it drift from time into reasoning: *after that* became *therefore*, and *therefore* became the small *well…* that a speaker puts at the front of a sentence while deciding what to say.
That drift is ordinary. English *then* does the same double duty — *I ate, then I left* is time, but *if that is so, then you are wrong* is logic.
You already own the compound. **Después** is three Latin words stacked up: **de ex post**, *from out of after*. Speakers kept adding reinforcement to *post* until it was three syllables long, and *pues* is the bare original that survived alongside it.
English never softened the word at all. It uses **post** raw and everywhere: a **post-war** year, a **postscript** written after, to **postpone** is to place after, **posterior** is the back, and a **post mortem** happens after death.
In speech, *pues* is one of the most common words in the language, and often carries almost no meaning — it is the sound of somebody taking a breath before answering.

What you've built

Three of five. You have *of that kind*, *of what kind*, and now *therefore*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pues*
- *pues sí*
- *pues no, gracias*

Before you move on

What did Latin *post* mean? (After.) And which three Latin words are stacked inside *después*? (*De ex post.*)

329.4 sino — two words fused into one, and both of them are yours

Say *which*, then *well, then.* (*Cual*; *pues.*)

What to know first

- no ... nada — the double negative this word belongs with.

Sounds you'll need

- *SI-no*, two even beats, the weight on the first. Both vowels are short and pure. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sino — "but rather."
This one is built from two words you already have, welded together: **si** (*if*, Latin **sī**) plus **no** (Latin **nōn**). *Si no* — *if not.*
Spanish uses it for a specific job that English handles clumsily. *Sino* does not merely oppose; it **corrects a negative**. First you deny something, then *sino* supplies the right answer in its place.
Watch the shape. *No hoy, sino mañana* — *not today, but rather*

tomorrow. The *no* opens a hole and the *sino* fills it. English has to lean on *but rather* or *but instead*, because plain *but* is doing a different job. That is why Spanish keeps two words where English has one. **Pero** contrasts two things that are both true. **Sino** replaces something that was denied. Listen for the *no* that comes before it: with one in the sentence, *sino* fits; with none, *pero* is the word you want.
Written as one word it is the conjunction. Written as two — *si no* — it is still the plain *if not* it was born as, and Spanish speakers have to keep the spelling straight for exactly that reason.

What you've built

Four of five. This is the first of these joiners that changes the shape of a whole sentence rather than colouring one word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sino*
- *no hoy, sino mañana*
- *no aquí, sino así*

Before you move on

Which two words are fused into *sino*? (*Si* and *no* — if not.) And what has to appear earlier in the sentence for *sino* to be right? (A *no*.)

329.5 salvo — the second half of *sano y salvo*

Say *well, then*, then *but rather*. (*Pues*; *sino*.)

What to know first

- sano — the word this one is normally said next to.

Sounds you'll need

- *SAL-vo*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *v* is soft, made without the lips quite closing, so it lands between an English *v* and *b*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

salvo — "except," and, as an adjective, "safe."
Latin **salvus** meant *unharmed, whole, in one piece*. Spanish kept it in both of those jobs, and you have already met one of them.
In the last chapter, *sano* came with the set phrase **sano y salvo** — *healthy and unharmed*, which English says as *safe and sound* with the two halves in the other order. That *salvo* is this word, and now it stands on its own.
The second job is the surprising one. If everything in a group is unharmed **except** one thing, then that one thing has been set aside — and *salvo* slid from *safe* into *excepted*. **Todo salvo eso** is *everything except that*. The excepted item is the one left standing outside the harm.
English inherited the root generously. To **salvage** is to bring something out unharmed. **Salvation** is being made whole. A **salve** heals. A **salver** was a tasting-tray that kept a nobleman safe from poison. A naval **salvo** was a salute — a wish for safety, fired from guns.
And English **safe** is the same word, arriving by a different road through French *sauf*, which is why *sauf* still means *except* in French to this day.

What you've built

Five joiners: *tal*, *cual*, *pues*, *sino*, *salvo*. With these you can qualify, correct, conclude and make an exception — the machinery of an argument, in five short words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *salvo*
- *sano y salvo*
- *todo salvo hoy*

Before you move on

What did Latin *salvus* mean? (Unharmed, whole.) And how does *salvo* get from *safe* to *except*? (The excepted thing is the one left unharmed.)

Chapter 330

The Road and the World

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name el camino, la parada, el mundo, la vida and la vez, and say which of them is Celtic rather than Latin.
>
> *Complete ES-C330-vez: follow a camino to a parada, widen out to el mundo and la vida, and open the noun inside otra vez.*

330.1 el camino — a Celtic word that outlived the Romans

Say *but rather*, then *except*. (*Sino*; *salvo*.)

What to know first

- el lugar — the spot a road runs between.

Sounds you'll need

- *ca-MI-no*, three beats with the weight in the middle. The single *m* and single *n* are both light taps; neither doubles. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el camino — "the road," "the way."
Almost every Spanish noun you have met so far has come down from Latin. This one did not start there.

Before Rome reached the Iberian peninsula and Gaul, Celtic-speaking peoples lived across both, and they had a word something like **cammanos** for a track or a way. The Romans, who were famous road-builders and had perfectly good words of their own, borrowed the local one anyway. It shows up in Late Latin as **camminus**, and from there it became Spanish **camino**, French **chemin**, and Italian **cammino**.

Very little Celtic survives in Spanish — a few dozen words for landscape, carts and beer — so this is a genuine rarity. When you say *camino* you are using a word that was in the ground before Latin arrived and refused to be replaced.

One collision to keep straight, because it looks like a match and is not. Latin also had **camīnus**, meaning a *furnace* or *hearth*, borrowed from Greek **kaminos**. That word gave English **chimney**. It has nothing to do with roads and nothing to do with this word. Two different sources landed on nearly the same spelling, and the resemblance is an accident.

What you've built

The first of five nouns for the shape of a day: where you go, and how long things take.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el camino*
- *un camino*
- *el camino a casa*

Before you move on

Which language did *camino* come from before Latin? (Celtic — Gaulish.) And which lookalike Latin word gave English *chimney*? (*Camīnus*, a furnace.)

330.2 la parada — the stop that used to mean *get ready*

Say *except*, then *the road.* (*Salvo*; *el camino.*)

What to know first

- ¿dónde está? — the question you ask about one of these.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-RA-da*, three beats, the weight in the middle. The *r* is a single quick tap of the tongue, and the *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* in *this*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la parada — "the stop," the place a bus or a train halts.
It is built from the verb **parar**, *to stop*, and *parar* comes from Latin **parāre** — which did not mean *to stop* at all. It meant **to make ready, to prepare**.
Follow the drift. To *make ready* is to set a thing in position. To set it in position is to place it. To place it is to make it stand still. Spanish walked that path over centuries and arrived at *stopping*; the other Romance languages mostly did not, which is why this meaning surprises people who know French or Italian.
English took *parāre* over and over and kept the original sense every time. To **prepare** is to make ready beforehand. To **repair** is to make ready again. An **apparatus** is a set of things made ready. To **parade** is to make a show ready. A **parasol** is made ready *against* the sun, and a **parachute** ready against a fall — that *para-* is the Romance *parare*, and not the Greek *para-* meaning *beside* that sits in *parallel* and *parable*.
So English has a dozen words insisting the root means *prepare*, and Spanish has the bus stop insisting it means *halt*. Both are honest descendants.

What you've built

Two of five. A road, and the places on it where you get off.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la parada*
- *una parada*
- *¿dónde está la parada?*

Before you move on

What did Latin *parāre* mean? (To make ready, to prepare.) And which sense did Spanish end up with? (Stopping.)

330.3 el mundo — the world, which used to mean *tidy*

Say *the road*, then *the stop*. (*El camino*; *la parada*.)

What to know first

- el país — the widest circle you had until now.

Sounds you'll need

- *MUN-do*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *n* before *d* is made with the tongue already at the teeth, so the two run together. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el mundo — "the world."
Latin **mundus** started life as an adjective, and it meant **clean, neat, orderly, elegant**. A *mundus* room was a tidy one. The opposite, **immundus**, meant filthy — and Spanish still has **inmundo** for something foul.
So how did *tidy* become *the world*?
Roman writers needed a Latin word for the Greek **kósmos**. And *kósmos* had made this exact journey already: it first meant *order, arrangement, adornment*, and Greek philosophers stretched it to name the universe — because what impressed them about the universe was

that it was **arranged**, not chaotic. To call the world a *kosmos* was to make a claim about it.
Latin needed a word that already meant *orderly* to translate a word that meant *orderly*. **Mundus** was the natural pick, and it inherited the second meaning along with the first.
Both halves of the Greek word survive in English, and they look unrelated until you know this. The **cosmos** is the ordered universe. **Cosmetics** are ordering and adornment applied to a face. Same word, two sizes.
And *mundus* survives in English too, in **mundane** — which now means *dull and everyday*, having slid from *of the world* to *worldly* to *ordinary*. A word that once meant *elegant* now means *boring*.

What you've built

Three of five. You can now speak about somewhere as small as a bus stop and as large as everything there is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el mundo*
- *todo el mundo*
- *el mundo es grande*

Before you move on

What did *mundus* mean as an adjective? (Clean, orderly.) And which Greek word made the same jump from order to world? (*Kósmos.*)

330.4 la vida — the root that vitamins were named for

Say *the stop*, then *the world*. (*La parada*; *el mundo.*)

What to know first

- pasar a mejor vida — an idiom this word already carries.

Sounds you'll need

- *VI-da*, two beats, the weight on the first. The *v* is soft, made without closing the lips, and the *d* between vowels is soft too. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la vida — "life."
Latin **vīta**. Spanish softened the *t* between vowels into a *d*, as it did in hundreds of words, and *vīta* became **vida**.
English holds the root everywhere. Something **vital** is necessary for life. To **revive** is to bring back to life, to **survive** is to live past something, and a plan that is **viable** is one that can live.
The best story belongs to **vitamin**. In 1912 the Polish biochemist Casimir Funk found a substance in rice husks that cured beriberi, and concluded that such life-critical compounds were **amines**, a family of nitrogen compounds. He named them **vitamines** — *vita* plus *amine*, life-amines.
He was half right. They were essential to life, but most of them were not amines at all. Rather than rename everything, chemists quietly dropped the final *e*, and **vitamine** became **vitamin** — a word whose spelling still records a mistake that was corrected by deleting one letter.
Spanish uses *vida* in more places than English uses *life*. **Así es la vida** is *that is how life is*, and you now have every word in it.

What you've built

Four of five. Road, stop, world, life — the frame around everything else you have learned to say.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la vida*
- *así es la vida*

- *mi vida*

Before you move on

What did Latin *vīta* mean? (Life.) And why did *vitamine* lose its final *e*? (Most of them turned out not to be amines.)

330.5 la vez — the noun inside *otra vez* and *tal vez*

Say *the world*, then *life*. (*El mundo*; *la vida*.)

What to know first

- otra vez — the repair phrase you already use.
- tal vez — the hedge, whose *tal* you met two chapters ago.

Sounds you'll need

- *VES*, one beat. The *v* is soft. The final *z* is a plain hissed *s* across the Americas, and a *th* sound in much of Spain. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la vez — "a time," in the sense of *an occasion* or *a turn*.
Spanish, like English, keeps two different words apart here. **El tiempo** is time as a substance, the stuff that passes. **La vez** is a countable occurrence: *one time, three times, the last time*.
Latin **vicem** was the source, and it meant *a turn, a change, a place taken in alternation*. The core idea is **substitution**: my turn is the slot I occupy when it is not yours.
You have been saying it for a long time already. **Otra vez** is *another turn* — which is why it means *again*. And **tal vez** is *such a turn*, *a turn of that kind*, which is how Spanish arrives at *maybe*. Now that you have *tal* from the chapter before this one, both words in that phrase are ones you can take apart.
English took the substitution sense and made a career of it. A **vice-president** holds office *in the turn of* the president. A **viceroy** ruled in the king's place. A **vicar** stands in for a higher authority.

And something learned **vicariously** is learned through somebody else's experience standing in for your own.
There is one more, and it is everywhere: **vice versa**, *the turn having been turned* — the positions swapped.

What you've built

Five nouns: *el camino*, *la parada*, *el mundo*, *la vida*, *la vez*. Two of them were hiding inside phrases you have used for hundreds of lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la vez*
- *otra vez*
- *tal vez*

Before you move on

What did Latin *vicem* mean? (A turn, a change of place.) And what does *otra vez* say word for word? (Another turn.)

Chapter 331

A While, a Way, a Thing

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el rato, la manera, el modo, la cosa and el asunto, and say which noun has been hiding inside como since chapter three.
>
> *Complete ES-C331-asunto: cut a rato out of el tiempo, choose between manera and modo, and go from any cosa to the asunto it becomes.*

331.1 el rato — a while, snatched

Say *life*, then *a time*. (*La vida*; *la vez*.)

What to know first

- el tiempo — the wider word this one cuts a piece out of.

Sounds you'll need

- *RA-to*, two beats with the weight on the first. The initial *r* at the start of a word is rolled, not tapped — hold it for a moment. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el rato — "a while," a short stretch of time.
The likeliest source is Latin **raptus**, *a snatching*, from the verb **rapere**, *to seize or carry off*. A *rato* is a piece of time grabbed out of the flow — which is exactly the feeling of the English phrase *a snatch*

of time.
That gives you a third word for time, and the three do different jobs. **El tiempo** is time as substance. **La vez** is a countable occasion. **El rato** is a *duration*, short and vague: *un rato* is anywhere from a few minutes to most of an afternoon, and its vagueness is the point.
English inherited *rapere* in a set of words that all still bite. Something **rapid** carries you off. A **raptor** is a bird that seizes. To be **rapt** is to be carried away by attention, and **rapture** is that state at full strength — a mind seized and taken. To **ravish** is the same verb through French.
Notice how many of them describe being taken against your will and how many describe delight. The root did not choose; it only ever meant *seized*, and speakers decided each time whether being seized was good.

What you've built

The first of five words for the *manner* and *matter* of things — how something is done, and what it is about.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *un rato*
- *el rato*
- *un rato más*

Before you move on

What did Latin *rapere* mean? (To seize, to carry off.) And which word means time as a substance rather than a stretch? (*El tiempo.*)

331.2 la manera — a way of doing is a way of handling

Say *a time*, then *a while*. (*La vez*; *el rato.*)

What to know first

- la mano — the word this one is built out of.

Sounds you'll need

- *ma-NE-ra*, three beats with the weight in the middle. The *r* is a single light tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la manera — "the way," "the manner."
The first three letters give it away: **man-**. Latin **manus** was *a hand*, and you met it as Spanish **la mano** long ago.
From *manus* Latin built **manuārius**, *belonging to the hand*, and the feminine of that became **manera**. So a *way of doing something* is, at root, a **way of handling** it. English says the same thing without noticing — *handling a situation*, *a heavy-handed approach*, *getting a handle on it*.
English **manner** is the same word, arriving through French *manière*, and the whole family is unusually easy to spot because the hand stayed visible:
Manual work is hand work, and a *manual* is a handbook.
Manufacture is *manu factum*, made by hand — a word coined before factories existed, which now names the opposite of handmade. A **manuscript** is *manu scriptum*, written by hand. To **manage** is to handle, originally to handle a horse. To **maintain** is *manū tenēre*, to hold in the hand. To **manipulate** is to work with the hands. And a **manoeuvre** is *manū operāre*, to work by hand.
Spanish also has **de manera que**, *in such a way that*, and **de ninguna manera**, *in no way at all*.

What you've built

Two of five. *La mano* has been in your vocabulary for hundreds of lessons; it turns out to have been holding this word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la manera*

- *de esta manera*
- *de otra manera*

Before you move on

Which body part is inside *manera*? (*La mano* — the hand.) And what does *manufacture* mean word for word? (Made by hand.)

331.3 el modo — the word that has been inside *cómo* since chapter three

Say *a while*, then *the way*. (*El rato*; *la manera*.)

What to know first

- cómo — the question word this noun is hiding inside.

Sounds you'll need

- *MO-do*, two beats, the weight on the first. Both *o* sounds are short and rounded, and the *d* between vowels is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el modo — "the way," "the manner," "the mode."
Latin **modus** meant *a measure, a limit, a due amount*. Not a way of doing in the abstract, but the **size** of a thing — how much of it there should be.
That original sense explains a whole shelf of English words that otherwise look unrelated. To be **modest** is to keep to your measure. To **moderate** is to hold something to its measure. A **modicum** is a small measure. To **modify** is to change a measure. A **module** is a small measure used as a unit, and a **model** is a small measure of a large thing. Even **commodity** is *com- modus*, something of the right measure — convenient, fitting.
Modern is the strangest of them: Late Latin **modo** meant *only recently* — a *measure* of time close to now — and *modernus* was built on it.
Now the payoff that has been waiting since chapter three. Spanish

cómo comes from Latin **quōmodo**, which is **quō** (*in what*) plus **modo** (*measure*) — *in what measure? in what manner?* Every time you have asked *¿cómo estás?* you have been asking *in what manner are you?* and this noun was the second half of it.
Modo and *manera* overlap almost completely. **De todos modos** — *at all events, anyway* — is one you will hear constantly.

What you've built

Three of five. Two words for *way*, and one of them was inside the first question you ever learned to ask.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el modo*
- *de este modo*
- *de todos modos*

Before you move on

What did Latin *modus* mean? (A measure, a limit.) And which two Latin pieces make Spanish *cómo*? (*Quō* and *modo* — in what measure.)

331.4 la cosa — a thing that started out as a court case

Say *the way*, then *the mode*. (*La manera*; *el modo*.)

What to know first

- nada — the word that answers this one when there is no thing at all.

Sounds you'll need

- *CO-sa*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *o* is a hard *k*, and the *s* is crisp and unvoiced. → pronunciation

reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cosa — "the thing."
The most ordinary noun in the language has one of the strangest histories.
Latin **causa** meant *a cause*, and more specifically **a legal case** — the matter being argued in a court. Roman lawyers said *causa* constantly: *the matter at hand, the business under discussion.*
Then the drift. *The matter at hand* generalised to *the matter*, and *the matter* generalised to *the thing.* By Vulgar Latin, *causa* had stopped being legal and become the all-purpose word for anything at all.
Spanish got **cosa**; French got **chose** by the same road, from the same word, at the same time.
But Spanish also has **la causa**, meaning *the cause.* That is not the same inheritance — it is the Latin word borrowed back later, straight from books, with its original meaning intact. Spanish therefore owns *causa* twice: once worn down by mouths into *cosa*, and once carried in by scholars unchanged. Linguists call that pair a **doublet**.
English never inherited the drifted form, only the learned one, so the courtroom sense stayed put: a **cause**, to **accuse**, to **excuse**, and **because**, which is *by cause.*

What you've built

Four of five. With *cosa* you can talk about something whose name you do not know, which is one of the most useful things a beginner can do.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cosa*
- *otra cosa*
- *una cosa más*

Before you move on

What did Latin *causa* mean? (A cause, and a legal case.) And which French word took the identical road? (*Chose.*)

331.5 el asunto — a matter is a thing taken up

Say *the mode*, then *the thing.* (*El modo*; *la cosa.*)

What to know first

- la cosa — the wider word this one narrows.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-SUN-to*, three beats with the weight in the middle. The *s* is crisp, and the *n* before *t* is made with the tongue already at the teeth. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el asunto — "the matter," "the affair," "the business at hand."
Latin **sūmere** meant *to take.* Add **ad-** and you get **assūmere**, *to take up*, whose past participle is **assūmptus** — *taken up.* Spanish smoothed the *mp* away and got **asunto**.
So an *asunto* is, precisely, **a matter that has been taken up**. Somebody raised it; now it is somebody's business. That is a sharper word than *cosa*, which is any thing at all. A *cosa* can sit there being a thing. An *asunto* is a thing that has become somebody's business.
English kept *sūmere* busy. To **assume** is to take something up — either a duty you take on, or a premise you take as given. An **assumption** is either. To **resume** is to take up again. To **consume** is to take completely. To **presume** is to take beforehand. To be **sumptuous** is to involve a great taking, which is why it means lavish. And **sumptuary** laws were rules limiting how much people could spend.
If you have an email in Spanish, the subject line is labelled **asunto** — the matter this message takes up.

What you've built

Five words for how and what: *el rato*, *la manera*, *el modo*, *la cosa*, *el asunto*. Between them, you can point at any topic without naming it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el asunto*
- *otro asunto*
- *un asunto más*

Before you move on

What did Latin *sūmere* mean? (To take.) And what is an *asunto*, taken literally? (A matter taken up.)

Chapter 332

Permission, Notice, and the Word

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el permiso, el aviso, la disculpa, la palabra and la voz, and say which Greek geometry term became the Spanish word for word.
>
> *Complete ES-C332-voz: open the noun inside con permiso, give an aviso, offer a disculpa, and carry a palabra on your voz.*

332.1 el permiso — the noun you have been saying since *con permiso*

Say *the thing*, then *the matter*. (*La cosa*; *el asunto*.)

What to know first

- con permiso — the phrase this word already lives in.

Sounds you'll need

- *per-MI-so*, three beats with the weight in the middle. The *r* is a single tap, and the *s* stays crisp all the way to the end. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el permiso — "permission," "leave," and on paper, "a permit." Latin **mittere** meant *to send, to let go*. Put **per-** in front — *through*

— and **permittere** is *to let go through*. Its past participle **permissus** is *let through*, and that is where this noun comes from.
That is a nicer picture than the English word gives you. To grant permission is not to approve; it is to **stand out of the way**. You were going somewhere, and somebody let you through.
Which is exactly what **con permiso** does. You have been saying it to squeeze past people in a corridor — *with permission* — and the word inside it means *with being-let-through*. The phrase and its literal sense agree perfectly.
Mittere is one of the busiest roots in English, and once you hear the *-mit-* and *-miss-* you will hear it everywhere. To **permit** is to send through. To **transmit** is to send across. To **submit** is to send under. To **admit** is to send toward. To **dismiss** is to send away. To **emit** is to send out. A **missile** is a thing sent, a **mission** is a sending, and a **missionary** is somebody sent.
Even **promise** belongs: *prō mittere*, to send forth — words sent ahead of the deed they commit you to.

What you've built

The first of five words for what courtesy is actually made of. *Por favor* gave you *el favor*; now *con permiso* gives you this.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el permiso*
- *con permiso*
- *un permiso más*

Before you move on

What did Latin *mittere* mean? (To send, to let go.) And what does *permittere* mean piece by piece? (To let go through.)

332.2 el aviso — a notice is something made to be seen

Say *the matter*, then *permission.* (*El asunto*; *el permiso.*)

What to know first

- el permiso — the word you met one lesson ago.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-VI-so*, three beats, the weight in the middle. The *v* is soft, made without the lips closing fully. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el aviso — "the notice," "the warning," "the heads-up."
Behind it is the verb **avisar**, *to notify*, and behind that is Latin **ad vīsum** — *toward what has been seen.* The root verb is **vidēre**, *to see.* So an *aviso* is not an instruction. It is a **making-visible**: somebody has put a thing where you can see it, and what you do next is yours to decide. That is why *aviso* covers a posted notice, a warning sign and a friendly heads-up without straining.
English built two words on the identical formation. **Advise** and **advice** come from the same *ad vīsum* through French, and they carry the same modesty — to advise is to make something visible to somebody, not to command them.
Vidēre is one of the great English suppliers. **Vision** and **visible** and **visit** are obvious. **Evident** is *ē-vidēns*, seeing-out, plain to see. To **provide** is to see beforehand, and **prudent** is the same word worn down. **Survey** is to see over. A **video** is, in Latin, the single word *I see.* And **envy** is *invidia*, seeing against — looking at somebody with a bad eye.
Spanish uses the phrase **sin previo aviso**, *without prior notice*, and you now have both halves of the idea.

What you've built

Two of five. A word for being let through, and a word for being shown.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el aviso*
- *un aviso*
- *sin aviso*

Before you move on

What did Latin *vidēre* mean? (To see.) And which two English words come from the same *ad vīsum*? (*Advise* and *advice*.)

332.3 la disculpa — an apology is blame taken back off

Say *permission*, then *the notice*. (*El permiso*; *el aviso*.)

What to know first

- la culpa — the noun this word undoes.
- perdón — the apology you already say.

Sounds you'll need

- *dis-CUL-pa*, three beats with the weight in the middle. The *c* before *u* is a hard *k*, and the *l* is light and forward. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la disculpa — "the apology," "the excuse."
This one is transparent once the seam is named. **Dis-** is the Latin prefix that undoes, reverses or removes. **Culpa** is Latin for *fault, blame*. So a *disculpa* is, structurally, **an un-blaming** — the act of taking the fault back off somebody.
You already have the second half on its own: **la culpa** is blame, and *es mi culpa* is *it is my fault*.
English kept *culpa* without ever building the negative form. Somebody

culpable is blameworthy. A **culprit** is the one who carries the blame. To **exculpate** is to clear of blame — *ex-culpa*, blame out — which is the same idea as *disculpa* built with a different prefix. And **mea culpa** is Latin still being spoken, word for word: *my fault.*
There is a difference in feel worth having. **Perdón** asks the other person to give something — pardon, a gift of forgiveness. **Disculpa** does the work at your own end: you are removing the blame yourself. And **disculpe** is the polite form you use to stop a stranger, where English says *excuse me* — which is, note, the same idea again, blame removed from *me*.

What you've built

Three of five. Let through, shown, and un-blamed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la disculpa*
- *una disculpa*
- *sin disculpa*

Before you move on

What does the *dis-* in *disculpa* do? (It undoes — it removes the blame.) And what does *mea culpa* mean word for word? (My fault.)

332.4 la palabra — a word that is Greek for *thrown alongside*

Say *the notice*, then *the apology.* (*El aviso*; *la disculpa.*)

What to know first

- la voz — the sound a word is carried on, next lesson.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-LA-bra*, three beats with the weight in the middle. The *b* between vowels is soft, made without the lips fully meeting, and *br* runs together as one cluster. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la palabra — "the word."
Latin had a perfectly good word for *word*: **verbum**. Spanish barely uses its descendant. What it uses instead is a borrowed Greek technical term that got loose.
Greek **parabolē** meant *a throwing beside* — **para-** (beside) plus **bállein** (to throw). It named a **comparison**: you throw one thing down next to another so the likeness shows. Greek-speaking writers used it for a figure of speech, and the Latin Bible took it over as **parabola** for the comparison-stories Jesus told.
Those stories were so central to preaching that the word for them drifted outward — from *the comparison* to *the speech* to *the utterance* to, finally, *the single word*. Spanish smoothed **parabola** into **palabra**, swapping the *r* and *l* along the way, and ended up with its ordinary noun.
Meanwhile the untouched Greek form was borrowed a second time, and English has both. A **parable** is the story. A **parabola** is the curve, named because it lies alongside a line of the cone. **Parley** is talk, **parole** is a prisoner released on his word, and **Parliament** is the place where the talking happens.
Latin *verbum* did survive in Spanish, but only in the grammatical **verbo** — and in English **verb**, **verbal** and **proverb**.

What you've built

Four of five. And one of them turns out to be a Greek geometry term that went to church.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la palabra*
- *otra palabra*

- *una palabra más*

Before you move on

What did Greek *parabolḗ* mean? (A throwing beside — a comparison.) And which Latin word did *palabra* push out of everyday use? (*Verbum.*)

332.5 la voz — the voice, and the vowels named after it

Say *the apology*, then *the word*. (*La disculpa*; *la palabra.*)

What to know first

- la palabra — what this one carries.

Sounds you'll need

- *VOS*, one beat. The *v* is soft. The final *z* is a plain *s* across the Americas, and a *th* sound in much of Spain. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la voz — "the voice."
Latin **vōx**, in its other cases **vōcem**, which is the form Spanish worked from — that is why the *c* shows up in every relative and the *z* only here.
English took the word twice, once through French and once from Latin directly, which is why the family looks slightly mixed. **Voice** came through French. **Vocal**, **vocalise**, **vociferous** and **vocabulary** came straight from the books.
A **vowel** is the quiet surprise in the list. It is *vocālis littera* — *the vocal letter*, the one made with voice alone and nothing blocking it. Every other letter needs some obstruction; a vowel is pure voice. The name is a definition.
A **vocation** is a *calling* — the noun assumes somebody is doing the calling. An **advocate** is one called to your side, which is what a lawyer is. To **evoke** is to call out, to **provoke** is to call forth, to

revoke is to call back, and to **convoke** is to call together.
Spanish has **en voz alta** — *in a high voice*, meaning *aloud* — and its partner **en voz baja**, under your breath.

What you've built

Five words for the machinery of politeness and speech: *el permiso*, *el aviso*, *la disculpa*, *la palabra*, *la voz*. Two of them were inside phrases you already said.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la voz*
- *mi voz*
- *una voz más*

Before you move on

What is a **vowel**, translated from its Latin name? (A vocal letter — made with voice alone.) And what is an **advocate**? (One called to your side.)

Chapter 333

Noise, Silence, Calm and Hurry

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el ruido, el silencio, la calma, la prisa and el cuidado, and say why a word for burning heat came to mean stillness.
>
> *Complete ES-C333-cuidado: answer ruido with silencio, ask for calma, take the prisa out of a moment, and say cuidado when it matters.*

333.1 el ruido — noise, from the roaring of lions

Say *the word*, then *the voice*. (*La palabra*; *la voz*.)

What to know first

- la voz — the sound this one drowns out.

Sounds you'll need

- *RUI-do*, two beats with the weight on the first. The initial *r* is rolled, and *ui* is a single glide, not two separate vowels. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el ruido — "the noise."
Latin **rugīre** meant *to roar*, and Roman writers used it of lions. The noun **rugītus** was *a roaring*. Spanish wore the *g* away entirely and

arrived at **ruido**, and along the way the meaning shrank from a lion's roar to any unwanted sound at all — traffic, a bad connection, a room too full of people.

That is a long fall in volume for one word, and it is worth hearing the original inside it. When Spanish says *hay mucho ruido*, the word underneath is still a lion.

Spanish also kept a closer descendant, **rugido**, which is still *a roar* and is what a lion does in a Spanish book. So the language has the word twice: once worn down and generalised, once preserved and specific. You met that pattern with *cosa* and *causa*.

English did receive the root, in an unlikely place. **Rut** — the season when stags bellow and fight — came through Old French *rut* from this same *rugītus*. The English word kept the roaring and lost the noise; the Spanish word kept the noise and lost the roaring.

Ruido is also the word for **noise** in the technical sense, the unwanted signal in a measurement, which is one of those places where Spanish and English happen to have reached for the same metaphor.

What you've built

The first of five words for how loud or how rushed a moment is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el ruido*
- *mucho ruido*
- *sin ruido*

Before you move on

What did Latin *rugīre* mean, and of which animal? (To roar — of lions.) And which English word for a deer's season comes from it? (*Rut.*)

333.2 el silencio — the one word here English took without changing it

Say *the voice*, then *the noise*. (*La voz*; *el ruido*.)

What to know first

- el ruido — the word this one answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *si-LEN-cio*, four beats with the weight on *-LEN-*. The *c* before *i* is soft — an *s* across the Americas, a *th* in much of Spain — and *-cio* runs together as one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el silencio — "the silence."
Latin **silēre** meant *to be still, to say nothing*, and **silentium** was the state of doing so. Spanish and English are looking at almost the same letters here, which makes this the easiest word in the chapter and a good place to say why that happens.
Most English words from Latin arrived through French, battered by centuries of French mouths, and come out looking different from their Spanish cousins. *Palabra* and *parable* barely resemble each other. But **silence** and **silentium** and **silencio** line up because the word was rare enough, and formal enough, that it was largely carried in writing rather than in speech. Written words do not wear down.
The pair in English splits neatly. **Silence**, the noun, came through French. **Silent**, the adjective, is the Latin present participle *silēns, silentis* taken straight. And the same Latin participle gives Spanish nothing extra — it uses **callado** or **en silencio** where English says *silent*.
Note that *silencio* is a **thing**, not a state you are in. Spanish says **estar en silencio**, to be *in* silence, the way you would be in a room. And *silencio* on its own, said sharply, is what a teacher says to a class.

What you've built

Two of five. Noise and its absence, and you can now name either.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el silencio*
- *en silencio*
- *silencio, por favor*

Before you move on

What did Latin *silēre* mean? (To be still, to say nothing.) And why do *silence* and *silencio* look so alike? (The word travelled in writing, not worn down by speech.)

333.3 la calma — calm began as the burning heat of noon

Say *the noise*, then *the silence*. (*El ruido*; *el silencio*.)

What to know first

- el silencio — the quiet this one describes from the inside.

Sounds you'll need

- *CAL-ma*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*, and the *l* is light with the tongue tip forward. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la calma — "the calm," "the stillness."
This word did not start out peaceful. It started out **hot**.
Greek **kaûma** meant *burning heat*, from **kaíein**, *to burn*. Late Latin borrowed it as **cauma**, still meaning the heat of the day.
The shift happened at sea. In the Mediterranean the hottest hours are the ones when the wind drops and a sailing ship cannot move — the burning noon and the dead air arrive together. Sailors talking about *cauma* were talking about the heat, but what mattered to them was the **stillness** that came with it. Over time the word stopped naming

the temperature and started naming the calm.
You can still hear the old meaning in the English phrase **dead calm**, and in the word **doldrums** for a windless band of ocean — a place named entirely by what it stops you doing.
English **calm** was borrowed from Romance with the shift already complete, so English never had the hot sense at all. Spanish keeps the family: **calmar** is to calm, and **calmado** is calmed.
Two phrases to have. **Con calma** is *calmly, take your time*, and it is one of the kindest things you can say to somebody who is flustered. And **¡calma!** on its own is *steady on.*

What you've built

Three of five. And one of them is a weather report that turned into a mood.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la calma*
- *con calma*
- *calma, por favor*

Before you move on

What did Greek *kaûma* mean? (Burning heat.) And why did a word for heat come to mean stillness? (At sea the hottest hours are the windless ones.)

333.4 la prisa — hurry is being pressed

Say *the silence*, then *the calm.* (*El silencio*; *la calma.*)

What to know first

- la calma — the word this one is the opposite of.

Sounds you'll need

- *PRI-sa*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *pr* is a tight cluster with no vowel between the letters, and the *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la prisa — "the hurry," "the rush."
Latin **premere** meant *to press*, and **pressa** was its feminine past participle: *pressed*. Spanish took that participle and made a noun of it. So Spanish does not think of hurry as speed. It thinks of it as **being under pressure**. The idiom follows the metaphor exactly: you do not *have* hurry, you say **tengo prisa** — *I have pressure on me* — and **de prisa** is *under pressure*, meaning quickly.
English has the same root in a dozen shapes, and the squeeze is audible in all of them. To **press** is the plain verb. **Pressure** is the noun. To **express** is to press out — which is what you do to a thought, and also what an espresso machine does to coffee. To **impress** is to press into, leaving a mark. To **oppress** is to press against. To **compress** is to press together. To **suppress** is to press down. A **printing** press pressed letters into paper, which is why **print** is the same word worn short.
And **espresso** is Italian for *pressed out*, named for the method, not the speed — though almost everybody now hears the *express* in it and assumes it means fast.
The most useful phrase is **sin prisa** — *unhurried*, and a good thing to say to somebody who is apologising for being slow.

What you've built

Four of five. Loud, quiet, still, and pressed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la prisa*
- *sin prisa*
- *tengo prisa*

Before you move on

What did Latin *premere* mean? (To press.) And what does *tengo prisa* say literally? (I have pressure on me.)

333.5 el cuidado — care is a thing you have thought about

Say *the calm*, then *the hurry*. (*La calma*; *la prisa*.)

What to know first

- la prisa — the thing this word warns you against.

Sounds you'll need

- *cui-DA-do*, three beats with the weight in the middle. The *cui-* is a hard *k* followed by a *w* glide, and both *d* sounds are soft between vowels. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cuidado — "care," "caution."
The path here is longer than it looks, and better.
Latin **cōgitāre** meant *to think*. Its past participle **cōgitātum** was *a thing that has been thought about*. Spanish wore it down — *cogitado*, *cuidado* — and kept the noun.
So *cuidado* is not fear and it is not worry. It is **thought given to a thing**. To do something *con cuidado* is to do it having thought about it. To *tener cuidado* is to keep a matter in mind. And the verb **cuidar**, *to look after*, is at root *to keep thinking about* — which is a rather good description of what looking after somebody actually involves.
English has the same verb in **cogitate**, though it now sounds heavier than plain *think*. And it has the most famous sentence in philosophy: Descartes' **cogito, ergo sum** — *I think, therefore I am*. That *cogito* is this word. Spanish care and Cartesian doubt are the same Latin verb, one worn smooth by speech and one preserved in a book.
Said sharply and alone, **¡cuidado!** is the Spanish shout for *watch out* — and even that is, underneath, an instruction to **think**.

What you've built

Five words for the temperature of a moment: *el ruido*, *el silencio*, *la calma*, *la prisa*, *el cuidado*. A noise, its absence, a stillness, a pressure, and a thought.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cuidado*
- *con cuidado*
- *cuidado, por favor*

Before you move on

What did Latin *cōgitāre* mean? (To think.) And which famous sentence is built on it? (*Cogito, ergo sum* — I think, therefore I am.)

Chapter 334

Health, Hunger, Cold and Heat

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can report la salud, el hambre, el frio, el calor and la edad, and say why el hambre takes el while staying feminine.
>
> *Complete ES-C334-edad: name your salud, say tengo hambre, split hace frio from tengo frio, and give your edad two ways.*

334.1 la salud — the health inside every greeting

Say *the hurry*, then *care*. (*La prisa*; *el cuidado*.)

What to know first

- el saludo — the greeting built on this word.
- salvo — its close relative, met a few chapters back.

Sounds you'll need

- *sa-LUD*, two beats with the weight on the second. The final *-d* is very soft, close to the *th* in *this*, and across much of the Spanish-speaking world it fades away entirely. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la salud — "health."
Latin **salūs**, in its other cases **salūtem**, was a wide word. It meant *health*, *safety*, *well-being*, and **a greeting** — all of them at once, because to greet somebody in Rome was to wish them *salūs*.
That is why **el saludo** is a greeting and **saludar** is to greet. When you say hello in Spanish you are, historically, wishing somebody health. English does the same thing in **salute**, and, more plainly, in the toast **¡salud!** — which is exactly what Spanish speakers raise a glass with, and what they say when somebody sneezes.
The English family keeps the two senses apart. **Salutary** means *good for you*. **Salubrious** describes a healthy place. A **salutation** is a greeting. And to **salute** is to greet formally.
Now the relation worth naming carefully. You met **salvo** a few chapters back, from Latin **salvus**, *unharmed*. *Salūs* and *salvus* are relatives — they come from the same ancient root for *whole, entire* — but they are **not the same word**. *Salvus* is the adjective for a thing that came through undamaged; *salūs* is the noun for the condition of being well. Spanish inherited both separately, and *sano y salvo* uses neither of them, reaching instead for *sānus*.
Three words for well-being, three different Latin stems, all alive at once.

What you've built

The first of five words for what the body reports. This one is the whole condition; the next four are the individual complaints.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la salud*
- *mi salud*
- *salud, por favor*

Before you move on

What three things did Latin *salūs* mean at once? (Health, safety, and a greeting.) And is *salud* the same word as *salvo*? (No — relatives from one ancient root, but different Latin words.)

334.2 el hambre — a feminine noun that takes *el*, and the *f* that became an *h*

Say *care*, then *health*. (*El cuidado*; *la salud*.)

What to know first

- la sed — the thirst this one is normally paired with.
- hermano ← *ermano* — the lesson on this silent *h*.

Sounds you'll need

- *AM-bre*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *h* is completely silent, and *br* runs together as one cluster. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el hambre — "hunger."
Two real rules are packed into this one short word.
First: the *f* that turned into an *h*. Latin **famēs** meant hunger. Spanish turned the initial *f-* into an *h-* and then stopped pronouncing the *h* at all. This happened to a whole class of words, and once you know it you can predict them: *facere* became **hacer**, *filius* became **hijo**, *ferrum* became **hierro**, *fabulāre* became **hablar**, and *germānus* became **hermano** by a different road. English, which borrowed from Latin later and from books, kept the *f* every time — which is why **famine** and **famished** still have theirs, and why English *fact* and Spanish *hecho* look nothing alike.
Second: *el* on a feminine noun. *Hambre* is **feminine**. But you say **el hambre**, not *la hambre*. The reason is purely about sound: a feminine noun beginning with a **stressed *a-*** takes *el* to stop two *a* sounds colliding. The silent *h* does not count, so *hambre* begins with a

stressed *a* for this purpose.
The noun stays feminine underneath, and every other word proves it. You say **mucha hambre**, not *mucho hambre*. The article changed; the gender did not. The same rule gives you **el agua** and **mucha agua**. Spanish says **tengo hambre** — *I have hunger* — exactly as it says *tengo sed*.

What you've built

Two of five. And a rule that will hold for every feminine noun starting with a stressed *a*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el hambre*
- *tengo hambre*
- *mucha hambre*

Before you move on

Why is it *el hambre* and not *la hambre*? (A feminine noun with a stressed *a-* takes *el*, for sound.) And is the noun still feminine? (Yes — *mucha hambre*.)

334.3 el frío — the cold your refrigerator is named after

Say *health*, then *hunger*. (*La salud*; *el hambre*.)

What to know first

- hace frío — the weather phrase this word is inside.

Sounds you'll need

- *FRÍ-o*, two beats. The written accent breaks the *i* and *o* apart so they do not glide together — say *FREE-oh*, not *fryoh*. The *fr* is

a tight cluster. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el frío — "cold," both the noun and the adjective.
Latin **frīgidus** meant *cold*. Spanish dropped the middle and got **frío**; English borrowed the whole thing and got **frigid**.
You have been saying this word for a long time inside **hace frío** — which is, word for word, *it makes cold*. Spanish treats weather as something the world *does* rather than something it *is*. Now the noun stands on its own.
And you get a second construction free. **Tengo frío** is *I have cold* — which is how Spanish says *I am cold*. Note the difference, because it matters: *hace frío* is about the weather, *tengo frío* is about you.
English uses the same word *cold* for both and lets context sort it out; Spanish makes you choose the verb, and choosing wrong is one of the most common beginner slips.
English kept the root in one very visible place. To **refrigerate** is to make cold again — *re-* plus *frīgidus* — and the **refrigerator** is a machine named in Latin. It is a formal word for a very ordinary box, which is why English speakers shortened it to *fridge* and quietly added a *d* that was never in the Latin at all.
There is also **frigid** for a cold manner, and the older **frigorific** for anything cold-making.

What you've built

Three of five. Health, hunger, cold — and two verbs to attach them to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el frío*
- *hace frío*
- *tengo frío*

Before you move on

What is the difference between *hace frío* and *tengo frío*? (The first is the weather; the second is you.) And which English machine is named in Latin? (The *refrigerator* — made cold again.)

334.4 el calor — heat, and the calorie that measures it

Say *hunger*, then *cold*. (*El hambre*; *el frío*.)

What to know first

- hace calor — the weather phrase this word is inside.
- el frío — the word it answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *ca-LOR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*, and the final *r* is a single tap, not held. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el calor — "heat," "warmth."
Latin **calēre** meant *to be warm*, and **calor** was the warmth itself. Spanish took the noun unchanged — it is one of the rare words that crossed sixteen centuries without losing a letter.
It works exactly like *frío*, with the same pair of verbs. **Hace calor** is *it makes heat*, about the weather. **Tengo calor** is *I have heat*, about you.
The English relatives are worth collecting, because they are scattered. A **calorie** is defined as the heat needed to warm water by one degree — a unit named directly for what it measures. A **cauldron** or **caldron** is a heating pot, from *caldārium*, and a Roman bath's hot room was the *caldarium*. To **scald** is *ex-caldāre*, to burn with hot water. And **chowder** arrived by a long route through the French *chaudière*, a cooking pot — a soup named after the kettle it was warmed in.
The best of them is **nonchalant**. It is Old French *non* plus *chaloir*, *to be warm*, from this same *calēre* — so somebody nonchalant is a person

who **does not warm up** about a thing. English has a precise word for studied coolness and almost nobody knows that the coolness is literal.

What you've built

Four of five. With *frío* and *calor* you can report the weather and your own body with the same two nouns and two different verbs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el calor*
- *hace calor*
- *tengo calor*

Before you move on

What did Latin *calēre* mean? (To be warm.) And what does **nonchalant** mean literally? (Not warming up about it.)

334.5 la edad — the answer to the first question you learned to ask

Say *cold*, then *heat*. (*El frío*; *el calor*.)

What to know first

- ¿Cuántos años tienes? — the question this noun answers.
- -dad — the ending, which you have now seen three times.

Sounds you'll need

- *e-DAD*, two beats with the weight on the second. The final *-d* is very soft, close to the *th* in *this*, and often fades away entirely. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la edad — "age."
Latin **aevum** meant *a lifetime, an age of the world.* From it came **aetās**, and from that accusative **aetātem**, which Spanish wore down to **edad**.
The ending is one you have met twice already, in **la verdad** and **la ciudad**, and it is always the same story: Latin **-tātem** becomes Spanish **-dad** and English **-ty**. *Veritātem* gives *verdad* and *verity.* *Civitātem* gives *ciudad* and *city.* And *aetātem* gives *edad* — and English **age**, which came the long way through French and got squashed almost beyond recognition.
Since you first learned to ask somebody's age you have been saying **¿cuántos años tienes?** — *how many years do you have?* Now you have the noun itself, and a second way to ask: **¿qué edad tienes?**
Aevum is generous in English. **Eternal** is *aeternus*, built on it — lasting for an age. **Medieval** is *medium aevum*, the middle age. **Primeval** is the first age. **Longevity** is *longa aevitas*, a long lifetime. And **coeval** things share an age.
Spanish also uses *edad* for historical ages: **la Edad Media** is the Middle Ages, the same two words English uses.

What you've built

Five reports from the body: *la salud*, *el hambre*, *el frío*, *el calor*, *la edad.* Seven chapters, thirty-five words, and the pre-A1 vocabulary of this track is complete.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la edad*
- *mi edad*
- *¿qué edad tienes?*

Before you move on

Which Latin ending is the *-dad* in *edad*, *verdad* and *ciudad*? (*-tātem*, which English turns into *-ty*.) And what does *medieval* mean word for word? (Middle age.)

Chapter 335

Review — Six Words That Arrived Last

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can give la pareja, el bebe, la entrada, el cambio, el calor and la edad from the English, each with its article.
>
> *Complete ES-C335-repaso-seis-palabras: name the noun that is both a doorway and a ticket, name the one that is both an exchange and the coins, and give all six back from the English.*

335.1 Review — six words that arrived last

Two people to begin. Who is *la pareja*? (A couple, or one half of one.) And who is *el bebé*? (A baby.)

What you've built

Six nouns, sharing something that has nothing to do with meaning: each one arrived at the end of its run. A word met in the middle of a run gets picked up by everything that comes after it. A word met last has nothing after it, so it was said once and then left alone. These six are here for a second hearing.

Two people. *La pareja* — a couple, from Latin *par*, equal. *El bebé* — a baby, and the accent pulls the weight onto the last beat.

Two things a stranger holds out to you. *La entrada* — the way in, and the ticket that buys the way in. *El cambio* — the exchange,

and the coins pressed back into your hand.
Two reports from your own body. *El calor* — heat. *La edad* — age.

Your turn

English first, then the Spanish with its article.

Say these aloud:

- *the partner — la pareja*
- *the baby — el bebé*
- *the way in — la entrada*
- *the change — el cambio*
- *the heat — el calor*
- *the age — la edad*

Before you move on

Which two of the six name a person? (*La pareja*, *el bebé.*) Which two would a stranger hand you? (*La entrada*, *el cambio.*) Which two report on your own body? (*El calor*, *la edad.*)

Chapter 336

Review — The Same Six, In Use

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can buy una entrada, ask for el cambio, name a bebe and a pareja, and report my calor and my edad in whole turns.
>
> *Complete ES-C336-repaso-seis-en-uso: split tengo calor from hace calor, ask an age with the noun, and put all six inside a turn of four words or fewer.*

336.1 Review — the same six, inside something you would say

Two from last time, in the other direction. Say *heat*, then *age*. (*El calor*; *la edad*.)

What you've built

Naming a word and using it are two different acts of memory, and the second is the one you will need at a counter. So the six come round again, each sitting inside the shortest real thing it belongs to.
Mi pareja — my partner. *El nombre del bebé* — the baby's name. *Una entrada, por favor* — one ticket, please. *¿Y el cambio?* — and the change? *Tengo calor* — I am hot. *¿Qué edad tienes?* — how old are you?
Every one of those is four words or fewer, and every one of them is a whole turn in a conversation.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mi pareja*
- *el nombre del bebé, por favor*
- *una entrada, por favor*
- *¿y el cambio?*
- *tengo calor*
- *¿qué edad tienes?*

Before you move on

How do you buy one way in? (*Una entrada, por favor.*) How do you ask for your coins back? (*¿Y el cambio?.*) How do you say the baby's name, and your own partner? (*El nombre del bebé*; *mi pareja.*) And two ways to report yourself? (*Tengo calor*; *mi edad.*)

Chapter 337

Writing — Your Own Line

Modes: ↙ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write a greeting and my name from a closed supply of known words, choosing the greeting the hour asks for.
>
> *Complete ES-W01-frase-propia: with no model to copy, choose one of four greetings by the hour and order it in front of me llamo.*

337.1 Your own line — the first writing with no model

You have written **hola** four ways: traced, copied, copied from memory, and written from a sound alone.

Every one of those had something to reach for. This one does not.

Writing — controlled composition

Here is your whole supply. Nothing outside it may go on the page.

hola · *buenos días* · *buenas tardes* · *buenas noches* · *me llamo*

Now the situation. **It is four in the afternoon, and you are meeting someone for the first time.**

Write two things, in this order: the greeting the hour asks for, and your name.

Two decisions live in that. Which of four greetings the clock allows — and what has to come first so a stranger knows who is talking. Nobody is supplying either one. That is what makes this different from every writing step before it: the words are old, and the choosing is new.

Write it now, then read on.

Your line should be **Buenas tardes. Me llamo** and then your name. If you reached for *buenos días*, check the hour again. If the name came first, read it back aloud and hear how the greeting wants to open the door.

Your turn

- *Say it:* your own line back to yourself, and hear that it is a real thing to say

Before you move on

What did you supply that no earlier writing lesson asked for? (The **choice** — which words, and in what order.)
Nothing on your page was new Spanish. The step is that you decided where each old word went. Next: the same skill on a longer answer, the kind a form asks for.

Chapter 338

Writing — Four Lines About You

Modes: ↙ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can fill a personal-information form with my name, age, origin and address, using only frames I already hold.
>
> *Complete ES-W01-ficha-personal: write four frames about yourself in the order a form asks for them, and stop when the four facts are down.*

338.1 Four lines about you

Last time you chose two things and put them in an order. Nothing new went on the page, and it was still your own line.

Now four of them, and the same rule holds: no word you have not already been given.

Writing — controlled composition

A clinic asks the person at the desk to write four facts about themselves. Here is your whole supply:

me llamo · *tengo … años* · *soy de …* · *vivo en …* · *gracias*

Write four lines. Your name, your age, where you are from, where you live — then close with the courtesy word.

Each line is a frame with one blank you fill from your own life:

Me llamo _____. *Tengo* _____ *años. Soy de* _____.
Vivo en _____.

Then *gracias* on its own line.

Two things are being asked of you, and only one of them is Spanish. The Spanish is the frames, and you have held every one of them for a long time. The other thing is deciding which frame answers which question, and stopping when the four facts are on the page. Writing what was asked and nothing more is a skill of its own.

Now compare. *Soy de* names the place you came from; *vivo en* names the place you are now. If both of your blanks hold the same word, that is a true answer, not a mistake — plenty of people never moved.

Your turn

- *Say it:* your four lines aloud, and hear that every word was already yours

Before you move on

How many words on your page were new? (**None.**)
And which verb carries your age? (***Tener*** — you *have* the years.)
Next: the same four lines, with a clock running.

Chapter 339

Writing — With A Clock

Modes: ✓ **pen** (1) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write the personal-information task inside the published DELE A1 timing and word count, and mark it against the published criteria.
>
> *Complete ES-W01-con-reloj: write the four lines in three minutes, count the words against the published 15-25 range, and mark task fulfilment before style.*

339.1 The same four lines, with a clock

You wrote four lines about yourself with as long as you liked.

A task you can only do untimed is not yet a task you can do. Here are the exam's own conditions.

Writing — timed composition

What the exam publishes. The DELE A1 writing paper runs **25 minutes** and holds **two** tasks. The first is a personal-information form asking for **15 to 25 words**. No dictionary. No phone. You write in the booklet you are given.

That is one task out of two, so give it its share and no more: **three minutes**, starting now.

Write the four lines about yourself, then close with the courtesy word.

When the three minutes are up, stop writing even if a line is unfinished. An unfinished paper is information; an untimed one is not.

Now mark your own. The published criteria for this task are two, and they are worth knowing in this order:

1. **Did you do what was asked?** Four facts and a close, nothing else.
2. **Can it be read?** Language a stranger at a desk would understand. Not elegant language — understandable language.

Count your words. Under fifteen and the task is half done; well past twenty-five and you spent time you did not have. Both are worth knowing before an examiner tells you.

Your turn

- *Say it:* your four lines aloud, at the pace you wrote them

Before you move on

Which of the two published criteria comes first — doing what was asked, or writing beautifully? (**Doing what was asked.**)
You have now written to a clock, to a word count, and to a stated standard, with no Spanish you did not already own.

Chapter 340

Near, Far, and Which Side

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say cerca, lejos, a la derecha, a la izquierda and enfrente, and say why the left-hand side is the one Spanish word in the set that is older than Rome.
>
> *Complete ES-C340-enfrente: place a thing near or far, send somebody right or left, and put one thing facing another.*

340.1 cerca — near, from the ring drawn around you

Say *heat*, then *age*. (*El calor*; *la edad*.)

What to know first

- ¿dónde está? — the question this answers.
- ahí · allí — the two distances you already have.

Sounds you'll need

- *SER-ka*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *e* is soft — an *s* across the Americas. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cerca — "near," "nearby."
Latin **circā** meant *around, round about* — the preposition of a ring drawn about a thing. What lies around you lies close, and Spanish let the word slide from *around* to *near*.
English took **circa** whole and left it in Latin, where it still marks a date given loosely: *circa 1500*, somewhere in the ring around that year. The same ring is in **circle**, in a **circuit** that goes round and comes back, and in the **circus**, which was a ring long before it was a show. So when you say *cerca*, the picture underneath is a circle with you at the centre, and everything inside it counted as near.

What you've built

The first of a handful of words for where a thing is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cerca*
- *muy cerca*
- *la plaza está cerca*

Before you move on

What did *circā* mean? (Around, round about.) And what does English *circa* still do to a date? (Marks it as roughly that year.)

340.2 lejos — far, from a rope let out further

Say *age*, then *near*. (*La edad*; *cerca*.)

What to know first

- cerca — the other end of this pair.

Sounds you'll need

- *LE-hos*, the weight on the first beat. The *j* is the throaty *jota*, further back than an English *h*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lejos — "far," "far away."
Latin **laxus** meant *loose, slack, not drawn tight* — said of a rope, a rein, a bowstring. Its comparative **laxius** meant *more loosely, further apart*, and Spanish froze that comparative into a plain adverb of distance.
The slack rope is all over English. Something **lax** is loose in its discipline. To **relax** is to let out again. To **release** is to slacken a hold entirely. Even a **leash** is the loose length you let a dog run on.
Two words, two pictures: *cerca* draws a ring and stays inside it; *lejos* pays the rope out until you are past the far end.

What you've built

A pair now: *cerca* and *lejos*, the two answers to how far.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lejos*
- *muy lejos*
- *la casa está lejos*

Before you move on

What did *laxus* mean? (Loose, slack.) And which English verb means to let that slack out again? (*Relax.*)

340.3 la derecha — the right hand, from the line that goes straight

Say *near*, then *far*. (*Cerca*; *lejos.*)

What to know first

- el camino — what you will be sending somebody along.
- la esquina — where the turn happens.

Sounds you'll need

- *de-RE-cha*, three beats with the weight on the middle. The *ch* is one sound, as in English *church*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la derecha — "the right," the right-hand side.
Latin **dīrigere** meant *to set straight, to line up* — *dis-* apart plus **regere**, to rule or guide. Its past participle **dīrectus** meant *straightened*, and that is the word underneath *derecha*.
Most languages name the right hand for what it does well, and Latin thought of it as the hand that goes straight to the mark. The left got the leftovers.
The straightening is loud in English. Something **direct** goes the straight way. A **direction** is the straight line you are pointed along. Something **erect** has been straightened upright. And to **address** a letter is to set it straight toward somebody.
Spanish keeps both jobs: **a la derecha** is *to the right*, and **derecho** on its own is *straight ahead* — the older meaning, still working.

What you've built

Now you can send somebody one way at the corner.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la derecha*
- *a la derecha*
- *la calle está a la derecha*

Before you move on

What did *dīrectus* mean? (Straightened, set straight.) And what does *derecho* mean when it stands alone? (Straight ahead.)

340.4 la izquierda — the left hand, the word that is older than Rome

Say *far*, then *the right*. (*Lejos*; *la derecha*.)

What to know first

- la derecha — the side this one answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *is-KYER-da*, the weight on the second beat. The *z* is an *s* across the Americas, and *-quie-* is one gliding syllable. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la izquierda — "the left," the left-hand side.
Nearly every Spanish word you have met came from Latin. This one did not.
Izquierda is **ezkerra**, from Basque — a language already old in the peninsula when the Romans arrived, related to nothing else alive. A few Basque words survived the whole Roman centuries and are still in daily Spanish, and this is the best known of them.
What it pushed aside was Latin **sinistra**, the ordinary Latin word for *left*. Latin had long treated the left as the unlucky side, and *sinistra* carried so much of that dread that Spanish quietly replaced it with a neutral borrowed word.
English went the other way and kept the discarded one. **Sinister** in English means threatening or evil, which is what Latin had already made of *left* — so Spanish and English ended up with opposite halves of the same old quarrel: Spanish took the plain Basque word, English took the dark Latin one.
A la izquierda is *to the left*.

What you've built

Both hands now, and one word in your Spanish older than Rome.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la izquierda*
- *a la izquierda*
- *a la derecha o a la izquierda*

Before you move on

Which language did *izquierda* come from? (Basque.) And which Latin word did it push out, that English kept? (*Sinistra* — English *sinister*.)

340.5 enfrente — opposite, standing forehead to forehead

Say *the right*, then *the left*. (*La derecha*; *la izquierda*.)

What to know first

- cerca — one of the distances this refines.
- la calle — what you will be crossing.

Sounds you'll need

- *en-FREN-te*, the weight on the middle beat. Both *e* sounds are short and even, never sliding the way an English *e* does. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

enfrente — "opposite," "across from," "facing."
It is two pieces you can see: **en** plus **frente**.
Frente is Latin **frontem**, from **frōns** — and the Latin word meant

the forehead. The forehead is the part of you that goes first, the flat face you present to whatever is coming, so *frons* widened to mean the front of anything at all.
English is full of that brow. The **front** of a building is its forehead. A **frontier** is the forehead of a country, the part that faces outward. To **confront** somebody is to bring foreheads together. An **affront** is a blow struck at the forehead, which is why it means an insult. And **effrontery** is behaving as though you had no forehead left to blush with.
So *enfrente* is not merely *near*. It is the thing whose forehead is turned toward yours — across the street, facing you.

What you've built

Five words for where a thing is: *cerca*, *lejos*, *la derecha*, *la izquierda*, *enfrente*. Enough to place almost anything.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *enfrente*
- *enfrente de la casa*
- *está enfrente, muy cerca*

Before you move on

What did *frontem* mean in Latin? (The forehead.) And what is an *affront*, word for word? (A blow at the forehead.)

Chapter 341

Above, Below, In Front, Behind

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say arriba, abajo, delante, detras and dentro, and say why arriba and English arrive are the same climb up the same riverbank.
>
> *Complete ES-C341-dentro: put a thing above or below, ahead or behind, and inside rather than out.*

341.1 arriba — up, from climbing the riverbank

Say *the left*, then *opposite*. (*La izquierda*; *enfrente*.)

What to know first

- enfrente — the last of the flat directions.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-RRI-ba*, the weight on the middle beat. The *rr* is a full trill, the tongue bouncing more than once. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

arriba — "up," "above," "upstairs."
Underneath it is **a** plus **riba**, and **riba** is Latin **rīpa** — *a riverbank*. A bank is the thing you climb when you come out of the water, and it is always the high side. *Ad rīpam*, **to the bank**, became a way of saying *upward*, and Spanish wore it down to one word.

The bank is still in English, in three shapes. A **river** is named for its banks rather than its water. **Riparian** rights are the rights of whoever owns the bank. And to **arrive** is Latin *ad rīpam* as well — it first meant *to come to shore*, said of a boat, and only later of anybody turning up anywhere.
So *arriba* and *arrive* are the same journey up the same bank, and Spanish kept the climb while English kept the landing.

What you've built

The first of the up-and-down words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *arriba*
- *está arriba*
- *aquí arriba*

Before you move on

What did *rīpa* mean? (A riverbank.) And what did English *arrive* first mean? (To come to shore.)

341.2 abajo — down, and the voice that sits at the bottom

Say *opposite*, then *up, above.* (*Enfrente*; *arriba.*)

What to know first

- arriba — the direction this one answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-BA-ho*, the weight on the middle beat. The *j* is the throaty *jota* again, and the *b* is soft between vowels. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

abajo — "down," "below," "downstairs."
Like its opposite, it is two pieces: **a** plus **bajo**.
Bajo is Late Latin **bassus**, meaning *low, squat, not tall.* Classical Latin barely used it; it was a plain spoken word that outlived the grand ones, and it gave the ordinary word for *low* to Spanish, French and Italian alike.
English has it several ways over. A **base** is the low part a thing stands on, and **base** behaviour is low behaviour. To **abase** or **debase** somebody is to bring them down. And the **bass** voice is the low one — spelled like the fish, pronounced like the Italian *basso*, and meaning nothing more exotic than *the low part.*
So *arriba* climbs the riverbank and *abajo* goes back down to the low ground.

What you've built

Up and down are both yours now.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *abajo*
- *está abajo*
- *arriba o abajo*

Before you move on

What did *bassus* mean? (Low.) And which English singing voice is the same word? (The *bass*, the low one.)

341.3 delante — in front, from the word that means before

Say *up, above*, then *down, below.* (*Arriba*; *abajo.*)

What to know first

- enfrente — the near neighbour of this one.
- antes — the same root doing time instead of space.

Sounds you'll need

- *de-LAN-te*, the weight on the middle beat. The *l* stays bright and forward, never the dark English *l* of *ball*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

delante — "in front," "ahead."
Buried in it is Latin **ante**, *before* — the same **ante** you already met in **antes**, doing time. Here it does space instead, which is what *before* originally meant in both languages: *before the king* is a position, not an hour.
English kept *ante* almost untouched. At a card table the **ante** is the stake put down before the deal. An **antecedent** is what went before. Something **anterior** is at the front. An **antique** is from before. To **anticipate** is to take a thing before it arrives.
Delante and **enfrente** are close but not the same: *enfrente* faces you across a gap, while *delante* is merely ahead of you — the person in the queue in front, who is not facing you at all.

What you've built

Front and back are starting; the back half comes next.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *delante*
- *delante de la puerta*
- *está delante*

Before you move on

Which Latin word is inside *delante*? (*Ante*, before.) And what is the *ante* at a card table? (The stake put down before the deal.)

341.4 detrás — behind, from the word for beyond

Say *down, below*, then *in front.* (*Abajo*; *delante.*)

What to know first

- delante — the side this one answers.

Sounds you'll need

- *de-TRAS*, the weight on the second beat, which is why it carries a written accent. The *tr* is one quick cluster. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

detrás — "behind," "at the back."
Inside it is **tras**, which is Latin **trāns** — *across, beyond, on the far side.*
That is a good picture of behind. What is behind you is what lies beyond you, past the edge of what you can see, on the other side of yourself.
English never wore *trans* down; it uses it whole, as a prefix, dozens of times. To **transfer** is to carry across. **Transit** is going across. To **translate** is to carry a meaning across into another language.
Something **transparent** lets light come across it. **Transatlantic** is across the Atlantic.
Spanish did wear it down — *trāns* to *tras* — and then built *detrás* on top. So the same syllable that stands proud at the front of half the long words in English is hiding in the middle of a short Spanish one.

What you've built

Four sides now: up, down, in front, behind.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *detrás*
- *detrás de la casa*
- *delante o detrás*

Before you move on

Which Latin word is *tras*? (*Trāns*, across or beyond.) And what does *translate* mean, word for word? (To carry across.)

341.5 dentro — inside, and the entrance you already knew

Say *in front*, then *behind*. (*Delante*; *detrás*.)

What to know first

- la entrada — the same root, already yours.
- detrás — the last of the position words.

Sounds you'll need

- *DEN-tro*, the weight on the first beat. The *tr* is one cluster, and the *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dentro — "inside," "within."
It is Latin **de intrō**, *from within*, squeezed into one word. Behind *intrō* stands **intra**, the Latin for *inside*.
You already own a piece of this. **La entrada** is the way in, and it is built on **intrāre**, *to go inside* — the same *intra*. So *dentro* and *entrada* are family: one names the inside, the other names the door to it.
English took *intra* and *inter* and never let go. Your **interior** is your inside. Something **internal** happens within. An **intranet** stays inside one building. And the **intro** to a song is the way in.

With this, the set is closed: *arriba*, *abajo*, *delante*, *detrás*, *dentro* — and *cerca*, *lejos*, *la derecha*, *la izquierda*, *enfrente* before them. Ten words, and almost nothing can hide from you now.

What you've built

Ten words for where a thing is, and the whole set is closed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dentro*
- *dentro de la casa*
- *está dentro, no está fuera*

Before you move on

What is *dentro*, taken apart? (*De intrō*, from within.) And which word you already had is built on the same root? (*La entrada.*)

Chapter 342

The Clock, Taken Apart

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el minuto, el cuarto, en punto, el horario and la madrugada, and say why the minute and the second are two halves of one Latin phrase.
>
> *Complete ES-C342-madrugada: cut an hour into minutes and quarters, give a time on the dot, ask for a timetable, and name the hours before dawn.*

342.1 el minuto — the minute, the first small cutting of the hour

Say *behind*, then *inside*. (*Detrás*; *dentro*.)

What to know first

- la hora — the thing this one cuts up.
- el reloj — what shows it.

Sounds you'll need

- *mi-NU-to*, the weight on the middle beat. Every vowel is short and clean; the *u* is always *oo*, never the English *yoo*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el minuto — "the minute."
Latin **minūtus** meant *made small* — the past participle of **minuere**, *to lessen*. It says nothing about clocks at all.
The clock meaning came from a piece of medieval bookkeeping. When astronomers divided the hour, they called the first cut **pars minūta prīma**, *the first small part*, and the cut after that **pars minūta secunda**, *the second small part*. Both names got shortened to their odd halves: the first small part became the **minute**, and the second small part became the **second**.
Which means the word you already have for *second* and this new one are two halves of the same phrase, and neither one was ever a time word.
English keeps the smallness plainly. Something **minor** is smaller. **Minus** takes away. To **diminish** is to make less. **Minuscule** is tiny. And **minute** spelled exactly the same way, said *my-NEWT*, still means *very small* — the original sense, sitting in plain sight.

What you've built

The hour, cut into its first small parts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el minuto*
- *un minuto, por favor*
- *cinco minutos*

Before you move on

What did *minūtus* mean? (Made small.) And what was the full name of the minute? (*Pars minūta prīma* — the first small part.)

342.2 el cuarto — the quarter, and the four you already count

Say *inside*, then *the minute*. (*Dentro*; *el minuto*.)

What to know first

- uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — the number this is built on.
- el minuto — the other piece of the hour.

Sounds you'll need

- *KWAR-to*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *cu-* is *kw*, and *-uar-* glides in one motion. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cuarto — "the quarter," "a fourth."
You have counted **cuatro** for a long time. This is that number turned into an order: Latin **quattuor**, *four*, gives **quārtus**, *fourth*, and Spanish wears that down to **cuarto**.
So *cuatro* and *cuarto* are one letter apart on the page and one step apart in meaning: the count, and the position in the count. Hearing the difference is worth practising, because the two are easy to swap.
English counts the same way. A **quarter** is a fourth. A **quart** is a fourth of a gallon. A **quartet** is four players. And **quarantine** is *quaranta giorni*, forty days — forty being four tens, the period ships once waited out before landing.
On a clock, **y cuarto** is *quarter past*: **la una y cuarto**. Spanish also uses *cuarto* for a room, which is the same idea — a quarter of a house divided into four.

What you've built

A quarter of the hour, from the four you already had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cuarto*
- *un cuarto*
- *la una y cuarto*

Before you move on

Which number is *cuarto* built on? (*Cuatro*, four.) And what is *quarantine*, word for word? (Forty days.)

342.3 el punto — the point, from the prick of a needle

Say *the minute*, then *the quarter*. (*El minuto*; *el cuarto*.)

What to know first

- la hora — what this pins down exactly.
- el cuarto — the last cut of the hour.

Sounds you'll need

- *PUN-to*, the weight on the first beat. The *n* before *t* stays a clean *n*, and the *u* is *oo*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el punto — "the point," "the dot."
Latin **pungere** meant *to prick, to pierce*. What a prick leaves behind is a **punctum** — a tiny mark made by something sharp. That is the whole word: a dot is the hole a needle made.
English carries the needle everywhere. A **point** is the sharp end. A **puncture** is the hole. **Punctuation** is the set of dots pricked into a sentence. Something **pungent** pricks your nose. And to be **punctual** is to arrive at the exact pricked spot on the dial — not near it, on it.
Spanish says the same thing with **en punto**: **la una en punto** is *one o'clock on the dot*, the hand standing exactly on the mark. English chose the identical picture without borrowing the phrase.
A *punto* is also the full stop at the end of a written sentence, for the same reason.

What you've built

Now an hour can be given exactly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el punto*
- *en punto*
- *la una en punto*

Before you move on

What did *pungere* mean? (To prick.) And what does it mean to be *punctual*? (To land on the exact pricked mark.)

342.4 el horario — the timetable, an hour-thing

Say *the quarter*, then *the point, the dot.* (*El cuarto*; *el punto.*)

What to know first

- la hora — the word this is built on.
- el reloj — what keeps the hours it lists.

Sounds you'll need

- *o-RA-rio*, the weight on the second beat. The *h* is silent, always, and *-rio* is one syllable with a quick glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el horario — "the timetable," "the opening hours."
This is **hora**, which you have had for a long time, plus the ending **-ario** — Latin **-ārium**, which makes *a thing to do with.* So a *horarium* is *an hour-thing*: the sheet that tells you which hours something happens in.
The ending is worth collecting, because it is English **-ary** and **-arium** almost every time. A **library** is a book-thing, from *liber.* An **aquarium** is a water-thing. A **granary** is a grain-thing. And a **horarium** is an hour-thing.
The *hora* half is English **hour** — the same word, with the *h* gone quiet

in both languages and the vowel wandering. It is also the *horo-* of **horoscope**, which is a *reading of the hour* you were born in, and of **horology**, the study of clocks.
A *horario* is what you ask for at a station or a shop: **¿cuál es el horario?**

What you've built

From the hour itself to the sheet that lists them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el horario*
- *el horario de hoy*
- *¿cuál es el horario?*

Before you move on

What does the *-ario* ending do? (Makes *a thing to do with.*) And what is a *horoscope*, word for word? (A reading of the hour.)

342.5 la madrugada — the small hours, named for ripeness

Say *the point, the dot*, then *the timetable.* (*El punto*; *el horario.*)

What to know first

- mediodía, medianoche — where this stretch begins.
- la noche — the stretch it closes.

Sounds you'll need

- *ma-dru-GA-da*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *d* between vowels is very soft, close to the *th* of *this.* → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la madrugada — the small hours, the stretch between midnight and daybreak.
Spanish has a whole word for a time English can only describe. English says *the small hours* or *the early morning* and needs several words. Spanish says **la madrugada** and is done.
It comes from the verb **madrugar**, *to get up very early*, and behind that stands Latin **mātūrus** — *ripe*. A ripe fruit is one that came to its proper time, and Latin used *maturus* for anything early, timely, ahead of schedule. Somebody who rose in the dark was rising while the day was still ripening.
English kept the fruit. Something **mature** is ripe, whether it is cheese or judgement. Something **premature** arrived before it had ripened. And to **maturate** is to ripen.
So this stretch of the night is not named for its darkness. It is named for being early, and *early* was named for being ripe.

What you've built

Five pieces of the clock: the minute, the quarter, the point, the timetable, and the hours before dawn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la madrugada*
- *a las tres de la madrugada*
- *muy de madrugada*

Before you move on

What did *mātūrus* mean? (Ripe.) And what does *premature* mean, word for word? (Before it has ripened.)

Chapter 343

Naming a Date, and the Stretches Around It

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la fecha, el calendario, proximo, la epoca and el siglo, and say why a calendar began as a moneylender's account book.
>
> *Complete ES-C343-siglo: name a date, find it on a calendar, point at the next one, and name the age it sits in.*

343.1 la fecha — the date, from the line at the foot of a letter

Say *the timetable*, then *the small hours.* (*El horario*; *la madrugada.*)

What to know first

- los meses — what a date names.
- la semana — the other unit a date sits in.

Sounds you'll need

- *FE-cha*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ch* is one sound, as in English *church.* → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la fecha — "the date."
Latin **facta** meant *done, made* — the feminine past participle of **facere**, *to do*.
The date meaning came off the bottom of letters. A scribe finished a document and wrote **facta in...** — *done at* such a place on such a day. The word sitting where the day was written slowly became the name of the day itself. Spanish still says **fecha en Madrid** in formal documents, which is the original line, unchanged.
English did exactly the same trick with a different Latin word: **date** is *data*, *given*, from the *datum* that closed a Roman letter. Two languages, two closing formulas, both promoted to mean the day.
Facere is one of the biggest roots in English. A **fact** is a thing done. A **feat** is a deed. A **factory** makes things. **Perfect** is thoroughly made. And to **affect** something is to do something to it.

What you've built

A day can now be named, not merely lived through.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la fecha*
- *¿cuál es la fecha?*
- *la fecha de hoy*

Before you move on

What did *facta* mean? (Done, made.) And where in a letter did the word sit? (At the foot — *done at* such a place, on such a day.)

343.2 el calendario — the calendar, which began as a debt ledger

Say *the small hours*, then *the date*. (*La madrugada*; *la fecha*.)

What to know first

- los meses — what it is divided into.
- el horario — the same -ario ending.

Sounds you'll need

- *ka-len-DA-rio*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *l* is bright and forward, and *-rio* glides as one. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el calendario — "the calendar."
Three layers, and none of them is a wall chart.
Start at the bottom with Latin **calāre**, *to call out, to proclaim.* In early Rome a priest watched for the new moon and then called it out to the city — that was the announcement that a month had begun.
The day he called became the **Calendae**, the first of the month. And the first of the month was the day debts fell due, so the book in which a Roman moneylender wrote what he was owed was his **calendārium** — his *first-of- the-month book.* An account ledger.
The ledger, not the moon, is what gave English its word. A **calendar** is a debt book that grew into a chart of days. The ending is the **-ario** you met in *horario*: a thing to do with the calends.
The calling-out survives in **intercalate**, to call an extra day into the year — which is what a leap year does.

What you've built

Days can be found, and now they can be kept.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el calendario*
- *en el calendario*
- *la fecha en el calendario*

Before you move on

What was a *calendarium* in Rome? (An account book.) And why were the calends called that? (From *calāre* — a priest called out the new moon.)

343.3 próximo — next, which is only a way of saying nearest

Say *the date*, then *the calendar*. (*La fecha*; *el calendario*.)

What to know first

- cerca — the other way of saying near.
- la semana — what this most often marks.

Sounds you'll need

- *PROK-si-mo*, the weight on the first beat, which is why it takes a written accent. The *pr* is one quick cluster. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

próximo — "next," "nearest."
Latin **prope** meant *near*. Its superlative **proximus** meant *nearest* — the very closest of all.
Nothing in that is about time. Spanish borrowed the distance word to do time, which is what almost every language does: **la próxima semana** is *next week*, and what it says underneath is *the nearest week*. English does the identical thing when it says *the coming week* or *close to Christmas*.
The nearness is loud in English. **Proximity** is nearness. To **approximate** is to come near the right answer. To **approach** is to come near. And to **reproach** somebody is to bring a thing near them again, up close, where they cannot avoid looking at it.
Spanish also uses **el prójimo**, from the same root, for *one's neighbour* — the nearest person, the one you are told to love.

What you've built

Time can be pointed forward.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *próximo*
- *la próxima semana*
- *el próximo día*

Before you move on

What did *proximus* mean? (Nearest.) And what does *next week* say underneath? (The nearest week.)

343.4 la época — the age, named for a stopping point

Say *the calendar*, then *next, nearest.* (*El calendario*; *próximo.*)

What to know first

- la fecha — the small version of this.
- el calendario — where both are kept.

Sounds you'll need

- *E-po-ka*, the weight on the first beat, which is why it takes a written accent. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la época — "the age," "the era," and in everyday speech "the season" or "the time of year."
This one is Greek, not Latin. **Epokhē** meant *a stopping, a halt, a holding back*, from **epekhein** — *to hold back.*

Astronomers gave it the meaning it now has. To measure where the stars are, you must first stop the clock at some agreed instant and reckon everything from there. That fixed instant was the **epoch**, the point where time was held still. From *the moment we stopped the clock* it drifted to *the stretch of time that moment opens*, which is what both Spanish and English mean by it now.
English kept the word almost unchanged as **epoch**. Greek *epekhein* is also the root of **epoché** in philosophy, the deliberate suspension of judgement — holding your opinion back, which is the older sense doing its original job.
In daily Spanish it is far less grand than in English: **en esta época del año** is no more than *at this time of year*.

What you've built

Stretches of time, not merely points in it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la época*
- *en esta época*
- *la época del año*

Before you move on

What did *epokhē* mean in Greek? (A stopping, a halt.) And why did astronomers need one? (To fix the instant they measured everything from.)

343.5 el siglo — the century, and why secular means worldly

Say *next, nearest*, then *the age, the era.* (*Próximo*; *la época.*)

What to know first

- la época — the vaguer stretch beside this exact one.
- los meses — the smaller divisions.

Sounds you'll need

- *SI-glo*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *gl* is one cluster, and the *g* is hard. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el siglo — "the century," "the age."
Latin **saeculum** first meant *a generation* — roughly the longest a person might live, and so *an age of the world*. Romans held a festival, the *ludi saeculares*, once per *saeculum*, on the theory that nobody alive should have seen the last one.
Then the Church picked the word up and used it for a purpose it was never built for. Set against **eternity**, the *saeculum* became *this present world, the time we are stuck in* — as opposed to the world to come. A priest who lived among ordinary people rather than in a monastery was *clerus saecularis*, clergy of this age.
That is where English **secular** comes from, and it explains a word that otherwise looks arbitrary. **Secular** does not mean *non-religious* by any logic of its parts. It means *belonging to this age* — and it drifted to mean worldly, then non-religious, one step at a time.
Spanish kept the plain arithmetic too: a *siglo* is a hundred years, and **el siglo XXI** is the twenty-first century.

What you've built

Ten words for placing a thing in time, from the minute to the century.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el siglo*
- *el siglo XXI*
- *hace un siglo*

Before you move on

What did *saeculum* first mean? (A generation, a lifetime.) And why does *secular* mean worldly? (It meant *of this age*, set against eternity.)

Chapter 344

Zero, Halves and Dozens

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say cero, el numero, la mitad, la docena and doble, and say why English borrowed the same Arabic word twice, as zero and as cipher.
>
> *Complete ES-C344-doble: count from zero, name the number itself, halve a thing, count it by twelves, and double it.*

344.1 cero — zero, the empty one, and the word English borrowed twice

Say *the age, the era*, then *the century.* (*La época*; *el siglo.*)

What to know first

- uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — the counting this completes.

Sounds you'll need

- *SE-ro*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *e* is soft, an *s* across the Americas. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cero — "zero."
Roman numerals have no zero. You cannot write it: there is no symbol, because there was no idea. Counting started at one, and

nothing was not a number.
The zero arrived with Arabic mathematics, and it brought its name. Arabic **ṣifr** meant *empty* — a translation of the Sanskrit *śūnya*, also *empty*. Latin took it as **zephirum** and **cifra**, and the two forms went separate ways across Europe.
English ended up borrowing the same Arabic word twice. From *zephirum* through Italian came **zero**. From *cifra* came **cipher** — which in older English means a nought, and also a secret code, because Arabic numerals looked like unreadable marks to people used to Roman ones. A **cipher** can be a nobody, a zero, or a code, and all three are the same borrowed emptiness.
Spanish kept both as well: *cero* is the number, and **la cifra** is a digit or a figure.

What you've built

Counting has a floor under it now.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cero*
- *cero o uno*
- *el número cero*

Before you move on

What did Arabic *ṣifr* mean? (Empty.) And which two English words came from it? (*Zero* and *cipher*.)

344.2 el número — the number, and the letter English added by mistake

Say *the century*, then *zero*. (*El siglo*; *cero*.)

What to know first

- cero — the one this now counts from.
- uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — what a number names.

Sounds you'll need

- *NU-me-ro*, the weight on the first beat, which is why it takes a written accent. Three even, short vowels. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el número — "the number."
Latin **numerus**, a number. The straight line from Latin to Spanish, with almost nothing happening on the way.
What is worth noticing is what happened in English instead. Latin *numerus* went into French as *nombre*, and English took it as **number** — with a **b** that was never in the Latin word. It crept in because *m* followed by *r* is awkward to say, and a *b* slips into the gap without anybody deciding to put it there. English did the same in **chamber** and **slumber**.
Spanish never added it. **Número** keeps the Latin shape exactly, so the Spanish word is closer to the original than the English one is.
The rest of the family is clean. A **numeral** is the written sign. **Numerous** means many. To **enumerate** is to go through one by one. And something **innumerable** cannot be counted at all.

What you've built

A word for the count itself, on top of the counting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el número*
- *el número dos*
- *¿cuál es el número?*

Before you move on

Where did the *b* in English *number* come from? (It slipped in between *m* and *r*; the Latin never had it.) And which language kept the Latin shape? (Spanish — *número*.)

344.3 la mitad — the half, built from middle with an ending you own

Say *zero*, then *the number*. (*Cero*; *el número*.)

What to know first

- -dad — the ending, for the fourth time.
- mediodía, medianoche — the same middle, doing the clock.

Sounds you'll need

- *mi-TAD*, the weight on the second beat. The final *-d* is very soft and often fades away entirely. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la mitad — "the half."
Two things you already own are inside it.
The ending is **-dad**, from Latin **-tātem** — the one you have met in **verdad**, **ciudad** and **edad**, and which English turns into **-ty**. It makes an abstract noun: *the state of being such-and-such*.
The stem is **medius**, *middle* — the same *medius* sitting in **mediodía** and **medianoche**, the middle of the day and the middle of the night. Put them together and Latin **medietātem** means *middle-ness*: the state of being in the middle. A half is what you get when you cut at the middle, so *middle-ness* became *a half*, and Spanish wore *medietatem* down to *mitad*.
English took *medius* many ways: a **medium** is in the middle, a **median** splits a road, to **mediate** is to stand between. And English has the very same word as *mitad*, though almost nobody uses it: **moiety** means a half, and came from *medietatem* through French.

What you've built

Numbers can now be broken as well as counted.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la mitad*
- *la mitad del agua*
- *una mitad y otra mitad*

Before you move on

Which two pieces make *mitad*? (*Medius*, middle, plus the *-tātem* that gives *-dad*.) And what does *medietātem* mean word for word? (Middle-ness.)

344.4 la docena — the dozen, which is two and ten said quickly

Say *the number*, then *the half*. (*El número*; *la mitad*.)

What to know first

- uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — where counting started.
- el número — the word for the count.

Sounds you'll need

- *do-SE-na*, the weight on the middle beat. The *c* before *e* is soft, and the *d* is soft between vowels. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la docena — "the dozen," a set of twelve.
Latin counted twelve as **duodecim** — **duo** *two* plus **decem** *ten*. Two and ten, said as one word, which is exactly how English says *thirteen* and *fourteen* but stops doing right before it reaches twelve.

Spanish wore *duodecim* down to **doce**, and then added the ending **-ena**, which makes a group of that size. So *docena* is *a twelve-ful*, a set counted out by twelves.
English took the same Latin word by the French road and got **dozen**, which is *duodecim* squashed nearly flat. Kept whole, it is **duodecimal** — counting in twelves, the system behind twelve inches, twelve months and twenty-four hours.
The *duo* half is everywhere in English: a **duo**, a **duet**, a **duel** — and **double**, which is next.

What you've built

A group can be counted as one thing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la docena*
- *una docena*
- *media docena*

Before you move on

What is *duodecim*, taken apart? (*Duo* two plus *decem* ten.) And what does the *-ena* ending do? (Makes a group of that size.)

344.5 doble — double, which means folded in two

Say *the half*, then *the dozen*. (*La mitad*; *la docena*.)

What to know first

- la docena — the last of the counting words.
- la mitad — what this undoes.

Sounds you'll need

- *DO-ble*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *b* is soft between vowels, made without quite closing the lips. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

doble — "double," twice as much.
Latin **duplus** is **duo**, *two*, plus **-plus**, which is a *fold*. So *duplus* is *twofold* — and English **double** says the same thing by the same route, through French.
That **-plus** is a hidden joint in a great many words, and once you see it you cannot stop. **Triple** is threefold. **Multiple** is many-fold.
Simple is *sim-plus*, **onefold** — a thing with only one layer, which is why *simple* means uncomplicated. English even has the plain Germanic version alongside: *twofold*, *threefold*, *manifold*.
The two-fold has a dark side as well. **Duplicity** is being folded in two — having a second, hidden layer — which is precisely what we accuse a double-dealer of. A **duplex** has two folds of floor, and to **duplicate** is to make the second fold.
Against it stands **la mitad**, which cuts back to one.

What you've built

Five counting words: *cero*, *el número*, *la mitad*, *la docena*, *doble*.
Nothing counted, halved or doubled is out of reach.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *doble*
- *el doble*
- *doble o mitad*

Before you move on

What does the *-plus* in *duplus* mean? (A fold.) And what is *simple*, taken apart? (*Sim-plus* — onefold.)

Chapter 345

Pinning Down Which One

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say mismo, cada, la parte, la persona and el objeto, and say why a Latin actor's mask became the ordinary word for a human being.
>
> *Complete ES-C345-objeto: say it is the same one, take a set one at a time, name a share of it, name a single human being, and name a thing on purpose.*

345.1 mismo — the very same, from a word built by piling on emphasis

Say *the dozen*, then *double*. (*La docena*; *doble*.)

What to know first

- otro — the word this answers.
- todo — another of the pointing words.

Sounds you'll need

- *MIS-mo*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *s* stays clean and never buzzes into a *z*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mismo — "same," "very," "self."
Latin had **ipse**, *self, the very one*. Spoken Latin decided that was not emphatic enough, and started stacking.
First **met**, an emphasising particle, was stuck on the front: *egomet*, *I myself*. Then the superlative ending *-issimus* was piled on the back. The result was something like **metipsimus** — roughly *the very most self-est one*, a word made almost entirely of insistence.
That collapsed into Spanish **mismo**, French *même* and Italian *medesimo*. All three languages built their ordinary word for *same* out of somebody thumping a fist on the bar.
English kept *ipse* undisguised in a few borrowed phrases. **Ipso facto** is *by that very fact*. **Solipsism** is *self-alone-ism*, the belief that only oneself exists. And **ipsissima verba** are *the very words themselves*. Spanish uses *mismo* both ways: **el mismo libro** is *the same book*, and **yo mismo** is *I myself*.

What you've built

The first word for pinning down which one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mismo*
- *el mismo libro*
- *yo mismo*

Before you move on

Which Latin word is under *mismo*? (*Ipse*, self.) And what does *ipso facto* mean? (By that very fact.)

345.2 cada — each, one by one, and a Greek word in plain clothes

Say *double*, then *same, self.* (*Doble*; *mismo.*)

What to know first

- todo — the whole this divides.
- mismo — the other pinning word.

Sounds you'll need

- *KA-da*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* in *this*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cada — "each," "every."
A very small, very common word, and it is Greek.
Greek **katá** meant *down, along, by.* It entered late spoken Latin in the phrase **cata ūnum** — *one by one* — which is exactly the sense *cada* still carries: not the whole heap at once, but taken one at a time.
That is the difference between *cada* and **todo**, which you have. *Todo* is the whole thing together; *cada* walks through it item by item.
Greek *katá* is at the front of a row of English words. A **catalogue** lists things down the page. A **catastrophe** is a *down-turning*, the moment a play overturns. A **cathedral** is where a bishop sits **down**.
Catalyst, **category** and **catapult** all start the same way.
So the everyday **cada día**, *each day*, opens with the same syllable as *catastrophe*.

What you've built

Wholes can now be walked through one at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cada*
- *cada día*
- *cada libro*

Before you move on

Which language does *cada* come from? (Greek — *katá*.) And what is a *catastrophe*, word for word? (A down-turning.)

345.3 la parte — the part, and why a party is only a portion of the people

Say *same, self*, then *each, every*. (*Mismo*; *cada*.)

What to know first

- la mitad — one particular part.
- todo — what parts are taken from.

Sounds you'll need

- *PAR-te*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* is a single tap, never a full trill here. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la parte — "the part," "the share."
Latin **pars**, accusative **partem**, meant *a part, a portion, a share.* English took it and then took it again, and again, until it had a whole shelf. A **part** is a piece. Something **partial** covers only some of it. A **particle** is a very small piece. To **participate** is to take a part. A **partner** is one who shares a part with you. A **portion** is a serving. And a **party** is a *part* of the people, taken apart from the rest — which is as true of a political party as of a dinner one.
Spanish uses it where English often reaches for a different word entirely. **¿De parte de quién?** is what somebody says when answering a telephone — *on whose part?*, meaning *who is calling?* And **en parte** means *partly.*
Beside *la mitad*, which is a half exactly, *la parte* is any share at all.

What you've built

Shares of a thing, not merely halves of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la parte*
- *una parte*
- *en parte*

Before you move on

What did *partem* mean? (A part, a share.) And what is a *party*, word for word? (A part of the people, taken apart.)

345.4 la persona — the person, who began as a mask

Say *each, every*, then *the part.* (*Cada*; *la parte.*)

What to know first

- la gente — people in the mass, not one by one.
- cada — how you take them one at a time.

Sounds you'll need

- *per-SO-na*, three beats with the weight on the middle. The *r* is a single tap, and the *s* stays clean. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la persona — "the person."
In Latin, a **persōna** was not a human being. It was *a mask* — the carved face a Roman actor held up or wore on stage. Probably from Etruscan, and often explained as *per-sonāre*, *to sound through*, because the mask's mouth carried the voice.
From the mask came the part the actor played, and from the part came the human being playing it. So the ordinary word for a human being started life as the thing worn over a human face.
The mask is still visible in English. Your **personality** is the face you

show. A **persona** is a mask you adopt on purpose. To **impersonate** is to put on somebody else's. Something **personal** belongs behind the mask.
Even grammar keeps it: the first, second and third **person** are the three masks a speaker can wear — *I*, *you*, and *the one being talked about*.
Beside **la gente**, which is people in the mass, *la persona* is one at a time.

What you've built

People one at a time, with a mask underneath the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la persona*
- *una persona*
- *cada persona*

Before you move on

What was a *persōna* in Latin? (An actor's mask.) And what are the three grammatical *persons*? (The three masks a speaker can wear.)

345.5 el objeto — the object, thrown down in front of you

Say *the part*, then *the person*. (*La parte*; *la persona*.)

What to know first

- la cosa — the everyday word beside this one.
- la parte — another of the pinning words.

Sounds you'll need

- *ob-HE-to*, three beats with the weight on the middle. The *j* is the throaty *jota*, and the *b* is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el objeto — "the object," "the thing."
Latin **iacere** meant *to throw*. Add **ob-**, *before, against*, and you get **objectum** — *the thing thrown down in front of you*. An object is whatever has been put in your way to be considered.
Iacere is one of the great English factories, and every one of its children is a throw. To **project** is to throw forward. To **inject** is to throw in. To **eject** is to throw out. To **reject** is to throw back. To **subject** somebody is to throw them under. To **interject** is to throw a remark between. A **trajectory** is the path of a throw. And to **object** to something is to throw it in the other person's path.
Spanish has both **la cosa**, which is the everyday word for a thing, and **el objeto**, which is the deliberate one — the thing considered, the thing put in front of you on purpose.
That closes the set: *mismo*, *cada*, *la parte*, *la persona*, *el objeto*.

What you've built

Five words for pinning down which one, and the tranche is closed: thirty words across six chapters.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el objeto*
- *un objeto*
- *el mismo objeto*

Before you move on

What did *iacere* mean? (To throw.) And what is a *projectile*, word for word? (A thing thrown forward.)

345.6 Review — the mask, the share, and the thing thrown down

Two nouns from this chapter. The person. (*La persona.*) The object. (*El objeto.*)

What you've built

Three chants, and one thing they share.
First. *La parte.* — Latin *partem*: a piece cut off a whole.
Second. *La persona.* — Latin *persōna*: a carved **mask**, held up in front of an actor's face.
Third. *El objeto.* — Latin *objectum*: something **thrown down in front of** you.
Every one of those started as a thing you could pick up. A cut piece. A mask. A thrown thing. And every one of them now names something with no shape at all — a share, a human being, a topic.

Why it's said this way

Here is the part worth keeping, and it is not about vocabulary. You did not meet *persona* and *objeto* this chapter. You have been using both for three hundred chapters, as **grammar labels**.

> *primera* ***persona*** — first person: *hablo*. ***objeto*** *directo* — direct object: *lo tengo*.

The first, second and third **person** are three masks a speaker can wear: *I*, *you*, and the one being talked about. And the **object** of a verb is exactly what the word says — the thing the action is thrown at. So the grammar words were never jargon. They were ordinary Spanish nouns the whole time, doing the same job in a classroom that they do in a kitchen.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la parte*, *la persona*, *el objeto*
- *primera persona*, then *objeto directo* — the same two words, at work

Twice through:

Before you move on

What did *objeto* mean before it meant a thing? (Something **thrown down in front of** you.) And where had you already been using *persona* without noticing? (In *primera persona* — the grammar label.)

345.7 Review — three plain words, none of them one piece

"Same." (*Mismo.*) "Each." (*Cada.*)

What you've built

Two of this chapter's words lean on a noun to say **which one**, and the chapter gave you the plainest noun there is to lean them on.

> *Cada* ***objeto.*** — each object. *El mismo* ***objeto.*** — the same object.

Say both and the difference is doing real work: *cada* takes them one at a time, *mismo* says this one is the one you already met.

Why it's said this way

Now look underneath. Not one of the three is a single piece.

- ***mismo*** was *ipse*, "self", with emphasis piled on it until it meant the very selfsame one. English keeps *ipse* bare in *ipso facto*.
- ***cada*** is Greek *kata*, "down, by", which reached Latin in the phrase *cata unum* — **one by one**, which is exactly what *cada* still does. English keeps *kata* at the front of *catalogue* and *cathedral*.
- ***objeto*** is *ob* plus *iacere*, thrown before. English *project* throws forward, *inject* throws in, *eject* throws out.

Three of the most ordinary words in the chapter, and each is a small machine with the parts still visible — in Spanish, and in English too.

Your turn

- *Say it: cada objeto*, *el mismo objeto* — the noun steady, the word in front doing the choosing

Before you move on

Which word takes them one at a time? (***Cada***.) And what was *el objeto* before it was a thing? (Something **thrown down in front of** you.)

Chapter 346

Five Places A Town Has

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name la escuela, la iglesia, el mercado, la oficina and la estacion, and say why an office was a workshop and a school was spare time.
>
> *Complete ES-C346-estacion: name five buildings a town has and ask where any of them is.*

346.1 la escuela — the school, which began as spare time

Say *heat*, then *age*. (*El calor*; *la edad*.)

What to know first

- estudiante — the person who goes there.
- el maestro — the person who waits there.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-KUE-la*, three beats with the weight on the second. Spanish will not begin a word with *sc-*, so it puts an *e* in front. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la escuela — "the school."
Greek **skholḗ** did not mean study. It meant *spare time* — the hours a free Athenian was not obliged to spend on work.
What did he do with them? He went and argued in public. So the word for the leisure slid over to the arguing, and then to the group that gathered to argue, and at last to the building they gathered in.
Latin borrowed it as **schola**, and Spanish worked it down to **escuela**.
English kept the same word twice over: a **school**, a **scholar**, a **scholarship**, and anything **scholastic**. All four rest on a Greek word for time off.
There is a small piece of Spanish machinery to notice too. Latin *schola* begins *sc-*, and Spanish mouths do not start a word that way, so an *e* grows in front. The same *e* is at the front of *España* and *estudiante*.

What you've built

The first of five places you can point at in a town.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la escuela*
- *una escuela*
- *¿dónde está la escuela?*

Before you move on

What did *skholḗ* mean in Greek? (Spare time, leisure.) And what English word for a learner comes off it? (Scholar.)

346.2 la iglesia — the church, named after the crowd

Say *age*, then *school*. (*La edad*; *la escuela*.)

What to know first

- la gente — who fills it.
- el pueblo — where it usually stands.

Sounds you'll need

- *i-GLE-sia*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *g* is hard, as in *gato*, and *-sia* runs together into one beat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la iglesia — "the church."
Greek **ekklēsía** was a political word before it was a religious one. It is **ek**, *out*, plus **kaleîn**, *to call*: the citizens **called out** of their houses by a herald, gathered in the open to vote.
Early Christians borrowed that word for their own gatherings, Latin took it as **ecclēsia**, and Spanish wore it down to **iglesia**.
So the name belongs to the people, not to the walls. A Spanish speaker saying *la iglesia* is naming a crowd that has been summoned, and only afterwards the roof over it.
English kept the Greek shape in **ecclesiastical**, and the *kaleîn* half turns up again in **council** and in a **calendar**, whose first day was *called out* aloud each month.

What you've built

Two buildings a town has, and both are named for the people inside.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la iglesia*
- *una iglesia*
- *la iglesia del pueblo*

Before you move on

What two Greek pieces make *ekklēsía*? (*Ek*, out, and *kaleîn*, to call.) And what did it name first — the crowd or the building? (The crowd.)

346.3 el mercado — the market, and the trade behind mercy

Say *school*, then *church*. (*La escuela*; *la iglesia*.)

What to know first

- la tienda — the smaller thing inside it.
- comprar — what you go there to do.

Sounds you'll need

- *mer-KA-do*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *r* is one tap, and the *d* between vowels is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el mercado — "the market."
Latin **merx**, **mercis** meant *goods, wares* — the things themselves. **Mercātus** was the act of trading them, and then the place where the trading happened.
English took the same root by two roads. Through Latin came **commerce**, **mercantile** and **mercenary**, a soldier who fights for goods rather than for a flag. Through Old French came **merchant** and **market**.
The strange one is **mercy**. Latin **mercēs** was *the pay owed* for work or wares. In church Latin it drifted: a *mercy* became a payment made where none was owed at all, a wage handed to somebody who had not earned it.
So a market square and an act of mercy come out of the same Latin heap of goods.

What you've built

Three places, and three different reasons a town gathers.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el mercado*
- *un mercado grande*
- *¿dónde está el mercado?*

Before you move on

What did Latin *merx* mean? (Goods, wares.) And what did *mercēs* mean before it meant mercy? (The pay owed.)

346.4 la oficina — the office, which used to be a workshop

Say *church*, then *market*. (*La iglesia*; *el mercado*.)

What to know first

- la mesa — what stands in it.
- el lugar — the general word this narrows.

Sounds you'll need

- *o-fi-SI-na*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *c* before *i* is soft — an *s* across the Americas. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la oficina — "the office."
Latin had **opus**, *work*, and **facere**, *to make*. Stick them together and you get **opifex**, a *work-maker*, a craftsman. The place he worked was an **opificīna**.
Four syllables was too many for daily speech, so Latin itself squeezed

the middle out and said **officīna** — a workshop, a forge, a place where something was actually being made.
Spanish kept the workshop sense for centuries. The desk and the paperwork are a late arrival; the word underneath still means the room where the work is done.
English took **office**, **officer**, **official** and **officious** off the same stem, and kept **opus** itself for a composer's work. **Operate**, **opera** and **operation** are all *opus* as well.

What you've built

Four places, and one of them is a workshop wearing a suit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la oficina*
- *una oficina nueva*
- *la oficina está en la plaza*

Before you move on

What two Latin words hide inside *officīna*? (*Opus*, work, and *facere*, to make.) And what was an *officīna* before it was an office? (A workshop.)

346.5 la estación — the station, a place for standing still

Say *market*, then *office*. (*El mercado*; *la oficina*.)

What to know first

- la parada — the smaller stop this outgrew.
- estar — the verb hiding at the front of it.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-ta-SIÓN*, three beats with the weight on the last, which is why it carries a written accent. The *c* before *i* is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la estación — "the station."
Latin **stāre** meant *to stand*, and a **statiō** was a *standing-place*: a post where a sentry was set, a road-house where horses were changed, an anchorage where ships stood at rest.
Every later sense grows out of that standing. A railway **estación** is where a train stands. A radio **estación** is a fixed point on a dial. And a season of the year is an *estación* too, because the sun appears to stand at the same height for a stretch of weeks.
The same **stāre** is already in your mouth. **Estar** is that verb, worn down by two thousand years of use — which is why *estar* is the *to be* you use for where a thing stands rather than what it permanently is.
English is full of it as well: **station**, **stationary**, **status**, **statue**, **stable**, **stance**, **estate** and **circumstance**.

What you've built

Five places you can name and ask for: a school, a church, a market, an office and a station.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la estación*
- *¿dónde está la estación?*
- *la estación está en la ciudad*

Before you move on

What did Latin *stāre* mean? (To stand.) And which everyday Spanish verb is the same word worn down? (*Estar*.)

Chapter 347

Which Way, And What Is Around You

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name el norte, el sur, el oeste, el centro and alrededor, and say why three of the four compass points came into Spanish from Germanic sailors rather than from Rome.
>
> *Complete ES-C347-alrededor: send somebody north, south or west, name the middle of a town, and say what encircles it.*

347.1 el norte — north, an English word living in Spanish

Say *office*, then *station*. (*La oficina*; *la estación*.)

What to know first

- ¿dónde está? — the question this answers.
- el país — the thing this often divides.

Sounds you'll need

- *NOR-te*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* is a single tap against the ridge behind your teeth. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el norte — "the north."
Almost every word you have met so far came down from Latin. This one did not.
Latin's word for the north was **septentriō**, *the seven plough-oxen* — the seven stars of the Great Bear, wheeling around the pole. It is a beautiful word and Spanish barely uses it.
What Spanish uses instead is Germanic. **Northa** was the north in the mouths of the sailors who worked the Atlantic and the North Sea, and their four direction words travelled with their trade: into Old French as **nord**, and from there into Spanish as **norte**.
So *norte* and English **north** are not cousins that drifted apart. They are the same word, and the *-e* on the end is the only thing Spanish added to make it pronounceable.
Names remember it. **Norway** is the *north way*; a **Norman** was a *north-man*.

What you've built

The first of the four points, and a reminder that Spanish borrows.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el norte*
- *el norte del país*
- *la estación está al norte*

Before you move on

Is *norte* Latin or Germanic? (Germanic.) And what did Latin's own *septentriō* name? (The seven plough-oxen, the stars of the Great Bear.)

347.2 el sur — south, the sunward quarter

Say *station*, then *north*. (*La estación*; *el norte*.)

What to know first

- el país — what a direction cuts in half.
- la ciudad — what sits in one half or the other.

Sounds you'll need

- *SUR*, one beat, and the *r* at the end is a single tap rather than a roll. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el sur — "the south."
Like *norte*, this came in with Atlantic sailors rather than down from Rome. Germanic **sunthaz** became Old French **sud**, and Spanish took it as **sur**. It is the same word as English **south**.
What is inside it is a guess, but a good one: **sun**. Stand anywhere in northern Europe and the sun is never overhead — it swings across the southern half of the sky, all day, all year. The sunward quarter is the south, and so the sun gave its name to a direction.
Spanish has both shapes. **Sur** on its own, and **sud-** when it joins onto another word, as in *Sudamérica*.
English does the same trick and never notices: **south**, but **southern** with a different vowel, and **Sussex** for the *South Saxons*.

What you've built

Two of the four points, and both of them Germanic.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el sur*
- *el norte y el sur*
- *la ciudad está al sur*

Before you move on

Which everyday thing is probably hiding inside *sur*? (The sun.) And which shape does Spanish use when the word joins onto another? (*Sud-*.)

347.3 el oeste — west, named after the evening

Say *north*, then *south*. (*El norte*; *el sur*.)

What to know first

- este — a word that will trip you here.
- ¿dónde está? — the question all four points answer.

Sounds you'll need

- *o-ES-te*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *o* and the *e* stay separate, each with its own beat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el oeste — "the west."
The third Germanic borrowing in a row: **westaz** to Old French **ouest** to Spanish **oeste**. Again the same word as English **west**.
Under it lies an old root meaning *evening*. Latin took that root as **vesper**, the evening star and then the evening itself, which is why the evening prayers of a monastery are called **vespers**. So the west is not named for a place. It is named for an hour — the quarter of the sky the sun falls into at the end of the day.
Now the trap. The fourth point, the east, is **el este** — and *este* is already in your mouth as the pointing word for *this*. The two have nothing to do with each other. The pointing *este* is Latin **iste**, *that one of yours*. The compass *este* is Germanic, a cousin of English **east**, from a root meaning *dawn*.
Two words that fell into the same shape by accident. The article tells you which is which: **el este** is a direction, plain **este** is a finger.

What you've built

Three points named and the fourth explained, with a warning attached.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el oeste*
- *el norte y el oeste*
- *el pueblo está al oeste*

Before you move on

What hour is *oeste* named for? (The evening.) And are the compass *este* and the pointing *este* the same word? (No — a pure accident of shape.)

347.4 el centro — the centre, and the spike it turns on

Say *south*, then *west*. (*El sur*; *el oeste*.)

What to know first

- la plaza — what usually sits in it.
- la ciudad — what has one.

Sounds you'll need

- *SEN-tro*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *e* is soft, and *tr* runs together. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el centro — "the centre," and in a town, "downtown."
Greek **kéntron** was a **goad** — the spiked stick a farmer used to drive oxen. From the spike came the second sense: the fixed leg of a pair of compasses, the point you stick into the paper so the other leg can

swing round it.
That is what a centre is. Not the middle in some vague way, but the place where the point went in.
Latin took it as **centrum** and geometry has used it ever since. English has **centre**, **central**, **concentrate** (to drive things toward one point), **eccentric** (out of centre, off the spike) and the **epicentre** of an earthquake.
In everyday Spanish, *el centro* is where you go to shop and to meet people — the old middle of a town, the part built first, with the plaza and the church in it.

What you've built

The four points of the compass, and the still place they turn around.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el centro*
- *el centro de la ciudad*
- *la iglesia está en el centro*

Before you move on

What was a *kéntron* first? (A goad, a spiked stick.) And what does **eccentric** mean, word for word? (Out of the centre, off the spike.)

347.5 alrededor — around, and the wheel inside your knee

Say *west*, then *the centre*. (*El oeste*; *el centro*.)

What to know first

- la rodilla — a little wheel, and a cousin of this.
- la plaza — the sort of thing you stand in the middle of.

Sounds you'll need

- *al-rre-de-DOR*, four beats with the weight on the last. The *r* after *l* is rolled, not tapped. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

alrededor — "around," "round about."
Take it apart: **al** + **rededor**. The second piece is an old Spanish word for the space surrounding a thing, and it comes from Latin **retrō**, *backwards*, pulled sideways by **rota**, *a wheel*.
Both ideas are in the word. Something *alrededor* is behind you as well as in front, because it has gone all the way round.
Rota is generous. English gets **rotate**, **rotation**, **rotary**, **rotund** and **roll** from it, and Spanish gets a surprise: **la rodilla**, the knee, is Latin **rotella**, *a little wheel* — the joint your leg turns on.
Retrō gave English **retro**, **retrograde** and **retrospect**.
So the space around you and the knee you stand on are both named for turning.

What you've built

Five ways to say where: north, south, west, the middle, and everything encircling it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *alrededor*
- *alrededor de la plaza*
- *la gente está alrededor*

Before you move on

What does Latin *rota* mean? (A wheel.) And which part of your body is a *little wheel* in Spanish? (*La rodilla*, the knee.)

Chapter 348

A Moment, And Its Two Edges

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name el principio, el fin, el instante, la demora and el turno, and say why an ending began as the boundary stone of a field.
>
> *Complete ES-C348-turno: mark where a stretch of time opens and closes, name an instant inside it, report a delay, and claim your turn.*

348.1 el principio — the beginning, and the prince inside it

Say *the centre*, then *around*. (*El centro*; *alrededor*.)

What to know first

- primero · segundo · tercero — the *first* this is built on.
- la entrada — the way in, which a beginning resembles.

Sounds you'll need

- *prin-SI-pio*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *c* before *i* is soft, and *-pio* runs together. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el principio — "the beginning," and also "the principle."
Latin built **princeps** out of two pieces you have already met inside other words: **prīmus**, *first*, and **capere**, *to take*. A *princeps* was the one who **takes first place** — the first name on the senate roll, and later the ruler.
From *princeps* came **principium**, *the taking of first place*, and so *the start of a thing*.
English keeps both halves of the meaning and spells them differently to tell them apart. A **principal** is the chief one. A **principle** is a starting rule, the thing everything else is built on. A **prince** and a **principality** are the ruler and the ruled.
Spanish declines to split them: *el principio* is the beginning of a story and the principle of a science with no change of spelling at all.

What you've built

The first edge of a stretch of time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el principio*
- *al principio*
- *el principio del día*

Before you move on

What two Latin words make *princeps*? (*Prīmus*, first, and *capere*, to take.) And which English word means the starting rule of a thing? (Principle.)

348.2 el fin — the end, which began as a boundary stone

Say *around*, then *the beginning*. (*Alrededor*; *el principio*.)

What to know first

- la salida — the way out, which an ending resembles.
- primero · segundo · tercero — the order this closes.

Sounds you'll need

- *FIN*, one beat. Short, and the *n* is fully sounded. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el fin — "the end."
Latin **fīnis** was not a word about time at all. It was a **boundary** — the stone at the edge of a field, the line where your land stopped and your neighbour's began. A Roman argued about *fines* the way people argue about fences.
Time borrowed the picture afterwards, and now the edge of a stretch of hours is named for the edge of a farm.
English took it in a crowd. Something **final** is at the boundary. **Finish** is to reach it. **Finite** means it has one at all, and **infinite** means it does not. To **define** is to set the bounds of a thing; to **confine** is to hold it inside them; a **frontier** is a boundary faced outward.
Even **finance** is here: settling a debt was *finishing* it.

What you've built

Both edges of a stretch of time — where it opens and where it stops.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el fin*
- *el fin de la semana*
- *del principio al fin*

Before you move on

What did Latin *fīnis* mark? (A boundary, the edge of a field.) And what does **define** mean, word for word? (To set the bounds of something.)

348.3 el instante — the instant, standing right on top of you

Say *the beginning*, then *the end*. (*El principio*; *el fin*.)

What to know first

- estar — the verb this is built on.
- la vez — the other way Spanish counts moments.

Sounds you'll need

- *ins-TAN-te*, three beats with the weight on the second. Spanish keeps both consonants of *-ns-* clearly. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el instante — "the instant," "the split second."
Latin **īnstāre** is **in**, *on*, plus **stāre**, *to stand*: to stand upon something, to press on it, to be right there.
Its present participle was **īnstāns**, *standing upon* — and that is a remarkably good picture of the present moment. Not the moment that is coming, not the one that has gone: the one with its whole weight on you.
You have that **stāre** twice already. It is inside **estar**, the verb for where a thing stands, and inside **la estación**, a standing-place.
English took the family whole. An **instant**; an **instance**, one standing case of a thing; something **constant**, standing with you; something **distant**, standing apart; and a **circumstance**, whatever stands around.
The Spanish phrase to keep is **en un instante** — in a moment.

What you've built

Two edges and the point between them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el instante*
- *en un instante*
- *un instante, por favor*

Before you move on

What does *īnstāns* mean, word for word? (Standing upon.) And which everyday Spanish verb is the same *stāre*? (*Estar*.)

348.4 la demora — the delay, and the art of hanging back

Say *the end*, then *the instant*. (*El fin*; *el instante*.)

What to know first

- temprano — its opposite in a timetable.
- la hora — what a delay is measured in.

Sounds you'll need

- *de-MO-ra*, three beats with the weight on the second. One tapped *r*, and the *d* at the front is soft after a vowel. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la demora — "the delay," "the wait."
Latin **mora** was a *lingering*: any stretch of not-yet, whether somebody meant it or not. Add **dē-** and you get **demorārī**, to hang about in a place, to be slow leaving.

Notice what the word does not say. It carries no blame. A *demora* is time that passed while nothing happened, and Spanish uses it for a late bus as easily as for a slow reply.
English took two narrow slices. To **demur** is to hang back from agreeing — the delay moved from the feet to the opinion. A **moratorium** is an official period of hanging back, a stretch of time in which a thing may not proceed.
Two useful shapes to carry: **sin demora**, without delay, and **con demora**, late.

What you've built

A word for time that goes by while you wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la demora*
- *sin demora*
- *hay una demora*

Before you move on

What did Latin *mora* mean? (A lingering, a pause.) And what does it mean to **demur**? (To hang back from agreeing.)

348.5 el turno — your turn, and the lathe it spins on

Say *the instant*, then *the delay*. (*El instante*; *la demora*.)

What to know first

- la vez — the near neighbour of this word.
- otro — whose turn it is next.

Sounds you'll need

- *TUR-no*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* is one tap, and the *u* is a pure *oo*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el turno — "the turn," "the shift," "your slot in the queue."
Greek **tórnos** was a tool: the **lathe**, and also the compass a woodworker used to scribe a circle. Latin borrowed it as **tornus**, and from there everything round in Europe took its name.
English has a great heap of it. To **turn**. A **tour**, which goes round and comes back. A **tournament**, where riders wheeled at each other. A **contour**, the line that goes round a shape. **Return**, **detour**, **turnstile** — and **tornado**, a Spanish word for a wind that turns.
The Spanish sense is the human one. In a bank, in a clinic, on a night shift, people take their **turno** — the circle comes round and stops at you.
Two shapes worth saying aloud: **es mi turno**, it's my turn, and **por turnos**, taking turns.

What you've built

Five ways to cut time up: a beginning, an end, an instant, a delay and a turn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el turno*
- *es mi turno*
- *por turnos*

Before you move on

What tool was a *tórnos*? (A lathe, and a woodworker's compass.)
And which storm word is Spanish for a wind that turns? (Tornado.)

Chapter 349

The Stretches A Calendar Marks

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name la jornada, la decada, la fiesta, el aniversario and la agenda, and say why a journey was once one day's travel.
>
> *Complete ES-C349-agenda: name a day's stretch, a decade, a holiday and an anniversary, and name the book they are written in.*

349.1 la jornada — a day's worth, and the journey inside it

Say *the delay*, then *the turn*. (*La demora*; *el turno*.)

What to know first

- el día — the same Latin day, by a different road.
- la hora — what this is measured in.

Sounds you'll need

- *hor-NA-da*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *j* is the scraped *jota*, back in the throat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la jornada — "a day's stretch": a working day, a day's march, a day's play.

Latin **diēs** was *day*, and **diurnus** meant *belonging to the day*. Spanish already had *día* straight from *diēs*. So why a second word?
Because this one came the long way round. **Diurnāta** travelled north into Occitan and French, was reshaped there into **jornada** and **journée**, and then walked back south into Spanish as a borrowing.
Two words, one Latin day, different roads — which is why they do not look alike.
The northern road left tracks in English. A **journey** was originally *one day's travel*. A **journal** is a *day-book*. To **adjourn** is to put something off to *another day*, and a **sojourn** is a stay counted in days. **Diurnal** came by the straight Latin route.
Jornada is the word a Spanish speaker reaches for when a day is a quantity of work rather than a square on a calendar.

What you've built

A day measured by what fits inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la jornada*
- *una jornada de ocho horas*
- *la jornada de hoy*

Before you move on

What was a **journey** at first? (One day's travel.) And which Spanish word comes from the same *diēs* by the straight road? (*Día*.)

349.2 la década — ten years, and the ten scattered through English

Say *the turn*, then *a day's stretch*. (*El turno*; *la jornada*.)

What to know first

- seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — the ten this counts by.
- veinte — two of them.

Sounds you'll need

- *DÉ-ca-da*, three beats with the weight on the first, which is why it is written with an accent. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la década — "the decade," ten years taken as one block.
Greek **déka** is *ten*. A **dekás** was *a set of ten* — of soldiers, of verses, of anything. Latin borrowed it as **decas**, and Spanish as **década**.
Latin also had its own *ten*, **decem**, and the two roots are the same ancient word travelling by different families. Between them they seeded English thickly.
Decimal counts by tens. To **decimate** a legion was to execute one man in ten. A **dime** is a tenth of a dollar. And **December** is the *tenth* month — which it was, before Rome shoved January and February in front of it and left the last four months carrying the wrong numbers forever.
Even a **dean** is here: a *decanus* was a man set over ten monks. Spanish keeps it as well, in the *diez* you already count with.

What you've built

Time in blocks bigger than a day.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la década*
- *una década*
- *en una década*

Before you move on

What number is *déka*? (Ten.) And why is **December** named for the tenth? (It was the tenth month before January and February were added.)

349.3 la fiesta — the day set apart, and the word English took twice

Say *a day's stretch*, then *a decade*. (*La jornada*; *la década*.)

What to know first

- feliz — how the day is meant to feel.
- la semana — the run of days it interrupts.

Sounds you'll need

- *FIES-ta*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ie* is one glide, not two beats. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la fiesta — "the holiday," and also "the party."
Latin **fēstus** meant *set apart, solemn, not for work*. A **fēstum** was such a day, and the plural **fēsta** — the feast days — is what Spanish inherited, which is why the word arrives already meaning a whole stretch rather than a single hour.
That double sense is still there. *La fiesta* can be a public holiday marked on a calendar, or the party you throw on a Saturday night, and Spanish does not think it needs two words.
English took the Latin road first and got **feast**, **festival**, **festive**, **festoon** and **fête**. Then, much later, it borrowed the Spanish shape whole, so **fiesta** now sits in an English dictionary beside **feast**, the same word arriving twice, centuries apart, by different ships.

What you've built

The days a calendar marks off from the rest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la fiesta*
- *una fiesta grande*
- *el día de la fiesta*

Before you move on

What did Latin *fēstus* mean? (Set apart, not for work.) And which plain English word is the same Latin word? (Feast.)

349.4 el aniversario — the year turning back to the same day

Say *a decade*, then *the holiday*. (*La década*; *la fiesta*.)

What to know first

- ¿Cuántos años tienes? — the year this counts.
- los meses — the twelve it walks through.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-ni-ver-SA-rio*, five beats with the weight on the fourth. The *v* is made with both lips, close to a soft *b*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el aniversario — "the anniversary."
Two Latin pieces. **Annus** is *a year*. **Vertere** is *to turn*. Put them together and **anniversārius** means *the year-turning* — the wheel has gone all the way round and stopped where it started.
That is a more exact picture than the English feeling of the word. An anniversary is not a memory. It is a position: the year has come back to the same mark.
Annus gave English **annual**, **annals** (a year-by-year record), **biennial** and **per annum**.

Vertere is even busier. A **verse** is where the plough turns at the end of a furrow. To **convert** is to turn something round; to **reverse** is to turn it back. **Versus** sets one side turned against another, and **vertigo** is the world turning when it should not.

What you've built

A date that comes back around, and a reason to call it a *fiesta*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el aniversario*
- *un aniversario feliz*
- *el aniversario es hoy*

Before you move on

What two Latin words are inside it? (*Annus*, year, and *vertere*, to turn.) And what does **vertigo** name? (The world turning when it should not.)

349.5 la agenda — the things that must be done

Say *the holiday*, then *the anniversary*. (*La fiesta*; *el aniversario*.)

What to know first

- la semana — what it is usually laid out by.
- los meses — the bigger squares in it.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-JEN-da*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *g* before *e* is the scraped *jota*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la agenda — "the diary," "the schedule," "the list of what is coming." This one is a Latin grammatical form that walked into modern life without being translated. **Agenda** is a plural, and it means *the things that must be done*. Not things done, not things happening — things owed to the future.

Behind it stands **agere**, one of Latin's great workhorse verbs. Its first sense is to **drive**, the way a herdsman drives cattle down a road.

Once you know the driving is there, the family opens up. An **agent** is somebody who drives a thing along. Something **agile** moves quickly. **Agitate** is to drive hard and repeatedly. To **act** is *agere* itself, and so are **exact**, **transact** and **navigate**.

And an *agenda* is the herd of tasks being driven at you.

What you've built

Five stretches of time and the book you write them in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la agenda*
- *mi agenda*
- *la agenda de la semana*

Before you move on

What does *agenda* mean, word for word? (The things that must be done.) And what does **agere** mean first of all? (To drive, as a herdsman drives cattle.)

Chapter 350

Mine, Somebody Else's, And Which Kind

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say propio, ajeno, igual, distinto and el tipo, and say why English proper meant owned long before it meant correct.
>
> *Complete ES-C350-tipo: mark a thing as yours or another's, as the same or a different one, and ask what sort it is.*

350.1 propio — one's own, and the owning inside *proper*

Say *the anniversary*, then *the diary*. (*El aniversario*; *la agenda*.)

What to know first

- María · España · profesor — the names this word labels.
- la casa — the sort of thing you say it about.

Sounds you'll need

- *PRO-pio*, two beats with the weight on the first. *-pio* is one glide, not two beats. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

propio — "one's own."
Spanish already has *mi*, *tu*, *su*. **Propio** is what you add when *su* is not emphatic enough: **su propia casa**, *her own house* — hers and nobody else's.
Latin **proprius** meant exactly that: belonging to the individual rather than held in common. The old guess at its make-up is **prō prīvō**, *for the private one*.
English took it and let it drift a long way. **Proper** meant *owned* first — a **proper noun** is a name that belongs to one thing only, which is the original sense sitting in plain sight. **Property** is what you own. A **proprietor** owns it. To **appropriate** something is to make it your own, and it is impolite for exactly that reason.
Only later did *proper* slide into *correct*, by way of *fitting, belonging to this occasion*.

What you've built

A way to say a thing is yours and not somebody else's.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *propio*
- *mi propia casa*
- *su propio libro*

Before you move on

What did English **proper** mean before it meant correct? (Owned.) And what is a **proper noun**, on that older sense? (A name belonging to one thing only.)

350.2 ajeno — somebody else's, the exact opposite of *propio*

Say *the diary*, then *one's own*. (*La agenda*; *propio*.)

What to know first

- otro — the other one this belongs to.
- alguien — the somebody in question.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-JE-no*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *j* is scraped at the back of the throat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ajeno — "somebody else's," "not mine."
English has no single word for this. It says *someone else's*, three words where Spanish uses one: **una casa ajena**, a house belonging to another person.
Latin **aliēnus** is built on **alius**, *other*. And Latin had two words for *other*, used carefully: **alius**, another out of many, and **alter**, the other of exactly two.
Spanish inherited both. *Otro* comes down from **alter** — the other one of a pair. **Ajeno** comes from **alius** — belonging to some other person out there, unnamed.
English took *alius* whole and never softened it. An **alien** is from elsewhere. To **alienate** somebody is to make them another person's problem. An **alias** is your other name, and an **alibi** is the plea that you were *elsewhere*.
Together with *propio*, you can now sort the world into mine and not-mine.

What you've built

Two sides of ownership, in one word each.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ajeno*
- *una casa ajena*
- *propio o ajeno*

Before you move on

Which Latin word for *other* is inside *ajeno*? (*Alius.*) And what does an **alibi** claim? (That you were elsewhere.)

350.3 igual — the same, from a surface with no tilt

Say *one's own*, then *somebody else's*. (*Propio*; *ajeno.*)

What to know first

- todo — the whole this measures against.
- la manera — the thing two people can do equally.

Sounds you'll need

- *i-GUAL*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *gua* is one glide, and the *g* is hard. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

igual — "the same," "equal."
Latin **aequus** did not mean *identical*. It meant **level** — a plain with no slope, a scale with neither pan down, water lying flat.
Aequālis is what has that levelness, and Spanish wore it into **igual**. Hold on to the flatness and the English family falls open. The **equator** is the line that levels the globe into halves. An **equinox** is the day whose night is level with it. To be **adequate** is to come up level with what is needed. **Equity** is fairness weighed on a level scale. **Equanimity** is a mind that does not tilt.
Two everyday Spanish uses to keep. **Es igual** means *it's all the same*, a polite shrug. And **igual que** compares: *igual que ayer*, the same as yesterday.

What you've built

A way to say two things match.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *igual*
- *es igual*
- *igual que ayer*

Before you move on

What did Latin *aequus* mean? (Level, with no tilt.) And what does the **equator** do to the globe? (Levels it into halves.)

350.4 distinto — a different one, marked apart with a pin

Say *somebody else's*, then *the same*. (*Ajeno*; *igual*.)

What to know first

- otro — the plain way to say another one.
- el modo — one of the things that can differ.

Sounds you'll need

- *dis-TIN-to*, three beats with the weight on the second. Both consonants of *-st-* are sounded. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

distinto — "different," "a different one."
You have **otro** for *another*. *Distinto* is sharper: not merely a second one, but one that is unlike the first.
Latin **distinguere** is **dis-**, *apart*, plus an old verb **stinguere**, *to prick*. Marking things apart meant putting a pinprick beside them — a tally, a dot, a small wound in the wax.
So a **distinct** thing is one somebody has pricked apart from its neighbours, and to **distinguish** is to do the pricking.
The family is odd and worth having. To **extinguish** is to prick a flame

out. An **instinct** is an urge that pricks you from inside. Something **distinguished** has been marked off from the crowd.
In use, remember that *distinto* usually goes after its noun — **un libro distinto** — while *otro* goes in front.

What you've built

Same, and not the same, in one pair.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *distinto*
- *un libro distinto*
- *igual o distinto*

Before you move on

What did *stinguere* mean? (To prick.) And what does it mean to **extinguish** a flame, on that picture? (To prick it out.)

350.5 el tipo — the kind, and the dent a hammer leaves

Say *the same*, then *a different one.* (*Igual*; *distinto.*)

What to know first

- la cosa — what has a kind.
- la manera — the near neighbour of this word.

Sounds you'll need

- *TI-po*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *t* is made with the tongue against the teeth, not the ridge behind them. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tipo — "the kind," "the sort."
Greek **týptein** was *to strike*, and a **týpos** was first the **blow**, then the **dent the blow left behind**.
Watch it move. Strike a coin with a die and the coin carries a *typos*. Strike a thousand coins with the same die and every one carries the same mark — so the word slides again, from the single dent to **the pattern all the dents share**. That is a *kind*.
English follows the whole path. Movable **type** is metal that strikes paper. **Typography** is writing by striking. Something **typical** matches the pattern. A **prototype** is the first strike, and a **stereotype** was a printing plate cast solid so it could never be re-set — which is why calling a thought a stereotype is an insult.
One warning. In everyday Latin American speech *un tipo* also means *a guy*. It is casual; it is not for strangers.

What you've built

Five ways to pin down which one: yours, another's, the same, a different one, and what sort it is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tipo*
- *un tipo de libro*
- *¿qué tipo?*

Before you move on

What was a *týpos* first? (A blow, and then the dent it left.) And what was a **stereotype** before it was an insult? (A printing plate cast solid.)

Chapter 351

Counting Past Your Fingers

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say cien, la cantidad, ambos, varios and el triple, and say why cien and English hundred are the same word split by one sound change.
>
> *Complete ES-C351-triple: count to a hundred, name an amount, take two together, say there are several, and treble a figure.*

351.1 cien — a hundred, and the *hundred* hiding in it

Say *a different one*, then *the kind.* (*Distinto*; *el tipo.*)

What to know first

- veinte — the biggest number you had until now.
- mucho · muy, malo · mal — the same tail-cutting at work.

Sounds you'll need

- *SIEN*, one beat. The *c* before *i* is soft, and *ie* is a single glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cien — "a hundred."
The full word is **ciento**, and Spanish cuts the tail off before a noun: **cien libros**, a hundred books. That is the same trick you have already met with *mucho* going to *muy* and *malo* going to *mal*.
Latin **centum** is the source, and it turns up all over English: a **cent** is a hundredth, a **century** is a hundred years, a **centipede** is a hundred-foot, a **centurion** commanded a hundred men, and **percent** is *by the hundred*.
Now the good part. English **hundred** is the same ancient word. The line that became Latin kept the sound at the front as a *c*; the line that became English turned that *c* into an *h*, all the way down the vocabulary — which is also why Latin *cornu* matches English **horn** and Latin *cord-* matches **heart**.
So **cien** and **hundred** are one word, separated by a single sound change, several thousand years ago.

What you've built

A number bigger than your fingers, and a rule for shortening it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cien*
- *cien libros*
- *cien días*

Before you move on

What is the full form of *cien*? (*Ciento.*) And which plain English number is the same ancient word? (Hundred.)

351.2 la cantidad — the amount, from a question word

Say *the kind*, then *a hundred*. (*El tipo*; *cien.*)

What to know first

- mucho — a rough answer to the question this asks.
- poco — the other rough answer.

Sounds you'll need

- *kan-ti-DAD*, three beats with the weight on the last. The final *d* is very soft, close to a breath. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cantidad — "the quantity," "the amount."
Latin **quantus** is a question: *how much?* Make a noun of it with **-tātem** and you get **quantitās**, *how-much-ness* — the answer treated as a thing.
Spanish has done this to you already. That **-tātem** is the **-dad** on the end of *verdad*, *ciudad* and *edad*. Once you spot it, you can hear a Latin abstract noun coming a long way off.
English took the same word twice. **Quantity** through French, worn smooth. And **quantum** straight out of Latin, meaning *how much there is of a thing* — which is why the smallest indivisible amount of energy got that name. **Quantify** and **quantitative** follow.
Cantidad is the neutral word. It carries no judgement about whether the amount is big or small; that is what *mucho* and *poco* are for.

What you've built

A noun for the answer to *how much*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cantidad*
- *una cantidad grande*
- *la cantidad de libros*

Before you move on

What does Latin *quantus* ask? (How much.) And which Spanish ending is Latin *-tātem*? (*-dad*, as in *verdad* and *ciudad*.)

351.3 ambos — both, and the two sides of *ambiguous*

Say *a hundred*, then *the amount*. (*Cien*; *la cantidad*.)

What to know first

- uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — the two this gathers.
- unos · unas — the vaguer handful.

Sounds you'll need

- *AM-bos*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *b* after *m* is a full *b*, not the soft one between vowels. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ambos — "both."
Spanish can say *los dos*. **Ambos** is the tighter word: the two of them, taken together as a pair rather than counted one after the other.
Latin **ambō** is that pair, and the **amb-** at its front is an old piece meaning *on both sides, round about*.
English is full of it and rarely notices. **Ambidextrous** is having a right hand on both sides. **Ambiguous** is a phrase that drives both ways at once — the *-ig-* is *agere*, to drive. **Ambition** was going round on both sides of a crowd asking for votes. **Ambient** is what goes round about you.
Greek had the same piece as **amphí**, which gives **amphitheatre**, a theatre with seats on both sides, and an **amphibian**, which lives both lives.
Ambos agrees like any adjective: **ambos libros**, **ambas casas**.

What you've built

A word for two things held as one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ambos*
- *ambos libros*
- *ambas casas*

Before you move on

What does the piece *amb-* mean? (On both sides, round about.) And what is an **amphibian**, word for word? (A thing that lives both lives.)

351.4 varios — several, and the speckled hide behind it

Say *the amount*, then *both*. (*La cantidad*; *ambos*.)

What to know first

- poco — fewer than this.
- bastante — more than this.

Sounds you'll need

- *BA-rios*, with a first syllable *va-* made with both lips, and the weight on it. *-rios* is one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

varios — "several," "a few of different sorts."
Latin **varius** did not mean *several*. It meant **speckled** — a hide with blotches on it, a sky of broken cloud, marble with veins running through.

From mottled came *mixed*, from mixed came *of more than one kind*, and only then came the plain plural sense Spanish uses now. So *varios libros* is not merely *some books*; underneath, it is *books that are not all the same*.
English kept every step. **Variegated** leaves are the speckled ones, right back at the start. **Variety** is a mixture. To **vary** is to become mottled with change. **Various** and **variance** finish the family.
You will hear it in front of its noun, agreeing with it: **varias casas**.

What you've built

Four counting words, and each one a different way of not saying a number.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *varios*
- *varios libros*
- *varias casas*

Before you move on

What did Latin *varius* mean first? (Speckled, blotched.) And which English word for leaves keeps that sense? (Variegated.)

351.5 el triple — three times over, and the fold in *simple*

Say *both*, then *several*. (*Ambos*; *varios*.)

What to know first

- uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — the *three* inside it.
- mucho — the vague version of the same idea.

Sounds you'll need

- *TRI-ple*, two beats with the weight on the first. *Tr* and *pl* each run together as one sound. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el triple — "triple," "three times as much."
Latin **triplus** is two pieces. **Tres** is *three*, which you already count with. The **-plus** on the end is an old root meaning **fold**.
So *triple* is *threefold* — a cloth creased three times, and therefore three layers thick where it was one.
That fold runs through English in disguise. **Simple** is *one-fold*, a thing with a single layer. **Double** is *two-fold*. **Multiple** is *many-fold*.
Triplicate is three copies, three folds of the same paper.
Spanish uses *el triple* as a noun, with *de*: **el triple de libros**, three times as many books.

What you've built

Five ways to count past your fingers: a hundred, an amount, both, several and three times over.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el triple*
- *el triple de libros*
- *tres o el triple*

Before you move on

What does the piece *-plus* mean? (Fold.) And what is **simple**, word for word? (One-fold, a single layer.)

Chapter 352

The Whole Set, And How Much Of It

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el conjunto, entero, la mayoria, el resto and escaso, and say why a whole thing is one nobody has touched.
>
> *Complete ES-C352-escaso: name a set, say it is whole, name most of it, name what is left, and say there is not enough.*

352.1 el conjunto — the set, and the yoke that holds it

Say *several*, then *triple*. (*Varios*; *el triple*.)

What to know first

- la gente — one sort of group.
- todo — the whole this names.

Sounds you'll need

- *kon-JUN-to*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *j* is the scraped *jota*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el conjunto — "the set," "the whole group taken as one."
Latin **iungere** meant *to yoke* — to put two oxen under one wooden beam so they must pull together. Add **com-**, *together*, and you get **coniungere**, and its participle **coniunctus**: yoked as one.
That is what a set is. Not things that happen to be near each other, but things counted as a unit because somebody has put them under one yoke.
English took *iungere* by every road. A **junction** is where roads are yoked. A **joint** is where bones are. **Conjunction** is the grammar word for a yoking word — *y*, *o*, *pero*. **Adjoin**, **subjugate** and **junta** all follow.
And the root reaches much further east. Sanskrit **yoga** is the same ancient word, and it means a *yoking* too — of body to breath, or of a mind to its task.

What you've built

A name for a group of things, before we start dividing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el conjunto*
- *un conjunto de libros*
- *todo el conjunto*

Before you move on

What did Latin *iungere* mean? (To yoke.) And which eastern word for a discipline is the same yoking? (Yoga.)

352.2 entero — whole, meaning nobody has touched it

Say *triple*, then *the set*. (*El triple*; *el conjunto*.)

What to know first

- todo — the nearest word you already have.
- poco — what is left if this fails.

Sounds you'll need

- *en-TE-ro*, three beats with the weight on the second. One tapped *r*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

entero — "whole," "entire."
Latin **integer** is **in-**, *not*, plus a form of **tangere**, *to touch*. A whole thing is one that **nobody has laid a hand on** — nothing broken off, nothing taken.
Spanish has two words where English has one feeling. **Todo** is the whole counted up: all of it. **Entero** is the whole left unbroken: none of it missing. *Todo el libro* is every page; *el libro entero* is the book with no page torn out.
English took *integer* twice. Once through French, worn down to **entire**. Once straight from Latin, kept whole, for a number with no fraction on it — an **integer**. **Integrity** is a character nobody has tampered with, and to **integrate** is to make a thing whole again.
Tangere on its own gives **tangent**, **tangible** and **contact**.

What you've built

A set, and a way to say the set is still complete.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *entero*
- *el libro entero*
- *un día entero*

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces make *integer*? (*In-*, not, and *tangere*, to touch.) And what is an **integer** in arithmetic? (A number with no fraction on it.)

352.3 la mayoría — most of them, and the greatness inside a mayor

Say *the set*, then *whole*. (*El conjunto*; *entero*.)

What to know first

- el maestro — a cousin of this word.
- mucho — the vaguer way to say a lot.

Sounds you'll need

- *ma-yo-RÍ-a*, four beats with the weight on the third. The written accent on the *í* keeps it from folding into the *a*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la mayoría — "most of them," "the majority."
Latin **magnus** was *great*, and its comparative **maior** was *greater*. Spanish softened the *-ai-* into *-ayo-* and got **mayor**, then hung the abstract ending on it: **mayoría**, *the greater part*.
Notice that it is a comparison, not a count. A *mayoría* is not a number; it is whichever side is larger.
English holds the family in several shapes. A **major** is the greater sort. A **mayor** is the greater man of a town. **Majesty** is greatness worn in public. **Magnitude**, **magnify** and **maximum** come off *magnus* itself. And you have a cousin already. **El maestro** goes back to Latin **magister**, *the greater one* — the man who was more than the rest of the room, which is what a teacher was supposed to be.

What you've built

A word for the larger share of a set.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la mayoría*
- *la mayoría de la gente*
- *la mayoría de los libros*

Before you move on

What does Latin *maior* mean? (Greater.) And what was a *magister*, word for word? (The greater one in the room.)

352.4 el resto — what is left standing

Say *whole*, then *most of them*. (*Entero*; *la mayoría*.)

What to know first

- otro — the others this gathers up.
- estar — the verb standing inside it.

Sounds you'll need

- *RES-to*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* at the start of a word is rolled. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el resto — "the rest," "the remainder."
Latin **restāre** is **re-**, *back*, plus **stāre**, *to stand*. What **stands back** when the others have gone is what is left over.
That verb is becoming an old friend. It is inside **estar**, inside **la estación**, inside **el instante**. Here it is again, standing still while the count moves on without it.
English **rest**, in the sense of *the remainder*, is this word — and it has nothing to do with the other English *rest*, the one that means sleep, which is a Germanic word about a resting-place on a journey. Two words, same spelling, no relation.

To **arrest** somebody is to make them stand still. Something **restive** will not move. A **residue** is what stays behind.
It comes with *de* behind it: **el resto de la gente**, the rest of the people.

What you've built

The larger share, and everything that is not in it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el resto*
- *el resto de la gente*
- *el resto del día*

Before you move on

What does *restāre* mean, word for word? (To stand back.) And are the two English **rest**s related? (No — one is Latin standing, one is Germanic sleeping.)

352.5 escaso — scarce, because the good parts were picked out

Say *most of them*, then *the rest.* (*La mayoría*; *el resto.*)

What to know first

- poco — the plain word this sharpens.
- bastante — the opposite end of the scale.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-KA-so*, three beats with the weight on the second. Both *s* sounds are clear, never buzzed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

escaso — "scarce," "in short supply."
Poco says *there is little*. **Escaso** says *there is less than there ought to be* — the word carries a shortfall in it.
Behind it is a late Latin **excarpsus**, from **carpere**, *to pluck*, with **ex-**, *out*. What is *escaso* is what is left after the good parts have been plucked out of it. A picked-over heap.
Carpere is a fine root to own. An **excerpt** is a passage plucked out of a book. A **carpet** was plucked wool before it was a floor. And **carpe diem** is not *seize the day* so much as *pluck the day*, the way you pick fruit that will not keep.
English **scarce** is the same *excarpsus*, arriving through Old French **escars** — so *escaso* and *scarce* are one word, and the Spanish shape is the more conservative of the two.

What you've built

A whole set, its larger share, its remainder, and the word for when there is not enough of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *escaso*
- *el agua está escasa*
- *poco o escaso*

Before you move on

What does *carpere* mean? (To pluck.) And what is an **excerpt**, word for word? (A passage plucked out.)

Chapter 353

Five Buildings You May Have To Find

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el hospital, el banco, la farmacia, la biblioteca and el museo, and ask where any one of them is.
>
> *Complete ES-C353-museo: name five buildings a town has, and ask a stranger where one of them is.*

353.1 el hospital — the guest house that became a sick house

Say *what is left over*, then *scarce*. (*El resto*; *escaso*.)

What to know first

- la salud — what you go there to get back.
- el dolor — what takes you there.

Sounds you'll need

- *os-pi-TAL*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *h* says nothing at all. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el hospital — "the hospital."
Latin **hospes** is one of the strangest nouns Rome had. It meant *host* and it meant *guest*, in one word, because the obligation ran both ways: you fed the traveller today and he fed you next year. Neither of you was the important one.
A **hospitāle** was a house kept for such people. Monasteries ran them along the pilgrim roads, and the guests who stayed longest were the ones too ill to walk on. Over a few centuries the guest house quietly became a sick house, and the name stayed put.
English took the word three separate times, by three separate roads, and ended up with three buildings where Rome had one. Two of them are **hospital** and **hostel**; the third is waiting for you in the next chapter. Add **hospice** and **hospitality** and it has the set.
There is a darker cousin. Latin **hostis** started as the stranger too, but the stranger you did *not* take in — so English **hostile** and **hospitable** are two answers to the same knock at the door.

What you've built

The first of five buildings you can ask a stranger for by name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el hospital*
- *un hospital*
- *¿dónde está el hospital?*

Before you move on

What two people did *hospes* mean at the same time? (The host and the guest.) And which English word for a cheap place to sleep is the same Latin word? (Hostel.)

353.2 el banco — the bench the money sat on

Say *scarce*, then *the hospital*. (*Escaso*; *el hospital*.)

What to know first

- el dinero — what it holds for you.
- la moneda — the small hard piece of it.

Sounds you'll need

- *BAN-ko*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *b* is soft between vowels and firm at the start. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el banco — "the bank," and also "the bench."
Both meanings are alive in Spanish at once, and that is not an accident: they are the same object, four hundred years apart.
The word is Germanic — a **bank**, a bench — and Italian took it as *banco*. In the Italian trading cities a man who changed one city's coins for another's set up a plank on trestles in *la plaza* and worked at it in the open. People stopped saying "the man at the bench" and started saying "the bench."
When one of them could not pay, his creditors broke the plank. **Banca rotta**, a broken bench, is where English gets **bankrupt** — a word about furniture.
The bench is also the seat: Italian **banchetto**, a little bench, is English **banquet**, because you sat on a bench to eat. And plain English **bench** is the same Germanic word, arriving on its own.

What you've built

A word you now own twice over — the place that holds your money, and the seat in the square outside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el banco*
- *un banco*
- *el dinero está en el banco*

Before you move on

What was a *banco* before it was a bank? (A bench.) And what did the creditors do to it to make somebody bankrupt? (They broke it.)

353.3 la farmacia — the shop of the word that would not choose

Say *the hospital*, then *the bank*. (*El hospital*; *el banco*.)

What to know first

- el remedio — what you go in for.
- la fiebre — one reason to go.

Sounds you'll need

- *far-MA-sia*, with the weight on the second beat. The *c* before *i* is soft, and *ia* runs together as one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la farmacia — "the pharmacy," the chemist's shop.
Greek **phármakon** is a famous problem. It means a drug, and Greek used the one noun for the thing that heals and the thing that kills. Translators have argued about it for two thousand years, because a Greek sentence about a *pharmakon* often refuses to tell you which one is meant.
The Greeks were not being careless. The difference between a medicine and a poison is how much of it you take, and a word that covers both is honest about that.
Pharmakeía was the handling of such things, and it walked into Latin, into French, and into Spanish as **farmacia**. English kept the same undecided root in **pharmacy**, **pharmacist** and **pharmacology**. Spanish also kept a short technical twin, *el fármaco*, for the substance itself, so the shop and the drug in it are one word wearing two shapes.

What you've built

The place to go when the hospital is more than you need.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la farmacia*
- *una farmacia*
- *¿dónde está la farmacia?*

Before you move on

What two opposite things did *phármakon* mean? (A remedy and a poison.) And what decides which one you have? (How much of it you take.)

353.4 la biblioteca — the book-chest, and the port it is named after

Say *the bank*, then *the pharmacy*. (*El banco*; *la farmacia*.)

What to know first

- el libro — what fills it.
- leer — what you go there to do.

Sounds you'll need

- *bi-blio-TE-ka*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *b* is soft, and *io* runs together. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la biblioteca — "the library."
Two Greek words are bolted together here, and both are worth having. **Biblíon** is a book — a small **bíblos**, which was the papyrus you wrote on. And *biblos* is a place name. **Byblos** was the Phoenician port that shipped Egyptian papyrus to Greece, and the Greeks named the material after the harbour it came from, the way English named *china* after a country. So every book in the world is quietly named after a town in Lebanon.

Thḗkē is a chest, a case, a thing you put things in, from **tithénai**, to put. So a *bibliotheke* is a book-chest.
That second half went everywhere. An **apothḗkē** was a store-room, and it came down into Spanish twice as **la bodega** and **la botica**, into French as **boutique**, and into English as **apothecary**. A wine cellar, a chemist's, a shop and a druggist are one Greek chest.
English took the first half instead, in **Bible** and **bibliography**.

What you've built

The building where the books live, and a Greek word for a chest you will meet again in a wine cellar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la biblioteca*
- *el libro está en la biblioteca*
- *¿dónde está la biblioteca?*

Before you move on

Which port gave its name to every book? (Byblos.) And what does the *-teca* half mean on its own? (A chest, a place to put things.)

353.5 el museo — the house of the Muses, which was once a research institute

Say *the pharmacy*, then *the library*. (*La farmacia*; *la biblioteca*.)

What to know first

- ver — what you go there to do.
- viejo — what most of what is in it is.

Sounds you'll need

- *mu-SE-o*, three beats with the weight on the second. Each vowel keeps its own beat; nothing runs together. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el museo — "the museum."
A **mouseîon** is a seat of the **Moûsai**, the Muses — nine goddesses who between them owned poetry, song, dance, history and astronomy. To a Greek those were one field, and the Muse was who you asked for help before starting.
The most famous *mouseion* was at Alexandria, and it was nothing like a museum. It was a walled institution where scholars lived at royal expense, ate together, argued, and worked — with the great library attached to it. Eratosthenes measured the size of the earth there. It was a research institute, and the glass cases came much later.
Mousikḗ tékhnē is "the art of the Muses," and English shortened it to **music**. So a museum and a song are two rooms in the same house. And when an English poet begs the **Muse** for a first line, he is asking one of the nine for exactly what the Alexandrians asked for: something worth writing down.

What you've built

Five buildings, all of them askable for by name: *el hospital*, *el banco*, *la farmacia*, *la biblioteca*, *el museo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el museo*
- *el hospital, el banco, la farmacia, la biblioteca*
- *¿dónde está el museo?*

Before you move on

What was the Mouseion at Alexandria really for? (Scholars lived and worked there.) And which everyday English word comes off the same Muses? (Music.)

Chapter 354

Where The Town Goes When The Work Stops

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el hotel, el restaurante, el cine, el parque and el jardin, and say which one I am going to.
>
> *Complete ES-C354-jardin: name five places you go when the work is done, and say which one you are going to.*

354.1 el hotel — the same word as hospital, worn down in France

Say *the library*, then *the museum*. (*La biblioteca*; *el museo*.)

What to know first

- el hospital — the same Latin word, taken by a different road.
- la maleta — what you carry in.

Sounds you'll need

- *o-TEL*, two beats with the weight on the last. The *h* goes unsaid, the same way it did in *el hospital*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el hotel — "the hotel."
You already have this word. It is **hospitāle** again, the guest house from the last chapter, arriving by a longer and rougher road.
Old French said **hostel**. Then French did to that *s* what French does to almost every *s* before a consonant: it dropped it. What is left behind is the little hat — *hôtel* — which is a headstone marking the spot. The same hat stands over *forêt* for *forest*, *île* for *isle*, *pâte* for *paste*.
English borrowed the word twice, once before the *s* fell and once after, so English has both **hostel** and **hotel** and treats them as different things.
Spanish had no need of it — it already had *hospital*, and *la posada* and *el mesón* for an inn — so **hotel** came late, straight from French, with its foreign stress on the last beat still attached.

What you've built

A place to sleep, and a rule of thumb for reading French words with a hat on them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el hotel*
- *un hotel*
- *¿dónde está el hotel?*

Before you move on

Which letter does the French circumflex stand in for? (A lost *s*.)
And which Spanish word is *hotel* a cousin of? (*Hospital*.)

354.2 el restaurante — a soup that turned into a room

Say *the museum*, then *the hotel*. (*El museo*; *el hotel*.)

What to know first

- la comida — what it sells.
- el plato — what it arrives on.

Sounds you'll need

- *res-tau-RAN-te*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *au* is one glide, not two beats. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el restaurante — "the restaurant."
In Paris in the 1760s, a **restaurant** was something you drank. It was a strong meat broth, sold to people who felt weak — a *restorative*. The word is the French present participle of **restaurer**: a thing that restores.
Shops opened to sell it. They were called *restaurants* after the broth, the way a chocolate shop is named after chocolate. Then the shops started serving other food, and other food at small tables, and within thirty years the word had climbed off the soup and onto the room.
Latin **restaurāre** is *re-* plus **instaurāre**, to set up — so to restore is to set a thing up again. English took it whole as **restore** and Spanish as *restaurar*, and both still mean putting a thing back the way it was. Which is a fair description of what a good meal does.

What you've built

The place to eat when the food is not at home.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el restaurante*
- *un restaurante*
- *comer en el restaurante*

Before you move on

What was a *restaurant* before it was a room? (A restorative broth.) And what does *restaurar* mean? (To put a thing back as it was.)

354.3 el cine — a movement-writer, cut down to one syllable

Say *the hotel*, then *the restaurant*. (*El hotel*; *el restaurante*.)

What to know first

- ver — what you do there.
- la luz — what they turn off first.

Sounds you'll need

- *SI-ne*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *e* is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cine — "the cinema," and the art as well as the building.
The Lumière brothers needed a name for their machine and did what the nineteenth century always did: they went to Greek. **Kínēma** is a movement, from **kineîn**, to move. **Gráphein** is to write or scratch. Bolt them together and you have a *cinématographe*, a movement-writer.
Nobody was going to say that twice. Spanish sheared off everything after the first two beats and kept **el cine**. English kept a different piece and got **cinema**. German kept a third and got *Kino*. Three languages, one word, cut in three places.
Kineîn survives uncut in English **kinetic**, and in *kinesiology* and *telekinesis*.
And **gráphein** you have met already, in the *-graphy* of bibliography — the book-writing that lives next door to *la biblioteca*.

What you've built

A word that is a stump of a much longer one, and the Greek verb for moving.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cine*
- *un cine*
- *vamos al cine*

Before you move on

What does *kínēma* mean? (Movement.) And what was the full word Spanish cut *cine* out of? (*Cinematógrafo.*)

354.4 el parque — the fence, not the grass

Say *the restaurant*, then *the cinema*. (*El restaurante*; *el cine.*)

What to know first

- el árbol — what stands in it.
- el banco — the word you now own twice.

Sounds you'll need

- *PAR-ke*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *qu* is a plain hard *k*; the *u* is silent. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el parque — "the park."
The oldest meaning of this word is a fence.
Frankish **parrik** was an enclosure, and Medieval Latin wrote it **parricus**. A *park* was a piece of ground a lord had fenced so that the deer inside it stayed inside it and the villagers outside it stayed

outside. Nothing in the word is about grass, or trees, or benches. It is about the boundary.
English has the same word twice: **park**, and the dialect **paddock**, which is *parrock* with the *r* and the *d* swapped around the way spoken words do.
What changed is who the fence is for. A royal park kept people out. A city park, which is a nineteenth-century idea, keeps a piece of green from being built on — the fence now protects the grass from the town rather than the deer from the villagers.
And when the motor car arrived, Spanish put it in the enclosure too, and got *aparcar*.

What you've built

A green square with a fence in its history, and the seat you already know how to name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el parque*
- *un parque*
- *el banco está en el parque*

Before you move on

What was a park before it was grass? (A fenced enclosure.) And what was kept inside the fence? (Deer.)

354.5 el jardín — the second fence in a row

Say *the cinema*, then *the park*. (*El cine*; *el parque*.)

What to know first

- la flor — what grows in it.
- el parque — the other enclosure.

Sounds you'll need

- *jar-DIN*, two beats with the weight on the last, which is why it carries a written accent. The *j* is the rough Spanish sound at the back. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el jardín — "the garden."
Two fences in a row. *El parque* came from a Frankish enclosure, and so does this one: **gardo**, a Germanic word for a fenced piece of ground, which French took as *jardin* and Spanish took from French.
English has the same word without the French detour. A **yard** is *gardo* arriving on its own, straight down the Germanic road. Then English borrowed the French shape back on top, and now it has **yard** and **garden** side by side and treats them as different sizes of the same thing.
The enclosure shows up in places English does not think of as words about fences:

- **kindergarten**, a children's enclosure, named by the German who invented it because he thought children should be grown rather than taught;
- **Stuttgart**, a stud-farm enclosure;
- **Asgard**, the enclosure of the Norse gods;
- and the *-chard* of **orchard**, which is a wort-yard, a herb enclosure.

So a garden, a farmyard and the home of Odin are one Germanic fence.

What you've built

Five places to go when the work is done: *el hotel*, *el restaurante*, *el cine*, *el parque*, *el jardín*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el jardín*

- *el hotel, el restaurante, el cine, el parque*
- *¿dónde está el jardín?*

Before you move on

Which plain English word is the same Germanic word as *jardín*? (Yard.) And what is a kindergarten, word for word? (A children's garden.)

Chapter 355

Inside The Building, Not Outside It

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la pared, el techo, el piso, el rincon and el fondo, and place a thing inside a room instead of inside a town.
>
> *Complete ES-C355-fondo: name the wall, the ceiling and the floor of a room, and put a thing in its corner or at its back.*

355.1 la pared — the indoor wall, which Latin counted separately

Say *the park*, then *the garden*. (*El parque*; *el jardín*.)

What to know first

- la casa — what it divides up.
- el cuarto — what it makes.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-RED*, two beats with the weight on the last. The final *d* is soft, nearly a breath. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la pared — "the wall," the one inside a building.
Latin counted two kinds of wall and gave them unrelated names, and Spanish kept the pair.
Pariēs was a house wall — the thing that divides one room from the next, or holds a roof up. **Mūrus** was the wall around a town, the defensive one. A Roman would not have used one for the other.
Spanish still has both. **La pared** is the indoor wall you hang things on; *el muro* and *la muralla* are the ones around a city, and English borrowed the second family for **mural**, the painting made on a big wall.
Pariēs had less luck in English, which kept it in one place only, and a strange one: the **parietal** bone is the one that walls the side of your skull. An anatomist's Latin, and the last survivor.

What you've built

The first surface of a room, and a Latin distinction between indoors and out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la pared*
- *una pared*
- *la pared de la casa*

Before you move on

Which Latin wall was the one around a town? (*Mūrus.*) And which one is *la pared*? (The wall inside a house.)

355.2 el techo — the covered part, and everything else that covers

Say *the garden*, then *the wall.* (*El jardín*; *la pared.*)

What to know first

- la casa — what it covers.
- la nieve — what it keeps off you.

Sounds you'll need

- *TE-cho*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ch* is one sound, as in English *cheese*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el techo — "the roof," and inside a room, "the ceiling."
Latin **tegere** is to cover, and **tēctum** is what has been covered — the covered part of a building. Spanish softened the middle of it into a *ch* and got *techo*.
The covering verb is one of the most productive Rome had, and English is full of it without noticing:

- to **protect** is to cover in front of a thing;
- to **detect** is to take the cover off it;
- an **integument** is the covering of a body;
- a Roman **toga** was the thing he covered himself with;
- and a roof **tile** is a **tēgula**, a little coverer.

English has the root a second time, older and rougher. **Thatch** is the same ancient word arriving down the Germanic road instead of the Latin one, where the *t* stayed put and the *g* wore into a *ch* — which is what a straw roof is: a covering.

What you've built

The second surface of a room, and the verb behind half the covering words in English.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el techo*
- *el techo de la casa*
- *la pared y el techo*

Before you move on

What does *tegere* mean? (To cover.) And what does the *de-* do in *detect*? (Takes the cover off.)

355.3 el piso — the floor is named for the treading

Say *the wall*, then *the ceiling*. (*La pared*; *el techo*.)

What to know first

- el pie — what walks on it.
- la escoba — what sweeps it.

Sounds you'll need

- *PI-so*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *s* is clear, never buzzed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el piso — "the floor," and in Spain, "the flat."
The floor is named after what you do to it. *Pisar* is to tread, and it comes from Late Latin **pīnsāre**, to pound or crush — the verb for a mortar and pestle, not for a gentle step. The **piso** is the pounded part. The pounding turns up in English twice, and both times in machinery:

- a **pestle** is the thing that pounds in a mortar, from **pistillum**, the little pounder;
- a **piston** is a pounder in a cylinder, borrowed through Italian.

The word then did something practical. One trodden level of a building is *un piso*, a storey — and in Spain a storey you can buy and

live in is *un piso*, a flat. Much of Latin America says *el departamento* instead, and keeps *piso* for the floor under your feet.
So the same three letters name the surface, the level and the home.

What you've built

The third surface of a room, and one word doing the work of floor, storey and flat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el piso*
- *el piso de la casa*
- *el techo y el piso*

Before you move on

What does *pisar* mean? (To tread.) And what does a pestle do? (It pounds.)

355.4 el rincón — the corner Arabic gave Spanish

Say *the ceiling*, then *the floor*. (*El techo*; *el piso*.)

What to know first

- la esquina — the corner out on the street.
- ojalá — another word Arabic gave Spanish.

Sounds you'll need

- *rin-KON*, two beats with the weight on the last, which is why it carries a written accent. The opening *r* is rolled. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el rincón — "the corner," the one inside a room.
Spanish keeps two corners apart, and it gets them from two different languages.
La esquina, which you have, is the corner you turn on a street — the outside angle of a building. It is Latin.
El rincón is the inside angle, where two *paredes* meet and a chair goes. And it is Arabic: **rukn**, a corner, and also a supporting pillar. The corner of the Kaaba where the black stone sits is *al-rukn*.
Eight centuries of al-Andalus left Spanish somewhere near four thousand Arabic words, and they are not exotic ones. You already own two: **ojalá**, which is *wa-shā' allāh*, "and may God will it," and **hasta**, which is *hattā*. Add *el café*, from *qahwa*, and *el jabón* is in the same neighbourhood.
What is unusual about *rincón* is that it displaced nothing and named something Latin had no separate word for. Arabic did not lend Spanish a synonym here. It lent it a distinction.

What you've built

The corner indoors, and a reminder that a good part of Spanish did not come from Latin at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el rincón*
- *un rincón*
- *la silla está en el rincón*

Before you move on

Which of the two corners is the Arabic one? (*El rincón*, the one indoors.) And which Spanish word for hoping is also Arabic? (*Ojalá*.)

355.5 el fondo — the bottom, and its Spanish twin

Say *the floor*, then *the corner*. (*El piso*; *el rincón*.)

What to know first

- dentro — where it is.
- f → h — the change that gave it a twin.

Sounds you'll need

- *FON-do*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *d* after *n* is firm, not the soft one between vowels. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el fondo — "the bottom," and in a room, "the back."
Latin **fundus** is the bottom of a thing — of a jar, of a valley — and by extension the piece of ground a farm sits on. English keeps the bottom everywhere:

- to **found** a building is to put its bottom in place, and that bottom is its **foundation**;
- a **fund** is money held at the bottom of things, in reserve;
- a ship that **founders** goes to the bottom;
- and something **profound** is *pro fundō*, toward the bottom.

Now the Spanish part. **Fondo** is a borrowed word — it came in from books, with its *f* intact. But Latin *fundus* also came down the long road, through mouths, and words that did that turned their Latin *f* into a Spanish *h*: *facere* to *hacer*, *fabulari* to *hablar*, *ferrum* to *hierro*. Do it to *fundus* and you get **hondo**, deep. So *fondo* and *hondo* are one Latin word that arrived twice, and the *h* is the receipt for the longer journey.

What you've built

A room named all the way round: *la pared*, *el techo*, *el piso*, *el rincón*, *el fondo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el fondo*
- *al fondo*
- *la pared del fondo*

Before you move on

What does *fundus* mean? (The bottom.) And which Spanish word for *deep* is the same word, arrived the long way? (*Hondo*.)

Chapter 356

From When, For How Long, And All At Once

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say desde, la cita, la etapa, la ocasion and de repente, and mark when something starts, how long it runs and how fast it arrives.
>
> *Complete ES-C356-repente: say when a thing starts, name the time you agreed on, and say that something arrived without warning.*

356.1 desde — three prepositions stacked into one

Say *the corner*, then *the back*. (*El rincón*; *el fondo*.)

What to know first

- hasta — the word it pairs with.
- después — built out of the same parts.

Sounds you'll need

- *DES-de*, two beats with the weight on the first. The final *d* is soft, nearly a breath. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

desde — "from," "since."
Latin's small words wore out. **Dē** on its own had been carrying too much for too long, and by the time Spanish was forming it could no longer be heard to mean any one thing. So speakers propped it up with another, and then with a third.
Desde is *dē* + *ex* + *dē*. Three prepositions, all doing the same job, fused into one word of two beats.
You have already met the trick without being told: **después** is *dē* + *ex* + *post*. Same first two pieces, different third.
English does exactly this and nobody blinks: *from out of the house*, *out from behind the door*. Three little words where one used to do.
Desde marks the point a thing starts from, in time or in space, and it wants **hasta** on the other end. *Desde* the beginning *hasta* the end.

What you've built

The word that opens a stretch of time, and the pair that closes it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *desde*
- *desde hoy*
- *desde las tres hasta las cinco*

Before you move on

How many Latin prepositions are inside *desde*? (Three.) And which word does it want at the other end of a stretch? (*Hasta*.)

356.2 la cita — the hour you were summoned to

Say *the back of the room*, then *from*. (*El fondo*; *desde*.)

What to know first

- la agenda — where you write it down.
- la hora — what it needs to exist.

Sounds you'll need

- *SI-ta*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *i* is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cita — "the appointment," and also "the quotation."
Latin **ciēre** is to set in motion. Its frequentative, **citāre**, is to keep setting in motion — which in practice meant to summon: to call a person and require them to appear.
English took the calling and kept four shades of it:

- to **cite** a source is to summon it to appear in your argument;
- to **recite** is to summon it again, out loud;
- to **incite** a crowd is to set it moving;
- to **excite** is to call the movement out of somebody.

Spanish took the appearing. **Una cita** is a time somebody has been called to — with a doctor, with a lawyer, or with a person you would like to see again. The second meaning, the quotation, is the English *cite* in noun form, so both halves of the Latin verb are alive in the same Spanish word.
What makes it useful is that it is the only ordinary word for a fixed appointment. *La hora* gives you the number. *La cita* gives you the promise.

What you've built

A time that two people have agreed to, rather than one the clock happens to show.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cita*
- *tengo una cita*
- *una cita a las cinco*

Before you move on

What did *citāre* mean in Latin? (To summon.) And what is the other thing *una cita* can be? (A quotation.)

356.3 la etapa — a storehouse that turned into a distance

Say *from*, then *the appointment*. (*Desde*; *la cita*.)

What to know first

- el viaje — what it is a piece of.
- la jornada — one day of one.

Sounds you'll need

- *e-TA-pa*, three beats with the weight on the second. Every vowel is short and clean. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la etapa — "a stage," "a leg" of a journey or of anything else.
The word did not start as a distance. It started as a building. Middle Dutch **stapel** was a heap — a market pile, a stack of goods for sale. French borrowed it as *estaple* for a depot: the storehouse where a marching army halted and drew its bread. Because the army stopped there, the word came to mean the *march between two of them*, and once it meant that it could mean any stretch of anything: a stage of a race, a stage of a plan, a stage of a life.
English borrowed the same Dutch pile and kept it a pile. A **staple** is a main commodity, and a *staple town* held the legal right to be the place where a commodity was heaped and sold.
And French did the usual thing to the *s* in *estaple*. It dropped it and

put a mark over the vowel: **étape**. The accent is the same headstone as the little hat in *hôtel* — Spanish borrowed the word after the *s* had already gone.

What you've built

A way to cut a long thing into pieces without naming a clock.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la etapa*
- *la primera etapa*
- *una etapa del viaje*

Before you move on

What was an *étape* before it was a distance? (A storehouse, a heap.) And which English word is the same Dutch pile? (Staple.)

356.4 la ocasión — chance, imagined as falling

Say *the appointment*, then *the stage*. (*La cita*; *la etapa*.)

What to know first

- la suerte — its neighbour, and a different picture.
- la vez — the plainer word for one time.

Sounds you'll need

- *o-ka-SION*, three beats with the weight on the last, which is why it carries a written accent. The *c* before *a* is hard. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la ocasión — "the occasion," "the chance."
Latin thought about luck as a falling. **Cadere** is to fall, and an **occāsiō** is a falling-down: *ob-*, down, plus *cadere*. What happens to you is what drops in front of you.
Once the falling is pointed out to you, it turns up everywhere:

- an **accident** is what falls toward you — *ad* + *cadere*;
- a **case** is how a thing fell out;
- **chance** is Vulgar Latin **cadentia**, the falling, worn down through French;
- a **cascade** falls down a hillside;
- a **cadence** is where a line of music falls at the end;
- and something **decays** by falling away.

Even the compass is in it: the **occident** is the west, because that is where the sun falls. Spanish keeps that one whole in *el occidente*, sitting beside *el oeste*, which is a Germanic word that came in through French.
La ocasión is a moment that fell your way. *La suerte* is luck as a drawn lot, and *la vez* is a plain turn — three pictures for three different things.

What you've built

A chance, and a Latin verb that turns out to be underneath half the English words for luck.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la ocasión*
- *en esta ocasión*
- *una buena ocasión*

Before you move on

What does *cadere* mean? (To fall.) And why is the west the *occident*? (It is where the sun falls.)

356.5 de repente — what is sudden is what crept

Say *the stage*, then *the occasion*. (*La etapa*; *la ocasión*.)

What to know first

- la demora — the opposite kind of arrival.
- el instante — how long it takes.

Sounds you'll need

- *de re-PEN-te*, with the weight on *PEN*. Both *r* sounds are single taps, not rolled. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de repente — "suddenly," "all at once."
Latin **repēns** means sudden, and it is the present participle of **repere**, to creep. Read that twice, because it is a whole idea about surprise: the thing that startles you is the thing that came *creeping*. It was on its way the whole time. You did not hear it.
Repente is that participle in the ablative — "creepingly" — and Spanish locked it into the phrase *de repente*.
English has *repere* in one common word and it is the right one: a **reptile** is a creeper, an animal named for how it moves rather than what it is.
So Spanish has three speeds now:

- *la demora*, the thing that is late;
- *el instante*, the smallest piece of time there is;
- and *de repente*, the thing that arrives without warning after creeping up on you.

What you've built

Five ways to place a thing in time: *desde*, *la cita*, *la etapa*, *la ocasión*, *de repente*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *de repente*
- *desde ayer*
- *una cita, una etapa, una ocasión*

Before you move on

What does *repere* mean? (To creep.) And which animal is named for it? (The reptile.)

Chapter 357

The Days A Calendar Circles

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la Navidad, la Pascua, la vispera, el regalo and la tarjeta, and name the two days a Spanish calendar circles first.
>
> *Complete ES-C357-tarjeta: name a feast, name the day before it, and name the two things that arrive with it.*

357.1 la Navidad — the birth, and the nothing that shares its root

Say *the occasion*, then *suddenly.* (*La ocasión*; *de repente.*)

What to know first

- nada — the same Latin verb, and the opposite meaning.
- nadie — and the same verb again.

Sounds you'll need

- *na-vi-DAD*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *v* sounds like a soft *b*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la Navidad — "Christmas."
Latin **nāscī** is to be born. **Nātīvitātem** is a birth. And **la Navidad** is *the* birth, with no need to say whose — the way *la Guerra* in a Spanish sentence about 1936 needs no adjective.
English kept the Latin whole in **nativity**, and the root in **native** (born here), **nation** (people of one birth), **nature** (what a thing is born as), and **innate**.
Now the part worth stopping for. Two of the commonest words you own are the same verb, and they mean the opposite:

- **nada** is Latin *(rēs) nāta*, "a thing born." Latin said *nōn... rem nātam*, "not a born thing," and Spanish threw away the *non* and kept the *nata*, so the word for *nothing* is literally *a born thing*;
- **nadie** is *(hominēs) nātī*, "born people," and did the same disappearing act with its negative.

So *nada*, *nadie* and *la Navidad* are one Latin verb. Three births, and two of them ended up meaning nobody and nothing.

What you've built

The first of the two days a Spanish calendar circles, and a root you have been using without knowing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la Navidad*
- *en Navidad*
- *feliz Navidad*

Before you move on

What does *nāscī* mean? (To be born.) And what does *nada* mean word for word? (A thing born.)

357.2 la Pascua — a Hebrew word that crossed three languages

Say *suddenly*, then *Christmas*. (*De repente*; *la Navidad*.)

What to know first

- la fiesta — what it is.
- la Navidad — the other one.

Sounds you'll need

- *PAS-kua*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *cu* is a hard *k* with a *w* glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la Pascua — "Easter."
This word has crossed more borders than most. Hebrew **pesach** is the Passover. Greek wrote it **páskha**, Latin **pascha**, and from Latin it went into every Romance language: Spanish **Pascua**, Italian *Pasqua*, French *Pâques*, Portuguese *Páscoa*.
English is the odd one out, and this is the interesting part. For the feast itself English kept a Germanic name — **Easter**, which Bede says came from a spring goddess — but it kept the Latin word for the adjective. So English has the **paschal** lamb and the **paschal** moon, and it has Easter eggs, and the two words never meet.
The *u* in **Pascua** is a passenger. Latin also had **pascua**, "pastures," and the two words sat close enough for centuries that the pasture lent its shape to the feast — helped along by the paschal lamb, which grazes.
Spanish also uses *Pascua* in the plural for the Christmas season, so *felices Pascuas* can mean the wrong feast to an English ear.

What you've built

Both of the days a Spanish year turns on, and one Hebrew word underneath one of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la Pascua*
- *en Pascua*
- *la Navidad y la Pascua*

Before you move on

Which Hebrew festival is *Pascua* named after? (The Passover, *pesach*.) And which English adjective kept the Latin word? (Paschal.)

357.3 la víspera — the evening that leans on the next day

Say *Christmas*, then *Easter*. (*La Navidad*; *la Pascua*.)

What to know first

- el oeste — the direction the evening is in.
- antes — what it means, reduced to one word.

Sounds you'll need

- *VIS-pe-ra*, three beats with the weight on the FIRST, which is unusual enough that it carries a written accent. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la víspera — "the eve," the day before.
Latin **vespera** is the evening. Spanish narrowed it to a particular evening: not any evening, but the one that leans on a bigger day. *La víspera de Navidad* is Christmas Eve. *La víspera del viaje* is the night before you leave.
English has the word in one place, and it is a quiet one. **Vespers** are the evening prayers, sung as the light goes.

Greek had the same ancient word with the *v* worn off the front: **hésperos**, the evening star, which is Venus seen after sunset. The **Hesperides**, whose garden held the golden apples, are the daughters of evening, and their garden was at the far western edge of the world — because that is where the evening is.
Which is the last piece. English **west** is a cousin of *vespera* and *hesperos*, all three from an ancient root for *down* or *late*. So *el oeste* and *la víspera* point at the same thing from two sides: the place the sun goes down, and the hours after it does.

What you've built

A way to name the day before a day, without counting backwards.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la víspera*
- *la víspera de Navidad*
- *la víspera de la fiesta*

Before you move on

What does *vespera* mean? (Evening.) And which English direction is a cousin of it? (West.)

357.4 el regalo — merry-making that turned into an object

Say *Easter*, then *the eve*. (*La Pascua*; *la víspera*.)

What to know first

- la fiesta — when it arrives.
- el placer — what it is for.

Sounds you'll need

- *rre-GA-lo*, three beats with the weight on the second. The opening *r* is rolled. The *g* before *a* is hard. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el regalo — "the present," "the gift."
Spanish borrowed the verb **regalar** from French *régaler*, to entertain somebody handsomely — to treat them. Under it is an Old French noun, **gale**, meaning merry-making or pleasure.
English took the same French verb and kept the entertaining: to **regale** a guest is to give them a fine story or a fine dinner. And *gale* on its own gave English **gala**, a day of merry-making.
Then Spanish did something the other languages did not. It let the word slide from the entertaining to the *object handed over*. In French you *régale* someone; in Spanish you *regalas* them a thing, and the thing itself is **un regalo**.
One warning, because the shape invites it. **Regalo** looks like *real* and *regio*, which come from Latin **rēx**, a king, and give English **regal** and **royal**. There is no connection. A *regalo* is about a good time, not about a crown.

What you've built

The thing that arrives on a feast day, and a false lead refused.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el regalo*
- *un regalo*
- *un regalo de Navidad*

Before you move on

What did Old French *gale* mean? (Merry-making.) And is *regalo* related to *real*, a king? (No — it only looks like it.)

357.5 la tarjeta — a small shield you write on

Say *the eve*, then *the present*. (*La víspera*; *el regalo*.)

What to know first

- la carta — its longer cousin.
- el regalo — what it travels with.

Sounds you'll need

- *tar-JE-ta*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *j* is the rough sound at the back of the mouth. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la tarjeta — "the card."
A *tarjeta* is a little **tarja**, and a *tarja* was a shield. Spanish took it from French **targe**, and French from a Frankish **targa** — a small round shield carried on the arm.
English took the same shield and made it small in its own way. **Target** is *targe* plus a diminutive ending, and for several hundred years it meant exactly that: a light shield. Only later did somebody set one up in a field to shoot at, and the name went with the thing being aimed at rather than the thing doing the protecting.
What carried the Spanish word from armour to stationery is the shape. A shield is a small stiff rectangle, or something near it, held up for other people to read: a coat of arms is a shield that tells you who is behind it.
A **tarjeta** does the same job with ink. *Una tarjeta de visita* announces who has arrived, and *una tarjeta de Navidad* says who remembered you.

What you've built

Five things a calendar day brings with it: *la Navidad*, *la Pascua*, *la víspera*, *el regalo*, *la tarjeta*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la tarjeta*
- *una tarjeta y un regalo*
- *la Navidad, la Pascua, la víspera*

Before you move on

What was a *targe*? (A small shield.) And what did **target** mean before anybody shot at one? (A shield.)

Chapter 358

Which One: By Colour, Size And Shape

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say el color, el tamano, la forma, la clase and la marca, and single out one thing from several without pointing at it.

Complete ES-C358-marca: single out one thing among several by its colour, its size, its shape, its kind and its maker.

358.1 el color — a covering, and the hiding under it

Say *the present*, then *the card*. (*El regalo*; *la tarjeta*.)

What to know first

- rojo — one answer to it.
- verde — another.

Sounds you'll need

- *ko-LOR*, two beats with the weight on the last. The *l* is clear and forward, never swallowed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el color — "the colour."
Latin **cēlāre** is to hide, and **color** is built on it. A colour is the coat over a surface — the thing that stops you seeing what the surface is actually made of. To a Roman, painting something was covering it up. The hiding is scattered through English:

- to **conceal** is to hide, with the Latin verb almost intact;
- an **occult** thing is a covered one;
- a **cell** and a **cellar** are places to hide things, from *cella*, a store room;
- a **helmet** hides a head, and **hull** is what covers a seed.

And then the good one. English **hell** is the same ancient root, arriving down the Germanic road rather than the Latin one — the *covered* place, the hidden place, before any theology was attached to it. Latin *c* comes out as Germanic *h*, which is the swap you already met standing between *cien* and **hundred**.
Once you have *el color*, you can pick one thing out of five without pointing at it.

What you've built

The first of five ways to single out one thing among several.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el color*
- *¿de qué color?*
- *el color rojo*

Before you move on

What does *cēlāre* mean? (To hide.) And what Latin sound turns into an English *h*? (A *c*, as in *cien* and hundred.)

358.2 el tamaño — *so big*, welded into a noun

Say *the card*, then *the colour*. (*La tarjeta*; *el color*.)

What to know first

- grande — one answer to it.
- también — where its first half is hiding.

Sounds you'll need

- *ta-MA-ño*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *ñ* is the *n*-with-a-*y* sound. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tamaño — "the size."
Two Latin words, hammered flat. **Tam magnum** is "so big," and Spanish welded it into one word.
It was an adjective first. *Un tamaño error* meant "an error that big," and you can still meet it in older writing. Then people kept asking *¿de qué tamaño?* — "of what so-big?" — and the answer hardened into a noun. Spanish now uses it for size the way English uses a word borrowed from French.
Both halves are worth having on their own.
Tam is the *tan* you already own. **También** is *tan bien*, "so well," which slid into "also." **Tampoco** is *tan poco*, "so little," which slid into "neither." The same little word, three times.
Magnus, great, is the *magn-* in English **magnify**, **magnitude**, **magnificent** and **magnate**, the *ma-* in **major** and **maximum**, and the *mas-* in **master**, who is the greater one. Spanish has it in *magno* — as in Alejandro Magno.

What you've built

The second way to single a thing out, and a Latin pair you have been using in two other words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tamaño*
- *¿de qué tamaño?*
- *un tamaño grande*

Before you move on

What two Latin words are inside *tamaño*? (*Tam* and *magnum* — so big.) And which word you know already carries the same *tam*? (*También.*)

358.3 la forma — one Latin word that arrived twice

Say *the colour*, then *the size*. (*El color*; *el tamaño.*)

What to know first

- la cosa — what has one.
- f → h — the change that gave it a twin.

Sounds you'll need

- *FOR-ma*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la forma — "the shape," "the form."
This word came into Spanish twice, and the two arrivals do not look alike.
The short road is the one you can see. **Forma** was borrowed out of Latin books with nothing changed at all, and it means shape. English borrowed it the same way and built a shelf from it: **form**, **formal**, **format**, **formula**, **uniform**, **transform**, **reform**, **conform**.
The long road is the good one. Latin **formōsus** meant "well shaped." It came down through mouths rather than books, and words that did that turned their Latin *f* into a Spanish *h* — *facere* to *hacer*, *fabulari* to *hablar*. Do it to *formōsus* and you get **hermoso**, which no longer

means shapely. It means beautiful.
So *la forma* and *hermoso* are the same Latin word, and the difference between them is eight hundred years of being said out loud.

What you've built

The third way to single a thing out, and a doublet with the same root at both ends.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la forma*
- *la forma de la mesa*
- *el color y la forma*

Before you move on

What does *formōsus* mean in Latin? (Well shaped.) And what does its Spanish descendant *hermoso* mean now? (Beautiful.)

358.4 la clase — six bands of Romans, sorted by money

Say *the size*, then *the shape*. (*El tamaño*; *la forma*.)

What to know first

- el tipo — the word standing beside it.
- cl-, pl-, fl- → ll- — the change this word escaped.

Sounds you'll need

- *KLA-se*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *cl* stays a hard *k* plus *l*, both sounded. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la clase — "the class," "the kind," and also "the lesson."
Rome counted its citizens every five years and sorted them into **classēs** by what they owned. There were six, and where you stood decided what armour you brought to war and how much your vote weighed.
A writer good enough to belong at the top was **classicus** — first class. That is where English **classic** comes from, and it is worth knowing that the word never meant *old*. It meant *top band*. A classic film made last year is being called first-rate, not ancient.
Spanish uses **la clase** for three things at once: the social band, the kind of thing, and the room where a lesson happens.
One sound to notice. A word that came down through mouths and started *cl-* usually comes out of Spanish as *ll-*: Latin *clamāre* gave *llamar*, *plēnus* gave *lleno*, *flamma* gave *llama*. **Clase** kept its *cl-* untouched, and that is the fingerprint of a word that came in from books instead.

What you've built

The fourth way to single a thing out, and the difference between a word that was said and one that was read.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la clase*
- *¿qué clase de queso?*
- *una clase de cosa*

Before you move on

What did *classicus* mean? (Of the top band, first class.) And what usually happens to an inherited Spanish word that starts *cl-*? (It comes out as *ll-*.)

358.5 la marca — a boundary before it was a sign

Say *the shape*, then *the kind*. (*La forma*; *la clase*.)

What to know first

- el nombre — what it sits next to.
- la huella — a mark of a different kind.

Sounds you'll need

- *MAR-ka*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* before the *c* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la marca — "the mark," and then "the brand."
The Germanic **marka** was a boundary first. Not a sign — an edge, the line where one people's land stopped and another's began. The sign came second: the stone, the cut in a tree, the thing you put there so the edge could be seen.
From the boundary meaning:

- a **march** is a border land, which is why the country between England and Wales is the Welsh **Marches**;
- the lord who held one was a **marquis**, ranked above a count because a border is harder to hold than a middle;
- and **Denmark** is the mark of the Danes.

From the sign meaning: English **mark**, to **remark** (to mark a thing again, out loud), and to **demarcate**. Latin had a cousin, **margō**, an edge, which gives **margin** — the boundary of a page.
Spanish **la marca** kept both. It is the mark on a thing, and then the maker who put it there: the brand. So asking *¿de qué marca?* is asking whose sign is on it.

What you've built

Five ways to single a thing out without pointing: *el color*, *el tamaño*, *la forma*, *la clase*, *la marca*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la marca*
- *¿de qué marca?*
- *el color, el tamaño, la forma y la clase*

Before you move on

What was a *marka* before it was a sign? (A boundary.) And why does a marquis outrank a count? (He held a border.)

Chapter 359

What It Weighs, And How Much There Is

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el metro, el gramo, el kilo, el litro and el peso, and put a number on a length, a weight and a volume.
>
> *Complete ES-C359-peso: put a number and a unit on a length, on a volume and on a weight, and ask a shopkeeper for that much.*

359.1 el metro — one Spanish word, two Greek ancestors

Say *the kind*, then *the brand*. (*La clase*; *la marca*.)

What to know first

- el número — what comes in front of it.
- la ciudad — what the other *metro* runs under.

Sounds you'll need

- *ME-tro*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *tr* is one cluster, with a tapped *r*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el metro — "the metre," and also "the underground."
Those are two different words that happen to have arrived at the same shape, and keeping them apart is the point of this lesson.
The first is Greek **métron**, a measure. It is everywhere:

- a **diameter** is a measure across;
- **geometry** is earth-measuring, which is what it was for — resurveying Egypt after the Nile flooded;
- **symmetry** is measuring together;
- and every **-meter** on an instrument is a measurer.

When the French Revolution wanted a unit that belonged to nobody, it went to Greek and called it a *mètre*.
The second **metro** is a train, and it has nothing to do with measuring. It is short for *ferrocarril metropolitano*, and **metropolis** is **mētēr**, a mother, plus **pólis**, a city: the mother city, the one that sent out colonies.
So one Spanish word, two Greek ancestors, no relation between them.

What you've built

The unit of length, and a warning that a short word can have two histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el metro*
- *un metro*
- *tres metros*

Before you move on

What does *métron* mean? (A measure.) And what is the *metro* you ride short for? (*Metropolitano* — the mother city.)

359.2 el gramo — the same word as grammar

Say *the brand*, then *the metre*. (*La marca*; *el metro*.)

What to know first

- la palabra — written, like its cousin.
- el cine — where you met *graphein* before.

Sounds you'll need

- *GRA-mo*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *g* before *a* is hard, and *gr* is one cluster. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el gramo — "the gram."
Greek **grámma** is what has been written — a letter, a mark, a scratch — from **gráphein**, to scratch or write. You met *gráphein* in *el cine*, inside the *cinematógrafo*.
It also named a very small unit of weight, because a small weight is a scratch on a balance beam. That is the one the metric system picked up.
Which means **el gramo** and **la gramática** are the same Greek word. Grammar is the art of letters; a gram is a written mark on a scale. Nothing else connects them.
The same *gramma* is all over Spanish and English:

- **el programa** — written in advance;
- **el diagrama** — written across;
- **el telegrama** — written far;
- **anagram** — written back;
- **epigram** — written on.

And a Spanish note worth keeping: *el programa*, *el diagrama* and *el telegrama* all end in *-a* and are all masculine, because Greek neuters in *-ma* came into Spanish that way.

What you've built

The unit of weight, and a Greek word that turns out to be underneath grammar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el gramo*
- *cien gramos*
- *un gramo y un metro*

Before you move on

What does *grámma* mean? (Something written.) And which everyday word for the rules of a language is the same root? (Grammar.)

359.3 el kilo — the Greek thousand, not the Latin one

Say *the metre*, then *the gram*. (*El metro*; *el gramo*.)

What to know first

- mil gracias — the other thousand.
- el gramo — what it counts a thousand of.

Sounds you'll need

- *KI-lo*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *k* is hard; this is one of the few Spanish words that keeps a *k* at all. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el kilo — "the kilo."
The men who built the metric system made one tidy decision: the

prefixes that make a unit **bigger** come from Greek, and the ones that make it **smaller** come from Latin.
So *kilo-*, *hecto-* and *deca-* are Greek, and *deci-*, *centi-* and *mili-* are Latin. You can read a metric word and know which way it is going before you know what it means.
Kilo- is Greek **khīlioi**, a thousand. A *kilogramo* is a thousand *gramos*; a *kilómetro* is a thousand *metros*. Spanish clips both in ordinary speech and says *un kilo*, *diez kilos*.
And here is what it is **not**. Latin's thousand is **mille**, and you already have it: it is the *mil* in *mil gracias*. English keeps *mille* in **mile**, which is *mille passūs*, a thousand paces, and in **million**, a big thousand.
Two languages, two thousands, and no relation between them at all — which is why *kilo* and *mil* look nothing alike.

What you've built

The unit you buy food in, and a rule of thumb for reading every other metric word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el kilo*
- *un kilo de arroz*
- *dos kilos*

Before you move on

Which language does *kilo-* come from? (Greek.) And which thousand is the *mil* of *mil gracias*? (The Latin one, *mille*.)

359.4 el litro — the same word as the pound

Say *the gram*, then *the kilo*. (*El gramo*; *el kilo*.)

What to know first

- el agua — what it measures most often.

- la cantidad — the plain word for how much.

Sounds you'll need

- *LI-tro*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *l* is clear, and *tr* is one cluster. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el litro — "the litre."
Lítra was a unit of weight in Greek Sicily, and Latin borrowed it as **lībra**, the pound. So the *litro* in a bottle and the *libra* on an old set of scales are one word that split in two: French took the Greek shape for the new metric measure, and Spanish took that from French.
The Latin half is hiding all over English, and nobody sees it because it is never spelled the way it sounds:

- a pound is abbreviated **lb** — that is *lībra*, not *pound*;
- **Libra** is the scales in the sky, the constellation shaped like a balance;
- to **deliberate** is *dē-lībrāre*, to weigh a thing thoroughly before deciding;
- **equilibrium** is equal weights;
- and a **level** is a *lībella*, a little balance.

Spanish kept *la libra* for the pound as well, so both halves of the split are still in the language, one in the kitchen and one in the history books.

What you've built

The unit you buy liquid in, and an old weight hiding inside five English words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el litro*

- *un litro de agua*
- *dos litros de agua*

Before you move on

Which Latin word is *litro* a twin of? (*Lībra*, the pound.) And why is a pound written *lb*? (From *lībra*.)

359.5 el peso — the weight that turned into money

Say *the kilo*, then *the litre*. (*El kilo*; *el litro*.)

What to know first

- contar — the other way to find out how much.
- la moneda — what took its name from it.

Sounds you'll need

- *PE-so*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *s* is clear, never buzzed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el peso — "the weight."
Latin **pendere** meant two things at once: to hang, and to weigh. That is not two meanings — it is one, because the way you weighed a thing was to hang it from a balance. **Pēnsum** is what came off the scale: a portion, weighed out.
Then money got involved. Before coins were trusted, you paid in metal and you weighed it, so paying and weighing became one act. English is still full of the consequences:

- a **pension** is a payment weighed out at intervals;
- to **spend** is *expendere*, to weigh out;
- something **expensive** cost a lot of weighing;
- to **compensate** is to weigh one thing against another.

The hanging survived too, in a **pendant** and a **pendulum**, both of which dangle. And to **ponder** is *ponderāre*, to weigh a thing in your mind — which is also what **pensive** does.
Spanish then named a coin after the weight and shipped it across an ocean, which is why so much of the Americas still counts in **pesos**.

What you've built

A length, a weight and a volume, all with a number in front: *el metro*, *el gramo*, *el kilo*, *el litro*, *el peso*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el peso*
- *el peso del pan*
- *un kilo, un litro, un metro*

Before you move on

What two things did *pendere* mean? (To hang and to weigh.) And why is a coin called *un peso*? (It was named after the weight of metal.)

Chapter 360

What You Put On

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la ropa, el vestido, el zapato, el pantalón and el botón, and name what someone is wearing.
>
> *Complete ES-C360-boton: name four things a person has on, and the one small thing that holds them shut.*

360.1 la ropa — the clothes that started out as loot

Say *the litre*, then *the weight*. (*El litro*; *el peso*.)

What to know first

- la tienda — the place where you go and get it.
- comprar — the verb you will pair with it constantly.

Sounds you'll need

- *RO-pa*, two beats with the weight on the first. The opening *r* is trilled, rolled at the front of the mouth, not the soft English one. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la ropa — "clothes."
This word begins with an armed band walking away from a burning village. Germanic **raupa** meant booty: the plunder, the pile you carry off. The verb standing beside it, **raupjan**, meant to pluck or to strip. What did raiders actually take? Not stone, not furniture. Cloth — bolts of it, cloaks, coats. Cloth was light, valuable, and easy to sell on. So the word for loot narrowed to the word for cloth goods, and then narrowed again to the things a person puts on.
English holds the older end of the same root:

- to **rob** is to take the plunder, arriving through Old French *rober*;
- to **reave**, and to be **bereaved**, is to be stripped of something;
- German still has *rauben*, to rob.

Here is the part worth carrying away. Old French **robe** also meant booty first, and it also drifted to mean a garment. Two languages, no contact between them on this point, and the same slide runs twice: what was taken becomes what is worn. Put on a **robe** and you are wearing spoils, in the same sense that *ropa* is spoils.
One trap, and it catches beginners often: *ropa* is not English **rope**. Rope is Old English *rāp*, a wholly separate word that happens to have landed on nearly the same sounds.

What you've built

You can name the whole category of what a person wears, in one word: *la ropa*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la ropa*
- *la ropa nueva*
- *la ropa de la tienda*

Before you move on

What did Germanic *raupa* mean before it meant clothes? (Plunder, booty.) And which English garment made the same slide on its own? (A *robe*, which meant spoils first.)

360.2 el vestido — the dress that is a past participle

Say *the weight*, then *the clothes*. (*El peso*; *la ropa*.)

What to know first

- la fiesta — the occasion this word turns up at.
- la bolsa — another thing you carry or wear, already yours.

Sounds you'll need

- *bes-TI-do*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *v* is made with the lips of a *b*, and the *d* between vowels goes soft, close to the *th* of *this*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el vestido — "the dress."
Latin **vestis** was a garment and **vestīre** was to clothe. Spanish then did something economical: it reached for the past participle of that verb — the form meaning having been clothed — and let it stand up on its own as a noun. A **vestido** is, in its bones, a clothed-thing. The garment is named after the act that put it on.
English borrowed the verb instead of the participle, and borrowed it more than once:

- a **vest** came through French and Italian *veste*;
- to **invest** was *investīre*, to clothe someone in an office — the cloth is still there in a bishop's investiture;
- to **divest** is to strip that clothing back off;
- a **travesty** is Italian *travestīre*, to dress across, meaning a

disguise, and then a grotesque imitation of the thing disguised.

The money sense of **invest** came later, out of Italian banking: you clothe your capital in something. The ceremony came first.
One label that looks like family and is not. **Transvestite** was coined in German in 1910, by Magnus Hirschfeld, out of Latin parts. That is modern manufacture, not a word handed down.
And the quiet cousin is one you use daily without noticing: to **wear**. It comes down the Germanic line from the same ancient root the Romans built *vestis* on — grown alongside Latin rather than borrowed from it.
The trap: *un vestido* is a dress. It is not a vest.

What you've built

You can name a garment by the act that put it on: *el vestido*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el vestido*
- *un vestido nuevo*
- *el vestido de la fiesta*

Before you move on

What form of *vestīre* is *vestido*? (The past participle — the clothed one.) And what did *invest* mean before money got involved? (To clothe a person in an office.)

360.3 el zapato — the shoe nobody can trace

Say *the clothes*, then *the dress*. (*La ropa*; *el vestido*.)

What to know first

- el pie — the part of you this goes on.
- caminar — what you do once it is on.

Sounds you'll need

- *sa-PA-to*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. Across most of the Spanish-speaking world the *z* is said as a clear *s*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el zapato — "the shoe."
Nearly every word you have met has a paper trail. This one has none. *Zapato* has relatives everywhere. Portuguese says *sapato*. Catalan and Occitan say *sabata*. French has *savate*, a worn-out old shoe — and the name of a kicking sport. Italian has *ciabatta*, which means an old slipper and also a bread, the loaf being named for the same flat floppy shape. Arabic has *sabbat*. A shoe-word ran across the western Mediterranean and settled in languages that are not related to each other.
Where did it start? Corominas, who spent a career on Spanish etymology, could not resolve it. A Turkic or Iranian source gets proposed from time to time, but that is speculation rather than a finding. The honest answer is that the trail goes cold.
There is one more thing to unlearn here, and it is famous. You have probably heard that **sabotage** comes from French workers hurling wooden shoes into machinery to wreck it. It does not. French *saboter* meant to bungle a job, or to clatter about noisily in clogs — careless, loud, useless work. The shoe-in-the-gears tale was assembled in the twentieth century and no document supports it.
So this word teaches two things at once: a shoe that half a continent shares, and a beloved etymology that turns out to be a story people enjoyed telling.

What you've built

You can name what goes on the foot, and you can name one famous etymology that is false: *el zapato*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el zapato*

- *un zapato nuevo*
- *los zapatos y la ropa*

Before you move on

Where does *zapato* come from? (Nobody has managed to trace it.) And what is wrong with the wooden-shoe account of *sabotage*? (It was invented in the twentieth century; *saboter* meant to bungle a job or clatter about in clogs.)

360.4 el pantalón — the trousers named after a stage character

Say *the dress*, then *the shoe*. (*El vestido*; *el zapato*.)

What to know first

- la pierna — the part of you this goes on.
- la rodilla — the joint the old kind of legwear stopped at.

Sounds you'll need

- *pan-ta-LON*, three beats with the weight on the last one — the accent mark is there to say so. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pantalón — "trousers."
This garment is named after a man who never existed.
The Venetian comic stage worked from a small cast of fixed characters, and one of them was **Pantalone**: an old miser, forever scheming, forever outwitted. His costume was as fixed as his temper, and its memorable feature was his legwear — long, narrow, running the whole way down to the foot, at a time when other men's legwear stopped at the knee. Audiences began calling that style by his name.
French took the character's name over as **pantalon**, meaning the garment itself. Spanish took the word from French in the seventeen hundreds.
Where did the character get his own name? The usual account sends it

to **San Pantaleone**, a saint with a strong following in Venice. *Pantaleon* is Greek: *pan-*, all, plus *leon*, lion. That step is an inference from Venetian naming habits rather than a documented handover, so hold it lightly. The Greek pieces themselves are solid — *pan-* is the *pan-* of **panorama**, and *leon* is the lion inside the name **Leonard**. English walked the same road at the same time. **Pantaloons** came in whole, then got clipped down to **pants**. So the word printed on the label of your trousers and *el pantalón* are one word wearing two lengths.
A small habit worth copying: Spanish is content with *un pantalón*, one of them, where English insists on a plural pair.

What you've built

You can name the garment for the legs, and say it in the singular the way Spanish prefers: *el pantalón.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pantalón*
- *un pantalón nuevo*
- *el pantalón y el zapato*

Before you move on

Who was Pantalone? (A stock character of the Venetian comic stage, whose long tight legwear got named after him.) And which English word is the same word, clipped short? (*Pants*, from *pantaloons.*)

360.5 el botón — the fastener that is still a bud

Say *the shoe*, then *the trousers.* (*El zapato*; *el pantalón.*)

What to know first

- la mano — what you need to work one.
- la flor — the other thing this word names.

Sounds you'll need

- *bo-TON*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *b* is soft here, the lips barely closing on it. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el botón — "the button."
Start with the verb, not the noun. Old French **bouter** meant to thrust, to push, to shove; French had taken it from a Germanic word, **bōtan**, to strike. Out of that verb came the noun **boton**: a thing that pushes out.
Notice what that describes. It is a shape, not a job. It says nothing about fastening, nothing about cloth. It says only: this sticks out. Which is why one word covers two objects that resemble each other in no other way. A **botón** on a shirt sticks out. And a **botón** on a rose bush — a bud, tight and rounded, pushing its way out of the stem — sticks out in precisely the same manner. Spanish was never asked to choose between the two, and Old French was not either; *boton* carried both from the beginning.
The pushing surfaces all over English:

- a **buttress** pushes back against a leaning wall;
- to **rebut** is to push a claim back at the person making it;
- to **abut** is to push up against;
- a goat **butts** you: it strikes, with its head.

And **beat** is the cousin that came down the Germanic line rather than through France — the same striking, inherited instead of borrowed.
A caution, because English is untidy here. The other **butt**s — a barrel, the butt of a joke, the one you sit on — are separate words with separate histories. Only the striking one belongs to this family.

What you've built

You can name the thing on your shirt and the bud on a stem with one word: *el botón*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el botón*
- *un botón nuevo*
- *el botón de la flor*

Before you move on

What did *bouter* mean? (To thrust or push.) And why does *botón* also name a flower bud? (Because the word means a thing that juts out, and a bud does exactly that.)

Chapter 361

What Is On The Table

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la carne, el pescado, la leche, la sal and el aceite, and ask for the things a plain meal is made of.
>
> *Complete ES-C361-aceite: name two things you cook and three things you cook them with.*

361.1 la carne — the flesh that named a party before a fast

Say *the trousers*, then *the button.* (*El pantalón*; *el botón.*)

What to know first

- la comida — the meal this word ends up inside.
- el plato — what the meat arrives on.

Sounds you'll need

- *KAR-ne*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* is a single tap of the tongue, not a roll. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la carne — "meat."
Latin **carō** had the stem **carn-**, and it meant flesh: the stuff of a body, on the animal or on the person. Spanish took it plain, and *la carne* is

what a butcher sells and what arrives for dinner. No shudder attached. English inherited nothing here and borrowed everything, which is why the same root arrives in English wearing solemn clothes:

- **carnal**, of the flesh rather than the spirit;
- **incarnate**, made flesh, out of the Latin of the Church;
- **carnage**, through French and Italian — flesh in quantity.

The generous one is **carnival**. Italian *carnevale* goes back to an older *carnelevare*, "the removing of meat" — the name of the hinge in the year where meat stops and Lent begins. The party is named after the fast that follows it.
You will also hear a tidier account: *carne, vale!*, "meat, farewell!", as though the word were a parting wave at a plate. It scans beautifully and it is not where the word came from. It is a reworking by speakers who heard *carnevale*, recognised *carne* inside it, and supplied a story for the rest.
Worth hearing too: the register gap. English *carnal* is a heavy word, kept for sermons and courtrooms. Spanish *carne* is the lightest one there is. It goes on the shopping list.

What you've built

You can name what is on a plate with the same root that named a street party in February: *la carne*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la carne*
- *la carne y el pan*
- *un plato de carne*

Before you move on

What did *carnelevare* mean? (The removing of meat, before Lent.)
And is *carne, vale* the real story? (No — that is a later guess, made

by ear.)

361.2 el pescado — the fish that has already been caught

Say *the button*, then *the meat*. (*El botón*; *la carne*.)

What to know first

- el agua — where the fish was before it was caught.
- la olla — where it goes afterwards.

Sounds you'll need

- *pes-KA-do*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The final *d* is soft, close to the *th* of *the*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pescado — "fish," the kind you eat.
Latin **piscis** was a fish. From it came the verb *piscārī*, to fish, and from that verb its past participle **piscātus**, "having been fished" — the catch. Spanish turned that participle into a noun. So *el pescado* is not a fish. It is **the caught one**.
That is why Spanish is holding two words. A fish moving through water is *un pez*. The same creature, netted and in a pan, is *el pescado*. The grammar of a finished action is doing the work, and you can hear the *-ado* on the end of it, the same ending that sits on the end of *hablado* and *comido*.
English took the learned half straight from Latin: **Pisces** in the sky, **piscine** for anything fishy, **piscatorial** for the business of fishing. But English also owns the word by inheritance. Latin *pater* is English *father*; Latin *pēs* is *foot*; Latin *plēnus* is *full*. *Piscis* and *fish* are that same pairing, one more time.
A caution on how far back to push it. Call it the p and f correspondence and stop there — the fish-word turns up only in the western languages, and one proposal is that they all took it from some older neighbour rather than inheriting it.

One letter of danger: *pescado* is fish, *pecado* is sin. *Pescador* fishes, *pecador* sins.

What you've built

You can order fish with a word that means the catch, and hear a finished action inside it: *el pescado*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pescado*
- *el pescado y el arroz*
- *un plato de pescado*

Before you move on

What does the *-ado* of *pescado* tell you? (That it has been caught — it is a past participle.) And what does *pecado* mean? (Sin — an unrelated word, one letter away.)

361.3 la leche — the milk hiding inside a lettuce

Say *the meat*, then *the fish*. (*La carne*; *el pescado*.)

What to know first

- la vaca — where the milk starts.
- el queso — what it turns into.

Sounds you'll need

- *LE-che*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ch* is one sound, the *ch* of *church*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la leche — "milk."
Latin **lac** had the stem **lact-**, and the spoken language flattened it to *lacte*, which wore down into *leche*. Chemists later went back to the Latin stem and cut it into **lactose**, **lactic** and **lactate** — modern coinages from an old root. Italian **latte** needs no explanation at all: it is *leche*, in another accent.
Now the good one. A **lettuce** is a *lactūca*, "the milky one," because a cut lettuce stem bleeds a pale sap. English got the word through Old French *laitues*. Spanish never had to borrow it — *lechuga* came down the ordinary way, so Spanish keeps the milk and the salad plant as an audible pair, no translation required.
Milky Way is a translation of Latin *via lactea*, which was itself a translation of a Greek phrase — the same picture handed along in three languages.
And a hedge on the Greek. **Galaxy** comes from *galaxías*, "milky", from Greek *gála*, stem *galakt-*. That much is solid. What is not solid is treating *gála* and *lac* as a tidy pair of cousins: the sounds do not line up the way inherited words normally do, and the usual account now is that Greek and Latin each picked their milk-word up from somewhere else that has been lost. Two words that look like damaged copies of each other, with no surviving original.

What you've built

You can name milk, and hear the same word inside a salad leaf: *la leche*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la leche*
- *la leche y el queso*
- *un vaso de leche*

Before you move on

Why is a lettuce named for milk? (A cut stem bleeds a milky sap.) And are Greek *gála* and Latin *lac* a clean pair of cousins? (No — they look like damaged copies of each other, and neither seems inherited.)

361.4 la sal — one short word, and three roots that only sound alike

Say *the fish*, then *the milk*. (*El pescado*; *la leche*.)

What to know first

- la salud — the sal- word that is not salt.
- la sopa — the first thing you reach for salt to fix.

Sounds you'll need

- *sal*, one beat. The *s* stays clear and unbuzzed, and the *l* is light, made at the tip of the tongue. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sal — "salt."
Latin **sal, salis**. Its family is a kitchen: **salad** is *herba salāta*, salted greens; **salsa** and **sauce** are one Latin word, *salsa*, "salted", arriving in English by two different doors; **sausage** is *salsīcia*; and **saline** and **salami** are the same root again.
Salary belongs here too — *salārium* is built on *sal*, and that much is real. What is not real is the story stapled to it. No Roman source says soldiers were paid in salt. Pliny remarks only that salt was valuable enough for the word to be named after it; the salt-money version traces to an eighteenth-century dictionary. It is the same species of invention as *carne, vale!*.
Now the part that matters for the ear. Spanish has other words that open with *sal-*, and they are not a crowd of separate accidents. There are three roots in total, counting salt.

- **Whole, safe.** *Salūs* gives *salud*; *salūtāre*, built directly on *salūs*,

gives *saludo*; *salvus* gives *salvo*. Those three Spanish words are **one root**, not three. English drew *salute*, *salvage*, *salvation* and *save* from it, and by way of Greek *hólos* the *holo-* of *holograph*.

- **Leap.** *Salīre* meant to jump. English took *salient*, *sally*, *assail*, *assault*, *result*, *insult* and *somersault* from it. Spanish *salir*, to go out, is a leap that calmed down into a doorway.

So: one root seasons the food, one wishes you well, one jumps.

What you've built

You can salt a soup, and tell three *sal-* families apart by ear: *la sal*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sal*
- *la sal y el pan*
- *un poco de sal*

Before you move on

How many roots hide behind the *sal-* words? (Three — salt, whole-or-safe, and leap.) And which Spanish words share the whole-or-safe one? (*Salud*, *saludo* and *salvo*, all from the same root.)

361.5 el aceite — an Arabic oil and a Latin olive in one phrase

Say *the milk*, then *the salt*. (*La leche*; *la sal*.)

What to know first

- la sartén — what you pour it into.
- la cebolla — what goes in after it.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-SEI-te*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. In much of Spain that *c* is the soft *th* of *think*; across the Americas it is a clear *s*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el aceite — "oil."
Arabic **az-zayt** means "the oil." Spanish borrowed the whole phrase, article and all, and never took the article back off. The Arabic *al-* had already softened to *az-* alongside that *z*, so what crossed over was *azzayt*, which settled into *aceite*. The olive, *az-zaytūna*, came the same way and became *aceituna*. English did this too, with **alcohol**, **algebra** and **alchemy** — each of them carrying an Arabic *al-* that means nothing at all in English now.
Latin had a perfectly good word of its own: **oleum**, oil, and **olīva**, the tree and its fruit. That is the source of English **oil** (through Old French), of **olive**, of **petroleum**, "rock oil", and of **linoleum**, a nineteenth- century coinage from *linum*, flax, plus *oleum*. Spanish kept *óleo* for the painter's oil and *el olivo* for the tree.
Here is the part to keep. Neither word is home-grown. Arabic *zayt* is Semitic — Hebrew *zayit* is the same word — and it has no connection to *oleum*. And *oleum* and *olīva* were themselves lifted from Greek *élaion* and *elaíā*, which are generally taken to come from some older Mediterranean language that left nothing else behind. So the phrase *aceite de oliva* stands two borrowings next to each other, a thousand years apart, naming one plant.
One warning for the kitchen and the garage: *aceite* is oil of every kind, cooking or engine. The stuff from the ground is *petróleo*.

What you've built

You can name the oil in a pan with a word Spain took from Arabic, and the olive in it with one Rome took from Greek: *el aceite*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el aceite*

- *el aceite y la sal*
- *un poco de aceite*

Before you move on

What is the *a-* at the front of *aceite*? (The Arabic article *al-*, already softened to *az-* before the *z*.) And where did Latin get *oleum*? (Borrowed from Greek — so both words for the plant are loans.)

Chapter 362

Earth, Sea And Sky

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la tierra, el mar, el aire, el fuego and la luna, and say which of them a place is near.
>
> *Complete ES-C362-luna: place a thing against earth, sea, air and fire, and name what is overhead at night.*

362.1 la tierra — the earth, and a mistake the Romans made about it

Say *the salt*, then *the oil*. (*La sal*; *el aceite*.)

What to know first

- el campo — the worked land, which is one piece of *la tierra*.
- el mundo — the world entire, the wider word this one sits inside.

Sounds you'll need

- *TIE-rra*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *rr* is rolled, held a moment longer than a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la tierra — "the earth, the ground."
Latin **terra** meant the dry part of the world, the half that is not water. English borrowed it hard: **terrain**, **terrace**, **subterranean**, **terrestrial**, and **terra cotta**, which is "cooked earth" and describes what a flowerpot is with no room left over. The **Mediterranean** is the sea *in the middle of the land*, and to **inter** someone is to put them into the earth.
The best of the family is small and loud. A **terrier** is the dog bred to go into the ground after a badger — an animal named for the place it works.
Now the trap. Romans themselves thought **territōrium** came from **terrēre**, "to frighten": territory as the ground you could scare intruders off. They had their own etymology wrong. *Territōrium* is **terra** with an ending meaning "the land around a town", and there is nothing frightening in it.
Terrēre is real, though, and it left descendants of its own: **terror**, **terrible**, **terrific**. That is the frightening family, and *tierra* is no part of it. The two roots even collide inside Spanish, where *aterrar* is two different verbs wearing one spelling — one that terrifies, one that brings a thing down to the ground. The word you will hear at an airport, *aterrizar*, "to land", belongs to the earth one.

What you've built

A place-word wide enough to hold everything that follows: *la tierra*, with *el campo* inside it and *el mundo* around it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la tierra*
- *la tierra y el campo*
- *el mundo, la tierra, el campo*

Before you move on

What did Roman scholars wrongly think territory came from? (*Terrēre*, to frighten.) And which of the two roots does *terror* belong to? (*Terrēre*, not *terra*.)

362.2 el mar — the sea, and the mermaid who is a cousin not a copy

Say *the oil*, then *the earth*. (*El aceite*; *la tierra*.)

What to know first

- el agua — the substance the sea is made of.
- la orilla — the edge where the sea has to stop.

Sounds you'll need

- *MAR*, one beat only. The *r* at the end is a single tap of the tongue, not a roll. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el mar — "the sea."
Latin **mare** came from an ancient root that meant sea long before Latin existed. Out of Latin, English borrowed a whole shelf of formal words: **marine**, **maritime**, **marina**, **submarine**. **Ultramarine** is the oddest of them — the blue "from beyond the sea", because the lapis it was ground from arrived by ship from Afghanistan.
Those are borrowings. Now the other route. English inherited that very same ancient root down its own line, where it surfaced as Old English **mere**, a lake or a sea. The word is still hiding inside **mermaid**: a *mere*-maid, a maiden of the sea. **Marsh** and **moor** came down the same way, both of them waterlogged ground.
So *mar* and the *mer-* of *mermaid* are not one word taken from the other. They are cousins, each walking down from a shared ancestor by a different road — one road through Rome, the other through the north.
One more, and it is a case of English mishearing itself. Latin called the

shrub *rōs marīnus*, standardly explained as "dew of the sea", for a plant that grows in salt wind. English bent that strange phrase into two familiar words and got **rosemary**, a rose and a Mary. It is not a rose, and it owes nothing to anyone named Mary. Spanish came down from the same *rōs marīnus* and never pulled it toward either — the reshaping happened on the English side alone.

What you've built

A word for the water with no edge to it, ready to set against the land: *el mar*, *el agua*, *la orilla*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el mar*
- *el agua del mar*
- *la orilla del mar*

Before you move on

Is English *mermaid* borrowed from Latin *mare*, or inherited? (Inherited — the *mer-* is Old English *mere*, a cousin of *mare*.) And what does *ultramarine* mean word for word? (Beyond the sea, where the blue stone was shipped from.)

362.3 el aire — the air that named a disease wrongly

Say *the earth*, then *the sea*. (*La tierra*; *el mar*.)

What to know first

- el viento — air once it has a direction and a speed.
- el cielo — the sky that the air fills.

Sounds you'll need

- *AI-re*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ai* is one glide, the sound of English *eye*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el aire — "the air."
Two journeys made this word. Greek had **aēr**, the lower air you breathe, as against the bright upper air of the gods. Latin borrowed it whole. Spanish then inherited it from Latin. Greek to Rome to Madrid, no stop in between.
English took the Greek shape for its technical vocabulary: **aerial**, **aerobic**, **aerosol**, **aeroplane**. All of them are breathing the same syllable.
The finest cousin is a mistake nobody has bothered to undo. Italian *mala aria* meant "bad air", and before anyone knew what a mosquito did, the fever that haunted marshes was blamed on the vapour rising off them. English borrowed the phrase in the eighteenth century and welded it into one word, **malaria**. The theory is dead; the word carries it around regardless.
Here is the pleasing part. Spanish mostly calls that same disease by a name built on Latin *palūs*, "a swamp". Spanish blamed the marsh, English blamed the air, and each language fossilised a different half of one abandoned idea.
Last, a small one. Italian **aria**, the piece a singer stands up to deliver, is this word yet again: *air* in the sense of a tune. English used *air* that way for centuries, which is why old songbooks are full of them.

What you've built

A third thing to place a body in, after ground and water: *el aire*, with *el viento* moving through it and *el cielo* over it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el aire*
- *el aire y el viento*

- *el cielo, el aire, el viento*

Before you move on

What did *malaria* mean before it meant a disease? (Bad air, in Italian.) And which language did Latin take *aer* from? (Greek.)

362.4 el fuego — the hearth that burned down the word for fire

Say *the sea*, then *the air*. (*El mar*; *el aire*.)

What to know first

- el calor — the heat a fire throws off.
- el horno — a fire with walls built around it.

Sounds you'll need

- *FUE-go*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *g* is hard, the *g* of English *go*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el fuego — "the fire."
Latin had a perfectly serviceable word for fire: **ignis**, which survives in English **ignite** and **igneous**. Spanish threw it away.
What Spanish kept instead was **focus**, and in Latin *focus* did not mean fire at all. It meant the hearth — the built place in a house where the fire was kept. The same swap ran right across Romance: French *feu*, Italian *fuoco*, Spanish *fuego*, each of them a hearth that took over the work of the flame.
English then borrowed the hearth back, three separate times, and the image survives in each of them:

- **focus** was Kepler's word, in 1604, for the burning point of a lens or a curved mirror. Put a hearth at the spot where the heat gathers and you have the picture exactly. **Focal** followed on from it.
- **curfew** is Old French *cuevrefeu*, "cover the fire" — the evening

bell that told a town to bank its embers before bed.

- **fuel** is Old French *fouaille*, from Late Latin *focālia*, the stuff you feed a hearth with.

Spanish went further than any of that. It let the hearth become the word for home itself, so the fireplace ended up naming the house around it. English did something similar when it made *hearth* and *home* neighbours — two languages agreeing on where a house really begins.

What you've built

The fourth element and the hottest: *el fuego*, the *el calor* it gives off, and *el horno* that keeps it in one place.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el fuego*
- *el calor del fuego*
- *el fuego en el horno*

Before you move on

Which Latin word is *fuego* from, and what did it mean? (*Focus*, the hearth.) And what does *curfew* literally tell a town to do? (Cover the fire.)

362.5 la luna — the shiny one, and a root you already own

Say *the air*, then *the fire*. (*El aire*; *el fuego*.)

What to know first

- la luz — the same ancient root as this word, met earlier under another shape.

- la noche — when the moon does its work.

Sounds you'll need

- *LU-na*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *u* is a pure *oo*, never the *yoo* of English *lunar*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la luna — "the moon."
You already own this root. When *la luz* was taught, the source was Latin **lūx**, light. *Luna* is that same root wearing a different ending, and the moon turns out to be named, quite literally, **the shiny one**. That is not a guess. Latin *lūna* is worn down from an earlier **louksna**, built on the ancient root **lewk-**, "to shine" — and archaic Latin actually preserves the older shape, spelled **Losna**, scratched onto a bronze mirror from Praeneste. The relatives elsewhere agree: Old Church Slavonic *luna*, Old Prussian *lauxnos* meaning "stars", Avestan *raoxshna*.
Out of that one root, English got three sets of words through three different doors:

- **light** walked in. It is the inherited Germanic cousin, borrowed from nobody.
- **lucid**, **luminous**, **illuminate**, **translucent** were carried in from Latin by scholars.
- **leukemia** arrived through Greek, where the root came out as *leukós*, "white" — a disease named for pale blood.

Lunatic belongs here too, from the long-held belief that the moon unsettled the mind.
Then the payoff lands on a Monday. Spanish *lunes* is Latin *diēs Lūnae*, "day of the Moon" — itself a translation, piece for piece, of a Greek phrase. English **Monday** is the same translation, made independently into Germanic. Two languages, one Greek habit, one moon.

What you've built

The thing overhead at night, tied back to a word you already met by day: *la luna* and *la luz*, one root in two shapes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la luna*
- *la luz de la luna*
- *la luna en la noche*

Before you move on

What does the name *luna* mean word for word? (The shiny one.) And which archaic Latin form confirms the older shape? (*Losna*, scratched on the Praeneste mirror.)

Chapter 363

How You Get There

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el coche, el avión, el barco, el autobús and la bicicleta, and say which one I am taking.
>
> *Complete ES-C363-bicicleta: name five ways to reach a place, and say which one you are taking.*

363.1 el coche — the car named after a Hungarian village

Say *the fire*, then *the moon*. (*El fuego*; *la luna*.)

What to know first

- el camino — the thing a coche needs underneath it.
- el viaje — what you take a coche on.

Sounds you'll need

- *KO-che*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ch* is the sound English has in *church*, and the opening *c* is a hard *k*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el coche — "the car."
A village did this. **Kocs** is a small place west of Budapest, and in the fifteenth century its wagon-makers worked out how to hang a carriage body on straps, so that the passengers stopped being shaken to pieces on a long road. Hungarian called the result a **kocsi szekér**, a "cart from Kocs", then dropped the *szekér* and kept **kocsi**, "the Kocs one". It is attested in that sense from 1469.
Europe wanted the ride, and took the name with it. German made **Kutsche** of it, French made **coche**, and Spanish took *coche* from French. English took it too and spelled it **coach** by the 1550s. So *coche* and *coach* are one word in two spellings, and underneath both of them there is still a village.
Then English did something odd with it. At Oxford and Cambridge, a tutor who carried a struggling student through an examination was called a **coach** — student slang, the tutor as vehicle. Sport borrowed the joke, and now a coach shouts from the touchline with no memory at all of the wagon-makers.
One warning, and it matters the moment you travel: *coche* is the car in **Spain**. Across much of Latin America the car is *carro* or *auto* instead, and in some countries *coche* means a pram, or is a word nobody reaches for.

What you've built

You can name the thing in the driveway, and you know why a stagecoach and a football coach share a word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el coche*
- *el coche nuevo*
- *un coche en el camino*

Before you move on

What is Kocs? (A town west of Budapest whose sprung carriages were famous.) And which English word is *coche*? (Coach.)

363.2 el avión — a bird-word that was coined, not inherited

Say *the moon*, then *the car*. (*La luna*; *el coche*.)

What to know first

- el cielo — where an avión spends its time.
- el viaje — what you board one for.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-BYON*, two beats with the weight on the second, which is what the written accent is telling you. The *v* is the same sound as a Spanish *b*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el avión — "the aeroplane."
Latin **avis** was a bird, and it is all over the learned end of English: **aviation**, an **aviator**, an **aviary**, anything **avian**. It hides inside two bird names worn smooth by use — an **ostrich** is *avis struthio*, a "sparrow-bird", and a **bustard** is *avis tarda*, a "slow bird". And under **auspices** there is a Roman standing in a field reading the flight of birds for omens: *avis* plus *specere*, to watch.
Here is the part that matters about *avión*, though. Spanish did not inherit it. *Avis* dropped out of everyday Latin as it became Spanish, and stayed out. The word you are learning was manufactured in French, in 1875, by **Clément Ader**, who built *avis* into a name for a flying machine before anyone had flown one. Spanish borrowed the finished French word, accent and all. It is a nineteenth-century invention in a Roman costume.
Which springs a trap that was set for you long ago. **El aviso**, the notice, belongs to a different family entirely. It comes through French

aviser, from Latin *vidēre*, "to see" — the root of **vision**, **video**, **advise** and **evident**, and by inheritance of **wit**, **wise** and **witness**. One is a bird-root, the other a see-root. Four letters apart, no relation.

What you've built

You can name what crosses the sky, and you can hold *el avión* and *el aviso* apart by their roots.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el avión*
- *el avión en el cielo*
- *un viaje en avión*

Before you move on

Who made the word *avión*, and when? (Clément Ader, in French, in 1875.) And does *el aviso* come from the same root? (No — it is from *vidēre*, to see.)

363.3 el barco — the little boat that grew

Say *the car*, then *the aeroplane*. (*El coche*; *el avión*.)

What to know first

- el mar — what a barco crosses.
- el puerto — where it stops.

Sounds you'll need

- *BAR-ko*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* is one quick tap of the tongue, not a roll. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el barco — "the ship."
Late Latin **barca** was a small boat, the kind you rowed. It turns up in writing around 400 AD, and where it came from before that is unsettled. The usual suggestion runs back through Greek *baris*, a flat-bottomed Egyptian river boat — plausible, often repeated, and never actually demonstrated. Careful sources hedge it, and so should you. Take *barca* as the oldest firm ground.
Forward from there the trail is clean. Old French made **barge** of it. Italian *barca* came into French as *barque*, and English took that as **bark**, the sailing ship of every poem about the sea. To **embark** is to be put into a *barque*; to **disembark** is to climb back out. Board a plane tomorrow and you are still, in Latin, being loaded into a small rowing boat.
English then hands you a three-way trap. The **bark** that is a ship is this Romance word. The **bark** on a tree is Old Norse, *borkr*. The **bark** of a dog is Old English, *beorcan*. Three words spelled alike, related to nothing.
And Spanish kept a distinction of size that English lost along the way: *barca* stayed the little rowing boat it had been, while *barco* grew up into the ship in general. The word you are learning is the small one that got big.

What you've built

You can name a ship, and you know that to embark is to be lowered into a rowing boat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el barco*
- *el barco en el mar*
- *un barco en el puerto*

Before you move on

What did *barca* mean in Late Latin? (A small boat.) And are the three English barks one word? (No — a ship, a tree and a dog, three separate origins.)

363.4 el autobús — two words, each cut in half

Say *the aeroplane*, then *the ship*. (*El avión*; *el barco*.)

What to know first

- el asiento — what you hope to find on one.
- la parada — where it picks you up.

Sounds you'll need

- *au-to-BUS*, three beats with the weight on the last, which is why the *u* carries a written accent. The opening *au* is one glide, not two beats. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el autobús — "the bus."
Take the back half first, because it may be the strangest word in this book. Latin **omnis** meant "all". Latin hung its grammar on the ends of words, and **omnibus** is one of those endings at work: the dative plural, "for all, to everybody". It is not a noun. It is *omnis* wearing a grammatical hat.
Around 1823, in Nantes, a carriage service began running from a spot outside the shop of a hatter named **Omnès**. His sign read **Omnes Omnibus** — "Omnès for everybody", a pun on his own name. Passengers took the joke for the name of the vehicle, and *omnibus* became the French word for a public carriage. English borrowed it whole.
Then French tired of the length and cut it short — and cut in an astonishing place. It kept *-bus* and threw away *omn-*, the entire stem, the part carrying the meaning. So the **bus** of English, Spanish and French is a Latin case ending, orphaned from its word, walking around doing a noun's work.

The front half is a second clipping. *Auto-* is chopped off **automóvil**, which was itself assembled as a hybrid: Greek *autós*, "self", bolted onto Latin *mōbilis*, "movable". Two clippings, three languages, one vehicle. It is also the most regional word in this chain. *Autobús* is what Spain says; Mexico says *camión*, the Caribbean and the Canaries *guagua*, Argentina *colectivo*, Chile *micro*.

What you've built

You can name the thing at the stop, and you know that *bus* is a Latin ending with its own word cut away.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el autobús*
- *el asiento del autobús*
- *la parada del autobús*

Before you move on

Which part of Latin *omnis* is *-bus*? (The dative plural ending, meaning for all.) And who was Omnès? (A hatter in Nantes whose punning sign named the vehicle.)

363.5 la bicicleta — two Greek wheels on a Latin prefix

Say *the ship*, then *the bus*. (*El barco*; *el autobús*.)

What to know first

- la calle — where you ride one.
- el parque — where you ride one without traffic.

Sounds you'll need

- *bi-si-KLE-ta*, four beats with the weight on the third. The first *c* softens in front of the *i*; the second stays hard in front of the *l*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la bicicleta — "the bicycle."
Greek **kyklos** was a circle, and also a wheel — one idea looked at twice. Latin **bi-** is "two". French set them together as **bicyclette** in the nineteenth century, and Spanish took the French word entire. Like a good many machines of that decade, it is a hybrid: a Latin prefix bolted onto a Greek noun by people who needed a name in a hurry.
Kyklos has been generous. A **cycle** turns and comes back to where it began. A **tricycle** has three wheels; a **motorcycle** has an engine. A **cyclops** is a "round-eye". And a **cyclone** was minted in 1848 by Henry Piddington, who wanted a word for a storm that turns.
Now the part worth carrying away. English **wheel** is not borrowed from *kyklos* at all — it is its **cousin**, come down the Germanic line from the same ancient root for turning. One of them arrived by ship; the other was never away. Both sit in the sentence "I rode my bicycle", and only one of them travelled.
One last thing, because it is a good story. **Encyclopedia** has no Greek original. Someone in the Renaissance read the two-word phrase *enkyklios paideia*, "a well-rounded education", ran the halves together, and invented an ancestor for it.
A caution to finish: a **circus** and its ring are from Greek *kirkos*, a different root. That is a family resemblance, not a family.

What you've built

You can name the two-wheeled one, and you can tell a borrowed cousin from an inherited one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la bicicleta*
- *la bicicleta en el parque*

- *una bicicleta en la calle*

Before you move on

Is English *wheel* borrowed from *kyklos*? (No — it is the inherited cousin.) And was *encyclopedia* ever a Greek word? (No — it is a misreading of a two-word Greek phrase.)

Chapter 364

The Person, Head To Hand

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la mujer, la cara, la nariz, el dedo and el corazón, and point at a person and name a part of them.
>
> *Complete ES-C364-corazon: name a person, then a face, a nose, a finger and the thing that beats underneath.*

364.1 la mujer — the Latin woman-word English never took

Say *the bus*, then *the bicycle*. (*El autobús*; *la bicicleta*.)

What to know first

- la persona — the general word for a human being, which this narrows.
- la esposa — the other way Spanish names a wife, and the contrast matters here.

Sounds you'll need

- *mu-JER*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *j* is the jota, scraped at the back of the throat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la mujer — "the woman."
Latin had two everyday words for a human being, and they had very different luck. **Homō** meant a person, and it travelled everywhere: English **human**, **humane**, **homicide**, and **homage** — a man declaring himself another man's man — all descend from it, some through French, some lifted straight out of Latin by scholars. **Mulier** meant a woman, and it went almost nowhere.
Count what English got. There is **muliebrity**, "womanhood", whose earliest evidence is around 1592 and which never became common; **muliebral** is rarer still. That is close to the whole harvest. A word Romans used constantly, for half of everybody, left English an empty shelf.
Spanish kept it and wore it down: *mulier* became **mujer**, the middle of the word hardening into that scraped jota. Portuguese, Catalan and Italian kept it too. French alone let it go, replacing it with *femme*, from Latin *fēmina*.
And where did *mulier* itself come from? Nobody knows. The Romans guessed **mollior**, "softer" — a tidy story, and wrong, because the sounds do not line up. A rival guess ties it to *mulgēre*, "to milk", with no more support than the first. Modern handbooks print the word and leave the origin line blank, which is an honest thing for a dictionary to do.
One practical note. **Mujer** carries two senses at once, "woman" and "wife", and only the sentence around it tells you which one is meant.

What you've built

You can name a human being and then narrow it: *la persona*, *la mujer*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la mujer*
- *una mujer*
- *la mujer de la casa*

Before you move on

What did English take from Latin *mulier*? (Almost nothing — the rare word *muliebrity*.) And where does *mulier* itself come from? (Unexplained; the softer story is a Roman folk etymology.)

364.2 la cara — the face that is also expensive

Say *the bicycle*, then *the woman*. (*La bicicleta*; *la mujer*.)

What to know first

- el ojo — one of the parts this word gathers together.
- la boca — the other part already named, which sits in the same place.

Sounds you'll need

- *CA-ra*, two beats with the weight on the first. The single *r* is a quick tap, the tongue brushing the ridge behind the teeth once. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cara — "the face."
Begin with the half that is solid. Spanish has two words with this exact shape, and they have nothing to do with each other.
The second one is an adjective. **Caro** means "expensive", from Latin **cārus**, "dear" — dear in both English senses, costly and beloved. That root was generous to English: **charity** is *cāritās*, dearness; **cherish** comes through Old French *cherir*; **caress** arrives from Italian *carezza* by way of French. Say the adjective first and you get *una cara cara*, an expensive face, a phrase Spaniards actually use and a small proof that the two words run independently. The same noun gives *cara o cruz*, the Spanish way of saying heads or tails.
Now the noun, and here the ground goes soft. Late Latin **cara** "face" is generally traced to Greek **kára**, "head". That is the majority account and it is worth carrying. It is also contested from inside the field: Corominas pointed out that *kára* is a poetic word in Greek rather than a workaday one, that no secure trace of it turns up in the

everyday Latin that fed Romance, and that the word surfaces in the wrong places across Romance for a Greek borrowing. So the honest version is this: usually derived from Greek *kára*, with the trail broken somewhere in the middle.
A word you use fifty times a day, whose family tree carries a question mark — and a twin meaning "costly" that is no relation at all.

What you've built

You can name three things that sit together: *el ojo*, *la boca*, *la cara*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cara*
- *una cara*
- *la cara de la mujer*

Before you move on

What else does *cara* mean, and from which root? (Expensive, from Latin cārus — the root of charity and cherish.) And how firm is the Greek origin of the face-word? (It is the usual account, but the trail is not clean.)

364.3 la nariz — the nostril word that swallowed the nose

Say *the woman*, then *the face*. (*La mujer*; *la cara*.)

What to know first

- la boca — the neighbouring opening, already named.
- el oído — another opening in the head, and another word built on what it does.

Sounds you'll need

- *na-RIZ*, two beats with the weight on the second. In much of Spain that final *z* is a soft th; across Latin America it is a clean *s*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la nariz — "the nose."
Latin kept the thing apart from its openings. **Nāsus** was the nose. **Nāris** was a nostril, and it mostly turned up in the plural, **nārēs**, since you have two of them. Spanish then did something unexpected with that pair: it held on to the nostril word and let the nose word go. **Nariz** is *nāris*, its shape nudged along the way by *nāsus* sitting close by.
The plural did not vanish either. Spanish still says *meter las narices* for poking your nose into someone else's business — nostrils, plural, counted exactly as a Roman would have counted them. A two-thousand-year-old habit of number, preserved inside an idiom about being nosy.
English kept the other branch, and took it through two different doors. **Nose** was inherited: Old English *nosu*, a Germanic cousin of *nāsus*, not a loan from it — the two words came down side by side from one ancient source. **Nasal** is the loan, pulled out of Latin *nāsālis* by writers who wanted a technical word. Then **nostril** is Old English *nosthyrl*, a nose-hole, where only the first half is the cousin; the *-thyrl* is kin to **through** and to **thrill**, which once meant to pierce. And **nozzle** is homegrown, a small English diminutive of *nose*, with no Latin anywhere in it.
So English ended up with the nose. Spanish, strictly speaking, ended up with the nostrils.

What you've built

You can name three openings in a head: *la boca*, *el oído*, *la nariz*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la nariz*

- *una nariz*
- *la nariz y la boca*

Before you move on

Which Latin word gave *nariz*, and what did it mean? (Nāris, a nostril.) And what does *meter las narices* preserve? (The Latin plural — nostrils rather than nose.)

364.4 el dedo — the finger inside anything digital

Say *the face*, then *the nose*. (*La cara*; *la nariz*.)

What to know first

- la mano — where five of these live.
- el pie — where the other five live, since Spanish uses one word for both.

Sounds you'll need

- *DE-do*, two beats with the weight on the first. Both *d*s are soft, the tongue barely touching, nearer the *th* of *this* than an English *d*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el dedo — "the finger."
Latin **digitus** covered fingers and toes with a single word, and Spanish inherited the arrangement: *dedo* does both jobs, and you add a phrase when it matters which end of a person you mean.
The English side of the family took a detour through arithmetic. A **digit** began as a finger and became a numeral, for the plain reason that hands are the first counting device anyone owns — ten fingers are why the numerals run out at ten and start over. Once *digit* had settled into "numeral", **digital** was built on that sense: discrete numbers, counted one at a time, as against a smoothly sliding quantity. So the word in *digital camera* reaches you through counting, not through hands. Finger, then number, then machine — and the middle step is

the one everybody forgets.
Two more relatives are worth having. **Prestidigitation**, a conjuror's sleight of hand, is "quick-fingered". And **digitalis**, the heart drug, is named for the foxglove, whose flowers are finger-shaped little tubes you could slip over a fingertip.
One collision to clear, because the shape invites it. Spanish **alrededor**, "around", appears to have a *dedo* buried in the middle. It does not. That word is built on Latin **retrō**, "backwards"; the sounds got shuffled on their way into Spanish and threw off a lookalike. Coincidence, not kinship.

What you've built

You can name a hand, a foot, and what sticks out of both: *la mano*, *el pie*, *el dedo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el dedo*
- *un dedo*
- *los dedos de la mano*

Before you move on

Why does *digit* mean a numeral? (Because people count on their fingers.) And is *alrededor* related to *dedo*? (No — it is built on Latin retrō, backwards.)

364.5 el corazón — the heart you bring things back to

Say *the nose*, then *the finger*. (*La nariz*; *el dedo*.)

What to know first

- el pecho — the part of the body this one sits inside.

- la sangre — what this organ moves, already named.

Sounds you'll need

- *co-ra-ZON*, three beats with the weight on the last, which is what the written accent marks. The single *r* is one quick tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el corazón — "the heart."
Latin **cor**, whose stem is **cord-**, is a short word that got everywhere. French kept it small as *coeur*, Italian as *cuore*. Spanish did something else: it hung an augmentative ending on it, the kind of ending that makes a thing bigger, and came away with **corazón** — a great heart where the neighbours kept a plain one.
English is thick with *cord-*. **Cordial** is "of the heart", which slid from heartfelt to a warming drink you press on a guest. **Courage** is what your heart holds. **Accord** is two hearts brought together, **concord** the same, and **discord** is hearts pulled apart. But **record** is the pick of them. Latin **recordārī** meant to remember: *re-* plus *cor(d)-*, "to bring back to the heart", on the ancient view that memory lived in the chest rather than the skull. The later senses — a written record, a vinyl record, a world record — all grew out of "a thing that helps you remember".
And Spanish kept the original meaning. **Recordar** is still the plain daily verb for remembering, while English *record* wandered off into filing cabinets and turntables.
Clear one collision before it catches you. That *-razón* at the end is not the word *razón*. **Razón** descends from Latin *ratiō*, from *rērī*, "to reckon", which also gave English **ratio**, **reason** and **rational**. What *corazón* holds is *cor* with an ending fastened on. The overlap is an accident of sound.

What you've built

You can name what is under the skin and what moves through it: *el pecho*, *la sangre*, *el corazón*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el corazón*
- *un corazón*
- *el corazón y la sangre*

Before you move on

What does *record* literally mean? (To bring a thing back to the heart.) And is *corazón* made of *co-* plus *razón*? (No — it is *cor* with a Spanish ending; *razón* is a different root entirely.)

Chapter 365

How Tall, How Long, How Full

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say alto, largo, ancho, corto and lleno, and put a measurement on a thing in words rather than numbers.
>
> *Complete ES-C365-lleno: describe a thing by height, length, width and how much is in it.*

365.1 alto — high, and deep as well

Say *the finger*, then *the heart*. (*El dedo*; *el corazón*.)

What to know first

- la montaña — the tallest thing you have named so far, and the first thing you will call *alto*.
- grande — the size word you already own, so you can feel where *alto* is narrower than it.

Sounds you'll need

- *AL-to*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *l* is light and forward, never swallowed the way an English *l* is at the end of *tall*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

alto — "high, tall."
Latin **altus** meant high. It also meant deep. A Roman writer could use the one adjective for a tower and for a trench in the sea, because *altus* measured how far a thing ran along the up-down line without saying which end you were standing at. Spanish kept the upward half. English kept a memory of the other half in **the high seas**, which are not tall. English owns the word several times over, and by several doors:

- **altitude** came straight across from the Latin;
- to **exalt** is to raise a thing up;
- **enhance** arrived through Old French *enhaucier*, from a late Latin *inaltiāre*, "to make higher";
- **haughty** is French *haut*, "high", with an English *-gh-* pushed in centuries later by scribes who liked the look of it. Someone haughty is carrying their head high.

The prettiest one is an instrument. French named a woodwind *hautbois* — *haut* "high" plus *bois* "wood", the high-pitched one. English borrowed that word once, as **hautboy**. Then it borrowed the same word a second time, after the Italians had respelled it, and that second helping is the **oboe** in every orchestra. One French word, two doors, two English words.
Carry one warning. If someone shouts **¡Alto!** at you in Spanish it means "Stop!" — and that is not this word. It came in from Germanic by way of Italian, a relative of German *halt*. Two spellings alike, two families.

What you've built

You can now say how tall a thing stands: *alto*, and *muy alto* when it towers.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *alto*

- *muy alto*
- *el árbol es alto*

Before you move on

What two directions did Latin *altus* cover? (High and deep.) And what is an *oboe* taken apart? (French *hautbois*, high wood.)

365.2 largo — the false friend that means long

Say *the heart*, then *tall*. (*El corazón*; *alto*.)

What to know first

- el metro — the unit you measure a *largo* thing in.
- el camino — the first noun most learners want to call *largo*.

Sounds you'll need

- *LAR-go*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* is one flick of the tongue, and the *g* is hard, the *g* of *gato*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

largo — "long."
Latin **largus** did not mean big, and it did not mean long. It meant **abundant, open-handed, generous**. A *largus* host poured freely. That adjective went into Old French, and out of Old French into English as **large**. Watch what English did with it. Abundant became broad. Broad became big. Today *large* is the plain word for size, and nothing about it sounds generous any more — except in one fossil, **largesse**, money or favour handed out lavishly. That fossil is how we know where the word began.
Spanish took the very same adjective down a different road. Abundant became extended; extended became **long**. Spanish already had an inherited word for long, *luengo*, worn down from Latin *longus*, and *largo* elbowed it so far aside that *luengo* now sounds like something out of an old ballad.
One Latin adjective, two languages, two narrowings — and a trap that

catches most beginners. **Una casa larga** is a house that runs back a long way. A large house is **una casa grande**. Reach for *largo* when you mean big and your listener will picture a corridor.
(English **grand** is Latin *grandis*, which has done its own drifting, from full-grown to imposing.)
Musicians know the word already without knowing it. A passage marked **largo** is played slowly, stretched out — long.

What you've built

You can now call a thing long without accidentally calling it big: *largo* for length, *grande* for size.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *largo*
- *muy largo*
- *el camino es largo*

Before you move on

What did Latin *largus* actually mean? (Abundant, generous.) And which English word still keeps that older sense? (*Largesse*.)

365.3 ancho — one Latin word that arrived twice

Say *tall*, then *long*. (*Alto*; *largo*.)

What to know first

- la calle — streets are the thing you most often call *ancha*.
- la puerta — a doorway is where width stops being an abstraction.

Sounds you'll need

- *AN-cho*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ch* is the sound in English *church* — never a *k*, never a *sh*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ancho — "wide."
Latin **amplus** meant spacious, roomy, ample. English has the borrowed branch of this family and uses it constantly: something **ample** is generous in size, to **amplify** is *amplus* plus *facere*, "to make roomy", and the **amplitude** of a wave is how much room the wave takes up.
Spanish has that borrowed branch too. But Spanish also has the word the hard way, worn thin by centuries of people saying it out loud. The middle of *amplus* is a pile of three consonants, *-mpl-*, and that pile did not survive the journey. What came out at the far end was **ancho**. Latin *īnflāre*, "to blow into", came out as *hinchar*, "to swell" — the same pile, the same landing.
Then something worth pausing on. Long after *ancho* had settled into everyday speech, scholars reading Latin reached back and pulled *amplus* into Spanish a second time, this time off the page rather than out of a mouth. That second helping is **amplio**, and it is still in use, in a more bookish register.
So Spanish holds one Latin adjective in two shapes at once: one that walked in and one that was carried in. Nothing demonstrates more cleanly that a word is shaped by the road it took.
A caution for the ear. **Ancla**, an anchor, is Greek *ankyra*. **Anchoa**, an anchovy, is something else again. Three Spanish words opening *anch-*, three unrelated families.

What you've built

You can now measure a thing across as well as up and along: *alto*, *largo*, *ancho*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ancho*

- *muy ancho*
- *la calle es ancha*

Before you move on

What Latin adjective is behind *ancho*? (*Amplus*, spacious.) And why does Spanish also have *amplio*? (It was taken from Latin a second time, straight off the page.)

365.4 corto — short, meaning cut off

Say *long*, then *wide*. (*Largo*; *ancho*.)

What to know first

- el rato — a short while is where a beginner first needs *corto*.
- la hora — the unit that makes a *rato corto* mean something.

Sounds you'll need

- *KOR-to*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* is a hard *k* and the *r* is a single tap against the ridge behind the teeth. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

corto — "short."
Latin **curtus** meant cut off, docked, shortened. It described a thing that had been trimmed, not a thing born small — and Spanish kept both halves of that idea, because *cortar*, "to cut", stands right beside *corto* in the language.
English has two descendants, and both repay a look:

- **curt** is the same adjective with its manners soured. It began as plain "short" and hardened into "so short it is rude."
- **curtail** came in from Middle French *courtault*, a horse whose tail had been docked. English then bent the spelling toward **tail** — a folk guess that happened to land near the truth, since a tail was exactly what got cut. The spelling is telling a story the word's own history never authorised.

Now the words you would swear belong here and do not. English **short**, **shirt** and **skirt** are Germanic to the bone: Old English *sceort*, Old English *scyrte*, Old Norse *skyrta*. They meet *curtus* only far back, at a reconstructed old root for cutting. Distant relatives, not the same word. (**Shirt** and **skirt** are worth a moment on their own: one Germanic word that entered English twice, once natively and once from Norse, and then split into the garment above and the garment below.) One trap left. **El corte**, a cut, belongs to *curtus*. **La corte**, a royal court, is Latin *cohors*, and gives English *court*, *cohort* and *courtesy*. Same letters, different gender, different family.

What you've built

You can now put a length at either end: *largo* when it runs on, *corto* when it stops early.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *corto*
- *un rato corto*
- *el camino es corto*

Before you move on

What did Latin *curtus* mean? (Cut off, docked.) And is English *short* the same word? (No — it is Germanic, a distant relative at best.)

365.5 lleno — full, with its front end changed

Say *wide*, then *short*. (*Ancho*; *corto*.)

What to know first

- la taza — a cup is the first thing you will call *llena*.
- el vaso — and a glass is the second — *el vaso está lleno*.

Sounds you'll need

- *YE-no*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ll* is a *y*, and the *e* stays pure, with no glide sliding off the end of it. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lleno — "full."
Latin **plēnus** meant full. Say *plēnus*, then say *lleno*, and you can hear what became of the front of the word: the *pl-* softened into the sound Spanish spells *ll*. It happened to a small crowd of words together. *Plūvia*, rain, came out as *lluvia*. *Plōrāre*, to weep, came out as *llorar*. *Flamma*, a flame, came out as *llama*. *Clāvis*, a key, came out as *llave*. Hear those four in a row and the shape of the thing arrives on its own. English holds the other side of the family, the borrowed side:

- **plenty**, **plenary** and **replenish** are all fullness;
- **complete** is *complēre*, "to fill up" — a complete thing has been filled;
- **complement**, **supplement** and **deplete** are still filling or emptying.

And the inherited cousin, the one English never needed to borrow because it already had it, is **full**. A Latin *p* facing an English *f*, the same pairing you get in *pater* and *father*.
Here is the trap. English **comply** looks like a sibling of *apply*, *imply* and *reply*. Those three come from *plicāre*, "to fold". *Comply* does not. It comes from *complēre*, filling, reaching English by way of Italian and of Spanish *cumplir*. To comply is to fulfil. Two families that resemble each other only in English spelling.

What you've built

You can now say a container has nothing left to add: *el vaso está lleno.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lleno*

- *el vaso está lleno*
- *la taza está llena*

Before you move on

What Latin word lies under *lleno*? (*Plēnus*, full.) And which English word for filling hides among the folding words? (*Comply* — from *complēre*, not *plicāre*.)

Chapter 366

Around The Room

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la caja, la lámpara, la almohada, la escalera and el armario, and name the furniture of an ordinary room.
>
> *Complete ES-C366-armario: name five things in a room, and say what each of them holds or does.*

366.1 la caja — the box that became the cash

Say *short*, then *full*. (*Corto*; *lleno*.)

What to know first

- la casa — the word *caja* is constantly mistaken for, and is not related to.
- la bolsa — the other thing you carry things in, so the pair sits together.

Sounds you'll need

- *KA-ha*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *j* is the jota, scraped at the back of the throat, and the *c* is a hard *k*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la caja — "the box."
Latin **capsa** was a box, and in particular the cylindrical case a Roman kept scrolls in. English holds it as **case** in the container sense; as **capsule**, which is *capsula*, a little *capsa*; and, arriving through French *châssis*, as **chassis**, the frame a car is built onto.
The route into Spanish deserves a hedge. The *-ps-* in the middle of *capsa* softens into a *sh*-like sound in Catalan and in Occitan, which is how Catalan arrives at *caixa*, and it does not behave that way in Castilian left to itself. So *caja* most likely walked in from the east rather than being inherited straight down the line. The usual account says Catalan or Occitan carried it.
The reward for all this is **cash**. English took *cash* from French *casse* or Italian *cassa*, and for its first stretch of life the English word meant **the money box** — not the money. Only later did the contents take the name of the container. A **cashier** is still the person who minds that box.
Be careful with the other *cashier*, though: the verb, "to dismiss an officer from service." That one came from French *casser*, "to break, to annul", and is not related to the box at all. Two spellings alike, two histories.
And **caja** is no relative of *casa*. Latin *casa* was a hut; it pushed the grander *domus* out of everyday Latin, and it gave English **casino**, "a little house."

What you've built

You can now name a container and say what state it is in: *la caja está llena*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la caja*
- *una caja*
- *la caja está llena*

Before you move on

What did a Latin *capsa* hold? (Scrolls.) And what did English *cash* mean first? (The box, not the money in it.)

366.2 la lámpara — the shining thing with a letter swapped

Say *full*, then *the box*. (*Lleno*; *la caja*.)

What to know first

- la luz — the light itself, before the thing that holds it.
- la noche — when a *lámpara* earns its keep.

Sounds you'll need

- *LAM-pa-ra*, three beats with the weight on the first — the written accent is there to tell you so. Both *r* sounds are single taps. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la lámpara — "the lamp."
Greek **lampein** meant to shine. From it came **lampas**, a torch — light you could carry with you. Latin borrowed the Greek word as *lampada*, and Spanish took it over from Latin.
But listen to what Spanish says now: *LAM-pa-ra*, with an *r* in it. Older Spanish really did say *lámpada*, and the *r* is a repair. The word held two very similar beats sitting close together, and the language traded the second of them for a different sound rather than keep saying both. The *r* in *lámpara* is a substitution, not an inheritance — a small scar you can hear.
English has the family through French. A **lamp** is Old French *lampe*, the same torch. A **lantern** is the Greek *lampter*, a light-holder, which picked up an intrusive *n* passing through Latin and has kept it ever since.
The real prize, though, is elsewhere in Spanish. **Relámpago** — lightning — is this root with a prefix on the front: the shining that

flashes back out of a cloud. The verb *relampaguear* is what a storm does. Learn the lamp and you have quietly learned the lightning as well.
One word does not belong here, however much it wants to. **Lampoon** is French *lampons*, "let us drink", the refrain shouted in old drinking songs. It reached English satire by an entirely separate road, and it is exactly the kind of lookalike that sneaks into a family it has no claim on.

What you've built

You can now name the thing that makes light indoors, and hear its root again in *relámpago*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la lámpara*
- *una lámpara*
- *la lámpara de la casa*

Before you move on

What did Greek *lampein* mean? (To shine.) And why does *lámpara* carry an *r* where older Spanish had a *d*? (Two like sounds sat too close, so one was traded away.)

366.3 la almohada — the Arabic word for your cheek

Say *the box*, then *the lamp*. (*La caja*; *la lámpara*.)

What to know first

- la cama — the *almohada* lives on it.
- el sueño — what the pillow is for.

Sounds you'll need

- *al-mo-A-da*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *h* is silent, doing nothing at all, the way it does nothing in *hermano*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la almohada — "the pillow."
Spanish took this word from Arabic, and it took the Arabic article along with it. Andalusi Arabic **al-mukhadda** came over whole — *al-* means "the" — and Spanish never pried the article off. The same fused *al-* sits at the front of *alcalde*, *alcohol*, *algodón* and *almacén*. When you say *la almohada* you are saying "the" twice, once in each language, and nobody minds.
Underneath the article is **khadd**, "cheek." The *mi-* on the front is the Arabic shape that builds a noun for the tool that does something: *fataha* is "to open", and *miftah* is "a key." So *al-mukhadda* is the cheek-instrument. The thing your cheek goes on.
Now the strange part, and the honest one. This word has **no English relative whatever**. Not a borrowed one, not an inherited one, not even a learned one lurking in a medical dictionary. English *pillow* comes down from Latin *pulvīnus* through Old English, and *cushion* from a Vulgar Latin *coxīnum*. There is nowhere in your English memory to hang *almohada*, which means you get to learn it the plain way: by putting your cheek on it. That happens rarely enough to be worth noticing when it does.
A small note on the article. Learners who have met *el agua* sometimes reach for *el* here. *Agua* takes *el* because its opening *a* is the stressed one; *almohada* carries its weight on *-ha-*, and stays **la almohada**.

What you've built

You can now furnish a bed in Spanish, with a word that came from Arabic and kept its article.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la almohada*

- *una almohada*
- *la almohada de la cama*

Before you move on

What does the *al-* at the front of *almohada* mean? (The — it is the Arabic article.) And what is the word underneath it? (*Khadd*, cheek: the cheek-instrument.)

366.4 la escalera — the ladder that grew a vowel

Say *the lamp*, then *the pillow*. (*La lámpara*; *la almohada*.)

What to know first

- el piso — the *escalera* is what joins one *piso* to the next.
- la escuela — another Spanish word that grew the same opening *e*.

Sounds you'll need

- *es-ka-LE-ra*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *r* is a single tap, never rolled, and the opening *es-* is unhurried. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la escalera — "the stairs, the ladder."
Latin **scāla** was a ladder or a flight of steps, and *scālāria* was the whole staircase. Spanish inherited it — but listen to the front of the Spanish word. Latin opened with *sc-*. Spanish opens with *es-*. A vowel grew there, the same way it grew in *escuela* from *schola*, in *estrella* from *stella*, and in *espada* from *spatha*. Say those three aloud in a row and you can hear Spanish doing the same thing each time it met that opening.
English has the climbing half of the family. To **scale** a wall is to set a *scāla* against it. **Ascend**, **descend** and **transcend** come from *scandere*, "to climb", the verb the ladder-word is built on. And **echelon** is French *échelon*, a rung of a ladder — which is why an echelon of an army, or of a company, is a step that somebody is

standing on above you.
One relative has to be handed over carefully. **Escalate** is not an old descendant of *scāla*. It is a twentieth-century back-formation from **escalator**, and *escalator* was a trademark, registered by the Otis company in 1900 and built to sound Latin. So a conflict that escalates is climbing a machine that a marketing department named.

What you've built

You can now name the way from one floor to the next: *la escalera*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la escalera*
- *una escalera*
- *la escalera del piso*

Before you move on

What was a Latin *scāla*? (A ladder or flight of steps.) And where does English *escalate* really come from? (From *escalator*, an Otis trademark of 1900.)

366.5 el armario — where the gear was kept

Say *the pillow*, then *the stairs*. (*La almohada*; *la escalera*.)

What to know first

- la ropa — what an *armario* is full of.
- la habitación — the room the *armario* stands in.

Sounds you'll need

- *ar-MA-rio*, three beats with the weight on the second. Both *r* sounds are single taps, and the *-rio* runs together into one beat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el armario — "the wardrobe, the cupboard."
Start with the question the word invites: why does a place for keeping clothes begin like *arms*? Because Latin **arma** did not mean weapons. It meant **tools, equipment, gear** — whatever a person needed on hand to do a job. An **armārium** was therefore the place where your gear lived: a chest, a cupboard, a recess fitted into a wall. Monastic libraries had one for their books.
The fighting sense came afterwards, and English mostly inherited that half: **arms** in the military sense, **army** from *armāta*, **armour** from *armātūra*.
The best of the family is **alarm**. Italians shouted *all'arme!* — "to the arms!" — and French and then English borrowed the entire shouted phrase and froze it into a noun. So an alarm clock is a small machine yelling "to arms!" at you before dawn. Spanish has *alarma* from the same cry.
That same Latin *armārium* also went through French as *armoire*, and English borrowed that too. **Armario** and **armoire** are one Latin word that reached English by a different door than the one it took into Spanish.
Two neighbours, sorted out. **Armonía**, harmony, is Greek *harmonia*, and it genuinely is a distant relative of *arma* — both go back to an old root for fitting things together. **Farmacia** is Greek *pharmakon*, a drug, and it is not related at all. The one that looks unrelated is; the one that looks related is not.

What you've built

You can now say where your clothes live: *la ropa está en el armario.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el armario*
- *un armario*
- *la ropa está en el armario*

Before you move on

What did Latin *arma* mean? (Tools and gear, not weapons.) And what is an *alarm* taken literally? (Italian *all'arme* — to the arms!)

Chapter 367

Breakfast, Fruit And Something Sweet

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el desayuno, la fruta, la naranja, la patata and el azúcar, and name the first meal of the day and what goes into it.
>
> *Complete ES-C367-azucar: name the first meal of the day and four things that can go into it.*

367.1 el desayuno — the meal that undoes a fast

Say *the stairs*, then *the wardrobe*. (*La escalera*; *el armario*.)

What to know first

- el pan — what is most often on the plate at this hour.
- el café — the drink beside it.

Sounds you'll need

- *de-sa-YU-no*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *y* here is a consonant, close to the *y* of English *yes*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el desayuno — "breakfast."
Take the word in two pieces. **Ayuno** is a fast — going without food. **Des-** undoes whatever follows it. So *desayuno* is the **un-fasting**: the meal that cancels a night of not eating.
English builds its own word out of exactly that idea, out of Germanic parts rather than Latin ones: **break** plus **fast**. Two languages, two vocabularies, one thought.
Then English does it a second time, by borrowing instead of building. **Dinner** came from Old French *disner*, and behind *disner* stands a late Latin verb meaning to break a fast. *Breakfast* and *dinner* are the same sentence in one language, one half of it homegrown and the other imported — which is how the imported half drifted all the way to the evening without anybody noticing what it said.
The Latin family behind *ayuno* left two more marks on English:

- **jejune** — thin, meagre, unsatisfying. A jejune argument leaves you hungry.
- **the jejunum** — a stretch of the small intestine. Early anatomists opened bodies and kept finding that particular stretch empty, so they called it "the fasting one."

One Latin root for going without: a meal that ends it, a criticism that means it, and a piece of your own body that got the name by accident of dissection.

What you've built

You can now name the first meal of the day: *el desayuno*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el desayuno*
- *un desayuno*
- *el pan del desayuno*

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *desayuno*? (*Des-*, undoing, and *ayuno*, a fast.) And why did anatomists call one stretch of gut the jejunum? (They kept finding it empty.)

367.2 la fruta — what a plant gives you back

Say *the wardrobe*, then *breakfast*. (*El armario*; *el desayuno*.)

What to know first

- la manzana — the one you can already name.
- el árbol — where most of it grows.

Sounds you'll need

- *FRU-ta*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* is a single tap, and the *fr* runs together without a vowel sneaking in between. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la fruta — "fruit."
Latin **frūctus** meant the yield of something — what it produced, what you got out of it. It was built on the verb **fruī**, "to enjoy, to make use of." So a fruit is not first a sweet round thing. It is **the enjoyment a plant hands back** to whoever tended it.
That older sense survives in English wherever *fruit* steps away from the greengrocer: the fruits of your labour, a fruitful meeting, fruitless effort.
Three relatives, and the road each one took matters:

- **fruit** came through Old French, which is why the Latin *-ct-* wore off it;
- **frugal** came through French too, from *frūx*, a sister noun meaning produce or crops. A frugal life is one lived on what the ground actually yields;
- **fructose** was assembled in a laboratory in the nineteenth

century out of the Latin stem and a chemist's ending. Nobody inherited it. It kept the *-ct-* because it was built from the spelling, not passed down by mouth.

There is one more, and it does not look related at all. English **brook**, in *she will brook no argument*, is the inherited Germanic cousin of the same ancient root. It once meant to use or enjoy a thing, and narrowed over centuries to putting up with it. Enjoy and endure, from one starting point.

What you've built

You can now name the class as well as the item: *la manzana es una fruta.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la fruta*
- *una fruta*
- *la manzana es una fruta*

Before you move on

What did Latin *fruī* mean? (To enjoy, to make use of.) And what does a frugal person live on? (What the ground yields.)

367.3 la naranja — the fruit that lent English a colour

Say *breakfast*, then *fruit.* (*El desayuno*; *la fruta.*)

What to know first

- la fruta — the class this one belongs to.
- el color — because in Spanish, as in English, this word does both jobs.

Sounds you'll need

- *na-RAN-ja*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *j* is the scraping sound at the back of the mouth, nothing like an English *j*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la naranja — "the orange."
This word walked to Spain, and you can follow its footprints backwards. Arabic **nāranj**. Persian **nārang**. Sanskrit **nāraṅga**, and probably a loan into Sanskrit before that, from further south in India. Spanish took the Arabic form with its first *n* still on the front. English got the same word and dropped that *n*. Somewhere in Romance the phrase was reheard: **a norange** turned into **an orange**, and the consonant walked across to the article. That is a reconstruction rather than a recorded event, but English has done the identical thing to itself twice where the paperwork survives:

- **an apron** was once *a napron*;
- **a newt** was once *an ewte*, and took an *n* it had no right to.

Portuguese has **laranja**, with an *l* where Spanish has *n*. Nobody has a convincing account of why, and the honest thing is to notice it rather than explain it.
Now the part people find hard to believe. The **colour** is named after the **fruit**. English has no record of the word as a colour until the sixteenth century, because before the fruit came north there was no ordinary word for that shade — writers reached for compounds of yellow and red. A carrot, a sunset and a traffic cone are all named after a piece of fruit.

What you've built

You can now name a fruit and a colour with one word: *la naranja*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la naranja*

- *una naranja*
- *la naranja es una fruta*

Before you move on

Which language did *naranja* reach Spanish from? (Arabic.) And which came first in English, the fruit or the colour? (The fruit — the colour was named after it.)

367.4 la patata — two American words in one

Say *fruit*, then *the orange*. (*La fruta*; *la naranja*.)

What to know first

- la comida — what this ends up inside.
- la tierra — where it grows, out of sight.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-TA-ta*, three beats with the weight on the second. Both *t* sounds are made with the tongue against the teeth, softer than an English *t*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la patata — "the potato."
Two plants, two American languages, one Spanish word — and a muddle nobody ever tidied up.
Batata is Taíno, an Arawakan language of the Caribbean islands, and it named the **sweet** potato. **Papa** is Quechua, from the Andes, and it named the tuber you would recognise as a potato. Spanish met both plants within a few decades of each other, and the standard reading of *patata* is that the two names ran together.
The muddle is still on the map. Much of Latin America says **papa** and holds the two plants apart with separate words. Spain says *patata* for the ordinary one. Both are Spanish; neither is a mistake, and you will be understood either way.
English took *patata* and made **potato** of it — and for its first decades

in English, a potato was the **sweet** one. The white potato borrowed the name afterwards, from the plant that had it first.
One warning worth carrying. Quechua *papa*, the tuber, has nothing to do with **papá**, father. That one is a nursery word, the sound a small child makes early, and dozens of unrelated languages arrived at it on their own.

What you've built

You can now name what grows underground: *la patata*, and *la papa* where they say it that way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la patata*
- *una patata*
- *la patata está en la tierra*

Before you move on

Which two American languages are read into *patata*? (Taíno and Quechua.) And which plant did English call a potato first? (The sweet potato.)

367.5 el azúcar — the article that came along with the word

Say *the orange*, then *the potato*. (*La naranja*; *la patata*.)

What to know first

- la miel — what sweetened food before this arrived.
- el café — the usual reason to reach for it.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-ZÚ-car*, three beats with the weight on the second, which is why the accent is written: a word ending in *-r* would otherwise carry its weight at the end. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el azúcar — "sugar."
Start with the front of the word, because the front of the word is not part of the word.
Arabic marks a definite noun with **al-**, and before certain letters that *l* assimilates to whatever follows. Before *s* it becomes **as-**. Arabic for the sugar is **as-sukkar**, and Spanish borrowed the whole phrase without noticing the seam. So *el azúcar* carries two definite articles stacked on one noun, a Spanish one and an Arabic one.
Behind the Arabic stands a Persian form, and behind that Sanskrit **śarkarā**, which meant **grit, gravel**. Somebody looked at a heap of dried sugar, broken up for carrying, and reached for the word for coarse sand.
English **sugar** is the same eastern word, but it arrived through French rather than through Spanish — which is why English kept the sugar and left the article behind.
And English holds that Sanskrit word a second time, from the other end of the sea route: **jaggery**, the dark palm sugar, came through the languages of south India and then Portuguese. Two borrowings of one word, centuries apart, arriving from opposite directions.

What you've built

You can now say how you take it: *con azúcar*, *sin azúcar*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el azúcar*
- *con azúcar*
- *un café con azúcar*

Before you move on

What is the *a-* at the front of *azúcar*? (The Arabic article *al-*, assimilated to *as-*.) And what did Sanskrit *śarkarā* mean? (Grit, gravel.)

Chapter 368

Five Animals, Two Of Them Small

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la abeja, la mosca, el cerdo, el lobo and el toro, and name five animals a field might hold.
>
> *Complete ES-C368-toro: name five animals, two of them small enough to sit on a hand.*

368.1 la abeja — the little one that outlived the big one

Say *the potato*, then *sugar*. (*La patata*; *el azúcar*.)

What to know first

- la miel — what she makes.
- la flor — where she works.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-BE-ja*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *b* between vowels is soft, the lips barely meeting, and the *j* scrapes at the back. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la abeja — "the bee."
Latin had a perfectly good word for a bee: **apis**. Spanish does not use it. *Abeja* comes from **apicula**, which is *apis* with a diminutive ending — "the little bee."
That happened more than once, and once you notice it you will keep meeting it:

- **oveja**, a sheep, comes from *ovicula*, the little *ovis*;
- **oreja**, an ear, comes from *auricula*, the little *auris*.

In each pair the plain Latin noun died in Spanish and the affectionate small form took over the ordinary job. Whatever the Romans were doing when they talked about their animals and their bodies, they were doing it in diminutives, and the diminutive is what survived.
One word that looks like it belongs in that list does not. **Conejo**, a rabbit, comes from Latin *cunīculus*, which **has** the diminutive ending but no base noun anywhere behind it — Latin most likely borrowed the whole word from an older language of Spain. It is a shape, not a formation.
English went the other way and took the plain **apis** for its bookish words: an **apiary** is a bee-yard, **apiculture** is bee-keeping. So one Latin noun ended up split between two languages, Spanish holding the small form and English the large one.
English **bee** is a different word entirely, Germanic, with no link to *apis*. And *apis* itself is a puzzle: it has no convincing ancestry in the older layers of Latin's own family, and looks like a word the Romans picked up from someone who was in Italy before them.

What you've built

You can now name the maker as well as what she makes: *la abeja hace la miel.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la abeja*

- *una abeja*
- *la abeja hace la miel*

Before you move on

What does *abeja* come from, *apis* or *apicula*? (*Apicula*, the little one.) And what is an apiary? (A place for bees.)

368.2 la mosca — the fly that became a gun

Say *sugar*, then *the bee*. (*El azúcar*; *la abeja*.)

What to know first

- la comida — what a *mosca* comes for.
- la sopa — the classic place to find one.

Sounds you'll need

- *MOS-ca*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *sc* is a clean *s* against a hard *k*, with no vowel between them. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la mosca — "the fly."
Latin **musca**, straight down, no complications. The interesting part is what grew out of it.
Spanish makes small things with **-ito**, so a little *mosca* is a **mosquito**. English borrowed that word entire — Spanish ending and all — which is why an English speaker is carrying a Spanish diminutive around without knowing it. Say *mosquito* and you have said "little fly" in Spanish.
Now the strange one. French made its own small form of *musca* and gave it to a bird: the **sparrowhawk**, small, and speckled when it moves. Firearms of that century were routinely named after hunting birds — the **falcon** and the **falconet** were both cannon — and the little-hawk name went to a shoulder gun. English took it from French as **musket**.

So the chain runs: fly, little fly, small hawk, gun. A musket is a mosquito with a longer barrel.
One more relative, offered with a caution. Greek *muia* and English **midge** are usually placed alongside *musca* far back in the family tree. But a word for a small buzzing insect is exactly the kind of word a language invents afresh out of the noise the thing makes, so a resemblance here proves less than the same resemblance would prove elsewhere.

What you've built

You can now name the household nuisance: *la mosca*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la mosca*
- *una mosca*
- *hay una mosca en la sopa*

Before you move on

What does *mosquito* mean taken apart? (Little fly.) And what animal stands between the fly and the gun? (The sparrowhawk.)

368.3 el cerdo — the animal named after its hair

Say *the bee*, then *the fly*. (*La abeja*; *la mosca*.)

What to know first

- la granja — where you meet one.
- la carne — what it turns into.

Sounds you'll need

- *CER-do*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *e* is soft, and the *d* after *r* is gentle, closer to the *th* of English *this*.

→ pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cerdo — "the pig."
This animal has two names in Spanish, and the ordinary one is the odd one.
Cerda is a coarse bristle — the stiff hair a pig has instead of fur. Farmers spoke of *ganado de la cerda*, the bristle livestock, and over a few centuries the herd's nickname squeezed out the animal's name. A *cerdo* is "the bristly one." Where *cerda* itself came from is argued over: one account takes it to a Latin word for a tuft of hair, another to a Latin word for a stiff bristle, and neither has won.
The name it pushed aside is still standing. Latin **porcus** came down into Spanish perfectly regularly as **puerco**, which nobody has to be taught and everybody understands. *Cerdo* did not replace it; it took the neutral, unremarkable slot and left *puerco* the blunter one.
English holds that same *porcus* twice over, arriving by two different doors:

- **pork** came in from French, which is why English eats *pork* and keeps a *pig*;
- **farrow**, a litter of piglets, was never borrowed at all. It came down the Germanic line from the same ancient word *porcus* came down the Latin line.

Two languages, one old word for a pig, and in each of them a second word elbowing in beside it.

What you've built

You can now name the farm animal and its meat: *el cerdo*, *la carne de cerdo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cerdo*
- *un cerdo*

- *la carne de cerdo*

Before you move on

What does *cerda* mean? (A bristle.) And what is the Spanish word that comes straight from Latin *porcus*? (*Puerco.*)

368.4 el lobo — the wolf that came in from the next valley

Say *the fly*, then *the pig*. (*La mosca*; *el cerdo.*)

What to know first

- el bosque — where he lives.
- la oveja — what he is counted against.

Sounds you'll need

- *LO-bo*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *b* between vowels is soft; the lips come close without quite closing. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el lobo — "the wolf."
Lobo is Latin **lupus**, and *lupus* is where the story gets strange, because *lupus* is not the shape Latin should have ended up with.
Languages change sound by sound, and the changes are regular enough that a scholar can predict what a word ought to look like. Run the ancient word for a wolf through Latin's own machinery and you do not get *lupus*. You get something else. English **wolf** is the shape that comes out when the same ancient word goes through the Germanic machinery instead, and it behaves.
The usual explanation is that Rome did not inherit this word. It **borrowed** it from a neighbouring language of Italy — a related one, spoken up the road, in which that consonant turning into a *p* was the ordinary outcome. Latin took its wolf from the next valley and kept it. That is the mainstream account, not a proven one; another proposal starts the word from an old name for the marten instead and has

trouble with the meaning. What everyone agrees on is the shape being wrong for a word Latin grew itself.
English also holds *lupus* directly, borrowed centuries later off the page: **lupine** for anything wolf-like, and **lupus** for the illness, named for the way the rash was thought to eat at a face.

What you've built

You can now put the two animals in one sentence: *el lobo y la oveja.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el lobo*
- *un lobo*
- *el lobo está en el bosque*

Before you move on

Why is *lupus* thought to be a borrowing? (Its shape is wrong for a word Latin inherited.) And which English word is the cousin that stayed home? (*Wolf.*)

368.5 el toro — the word that predates the languages that carry it

Say *the pig*, then *the wolf.* (*El cerdo*; *el lobo.*)

What to know first

- la vaca — his counterpart.
- el campo — where the two of them stand.

Sounds you'll need

- *TO-ro*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *t* touches the teeth and the *r* is a single tap, not a roll. → pronunciation

reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el toro — "the bull."
Toro is Latin **taurus**, and *taurus* is a traveller.
Something very close to it turns up in Greek, in the Celtic languages, and further east as well. That looks at first like a family resemblance — cousins who inherited the word from one ancestor. But the shapes do not line up the way inherited words line up. They agree too well in some places and not well enough in others.
The reading most scholars now take is that this is a **wandering word**: not inherited by any of them, but picked up from a language spoken around the Mediterranean before any of these languages arrived, and passed hand to hand along with the animal. A bull is a valuable thing to trade, and a traded thing brings its name.
English carries the Latin form in two ways. **Taurus** is the constellation and the zodiac sign, borrowed off the page. **Toreador** came from Spanish with the bullring attached.
And English **steer**, the ox, is sometimes filed with *taurus* and sometimes kept apart, depending on whose reconstruction you follow. That disagreement is not a gap in the scholarship. It is what a word looks like when it is older than the families trying to claim it.

What you've built

You can now name both animals in the field: *el toro y la vaca.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el toro*
- *un toro*
- *el toro está en el campo*

Before you move on

Why is *taurus* called a wandering word? (It travelled between languages instead of being inherited by them.) And what does *Taurus* name in the sky? (The constellation, the bull.)

Chapter 369

The River, The Sand And The Ash

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el río, la arena, el polvo, el humo and la ceniza, and name what the ground carries and what a fire leaves.
>
> *Complete ES-C369-ceniza: name what the ground carries and what a fire leaves behind.*

369.1 el río — and the English river that is not the same word

Say *the wolf*, then *the bull*. (*El lobo*; *el toro*.)

What to know first

- el agua — what runs in it.
- el valle — the shape it cuts.

Sounds you'll need

- *RÍ-o*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* at the start of a word is rolled, and the written accent keeps the *i* and the *o* apart as two separate beats. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el río — "the river."
Río is Latin **rīvus**, a stream. English has two words from it, and both still carry the water:

- a **rival** is *rīvālis*, one of the people drawing on the **same stream**. Share a watercourse with a neighbour and you will eventually disagree about it, and the Romans built that observation into a noun;
- to **derive** is *dērīvāre*, to lead water **off** a channel. A derived word has been drawn off from an earlier one the way a ditch is drawn off a river.

Now the part worth slowing down for. English **river** is **not** this word. *River* came through Old French from a different Latin noun, **rīpa**, which means a **bank** — the edge, not the water. The French word named the land along the water first and slid across to the water itself later. And that same *rīpa* sits inside **arrive**, which began as *ad rīpam*, "to the shore": to arrive was to reach the bank.
So English **river** belongs with **arrive**, and Spanish **río** belongs with **rival**. Two words that look alike, mean almost the same thing, and come from two Latin nouns with no relationship to each other at all. This is the trap the whole business of etymology exists to catch. Resemblance is not descent. *Río* and *river* have four letters in common and nothing else.

What you've built

You can now name the water in the landscape: *el río está en el valle.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el río*
- *un río*
- *el río está en el valle*

Before you move on

What is a rival, taken literally? (Someone drawing on the same stream.) And is English *river* the same word as *río*? (No — it comes from *rīpa*, a bank, like *arrive*.)

369.2 la arena — the sand that gave its name to the building

Say *the bull*, then *the river*. (*El toro*; *el río*.)

What to know first

- el mar — what puts it there.
- la orilla — the strip it covers.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-RE-na*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *r* between vowels is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la arena — "sand."
Latin **harēna**, sand — and after that the trail goes cold. This is one of the words where the reference books shrug.
The standing guess is Etruscan, the language of the people Rome grew up beside, on the grounds that the ending looks Etruscan. The other piece of evidence is a form **fasēna**, which the Roman scholar Varro reports as the Sabine version of the word. Neither has ever been made to prove anything, and the verdict printed in the best modern dictionary of Latin origins is: unknown.
So keep the word and let the ancestry go. It is worth meeting a word that nobody can trace, because most vocabularies contain a few and it is honest to say which ones they are.
What the word did next is well documented. A Roman amphitheatre had **sand** spread across its floor, to give footing and to soak up what got spilled on it. People called the floor by the name of what was on it. Then they called the whole building that. English **arena** is that Latin

word for sand, and every political arena, every sporting arena, is named after a surface.
Spanish kept both jobs. *La arena* is the beach, and *la arena* is the bullring.

What you've built

You can now name what the beach is made of: *la arena*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la arena*
- *la arena del mar*
- *hay arena en la orilla*

Before you move on

What was spread on the floor of a Roman amphitheatre? (Sand.) And what is the honest answer about where *harēna* came from? (Nobody knows.)

369.3 el polvo — one Latin word, two English roads

Say *the river*, then *sand*. (*El río*; *la arena*.)

What to know first

- la tierra — what it comes off.
- limpio — its opposite, in one word.

Sounds you'll need

- *POL-vo*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *v* is pronounced the same as a Spanish *b*, with the lips barely meeting. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el polvo — "dust."
Latin **pulvis**, with the stem *pulver-*: dust, powder, the fine stuff left when something has been ground or has fallen apart.
English took that word twice, and the two arrivals do not look alike:

- **powder** came through Old French *poudre*. French had put a **d** into it that Latin never had — the sort of consonant that grows between an *l* and an *r* because it is easier to say than to avoid;
- **pulverize** was taken off the written Latin stem centuries later, so it still has the *v* and no *d* at all.

German kept both and gave each a separate job, which makes the split easy to hold on to: **Puder** is the powder for a face, borrowed from French with the *d*; **Pulver** is gunpowder, taken from the Latin with the *v*. Same word, two doors, two meanings, no confusion.
One connection you may be offered elsewhere is worth declining. **Pollen** is sometimes filed with *pulvis*, on the grounds that both are fine ground stuff. Specialists doubt it, and the objection is a good one: flour and dust are what you get at the two ends of the same milling, and words for them do not reliably share ancestors.

What you've built

You can now describe what settles on a shelf: *hay polvo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el polvo*
- *hay polvo*
- *la mesa tiene polvo*

Before you move on

Which of *powder* and *pulverize* came through French? (*Powder* — and French added the *d*.) And which German word is gunpowder?

(*Pulver.*)

369.4 el humo — an f that turned into a silent h

Say *sand*, then *dust*. (*La arena*; *el polvo.*)

What to know first

- el fuego — what makes it.
- la nube — what it looks like from far off.

Sounds you'll need

- *HU-mo*, two beats with the weight on the first, and the *h* is completely silent — the word begins on the *u*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el humo — "smoke."
Latin **fūmus**, smoke. Spanish writes **humo**, with a silent *h* where the *f* was.
That *h* is a gravestone. At one stage Spanish said *fumo*, then softened the *f* to a breath, then stopped pronouncing the breath, and kept writing the letter anyway. Medieval texts catch the word mid-fall: *fumo* on the page long after speakers had begun to let it go. The same change carried Latin *facere* to **hacer** and *filium* to **hijo**.
English never had that change, so English still has the *f* wherever it took the word off the Latin:

- **fume** — the vapour itself, and by extension the temper of somebody fuming;
- **fumigate** — to treat a place with smoke;
- **fumitory** — a small plant whose name means *fūmus terrae*, smoke of the earth, for its grey-green haze low to the ground.

The best of them is **perfume**: *per* plus the smoke, "through smoke." A perfume was what rose off something burning, and the first English uses of the word mean precisely that — the fumes of a burning

substance, incense in a room, not a bottle on a shelf. The bottle came later and kept the word for smoke.

What you've built

You can now say what a fire sends up: *hay humo.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el humo*
- *hay humo*
- *el fuego hace humo*

Before you move on

Which Latin letter is the *h* of *humo* standing in for? (*F.*) And what did a perfume originally mean? (Something that rose off a fire — through smoke.)

369.5 la ceniza — and the cinder that is wearing a costume

Say *dust*, then *smoke*. (*El polvo*; *el humo.*)

What to know first

- el fuego — what leaves it behind.
- el humo — the other thing a fire sends out.

Sounds you'll need

- *ce-NI-za*, three beats with the weight on the second. Both the *c* and the *z* are the same sound in one accent or another — a soft *th* in much of Spain, an *s* across the Americas. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la ceniza — "ash."
Latin **cinis**, with the stem *ciner-*: ashes. A late spoken form built on it gave Spanish *ceniza*. English has the same Latin word wherever it borrowed off the page — to **incinerate** is to reduce to ashes, and a **cinerary** urn holds what is left after one.
So English **cinder** must belong here too. It does not.
Cinder is Old English *sinder*, and it meant the **slag** that comes off iron — a Germanic word, no Latin in it anywhere. It began with an *s*. Then French *cendre*, the genuine descendant of *cinis*, was sitting nearby in the same language, meaning nearly the same thing, and English respelled its own native word with a *c* to match. The costume has been on for so long that the word looks Latin to everybody who meets it.
That is worth holding on to, because it is the reverse of the usual mistake. Words that look unrelated often are related. This is one that looks related and is not, and the resemblance was applied on purpose by scribes.
The girl in the ashes carries the honest version. French calls her **Cendrillon**, from *cendre*; Spanish calls her **Cenicienta**, from *ceniza*; German calls her **Aschenputtel**, from *Asche*. Three languages naming her after the hearth she sleeps by, each out of its own word for ash.

What you've built

You can now name what a fire leaves: *la ceniza*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la ceniza*
- *la ceniza del fuego*
- *hay ceniza*

Before you move on

Is English *cinder* from the same word as *ceniza*? (No — it is Germanic, only respelled to look Latin.) And what is *Cenicienta*

named after? (*La ceniza*, the ash.)

Chapter 370

Storm, Thunder And Ice

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la tormenta, el trueno, el hielo, la cueva and la costa, and say what the weather is doing and where I am standing while it does it.
>
> *Complete ES-C370-costa: say what the weather is doing and where you are standing while it does it.*

370.1 la tormenta — weather that wrings the sky

Say *smoke*, then *ash*. (*El humo*; *la ceniza*.)

What to know first

- la nube — what one is made of.
- el viento — what arrives with it.

Sounds you'll need

- *tor-MEN-ta*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *r* before the *m* is a single tap, not a roll. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la tormenta — "the storm."
Behind it is Latin **torquēre**, to twist or wring, and a noun **tormentum** built from it: a twisting.

A *tormentum* was first a machine. Roman artillery stored its power in ropes of twisted sinew, wound tighter and tighter until they were let go. The twisting was the engine.
From there the word travels by short steps, and English took a piece at each stop:

- **torment** and **torture** — what a twisting machine does to a person;
- **contort** and **distort** — twisted out of shape;
- **tortuous** — a road that twists;
- **torque** — the engineer's word for twisting force, taken off the Latin in the nineteenth century when machines needed a name for it again.

And *tormenta*, the weather. A storm is the sky being wrung.
One caution, because it catches people. Spanish **torno** and **turno** look as though they belong to this family and do not. They come from a Greek word for a **lathe**, a completely separate line. Turning and twisting are near enough in sense to make the mistake feel safe, which is exactly why it is not.

What you've built

You can now say what the weather is doing: *hay tormenta.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la tormenta*
- *hay tormenta*
- *una tormenta con viento*

Before you move on

What did a Roman *tormentum* twist? (Ropes of sinew, in a catapult.) And do *torno* and *turno* belong to this family? (No —

they come from a Greek word for a lathe.)

370.2 el trueno — the noise that reshaped an English word

Say *ash*, then *the storm*. (*La ceniza*; *la tormenta*.)

What to know first

- la tormenta — what brings it.
- la luz — the flash that comes first.

Sounds you'll need

- *TRUE-no*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ue* is one glide, not two beats, and the *tr* runs together. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el trueno — "thunder."
The verb is **tronar**, to thunder, and it comes straight from Latin **tonāre**. The noun *trueno* comes from a Latin noun for a thunderclap — with an extra *r* that wandered in from a neighbouring Latin word for thunder and never left. Words borrow letters from their neighbours the way people borrow habits.
English holds *tonāre* in three places, and only the first is obvious:

- **detonate** — to thunder down;
- **astonish** — from a late Latin compound meaning to thunder **at** somebody. To astonish was to leave a person the way a thunderclap leaves them;
- **stun** — the same word again, worn shorter on its way through French. To stun and to astonish are one word at two lengths.

English **thunder** is not borrowed at all. It came down the Germanic line from the same ancient root, which is also where the god **Thor** gets his name — the thunderer.

The best of the family is one English took **from Spanish and got wrong**. A *tronada* is a thunderstorm. English sailors brought the word home, and somewhere along the way its letters were shuffled into **tornado** — most likely under the pull of *tornar*, "to turn," a different Spanish word that happened to describe exactly what the wind was doing. A mishearing that improved the word.

What you've built

You can now name both halves of a storm: *el trueno y la luz*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el trueno*
- *un trueno*
- *hay truenos en la tormenta*

Before you move on

Which English word is *astonish* the shorter twin of? (*Stun.*) And what Spanish word is *tornado* a mangling of? (*Tronada*, a thunderstorm.)

370.3 el hielo — an h that stands for nothing

Say *the storm*, then *thunder*. (*La tormenta*; *el trueno*.)

What to know first

- la nieve — its softer neighbour.
- el frío — the condition that makes it.

Sounds you'll need

- *HIE-lo*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *h* is silent and the *ie* is one glide, so the word starts on a *y*-like sound. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el hielo — "ice."
Latin **gelū**, frost. English has the family wherever something sets as it cools:

- **gelid**, taken straight off the Latin, meaning icy;
- **congeal**, to freeze together, through French;
- **jelly**, through French *gelée*, a thing that has set;
- **gelatin**, through Italian and then French — the same word again, arriving a third time by a third road.

Now the letter at the front, because it is a different animal from the *h* on *humo*.
Humo has an *h* standing in for a Latin **f**. *Hielo* does not: *gelū* has no *f* in it anywhere. That *h* is a **spelling habit**. Medieval scribes wrote *u* and *v* with the same letter, so a word beginning *ue-* was liable to be read as though it began with a consonant. Sticking an *h* on the front settled the question, and the habit spread to *ie-* as well.
That is why **huevo** and **hueso** carry one too. Latin *ōvum* and *ossum* have no *f* to stand for either.
So Spanish has two silent *h*'s doing two unrelated jobs. Do not generalise from one to the other: **hierro**, iron, comes from *ferrum*, and its *h* is the *humo* kind after all.
One relative that will not come quietly: **glaciar**. It looks like it belongs with *hielo*, and specialists cannot show that it does — the Latin word behind it resists being derived from *gelū*. Near in meaning, unproven in ancestry.

What you've built

You can now name what cold water becomes: *el hielo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el hielo*
- *con hielo*

- *un café con hielo*

Before you move on

Does the *h* of *hielo* stand in for a Latin *f*? (No — it is a spelling habit, like the one on *huevo*.) And what does *jelly* have in common with *hielo*? (Both come from *gelū*.)

370.4 la cueva — the hollow, and one word that only looks hollow

Say *thunder*, then *ice*. (*El trueno*; *el hielo*.)

What to know first

- la montaña — what one is usually inside.
- la sombra — what there is a lot of in there.

Sounds you'll need

- *CUE-va*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *cu-* is a hard *k* with a *w* glide, and the *v* is the same soft sound as a Spanish *b*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cueva — "the cave."
Latin **cavus** meant hollow. Spoken Latin also had a variant **cova**, and that is what Spanish grew *cueva* out of — the stressed vowel breaking into *ue*, which is why the word has a glide the Latin never did.
The family is wide, and every member is still hollow:

- **cave** itself, which reached English through French;
- **cavity** and **excavate**, taken off the Latin;
- **cage**, from *cavea*, a hollow enclosure for keeping animals;
- **gabion**, the wicker basket packed with earth that soldiers stack for cover — the same *cavea*, come through Italian, still a hollow container.

And then the one to refuse. English **cove** — a small sheltered bay — looks like it must be *cova* with the vowel worn down. It is not. *Cove* is Old English *cofa*, a small chamber, a Germanic word with no Latin in it; the seaside meaning is a late arrival, not turning up until the sixteenth century.
Two words for a hollow place, from two families, meeting in the middle by accident. Spanish caves and English coves are neighbours who are not related.

What you've built

You can now say where the shelter is: *la cueva está en la montaña.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cueva*
- *una cueva*
- *la cueva está en la montaña*

Before you move on

What did Latin *cavus* mean? (Hollow.) And is English *cove* from the same word? (No — it is Germanic, *cofa*, a small chamber.)

370.5 la costa — the country's rib

Say *ice*, then *the cave*. (*El hielo*; *la cueva*.)

What to know first

- el mar — what it holds back.
- la isla — a place that is all of it.

Sounds you'll need

- *COS-ta*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *st* is a clean *s* against a *t* on the teeth, with no vowel in front of the *s*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la costa — "the coast."
Latin **costa** is a **rib**. Not the sea, not the shore — a bone in your side. The step to a coastline is a picture rather than a definition. A rib is the **side** of a body; a coast is the side of a country. English took the same picture and uses it every day without opening it up:

- **coast**, from the Latin through French;
- **intercostal**, the muscles between the ribs, straight off the Latin;
- to **accost** — *ad* plus *costa*, to come up alongside. You accost somebody by arriving at their side;
- **cutlet**, which is French *côtelette*, a diminutive of a diminutive: a little little rib. English speakers pulled its first syllable towards **cut** because a cutlet is something cut, and the word has looked like that ever since.

There is a footnote about the Spanish word itself. *Costa* did not come down the inherited line into Castilian; it was taken in from a neighbouring language of the peninsula. The form that **did** come down the inherited line is **cuesta**, a slope — with the broken vowel that marks an inherited word. One Latin rib, two Spanish words, and the diphthong tells you which is which.
Two neighbours that are nothing to do with it: **cosa**, a thing, and **cosecha**, a harvest. Both begin the same and neither is a relative.

What you've built

You can now say where the land stops: *la costa del mar*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la costa*
- *la costa del mar*
- *la casa está en la costa*

Before you move on

What does Latin *costa* mean? (A rib.) And which Spanish word is the inherited form of it? (*Cuesta*, a slope.)

Chapter 371

Small, Fat, Young, Slow, Sweet

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say pequeño, gordo, joven, lento and dulce, and put five more judgements on a thing without reaching for a number.
>
> *Complete ES-C371-dulce: put five judgements on a thing without reaching for a number.*

371.1 pequeño — the word with no ancestors

Say *the cave*, then *the coast*. (*La cueva*; *la costa*.)

What to know first

- grande — the word this one answers.
- el tamaño — what both of them are about.

Sounds you'll need

- *pe-QUE-ño*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *qu* is a hard *k*, and the *ñ* is the *ny* of English *canyon*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pequeño — "small."
Nearly every word in this book has a Latin ancestor standing behind

it. This one does not, and the Spanish dictionary of record says so in as many words: an **expressive** word, common to all the Romance languages, with no etymon given.

What that means is worth unpacking, because it is not a confession of ignorance. Some words are not inherited. They are **made**, over and over, out of the sounds people reach for when they are talking to something small — a child, an animal, a thing they are fond of. Across the Romance languages those sounds cluster around a tight little syllable of the *pikk-* or *pitt-* shape.

Italian **piccolo**. French **petit**. Spanish **pequeño**. They are not three descendants of one Latin word. They are three separate helpings from the same nursery cupboard.

English then borrowed two of them and can now say the idea three ways: **small** from its own stock, **petite** from French, and the **piccolo**, the little flute, from Italian.

Take the lesson as well as the word. An etymology that ends in *nobody knows* is sometimes a gap in the record, and sometimes it is the answer: this word was never handed down, so there is nothing upstream to find.

What you've built

You can now set the two sizes against each other: *grande* and *pequeño*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pequeño*
- *muy pequeño*
- *una casa pequeña*

Before you move on

Does *pequeño* have a Latin ancestor? (No — it is an expressive word with no etymon.) And which two Romance small-words did English borrow? (*Petite* and *piccolo*.)

371.2 gordo — the word that may have gone to Rome and come back

Say *the coast*, then *small*. (*La costa*; *pequeño*.)

What to know first

- delgado / flaco — the two words this one answers.
- la carne — where the idea usually lands.

Sounds you'll need

- *GOR-do*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *g* is hard, and the *d* after *r* is soft, closer to the *th* of English *this*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gordo — "fat."
Latin **gurdus** did not mean fat. It meant **dull, blunt, thick-witted** — an insult about a mind rather than a body.
It comes with a footnote from a Roman who noticed it. Quintilian, writing about words that had come into Latin from elsewhere, mentions *gurdi*, which ordinary people say for stupid, and adds: **I have heard it took its origin from Spain.**
Read the verb carefully. He heard it. He is passing on a report, not making a finding, and nobody since has been able to prove or disprove him. But if he is right, then *gordo* is a word that left the Iberian peninsula, worked in Rome for several centuries, drifted from a blunt mind to a blunt shape, and came back home in Spanish with a new job. A word that emigrated and returned.
French kept a piece of it: **gourd**, meaning numb or stiff — still the idea of something that does not move quickly.
English kept none of it, which matters because English has a word that looks like it does. A **gourd**, the hard-shelled vegetable, is a different word entirely, come through French from Latin *cucurbita*. Same spelling as the French adjective, no relation to it, and no relation to *gordo*.

What you've built

You can now describe a build both ways: *gordo* and *delgado*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *gordo*
- *muy gordo*
- *un gato gordo*

Before you move on

What did Latin *gurdus* mean? (Dull, thick-witted.) And did Quintilian state the Spanish origin, or report it? (He reported hearing it.)

371.3 joven — young twice in one language

Say *small*, then *fat*. (*Pequeño*; *gordo*.)

What to know first

- viejo — the word this one answers.
- la edad — what both of them measure.

Sounds you'll need

- *JO-ven*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *j* scrapes at the back of the mouth, and the *v* sounds like a soft *b*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

joven — "young."
Latin **iuvenis**, young. English has this word twice, and the two arrivals look nothing alike:

- **young** and **youth** were never borrowed. They came down the

Germanic line from the same ancient root that fed *iuvenis*, changing at every step, which is why they have kept no letters in common with the Latin;

- **juvenile** and **junior** were taken off the page much later. *Junior* is a comparative worn short — *iūnior*, "younger." Every Junior in a family name is being called the younger one in Latin.

Rejuvenate is not a Latin word. English built it in the nineteenth century out of Latin parts, and Rome would not have recognised it. Then there is **June**, and it is a good example of an answer that has to stay hedged. *Iūnius* is probably named for **Juno**, and Juno's own name may itself mean "the young one" from this very root — so June reaches *joven* at one remove, through two probablys.
The Romans were no surer. Ovid put three goddesses in a room arguing over who the month belonged to, let each make her case, and pointedly refused to declare a winner. When a poet who lived there will not settle it, a modern reader should not pretend to.

What you've built

You can now place someone on the scale: *joven* or *viejo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *joven*
- *muy joven*
- *una mujer joven*

Before you move on

Which English word is the inherited cousin of *joven*? (*Young.*) And what does *junior* mean taken literally? (Younger.)

371.4 lento — the word that arrived by post

Say *fat*, then *young*. (*Gordo*; *joven*.)

What to know first

- más despacio — what you already say when you need someone to slow down.
- el tiempo — what slowness is measured against.

Sounds you'll need

- *LEN-to*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *l* is light and forward, and the *t* touches the teeth. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lento — "slow."
Latin **lentus** started somewhere else. It meant **pliant, tough, flexible** — a branch that bends without breaking, pitch that stretches when you pull it. Slowness came out of that: a thing that yields slowly, that will not be hurried.
There is a fingerprint on this word telling you it was **borrowed off the page** rather than passed down by mouth, and it is the *-nt-*. Latin consonant clusters wear down when a word travels through centuries of speech, and this one has not worn at all. Spanish took *lento* from written Latin in the fifteenth century.
The form that **did** come down by mouth also survives, and it went somewhere unexpected: **liento**, meaning damp. It grew out of the clammy, sticky end of *lentus* rather than the slow end. One Latin adjective, two Spanish words, one written and one spoken.
English has the word through French as **relent** — to bend back, to soften under pressure — and built **relentless** on top of it. Someone relentless is someone with no bend in them.
And a false friend to leave alone. A **lentil** is not a slow bean. Latin *lēns, lentis* is a separate word whose own origin nobody has traced, resembling *lentus* by accident.

What you've built

You can now ask for a change of pace with an adjective, not only a phrase: *muy lento.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lento*
- *muy lento*
- *el autobús es lento*

Before you move on

What did *lentus* mean before it meant slow? (Pliant, flexible.) And what is the Spanish word that came down by mouth instead? (*Liento*, damp.)

371.5 dulce — a resemblance nobody can explain

Say *young*, then *slow*. (*Joven*; *lento*.)

What to know first

- la miel — the oldest sweet thing there is.
- el azúcar — the one that replaced it.

Sounds you'll need

- *DUL-ce*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *e* is soft — a *th* in much of Spain, an *s* across the Americas. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dulce — "sweet."
Latin **dulcis**. But the word Spanish actually inherited by mouth was **duz** — the *l* had worn away, the way letters do. It came back later, pulled into place by educated speakers who could read the Latin and wanted the spelling honoured. The same pressure keeps the *l* standing in *alto*.
English has the family in two quiet places: **dulcet**, a sweet sound, through French; and the **dulcimer**, the struck-string instrument, whose name most likely began as a phrase meaning sweet song.
Now the real reason this word is here.
Greek has **glykys**, sweet, which is where **glucose** and **glycerine** come from. *Dulcis* and *glykys* mean the same thing and look tantalisingly

alike — and no rule of sound change allows a Latin *d-* to match a Greek *gl-*. Reconstruction can force a shape that would produce both, but then the missing vowel in the Latin has no explanation, and specialists say so.

The suggestion that has the most support is that neither language inherited the word: both **borrowed** it, from some third language around the Mediterranean that left no other trace.

Keep this one as a specimen. Most etymologies in this book end in an answer. This one ends in two languages holding nearly the same word and nobody able to say how either of them got it.

What you've built

You can now describe a taste: *muy dulce*, *un café dulce*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dulce*
- *muy dulce*
- *un café dulce*

Before you move on

What was the older Spanish form of *dulce*? (*Duz.*) And why is the Greek *glykys* resemblance a puzzle? (No sound rule turns a Latin *d-* into a Greek *gl-*.)

Chapter 372

Grey, Pink And Dark

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say gris, rosa, oscuro, pálido and suave, and pick out which thing I mean by how it looks and how it feels.
>
> *Complete ES-C372-suave: pick out which thing you mean by how it looks and how it feels.*

372.1 gris — a colour that came in from the north

Say *slow*, then *sweet*. (*Lento*; *dulce*.)

What to know first

- negro, blanco — the two this one sits between.
- la nube — the thing it describes most often.

Sounds you'll need

- *GRIS*, one beat. The *g* is hard, the *r* is a single tap, and the *s* at the end stays crisp. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gris — "grey."
Most Spanish colour words come down from Latin. This one does not. *Gris* is **Germanic**, and it walked into Spanish sideways — through the Romance languages to the north, along the routes that carried furs and cloth. One of its earliest Spanish appearances is in a thirteenth-century inventory, describing a fur.
English **grey** is a cousin, not a twin. The two go back to two different Germanic stems that happen to mean the same thing — so *gris* and *grey* are family, but they are not the same word wearing two spellings. The Germanic word left tracks all over English, and they are easy to spot once you know what you are spotting:

- **grizzled** — greying, through French *grisel*;
- **grisaille** — a painting done entirely in greys, so that it imitates stone;
- **ambergris** — the waxy substance from a whale, used in perfume. The name is French *ambre gris*, **grey amber**, distinguishing it from *ambre jaune*, the yellow amber that is fossil resin. People have offered prettier stories for that word — amber grease, amber of Greece — and they are inventions.

A colour word that took a trade route, arriving with the goods it described.

What you've built

You can now describe an overcast day: *el cielo está gris.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *gris*
- *muy gris*
- *el cielo está gris*

Before you move on

Did *gris* come from Latin? (No — it is a Germanic word taken in through Spanish's northern neighbours.) And what does *ambergris* mean? (Grey amber.)

372.2 rosa — a flower Latin borrowed, and a herb that is not one

Say *sweet*, then *grey*. (*Dulce*; *gris*.)

What to know first

- la flor — the class the flower belongs to.
- rojo — the colour this one is a pale version of.

Sounds you'll need

- *RO-sa*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* at the start of a word is rolled, and the *s* between vowels stays crisp. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rosa — "pink," and also "the rose."
Spanish does the same thing English does with *orange*: one word for the flower and for the shade it comes in.
Latin **rosa** looks like the most Latin word imaginable, and Latin did not make it. The rose came from the east and its name came with it — most likely through a dialect form of Greek **rhódon**, and behind the Greek an Iranian word. The route has a hole in it: nobody has explained where the Latin *s* came from, when Greek has a *d*. So the borrowing is certain and the road it took is not.
The Greek side of that same loan is standing in English already: **rhododendron**, the rose tree.
And now the trap, which is one of the finest in English. **Rosemary** has nothing to do with a rose, and nothing to do with Mary.
It is Latin **rōs marīnus** — **sea dew**. English speakers who had never met *rōs* or *marīnus* heard two words they did know, and pulled the

spelling across to fit. The plant kept the sound and lost the sense. That is folk etymology working exactly as it always works: not by lying, but by making a strange word comfortable. Every time you write *rosemary* you are writing down somebody's guess from several centuries ago.

What you've built

You can now name a colour and a flower at once: *rosa*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *rosa*
- *una flor rosa*
- *la casa es rosa*

Before you move on

Did Latin build the word *rosa* or borrow it? (Borrow it, from the east.) And what does *rosemary* actually mean? (Sea dew — *rōs marīnus*.)

372.3 oscuro — a word split down the middle by scholars

Say *grey*, then *pink*. (*Gris*; *rosa*.)

What to know first

- la luz — what it is the absence of.
- la noche — when there is most of it.

Sounds you'll need

- *os-CU-ro*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *sc* is an *s* against a hard *k*, and the *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

oscuro — "dark."
Latin **obscūrus**, and English borrowed it whole as **obscure** — which still carries the darkness under its modern sense. An obscure passage is one you cannot see into.
Splitting the word is easy: **ob-**, a common Latin prefix, plus a second piece that means dark.
Saying where that second piece came from is not easy at all, and this lesson is here to show you a live disagreement rather than a settled answer.
The older reference books attach it to an ancient root meaning **to cover**, and draw in a wide family of English words on the strength of it. The standard modern dictionary of Latin origins rejects that and attaches it instead to a root meaning **dark** outright — pointing out that "cover" makes poor sense with the prefix, and listing none of that family. A third scholar has proposed cutting the word at a different point altogether.
So: the meaning is certain, the prefix is certain, and the ancestry is open. The honest thing is to hand you the word and the argument, rather than one book's answer dressed up as the answer.
One relative that is not in doubt. Italian **chiaroscuro** is *chiaro* plus *scuro*, bright plus dark — the painter's term for a scene lit by one small source, all highlight and shadow with little in between.

What you've built

You can now describe a room or a colour: *muy oscuro*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *oscuro*
- *muy oscuro*
- *la noche es oscura*

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *obscūrus*? (*Ob-* and a piece meaning dark.) And what does *chiaroscuro* name? (Bright and dark together — the painter's word.)

372.4 pálido — one Latin word, arriving twice

Say *pink*, then *dark*. (*Rosa*; *oscuro*.)

What to know first

- la cara — where you notice it first.
- el color — what it is a shortage of.

Sounds you'll need

- *PÁ-li-do*, three beats with the weight on the **first**, which is why the accent is written: the ordinary place for it would be the second. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pálido — "pale."
Latin **pallidus**, from the verb **pallēre**, to be pale. English has this word twice over, and the pair is worth setting side by side because it shows what the two roads do to a word:

- **pale** came through Old French. Passing through a spoken language wore it down to one syllable and took the double *l* out;
- **pallid** was taken straight off the written Latin. It kept both *l*'s and the ending, and it kept a bookish feel that *pale* has lost.

Same Latin adjective, several centuries apart, and English uses them differently without anybody deciding to.
A third relative hides its face. To **appall** is the same family through French: to make somebody go pale. An appalling thing is one that drains the colour out of a face, which is a much more physical word than its everyday use suggests.

And the inherited Germanic cousin — never borrowed, come down the other line — is **fallow**: the dull yellowish brown of a fallow deer, or of a field left unsown. Pale and fallow meet only far back, at the reconstructed level, but they meet.
One neighbour to leave alone: **la palabra**, a word, is nothing to do with any of this. It comes from Greek *parabolē* with two of its letters swapped on the way.

What you've built

You can now describe someone who does not look well: *está pálido.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pálido*
- *muy pálido*
- *está pálido*

Before you move on

Which of *pale* and *pallid* came through French? (*Pale.*) And what does it mean to appall somebody, literally? (To make them go pale.)

372.5 suave — the same word as sweet

Say *dark*, then *pale.* (*Oscuro*; *pálido.*)

What to know first

- la piel — the first thing you call *suave.*
- la manta — the second.

Sounds you'll need

- *SUA-ve*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ua* is one glide, and the *v* is the same soft sound as a Spanish *b.* → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

suave — "smooth, soft, gentle."
Latin **suāvis** meant agreeable to the senses — pleasant to taste, to touch, to hear.
English **sweet** is the same word. Not a translation of it: the same ancient root, come down the Germanic line instead of the Latin one, changing sound by sound until nothing recognisable was left on the surface. *Suave* and *sweet* are twins raised in different houses.
Latin built a verb on that root too: **suādēre**, to advise, to urge.
Which means **persuade** is *per-* plus that verb — to make a thing thoroughly **sweet** to somebody. You do not persuade a person by proving them wrong; the word says you persuade them by making your position pleasant to accept. And **dissuade** is the same move in reverse.
Assuage belongs here as well, arriving through French: to sweeten a grief until it can be borne.
English also borrowed **suave** itself, straight off the Latin in the fifteenth century. Its modern sense — smooth manners, a shade too smooth — came later, under French influence, and is the language's own judgement rather than anything the Romans put there.
Further back still, Greek *hēdys*, sweet, belongs to the same root — and **hedonism** is built on it. Sweetness as a philosophy.

What you've built

You can now describe how something feels: *muy suave*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *suave*
- *muy suave*
- *la manta es suave*

Before you move on

Which everyday English word is the inherited cousin of *suave*? (*Sweet.*) And what does *persuade* say, taken apart? (To make a thing sweet to somebody.)

Chapter 373

Five Things You Can Pick Up

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el oro, la botella, la alfombra, la falda and el peine, and name five ordinary things I can pick up.
>
> *Complete ES-C373-peine: name five ordinary things you can pick up, and say what each is for.*

373.1 el oro — named after the colour of dawn

Say *pale*, then *smooth*. (*Pálido*; *suave*.)

What to know first

- el dinero — what it stands behind.
- la moneda — the shape it usually takes.

Sounds you'll need

- *O-ro*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *r* between vowels is a single tap, never rolled. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el oro — "gold."
Latin **aurum**, and behind *aurum* an ancient root meaning **to shine, to dawn**. Gold was not named for its weight or its rarity or its price.

It was named for looking like the first light of the morning.
The same root, barely disguised, is **aurora** — the dawn, and the aurora borealis, which is dawn where dawn has no business being.
And, far enough back to need reconstructing, English **east** belongs to it too. The east is the shining place. Gold, the dawn and a compass direction all come from one idea about light.
English took the Latin word by a couple of side doors, both through French:

- an **oriole** is *aureolus*, "a little golden one," named for the bird's colour;
- an **aureole** is the ring of gold light a painter puts round a head. Same Latin word, different job.

The shortest survival is on the periodic table. Gold's symbol is **Au** — the first two letters of *aurum*, sitting in a chemistry textbook long after Latin stopped being spoken. Chemistry kept the Roman name for a metal the Romans measured their world in.

What you've built

You can now name the metal behind the money: *el oro*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el oro*
- *de oro*
- *una moneda de oro*

Before you move on

What did the root behind *aurum* mean? (To shine, to dawn.) And which two letters does gold get on the periodic table? (*Au*, from *aurum*.)

373.2 la botella — and the servant who kept it

Say *smooth*, then *gold*. (*Suave*; *el oro*.)

What to know first

- el vino — the reason the word exists.
- el agua — what is in it now.

Sounds you'll need

- *bo-TE-lla*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *ll* is a *y* sound across most of the Spanish-speaking world. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la botella — "the bottle."
Late Latin had **buttis**, a cask, and a diminutive **butticula**, a little cask. French turned that into *bouteille*, and Spanish borrowed the French word in the eighteenth century — recently, as these things go. Spanish already had the same Latin word, inherited by mouth: **la bota**, the leather wineskin. So *bota* and *botella* are one word twice, the old one worn smooth by centuries of use and the new one arriving with a French accent.
English took the French word too, as **bottle** — and took something better with it. A **butler** is *bouteillier*, **the bottle-man**: the servant in charge of the wine. He had the keys to the cellar, which is a position of trust, and trust promotes; over a few centuries the bottle-keeper rose to running the entire household and kept his old name.
English **butt**, a large cask, is the same family again, also through French.
One near neighbour that is not a relative. **El botón**, the button, comes from a Frankish verb meaning to thrust or push — because a button is pushed through. It is a relative of the English verb to **butt**, as a goat does, and no relation at all to *butt* the cask. Two English *butt*s, two families, and Spanish keeps them apart cleanly.

What you've built

You can now ask for a bottle of something: *una botella de agua*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la botella*
- *una botella*
- *una botella de agua*

Before you move on

What is a butler, taken literally? (The bottle-keeper.) And which Spanish word is the inherited form of the same Latin cask? (*La bota*, the wineskin.)

373.3 la alfombra — and a red that was never there

Say *gold*, then *the bottle*. (*El oro*; *la botella*.)

What to know first

- la almohada — its neighbour, which carries the same Arabic article.
- el piso — what it lies on.

Sounds you'll need

- *al-FOM-bra*, three beats with the weight on the second. The *mb* runs together, and the *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la alfombra — "the rug, the carpet."
The *al-* on the front is the Arabic definite article, brought across stuck to the noun — the same passenger that rides in on *almohada* and on *azúcar*. Spanish then puts its own article in front of it, so *la alfombra* has two.
The noun underneath is Andalusi Arabic **alḥánbal**, a kind of hanging or tapestry laid over a dais.

Now the part that makes this word worth a lesson. For a long time the dictionaries printed a different story: that *alfombra* came from an Arabic phrase meaning **the red one**. It is a lovely story. A carpet named for its colour, a red carpet before there were red carpets. Corominas took it apart, and the way he did it is the lesson. The redness, he pointed out, had been read **out of** the proposed etymology and then offered back as evidence **for** it. Nobody had found a red carpet and then looked for a word; somebody had found a word that could mean red and then imagined the carpet. The Academy's dictionary now prints the tapestry word instead.
What produced the mistake was a real word standing nearby. Spanish also had **alhamar**, a coverlet, and *that* one genuinely does come from the Arabic root for **red**. The two got tangled in the record, and the redness walked from one word to the other.
Keep both halves: the rug, and the reminder that a beautiful etymology is the kind most worth checking.

What you've built

You can now name what is on the floor: *la alfombra*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la alfombra*
- *una alfombra*
- *la alfombra está en el piso*

Before you move on

What is the *al-* of *alfombra*? (The Arabic article, carried in with the noun.) And which nearby word really is the one meaning red? (*Alhamar*, a coverlet.)

373.4 la falda — the folded thing

Say *the bottle*, then *the rug*. (*La botella*; *la alfombra*.)

What to know first

- la ropa — the class it belongs to.
- el vestido — its nearest neighbour in a wardrobe.

Sounds you'll need

- *FAL-da*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *l* is light and forward, and the *d* after it is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la falda — "the skirt."
This is a **Germanic** word, not a Latin one. It came into Spanish from one of the Germanic languages that arrived in the peninsula — which one is not settled, with Frankish and Gothic both proposed — and it meant a **fold**.
A skirt is the folded thing: cloth hung in pleats. Spanish still uses *falda* for the lower slope of a mountain, where the ground falls away in folds, which is the older picture showing through.
English **fold** is the inherited cousin of that same Germanic word — never borrowed, come straight down the English line. So *falda* and *fold* are one word travelling by two routes: one carried into Spain by settlers, the other carried into England the ordinary way.
And here is the look-alike to refuse. **Falso**, false, begins with the same three letters and has nothing to do with it. *Falso* is Latin *falsus*, from *fallere*, to deceive — the word behind English **fault**, **fail** and **fallacy**. The two *f*'s are not even the same kind of *f*. One grew out of a Germanic sound and one out of a Latin one, arriving at the same letter from opposite directions. Three shared letters, two families, no relationship.

What you've built

You can now name another piece of clothing: *la falda*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la falda*

- *una falda*
- *la falda es gris*

Before you move on

What did *falda* mean before it meant a skirt? (A fold.) And is *falso* a relative? (No — it comes from Latin *fallere*, to deceive.)

373.5 el peine — the comb, and a story about money

Say *the rug*, then *the skirt*. (*La alfombra*; *la falda*.)

What to know first

- la cabeza — what it is for.
- la mano — what holds it.

Sounds you'll need

- *PEI-ne*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ei* is one glide, close to the vowel of English *hay*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el peine — "the comb."
Latin **pecten**, a comb, from **pectere**, to comb — used of hair and of wool, since carding wool is combing it. English keeps the word in **pectinate**, a botanist's and anatomist's term for anything shaped like a comb.
So far so ordinary. Now a story, offered as a story.
Latin also had **pecū**, livestock, and a long tradition joins it to this comb-word, on the reasoning that a sheep is the animal you **pluck**. If that holds, then *peine* is a distant relative of a whole family about money:

- **pecuniary**, to do with money, from *pecūnia* — because a Roman's wealth was counted in animals before it was counted in coins;

- **peculiar**, from *pecūlium*, the private property a son or a slave was allowed to keep. Something peculiar is something **your own**, and the sense of odd came from there by way of distinctive;
- **peculate**, to embezzle — helping yourself to the herd.

English has the same idea by its own road: **fee** was Old English *feoh*, which meant cattle, then property, then money.
The caution belongs with the story. Specialists no longer agree that the combing half and the livestock half were ever one word; some now treat the wealth sense as the original and the animals as second. So take the money family as a **tradition** rather than a fact — which is worth knowing in itself, because a great many etymologies people repeat with confidence are exactly this: an old, tidy, widely printed proposal that the current specialists have quietly stopped endorsing.

What you've built

You can now name the thing on the shelf: *el peine*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el peine*
- *un peine*
- *el peine está en la mano*

Before you move on

What did Latin *pecū* mean? (Livestock.) And is the link between the comb and the money words a fact? (No — a long tradition that specialists no longer agree on.)

Chapter 374

Five Things You Hold

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el lápiz, el cepillo, el guante, la vela and el nudo, and name five things that fit in one hand.
>
> *Complete ES-C374-nudo: name five things that fit in one hand, and say one thing about each.*

374.1 el lápiz — a stone you write with

Say *the skirt*, then *the comb*. (*La falda*; *El peine*.)

What to know first

- el papel — what it goes onto.
- azul — a word from the other half of the same stone.

Sounds you'll need

- *LÁ-piz*, two beats with the weight on the first. The written accent is there because a word ending in *-z* would otherwise be stressed on its last beat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el lápiz — "pencil."
Latin **lapis** meant a stone. That is the whole word: no suffix, no diminutive, nothing meaning "little". A pencil is named for the mineral

running down its middle.
Where Spanish picked it up is less settled. The Academy's dictionary takes it straight from Latin. Corominas puts it three centuries later and routes it through Italian, where *lapis* was already a painters' word for a drawing stone.
Then there is a near miss worth slowing down for.
Lapis lazuli is the deep blue stone, and its name has two halves that come from opposite ends of the earth:

- **lapis** is the Latin you have right here;
- **lazuli** is Arabic **lāzaward**, which reached Arabic from Persian and Persian from Sanskrit.

Spanish **azul** descends from the second half. *Lápiz* descends from the first. The two words meet inside one stone's name and share no ancestor at all — a real resemblance, and no relationship.

What you've built

You can now name the thing you write with: *un lápiz.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el lápiz*
- *un lápiz*
- *un lápiz azul*

Before you move on

What did Latin *lapis* mean on its own? (A stone — with no "little" in it.) And which half of *lapis lazuli* gave Spanish *azul*? (The second half, the Arabic one.)

374.2 el cepillo — named after its back

Say *the comb*, then *the pencil.* (*El peine*; *El lápiz.*)

What to know first

- el peine — the one you met a moment ago.
- el jabón — what it works with.

Sounds you'll need

- *ce-PI-llo*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *ll* is a *y* sound across nearly all of the Spanish-speaking world. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el cepillo — "brush."
Cepillo is a small **cepo**, and *cepo* is Latin **cippus**: a post, a stake, a block of wood. The Academy's dictionary puts the diminutive right in the entry.
So the brush is named after its **back**. The part a Roman would have recognised is the block of wood your hand closes around — not the bristles, which are the part you would probably have named it for.
Cepo has never gone away, and it has kept that block in three separate jobs:

- the block a trap is built on;
- the stocks, the timber a prisoner's ankles went through;
- the clamp a city locks onto a badly parked wheel.

One piece of wood, three very different centuries, and a brush quietly carrying the oldest of them.

What you've built

You can now name what you clean with: *un cepillo.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cepillo*
- *un cepillo*

- *el cepillo y el peine*

Before you move on

What did Latin *cippus* mean? (A post or a block of wood.) And which part of a brush does its name point at? (The wooden back, not the bristles.)

374.3 el guante — a Germanic word in Romance clothes

Say *the pencil*, then *the brush*. (*El lápiz*; *El cepillo*.)

What to know first

- la mano — what goes inside it.
- el zapato — the other thing you pull onto an end of yourself.

Sounds you'll need

- *GUAN-te*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *u* is pronounced, so *gua* runs together as one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el guante — "glove."
Nearly everything you have met came down from Latin. This one did not.
The Academy's dictionary traces **guante** — hedging, with a *perhaps* — through Catalan **guant** to a Frankish word **want**, a mitten. Dutch still says *want* for the same thing.
What repays attention is the front of the word. Germanic words beginning in **w-** do not keep it when they move into Romance. They turn up wearing **gu-**, and two pairs make the swap audible:

- **guerra** beside English *war*;
- **Guillermo** beside English *William*.

Say each pair out loud and the *w* and the *gu* land in the same place in

your mouth.
One correction while it is fresh. Spanish did not perform that change on *guante*. The word was reshaped on its way in and arrived already wearing the *gu-*. Those pairs show a habit of Romance, not an operation Spanish ran on this particular noun.

What you've built

You can now name what goes on a hand: *un guante*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el guante*
- *un guante*
- *dos guantes*

Before you move on

Is *guante* Latin or Germanic? (Germanic — a Frankish word for a mitten.) And what does a Germanic *w-* become when it moves into Romance? (A *gu-*, as in *guerra* and *Guillermo*.)

374.4 la vela — two words wearing one spelling

Say *the brush*, then *the glove*. (*El cepillo*; *El guante*.)

What to know first

- la luz — what it gives.
- la noche — when you need it.

Sounds you'll need

- *VE-la*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *v* and a *b* are the same sound in Spanish, so this begins the way *bien* does. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la vela — "candle."
Spanish has **two** words spelled *vela*, and the Academy's dictionary keeps them in separate entries because they are separate words.
The candle comes from the verb **velar**, and *velar* is Latin **vigilāre**, "to keep watch." A *vela* is what burns while somebody sits up. Its family in Spanish is *vigilia*, *vigilancia*, *centinela* — watching words, every one.
The sail is a different noun: Latin **vela**, the plural of **velum**, "cloth." It is tempting to knit these together — a sail is stretched cloth, a candle has a wick of cloth, so surely one word. That story is wrong, and wrong in a way worth noticing: it starts from the sail and reasons toward the candle, when the candle came from an entirely different verb.
A useful habit falls out of this. When two Spanish words look identical, the question to ask is not "how are these connected?" but "are these one word or two?" Here the answer is two, and the dictionary says so on the page.

What you've built

You can now name what you light: *una vela*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la vela*
- *una vela*
- *una vela en la mesa*

Before you move on

Which Latin verb is behind *vela*, the candle? (*Vigilāre*, to keep watch.) And is *vela* meaning "sail" the same word? (No — a separate noun, from *velum*, cloth.)

374.5 el nudo — a vowel nobody can account for

Say *the glove*, then *the candle*. (*El guante*; *La vela*.)

What to know first

- la cuerda — what you tie it in.
- el hilo — the thinner version.

Sounds you'll need

- *NU-do*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* of English *this*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el nudo — "knot."
Latin **nodus** was a knot. English took it twice, as **node** and as **nodule**, and both still mean a knot of something.
Spanish took it too — and the vowel came out wrong.
Nodus should have given ***nodo***. Spanish has *nodo*, in fact, as a later bookish borrowing. What ordinary speech produced was *nudo*, with a **u** that no sound change accounts for, so the Academy's dictionary reconstructs a spoken Latin form to bridge the gap.
The obvious guess is sitting right there: Latin also had **nudus**, "naked," which is where *desnudo* comes from. Two words, one vowel apart, surely they leaned on each other.
Corominas says no, and says it flatly — there is no reason for such a confusion, and Catalan, facing the identical pair, went to some trouble to keep its knot and its naked distinct rather than letting them merge. So the honest answer is that the *u* is unexplained, and that the tidiest available explanation has been examined and turned down.

What you've built

You can now name what you tie: *un nudo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el nudo*
- *un nudo*
- *un nudo en la cuerda*

Before you move on

What form should Latin *nodus* have produced in Spanish? (*Nodo* — which exists, as a later borrowing.) And does *nudo* come from *nudus*, "naked"? (No; Corominas rejects that.)

Chapter 375

Five Things a Person Has

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la uña, el labio, el pulgar, el beso and el sobrino, and name five things that belong to a person.
>
> *Complete ES-C375-sobrino: name five things that belong to a person, and say one thing about each.*

375.1 la uña — a small claw

Say *the candle*, then *the knot*. (*La vela*; *El nudo*.)

What to know first

- el dedo — where it sits.
- la mano — the whole of which it is a corner.

Sounds you'll need

- *U-ña*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ñ* is one sound, the *ny* in English *canyon*, never two. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la uña — "fingernail."
Latin **unguis** was a nail or a claw. **Ungula** was its diminutive: a small claw. Spanish inherited the diminutive, so *uña* has a "little" folded into it that no Spanish speaker hears any more.

English borrowed the same Latin diminutive much later and used it to name a whole branch of the animal kingdom. An **ungulate** is a hoofed animal — a horse, a deer, a cow — filed under a word that literally means *small claw*, because a hoof is what a claw becomes when an animal walks on it.
One caution, because the resemblance invites the wrong conclusion. English **nail** is not descended from *unguis*. The two are relatives at a depth that has to be reconstructed rather than read off the page, which is a different kind of claim from *ungulate*, where you can watch the borrowing happen.

What you've built

You can now name the hard part of a finger: *la uña*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la uña*
- *las uñas*
- *una uña rota*

Before you move on

What did Latin *ungula* mean? (A small claw — it was already a diminutive.) And what kind of animal is an ungulate? (A hoofed one, named from the same word.)

375.2 el labio — a resemblance the handbooks have stopped explaining

Say *the knot*, then *the fingernail*. (*El nudo*; *La uña*.)

What to know first

- la boca — what it closes.
- el diente — what sits behind it.

Sounds you'll need

- *LA-bio*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *b* between vowels is soft — the lips come close without quite meeting. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el labio — "lip."
Latin **labium** gave Spanish *labio*, and English took the same word directly for its technical use: a **labial** sound is one made with the lips. English **lip** is a different story. It is native Germanic, Old English *lippa*, and it is not descended from *labium*.
For a long time the handbooks put the two under one Indo-European root and left it there. That is no longer where the argument stands. De Vaan and Boutkan reject the Indo-European derivation for this whole group and suspect something stranger: that Latin and Germanic each **borrowed** the word from a language spoken in Europe before either of them arrived, and then lost.
So the resemblance between *labio* and *lip* is probably not an accident. It is probably also not inheritance. What it most likely records is a word that was already in Europe when the languages you can trace showed up — and a speaker nobody can name.

What you've built

You can now name the edge of a mouth: *el labio*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el labio*
- *los labios*
- *el labio y el diente*

Before you move on

Which English word is the direct borrowing of *labium*? (*Labial.*)
And is English *lip* descended from it? (No — Germanic, and the old

shared-root story is now doubted.)

375.3 el pulgar — a ruler before it was a word

Say *the fingernail*, then *the lip*. (*La uña*; *El labio.*)

What to know first

- el dedo — the family it belongs to.
- la mano — where it sits, opposite the rest.

Sounds you'll need

- *pul-GAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. A word ending in *-r* takes its stress on the last beat and needs no written accent. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pulgar — "thumb."
Latin **pollex** was the thumb. From it came the adjective **pollicāris** — and the Academy's dictionary glosses that adjective not as "of the thumb" but as **"an inch long."**
That is the real find here. The thumb was a **measuring instrument** before it was a word for a body part, and Spanish still carries the proof: a **pulgada** is an inch. English does the same thing in reverse — *inch* comes from Latin *uncia*, a twelfth part, and *thumb* stays out of it, but French *pouce* means both thumb and inch to this day.
There is a story attached to *pollex* that you will meet, and it should be set aside. It says the thumb is "the strong one," from the verb *pollēre*, "to be strong."
Follow how that argument runs. It reads strength **out of** the proposed ancestor, then points at how strong a thumb is as **evidence for** that ancestor. The thumb's strength is a fact about thumbs; it proves nothing about the word. De Vaan is unconvinced, and *pollex* is best left as disputed.

What you've built

You can now name the odd one out on a hand: *el pulgar*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pulgar*
- *un pulgar*
- *el pulgar y los dedos*

Before you move on

What did Latin *pollicāris* actually mean? (An inch long.) And which Spanish word for a measurement comes from it? (*Pulgada*.)

375.4 el beso — a word Latin borrowed too

Say *the lip*, then *the thumb*. (*El labio*; *El pulgar*.)

What to know first

- el abrazo — what usually comes with it.
- la boca — what makes it.

Sounds you'll need

- *BE-so*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *s* is clear and sharp, never buzzing into a *z*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el beso — "kiss."
Latin **basium** gave Spanish *beso*, French **baiser**, Italian **bacio**. Three Romance languages, one Latin noun, nothing surprising so far.
The surprise is in the Academy's own entry, which does not stop at Latin. It says *basium* was itself **of Celtic origin** — so the word had already crossed a language boundary before Latin got hold of it, and

every Romance kiss is a loan on top of a loan.
English has an old word **buss** for a kiss, and it is exactly the kind of resemblance that should make you slow down rather than speed up. *Buss*, *bacio*, Welsh and Gaelic *bus* for a lip — they all sound alike because the sound of a kiss is a short one made with the lips, and several languages appear to have arrived at it separately.
That makes *buss* a look-alike, not a cousin. A word can resemble another because of shared ancestry or because both are imitating the same noise, and only one of those is a family tie.

What you've built

You can now name what goes with an embrace: *un beso*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el beso*
- *un beso*
- *un abrazo y un beso*

Before you move on

Where did Latin get *basium*? (From Celtic — Latin borrowed it too.) And is English *buss* a relative? (Probably not; it imitates the sound.)

375.5 el sobrino — a cousin that slid down a generation

Say *the thumb*, then *the kiss*. (*El pulgar*; *El beso*.)

What to know first

- el primo — what the Latin word actually meant.
- el tío — the other end of the same relationship.

Sounds you'll need

- *so-BRI-no*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *r* is a single tap, and *br* runs together with no vowel between. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el sobrino — "nephew."
Latin **sobrīnus** meant a **cousin** — on the mother's side. Underneath it is **soror**, "sister": *sobrinus* is a worn-down **sororinus**, the child of your mother's sister.
Latin then built a second word on it. Prefixing *com-* gave **consobrinus**, and that one named the **closer** relation, the first cousin, where bare *sobrinus* drifted out to the more distant ones. Isidore of Seville uses *consobrinus* for a first cousin and *sobrinus* for a second. Each of the two words then went its own way:

- **consobrinus** travelled through Old French and became English **cousin**;
- **sobrinus** stayed in Spanish and **moved down a generation**, from cousin to nephew.

So when an English speaker says *cousin* and a Spanish speaker says *sobrino*, they are reaching for the same Latin noun and landing on two different branches of the family. Spanish did not lose the cousin: *el primo* took the job instead.

What you've built

You can now name your sibling's child: *mi sobrino*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el sobrino*
- *mi sobrino*
- *mi sobrino y mi primo*

Before you move on

What did Latin *sobrīnus* mean? (A cousin, on the mother's side.) And which English word comes from its prefixed form *consobrinus*? (*Cousin.*)

Chapter 376

Five Things on a Plate

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la harina, la uva, el maíz, el chocolate and el pimiento, and name five things that go on a plate.
>
> *Complete ES-C376-pimiento: name five things that go on a plate, and say one thing about each.*

376.1 la harina — the f that turned into silence

Say *the kiss*, then *the nephew*. (*El beso*; *El sobrino*.)

What to know first

- el pan — what it becomes.
- el trigo — what it was first.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-RI-na*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *h* is written and not pronounced, so the word opens on its vowel. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la harina — "flour."
Latin **farīna** was ground grain, built on **far** — husked wheat, the coarse stuff Romans ate long before anybody bolted flour fine. English

holds the same Latin word twice, in **farina** and **farinaceous**. Spanish turned the **f** into an **h**, and then stopped pronouncing the *h* altogether. You have already met the change several times without it being named:

- *facere* → **hacer**;
- *filius* → **hijo**;
- *farīna* → **harina**.

Here is the part that makes it usable rather than a curiosity. The change had a **boundary**. It did not happen before *r*, before *l*, or before the *ue* glide, which is why these kept their *f*:

- **frente**, not *hrente*;
- **flor**, not *hlor*;
- **fuego**, not *huego*.

Do not turn that into a rule about every *f*, though, because there is a second reason and it covers many more words: **the word never went through the change at all.** It was lifted out of written Latin centuries after the change had finished, so there was nothing for it to apply to. *Fácil*, *familia*, *forma*, *final*, *fecha*, *feliz* and *fiesta* are all in that group.
So an initial *f* tells you one of two things. Either an *r*, an *l* or a *ue* was standing directly behind it – or the word came into Spanish through a book rather than through speech.

What you've built

You can now name what bread is made of: *la harina*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la harina*
- *un kilo de harina*

- *harina y agua*

Before you move on

What happened to the *f* of Latin *farīna*? (It became a written, silent *h*.) And name the two reasons a Spanish word can still start with *f*. (An *r*, *l* or *ue* stood behind it — or it was lifted from written Latin long after the change finished.)

376.2 la uva — a little grape in your throat

Say *the nephew*, then *the flour*. (*El sobrino*; *La harina*.)

What to know first

- el vino — what it becomes.
- la fruta — the family it belongs to.

Sounds you'll need

- *U-va*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *v* is the same sound as a soft *b*, made with the lips barely touching. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la uva — "grape."
Latin **uva** meant a grape — and also the bunch. One word for the single thing and the cluster, which is convenient when the two rarely appear apart.
Its diminutive was **uvula**, "little grape," and that word is still in English, unchanged, naming the small soft flap that hangs at the back of your throat.
Why that name? Because whoever first wrote it down thought the flap looked like a small grape, and said so. That is worth pausing on. Most of the time an explanation of why a word means what it does has to be reconstructed, and reconstructions can be talked into almost anything. Here the reason was written down at the time.
So you have a Spanish fruit and an English piece of anatomy that are the same Latin word, one of them shrunk, and a recorded explanation

joining them.

What you've built

You can now name what wine starts as: *la uva*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la uva*
- *las uvas*
- *un kilo de uvas*

Before you move on

What did Latin *uva* cover, one grape or the bunch? (Both.) And what is the *uvula* named after? (A little grape, because of how it looks.)

376.3 el maíz — one of the first words to cross

Say *the flour*, then *the grape*. (*La harina*; *La uva*.)

What to know first

- el trigo — the grain Europe already had.
- la patata — another word that came the same way.

Sounds you'll need

- *ma-ÍZ*, two beats with the weight on the second. The written accent on the *í* keeps the *a* and the *i* apart, so they do not collapse into one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el maíz — "maize."
Maíz comes from **mahís**, a word in Taíno — the Arawakan language

spoken in the Caribbean islands Columbus reached in 1492. Spanish took it and handed it on: English **maize** is the Spanish word with an English spelling.
It was among the very first American words to reach Europe. *Canoa* is in the same log, recorded within a fortnight of landfall, and so are *hamaca* and *cacique*.
A note on how to say that safely. It is tempting to promote *maíz* to **the** first — a good line, and unprovable. Which word arrived first depends on which manuscript you trust and which transcription of it, and *canoa* is the usual claimant anyway. "Among the first" is a claim the evidence supports. "The first" is a claim nobody can check, and this word does not need it.

What you've built

You can now name a grain that crossed an ocean: *el maíz*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el maíz*
- *un poco de maíz*
- *harina de maíz*

Before you move on

Which language did *maíz* come from? (Taíno, in the Caribbean.)
And which word probably reached Europe before it? (*Canoa*.)

376.4 el chocolate — a famous etymology that is not attested

Say *the grape*, then *the maize*. (*La uva*; *El maíz*.)

What to know first

- la leche — what it is usually made with.

- el azúcar — what was added later.

Sounds you'll need

- *cho-co-LA-te*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *ch* is one sound, as in English *church*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el chocolate — "chocolate."
Chocolate came into Spanish from **Nahuatl**, the language of the Aztec empire. That much is agreed.
After that, very little is. The Academy's dictionary marks the entry **disputed** — which a dictionary does not do lightly.
You have probably met the standard story: Nahuatl **xocolātl**, "bitter water," from *xoco* "bitter" and *atl* "water." It has a problem. **No colonial source records that word.** It is missing from Molina's dictionary, the great sixteenth-century record of the language, and *chocolatl* does not surface in Nahuatl until the seventeen hundreds — long after the drink was being drunk in Madrid.
And notice the shape of the argument. "Bitter water" is not evidence for the etymology; it is the etymology chopped in half and read back. Segmenting a reconstruction and then admiring how well the pieces fit proves only that you did the segmenting.
The proposal that has gained ground instead is **chicolātl**, from **chicolli** — the wooden stick used to beat the drink into foam. The drink named for the implement, not the taste. Two things support it: living Nahuatl dialects, and the **i** that shows up in the earliest borrowings outside Spanish, where "bitter water" predicts an *o*.
So this is a word you can use with complete confidence and cannot explain with any.

What you've built

You can now name what was drunk before it was eaten: *el chocolate*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el chocolate*
- *un chocolate*

- *chocolate con leche*

Before you move on

What does the Academy's dictionary say about this etymology? (That it is disputed.) And what does the leading proposal name the drink after? (*Chicolli*, the stick used to whisk it.)

376.5 el pimiento — a name that arrived through the spice cupboard

Say *the maize*, then *the chocolate*. (*El maíz*; *El chocolate*.)

What to know first

- la sal — the other thing on every table.
- el tomate — another that crossed the same ocean.

Sounds you'll need

- *pi-MIEN-to*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *ie* is one glide, not two separate vowels. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pimiento — "pepper."
Pimiento comes from **pimienta**, black pepper, and *pimienta* is Latin **pigmenta** — the plural of **pigmentum**.
A *pigmentum* started out as colouring matter, the stuff a painter grinds. In later Latin it slid: from colouring matter to **a drug**, from a drug to **an ingredient**, from an ingredient to **a condiment**. And the condiment that mattered most in medieval Europe was pepper. So a word that began in the paint pot ended up meaning the spice.
It is tempting to shorten that to "the pepper is named for its colour." Do not. That version takes the *earliest* sense of the Latin word, skips the three steps that actually carried it, and then points at a red pepper as though the colour were the proof. The dictionary's own gloss lays the route out, and the route runs through the apothecary, not the paint.

English keeps the older sense alive in **pigment**, and **paint** is a relative — both are built on *pingere*, "to paint."
One more turn. The pepper on a Spanish table is American, and it was named by transfer: Europeans reached for the word they already had for the hot thing you grind. *Pimienta* stayed with the peppercorn; *pimiento* went to the newcomer.

What you've built

You can now name a pepper: *un pimiento*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pimiento*
- *un pimiento*
- *un pimiento rojo*

Before you move on

What did Latin *pigmentum* come to mean by late Latin? (A drug, an ingredient, a condiment.) And was the pepper named for its colour? (No — for being the spice.)

Chapter 377

Five Things You Can Learn

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la letra, la frase, el idioma, la historia and el baile, and name five things a person can learn.
>
> *Complete ES-C377-baile: name five things a person can learn, and say one thing about each.*

377.1 la letra — the word for writing, and nobody knows where it came from

Say *the chocolate*, then *the pepper*. (*El chocolate*; *El pimiento*.)

What to know first

- la palabra — what letters build.
- la carta — the other thing English calls a letter.

Sounds you'll need

- *LE-tra*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *tr* runs together and the *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la letra — "letter."
Latin **littera** was a letter of the alphabet, and English took it three times:

- **letter**, through French, worn down;
- **literal**, straight from Latin, meaning by the letter;
- **literature**, the whole of what letters have been used for.

Watch out for one thing in English. *Letter* covers two different objects: a mark on a page and something you post. Spanish keeps them apart. *La letra* is the mark. The thing you post is **la carta**, which you already have.

And here is the part that ought to be embarrassing and is only honest. Nobody knows where Latin got *littera*.

Two attempts exist. One builds it on **linō**, "to smear" — writing as smearing — and it fails on the shape of the word rather than the sense. The other has Latin borrowing it from Greek **diphthéra**, a prepared hide people wrote on, by way of Etruscan. That one is still live and still unproven.

The word for writing is one of the words we cannot trace. Whatever else literacy did, it did not preserve its own name.

What you've built

You can now name a single character: *una letra*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la letra*
- *una letra*
- *la primera letra*

Before you move on

Which Spanish word means a letter you post? (*La carta* — not *la letra*.) And does anyone know where Latin got *littera*? (No; both proposals are unproven.)

377.2 la frase — a way of speaking

Say *the pepper*, then *the letter*. (*El pimiento*; *La letra*.)

What to know first

- la palabra — the smaller unit.
- hablar — what you do with one.

Sounds you'll need

- *FRA-se*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *fr* runs together and the *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la frase — "phrase."
Greek **phrásis** meant an expression, a manner of speaking. Behind it is the verb **phrázein**, "to point out, to declare." The word came into Latin as *phrasis* and into Spanish from there.
English has it twice, and the second one repays unpacking. A **paraphrase** is *para-* "beside" plus *phrasis*: a saying-alongside. When you paraphrase, you set a second version of the words next to the first. The word describes the action exactly.
One useful difference from English. Spanish *frase* is wider than English *phrase* — it covers a whole sentence, not only a fragment of one. *Una frase* is something you can say and stop.

What you've built

You can now name a whole thing you say: *una frase*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la frase*
- *una frase*
- *una frase en español*

Before you move on

What did Greek *phrásis* mean? (An expression, a way of speaking.) And what does *para-* add in *paraphrase*? (Beside — a saying-alongside.)

377.3 el idioma — what belongs to you

Say *the letter*, then *the phrase*. (*La letra*; *La frase*.)

What to know first

- español — the one you are learning.
- la palabra — what one is made of.

Sounds you'll need

- *i-DIO-ma*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *io* is one glide. The word ends in *-a* and is masculine — *el idioma*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el idioma — "language."
Greek **ídios** meant "one's own, private, particular." From it Greek built **idíōma**, a peculiarity of style — the way of speaking that belongs to one person or one place. Late Latin took it, and Spanish took it from there.
Three English words come off that same root, and the roads are worth walking separately:

- an **idiom** is a turn of phrase belonging to one language and refusing to move into another;
- an **idiosyncrasy** is a temperament belonging to one person;
- an **idiot** is, in Greek, an **idiōtēs** — a **private** person. Someone who held no public office and took no part in civic life. From there it slid to "layman," then to "non-expert," and only much later to the insult.

So the word for a language and the word for a fool start in the same place: what is yours alone. One kept the pride in that and the other picked up the contempt.
A grammatical note you will need. *El idioma* ends in *-a* and is masculine. That *-ma* ending is Greek, and Spanish keeps those nouns masculine as a group.

What you've built

You can now name what you are learning: *un idioma*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el idioma*
- *un idioma*
- *el idioma español*

Before you move on

What did Greek *ídios* mean? (One's own, private.) And what was an *idiōtēs* in Greek? (A private person, one with no public role.)

377.4 la historia — one Greek word that became two English ones

Say *the phrase*, then *the language*. (*La frase*; *El idioma*.)

What to know first

- la carta — one place you might write one down.
- la palabra — what it is built from.

Sounds you'll need

- *his-TO-ria*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *h* is silent, so the word opens on the *i*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la historia — "story."
Greek **historía** did not mean the past. It meant **inquiry** — and then the knowledge you come away with after inquiring. A *hístōr* was someone who knows because they went and found out.
The narrowing to "past events" happened later, and it is worth keeping in mind, because it turns *history* from a subject into a method.
English then took the word **twice**:

- **history**, borrowed formally from Latin *historia*;
- **story**, which came through Anglo-French *estorie* and lost its opening syllable on the way.

For a long time English used them interchangeably. The split between a *history* that happened and a *story* that might not is only about five hundred years old.
Spanish never made that split. **Una historia** is both — the account of what happened and the tale you tell a child — and which one you mean comes from the situation rather than the word.

What you've built

You can now name what you tell: *una historia*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la historia*
- *una historia*
- *una historia larga*

Before you move on

What did Greek *historía* originally mean? (Inquiry, and the knowledge you get from it.) And which English word is the same one worn down through French? (*Story.*)

377.5 el baile — two English balls, one of them unrelated

Say *the language*, then *the story.* (*El idioma*; *La historia.*)

What to know first

- la fiesta — where one happens.
- la risa — what usually comes with it.

Sounds you'll need

- *BAI-le*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ai* is one glide, close to English *eye.* → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el baile — "dance."
Late Latin **ballāre** meant to dance. What Spanish did with it is not the straightforward thing.
An inherited *ballāre* would have come out as ***ballar***. Spanish says **bailar**, and Corominas reads that as a **borrowing** — from Occitan **balar**, taken up around 1270. The stray *-i-* has never been fully explained.
Go one step further back and the Academy's dictionary hedges twice. It offers Greek **pállein**, "to shake," and marks the link *perhaps* both times. So the chain is: certain Spanish word, probable Occitan route, secure Late Latin verb, speculative Greek origin — four links of steadily decreasing confidence.
English inherited the middle of that chain and shows it off:

- a **ball**, the event you dress up for;
- a **ballet**, through Italian;
- a **ballad**, which began as a song to dance to.

And then there is the other **ball**, the round one you throw. That is a Germanic word with no connection whatsoever. Two identical English words, two separate ancestries, and the one that means a dance is the one related to *baile.*

What you've built

You can now name what happens at a party: *un baile*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el baile*
- *un baile*
- *un baile largo*

Before you move on

Did Spanish inherit *bailar* from Latin or borrow it? (Borrow it — from Occitan.) And which English *ball* is related to it? (The dance, not the round thing.)

Chapter 378

Five Places You Can Ask About

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la selva, el prado, el volcán, la cumbre and el edificio, and ask where five kinds of place are.
>
> *Complete ES-C378-edificio: ask where five kinds of place are, and say one thing about each.*

378.1 la selva — the wood inside the word savage

Say *the story*, then *the dance*. (*La historia*; *El baile*.)

What to know first

- el bosque — the cooler kind.
- el árbol — what fills it.

Sounds you'll need

- *SEL-va*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *l* is clear and forward, not the dark *l* English uses at the end of a syllable. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la selva — "jungle."
Latin **silva** was a wood. Spanish kept it as *selva* for the thick, steaming kind. English took it three separate times, and the third is

the one nobody expects.
Sylvan means "of the woods" — and its *y* is a mistake. Somebody decided the word must be Greek, from *hýlē* "forest," and spelled it accordingly. The spelling stuck; the theory did not.
Pennsylvania is "Penn's woods." A detail here gets told wrong nearly every time: it does not honour William Penn the Quaker founder. Charles II named it for **his father**, Admiral Penn, and the son was reportedly uncomfortable about it.
And then **savage**. Latin **silvaticus** meant "of the woods"; Vulgar Latin reshaped it to *salvaticus*; Old French wore it down to *sauvage*; English took that. So the word for wild and cruel began as the word for someone who lives among trees — a judgement passed by people who lived in towns.

What you've built

You can now name a thick forest: *la selva*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la selva*
- *en la selva*
- *¿dónde está la selva?*

Before you move on

Which English word for wildness comes from *silvaticus*? (*Savage* — "of the woods".) And whom is Pennsylvania named for? (Admiral Penn, the founder's father.)

378.2 el prado — a museum named after a field

Say *the dance*, then *the jungle*. (*El baile*; *La selva*.)

What to know first

- el campo — the bigger version.

- la vaca — what stands in it.

Sounds you'll need

- *PRA-do*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *pr* runs together, the *r* is a single tap, and the *d* between vowels is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el prado — "meadow."
Latin **pratum** was a meadow, and Spanish kept it almost unchanged. English has the same word, gone a long way round. French built **prairie** on a Vulgar Latin *prataria*, and English borrowed that — which is why the grasslands of North America are named in Latin by way of Paris.
The best use of this word is a place you may already know by name without knowing what it says. The **Prado** in Madrid is a museum, and the word on the front of it means *meadow*. It stands on what were the **Prado de los Jerónimos**, the fields beside the monastery of Saint Jerome. People called the building "the Prado" long before anybody made that official, and the Academy's dictionary still gives a second sense for *prado*: a pleasant place in a town where people go to walk. Where *pratum* itself came from, nobody has established. The trail stops at Latin, which is a perfectly respectable place for a trail to stop.

What you've built

You can now name a field of grass: *el prado*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el prado*
- *en el prado*
- *¿dónde está el prado?*

Before you move on

Which English word for grassland comes from *pratum*? (*Prairie*, through French.) And what does the name of Madrid's Prado museum mean? (Meadow — it stands on one.)

378.3 el volcán — a mountain named after a god

Say *the jungle*, then *the meadow*. (*La selva*; *El prado.*)

What to know first

- la montaña — what it looks like from far off.
- el fuego — what comes out of it.

Sounds you'll need

- *vol-CÁN*, two beats with the weight on the second. The written accent is needed because a word ending in *-n* would otherwise be stressed on the first beat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el volcán — "volcano."
Almost every word you have for a landscape describes what the thing is like. This one names a **person**.
Vulcānus was the Roman god of fire and the forge. The Academy's dictionary routes the word into Spanish through **Portuguese** *volcão* — sailors' vocabulary, brought back — and from there to the god's name. The Romans looked at the burning mountains of Sicily and read them as his workshop: the smoke was a chimney, the noise was hammering. One thing to hold loosely. You will often read that the word comes specifically from the island of **Vulcano**, off Sicily, taken to be the chimney of the forge. It is a good story and it is not what the etymological dictionaries say — they go from the god to the word and leave the island out. Where a decorative detail turns up in travel writing but not in the dictionaries, keep it as decoration.

What you've built

You can now name a mountain that burns: *un volcán.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el volcán*
- *un volcán*
- *¿dónde está el volcán?*

Before you move on

Which god is *volcán* named after? (Vulcan, the Roman god of fire and the forge.) And which language did Spanish take the word from? (Portuguese.)

378.4 la cumbre — the ridge of a roof

Say *the meadow*, then *the volcano.* (*El prado*; *El volcán.*)

What to know first

- la montaña — what it is the top of.
- el techo — what the word meant first.

Sounds you'll need

- *CUM-bre*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *mb* runs together, and the *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la cumbre — "summit."
Latin **culmen** was the **ridge of a roof** – the beam along the very top, where the two slopes meet. The mountain came later.
Spanish still had the old sense well into the Middle Ages. Berceo, writing around 1236, uses *cunbre* for a roofline, not a peak.
The ending is a pattern you already own without having been told its

name. Latin nouns in *-men* lose their middle vowel in Spanish and grow a *b* to hold the wreckage together:

- *hominem* → **hombre**;
- *nominem* → **nombre**;
- *culminem* → **cumbre**.

Only the first of those is real Latin. *Nomen* and *culmen* are neuter, and a neuter accusative matches its nominative – so Latin had *nomen* and *culmen*, full stop. The other two are **reconstructed**, remade later by analogy with *hominem*. A dictionary prints a star in front of a form like that to say that nobody ever wrote it down.

The vowel is irregular too. A short *u* normally lands as *o* in Spanish, so this word should have come out *combre*. Corominas blames the *l*, which pulled the vowel upward and then vanished into it. So do not use *cumbre* as your model for what a short *u* does.

One last thing, because it is the opposite of what you would guess. The word closest to *culmen* is not English **culminate**, a late borrowing taken straight off *culmen* itself. It is Latin **columen** – *culmen* is that word with its middle syllable squeezed out, one word in two states of compression.

Latin **columna**, the pillar, is built on the same root by a different route, which makes it a **cousin** rather than a twin. The difference is the point: a twin is one word in two shapes, a cousin is a separate word built from the same material. A roof ridge, a pillar and a mountaintop are all the thing that stands highest.

What you've built

You can now name the top of a mountain: *la cumbre*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la cumbre*
- *en la cumbre*
- *¿dónde está la cumbre?*

Before you move on

What did Latin *culmen* mean first? (The ridge of a roof.) And which Latin word is *culmen* the squeezed-down form of? (*Columen* — while *columna*, the pillar, is a cousin rather than a twin.)

378.5 el edificio — a house-making

Say *the volcano*, then *the summit*. (*El volcán*; *La cumbre*.)

What to know first

- la casa — the smaller version.
- la ciudad — what enough of them make.

Sounds you'll need

- *e-di-FI-cio*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *c* before *i* is soft, and the *io* at the end is one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el edificio — "building."
Edificio is Latin **aedificium**, and it comes apart cleanly:

- **aedes** — a temple in the singular, a house in the plural;
- **facere** — to make, which you have already met behind *hacer*.

A building is a house-making. Spanish has kept both halves visible, which is unusual: most compounds this old have worn smooth.
English took the same Latin twice. An **edifice** is the thing built. To **edify** is the act — and English kept only the figurative sense of it, which is building a *person* up rather than a wall. Spanish did the same: the Academy's dictionary gives *edificar* a second meaning about instilling virtue.
One temptation to resist. *Aedes* is sometimes glossed "hearth," and it is not a Latin meaning. It is a reconstructed prehistoric sense, inferred from a root meaning "to burn" — a much older and much shakier

claim than the ones above. In actual Latin, *aedes* is a temple or a house, and that is what the word was built on.

What you've built

You can now name what a street is made of: *un edificio*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el edificio*
- *un edificio*
- *¿dónde está el edificio?*

Before you move on

What two Latin words make up *aedificium*? (*Aedes*, temple or house, and *facere*, to make.) And what does English *edify* build? (A person, not a wall.)

Chapter 379

Five Words for How Something Feels

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say seco, mojado, fresco, tibio and grueso, and count five things and say how each one feels.
>
> *Complete ES-C379-grueso: count five things and say how each one feels, and say one thing about each.*

379.1 seco — the word on a wine label

Say *the summit*, then *the building.* (*La cumbre*; *El edificio.*)

What to know first

- el polvo — what a dry place makes.
- la arena — dry by definition.

Sounds you'll need

- *SE-co*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *o* is a hard *k*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

seco — "dry."
Latin **siccus** was dry. English has it in **desiccate**, and French put it

on a bottle: *sec* on a wine label means the wine is not sweet.
Two further claims travel with this word, and they are worth separating, because one is true in a complicated way and the other may not be true at all.
German *Sekt* really does descend from French *sec*, borrowed in the seventeenth century. But in German it never meant dry. It named a **sweet** wine from southern Spain and the Canaries, and it became the word for sparkling wine by accident: German translators rendered Shakespeare's *sack* as *Sect*, and the story goes that in an 1825 Berlin tavern the actor Ludwig Devrient, still in character as Falstaff, demanded "Sekt" and was served champagne.
Treat that last part as an anecdote. It is repeated everywhere and rests on very little. The borrowing itself is not in doubt; the tavern is.
English *sack*, the old name for sherry, is usually filed under *sec* too — and there the evidence gets thin. The Oxford dictionary admits it cannot explain the vowel, and the wine in question was sweet, which is awkward for a word meaning dry. Others propose Spanish *sacar*, "to draw out," from the export trade. Unsettled.
So: *seco*, *desiccate* and *sec* are secure. *Sekt* is a genuine relative that changed jobs. *Sack* is a maybe.

What you've built

You can now describe a thing with no water in it: *muy seco*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *seco*
- *muy seco*
- *un vino seco*

Before you move on

Which English word means to dry something out completely? (*Desiccate.*) And does German *Sekt* mean dry? (No — sparkling, and the tavern story behind that shift is only a story.)

379.2 mojado — wet means softened

Say *the building*, then *dry*. (*El edificio*; *Seco*.)

What to know first

- el agua — what does it.
- la toalla — what undoes it.

Sounds you'll need

- *mo-JA-do*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *j* is a rasp from the back of the throat, and the *d* between vowels is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mojado — "wet."
Mojado comes from **mojar**, and *mojar* is Vulgar Latin **molliāre** — to soften, to make soft. Behind that is **mollis**, "soft."
So Spanish did not name wetness after water. It named it after what water **does**: bread goes soft, leather goes soft, earth goes soft. The word is about the result, not the substance.
English holds the same *mollis* in two places, both of them still about softening:

- to **mollify** someone is to soften them;
- an **emollient** is a cream that softens skin.

Spanish keeps two more cousins nearby. A **muelle** is a spring — the soft, yielding thing in a mattress. And a **molusco** is a mollusc, an animal classified by its soft body.
The Academy's dictionary gives this chain without a single hedge, which is rarer than you might expect and worth noticing when it happens.

What you've built

You can now describe something covered in water: *muy mojado*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mojado*
- *muy mojado*
- *el papel está mojado*

Before you move on

What did Latin *molliāre* mean? (To soften.) And which English cream is named from the same *mollis*? (An emollient.)

379.3 fresco — the word on a church ceiling

Say *dry*, then *wet*. (*Seco*; *Mojado*.)

What to know first

- el frío — the stronger version.
- el calor — what it relieves.

Sounds you'll need

- *FRES-co*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *fr* runs together, the *r* is a single tap, and the *c* before *o* is a hard *k*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

fresco — "cool."
This one is Germanic. Some form of **frisk** — "new, lively" — spread through Romance and settled in Spanish as *fresco*. The Academy's dictionary does not say which Germanic language handed it over, and neither will anybody else with confidence.
English **fresh** has that same Germanic root, but it did not borrow it from Spanish or from French. It inherited it: Old English **fersc** meant "unsalted."
The interesting part is that Romance then came back and reshaped the

English word anyway. The letters swapped places (*fersc* to *fresh*), and the senses spread out to "new, pure, eager" — both changes probably under the influence of Old French *fres*, which was the same Germanic word arriving from the other direction. So English kept its own root and borrowed its own word's shape.
And a **fresco** on a church ceiling is this word in Italian dress. The painter works *a fresco*, on the fresh plaster, while it is still damp — the pigment sinks in and dries as part of the wall. Painting on plaster that has already set is a different technique with a different name.

What you've built

You can now describe cool air: *muy fresco*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *fresco*
- *muy fresco*
- *hace fresco*

Before you move on

Is *fresco* Latin or Germanic? (Germanic.) And why is a fresco called that? (The paint goes onto fresh, still-wet plaster.)

379.4 tibio — one Latin word, two states of wear

Say *wet*, then *cool*. (*Mojado*; *Fresco*.)

What to know first

- el calor — the far end of it.
- la leche — the thing most often described this way.

Sounds you'll need

- *TI-bio*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *b* between vowels is soft, and the *io* is one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tibio — "lukewarm."
Latin **tepidus** meant lukewarm. Spanish has *tibio*. English has **tepid**. They are the same word.
What separates them is not ancestry but **mileage**.
Tibio travelled the long way: mouth to mouth, generation after generation, for two thousand years, and it wore down the way a stone step wears down. *Tepid* took a shortcut. English lifted it out of written Latin around 1400, which is why it still looks like the original.
This is one of the most useful things to know about Romance vocabulary. When a Spanish word and an English word come from the same Latin but look different, the usual reason is that one was **spoken** the whole way and the other was **read** into existence much later.
A footnote for anyone checking the sound changes: the *i* in *tibio* is not what the ordinary rules predict — a short *e* should have given *ie*. Corominas explains it as the vowel being pulled upward by the glide that follows. Worth knowing so you do not use this word as your model.

What you've built

You can now describe something neither hot nor cold: *muy tibio*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tibio*
- *muy tibio*
- *la leche está tibia*

Before you move on

Which English word is *tibio*'s exact Latin twin? (*Tepid.*) And why do they look so different? (One was spoken for two thousand years; the other was read out of a book around 1400.)

379.5 grueso — the word behind grocer

Say *cool*, then *lukewarm*. (*Fresco*; *Tibio.*)

What to know first

- la manta — the thing you want to be thick.
- el hilo — the thing you want thin.

Sounds you'll need

- *GRUE-so*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *ue* is one glide, and the *r* after the *g* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

grueso — "thick."
Grossus meant thick or coarse — and it is **Late** Latin, not classical. Cicero would not have used it, and where it came from before that is not known.
English took it through Old French as **gross**, which still carries both the old sense (a gross weight, the whole of it) and a newer disgusted one.
The better cousin is **grocer**. A grocer is not named for groceries. Medieval Latin **grossarius** meant a dealer who sold in **quantity** — wholesale, rather than a piece at a time. That is what the word says about the job: not what you sell, but the size you sell it in.
One tidy-looking bridge to refuse. English also has a noun **a gross**, meaning twelve dozen, and it is tempting to say a grocer is someone who sells "by the gross." That is a later and separate development, from a French phrase for a large dozen. The occupation came from the adjective, not from the counting word.

What you've built

You can now describe something with weight to it: *muy grueso*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *grueso*
- *muy grueso*
- *un libro grueso*

Before you move on

Was *grossus* classical Latin? (No — Late Latin, and its own origin is unknown.) And what did a *grossarius* sell? (Goods in bulk, rather than by the piece.)

Chapter 380

Five Words for What Something Is Like

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say simpático, alegre, feo, último and necesario, and count five people or things and say what each is like.
>
> *Complete ES-C380-necesario: count five people or things and say what each is like, and say one thing about each.*

380.1 simpático — a false friend worth knowing

Say *lukewarm*, then *thick*. (*Tibio*; *Grueso*.)

What to know first

- amable — the nearest thing you already have.
- la gente — who you use it about.

Sounds you'll need

- *sim-PÁ-ti-co*, four beats with the weight on the second. Words stressed that far back always carry a written accent. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

simpático — "likeable."
Simpático means **likeable**. Pleasant company. Someone you are glad to sit next to.
It does **not** mean sympathetic, and this catches English speakers constantly. If you want sympathetic — feeling for somebody's trouble — Spanish reaches for **compasivo**.
The history explains the gap. Greek **sympátheia** meant a community of feeling; Latin borrowed it as *sympathīa*; Spanish has it as **simpatía**. Then Spanish built its own adjective on top, and the Academy's dictionary gives *simpático* no separate etymology at all — because there is nothing further back to give. The word was made in Spanish, and the sense "likeable" is only about two and a half centuries old.
English **sympathetic** was built separately, on a different Greek suffix. So the two adjectives are cousins through the noun rather than the same word wearing two spellings, which is precisely why they were free to drift apart.
There is one place they still agree, and it is a strange one: the *sistema nervioso simpático* is the sympathetic nervous system. Medicine kept the older meaning while ordinary speech walked off with it.

What you've built

You can now describe somebody you like: *muy simpático.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *simpático*
- *muy simpático*
- *una persona simpática*

Before you move on

What does *simpático* mean? (Likeable — not sympathetic.) And which Spanish word does mean sympathetic? (*Compasivo.*)

380.2 alegre — the word on a piece of sheet music

Say *thick*, then *likeable*. (*Grueso*; *Simpático*.)

What to know first

- contento — the quieter version.
- triste — the opposite.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-LE-gre*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *g* before *r* is hard, and the *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

alegre — "cheerful."
Latin **alacer** meant lively, brisk, eager — quicker and more physical than "cheerful."
The Academy's dictionary does something worth noticing on the way to Spanish. Rather than going straight from *alacer* to *alegre*, it puts a spoken-Latin stage in between and prints **two** reconstructed forms for it – not a chain of two ancestors, but one step somebody had to guess at twice.
What makes that worth pointing out is the contrast inside the entry. The two spoken forms carry a star; *alacer* does not, because *alacer* is written down in real Latin texts. The dictionary is marking, form by form, which words it has evidence for and which it is reconstructing.
English has the word as **alacrity** — a brisk willingness, doing something without being asked twice. The old "quick" sense survives there better than in Spanish.
And Italian handed it to music. **Allegro** on a score means fast, and every orchestra in the world reads a Latin word for liveliness at the top of the page.
Where *alacer* came from before Latin is not settled. Several proposals exist; none has won.

What you've built

You can now describe somebody in good spirits: *muy alegre*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *alegre*
- *muy alegre*
- *una fiesta alegre*

Before you move on

What did Latin *alacer* mean? (Lively, brisk.) And which musical instruction is the same word? (*Allegro*.)

380.3 feo — two Latin words that fell together

Say *likeable*, then *cheerful*. (*Simpático*; *Alegre*.)

What to know first

- la cara — what it is usually said about.
- pálido — another word for how something looks.

Sounds you'll need

- *FE-o*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *e* and the *o* stay as two separate vowels — they do not run together. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

feo — "ugly."
Latin had **two** words spelled *foedus*, and they had nothing to do with each other.
One was an **adjective**: foul, filthy, loathsome. That one is *feo*.
The other was a **noun**: a treaty, a league, an alliance. That one is

where English gets **federal**, **federation** and **confederate** — and, further back, it belongs with *fidēs*, "trust," which Spanish keeps as *fe* and *fiel*. A federation is a thing built on trust.
The Academy's dictionary quietly keeps them apart. Under *federal* it prints a gloss — "pact, alliance." Under *feo* it prints none, because the adjective is a different word and needs no such explanation.
So *feo* and *federal* are one of the cleanest look-alikes in the language: a spelling collision inside Latin itself, carried forward into two modern languages that have no idea they are holding a coincidence.
One restraint worth keeping. It is safe to say the two Latin words are unrelated. It is less safe to give each of them a confident deeper ancestor — the treaty word's is well established, the ugly word's is not.

What you've built

You can now describe something nobody wants to see: *muy feo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *feo*
- *muy feo*
- *un día feo*

Before you move on

How many Latin words were spelled *foedus*? (Two — an adjective meaning foul and a noun meaning treaty.) And which one gave English *federal*? (The noun.)

380.4 último — the far end of beyond

Say *cheerful*, then *ugly*. (*Alegre*; *Feo*.)

What to know first

- primero — the other end.

- próximo — the one after this.

Sounds you'll need

- *ÚL-ti-mo*, three beats with the weight on the first. Words stressed that far back always carry a written accent. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

último — "last."
Latin **ultimus** meant farthest, last. It is a **superlative** — the furthest-out member of a family built on a stem meaning "beyond." The family has three steps, and getting them in order matters:

- the stem, meaning beyond;
- the comparative **ulter**, "farther";
- the superlative **ultimus**, "farthest."

English borrowed from the end of that list. An **ultimate** answer is the last one there is. An **ultimatum** is the last offer before something unpleasant.
And **ultra** belongs to the family too — but not where people usually put it. *Ultra* is not the base that *ultimus* was built on. It is a frozen form of the comparative *ulter*, which makes it *ultimus*'s **sibling**, not its parent. Saying "*ultra* gave us *ultimus*" reverses the relationship.
A small thing, and a good habit: when a family is laid out for you, check which member is the ancestor and which are the cousins standing beside it.

What you've built

You can now name the final one: *el último*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *último*
- *el último*

- *la última vez*

Before you move on

What kind of form is *ultimus*? (A superlative — the farthest.) And is *ultra* its parent? (No — its sibling, a frozen form of the comparative.)

380.5 necesario — a word two languages read out of the same book

Say *ugly*, then *last*. (*Feo*; *Último*.)

What to know first

- bastante — the word for having enough.
- poco — the word for not having enough.

Sounds you'll need

- *ne-ce-SA-rio*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *c* before *e* is soft, and the *io* at the end is one glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

necesario — "necessary."
Latin **necessarius** came from **necesse**, "unavoidable." Spanish has *necesario*; English has **necessary**.
Neither language inherited it. Both **read it out of Latin** — Spanish and English each lifted the word from the written language rather than receiving it through centuries of speech. That is why they still match almost letter for letter:

- *necesario* and *necessary*;
- *necesidad* and *necessity*.

Compare that with a word that was actually spoken the whole way, where the two languages end up unrecognisable to each other. A pair

that still line up this neatly are usually a pair that were **borrowed**, not inherited, and that is a reliable thing to notice.
On where *necesse* itself came from: nobody has closed the case. There is a defensible proposal, and there is a tempting gloss attached to it — that *necesse* means "what cannot be got round." Set that aside. The gloss is the proposal restated and nothing more: you get "cannot be got round" only by first assuming the analysis it is supposed to support. A translation of a guess is not evidence for the guess.

What you've built

You can now say that something must happen: *es necesario*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *necesario*
- *es necesario*
- *no es necesario*

Before you move on

Did Spanish inherit *necesario* or borrow it? (Borrow it, out of written Latin — which is why English matches it so closely.) And is it known what *necesse* is built from? (No; the case is open.)

Chapter 381

Four Everyday Actions English Kept

Modes: **voice** (3) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 3 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say lavar, romper, saltar and soñar, and name four everyday actions.

Complete ES-C381-sonar: name four everyday actions, and say which one you do most often.

381.1 lavar — a washing-place, and a downpour

Say *last*, then *necessary.* (*Último*; *necesario.*)

What to know first

- el agua — what you wash with.
- la cara — one thing you wash.

Sounds you'll need

- *la-VAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *v* is the same sound as *b*, and the final *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lavar — "to wash."
Latin **lavare** meant to wash, and that is the whole of the Spanish story. Said like that it is a circle: the word for washing comes from the word for washing. So the interesting part is not where *lavar* came from. It is where else the same Latin verb went.
English has it three times over, and never looking like itself.
A **lavatory** is, literally, a washing-place. The room got its name from the basin, not the other way round — which is why the word sounds so formal for so ordinary a thing.
To **launder** is the same verb, arrived by a longer road: Latin *lavandaria*, things to be washed, through French, losing a syllable on the way. The modern sense of laundering money is a metaphor somebody built on top of an already buried one.
And **lavish** is the surprise. Before it meant generous, it meant a downpour — a *lavasse*, a sudden heavy rain. Spending lavishly is spending the way rain falls.
One caution, because it is the connection everyone reaches for first: **lava** and **lavender** are *not* safe to add to this list. Both have disputed etymologies, and the tidy story that lava is "what washes down the mountain" is one proposal among several rather than the answer.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *lavar*. And you can hear it inside an English word you already knew.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lavar*
- *lavar la cara*
- *el agua*

Before you move on

Which English room is named for its basin? (*Lavatory.*) And what did *lavish* mean before it meant generous? (A downpour.)

381.2 romper — a road is something broken through a forest

Say *necessary.* (*Necesario.*) And *to wash*? (*Lavar.*)

What to know first

- la puerta — something breakable.
- la ventana — another.

Sounds you'll need

- *rom-PER*, two beats with the weight on the second. The opening *r* is the strong trilled one at the start of a word. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

romper — "to break."
Latin **rumpere**, to break or burst. Again the direct line is a circle, so take the branch instead — and this one is worth the walk.
The past participle of *rumpere* was **rupta**, "broken." Roman Latin had the phrase **rupta via**: a *broken way.* It meant a path forced through a forest by breaking the trees down, as opposed to a road that was built. Drop the *via*, keep the adjective, and *rupta* becomes French *route* and then English **route**. Every route you have ever taken is, etymologically, something somebody smashed a way through.
English also kept the verb straight, in **rupture**, **erupt** and **abrupt** — an abrupt ending is one that breaks off.
A false friend to refuse: **romp** has nothing to do with *romper.* It is a much later English word of unclear origin, and the resemblance is an accident.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *romper.* And you know why a route is not a built road.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *romper*
- *romper la ventana*
- *lavar la puerta*

Before you move on

What was a *rupta via*? (A way broken through a forest.) Is English *romp* related? (No — an accident.)

381.3 saltar — a jump over the top

Say *to break*. (*Romper*.) And *to wash*? (*Lavar*.)

What to know first

- el pie — what you jump with.
- arriba — where you jump to.

Sounds you'll need

- *sal-TAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *l* is clear, never swallowed the way English swallows it in *salt*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

saltar — "to jump."
Latin **saltare** meant to leap, and also to dance — the two were one idea to a Roman. The Spanish is the Latin, so once more the branch is the interesting part.
The best one is **somersault**, which does not look like it contains a Latin verb at all. It is *supra saltus* — a jump *over the top*. The first half is Latin *supra*, above, the same *supra* in *supranational*; the second half is this verb. A somersault is a going-over-jump, and the word has been carrying that description, unread, for centuries.
Two more: **assault** is *ad-* plus this verb, leaping *at* somebody. And a **sally**, when troops rush out of a fort, is the same leap from the French.
The false friend is right there in the pronunciation note: **salt** is not related. English *salt* is a native Germanic word, cousin to Latin *sal*,

and has nothing to do with jumping. *Salt* and *somersault* only rhyme.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *saltar*. And you can take a somersault apart into two Latin words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *saltar*
- *saltar arriba*
- *romper*

Before you move on

What are the two halves of *somersault*? (*Supra* — above; *saltus* — a jump.) Is *salt* related? (No.)

381.4 soñar — the tilde used to be an m

Say *to jump*. (*Saltar.*) And *to break*? (*Romper.*)

What to know first

- la cama — where you do it.
- la noche — when.

Sounds you'll need

- *so-ÑAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *ñ* is one sound, the *ny* of *canyon*, not an *n* followed by a *y*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

soñar — "to dream."
Latin **somnus** was sleep; **somniare** was to dream. Spanish took the

verb.
Look at what happened to the **m**. *Somniare* has *mn* in the middle, and Spanish would not keep that cluster — the two nasals collapsed into a single new sound, and the letter invented to write it was **ñ**. The tilde itself began as a small *n* written above the line by scribes saving parchment. So the mark on top of *soñar* is, quite literally, the second nasal of the Latin word, moved upstairs.
English kept *somnus* rather than the verb. **Insomnia** is *in-* plus *somnus*: not-sleep. **Somnolent** means sleepy, and a **somnambulist** is a sleep-walker — *somnus* plus *ambulare*, to walk.
A false friend, and an easy one to fall into: **sonar** without the tilde is a different Spanish verb, meaning to sound, and English *sonar* is not Spanish at all — it is a modern acronym. The tilde is doing real work here.

What you've built

You can now name four everyday actions: *lavar*, *romper*, *saltar*, *soñar*. Say which one you do most often.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *soñar*
- *soñar en la cama*
- *lavar, romper, saltar, soñar*

Before you move on

What does *insomnia* take apart into? (*In-* not, *somnus* sleep.) And what did the tilde on *ñ* used to be? (A small *n* written above the line.)

Chapter 382

Four Verbs Two Languages Built Twice

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say empezar, acabar, pagar and quedar, and name four everyday actions.
>
> *Complete ES-C382-quedar: name four everyday actions, and say which one you did today.*

382.1 empezar — taking the first piece off

Say *to jump*, then *to dream*. (*Saltar*; *soñar*.)

What to know first

- el pan — something you begin by taking a piece off.
- el libro — something else you begin.

Sounds you'll need

- *em-pe-ZAR*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *z* is the *th* of *think* in much of Spain and an *s* across the Americas. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

empezar — "to begin."
There is a noun hiding in the middle of it: **pieza**, a piece. The Academy's dictionary builds *empezar* from *en-* plus *pieza*, and the picture that gives you is physical. To begin a thing is to take the first piece off it — the first slice of bread, the first page.
Pieza itself goes back to a spoken-Romance **pettia**, a word the dictionaries star because nobody wrote it down. It is one of the small group of everyday words the Romans seem to have taken from the Gaulish spoken around them rather than brought with them, though that origin is offered with a hedge rather than asserted.
Now the part worth slowing down for. English **begin** comes from a Germanic verb with no piece in it anywhere. Two languages, no contact on this word, and both of them reached for the same image: starting is breaking into something whole.
English did keep *pettia* by another road. A **piece** is the same word, arriving through French. So *empezar* and *piece* are relatives, and *empezar* and *begin* are strangers who happen to think alike.
One caution: the Academy marks the *pettia* step as reconstructed. The line from *pieza* to *empezar* is firm; the line behind *pieza* is a proposal.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *empezar*. And you can see a piece inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *empezar*
- *empezar el libro*
- *soñar*

Before you move on

Which noun is hiding inside *empezar*? (*Pieza* — a piece.) And is English *begin* related? (No — the same idea, built separately.)

382.2 acabar — bringing a thing to its head

Say *to dream*, then *to begin*. (*Soñar*; *empezar*.)

What to know first

- empezar — the opposite end of the same job.
- el libro — something you finish.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-ca-BAR*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*, and the *b* between vowels is soft, closer to a *v* made with both lips. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

acabar — "to finish."
Inside it is **cabo**, which in Spanish means an end — and also a headland, the bit of land that runs out into the sea. Both senses come from Latin **caput**, a head. To *acabar* something is to bring it to its head, its far end.
That metaphor is not unusual. What is unusual is that English built it twice, independently, and you use one of them constantly.
Achieve came into English from Old French *achever*, and *achever* is *à chef* — *chef* being the French descendant of the same *caput*. To achieve is to come to a head. *Acabar* and *achieve* are not borrowings of one another. They are the same sentence written by two neighbours who each had the word for head and the same idea about what finishing is.
The family is large once you can see it. A **chief** is a head person. A **chef** is the head of a kitchen. **Capital** is head-money, a **captain** is a head-officer, and to **decapitate** is to remove one.
And Spanish kept the plain noun too: **la cabeza**, the head, which you already have. *Cabo* and *cabeza* are two children of *caput* that grew up in different rooms.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *acabar*. And you can hear *caput* in *achieve*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *acabar*
- *empezar y acabar*
- *acabar el libro*

Before you move on

What did Latin *caput* mean? (A head.) And what does *achieve* take apart into? (The French *à chef* — to a head.)

382.3 pagar — paying is making peace

Say *to begin*, then *to finish*. (*Empezar*; *acabar*.)

What to know first

- el dinero — what you pay with.
- el mercado — where.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-GAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *g* before *a* is hard, and between vowels it softens almost to nothing. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pagar — "to pay."
Latin **pacare** meant to pacify, to bring to peace. It was built on **pax**, peace, which you can still see in the *pa-* at the front.
The road from peace to money is short once you stand where a Roman stood. If you owed somebody, there was a quarrel between you. To settle the debt was to settle the quarrel — to *pacify* the creditor, so that no claim remained. Payment was the end of a dispute before it was a transaction.
English took the same verb by the same road, through French *payer*, and so **pay** is *pagar*'s sibling rather than its translation. Once you

have that, the family opens up: **peace** itself, a **pact** (an agreement that ends an argument), to **appease**, and **pacific** — an ocean named for looking calm.
Now the trap. **Pagan** looks like it belongs here and does not. It comes from Latin *paganus*, a country-dweller, from *pagus*, a rural district.
The two words share their first three letters and nothing else. A pagan is a villager, not a payer.
Spanish keeps the plain noun as well: **la paz**, peace — *pax* with its ending worn off.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *pagar*. And you know why paying and peace are one word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pagar*
- *pagar el pan*
- *pagar en el mercado*

Before you move on

What did *pacare* mean? (To pacify, to bring to peace.) Is *pagan* in this family? (No — that is *pagus*, a village.)

382.4 quedar — coming to rest

Say *to finish*, then *to pay*. (*Acabar*; *pagar*.)

What to know first

- la casa — where you might stay.
- abajo — a place you might stay.

Sounds you'll need

- *que-DAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. *Qu-* before *e* is a plain *k*; the *u* is silent, doing nothing but keeping the *c* hard. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

quedar — "to stay, to remain."
Latin **quies** was rest or stillness, and **quietare** was to make something still. Spanish turned that into *quedar*: to stay is to come to rest in a place rather than to move through it.
English helped itself to this root three separate times, and the three do not look like relatives.
Quiet is the closest — the adjective straight off *quietus*, still.
Quit is the surprise. To quit was to release somebody from an obligation, to leave them in peace, and only later to leave a place or a job. A **requiem** is the same word again, asking rest for the dead.
And **coy** is the one nobody guesses. It came through French *coi*, which meant still and quiet, from *quietus*. Somebody described as coy was originally motionless and reserved. The modern flirtatious sense is a later drift, and the word has quietly kept its old meaning underneath.
Spanish also kept the adjective **quieto**, still, alongside the verb — the two sitting next to each other, one describing the state and one the act of arriving at it.

What you've built

You can now name four more everyday actions: *empezar*, *acabar*, *pagar*, *quedar*. Say which one you did today.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *quedar*
- *quedar en casa*
- *empezar, acabar, pagar, quedar*

Before you move on

What did *quies* mean? (Rest, stillness.) And what did *coy* mean before it meant teasing? (Still and reserved.)

Chapter 383

Two Words From Outside, and Two Nobody Can Place

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say guardar, dejar, sacar and buscar, and name four everyday actions.
>
> *Complete ES-C383-buscar: name four everyday actions, and say which one you do most.*

383.1 guardar — why English has both ward and guard

Say *to pay*, then *to stay*. (*Pagar*; *quedar*.)

What to know first

- la llave — something you keep.
- la casa — where you keep it.

Sounds you'll need

- *guar-DAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. *Gu-* before *a* is a hard *g* followed by a real *w* glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

guardar — "to keep, to put away."
This one is not Latin. It comes from a Germanic verb **wardōn**, to watch over — the same root as English **ward**, in the sense of watching and protecting.
The interesting part is the first sound. Latin and its descendants had no **w-** at the start of a word, so when Germanic words arrived, Romance speakers reached for the nearest thing they had and produced **gu-**. *Wardōn* became *guardar*.
Now watch what that does to English, which borrowed from both sides. English already had **ward** from its own Germanic stock. Then it borrowed the French version of the very same word and got **guard**. Both are in the dictionary, meaning almost the same thing, and most speakers never notice.
The pattern repeats down the whole family:

- a **warden** and a **guardian**
- a **reward** and a **regard**
- **warranty** and **guarantee**
- and the names **William** and **Guillermo**, which are one name

Each pair is one word that entered English twice, once before the sound change and once after. Whenever you meet an English pair where one has *w-* and the other *gu-*, you are looking at this.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *guardar*. And you can spot a *w-*/*gu-* pair on sight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *guardar*
- *guardar la llave*
- *guardar en casa*

Before you move on

Why does Spanish have *gu-* where Germanic had *w-*? (Romance had no word-initial *w-*.) Name a pair. (*Ward* and *guard*.)

383.2 dejar — the d- was borrowed from another verb

Say *to stay*, then *to keep*. (*Quedar*; *guardar*.)

What to know first

- la puerta — something you leave open.
- guardar — the opposite move.

Sounds you'll need

- *de-JAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *j* is the rasping sound made at the back of the mouth, not an English *j*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dejar — "to leave, to let."
The root is Latin **laxare**, to loosen or slacken, from *laxus*, loose. Leaving something alone is loosening your grip on it, and letting somebody do something is slackening the rein.
But *laxare* does not give you *dejar*, and the gap is the lesson. Latin *l-* gives Spanish *l-*, and older Spanish had exactly what you would predict: **lejar**. That form is written down.
So where did the *d-* come from? The Academy's dictionary answers it in three words — *infl. por dar*. **Dar**, to give, is one of the commonest verbs in the language, and it sat close to *lejar* in meaning and in use. Its opening consonant leaked across. The word was pulled out of shape by a neighbour.
That kind of change has no rule behind it. It happens because two words keep company, and it is worth seeing once, because a sound law would never have predicted this *d*.
English took *laxare* several times: **relax**, **lax**, and — through French

— **leash**, which is a thing you slacken. **Laxative** is the same idea applied somewhere else entirely.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *dejar*. And you know one word can reshape another.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dejar*
- *dejar la puerta*
- *guardar y dejar*

Before you move on

What did *laxare* mean? (To loosen.) And which verb lent *dejar* its *d-*? (*Dar.*)

383.3 sacar — an argument that is still open

Say *to keep*, then *to leave*. (*Guardar*; *dejar.*)

What to know first

- el dinero — something you take out.
- dejar — a near neighbour in meaning.

Sounds you'll need

- *sa-CAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sacar — "to take out."
This is a word where the honest answer is that scholars disagree, and it

is worth watching them disagree.
Start with what is settled — a negative. *Sacar* is **not** a verb built on **saco**, a bag, in the plain way it looks like it might be. Making a verb from *saco* would give you something meaning to put *into* a sack, which is the opposite of what *sacar* means. Corominas dismissed the attempt to rescue that reading as a desperate expedient.
From there the road forks.
Corominas proposed **Gothic sakan**, to go to law, to dispute — the idea being a legal one, taking something out by judgement. The Academy's dictionary follows him, with *Quizá* in front of it.
A long line of Romance scholars prefers **Latin saccare**. That looks like the bag again, and it is not: alongside the bag, Latin *saccus* named a **filter**, and the verb *saccare* is written down only in the sense of filtering — straining wine, straining water. Taking out by filtering is a very different picture from taking out by lawsuit.
So the bag may be a distant relative after all, by way of a strainer rather than a sack. Nobody has closed the question. What you can say safely is the negative, and that **saquear**, to plunder, really does come from *saco*.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *sacar*. And you can hold two proposals without picking one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sacar*
- *sacar el dinero*
- *guardar y sacar*

Before you move on

What is the settled part? (That *sacar* is not a plain verb from *saco*, a bag.) What did Latin *saccus* mean besides a bag? (A filter.)

383.4 buscar — one of the commonest verbs, and nobody knows

Say *to leave*, then *to take out*. (*Dejar*; *sacar*.)

What to know first

- la llave — something you look for.
- la calle — where you look.

Sounds you'll need

- *bus-CAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The opening *b* is soft between vowels and firmer at the start of a phrase. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buscar — "to look for."
Every lesson so far has ended somewhere. This one does not, and that is the point of it.
Buscar is one of the most-used verbs in Spanish. It is written down in the eleventh century. And Corominas, whose dictionary is the standard work on Spanish origins, gives his verdict as **de origen desconocido** — of unknown origin. That is his strongest negative label, stronger than calling something uncertain.
He does float an idea. Perhaps, he asks, a Celtic word about winning or conquering? Then he answers his own question: the hypothesis, though possible, is very risky. Two modern dictionaries of reconstructed Celtic list what that root became in each language, and *buscar* is on neither list.
There is a second story you may meet, connecting *buscar* to **bosque**, a wood, as though searching were foraging. The dates refuse it. *Bosque* does not appear in Castilian until the fifteenth century, four hundred years after *buscar* is already in use. A word cannot descend from one that arrives later.
One relative can be pointed at, and it is English. To **busk** meant to go about seeking, and a **busker** — a street performer — is one who goes about seeking. The dictionaries name *buscar* in that chain. It tells you nothing about where *buscar* began, and it is the one thread that holds.

What you've built

You can now name four more everyday actions: *guardar*, *dejar*, *sacar*, *buscar*. Say which one you do most.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *buscar*
- *buscar la llave*
- *guardar, dejar, sacar, buscar*

Before you move on

What is Corominas's verdict on *buscar*? (Of unknown origin.) Why can it not come from *bosque*? (*Bosque* arrives four centuries later.)

Chapter 384

Four Roads, and Where the Trail Stops

Modes: **voice** (2) **eyes** (2) **Hands-free start:** none of the 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say enviar, subir, morir and olvidar, and name four everyday actions.

Complete ES-C384-olvidar: name four everyday actions, and say one thing about each.

384.1 enviar — putting a thing on the road

Say *to take out*, then *to look for*. (*Sacar*; *buscar*.)

What to know first

- la calle — a road.
- la ciudad — where you send it.

Sounds you'll need

- *en-vi-AR*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *v* is the same sound as *b*, and *-ia-* here is two beats rather than a glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

enviar — "to send."
Latin **via** was a road, and **inviare** was to put something *on* the road. That is the whole of *enviar*: sending is road-putting, and the road is still sitting in the middle of the word where you can see it.
English borrowed *via* untranslated and uses it as a preposition — travelling *via* Madrid is travelling by way of the road through it. **Obvious** is the same noun: *ob viam*, lying in the way, so obvious things are the ones you trip over. A **viaduct** carries a road.
And an **envoy** is *enviar* itself, borrowed through French: an envoy is a person who has been sent.
Now the false friend, which is a good one because the resemblance is close. **Envy** is *not* in this family. It comes from Latin *invidēre*, to look upon — *in-* plus *vidēre*, to see. To envy somebody is to look at them too hard, with the wrong sort of attention. The Romans thought of it as a kind of gaze.
So *enviar* holds a road and *envy* holds an eye, and the two words merely start the same way.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *enviar*. And you can find a road inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *enviar*
- *enviar a la ciudad*
- *buscar y enviar*

Before you move on

Which noun is inside *enviar*? (*Via* — a road.) Is *envy* related? (No — that is *vidēre*, to see.)

384.2 subir — a verb for going up that starts with under

Say *to look for*, then *to send*. (*Buscar*; *enviar*.)

What to know first

- arriba — where you end up.
- abajo — where you start.

Sounds you'll need

- *su-BIR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *b* between vowels is soft, made with the lips barely touching. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

subir — "to go up."
Look at the front of it. **Sub-** is the Latin for *under*, and English uses it that way constantly: a **submarine** goes under the sea, a **subway** runs under the street, and something **subterranean** is under the ground.
So why does a verb beginning with *under* mean to go **up**?
Because Latin **subire** meant to go up *from underneath*. The picture is of approaching something from below and rising into it — coming up at it. The *sub-* is not describing where you end up. It is describing where you started.
Once that clicks, some odd English words settle down. To **submit** is to send yourself under somebody. To **suffer** is to bear up under a weight — *sub-* plus *ferre*, to carry, with the *b* assimilated. And **sudden** is the surprise: it comes from *subitus*, which is the participle of this very verb. A sudden thing is a thing that has come up on you from below, unnoticed until it arrived.
Spanish also has **subito** as a formal word for the same idea, sitting beside the everyday *subir* — the noun-shaped relative and the verb you actually use.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *subir*. And you know why it starts with *under*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *subir*
- *subir arriba*
- *enviar y subir*

Before you move on

What did *sub-* mean? (Under.) So how can *subir* mean to go up? (Latin *subire* was to come up from underneath.)

384.3 morir — a pledge that dies

Say *to send*, then *to go up*. (*Enviar*; *subir*.)

What to know first

- la noche — a word for endings.
- subir — the last verb you met.

Sounds you'll need

- *mo-RIR*, two beats with the weight on the second. Both *r* sounds are single taps here. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

morir — "to die."
Latin **mori**, to die, with **mors** the noun. English took the family whole: **mortal**, **mortality**, **mortuary**, **immortal**.
The one worth stopping on is **mortgage**, because almost nobody reads it. It is two French words: *mort* + *gage*, a **dead pledge**. The medieval lawyers meant something precise by it. The pledge is alive while the debt runs; when the debt is paid the pledge dies, and the property comes free. So a mortgage is named for its own ending.
Now a careful point, because there is a tempting shortcut here that is wrong. **Murder** does belong to the same family — but not through

Latin. It is a native English word, Old English *morthor* — written with a letter English has since lost — arriving through Germanic. What it shares with *mori* is the far older Indo-European root behind both. Calling *murder* a Latin word would be false; calling it a cousin that travelled a different road is right, and the distinction is the kind that separates a real etymology from a plausible one.
One more to refuse: **morgue** is not in this family. It came into French with a different meaning entirely and was only later attached to a place for the dead.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *morir*. And you can read *mortgage* as two words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *morir*
- *subir y morir*
- *enviar*

Before you move on

What are the two halves of *mortgage*? (*Mort* — dead; *gage* — pledge.) Did *murder* come through Latin? (No — through Germanic, from the same older root.)

384.4 olvidar — where to stop

Say *to go up*, then *to die*. (*Subir*; *morir*.)

What to know first

- buscar — what you do after forgetting.
- la llave — a thing worth not forgetting.

Sounds you'll need

- *ol-vi-DAR*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *v* is the same sound as *b*, and the *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* of *this*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

olvidar — "to forget."
Latin **oblivisci** meant to forget. Spoken Latin rebuilt it as *oblitare*, a tidier verb with regular endings, and that is what came down into Spanish as *olvidar*.
English has the noun: **oblivion**, the state of being forgotten, and **oblivious**, unaware. Same word, different shape.
And here the lesson does something the others have not, which is stop. There is a further step everybody wants to take. *Oblivisci* looks like it comes apart into *ob-* and a root meaning smooth — as though forgetting were smoothing something away, wiping a wax tablet flat. It is a lovely picture. It is also one that specialists in Latin's own history have examined and rejected, on the evidence of how the word behaves rather than on how good the story sounds.
So the trail runs: *oblivisci*, *oblitare*, *olvidar*, and beside it English *oblivion*. Past that point, nobody can take you.
That is worth practising as much as any of the roads that go all the way through. A word's history is a piece of evidence, and evidence runs out. Knowing where it runs out is part of knowing the word.

What you've built

You can now name four more everyday actions: *enviar*, *subir*, *morir*, *olvidar*. Say one thing about each.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *olvidar*
- *olvidar la llave*
- *enviar, subir, morir, olvidar*

Before you move on

Which English noun is the same word? (*Oblivion.*) And why does the lesson stop there? (The next step is rejected by specialists.)

Chapter 385

Four Things the Hands Do

Modes: **voice** (4) **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say usar, tocar, mezclar and colgar, and name four everyday actions.
>
> *Complete ES-C385-colgar: name four everyday actions your hands do, and say which one you did today.*

385.1 usar — a word English has, without knowing it

Say *to die*, then *to forget*. (*Morir*; *olvidar*.)

What to know first

- la llave — something you use.
- la mano — what you use it with.

Sounds you'll need

- *u-SAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *s* sits between two vowels and stays a clean hiss — never a buzz. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

usar — "to use."
English has this verb already. Not a relative of it: the same verb. Spoken Latin made **usare** out of *uti*, to use, and *usare* went two ways at once — south into Spanish as *usar*, north through French into English as **use**.
One thing to notice about that *usare*, because it is a habit worth building. It is printed with a **star** in front of it, and the star means *reconstructed*: no Roman text from the period that matters here uses the word. Scholars worked backwards from the words that survive. (It does turn up in much later legal Latin, in charters of the eight-hundreds — but by then Romance was already forming, so those are not evidence for the earlier stage.) The Academy's dictionary prints no origin for *usar* at all; a starred ancestor is not the kind of thing it lists. Corominas supplies it, star and all.
So the interesting part is not the meaning. It is the three English words built on the same Latin that no longer look like using anything.
Usury is the plainest of them. It meant payment for the *use* of money, and that is all it meant — a use, a usage. There was no accusation in the word. The disapproval arrived later and stuck so hard that the neutral sense is gone.
A **utensil** is, word for word, *something that is to be used*. Any tool at all, in Latin. English shrank it down to a kitchen drawer.
And **abuse** is *ab-* on the front of *uti*: to use *away*, to use something up. The Latin describes a direction, not a crime. English supplied the judgement.
Three words, one verb, and none of them wearing it on the outside. One to refuse. An **usher** looks like a member of this family and is not: the word is built on Latin *ostium*, a **door**. An usher is a door-keeper.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *usar*. And you can hear the same verb inside three English words that hide it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *usar*

- *usar la llave*
- *la mano*

Before you move on

What did *usury* mean before it meant anything harsh? (Payment for the use of money — a use.) What is a *utensil*, taken word for word? (Something that is to be used.)

385.2 tocar — a word that began as a knock

Say *to forget*, then *to use*. (*Olvidar*; *usar*.)

What to know first

- la puerta — something you knock on.
- la mesa — something you touch.

Sounds you'll need

- *to-CAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tocar — "to touch."
Behind it is a Romance verb **toccare**, and its first meaning was harder than the one it ended with: to **knock**, to **strike** — the word you would use for a bell being struck.
Watch the softening. A strike, made lighter and lighter, becomes a tap; a tap, made lighter still, becomes a touch. English **touch** came out of the same verb through Old French, carrying the same slide with it.
That is also why *tocar* is the Spanish word for making a piano or a guitar sound. Striking a bell and touching a key are the one idea, seen at two pressures.
The Italians kept the older feel in a word English borrowed whole: a **toccata** is a piece written to show what a player's *touch* can do.
Two cautions, because the shelf around this word is full of look-alikes. Where *toccare* itself came from is a question the two dictionaries

answer at different volumes. The Academy's entry says flatly: *from the sound* **toc** — the word is an imitation of a knock, full stop. Corominas agrees and adds the reason it convinces him, which is that every Romance language has its own version, as you would expect of a noise rather than an inheritance. The English dictionaries are more cautious and write *perhaps*. Worth noticing that the more confident answer here is the Spanish one; that is not always the way round.
And English **took** is not a relative. It came from Old Norse, through the Germanic side of English, with no Latin anywhere in it. Nor is a **toque**, the tall hat. Nor, for that matter, are **tact** and **contact**, which are about touching but come from an entirely different Latin verb.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *tocar*. And you can hear a bell inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tocar*
- *tocar la puerta*
- *usar y tocar*

Before you move on

What did *toccare* mean before it meant touching? (Knocking or striking, as on a bell.) Is English *took* a relative? (No — it came through Germanic, with no Latin in it.)

385.3 mezclar — the word that was once a brawl

Say *to use*, then *to touch*. (*Usar*; *tocar*.)

What to know first

- la sal — something you mix in.
- el azúcar — something else you mix in.

Sounds you'll need

- *mez-CLAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *z* is a soft *s* across the Americas and a *th* across much of Spain. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mezclar — "to mix."
Latin had **miscere**, to mix. Everyday spoken Latin roughened it into **misculare** — a form that carries a star, meaning nobody found it written down and it was worked out backwards from the words that came after. It is that spoken form, not the written one, that became *mezclar*, by way of an older Spanish **mesclar** that the Academy still routes the entry through.
That matters, because the family split there and the two halves came out of it looking nothing alike.
The spoken branch gave English two words, and they are the true siblings of *mezclar*.
Meddle is one. It arrived through French, and its meaning shifted a step at a time: to mix, then to mix oneself in, then to interfere. Somebody who meddles is doing exactly what the word says.
Medley is the better one. Today it means a mixture — a medley of songs. But around the year 1300 a medley was a **hand-to-hand fight**, a scrum, bodies mixed together. That is the picture the word started from: not a pleasant blend, a pile-up.
The written branch went to the learned words. **Mixture** comes straight off Latin *mixtus* rather than through the spoken verb.
Promiscuous is *pro-* plus *miscere*, mingled without sorting; its narrow modern sense is only about a hundred and fifty years old.
Miscellaneous is there too.
Same family, two roads, and the road decides how the word looks.
Spanish keeps a quieter relative of its own. **Mecer** is the same Latin root, and it now means to rock a cradle — mixing, slowed down to a single gentle motion.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *mezclar*. And you know which English words came by the spoken road.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mezclar*
- *mezclar la sal*
- *el azúcar*

Before you move on

What was a *medley* around 1300? (A hand-to-hand fight.) What is somebody doing, word for word, when they meddle? (Mixing themselves in.)

385.4 colgar — a couch is a placing

Say *to touch*, then *to mix*. (*Tocar*; *mezclar*.)

What to know first

- la ropa — something you hang.
- el armario — where you hang it.

Sounds you'll need

- *col-GAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *g* before *a* is hard, as in *gato*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

colgar — "to hang."
Latin **collocare** meant to place, to lay, to set something in position. It is *com-* plus *locare*, and *locare* is about a *place*.
English got it as a piece of furniture. Old French turned *collocare* into *couchier*, to lay down, to go to bed — and English borrowed that as **couch**. A couch is, word for word, a *placing*: the thing you lay yourself down on.
Now the honest part, because this is where a tidy story would lie to you.

English kept the old meaning. *Couch* is about laying something down. Spanish did not: *colgar* means to **hang**, which is placing something so that it does *not* come to rest.
Nothing on the English side explains that. The shift from placing to hanging happened inside Spanish and only inside Spanish, and the English cousin cannot be used as evidence for it. What English gives you is the *root*, not the meaning — and knowing which of the two a cognate is offering you is most of the skill.
Spanish also kept the plain descendant beside the shifted one: *colocar* still means to place. Two verbs, one Latin ancestor, and centuries of drift between them.
English did the same trick. Beside the worn-down *couch* it also has the tidy Latin **collocate**, borrowed straight off the page much later. One verb, entering the same language twice, once through a mouth and once through a book.
One to refuse: **cough** is not in this family. It is Germanic, and made out of the noise.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *colgar*. And you know when a cognate is evidence and when it is only a root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *colgar*
- *colgar la ropa*
- *el armario*

Before you move on

What is a couch, taken back to Latin? (A placing — the thing you lay yourself down on.) Which side of the family moved to "hang"? (The Spanish side; English kept "place".)

Chapter 386

Selling, Serving, Spending, Growing

Modes: **voice** (4) **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say vender, servir, gastar and crecer, and name four everyday actions.

Complete ES-C386-crecer: name four everyday actions, and say one thing that grows.

386.1 vender — two words squeezed into one

Say *to mix*, then *to hang*. (*Mezclar*; *colgar*.)

What to know first

- la tienda — where selling happens.
- el precio — what it happens at.

Sounds you'll need

- *ven-DER*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *v* is the same sound as *b*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vender — "to sell."
Latin **vendere** looks like one word. It is two, worn down until the

seam stopped showing.

The first half is **venum**, which meant *for sale*. The second half is **dare**, to give. *Venum dare* — to give something for sale. Say it quickly enough, for long enough, and it collapses into *vendere*.

That is not a guess, and the proof is sitting in the verb's own other forms. Latin's past of *dare* was **dedi**, and the past of *vendere* is **vendidi** — with *dedi* still visible inside it, unabsorbed. The same happens in **venditum**, which carries *datum*. The compound wore down at the seam but the old forms did not.

There is a second clue, in the sound. The *e* in *vendere* is long, which is not what Latin normally does before *-nd-*. Two words pressed together explain the oddity; nothing else does.

So the Latin for selling has a **giving** inside it. Spanish still keeps that second half on its own: *dar*, to give, is the same verb, standing separately in the language beside the compound it was folded into.

English took the family from the outside. A **vendor** vends; a **vending** machine sells without a person. And the first half surfaces in **venal** — said of an official, a vote, a witness who can be *bought*. That is *venum* almost untouched: for sale.

One to refuse: a **vendetta** is not in this family. It comes from Latin *vindicta*, revenge, and only looks the part.

It is a good habit to build. A Latin word that seems oddly short for its meaning is often two words that stopped being two — and the old past tenses are where you go looking for the seam.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *vender*. And you can take a Latin verb apart at a seam.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vender*
- *vender la casa*
- *el precio*

Before you move on

What two words are inside *vendere*? (*Venum*, for sale; *dare*, to give.) What does calling someone *venal* say about them? (That they can be bought.)

386.2 servir — dessert is named for the clearing

Say *to hang*, then *to sell*. (*Colgar*; *vender*.)

What to know first

- la sopa — something you serve.
- el plato — what you serve it on.

Sounds you'll need

- *ser-VIR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *v* is the same sound as *b*, and both *r* sounds are single taps. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

servir — "to serve."
Latin **servire** was built on **servus**, a slave. To serve, at the bottom of the word, was to *be* one. Everything polite about the modern verb is a coat of paint over that.
Where *servus* itself came from is not agreed. One reading takes it back to an older word for a *guardian*, soured into "slave" somewhere in early Italy; another suspects Rome borrowed it from the Etruscans. The dictionaries that report both end by saying the matter is uncertain, so the trail stops at the slave.
The word to chase is **dessert**, because almost nobody reads it.
French **desservir** means to *un*-serve: to clear the table, to take away what was served. The noun made from it, *dessert*, named the part of the meal that came after the clearing. So the sweet course is not named for being sweet. It is named for the moment the plates went out.
Next, a pair. **Servant** and **sergeant** are the same Latin word, arriving in English twice by two roads — Medieval Latin *servientem*, one who is serving. In the sixteenth century English writers still used the two

more or less interchangeably. One of them then walked into the army and the other stayed in the house.
And **deserve** is *de-* plus *servire*: to serve thoroughly, to serve well. To deserve something was to have earned it by service. The word remembers a transaction that English speakers no longer hear. When somebody gets their **deserts**, that word is *deserve* wearing a noun's coat — nothing to do with the sandy kind.
One thing not to over-read. Spanish does not call the sweet course a *dessert*. It says **postre**, from a Latin word meaning *what comes after*. The clearing of the table is the French picture, not the Spanish one.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *servir*. And you can say what *dessert* is really named after.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *servir*
- *servir la sopa*
- *el plato*

Before you move on

What does *dessert* name — the food or the clearing? (The clearing: to un-serve the table.) Which English word is *servant* arriving a second time? (*Sergeant*.)

386.3 gastar — spending, and laying waste

Say *to sell*, then *to serve*. (*Vender*; *servir*.)

What to know first

- el dinero — what you spend.
- la cuenta — what tells you how much.

Sounds you'll need

- *gas-TAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *g* before *a* is hard, as in *gato*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gastar — "to spend."
Latin **vastare** meant to lay waste, to ruin, to empty a country out. Spanish took that verb and pointed it at a purse. Spending money is laying it waste.
The clean English relative is **devastate** — *de-* plus *vastare*, to lay waste completely. Nothing has been bent on the way; it is the Latin verb with a prefix.
English **waste** is the interesting one, because it did not arrive clean. Old North French had *waster*, and *waster* is Latin *vastare* after a West Germanic word of similar sound and meaning had leaned on it. That leaning left a mark you can still hear: English opens the word with **w**, while the Romance side opens it with **g** — *gastar*. The *w* is the Germanic fingerprint on a Latin word, and Spanish sits on the other side of the same split.
The Academy's dictionary gives *gastar* one line and mentions none of this. It is not wrong; it is short. An entry can be right about the ancestor and silent about what happened on the road.
One thing to leave alone. It is tempting to add **vast** to the pile. Latin *vastus* meant both *huge* and *empty, desolate* — and those two senses probably belonged to two different words that fell together early in Latin. So *vast* may not be the same word as *vastare* at all, and the honest move is not to claim it.
And a trap worth naming: **gastric**, **gastronomy** and the rest are Greek *gaster*, a belly. They have nothing to do with *gastar*.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *gastar*. And you can read a *w* as a fingerprint.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *gastar*

- *gastar el dinero*
- *la cuenta*

Before you move on

Where does the *w* in *waste* come from, when the Romance side has a *g*? (A West Germanic word that leaned on the Latin one.) Is *gastronomy* a relative? (No — Greek for belly.)

386.4 crecer — the moon caught in the act

Say *to serve*, then *to spend*. (*Servir*; *gastar*.)

What to know first

- el árbol — something that grows.
- el niño — something else that grows.

Sounds you'll need

- *cre-CER*, two beats with the weight on the second. The first *c* is a hard *k*; the second, before *e*, is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

crecer — "to grow."
Latin **crescere**, to grow. Said like that it is a circle, so here are the two places the verb went and stopped looking like itself.
The first is over your head. Latin called the waxing moon **luna crescens** — the *growing* moon. English kept the second half and dropped the moon: **crescent**. The shape is not named for being a curve. It is named for a *direction* — a moon on its way up. A moon on its way down is the same curve and is not a crescent.
Musicians borrowed the Italian form of the same word for the same idea: **crescendo**, growing, and what grows is the sound.
The second is stranger. A **recruit** is a soldier newly joined. The word came through French *recrue*, from a verb meaning *to grow again* — *re-* on the front of the same *crescere*. An army that has lost people and taken on new ones has, in the picture the word paints, **grown back**. A

recruit is a fresh growth. A ship's **crew** started in the same place: an increase in hands.
And one that sits closer to home. Spanish *crear*, to create, is the older partner of this verb: Latin *creare* is the *causing* form, to **make** grow, while *crescere* is the plain one, to grow. Creating and growing were one idea with two settings.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *crecer*. And you know why only one of the two curved moons is a crescent.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *crecer*
- *el árbol*
- *gastar y crecer*

Before you move on

What is a crescent moon, in Latin? (*Luna crescens* — the growing moon.) What is a recruit, taken word for word? (A fresh growth.)

Chapter 387

Fire, Crossings, and Things That Turn

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say quemar, cruzar, volar and girar, and name four everyday actions.
>
> *Complete ES-C387-girar: name four everyday actions, and say which one you can watch happening.*

387.1 quemar — two dictionaries, one word, no agreement

Say *to spend*, then *to grow*. (*Gastar*; *crecer*.)

What to know first

- el fuego — what does the burning.
- el humo — what it leaves behind.

Sounds you'll need

- *que-MAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. *Qu* before *e* is a hard *k*, and the *u* is silent. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

quemar — "to burn."
The Academy's dictionary gives this one line: from Latin **cremare**, to burn. No hedge, no *quizá*. It looks closed.
Corominas opens his entry by saying it cannot be so, and his objection is entirely about sounds.
The first half of it comes from Portuguese, which has **queimar** for the same verb. That *-ei-* can only have grown out of an older **ai**. *Cremare* offers an **e** instead, and a short Latin *e* there does something else in Spanish — it breaks into *ie*. Spanish should have ended up with a *quiemar*. It never has.
The second half is a missing letter. *Cremare* has an **r** sitting right after the *c*. *Quemar* has no *r* at all. Dropping one from that position is, he says, a very grave obstacle.
So he proposes that the Latin verb was reshaped along the way, under the pull of a Greek word for a burn — *kaima* — carried west, he suggests, in the working vocabulary of Greek physicians, who burned wounds shut. And he says plainly that he cannot fully explain why Spanish speakers would have taken it up.
Nobody has closed this. Two dictionaries, one word, and the honest position is to hold both and pick neither.
Here is one thing about the Latin verb that is not in doubt, on the English side. English borrowed **cremation** in the sixteen-hundreds, and for two hundred years had the noun with no verb beside it. In 1851 somebody wanted the verb and, instead of borrowing one, cut the ending off the noun to make **cremate** — backwards from the usual direction of traffic.
And one to refuse. **Quench** sounds near enough to fool anybody, and means very nearly the opposite. It is Old English *acwencan*, from the Germanic side, with no confident relatives outside Germanic and no Latin in it whatsoever.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *quemar*. And you can say why a phonetic objection outranks a resemblance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *quemar*
- *quemar el papel*
- *el fuego*

Before you move on

What letter does *cremare* have that *quemar* does not? (An *r*, right after the *c*.) Is *quench* a relative? (No — Old English, with no Latin in it.)

387.2 cruzar — the long way round to England

Say *to grow*, then *to burn*. (*Crecer*; *quemar*.)

What to know first

- la calle — something you cross.
- el puente — something you cross on.

Sounds you'll need

- *cru-ZAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *z* is a soft *s* across the Americas and a *th* across much of Spain. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cruzar — "to cross."
It is built straight on **cruz**, and *cruz* is Latin **crux**. Not on a Latin verb — Latin had one, *cruciare*, and it even came to mean crossing, but the sounds do not work out, so *cruzar* is a verb Spanish made for itself out of the noun it already had.
And *cruz* is a slightly odd noun. Latin *crux* has a short *u*, and a short *u* in that spot regularly comes out of Spanish as an *o*. Spanish should be saying **croz**. It says *cruz*, and that surviving *u* is the mark of a word that stayed close to its written form because the church kept saying it — the same mark *Dios* carries. A word handled by clerks and priests wears down less than one handled by everybody.
English took a very long road indeed, and the road is the story. Latin

crux went first to Ireland, where Old Irish made **cros** of it. Scandinavians picked it up from the Irish; Old English took it from them. Latin, Irish, Norse, English — three borrowings to travel a distance a Roman road already covered. The older English word for the shape was **rood**, and that is no relation.

Crucial is sharper than it looks. In 1620 Francis Bacon wrote of an *instantia crucis*, an instance of the crossroads — the fingerpost standing where two roads fork, forcing a traveller to choose. A crucial question is a fork in a road.

Crusade is medieval Latin *cruciata*, a thing marked with a cross; the Spanish form of that same word is **cruzada**. And **cruise** belongs here too, arriving through Dutch *kruisen*, to cross, to sail to and fro. A cruise is a crossing.

One to refuse. **Cruel** is not in this family. It is Latin *crudelis*, from *crudus*, *raw* — cruelty is rawness, not crucifixion.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *cruzar*. And you can trace one Latin word through four languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cruzar*
- *cruzar la calle*
- *el puente*

Before you move on

By what road did *cross* reach English? (Latin, then Old Irish, then Old Norse, then Old English.) What is a *crucial* question, in Bacon's picture? (A fingerpost where two roads fork, and you have to choose.)

387.3 volar — a volley is a flight

Say *to burn*, then *to cross*. (*Quemar*; *cruzar*.)

What to know first

- el avión — something that flies.
- el cielo — where it flies.

Sounds you'll need

- *vo-LAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *v* is the same sound as *b*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

volar — "to fly."
Latin **volare**, to fly, and nothing has been bent on the way. So the payoff is in two English words that stopped sounding like flight.
A **volley** is the better one. It came through a French word meaning *a flight* — and the first volleys were arrows. A volley of arrows is not a metaphor and never was: it is a *flight* of them, released together. Centuries later a tennis player borrowed the word for a ball struck while still in the air, which is the same picture with one object instead of a hundred.
Volatile is the other. Latin *volatilis* meant *flying, winged.* English now uses it for a liquid that disappears into the air and for a person whose temper does the same. Both are the Latin word doing its ordinary job: something that gets away from you.
One caution, and it is a Spanish one rather than an English one. *Volar* and *volver* look like each other and are not related. They descend from two different Latin verbs that happen to have arrived at three shared letters. The resemblance is an accident, and treating it as a family tie is the exact mistake this strand exists to stop.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *volar*. And you know what the first volleys were.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *volar*

- *el avión*
- *cruzar el cielo*

Before you move on

What were the first volleys? (Arrows — a flight of them.) What did Latin *volatilis* mean? (Flying, winged.)

387.4 girar — a word that came in through a book

Say *to cross*, then *to fly*. (*Cruzar*; *volar*.)

What to know first

- la llave — something you turn.
- la derecha — a direction you turn in.

Sounds you'll need

- *gi-RAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. *G* before *i* is the harsh throat sound, the same one *j* makes. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

girar — "to turn."
The trail runs Latin **gyrare**, from **gyrus**, a ring or a circle — and Latin had that from Greek **gyros**, the same thing.
But *girar* is unusual company for the other verbs around it, and the reason is worth knowing. Every one of them came down through ordinary speech, mouth to mouth, wearing away as it went. *Girar* did not. Corominas calls it frankly bookish: scholars lifted it out of written Latin and put it into Spanish. It turns up in the middle of the fourteen-hundreds among writers straining to sound Latin, and then almost vanishes for a century and a half. As late as 1611 Covarrubias was still telling readers it was **not a word used in Castile**.
An inherited word arrives worn. A borrowed one arrives clean. *Girar* looks almost exactly like *gyrare* because it never had the centuries of

use that would have rubbed it down.
The Greek circle is still busy in English. A **gyroscope** is a circle-watcher — *gyros* plus *skopos*, a watcher — named in French in 1852 for a device whose whole point is watching a spin.
And the **gyros** you can buy for lunch is the same Greek word, meaning *turn* — named for meat turning on an upright spit. It is a genuine relative, but not by this road: it walked into English straight from modern Greek in 1971 and never went through Latin at all. The Greek name is itself a translation of the Turkish name for the same food, which also means *turning*. Three languages, one idea, and none of them borrowed the meat without borrowing the spin.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *girar*. And you can tell an inherited word from a borrowed one by how worn it looks.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *girar*
- *girar la llave*
- *la derecha*

Before you move on

Did *girar* come down through speech or out of a book? (Out of a book — it was still being called unusual in 1611.) Did the sandwich come through Latin? (No — straight from modern Greek, and only in 1971.)

Chapter 388

Push, Throw, Rub Out, Shout

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say empujar, lanzar, borrar and gritar, and name four everyday actions.
>
> *Complete ES-C388-gritar: name four everyday actions, and say one thing you would do with each.*

388.1 empujar — cousins, not the same word

Say *to fly*, then *to turn*. (*Volar*; *girar*.)

What to know first

- la puerta — something you push.
- la silla — something else you push.

Sounds you'll need

- *em-pu-JAR*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *j* is the harsh throat sound. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

empujar — "to push."
Both dictionaries hedge here, and they hedge in the same direction. The Academy writes *quizá* — perhaps — in front of late Latin **impulsare**. Corominas writes *probablemente*. Neither will say it

outright, and neither has anything better to offer.
They hedge, and there is still hard evidence in the word. Old Spanish spelled it **empuxar**, with an *x*. That letter is not decoration: an *x* in that spot is what Spanish does to a Latin **-ls-**. The same change turned Latin *multum* into *mucho*. So whatever the exact Latin verb was, it had an *l* pressed against an *s* inside it — and *impulsare* does.
Behind *impulsare* is **pellere**, to drive or strike, whose repeating form is **pulsare**. That is a large family, and English has a great deal of it: **impulse**, **impel**, **propel**, and the **pulse** in your wrist.
Now the careful part. English **push** is in that family — but it is *not* the same word as *empujar*. *Push* came through French from the plain **pulsare**, with nothing on the front. *Empujar* carries an **in-** that *push* never had. They are cousins who look alike, and calling them one word would be wrong in a way that is easy to check and easy to miss.
Two more traps. The **pulse** you cook — lentils, chickpeas — is a different word altogether, from Latin *puls*, a thick porridge. And Spanish itself has a *pujar* meaning to bid at an auction, which comes from somewhere else entirely and is no relation to this one.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *empujar*. And you can read an old spelling as evidence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *empujar*
- *empujar la puerta*
- *la silla*

Before you move on

What does the *x* in old *empuxar* prove was inside the Latin word? (An *l* pressed against an *s*.) Are *push* and *empujar* the same word? (No — cousins; *empujar* carries an *in-* that *push* never had.)

388.2 lanzar — a rocket is thrown like a spear

Say *to turn*, then *to push*. (*Girar*; *empujar*.)

What to know first

- la mano — what you throw with.
- empujar — the gentler neighbour.

Sounds you'll need

- *lan-ZAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *z* is a soft *s* across the Americas and a *th* across much of Spain. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lanzar — "to throw."
Underneath it is a **lanza**, a lance. Late Latin made the verb **lanceare**, to handle a lance, and Spanish kept it.
English kept it too, and the English form is the surprise. Around the year 1300 *launchen* meant **to hurl** — specifically, to hurl the way a spear is hurled. A century later sailors took it for pushing a boat off the beach, and from there it went to rockets, to products, to careers. Every launch in English is still, underneath, a spear leaving a hand.
The plainer relatives are easy: a **lance**, and a **lancet**, which is a little lance in a doctor's fingers.
Now where the dictionaries part company, and it is a pattern worth recognising.
Where did Latin get *lancea*? The Academy answers flatly: a word of Celtiberian origin, from the peninsula Spanish is now spoken on. Corominas is far more careful — the Roman writer Varro said it came from Spain, and *quizá*, perhaps, it was Celtiberian. More recent specialists argue for a different ancient Iberian language altogether. One dictionary printed a possibility as a fact. When a source states plainly what its own sources hedge on, the hedge is the thing to keep.
And one to refuse: the small motor boat called a **launch** is a different word. It came from Portuguese *lancha*, which the Portuguese took from Malay. It only came to look like the verb afterwards.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *lanzar*. And you can spot a dictionary sounding surer than its own evidence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lanzar*
- *empujar y lanzar*
- *la mano*

Before you move on

What did *launch* mean around 1300? (To hurl, the way a spear is hurled.) Is the boat called a launch the same word? (No — it came from Malay by way of Portuguese.)

388.3 borrar — a verb made out of wool

Say *to push*, then *to throw*. (*Empujar*; *lanzar*.)

What to know first

- el papel — what you write on.
- la clase — where the rubbing out happens.

Sounds you'll need

- *bo-RRAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *rr* is a full roll; the final *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

borrar — "to erase."
This one is a verb made out of a material. **Borra** is coarse wool — the rough leftover kind, not the sort you would wear. Late Latin called it *burra*. And a wad of coarse wool was what you rubbed writing off

with, back when writing sat on a surface that could be wiped.
So *borrar* does not mean "to erase" by any abstract route. It means *to wool-it-off*.
Spanish still keeps the receipt. A rough draft is a **borrador** — a thing that is *going to be rubbed out*. The same word names the eraser and the board rubber. A first attempt is named for its own impermanence.
English may have a piece of this cloth too, though this is the point at which to slow down.
French had **bure**, a dark coarse cloth, and its small form *burel* named the cloth spread over a writing table. The cloth gave its name to the table; the table gave its name to the room; the room gave its name to the government department; and the department gave us **bureaucracy**. That chain is solid all the way along.
The weak joint is at the very start. Dictionaries will not choose between two candidates for where French got *bure* — a Latin word for *red*, or the *burra* above. So the desk really is named after its tablecloth, and whether that tablecloth is *borra*'s relative is not settled.
Say the part that holds; leave the part that does not.
One flat refusal: **borrow** is Old English *borgian*, from the Germanic side of English, and originally meant to stand surety for something. A pure look-alike.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *borrar*. And you know why a rough draft is called a *borrador*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *borrar*
- *borrar el papel*
- *la clase*

Before you move on

What was a *borra*? (Coarse wool — what you rubbed writing out with.) Is *borrow* a relative? (No — Old English, with no Latin in it.)

388.4 gritar — a story the Romans told about themselves

Say *to throw*, then *to erase*. (*Lanzar*; *borrar*.)

What to know first

- la voz — what you shout with.
- el llanto — what shouting is not.

Sounds you'll need

- *gri-TAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *g* before *r* is hard, and both *r* sounds are single taps. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gritar — "to shout."
The Academy takes it back to Latin **quiritare**, to cry out loudly. Corominas agrees that this is probable and calls the origin uncertain even so — which is the more careful of the two positions.
There is a famous story attached, and it is worth telling for the right reason.
Roman writers explained *quiritare* as *calling on the Quirites* — the citizens of Rome — for help. A person in trouble shouts for the townspeople; the verb is named after who you shout at. It is a lovely picture.
It is also almost certainly backwards. Corominas suspects that the ancient dictionary-makers built that gloss out of the resemblance between the two words and then wrote it down as the meaning, which later readers took as evidence. Modern dictionaries set it aside and look elsewhere.
Keep the story, then, but keep it labelled. It is what the Romans believed about their own word, and what a language believes about itself is a real thing to know — as long as you do not file it under fact.
Now the part that is solid. English **cry** is this same word: Old French *crier*, from the same Latin. And then English did something Spanish did not. *Cry* meant to shout out; over the fifteen-hundreds it drifted across and took over the job of *weep*, until today the shouting sense

survives only in phrases like *a far cry* and *hue and cry*.
Gritar never made that move. It still means shouting and only shouting — which is why translating English *cry* with it goes wrong so often.
One more to refuse: **grit** and **gritty** are Old English *greot*, gravel. Germanic, and no relation.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *gritar*. And you can hold a story without believing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *gritar*
- *la voz*
- *borrar y gritar*

Before you move on

Is the story about calling on the citizens of Rome the real explanation? (No — it looks like a guess the Romans made from the resemblance.) Does *gritar* mean weeping? (No — only shouting; English *cry* moved and Spanish did not.)

388.5 Review — four verbs, four kinds of "related"

"I shout." (*Grito.*) "I throw." (*Lanzo.*)

What you've built

Four ordinary *-ar* verbs. Each one sits next to an English word that looks like it — and each one is related to that English word in a **different** way.

Spanish	English lookalike	the truth
lanzar	launch	**the same word**
gritar	cry	**the same word**, meaning moved
empujar	push	**a cousin**, not the same word
borrar	borrow	**no relation at all**

Four verbs is a small chapter. Four different answers is a whole method.

Why it's said this way

Push misses being the same word as *empujar* by one piece. Both go back to Latin *pulsare*, but Spanish took the form with *in-* stuck on the front and English took the plain one. Same root, different word.

Cry really is *gritar*. Latin *quiritare* went into French and on into English, and then **English alone** slid the meaning from shouting to weeping. Spanish never did — which is why *gritar* is not the word for tears.

And *borrar* has nothing to do with *borrow*, which is Germanic. *Borrar* comes from *borra*, coarse wool: the pad you rubbed writing out with. A rough draft is still *un borrador* — the thing meant to be rubbed out.

Now the part worth keeping. Look at how the dictionaries actually talk. The Academy writes *quizá* in front of *empujar*; Corominas writes *probablemente*. On *lanzar* they part company outright — the Academy calls its root Celtiberian, Corominas only says *quizá*. On *borrar* neither will choose between two candidates.

A hedge is not a failure. It is a dictionary telling you exactly how much it knows, and a claim with no hedge on it has not been made more certain by leaving the hedge off.

Your turn

- *Say it: empujo · lanzo · borro · grito*

Twice through:

Before you move on

Does *gritar* mean to weep? (**No** — English moved that meaning, not Spanish.) What is *un borrador*? (**A rough draft** — a thing meant to be rubbed out.) When a dictionary writes *quizá*, what is it doing? (**Telling you how much it knows**.)

Chapter 389

Knowing How — the Verb That Once Meant Taste

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what I know how to do with sé plus an infinitive, ask someone else with sabes, and tell that apart from what poder says.
>
> *Complete ES-C389-saber: say one thing you know how to do with sé plus an infinitive, ask a partner the same with sabes, and say one thing you know how to do but cannot do today.*

389.1 saber — the verb that started out meaning "to taste"

Say *I can read.* (*Puedo leer.*) Hold that sentence — it means something narrower than you think.

What to know first

- poder — *puedo, puedes, puede.*
- la sopa and el ajo — how this starts.

Sounds you'll need

- *sa-BER*, weight on the second beat. The *b* is soft — lips close but never quite meet. The final *r* is one tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

saber — "to know." That gloss is the end of the story; the beginning is better.
Latin **sapere** meant *to taste*, and Spanish still uses it that way daily:

> *Esta sopa sabe a ajo.* — This soup **tastes** of garlic.

Not a second verb that looks the same. It is *saber*, doing its original job.
Tasting to knowing is one short step, and English takes it too: whoever can taste the difference can *tell* the difference. Say *he has taste* and you are not talking about his tongue. So the seam still shows — *sabe a ajo*, it tastes of garlic; *sabe leer*, he knows how to read.
English borrowed pieces of the family from Latin. **Savour** is *sapor*, "flavour," *sapere*'s own noun. **Insipid** is *in-* plus *sapidus*, "tasty" — what is insipid has no *sapor*. And *sapiens*, the present participle, gave us ***Homo sapiens***: read strictly, not the *wise* animal but the **tasting** one, the animal that tells things apart.

Grammar lens — saber plus an infinitive

A plain infinitive straight after *saber* means **know how to** — a skill you were taught and still have.

> *Sé leer.* — I know how to read. *¿Sabes escribir?* — Do you know how to write?

Against the verb you already had:

***Sé* leer.**	I know how. I learned it.
***Puedo* leer.**	I am able to right now — there is light.

Both come out as "I can read," and they are not interchangeable. *Sé leer pero hoy no puedo* is ordinary Spanish: the skill is permanent, the opportunity is not.
Two forms to start with. The *yo* form is irregular and very short:

- *sé* — I know how
- *sabes* — you know how

What you've built

You can say what you know how to do, and ask someone else — and you know why the soup and the skill are one verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sé leer*
- *¿sabes escribir?*
- *sé leer pero hoy no puedo*

Before you move on

What did *sapere* mean first? (To taste.) Which is the learned skill, *sé leer* or *puedo leer*? (*Sé leer.*)

389.2 Review — the verbs that will not sit behind *sé*

"I know how to throw." (*Sé lanzar.*)

What you've built

You have *saber* plus a plain verb, and you have the four verbs from the chapter before. Put them together and something useful goes wrong.

	behind *sé*	**behind *puedo***
lanzar	**sé lanzar** — fine	**puedo lanzar** — fine
borrar	**sé borrar** — fine	**puedo borrar** — fine
empujar	*sé empujar* — **odd**	**puedo empujar** — fine
gritar	*sé gritar* — **odd**	**puedo gritar** — fine

All four go behind *puedo* without a blink. Only two go behind *sé*.

Why it's said this way

Saber before a plain verb does not mean "can." It means **know how to** — and knowing how is something you were once taught. Throwing well is learned. Erasing properly is learned. But nobody was ever taught to **shout**, and nobody took lessons in **pushing**. So *sé gritar* lands strangely. It is not ungrammatical; it claims a skill where there is none.

That is the cleanest test there is for the difference you met with *poder*. *Puedo gritar* is ordinary: I am able to, right now, or I am allowed to. Swap in *sé* and the sentence quietly claims you studied it. *Sé nadar pero hoy no puedo.* The skill is permanent; the chance is not.

And the root says the same thing from underneath. *Saber* is Latin *sapere*, "to taste" — and the one who can taste is the one who can **tell things apart**. Discrimination first, knowledge second. It is why the verb for having a flavour and the verb for having a skill are one verb in Spanish.

Your turn

- *Say it: sé lanzar · sé borrar · puedo empujar · puedo gritar*

Twice through:

Before you move on

What does *saber* plus a plain verb claim? (**That you learned it**.) Which of the two is about the chance you happen to have? (***Poder***.) And what did *sapere* mean first? (**To taste**.)

Chapter 390

Five Parts of a Building

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la terraza, la sala, la planta, el ascensor and la piscina, and name five parts of a building.
>
> *Complete ES-C390-piscina: name five parts of a building, and say one thing about each.*

390.1 la terraza — earth, flattened out and stood on

Say *I know how to read.* (*Sé leer.*)

What to know first

- la tierra — the root underneath this one.
- el café — where you will hear the word most often.

Sounds you'll need

- *te-RRA-za*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *rr* is rolled, held a moment longer than a single tap. The *z* is a soft *s* across the Americas and a *th* across much of Spain. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la terraza — an open flat outdoor level: a roof terrace, a balcony floor, and above all the tables a café sets out on the pavement.
Latin **terra** was earth. From it came a Vulgar Latin **terrācea**, "earthen" — a thing made of packed dirt. That much is certain, and the family is wide: English has **terrain**, **terrestrial**, **terra cotta**.
English **terrace** is not a relative but the same word, arriving through French. The twelfth-century Old French gloss is worth quoting because it is the evidence rather than a guess: *a platform raised on a mound of earth faced with turf*. Not tiles. Not pottery. A flat place you built by heaping up soil and laying grass over the front of it, so you could stand above the ground.
Now the part that has to be said carefully, because the references disagree with each other and none of them is a fool.

- The Academy's dictionary keeps it at home, deriving *terraza* from *terrazo* inside Spanish.
- Wiktionary calls it "more likely borrowed" from French **terrasse**, which took it from Old Occitan **terrassa**.
- And Corominas, going through everything that grew out of *tierra*, does not list *terraza* among them at all.

So: *terra* is certain, and the road from *terra* to *terraza* is not. When three careful sources give three answers, the answer is that nobody knows yet.
One thing to refuse. English calls a row of joined houses a *terrace*, and that sense is English-only, dated to 1769. A Spanish *terraza* is never a house.

un café con terraza — a café with tables outside.

What you've built

You can name the flat open space outside: *la terraza*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la terraza*
- *un café con terraza*
- *estamos en la terraza*

Before you move on

What did *terrācea* mean? (Earthen — made of packed earth.) Does *terraza* name a terraced house? (No. That row-of-houses sense is English only; a *terraza* is an open flat level, usually a café's outdoor tables.)

390.2 la sala — the one Germanic room in a Latin house

Say *the terrace*, then *a café with tables outside*. (*La terraza*; *un café con terraza*.)

What to know first

- la casa — what this is a room of.
- la habitación — the neighbouring word.

Sounds you'll need

- *SA-la*, two beats with the weight on the first. Both *a*s are the same open sound, neither of them swallowed. The *s* stays clear and hissed; the *l* is bright, made with the tongue tip forward. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sala — the main room of a house, the living room; also a large room put to public use.
Nearly everything in a Spanish house came from Latin. This did not. Behind *sala* is Proto-Germanic **salaz**, and what it named was a *one-room building*. The house was the room and the room was the house. Its relatives sit across the old Germanic languages: Old High German **sal**, Old English **sele**, Old Norse **salr**, all on a very old root

meaning a dwelling.
English then borrowed it back out of French, twice over. **Salon** came in during the 1690s; **saloon** followed. English's own inherited form of the word is **sele**, which survives only in old poetry.
One pairing to keep out, because it looks irresistible and is wrong: English **hall** is *not* this word. It comes from a separate Germanic form, *hallō*. Two Germanic words for large rooms, two different ancestries.
Now the honest part. Germanic words reached Spanish by more than one road — Gothic speakers in the peninsula, and Frankish words passing down through Catalan and southern France — and for *sala* Corominas refuses to pick. He calls it **inseguro** whether it arrived through Catalan and Gallo-Romance or straight from Gothic, and settles on there having been **varios focos de difusión**, several separate points from which it spread. The one story he throws out flatly, as **inadmisible**, is that it came from France alone.
One firm date: *sala* is on record as a proper name in a Leonese document of **1102**.
Two lookalikes that are not family: *sal*, salt, is Latin **sāl**; *salir* is Latin **salīre**, to jump. Neither touches a room.

una sala grande — a big living room.

What you've built

You can name the room a house is lived in: *la sala*. And you know one Spanish noun that came in from the north instead of from Rome.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la sala*
- *una sala grande*
- *la sala y la terraza*

Before you move on

Is *sala* a Latin word? (No — Germanic, from *salaz*, a one-room building.) Did it come to Spanish through France? (Corominas says

that story alone is inadmissible; the routes were several, and which one carried it is uncertain.)

390.3 la planta — a book word with a mouth-worn twin

Say *the terrace*, then *the living room*. (*La terraza*; *la sala*.)

What to know first

- el piso — the everyday word alongside this one.
- el pie — where the Latin word starts.

Sounds you'll need

- *PLAN-ta*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *l* is bright, made with the tongue tip forward, and the *pl* stays a crisp pair with nothing slipped between them. The *t* is dental — tongue against the back of the top teeth, not up on the ridge. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la planta — a floor of a building, a storey.
Latin **planta** carried two senses at once: the **sole of the foot**, and a **cutting**, a shoot pressed down into soil. English kept them both and kept them apart. *Plantar*, as in plantar fasciitis, is the sole. *Plant* and *plantation* are the cutting. Whether Latin had one word doing two jobs or two words that fell together, the references disagree — Corominas suspects **dos vocablos distintos**; Wiktionary concludes they are one and the same.
Here is the best thing in the word, and it is visible in the first two letters.
Look at what happened to Latin *pl-* in words Spanish inherited by mouth, worn down by ordinary speakers over centuries:

- *plēnum* → **lleno**
- *plūvia* → **lluvia**

- *plicāre* → **llegar**

Every one of them came out with *ll-*. So *planta*, which still has its *pl-* intact, did not come down that road. Corominas states the inference outright: **el tratamiento de *pl-* indica que ha de ser cultismo** — the treatment of the *pl-* shows it has to be a word taken from writing. The mouth-worn twin is not hypothetical: **llanta**, which in the *Partidas* meant a vegetable. One Latin word, two routes, two shapes — the spoken one bent, the written one preserved.
Careful with that twin: *llanta* is really two words — the cabbage-plant one from *planta*, and a wheel rim from elsewhere. Corominas separates them.
One question stays open, and it is the sense used here. How *planta* came to name a **storey** is not settled: Corominas declines to decide — **no está bastante estudiado el problema** — leaving Italian and a home-grown development both open.

la primera planta — the first floor.

What you've built

You can say which floor of a building you mean: *la planta*. And you can read a surviving *pl-* as a fingerprint of a word that came in through writing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la planta*
- *la primera planta*
- *la sala está en la primera planta*

Before you move on

What shape did *plēnum*, *plūvia* and *plicāre* come out in? (*Lleno*, *lluvia*, *llegar* — the *pl-* arrived as *ll-*.) So what does the surviving *pl-* of *planta* tell you? (That it was not worn down by speech; it was lifted out of written Latin.)

390.4 el ascensor — an old word waiting for its machine

Say *the living room*, then *the first floor*. (*La sala*; *la primera planta*.)

What to know first

- subir — what it does.
- la escalera — what people used before it.

Sounds you'll need

- *as-cen-SOR*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *c* before *e* is soft, so the middle beat begins with an *s* sound and the written *sc* comes out as one clean hiss. The final *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el ascensor — the elevator.
It takes apart cleanly. Latin **ascēnsor** is an agent noun — a *-tor* word, the one who does the thing — built on **ascendere**. And *ascendere* is **ad-**, "to, up to," plus **scandere**, "to climb." So the whole word says: *the one who ascends*. Nothing about cables, cars or shafts is in there.
The Romans had the word for eighteen centuries before anyone had the machine, and it is worth seeing what they used it for. In the Vulgate, at Exodus 15, the **ascensor** is a **horseman** — the rider, the one gone up onto the horse. That is who an ascender was.
So the form and the meaning came by different roads, and the meaning has a date. French **ascenseur** existed in the early sixteenth century and meant a rider too. The sense we want — *an apparatus that serves to go up* — is recorded by the CNRTL for the first time in **1867**.
Spanish *ascensor* is therefore ancient in shape and modern in what it points at: a Latin word handed a nineteenth-century job.
The English family is large and regular. From *ascendere*: **ascend**, **ascent**, **ascension**. From the *scandere* underneath it: **descend**, **transcend**, and **scansion** — climbing along the beats of a line of verse.
One that is not family, however much it looks it: **scandal**. That comes

from Greek *skandalon* and has no share in this.

¿Dónde está el ascensor? — Where is the elevator?

What you've built

You can ask for the elevator: *el ascensor*. And you can tell an old form from a young meaning wearing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el ascensor*
- *¿dónde está el ascensor?*
- *subo a la primera planta en el ascensor*

Before you move on

Who was an *ascēnsor* in the Vulgate? (A horseman — the one gone up onto the horse.) When does the machine sense first appear? (In French, in 1867.)

390.5 la piscina — one Latin fish, two Spanish roads

Say *the first floor*, then *where is the elevator?*. (*La primera planta*; *¿dónde está el ascensor?*)

What to know first

- el agua — what fills it.
- el pescado — the fish you eat, built on the same *piscis*.

Sounds you'll need

- *pis-CI-na*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *c* before *i* is soft, so that beat is *see* across the Americas and *thee*

across much of Spain. Both *i*s are tight and bright, never sliding toward an *uh*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la piscina — a swimming pool.
Latin **piscīna** is **piscis**, a fish, with the ending **-īna** on it.
The cleanest thing here is a pair. That same Latin root reached Spanish twice, by two roads, and the two arrivals look nothing alike:

- **pez** — inherited, carried down by mouth, worn short;
- **piscina** — taken out of writing, its shape kept whole.

One root, two routes. (*Piscīna* has a worn-down double of its own, **pecina**.)
Now a warning about the gloss, because the tempting move is wrong. *Piscina* does not mean "fishpond" in Spanish, and Spanish did not stretch it from fish to swimmers. That stretch had already happened in Rome. Lewis and Short mark the bathing sense as a post-Augustan transfer, and it turns up in Pliny, Seneca and Martial. Spanish borrowed the word with that meaning already attached.
English holds the root twice: **fish** is the inherited cousin of *piscis*, the Latin *p* answering a Germanic *f*. Borrowed straight from Latin: **Pisces**, **piscine**, **piscatorial**.
Before you travel: Mexico often says **alberca**, the Río de la Plata **pileta** — not variants but separate words, *alberca* from Arabic *al-birka*, *pileta* Romance.

What you've built

You can name five parts of a building: *la terraza*, *la sala*, *la planta*, *el ascensor*, *la piscina*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la piscina*
- *la piscina y el ascensor*

Now all five together. Name each part of the building, then say one thing about it.

Say these aloud:

- *la terraza — la terraza es pequeña*
- *la sala — la sala es grande*
- *la planta — vivo en la primera planta*
- *el ascensor — el ascensor sube*
- *la piscina — la piscina está abajo*

Before you move on

Which of *pez* and *piscina* came down by mouth? (*Pez.*) Did Spanish turn a fishpond into a swimming pool? (No — the Romans had already done it; the swimming sense came with the word.)

Chapter 391

Five Words for Eating Out

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el menú, el camarero, el postre, el supermercado and el euro, and name five things I meet when I eat out.
>
> *Complete ES-C391-euro: name five things I meet when I eat out, and say one thing about each.*

391.1 el menú — one Latin word, three Spanish arrivals

Say *the elevator*, then *the swimming pool*. (*El ascensor*; *la piscina*.)

What to know first

- la carta — the other thing a restaurant hands you.
- el restaurante — where both arrive.

Sounds you'll need

- *me-NÚ*, two beats with the weight on the second. The written accent is there to say so; without it the eye would fall on the first beat instead. The *u* is a tight *oo*, held short, and the *n* is a plain *n*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el menú — the meal a kitchen has already decided on, written out. Spanish took the word from French **menu**, and in French it was a describing word before it was anything else: small, detailed, fine-grained. A *menu* list was a list broken down small. Behind the French sits Latin **minūtus**, made small, from **minuere**, to lessen.
The stress is the proof, and it is the kind of proof you can hear. Spanish says *me-NÚ*, weight on the last beat, exactly where French puts it. A word carried down out of Latin by mouth would not have landed there.
That is worth pressing, because *minūtus* reached Spanish twice more, by two other roads:

- **menudo** — carried down by mouth, worn short, everyday;
- **minuto** — lifted out of writing, its Latin shape kept whole;
- **menú** — handed over by French, keeping the French weight on the end.

Three words, three shapes, one Latin word. English holds the same root in **minute**, **diminish**, **minor**, **minus** and **mince**, and borrowed the list itself in 1837 as **menu**.
Now the warning, which will cost you a meal if you skip it. In Spain, *el menú* normally names the fixed set meal — the **menú del día**, one price, the courses chosen by the kitchen. The list you order freely from is **la carta**. Ask for *el menú* expecting the second, and the first is what arrives.

What you've built

You can name what the kitchen has already decided on: *el menú*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el menú*
- *el menú del día*

Now three in a row: *el ascensor*, *la piscina*, *el menú*.

Before you move on

Which of *menudo*, *minuto* and *menú* came in through French? (*Menú* — the final stress is the tell.) In Spain, which one is the fixed meal of the day, *el menú* or *la carta*? (*El menú.*)

391.2 el camarero — the servant of a room, at your table

Say *the swimming pool*, then *the set meal of the day.* (*La piscina*; *el menú del día.*)

What to know first

- el restaurante — where you will say it.
- el cuarto — a room, which is where this word started.

Sounds you'll need

- *ca-ma-RE-ro*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*. Both *r*s are single quick taps of the tongue tip, nothing rolled. Both *a*s are wide open and equal, the unstressed one no fainter than the other. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el camarero — the person who takes your order and brings your food. Underneath it sits **cámara**, a room. That goes back to Greek **kamára**, a vault or vaulted chamber, which Latin took as **camera**. One small thing in the shape is worth catching. Spanish has *cámara*, with an **a** in the middle — matching the everyday Latin **camara**, not the classical **camera** with its **e**. The word came up through speech, not off the page. Corominas finds *cámara* in Spanish already in the *Cid*.

English has that room twice over: **chamber** and **camera** are one Latin word arriving by two routes, and **bicameral**, a state with two chambers, keeps the plain sense.

Now the part where care is owed, because the sources split and neither

is careless:

- Wiktionary derives *camarero* from Medieval Latin **camarārius**;
- Corominas keeps it at home — Spanish *cámara* with the ending **-ero** on it, dated 1206.

Both roads end at exactly the word Spanish has. There is no crack of sound or spelling between them to prise apart, so the honest answer is not one of the two — it is that they cannot be told apart.
Two near-misses to refuse. English **chamberlain** looks like a cousin and is not: it is *camera* with a Germanic ending instead of the Spanish one, built alongside *camarero* rather than before it. And **camarón**, a shrimp, has nothing to do with any of this — different Latin word, *cammarus*.
One more honesty. When and how the servant of a chamber became the person who brings your dinner is not something the sources record. You will see confident centuries quoted for it; none is offered here.

What you've built

You can name the person who serves you: *el camarero*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el camarero*
- *el camarero trae el menú*

Now three in a row: *la piscina*, *el menú*, *el camarero*.

Before you move on

What did *cámara* name before anything else? (A room — and before that, a vault.) Can anyone say whether *camarero* was made inside Spanish or borrowed from Medieval Latin? (No. Both roads arrive at the same word.)

391.3 el postre — a word cut out of the middle of a phrase

Say *the set meal of the day*, then *the waiter*. (*El menú del día*; *el camarero.*)

What to know first

- dulce — what it usually is.
- la fruta — what it often was.

Sounds you'll need

- *POS-tre*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *s* stays a clean hiss and never buzzes into a *z*. The *t* is made with the tongue against the back of the teeth, drier than an English *t*, and the *r* behind it is one quick tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el postre — dessert; the last thing brought to the table.
The family is Latin **post**, after, with **posterus**, following, and **postrēmus**, last, standing behind it. That much is firm. Almost nothing after it is, and this is a word where you should be told so. Corominas, who is the careful one here, does not make *postre* something Spanish inherited. He makes it something Spanish **cut out of a phrase it already had**:

- **a la postre** — in the end, finally;
- then **fruta de postre** — the fruit that comes at the end;
- then *postre* standing alone as the dish itself, documented in 1561.

That is why the word looks like a fragment. It is one. It was carved out of the middle of a fixed expression and left to stand up by itself. And he does not stop hedging there. The *postrero* underneath *a la postre* he calls *más dudosa* — more doubtful — offering only that it **probably** arose from a crossing of *postremo* with the words that meant much the same thing: *cabero*, *trasero*, *derradero*. Probably. He says no more, and neither will this page.

You will meet tidier accounts of *postre* than this, printed with no hedge at all. Refuse them. The neatest of them rests on a Latin expression that no source attests — reverse-engineered so that it produces the dessert, which is the one thing it was built to produce.
The English relatives are **posterior**, **posterity** and plain **post-**. The best of them is **preposterous**: *prae*, before, plus *posterus*, after. It means back-to-front because it says back-to-front. English **poster** is no relation whatever.

What you've built

You can name the last course of the meal: *el postre*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el postre*
- *el postre es dulce*

Now three in a row: *el menú*, *el camarero*, *el postre*.

Before you move on

Which phrase was *postre* cut out of? (*A la postre*, finally — then *fruta de postre*, and then the dish on its own.) Is *postre* any relation to English *poster*? (None at all.)

391.4 el supermercado — an English shop, rebuilt out of Spanish parts

Say *the waiter*, then *the dessert is sweet*. (*El camarero*; *el postre es dulce*.)

What to know first

- el mercado — the half you already have.
- la tienda — the smaller shop beside it.

Sounds you'll need

- *su-per-mer-CA-do*, five beats with the weight on the fourth. The opening *s* is a clean hiss. Both *r*s are quick taps, not rolls. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*, and the *d* of *-ado* is barely closed at all — the tongue brushes the teeth, nearer the *th* of English *this* than a full *d*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el supermercado — a supermarket.

The two halves of this word are separated by roughly two thousand years, and that gap is the whole lesson.

The back half is ancient and came in by mouth. Latin **mercātus** was a trading, from **mercārī**, to trade, from **merx, mercis**, wares. Centuries of speech wore it down into **mercado**, and nobody sat down to make it. English took the same root by other doors: **market**, **merchant**, **mercantile**, **merchandise**, **commerce**, and the name **Mercury**.

The front half is younger than most people's grandparents. American English coined **supermarket** in 1933 — and Spanish did not take the English word. It translated it, piece against piece: *super* onto *super*, *market* onto *mercado*. A word built that way has a name. It is a **calque**: the foreign pattern crosses the border while the foreign sounds stay home.

Set the two ways in beside each other. A borrowed word arrives with its foreignness showing, and you can often hear where it came from. A calque arrives invisible — Spanish material throughout, Spanish stress, nothing to hear — and you would never guess it had been abroad unless someone told you.

One caution, because this move gets over-used. *Supermercado* really is a calque, and a dictionary says so, which is why it can be stated flatly here. The same tidy story gets told about *aeropuerto* — air plus port, copied straight from English — and there the claim is not actually supported by the sources. A word that **looks** assembled has not thereby been shown to be assembled.

What you've built

You can name where the food comes from before it reaches the table: *el supermercado*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el supermercado*
- *el supermercado está cerca*

Now three in a row: *el camarero*, *el postre*, *el supermercado*.

Before you move on

Which half of *supermercado* was carried down by mouth from Latin? (*Mercado*.) What does calling the word a calque claim about it? (Its parts were translated one for one instead of borrowed — an English pattern in Spanish material.)

391.5 el euro — a coin cut out of a longer word

Say *the dessert*, then *the supermarket is nearby*. (*El postre*; *el supermercado está cerca*.)

What to know first

- el dinero — money in general.
- la moneda — the coin in your hand.

Sounds you'll need

- *EU-ro*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *e* and the *u* run together inside that one beat, both still audible, an *eh* sliding into an *oo* in the time of a single vowel. The *r* is one tap; the final *o* stays round and full. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el euro — the currency.
Open the Academy's dictionary at *euro* and find two entries, not one — and not the same word.
The first is Latin **eurus**, from Greek **euros** — a poetic name for one of the cardinal winds. The second is the money. Four shared letters, nothing else.
This matters, because the wind is the tempting answer: old, Greek, the better story, and sitting in the dictionary looking like an ancestor. Any account of the currency that opens "from the Greek" has changed the subject to weather.
The money is plainer than that. It is a longer word cut short — and the Academy cuts it from **europeo**, not from *Europa*. A small divergence from the usual telling, worth keeping: it is what the dictionary prints — the describing word clipped, not the name of the continent.
The name itself was settled at the European Council in Madrid, in December 1995.
Who first thought of it is where the record thins. The coinage is widely attributed to **Germain Pirlot**, a Belgian teacher, in a letter written that year. Hold that as an attribution rather than a fact: Wiktionary itself calls it *the official story*, the priority rests on Pirlot's own statement that he knew of nobody proposing it earlier, and etymonline names no coiner whatever. Somebody wrote the word down first; whether it was him is not settled.

What you've built

You can name five things you meet when you eat out: *el menú*, *el camarero*, *el postre*, *el supermercado*, *el euro*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el euro*
- *pago con euros*

Now all five together. Name each thing, then say one thing about it. Say these aloud:

- *el menú — el menú está en la mesa*
- *el camarero — el camarero trae el agua*
- *el postre — el postre es dulce*
- *el supermercado — el supermercado está cerca*
- *el euro — pago con euros*

Before you move on

Where does the Academy's dictionary take the currency's name from? (From *europeo*, clipped short — not from the Greek wind, a separate entry and a separate word.) Is Germain Pirlot documented as the coiner? (No — it is an attribution, and one reference names nobody at all.)

Chapter 392

Five Words for a Journey

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el aeropuerto, las vacaciones, el destino, el pasajero and agosto, and name five things about a journey.
>
> *Complete ES-C392-agosto: name five things about a journey, and say one thing about each.*

392.1 el aeropuerto — a harbour with air for a sea

Say *the supermarket*, then *the euro*. (*El supermercado*; *el euro*.)

What to know first

- el aire — the first half, standing on its own.
- el puerto — the second half, standing on its own.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-e-ro-PUER-to*, five beats with the weight on the fourth. The opening *a* and *e* are two clean vowels in a row, each with its own beat; *ue* runs together into a quick *weh*; the single *r* is a light tap; and the *p* carries no puff of breath behind it. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el aeropuerto — "the airport."
Two pieces, both visible. Greek **aēr** was air, and it is the *aero-* of **aerial** and **aerobic**. Latin **portus** was a harbour, and it sits inside English **port** and **portal** — and, more quietly, inside **opportunity**, which is *ob portum*, the wind standing toward the harbour. A favourable wind was your opportunity.
So the picture to keep: a harbour is where things arrive out of the sea. An *aeropuerto* is a harbour whose sea is the air.
Now the part worth being careful about, because the easy answer is not available. The word looks exactly like English *airport*, piece for piece, and that resemblance settles nothing at all. Put *air* beside *harbour* in any European language of the 1920s and you get the same two-part word without anybody copying anybody. That is not speculation — it is documented next door: French **aéroport** is first attested in 1922, and CNRTL derives it inside French, from *aéro-* plus *port*, rather than out of English.
What can be said honestly is this. *Aeropuerto* belongs to a pan-European habit of early-aviation compounding, and whether Spanish took it from English, took it from French, or built it at home is not known. Structural likeness is the one piece of evidence that cannot decide the question, since every hypothesis predicts it.

What you've built

You can name where a journey begins: *el aeropuerto.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el aeropuerto*
- *un aeropuerto grande*
- *estamos en el aeropuerto*

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *aeropuerto*? (Greek *aēr*, air, and Latin *portus*, a harbour.) And does the word's shape prove Spanish copied

English *airport*? (No — air plus harbour gives that shape in several languages independently, and French built *aéroport* at home in 1922; the route into Spanish is open.)

392.2 las vacaciones — weeks with the duty taken out

Say *the airport*, then *the euro*. (*El aeropuerto*; *el euro*.)

What to know first

- el viaje — what you take during them.
- la semana — how they get counted.

Sounds you'll need

- *va-ca-CIO-nes*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *v* is a soft *b*, the same sound the letter *b* would give. The *ci* is an *s* across the Americas and a *th* across much of Spain, and *io* runs together into a single beat. The final *s* stays clear and hissed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

las vacaciones — "the holidays, the vacation." Spanish says it in the plural. The singular *vacación* survives mainly in old talk about an office standing empty.

Latin **vacāre** was to be empty, to stand free of an obligation. Out of it came **vacātiō**: exemption, release from a duty. English carries that root several times over — **vacant**, **vacate**, **vacuum**, **evacuate**, and **vacation** itself.

The step from *emptiness* to *August by the sea* looks like a leap, and it is not a guessed one. The mid-fifteenth-century English sense of *vacation* was a formal suspension of activity, as of schools and law courts. An empty term. An empty docket. Then, later, empty weeks belonging to you.

This word came into Spanish through a book rather than through a mouth, and it left two fingerprints. The *c* between the vowels is still

there, unworn. And the Latin ending arrived as **-ción**. Compare the same ending after centuries of speech: Latin *ratiōnem* came out as **razón**. One ending, two roads — *razón* walked, *vacaciones* was carried. One trap, and it is the likeliest one in this chapter. **Vaca**, the cow, has nothing to do with any of this. That word is Latin **vacca**, with a doubled *c*, and the resemblance to the *vac-* of *vacaciones* is pure accident. Cows are not empty; they are unrelated.

estar de vacaciones — to be away on holiday.

What you've built

You can name the weeks you leave for: *las vacaciones*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *las vacaciones*
- *estoy de vacaciones*
- *en el aeropuerto, de vacaciones*

Before you move on

What did *vacāre* mean? (To be empty, to stand free of a duty.) And is *vacaciones* a relative of *vaca*, the cow? (No — the cow is Latin *vacca*, and the likeness is an accident.)

392.3 el destino — one word doing three jobs

Say *the airport*, then *the holidays*. (*El aeropuerto*; *las vacaciones*.)

What to know first

- estar — the standing verb from the same Latin root.
- la ciudad — one thing a *destino* can be.

Sounds you'll need

- *des-TI-no*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *i* is the *ee* of *see*, never the *i* of *sit*. The *t* is dental, tongue on the back of the teeth and no puff after it. Note too that *st* sits happily inside the word, where a Spanish word opening on those two letters puts an *e* in front first: *estar*, *estudiante*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el destino — the destination. And two more things besides.
Latin **dēstināre** was *dē-* plus an element belonging to **stāre**, to stand: to make firm, to fix a thing in place. Spanish took the verb **destinar** straight off the written page, and the dates say so plainly. Corominas finds *destinar* no earlier than the fifteenth century, and *destino* first in Garcilaso, between 1503 and 1536. A word surfacing that late has not been rubbing along in people's mouths since Rome; it was read into the language.
English got the same Latin: **destiny**, **destination**, **destine**, and the lovely **obstinate**, someone standing firmly in the way. Further back still, plain **stand** and **stable** are cousins.
Here is the most useful thing in the lesson, and it is a false friend three ways over. English *destination* means one thing. Spanish *destino* means three:

- **fate** — *el destino quiso otra cosa*, fate wanted something else;
- **the end of a journey** — *nuestro destino es Madrid*;
- **a job posting**, a duty station, which the Academy glosses with the single word *empleo* — *un destino en el extranjero* is work abroad, not a holiday.

So when you hear *su destino es la capital*, the sentence has two readings, and only context tells you whether the person is flying there or has been assigned there. Fixing a plane's endpoint and fixing an officer's post are the same act of *dēstināre*: putting something firmly where it will be.

What you've built

You can name where the journey ends: *el destino*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el destino*
- *nuestro destino*
- *un destino de vacaciones*

Before you move on

What did *dēstināre* mean? (To make firm, to fix a thing in place.) And name the third sense of *destino*, the one English *destination* has no room for. (A job posting or duty station — the Academy's *empleo*. Fate is the other.)

392.4 el pasajero — an adjective that was given a seat

Say *the holidays*, then *the destination*. (*Las vacaciones*; *el destino*.)

What to know first

- el pasaporte — the same *pasar*, at the gate.
- billete — what this person is holding.

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-sa-JE-ro*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *j* is a rough throat sound, further back than English *h*. The single *r* between vowels is a light tap rather than a roll, and both *s* stay clear and hissed. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pasajero — "the passenger." Built in three moves, each one visible. **Pasar**, to pass, goes back through Vulgar Latin **passāre** to Latin **passus**, a step — the stride of a marching legion. Add *-aje* and you get **pasaje**, a passing, a crossing, a fare. Add *-ero*, the ending for the person who deals in a thing, and you get *pasajero*: the one making the crossing.

The middle piece has a passport of its own. **-aje** came in from Old French **-age** and Occitan **-atge**, and it lives in Spanish beside its inherited twin **-azgo**, the ending the language grew at home. So *pasaje* is not a purely native build: Latin stem, borrowed ending, arriving early — Corominas has *pasaje* by 1309 and *pasajero* by Nebrija.

Two traps, and both repay the attention.

The first is what kind of word this is. The Academy's opening sense is not the person at all: *que pasa presto o dura poco* — passing quickly, lasting little. Fleeting. *Un dolor pasajero* is a pain that goes away. Even the traveller senses are filed as that same adjective, doing duty as a noun. A passenger, in Spanish, is a *passing one* who has been made into a person.

The second is a letter. English **passenger** carries an *n* that was never in the word — *passager* picked it up in the early fifteenth century, in company with **messenger**, **harbinger** and **scavenger**, which all did the same thing. Etymonline's account of why is honest and short: it was done "for no apparent reason except that people liked to say it that way." Spanish never caught the habit. *Pasajero*, never *pasanjero*. English keeps the rest of the family in **passage**, **pass**, **pace** and **compass**.

What you've built

You can name who is travelling: *el pasajero*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pasajero*
- *los pasajeros*
- *el pasajero y su destino*

Before you move on

What is the Academy's first sense of *pasajero*? (Fleeting, short-lived — an adjective; the passenger is that adjective made into a noun.) And which letter does English *passenger* carry that Spanish never had? (The *n*.)

392.5 agosto — an emperor with a vowel missing

Say *the destination*, then *the passenger*. (*El destino*; *el pasajero*.)

What to know first

- los meses — the list this one belongs to.
- el calor — what the month brings with it.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-GOS-to*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *g* is hard, as in English *go*. The *s* stays clear. The *t* is dental, tongue against the back of the teeth, with no puff of breath after it. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

agosto — "August."
Latin **Augustus**, the emperor; the month had an older name and was renamed in his honour. This word travelled by mouth, not by book, and it carries the mileage on it in two places.
The first is the stressed vowel. *Augustus* had a *u* there; *agosto* has an **o** — what a word gets from centuries of being spoken. Set beside it the twin that came the other way: Spanish also has **augusto**, the adjective, majestic or lofty, lifted straight off the Latin page, and it still has its *au* and its *u*, both untouched. One Latin word, two Spanish descendants: *agosto* out of the mouth, *augusto* out of the book.
The second is a genuine puzzle. The opening *au* should not have come out as *a*. Look at what happened to its neighbours:

- Latin *causa* gave Spanish **cosa**;

- Latin *taurum* gave Spanish **toro**.

On that showing, *Augustus* ought to have produced *ogosto*. It did not, because Spanish never started from *Augustus*. It started from **agustus**, a Vulgar Latin form attested from the mid-to-late first century CE, in which the *au* had already given way to *a* under the pull of the *u* in the next syllable. Catalan and Occitan **agost** point back to that same starting line, and Corominas dates the Spanish word to 1192.
One thing stays open. What the name *Augustus* meant to begin with is disputed — consecrated by the augurs, perhaps; or built on *augeo*, to increase. Two respectable answers, and no settled verdict between them.

What you've built

Five words and a journey: *el aeropuerto*, *las vacaciones*, *el destino*, *el pasajero*, *agosto*.

Your turn

Name five things about a journey, and say one thing about each.
Say these aloud:

- *el aeropuerto — el aeropuerto es grande*
- *las vacaciones — estoy de vacaciones*
- *el destino — mi destino es la ciudad*
- *el pasajero — el pasajero tiene su billete*
- *agosto — en agosto hace calor*

Before you move on

Which Spanish word kept the *au* and the *u* of *augustus*? (*Augusto*, the adjective — the copy that came off the page.) And why does *agosto* not begin like *cosa* and *toro*? (Because Spanish started from the attested Vulgar Latin *agustus*, whose *au* had already become *a*.)

Chapter 393

Five Things a Form Asks For

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 3 of 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el ordenador, internet, el correo electrónico, la dirección and la nacionalidad, and name five things I need to fill in a form online.
>
> *Complete ES-C393-nacionalidad: name five things I need to fill in a form online, and say one thing about each.*

393.1 el ordenador — the word stayed, the meaning arrived

Say *the passenger*, then *August.* (*El pasajero*; *agosto.*)

What to know first

- escribir — what you do at one.
- la oficina — where you will most often see one.

Sounds you'll need

- *or-de-na-DOR*, four beats with the weight on the last. Both *d*s are soft, closer to the *th* of English *this* than to a hard *d*, because a vowel runs into each of them. The two *r*s are single taps, not rolls. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el ordenador — a computer.
Latin **ōrdinātor** was an agent noun — a *-tor* word, the one who does the thing — built on **ōrdināre**, and behind that on **ōrdō, ōrdinem**: a rank, a row, things put in their proper places. So the word says *the one who puts in order*, and English carries the same Latin in **ordain**, **ordinal**, **order**, **coordinate** and **subordinate**.
Now the careful part, because two different things happened at two different times and running them together is the mistake.

- The **word** *ordenador*, "one who orders or arranges", is old in Spanish and came down from that Latin.
- The **computing sense** was taken from French **ordinateur**.

Spanish already owned the shape and imported only the meaning. Nothing was borrowed letter by letter, and nothing was translated piece by piece; a sense moved across and settled into a word that was standing there waiting.
The French side has two dates, both defensible, so say which one you mean. The coinage appears in a **letter of 16 April 1955**, written for IBM France, who thought *calculateur* too narrow for the machine. The CNRTL dates the computing sense to **1956** — the first use actually recorded.
One caution before you take it travelling. The Academy's dictionary marks the computing sense **Esp.**, for Spain. Across much of Latin America the machine goes by *computadora* or *computador*, so *ordenador* names it in Madrid and marks you as speaking Peninsular Spanish in Lima.

el ordenador nuevo — the new computer.

What you've built

You can name the machine you fill forms in on: *el ordenador*. And you can tell a borrowed word from a borrowed meaning.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el ordenador*
- *un ordenador nuevo*
- *el pasajero tiene un ordenador*

Before you move on

What did *ōrdinātor* name in Latin? (The one who puts things in order.) And which of the two — the word or the machine sense — came from French? (The machine sense; the word was already Spanish.)

393.2 internet — the same letters, a different beat

Say *August*, then *the computer*. (*Agosto*; *el ordenador*.)

What to know first

- el ordenador — what you reach it from.
- el teléfono — the other thing you reach it from.

Sounds you'll need

- *in-ter-NET*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *t*s are dental, the tongue touching the back of the top teeth rather than the ridge behind them. The *r* is one tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

internet — the internet.
It came into Spanish out of English with nothing changed on the page. The English word is a hybrid, and the two halves come from opposite ends of Europe:

- **inter-** is Latin **inter**, "between" — the same piece inside *international* and *intervene*;
- **net** is Germanic, Old English **nett**, a mesh of knotted cord.

A Latin prefix welded to a Germanic noun, in a coinage of the last century.
The page is unchanged; the sound is not, and this is the thing worth carrying away. English puts the weight at the front: *ÍN-ter-net*. Spanish puts it at the back: **in-ter-NET**. The Academy's *Diccionario panhispánico de dudas* spells this out. An English speaker who keeps the English beat will be understood and will sound foreign for exactly one syllable's worth of reason.
The same dictionary is candid about the article, which is unsettled. Both *el internet* and *la internet* are recorded, and the **feminine is the more frequent** of the two — the pull coming from *red*, the Spanish word for a net, which is feminine. So the word is drifting toward the gender of its own translation.
Two more things it records. Written with a capital when it names the one global network; written small when the word works as an ordinary noun. And the shape resists two temptations: no *internete* with a vowel tacked on to make it comfortable, and no tilde anywhere on it.

todo está en internet — it is all on the internet.

What you've built

You can say *internet* with the Spanish beat, and you know why the article wobbles.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *internet*
- *el ordenador tiene internet*
- *en agosto no tengo internet*

Before you move on

Which syllable carries the weight in Spanish? (The last: *in-ter-NET*.) And which article does the Academy record as the more frequent, and why? (The feminine, pulled there by *red*, which is feminine.)

393.3 el correo electrónico — the messenger who only looks like a runner

Say *the computer*, then *the internet*. (*El ordenador*; *internet*.)

What to know first

- la carta — what it replaced.
- internet — what it travels over.

Sounds you'll need

- *co-RRE-o e-lec-TRÓ-ni-co*. The *rr* is rolled, held longer than a single tap. Every *c* here comes out as a hard *k*, each standing before an *o* or a consonant. *Correo* takes its weight on the middle beat; the written accent marks where *electrónico* takes its own. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el correo electrónico — email.
Correo sits one letter from **correr**, "to run", and a messenger runs, so the story writes itself. The story is wrong, and that is the point of this word.
The Academy's dictionary gives the road. Spanish **correo** comes from Catalan **correu**, and Catalan took it from Old French **corlieu**, "a messenger" — a compound of a verb meaning *to run* plus **lieu**, "place". Catalan then reshaped it under the pull of its own *córrer*.
So Latin **currere**, "to run", really is the ancestor of that first element. But *correo* was not built in Spanish out of *correr*, and part of the resemblance is a later tidying-up rather than descent. Right about the ancestor, wrong about the route.
Now the best thing in the word. That same Old French *courlieu* gave English a bird: the **curlew**. Etymonline says the bird's name imitates its cry — and that it was "apparently assimilated with *corliu*, 'runner, messenger'". Two unrelated ancestries, a call heard on a marsh and a word for a courier, walked into Old French and came out wearing one shape.
From *currere*, English keeps **current**, **courier**, **course**, **corridor**, **occur** and **excursion**.

The second half is far younger. *Electrónico* is *electrón* plus *-ico*, and *electrón* goes back to Ancient Greek **ēlektron**, "amber". A modern international scientific word, passed between languages rather than handed down inside one.
Put the halves together and you have a loan translation of English *electronic mail*, element for element. The Academy recommends the full form and turns down *correo-e*.
One ambiguity to expect: *correo* alone now carries the email sense in ordinary speech, so it can mean the post or the inbox.

What you've built

You can name the thing a form asks for: *el correo electrónico*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el correo electrónico*
- *mi correo electrónico*
- *leo el correo electrónico en el ordenador*

Before you move on

Did *correo* grow out of *correr*? (No — it came through Catalan *correu* from Old French *corlieu*, a messenger, and *córrer* only reshaped it afterwards.) Which English bird shares that word? (The curlew.)

393.4 la dirección — the word for where you live

Say *the internet*, then *email*. (*Internet*; *el correo electrónico*.)

What to know first

- la calle — the first line of one.
- el número — the second line of one.

Sounds you'll need

- *di-rec-CIÓN*, three beats with the weight on the last, where the written accent puts it. The double *cc* is two different sounds in a row: a hard *k*, then a soft *c* before the *i*, an *s* across the Americas and a *th* across much of Spain. The *r* is a single tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la dirección — an address.
Behind it is Latin **dīrēctiō, dīrēctiōnem**. What is worth seeing is that this word did not come down to Spanish through everyday speech; it was lifted out of written Latin, later and deliberately. You do not have to take that on trust, because Spanish kept both outcomes side by side, twice over.
Look at what happened to Latin **dīrēctus**:

- **derecho** — "right, straight";
- **directo** — "direct".

And at what happened to Latin **ratiōnem**:

- **razón** — "reason";
- **ración** — "a ration, a portion".

Each pair is one Latin word arriving twice. In each pair, one member has been handled by generations of speakers and shows it, and the other still looks close to the Latin it was copied from. Now put our word beside them. Where *derecho* melted its Latin *c* away into *-ch-*, *dirección* still shows that *c*. And it ends **-ción**, as *ración* does, rather than **-zón**, as *razón* does. It stands with the copies, not with the worn ones.
The real trap here is the meaning. Spanish **dirección** covers three things:

- the **address** where you live or receive post;
- the **management** or leadership of a company or a school;
- **direction**, the way something points.

English *direction* has only the third. A Spaniard who *trabaja en la dirección* works in management, not in a compass. On a form, the first sense is the one being asked for.
English holds the same Latin in **direction**, **direct**, **dress**, **address** and **redress**.

¿Cuál es tu dirección? — What is your address?

What you've built

You can give the line of a form that asks where you live: *la dirección*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la dirección*
- *mi dirección y mi correo electrónico*
- *busco la dirección en internet*

Before you move on

Which of *derecho* and *directo* does *dirección* resemble, and which of *razón* and *ración*? (*Directo*, and *ración*.) What does *dirección* mean on a form? (The address where you live.)

393.5 la nacionalidad — a word built at home on a borrowed floor

Say *email*, then *the address*. (*El correo electrónico*; *la dirección*.)

What to know first

- el país — what it names you by.
- el apellido — the line above it on the form.

Sounds you'll need

- *na-cio-na-li-DAD*, five beats with the weight on the last. The *c* before *i* is soft — an *s* across the Americas, a *th* across much of Spain — and *cio* is one beat, the *i* gliding into the *o*. Both *d*s are soft, the final one barely there. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la nacionalidad — nationality.
Assembled in Spanish rather than imported: *nacional* plus **-idad**, the ending that turns a description into the quality itself.
The borrowing sits one floor down, in **nación**. That came from Latin **nātiō, nātiōnem**: *a birth*, then *the place of birth*, then *a people*.
Corominas dates *nación* to the **fifteenth century** — late, and lateness is the tell for a word taken from books rather than speakers.
Set it beside **razón**, "reason", which came down the long way, through mouths. Both Latin ancestors ended alike; the two Spanish words do not. *Razón* has been worn smooth. *Nación* still has its Latin face on.
There is a limit to what can be claimed for the modern political sense. Etymonline notes that English *nationality* is "in some usages perhaps from French *nationalité*", and nineteenth-century French influence on the Spanish sense is plausible — and unsettled. Hold it loosely at the top, firmly at the root.
English relatives run wide: **nation**, **native**, **nature**, **innate**, and further back **genus** and **genesis**.
One more sense exists. In Spain, *nacionalidad* also names an autonomous community whose statute recognises a special historical and cultural identity.

¿Cuál es tu nacionalidad? — What is your nationality?

What you've built

You can fill in a form online end to end: the machine, the network, the address that reaches you, the address you live at, and where you are from.

Your turn

Name the five things you need to fill in a form online, and say one thing about each.

Say these aloud:

- *el ordenador — el ordenador es nuevo*
- *internet — el ordenador tiene internet*
- *el correo electrónico — mi correo electrónico es corto*
- *la dirección — mi dirección está en esta calle*
- *la nacionalidad — mi nacionalidad está en el pasaporte*

Before you move on

Was *nacionalidad* borrowed, or built? (Built in Spanish, from *nacional* plus *-idad*; the borrowing is *nación* underneath it.) And which word shows the other road out of Latin? (*Razón* — worn down by speech, where *nación* was copied from the page.)

Chapter 394

Five Places and Things in a Week

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la universidad, el trabajo, la actividad, la guitarra and el médico, and name five places I go or things I do in a week.
>
> *Complete ES-C394-medico: name five places I go or things I do in a week, and say one thing about each.*

394.1 la universidad — a body of people, before it was a place

Say *the address*, then *the nationality.* (*La dirección*; *La nacionalidad.*)

What to know first

- el estudiante — who the word was named after.
- la escuela — the other place you go to learn.

Sounds you'll need

- *u-ni-ver-si-DAD*, five beats with the weight on the last. The opening *u* is *oo*, not the English *you-*. The *v* comes out as a *b*. The *s* stays a clean hiss, and the final *d* is soft, nearer the *th* of *the*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la universidad — "university."
Latin **ūniversitās** — and the meaning to hold onto is not the one the shape tempts you into. In Roman and medieval law a *ūniversitās* was a **body of people**: a corporation, a guild, a company treated as one thing. A trade guild was a *universitas*. So was a town council.
A medieval university got its name the same way — after the people in it, not after the breadth of what they studied. On the exact phrase the references part company. Corominas shortens it from *universitas scholarium*, the guild of students. Etymonline gives *universitas magistrorum et scholarium*, of masters and students. Take the shape and leave the sentence: what got named was an association of its members.
The pieces: **ūnus**, one, plus **versus**, the turned form of **vertere**, to turn. *Ūniversus* is *turned into one*, many things faced the same way. English holds that in **universe** and **universal**; *vertere* alone hands over **verse**, **version**, **convert**, **reverse**, **divorce** and **vertigo**.
Two dates carry the argument better than any reasoning could.

- **1490**, Alfonso de Palencia — the earliest Spanish *universidad* on record. It means **totality**, the whole of a thing. No school in sight.
- **1505** — the school sense appears, and cannot stand on its own. What was written is *universidad de estudio*, a *universidad* **of study**.

That second date is the tell. A word already meaning "the whole of knowledge" would have needed no such help.

What you've built

You can name where you study: *la universidad*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la universidad*
- *estudio en la universidad*

- *la universidad es grande*

Before you move on

What kind of thing was a Latin *ūniversitās*? (A body of people — a corporation or guild, held together as one.) And what did the first Spanish *universidad*, in 1490, mean? (Totality. The school sense came fifteen years later, needing the phrase *universidad de estudio* to say so.)

394.2 el trabajo — a word with an asterisk in the middle of it

Say *the nationality*, then *the university*. (*La nacionalidad*; *La universidad*.)

What to know first

- trabajar — the doing word this is cut from.
- la semana — the stretch you measure it in.

Sounds you'll need

- *tra-BA-jo*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *r* is one quick tap of the tongue, not the English glide. The *b* between vowels is soft, the lips never quite closing. The *j* is the throaty *jota*, scraped at the back. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el trabajo — "work"; also "a job", and a piece of work you hand in. Corominas dates it in Spanish to **1212**. Behind it sits Vulgar Latin **tripaliāre**, "to torture", on Late Latin **tripalium**, an instrument of torture. Told properly it has an asterisk in the middle, and the asterisk is where the honesty lives.

The instrument is real. *Tripalium* is on record, spelled **trepalium**, in the Councils of Auxerre and Mâcon. The Auxerre canon of **578** forbids a priest or deacon to stand *ad trepalium, ubi rei torquentur* — at the *trepalium*, where the accused are tortured. Somebody wrote that down because it stood in a real place.

***Tripaliāre* is not. The form that would mean "to torture with one" carries an asterisk in the Academy's dictionary and in Corominas alike: reconstructed backwards from its descendants, because no surviving text holds it. Two claims, two grades of evidence, worth keeping apart.**
What saves the story from being a good line is that the middle of it is documented too:

- Old Spanish *trabajo* — **suffering, pain**;
- Old Spanish *trabajarse* — **to strive**;
- the **labour** sense — only from the **fourteenth century**;
- and the Academy today still carries a sense *penalidad, molestia, tormento.*

Torture, suffering, striving, work. Nobody had to guess a link.
One step further up goes soft. *Tripalium* from **tripalis**, "having three stakes", is called darkly suggestive with its exact notion obscure.
Hedge the three stakes; the descent of *trabajo* itself stands.
And refuse the moral. None of this says how Spanish speakers feel about Monday. English **travail** is the same word, **travel** its doublet, and nobody calls a holiday agony.

What you've built

You can name what you do for a living: *el trabajo.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el trabajo*
- *voy al trabajo*
- *el trabajo y la universidad*

Before you move on

Which part of the story is attested and which is reconstructed? (*Trepalium* is written down in a canon of 578; **tripaliāre** carries an asterisk in both the Academy and Corominas.) And what did *trabajo* mean in Old Spanish? (Suffering, pain — the work sense only from the fourteenth century.)

394.3 la actividad — the cluster that never wore down

Say *the university*, then *the work*. (*La universidad*; *El trabajo.*)

What to know first

- hacer — what you do with one.
- la clase — where you will meet the word most often.

Sounds you'll need

- *ac-ti-vi-DAD*, four beats with the weight on the last. The *c* is a hard *k*, and it lands — *k* and *t* back to back. The *t* is dental, tongue against the teeth rather than the ridge behind them. The *v* comes out as a *b*, and the final *d* is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la actividad — "activity": something you do, and the state of being at it.
Latin **agere** was to drive, to set in motion, to do. From it **āctīvus**, and from that **āctīvitās**. English carries the root in **activity**, **active**, **act**, **agent**, **agile**, **exact** and **agenda**.
Now the part worth stopping on, because the word wears its own history on the outside. Put these three beside each other and look at the middle:

- *factum* → **hecho**
- *lactem* → **leche**

- *āctīvitās* → **actividad**

Two of those went down through mouths for centuries and came out with their *-ct-* rubbed into a *-ch-*. The third still has both letters, and you can still hear both of them land. It did not travel that road; it was lifted off a written page long after the wearing had stopped.
Do not try to argue the same thing from the *-dad* ending — it proves nothing. Words that did come down by mouth arrive at *-dad* as well: *bonitātem* gives **bondad**. The ending is silent about which road a word took. The cluster is the witness.
Two cautions about the Latin, and neither is small.
āctīvitās is not Cicero's word. It is Medieval Latin, coined by the Scholastics for their own arguments. Writing it out with Classical macrons, as above, flatters it into an age it never had.
And the last stretch is dark. Whether Spanish took *actividad* straight off the Latin page or through French *activité* is unverified. The root is certain, the arrival is not.

What you've built

You can name a thing you do with your time: *la actividad*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la actividad*
- *una actividad nueva*
- *hago una actividad*

Before you move on

What happened to the *-ct-* of *factum* and *lactem*, and what happened to the one in *activ-*? (The first two wore down to *-ch-* in *hecho* and *leche*; *activ-* kept both letters, because it came off the page.) Does the *-dad* ending help you tell? (No — *bonitātem* reaches *bondad* by mouth.)

394.4 la guitarra — one Greek word, three disputed roads

Say *the work*, then *the activity*. (*El trabajo*; *La actividad*.)

What to know first

- tocar — what you do to one.
- la cuerda — what it is strung with.

Sounds you'll need

- *gui-TA-rra*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *gu* before an *i* is a hard *g* and nothing more — *ghee*, not *gwee*; the *u* sits there to keep the *g* hard and is not pronounced. The *t* is dental. The *rr* is rolled, held a moment longer than a tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la guitarra — "guitar."
It starts in Ancient Greek: **kithára**, *kithára*, a stringed instrument — not this one, but an ancestor of the idea. Its first documented Spanish use is in Juan Ruiz, and it is a fine entrance: he already needs two kinds side by side, *guitarra morisca* and *guitarra latina*.
Between the Greek and the Spanish, the references stop agreeing. This is one of those words where the honest answer is the disagreement itself.

- **The Academy's dictionary** takes it from an **Arabic** form, and that from an **Aramaic** one, and that from the Greek.
- **Corominas** has the Arabic form coming **straight from Greek** — no Aramaic step at all; that step is the Academy's addition. And he places the borrowing **in the East, not by way of Spain**: *el vocablo no pasó de Europa a los árabes por España*. His evidence sits inside the word — the Greek accentuation survives, and so does the hard *k* at the front.
- **Etymonline** routes it through **French** and Latin **cithara** with **no Arabic step whatever**, and adds the sting: the Arabic

word may itself have come *from* Spanish or Greek, the relationship often being stated the other way round.

That last one does not only doubt the route. It doubts which direction the word was travelling.
So hold the Greek and let the middle stay open. What nobody argues about is the family that came out the far end. English **guitar**, **cithara**, **zither**, **cittern** and **gittern** are one Greek word wearing five coats, and Spanish keeps **cítara** and **cítola** standing beside *guitarra*.

What you've built

You can name the instrument: *la guitarra*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la guitarra*
- *toco la guitarra*
- *tocar la guitarra es una actividad*

Before you move on

Which part of the *guitarra* story is settled and which is not? (The Greek *kithára* is settled; the road after it is disputed — the Academy through Arabic and Aramaic, Corominas through Arabic with no Aramaic, and etymonline through French with no Arabic at all, doubting even the direction.) What does the *u* in *gui-* do? (Keeps the *g* hard. It is not pronounced.)

394.5 el médico — three beats that never wore down

Say *the activity*, then *the guitar*. (*La actividad*; *La guitarra*.)

What to know first

- el hospital — where you find one.
- la cita — what you make to see one.

Sounds you'll need

- *MÉ-di-co*, three beats with the weight right back on the first, which is what the written mark over the *e* is there to do. The *d* between vowels is soft, nearer the *th* of *the*. The *c* is a hard *k*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el médico — "doctor": the person, and the profession.
Latin **medicus**, a physician, from **medeor**, to heal. English holds the family in **medic**, **medical**, **medicine** and **remedy**.
What is interesting about *médico* is how little happened to it. Count what survived: three beats, all present; a *d* still between its vowels; a *c* still landing as a hard stop. Nothing worn off anywhere.
Set it against a word that did go down through mouths. Catalan inherited the same *medicus* by ordinary descent and came out with **metge** — middle beat gone, the hard *c* softened. Occitan **mètge** and archaic French **mège** show the same wear. *Médico* has none of it: lifted off a written page instead, late and intact.
An older root sits behind *medeor*, independently supported by **modus**, **moderate** and **meditate**. Take care with it: glossing that root as "measure" and then offering a doctor's judgement as proof argues in a circle. The conclusion was smuggled into the gloss.
One thing to hear rather than be told. These three aloud, one after another:

- **médico**
- **medico**
- **medicó**

Same letters, three different words: the doctor, then *I medicate*, then *he medicated*. Nothing changed but where the weight landed — and the written mark moved with it.

Médico does double duty: it names the person, and describes what belongs to the profession — *un centro médico*, a medical centre.

What you've built

You can name the doctor: *el médico*. And with it, five places you go or things you do in a week.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el médico*
- *voy al médico*

Now all five together. Name five places you go or things you do in a week, and say one thing about each.

Say these aloud:

- *la universidad — estudio en la universidad*
- *el trabajo — voy al trabajo*
- *la actividad — hago una actividad nueva*
- *la guitarra — toco la guitarra*
- *el médico — tengo una cita con el médico*

Before you move on

What does Catalan *metge* show that *médico* does not? (Wear — a lost middle beat and a softened *c*; *médico* came off the page intact.) And what separates *médico*, *medico* and *medicó*? (Only where the weight lands.)

Chapter 395

Five Everyday Actions

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say entrar, volver, llegar, perder and necesitar, and name five everyday actions.
>
> *Complete ES-C395-necesitar: name five everyday actions, and say one thing about each.*

395.1 entrar — the vowel that tells you how the word travelled

Say *the guitar*, then *the doctor*. (*La guitarra*; *el médico*.)

What to know first

- la puerta — what you go through.
- la entrada — the noun standing beside this verb.
- salir — the other direction.

Sounds you'll need

- *en-TRAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. Both *r*'s are one quick tap of the tongue, not the long English *r*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

entrar — "to go in."
Latin **intrāre**, "to go into," built on **intrā**, "within."
The mark worth keeping is the first vowel. Latin's short **i** came down to Spanish as **e**, so *intrāre* surfaced as **entrar**. That happened to words carried in the mouth, generation to generation, with nobody consulting a page.
Set it against a word that *was* consulted from a page. The prefix **intra-** turns up in Spanish with its Latin *i* intact — *intravenoso*, *intramuros* — because it was lifted out of written Latin long afterwards and had no journey to change it. Same Latin *intrā*, two different routes, two different vowels.
English took the verb the long way round too, through Old French, and got **enter** — with the same lowered vowel. Beside it sit **entrance**, and the bookish **interior**, which kept its *i* for the same reason *intravenoso* did.
One thing English will not hand over: the grammar. English says *enter the room* with nothing in between. Spanish puts a small word there.

- *entrar* ***en*** *la habitación* — across Spain;
- *entrar* ***a*** *la habitación* — across much of Latin America.

Neither is the careless one. The verb points at a direction; the little word attaches the place.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *entrar*. And you can read an initial *entr-* as the fingerprint of a word that came through speech.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *entrar*
- *entrar en la casa*
- *la puerta*

Before you move on

What became of the short *i* of Latin *intrāre*? (It dropped to *e*.) So why does *intravenoso* still show an *i*? (It came out of written Latin long after the change had finished.)

395.2 volver — the o that breaks in two

Say *the doctor*, then *to go in*. (*El médico*; *entrar*.)

What to know first

- la vuelta — the noun that came out of this verb.
- la puerta — the same *o*, the same break.
- volar — the near neighbour that is not a relative.

Sounds you'll need

- *bol-BER*, two beats with the weight on the second. Both *v*'s are the soft Spanish *b*; the *ue* of *vuelvo* is a quick *weh*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

volver — "to return."
Latin **volvere** meant "to roll," on a very old root meaning "to turn." English borrowed the Latin verb several times over and kept the rolling in every one: **revolve**, **involve**, **evolve**, a **volume** (a rolled scroll), a **vault** (a rolled arch).
Now listen to what happens when the stress lands on that *o*:

- *vuelvo*, *vuelves*, *vuelve* — the *o* has broken into *ue*.

That break reaches words carried down by mouth and leaves alone the ones lifted off a page. *Volumen* and *revolución* came out of books; their *o* sits still. The same break already sits in *puerta*, from Latin *porta*.
The spelling has a wrinkle. Old Spanish wrote the verb **bolver**, with a *b*, and that was the honest spelling for what people said. The modern *v* is a later respelling aimed back at Latin *volvere* — a change of ink, not of sound.

Three things to keep apart:

- **revolver**, "to stir," really is *re-* plus this verb, and it breaks the same way: *revuelvo*.
- **revólver**, the firearm, is a separate word, borrowed from English in modern times. The stress has moved and an accent is written on it; that is the tell.
- **volver a** followed by another verb means doing that thing over — *vuelvo a entrar*, "I go in again." No piece has been added to *volver*. The pattern is an idiom, not a build.

And *volar*, "to fly," is a stranger. Close in shape, unrelated in descent.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *volver*. And you can hear a broken *o* as the sound of a word that never went through a book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *volver*
- *vuelvo*
- *entrar y volver*

Before you move on

What does the *o* do when the stress lands on it? (It breaks into *ue* — *vuelvo*.) And is *revólver*, the firearm, this same word? (No — a modern borrowing from English, with its stress moved and an accent written on it.)

395.3 llegar — a ship brought to shore

Say *to go in*, then *to return*. (*Entrar*; *volver*.)

What to know first

- el barco — where the meaning began.
- lleno — the same *ll-* out of the same *pl-*.
- entrar — what you do after arriving.

Sounds you'll need

- *ye-GAR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *ll* is the *y* of *yes* across most of the Spanish-speaking world; the *g* is hard, as in *go*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llegar — "to arrive."
Take the secure half first: the **form**. Corominas gives the etymon as Latin **plicāre**, which he treats as a back-formation from the compound *applicāre*.
The sound history holds it up. Latin words beginning **pl-** came into Spanish with **ll-** and into Portuguese with **ch-**:

- **lleno** / *cheio*;
- **lluvia** / *chuva*;
- **llorar** / *chorar*;
- **llegar** / *chegar*.

Now the unsteady half: the **meaning**. Corominas does not bridge it with sails. His bridge is a sailors' phrase the most classical authors used constantly — **applicāre nāvem**, "to bring a ship to shore," *frecuentísimo*, he calls it. The chain runs: to dock, then to arrive by sea, then to arrive anywhere.
He also declines to close the case, allowing in his own entry that there were **probably several semantic origins at once**. The form is settled; the story about the meaning is a probability, offered as one.
Two things to refuse.
The first is the tale you will meet everywhere: *plicāre* meant "to fold," sailors folded their sails on arriving, so folding became arriving. No source argues it. It assumes arrival in order to explain arrival.

The second is a footnote that has escaped into the world. Both Wiktionaries give *applicāre* as the etymon and hang Corominas's name on it. His entry gives *plicāre* as the etymon and *applicāre* only as the source of the sense. The name has travelled further than the claim it belongs to.
In fairness, the competing account is not empty: Spanish **allegar** and Portuguese **achegar** are exactly what *applicāre* should have produced, and both exist. The paper trail is early too — *aplekare* stands in the tenth-century Glosas Silenses, and *llegar* is already in the Cid.
English takes the same root by the borrowed route: **apply**, **imply**, **employ**, **deploy**, **pliant**.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *llegar*. And you have watched a citation outrun the claim it came from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *llegar*
- *llegar a la casa*
- *llegar y entrar*

Before you move on

What did *applicāre nāvem* mean? (To bring a ship to shore.) And what does a Spanish *ll-* at the front of a word often answer to in Portuguese? (*ch-* — *lleno* beside *cheio*, *llegar* beside *chegar*.)

395.4 perder — a second half nobody has settled

Say *to return*, then *to arrive*. (*Volver*; *llegar*.)

What to know first

- la llave — the thing most often lost.

- buscar — what you do afterwards.
- perdón — the look-alike with a different build.

Sounds you'll need

- *per-DER*, two beats with the weight on the second. Both *r*'s are one tap; the *d* is soft, with the tongue against the teeth rather than behind them. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perder — "to lose."
Latin **perdere**, "to destroy, to lose," carried down by mouth. Its *-dere* ending came out as *-der* along the regular road, and you can hear the stressed vowel do the familiar thing: *pierdo*, *pierdes*, *pierde* — the *e* has broken into *ie*, the same kind of break you heard in *vuelvo*.
English holds the clean cognate in **perdition** — destruction, loss, total and final.
The front half of the Latin word is not in doubt: **per-**, "through, thoroughly," the piece that pushes a verb to its limit.
The back half is where careful sources part company, and this is the point of the lesson.

- Etymonline reads it as **dare**, "to give" — losing as giving something away completely.
- Wiktionary and de Vaan read it as a **separate element meaning "to put"**, descended from a different old root, the one that also stands behind English *do*.

The two ancient roots are close enough in shape that Wiktionary itself warns they are not always easy to tell apart. So the honest description of *perdere* is: **per-** plus a verbal element whose identity is disputed. Anyone who hands you "per- plus give" flat, with no hedge, has skipped a live argument.
One trap that catches learners. *Perder* and **perdón** look like a matched pair and are not one. *Perdón* rests on *per-* plus **dōnāre**, and *dōnāre* really does come from the "give" root. Same prefix, different second half, and the second half is the whole question.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *perder*. And you have a case where good dictionaries split, and the accurate answer is to name the split.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *perder*
- *pierdo la llave*
- *llegar y perder*

Before you move on

What is the front half of *perdere*, and how much of the back half is settled? (*Per-*, "thoroughly"; the back half is disputed — "to give" or a separate element meaning "to put.") Is *perdón* the same build? (No — *per-* plus *dōnāre*, which does rest on the "give" root.)

395.5 necesitar — the word that came in through a book

Say *to arrive*, then *to lose*. (*Llegar*; *perder*.)

What to know first

- necesario — the adjective standing beside it.
- la ayuda — what you most often need.

Sounds you'll need

- *ne-se-si-TAR*, four beats with the weight on the last. The *c* before *e* is a soft *s* across the Americas and a *th* across much of Spain. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

necesitar — "to need."
This verb arrived by a different door from the others. Medieval Latin had **necessitō**; Spanish took it over from writing, and it is on record here by the seventeenth century — read in late off a page, not handed down mouth to mouth from the Romans. French *nécessiter* is attested a good deal earlier, but no source claims the Spanish came through French, so that stays unsaid.
English draws on the same family: **necessary**, **necessity**, **necessitate**.
Now the interesting part, which is a lesson in reading dictionaries. Inside Latin **necesse**, the two easiest sources answer without blinking. Both parse it as *ne-* plus an element meaning "yielded" or "backing away" — hence the tidy gloss, "that from which there is no yielding." Baldi, writing in 2013, takes that apart. *Necessus*, he says, **has resisted definitive analysis**. The *nec* plus *esse* account is a popular etymology with obvious shortcomings. And the particular *cessus* form the tidy parse leans on does not turn up until the late Imperial period — far too late to be of any value.
Notice how the tidy gloss argues, too: it reads "yielding" out of a reconstructed piece, then offers the word's own sense of the unavoidable back as proof. The conclusion sat in the premise.
So: the **ne-** is secure, and the rest is open. That is the whole of what can be said, and saying it beats borrowing someone else's confidence.
One construction note: this verb takes its object plain — *necesito ayuda*, "I need help." (*Necesitar de* survives in archaic and literary writing.)

What you've built

Five everyday actions: *entrar*, *volver*, *llegar*, *perder*, *necesitar*. And a habit — when a source sounds surer than its evidence, keep the hedge.

Your turn

Name all five actions, one after another, and add one thing you know about each.

Say these aloud:

- *entrar* — and where you go in

- *volver* — and what the *o* does under stress
- *llegar* — and what Portuguese puts at the front instead
- *perder* — and what you lost
- *necesitar* — and what you need

Before you move on

Did *necesitar* come down in speech or in from writing? (In from writing — Medieval Latin *necessitō*, in Spanish by the seventeenth century.) Which piece of *necesse* is secure? (The *ne-*; the second element has resisted definitive analysis.)

Chapter 396

Five More Everyday Actions

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 3 of 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say aprender, cocinar, preferir, funcionar and reparar, and name five everyday actions.
>
> *Complete ES-C396-reparar: name five everyday actions, and say one thing about each.*

396.1 aprender — the hand closes on it

Say *to lose*, then *to need*. (*Perder*; *necesitar*.)

What to know first

- estudiar — the work you put in.
- la escuela — the building it happens in.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-pren-DER*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *pr* runs together with nothing between the two letters, and each *r* is a light tap of the tongue rather than the English glide. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

aprender — "to learn."
Latin **apprehendere** meant to seize: *ad-*, toward, plus **prehendere**,

to grasp. Speech wore it down long before Spanish existed — the *-he-* in the middle fell out, leaving **apprēndere**, and the doubled *pp* thinned to one. Those two small losses are the fingerprints of a word that came down a road.

Then Latin handed Spanish the very same verb a second time, copied off a page this time, and the copy landed intact: **aprehender**. Its *-he-* is still sitting there, and that untouched cluster is what tells you which route the word took.

Two arrivals, two jobs, and swapping them is a real error. Police **aprehenden** a suspect. Students **aprenden** a language. The bookish twin kept the seizing; the worn one kept only the metaphor.

And that metaphor is worth defending, because it is not guesswork. Medieval Latin already had the verb meaning to learn — the sense is written down, not inferred from the root by someone who liked the picture. English carries that very sense in **apprentice**, a person who takes hold of a trade.

The plainer English relatives keep the grip: **apprehend**, to seize a person or a meaning; **comprehend**, to take hold of something whole; **prehensile**, of a tail that grasps a branch; and **prey**, the thing seized.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *aprender*. And you can read a preserved *-he-* as a sign that a word arrived off a page rather than down a road.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aprender*
- *necesito aprender*
- *aprender en la escuela*

Before you move on

What did *apprehendere* mean in Latin? (To seize, to grasp.) Which of *aprender* and *aprehender* would a police report reach for, and what marks it as the copy off the page? (*Aprehender* — it kept the *-he-* whole, and it kept the seizing.)

396.2 cocinar — one Latin word, two kitchens

Say *to need*, then *to learn*. (*Necesitar*; *aprender*.)

What to know first

- la comida — what comes out of it.
- la casa — where the room is.

Sounds you'll need

- *co-ci-NAR*, three beats with the weight on the last. One word, both values of the letter *c*: a hard *k* in front of the *o*, and in front of the *i* a soft one — an *s* across the Americas, a *th* across much of Spain. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cocinar — "to cook."
The verb is young and the room is old. Underneath it sits **cocina**, the kitchen, which is Latin **coquīna**, from **coquere**, to cook. Corominas finds *cocina* in Spanish by the year 947 and puts no mark against it — no suggestion it was lifted out of a book. It came down by mouth, like the food.
The *qu* of *coquīna* had a *w*-colour in it, and Latin lost that colour in front of a back vowel. What is left is the plain *c* of *cocina*.
Now the fact worth carrying away. English **kitchen** is that same Latin noun. Germanic speakers borrowed it early, out of an everyday Latin form reconstructed as *cocina*, and Old English wrote it **cycene**; English mouths turned that into *kitchen*. Spanish, meanwhile, kept the room close to its Latin shape. Two peoples took one word in opposite directions and neither can hear the other in it. **Cook** is the same family — Old English *coc*, from Latin **coquus** — and **cuisine** is the same room once more, come round by way of French.
One caution about the verb, and one about the neighbours.
Cocer and **cocinar** are not swaps for one another. *Cocer* is the old inherited verb for a particular process, boiling or baking a thing. *Cocinar* is the newer one built on the room, and it covers the whole activity.
And *coco*, *cocaína* and *cochino* have nothing to do with any of this.

They merely start the same way.

What you've built

You can now name the action: *cocinar*. And you know one Latin noun that reached English and Spanish by separate roads and surfaced as *kitchen* in one and *cocina* in the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cocinar*
- *aprender a cocinar*
- *necesito cocinar hoy*

Before you move on

Which English word is *cocina* in other clothes? (*Kitchen* — Old English *cycene*, borrowed early from Vulgar Latin.) And which of *cocer* and *cocinar* names the general activity? (*Cocinar*; *cocer* names a process, boiling or baking.)

396.3 preferir — a verb Spanish never inherited

Say *to learn*, then *to cook*. (*Aprender*; *cocinar*.)

What to know first

- gustar — the neighbour that says what pleases you.
- elegir — the neighbour that acts on it.

Sounds you'll need

- *pre-fe-RIR*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *pr* runs together with nothing between the letters, and each *r* is a light tap. Said of yourself, the middle beat comes out differently: *pre-FYE-ro*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

preferir — "to prefer."
Latin **praeferre** is *prae-*, in front, plus **ferre**, to carry. To carry one thing in front of another is to put it first, and putting a thing first is what preferring has been ever since.
This verb came out of a book, and for once the evidence is airtight. Latin *ferre* was irregular — one of the ragged verbs every Latin student meets — and Spanish inherited nothing from it. Not one verb. Yet Spanish has a shelf of them: *preferir*, *referir*, *transferir*, *conferir*, *diferir*. A family with no ancestor in the language is a family of imports, and the tell is that they arrived as a set and were all handed to the same *-ir* class on the way in. *Preferir* is first documented in 1490, in Alfonso de Palencia.
Now set its forms side by side and watch the middle beat:

- **preferir** — the bare verb;
- **prefiero** — what I do;
- **prefieres** — what you do.

That *e* turning into *ie* is worth a thought rather than a label. An inherited sound change is out of the question here: it would have run its course centuries before 1490, and there was no Spanish *ferre* for it to run on. The *ie* must have come from somewhere else — most plausibly the newcomer falling in with native verbs already built that way, *sentir* and *siento* among them. That is reasoning, though, not a finding: no source consulted here states it. Hold it loosely.
The English relatives are **prefer** and **preference**. Behind them, *ferre* is the same ancient root as English **bear**, which is why **refer**, **transfer**, **differ**, **suffer** and **fertile** belong to the household.

What you've built

You can now say what you prefer: *preferir*. And you can treat a whole set of verbs landing together in one class as evidence of where they came from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *preferir*
- *prefiero cocinar*
- *prefiero aprender en casa*

Before you move on

Why is *preferir* certain to be a borrowing? (Latin *ferre* left Spanish no inherited verb at all, and the whole *-ferir* set arrived together in one class.) And is the *ie* of *prefiero* an inherited sound change? (No — and the account offered here, falling in with *sentir* and *siento*, is reasoning rather than a finding.)

396.4 funcionar — the machine works, the doctor does not

Say *to cook*, then *to prefer*. (*Cocinar*; *preferir*.)

What to know first

- el teléfono — a thing that does this or fails to.
- trabajar — the word for people, kept separate.

Sounds you'll need

- *fun-cio-NAR*, three beats with the weight on the last. The *cio* is one glide and not two beats: a soft *c* before the *i*, then straight out into the *o*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

funcionar — "to work," said of a thing rather than a person. Underneath it is **función**, and under that Latin **fūnctiō**, accusative **fūnctiōnem** — a carrying-out, the discharging of a duty — from the verb **fungī**, to perform. A Roman's *fūnctiō* was an office done properly. A Spanish machine's *función* is the job it exists to do, and *funcionar* is that job actually getting done.
Look at the *-ct-* that Latin wrote in the middle of *fūnctiōnem*, because it is a passport stamp. Latin clusters of that shape, carried down by

mouth, come out of Spanish as *ch*:

- *factum* → **hecho**;
- *noctem* → **noche**.

Had *fūnctiōnem* walked that same road, Spanish would be saying something like *fuchón* today. It says *función*. The cluster survived because the word never made the journey — it was copied out of written Latin long after the mouths had finished their work.
One claim to hold at arm's length. You will meet the assertion that *funcionar* came into Spanish from French *fonctionner*, a nineteenth-century import. It may have. Neither route consulted for this lesson mentions French at all, and nothing here could test it, so it stays a claim rather than a fact. French mediation *is* documented for the English word — but that is a different language's history, and it settles nothing about this one.
The trap is a live one. **El coche funciona** — the car works. **El médico trabaja** — the doctor works. *El médico funciona* is wrong, and English hides the difference by using one verb for both.
English holds the same Latin in **function**, in **defunct**, and in **perfunctory**.

What you've built

You can now say that a thing works: *funcionar*. And you can read an untouched Latin cluster as proof that a word came off a page.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *funcionar*
- *el teléfono funciona*
- *prefiero cocinar en casa*

Before you move on

What would *fūnctiōnem* look like had it come down by mouth? (Something like *fuchón* — that cluster gives *ch*, as in *hecho* and *noche*.) And can you say *el médico funciona*? (No. A machine *funciona*; a person *trabaja*.)

396.5 reparar — the word that cannot say where it has been

Say *to prefer*, then *to work*, of a machine. (*Preferir*; *funcionar*.)

What to know first

- romper — what happens first.
- la harina — a word whose sounds do name its road.

Sounds you'll need

- *re-pa-RAR*, three beats with the weight on the last. The opening *r* is a full roll; the two inside are light taps. The *p* carries no puff of air. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

reparar — "to repair."
Latin **reparāre** is *re-*, back or anew, plus **parāre**, to make ready: to make ready once more. The mending sense is already classical — to restore, to put back in order. That much is settled.
How the word reached Spanish is not. Wiktionary tags it inherited from Old Spanish, then adds, in the same entry, that it is possibly a borrowing, and points at Corominas. Two verdicts, one entry.
That is honesty, not sloppiness, and here is why.
A word usually wears its road on its face: *harina* lost an *f* coming down, *noche* turned a Latin cluster into *ch*, and a word copied off a page skipped both. The sounds testify.
Run *reparar* through that test and nothing happens. *Re-* comes out *re-* either way. *Par-* has no cluster to simplify, no *f* to lose, no vowel a sound change could reach. The *-ar* is where Latin *-āre* lands on both

roads. No segment would differ by route.
So phonology is silent, and the weight falls entirely on dates and manuscripts. One dictionary can call it inherited and another hedge, neither of them careless. A word can be perfectly well understood and still refuse to say where it has been.
Its commonest modern use is *reparar en* something, to notice it; how the verb travelled from mending to noticing is not accounted for here.
English has two unrelated **repair**s: the one that mends is *reparāre*; the *repair* of *repair to the drawing room* is Late Latin *repatriāre*, to return to one's country. **Prepare**, **apparatus** and **parade** are true relatives.

What you've built

You can now name five everyday actions, this one included: *reparar*. And you have met a word whose sounds cannot settle its history.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *reparar*
- *reparo el teléfono*

Now all five together. Name five everyday actions, and say one thing about each.

Say these aloud:

- *aprender — aprendo en la escuela*
- *cocinar — cocino en casa*
- *preferir — prefiero el arroz*
- *funcionar — el teléfono funciona*
- *reparar — reparo la puerta*

Before you move on

Why can the sounds of *reparar* not settle its history? (No segment of *re-par-ar* would differ on the two roads, so phonology has nothing

to give.) And which English *repair* is this word? (The one that mends; the one meaning to betake oneself is *repatriāre*.)

Chapter 397

Five Words for Weighing One Thing Against Another

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say barato, caro, gratis, mayor and menor, and say how one thing compares with another.
>
> *Complete ES-C397-menor: weigh one thing against another, and say why.*

397.1 barato — a price that started out as a shady deal

Say *to work, to run*, then *to repair*. (*Funcionar*; *reparar*.)

What to know first

- el precio — what this word is about.
- el dinero — what you hand over.
- comprar — what you are doing when the price matters.

Sounds you'll need

- *ba-RA-to*, three beats with the weight on the middle one. The *r* is one quick tap, and the *b* between two vowels is soft — lips close only halfway. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

barato — "cheap."
Behind it sits an old verb, **baratar**, "to trade, to haggle, to do a deal." The Academy's dictionary gives that verb four words: *de origen incierto* — of uncertain origin. Corominas adds what can be added and no more: the verb turns up across Spanish, French and Italian alike, and is *probably pre-Roman, and perhaps Celtic.* That is where the trail stops, and this lesson stops there too.
What is *not* uncertain is the direction the meaning came from. Corominas is explicit that *barato* in the sense "low-priced" was born attached to the idea of a **shady bargain** — cheap because of the circumstances of the deal, not because of anything measurable about the thing. The price was a comment on the dealing.
English has a word from the same guess, reached from the same direction: **barter**. Old French *barater* meant "to barter, to cheat, to haggle," and the dictionaries that hunt its origin land on the same Celtic hypothesis Corominas lands on. So *barato* and *barter* are relatives at the level of the family — not a line anyone has traced end to end, which is why this says *family* and not *ancestor*.
One story you will meet and should not repeat: that *barato* comes from Greek *prattein*, "to do business," carried by Greek merchants. Corominas rejects it on the sounds alone, and there were no Greek merchants in medieval Spain to carry it. It is tidy, it is everywhere, and it is not true.

- *un hotel barato* — a cheap hotel;
- *muy barato* — very cheap.

What you've built

You can now price a thing low: *barato*. And you have met a word whose origin the best dictionary in the language declines to give — which is itself worth seeing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *barato*

- *un hotel barato*
- *muy barato*

Before you move on

What did *baratar* mean? (*To trade, to haggle.*) And what does the dictionary say about where it came from? (*That it is uncertain* — probably pre-Roman, perhaps Celtic.)

397.2 caro — the word English keeps saying as "dear"

Say *to repair*, then *cheap*. (*Reparar*; *barato*.)

What to know first

- barato — the other end of the same scale.
- la cara — a different word you already own. Hold on to it.
- cero — and this one too.

Sounds you'll need

- *CA-ro*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *c* before *a* is a hard *k*, and the *r* is one tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

caro — "expensive."
Latin **cārus** meant *beloved* — and it also meant *costly*. Both, from the start. Nothing had to move.
English does the same thing today and nobody notices. *My dear friend. That coat is a bit dear.* One word, both jobs, exactly as in Spanish — and this is a coincidence of habit, not of ancestry: English *dear* is a Germanic word and is not related to *cārus* at all. Spanish keeps both jobs too, and *caro amigo* is still readable, though it now sounds bookish.
Three ordinary English words *are* from *cārus*, all of them arriving through Romance:

- **charity** — from *cāritās*, "costliness, esteem, affection";
- **cherish** — from Old French *chierir*;
- **caress** — through Italian *carezza*, whose Spanish sibling is *caricia*.

Now the two words that look like this one and are not this one.
La cara is a face. *Cara* is also what *caro* becomes before a feminine noun. So the same four letters do two unrelated jobs, and what tells you which is what comes **before** it:

- *la cara* — the face; a noun with *la* in front;
- *una casa cara* — an expensive house; *cara* sitting after the thing it describes.

And *cero* is not this word either. *Cero* is the number nought. One vowel apart, and it is the only vowel doing any work:

- *caro* — expensive;
- *cero* — zero.

Say the pair aloud twice and the *a* stops being optional.
Finally, one trap from the dictionary shelf. Latin has a second *caro* — *caro, carnis*, "flesh" — which gives Spanish *carne* and English *carnival*. Same spelling in an index, different word entirely.

What you've built

You can now price a thing high: *caro*. And you can keep *caro*, *cara* and *cero* apart by what stands in front of them and by one vowel.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *caro*
- *una casa cara*

- *barato, caro*

Before you move on

Which two things did Latin *cārus* mean at once? (*Beloved*, and *costly.*) In *la cara*, what tells you this is a face and not a price? (*La* — it is a noun here.)

397.3 gratis — a Latin word that never unpacked

Say *cheap*, then *expensive.* (*Barato*; *caro.*)

What to know first

- gracias — the word this one is built out of.
- el precio — what *gratis* says there isn't one of.
- pagar — what you do not do.

Sounds you'll need

- *GRA-tis*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *g* is hard, the *r* is one tap, and the final *s* is clear. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gratis — "free of charge."
You already own the root. *Gracias* is **grātia**, "favour, thanks." And *gratis* is the same noun in a case form — Latin **grātiīs**, squeezed down to **grātīs** — which the Romans used to mean **"for thanks."**
That is the whole idea. You are not paying money for it. You are paying in gratitude.
Look at what that history left behind. *Barato* and *caro* bend to fit the noun they sit beside:

- *un hotel barato*, *una casa cara*;

and *gratis* does not:

- *un café* ***gratis***, *una entrada* ***gratis***.

It arrived in Spanish as a finished Latin word rather than growing up inside the language, so it never learned the endings. The same fossil is sitting in English, which borrowed *gratis* in the 1400s and left it alone in exactly the same way.
The rest of the family is large and mostly English:

- **grace**, **gracious**, **grateful**, **gratitude**;
- **gratuity** — a tip, money given for thanks;
- **gratuitous** — which still does both jobs, meaning *free of charge* and also *uncalled-for*, because both are "given for nothing."

(Grammarians file grātiīs *as dative-or-ablative, since Latin ran the two together in the plural; it is read as ablative here.)*

What you've built

You can now say a thing costs nothing: *gratis*. And you can hear it as *gracias* wearing a Latin ending — which is why it never changes shape.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *gratis*
- *un café gratis*
- *una entrada gratis*

Before you move on

What does *gratis* literally say you are paying with? (*Thanks* — it is *gracias* in a Latin case form.) So why is there no *gratisa*? (It came in as a finished Latin word and never took Spanish endings.)

397.4 mayor — the greater one, and the man at the town hall

Say *expensive*, then *free of charge*. (*Caro*; *gratis*.)

What to know first

- grande — the plain word this one is the step above.
- el hermano, la hermana — who you will use it about.

Sounds you'll need

- *ma-YOR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The *y* is the same sound Spanish writes with *ll*, and the final *r* is one tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mayor — "bigger," "older."
Latin **maior** is the comparative of **magnus**, "great." Not *bigger* as a separate word — *great*, with the comparison built in. *Greater.*
Spanish runs it two ways, and the exam will want both:

- *mi hermano* ***mayor*** — my **older** brother;
- *personas* ***mayores*** — **older** people;
- *la plaza* ***mayor*** — the **main** square, the greater one.

English carries the same Latin word twice. **Major** is the obvious one. The other is **mayor** — the head of a town, who is, quite literally, *the greater man.* Beside them sit **majority**, **majesty**, and the wider *magnus* family: **magnify**, **magnificent**, **maximum**.
And here is the part worth keeping. English put that word to work at the town hall. Spanish did not. The Spanish official is **el alcalde** — from Arabic *al-qāḍī*, "the judge." Two languages inherited one Latin word, and only one of them handed it the job.
One story to leave alone: that the month **mayo** is *maior* as well, named for the elders. Dictionaries derive *Maius* from the goddess **Maia**, and the elders-and-youngers tale is an old guess repeated ever since. *Mayo* and *mayor* are not the same word, whatever the four shared letters suggest.

What you've built

You can now say a thing is bigger, or a person older: *mayor.* And you know one job English gives it that Spanish gives to an Arabic word

instead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mayor*
- *mi hermano mayor*
- *personas mayores*

Before you move on

Mayor is the comparative of which Latin word? (*Magnus*, "great" — so it means *greater*.) What does Spanish call the mayor of a town, and where is that word from? (*El alcalde*, from Arabic *al-qāḍī*, "the judge.")

397.5 menor — and the minister Latin built to face the master

Say *free of charge*, then *bigger, older*. (*Gratis*; *mayor*.)

What to know first

- mayor — the one this answers.
- pequeño — the plain word it steps above.
- menos — you own this already. Keep it close; it is not this word.

Sounds you'll need

- *me-NOR*, two beats with the weight on the second. The final *r* is one tap. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

menor — "smaller," "younger."
Latin **minor** is the partner of **minus**, which you already have. *Minus* is the neuter; *minor* is the one you use of people and things.

- *mi hermana* ***menor*** — my **younger** sister;
- ***menor*** *de edad* — under age, a minor.

Now hold it against the word you already own. *Menos* and *menor* are one letter apart at the end, and that letter is the whole difference:

- ***menos*** — *less*, the amount. *Menos dinero.*
- ***menor*** — *smaller, younger*, said of a thing or a person. *Mi hermana menor.*

Same root, two jobs. Say them as a pair — *menos, menor* — and the ending starts doing the work.
Now the shape of the pair with *mayor*. *Menor* serves as the step above *pequeño*, and *mayor* as the step above *grande* — but neither is built from the word it serves. Latin took them from somewhere else entirely, the way English reaches for *better* instead of *gooder*.
And Latin did something deliberate with this root. **Minister** is **minus** plus the ending *-ter* — and it was made that way *to stand opposite* **magister**, which is **magis** ("more") plus the same *-ter*. The lesser one and the greater one, built as a matched pair. English holds both: **minister** and **master**.
The rest of the family is everywhere once you look: **minus**, **minute** (both the small kind and the sixty-second kind), **diminish**, **minimum**, **mince**, and **menu** — a *small* list.

What you've built

You can now say a thing is smaller, or a person younger: *menor*. You have five words for weighing one thing against another — *barato*, *caro*, *gratis*, *mayor*, *menor* — and you can keep *menor* apart from *menos* by its last letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *menor*
- *mi hermana menor*

- *menos, menor*
- *barato, caro, gratis, mayor, menor*

Before you move on

Which of *menos* and *menor* would you use for *my younger sister*? (*Menor — mi hermana menor.*) And which two English words did Latin build as a deliberate pair from *minus* and *magis*? (*Minister* and *master.*)

Chapter 398

Five Words for What a Thing Is Worth

Modes: **voice** (3) **eyes** (2) **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say importante, interesante, favorito, fácil and difícil, and say what I think of something.

Complete ES-C398-dificil: say what you think of five things, and why.

398.1 importante — what a thing carries in with it

Say *bigger, older*, then *smaller, younger.* (*Mayor*; *menor.*)

What to know first

- la puerta — the same *port-* you are about to meet.
- el precio — one thing that can matter.

Sounds you'll need

- *im-por-TAN-te*, four beats with the weight on the third. Every vowel stays short and clean — none of them slides. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

importante — "important."
Take it apart and it is *importar* with an *-ante* on the end. And *importar* is Latin **importāre**: **in-** + **portāre**, "to **carry in**."
That is all it meant in Latin. Bring in. Introduce. Bring about. A Roman who said *importat* was talking about cargo, not significance.
So where did *mattering* come from? Later, and not from Rome. The sense grew up inside the Romance languages after Latin, and the dictionaries that follow the trail point at **Italian** as the place it started. Spanish and French both have it; Latin did not. This is one of the cases where the modern meaning is younger than the word by a thousand years.
English kept both jobs in one word, which is the clearest way to see it:

- *to* ***import*** *goods* — to carry them in;
- *the* ***import*** *of his remarks* — their weight, what they bring in with them.

Same word, both senses, sitting in an English dictionary right now.
The *portāre* family is large and you will recognise all of it: **portable**, **porter**, **transport**, **export**, **report**, **deport**.

- *Es muy* ***importante****.* — It is very important.
- *No* ***importa****.* — It does not matter.

What you've built

You can now say a thing matters: *importante*. And you know that the mattering is the new part — the old part is nothing but carrying something in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *importante*
- *es muy importante*
- *no importa*

Before you move on

What did Latin *importāre* mean? (*To carry in* — nothing about mattering.) Which English word still does both jobs at once? (*Import.*)

398.2 interesante — what stands between you and it

Say *smaller, younger*, then *important.* (*Menor*; *importante.*)

What to know first

- importante — its neighbour, built the same way.
- el dinero — you will need it for the second half of this.

Sounds you'll need

- *in-te-re-SAN-te*, five beats with the weight on the fourth. Every *e* is the same short, flat vowel — none of them drifts toward English *uh.* → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

interesante — "interesting."
Underneath is Latin **interesse**: **inter** ("between") + **esse** ("to be"). *To be between.*
The step from there to *interesting* is short. What stands **between** you and something else is what concerns you, what you have a stake in. Spanish keeps the plain verb — *interesar*, "to interest" — and the noun *interés.*
And now the good part, which is about money.
Medieval canon law forbade charging for a loan; that was usury. But it permitted a lender to recover what he had *lost by not having his money* — and lawyers named that **id quod interest**: "that which is between." The difference between where the lender stood and where he would have stood.
The prohibition is long gone. The name stayed. Every time a bank

quotes you an **interest** rate, it is using a Latin lawyer's phrase for a gap.
Spanish holds the same double:

- *un libro* ***interesante*** — an interesting book;
- *el* ***interés*** *del banco* — the bank's interest.

The *esse* half turns up in English too, in **essence** and **present** — the verb *to be*, dressed differently each time.

What you've built

You can now say a thing holds your attention: *interesante*. And you know why a bank's charge and your curiosity are the same word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *interesante*
- *un libro interesante*
- *muy interesante*

Before you move on

What do *inter* and *esse* mean apart? (*Between*, and *to be*.) What were medieval lenders allowed to recover, since they could not charge for a loan? (*Id quod interest* — the difference, "that which is between.")

398.3 favorito — an ending that only looks like a little word

Say *important*, then *interesting*. (*Importante*; *interesante*.)

What to know first

- la casa — and the *casita* you can make from it. Hold that ending.
- el color — what you will use this word about.

Sounds you'll need

- *fa-vo-RI-to*, four beats with the weight on the third. The *v* is the same soft sound as Spanish *b*, made with both lips. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

favorito — "favourite."
The root is easy. **Favor** is Latin **favēre**, "to be well disposed toward, to look kindly on." English has **favour**, **favourable**, and — from the same verb — the **fan**, who is a *favourer* of a team.
Now look at the ending, because it is a trap.
You have met *-ito* before. It is the ending that turns *casa* into *casita*, a little house. Seeing *favor* + *-ito*, a reader who has learned that ending will read "a little favour."
It is not that ending.
Favorito was borrowed whole from Italian **favorito** — and in Italian, that is the **past participle** of the verb *favorire*. It means **"favoured."** The *-ito* was already on the word when Spanish took it; nobody in Spanish added it. Two endings that look identical, doing entirely different work, and only the word's history tells them apart.
English took the very same Italian word by the same road, through French, in the 1500s — so **favourite** and *favorito* are the same borrowing twice over.

- *mi color* ***favorito*** — my favourite colour;
- *mi comida* ***favorita*** — my favourite food.

What you've built

You can now name the one you like best: *favorito*. And you have seen two identical endings that mean different things — one Spanish and small, one Italian and participial.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *favorito*
- *mi color favorito*
- *mi comida favorita*

Before you move on

Does the *-ito* of *favorito* mean "little"? (*No* — it is an Italian past participle meaning *favoured*, and it arrived already attached.) What does Latin *favēre* mean? (*To look kindly on.*)

398.4 fácil — not "light", but "doable"

Say *interesting*, then *favourite*. (*Interesante*; *favorito.*)

What to know first

- hacer — you already own this. It is about to turn out to be the same word.

Sounds you'll need

- *FÁ-cil*, two beats with the weight on the first — and the written accent is there to tell you so. The *c* before *i* is soft. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

fácil — "easy."
Latin **facilis** is **facere**, "to do," with an ending that means *-able*.
So the word does not say *light*. It does not say *gentle*. It says **doable**. That is a sharper idea than "easy," and a kinder one: a thing is *fácil* because you can do it.
And you have met *facere* already. It is *hacer*.
Look at the two side by side:

- ***hacer*** — carried in the mouth for centuries. The *f* fell away to

an *h* that nobody pronounces, and the middle softened out entirely.

- ***fácil*** — lifted off a Latin page long afterwards, by people reading. It still shows the *f* and the *c*, because it had no journey in which to lose them.

One Latin verb, two arrivals, and the spelling of each records how it travelled.
The bookish end of the family is all in English: **facile**, **facility**, **faculty**. And a *facility* is exactly what the Latin says — a thing that makes something **doable**.

- *Es muy* ***fácil.*** — It is very easy.
- *un examen* ***fácil*** — an easy exam.

What you've built

You can now say a thing gives no trouble: *fácil.* And you can hear *hacer* inside it — the same verb, arriving twice by two different roads.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *fácil*
- *es muy fácil*
- *hacer, fácil*

Before you move on

What does *facilis* say a thing is, literally? (*Doable* — *facere* plus an *-able* ending.) Which verb you already know is the same Latin word? (*Hacer.*)

398.5 difícil — the word English had to build backwards

Say *favourite*, then *easy.* (*Favorito*; *fácil.*)

What to know first

- fácil — this word is that word with a *no* on the front.

Sounds you'll need

- *di-FÍ-cil*, three beats with the weight on the middle one, which the written accent marks. Both *c* and the second *i* stay soft and short. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

difícil — "difficult."
You already have the whole word. Latin **difficilis** is **dis-** — the prefix that undoes things — stuck on **facilis**.
Not doable.
That is the entire construction, and it is worth saying aloud in that order: *facilis*, doable; *difficilis*, not doable. Latin doubled the letter when *dis-* ran into that *f*, which is why the Latin has *-ff-*, and Spanish later settled back to one.
The strange half of this story is English, not Spanish.
English did not borrow *difficult* as an adjective. It borrowed the **noun** first — **difficulty**, from Latin *difficultās* — and then, about a century later, writers cut the adjective *back out of it*. **Difficult** is a word made by trimming a longer word that was already there.
So Spanish holds the plain inherited shape, and English holds one that had to be reverse-engineered. When you say *difícil*, you are saying the older, simpler thing.

- *Es* ***difícil***. — It is difficult.
- *un examen* ***difícil*** — a hard exam.

What you've built

You can now say a thing gives trouble: *difícil*. You have five words for saying what you think of something — *importante*, *interesante*, *favorito*, *fácil*, *difícil* — and you can build the last one out of the one before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *difícil*
- *fácil, difícil*
- *un examen difícil*
- *importante, interesante, favorito, fácil, difícil*

Before you move on

Take *difícil* apart. (*Dis-* plus *facilis* — "not doable.") Which came into English first, *difficult* or *difficulty*? (*Difficulty* — the adjective was cut out of the noun afterwards.)

Chapter 399

Two Words for How Something Looks

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (2) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 2 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say bonito and guapo, and say how something or someone looks.
>
> *Complete ES-C399-guapo: say how two things look, and say which you prefer.*

399.1 bonito — the same word made small twice

Say *easy*, then *difficult*. (*Fácil*; *difícil*.)

What to know first

- buenos / buenas — the good you already own.
- favorito — whose *-ito* was a false friend. This one is the real thing.

Sounds you'll need

- *bo-NI-to*, three beats with the weight on the middle. The *b* between vowels is soft — lips barely meet. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bonito — "pretty," "nice."
It is **bueno** with **-ito** on the end. And this time — unlike *favorito* two lessons back — the ending really *is* the Spanish diminutive, the one that turns *casa* into *casita*. Something like *nicely good*.
Latin had already done exactly this, with exactly this root.
Latin **bellus**, "pretty," looks like a simple word. It is not. It is a worn-down form of an older **duenelos**, which was built on the same **bonus** — *good* — with a small-and-fond ending on it. *Bellus* was a diminutive that had forgotten it was one.
So the sequence runs:

- **bonus**, "good";
- Latin shrinks it fondly → **bellus**, "pretty" → Spanish *bello*, and English **beauty**, **beautiful**, **embellish**;
- Spanish, centuries later, reaches for *bueno* and shrinks it fondly again → **bonito**.

One root, the same move made twice, a thousand years apart, in two languages.
A note on the fish: *el bonito* is also a tuna, and the dictionaries do not agree that it is this word. Treat it as a separate entry rather than a pretty fish.

- *un pueblo* ***bonito*** — a pretty village;
- *¡Qué* ***bonito***! — How lovely!

What you've built

You can now call a thing pretty: *bonito*. And you can tell a real *-ito* from the borrowed one in *favorito*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bonito*
- *un pueblo bonito*

- *¡Qué bonito!*

Before you move on

What two pieces make *bonito*? (*Bueno* plus the diminutive *-ito*.) And what was Latin *bellus*, before it meant "pretty"? (*A diminutive of the same bonus* — good, made small.)

399.2 guapo — the word the dictionaries argue about

Say *difficult*, then *pretty*. (*Difícil*; *bonito*.)

What to know first

- bonito — said of things. This one is said of people.
- feo — the opposite, and you have met it already.

Sounds you'll need

- *GUA-po*, two beats with the weight on the first. The *u* after *g* is pronounced here — *gwa*, one slide, not two beats. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

guapo — "good-looking," "handsome."
Every other word in this chapter has an answer. This one does not, and that is what it is here to show you.
The Academy's account. The *Diccionario de la lengua española* sends *guapo* to Latin **vappa** — wine that has gone flat — which Romans also used of a man who had gone the same way: a **good-for-nothing**. The road offered is *good-for-nothing → swaggerer, bully → handsome.*
Corominas does not accept it. In the standard etymological dictionary of Spanish, that sense-history is argued against — the steps do not join up well enough to carry the word.
So: two standard authorities, one ordinary everyday adjective, no agreement. The DLE prints its derivation as a flat single line with no hedge, and a reader who saw only that line would never know there

was a question.
What is not in doubt is the recent end of the story. In Spanish, *guapo* meant **bold, swaggering, showy** before it meant *good-looking* — you can still hear that older sense in *un guapo* for a tough or a braggart. The handsome meaning is the youngest thing about the word.

- *un chico* ***guapo*** — a good-looking boy;
- *una chica* ***guapa*** — a good-looking girl;
- *¡Qué* ***guapa*** *estás!* — You look lovely!

What you've built

You can now say how something looks — *bonito* for a thing, *guapo* for a person, and *feo* for either — and say which you prefer. And you have met a word where the two dictionaries you would reach for disagree, which is a normal condition for a word rather than a failure of the lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *guapo*
- *un chico guapo*
- *una chica guapa*
- *bonito, guapo, feo*

Before you move on

What does the Academy derive *guapo* from, and who disagrees? (*Latin vappa, flat wine* — and *Corominas* argues against it.) Which sense of *guapo* is older, *bold* or *good-looking*? (*Bold.*)

Chapter 400

Five Words for Making a Journey

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say el tren, el vuelo, el aparcamiento, el abono and la playa, and use them to plan a journey.
>
> *Complete ES-C400-playa: choose transport, name its practical details, and say where the journey ends.*

400.1 el tren — a line drawn along

> Say both words from the last chapter for *good-looking*. (*Bonito; guapo.*)

What to know first

- el coche — another way to travel on land.
- la estación — where this one waits.

Sounds you'll need

- *TREN*, one compact beat. Tap the *r* once and finish with *n*. Keep that ending audible: **tren** is a train; **tres** is three. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tren — "the train."
Spanish borrowed the word from French **train**. The French noun

belongs to **traîner**, "to draw, drag, or pull along." Before rails, the central picture was already a line of connected things following one another because the front one pulled the rest. A railway made that old picture literal in iron.
English borrowed the same French noun. That is why a railway *train*, a bridal *train*, and a *train of thought* all keep the same shape: one thing following another in a connected line.
Now make the contrast the lesson, because the mock requires this word and the book already owns its near-neighbour:

- **el tren** — the train;
- **tres trenes** — three trains.

The last sound carries the distinction: *-n* against *-s*. Do not guess from context when your ear can learn the difference directly.

What you've built

You can name rail transport and keep *tren* separate from *tres*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el tren*
- *tres trenes*
- *voy en tren*

Before you move on

What did French *traîner* mean? (*To draw or drag along.*) What single sound separates *tren* from *tres*? (*Final n versus final s.*)

400.2 el vuelo — the journey made by flying

Say *the train*, then recall both recent words for *good-looking*. (*El tren; bonito; guapo.*)

What to know first

- el aeropuerto — where a flight begins.
- el destino — where it is going.

Sounds you'll need

- *VUE-lo*, two beats, with *ue* joined into one quick *weh*. Spanish *v* and *b* belong to the same sound pattern: after a pause the lips meet, while between vowels they usually soften. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el vuelo — "the flight."
The noun sits beside **volar**, "to fly," from Latin **volāre**. The oldest meaning is the act of flying. Travel language narrows it neatly: the dictionary's third sense is the route an aeroplane covers, with or without stops, between its point of origin and its destination.
That definition gives you a useful frame rather than an isolated label:

- **el vuelo sale del aeropuerto** — the flight leaves the airport;
- **el destino del vuelo** — the flight's destination.

English **volatile** belongs to the same Latin family. Before it meant chemically quick to evaporate or emotionally changeable, it described what could fly away. The common picture is movement into the air.

What you've built

You can name the air journey itself: *el vuelo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el vuelo*
- *el destino del vuelo*
- *el tren o el vuelo*

Before you move on

Which verb stands behind *vuelo*? (*Volar*, to fly.) In travel, what does *vuelo* name? (*The route an aeroplane covers from origin to destination.*)

400.3 el aparcamiento — the place built from a verb

Say *the flight.* (*El vuelo.*)

What to know first

- el coche — what goes here.
- el parque — the word inside the verb.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-par-ca-MIEN-to*, five beats, with the weight on *mien.* The *c* before *a* is hard, and *ie* stays together in one beat. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el aparcamiento — "parking" or "the car park."
The pieces are transparent once you see them. **Aparcar** is "to park," and **-miento** turns an action into its result or place. So *aparcamiento* can be the act of parking or the place set aside for it.
The tempting origin story is wrong in a useful way. Spanish *aparcar* was not lifted directly from English **park** when cars arrived. The Academy derives it from Spanish **parque**. The verb first meant placing vehicles or equipment in a designated park or camp; the modern car sense grew from that Spanish family.
You will also see **parking** on signs, and across the Americas **estacionamiento**, **parqueadero**, and **parqueo** are common. This lesson teaches *aparcamiento* because that is the exam's form, not because it is the only Spanish word in use.

What you've built

You can ask about the place for a car: *el aparcamiento*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el aparcamiento*
- *el aparcamiento del hotel*
- *el coche está en el aparcamiento*

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *aparcamiento*? (*Aparcar* plus *-miento*.) Where does the Academy derive *aparcar* from? (*Spanish parque*, not a direct borrowing of English *park*.)

400.4 el abono — a right you can carry

Say *the car park*. (*El aparcamiento*.)

What to know first

- el metro — one service a pass can cover.
- el euro — how its price may be shown.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-BO-no*, three beats, weighted in the middle. The *b* between vowels is soft: the lips approach without a hard burst. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el abono — "the pass," "the season ticket," or "the subscription." The dictionary keeps two nouns spelled **abono** apart. One belongs to *abonar* in the sense of paying or improving soil, so it can mean a payment or fertilizer. The other belongs to **abonarse**, "to subscribe."

It names the right a subscriber acquires and the document or set of tickets that proves that right.
Travel uses the second word:

- **un abono de transporte** — a public-transport pass;
- **un abono mensual** — a monthly pass.

Context is doing real work. At a metro ticket machine, *abono* is not compost; in a garden shop, it probably is. One spelling can hold two histories, and the noun beside it tells you which one you have.

What you've built

You can name a pass that buys repeated use of a service: *el abono*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el abono*
- *un abono mensual*
- *un abono de transporte*

Before you move on

What does a travel *abono* prove? (*A subscriber's right to use a service.*) What other everyday meaning shares the spelling? (*Fertilizer.*)

400.5 la playa — the flat shore at the journey's end

Name the four travel words so far. (*El tren, el vuelo, el aparcamiento, el abono.*)

What to know first

- el mar — the water beside it.
- las vacaciones — when the mock sends you there.

Sounds you'll need

- *PLA-ya*, two beats, weighted first. Finish with the consonant sound in English *yes*. That keeps it apart from **plaza**, whose final consonant is *th* in most of Spain and *s* across most of the Americas. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la playa — "the beach."
It comes from Late Latin **plagia**, a flat stretch of shore. The dictionary's first definition keeps both pieces: the edge of the sea or a large river, formed by sand on a surface that is nearly level.
Across parts of South America the old flat-open-ground idea widened beyond the water. A **playa de estacionamiento** can be an open parking area. That is not a new unrelated word; it is the same flat expanse put to another use.
Now keep the required contrast visible:

- **la playa** — the beach;
- **la plaza** — the square.

The words differ at one place, and that place matters. Do not drop either word; say the pair until the ending decides it before context has to rescue you.

What you've built

You can name a beach as a destination and distinguish it from a town square.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la playa*

- *la playa, la plaza*
- *voy a la playa en tren*

Before you move on

What did Late Latin *plagia* name? (*A flat stretch of shore.*) Which sound separates *playa* from *plaza*? (*Y from z or s.*) Then name the whole travel set. (*El tren, el vuelo, el aparcamiento, el abono, la playa.*)

Chapter 401

Four Words for Following Directions

Modes: **voice** (6) **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say la avenida, seguir, recto and cambiar, and use them to follow or change a route.
>
> *Complete ES-C401-cambiar: follow an avenue, continue straight, and change route or transport.*

401.1 seguir — follow what comes next

Say train, flight, and beach. (*El tren, el vuelo, la playa.*)

What to know first

- ir — to go.
- continuar — another way to say to continue.

Sounds you'll need

- *se-GUIR*, two beats, weighted last. In *gui*, the written *u* is silent and keeps the *g* hard: say *geer*, not *goo-eer*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

seguir — "to follow" or "to continue."
It comes through Vulgar Latin **sequīre** from Latin **sequī**, "to follow," reshaped with the ending of **īre**, "to go." English **sequence** is a set in which one thing follows another; a **consequence** follows from a cause. Those words keep the same old motion.
In directions, **seguir** tells you to keep to the route:

- **seguir la avenida** — follow the avenue;
- **seguir** — continue.

What you've built

You can tell someone to follow a named road or continue moving.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *seguir*
- *seguir la avenida*
- *seguir en tren*
- *después del vuelo, seguir a la playa*

Before you move on

Say *follow the avenue.* (*Seguir la avenida.*) What is the old idea shared with English *sequence*? (*One thing follows another.*)

401.2 cambiar — leave one route and take another

Name the flight, parking area, pass, and beach. (*El vuelo, el aparcamiento, el abono, la playa.*)

What to know first

- el cambio — the related noun, a change or exchange.
- el destino — what may stay fixed when the route changes.

Sounds you'll need

- *cam-BIAR*, two beats, weighted last. Keep *mb* together as you move into the final *iar*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cambiar — "to change" or "to exchange."
It comes from Latin **cambiāre**, which the Academy identifies as a word of Gaulish origin. Its exchange sense makes the core visible: leave one thing and take another. On a journey that may mean another train, route, or destination.

- **cambiar de tren** — change trains;
- **cambiar de dirección** — change direction;
- **cambiar el destino** — change the destination.

English **change** reached its present form by a different Romance route, but it belongs to this same old family of exchange.

What you've built

You can follow an avenue, continue straight, and say when the journey changes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cambiar*
- *cambiar de tren*
- *seguir recto por la avenida*
- *con el abono, cambiar después del vuelo*

- *cambiar la ruta del aparcamiento a la playa*

Before you move on

Give the whole direction set: avenue, follow, straight, change. (*La avenida, seguir, recto, cambiar.*) What older action sits inside *cambiar*? (*Exchanging one thing for another.*)

401.3 la avenida — the road by which you come

Say *the train*, *the travel pass*, and *the beach*. (*El tren, el abono, la playa.*)

What to know first

- la calle — any street; an *avenida* is usually broader.
- venir — to come, the idea that helps anchor this road.

Sounds you'll need

- *a-ve-NI-da*, four even vowels with the weight on *ni*. The written *v* has the same Spanish sound as *b*; do not give it the English *v*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la avenida — "the avenue," usually a broad street.
The Academy derives **avenida** from Spanish **avenir**. The older noun could name something that came in force — especially a river's sudden rise — and also a road that leads, or lets people come, to a particular place. The modern broad city street grew from that road sense.
Keep the scale contrast:

- **la calle** — the general word for a street;
- **la avenida** — usually a broad street, sometimes tree-lined.

What you've built

You can name the broad street that begins a set of directions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la avenida*
- *la avenida y la calle*
- *seguir y cambiar por la avenida*
- *voy en tren a la avenida*
- *tengo un abono y voy a la playa*

Before you move on

Which word names a broad street, and which verb lies behind its history? (*La avenida*; *avenir*.)

401.4 recto — keep the line straight

Name the beach and parking. (*La playa, el aparcamiento.*)

What to know first

- seguir — the action this direction modifies.
- derecha — right; a turn rather than a straight line.

Sounds you'll need

- *REC-to*, two beats, weighted first. The pair in the middle is *k*-*t*.
- Keep **recto/resto** apart: *REC-to* has *k*; *RES-to* has *s*. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

recto — "straight."
It comes from Latin **rectus**, also "straight." English **rectilinear** keeps the straight-line meaning, and every **rectangle** is built from straight sides and right angles.
For a route, put it after the action:

- **seguir recto** — continue straight.

Do not let the exam's near-neighbour replace it:

- **recto** — straight;
- **resto** — the rest, the remainder.

What you've built

You can combine an action and a quality into the direction *seguir recto*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *recto*
- *recto, resto*
- *seguir recto por la avenida*
- *cambiar y después seguir recto*
- *seguir recto al aparcamiento y después a la playa*

Before you move on

Say *continue straight.* (*Seguir recto.*) Which consonant keeps *recto* apart from *resto*? (*K rather than s.*)

401.5 route recall one — hear the chain, then rebuild it

Give the four-word chain from a broad road to a changed route. (*La avenida, seguir, recto, cambiar.*)

What you've built

You are on **la avenida**. The instruction is **seguir recto**. Then the route changes: **cambiar de dirección**. Say those three steps again without the English prompts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la avenida*
- *seguir recto*
- *cambiar de dirección*

Before you move on

Say the route in one line. (*Seguir recto por la avenida y después cambiar de dirección.*)

401.6 route recall two — rebuild it from the change

Start with *change*, then say *avenue*, *follow*, and *straight*. (*Cambiar, la avenida, seguir, recto.*)

What you've built

Someone says **cambiar**. Ask which road: **¿Qué avenida?** Then recover the instruction **seguir recto**. The same four words now survive a different cue.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cambiar*
- *¿Qué avenida?*
- *seguir recto*
- *cambiar y seguir recto por la avenida*

Before you move on

Without looking back, name and use all four direction words. (*La avenida; seguir recto; cambiar de dirección.*)

Chapter 402

Five Words in a Clothes Shop

Modes: **voice** (7) **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name a shirt, T-shirt, size and cap, and ask or say what something costs.
>
> *Complete ES-C402-gorro: identify four clothes-shop words and ask what an item costs.*

402.1 costar — when the price stands settled

Say *the euro* and *the price*. (*El euro, el precio.*)

What to know first

- el precio — the number this verb asks about.
- el euro — one unit the answer can use.

Sounds you'll need

- *cos-TAR*: keep the first *s* clear. **Costar** differs from **contar** only in that middle consonant: *cos-tar*, not *con-tar*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

costar — "to cost."
It descends from Latin **constare**, "to stand together" and then "to be settled or established." A settled price is what an item **costs**. English **cost** reached the same Latin family through French.

Use the third-person question for one item: **¿Cuánto cuesta?** — "How much does it cost?" The answer can be **Cuesta diez euros**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *costar*
- *¿Cuánto cuesta?*
- *Cuesta diez euros.*

Before you move on

Ask how much it costs. (*¿Cuánto cuesta?*)
Source: Diccionario de la lengua española: costar.

402.2 la camisa — a garment with a long family

Ask how much it costs. (*¿Cuánto cuesta?*)

Sounds you'll need

- *ca-MI-sa*: three open syllables, with the weight on *mi*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la camisa — "the shirt."
Spanish continues Late Latin **camisia**, a garment worn close to the body. English **chemise** and **camisole** travelled by another route from the same old garment word, so their opening sound changed while Spanish kept *camisa*.
In the shop: **¿Cuánto cuesta la camisa?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la camisa*
- *¿Cuánto cuesta la camisa?*
- *La camisa cuesta diez euros.*

Before you move on

Name the shirt, then ask its cost. (*La camisa. ¿Cuánto cuesta?*)
Source: Diccionario de la lengua española: camisa.

402.3 la camiseta — the smaller shirt

Say *the shirt* and ask what it costs. (*La camisa. ¿Cuánto cuesta?*)

Sounds you'll need

- *ca-mi-SE-ta*: keep all four vowels; the stress moves to *se*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la camiseta — "the T-shirt."
The build is visible: **camisa** plus **-eta**, a suffix that can make something smaller. The lighter, smaller shirt became the ordinary T-shirt. Keep the two shop labels distinct: **camisa** for a shirt, **camiseta** for a T-shirt.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la camisa*
- *la camiseta*
- *¿Cuánto cuesta la camiseta?*

Before you move on

Give the two garment words, larger category first. (*La camisa, la camiseta.*)
Source: Diccionario de la lengua española: camiseta.

402.4 la talla — the cut that became a size

Name a shirt and a T-shirt. (*Una camisa, una camiseta.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *TA-ya* for most speakers: the written **ll** commonly has the same sound as **y**. → pronunciation reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la talla — "the size," especially a clothing size.
The noun belongs to **tallar**, "to cut or shape." A garment is cut to a measure, and that cut becomes its **talla**. In a shop, **¿Qué talla?** asks "What size?"

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la talla*
- *¿Qué talla?*
- *¿Qué talla tiene la camiseta?*
- *¿Cuánto cuesta la camisa?*

Before you move on

Ask "What size?" (*¿Qué talla?*)
Source: Diccionario de la lengua española: talla.

402.5 el gorro — the cap with no invented origin

Ask the size of the T-shirt, then ask its cost. (*¿Qué talla tiene la camiseta? ¿Cuánto cuesta?*)

Sounds you'll need

- *GO-rro*: hold the rolled **rr** clear. Contrast **gorro**, with *rr*, and **gordo**, with *rd*. The new word does not contain a *d*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el gorro — "the brimless cap," often round or close-fitting.
There is no secure etymology to turn into a story here. The Academy marks the origin of **gorra** as uncertain and derives **gorro** from it. Learn the shape instead: a **gorra** normally has a peak; a **gorro** is round or brimless. They are not masculine and feminine forms of one object.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el gorro*
- *gorro, no gordo*
- *¿Qué talla tiene el gorro?*
- *¿Cuánto cuesta el gorro?*

Before you move on

Name the brimless cap and ask its cost. (*El gorro. ¿Cuánto cuesta?*)
Sources: DLE: gorro and DLE: gorra.

402.6 shopping recall one — rebuild the counter exchange

Give the five-word chain. (*Costar, la camisa, la camiseta, la talla, el gorro.*)

What you've built

You can distinguish **camisa** from **camiseta**, ask **¿Qué talla?**, name **el gorro**, and ask **¿Cuánto cuesta?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la camisa y la camiseta*

- *¿Qué talla?*
- *el gorro*
- *¿Cuánto cuesta?*

Before you move on

Ask the size and cost of the T-shirt. (*¿Qué talla tiene la camiseta? ¿Cuánto cuesta?*)

402.7 shopping recall two — choose, size, and price

Without looking back, name the four shop nouns. (*La camisa, la camiseta, la talla, el gorro.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *Busco una camiseta.*
- *¿Qué talla?*
- *También busco un gorro.*
- *¿Cuánto cuesta?*

Before you move on

Build a two-question shop exchange using a garment, its size, and its price. (*Busco una camiseta. ¿Qué talla? ¿Cuánto cuesta?*)

Chapter 403

Chicken, Vegetables and Paella

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name chicken, vegetables and paella in a menu, market or family-kitchen context.
>
> *Retrieve the three food words across the menu, supermarket and family-kitchen scenes.*

403.1 el pollo — chicken, not dust

Say *the meat.* (*La carne.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *PO-yo* for most speakers: written **ll** commonly has the sound of English *y*. Keep the final vowel round and clear.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pollo — "the chicken," especially chicken as food.
Latin **pullus** meant a young animal. Spanish **pollo** comes from that word. Keep it distinct from **polvo**, "dust," which comes from unrelated Latin **pulvis**. The useful listening contrast is only **pollo / polvo**: the first has *-ll-*, the second has *-lv-*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pollo*
- *pollo, no polvo*
- *carne de pollo*

Before you move on

Say *the chicken*, then contrast it with *dust*. (*El pollo; pollo, no polvo.*)
Sources: DLE: pollo and DLE: polvo.

403.2 la verdura — the green growth that became vegetables

Name chicken and fruit. (*El pollo, la fruta.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *ver-DU-ra*: tap the single **r** once; the stress falls on **du**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la verdura — "the vegetables" or "the greens."
The word is built on **verde**, from Latin **viridis**, "green." The food sense grew from green plant growth. But **verde** cannot be reduced to a colour in every context: Spanish can also use it of an indecent or erotic joke, and the dictionary records a marked secondary sense of **verdura**. Here the context is plainly food.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la verdura*
- *fruta y verdura*
- *pollo con verdura*

Before you move on

Give the supermarket pair: fruit and vegetables. (*Fruta y verdura.*)
Sources: DLE: verdura and DLE: verde.

403.3 la paella — the pan that named the dish

Say *to cook* and *the vegetables.* (*Cocinar, la verdura.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *pa-E-ya* for most speakers: keep three clear beats, with the stress on **e**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la paella — "paella," the Valencian rice dish.
The dish took the name of its pan. Valencian **paella** came through Old French **paele** from Latin **patella**, a small pan or dish. Catalan also has native **padella**; the different middle consonant is evidence that **paella** made the French detour rather than wearing down inside Catalan.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la paella*
- *cocinar paella*
- *paella con pollo y verdura*

Before you move on

Say that your mother cooks paella. (*Mi madre cocina paella.*)
Source: DLE: paella.

403.4 food recall one — rebuild the meal

Give the three new food words. (*El pollo, la verdura, la paella.*)

What you've built

You can name chicken and vegetables, distinguish **pollo** from **polvo**, and name the dish whose pan supplied its name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pollo, no polvo*
- *fruta y verdura*
- *la paella*

Before you move on

Name a dish with chicken and vegetables. (*Paella con pollo y verdura.*)

403.5 food recall two — menu, market, kitchen

Say *chicken*, *vegetables*, *paella*. (*Pollo, verdura, paella.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pollo con patatas*
- *frutas y verduras frescas*
- *mi madre cocina paella*

Before you move on

Rebuild all three scenes: the menu food, the supermarket section, and the family dish. (*Pollo; fruta y verdura; paella.*)

Chapter 404

Wi-Fi, Mobile Phones and Films

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can identify Wi-Fi, a mobile phone and a film, and ask someone to turn a phone off.
>
> *Retrieve the four media words across hotel, phone and cinema scenes.*

404.1 apagar — make the active thing quiet

Say *the telephone.* (*El teléfono.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *a-pa-GAR*: keep all three **a** sounds clear and stress the final syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

apagar — "to turn off" a device or light, and "to put out" a fire. It continues Latin **pacāre**, "to calm or pacify." The meaning moved from making something quiet to stopping its light, fire or activity. In the cinema, **apagar el teléfono** means "to turn off the phone."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *apagar*

- *apagar el teléfono*
- *por favor, apagar el teléfono*

Before you move on

Say *to turn off.* (*Apagar.*)
Source: DLE: apagar.

404.2 el wifi — the connection with a deliberately catchy name

Say *internet.* (*Internet.*)

Sounds you'll need

- In much of the Spanish-speaking world you will hear *WEE-fee.* **El wifi** is widely used; **la wifi** also occurs in parts of the Spanish-speaking world.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el wifi — "the Wi-Fi" or "Wi-Fi."
The name was coined to sound like **Hi-Fi**. The phrase **Wireless Fidelity** was attached afterward as marketing by the industry alliance and was later dropped. That history is why treating the phrase as the name's simple original expansion is misleading, while pretending the Alliance never used it also goes too far.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el wifi*
- *¿Hay wifi?*
- *wifi gratis*

Before you move on

Ask whether there is Wi-Fi. (*¿Hay wifi?*)
Sources: DLE: wifi and Phil Belanger's account of the naming.

404.3 el móvil — the phone named for moving

Say *the telephone* and *Wi-Fi*. (*El teléfono, el wifi.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *MO-vil*: the written accent keeps the stress on **mó**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el móvil — "the mobile phone," especially in Spain. Across much of Latin America, **el celular** is more usual.
Latin **mōbilis** meant "movable." Spanish **teléfono móvil** is literally a mobile telephone; **el móvil** leaves the noun unstated because the movable device is understood.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el móvil*
- *el teléfono móvil*
- *apagar el móvil*

Before you move on

Say *turn off the mobile phone*. (*Apagar el móvil.*)
Source: DLE: móvil.

404.4 la película — from a thin skin to a film

Say *the cinema* and *to begin*. (*El cine, empezar.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *pe-LEE-ku-la*: the written accent keeps the stress on **lí**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la película — "the film" or "the movie."
Latin **pellicula** meant a little skin, a diminutive of **pellis**, "skin." A thin photographic layer, and then the strip coated with it, carried the word into cinema. The material's name became the movie's name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la película*
- *el cine y la película*
- *la película empieza*

Before you move on

Say *the film begins.* (*La película empieza.*)
Source: DLE: película.

404.5 media recall one — connection, device, film

Give the four new words. (*Apagar, el wifi, el móvil, la película.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¿Hay wifi?*
- *apagar el móvil*
- *la película empieza*

Before you move on

Ask about the connection, then name what starts at the cinema. (*¿Hay wifi? La película empieza.*)

404.6 media recall two — hotel and cinema

Say *Wi-Fi, mobile phone, film.* (*Wifi, móvil, película.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el wifi es gratis*
- *apaguen sus teléfonos móviles*
- *la película empieza en cinco minutos*

Before you move on

Rebuild the hotel fact and cinema announcement. (*El wifi es gratis; apaguen sus teléfonos móviles; la película empieza.*)

Chapter 405

Photography, Photos and Permission

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can distinguish a photo from photography and understand whether taking photographs is permitted.
>
> *Retrieve the three image words across an ID form and a public sign.*

405.1 la fotografía — writing with light

Say *to make or do* and *the room.* (*Hacer, la sala.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *fo-to-gra-FEE-a*: the written accent keeps **í** and **a** in separate syllables.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la fotografía means both "photography" and "a photograph." Its international parts come from Greek **phôs, phōtós**, "light," and **graphía**, "writing or description." A photograph is, quite literally, writing with light.
Spanish commonly says **hacer fotografías**, "to take photographs." The verb is the familiar **hacer**: Spanish pictures the activity as making photographs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la fotografía*
- *hacer fotografías*
- *hacer fotografías en la sala*

Before you move on

Say *to take photographs.* (*Hacer fotografías.*)
Sources: DLE: fotografía and DLE: foto-.

405.2 la foto — the short word keeps the long word's gender

Say *the photograph* and *the passport.* (*La fotografía, el pasaporte.*)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la foto is the everyday short form of **la fotografía**. It ends in **-o**, but it remains feminine because the full word is feminine: **la foto**, never *el foto* for an ordinary photograph.
The two forms overlap, but the short one is especially natural for a physical photo or an ID picture: **una foto y el pasaporte**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la foto*
- *una foto*
- *una foto y el pasaporte*
- *la foto, la fotografía*

Before you move on

Say *a photo and the passport.* (*Una foto y el pasaporte.*)
Source: DLE: foto.

405.3 permitir — let something pass through

Say *to take photographs in the room.* (*Hacer fotografías en la sala.*)

Sounds you'll need

- *per-mi-TEER*: keep the two **r** sounds light and stress the final syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

permitir means "to permit" or "to allow." It continues Latin **permittere**, "to let through," built from **per-**, "through," and **mittere**, "to send or let go." English *permit* belongs to the same family.
On a public sign, **está permitido** means "it is permitted," while **no está permitido** means "it is not permitted." Treat that whole sign formula as one useful chunk here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *permitir*
- *está permitido*
- *no está permitido*
- *no está permitido hacer fotografías en la sala*

Before you move on

Say *it is not permitted to take photographs.* (*No está permitido hacer fotografías.*)
Source: DLE: permitir.

405.4 images recall one — ID photo and public sign

Give the three new words. (*La fotografía, la foto, permitir.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *una foto y el pasaporte*
- *hacer fotografías*
- *no está permitido*

Before you move on

Give the ID phrase, then the sign phrase. (*Una foto y el pasaporte. No está permitido.*)

405.5 images recall two — from the form to the museum

Contrast the short and full image words, then say *to permit.* (*La foto, la fotografía, permitir.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *una foto y el pasaporte*
- *hacer fotografías en la sala*
- *no está permitido hacer fotografías en la sala*

Before you move on

Retrieve both scenes without notes. (*Una foto y el pasaporte. No está permitido hacer fotografías en la sala.*)

Chapter 406

Clients, Documents and Data

Modes: **voice** (7) **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand a basic form and say that a client fills in a document with data.
>
> *Retrieve the five form-and-document words in one practical instruction.*

406.1 el cliente, la cliente — the person on the other side of the counter

Say *the shop.* (*La tienda.*) Now name the person who buys there: **el cliente** or **la cliente**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Cliente comes from Latin **cliens**, a person connected to and protected by a patron. The relationship changed over time. In modern Spanish, a **cliente** is a customer of a shop or a client who uses a professional service.
The word itself can stay the same for a man or a woman; the article does the work: **el cliente**, **la cliente**. You may also meet **clienta** for a woman.

Grammar Lens: meaning in a scene

Picture a counter. One person works for the shop; the other asks for a product or service. That second person is **el cliente** or **la cliente**.

- **el cliente de la tienda** — the shop's customer
- **la cliente necesita ayuda** — the customer needs help

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cliente*
- *la cliente*
- *el cliente de la tienda*

Before you move on

What is the customer or client? (*El cliente; la cliente.*)
Source: DLE: cliente.

406.2 el documento — a paper that shows or proves

Say *the passport* and *the paper*. (*El pasaporte, el papel.*) A passport is one kind of **documento**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

El documento comes from Latin **documentum**, something that gives evidence or instruction. Its deeper verb is **docēre**, "to teach." English **document**, **doctor**, **doctrine** and **docent** belong to the same family: each points to showing, teaching or establishing something. A **papel** is the material. A **documento** is the meaningful record on it — or the digital equivalent. A passport is both a small book and an official **documento**.

Grammar Lens: useful combinations

- **el documento de identidad** — the identity document
- **el pasaporte es un documento** — the passport is a document
- **necesito el documento** — I need the document

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el documento*
- *el documento de identidad*
- *el pasaporte es un documento*

Before you move on

What written record can serve as proof? (*El documento.*)
Source: DLE: documento.

406.3 el dato — one thing given as information

A form may ask for your name and address: *el nombre, la dirección.* Each answer is **un dato**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Dato comes straight from Latin **datum**, "something given." English kept **datum** for one item and **data** for several; Spanish made the everyday noun **el dato**, plural **los datos**.
A name, address or telephone number can each be **un dato**. Together they are **los datos personales**, personal details.

Grammar Lens: one or several

- **un dato** — one piece of information
- **los datos** — the information / details
- **nombre y dirección: dos datos** — name and address: two details

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *un dato*
- *los datos*

- *los datos personales*

Before you move on

One piece of information? (*Un dato.*) Several details? (*Los datos.*)
Source: DLE: dato.

406.4 el impreso — a form waiting for your data

Say *the document*, *the data* and *the paper*. (*El documento, los datos, el papel.*) Put blank spaces on that paper and you have **el impreso**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Impreso is the irregular past participle of **imprimir**, "to print," from Latin **impressus**, "pressed into." Printing once meant pressing inked type onto paper. English **impress** preserves the same image.
As a noun, **el impreso** can mean a printed sheet, especially a form with blank spaces for a procedure. In much of the Spanish-speaking world you will also hear **el formulario**. Here the exam-derived word is **impreso**.

Grammar Lens: a form has two sides

The **impreso** supplies the labels; you supply **los datos**:

- **Nombre:** Ana
- **Dirección:** Calle Sol, 4

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el impreso*
- *los datos del impreso*
- *el documento y el impreso*

Before you move on

What printed sheet waits for your details? (*El impreso.*) What do you put in it? (*Los datos.*)
Source: DLE: impreso.

406.5 rellenar — fill the blanks with what they need

Say *the form*, *the data* and *full*. (*El impreso, los datos, lleno.*)
The action that connects them is **rellenar**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Rellenar shows its construction on the surface: **re-** + **llenar**, "to fill." Its broad sense is to fill something again or completely. In an office, it has the practical meaning "to fill in" or "to fill out."
The DLE gives the form sense precisely: putting the necessary data into blank spaces in forms or documents. That is why the noun chain from this chapter ends in an action:

rellenar el impreso con los datos

Grammar Lens: a regular -ar action

You already know the regular **-ar** machine:

- **relleno el impreso** — I fill in the form
- **rellena el impreso** — he/she fills in the form; fill in the form

The noun **relleno** can also mean a filling, but the sentence and article tell you what job the form is doing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *rellenar*
- *rellenar el impreso*

- *rellenar el impreso con los datos*

Before you move on

Say *to fill in the form with the data.* (*Rellenar el impreso con los datos.*)
Source: DLE: rellenar.

406.6 documents recall one — build the form scene

Give the five new forms. (*El cliente, el documento, el dato, el impreso, rellenar.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cliente y el documento*
- *los datos del cliente*
- *rellenar el impreso*
- *rellenar el impreso con los datos*

Before you move on

Who has the details, what sheet receives them, and what is the action? (*El cliente; el impreso; rellenar.*)

406.7 documents recall two — one complete instruction

Rebuild the chain without looking: person, record, information, printed form, action. (*Cliente, documento, dato, impreso, rellenar.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el documento del cliente*
- *los datos: nombre y dirección*
- *el cliente rellena el impreso*
- *el cliente rellena el impreso con los datos*

Before you move on

Say the whole office sentence. (*El cliente rellena el impreso con los datos.*) Then name the record it creates. (*El documento.*)

Chapter 407

Middle, Below, Outside and Beside

Modes: **voice** (6) **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can place something in the middle, underneath, outside or beside a reference point.
>
> *Use four location frames without translating.*

407.1 en medio — in the middle

Recall **la puerta**, the door. Now place it at the centre: **la puerta está en medio**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Medio comes from Latin **medius**, "middle." English kept the same root in **median**, **medium** and **intermediate**. Spanish uses **en medio** for a position between the edges or between two things.

Grammar Lens: the frame en medio de

Say **en medio** when the reference is understood. Add **de** before the thing that frames the middle: **en medio de la puerta**, in the middle of the door.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en medio*

- *en medio de la puerta*
- *la puerta está en medio*

Before you move on

In the middle? (*En medio.*)
Source: DLE: medio.

407.2 debajo — underneath

Recall **la mesa**. Something lower than the tabletop can be **debajo de la mesa**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The history is visible: **de + bajo**. **Bajo** is low; **debajo** names the lower position. The DLE defines it as a place below another higher one.

Grammar Lens: debajo de

Before a reference object, use **debajo de**: **debajo de la mesa**. With no object stated, **está debajo** is complete.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *debajo*
- *debajo de la mesa*
- *está debajo*

Before you move on

Underneath? (*Debajo.*) Under the table? (*Debajo de la mesa.*)
Source: DLE: debajo.

407.3 fuera — outside

Recall **la casa**. Inside it is one location; beyond it is **fuera**, outside.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Fuera comes from Latin **foras**, "outward." The core picture is crossing the boundary and standing beyond it. The opening **fue-** is one syllable: say FWE-ra, not fu-E-ra.

Grammar Lens: fuera and fuera de

Está fuera means it is outside. Add **de** for the boundary: **fuera de la casa**, outside the house.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *fuera*
- *está fuera*
- *fuera de la casa*

Before you move on

Outside? (*Fuera.*)
Source: DLE: fuera.

407.4 el lado — the side

A door has a left edge and a right edge. Each edge belongs to **un lado**, a side.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Lado continues Latin **latus**, "side." English **lateral** is the learned cousin: a lateral movement goes toward one side.

Grammar Lens: al lado de

The useful location frame is **al lado de**, beside or next to: **al lado de la puerta**. The **al** is **a + el**, literally "at the side of."

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el lado*
- *al lado*
- *al lado de la puerta*

Before you move on

The side? (*El lado.*) Beside the door? (*Al lado de la puerta.*)
Source: DLE: lado.

407.5 location recall one — place four points

Give the four locations. (*En medio, debajo, fuera, el lado.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en medio de la puerta*
- *debajo de la mesa*
- *fuera de la casa*
- *al lado de la puerta*

Before you move on

Middle, below, outside, side? (*Medio, debajo, fuera, lado.*)

407.6 location recall two — complete the map

Complete each frame: **en** _____ **de**, _____ **de**, _____ **de**, **al** _____ **de**. (*Medio, debajo, fuera, lado.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *en medio*
- *debajo*
- *fuera*
- *al lado*

Before you move on

Place an object in four different relations without translating. (*En medio de, debajo de, fuera de, al lado de.*)

Chapter 408

Doctor, Pills and Tiredness

Modes: **voice** (4) **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can identify a doctor, a medicinal tablet and the state of being tired.
>
> *Retrieve three health words across appointment, medicine and state messages.*

408.1 el doctor / la doctora — the teacher-word at the clinic

Recall **el médico**, the physician. Spanish has another word you will hear when making an appointment: **el doctor** or **la doctora**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Medieval Latin **doctor** meant "teacher," from **docēre**, "to teach." English kept the same academic word. Spanish also uses **doctor** for a physician and as a form of address. That does not erase the older academic meaning: context tells you whether the doctor holds a doctorate or is treating a patient.

Grammar Lens: name the person

The ending follows the person: **el doctor**, **la doctora**. To ask for an appointment, use the frame **pedir cita con el doctor**. **Médico** remains the more specific profession-word; **doctor** is the word the

mock message uses.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el doctor*
- *la doctora*
- *una cita con el doctor*

Before you move on

Doctor? (*El doctor; la doctora.*)
Source: DLE: doctor.

408.2 la pastilla — a small formed portion

You have an appointment with **el doctor**. The next message names what you take: **la pastilla**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Pastilla belongs transparently with **pasta** and the small-form ending **-illa**: a little formed portion. The older physical idea survives in a bar of soap or a mint. In the clinic, **una pastilla** is a small medicinal tablet.
Do not overtranslate the shape. In this health frame, **pastilla** means the pill or tablet, not pasta to eat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la pastilla*
- *una pastilla*
- *el doctor y la pastilla*

Before you move on

Pill or tablet? (*La pastilla.*)
Sources: DLE: pastilla; RAE, derivation and composition: *pastilla* from *pasta.*

408.3 health recall one — person, medicine, state

Give the person, the medicine and the state. (*El doctor, la pastilla, cansado.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *una cita con el doctor*
- *una pastilla*
- *estoy cansado*

Before you move on

Doctor, pill, tired? (*Doctor, pastilla, cansado.*)

408.4 health recall two — close the three messages

Complete the three cues: cita con el _____; una _____; estoy _____. (*Doctor, pastilla, cansado.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el doctor*
- *la pastilla*
- *estoy cansado*

Before you move on

Retrieve all three without translating. (*Doctor, pastilla, cansado.*)

Chapter 409

Finish, Prepare and Plan the Weekend

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can understand five common words used to finish, prepare and book a simple plan.

Retrieve five planning words across work, food, weekend and hotel messages.

409.1 terminar — reach the boundary

Recall **el trabajo**, the work. Now add the action that brings it to its endpoint: **terminar**, "to finish" or "to end."

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **terminā̆re** meant to set a boundary or bring something to an end. Its base was **terminus**, a boundary. English **term**, **terminal** and **terminate** keep the same boundary picture. Spanish **terminar** is the everyday verb: **terminar el trabajo**, finish the work.

Grammar Lens: the regular -ar frame

For "I finish," remove **-ar** and add **-o**: **termino**. After another verb, keep the infinitive: **quiero terminar**. Hear the difference between a plan and a completed statement: **quiero terminar / termino**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *terminar*
- *terminar el trabajo*
- *quiero terminar*

Before you move on

To finish? (*Terminar.*)
Source: DLE: terminar.

409.2 preparar — make ready beforehand

Recall **el postre**, dessert. Before it is served, someone has to make it ready: **preparar un postre**, "to prepare a dessert." You can **terminar** a task; first you may need to **preparar** its parts.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **praeparāre** joined **prae**, "before," to **parāre**, "make ready." Spanish **preparar** and English **prepare** preserve that family almost unchanged. The older verb **parar** is visible inside, but do not translate the modern compound as "pre-stop": use the whole word, "prepare."

Grammar Lens: prepare a thing or prepare to act

Use a noun directly: **preparar un postre**. Before another action, Spanish can use **prepararse para**; this lesson keeps the simpler A1 object frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *preparar*
- *preparar un postre*
- *me gusta preparar postres*

Before you move on

To prepare? (*Preparar.*)
Source: DLE: preparar.

409.3 el fin de semana — the week's end

Spanish builds "weekend" as a transparent phrase: **el fin de semana**, literally "the end of the week." It gives a time for a plan: **voy a preparar el postre este fin de semana**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Fin continues Latin **fīnis**, "boundary" or "end." **Semana** continues Late Latin **septimāna**, the seven-day period. The little **de** joins them: **fin de semana**. Learn the three words as one planning block.

Grammar Lens: one weekend, many weekends

For one, say **el fin de semana**. In the plural, only the first noun changes: **los fines de semana**. For a regular habit, **trabajo los fines de semana**; for one upcoming period, **este fin de semana**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el fin de semana*
- *este fin de semana*
- *los fines de semana*

Before you move on

The weekend? (*El fin de semana.*)
Sources: DLE: fin; DLE: semana.

409.4 reservar — set it aside

You have chosen **el fin de semana**. To book a room for it, use **reservar**: **reservar una habitación**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **reservāre** meant "keep back" or "preserve." That image still works: a hotel sets a room aside for you. English **reserve** is a close relative. Keep the history at that safe level; resemblance to **servir** is not a reason to invent a separate family story.

Grammar Lens: book a thing for people

The thing follows directly: **reservar una habitación**. Add the people with **para**: **para dos personas**. Together: **quiero reservar una habitación para dos personas**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *reservar*
- *reservar una habitación*
- *para dos personas*

Before you move on

To reserve or book? (*Reservar.*)
Source: DLE: reservar.

409.5 incluir — close it inside the whole

You can **reservar** a room. Now ask what comes inside the price: **¿Incluye el desayuno?**, "Does it include breakfast?"

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish borrowed **incluir** from Latin **inclūdere**, literally "close in": **in**, "in," plus **claudere**, "close." English **include**, **exclude** and **conclude** share the same learned family. Something included is enclosed inside the whole.

Grammar Lens: the useful third-person form

The infinitive is **incluir**, but hotel messages often use **incluye**: **el precio incluye el desayuno**. In a question, keep the same form and lift the intonation: **¿Incluye el desayuno?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *incluir*
- *incluye el desayuno*
- *el precio incluye el desayuno*

Before you move on

To include? (*Incluir.*) Does it include breakfast? (*¿Incluye el desayuno?*)
Source: DLE: incluir.

409.6 planning recall one — work, food, weekend, hotel

Give the five planning blocks. (*Terminar, preparar, fin de semana, reservar, incluir.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *terminar el trabajo*
- *preparar postres*
- *este fin de semana*
- *reservar una habitación*
- *incluye el desayuno*

Before you move on

Finish, prepare, weekend, reserve, include? (*Terminar, preparar, fin de semana, reservar, incluir.*)

409.7 planning recall two — complete the message

Complete each short message from meaning, not from the first letter.

Your turn

- "I finish at one." [YOU SAY: *Termino a la una.*]
- "I like preparing desserts." [YOU SAY: *Me gusta preparar postres.*]
- "I work on weekends." [YOU SAY: *Trabajo los fines de semana.*]
- "I want to book a room." [YOU SAY: *Quiero reservar una habitación.*]
- "The price includes breakfast." [YOU SAY: *El precio incluye el desayuno.*]

Before you move on

Say the five planning blocks once more. (*Terminar, preparar, fin de semana, reservar, incluir.*)

Chapter 410

Academy, French, Student and Exam

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can identify an academy, French, a student and an exam in simple education messages.

Retrieve four education words across course, identity and assessment messages.

410.1 la academia — from a place-name to a place of learning

Recall **estudiante**, a student. A student may learn at **la academia**, an academy or teaching centre.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **academia** came through Latin **academia** from Greek **Akadēmía**, the place-name associated with Plato's school. English **academy** belongs to the same travelled family. In an A1 message, **una academia de idiomas** is a language school, not necessarily a university institution.

Grammar Lens: what kind of academy?

Use **de** to name the subject: **una academia de idiomas**. The noun is feminine: **la academia**, **una academia**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la academia*
- *una academia de idiomas*
- *soy estudiante en una academia*

Before you move on

Academy or teaching centre? (*La academia.*)
Source: DLE: academia.

410.2 francés / francesa — language and person

At **una academia de idiomas**, one possible subject is **francés**, French.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **francés** came from French **français**. The language name is the masculine singular form: **hablo francés**. For people and adjectives, the ending agrees: **un estudiante francés**, **una estudiante francesa**.

Grammar Lens: the accent comes and goes

The final stress of **francés** needs its written accent. Adding **-a** moves the natural stress: **francesa**, with no accent mark. The plural follows the same pattern: **franceses, francesas**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *francés*
- *una academia de francés*
- *una estudiante francesa*

Before you move on

French? (*Francés.*) A French woman or feminine adjective? (*Francesa.*)
Source: DLE: francés.

410.3 el examen — a weighing of what you know

A student of French may take **un examen de francés**, a French exam.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **examen** is Latin **exāmen**, a weighing or examination. English **exam** and **examination** are learned relatives. The old weighing image is a useful memory hook: an exam weighs what has been learned.

Grammar Lens: singular and plural stress

The singular is **el examen**, with no written accent because the stress falls naturally on **-xa-**. The plural is **los exámenes**; the accent appears to keep that stress when another syllable is added.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el examen*
- *un examen de francés*
- *los exámenes*

Before you move on

Exam? (*El examen.*) Exams? (*Los exámenes.*)
Source: DLE: examen.

410.4 education recall one — place, subject, learner, assessment

Give the place, subject, learner and assessment. (*Academia, francés, estudiante, examen.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *una academia de idiomas*
- *hablo francés*
- *soy estudiante*
- *un examen de francés*

Before you move on

Academy, French, student, exam? (*Academia, francés, estudiante, examen.*)

410.5 education recall two — complete the message

Complete each education message from meaning.

Your turn

- "It is a language academy." [YOU SAY: *Es una academia de idiomas.*]
- "I speak French." [YOU SAY: *Hablo francés.*]
- "I am a student." [YOU SAY: *Soy estudiante.*]
- "The exam is difficult." [YOU SAY: *El examen es difícil.*]

Before you move on

Say the four education words once more. (*Academia, francés, estudiante, examen.*)

Chapter 411

Ice Cream

Modes: **voice** (3) **Hands-free start:** all 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can identify and order ice cream in a simple café conversation.
>
> *Retrieve ice cream across identification and café-order messages.*

411.1 el helado — something frozen becomes a treat

Recall **el hielo**, ice. Its cold family leads to **el helado**, ice cream.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Helado is the participle of **helar**, to freeze: its first sense is "frozen." Used as a noun with **el**, it names ice cream. **Hielo**, **helar** and **helado** all continue the Latin cold-family already met in the ice lesson. The silent **h** links their modern spelling even though it makes no sound.

Grammar Lens: thing or description?

With an article, **el helado** is the food. After a noun, **helado / helada** can describe something frozen: **agua helada**. For the mock café message, listen for the noun **un helado**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el helado*
- *un helado de chocolate*
- *quiero un helado*

Before you move on

Ice cream? (*El helado.*) One chocolate ice cream? (*Un helado de chocolate.*)
Source: DLE: helado.

411.2 helado recall one — choose the frozen treat

Say "ice cream." (*Helado.*)

Your turn

- *Say it: un helado*
- *Say it: un helado de chocolate*
- "I want an ice cream." [YOU SAY: *Quiero un helado.*]

Before you move on

What frozen treat begins with a silent **h**? (*El helado.*)

411.3 helado recall two — complete the café exchange

Listen for the food after **un**: **un helado**.

Your turn

- "What would you like?" — "A chocolate ice cream." [YOU SAY: *¿Qué quieres? — Un helado de chocolate.*]
- "I would like an ice cream, please." [YOU SAY: *Quiero un helado, por favor.*]

Before you move on

Give the café answer once more. (*Un helado de chocolate.*)

Chapter 412

Gym and Sport

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can identify a gym and understand a simple message about doing sport.
>
> *Retrieve gym and sport across opening-hours and after-work messages.*

412.1 el gimnasio — the long form behind gym

English shortens **gymnasium** to **gym**. Spanish keeps more of the old word: **el gimnasio**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **gimnasio** came through Latin **gymnasium** from Greek **gymnásion**, a place for exercise and training. English **gymnasium** is the same travelled word, and **gym** is its clipped form. Spanish spelling turns the learned **gy-** into **gi-**, pronounced with the strong Spanish **g** sound heard before **i**.

Grammar Lens: naming the place

The noun is masculine: **el gimnasio**, **un gimnasio**. Opening-hours signs often place the name first: **Gimnasio Atlas — abierto de 7 a 23 h**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el gimnasio*
- *un gimnasio*
- *el gimnasio está abierto*

Before you move on

Gym? (*El gimnasio.*)
Source: DLE: gimnasio.

412.2 el deporte — recreation that became sport

Recall the place for exercise: **el gimnasio**. What you may do there is **deporte**, sport.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Deporte belongs to an older **deportar** family that once meant recreation or amusement. English **sport** hides a useful cousin: it is the shortened form of **disport**, which came through French from the same Latin **deportāre** family. The histories narrowed toward organised physical activity.

Grammar Lens: hacer deporte

Spanish commonly says **hacer deporte**, literally "to do sport," for taking exercise. No article is needed in that general expression. Compare **el deporte es importante**, where the noun is the subject and keeps **el**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el deporte*
- *hacer deporte*
- *hacer deporte en el gimnasio*

Before you move on

To do sport? (*Hacer deporte.*)
Source: DLE: deporte.

412.3 fitness recall one — place and activity

Give the place and the activity. (*Gimnasio, deporte.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el gimnasio*
- *hacer deporte*
- *hacer deporte en el gimnasio*

Before you move on

Gym, sport? (*Gimnasio, deporte.*)

412.4 fitness recall two — choose from the opening hours

A place open until 23 h suits someone active after work.

Your turn

- "The gym is open until eleven." [YOU SAY: *El gimnasio está abierto hasta las once.*]
- "Marta wants to do sport after work." [YOU SAY: *Marta quiere hacer deporte después del trabajo.*]

Before you move on

Which place matches **hacer deporte por la noche**? (*El gimnasio.*)

Chapter 413

Music and Concert

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can identify music and a concert in a simple night-out announcement.
>
> *Retrieve music and concert across preference and event messages.*

413.1 la música — another art of the Muses

Recall **el museo**, a place whose name once meant a seat of the Muses. Their art also gives Spanish **la música**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Greek **mousikḗ**, the art of the Muses, travelled into Latin **mūsica** and then Spanish **música**. English **music** followed the same road through French. The root is already anchored in **museo**, so this lesson extends that family rather than assigning it a second owner.

Grammar Lens: the written accent

The stress falls on the first beat: **MÚ-si-ca**. Spanish writes the accent because that antepenultimate stress must always be marked. The noun is feminine: **la música**, **música clásica**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la música*
- *música clásica*
- *me gusta la música*

Before you move on

Music? (*La música.*) Classical music? (*Música clásica.*)
Source: DLE: música.

413.2 el concierto — music brought together

Recall **la música**. A scheduled event where people perform music is **el concierto**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Concierto belongs to **concertar**, to bring things into agreement, from Latin **concertāre**. Italian and French helped the musical event-sense travel, and English **concert** is a close relative. Think of performers bringing their parts together.

Grammar Lens: concert of what?

Use **de** to name the kind: **un concierto de música clásica**. The event is masculine: **el concierto**, **un concierto**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el concierto*
- *un concierto de música*
- *un concierto de música clásica*

Before you move on

Concert? (*El concierto.*)
Source: DLE: concierto.

413.3 music recall one — preference and event

Give the art and the event. (*Música, concierto.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *me gusta la música*
- *un concierto*
- *un concierto de música clásica*

Before you move on

Music, concert? (*Música, concierto.*)

413.4 music recall two — choose the Saturday-night event

Someone likes music and wants to go out on Saturday night.

Your turn

- "Jorge likes music." [YOU SAY: *A Jorge le gusta la música.*]
- "There is a classical music concert on Saturday." [YOU SAY: *Hay un concierto de música clásica el sábado.*]

Before you move on

Which event matches the Saturday-night plan? (*El concierto de música clásica.*)

Chapter 414

Sign Up at Reception

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand where and when to sign up for a class.
>
> *Retrieve sign up and reception in a simple class notice.*

414.1 apuntarse — put your name on the list

Recall **el punto**, a point or item. Spanish builds **apuntar** from that family, and **apuntarse** can mean to put your own name down: to sign up.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The base **punto** goes back to Latin **punctum**, a mark made by a prick. To **apuntar** is to note or point something; with **se**, **apuntarse** often means to add oneself to a list. The root is already anchored in **punto**, so this lesson extends that family.

Grammar Lens: who signs up?

The pronoun changes with the person: **me apunto** for "I sign up" and **apuntarse** after another verb, as in **hay que apuntarse**, "one must sign up." Use **a** for the activity: **apuntarse a una clase**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *apuntarse*
- *me apunto a la clase*
- *hay que apuntarse antes*

Before you move on

To sign up? (*Apuntarse.*) One must sign up beforehand? (*Hay que apuntarse antes.*)
Source: DLE: apuntar.

414.2 la recepción — the place that receives you

Recall **apuntarse**, to put your name on a list. At a sports centre, the list may be kept at **la recepción**, the reception desk.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **receptio** meant a receiving. Spanish **recepción** and English **reception** belong to the same family. The place receives visitors, questions and sign-up requests.

Grammar Lens: place after en

Use **en la recepción** for "at the reception desk." The written accent marks the final stress: re-cep-**CIÓN**. A useful notice says **Hay que apuntarse en la recepción**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la recepción*
- *en la recepción*
- *hay que apuntarse en la recepción*

Before you move on

Reception desk? (*La recepción.*) At reception? (*En la recepción.*)
Source: DLE: recepción.

414.3 sign-up recall one — action and place

Give the action and the place. (*Apuntarse, recepción.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *apuntarse a una clase*
- *en la recepción*
- *hay que apuntarse en la recepción*

Before you move on

Sign up, reception? (*Apuntarse, recepción.*)

414.4 sign-up recall two — read the class notice

A yoga class has limited places. The notice tells visitors what to do before class and where to do it.

Your turn

- "One must sign up beforehand." [YOU SAY: *Hay que apuntarse antes.*]
- "One must sign up at reception." [YOU SAY: *Hay que apuntarse en la recepción.*]

Before you move on

What must a visitor do before the class? (*Apuntarse en la recepción.*)

Chapter 415

A Package Abroad

Modes: **voice** (4) **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can identify a package being sent abroad in a simple post-office message.
>
> *Retrieve package and abroad in a short post-office instruction.*

415.1 el paquete — a bundle packed for travel

Recall **el impreso**, the form you fill in. At a post office, the form may travel with **el paquete**, the package or parcel.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish borrowed **paquete** through French **paquet**, a small bundle. English **packet** travelled from the same word, and **pack** is a close family clue. Picture several things packed together into one parcel.

Grammar Lens: what happens to the package?

The noun is masculine: **el paquete**, **un paquete**. Use **enviar** for the action: **enviar el paquete**, to send the package.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el paquete*

- *un paquete*
- *enviar el paquete*

Before you move on

Package? (*El paquete.*) To send the package? (*Enviar el paquete.*)
Source: DLE: paquete.

415.2 el extranjero — the world outside one's country

Recall **el paquete**. If it crosses a national border, you can send it **al extranjero**, abroad.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The family reaches back to Latin **extraneus**, "from outside." It travelled through Romance in several directions; English **strange** and **stranger** are distant relatives. Spanish **extranjero** can name a foreign person, but **el extranjero** in the frame **al extranjero** means abroad.

Grammar Lens: a + el

Spanish contracts **a** + **el** to **al**: **enviar el paquete al extranjero**. The place frame, not a person's nationality, is the useful meaning here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el extranjero*
- *al extranjero*
- *enviar el paquete al extranjero*

Before you move on

Abroad? (*Al extranjero.*)
Source: DLE: extranjero.

415.3 package recall one — parcel and destination

Give the parcel and the destination. (*Paquete, al extranjero.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el paquete*
- *al extranjero*
- *enviar el paquete al extranjero*

Before you move on

Package, abroad? (*Paquete, al extranjero.*)

415.4 package recall two — hear the post-office message

A post-office worker explains which form a customer needs for an international parcel.

Your turn

- "Send the package abroad." [YOU SAY: *Enviar el paquete al extranjero.*]
- "To send the package abroad, you need to fill in this form." [YOU SAY: *Para enviar el paquete al extranjero, necesita rellenar este impreso.*]

Before you move on

Which place does that message belong to? (*Una oficina de correos.*)

Chapter 416

Stay in May

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand the month and length of a simple hotel stay.
>
> *Retrieve stay and May in a short hotel booking exchange.*

416.1 quedarse — come to rest and stay

Recall **una habitación**, a room. A traveller who keeps that room for several nights is going to **quedarse**, to stay.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **quedar** reaches back to Latin **quietāre**, to make quiet or bring to rest. The **se** turns the action toward the person: **quedarse** is to remain or stay. Think of a traveller coming to rest in one place.

Grammar Lens: say who stays

The pronoun changes with the person: **me quedo** means "I stay," while the infinitive follows another verb in **quiero quedarme**, "I want to stay." A duration can follow directly: **quedarse tres noches**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *quedarse*

- *me quedo tres noches*
- *quiero quedarme tres noches*

Before you move on

To stay? (*Quedarse.*) I am staying three nights? (*Me quedo tres noches.*)
Source: DLE: quedar.

416.2 mayo — Maia's month

Recall the months and **quedarse**, to stay. The hotel dates in this chapter fall in **mayo**, May.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **mayo** continues Latin **Maius**, the Roman month associated with **Maia**. English **May** preserves the same name. Keep it separate from **mayor**, "bigger" or "older": their similar spelling does not make them the same word.

Grammar Lens: dates use de

Spanish links a day to its month with **de**: **el quince de mayo**, the fifteenth of May. A range uses **del ... al ...**: **del quince al dieciocho de mayo**. The month name stays lowercase.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mayo*
- *el quince de mayo*
- *quedarse tres noches en mayo*

Before you move on

May? (*Mayo.*) The fifteenth of May? (*El quince de mayo.*)
Source: DLE: mayo.

416.3 stay recall one — duration and month

Give the action and the month. (*Quedarse, mayo.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *quedarse*
- *mayo*
- *quedarse tres noches en mayo*

Before you move on

Stay, May? (*Quedarse, mayo.*)

416.4 stay recall two — hear the hotel dates

A hotel guest gives arrival and departure dates, then confirms the number of nights.

Your turn

- "I want to stay three nights." [YOU SAY: *Quiero quedarme tres noches.*]
- "From the fifteenth to the eighteenth of May." [YOU SAY: *Del quince al dieciocho de mayo.*]

Before you move on

How many nights, and in which month? (*Tres noches, en mayo.*)

Chapter 417

An Adult Swimming Course

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can understand a simple notice for an adult swimming course.
>
> *Retrieve course, swim, and adult in a short class notice.*

417.1 el curso — a path of learning

Recall **aprender**, to learn. A planned path for learning something is **un curso**, a course or class.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **cursus** meant a running or a course, from **currere**, to run. English **course** keeps the same idea of a route, while **current** is something running onward. A learning course is a route followed from lesson to lesson.

Grammar Lens: name the subject

The noun is masculine: **el curso**, **un curso**. Use **de** to name its subject: **un curso de natación**, a swimming course.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el curso*

- *un curso*
- *un curso de natación*

Before you move on

Course? (*El curso.*) A swimming course? (*Un curso de natación.*)
Source: DLE: curso.

417.2 nadar — move through the water

Recall **la piscina** and **un curso**. What might a course at a pool teach? **Nadar**, to swim.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **nadar** continues Latin **natāre**, to swim. English keeps the root in **natatorium**, a building with a swimming pool. The infinitive ends in **-ar**, like many familiar action words.

Grammar Lens: learn to swim

After **aprender**, Spanish uses **a** before another verb: **aprender a nadar**, to learn to swim. The related noun is **la natación**, swimming, as in **curso de natación**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nadar*
- *aprender a nadar*
- *un curso de natación*

Before you move on

To swim? (*Nadar.*) To learn to swim? (*Aprender a nadar.*)
Source: DLE: nadar.

417.3 adulto, adulta — fully grown

Recall **un curso** and **nadar**. If this class is for grown-ups, the notice says **para adultos**, for adults.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **adultus** meant grown up, from **adolescere**, to grow. English **adult** is the same word with its ending shortened. Spanish keeps the ending and matches gender and number: **adulto**, **adulta**, **adultos**, **adultas**.

Grammar Lens: say who it is for

Use **para** for the intended group: **un curso de natación para adultos**. The plural **adultos** can describe a mixed group or a group of men.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *adulto, adulta*
- *para adultos*
- *un curso de natación para adultos*

Before you move on

Adult? (*Adulto, adulta.*) For adults? (*Para adultos.*)
Source: DLE: adulto.

417.4 swimming recall one — course, action, learner

Give the class, the action, and the learner. (*Curso, nadar, adulto.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *un curso*
- *aprender a nadar*
- *para adultos*

Before you move on

Course, swim, adults? (*Curso, nadar, adultos.*)

417.5 swimming recall two — read the class notice

A municipal pool advertises evening lessons for grown learners.

Your turn

- "Here you can learn to swim." [YOU SAY: *Aquí puede aprender a nadar.*]
- "Swimming course for adults." [YOU SAY: *Curso de natación para adultos.*]

Before you move on

What is offered, and for whom? (*Un curso de natación para adultos.*)

Chapter 418

Writing — Four Lines That Hold Together

Modes: ✓ **pen** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can write four connected lines to a named reader about what I did yesterday, using y to add and porque to give a reason, so that a line depends on the one before it.
>
> *Complete ES-W02-cuatro-lineas-ayer: four lines to one named reader, at least one joined with y and at least one with porque, then cover line one and check line two still needs it.*

418.1 Four lines to one person — where the second needs the first

> The last writing lesson asked for lines that were **correct**. This one asks for lines that **hold together**, which is a different thing and a harder one.
>
> Pick one person who will read this. A real one. You will need them in a moment.

What to know first

Connected writing is not **longer** writing. Four short lines can be connected, and one long line can fail to be.

What makes writing connected is that a sentence stops standing on its own — line two is about line one, and a reader who skipped line one would not follow it.

Spanish gives you exactly two words for that at this point, and they do opposite jobs. **y** adds one thing to another. **porque** puts one thing *under* another and says it is the reason.

That is the whole difference between a list and a paragraph. A list can be read in any order. A paragraph cannot.

Writing — connected composition

Write **four lines** about yesterday, addressed to the person you picked. Greet them, tell them two things you did, and close.

At least one line must use **y**, and at least one must use **porque**.

A worked example, from words you already hold:

> Hola. Ayer fui a la tienda y comí pan. Hablé con mi amiga porque tuve tiempo. Hasta luego.

Now write your own four. Do not copy the example — it is there to show the **shape**, and its second and third lines are the only ones doing the work.

Before you move on

Cover your first line and read the second on its own. Does it still make sense without the first?

If it does, you wrote a **list**. That is not a failure — it is the stage you were at one lesson ago — but go back and make one line depend on another before you stop.

And read it as the person you named would. Writing for a reader you can picture is the part that makes this a real task rather than an exercise, and it is the part the exam will keep asking for at every level above this one.

Chapter 419

Dancing, and the Article You Drop

Modes: **voice** (1) **Hands-free start:** all 1 lesson.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that I like dancing, dropping the article before the infinitive that I keep before the noun.
>
> *Say both halves in one breath: me gusta la musica y me gusta bailar, and notice that la was said once and not twice.*

419.1 bailar — and the verb that needs no article

You have met *me gusta* ***la*** *música*, which keeps an article English throws away. Hold that thought — this lesson is the case where the rule switches off.

What to know first

- música — the noun this verb belongs with, and the article rule this lesson contrasts against.

Sounds you'll need

- `diphthong-ai` — **ai** is one syllable, *bai-*, close to English *bye*. → reference
- `b-soft` — the **b** is softer than an English *b*; the lips barely close.
- `r-tap` — the final **r** is a single flick of the tongue, not a growl.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bailar — "to dance." An *-ar* infinitive, the most ordinary shape a Spanish verb can have.
Root: Late Latin **ballare**, "to dance," from Greek *ballízein*. This root travelled further into English than almost any other on this page:

- a **ball** — the *dancing* kind. A ballroom is a room for *ballare*.
- **ball**et — through Italian *balletto*, "a little dance."
- **ball**ad — Provençal *balada*, originally a **song you danced to**. That is why a ballad tells a story in verses: the verses were danced.

And now the trap worth knowing, because it looks like the strongest member of the family and is not:

> A **ball** you *throw* is not related. That one is Germanic, a cousin of *balloon* and *bowl*. English has two unrelated words spelled *ball*, and only the one you dance at comes from *ballare*.

Grammar Lens: where the article rule switches off

Put the two halves of this chapter side by side:

> *Me gusta* ***la*** *música.* — I like music. **Article.** *Me gusta bailar.* — I like dancing. **No article.**

This is not an exception to memorise; it follows from what *gustar* does. It needs a subject, and an infinitive is already one — *bailar* means "to dance," a whole action named. A **noun** needs its article to be spoken of in general; a **verb** does not, because naming it is what the infinitive is for.
So: if what pleases you is a thing, it takes *el* or *la*. If what pleases you is an action, the bare infinitive is the whole answer.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "bailar" — one flick of the tongue on the final *r*

- “me gusta bailar” — I like dancing, with no article
- “me gusta la música y me gusta bailar” — both halves, and notice you said *la* once and not twice

Before you move on

Why does *me gusta la música* take *la* while *me gusta bailar* takes nothing? (A noun needs its article to mean the thing in general; an infinitive already names the action.) Which English *ball* comes from this root — the dance or the thing you throw? (The dance.)

Chapter 420

Theatre, Exhibition, Circus

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the theatre, an exhibition and the circus, and say what each word is actually named after: the audience, a putting-out, and the shape of the floor.
>
> *Propose an outing to each of the five places, choosing al or a la without stopping to think, because the -cion ending already told you which one is feminine.*

420.1 el teatro — a place for looking, and the word theory came from it

You can already name *el cine*. Say it, then say the building people went to for two thousand years before there was any such thing.

What to know first

- el cine — the other place you go to watch something, and the one whose name is barely a century old.

Sounds you'll need

- `stress-penultimate` — *te-A-tro*, stress on the second of three. → reference
- `r-tap` — the **r** is one flick of the tongue, not a growl.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el teatro — "the theatre." Latin *theatrum*, from Greek **théatron**, "a place for viewing," built on *theáomai*, "to behold."
The Greeks named the building after **what the audience does**, not after what happens on the stage. A theatre is a looking-place.
Now the payoff. That same *theá-* gives Greek *theōría* — "a viewing, a contemplation" — which arrives in English as **theory**:

- **theat**re, amphi**theat**re — the looking-place.
- **theor**y, **theor**etical — what you see when you look hard at something.

A theory and a theatre are the same idea twice: **someone standing back and watching.** Spanish keeps both, *teatro* and *teoría*, and they have never stopped being cousins.

Grammar Lens: two names, two ages

Set the two buildings beside each other:

place	named after	age of the word
el teatro	what the audience does — viewing	ancient Greek
el cine	what the machine does — writing movement	about 1900

Both are masculine and both take *el*. One is among the oldest words in this book and one is among the newest, and you learned them a chapter apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el teatro" — *te-A-tro*
- "el cine y el teatro" — both places, both masculine
- which English word for an idea comes from the same root as *teatro* (theory)

Before you move on

What did the Greeks name the theatre after — the stage, or the audience? (The audience: *théatron* is a place for viewing.) What everyday English word for an explanation shares that root? (*Theory.*)

420.2 la exposición — a putting-out

You have *el museo*. A museum holds its collection all year. Say the word for the thing a museum puts on for three months and then takes down.

What to know first

- el museo — the building. This lesson is the event inside it.

Sounds you'll need

- `accent-acute` — the accent is on the last syllable: *ex-po-si-CIÓN.* → reference
- `ci-th-s` — the **c** before **i** is the soft one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la exposición — "the exhibition." Latin *expositio*: **ex-** ("out") plus **ponere** ("to place"). An exhibition is literally **a putting-out**. *ponere* is one of the most productive verbs Latin ever handed on. Once you see it, it is everywhere:

- ex**pos**e, ex**pos**ition — placed out.
- com**pos**e — placed together. de**pos**it — placed down.
- **pos**ition, post**pone**, com**pon**ent, op**pon**ent.

Spanish has the verb itself, *poner*, "to put" — so *exposición* is transparent to a Spanish speaker in a way that *exhibition* is not to an English one.

Grammar Lens: the ending that tells you the gender

Nouns ending in **-ción** are feminine, without exception worth worrying about.

la exposición, *la habitación*, *la nación*. The ending comes from Latin *-tio*, which was feminine, and Spanish kept the gender along with the sound.
That makes **-ción** one of the few endings you can trust on sight — most noun gender has to be learned with the word, and this one does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la exposición" — accent on the last syllable
- "el museo y la exposición" — the building and the event
- which article a noun ending in *-ción* takes, and why (*la* — the ending is feminine, from Latin *-tio*)

Before you move on

What are the two Latin pieces inside *exposición*, and what do they add up to? (*ex-* "out" plus *ponere* "to place" — a putting-out.)
What gender does **-ción** guarantee? (Feminine.)

420.3 el circo — the ring, and the two c's in one word

Circo has two **c**'s and they are not the same sound. Before reading on, say the word and listen to which one is soft.

Sounds you'll need

- `ci-th-s` — the first **c**, before **i**, is soft. → reference
- `c-hard` — the second **c**, before **o**, is hard, as in *cat*.
- `stress-penultimate` — *CIR-co*.

One word, one letter, two jobs. The vowel that follows decides, every time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el circo — "the circus." Latin *circus*, "a ring," borrowed from Greek *kírkos*. The Romans' *Circus Maximus* was a ring you raced around; the tent came much later and kept the shape and the name.
The family is large and all of it is round:

- **circ**le, **circ**uit, **circ**ular, **circ**umference.
- **circ**a — "around" a date.
- Spanish *cerca* ("near") and *cercar* ("to surround") come from the same ring.

So a circus is not named for clowns or animals. It is named for **the shape of the floor**.

Grammar Lens: the rule you can see inside one word

Most words make you check the letter against the vowel that follows it. *Circo* does the checking for you, because it contains both cases:

letter	followed by	sound
cir-	i	soft
-**c**o	o	hard

Keep this word as your reference. Whenever you are unsure how a **c** should sound, say *circo* and listen to which half matches.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el circo" — soft, then hard
- "el teatro y el circo" — both masculine
- what the word is actually named after (the ring — the shape of the floor)

Before you move on

Which **c** in *circo* is soft and why? (The first — it is followed by **i**.) What does the Latin *circus* mean, and which English words keep it? (A ring: circle, circuit, circa.)

420.4 cinco lugares — five places, sorted by what their names describe

Name the five places you can now go to. Say them out loud before reading the list.

Grammar Lens: what each name is actually about

Every one of these buildings is named after something different, and once you sort them that way they stop being a list to memorise:

place	named after	the thing itself
el teatro	the audience	a looking-place
el cine	the machine	a movement-writer
el museo	the Muses	a seat of the arts
la exposición	the act	a putting-out
el circo	the floor	a ring

Two are named for **people** (the audience, the Muses), one for a **machine**, one for an **action**, and one for a **shape**. Not one of them is named for the art that happens inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the four masculine ones with *el* (teatro, cine, museo, circo)
- which of the five you would go to in order to *bailar*, and notice that none of them is the obvious answer — the verb needs no place at all
- the one feminine one with *la*, and why (*la exposición* — the **-ción** ending)
- which two are named after people (*el teatro*, *el museo*)

Before you move on

Which of the five is named after the shape of its floor? (*El circo.*) Which is named after what the audience does? (*El teatro.*) Which one is an event rather than a building? (*La exposición.*)

420.5 ¿Vamos al teatro o al circo? — the five places in a real question

A place you can name is not yet a place you can propose. Ask a friend whether they want to go to the theatre or the circus, out loud, before reading on.

Grammar Lens: al and a la, doing the gender work for you

Proposing an outing needs *a* ("to") in front of the place, and the article comes along:

> *¿Vamos* ***al*** *teatro?* — masculine, so *a + el* squeezes into **al**.
> *¿Vamos* ***a la*** *exposición?* — feminine, so the two words stay apart.

Four of your five places take **al**. Only *la exposición* takes **a la**, and you can predict which without remembering, because **-ción** told you the gender when you met the word.

Read this

Every word here is one you have met:

> —¿Vamos al cine? —No. Vamos al teatro. —¿Y el sábado? —El sábado, a la exposición del museo. Y el domingo, al circo. —¿Y después del circo? —Después, a bailar.

Four places, one short exchange, and the only thing you had to decide each time was **al** or **a la**.
The last line is the exception that proves it. *Bailar* is a verb, not a place, so it takes plain **a** and no article at all — the same reason *me gusta bailar* needed none.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Vamos al teatro?" — with the opening question mark heard as a rise from the start
- "¿Vamos a la exposición?" — two words, because the noun is feminine
- propose the circus, then the museum, in the same shape

Before you move on

Which of your five places is the only one that takes *a la*, and how did you know before you had to think about it? (*La exposición* — the **-ción** ending is feminine.) Say the other four with *al*.

Chapter 421

The Actor and the Actress

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (4) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 4 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the actor and the actress, say why the feminine is actriz rather than actora, and ask who is in a film rather than only what the film is.
>
> *Ask who is in the film and answer with a person rather than a thing, choosing the article from the person's gender and not from the word's ending.*

421.1 el actor — the one who does, which is all the word has ever meant

You can name *el teatro* and *la película*. Say both. Now say the one thing neither of them can do without, and that you have never been given a word for.

What to know first

- el teatro — the looking-place, where this person works in front of you.
- la película — the film, where this person works on a strip of plastic instead.

Sounds you'll need

- `stress-final` — *ac-TOR*, stress on the last syllable. English says *AC-tor* and Spanish says the opposite end. Moving it is the whole difference between sounding Spanish and sounding foreign here. → reference
- `r-tap` — the final **r** is one flick of the tongue, not the English curl.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el actor — "the actor." Latin **actor**, from the verb **agere**, "to drive, to do, to set in motion."
Latin built agent nouns with **-tor**: take a verb, add *-tor*, and you get *the one who does it*. The pattern is still visible in dozens of English words that were borrowed whole:

Latin verb	meaning	the one who does it
agere	to do	**actor**
docere	to teach	doctor
dirigere	to direct	director
inspicere	to look into	inspector

So *actor* is not a theatre word at all. It is **doer**, and Latin used it for anyone who acted in any sense — an agent, a driver of cattle, a man pleading a case in court. The stage borrowed a perfectly ordinary word and kept it.
Agere is still visible all over English, and it never stopped meaning "do": an **agent** is someone doing something on your behalf, an **agenda** is literally *things that must be done*, and an **action** is a doing.

Grammar Lens: the two workplaces

The same person, two places you already have words for:

where	what is watched	live?
el teatro	the actor	yes
el cine	la película	no

El actor is masculine and takes *el*. That is the easy half. The other half — what to call a woman who does the same work — is the next

lesson, and Spanish answers it with an ending that almost nothing else in the language uses.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el actor" — *ac-TOR*, stress at the end
- "el actor del teatro" — the actor from the theatre
- which English word meaning "things to be done" comes from the same Latin verb (*agenda*)

Before you move on

What did Latin *agere* mean? (To do, to drive.) So what does the *-tor* ending add? (The one who does it.) Where does the stress fall in *actor* in Spanish? (On the last syllable: *ac-TOR*.)

421.2 la actriz — the ending that did not follow the usual rule

You have *el actor*. Say it. Now guess the feminine before reading on, and expect to be wrong — the obvious guess is not what Spanish does here.

What to know first

- el actor — the doer, from *agere*, with the Latin agent-noun ending *-tor*.

Sounds you'll need

- `stress-final` — *ac-TRIZ*, stress on the last syllable, like *actor*. → reference
- `r-tap` — the **r** in *-triz* is a single tap, and it sits between two consonants, which is where it is easiest to over-roll.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la actriz — "the actress." Not *la actora*, which is what the ordinary Spanish habit of swapping **-o** for **-a** would have produced.
Latin had its own feminine for *-tor* nouns: **-trix**. *Actor* / **actrix**. Spanish inherited that pair intact, turned the Latin **-x** into **-z**, and kept it.
The ending is nearly extinct. Spanish has only a small handful of *-triz* words left, and they are worth seeing together because the list is short enough to hold in your head:

masculine	feminine	meaning
el actor	la **actriz**	the actor
el emperador	la empera**triz**	the emperor
el institutor	la institu**triz**	the governess

English kept the same Latin ending in **aviatrix** and **dominatrix**, and in the mathematical **matrix** — originally *mater* plus *-trix*, "the womb", the thing from which other things are produced.
Everywhere else in Spanish, the feminine of a person-noun is the ordinary swap: *el camarero* / *la camarera*. **-triz** is the exception, and *actriz* is the one you will meet most.

Grammar Lens: two words, one root, three endings

Everything on this row came out of one Latin verb:

word	ending	what the ending does
acto	—	the deed itself
el **act**or	-or	the man who does it
la **act**riz	-riz	the woman who does it

Strip the endings and the same three letters are left standing: **act-**.
The root does the meaning; the ending only says *who*.
Note the article changes with the person, not with the building: *el actor del teatro*, *la actriz del teatro*. The theatre stays masculine either way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la actriz" — *ac-TRIZ*, stress at the end
- "el actor y la actriz" — and hear that only the article and the ending moved
- "la actriz del teatro"
- the feminine of *emperador*, using the same ending (*emperatriz*)

Before you move on

Why is it not *la actora*? (Spanish inherited the Latin feminine *actrix* whole, rather than applying its own **-o** to **-a** swap.) Which English word for a grid of numbers carries the same ending? (*Matrix*.) Which syllable is stressed in both *actor* and *actriz*? (The last.)

421.3 la escena completa — two places, one thing, two people

Name the two people from the last two lessons, with their articles, before reading further.

Grammar Lens: places, things and people take different endings

Five words, and the gender of each is decided by a different kind of evidence:

word	article	what decides it
el teatro	el	the **-o** ending of a place-word
el cine	el	inherited with the shortened word
la película	la	the **-a** ending of a thing-word
el actor	el	the person is male
la actriz	la	the person is female

That is the useful split. For a **place** or a **thing**, the ending tells you the article and the world has no say in it. For a **person**, the world decides and the ending follows.

So *la película* is feminine for a reason that has nothing to do with

anyone being female, while *la actriz* is feminine for exactly that reason.

Read this

Read this aloud. Every word in it has appeared before:

> El actor está en el teatro. La actriz está en el cine. La película es de la actriz.

Three short sentences, five known words, no new grammar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two places with *el* (*el teatro*, *el cine*)
- the thing with *la* (*la película*)
- the two people, each with its own article (*el actor*, *la actriz*)
- which of the five is feminine because a person is female, and which is feminine only because of its ending

Before you move on

Which two of the five change their article according to who is being talked about? (*El actor* and *la actriz*.) Which three never change? (*El teatro*, *el cine*, *la película*.)

421.4 ¿Quién está en la película? — the question the two new words were for

Say *el actor* and *la actriz* once each. You are about to use both inside a question rather than on their own.

Grammar Lens: naming a person answers a different question

Two question words you already have, pointed at the same film:

question	what it asks for	answer from this chapter
¿Qué es?	a thing	*Es una película.*
¿Quién está en la película?	a person	*El actor.* / *La actriz.*

Qué wants the thing word. *Quién* wants the person word. Until this chapter you could answer only the first of the two about anything on a screen or a stage, because the corpus had named the film and never named anyone in it.

Read this

— ¿Vamos al cine? — Sí. ¿Qué película es? — Es la película de la actriz. — ¿Y el actor? — El actor está en el teatro.

Note the inverted marks opening each question, and that *de la actriz* is how Spanish says *the actress's*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Quién está en la película?" and then answer it with each of the two people in turn
- "la película del actor" and "la película de la actriz", and hear where *de + el* contracts and where it cannot
- where each of the two people is, using *el teatro* and *el cine*

Before you move on

Which question word asks for a person rather than a thing? (*Quién*.) What happens to *de el* in *la película del actor*? (It contracts to *del*.) Why does *de la actriz* not contract? (The contraction exists only for *de + el*.)

Chapter 422

The Web Page

Modes: **eyes** (3) **Hands-free start:** none of the 3 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name a web page, say why it is feminine and why web never takes a plural -s, and read the line a form prints without its article.
>
> *Read the bare noun on a printed form and say the same thing aloud with its article, which is the difference between how a reading paper and a listening paper present the identical word.*

422.1 la página web — a two-thousand-year-old word doing a thirty-year-old job

Say *internet* and *el ordenador*. You have the network and you have the machine. Say what is missing: the thing you actually look at.

What to know first

- internet — the network itself.
- el ordenador — the machine, named in Spanish for what it *orders* rather than what it counts.
- el correo electrónico — the other thing that travels over the network.

Sounds you'll need

- `stress-antepenultimate` — *PÁ-gi-na*, stress on the third syllable from the end, which is exactly what the written accent is there to tell you. → reference
- `g-soft` — the **g** in *página* comes before **i**, so it is the throaty sound, not the **g** of *gato*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la página web — "the web page." Two words from two thousand years apart, and only one of them was borrowed.
Página is Latin **pagina**, from **pangere**, "to fasten, to fix in place." A Roman *pagina* was a column of writing, named for the way vine-growers fastened shoots to a trellis: a column of text is writing **fixed into a frame**.

word	what got fastened
página	writing, into a column
pacto (a pact)	two parties, into an agreement
paz (peace)	the same, after a war

Web is English, taken whole. Spanish did not translate it.

Grammar Lens: which half carries the gender

name	article	what the second word is
el correo electrónico	**el**	an adjective, and it agrees with *correo*
la página web	**la**	a noun bolted on, and it never moves

The first word is the real noun and it decides everything. *Web* is a borrowed noun in an adjective's chair, so it never changes: *dos páginas web*, with no **-s** on *web*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la página web" — *PÁ-gi-na web*

- "la página web está en internet"
- "dos páginas web" — and stop yourself before adding an **-s** to *web*
- which Spanish word for peace comes from the same root as *página* (*paz*)

Before you move on

What did Latin *pangere* mean? (To fasten, to fix in place.) Why is *página web* feminine? (*Página* is the head noun and it ends in **-a**.) What happens to *web* in the plural? (Nothing — it stays *web*.)

422.2 cuatro palabras de internet — four words, four different ways in

Name the four things you can now talk about on a screen. Say them with their articles before reading the table.

Grammar Lens: borrowed, translated, or built

English named all four of these things first. Spanish did something different with each one, and that is the pattern worth carrying away:

Spanish	English source	what Spanish did
internet	internet	took it whole
el ordenador	computer	**refused** it and used a French word instead
el correo electrónico	e-mail	translated both halves
la página web	web page	translated one half and kept the other

Four things, four strategies, and no rule decided which. *Ordenador* is the interesting one: Spain went to French *ordinateur*, "the thing that puts in order," rather than to the Latin *computare*, "to count." A machine that orders is a different idea about what the machine is for than a machine that counts.

Read this

Read aloud. Nothing here is new:

> El ordenador está en internet. La página web está en el ordenador. El correo electrónico también.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three that take *el* (*el ordenador*, *el correo electrónico*, and the network word, which takes no article at all)
- the one that takes *la* (*la página web*)
- which of the four Spanish refused to borrow (*el ordenador*)
- "la página web y el correo electrónico"

Before you move on

Which of the four words is entirely Spanish in both halves? (*El correo electrónico.*) Which came from French rather than English? (*El ordenador.*) Which keeps an English word inside it? (*La página web.*)

422.3 ¿Cuál es la página web? — the question a form actually asks you

Say *la página web* and *el correo electrónico* one after the other. Both are things a form will ask you for.

Grammar Lens: the line on a form is the bare noun

A printed form drops the article; a person speaking puts it back:

on the form	**spoken aloud**
Correo electrónico:	¿Cuál es **el** correo electrónico?
Página web:	¿Cuál es **la** página web?

This is worth noticing because a reading paper shows you the left-hand column and a listening paper plays you the right-hand one. The same

word looks bare in one and dressed in the other.

Read this

Formulario Nombre: Correo electrónico: Página web:

Three lines, no articles, and you can now read every one of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Cuál es la página web?"
- "¿Cuál es el correo electrónico?" and hear the article change while the question word does not
- "la página web está en el ordenador"

Before you move on

Why does a form print *Página web:* without *la*? (A form label is the bare noun; the article belongs to speech.) Which article does it take when you say it aloud? (*La.*)

Chapter 423

Character, Not Mood

Modes: **voice** (7) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 6 of 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can describe what a person is like rather than how they feel today, using eight settled-character adjectives and predicting from the spelling alone which of them change ending for a woman.
>
> *Answer the question how is he or she, using es for settled character and letting only the adjectives that can agree do so.*

423.1 antipático — the opposite made by fastening four letters on the front

Say *simpático*. Now say what you would expect its opposite to look like, before reading on. This is one of the times the obvious guess is right.

What to know first

- simpático — likeable, and a false friend: it does not mean *sympathetic*.

Sounds you'll need

- `accent-acute` — *an-ti-PÁ-ti-co*: the written accent sits where the stress does, and adding *anti-* does not move it. → reference
- `t-dental` — both **t** sounds are made with the tongue on the

teeth, with no puff of air after them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

antipático — "unpleasant, disagreeable." Take *simpático* and put Greek **anti-**, "against, opposite," on the front.
The two Greek prefixes underneath are a pair, and seeing them together makes both words transparent:

prefix	**Greek meaning**	**with *-pático***
sym-	together with	feeling **with** you
anti-	against	feeling **against** you

The *-patí-* in the middle is *páthos*, "feeling, suffering" — the same piece inside English **sympathy**, **empathy** and **pathetic**.
So *simpático* and *antipático* are literally *feeling-with* and *feeling-against*. Spanish uses them for people who are pleasant and unpleasant to be around, which is a fair everyday translation of the same idea.
Anti- is doing exactly the job you already know it does in English: **anti**biotic, **anti**septic, **Anti**arctic — against life, against rot, opposite the Bear.

What you've built

Both words end in **-o** and both change ending to match the person:

	masculine	**feminine**
pleasant	simpátic**o**	simpátic**a**
unpleasant	antipátic**o**	antipátic**a**

The prefix never moves and never agrees. Only the last letter does the work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "antipático" — five syllables, stress on *PÁ*
- "simpático y antipático" one after the other
- both in the feminine (*simpática*, *antipática*)
- which Greek word for feeling is buried in the middle of both (*páthos*)

Before you move on

What does *anti-* mean? (Against.) What does the *-patí-* in the middle mean? (Feeling.) Does the written accent move when the prefix is added? (No — it stays on *PÁ*.)

423.2 inteligente — picking between things, which is all intelligence ever was

Say *alegre*. Notice it ends in **-e** and never changes for a man or a woman. The word in this lesson does the same thing.

What to know first

- alegre — cheerful, and the first **-e** adjective you met that refuses to agree.

Sounds you'll need

- `g-soft` — the **g** in *-gente* comes before **e**, so it is the throaty sound. *In-te-li-JEN-te*, not *gen* as in English. → reference
- `stress-penultimate` — stress on *JEN*, the second syllable from the end, and the word carries no written accent because that is already the default.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

inteligente — "intelligent." Latin **intellegere**, which is two pieces:

- **inter** — between
- **legere** — to gather, to pick out, and later to read

To be intelligent is to **pick between**. Not to know a great deal; to choose well among the things in front of you. The Romans named the ability after the sorting, not after the store of facts.
Legere is one of the most productive verbs Latin ever handed over, and every one of these is the same act of picking:

word	what is picked
select	chosen out (*se-* apart + *legere*)
collect	picked together
elect	picked out of a group
legible	able to be picked out by eye
lecture	a reading aloud

Spanish has them too: *seleccionar*, *colección*, *elegir*, *legible*, *lectura*.

What you've built

Two shapes of adjective, side by side:

ending	masculine	feminine
-o	antipátic**o**	antipátic**a**
-e	inteligente	inteligente

An **-o** adjective has two forms. An **-e** adjective has one. That is the whole distinction, and it saves you from ever inventing *inteligenta*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "inteligente" — *in-te-li-JEN-te*, with the throaty **g**
- "alegre e inteligente" — two **-e** adjectives, neither agreeing
- "antipático e inteligente" — and hear only the first one able to change
- which English word for choosing a leader comes from *legere* (*elect*)

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces are inside *inteligente*? (*Inter*, between, and *legere*, to pick out.) Does it change for a woman? (No — it ends in **-e**.)

423.3 trabajador — the same ending as actor, four hundred years further along

Say *trabajar*. Say *el actor*. One is a verb and one is a person, and this lesson turns the first into the second using the ending the second already showed you.

What to know first

- trabajar — to work, and a word with a violent past you have already been told about.
- el actor — the doer, built with Latin **-tor**.

Sounds you'll need

- `stress-final` — *tra-ba-ja-DOR*, stress on the last syllable, exactly as in *actor*. → reference
- `b-soft` — the **b** between vowels is soft, with the lips nearly but not quite touching.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

trabajador — "hard-working." Take *trabajar*, drop the **-ar**, add **-dor**. That ending is the Latin **-tor** from *actor*, worn down by centuries of Spanish mouths. Latin *-tor* became Spanish *-dor* between vowels, and Spanish then used it on its own verbs to build new words the Romans never had:

verb	meaning	the one who does it
trabajar	to work	trabaja**dor**
jugar	to play	juga**dor**
hablar	to speak	habla**dor**
ganar	to win	gana**dor**

Actor was borrowed from Latin whole and kept the old **-tor**. *Trabajador* was built inside Spanish and got the modern **-dor**. Same ending, two different ages, and the pair tells you which words came in through books and which grew at home.

Here is the piece that surprises people: *trabajador* is **both a noun and an adjective**. *Un trabajador* is a worker. *Es trabajador* means he

is hard-working. The word does not change; only the sentence around it does.

What you've built

A third shape of adjective, and it is not the **-o** one:

adjective	**masculine**	**feminine**
antipático	antipático	antipátic**a**
inteligente	inteligente	inteligente
trabajador	trabajador	trabajador**a**

An adjective ending in a consonant normally refuses to agree. **-dor** is one of the exceptions that does: it adds **-a** and nothing else. *Una mujer trabajadora.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "trabajador" — *tra-ba-ja-DOR*, stress at the end
- "trabajadora", the feminine
- "el actor es trabajador" — the borrowed ending and the home-grown one in a single sentence
- the person-word built from *jugar* the same way (*jugador*)

Before you move on

What did Latin **-tor** become in home-grown Spanish words? (**-dor**.)
Which of *actor* and *trabajador* came in through books? (*Actor.*)
What is the feminine of *trabajador*? (*Trabajadora.*)

423.4 serio — the opposite of cheerful, and a word about weight

Say *alegre*. This lesson gives you the other end of that same scale.

What to know first

- alegre — cheerful, the word printed on sheet music as *allegro*.

Sounds you'll need

- `stress-penultimate` — *SE-rio*: **-io** is a single syllable here, so the stress lands on *SE*. → reference
- `r-tap` — one flick, between two vowels, which is the easiest place in Spanish to get it right.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

serio — "serious, earnest." Latin **serius**, whose first meaning was **weighty, heavy**.
Every language seems to reach for weight when it wants to talk about gravity of manner, and English does it three separate times without noticing:

- a **grave** matter — Latin *gravis*, heavy
- a **weighty** decision
- a matter of some **gravity**

Spanish does the same with *serio* and *grave*. The metaphor is so worn that nobody hears it any more: a serious person is a person who is **hard to lift**.
One warning worth having. English *serious* has drifted toward meaning *bad* — *a serious accident*. Spanish *serio* stayed with the manner: a *persona seria* is earnest and reliable, not damaged. For the bad kind Spanish uses *grave*.

What you've built

Two words for mood and manner, at opposite ends and in different shapes:

ending	masculine	feminine
-e (cheerful)	alegre	alegre
-o (serious)	seri**o**	seri**a**

You now have both ends of the scale, and each one demonstrates a

different agreement rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "serio" — *SE-rio*, two syllables
- "seria", the feminine
- "alegre y serio" — the pair, one agreeing and one not
- "trabajador y serio" — two consonant-ending and **-o**-ending adjectives together

Before you move on

What did Latin *serius* first mean? (Weighty, heavy.) Does Spanish *serio* mean *grave* in the sense of a bad accident? (No — that is *grave*.) How many syllables is *serio*? (Two: *SE-rio*.)

423.5 tímido — fear, and the verb for putting it into somebody

Say *serio*. A serious person and a shy person look similar from the outside and are nothing alike inside. This lesson names the second one.

What to know first

- serio — earnest, from Latin for *weighty*.

Sounds you'll need

- `accent-acute` — *TÍ-mi-do*: the accent marks the stress on the third syllable from the end, which Spanish always writes out. → reference
- `t-dental` — tongue against the teeth, no puff of air. An English *t* here is the single clearest giveaway of an English speaker.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tímido — "shy, timid." Latin **timidus**, from the verb **timere**, "to fear."

Timere built a small family, and English took all of it:

word	**literally**
timid	inclined to fear
timorous	full of fear
intimidate	to put fear **into** someone

That last one is the useful one. *In-* means *into*. To **intimidate** somebody is to place the fear inside them — the exact fear that *tímido* names. The shy person and the bully are described with the same Latin root, from opposite ends.

Spanish keeps the whole family too: *tímido*, *temer* (to fear), *intimidar*.

A note on what the word does **not** say. *Tímido* describes how a person meets strangers, not whether they are frightened at this moment. For being afraid right now, Spanish says *tener miedo*. This is settled character, which is the whole point of the chapter.

What you've built

Three **-o** adjectives now, all agreeing the same way:

masculine	**feminine**
antipático	antipática
serio	seria
tímido	tímida

Two of the three carry a written accent, and in both cases the accent stays exactly where it was when the ending changes: *tímido* → *tímida*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "tímido" — *TÍ-mi-do*, stress on the first of three
- "tímida", and notice the accent has not moved
- "serio y tímido"
- which English verb means to put fear into someone (*intimidate*)

Before you move on

What does Latin *timere* mean? (To fear.) What does the *in-* of *intimidate* add? (Into — putting the fear into someone.) Does *tímido* mean frightened right now? (No — that is *tener miedo*.)

423.6 sociable — a companion, an ending, and the strangest word in English sport

Say *tímido*. Now say the opposite kind of person, and expect the word to look almost exactly like its English twin.

What to know first

- tímido — shy, from Latin for fear.

Sounds you'll need

- `stress-penultimate` — *so-CIA-ble*, stress on the second syllable from the end and no written accent, because that is the default. → reference
- `b-soft` — the **b** is soft, between a vowel and an **l**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sociable — "sociable, outgoing." Latin **socius**, "a companion, an ally, a sharer," plus **-able**, "able to be, inclined to."
Socius is one of those roots that turns out to be everywhere:

word	the companion in it
society	the whole body of companions
associate	to make someone a companion
social	to do with companions

And then there is the one nobody expects. English *association football* was shortened by Oxford students, who liked adding **-er** to clipped words, into **soccer** — from *assoc*. The most ordinary word in world sport has *socius* sitting inside it, meaning nothing more than *companion*.
Spanish has the family too: *la sociedad*, *social*, *el socio* — which is a

business partner or a club member, and is *socius* almost unchanged after two thousand years.

What you've built

The six character words of this chapter sort into three agreement shapes, and now you have seen all three:

shape	example	feminine
-o	tímido	tímida
-e	inteligente	inteligente
-able	sociable	sociable

-able behaves like **-e**: one form for everyone. A *hombre sociable* and a *mujer sociable*, spelled identically.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "sociable" — *so-CIA-ble*
- "tímido y sociable" — the two ends of the same trait
- "inteligente y sociable" — both invariable
- which English sport hides *socius* in its name (*soccer*)

Before you move on

What did Latin *socius* mean? (A companion or ally.) Does *sociable* change for a woman? (No — **-able** has one form.) Which everyday Spanish word for a club member is *socius* barely changed? (*El socio.*)

423.7 ocho palabras de carácter — eight words, three endings, two pairs

Name as many of the eight as you can before reading the table. Aim for six.

Grammar Lens: the ending decides whether the word can move

All eight, sorted by what their last letters allow:

word	meaning	feminine
simpático	likeable	simpática
antipático	unpleasant	antipática
serio	earnest	seria
tímido	shy	tímida
trabajador	hard-working	trabajadora
alegre	cheerful	alegre
inteligente	clever	inteligente
sociable	outgoing	sociable

Read the third column against the first. Where the two differ, the word moves for a woman; where they are identical, it does not. Five move and three do not, and you can predict which from the spelling alone: a word ending in **-o** changes, a word ending in **-e** does not, and **-dor** is the consonant ending that changes anyway.

Grammar Lens: two of them are matched opposites

Four of the eight come in pairs, which halves what there is to remember:

one end	other end	what the pair measures
simpático	antipático	how you are to be around
tímido	sociable	how you meet strangers
alegre	serio	how you carry yourself

Three scales, six words. *Inteligente* and *trabajador* stand alone.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the five that change, in their feminine forms
- the three that do not change

- each pair as an opposite — *simpático, antipático*; *tímido, sociable*; *alegre, serio*
- the two that have no partner (*inteligente*, *trabajador*)

Before you move on

Which consonant ending agrees anyway? (**-dor**, as in *trabajadora.*) Which two of the eight are not one half of a pair? (*Inteligente* and *trabajador.*)

423.8 ¿Cómo es? — the question these eight words exist to answer

Say *inteligente* and *trabajador*. Two words a reference letter cannot do without, and you have had neither until now.

Grammar Lens: es for character, está for the moment

Spanish has two verbs where English has one, and character is the clean half of the split:

verb	what it reports	example
es	settled character	*Es tímido.* — He is a shy person.
está	how someone is right now	*Está alegre.* — He is cheerful today.

All eight of these adjectives are about settled character, so all eight take **es**. That is what makes them exam adjectives rather than mood adjectives: a question asking *¿Cómo es tu hermano?* wants the lasting answer.

Alegre is the one that can honestly go either way — *es alegre* is a cheerful person, *está alegre* is a person having a good day.

Read this

Read aloud. Every word has been taught:

> — ¿Cómo es tu hermana? — Es simpática e inteligente. Es un poco tímida, pero es muy trabajadora. — ¿Y tu hermano? — No es antipático, pero es muy serio.

Two things to catch. *Y* becomes **e** before a word starting with the *i* sound — *simpática* ***e*** *inteligente* — because *y inteligente* would blur into one vowel. And every adjective describing *hermana* has taken its **-a**, while the ones that cannot change have stayed put.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Cómo es?" and answer it with three of the eight
- the same three describing a woman, changing only the ones that can change
- "es simpática e inteligente" and hear why it is not *y*
- one sentence about somebody you know, using *es* and two adjectives

Before you move on

Which of the two verbs does settled character take? (*Es.*) Why does *y* become *e* before *inteligente*? (The following word begins with the *i* sound, and the two vowels would run together.) Which of the eight can honestly take either verb? (*Alegre.*)

Chapter 424

The Marks Themselves

Modes: **voice** (8) **eyes** (2) **Hands-free start:** none of the 10 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name eight Spanish punctuation marks, say what each one does to a sentence, and write a short note that uses six of them correctly.

Write a short note that opens with a colon after the name, lists three things without a comma before the final y, carries an aside in parentheses and an address abbreviated with a slash.

424.1 el punto — the mark you have read ten thousand times and never been told about

Look at the last sentence you read. It ended in a mark. Say what that mark is called in Spanish before reading on — and notice that this book has printed it on every page without once naming it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el punto — "the full stop," or in American English, the period. Spanish gives the same mark a different name according to what follows it, and those names appear in exam instructions, so they are worth having:

what comes next	name	what it closes
another sentence, same paragraph	**punto y seguido**	a sentence
a new paragraph	**punto y aparte**	a paragraph
nothing	**punto final**	the whole text

The mark on the page is identical in all three. What changes is the size of the thing being finished — a sentence, a block, or a text. *Seguido* means "continued," *aparte* means "separate," and *final* means what it looks like.

Grammar Lens: spacing, and the one place the mark is left off

Two mechanical habits that a written paper is marked on:

	correct	wrong
spacing	`Hola. Adiós.`	`Hola .Adiós.`
after a title	`Mi familia`	`Mi familia.`

No space before the point, one space after it. And a **title or a heading takes no point at all** — which is why every heading in this book ends bare.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el punto"
- which of the three names a point gets when a new paragraph follows (*punto y aparte*)
- whether the title of your exam answer should end in a point (no)

Before you move on

What is the difference on the page between *punto y seguido* and *punto y aparte*? (Nothing — the mark is the same; what follows it differs.) Where does the space go? (After the point, not before.)

424.2 la coma — where Spanish and English disagree about lists

Say *el punto*. This mark is its smaller relative: it divides without finishing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la coma — "the comma." From Greek *kómma*, "a piece cut off," which is what a comma does to a sentence.
In a list, the items are divided by commas — and **in front of the final *y*, Spanish writes no comma**:

> Tengo un hermano, una hermana **y** un perro.

English allows *a brother, a sister, and a dog.* Spanish does not put a comma there. This is one of the few orthographic points where a habit carried from English is visible to a marker.

Grammar Lens: when y becomes e, and o becomes u

The joining word itself changes shape to avoid two identical vowel sounds colliding:

written	becomes	before a word starting with
y	**e**	*i-* or *hi-*
o	**u**	*o-* or *ho-*

- padres **e** hijos — parents and children
- siete **u** ocho — seven or eight

You met this already without being told its name: *simpática* ***e*** *inteligente* in the character chapter changed for exactly this reason.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la coma"

- a list of three things, and stop yourself before putting a comma in front of the *y*
- "padres e hijos", and why it is not *y hijos*
- "siete u ocho", and why it is not *o ocho*

Before you move on

Does Spanish put a comma before the final *y* of a list? (No.) What does *y* become before *hijos*? (*E.*) What does *o* become before *ocho*? (*U.*)

424.3 los dos puntos — a plural name, and the mark that opens a letter

Say *la coma*. The next mark also introduces a list — but it stands in front of the list rather than inside it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

los dos puntos — "the colon." Spanish names it for what it looks like: **two points**, and the name is plural, so it takes *los* and a plural verb. Its main job is to **announce** what follows:

> Tengo tres colores favoritos: rojo, azul y verde.

The colon promises a list; the commas then divide it; and there is still no comma before the final *y*.

Grammar Lens: the letter opening, where English disagrees

This is the exam-relevant half, because a written paper often asks for a note or a message:

language	opening
Spanish	Querido Juan**:**
English	Dear John**,**

Spanish puts **dos puntos** after the greeting of a letter, an email or a note. English puts a comma. A Spanish reader notices the comma immediately, the way an English reader notices a colon.

After it, the text begins on the next line, and it begins with a **capital**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "los dos puntos", with *los*, because the name is plural
- a sentence that announces a list of three things and then gives it
- how you would open a note to a friend called Ana (*Querida Ana:*)

Before you move on

Why is the name plural? (There are two points in the mark.) What goes after *Querido Juan* in Spanish? (A colon, where English uses a comma.)

424.4 la raya — you have been reading this mark for chapters

Every printed conversation you have read in this book opened its lines with a long horizontal mark. Name what it was doing there, before reading on.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la raya — "the dash." A *raya* is a line or a stripe, and it is longer than the hyphen, which is a different mark with a different job.
In printed Spanish dialogue, a **raya opens each turn of speech**, and nobody is named:

— ¿Cómo estás? — Bien, gracias. ¿Y tú? — Muy bien.

Three turns, two speakers, no *he said* and no quotation marks. The reader tracks who is talking by alternation alone.

Grammar Lens: what replaces the quotation marks

Set the two traditions side by side, because a reading paper prints the Spanish one and an English-trained eye looks for the wrong thing:

	English	**Spanish**
opens a turn	"Hello,"	— Hola.
names the speaker	he said	often nobody
new speaker	new paragraph	new paragraph

An English reader hunting for quotation marks in a Spanish story finds none and concludes there is no dialogue. There is; it is marked with **la raya**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la raya"
- how a reader knows who is speaking when nobody is named (the turns alternate)
- what an English reader is looking for that will not be there (quotation marks)

Before you move on

What opens a turn of speech in printed Spanish? (*La raya.*) How many speakers are named in a typical exchange? (Often none.)

424.5 las comillas — three shapes, and the preferred one points outward

The last lesson said a Spanish dialogue carries no quotation marks. So Spanish does have them — they are for something else. This lesson says what.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

las comillas — "quotation marks." Plural, like *los dos puntos*, because they come as a pair.

Spanish uses three shapes and puts them in an order of preference:

shape	name	when
« »	comillas latinas, or angulares	preferred in printed Spanish
“ ”	comillas inglesas	inside a quotation already in « »
‘ ’	comillas simples	inside that again

The outermost pair is the angular one. Nesting works from the outside in, so the English-looking pair appears **inside** the Spanish-looking one, rather than first.

Grammar Lens: what they are actually for

Since **la raya** already handles dialogue, the marks are free for other work, and the one an A1 paper shows is the **foreign word**:

> El camarero trajo un «sandwich».

A word borrowed and not yet naturalised is set apart from the sentence around it. Spanish also uses them for a title inside a text, and for a word being talked about rather than used.
The name is a diminutive of **coma**: a *comilla* is a small comma, which is what the mark once looked like.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “las comillas”, plural, with *las*
- which shape a printed Spanish text reaches for first (« »)
- what the name is a small version of (*coma*)

Before you move on

Which pair does printed Spanish prefer? (The angular « ».) Why are they not needed for dialogue? (*La raya* marks the turns instead.)

424.6 los paréntesis — a putting-in-beside

Say *las comillas.* The next mark also sets something apart from the sentence — but what it sets apart is an aside rather than a quotation.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

los paréntesis — "the parentheses," the curved pair.
The word is Greek and it describes the job precisely: **para-** beside, **en-** in, **thesis** a putting. A *parénthesis* is *a putting-in-beside* — a remark placed next to the sentence rather than inside its grammar.

> Mi hermana (la mayor) vive en Madrid.

Remove what is between them and the sentence still stands: *Mi hermana vive en Madrid.* That is the test for whether the mark is the right one.

Grammar Lens: spacing, and where the point goes

	correct	**wrong**
spacing	`casa (grande) blanca`	`casa ( grande ) blanca`
with a point	`... en Madrid.`	`... en Madrid).` inside

No space on the inside of either curve. And when a parenthesis closes at the end of a sentence, the point goes **outside** it — the aside finishes first, then the sentence does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "los paréntesis"
- what the three Greek pieces mean (beside, in, a putting)
- the test for whether an aside belongs in them (remove it, and see whether the sentence still stands)

Before you move on

What does the Greek word literally describe? (A putting-in-beside.) Where does the full stop go at the end of a sentence that closes with a parenthesis? (Outside it.)

424.7 el guion — the short one, and why it is not la raya

Say *la raya*. This lesson gives you a mark that looks like a small version of it and does something completely different.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el guion — "the hyphen."
The two marks are easy to confuse on a page and easy to keep apart once you know what each is for:

mark	length	job
la raya	long	opens a turn of speech
el guion	short	**joins** two words into one

Its everyday A1 use is in names:

- **Ana-María** — a compound forename
- **Sánchez-Pérez** — a compound surname, often a married name or a double family name

A form asking for *apellidos* may come back with a hyphen in it, and the hyphen is telling you the two halves are one name rather than two.

Grammar Lens: the word changed its own spelling

This one is a small piece of history you will see both ways in print:

spelling	status
guión	the older form, with a written accent
guion	the current recommendation

The Academy reclassified *guion* as a one-syllable word in 2010, and a one-syllable word carries no written accent. Older books print *guión* and are not wrong for their date. Both will appear in front of you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el guion"
- the difference between what *la raya* does and what *el guion* does
- a compound surname with a hyphen in it

Before you move on

Which of the two marks opens a line of dialogue? (*La raya*, the long one.) Why does the current spelling *guion* carry no accent? (It is counted as one syllable.)

424.8 la barra — a choice, a street, and a speed limit

Say *el guion*, the mark that joins. This one separates — and what it separates are usually alternatives.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la barra — "the slash." A *barra* is a bar or a rod, named for its shape. Three jobs, all of which turn up on an A1 reading paper:

use	example	reading
alternatives	y/o	and, or both
abbreviation	c/ Mayor	*calle* Mayor
per	km/h	kilometres per hour

The middle one is the useful surprise: **c/** on a Spanish address is *calle*, the street. An envelope, a form or a shop sign will print it that way, and it is unreadable if nobody has told you.

Grammar Lens: the mark that means "per"

In a measurement, *la barra* is read aloud as **por**:

50 km/h — *cincuenta kilómetros por hora*

It is not silent and it is not spelled out. A listening paper that reads a speed limit aloud gives you *por* where the page shows a slash.
No spaces around it in any of these uses.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la barra"
- what **c/** stands for on an address (*calle*)
- "50 km/h" the way it is read aloud

Before you move on

What does **c/** abbreviate? (*Calle.*) What word replaces the slash when a measurement is read aloud? (*Por.*)

424.9 ocho signos — sorted by what each one does to a sentence

Name as many of the eight marks as you can, in Spanish, before reading the table. Aim for five.

Grammar Lens: divide, join, or set apart

Eight marks, and every one of them is doing one of three jobs:

mark	name	job
.	el punto	divides — a sentence, a paragraph, a text
,	la coma	divides — inside a sentence
:	los dos puntos	divides — and announces what follows
—	la raya	sets apart — a turn of speech
« »	las comillas	sets apart — a quoted or foreign word
( )	los paréntesis	sets apart — an aside
-	el guion	**joins** — two words into one name
/	la barra	divides — alternatives, or *per*

Seven divide or set apart. **El guion** is the only one of the eight that joins, which is the cleanest way to keep it from being confused with the mark it most resembles.

Grammar Lens: the three with plural names

name	why plural
los dos puntos	two points in the mark
las comillas	they come as a pair
los paréntesis	so do these

Each of the three is one mark to an English speaker and a plural noun in Spanish, so each takes *los* or *las* and a plural verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three with plural names, with their articles
- the one that joins rather than divides (*el guion*)
- the one that opens a line of dialogue (*la raya*)

- the one Spanish leaves out in front of the final *y* of a list (*la coma*)

Before you move on

Which of the eight joins? (*El guion.*) Which two are both horizontal lines with different lengths and different jobs? (*La raya* and *el guion.*) Which one is read aloud as *por*? (*La barra.*)

424.10 una nota con todos los signos — the marks doing their jobs at once

Say how a Spanish note opens after the name, and say whether a list of three takes a comma before its *y*.

Read this

Read this note and count the marks. Every word in it has been taught:

> Querida Ana:
>
> Mañana voy al teatro con mi hermana (la mayor). Vamos a ver una película, una exposición y un concierto. Mi dirección es c/ Mayor, 5.
>
> Un abrazo, Marta

Six of the eight marks are at work: the colon after the name, commas inside the list with none before the *y*, a parenthesis around the aside, a slash in the address, and points closing the sentences.

Read this

And the two the note had no use for, doing their own jobs:

> — ¿Vamos al cine? — Sí. Traigo un «sandwich».

The first line opens with **la raya** because it is a turn of speech. The borrowed word sits inside **las comillas** because it is not naturalised.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the mark that opens the note after *Querida Ana*
- the list of three from the note, and stop before the *y* without putting a comma there
- what **c/** is short for
- which mark would open the note if it were a line of dialogue instead
- what a hyphen in *Sánchez-Pérez* is telling you (that the two halves are one name)

Before you move on

Where does the point go when a sentence ends with a parenthesis? (Outside it.) Which mark marks the foreign word, and which marks the turn of speech? (*Las comillas* and *la raya*.)

Chapter 425

The Letters Themselves

Modes: **voice** (6) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name every letter of the Spanish alphabet, spell a name aloud over a telephone, tell b from v when somebody asks, and say where a word may and may not be broken.
>
> *Spell a surname aloud letter by letter, say that a vowel carries its accent, and settle the b-or-v question the way a Spanish speaker does.*

425.1 el abecedario — twenty-seven letters, and one that English does not have

The last chapter gave you the marks that go between the letters. This chapter is about the letters themselves — which you have been reading for four hundred chapters and have never been asked to name.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el abecedario — "the alphabet."
Look at the name: **a-be-ce-de**. It is the first four letters, read aloud and glued together. Spanish also says **el alfabeto**, from the Greek *alpha* and *beta* doing the identical trick in another language.
The Spanish alphabet has **twenty-seven** letters: the twenty-six of English, plus **ñ**.

Grammar Lens: the letters, and what each is called

Knowing the shapes is not enough. To spell a name over a telephone you need the **names**, and most of them are not what an English speaker would guess:

The names are not a list to memorise. A letter is named by **putting a vowel beside its sound**, and there are only three patterns.

The five vowels are called by their own sound, and that is the whole rule for them: *a, e, i, o, u*.

Most consonants take an -e after:

letter	**name**
b, c, d	be, ce, de
g, p, t	ge, pe, te
v, y	uve, ye

Five take an e- before instead:

letter	**name**
f, l	efe, ele
m, n	eme, ene
s	ese

And the leftovers have names of their own, which are the ones to learn deliberately:

letter	**name**
h	hache
j	jota
k	ka
q	cu
r	erre
w	uve doble
x	equis
z	zeta
ñ	eñe

Nine irregular names out of twenty-seven letters is a small thing to carry.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el abecedario”, and hear the four letters inside the word

- how many letters Spanish has (twenty-seven)
- the one Spanish has and English does not (*eñe*)
- the names of the letters in your own first name

Before you move on

Where does the word *abecedario* come from? (The first four letters said aloud.) What is **h** called? (*Hache.*) What is **j** called? (*Jota.*)

425.2 be larga o be corta — the letters that needed a second name

Say the names of **b** and **v**. Now say the two letters out loud as sounds, and notice the problem you have created.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

In Spanish, **b** and **v** are pronounced **identically**. There is no *v* sound in the language at all.
That is fine while you are speaking and a catastrophe while you are spelling. So Spanish grew extra names whose whole job is to tell the two apart:

letter	plain name	the disambiguating names
b	be	**be larga**, be alta, be grande
v	uve	**ve corta**, ve baja, ve chica

Larga and *alta* describe the tall stem of **b**; *corta* and *baja* describe the short **v**. A Spanish speaker dictating an address will reach for these without thinking, and a listening paper will play them.

Grammar Lens: the other letters with two names

letter	names
w	uve doble, doble ve, doble u
y	ye, i griega
z	zeta, ceta

Y is the interesting one. *I griega* means "Greek i" — the letter arrived from Greek *upsilon* and Spanish named it after where it came from, while calling the ordinary **i** *i latina* when it needs the contrast. The Academy now recommends **ye**, and both are in use.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *be larga* and *ve corta*, and say which letter each one is
- why Spanish needed the second names at all
- the two names for **y**
- what *i griega* literally means, and why

Before you move on

Do **b** and **v** sound different in Spanish? (No — they are identical.) So what are *be larga* and *ve corta* for? (Telling the two apart when spelling aloud.) What does *i griega* mean? (Greek i.)

425.3 las cinco vocales — five letters, five sounds, and no exceptions

Name the five vowels in Spanish. You have been saying them since the first chapter without being told they were a closed set.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

las cinco vocales — "the five vowels": **a, e, i, o, u**.
Vocal is from Latin *vox*, "voice" — a vowel is the part of a word you can actually sing. The same root gives *voz*, *vocabulario* and English

vocal.
Here is the part that makes Spanish kind to a reader: **each of the five has one sound, and it keeps it.** English *a* is different in *cat*, *car*, *cake* and *about*. Spanish *a* is the same in every word that has ever been written.

Grammar Lens: the two marks a vowel can carry

Only vowels take marks in Spanish, and there are exactly two:

mark	name	what it does
á é í ó ú	la tilde, el acento	marks which syllable is stressed
ü	la diéresis	makes a silent **u** speak

La tilde never changes the sound of the vowel — it only says *stress this one*. That is why it can tell two identical words apart: *el* is *the*, *él* is *he*; *si* is *if*, *sí* is *yes*.
La diéresis appears on **ü** and nowhere else. In *guerra* the **u** is silent; in *pingüino* the two dots say *pronounce me*. Two dots, one job.
Note the vocabulary trap: Spanish *tilde* means the **accent mark**. The squiggle over **ñ** is *la virgulilla*, and English calls that one the tilde. The two languages use the word for different marks.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the five vowels in order
- the difference between *el* and *él*, and what the mark is doing
- *pingüino*, and say what the two dots are for
- how many sounds Spanish **a** has (one)

Before you move on

What does *la tilde* do to the sound of a vowel? (Nothing — it marks stress.) Which letter carries *la diéresis*? (Only **ü**.) In Spanish, is *tilde* the mark on **ñ**? (No — that is *la virgulilla*.)

425.4 los dígrafos — two letters, one sound, and a change made in 1994

Say *chico*, *llave* and *perro*. Each of those has two identical or paired letters doing a single job. Name how many sounds the doubled part makes.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

un dígrafo — "a digraph": **two letters that spell one sound.** Greek *di-* two + *graphē* writing. Spanish has five:

digraph	example	one sound
ch	chico	as in English *church*
ll	llave	a *y* sound for most speakers
rr	perro	the long rolled r
gu	guerra	a hard **g**, with the **u** silent
qu	queso	a **k**, with the **u** silent

The last two are the ones that catch a reader out. In *guerra* and *queso* the **u** is **not pronounced**. It is there to keep the **g** and **c** hard in front of **e** and **i** — which is exactly why *pingüino* needs the two dots to cancel the silence.

Grammar Lens: the 1994 change, and why a dictionary moved

Ch and **ll** used to be letters of the alphabet in their own right, with their own names (*che*, *elle*) and their own sections in a dictionary. *Chico* came after every word beginning with **c**, not inside them. In 1994 they stopped being separate letters. A dictionary printed before then and one printed after put the same word in a different place:

word	before 1994	after
chico	its own **ch** section	under **c**
llave	its own **ll** section	under **l**

They are still digraphs and still spell one sound. What changed is only how they are **filed**. If you use an older Spanish dictionary and cannot find a word, this is usually why.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the five digraphs
- *guerra* and *queso*, and say what the **u** is doing in each (nothing audible — it keeps the first letter hard)
- where you would look up *chico* in a dictionary printed today
- why *pingüino* needs the two dots

Before you move on

How many sounds does a digraph spell? (One.) Is the **u** of *queso* pronounced? (No.) What happened to **ch** and **ll** in 1994? (They stopped being separate letters of the alphabet and are filed under **c** and **l**.)

425.5 la sílaba — what you may break, and what you may not

Say *chico* slowly, in pieces. Say where you would break it if the line ran out — and note that the answer cannot be between the **c** and the **h**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la sílaba — "the syllable." Greek *syllabḗ*, "a taking together" — letters taken together into one beat.
When a word will not fit at the end of a line, Spanish breaks it **between syllables** and marks the break with *el guion*. What matters for a written paper is which groups may **never** be split:

never split	**because**
ch, ll, rr, gu, qu	each is one sound
a consonant + l or r	*bl, br, cl, cr, pl, pr, tr…* hold together
a diphthong	two vowels in one beat stay in it

So *chi-co*, never *c-hico*. *Ha-blar*, never *hab-lar*. *Pe-rro*, never *per-ro*.

Grammar Lens: words Spanish spells two ways

A small set of words has two accepted spellings, and an exam will not mark either wrong:

both accepted	
sicología	psicología
setiembre	septiembre
quiosco	kiosco

The pattern is a **simplified** form beside the older one that keeps a consonant cluster the language stopped pronouncing. Spanish spelling follows the mouth more closely than English does, so when a cluster goes quiet the spelling is eventually allowed to follow.
One last rule a form actually tests: **a number written in figures is never split across a line.** *2026* stays whole.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- where *hablar* may be broken (*ha-blar*)
- why *chico* cannot be broken between **c** and **h**
- two accepted spellings of the word for September
- whether a year in figures may be split (no)

Before you move on

What does Greek *syllabḗ* mean? (A taking together.) May *br* be split? (No.) Is *sicología* a spelling mistake? (No — both spellings are accepted.)

425.6 veintisiete letras — the whole set, sorted three ways

Say how many letters Spanish has, and name the one English lacks.

Grammar Lens: what you now know about each group

group	the useful fact
the five vowels	one sound each, and it never varies
most consonants	named by adding **-e**, or **e-** in front
nine consonants	have names of their own to learn
five digraphs	two letters, one sound

And the marks, which only vowels take:

mark	on	job
la tilde	any vowel	marks the stressed syllable
la diéresis	only **ü**	makes a silent **u** speak

Grammar Lens: the three things that stop a line break

A break may fall between syllables but never inside:

- a **digraph** — *chi-co*, not *c-hico*
- a consonant plus **l** or **r** — *ha-blar*, not *hab-lar*
- a **diphthong**, or a number in figures

Those three cover nearly everything a written paper can test, and all three come from one idea: **do not break what is said in one beat.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the nine letters with names of their own
- the five digraphs
- the two names for **b** and the two for **v**, and why they exist
- three places a line may not be broken

Before you move on

Why does Spanish need *be larga* and *ve corta*? (**B** and **v** sound identical.) How many sounds does a digraph spell? (One.) What single idea governs where a line may break? (Do not break what is said in one beat.)

425.7 ¿Cómo se escribe? — the task the letter names are for

Somebody on a telephone asks how your surname is written. Spell it aloud in Spanish before reading on.

Grammar Lens: the question, and what it is not

question	what it asks for
¿Cómo se escribe?	how it is **written** — spell it
¿Cómo se dice?	how it is **said** — the word itself

A form-filling exchange uses the first. An exam's listening paper uses it to dictate a name at you letter by letter, which is the one situation where knowing *hache* and *jota* and *equis* is the difference between hearing a name and writing it.

Read this

Read this exchange aloud:

> — ¿Cómo se escribe su apellido? — Vázquez. Uve, a con tilde, zeta, cu, u, e, zeta. — ¿Uve o be? — Uve. Ve corta.

The last two turns are the reason the second names exist. The listener could not tell **b** from **v** by ear, asked, and got an answer that settles it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿Cómo se escribe?"
- your own first name, letter by letter, in Spanish

- how you would say that a letter carries a written accent (*con tilde*)
- how you would settle it if somebody could not tell your **b** from a **v**
- where your surname would break if it ran off the end of a line, and name one group inside it that may not be split

Before you move on

Which question asks for a spelling rather than a word? (*¿Cómo se escribe?*) How do you say that a vowel carries its accent mark? (*Con tilde.*)

Chapter 426

Capitals, Short Forms And Symbols

Modes: **voice** (5) **eyes** (3) **Hands-free start:** first 3 of 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can keep days, months, languages and nationalities lower-case the way Spanish does, tell an abbreviation from an initialism from a symbol by whether it takes a point, and read a filled-in form line by line.

Read a completed personal-details form, saying each short form aloud in full and explaining why each lower-case word is lower-case.

426.1 las mayúsculas — and the four things Spanish refuses to capitalise

Write today's day and month in English. Now write them in Spanish, and read on to find out what you almost certainly got wrong.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la mayúscula — "the capital letter." **La minúscula** is the small one. Latin *maiusculus*, "somewhat larger," and *minusculus*, "somewhat smaller" — the two names describe nothing but size.
Spanish capitalises where you expect: the first word of a sentence, and proper names — people, cities, countries, rivers.

Grammar Lens: the four that English capitalises and Spanish does not

This is the highest-value fact in the chapter, because an English-trained hand gets all four wrong and the marker sees every one:

	English	Spanish
days	Monday	**lunes**
months	January	**enero**
languages	Spanish	**español**
nationalities	I am Spanish	soy **español**

Add religions and titles: *católico*, and *el rey*, *el presidente*, *doctor* — all lower-case in running text.

The idea underneath is consistent. Spanish capitalises a **name**, not a **category**. *España* is a name; *español* is a description of a kind of person, and a description is an ordinary adjective.

Grammar Lens: the title of a book or a film

English	*One Hundred Years of Solitude*
Spanish	*Cien años de soledad*

Only the first word takes a capital. English capitalises most words in a title; Spanish treats a title as an ordinary sentence with a capital at the front.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- today's day and month in Spanish, both lower-case
- "soy español" and hear that the nationality is not capitalised
- the single rule underneath all four (a name is capitalised, a category is not)
- how many words of a Spanish book title take a capital (one)

Before you move on

Does Spanish capitalise *lunes*? (No.) Does it capitalise *España*? (Yes.) What is the difference? (A name takes a capital; a category does not.)

426.2 la minúscula inicial — the capital that depends on what stands beside it

Say the principle from the last lesson: a name takes a capital, a category does not. This lesson gives you a case where the same word takes a capital in one sentence and not in another.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Many Spanish surnames contain a small word: **de**, **del**, **la**, **las**. Whether it is capitalised depends on **what stands in front of it**:

written	**form**
with the first name	Pedro **de** la Cruz
without it	el señor **De** la Cruz

With the forename present, the small word is lower-case. Standing alone at the head of the name, it takes the capital.

Grammar Lens: why the rule has that shape

It is not arbitrary. **De** originally meant *from* — *Pedro de la Cruz* was Pedro **from** the Cross, a description of where he came from rather than a name. A description does not take a capital, which is the rule from the last lesson exactly.
Once the forename is gone, *De la Cruz* has become the whole name, and a name takes a capital.
This appears on forms. A field asking for *apellidos* alone is the second row; a field with *nombre y apellidos* together is the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "Pedro de la Cruz", and say which word is lower-case

- the same surname without the forename, and say what changed
- what *de* originally meant, and why that explains the rule

Before you move on

Is it *Pedro De la Cruz* or *Pedro de la Cruz*? (Lower-case *de*, because the forename is there.) And with no forename? (*De la Cruz*, capital.)

426.3 las abreviaturas — the short forms a letter opens with

You know that **c/** on an address is *calle*. Say it. That slash was your first abbreviation; this lesson gives you the rest of the set.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

una abreviatura — "an abbreviation": a word written short, and **always closed with a point**.
The forms of address are the ones an A1 paper prints:

short	**full**	
Sr.	señor	Mr
Sra.	señora	Mrs
Srta.	señorita	Miss
D.	don	a courtesy title before a first name
Dña.	doña	its feminine
Dr.	doctor	

The point is not decoration. **Sr** without it is an error, because the point is what marks the word as shortened.

Grammar Lens: don and señor are not the same word

The distinction is one an English speaker has no equivalent for:

	goes before	**example**
señor	the **surname**	el Sr. García
don	the **first name**	D. Pedro

Don Pedro is respectful and warm; *Señor García* is respectful and

formal. Putting them the wrong way round — *don García* — sounds wrong to a Spanish ear in the way *Mr. Peter* does to an English one. Two more an address prints, both of which you can now read: **c/** for *calle* and **n.º** for *número*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the abbreviations for *señor*, *señora* and *señorita*
- what must never be left off the end of an abbreviation (the point)
- which of *don* and *señor* goes with a first name
- what **c/** and **n.º** stand for

Before you move on

What closes every abbreviation? (A point.) Which goes before a first name, *don* or *señor*? (*Don.*) What is *Dña.* short for? (*Doña.*)

426.4 las letras voladitas — the little letters that sit above the line

Say the abbreviation for *señora*. Now say what you would write for *señorita* if you wanted the raised form, and read on.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

las letras voladitas — "the flown letters," raised above the line. Spanish uses exactly two of them, º and ª, and which one you use is decided by gender.

Their commonest job is the **ordinal indicator**:

written	**read**
1.º	primero
1.ª	primera
2.º	segundo
n.º	número

English writes *1st* and *2nd*, changing the ending with the number.

Spanish writes the same raised letter every time and changes it only for **gender**: º for a masculine word, ª for a feminine one.

Grammar Lens: the point goes before the raised letter

correct	wrong
1.º	1º
Sr.ª	Srª

The Academy's recommendation puts the **point first and the raised letter after**, because the point is the abbreviation mark and the raised letter is the ending. You will see the pointless form printed everywhere; the one with the point is the one to write.
A warning about the shape. º is a raised letter **o**, not a degree sign, even though the two look nearly identical. A temperature uses the degree sign; an ordinal uses the letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- 1.º and 1.ª, and say what decides between them
- where the point goes relative to the raised letter
- what **n.º** stands for
- the difference between the raised º and a degree sign

Before you move on

What decides between º and ª? (The gender of the word.) Does the point come before or after the raised letter? (Before.) Is º a degree sign? (No — it is a raised letter o.)

426.5 las siglas — no points, and a plural made by doubling

Say the rule you learned for abbreviations: every one ends in a point. This lesson gives you a kind of short form where that rule is reversed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

una sigla — a set of initials standing for a name. *ONU*, *DNI*, *RENFE*. Unlike an abbreviation, **a sigla takes no points at all**:

correct	**wrong**
DNI	D.N.I.
ONU	O.N.U.

The two you will actually meet on a form are **DNI** — *Documento Nacional de Identidad*, the Spanish identity card — and **UE**, the European Union.

Grammar Lens: the plural, which is the strange part

A sigla does **not** take an **-s** in writing. It is made plural by **doubling its letters**, with a space in the middle:

singular	**plural**	**meaning**
EU	**EE. UU.**	the United States
CC	**CC. OO.**	a trade union confederation

EE. UU. is *Estados Unidos* — two words, so two doubled letters. Said aloud it is the full name; the doubling exists only on the page.

One more distinction the names record. A **sigla** is spelled out letter by letter (*DNI* is *de-ene-i*). An **acrónimo** is said as a word (*RENFE*, *ONU*). Which one a set of initials becomes depends on nothing but whether the result is pronounceable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **DNI**, spelled out with the letter names you learned
- whether a sigla takes points (no)
- how *Estados Unidos* is written short (*EE. UU.*)
- the difference between a *sigla* and an *acrónimo*

Before you move on

Does a sigla end in a point? (No — an abbreviation does, a sigla does not.) How is a sigla made plural in writing? (By doubling its letters.) What does **DNI** stand for? (*Documento Nacional de Identidad.*)

426.6 los símbolos — the third kind of short form, and the one with no point

An abbreviation ends in a point and a sigla does not. Say both rules. This lesson adds a third kind, and it sides with the sigla.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

un símbolo — a fixed sign for a unit, a currency or a direction. It is **international, unchanging, and takes no point**.

symbol	meaning
€	the euro
km	kilometre
kg	kilogram
h	hour

km is never *km.* and never *kms.* A symbol has no plural and no point, because it is not a shortened Spanish word — it is the same sign in every language.

You have already read one in use: **km/h**, which you learned to say aloud as *kilómetros por hora.*

Grammar Lens: the compass, and where the euro goes

The four points of the compass have symbols that match their Spanish names, and one does not match the English:

symbol	Spanish	English
N	norte	north
S	sur	south
E	este	east
O	**oeste**	west (**W**)

A Spanish map prints **O** where an English map prints **W**. On a

reading paper that is a trap worth having seen once.
And the currency: Spanish writes the amount first and the symbol after, with a space — **20 €**, not *€20*. English does the reverse.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- whether a symbol takes a point (no)
- the four compass letters in Spanish, and the one that differs from English
- "20 €" the way Spanish writes it, and say what English would do instead
- the plural of *km* (there is none)

Before you move on

Which of the three short forms takes a point — abbreviation, sigla or symbol? (Only the abbreviation.) Which compass letter differs between Spanish and English? (**O** for *oeste*, where English writes **W**.) Where does the euro sign go? (After the amount.)

426.7 tres formas cortas — and the point tells you which is which

Name the three kinds of short form before reading on, and say which one takes a point.

Grammar Lens: one test separates all three

kind	example	point?
abreviatura	Sr., Dña., n.º	**yes**
sigla	DNI, ONU, UE	no
símbolo	€, km, N	no

The reason is worth more than the table. An **abreviatura** is a Spanish word cut short, and the point marks the cut. A **sigla** is not a

cut word but a set of initials. A **símbolo** is not Spanish at all — it is an international sign that happens to appear in a Spanish sentence. Only something that was cut needs a mark showing where.

Grammar Lens: the capitals, gathered

lower-case in Spanish	capitalised
lunes, enero	España, Madrid
español, católico	Pedro, García
el rey, el doctor	De la Cruz, with no forename

One idea covers the whole left column: **a category is not a name.** Days, months, languages, nationalities, religions and titles all describe a kind of thing rather than naming a particular one.
And the raised letters: º for a masculine word, ª for a feminine one, with the point **before** — 1.º, 1.ª, Sr.ª.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three kinds of short form, and which takes a point
- four things Spanish leaves lower-case that English capitalises
- why an abbreviation needs a point and a symbol does not
- 1.ª, and say what the raised letter is agreeing with

Before you move on

Which of the three takes a point, and why? (The abbreviation — the point marks where the word was cut.) What single idea keeps *lunes* and *español* lower-case? (They are categories, not names.)

426.8 un formulario completo — where all of it actually turns up

Say what **DNI** stands for, and say whether it takes points.

Read this

Read this form. Every short form in it has been taught:

> **Datos personales** Nombre y apellidos: Pedro de la Cruz DNI: 12345678-A Dirección: c/ Mayor, n.º 5, 1.º Teléfono: 600 123 456 Correo electrónico: Nacionalidad: español

Six things to notice, and every one is a rule rather than a detail: *de la Cruz* is lower-case because the forename is present; **DNI** carries no points; **c/** is the street and **n.º** the number; **1.º** is the floor, with the point before the raised letter; and **español** is lower-case because a nationality is a category.

Grammar Lens: the same data spoken aloud

A form prints the short forms; a person says them in full:

on the form	said aloud
c/ Mayor	calle Mayor
n.º 5	número cinco
1.º	primero

A reading paper gives you the left column and a listening paper the right, which is why both have to be learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the address line of the form, aloud and in full
- your own nationality, and keep it lower-case
- **DNI**, letter by letter, using the Spanish letter names
- why *de* is small in *Pedro de la Cruz*

Before you move on

Why is *español* lower-case on the form? (A nationality is a category, not a name.) How is **1.º** read aloud? (*Primero.*) Where does the point go in **n.º**? (Before the raised letter.)

Chapter 427

People Named By What They Do

Modes: **voice** (7) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 6 of 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name five professions and the company somebody works for, take any profession word apart to see how it was built, and answer a question about my work without putting an article where Spanish leaves one out.
>
> *Answer the question about what somebody does for a living, naming the profession with no article and the company with one.*

427.1 el vendedor — the ending you already have, doing its real job

Say *vender*. Say *trabajador*. You have the verb and you have the ending. Put them together before reading on.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el vendedor — "the seller, the shop assistant."
Take *vender*, drop the **-er**, add **-dor**. That is the whole operation, and you met the ending as an adjective in the character chapter. Here it does what it was built for: **making a person out of an action.**

verb	the one who does it
trabajar	el trabaja**dor**
vender	el vende**dor**
jugar	el juga**dor**
ganar	el gana**dor**

The ending is **productive**, which is the property worth having. You are not learning a word; you are learning a machine that turns any verb you know into the person who does it.

Grammar Lens: where the ending puts the stress

Every **-dor** noun stresses its last syllable: *vende-DOR*, *trabaja-DOR*, *juga-DOR*. None of them carries a written accent, because a word ending in **-r** is stressed on the last syllable by default and the accent marks only departures from the default.
The feminine adds **-a** and nothing else: *la vendedora*, *la trabajadora*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el vendedor" — *vende-DOR*
- the feminine form
- the two steps that build it from *vender*
- the person-word for somebody who plays, built the same way

Before you move on

What does the **-dor** ending do to a verb? (Makes a person out of it.) Why does *vendedor* carry no written accent? (A word ending in **-r** is stressed on the last syllable anyway.)

427.2 el comprador — the other side of the counter

Say *el vendedor*. Say *comprar*. Build the person who does the second thing, using the machine from the first.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el comprador — "the buyer."
Comprar minus **-ar**, plus **-dor**. No new rule, which is the point of teaching the pair together: one ending buys both halves of a

transaction.

side	verb	person
sells	vender	el vendedor
buys	comprar	el comprador

Grammar Lens: the pair that names an economy

These two words are how a form, a contract or a news item names the parties to a sale. They are not shop vocabulary — *el vendedor* in a shop is the assistant, but *vendedor* and *comprador* together are the **roles**, the way English says *seller* and *buyer* rather than *shopkeeper* and *customer*.
That distinction is why the source lists them under commerce rather than under shopping, and why knowing *comprar* was not enough to cover it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el comprador" — *compra-DOR*
- the pair, seller then buyer
- both in the feminine
- which of the two you are when you hand over the money

Before you move on

What two steps build *comprador* from *comprar*? (Drop the **-ar**, add **-dor**.) Are *vendedor* and *comprador* shop words or role words? (Roles — the two parties to a sale.)

427.3 el policía — where the article changes the meaning

Say *el comprador* and *la compradora*, where the article follows the person. The word in this lesson does something different, and it is worth noticing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el policía — "the police officer." Greek **pólis**, "the city," through Latin *politia*, "the administration of a state."
The root is unusually productive, and every word on it is about the city:

word	**the city in it**
política	the running of the city
metró**polis**	the mother-city
policía	the keeping of the city's order

So a police officer is named after **the city**, not after policing. The institution came first and the person was named from it.

Grammar Lens: the article does the distinguishing

This is the fact a reading paper can test, and it catches people:

	meaning
el policía	a police officer, a man
la policía	the police **force** — or a woman officer

The word does not change. **The article carries the whole difference**, and *la policía* is ambiguous between the force and a female officer in a way that only context settles.
Compare it with the **-dor** pair from the last two lessons, where the ending moved and the article merely followed. Here the ending is fixed at **-ía** and the article is doing all the work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el policía" — *po-li-CÍ-a*, four syllables
- what *la policía* means, and why it has two readings
- which Greek word is inside it, and what it meant
- how this differs from *el vendedor* / *la vendedora*

Before you move on

What does Greek *pólis* mean? (The city.) What is the difference between *el policía* and *la policía*? (The first is an officer; the second is the force, or a woman officer.)

427.4 el bombero — named after the pump, not the fire

Say *el policía*. The other emergency service has a name built a different way again — and it is named after a piece of equipment.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el bombero — "the firefighter."
From **la bomba**, which in Spanish means **a pump** as well as a bomb. A *bombero* is the person who works the pump.
English names the same person after what they fight: *fire*-fighter, *fire*-man. Spanish names them after what they carry. Two languages looking at the same person and choosing opposite halves of the scene.
The **-ero** ending is the third person-making ending in this chapter, and it attaches to **things** rather than to verbs:

thing	**the person who works with it**
la bomba — the pump	el bomb**ero**
el pan — bread	el pan**adero**
la carta — the letter	el cart**ero**

So Spanish has **-dor** for *the one who does the action* and **-ero** for *the one who works with the thing.*

Grammar Lens: three endings, three logics

ending	**built from**	**example**
-dor	a verb	vendedor
-ero	a thing	bombero
-ía	an institution	policía

None of the three is guessable from the meaning; all three are readable once you know which is which. That is the honest position: you cannot predict which ending a profession takes, but you can take any

profession apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el bombero" — *bom-BE-ro*
- what *la bomba* means besides a bomb
- the feminine form (*la bombera*)
- the difference between what **-dor** and **-ero** attach to

Before you move on

What is a *bombero* named after? (The pump.) What does **-ero** attach to, as against **-dor**? (A thing, where **-dor** attaches to a verb.)

427.5 el abogado — somebody called to your side

Say *el bombero*, named after his pump. The next profession is named after something nobody carries: a summons.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el abogado — "the lawyer."
Latin **advocatus**: **ad-** to + **vocatus**, "called." Literally **one called to your side** — in a Roman court, the friend you summoned to speak for you.
English borrowed the same word twice and kept both:

word	**the calling in it**
advocate	one called to your side
vocation	a calling, in the older sense
convoke	to call together

Vocare, "to call," is the root under all of them, and it is the same root as *voz*, the voice.
Spanish wore *advocatus* down to *abogado* while English kept the Latin shape intact, which is the ordinary difference between a word that was **inherited** and a word that was **borrowed** — the same distinction

actor and *trabajador* demonstrated.

Grammar Lens: the profession without a visible ending

profession	how the word was made
vendedor	Spanish added **-dor** to a Spanish verb
bombero	Spanish added **-ero** to a Spanish noun
abogado	Latin made it, and Spanish inherited it whole

Abogado has no ending you can remove to find a Spanish verb, because it was never built in Spanish. It arrived finished.
The feminine is the ordinary swap: *la abogada*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el abogado" — *a-bo-GA-do*
- the feminine form
- what the two Latin pieces mean (to, and called)
- which English word is the same Latin word kept whole (*advocate*)

Before you move on

What did *advocatus* literally mean? (One called to your side.) Can you find a Spanish verb inside *abogado*? (No — it was inherited whole from Latin rather than built in Spanish.)

427.6 la empresa — a thing taken on

Say *el vendedor* and *el comprador*. You can name both parties to a sale. Say where the seller works, and notice you have no word for it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la empresa — "the company, the firm."
From Latin **in-** + **prehendere**, "to take hold of." An *empresa* is literally **a thing taken on** — an undertaking.
English took the same idea through French and got **enterprise**, from *entre-* + *prendre*, the same two pieces in the other Romance language. The words are cousins built to the same plan.
The difference is what each language did with it afterwards. English *enterprise* mostly means the **venture**; Spanish *empresa* means both the venture **and the firm that carries it out**. For an A1 form asking where you work, *empresa* is the everyday word — it is what English calls *the company*.
Prehendere is generous, and two of its descendants are already useful to you: *aprender*, to learn, is to **take hold of** something; and *sorprender*, to surprise, is to take somebody from above.

Grammar Lens: a workplace rather than a worker

The chapter has named five people by what they do. **La empresa** is the one word in it that names a **place and an organisation** instead:

word	**what it names**
el vendedor	a person
el abogado	a person
la empresa	the organisation they work for

That is why a form has two separate lines, *profesión* and *empresa*, and why answering one does not answer the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la empresa" — *em-PRE-sa*
- what the two Latin pieces mean (in, and take hold of)
- the English cousin, and the one difference in what it covers
- which verb for learning comes from the same root (*aprender*)

Before you move on

What does *empresa* literally describe? (A thing taken on.) Does it mean the venture or the firm? (Both — where English *enterprise* mostly means only the venture.)

427.7 cinco personas y un lugar — sorted by how each name was built

Name as many of the six as you can before reading the table.

Grammar Lens: four ways to name a person

word	built from
el vendedor	the verb *vender*, plus **-dor**
el comprador	the verb *comprar*, plus **-dor**
el bombero	the noun *bomba*, plus **-ero**
el policía	the institution, *la policía*
el abogado	nothing in Spanish — inherited whole from Latin

Four different methods for five words, which is the honest summary: Spanish does not have one way of naming a profession. What it has is a small set of methods, and knowing them lets you **take a profession apart** even when you could not have predicted it.

The **-dor** pair is the only one that is productive for you: give it any verb you know and it gives you back the person — which is how *trabajar* gave *trabajador* in the character chapter, before you had any use for the ending.

Grammar Lens: which ones change, and how

masculine	feminine
el vendedor	la vendedora
el bombero	la bombera
el abogado	la abogada
el policía	**la policía** — and the word also means the force

Three behave ordinarily. **Policía** is the exception worth remembering, because the article is carrying a distinction no ending marks.
And **la empresa** is not a person at all — it is where several of these people work, which is why a form asks for it on its own line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two built with **-dor**, and the verb inside each
- the one built with **-ero**, and the thing inside it
- the one whose article changes the meaning, and both readings
- the one that is not a person

Before you move on

Which of the endings can you apply to a new verb yourself? (**-dor**.) Which word's meaning is decided by its article? (*Policía*.) Which of the six is not a person? (*La empresa*.)

427.8 ¿A qué se dedica? — the question about work

Say *el abogado* and *la empresa*. One answers what somebody does and one answers where. A conversation about work needs both.

Grammar Lens: naming a profession takes no article

This is the one grammatical trap in the answer, and English speakers fall into it every time:

correct	Soy abogado.
wrong	Soy **un** abogado.

English says *I am **a** lawyer*. Spanish drops the article when the sentence states nothing but the profession, because the bare noun is working as a description rather than picking out one individual.

The article comes back as soon as you add anything to it: *Soy* ***un*** *abogado trabajador* — "I am a hard-working lawyer." Adding the adjective turns the description into a particular kind of thing, and a particular thing takes an article.

Read this

Read aloud. Every word has been taught:

> — ¿A qué se dedica? — Soy abogado. Trabajo en una empresa grande. — ¿Y su hermana? — Es policía. Mi hermano es bombero.

Three professions, no article on any of them, and *una empresa* taking one because it is a thing rather than a description.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¿A qué se dedica?"
- "Soy abogado", and stop yourself before putting *un* in
- the same sentence with an adjective added, where the article returns
- your own answer, with the profession and the company

Before you move on

Why is it *Soy abogado* and not *Soy un abogado*? (A bare profession is a description, and a description takes no article.) When does the article come back? (As soon as an adjective is added.)

Chapter 428

Five Last Pieces

Modes: **voice** (6) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 5 of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read an e-mail address aloud with every symbol named, congratulate somebody, raise a glass, answer a sneeze, and name a creature I do not have the word for.
>
> *Read an invitation with an address on it, saying each symbol by name, and answer it with the right word at each moment of the evening.*

428.1 la arroba — Spanish has a word where English has a noise

> Say *el correo electrónico*. Now try to say your e-mail address aloud in Spanish, and stop at the symbol in the middle.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la arroba — the **@** sign.
English calls it *at*, which is a preposition pressed into service. Spanish has a **noun** for it, and the noun is much older than e-mail.
An *arroba* was a unit of weight — about eleven and a half kilos — from Arabic **ar-rub^{c}**, "the quarter," because it was a quarter of a *quintal*. Merchants wrote it with a looped **a**, and that shorthand is the symbol on your keyboard.
So when a Spanish speaker reads out an address, they are naming a **medieval unit of weight**:

> ana **arroba** ejemplo punto example

You have the other two pieces already: **punto** for the dot, from the punctuation chapter, and **guion** if the address carries one.

Grammar Lens: reading an address aloud

symbol	said aloud
@	arroba
.	punto
-	guion

A listening paper dictates an address using exactly these words, and the whole task is unreadable without the first one. Note that the symbol is **feminine**: *la arroba*, because the unit of weight was.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la arroba"
- what an *arroba* was before it was a symbol
- your own e-mail address aloud, in Spanish
- the three symbols and their Spanish names

Before you move on

What was an *arroba* originally? (A unit of weight, a quarter of a *quintal*.) Which article does it take? (*La*.) What does a Spanish speaker say where an English speaker says "at"? (*Arroba*.)

428.2 el guion bajo — the hyphen that sits on the floor

Say *el guion*, the short mark that joins. Say *la arroba*. One symbol remains before an address can be read out complete.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el guion bajo — the underscore, _.
The name is transparent and worth admiring for it: *guion* is the hyphen you already know, and **bajo** means *low*. It is the **low hyphen** — the same mark, dropped to the baseline.
English names it *under-score*, from the typewriter habit of scoring a line *under* text to underline it. Spanish names it by where it sits relative to the mark it resembles. Two languages, two entirely reasonable descriptions of the same key.

Grammar Lens: the address, complete

Every symbol an e-mail address can contain now has a Spanish name:

symbol	said aloud
@	arroba
.	punto
-	guion
_	guion bajo

ana_lopez **arroba** ejemplo **punto** example

Read that aloud and you have completed the task the source calls *dictating an e-mail address*. It needed four words, three of which you already had.
A real Spanish address usually ends in **punto es**, for the country. The addresses printed here end in *example* because that ending is reserved for teaching and can never belong to anybody.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el guion bajo", and say what *bajo* is telling you
- the four symbol names in order
- the address above, aloud and complete
- the difference between *guion* and *guion bajo* on the page

Before you move on

What does *bajo* mean? (Low.) So what is a *guion bajo*? (A low hyphen — the underscore.) How many of the four address symbols did you already have before this chapter? (Three.)

428.3 ¡Felicidades! — the word you say, not the word you describe with

Say *el guion bajo*. The symbols are finished; what follows is what you say to people. Say *feliz*, then try to congratulate somebody with it — and notice the adjective will not do it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¡Felicidades! — "congratulations."
It is *felicidad*, "happiness," in the **plural** — literally *happinesses*. Spanish wishes several at once, which is what a congratulation is: not a description of a state but a handful of good wishes thrown at somebody.
The relationship to *feliz* is visible: *feliz* → *felicidad* → *felicidades*. An adjective, the noun made from it, and that noun pluralised into an act.

Grammar Lens: which one on which occasion

Spanish has two congratulation words and they are not interchangeable:

word	**for**
¡Felicidades!	a birthday, a saint's day, a wedding — an **occasion**
¡Felicitaciones!	an exam passed, a job won — an **achievement**

Felicidades is the one an A1 paper wants, because A1 life is birthdays rather than promotions. In much of Latin America *felicitaciones* is the commoner of the two; in Spain *felicidades* covers nearly everything. And note the marks: an exclamation in Spanish opens with **¡** and closes with **!**, the same doubling you learned for questions.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¡Felicidades!"
- the singular noun it is built from (*felicidad*)
- the adjective under that (*feliz*)
- which of the two congratulation words fits a birthday

Before you move on

What does *¡Felicidades!* literally say? (*Happinesses* — several at once.) Which word suits an achievement rather than an occasion? (*¡Felicitaciones!*)

428.4 ¡Salud! — a noun doing a job

Say *la salud*, health. Say *¡Felicidades!* You have one noun that describes and one that acts. This lesson turns the first into the second.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¡Salud! — "cheers," raising a glass.
It is the same word you already have, with no article and an exclamation around it. Stripped of *la*, it stops describing a condition and becomes a **wish**: *health to you.*
That is what almost every toast in Europe is. English *cheers* wishes cheerfulness; Irish *sláinte* is literally *health*; and *¡Salud!* is the Spanish member of the same family. Raising a glass is wishing somebody well, and most languages say so plainly.

Grammar Lens: the same word, two occasions

¡Salud! does a second job that catches English speakers out:

when	what it means
raising a glass	cheers
after somebody sneezes	bless you

English uses two unrelated expressions for those. Spanish uses one word for both, and the reason is the same in each case: **you are wishing the person health**, whether because they are about to drink or because they have sneezed.
Some speakers say *¡Jesús!* after a sneeze instead, and in a formal toast you may hear the fuller *¡A tu salud!* — "to your health." The bare word covers both occasions and is never wrong.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "¡Salud!" with no article
- the two occasions it fits
- *la salud* and *¡Salud!* one after the other, and name the difference
- which one you would use at a birthday alongside *¡Felicidades!*

Before you move on

What is the difference on the page between the noun and the toast? (The article — the toast drops it.) What are the two occasions for *¡Salud!*? (Raising a glass, and after a sneeze.)

428.5 el animal — a thing with breath in it

Say *¡Salud!* — a word you already had, put to a new use. Now name three creatures you can say in Spanish, and try to say the word that covers all three at once.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el animal — "the animal."
Latin **animal**, from **anima**, "breath, soul." An animal is literally **a thing that has breath in it** — which is how Latin drew the line between the living and the not-living, at the lungs.
Anima is generous, and every word on it is about that breath:

word	the breath in it
animal	a thing that breathes
ánimo	spirit, courage
des**anim**ado	discouraged — the breath gone out
re**anim**ar	to revive — to put the breath back

English took the same root for **animate**, **unanimous** (of one *anima*, one mind) and **magnanimous** (of a great one).

Grammar Lens: the word that covers the others

This is a **superordinate** — a word one level up from the ones it covers. The corpus has taught particular creatures for hundreds of chapters without ever teaching the category they belong to.
That gap matters more than it looks. A superordinate is what lets you talk about something you cannot name: *un animal grande* works when you do not know the word for the creature in front of you, and a reading paper will use it exactly that way, in a notice or a sign that must cover every creature at once.
The stress is on the last syllable — *a-ni-MAL* — and there is no written accent, because a word ending in **-l** is stressed there by default.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el animal" — *a-ni-MAL*
- what *anima* meant, and where Latin drew the line
- "un animal grande", and say when you would need it
- which English word means "of one mind" and hides the same root

Before you move on

What does *anima* mean? (Breath, soul.) Why does *animal* carry no written accent? (A word ending in **-l** is stressed on the last syllable anyway.) What is a superordinate for? (Talking about a thing you

cannot name.)

428.6 cinco piezas sueltas — five things that finish five different jobs

Name the five before reading the table. They have less in common than usual, which is the point.

Grammar Lens: what each one completes

word	finishes
la arroba	reading an address aloud
el guion bajo	the same
¡Felicidades!	congratulating somebody
¡Salud!	raising a glass, and answering a sneeze
el animal	naming a creature you cannot name

The address needed only these two: *punto* and *guion* were already yours from the punctuation chapter.
Each was the **last missing piece** of something the corpus could otherwise nearly do. That is what makes them worth a chapter together despite having nothing else in common: the address needed two more words, the social phrases were absent although the adjectives behind them were taught, and a dozen creatures had no category.

Grammar Lens: two of them are nouns doing other work

word	as a noun	as an act
salud	health	cheers, bless you
felicidad	happiness	—
felicidades	—	congratulations

¡Salud! drops its article and becomes a wish. **¡Felicidades!** takes a plural and becomes an act. Neither is a new word in the ordinary sense; both are an existing word put to a different use, which is why the adjectives behind them were never enough on their own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two symbol names, and the two you already had
- the two things you say to people, and the occasion for each
- what a superordinate is for
- what happens to *salud* when it loses its article

Before you move on

Which two of the five are existing words put to a new use? (*Salud* and *felicidades*.) What was an *arroba* before it was a symbol? (A unit of weight.)

428.7 una invitación — reading it, and answering it

Say the two things you would say at a birthday. One congratulates and one raises a glass.

Read this

Read this invitation aloud, saying every symbol by name:

> **Cumpleaños de Ana** Sábado, a las ocho. Confirma en ana_lopez arroba ejemplo punto example

The address line is written in words here because that is how it is **said**. On a screen it would read *ana_lopez@ejemplo.example*, and saying it aloud requires the four names: *guion bajo*, *arroba*, *punto*, and the letters themselves.
A real Spanish address would end *punto es*; this one ends in the reserved teaching word instead, so that nobody is written to by accident.

Grammar Lens: answering it

moment	what you say
arriving	¡Felicidades!
the first glass	¡Salud!
somebody sneezes	¡Salud!

Two words cover the whole evening, and one of them covers two of the three moments.
If the invitation had been to a farm rather than a flat, you would also have the word for whatever was in the field: *un animal*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the address line aloud, every symbol by name
- what you say on arriving, and what you say at the first glass
- the same word again, this time because somebody sneezed
- your own e-mail address aloud in Spanish

Before you move on

How many symbol names does reading an address aloud need? (Four.) Which of the two social words covers two different moments? (*¡Salud!*)

Chapter 429

The Instituto, And What A Mark Is Called

Modes: **voice** (3) **eyes** (4) **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the school a Spanish teenager goes to, read a report card, say what mark I got, and say whether I passed or failed.

Read a three-row report card from a Spanish secondary school, say which subjects passed and which hangs, and answer the spoken version of the same question.

429.1 el instituto — the building between the two you already know

You can say *la escuela* and *la universidad*. A Spanish fifteen-year-old goes to neither. Where do they go?

You'll want to know: el instituto

el instituto — the secondary school, for students of about twelve to eighteen.

On a sign it is often shortened to **IES** — *Instituto de Educación Secundaria*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **instituere** — *in-* plus **statuere**, "to set up, to stand a thing upright." An **institutum** was **something that had been set up**: a custom, an arrangement, a foundation. A Spanish *instituto* is a **thing that was established**, and the school sense is one narrow use of a very wide word.
Statuere is behind a crowd of words you can already half-read: *estatua*, *estado*, *estatura*, *constituir*. Every one of them is about **standing**.

Grammar Lens: the false friend, and the ladder it breaks

English *institute* names a research body — the Institute of Physics. Spanish *instituto* can mean that too, but its everyday sense is **the school**, and that is the one a reading paper uses.
The three buildings in order:

age	building
about 6 to 12	la escuela
about 12 to 18	el instituto
after 18	la universidad

Without the middle rung the ladder has a gap in exactly the years an exam candidate is most likely to be asked about.
The stress is *ins-ti-TU-to*, on the second-last syllable, and no accent is written because a word ending in a vowel is stressed there by default.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el instituto" — *ins-ti-TU-to*
- the three buildings in order of age
- what the letters *IES* stand for
- what *statuere* meant, and one Spanish word that still shows it

Before you move on

Where does a fifteen-year-old go? (*Al instituto.*) What does English *institute* name instead? (A research body.) What was an *institutum*

in Latin? (Something that had been set up.)

429.2 la nota — a mark, in the oldest sense of the word

You can say *el examen*. Now try to say what you got for it, and notice you have the event and not the result.

You'll want to know: la nota

la nota — the mark, the grade.

¿Qué nota tienes? — "What mark did you get?" In Spain the answer is a number **out of ten**, and five is where passing begins.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **nota** meant **a mark scratched onto something** — a sign cut into wax, wood or skin so it could be told apart later.
Every modern sense grew out of that one scratch:

word	**the mark in it**
nota	the mark a teacher puts on your work
notar	to notice — to catch the mark
notable	worth marking

English *note*, *notice*, *notable* and *notorious* are the same word arriving by a different road.
So the grade sense is not a metaphor. **It is the literal one**, and a written note — a mark made on paper to be read later — is the extension.

Grammar Lens: one word, two senses, and how to tell them apart

You have met *nota* before, on a message left for somebody. Both senses are live, and what sorts them is the company the word keeps:

what stands nearby	which sense
examen, *clase*, a number	the mark
dejar, *escribir*, a person	the message

Sacar buena nota is the set phrase for doing well — literally "to take out a good mark," the way you take out anything you have earned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la nota" — the mark
- "¿Qué nota tienes?"
- what a Latin *nota* physically was
- the phrase for doing well in an exam (*sacar buena nota*)

Before you move on

Out of how many is a Spanish school mark? (Ten.) Which sense of *nota* came first, the mark or the message? (The mark — Latin *nota* was a scratch.) What tells the two senses apart in a sentence? (The words standing next to it.)

429.3 la calificación — the word the paper uses when the person would say *nota*

Say *nota*. Now imagine it printed at the top of an official column on a school document, and expect a longer word.

You'll want to know: la calificación

la calificación — the grade, in its formal dress.

Spoken between students it is *nota*. Printed on a report, a transcript or a form, it is **calificación**, and the two name the same thing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Medieval Latin **qualificare**, built from **qualis** ("of what kind") plus **facere** ("to make"). To *calificar* is **to say what kind a thing is**. That is a startlingly honest description of what a grade does. A number out of ten is a claim about the **kind** of work in front of the reader, which is why the formal word for it is built from the question *of what kind?*

English took the same compound as **qualify**, and kept the other half of the sense: to *qualify* a statement is to say what kind of statement it is.

Grammar Lens: where the accent sits, and why

Calificación ends in **-n**, which by default pulls the stress to the second-last syllable — *ca-li-fi-CA-cion*. The stress is on the last one, so an accent has to be written: **-ción**.

Every Spanish word ending in **-ción** works this way, and you have met dozens:

word	**stressed syllable**
calificación	-ción
educación	-ción
información	-ción

In the plural the accent disappears — *calificaciones* — because adding a syllable puts the stress where the default would have put it anyway.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "la calificación" — *ca-li-fi-ca-CIÓN*
- which of *nota* and *calificación* you would hear in a corridor
- what *qualis* meant, and what a grade therefore claims
- the plural, and say why it loses its accent

Before you move on

What question is hiding inside *calificación*? (*Of what kind?*) Where does its accent go, and where does it go in the plural? (On *-ción*;

the plural drops it.) Which English word is the same compound? (*Qualify.*)

429.4 aprobar — to pass, and who is really doing the approving

You can name the exam and the mark. Say what you did with the exam when the mark was a five or better.

You'll want to know: aprobar

aprobar — to pass, as in to pass an exam.
He aprobado el examen. — "I have passed the exam."
The mark that does it is a **five out of ten** and upward.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **approbare** — *ad-* ("towards") plus **probare**, "to test something and find it good."
Look at the direction that gives you. English says *I passed the exam*, with the student doing the acting and the exam standing still. The Latin behind *aprobar* says something closer to **the examiner tested the work and found it good** — the judgement travels the other way. *Probare* is a generous root, and you can read its family off the page:

word	what it tests
probar	to try, to taste, to test
prueba	a test, a piece of evidence
a**prob**ar	to test and find good

English *probe*, *proof*, *prove* and *approve* all come from the same verb.

Grammar Lens: the vowel that breaks in the middle

Aprobar is one of the verbs whose **o** splits into **ue** when the stress lands on it:

form	stem
yo apr**ue**bo	stressed
nosotros apr**o**bamos	unstressed

You have seen this before in *poder* and *contar*. The rule has not

changed: the stem breaks where the stress falls and stays whole where it does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "aprobar" — to pass
- "He aprobado el examen"
- the *yo* form, and hear where the stem breaks
- what *probare* meant, and which direction the judgement travels
- the formal word a report prints for the number you got

Before you move on

What mark passes? (Five out of ten.) What did *probare* mean? (To test and find good.) What happens to the **o** in *yo apruebo*? (It breaks into **ue**, because the stress lands on it.)

429.5 suspender — to fail, and the picture the word is holding

You can say *aprobar*. Guess its opposite, and then read on to see what the Spanish word is actually picturing.

You'll want to know: suspender

suspender — to fail, as in to fail an exam or a subject.

He suspendido el examen. — "I have failed the exam." A mark below **five** does it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **suspendere** — *sub-* ("beneath") plus **pendere**, "to hang." To suspend a thing is to leave it **hanging**.
That is not a dead metaphor here. A failed subject in Spain is **not finished**: it hangs over the student until a resit in a later term. There

is even a word for one — *una asignatura pendiente*, "a hanging subject" — which people also use for anything in life they have been putting off. **Pendere** built a shelf of words that all hang:

word	what hangs
pendiente	a slope, an earring, a thing outstanding
de**pend**er	to hang from something else
pensar	to weigh a thing in the mind

English *pendant*, *pending*, *suspense* and *depend* hang from the same nail.

Grammar Lens: the English false friend, and the Spanish one

English *suspend* keeps only the harsher senses — a suspended player, a suspended sentence. The school sense does not survive the crossing, so an English speaker reading *he suspendido* will hear something far more dramatic than what happened.

The pair, side by side:

mark	verb
five or above	aprobar
below five	suspender

Both verbs take the exam as their object, so the exam is what is passed or failed, rather than the student.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "suspender" — to fail
- "He suspendido el examen"
- the pair, with the mark that decides each
- what *una asignatura pendiente* is, and what it means outside school

Before you move on

What does *pendere* mean? (To hang.) What is *una asignatura pendiente*? (A subject left hanging, and by extension anything

outstanding.) Which mark divides *aprobar* from *suspender*? (Five.)

429.6 el curso entero — one school year, in five words

Name the building and the thing a teacher writes on your work, before you look at the table.

Grammar Lens: the year, in order

what happens	the word
you go to the building	el instituto
you sit in the room	la clase
you sit the thing	el examen
a number comes back	la nota
the document prints it	la calificación
five or above	aprobar
below five	suspender

Two of those seven were already yours. The chapter added the other five, and with them the track can follow a school year from the door to the report.

Grammar Lens: two words for one number

where you meet it	which word
a friend asking in a corridor	la nota
a column heading on a document	la calificación

Same number, two registers. A reading paper prints the formal one; a listening paper says the short one.

Grammar Lens: three Latin pictures

word	the picture under it
nota	a scratch cut into a surface
aprobar	a thing tested and found good
suspender	a thing left hanging

The third one is still literally true in Spain, where a failed subject hangs over a student until the resit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three school buildings by the age that goes to each
- the two words for the number, and where each one appears
- the two verbs, and the mark that divides them
- the picture hiding inside *suspender*

Before you move on

Which word heads a column on a report? (*Calificación.*) Which verb is the Latin for *found good*? (*Aprobar.*) Which building takes a fifteen-year-old? (*El instituto.*)

429.7 Synthesis — reading a report card

Say the two words for a mark. One of them is about to appear as a column heading.

Read this

IES Ejemplo Boletín de calificaciones

clase	calificación
Matemáticas	7
Historia	4
Inglés	9

Three rows, and everything in them is now readable. **IES** is the school. **Calificación** heads the column because this is a printed document. The numbers are out of ten.

A real letterhead carries the centre's own name after those three letters — usually a poet, a scientist or a place. **Ejemplo** stands in for it here, so nothing on this page points at a school somebody actually attends. What you read off a real document is the same three things: the **IES**,

the heading, and the column.

How to answer

Two of the three rows passed and one did not. Say which verb goes with each:

> *He aprobado Matemáticas e Inglés. He suspendido Historia.*

The history row is the one that hangs. The student will carry it into the next term as **una asignatura pendiente**, and the family will ask about it in exactly those words.

The exchange

> *— ¿Qué notas has sacado? — He aprobado casi todo. Historia no.*

The question uses **notas** because it is spoken. The answer names the one that did not pass, which is what the question is really asking about.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- what *IES* at the top of the document stands for
- which subjects passed, using the right verb
- which subject hangs, and the phrase for it
- the spoken version of the question, and answer it about the 4

Before you move on

Which word heads the column on the printed report? (*Calificación.*) What happened to Historia? (*Suspendida* — it hangs.) What is the spoken word for the same number? (*La nota.*)

Chapter 430

The Wardrobe, And The Word For Having No Work

Modes: **voice** (6) **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that somebody is out of work, read a clothes-shop price list, and name the three garments the corpus was missing.
>
> *Read a sale board with three garments and three prices, say which is cheapest and what you would buy, and answer whether you are working.*

430.1 estar en paro — the halt, rather than the missing job

> You can say *el trabajo*. Try to say that somebody has none, and notice English reaches for a word built on *employ* that Spanish does not use in conversation.

You'll want to know: estar en paro

estar en paro — to be unemployed, to be out of work.
Mi hermano está en paro. — "My brother is out of work."
El paro on its own is both the state and the benefit paid during it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

El paro is built straight off **parar**, "to stop" — so it is a **stoppage**. Spanish names the situation after **the halt**, where English names it after the missing employment.

The verb has a startling history. Latin **parare** meant **to make ready** — the root inside *preparar* and *reparar*. The sense travelled in steps: *to get ready* became *to stand ready*, and *to stand ready* became **to stand still**.

word	**where on the journey**
pre**parar**	to make ready beforehand
parar	to stand still
el **paro**	the standing still itself

So *estar en paro* is, underneath, **being in the halt**.

Grammar Lens: which verb, and which country

It takes **estar** rather than **ser**, because it names a situation rather than a person, and situations change.

where	**the everyday word**
Spain	el paro
much of Latin America	el desempleo

Desempleo is the formal word everywhere, and the one a newspaper prints. A person in Spain talking about their own life says **paro**.

The pair a form will ask you to choose between is short: *tengo trabajo* against *estoy en paro*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "estar en paro" — to be out of work
- "Mi hermano está en paro"
- the two halves of the pair — having work, and being in the halt
- what *parare* meant in Latin, and the two steps to *stop*

Before you move on

Which verb does *en paro* take, *ser* or *estar*? (**Estar** — it is a situation.) What does *el paro* literally name? (The stoppage.) Which word would a newspaper print instead? (*El desempleo.*)

430.2 los vaqueros — trousers named after the man who wore them

You can say *el pantalón* for trousers in general. Name the one kind of trousers almost everybody in the room is wearing, and see whether you have a word for it.

You'll want to know: los vaqueros

los vaqueros — jeans.

Always plural, the way *pantalones* is, because the garment has two legs.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

La vaca is a cow, from Latin **vacca**. A **vaquero** is the man who looks after them — a cowherd, and in the Americas a **cowboy**.

Jeans arrived in Spain as the trousers those men wore, and Spanish named them after **the wearer** rather than the cloth. English went the other way: *jeans* comes from **Genoa**, the Italian port whose hard cotton the trousers were cut from, and *denim* from *de Nîmes*, the French town. Three languages, three different things noticed about the same garment.

Some regions say **los tejanos** instead — "the Texans" — which is the same thought arriving from a different direction.

Grammar Lens: garments that come in pairs

garment	usual number
los vaqueros	plural
los pantalones	plural
la camisa	singular

Anything with two legs tends to arrive plural. Spanish tolerates *el pantalón* in the singular, and does **not** do the same for *vaqueros* — you

will hear the plural every time.
The **v** and the **b** sound alike in Spanish, so *vaquero* opens with the same soft sound as *bueno*. Spelling keeps the Latin **v**; the mouth stopped distinguishing them centuries ago.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "los vaqueros" — jeans
- what a *vaquero* is when it is a person
- which garments Spanish keeps plural, and why
- where English *jeans* and *denim* come from

Before you move on

What animal is hiding in *vaqueros*? (*La vaca*, the cow.) What did English name the same trousers after? (Two cities — Genoa and Nîmes.) Would you say *el vaquero* for the garment? (No — the garment is plural.)

430.3 el jersey — an island, worn

You can say *la camisa*. Name what you put **over** it when the weather turns, and see whether the word is there.

You'll want to know: el jersey

el jersey — the jumper, the pullover, the sweater.

Said the Spanish way: *jer-SÉI*, with the **j** as the throaty *jota* you already have from *jamón*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Jersey is an island in the Channel, between England and France. Its knitters were famous, and the heavy woollen garment they made took the island's name in English. Spanish borrowed the English word entire, island and all.

That makes it one of a small set of Spanish clothing words that name a **place** rather than a shape or a material:

garment	**the place**
el jersey	a Channel island
los tejanos	Texas
la chaqueta	a French peasant named Jacques

Latin America mostly says **el suéter** instead — also English, borrowed a different way, and spelled to fit Spanish.

Grammar Lens: what a borrowed word has to learn

A word taken from another language still has to obey the accent rules of this one. *Jersey* is stressed on its last syllable, and a word ending in **-y** takes no written accent, so the singular is bare.
The plural is where it shows:

number	**form**
singular	el jersey
plural	los jerséis

The **y** turns into an **i**, the ending becomes **-s**, and now an accent is needed to hold the stress where it was. Spanish did not leave the word foreign; it made it follow the rules.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el jersey" — *jer-SÉI*
- the plural, and hear where the accent has to appear
- what Jersey is, before it was a garment
- the word much of Latin America uses instead

Before you move on

What is a *jersey*, before it is clothing? (An island in the Channel.) What is the plural? (*Los jerséis* — with a written accent.) Why does the accent appear only in the plural? (The ending changes, so the stress needs holding.)

430.4 el bolso — a hide, a purse, and one vowel that changes the object

You have clothes and now a jumper. Name the thing carried **beside** the clothes rather than worn, and see whether you have it.

You'll want to know: el bolso

el bolso — the handbag.

Not a shopping bag and not a pocket. A *bolso* is the bag carried on the arm or shoulder, and a shop will file it under accessories beside the shoes.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Greek **byrsa** meant **a hide, a piece of worked leather**. Latin took it as **bursa**, and because a leather pouch is what money was carried in, the word came to mean **purse**.

From that one pouch:

word	what it kept
el bolso	the bag on your arm
el bolsillo	the little one sewn into your clothes
la bolsa	the bag, and the stock exchange

English got **bursar**, **reimburse** and **purse** from the same leather. The stock-exchange sense is the strangest and the best attested: traders in fifteenth-century Bruges met at the house of a family called **Van der Buerse**, and the name of the meeting place became the name of the market everywhere.

Grammar Lens: the vowel that picks the object

Bolso and **bolsa** are one letter apart and name different things:

word	what it is
el bolso	a handbag
la bolsa	a bag, a carrier bag, the stock exchange

Ask for *una bolsa* in a shop and you get something to carry the shopping home in. Ask for *un bolso* and you are shown the leather

goods.
This is a pattern worth knowing rather than a single oddity: Spanish sometimes uses the **-o / -a** pair to separate two related objects rather than two genders of one. You have already met *el pantalón* keeping its own shape for the same kind of reason.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el bolso" — the handbag
- what *una bolsa* would get you in a shop instead
- what *byrsa* meant, and what it was used to carry
- the word for the small one sewn into your clothes

Before you move on

Which of *bolso* and *bolsa* is the handbag? (*El bolso.*) What did the Greek word name? (A hide.) What else does *la bolsa* mean? (The stock exchange — after a family's house in Bruges.)

430.5 cuatro que cierran dos listas — four words, two finished lists

Say the two halves of the work pair — having it, and not having it — before you read on.

Grammar Lens: the wardrobe, complete

garment	already yours
el pantalón	yes
la falda	yes
la camisa	yes
el zapato	yes
los vaqueros	new
el jersey	new
el bolso	new

Four were taught across earlier chapters and three arrived here. The list an exam works from is now covered end to end, which is what the three were for.

Grammar Lens: each one's own trap

word	what to watch
estar en paro	takes *estar*, and *paro* means the halt
los vaqueros	plural every time
el jersey	plural *jerséis*, with a written accent
el bolso	*la bolsa* is a different object

Grammar Lens: where each word came from

word	named after
el paro	the stopping
los vaqueros	the cowherd
el jersey	an island
el bolso	a leather hide

Three of the four are named after something other than themselves — a person, a place, a material. That is a habit worth noticing, because it is how a reader guesses at a word they have not met.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the seven garments, running through the whole wardrobe
- the plural of *jersey*
- the difference between *el bolso* and *la bolsa*
- which verb goes with *en paro*, and why

Before you move on

Which garment is always plural? (*Los vaqueros.*) Which word changes object when you change its last vowel? (*Bolso* against *bolsa.*) What does *el paro* name? (The halt.)

430.6 Synthesis — a shop window and a sentence about yourself

Name the three garments this chapter added, before they appear in a price list.

Read this

ROPA — REBAJAS

artículo	**precio**
vaqueros	25 €
jerséis	18 €
bolsos	30 €

Every line is readable, and one of them is teaching you something: the middle row is a **plural**, and the accent on *jerséis* is exactly where the singular did not need one.

How to answer

Say what is cheapest, what is dearest, and what you would buy:

Los jerséis son los más baratos. Quiero unos vaqueros.

Note *unos vaqueros* rather than *un vaquero.* A pair of trousers is a plural thing, so the article is plural too.

The exchange

The other half of the chapter, in the two lines a form or an interview wants:

> *— ¿Trabajas? — No, estoy en paro.*

Estoy, not *soy*. Being out of work is a situation, and Spanish keeps situations away from *ser*. The same answer in the positive is *sí, tengo trabajo* — the noun you have had since the professions chapter, finally with a negative to stand against.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three prices with their garments
- which row carries a written accent, and where the singular has none
- "Quiero unos vaqueros", and say why the article is plural
- both answers to *¿Trabajas?*

Before you move on

Which verb answers *¿Trabajas?* in the negative? (*Estoy — estoy en paro.*) Which word in the price list gained an accent in the plural? (*Jerséis.*) Why *unos vaqueros* rather than *un*? (The garment is plural.)

Chapter 431

El Pedido Y La Devolución

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about an order that has arrived late, say who the shop blames, ask to return it and understand what I am being charged.
>
> *Read the notice or advert this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

431.1 el pedido — what you asked for

> You can say *comprar* and *la tienda*. Now say the **thing itself** — the parcel that has not arrived yet — and see whether you have a word for it.

You'll want to know: el pedido

el pedido — the order.

Not the act of ordering: the **thing ordered**. The box on its way to you, the line on the restaurant's docket, the number you quote on the phone.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pedido is the past participle of **pedir**, to ask for, used as a noun. What was asked for. Spanish does this constantly, and once you see it you will see it everywhere:

verb	the noun made from it
pedir	el pedido
llamar	la llamada
entrar	la entrada

You already hold **la entrada** for a ticket. It is *the entered thing* by the same move. A participle that hardens into a noun is one of the cheapest ways this language makes new words, and it costs you no new ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el pedido*
- I bought it in the shop, and the order has not arrived
- which verb *el pedido* was made from

Before you move on

The order? (**el pedido**.) From which verb? (**pedir**.) Does it mean the asking or the thing asked for? (**The thing.**)

431.2 devolver — to turn it back

Say *el pedido*. Say *pagar*. The order came, you paid, and it is the wrong size. Say what you do next.

You'll want to know: devolver

devolver — to give back, to return a thing.

A thing, not a place. You *devolver* a jumper, a book, a borrowed charger. For going back somewhere yourself, Spanish uses **volver** on its own.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de- back, plus **volver**, to turn. To turn a thing back.
That is the whole word, and it tells you the grammar too: **devolver** turns exactly like **volver**, which you already say. The **o** becomes **ue**

when the stress lands on it:

form	
yo devuelvo	I give back
nosotros devolvemos	we give back

The stress moves off the **o** in *devolvemos*, and the **ue** goes with it. This is the same pattern as *poder / puedo* and *dormir / duermo*; learning it once buys you a whole family of verbs.

Grammar Lens: the two ways back

you mean	**you say**
I return the order	devuelvo el pedido
I return home	vuelvo a casa

English uses *return* for both and lets context sort it out. Spanish splits them, and the split is not a nuisance — it is the prefix doing exactly what it says.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *devolver*
- I want to return the order
- I paid and now I am returning it
- the difference between *devuelvo* and *vuelvo*

Before you move on

To give a thing back? (**devolver**.) And to go back yourself? (**volver**.) What does the **de-** add? (**Back.**)

431.3 el retraso — put further behind

Say *el pedido*. Say *devolver*. The order is not late enough to return yet — it is only late. Say that.

You'll want to know: el retraso

el retraso — the delay.

con retraso — late, running behind. That is the phrase you will hear on a platform: *el tren sale con veinte minutos de retraso.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

re- again, plus **tras**, behind. Something put further behind than it should be.

tras is worth a moment on its own, because it is hiding in words you will meet all week:

word	**the behind in it**
detrás	behind, in place
atrasar	to put back
el retraso	the being-behind

Spanish also has **tardar**, to take time, from a different Latin word for *slow*. Two families, one idea, and a speaker picks whichever fits: a train *lleva retraso*, a journey *tarda* two hours.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el retraso*
- the order is arriving late
- the train leaves with twenty minutes' delay

Before you move on

The delay? (**el retraso**.) Running late? (**con retraso**.) What does **tras** mean on its own? (**Behind.**)

431.4 el proveedor — the one further up the line

Say *la tienda.* Say *el retraso.* The shop says the delay is not their fault. Whose, then?

You'll want to know: el proveedor

el proveedor — the supplier.

The company that supplies the shop. You rarely deal with one; you hear about one when something has gone wrong: *un problema con nuestro proveedor.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

proveer, to provide, plus **-dor**, the ending that makes a doer. That ending is worth more to you than this one word, because it is completely regular and it turns verbs you already hold into people and machines:

verb	the doer
proveer	el proveedor
trabajar	el trabajador
vender	el vendedor

Once you notice **-dor**, a long unfamiliar noun often decomposes into a verb you know plus *the one who does it.* That is a reading strategy, not a word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el proveedor*
- there is a problem with the supplier
- the doer-word made from *trabajar*

Before you move on

The supplier? (**el proveedor**.) What does **-dor** add? (**The one who does it.**) From which verb? (**proveer**.)

431.5 cobrar — the other end of paying

Say *pagar.* Say *el dinero.* You have had both a long time. Now say what the **shop** does, from its own side of the counter.

You'll want to know: cobrar

cobrar — to charge somebody, to collect money, to get paid.

One verb for all three, and which one it means depends on who is speaking.

Grammar Lens: who is on each end

pagar and **cobrar** are the same transaction from opposite sides:

who	**verb**
the customer	paga
the shop	cobra

So *me cobraron treinta euros* — they charged me thirty. And *cobro el viernes* — I get paid on Friday, said by somebody with a job. English needs three different verbs (*charge*, *collect*, *get paid*) where Spanish holds one, and the one holds because the money is always moving **toward** the speaker.

That is also why **no se cobra nada** on a shop notice means nothing will be charged to you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cobrar*
- I pay and the shop charges
- they charged me thirty euros
- I get paid on Friday

Before you move on

The customer does what? (**paga**.) And the shop? (**cobra**.) What does *no se cobra nada* tell you? (**You will not be charged.**)

431.6 (pedido, devolver, retraso, proveedor, cobrar) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say *the order*, *to give back* and *the delay*.

Grammar Lens: three of the five were built, not learned

word	made from	by
el pedido	pedir	a participle used as a noun
el proveedor	proveer	the doer-ending **-dor**
devolver	volver	the prefix **de-**, back

Three of this chapter's five words are a piece you already had plus one move. Do not read a rule into it — plenty of Spanish words are simple and whole. What is worth carrying is the habit of **looking** for the join before deciding a long word is new.

What you've built

You could buy things and pay for them, and you could not say what happens when it goes wrong. *Comprar*, *pagar*, *la tienda* and *el dinero* have been yours for a long time, and between them they cover only the half of a transaction where everybody is content. This chapter adds the other half: the thing itself (**el pedido**), it arriving late (**el retraso**), whose fault the shop says that is (**el proveedor**), sending it back (**devolver**) and what you are or are not charged (**cobrar**).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all five words
- which three were built from a piece you already had
- the customer pays and the shop ...
- the order is arriving late and I want to return it

Before you move on

To give a thing back? (**devolver**.) The one who supplies the shop? (**el proveedor**.) The shop's side of *pagar*? (**cobrar**.)

431.7 (una reclamación) — the whole transaction, gone wrong

You are about to read a real notice of the kind a shop sends. Before you do, say *el pedido* and *el retraso* once each.

Your turn

Read it once without stopping, then answer.

> Estimado cliente: su **pedido** número 3182 sufrirá un **retraso** de tres días por un problema con nuestro **proveedor**. No se le **cobrará** el envío.

Say these aloud:

- how many days late it is
- whose problem the shop says it is
- whether you will be charged for delivery

What you've built

Now the other direction. Say aloud, as if on the telephone:
Say these aloud:

- my order is arriving with a delay of three days
- I paid on Monday and nobody has charged me for the delivery
- if it does not arrive this week I want to return it

Four sentences ago you could not have said any of that. The transaction you could describe stopped at the moment of paying; it now runs all the way to the complaint.

Before you move on

Your order? (**mi pedido**.) With a delay? (**con retraso**.) And if you want to send it back? (**devolver**.)

Chapter 432

La Casa Por Dentro

Modes: **voice** (7) **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can name the machines and fittings a building notice talks about, and read a notice about the water being cut off.
>
> *Read the notice or advert this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

432.1 la lavadora — the thing that washes

Say *lavar*. Say *el proveedor*. You met the doer-ending one chapter ago. Put it on *lavar* and guess before you are told.

You'll want to know: la lavadora

la lavadora — the washing machine.

If you guessed it, that is the point of the last chapter arriving before this one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lavar plus **-dora**. The same ending as **el proveedor**, in its feminine form, and it does the same job — except that here the doer is a machine rather than a person.

verb	the doer
lavar	la lavadora
secar	la secadora
calcular	la calculadora

Spanish names most household machines this way, so **-dora** is worth more to you than any single appliance. A machine that does something is usually that something plus this ending, and you can often reach the word without having met it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la lavadora*
- the verb it was built from
- what a machine for drying would be called

Before you move on

The washing machine? (**la lavadora**.) The ending? (**-dora**.) Where did you meet it first? (**On the supplier.**)

432.2 el contador — the thing that counts

Say *contar*. Say *la lavadora*. Do the same move again: the ending on the verb, and say what the machine must be.

You'll want to know: el contador

el contador — the meter. The box that counts your water, your gas, your electricity.

contar carries two senses you already hold — to count, and to tell a story. The meter takes the counting one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Twice in two lessons the same ending has handed you a word. That is worth pausing on, because it is the difference between a vocabulary

you memorise and one you can extend.

you know	**you can reach**
lavar	la lavadora
contar	el contador

el contador del agua is the phrase you will actually meet, on notices about somebody coming to read it. Note the gender: this one is masculine where the washing machine was feminine, and nothing about the ending decides that — the machine takes whatever gender its own word already had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el contador*
- the water meter
- the two things *contar* can mean

Before you move on

The meter? (**el contador**.) Built from? (**contar**.) And the washing machine? (**la lavadora**.)

432.3 la estantería — a place full of shelves

Say *el contador*. That ending has now served you twice. Here is a different one, and it does a different job.

You'll want to know: la estantería

la estantería — the shelving, the bookcase, the shelf unit.
A single shelf is **el estante**. The **-ería** makes it the whole structure.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

-ería does not make a doer. It makes a **place or collection** of the thing:

the thing	the place or collection
el estante	la estantería
el pan	la panadería
el libro	la librería

That is why so many shop names end this way: a *panadería* is where the bread is, a *librería* where the books are. Meeting the ending once tells you what a shop sells before you have read the sign properly. Two endings, two different jobs: **-dor** gives you who or what does it, **-ería** gives you where it is kept.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la estantería*
- one shelf, then the whole unit
- where you would buy bread, using the ending

Before you move on

The shelving? (**la estantería**.) One shelf? (**el estante**.) What does **-ería** add? (**The place or collection.**)

432.4 la tubería — all the pipes together

Say *la estantería*. Say *el agua*. A **tubo** is a pipe. Say what a *tubería* must be before reading on.

You'll want to know: la tubería

la tubería — the pipework, the plumbing, the run of pipes.

el tubo is one pipe. The ending collects them, exactly as it collected the shelves.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Third time for an ending in two chapters, and the second time for this one:

one	the collection
el estante	la estantería
el tubo	la tubería

This is the word in the notice that says the water is being cut off: *reparar una tubería*. The repair is to the **run of pipes**, not to one length of tube, and the word chooses itself accordingly.
If you are keeping count, you have now reached four words in this chapter and three of them you could have guessed from a piece you already had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la tubería*
- one pipe, then all of them
- they are repairing a pipe and cutting off the water

Before you move on

The pipework? (**la tubería**.) One pipe? (**el tubo**.) Which other word this chapter used the same ending? (**la estantería**.)

432.5 el sofá — the one you could not guess

Say *la silla*. You can name one seat. Name the long soft one that three people share.

You'll want to know: el sofá

el sofá — the sofa.

Stressed on the last syllable, *so-FÁ*, and the written accent is there to say so.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

This one was not built from anything you hold. Four words in this chapter came apart into a piece plus an ending; this one did not,

and pretending otherwise would waste your time.
It came into Spanish from Arabic, where the word named a raised, cushioned bench along a wall. Spanish took hundreds of words from Arabic over several centuries, and they tend to arrive **whole** like this rather than as pieces you can recombine.
So the honest lesson of the chapter is two-sided:

when a word comes apart	**when it does not**
look for the ending first	learn it whole, and move on

Knowing which kind you are looking at is the skill. Trying to decompose *sofá* would cost you minutes and teach you nothing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el sofá*
- a chair, then a sofa
- which syllable takes the stress

Before you move on

The sofa? (**el sofá**.) Could you have built it from a piece you had? (**No.**) Where did it come from? (**Arabic.**)

432.6 (lavadora, contador, estantería, tubería, sofá) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say *the washing machine*, *the meter* and *the sofa*.

Grammar Lens: two endings and one exception

word	built from
la lavadora	lavar + **-dora**
el contador	contar + **-dor**
la estantería	estante + **-ería**
la tubería	tubo + **-ería**
el sofá	nothing — borrowed whole

Four of five came apart. Do not read a rule into it — the next five household words might all be whole. What this chapter is for is the **question**, asked before you reach for a dictionary: *is there a piece in here I already have?*
The two endings answer different questions. **-dor** and **-dora** name the one that does it. **-ería** names where the thing is kept or collected.

What you've built

You could name a house and a chair, and almost nothing inside either. *La casa*, *la silla* and *el agua* have been yours for a long time. What was missing was everything a notice on a door actually talks about: the meter somebody comes to read, the pipework they are repairing, the machine that broke.
You now hold the vocabulary of the **building**, not only of the home.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all five words
- which one you could not have built
- the two endings and what each one does
- they are repairing the pipework and reading the water meter

Before you move on

The shelving? (**la estantería**.) The pipework? (**la tubería**.) And the one that came in whole? (**el sofá**.)

432.7 (un aviso a los vecinos) — the notice on the door

Say *la tubería* and *el agua*. You are about to read the notice those two words exist for.

Your turn

Read it once straight through, then answer.

> **AVISO A LOS VECINOS** El martes cortaremos el **agua** entre las nueve y las dos para reparar una **tubería** del garaje. El miércoles vendrán a leer los **contadores**.

Say these aloud:

- what happens on Tuesday and for how long
- what is being repaired
- what happens the following day

What you've built

Now say these aloud, as if telling somebody who has not read the notice:
Say these aloud:

- on Tuesday there is no water in the morning
- they are repairing a pipe in the garage
- I cannot put the washing machine on until the afternoon
- so I am reading on the sofa until they finish

A notice like this one is where a beginner's Spanish usually stops. Every word in it is ordinary and none of it is in a textbook dialogue. You can read it now, and you could not two chapters ago.

Before you move on

What are they repairing? (**una tubería**.) What are they coming to read? (**los contadores**.) What can you not use that morning? (**la lavadora**.)

Chapter 433

El Edificio Y Sus Normas

Modes: **voice** (7) **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read the notices in a block of flats, say where to leave a key, and say where something is in relation to something else.
>
> *Read the notice or advert this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

433.1 el portal — the big door, and the space behind it

> Say *la puerta*. Say *el edificio*. Between the street and the stairs of a Spanish block there is a space you have no word for. Here it is.

You'll want to know: el portal

el portal — the street door of a block of flats, and the hall behind it.

One word covers both the door and the space. *Te espero en el portal* means downstairs, inside, out of the rain.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

puerta plus **-al**, an ending that makes a bigger or more general thing of the noun it lands on.

the thing	the larger thing
la puerta	el portal
el árbol	la arboleda
la rama	el ramal

English has no single word here, which is why translations reach for *doorway*, *entrance*, *lobby* or *hallway* and none quite fits. When a Spanish word has no clean English partner, learning the **situation** beats learning a gloss: the portal is where you buzz, where the post boxes are, and where you wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el portal*
- the door, then the entrance hall
- I will wait for you in the portal

Before you move on

The street door of a block? (**el portal**.) Which word is inside it? (**puerta**.) Does it name the door or the hall? (**Both.**)

433.2 la portera — the person of the portal

Say *el portal*. Say *el vecino*. There is somebody who is neither a neighbour nor a stranger, and who is in the portal most mornings.

You'll want to know: la portera

la portera — the concierge, the caretaker. **el portero** if a man.

She cleans the stairs, takes in parcels, knows who is away, and is the person a notice tells you to leave a key with.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

portal and **portera** share **puerta**, and the ending **-ero / -era** makes the **person associated with** a thing:

the thing	**the person**
la puerta	la portera
el pan	el panadero
el zapato	el zapatero

You met **-ería** for the place and **-dor** for the doer. This is the third: **-ero** for the person whose job is that thing. Three endings, three different questions, and all of them turn nouns you have into words you have not met.

el portero also means the goalkeeper. The one who guards the gate, in both cases.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la portera*
- leave the key with the concierge
- the person who works with bread, using the ending

Before you move on

The concierge? (**la portera**.) What does **-ero** name? (**The person whose job it is.**) What else is *el portero*? (**The goalkeeper.**)

433.3 el garaje — spelled to be said

Say *el coche*. Say *la portera*. Now name the floor below the portal where the cars live.

You'll want to know: el garaje

el garaje — the garage, the underground car park of a building.
Said *ga-RA-je*, with the **j** as the throaty *jota*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

French **garage** came into Spanish and was **respelled**. French writes the sound at the end with *-ge*; Spanish has no such spelling, so it wrote what it heard with the letter it uses for that sound: **j**.

language	spelling
French	garage
Spanish	garaje

That habit is worth more than the word. Spanish borrows freely but **respells to its own rules**, which is why *fútbol*, *champú* and *chófer* look the way they do. A borrowed word you meet in Spanish has usually been made to spell itself the Spanish way, so read it aloud by Spanish rules and the original often appears.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el garaje*
- the car is in the garage
- why it is not spelled the French way

Before you move on

The garage? (**el garaje**.) Which language did it come from? (**French**.) What did Spanish change? (**The spelling.**)

433.4 la norma — what is written on the wall

Say *el portal*. Say *el garaje*. Both have a list on the wall. Name what that list is called.

You'll want to know: la norma

la norma — the rule. **las normas** — the rules, the regulations.

You meet it in the plural almost always, as a heading: *NORMAS DE USO*, *NORMAS DE PRÉSTAMO*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **norma** was a carpenter's square — the tool for checking a right angle. A thing that matched it was *correct*; a thing that did not was off. The word travelled from the tool to the standard itself, and from there into every European language.
That history explains a family you can now read at sight:

word	**what it holds**
la norma	the standard
normal	matching the standard
enorme	out of the square, huge

enorme is the one worth noticing. *E-* out of, plus *norma*: outside the square. Something enormous is something that will not fit the measure.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *las normas*
- the rules of the building
- what *enorme* has to do with *norma*

Before you move on

The rules? (**las normas**.) What was a Latin *norma*? (**A carpenter's square**.) And *enorme*? (**Outside the square.**)

433.5 junto — together, or beside

Say *la calle*. You can put a thing **in** a street. Say that two people did something **together** and see whether you have the word.

You'll want to know: junto

juntos — together. **junto a** — next to, beside.
Same word, two jobs, and the little **a** is what separates them.

Grammar Lens: the a decides

you say	it means
cenamos juntos	we had dinner together
junto a la puerta	next to the door

Without **a**, it describes the people and agrees with them: *juntos*, *juntas*. With **a**, it stops describing anybody and becomes a position — and then it stops agreeing, staying **junto** whatever follows.
That is a small thing to watch, and it is the sort of small thing a reader trips on: *las cajas, juntas* is a comment about the boxes; *junto a las cajas* is where you are standing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- we went together
- next to the portal
- which of the two agrees with the people

Before you move on

Together? (**juntos**.) Next to? (**junto a**.) Which one changes for gender? (**The one without *a*.**)

433.6 (portal, portera, garaje, norma, junto) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say *the entrance hall*, *the concierge* and *the garage*.

Grammar Lens: three endings, three questions

ending	the question it answers
-dor	who or what does it?
-ería	where is it kept?
-ero	whose job is it?

All three land on **puerta** or a word like it and hand you a noun you never learned. Do not read a rule into it — many words have no ending at all, and *el garaje* and *la norma* in this very chapter came in whole from elsewhere.
What these three chapters have built is a **habit**: before treating a long word as new, look for a piece you already hold.

What you've built

You could describe a home. You could not describe a building. *La casa*, *la puerta* and *el vecino* were yours; the hall, the person who cleans it, the car park beneath it and the list of rules on its wall were not.
Those four are where written Spanish actually meets a resident — on a notice, in a message from an administrator, in an instruction about a key. And **junto a** is the small word that lets you say where any of it is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all five words
- leave the key with the concierge, next to the door
- the rules of the garage
- the three endings and what each asks

Before you move on

The concierge? (**la portera**.) The rules? (**las normas**.) Next to? (**junto a**.)

433.7 (dejar una llave) — read it, then do what it says

Say *la portera* and *el contador*. Both appear in the notice you are about to read, and the notice asks you to do something.

Your turn

Read it once straight through, then answer.

> **NORMAS DEL PORTAL** El jueves vendrán a leer los **contadores** entre las nueve y las dos. Es necesario que haya alguien en casa. Quien no pueda estar debe dejar una llave a la **portera**.

Say these aloud:

- what day they are coming and what for
- what you must do if you cannot be at home
- who you leave the key with

What you've built

Now produce it yourself. Say aloud:
Say these aloud:

- I cannot be at home on Thursday
- I am leaving the key with the concierge
- my car is in the garage, next to the door

This is the level's real test, and it is not a conversation. A2 asks you to read a short official notice and act on it correctly. Three chapters ago the words for the notice did not exist for you; the grammar never changed.

Before you move on

Who do you leave the key with? (**la portera**.) Where do you wait? (**en el portal**.) What is the heading on the wall? (**NORMAS**.)

Chapter 434

El Taller Y La Máquina

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say that a device has stopped working, what part is missing, where it has gone to be repaired and what I am being charged.
>
> *Read the notice or advert this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

434.1 el taller — where things get mended

> Say *el coche*. Say *el trabajo*. The car has stopped working. Name the place it goes.

You'll want to know: el taller

el taller — the workshop, the garage in the sense of *repair shop*.

Careful with that English word: **el garaje** is where you park; **el taller** is where it gets fixed. English uses *garage* for both and Spanish does not.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el taller also means a **workshop** in the other sense — a short practical class. *Un taller de cocina*, *un taller de reparación de bicicletas.*

the phrase	what it is
llevar el coche al taller	the repair shop
un taller de cocina	a hands-on class

The two meanings share a core that English keeps as well: a place where people work with their hands, rather than sit and listen. If a notice offers you a *taller*, expect to do something, not to watch.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el taller*
- I am taking the car to the workshop
- the difference between *el taller* and *el garaje*

Before you move on

Where the car is repaired? (**el taller**.) Where it is parked? (**el garaje**.) What else can a *taller* be? (**A hands-on class**.)

434.2 la máquina — the word above the others

Say *la lavadora*. Say *el ordenador*. You can name particular machines. Name the **kind**.

You'll want to know: la máquina

la máquina — the machine.

Stressed on the first syllable, *MÁ-qui-na*, and the written accent marks it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Notice what **el ordenador** is: *ordenar* plus the doer-ending, the thing that orders. Spanish named the computer after what it **does**, where English named it after **counting**.

language	the computer is
Spanish	the orderer
English	the counter

la máquina sits above all of these as the general term, and it is the word you need for the ones with no special name: *la máquina de hacer*

pan, *la máquina del billete*. When you do not know an appliance's name, *la máquina de* plus what it does will be understood every time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la máquina*
- the washing machine is a machine
- the machine for making bread

Before you move on

The machine? (**la máquina**.) What does *ordenador* literally name? (**The one that orders**.) Which syllable is stressed in *máquina*? (**The first**.)

434.3 la pieza — the part that is missing

Say *la máquina* and *el taller*. The machine is in the workshop and one small thing is wrong with it. Name that thing.

You'll want to know: la pieza

la pieza — the part, the piece, the component.

Falta una pieza — a part is missing. *Era una pieza pequeña* — it was a small part. Both are what a repair shop says to you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la pieza is wider than English *part*. It also names a **room** in some regions, and a **piece of music** almost everywhere.

the phrase	what it means
una pieza de la lavadora	a component
una pieza de Mozart	a piece of music

A word that covers several English words is not being vague. It is naming something English happens to split: *a discrete thing that belongs to a larger whole*. Hold that idea and all three uses follow from

it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la pieza*
- a part is missing
- it was a small part

Before you move on

The part? (**la pieza**.) A part is missing? (**Falta una pieza**.) What else can a *pieza* be? (**A piece of music**.)

434.4 la batería — the ending that is not one

Say *la tubería*. You learned that **-ería** collects. Here is a word that ends the same way. Guess what it collects, then read on.

You'll want to know: la batería

la batería — the battery. The one in a car, a phone, a torch.

It also names a **drum kit**, which is the same idea of *a set of things acting together*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here the guess fails, and it is worth knowing why.
There is no Spanish word *bate* that *batería* collects. The word arrived whole from French **batterie**, where it had been built from *battre*, to beat — a battery of guns, a set of things striking together.

word	where the building happened
la tubería	in Spanish, from *tubo*
la estantería	in Spanish, from *estante*
la batería	in French, from *battre*

So the resemblance is real but it is **inherited**, not made here. That is the honest shape of the rule you have been building for three chapters:

look for the join, and accept that sometimes the join happened in another language and the pieces never entered this one.
A guess that fails costs you nothing. Not guessing costs you every word you could have read.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la batería*
- the car battery
- why *tubería* comes apart and *batería* does not

Before you move on

The battery? (**la batería**.) Is there a Spanish word *bate* under it? (**No**.) Where was it built? (**In French**.)

434.5 el cargador — the one that loads

Say *el móvil*. Say *la batería*. The battery is empty. Name the thing you plug in — and try the ending before you are told.

You'll want to know: el cargador

el cargador — the charger.
cargar — to load, to charge. **cargar el móvil** is to charge the phone.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Fourth time for **-dor**, and by now it should arrive before the lesson does:

verb	the doer
proveer	el proveedor
lavar	la lavadora
contar	el contador
cargar	el cargador

cargar is worth more than the charger. It means *to load*, and it

reaches much further than electricity: *cargar el coche* is to load the car, *la carga* is the load itself, and *no se cobra* from earlier meets it in *hacerse cargo de* — to take charge of something.
The same verb also turns up wherever a shop charges you, which is why **cobrar** and **cargar** feel adjacent without being the same word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cargador*
- I have to charge the phone
- the battery is empty and I have no charger
- all four doer-words you now hold

Before you move on

The charger? (**el cargador**.) The verb? (**cargar**.) What does it mean beyond electricity? (**To load**.)

434.6 (taller, máquina, pieza, batería, cargador) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say *the workshop*, *the machine* and *the charger*.

Grammar Lens: the guess, and the one that failed

word	comes apart?
el cargador	yes — cargar + **-dor**
la batería	no — built in French, not here

Four chapters have now handed you **-dor**, **-ería** and **-ero**, and *batería* is the first word that wore an ending and did not come apart. Do not read that as a warning against guessing. A guess that fails costs nothing; not guessing costs every word you could have read without help.

el taller and **el garaje** are the pair to keep straight: English calls both *garage*, Spanish does not. You park in one and your car is repaired in the other.

What you've built

You could name machines and could not say anything about one that had stopped. *La lavadora* and *el ordenador* were yours; the place they go, the general word for the kind, the part that is missing, the battery that is flat and the charger you lent somebody were not. That is most of what a person actually says about a device — and almost none of it is in a beginner's dialogue, because beginners' dialogues are about things that work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all five words
- the battery is flat and I have no charger
- the car is at the workshop because a part is missing
- which of the five did not come apart

Before you move on

The part? (**la pieza**.) Where the car is repaired? (**el taller**.) The charger? (**el cargador**.)

434.7 (una avería) — the message the shop leaves you

Say *la pieza* and *la lavadora*. The message you are about to hear contains both.

Your turn

Read it once, as though hearing it on the telephone, then answer.

> Buenas tardes, llamo del **taller**. Su **lavadora** ya está reparada: era una **pieza** pequeña, así que no le vamos a **cobrar** la mano de obra. Podemos llevársela el miércoles por la mañana.

Say these aloud:

- what was wrong with it
- whether you are being charged for the labour
- when they can bring it

What you've built

Now the other direction. Say aloud, as if leaving the message yourself: Say these aloud:

- the machine does not work and I think a part is missing
- I am taking it to the workshop on Monday
- I have lent my charger and I need it back

Four chapters ago none of this was sayable, and the grammar has not changed once. Every sentence above uses tenses you already had. What was missing was never structure — it was the nouns that ordinary life is actually about.

Before you move on

Who is calling? (**el taller**.) What was wrong? (**una pieza pequeña**.) What do you need back? (**el cargador**.)

Chapter 435

Los Papeles Del Trabajo

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a job advert, say what experience I have, and say what I must send and bring.
>
> *Read the notice or advert this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

435.1 el currículum — a word that stayed Latin

Say *el trabajo*. Say *el papel*. A job advert asks you to send one particular piece of paper. Name it.

You'll want to know: el currículum

el currículum — the CV, the résumé.

The full form is **currículum vítae**, and in speech people usually say only **el currículum**, or shorten it further to **el currí**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **curriculum** meant *a running*, a lap of a track — from *currere*, to run. *Currículum vítae* is **the running of a life**.
Spanish kept the Latin **-um** ending instead of reshaping it, which marks the word as a formal borrowing rather than an inherited one:

inherited from Latin	borrowed from Latin
la puerta	el currículum
el agua	el álbum

An inherited word has been worn down by centuries of speech; a borrowed one was lifted from a book and still looks like it. That ending is the giveaway, and it tells you the register before you know the meaning: a word ending **-um** in Spanish is almost always formal, technical or administrative.
The same *currere* is under **el curso** and **la carrera**, both of which are also runnings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el currículum*
- send your CV
- what *currículum vítae* means literally

Before you move on

The CV? (**el currículum**.) What does the Latin mean? (**The running of a life**.) What does the **-um** ending tell you? (**It was borrowed, not inherited.**)

435.2 la documentación — the papers, as one thing

Say *el currículum*. Say *el papel*. The garage asked you to bring something more than one sheet. Name it.

You'll want to know: la documentación

la documentación — the paperwork, the documents, your papers.

Singular in form and plural in meaning: one word for **the whole set**. *Traiga la documentación* asks for all of it, not one sheet.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

documentar plus **-ción**, the ending that turns an action into a thing:

verb	**the thing**
documentar	la documentación
reparar	la reparación
informar	la información

Fourth ending in five chapters, and the most productive of the lot. Almost any Spanish verb in **-ar** can take it, and English usually has the twin in **-tion** — so **-ción** words are the cheapest reading you will ever get.
One thing to watch: they are **always feminine**, whatever the verb, and the plural drops the accent — *la reparación*, *las reparaciones*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la documentación*
- bring the paperwork and your CV
- the noun made from *reparar*

Before you move on

The paperwork? (**la documentación**.) What does **-ción** do? (**Turns an action into a thing**.) What gender are they? (**Feminine**.)

435.3 la experiencia — the word you can already read

Say *la documentación*. Say *la empresa*. An advert wants one more thing from you before the papers. Say it and check your guess below.

You'll want to know: la experiencia

la experiencia — experience.

experiencia previa is the set phrase every job advert uses: *se valora experiencia previa*, *imprescindible experiencia previa*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You did not need this lesson to read the word, and that is worth noticing rather than passing over.

Spanish	English
la experiencia	experience
la diferencia	difference
la paciencia	patience

-encia and English **-ence** are the same ending, inherited by both from Latin. Hundreds of words pair this way, and the pairing almost never misleads.

So the real content of this lesson is a **licence**: when a long Spanish noun ends in **-ción**, **-encia**, **-idad** or **-mente**, try the English twin first. You will be right far more often than wrong, and the cost of being wrong is a moment.

That is not true of short words, where the false friends live — *embarazada* does not mean embarrassed, and *éxito* is not exit. The long formal endings are the safe ones.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la experiencia*
- previous experience is essential
- two more words ending in *-encia*

Before you move on

Experience? (**la experiencia**.) Which endings can you usually trust? (**-ción, -encia, -idad, -mente**.) Which words are risky? (**Short ones**.)

435.4 previo — before this one

> Say *la experiencia*. The advert wants a particular kind of it — the kind you got somewhere else, earlier. Name that kind.

You'll want to know: previo

previo / previa — previous, prior, earlier.

experiencia previa — previous experience. **sin previo aviso** — without prior warning, which is the other place you will meet it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pre- before, plus **-vio** from *via*, way. What lies on the way **before**. The position is worth watching, because Spanish adjectives usually follow the noun and this one does both:

phrase	where it sits
experiencia previa	after
sin previo aviso	before

Sin previo aviso is a fixed phrase and keeps the older order. Fixed phrases preserve arrangements that ordinary speech has left behind, which is why they so often look like exceptions — they are the older rule, kept whole.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *previo*
- previous experience is essential
- without prior warning

Before you move on

Previous? (**previo**.) Previous experience? (**experiencia previa**.) Without warning? (**sin previo aviso**.)

435.5 jubilado — the participle that became a person

Say *el pedido*. Say *el trabajo*. You learned that a participle can harden into a noun. Here it hardens into a **person**.

You'll want to know: jubilado

jubilado / jubilada — retired, and also *a retired person.*
jubilarse — to retire. *Se jubila en marzo* — she retires in March.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Same move as **el pedido**, one chapter apart:

verb	participle	used as
pedir	pedido	a thing
jubilar	jubilado	a person

A Spanish participle can stand as an adjective *or* a noun with no further change, which is why *un jubilado* needs no word for *person* in it. **And the root is not what you would expect.** Latin *iubilare* meant to **shout for joy** — it is the same word under *jubilee* and *jubilant*. Retiring in Spanish is, etymologically, letting out a cheer. Whether anybody feels that on the day is another matter, but the word was built by people who thought the end of work was worth shouting about.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *jubilado*
- a retired neighbour
- she retires in March
- the other participle-turned-noun you hold

Before you move on

Retired? (**jubilado**.) To retire? (**jubilarse**.) What did the Latin root mean? (**To shout for joy**.)

435.6 (currículum, documentación, experiencia, previo, jubilado) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say *the CV*, *the paperwork* and *retired*.

Grammar Lens: the endings that read themselves

ending	what it does	example
-ción	action becomes a thing	la documentación
-encia	pairs with English *-ence*	la experiencia
participle	becomes a thing or a person	jubilado

The participle row is the one to keep: **el pedido** in the first chapter of this run was a thing, **jubilado** here is a person, and neither needed an extra word to become one.

Five chapters have now handed you **-dor**, **-ería**, **-ero**, **-ción** and **-encia**. Do not read that as a rule that every word yields — *el currículum* in this very chapter kept a Latin ending and yields nothing. The habit is to look, not to expect.

What you've built

You could say you had a job, and nothing about getting one. *El trabajo*, *la empresa* and *trabajar* were yours; the CV you send, the papers you bring, the experience an advert demands and the word for somebody who has stopped working were not.

A job advert is four lines long and uses all five. That is the shape of A2 reading: short, ordinary, administrative, and impossible without exactly these nouns.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all five words
- previous experience is essential
- send your CV and bring the paperwork
- which one kept a Latin ending

Before you move on

The CV? (**el currículum**.) Previous experience? (**experiencia previa**.) Retired? (**jubilado**.)

435.7 (un anuncio de trabajo) — four lines, five new words

Say *experiencia previa*. The advert you are about to read turns on that phrase.

Your turn

Read it once straight through, then answer.

> **SE BUSCA DEPENDIENTE/A** Tienda del centro. Imprescindible **experiencia previa** de al menos un año. Enviar **currículum** y traer la **documentación** el día de la entrevista.

Say these aloud:

- how much experience they want
- what you have to send
- what you have to bring, and when

What you've built

Now produce it. Say aloud:
Say these aloud:

- I have two years of previous experience
- I am sending my CV today
- my neighbour is retired and does not work now

Five chapters, twenty-five words, and no new grammar at all. Everything you said a moment ago uses tenses you held before this run started. What was missing was the vocabulary an ordinary week is made of — orders, buildings, machines, paperwork — and none of it appears in a beginner's dialogue, because beginners' dialogues are about holidays and hobbies.

Before you move on

What do you send? (**el currículum**.) What do you bring? (**la documentación**.) What is essential? (**experiencia previa**.)

Chapter 436

Gente Y Trato

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can talk about colleagues and groups, offer an alternative, and say who lent, collected or returned a thing.
>
> *Read the notice or advert this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

436.1 el compañero — you already know where this comes from

> Say *el pan*. When you learned it you were told what *com-* plus *pānis* makes. Say that word now, before reading on.

You'll want to know: el compañero

el compañero / la compañera — the colleague, the classmate, the companion.

You were given the etymology long ago and never the word. The bread lesson told you it means *one you share bread with*; this lesson hands you the word to use.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

com- with, plus **pan**, bread, plus **-ero**, the person-ending you met on *la portera*. Three pieces you already hold, and not one of them new. What is worth adding is how wide the word runs in practice:

phrase	who it means
un compañero de trabajo	a colleague
un compañero de clase	a classmate
mi compañero	a partner, depending on context

On its own, **mi compañero** is ambiguous between a work partner and a life partner, and Spanish speakers disambiguate with *de trabajo*, *de piso*, *de clase* when it matters. That ambiguity is not sloppiness; the word never promised more than *the one I share things with.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el compañero*
- a colleague from work
- the three pieces the word is made of

Before you move on

The colleague? (**el compañero**.) What is hiding in the middle of it? (**pan**.) How do you make it mean *classmate*? (**de clase**.)

436.2 el grupo — the unit things get organised into

Say *la clase.* Say *el compañero.* A course splits its people into smaller sets. Name a set.

You'll want to know: el grupo

el grupo — the group.

cambiar de grupo — to switch groups. **el grupo de los martes** — the Tuesday group.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

This one does not come apart. It arrived whole, by way of Italian, and there is no Spanish piece inside it to recognise.
That is the second thing this run has taught you about long-versus-short words:

kind of word	what to do
long and formal	look for the ending
short and plain	learn it whole

el grupo is short and plain, so there is nothing to unfold. Spending time hunting for a join in a five-letter noun is the opposite of the habit — the habit is to look **once**, cheaply, and move on when nothing is there.
Where it matters most for you is administrative: courses, trips, exams and sports are all divided into *grupos*, and the DELE pass rule itself is written in terms of two of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el grupo*
- I have changed groups
- the Tuesday group is too advanced for me

Before you move on

The group? (**el grupo**.) Does it come apart? (**No** — it arrived whole.) To switch groups? (**cambiar de grupo**.)

436.3 ofrecer — to carry it toward somebody

Say *ayudar*. Say *cobrar*. The restaurant has no table on Friday. Say what it does next instead of refusing outright.

You'll want to know: ofrecer

ofrecer — to offer.

Le puedo ofrecer el jueves — I can offer you Thursday. It is the polite move between *no* and nothing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ob- toward, plus **ferre**, to carry. To carry a thing toward somebody. That *ferre* is one of the most productive roots in the language, and once you see it you will read words you have never met:

word	**what is carried**
ofrecer	toward you
transferir	across
referir	back

Watch the spelling in the yo form. *Ofrecer* takes a **z** before the *o*: *ofrezco*, not *ofreco*. Every verb ending **-cer** after a vowel does the same — *conocer / conozco*, *parecer / parezco* — so learning this one buys the pattern for a large family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ofrecer*
- I can offer you Thursday
- the yo form, with its z

Before you move on

To offer? (**ofrecer**.) The yo form? (**ofrezco**.) What do the two pieces mean? (**To carry toward**.)

436.4 prestar — the move that devolver undoes

Say *devolver*. Say *el cargador*. You can already say you gave the charger back. Say how it reached you in the first place.

You'll want to know: prestar

prestar — to lend.

Te presto el cargador — I lend you the charger. And then, later, *te lo devuelvo.*

Grammar Lens: which way is it moving

English has one word doing two opposite jobs — people say *borrow* and *lend* and then muddle them. Spanish keeps the giver's side and marks the receiver's with a preposition:

Spanish	English
te presto el libro	I lend you the book
pedir prestado un libro	to borrow a book

So **prestar** is always the **lender** speaking. To be the borrower you say *pedir prestado* — literally *to ask for it lent*, which uses the *pedir* under **el pedido** from four chapters ago.
The three verbs now sit in a cycle you can say end to end: **prestar** hands it over, the other person has it, **devolver** brings it back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *prestar*
- I lend you my charger
- I lent it to him and he has not given it back
- how to say it from the borrower's side

Before you move on

To lend? (**prestar**.) To borrow? (**pedir prestado**.) And to give it back? (**devolver**.)

436.5 recoger — to gather it back up

Say *el pedido.* Say *el taller.* The order is ready and the car is repaired. Say what you go and do at both.

You'll want to know: recoger

recoger — to collect, to pick up, to fetch, to tidy away.

Vengo a recoger unas fotos — I have come to collect some photos. *Recojo a los niños del colegio* — I pick the children up from school.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

re- back, plus **coger**, to take. To take back up what is there.
One Spanish verb covers what English splits four ways, and the split is arbitrary in English rather than meaningful:

what you recoger	English wants
un pedido	collect
a los niños	pick up
la mesa	clear
la ropa tendida	bring in

Hold the Spanish idea — *gather back up* — and all four fall out of it. Trying to remember four English translations is four times the work for less accuracy.
Watch the spelling: *recojo* with a **j** in the yo form, because *ge* would be said differently from *go*. The sound stays put and the letter moves, which is the reverse of what English spelling usually does to you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *recoger*
- I have come to collect the order
- I pick the children up at five
- the yo form, with its j

Before you move on

To collect? (**recoger**.) The yo form? (**recojo**.) What do the two pieces mean? (**To take back up**.)

436.6 (compañero, grupo, ofrecer, prestar, recoger) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say *the colleague*, *to lend* and *to collect*.

Grammar Lens: the cycle is now complete

step	verb
I hand it over	**presto**
you go and get it	**recoges**
you give it back	**devuelves**

Six chapters ago you could buy a thing and pay for it. You can now describe its whole life: ordered, delayed, collected, lent, returned. **prestar** is the lender's verb only. The borrower says **pedir prestado**, which contains the *pedir* under **el pedido** from the first chapter of this run — so the cycle closes on the word it opened with.

What you've built

Two of these you could have guessed and did not need to be told. compañero was fully explained when you learned *pan*, years of pages ago in book time — *com-* plus *pānis*, one you share bread with — and all this chapter did was hand you the word the story was about. **ofrecer** unfolds into *carry toward*.
The other three are plainer, and that is the honest proportion: some words open, some do not, and the only way to know is to try.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all five words
- I lent my colleague the charger and he has not given it back
- I can offer you Thursday
- I have come to collect the order

Before you move on

To lend? (**prestar**.) To collect? (**recoger**.) What is hiding inside *compañero*? (**pan**.)

436.7 (un aviso del curso) — read it as the person it is for

Say *el grupo* and *recoger*. Both are in the notice you are about to read.

Your turn

Read it once straight through, then answer.

> **CURSO DE COCINA — AVISO** El **grupo** de los martes está completo. Podemos **ofrecer** plaza en el de los jueves. Los materiales se **recogen** en recepción el primer día.

Say these aloud:

- which group is full
- what they can offer instead
- where and when you collect the materials

What you've built

Now produce it. Say aloud:
Say these aloud:

- I have changed to the Thursday group
- a colleague from work lent me the book
- I will collect the materials on the first day

Notice what kind of text this is. It is not a conversation, not a story and not a dialogue between two friends in a café. It is an administrative notice addressed to somebody who has to act on it — and that is what the A2 reading paper is mostly made of.

Before you move on

Which group is full? (**el de los martes**.) What do they offer? (**plaza el jueves**.) What do you do with the materials? (**recogerlos en recepción**.)

Chapter 437

Decidir, Coincidir, Equivocarse

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can decide between two dates, say that one clashes, admit a mistake, say how long something takes, and name the evening meal.
>
> *Read the notice or message this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

437.1 decidir — to cut the question off

> Say *ofrecer*. The shop has offered you Thursday or Saturday. Say what you now have to do.

You'll want to know: decidir

decidir — to decide. **decidirse** — to make up your mind.

Usted decide — you decide. It is what a notice says when it has finished offering and the choice is yours.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de- off, plus **-cidir** from Latin *caedere*, to cut. To **cut the question off**.

The same *caedere* is under a family that all involve cutting something away:

word	what is cut
decidir	the question
preciso	cut exactly to size
conciso	cut short

decidir and **decidirse** are not the same. *Decido el menú* is choosing a thing; *me decido* is the inner moment when you stop hesitating. Spanish marks that difference with the reflexive, where English leans on *decide* versus *make up my mind*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *decidir*
- they offered me Thursday and I have to decide
- the difference between *decido* and *me decido*

Before you move on

To decide? (**decidir**.) To make up your mind? (**decidirse**.) What does the Latin piece mean? (**To cut**.)

437.2 coincidir — to fall on the same day

> Say *el grupo*. Say *decidir*. The Tuesday group meets at the hour you already have something else. Name that problem.

You'll want to know: coincidir

coincidir — to coincide, and in everyday use **to clash**.

Me coincide con el trabajo — it clashes with work. That is the ordinary reason somebody gives for not taking a place.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

co- together, plus the same **-incidir** family as *decidir* — things falling together.
Your English eye can read it without help, and that is the point worth

taking:

Spanish	English
coincidir	coincide
decidir	decide
dividir	divide

But the everyday meaning has drifted. English *coincide* is neutral or lucky; Spanish **coincidir**, said about a timetable, is almost always a complaint. The form is transparent and the use is not, which is exactly where a confident reader gets caught.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *coincidir*
- it clashes with my work
- the Tuesday group clashes with my class

Before you move on

To clash? (**coincidir**.) What does the *co-* add? (**Together**.) Is it usually good news? (**No** — about a timetable it is a complaint.)

437.3 equivocarse — when two things sound the same

Say *el pedido*. The restaurant has sent two salads instead of a salad and a soup. Say what they did.

You'll want to know: equivocarse

equivocarse — to be mistaken, to get it wrong.

Nos hemos equivocado — we have made a mistake. It is how a shop apologises without naming who is at fault.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

aequus equal, plus **vox** voice. *Equal voice* — two things that sound the same and get taken for each other.
That is a precise picture of what a mistake is, and the same two pieces give you a word you may already recognise:

word	**the equal voice in it**
equivocarse	to confuse two things
equívoco	ambiguous

It is almost always reflexive. You say *me equivoco*, not *equivoco*, because the error happens **to you** rather than being done to something else. Spanish uses that reflexive for a whole family of things that befall a person — *caerse*, *olvidarse*, *perderse* — and it is worth noticing as a group rather than memorising one at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *equivocarse*
- we have made a mistake with the order
- I was wrong
- what the two Latin pieces mean

Before you move on

To get it wrong? (**equivocarse**.) The two pieces? (**Equal voice**.) Which form do you use? (**The reflexive** — *me equivoco*.)

437.4 tardar — how long a thing takes

Say *el retraso*. That lesson mentioned a second word for lateness and did not teach it. Say it if you remember; here it is either way.

You'll want to know: tardar

tardar — to take time, to be long about something.

Tardo una hora — it takes me an hour. *¿Cuánto tarda?* — how long does it take?

Grammar Lens: the delay and the duration

el retraso and **tardar** are not interchangeable, and the difference is worth having exactly:

you mean	you say
it is later than promised	lleva retraso
it takes this long	tarda una hora

A journey that **tarda** two hours is not late — two hours is what the journey costs. A train with **retraso** has broken a promise. English blurs both into *late* and *takes*, and a reader who maps one to one will misread a station announcement.

Both come from **tardus**, slow, so the shared root is real and the split is recent.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tardar*
- how long does it take?
- it takes an hour and it is not late

Before you move on

To take time? (**tardar**.) Later than promised? (**con retraso**.) Which one is a broken promise? (**retraso**.)

437.5 cenar — the meal as a verb

Say *comer*. You can say you eat. Say that you eat **in the evening**, and notice how many words English needs.

You'll want to know: cenar

cenar — to have dinner, to dine. **la cena** is the meal itself.

Cenamos a las nueve — we have dinner at nine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish makes a **verb out of each meal**, where English has to say *have* plus a noun:

Spanish verb	English needs
desayunar	to have breakfast
comer	to have lunch
cenar	to have dinner

comer is the trap in that list. You already hold it as *to eat*, and in Spain it also means specifically **to have lunch** — *¿has comido?* at four in the afternoon is asking whether you have had lunch, not whether you have eaten anything at all today.
So the three verbs are a set, and *comer* belongs to it as well as to the general sense.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cenar*
- we have dinner at nine
- the three meal verbs in order
- dinner takes an hour

Before you move on

To have dinner? (**cenar**.) The meal itself? (**la cena**.) What else can *comer* mean in Spain? (**To have lunch**.)

437.6 (decidir, coincidir, equivocarse, tardar, cenar) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *to decide*, *to clash*, *to get it wrong*, *to take time*, *to have dinner*.

Grammar Lens: the reflexive marks what happens to you

plain	reflexive	the difference
decido	me decido	choosing a thing vs making up your mind
equivoco	**me equivoco**	the error befalls you

equivocarse is almost never plain, because a mistake is something that happens **to** a person. The same shape covers *caerse*, *olvidarse* and *perderse* — a family worth noticing together rather than one at a time. **coincidir** takes no reflexive and still points at you: *me coincide* uses the indirect pronoun, not the reflexive, because the clash is reported **to** you rather than done by you.

What you've built

Seven chapters ago you could name things. You can now arrange an evening and say what went wrong with it. You can be offered two dates, decide, say the other one clashes, admit a mistake, say how long something takes and name the meal at the end of it. **tardar** closes a debt: the chapter on delays mentioned it in passing and did not teach it, and a word shown but never given is one a reader half-knows.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all five words
- it clashes with work, so I have to decide
- they made a mistake with my order
- it takes an hour and we have dinner at nine

Before you move on

To clash? (**coincidir**.) To get it wrong? (**equivocarse**.) To take time? (**tardar**.) To decide? (**decidir**.) To have dinner? (**cenar**.)

437.7 (cambiar un plan) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *coincidir* and *decidir*. The message you are about to read turns on both.

Your turn

Read it once straight through, then answer.

> Hola: al final no puedo el jueves, me **coincide** con el curso. Perdona, me **equivoqué** de semana al apuntarlo. ¿**Cenamos** el viernes? Yo **tardo** media hora en llegar, así que sobre las nueve.

Say these aloud:

- why Thursday is impossible
- what mistake the writer admits
- what is proposed instead, and at what time

What you've built

Now write the reply. Say aloud:
Say these aloud:

- Friday clashes with my class
- I got the week wrong too
- I take twenty minutes to get there
- let us decide now and have dinner on Saturday

Every sentence there is an ordinary message between two friends, and none of it was sayable seven chapters ago — not because the grammar was missing, but because the verbs were.

Before you move on

It clashes? (**me coincide**.) I got it wrong? (**me equivoqué**.) Shall we have dinner? (**¿cenamos?**)

Chapter 438

El Cuerpo Y El Descanso

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say where I exercise, report an injury the way a clinic expects to hear it, say I have to rest, and close the story by laughing about it.
>
> *Read the notice or message this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

438.1 el polideportivo — one roof, many sports

> Say **el deporte** and **el gimnasio**. A gimnasio holds one room of machines. Now picture a building that holds a pool, a court and a running track at once.

You'll want to know: el polideportivo

el polideportivo — the municipal sports centre.

Every town of any size has one, and its sign is the one you read to find out what the pool costs and when the court is free. It is a **deporte** word, so it is masculine: *el polideportivo*, *los polideportivos*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Three pieces, and the middle one is already yours.

piece	where it comes from
poli-	Greek *polýs*, many
deportiv-	from **deporte**, sport
-o	masculine ending

Many-sport-place. Spanish did not borrow this word from anywhere; it built it, in the twentieth century, out of a Greek prefix and a Latin stem, because town councils needed a name for a thing that did not exist before.

That Greek **poli-** is the same one inside *polígono* and *poliglota*. It is not the *poli-* of *policía*, which is a different Greek word entirely — *pólis*, the city. Two prefixes that look identical and mean nothing like each other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el polideportivo*
- the difference between a gimnasio and a polideportivo
- what the piece *poli-* is doing in the word

Before you move on

The sports centre? (**El polideportivo**.) What does **poli-** mean? (**Many**.) Which syllable carries the stress? (*-ti-*, the second from last.)

438.2 la natación — the same root, arriving twice

> Say **nadar**. Now say **el polideportivo**. The timetable on its door does not list *nadar*; it lists a noun.

You'll want to know: la natación

la natación — swimming, the activity as a named thing.

Hago natación los martes — I swim on Tuesdays. *Un curso de natación* — a swimming course. **nadar** is what your arms do; **la natación** is what the timetable, the club and the medal call it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nat- from Latin *natāre*, to swim, plus **-ción**, the ending you met on *documentación* for turning an action into a thing.
documentar gave *documentación*; *natar* gives *natación*. Same machine.

Why it's said this way

Here is the part worth slowing down for. **nadar** and **la natación** come from the *same* Latin word, and they do not look alike. That is because they took different roads out of Latin.

the word	**the road it took**
nadar	carried in every mouth, worn smooth
natación	lifted off the page, centuries later

natāre was spoken without a break for a thousand years, and a thousand years of speaking wore the **t** soft into a **d** and dropped a syllable: *natāre* became *nadar*. Then scholars who could read Latin needed a formal noun, went back to the written form, and took *natātiōnem* out intact.
A pair like this is called a **doublet**: one word, two arrivals, both alive. Once you can see them, Spanish is full of them, and the learned twin is nearly always the one on the official sign.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la natación*
- I do swimming at the sports centre
- why *nadar* and *natación* look so different

Before you move on

Swimming, the discipline? (**La natación**.) Which ending makes it a noun? (**-ción**.) Which of the twins was worn down by mouths? (*Nadar*.)

438.3 torcerse — the ankle that turns the wrong way

Say **la natación**, **el pie** and **el tobillo**. Getting out of the pool, the tiled edge is wet. Name the part of you that is about to go wrong.

You'll want to know: torcerse

torcer — to twist something. **torcerse** — to twist a part of yourself.

Me he torcido el pie — I have twisted my foot. This is the sentence a Spanish doctor's waiting room hears twenty times a week, and it is the one you want ready before you need it.

Spanish does not say *my* foot here. It says **el** pie and lets **me** carry the ownership: *me torcí **el** tobillo*, not *mi tobillo*. When the body part is yours and the verb is reflexive, the possessive is redundant and Spanish drops it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **torquēre**, to twist. It is one of those roots that stayed busy.

word	the twist in it
torcer	a joint, the wrong way
torcido	crooked, not straight
antorcha	a torch, of twisted rags

English took the same root twice over: **torque**, the twisting force on a shaft, and **torture**, which needs no explanation once you know the root.

Grammar Lens: the stem that breaks

dormir taught you that some verbs split their vowel when the stress lands on it: *dormir* but *duermo*. **torcer** does the same thing.

form	vowel
torcer, torcemos	**o**, unstressed
me tuerzo, se tuerce	**ue**, stressed

What decides it is stress, not person. Wherever the stress falls on the stem vowel, the **o** breaks into **ue**; wherever the ending pulls the stress away, the **o** holds. That is why *torcemos* keeps its **o** while *tuerce* does not — and why you never have to memorise which forms change.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *torcerse*
- I twisted my foot at the swimming class
- *torcemos* and *se tuerce*, and why the vowel differs

Before you move on

To twist your own ankle? (**Torcerse**.) What is the Latin root? (*Torquēre*, to twist.) What happens to the **o** when the stress lands on it? (**It breaks into ue**.)

438.4 descansar — to un-tire yourself

Say **cansado**, the word for a body with nothing left in it. Say **torcerse**. You have twisted your ankle and you are tired. Name what the doctor is about to tell you to do.

You'll want to know: descansar

descansar — to rest.

Tiene que descansar dos días — you have to rest for two days. *Descanse* on a sign at a viewpoint or a clinic is an invitation to sit. The related noun **el descanso** is what a timetable calls a break, and what a football match calls half-time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

des- plus **cansar**, and you already own the second half.

Cansado came from Latin **campsāre**, which was a sailor's word: to turn a ship round a headland. Turning the ship round, over and over, was the hard work that wore a crew out, and the word slid from the manoeuvre to the exhaustion it caused.

des- is the undoing prefix. Put it on **cansar** and you get the reversal:

word	what it does to the tiredness
cansar	puts it there
descansar	takes it away

Why it's said this way

English **rest** names a condition you are in. Spanish **descansar** names an action you perform on a condition: you go in and remove the tiredness.
That is not a curiosity, it changes how the word behaves. Because it is a reversal and not a state, it takes a duration the way any action does — *descansé media hora*, I rested for half an hour — where English has to reach for *had a rest* to make *rest* countable.
The prefix is productive, so the move is reusable. **des-** on a verb you already know gives you its undoing, and you can often guess the result before anyone teaches it to you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *descansar*
- I twisted my ankle, so I have to rest
- what **des-** is doing to *cansar*

Before you move on

To rest? (**Descansar**.) What does **des-** do? (**Undoes**.) What was *campsāre* originally about? (**Turning a ship round a headland**.)

438.5 reír — the prefix that is not there

Say **la risa**, the noun for the sound itself. Say **descansar**. You are resting a twisted ankle and the whole thing is faintly ridiculous. Name the verb *risa* belongs to.

You'll want to know: reír

reír — to laugh. **reírse de** — to laugh *at* something.

Nos reímos mucho — we laughed a lot. *No te rías* — do not laugh. And **sonreír**, with *son-* from Latin *sub-*, under: a laugh kept low, which is exactly what a smile is.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is the trap, and it is worth setting off deliberately.
reír looks like **re-** plus **ír**. It is neither. There is no prefix and there is no *ir*. The whole word is Latin **rīdēre**, to laugh, arriving in one piece — the *r-e* at the front is nothing more than the first two letters of the root.
You met **batería**, a word that wears an *ending* it never earned. This is the other half of that lesson: a word that wears a *prefix* it never had. Spanish has both kinds, and neither announces itself.

Why it's said this way

The written accent on **reír** is physical evidence, and you can read it. *Rīdēre* had a **d** between its vowels: *ri-d-ere*. Spanish wore intervocalic **d** away in word after word, and when it went here it left the **i** and the **e** standing next to each other with nothing between them.
Two vowels side by side would normally collapse into one syllable. These do not, because they were never together — a consonant used to hold them apart. The accent on the **í** is how Spanish writes down that refusal: *re-ír*, two syllables, the join still visible where the **d** used to be.
The family keeps the evidence too: **la risa** lost the same **d**, while **ridículo** was borrowed back from Latin late enough to keep it. One root, one missing consonant, and a word on each side of the loss.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *reír*
- we rested and we laughed a lot
- what the accent on the **í** is recording

Before you move on

To laugh? (**Reír**.) Is the **re-** a prefix? (**No — it is part of the root**.) Which consonant fell out and left the accent behind? (**The d**.)

438.6 (polideportivo, natación, torcerse, descansar, reír) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *the sports centre*, *swimming*, *to twist your ankle*, *to rest*, *to laugh*.

Grammar Lens: pieces that are real, and pieces that are not

Three of this chapter's words look built. Two of them are.

word	the front piece
polideportivo	real — Greek *polýs*, many
descansar	real — *des-*, the undoing
reír	**not a piece at all**

The test is not how the word looks; it is whether the rest of the word survives without the piece. Take *poli-* off and *deportivo* stands. Take *des-* off and *cansar* stands. Take *re-* off *reír* and nothing is left, which is the proof that it was never a prefix.

Carry that test forward. It is the one move that keeps morphology from turning into guesswork, and it costs you a second per word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I do swimming at the sports centre on Tuesdays
- I twisted my ankle getting out of the pool
- *torcemos* and *se tuerce*, and which one breaks the vowel

What you've built

You can now say where you exercise, what goes wrong there, what you have to do about it, and how you feel about the whole business. That is a complete small episode, and it is the shape a clinic conversation and a message to a friend both take.

You also have a second doublet. **nadar** and **la natación** are one Latin verb arriving twice, once worn down by mouths and once lifted off the page — and the learned twin is the one on the timetable.

Before you move on

To laugh? (**Reír**.) To rest? (**Descansar**.) The sports centre? (**El polideportivo**.) Which of those three has no prefix? (**Reír**.)

438.7 (una lesión en el polideportivo) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *el polideportivo* and *la natación*. Both are on the notice you are about to read, and one of them is cancelled.

Your turn

Read the notice once straight through, then answer.

> **AVISO — POLIDEPORTIVO MUNICIPAL** Los cursos de **natación** de la tarde quedan suspendidos del 3 al 10 de octubre por obras en los vestuarios. Las clases de la mañana siguen igual. Para cualquier duda, escriba a avisos@polideportivo.invalid.

Say these aloud:

- which classes are suspended, and for how long
- which classes are not affected
- where to write if you have a question

Why it's said this way

Now a message from a friend who went anyway, on a morning.

> Fui por la mañana y **me torcí** el tobillo saliendo de la piscina. Nada grave: el médico dice que tengo que **descansar** tres días. Luego **nos reímos**, porque llevaba veinte años sin caerme en ningún sitio.

Notice what each verb is doing. **Me torcí** puts the injury on the speaker without blaming anyone. **Descansar** is an instruction with a duration attached. **Nos reímos** closes the episode, and that closing

move is what a Spanish speaker expects at the end of a small misfortune: name it, size it, laugh it off.
A report that stops after *me torcí el tobillo* sounds like a complaint. The same report with *nos reímos* on the end sounds like a story. Same facts, and the last clause decides which one the listener hears.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four sentences: where you went, what you were doing there, what you twisted, and what you have to do now. End it the way the message above ends it.
Then check yourself: did you say *me torcí* ***el*** *tobillo* and not *mi tobillo*?

Chapter 439

Andenes Y Cierres

Modes: **voice** (7) **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read the signs that decide where I may walk: a platform number, a shop shut for now, a street severed, and an office that has moved.
>
> *Read the notice or message this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

439.1 el andén — where you wait for the train

> Say **el tren**, **la estación** and **la parada**. You are inside the station and the train has not come. Name the strip of concrete you are standing on.

You'll want to know: el andén

el andén — the platform.

El tren sale del andén 4 — the train leaves from platform 4. Announcements put the number after the word, never before, and they say it fast: *andén cuatro*.

The written accent tells you where to put the weight: **an-DÉN**, on the last syllable. Without it the word would be read *AN-den*, and the stress is the part a listener uses to recognise it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

It does not come apart, and this time that is not a trick. Nobody knows where **andén** comes from.
The tempting guess is **andar**, to walk, because a platform is a place you walk along. Dictionaries do not accept it: the endings do not line up, and the word turns up first in senses that have nothing to do with walking. Other proposals have been made and none has carried the field.
So the honest entry is *origin uncertain*, and that is worth meeting on purpose. Any book that produces an etymology for every word is inventing some of them. Spanish has a few hundred words like this, and the right response is to learn the word and let the history stay open.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el andén*
- the train leaves from platform four
- the difference between *la parada* and *el andén*

Before you move on

The platform? (**El andén**.) Which syllable is stressed? (**The last**.) Where does the word come from? (**Nobody knows for certain**.)

439.2 trasladar — carried across

Say **la oficina**, **el piso** and **el andén**. All three are places a thing or a person can be taken **from** one of and **to** another.

You'll want to know: trasladar

trasladar — to move something or someone from one place to another. **trasladarse** — to move yourself, to relocate.

Han trasladado la oficina al centro — they have moved the office to the centre. *Me traslado a Sevilla en enero* — I am relocating to Seville in January.

This is the formal word, the one on a letter from a bank or a clinic. For moving house among friends you would hear *mudarse*, but the notice on the door will say *trasladado*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tras- from Latin *trans*, across, plus **-ladar** from *lātus*, carried.

piece	meaning
tras-	across
-lad-	carried

Carried across. English has the same two pieces bolted together in **translate**, which is a text carried across into another language, and in **relate**, **collate** and **dilate**.

Why it's said this way

Lātus is the odd piece, and it is worth a minute.
Latin's verb for carrying was *ferre*. Its past participle was not *ferred* or anything built from *fer-*; it was **lātus**, from a completely different root that had been absorbed into the same verb long before anyone wrote it down. A verb whose forms come from two unrelated stems is called **suppletive**, and English has the famous one: *go* and *went*, where *went* was borrowed whole from *wend*.
So **trasladar** carries a fossil. The *-lad-* in it is the past participle of a Latin verb whose present tense left no trace in the Spanish word at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *trasladar*
- they have moved the office
- I am relocating to a new flat in January

Before you move on

To move something across? (**Trasladar**.) What do the two pieces mean? (**Across** and **carried**.) Which English word is built from the same two? (**Translate**.)

439.3 cerrado — the word on the glass

> Say **cerrar** and **la puerta**. The office has been **trasladada** and you are standing in front of the old door. Name what the card hanging on it says.

You'll want to know: cerrado

cerrado — closed.

CERRADO POR VACACIONES — closed for holidays. *La piscina está cerrada los lunes* — the pool is closed on Mondays. It agrees like any adjective: *cerrado*, *cerrada*, *cerrados*, *cerradas*, matching the thing that is shut.

It also stretches past doors. *Una curva cerrada* is a tight bend; *un acento cerrado* is a thick accent you struggle to follow. The common thread is **not letting anything through**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cerrar plus **-ado**, the ending that turns an *-ar* verb into its past participle. Nothing exotic: *hablar* gives *hablado*, *cerrar* gives *cerrado*. Underneath sits Latin **claudere**, to shut, which you met under *cerrar*. It is still visible in **la clausura**, **excluir** and English **closure**, **clause** and **claustrophobia** — a fear named for a shut room.

Grammar Lens: two participles, two shapes

abrir gave you **abierto**, which does not follow the pattern. **cerrar** gives **cerrado**, which does. The pair sits on opposite sides of the same shop door, and their shapes do not match.

verb	participle
cerrar	cerrado — regular
abrir	**abierto** — irregular

The regular ones you build; the irregular ones you learn one at a time, and there are only about a dozen that matter. Spanish put the irregularity on the oldest and most-used verbs, which is the usual bargain a language makes: the words you say constantly are the ones that resist tidying.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cerrado*, then *cerrada*
- the office is closed because they have moved it
- *abierto* and *cerrado*, and which one is the irregular shape

Before you move on

Closed? (**Cerrado**.) Feminine? (**Cerrada**.) Is it a regular participle? (**Yes — *-ar* gives *-ado***.)

439.4 cortar — and what a cut road means

Say **corto** and **el cuchillo**. One is a shape, one is a tool, and the same idea is inside both. Name the verb.

You'll want to know: cortar

cortar — to cut.

Corta el pan — cut the bread. *Me he cortado* — I have cut myself. *Se ha cortado la llamada* — the call has dropped, which Spanish sees as a line cut rather than a call lost.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

corto and **cortar** are the same Latin word, one taken as a description and one as an action. *Curtus* meant shortened, cut off.

word	**the same idea as**
corto	the result of the cut
cortar	the act of cutting

English keeps *curtus* in **curt**, a reply cut short, and in **curtail**. The scissors in a barber's window and the adjective for a short skirt are relatives.

Why it's said this way

Now the meaning that catches travellers out. On a road or a rail line, **cortado** does not mean damaged. It means **closed**.

VÍA CORTADA POR OBRAS

A **vía cortada** is a line out of service. A **calle cortada** is a street shut to traffic, often for a market or a race, with nothing wrong with it at all.
Set it beside **cerrado**, which you met a moment ago, because the two are not interchangeable. A shop is **cerrado**: someone shut it and will open it again. A road is **cortada**: the through-route has been severed, and you must go round. Spanish picks the verb by *how* the way is blocked, and a sign that says *cortada* is telling you there is no waiting for it to reopen today.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cortar*
- the street is closed for works
- why a shop is *cerrada* but a street is *cortada*

Before you move on

To cut? (**Cortar**.) What does *VÍA CORTADA* mean? (**The line is closed**.) Which adjective you already had comes from the same Latin word? (**Corto**.)

439.5 tirar — the door that says pull

Say **la caja** and **la puerta**. The street was **cortada**, you carried an empty box round the long way, and now you want rid of it. Name what you do with the box.

You'll want to know: tirar

tirar — to throw, and above all **to throw away**.

Tira la caja — throw the box out. *No tires eso* — do not throw that away. *Tirar la basura* is the everyday phrase for taking the rubbish out, and the bin itself is where things **se tiran**.

Why it's said this way

Now the sign, and it surprises every English speaker exactly once.

> **TIRAR** on a door means **PULL**.

The opposite side says **EMPUJAR**, push. A reader who knows *tirar* as *throw* reads the door as an instruction to hurl something, and gets it backwards.

The two senses are one idea seen from each end. **Tirar** is about applying force along a line away from where the thing sits: a box goes out of your hand, and a door comes out of its frame toward you. Spanish did not split the word; English happens to use two.

the sign	what to do
TIRAR	pull
EMPUJAR	push

Read the door before you lean on it. The mistake is harmless and universal, and knowing it in advance saves you making it in a doorway with people behind you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

It does not come apart, and like **el andén** at the start of this chapter its history is unsettled. A Germanic verb meaning to tear, reaching Spanish through the Goths, is the usual suggestion; an origin in the sound of a snapping cord has also been argued. Neither is agreed.

Two words in one chapter with no recoverable history is not unusual. The very common, very short, very old verbs are the ones whose trail goes cold soonest, because they were worn down long before anyone was writing Spanish at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tirar*
- throw the box away, the street is closed anyway
- what to do at a door marked *TIRAR*

Before you move on

To throw away? (**Tirar**.) What does *TIRAR* mean on a door? (**Pull**.) And the sign on the other side? (**Empujar**, push.)

439.6 (andén, trasladar, cerrado, cortar, tirar) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *the platform*, *to move something across*, *closed*, *to cut*, *to throw away*.

Grammar Lens: three signs that stop you, and they are not the same

English puts *closed* on all three of these. Spanish does not, and the word it picks tells you what to do next.

the sign	what it tells you
CERRADO	shut for now; come back later
CORTADA	the route is severed; go round
TRASLADADO	it is open, somewhere else

A card reading *TRASLADADO* is the one worth recognising fastest, because it is the only one of the three with an address underneath it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the train leaves from platform four
- throw the box away
- what you do at a door marked *TIRAR*, and at one marked *EMPUJAR*

What you've built

You can now read the signs that decide where you are allowed to walk. A station, a shut shop, a severed street and an office that has gone somewhere else are four different pieces of bad news, and you can tell them apart at a glance instead of guessing from context.
You also met the limit of etymology. **el andén** and **tirar** have no recoverable history, and the honest entry for both is *origin uncertain.* Every other word in this chapter and the last came apart; these two did not, and saying otherwise would mean making something up.

Before you move on

To cut? (**Cortar**.) To throw away? (**Tirar**.) Closed, on a shop door? (**Cerrado**.) And on a street? (**Cortada**.)

439.7 (la oficina que se ha mudado) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *el andén* and *cerrado.* You are going to meet four signs in a row, and every one of them is going to send you somewhere else.

Your turn

Read all four, then answer.

1 — ANDÉN 2. SALIDA A LA CALLE.

2 — CALLE MAYOR CORTADA AL TRÁFICO.

3 — CERRADO DE 14:00 A 16:00.

4 — OFICINA TRASLADADA AL NÚMERO 40.

Say these aloud:

- which sign means the place still exists
- which sign is about a time and not a place
- what sign 2 tells you to do about your route

Why it's said this way

Sign 2 repays a second look. **Cortada al tráfico** names *what* the cut applies to, and that qualifier is doing real work: a street can be cut to cars and still open to feet. Spanish puts the limit of the cut inside the same phrase, where English would need a second sentence to say who is still allowed through.

Sign 4 is the one that saves your afternoon: **trasladada**, agreeing with *oficina*, followed by an address. Compare it with a card that said only *CERRADO* — that one would leave you waiting on a pavement for a door that is never opening again.

And when you finally reach number 40, the glass door will say **TIRAR**. Pull it.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Five sentences: which platform you came out at, what the street was like, why the first door was no use, where the office went, and what you had to do to the last door.

Then check yourself: did you make **cortada** and **trasladada** agree with the words they describe?

Chapter 440

La Fiesta Y El Año

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can be invited to a wedding or a birthday, say I went, say what mood I was in, and tell a notice's "is held" apart from a friend's "we're celebrating".
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

440.1 la boda — the vows, taken as one thing

> Say **la fiesta**, **la iglesia** and **la familia**. One day puts all three in the same place. Name it.

You'll want to know: la boda

la boda — the wedding.

Vamos a una boda el sábado — we are going to a wedding on Saturday. Spanish uses the singular for the event and the plural **las bodas** for an anniversary of it: *las bodas de plata* are a silver wedding, twenty-five years on.

The **b** is soft between vowels — *la BO-da*, with the lips barely closing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

boda looks like one solid piece and is not. It is Latin **vōta**, *the vows* — the plural of **vōtum**, a vow.
A wedding was named for what is said at it, and the name is plural

because more than one vow is spoken. Then Spanish stopped hearing the plural and treated the whole word as a single feminine noun, which is why you can now say *una boda*, one-of-the-vows, without it sounding odd to anybody.
English kept the same root in **vote**, **votive** and **devotion**, all of them about something pledged.

Why it's said this way

This is not a one-off. Latin had a third gender, **neuter**, whose plural ended in **-a**, and Spanish lost that gender entirely. The plurals were left standing with a feminine-looking ending and nothing to belong to, so the language took them as feminine singulars.

Latin, a neuter plural	**Spanish, a feminine singular**
vōta, the vows	**la boda**
folia, the leaves	la hoja
ligna, the firewoods	la leña

Every one of those is a **countable plural read as a single mass or event**, and that is the shape to look for: a Spanish feminine noun naming one thing made of many. It is a third way for a word to hide its pieces — not a false ending, not a false prefix, but a number the language forgot.
`cerrado` in the last chapter came apart the moment you looked. **boda** will not, and no amount of looking at modern Spanish would tell you why.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la boda*
- we are going to a wedding on Saturday
- what *boda* originally meant, and why it was plural

Before you move on

The wedding? (**La boda**.) What was the Latin word? (***Vōta***, the vows.) What number was it? (**Plural**.)

440.2 el cumpleaños — the years you have completed

Say *¿Cuántos años tienes?* Say **el aniversario**. Say **la boda**. One day a year answers the first question, and it is not called an *aniversario*.

You'll want to know: el cumpleaños

el cumpleaños — the birthday.

It ends in **-s** and it is **singular**: *el cumpleaños*, *los cumpleaños*. The word does not change; only the article tells you how many.

¡Feliz cumpleaños! — happy birthday. *Mañana es mi cumpleaños* — tomorrow is my birthday.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two words fused into one: **cumple** plus **años**.
cumplir is to complete, to fulfil, to carry something through to its end. *Cumplo treinta* — I complete thirty. So a **cumple-años** is the day the years get completed, and the **-s** you can hear is the plural of *años* trapped inside a word that is now singular.
That is why *el cumpleaños* looks plural and is not. It is not an exception to be memorised; it is a sentence that hardened.

Why it's said this way

Spanish has two words for the same square on the calendar, and they disagree about what is happening.

the word	**what it says is happening**
el aniversario	the **year turns**
el cumpleaños	**you complete** years

Aniversario is *annus* plus *vertere*, the year coming round again — the calendar does the work, and you stand still. *Cumpleaños* puts the work on you: the years are something you finish, one at a time, like a task. Spanish keeps both and uses them for different things. A wedding gets an **aniversario** because a date recurs; a person gets a **cumpleaños** because a person is doing the ageing. That is not a rule anyone wrote down — it is the metaphor inside each word still deciding where it is welcome.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el cumpleaños*, then *los cumpleaños*
- tomorrow is my birthday
- why a wedding has an *aniversario* and a person has a *cumpleaños*

Before you move on

The birthday? (**El cumpleaños**.) Is it plural? (**No — singular, with a plural trapped inside**.) Which two words is it made of? (***Cumple*** and ***años***.)

440.3 celebrar — to make a crowd of it

Say **el cumpleaños**, **la fiesta** and **la música**. You have the day, the party and the sound. Name the verb that puts them together.

You'll want to know: celebrar

celebrar — to celebrate.

Celebramos su cumpleaños en casa — we are celebrating her birthday at home. *Celebrarse* is the form a notice uses: *la reunión se celebra el martes* — the meeting is held on Tuesday.

That second use is worth having early. On an official notice, **celebrarse** does not mean anybody is enjoying themselves; it means the event **takes place**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **celebrāre**, from **celeber** — *crowded, much-visited, thronged.* A *celeber locus* was a place people went to in numbers. To **celebrate** something was therefore to **make a crowd of it**, and only later to enjoy it. The idea underneath is attendance, not happiness.
English took the same root twice: **celebrate**, and **celebrity** — a person who has a crowd.

Why it's said this way

That original meaning is exactly why a town-hall notice can say *se celebra* for an event nobody would call festive.

what the sign says	what it means
se celebra la fiesta	the party takes place
se celebra la reunión	the meeting takes place

Both are *celebrar*, because both are a gathering. English would need two verbs here, and a reader who knows only the happy sense will misread the second one as a joke.
When you meet **celebrarse** on a notice, read it as **is held**. The crowd is what the word is really about, and a meeting has one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *celebrar*
- we are celebrating my birthday at home
- what *la reunión se celebra el martes* is telling you

Before you move on

To celebrate? (**Celebrar**.) What did *celeber* mean? (**Crowded**.) What does *se celebra* mean on a notice? (**It is held**.)

440.4 disfrutar — to take the fruit of it

Say **la fruta**, **descansar** and **celebrar**. Two of those three share a prefix shape. Hold on to that.

You'll want to know: disfrutar

disfrutar — to enjoy.

Disfruté mucho de la boda — I really enjoyed the wedding. *¡Que disfrutes!* — enjoy yourself, said as you hand somebody a ticket or wave them off.

It usually takes **de**: *disfrutar* ***de*** *algo*. Dropping the *de* is common in speech and still reads as informal in writing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dis- plus **frut-**, and the second half is **la fruta** you already have. Both come from Latin **frūctus**, which meant *produce, yield, the thing a plant gives you*.
To **disfrutar** something is to **take the fruit of** it — to get the yield. English has the same picture in *to enjoy the fruits of your labour*, which most speakers hear as a metaphor and which Spanish has compressed into one verb.

Why it's said this way

Now the trap, and it corrects the test you learned two chapters ago. **descansar** is **des-** plus *cansar*, and the prefix **undoes**: it takes the tiredness away. It would be natural to read **dis-** in *disfrutar* the same way and land on *to un-fruit*, which would be the opposite of what the word means.

word	**what the prefix does**
descansar	reverses — removes the tiredness
disfrutar	**intensifies — takes the yield fully**

The piece-test still works: take **dis-** off and *frutar* stands, so the join is real. What the test does **not** tell you is what the join *means*. A prefix that usually reverses does not always reverse, and the only way to know is the word's sense, not its shape.
That is the honest limit of taking words apart. It shows you the seams; it does not read them for you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *disfrutar*
- I really enjoyed the wedding we celebrated
- why *dis-* in *disfrutar* is not the *des-* of *descansar*

Before you move on

To enjoy? (**Disfrutar**.) Which preposition follows it? (***De***.) What does the second half mean? (**Fruit, yield**.)

440.5 el humor — the fluid you are in

Say **reír**, **alegre** and **disfrutar**. All three describe a person having a good time. Now name the thing that person is **in**.

You'll want to know: el humor

el humor — mood, and also humour.

Estoy de buen humor — I am in a good mood. *Está de mal humor* — he is in a bad mood. *Tiene mucho sentido del humor* — she has a great sense of humour.

The **h** is silent here as everywhere in Spanish: *el u-MOR*. And note the preposition — Spanish says you are **de** a mood, of it, not *in* it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **ūmor** meant one thing only: **moisture, a fluid**. English keeps that original sense in **humid**.

Medieval medicine held that a body ran on four fluids, and that whichever one you had most of set your temperament. Your *humour* was literally which liquid you were full of. The theory is long dead, and the word survived it — so when a Spanish speaker says *estar de buen humor*, the sentence still says *to be of a good fluid*, and nobody notices.

Why it's said this way

One Spanish word covers what English splits into **mood** and **humour**, and the split happened in English rather than the join happening in Spanish.

Spanish	English needs
estar de buen humor	to be in a good **mood**
sentido del humor	sense of **humour**

English narrowed *humour* onto the funny sense and borrowed *mood* from its own older stock to carry the rest. Spanish never divided the

work, so *el humor* still holds both — the state you are in, and the thing that makes other people laugh.
That is worth noticing whenever an English pair maps to one Spanish word. The usual cause is not that Spanish is vaguer; it is that English acquired a second word from somewhere and gave it half the job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el humor*
- I am in a good mood and I enjoyed it a lot
- *sentido del humor*, and what the word first meant

Before you move on

Mood? (**El humor**.) Which preposition goes with it? (***De***.) What did the Latin word mean? (**Moisture**.)

440.6 (boda, cumpleaños, celebrar, disfrutar, humor) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *the wedding*, *the birthday*, *to celebrate*, *to enjoy*, *the mood*.

Grammar Lens: three ways a word hides its pieces

You now have a small collection of them, and they fail differently.

the word	what is hidden
boda	a **plural** the language forgot
cumpleaños	a whole **phrase**, fused
disfrutar	a real join whose **meaning** misleads

Boda cannot be recovered from modern Spanish at all — only Latin says why it is one word. *Cumpleaños* can: say it slowly and *cumple* and *años* fall apart in your mouth. *Disfrutar* comes apart cleanly and then lies about what the prefix is doing.

The piece-test tells you **whether** there is a join. It never tells you what the join means, and *disfrutar* is the word that proves it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- we are celebrating my birthday on Saturday
- I am in a good mood
- what *se celebra* means on an official notice

What you've built

You can now be invited to something, say you went, and say how it was. That is the whole social round-trip, and it is what a message from a friend actually contains.
You also have the pair that will keep paying: **celebrarse** on a notice means *is held*, not *is enjoyed*, and **el humor** is one word where English keeps two.

Before you move on

The birthday? (**El cumpleaños**.) The wedding? (**La boda**.) In a good mood? (**De buen humor**.) Which of those two nouns hides a plural? (***Boda*** — *vōta*, the vows.)

440.7 (una invitación y una respuesta) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *la boda* and *celebrar*. The same verb is about to appear twice in front of you, meaning two different things.

Your turn

Read both, then answer.

1 — un mensaje

¡Hola! El sábado **celebramos** mi **cumpleaños** en casa de mis padres. Nada especial, solo familia y unos amigos. ¿Te apuntas?

2 — un aviso en el portal

> La junta de vecinos se **celebrará** el jueves 9 a las 19:00 en el portal. Se ruega puntualidad.

Say these aloud:

- which of the two is something you would enjoy
- what *se celebrará* is telling you in the second one
- where and when each one happens

Why it's said this way

The two uses look identical and are told apart by one thing: whether the verb is reflexive.
Celebramos mi cumpleaños — *we* celebrate, somebody is doing the enjoying. **Se celebrará la junta** — it *gets* held, and no one is named, because a notice does not care who convenes a meeting. The reflexive drains the person out of the sentence, and what is left is the bare fact that the thing takes place.
So the answer to *which of the two would you enjoy* is not a matter of tone. It is in the grammar: the message has a **we**, and the notice does not.
Now answer the message the way a friend would: say yes, say what mood you are in, and say you will enjoy it.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four sentences: accept the invitation, say what mood you are in, say you are sure you will enjoy it, and mention one wedding or birthday of your own coming up.
Then check yourself: did you use **de** after *humor* and after *disfrutar*?

Chapter 441

El Contrato

Modes: **voice** (7) **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read the four pieces of paper that decide where my money goes: what I agreed to, that I agreed to it, what I owe, and what I owe it on.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

441.1 el contrato — drawn together

> Say **el trabajo** and **el documento**. One document turns a job into an obligation on both sides. Name it.

You'll want to know: el contrato

el contrato — the contract.

Un contrato de trabajo is an employment contract; *un contrato de alquiler* is a tenancy agreement. The verb is **contratar**, to hire or to contract: *me han contratado* — they have hired me.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

con- together, plus **-trat-** from Latin **trahere**, to pull or draw.
A contract is **a drawing-together** — two parties pulled into the same agreement. English says the same thing and has stopped hearing it: *contract*, and also *contraction*, which is a muscle drawing itself in.
Trahere is busy in Spanish too. **traer** is to bring, to draw something to

you; **atraer** is to attract; **contraer** is to contract a debt or an illness, the same word as the noun above with its verb ending still on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el contrato*
- they have hired me, I have an employment contract
- what the two pieces of the word mean

Before you move on

The contract? (**El contrato**.) What does **-trat-** mean? (**To draw, to pull**.) The verb? (**Contratar**.)

441.2 firmar — to make it firm

Say **el nombre**, **escribir** and **el contrato**. Writing your name at the bottom of one of those is not the same act as writing it at the top.

You'll want to know: firmar

firmar — to sign. **la firma** — the signature, and also *a firm* in the business sense.

Firme aquí, por favor — sign here, please. *Sin firmar* — unsigned, the state a form is in when the clerk hands it back to you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **firmus**, firm, solid, not moving. To **firmar** is **to make firm**. The name at the bottom is not information; it is the act that hardens a piece of paper from a proposal into an obligation. Spanish says that outright, where English borrowed *sign* from *signum*, a mark, and kept only the mark.

the word	what it is built on
firmar	*firmus*, firm
to sign	*signum*, a mark

English has *firmus* too, in **firm**, **affirm** and **confirm** — all of them about making something hold.

Why it's said this way

Look at what the two words in this chapter are doing so far. **Contrato** draws the parties together. **Firmar** makes the result solid. They are two halves of one physical picture: pull the sides in, then set them.

That picture is why **la firma** can also mean a company. A firm is a name that has been made firm — an entity that holds, that you can sign with and be bound by. Spanish did not need a second word for it, and the double meaning is not a coincidence you have to memorise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *firmar*, then *la firma*
- sign the contract here, please
- why a company can be called *una firma*

Before you move on

To sign? (**Firmar**.) The signature? (**La firma**.) What does *firmus* mean? (**Firm, solid**.)

441.3 fijo — nailed down

Say **la empresa** and **firmar**. A company offers you two kinds of contract, and only one of them ends on a date.

You'll want to know: fijo

fijo — fixed, permanent, settled.

Un contrato fijo is a permanent contract, the one a Spanish job advert contrasts with *temporal*. *Un precio fijo* is a fixed price. *Un cliente fijo* is a regular. The verb is **fijar**, to fix or to set: *fijar una fecha* — to set a date.

It agrees: *fijo*, *fija*, *fijos*, *fijas*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **fīgere**, to drive in, to fasten — the verb for putting a stake in the ground. **Fijo** is its past participle, worn down: *the thing that has been fastened*.

English took the same participle intact as **fix**, and kept the original sense in **transfix**, to pin something through.

So the chapter now has three ways of binding, and they are all physical:

word	the picture
contrato	pulled together
firmar	made solid
fijo	driven in

Why it's said this way

cerrado is a participle you can still feel as one: *cerrar* is right there, and nobody would call *cerrado* a plain adjective.

fijo is a participle too, and nothing about it feels like one. The verb *fijar* exists, but it was built backwards *from* the adjective rather than the other way round, and the form you would expect — *fijado* — also exists and means something narrower.

That is what age does. A participle used constantly enough stops being read as the result of an action and becomes a quality in its own right. **Cerrado** is still at the first stage; **fijo** finished the journey centuries ago.

When you meet a short adjective ending in a bare vowel where a verb also exists — *fijo*, *limpio*, *seco* — it is worth asking which came first. The answer is often not the one the modern shape suggests.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *fijo*, then *fija*
- I signed a permanent contract
- what *fijar una fecha* means

Before you move on

Permanent? (**Fijo**.) What did *fīgere* mean? (**To drive in, to fasten**.) The verb built from it? (**Fijar**.)

441.4 la factura — a making, itemised

Say **pagar**, **la cuenta** and **el precio**. In a restaurant you ask for *la cuenta*. For work done on a **contrato**, the paper has a different name.

You'll want to know: la factura

la factura — the invoice, the bill.

La factura de la luz — the electricity bill. *¿Me hace una factura?* — could you make me out an invoice? The verb is **facturar**, to invoice, and also to check in luggage at an airport.

la cuenta is what you ask for at a table; **la factura** is the formal document, with a number on it, that a business issues and a tax office may want to see.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **facere**, to make or do, plus **-tūra**, an ending that names **the thing an action produces**.

verb	the thing it produces
facere, to make	**factura**, a making
escribir, to write	escritura, a writing
leer, to read	lectura, a reading

A *factura* is literally **a making** — the itemised account of what was made or done for you. The ending is still productive, so when you meet an unfamiliar noun in **-ura**, look for the verb inside it before you look it up.

Why it's said this way

Facere is one of the two or three hardest-working roots in the language, and you can see it under a lot of words that do not look related. **hacer** is its direct Spanish descendant — *facere* lost its **f** to an **h** the way *filius* became *hijo*. **satisfacer** is *satis* plus *facere*, to make enough. **fácil** is what can be done.

So *la factura* and *hacer* are the same word arriving by different routes: one worn smooth by a thousand years of speech, one lifted off the page by clerks who needed a formal noun. That is the same doublet shape as **nadar** and **la natación** — and, as there, the learned twin is the one on the official paper.

A **precio fijo** and a **factura** belong to the same world: both are things written down so they stop moving.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la factura*
- I have to pay the electricity bill
- the difference between *la cuenta* and *la factura*

Before you move on

The invoice? (**La factura**.) What does the ending **-ura** name? (**The thing an action produces**.) Which everyday verb is its worn-down twin? (**Hacer**.)

441.5 el préstamo — what lending leaves behind

Say **prestar**, **el banco** and **el dinero**. You have the verb for handing something over. Name the thing that exists afterwards.

You'll want to know: el préstamo

el préstamo — the loan.

Pedir un préstamo — to apply for a loan. *Devolver el préstamo* — to pay it back, with the same **devolver** the lending cycle already gave you.

The stress is three syllables from the end — **PRÉS-ta-mo** — and the written accent is what tells you so. Without it the word would be read *pres-TA-mo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

It is **prestar** with a noun ending, and both go back to Latin **praestāre** — *prae-* in front, plus *stāre*, to stand. To *praestāre* was **to stand out in front of** someone: to furnish, to supply, to put something forward. So a **préstamo** is what has been *put forward*, and English keeps the same idea in **to advance** a sum.
This completes a set you already had. **Prestar** hands it over, **recoger** fetches it, **devolver** brings it back — and now **el préstamo** is the name of the thing while it is out of your hands.

Why it's said this way

Préstamo has a second life worth knowing, because you will meet it in this kind of explanation rather than at a bank.
Un préstamo lingüístico is a **loanword** — a word one language has taken from another. Spanish calls **garaje** and **sofá** *préstamos*, and it uses the borrowing metaphor exactly as English does, down to the fact that nobody gives them back.

the word on the page	what it is a loan of
un préstamo del banco	dinero
un préstamo del francés	una palabra

That is the sense in which **factura** is not a *préstamo* and **garaje** is: *factura* was taken from the Latin that Spanish itself grew out of, which makes it an inheritance claimed late rather than a borrowing from a neighbour.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el préstamo*
- I asked the bank for a loan and I am paying it back
- what *un préstamo del francés* means

Before you move on

The loan? (**El préstamo**.) Which syllable is stressed? (**The third from the end**.) What did *praestāre* mean? (**To stand out in front, to furnish**.)

441.6 (contrato, firmar, fijo, factura, préstamo) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *the contract*, *to sign*, *permanent*, *the invoice*, *the loan*.

Grammar Lens: paperwork is a set of physical acts

Nothing in this chapter began as an abstraction. Every one of the three binding words is a thing done with the hands.

word	the act underneath
contrato	pull the two sides together
firmar	make the result solid
fijo	drive it in so it cannot move

Read a Spanish contract with those three in mind and the vocabulary stops looking like jargon. *Contratar*, *firmar*, *fijar* — draw, harden, fasten. The law borrowed its whole vocabulary from carpentry and rope.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I signed a permanent contract with the company
- I asked for a loan and I have to pay it back
- could you make me out an invoice

What you've built

You can now read the four pieces of paper that decide where your money goes — what you agreed to, that you agreed to it, what you owe, and what you owe it on. That is the administrative half of

living somewhere, and it is what an A2 reading paper is mostly made of.
You also have two endings that keep paying. **-ura** names the thing an action produces, so *factura*, *escritura* and *lectura* stop being three separate words to learn. And **fijo** showed that a participle used long enough stops feeling like one at all.

Before you move on

The invoice? (**La factura**.) The contract? (**El contrato**.) The loan? (**El préstamo**.) Which everyday verb is *factura*'s worn-down twin? (**Hacer**.)

441.7 (una oferta de trabajo) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *el contrato* and *fijo*. The advert you are about to read uses both, and the second one is the part that matters.

Your turn

Read both, then answer.

1 — oferta de empleo

Se busca ayudante de cocina. **Contrato fijo** a partir de enero, jornada completa. Se valora experiencia previa. Enviar currículum a empleo@cocinacentral.invalid.

2 — un aviso del banco

Le recordamos que la cuota de su **préstamo** se cargará el día 5. Puede descargar la **factura** del mes en su área privada. Cualquier cambio de cuenta debe comunicarse **firmado**.

Say these aloud:

- what kind of contract the job offers, and from when
- which of the two documents you would have to sign
- what the bank will do on the fifth

Why it's said this way

Notice the last line of the second notice: **debe comunicarse firmado**. There is no *you* in it. **Comunicarse** drains out the person exactly as *celebrarse* did on the notice about the meeting, and **firmado** is the participle doing an adjective's work, the way *cerrado* does on a shop door. The sentence says *any change must be communicated in-a-signed-state*, and names nobody at all.

That impersonal shape is the register of official Spanish, and it is worth recognising rather than translating. When a notice stops naming who must act, it is not being vague — it is saying the obligation attaches to the *document*, not to a particular clerk.

Contrast the job advert: *se busca*, *se valora*, *enviar*. Same move. An advert and a bank notice are written by the same hand.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Five sentences: say you applied, say what contract you were offered, say you signed it, say you have a loan to pay, and say when the bill arrives.

Then check yourself: did **fijo** agree with *contrato*, and did you use **pedir** with *préstamo* rather than *preguntar*?

Chapter 442

La Gestion

Modes: **voice** (6) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can deal with an institution rather than a person: book the appointment, read what the office wants, track what it sent me, and do it on a screen.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

442.1 la administración — the lesser one, serving

> Say **la oficina**, **el documento** and **servir**. Put the three together and you have named the thing that asks you for papers.

You'll want to know: la administración

la administración — the administration, and in Spain usually **the state**: *la Administración* with a capital letter is officialdom as a whole.

Trabaja en la administración — he works in the public sector. *Trámites con la administración* — dealings with officialdom. The verb is **administrar**, to manage or to administer.

The ending is **-ción**, which you have had since the chapter on paperwork, so the word is *the act of administering* made into a thing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ad- towards, plus **ministr-** from Latin **minister**, a servant or attendant, plus **-ción**.
And *minister* comes from **minus**, less. A *minister* was **the lesser**

one, the person who serves — which is why the word for a government's most senior officials is built on the word for *less*.
The pair is the point:

Latin word	built on	what it named
minister	*minus*, less	the one who serves
magister	*magis*, more	the one who directs

Magister is where **el maestro** comes from. So *maestro* and *ministro* are the same shape twice over, once on *more* and once on *less*, and Spanish kept both.
You already own the smaller half of that pair outright: **menos** is *minus*, unchanged in meaning and barely changed in sound. The administration is named with the same word you use to say *less*.

Why it's said this way

That etymology is not a curiosity here; it tells you the register. **La administración** is what a notice calls itself when it wants to sound like an institution rather than a person. A letter from it will not say *le pedimos* — it will say *se requiere*, and it will ask for **documentación** rather than papers.
So when you see the word on a form, expect the impersonal grammar that comes with it. The vocabulary and the sentence shape travel together, and recognising one tells you to expect the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la administración*
- she works in an office, in the public sector
- what *minister* originally meant, and what *magister* meant

Before you move on

The administration? (**La administración**.) What does *minus* mean? (**Less**.) And the word built on *more*? (***Magister***, behind *maestro*.)

442.2 el envío — put on the road

Say **enviar** and **la carta**. Say **la administración**. You have the verb for sending. Name the thing that is on its way.

You'll want to know: el envío

el envío — the shipment, the dispatch, the consignment.

Gastos de envío — shipping costs, the line on every order page. *Su envío está en camino* — your parcel is on its way. *El envío se ha retrasado* uses the **retraso** family you already have.

The accent sits on the **í** and breaks it away from the **o**: *en-VÍ-o*, three syllables.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

enviar is Latin **inviāre** — **in-** onto, plus **via**, a road.
To send something was **to put it on the road**, and the road is still sitting inside the word. *El envío* is what has been put on it.

word	**the road in it**
enviar	put onto the way
el envío	the thing on the way

English has *via* unchanged as a preposition, and the same *via* is inside **obvious** — *ob viam*, lying in the way, so plain you trip over it.

Why it's said this way

Envío is the second word in two chapters built by putting a plain ending on a verb you already own: *prestar* gave **préstamo**, *enviar* gives **envío**.
That is a pattern worth using deliberately. When you know a Spanish verb and need the noun for its result, the noun very often exists and is short — and you can usually recognise it even when you could not have produced it.
The administración will use the noun where a friend would use the verb. A friend says *te lo envío*; the tracking page says *su envío*. Same event, and the choice of word tells you who is writing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el envío*
- the shipping costs are not included
- what the word *via* is doing inside *enviar*

Before you move on

The shipment? (**El envío**.) Which Latin word is hidden in it? (***Via***, a road.) How many syllables? (**Three — en-VÍ-o**.)

442.3 concertar — agreeing, by way of a fight

Say **la cita** and **la hora**. Say **el envío**. You know the appointment and you know the time. Name the act of fixing them together.

You'll want to know: concertar

concertar — to arrange, to set up by agreement.

Concertar una cita — to make an appointment. It is the verb a clinic, a bank or a council uses on its website, where a friend would say *quedar*.

It breaks its stem under stress, like *cerrar*: **concierto**, **conciertas**, **concierta**, but *concertamos*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Say the *yo* form aloud: **concierto**. You have met that word already, and it meant a performance.

el concierto and **yo concierto** are the same word. Both are Latin **concertāre**, and here is the part that surprises people: *concertāre* meant **to contend, to fight it out** — *con-* together plus *certāre*, to compete.

what it became	**how the contest turned into it**
concertar una cita	settle it by thrashing it out
un concierto	voices contending *with* each other

The sense slid from fighting *against* to striving *together*, and both descendants kept a piece of it. A negotiation and an orchestra are the same activity seen from two moods.

Why it's said this way

English has the same pair and hides it every bit as well. A **concert** is the performance; **to concert** an effort, and **in concert with**, are the agreement sense, and **concerted** is what several people fought out in advance.
So *concertar* is not a word to learn cold. You already had **el concierto**, and the only new thing is that the noun has a verb standing behind it.
That is worth doing on purpose whenever a new verb looks like a noun you know. Check whether they are the same word before you treat them as two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *concertar*
- I want to make an appointment for Thursday at nine
- why *concierto* has two meanings

Before you move on

To arrange an appointment? (**Concertar una cita**.) What did *certāre* mean? (**To compete, to fight**.) What is the *yo* form? (**Concierto**.)

442.4 la reunión — made one again

> Say **la sala** and **celebrar**. Say **concertar**. You can fix a time and you know what a notice calls holding an event. Name the event itself.

You'll want to know: la reunión

la reunión — the meeting.

Una reunión de vecinos is a residents' meeting, the one whose notice goes up in the entrance hall. *La sala de reuniones* is the meeting room. The verb is **reunirse**: *nos reunimos el jueves* — we are meeting on Thursday.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

re- again, plus **unir** from Latin **ūnus**, one, plus **-ión**.
A *reunión* is **a making-one-again**. The word assumes the people were together before and have scattered, which is why *reunirse* also covers a family gathering and why English **reunion** sounds warmer than **meeting**.
Spanish uses the one word for both. *Una reunión de trabajo* and *una reunión familiar* are the same noun, and only the adjective says which.

Why it's said this way

Put this next to **celebrarse**, which you met on a notice meaning *is held*.

> La reunión de vecinos se **celebrará** el jueves.

Both halves of that sentence are about a crowd. **Celebrar** is built on *celeber*, thronged; **reunión** is built on making people one again. The sentence says, twice over, that people are being brought together — and neither word mentions anybody doing the bringing.
That doubling is ordinary in official Spanish. Once you can hear it, a notice stops being a wall of formal vocabulary and becomes two or three plain ideas said in their dressed-up clothes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la reunión*
- we are meeting on Thursday in the meeting room
- I want to arrange a meeting

Before you move on

The meeting? (**La reunión**.) Which number is inside it? (***Ūnus***, one.) What does the **re-** add? (**Again**.)

442.5 la pantalla — the thing you put in front of a light

Say **el ordenador** and **el móvil**. Say **la reunión**. Both devices have the same part, and a meeting held remotely happens on it.

You'll want to know: la pantalla

la pantalla — the screen.

La pantalla del ordenador, *la pantalla del móvil*. *Compartir pantalla* — to share your screen. *En pantalla* — on screen. It also still means a lampshade, and a cinema screen: *la gran pantalla* is the big screen.

The **ll** is one sound, not two: *pan-TA-ya*.

Why it's said this way

The oldest sense is the useful one. A *pantalla* was **a shade put in front of a flame** so the light did not hit your eyes directly.
That is one idea, and every later use is the same idea moved:

what it shades	the sense
a candle	the lampshade
a projector's beam	the cinema screen
a lit device	the phone or computer screen

Nothing about a modern screen shades anything, but the word arrived by way of things that did. Spanish did not borrow a new word for the new object; it moved an old one, and the chain is short enough to hold in your head.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

It does not come apart, and its history is unsettled. Dictionaries reach for a crossing of two older words and do not commit further; no derivation has carried the field.
That makes three now — **el andén**, **tirar** and **la pantalla** — and it is the same honest answer each time. You met the piece-test in the chapter on the sports centre: take a piece off and see whether the rest stands. These words fail that test at the first step, because there is no piece to take off, and no amount of staring at modern Spanish supplies one.
What you *can* do with a word like this is what the block above did:

follow the **meanings** instead of the parts. *Pantalla* has no recoverable ancestry and a perfectly clear career, and the career is what makes it memorable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la pantalla*
- the meeting is on screen, I will share my screen
- what a *pantalla* was before it was a screen

Before you move on

The screen? (**La pantalla**.) What did it mean first? (**A shade in front of a light**.) Does the word come apart? (**No, and its origin is unsettled**.)

442.6 (administración, envío, concertar, reunión, pantalla) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *officialdom*, *the shipment*, *to arrange an appointment*, *the meeting*, *the screen*.

Grammar Lens: two routes into a word, and when each one runs out

Four of this chapter's five words come apart cleanly.

word	the part that carries it
administración	*minus*, less — the one who serves
reunión	*ūnus*, one — made one again
pantalla	**nothing; follow the meanings instead**

For **pantalla** the parts route is closed, and a different one is open: a shade in front of a flame, then in front of a projector, then in front of a lit device. One idea moved three times.

Both routes make a word stick. What does not work is insisting on the

first when only the second is available, because that is how invented etymologies get made.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I want to arrange a meeting for Thursday
- the shipping costs are not included
- *concertar* and *un concierto*, and why they are one word

What you've built

You can now deal with an institution rather than a person — book the appointment, read what the office wants, track what it sent you, and do it on a screen. That is the half of A2 reading that is not about friends.
The register travels with the vocabulary. **La administración** does not write *le pedimos*; it writes *se requiere*. When one of these words appears, expect the impersonal grammar that comes with it.

Before you move on

The meeting? (**La reunión**.) The screen? (**La pantalla**.) Officialdom? (**La administración**.) Which of the three has no recoverable origin? (***Pantalla***.)

442.7 (una cita con la administración) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *la administración* and *concertar*. The page you are about to read uses both, and it never once says *you*.

Your turn

Read it once straight through, then answer.

en la web de la administración

> Para **concertar** una cita, seleccione el trámite en la **pantalla** de inicio. Se requiere documentación en vigor. La cita se confirmará por correo. Si no puede acudir, se ruega anular con 24 horas de antelación.

Say these aloud:

- what you have to do first
- what you must bring
- what to do if you cannot come

Why it's said this way

Count the people in that notice. There are none.
Se requiere, **se confirmará**, **se ruega** — three verbs, no subject. The one exception is *seleccione*, an instruction aimed at whoever is reading, and even that is the formal form that avoids saying *tú*.
This is the same **se** you met on *la junta se celebra* and *la oficina ha sido trasladada*: it takes the person out and leaves the obligation attached to the procedure. A public-sector page is written this way from top to bottom, and once you expect it, the sentences get shorter — *se requiere documentación* means no more than *bring your papers*.
The tracking page for your **envío** and the notice about the **reunión** use exactly the same grammar. One register, three settings.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Five sentences: say you want to make an appointment, say what the screen asked for, say what papers you took, say the meeting was moved, and say your parcel has not come.
Then say the first one again the way the website would say it, with no *you* in it at all.

Chapter 443

El Animo

Modes: **voice** (6) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can say what is going on inside me: what hurts, what I care about, what I am struggling to do, and what I wish I had not done.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

443.1 doler — the pain does the acting

> Say **el dolor** and **la cabeza**. You have the noun for pain and the part of you that has it. Name the verb.

You'll want to know: doler

doler — to hurt, to ache.

Me duele la cabeza — I have a headache. *Me duelen los pies* — my feet hurt. *¿Le duele aquí?* — does it hurt here? That last one is what a doctor says, and it is worth having ready before you need it.

Grammar Lens: it is built like gustar

Look at *me duele la cabeza* and find the subject. It is not *me*. **La cabeza** is the subject; the head is what does the hurting, and *me* is the person it happens to.
That is the same machine as **gustar**, which you have had since early on.

Spanish	what is the subject
me gusta el pan	**el pan**
me duele la cabeza	**la cabeza**

So the verb agrees with the body part, not with you: *me duele la cabeza* but *me* ***duelen*** *los pies*. Two feet, plural verb. This is the single most common mistake English speakers make with the word, because English puts the person in charge — *I have a headache* — and Spanish does not.
Nothing new is being learned here. You already owned the pattern; this is a second verb that runs on it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **dolēre**, to hurt. **el dolor** is its noun and you have had it for a long time; **doler** is the verb it was cut from.
The stem breaks under stress, exactly as *dormir* and *torcer* do: *doler*, *dolemos*, but **duele** and **duelen**. Same condition, same result — when the stress lands on the **o**, the **o** opens into **ue**.
English keeps *dolēre* in **condolence**, hurting *with* somebody, and in **doleful**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *doler*
- I have a headache
- my feet hurt — and check which word the verb agreed with

Before you move on

To hurt? (**Doler**.) My feet hurt? (**Me duelen los pies**.) Which verb is it built like? (***Gustar***.)

443.2 interesar — what lies between you and a thing

Say **interesante** and **estudiar**. Say **doler**. You can call a class interesting. Now say that it interests *you*.

You'll want to know: interesar

interesar — to interest, to be of interest to somebody.

Me interesa la clase — the class interests me, I am interested in it. *No me interesa* — I am not interested, which is the ordinary way to decline an offer. **interesarse por** is to take an interest in: *se interesó por mi salud*.

You already had **interesante**. This is the verb the adjective was made from, so the only new thing is what it does in a sentence.

Grammar Lens: the same machine again

Me interesa el curso has the same shape as *me duele la cabeza*.

Spanish	the subject	the person
me duele **la cabeza**	la cabeza	me
me interesa **la clase**	la clase	me

The verb agrees with the thing, not with you — *me interesan **las clases***, plural. Once you have seen the pattern three times (*gustar*, *doler*, *interesar*) it stops being a special case and becomes what this whole family of verbs does.

English turns them the other way round and needs an adjective to do it: *I am interested*. Spanish keeps the thing in charge.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **inter esse** — **inter**, between, plus **esse**, to be. To *interest* somebody was for a thing **to be between** them and something else: to be involved, to be at stake.

That older sense is still in **el interés** on a loan, which is what is at stake in the deal, and in English **interested party** — not a party that is curious, but one with something at stake.

So *interesante* does not mean "makes me curious" at root. It means **standing between**, involved, concerned. The curiosity sense came later and took over.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *interesar*
- the class interests me and I want to study it
- *no me interesa*, and why it is a polite refusal

Before you move on

To interest? (**Interesar**.) What do the two Latin pieces mean? (**Between** and **to be**.) Which verbs is it built like? (***Gustar*** and ***doler***.)

443.3 acercarse — making it near

Say **cerca** and **lejos**. Say **interesar**. You can say where something is. Name the act of closing the gap.

You'll want to know: acercarse

acercar — to bring something nearer. **acercarse** — to come closer yourself.

Acércate — come here, come closer. *Me acerqué a la ventana* — I went over to the window. *Se acerca la fecha* — the date is getting close, which a Spanish speaker says about an exam or a deadline the way English says *it's coming up*.

It takes **a**: *acercarse* ***a*** *algo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

a- plus **cerca** plus the **-ar** ending, and every piece is one you own.

piece	**what it does**
a-	towards
cerc-	**cerca**, near
-ar	makes it a verb

That is Spanish building a verb out of a preposition, and it does it constantly: *acercar* from *cerca*, *alejar* from *lejos*, *aclarar* from *claro*. The pattern is **a-** plus a word plus **-ar**, meaning *to make it that*. Underneath, *cerca* is Latin **circā**, around — the same root English has

in **circa** on a date and in **circle**. Something near you was something *round about* you.

Why it's said this way

The reflexive is doing real work. **Acercar** something is an act with an object; **acercarse** turns it back on the subject.
But notice the third example above. *Se acerca la fecha* — the date does not move, and nobody moves it. Spanish still uses the reflexive, because what it marks is not *doing it to yourself* so much as **nobody else did it**: the change happened, and the sentence declines to name an agent.
That is the same reflexive you met on *equivocarse*, where the mistake befalls the person. One form, one job: take the doer out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *acercarse*
- come closer, you are too far away
- the date is getting close

Before you move on

To come closer? (**Acercarse**.) Which word is inside it? (***Cerca***.) Which preposition follows? (***A***.)

443.4 concentrarse — gathered to a point

Say **el centro** and **el examen**. Say **acercarse**. The exam is getting close. Name what you have to do with your attention.

You'll want to know: concentrarse

concentrarse — to concentrate.

No me puedo concentrar — I cannot concentrate. *Concéntrate en el examen* — concentrate on the exam. **la concentración** is both the mental state and, in a notice, a gathering of people in a square.

It takes **en**: *concentrarse **en** algo.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

con- together, plus **centr-** from **el centro**, plus the verb ending. To concentrate is **to bring together to a centre**, and the reflexive says you are doing it to yourself.

piece	**what it does**
con-	together
centr-	**el centro**
-arse	to yourself

That is the third verb in this chapter built by putting a prefix and an ending on a word you already owned — *acercarse* on *cerca*, *concentrarse* on *centro*. Look for the bare word inside before you look anything up.

Why it's said this way

El centro is not originally about the middle of a town.
Greek **kéntron** was **a goad** — the spike used to drive cattle — and then the fixed point of a pair of compasses, the spike you press into the paper so the other leg can swing round it. Latin took it as *centrum*, and the geometry sense is what survived.
So a centre is, at bottom, **the point that does not move while everything else turns around it**. That is a better picture than "the middle", and it explains *concentrarse*: you are pulling a scattered mind in towards the one fixed point.
English has the same spike in **eccentric** — *ek-*, out of, plus the centre. An eccentric wheel is one whose axle is off the fixed point, and an eccentric person is one whose life turns around a different one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *concentrarse*
- the exam is getting close and I cannot concentrate
- what *kéntron* meant before it meant a centre

Before you move on

To concentrate? (**Concentrarse**.) Which preposition follows it? (***En***.) What was a *kéntron*? (**A goad, then the fixed point of a pair of compasses**.)

443.5 arrepentirse — the verb that is not made of *sentir*

Say **perdón**. Say **equivocarse**. You can admit a mistake and you can ask to be excused for it. Name the feeling that comes in between.

You'll want to know: arrepentirse

arrepentirse — to regret, to be sorry for having done something.

Me arrepiento de haberlo dicho — I regret having said it. *No te vas a arrepentir* — you will not regret it, which is what somebody says to talk you into something.

It takes **de**, and it is always reflexive. There is no plain *arrepentir*.

Equivocarse is the error; **arrepentirse** is what you feel about it afterwards.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here is the trap, and this chapter has earned it.

arrepentirse looks like **a-** plus **re-** plus **sentir**, with the **s** worn away. It is not. There is no *sentir* in it at all.

The middle is Latin **paenitēre**, to cause regret — the verb behind English **penitent**, **penance** and **repent**. Spanish took *repentirse* and put its familiar **a-** on the front.

what it looks like	what it is
a- + re- + sentir	a- + re- + **paenitēre**

And the trap is doubled, because **it conjugates like *sentir* too**: *me arrepiento*, *te arrepientes*, *se arrepiente*, *nos arrepentimos*. That is the **e→ie** break, exactly as *siento*, *sientes*, *siente*, *sentimos*.

So the form misleads and the behaviour agrees with the form. Both are accidents of shape: any verb with a stressed **e** in its stem breaks that

way, related or not.

Why it's said this way

This is the strongest case yet for the test you have been building. **reír** wore a prefix it never had, and the test caught it: take *re-* off and nothing stands. **arrepentirse** is harder, because if you take *a-* and *re-* off you get *pentir*, which stands on nothing — and the fact that it looks like *sentir* is the only reason you would have thought otherwise. What that means in practice: a resemblance is not evidence. *Concentrarse* really does contain *centro*, and you can check it because *centro* is a word. *Sentir* is a word too, and *arrepentirse* still does not contain it.
The honest position is the one worth keeping — take the word apart where the pieces are real, and when they are not, learn the word and let the history be what it is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *arrepentirse*
- I regret having said it
- why the *-pentir-* is not *sentir*

Before you move on

To regret? (**Arrepentirse**.) Which preposition follows it? (***De***.) Is *sentir* inside it? (**No — *paenitēre* is**.)

443.6 (doler, interesar, acercarse, concentrarse, arrepentirse) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *to hurt*, *to interest*, *to come closer*, *to concentrate*, *to regret*.

Grammar Lens: five new words, no new grammar

This chapter taught nothing you did not already have. It handed five words to two machines you owned.

the machine	where you got it	the new words
the thing is the subject	*gustar*	doler, interesar
the reflexive	*equivocarse*	acercarse, concentrarse, arrepentirse

Me duele la cabeza — the head hurts, and the verb agrees with the head. *Me interesan las clases* — plural thing, plural verb. If you can catch yourself about to say *yo duelo*, the machine is working.
That is the whole point of building on what came before, and it is worth noticing when it happens: the fifth verb on a pattern costs almost nothing, where the first one cost a lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- my head hurts and I cannot concentrate
- I regret having said it
- *me duele* and *me duelen*, and what decides between them

What you've built

You can now say what is going on inside you — what hurts, what you care about, what you are struggling to do and what you wish you had not done. A reading paper asks that constantly, because most short texts about people are about exactly this.
You also have the sharpest case yet of a word that misleads. **Arrepentirse** looks like it is made of *sentir* and behaves like it, and is not related to it at all. A resemblance is not evidence, and the check is whether the piece you think you see is a word in its own right that leaves something standing behind it.

Before you move on

My feet hurt? (**Me duelen los pies**.) To come closer? (**Acercarse**.) To concentrate on something? (**Concentrarse en algo**.)

443.7 (un mensaje antes del examen) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *concentrarse* and *acercarse*. Both are in the message you are about to read, and one of them is about a date rather than a person.

Your turn

Read both, then answer.

1 — de Marta

Se **acerca** el examen y no me puedo **concentrar** en nada. Llevo dos días con dolor de cabeza: me **duele** por la mañana y se me pasa por la tarde. ¿Tú cómo lo llevas?

2 — la respuesta

Yo igual. Me **arrepiento** de no haber empezado en septiembre. Pero me **interesa** de verdad la asignatura, así que algo se me quedará. Nos vemos el jueves y lo repasamos juntos.

Say these aloud:

- what is making Marta anxious
- when her headache comes and when it goes
- what the second writer regrets, and what she says in spite of it

Why it's said this way

Four of the five verbs in those messages put the writer in the object, not the subject. **Se acerca** el examen, **me duele** la cabeza, **me interesa** la asignatura, **me arrepiento** — in every one, something

else is doing the acting and the writer is on the receiving end.
That is not a coincidence of these two messages. It is how Spanish talks about inner states by default: the feeling arrives, the date approaches, the subject interests. English reaches for *I am* plus an adjective — *I am worried*, *I am interested* — and puts the person in charge of a state they did not choose.
Neither is more accurate. But if you translate your English shape word for word you will produce *estoy interesado en* where a Spanish speaker says *me interesa*, and the sentence will be understood and will not sound like theirs.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Five sentences about a week before something difficult: say the date is getting close, say what hurts, say you cannot concentrate, say what you regret, and say what still interests you.
Then check yourself: did you write *me interesa*, or did you reach for *estoy interesado*?

Chapter 444

La Casa Por Fuera

Modes: **voice** (6) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 6 of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can report what is wrong with a home and say what I did about it: the heating, the material, the garden, the thing I covered, the trolley I took to the shop.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

444.1 la calefacción — heat, made

> Say **el calor** and **el frío**. It is January and the flat is cold. Name the thing that is not working.

You'll want to know: la calefacción

la calefacción — the heating.

No funciona la calefacción — the heating is not working, which is the sentence a tenant needs first. *Calefacción central* — central heating. *Poner la calefacción* — to put the heating on.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two pieces, and you own both.

piece	where you have it
cale-	*calor*, heat
-facción	*facere*, to make

Heat-making. The second half is the same *facere* that sits under

hacer and under **la factura**, which you met as *a making*. A *factura* is a making of accounts; a *calefacción* is a making of heat.
English has the pieces too, in **calorie** — a unit of heat — and in the **-faction** of *satisfaction* and *liquefaction*.

Why it's said this way

Notice that Spanish names the *process*, not the *device*.
English **heating** can mean the radiators, the boiler, or the service. Spanish **calefacción** is the making-of-heat, and the hardware has its own words — *el radiador*, *la caldera*. That is why the bill says *calefacción* and the plumber talks about *la caldera*: the two are not the same noun.
So *la factura de la calefacción* is the bill for heat-made, not the bill for a machine. Both words on that line come from *facere*, one making heat and one making the account of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la calefacción*
- the heating is not working and I am cold
- what the two pieces of the word mean

Before you move on

The heating? (**La calefacción**.) What does the second half mean? (**To make**.) Which other word you have is built on it? (***La factura***.)

444.2 la madera — the stuff a tree is for

Say **la mesa**, **la silla** and **el árbol**. Two of those are made of the third. Name what they are made of.

You'll want to know: la madera

la madera — wood, as a material.

Una mesa de madera — a wooden table. Spanish says **de madera**, of wood, where English turns the noun into an adjective.

The tree is *el árbol*, the wood you build with is *la madera*, and a wood you walk in is *el bosque* — three words where English stretches one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

madera is Latin **māteria**, and *māteria* meant **timber** before it meant anything else.

Behind it sits **māter**, mother. A tree's *māteria* was its trunk — the part that puts out the branches, the mothering stock. Only later did Roman philosophers borrow the word for *the stuff a thing is made of* in general.

So the abstract sense came **second**. Matter was named after wood, not the other way round.

Why it's said this way

That one Latin word reached Spanish **twice**, and this is the third pair of its kind you have met.

the word	the road it took
la madera	carried in every mouth, worn down
la materia	lifted off the page by scholars

Māteria spoken for a thousand years became **madera** and kept the concrete sense: the planks. *Māteria* read off the page centuries later came back as **la materia** and kept the abstract one: matter, subject-matter, a school subject.

You have seen the shape before — **nadar** beside **la natación**, **hacer** beside **la factura**, and now **madera** beside **materia**. The worn twin is the everyday one; the learned twin is the one on the timetable, the bill or the syllabus. When two Spanish words look loosely alike and one is plainer than the other, this is the first thing to suspect.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la madera*
- a wooden table and a wooden chair
- why *madera* and *materia* are the same word

Before you move on

Wood? (**La madera**.) A wooden table? (**Una mesa de madera**.) What did *māteria* mean first? (**Timber**.)

444.3 plantar — pressed in with the foot

Say **la planta**, **el jardín** and **la tierra**. You have the thing, the place and the ground. Name the act.

You'll want to know: plantar

plantar — to plant.

Plantamos un árbol en el jardín — we planted a tree in the garden. *Plantar cara* is to stand up to somebody, and *dejar plantado* is to stand somebody up — to leave them planted where they were waiting.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la planta has three meanings in Spanish and one origin.

the sense	what it names
la planta del pie	the **sole** of the foot
una planta	a growing plant
la primera planta	a storey of a building

Latin **planta** was the sole of the foot, and nothing else. To *plantāre* was to **press a cutting into the soil with your heel** — the actual gesture a Roman gardener made. The plant is named after the foot that put it there.

The storey follows the same foot: a *planta* of a building is a **floor plan**, the outline you would leave standing on it, which is why English **plan** is the same word again.

Why it's said this way

This is worth holding next to **madera**.
Madera went the other way: a concrete thing (timber) whose name was borrowed upward into an abstraction (matter). *Planta* started as a body part and spread sideways into two unrelated-looking objects — a shrub and a floor of a building.
Neither is a word splitting into homonyms by accident. Both are **one image being reused**, and if you can recover the image you get the whole family instead of three separate entries. For *planta*, the image is a foot pressing down.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *plantar*
- we planted a tree in the garden
- the three meanings of *planta*, and the one picture behind them

Before you move on

To plant? (**Plantar**.) What did Latin *planta* mean? (**The sole of the foot**.) What is *la primera planta*? (**The first floor**.)

444.4 cubrir — and the lid that comes off again

> Say **abrir** and **cerrado**. Say **plantar**. You have put a cutting in the ground and the frost is coming. Name what you do to it.

You'll want to know: cubrir

cubrir — to cover.

Cubre la olla — cover the pot. *El seguro no lo cubre* — the insurance does not cover it, which is the sense you will meet on paper rather than in a kitchen. **el cubierto** is a place setting at table, the knife and fork laid out — what *covers* your place.

Grammar Lens: a third irregular participle

abrir gave you **abierto** and **cerrar** gave you **cerrado**. *Cubrir* follows *abrir*.

verb	**participle**
cerrar	cerrado — regular
abrir	**abierto** — irregular
cubrir	**cubierto** — irregular

Abrir and *cubrir* both end in **-brir**, and both break the same way. That is not a coincidence you have to memorise separately: the handful of irregular participles come in small families, and finding one member gives you the others. *Descubrir* makes **descubierto**, because it is *cubrir* with something on the front.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **cooperīre** — **co-** together, plus **operīre**, to shut or cover over. *Operīre* is itself **ob-** plus a root meaning *to close*, and its opposite, **aperīre**, gave you **abrir**. So *cubrir* and *abrir* are not merely alike in shape; they are two halves of one Latin pair.

And now the prefix that earns its keep:

word	**what des- does**
cubrir	put the cover on
descubrir	**take it off — to discover**

Descansar taught you *des-* as an undoing, and this is the same job done plainly: to *discover* something is to **uncover** it. Compare *disfrutar*, where the prefix did not reverse at all. Same shape, two behaviours, and only the meaning of the whole word tells you which you have.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cubrir*, then *cubierto*
- cover the pot, the frost is coming
- *descubrir*, and what *des-* is doing to it

Before you move on

To cover? (**Cubrir**.) The participle? (**Cubierto** — irregular, like *abierto*.) To discover? (**Descubrir** — to un-cover.)

444.5 el carrito — a small cart, and a very large ending

Say **el supermercado** and **el coche**. Say **cubrir**. You are at the door of the shop with a week's shopping to do. Name what you take.

You'll want to know: el carrito

el carrito — the trolley, the cart.

El carrito de la compra — the shopping trolley. *Un carrito de bebé* — a pushchair. On a website, *añadir al carrito* is **add to basket**, and that is where you will meet the word most often.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

carro plus **-ito**.
El carro is a cart, from Latin **carrus**, a wagon — a word Latin itself took from Gaulish, and the same one behind English **car**, **carry** and **cargo**. Add **-ito** and you have a small one.

Grammar Lens: the ending that does more than shrink

-ito and **-ita** attach to almost any noun, and size is only its first job.

word	with -ito	what it adds
un momento	un moment**ito**	*a moment* → *one moment, please*
ahora	ahor**ita**	now → right now, or soon

Momentito is not a shorter moment. The ending softens the request, the way English softens one by adding *a little* or *if you would*. Spanish speakers use it constantly for that, not for measuring.
Two things to watch. **Spelling follows sound**: *poco* becomes *poquito*, because *c* before *i* would go soft and the word must keep its **k**. And

the ending has a cousin, **-illo**, which shrinks less kindly — *un librillo* is faintly dismissive where *un librito* is affectionate.
So when a Spanish speaker adds *-ito* to something that is not small, they are usually being warm rather than inaccurate.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el carrito*
- add it to the basket
- *un momentito*, and what the ending is doing there

Before you move on

The trolley? (**El carrito**.) What does **-ito** add besides size? (**Warmth, or softening**.) Why is it *poquito* and not *pocito*? (**To keep the hard k**.)

444.6 (calefacción, madera, plantar, cubrir, carrito) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *the heating*, *wood*, *to plant*, *to cover*, *the trolley*.

Grammar Lens: three things a word can do on its way into Spanish

Every word in this chapter came from Latin, and no two arrived the same way.

word	what happened to it
madera	arrived **twice** — and *materia* is the other one
planta	arrived once and **spread** into three meanings
carrito	arrived, then Spanish **built on it**

Madera and *materia* are one word on two roads, the worn twin and the

learned twin. *Planta* is one road and one word that kept being reused — sole of the foot, then the cutting pressed in by it, then the floor plan you stand on. *Carrito* is neither: *carro* came in, and the **-ito** on the end is Spanish's own work, added centuries after Latin had finished. Those three cover most of what you will meet. A word arrives twice, or it arrives once and stretches, or it arrives and the language grows something new on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the heating is not working
- cover the pot before the frost
- a wooden table, and why *madera* and *materia* are one word

What you've built

You can now report what is wrong with a home and say what you did about it — the heating, the material, the garden, the thing you covered, the trolley you took to the shop. Between this and the contract chapter you can hold up most of a tenancy in Spanish.
You also have a third irregular participle. **Cubierto** joins **abierto**, and they break together because they rhyme: the irregulars come in small families, so finding one gives you the rest.

Before you move on

The participle of *cubrir*? (**Cubierto**.) Wood? (**La madera**.) The heating? (**La calefacción**.) Which of those three is a doublet? (***Madera***, with *materia*.)

444.7 (un aviso del casero) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *la calefacción* and *cubrir*. The notice you are about to read uses one of them, and the reply uses the other.

Your turn

Read both, then answer.

1 — un aviso en el portal

> Se informa a los vecinos de que la **calefacción** quedará apagada el martes por trabajos en la caldera. Los suelos de **madera** del portal se barnizarán el mismo día. Rogamos no pisar.

2 — un mensaje al casero

> Buenos días. La ventana del salón no cierra bien y entra frío. También he **plantado** las macetas que dejó en la terraza, pero habrá que **cubrirlas** si hiela. ¿Puede pasar el técnico esta semana?

Say these aloud:

- what will be off on Tuesday, and why
- what the residents are asked not to do
- the two things the tenant reports, and the one request

Why it's said this way

Look at **cubrirlas** in the second message.
The pronoun is stuck on the **end** of the infinitive: *cubrir* plus *las*, the flowerpots. Spanish attaches the object to an infinitive rather than putting it in front, and does the same to a command — *cúbrelas* — and to a gerund. English never does this, which is why *habrá que cubrirlas* looks like one long word and is two.
The first notice will not do that, because it has no people in it: *se informa*, *se barnizarán*, *rogamos*. It is the impersonal register you met on the council's page, and the contrast between the two texts is the whole point of reading them together. A neighbour writes with pronouns; a notice writes without.
Even the **-ito** ending belongs to the message and not the notice. Nobody puts *un momentito* on a formal sign.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Five sentences to a landlord: say the heating is not working, say which room, say what you planted, say you had to cover it, and ask for someone to come. Then check yourself: did you write **cubrirlas** as one word?

Chapter 445

El Puesto

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a job advert and say what the work asks of me: what it demands, what I am answerable for, what I would be teaching, and when the person I am replacing leaves.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

445.1 jubilarse — the shout at the end of the work

> Say **jubilado** and **el trabajo**. You have the word for the person who has stopped. Name the act of stopping.

You'll want to know: jubilarse

jubilarse — to retire.

Se jubila en marzo — he retires in March. *Me jubilé hace dos años* — I retired two years ago. **la jubilación** is both the act and the pension.

It is reflexive: you retire *yourself*. *Jubilar* without the pronoun is what an employer does to somebody, and it can sound abrupt.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **iubilāre** — **to shout, to whoop for joy**. It was a countryman's word for the noise you make across a field, not a word about work at all.

The connection runs through the **jubilee**: in the older calendar a jubilee year cancelled debts and released people from service, and *jubilar* came to mean *to release from service*. The shout came first and the pension came after.
So **el jubilado** is, underneath, *the one who has been cheered off*, and every Spanish retirement notice carries a faint sound of celebration nobody hears any more.
English keeps the shout in **jubilant** and **jubilation**, and has no verb for the Spanish sense at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *jubilarse*
- she retires in March after forty years of work
- what *iubilāre* meant

Before you move on

To retire? (**Jubilarse**.) Is it reflexive? (**Yes**.) What did the Latin verb mean? (**To shout for joy**.)

445.2 la responsabilidad — answerable

Say **el contrato** and **jubilarse**. A contract lists what a job pays and what it asks. Name what it asks.

You'll want to know: la responsabilidad

la responsabilidad — responsibility.

Es una responsabilidad grande — it is a big responsibility. *Bajo mi responsabilidad* — on my own responsibility. The adjective is **responsable**, which is both *responsible* and, in an advert, *the person in charge*: *el responsable de compras*.

Six syllables, stress on the last: *res-pon-sa-bi-li-DAD*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

re- back, plus **spondēre**, to promise, plus the ending **-bilidad** that turns an adjective into a quality.
To be *responsable* is to be **able to promise back** — to answer for what you did. That is the same *spondēre* you already have in a place you would never look for it:

word	**the promise in it**
el esposo	the one who was **promised**
responder	to promise **back**, to answer
la responsabilidad	being answerable

A spouse and a responsibility are the same verb. Latin *spondēre* was the formal word for pledging — a betrothal was a *sponsalia* — and English keeps it in **sponsor**, **respond** and **despondent**, which is what you are when the promise has gone out of you.

Why it's said this way

The long ending is worth a moment, because it is a machine.
-idad (and **-bilidad** after *-ble*) turns an adjective into the abstract noun of its quality, and it is completely regular:

adjective	**quality**
responsable	responsabilidad
posible	posibilidad
fácil	facilidad

English does the same with *-ity*, and the two endings are the same Latin *-itātem*, which is why they line up so neatly. If you know a Spanish adjective in **-ble**, you can usually build its noun without being taught it.
Note the stress: every one of these nouns ends stressed, on the **-dad**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la responsabilidad*
- it is a big responsibility and he retires in March
- why *esposo* and *responsabilidad* share a root

Before you move on

Responsibility? (**La responsabilidad**.) What does *spondēre* mean? (**To promise**.) Which syllable is stressed? (**The last**.)

445.3 exigente — driving it out of you

Say **difícil** and **fácil**. Say **la responsabilidad**. A job can be hard without anybody being hard on you. Name the word for a boss who is.

You'll want to know: exigente

exigente — demanding, exacting.

Un jefe exigente — a demanding boss. *Es muy exigente consigo mismo* — he is very hard on himself. The verb is **exigir**, to demand: *exigen dos años de experiencia* — they require two years of experience, which is the line you meet in a job advert.

It does not change for gender: *un jefe exigente*, *una jefa exigente*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ex- out, plus **-igente** from Latin **agere**, to drive.
Exigere was **to drive something out** — originally to drive out a payment, to collect what was owed. An *exigente* boss drives the work out of you, and the picture is the same one the Roman tax collector used.
Agere is one of the great Latin roots, and the words it gave English all keep some sense of driving something forward:

word	what is driven
agenda	the things to be driven through
actor	the one who drives the action
agile	easily driven

Why it's said this way

Difícil and **exigente** are not the same complaint, and a job advert uses them differently.
Difícil is a property of the task: the work is hard. *Exigente* is a

property of whoever is asking: the standard is high. A puzzle is *difícil*; a person is *exigente*. You can have an easy job with a demanding manager, and Spanish requires you to pick which you mean.
The ending **-ente** is doing that work. It comes from a Latin present participle and marks **the one doing the verb** — *exigente* is the one demanding, the way *estudiante* is the one studying and *cliente* is the one leaning on you for service.
So when you meet an unfamiliar word in **-ante** or **-ente**, look for a verb inside it and read the whole as *the one who does that*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *exigente*
- an easy job with a demanding boss
- what the two pieces of *exigir* mean

Before you move on

Demanding? (**Exigente**.) The verb? (**Exigir**.) What does *agere* mean? (**To drive**.)

445.4 enseñar — to put a sign into somebody

Say **aprender** and **la clase**. Say **exigente**. You have the half of the class that receives. Name the half that gives.

You'll want to know: enseñar

enseñar — to teach, and equally **to show**.

Enseña matemáticas — she teaches maths. *¿Me enseñas la foto?* — will you show me the photo? *Me enseñó a conducir* — he taught me to drive, with **a** before the second verb.

One word for both jobs, where English keeps *teach* and *show* apart.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en- in, plus **señ-** from Latin **signum**, a sign or mark.
To *enseñar* is **to mark something into somebody** — to put a sign in them. The Latin was *insignāre*, and once you see it, *teach* and *show* stop being two meanings. Both are **putting a mark where somebody can see it**: on a wall, or in a head.

word	**the sign in it**
la señal	the sign itself
enseñar	to put the sign in
diseñar	to mark it **out** — to design

English took the same *signum* through French into **ensign**, a banner, and into **design**, which is *de-* plus the mark.

Why it's said this way

That one verb covering two English ones is not vagueness; it is a different cut of the same territory, and it goes the other way too. Spanish splits what English joins all the time — *ser* and *estar* for one *to be*, *saber* and *conocer* for one *to know*. Here it joins what English splits. Neither language is being imprecise; they have drawn the lines in different places, and the only reliable way through is to learn where the line is rather than to translate across it.
A practical consequence: if you want *show* specifically and fear being misheard as *teach*, Spanish has **mostrar** — but in speech *enseñar* is far commoner for both, and the context does the work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *enseñar*
- she teaches maths, and I am learning
- will you show me the photo

Before you move on

To teach? (**Enseñar**.) And to show? (**Enseñar** — the same word.) What does *signum* mean? (**A sign, a mark**.)

445.5 repetir — seeking it again

Say **otra vez**. Say **enseñar**. You did not catch what the teacher said. Name what you ask for.

You'll want to know: repetir

repetir — to repeat.

¿Puede repetir, por favor? — could you repeat that, please. This is the single most useful sentence in a language you are still learning, and it is worth saying aloud until it arrives without thinking.

It breaks its stem: **repito**, **repites**, **repite**, but *repetimos* — the **e→i** change, the one *pedir* makes too.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

re- again, plus **petere**, to seek or to ask for.
And you have met *petere* before, under a word from a completely different part of life. **El pedido** — the order you place with a shop — is built on *pedir*, and *pedir* is *petere*.

word	**the seeking in it**
pedir, el pedido	to ask for a thing
repetir	to seek it **again**

That is why the two verbs break their stems the same way: *pido*, *pides*, *pide*; *repito*, *repites*, *repite*. They are not merely similar. They are one Latin verb, with and without a prefix, and the shared conjugation is the evidence rather than a coincidence you have to remember.

Why it's said this way

Notice what this chapter has quietly done. **Responsabilidad** shares a root with **el esposo**, a word from family; **repetir** shares one with **el pedido**, a word from shopping. Neither link is visible in modern Spanish, and neither is decoration — both times the shared root predicts something usable: the promise inside *responsable*, and the conjugation of *repetir*.
That is the return on etymology. Not that the stories are charming, but that a root you own tells you how an unfamiliar word will behave before anybody explains it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *¿Puede repetir, por favor?*
- the teacher repeated it and then I understood
- *pido* and *repito*, and why they change the same way

Before you move on

To repeat? (**Repetir**.) The *yo* form? (**Repito**.) Which word you already had shares its root? (***El pedido***, through *pedir*.)

445.6 (jubilarse, responsabilidad, exigente, enseñar, repetir) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *to retire*, *responsibility*, *demanding*, *to teach*, *to repeat*.

Grammar Lens: a root you own predicts how a new word behaves

Two of these words turned out to be built on roots you had already, from somewhere else entirely.

new word	the word you already had	what the shared root buys
responsabilidad	**el esposo**	the promise inside *responsable*
repetir	**el pedido**	the **e→i** stem change

Repetir is the sharper of the two. *Pedir* changes *pido*, *pides*, *pide*; *repetir* changes *repito*, *repites*, *repite*. Nobody has to tell you that, because they are one Latin verb with a prefix on one of them. That is the return on etymology here — not that the stories are pleasant, but that a root you own tells you how an unfamiliar word will behave before anybody explains it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- could you repeat that, please
- she teaches maths and she is very demanding
- he retires in March

What you've built

You can now read a job advert and say what the work asks of you — what it demands, what you are answerable for, what you would be teaching or shown, and when the person you are replacing is leaving. You also have two endings that keep paying. **-idad** turns an adjective into its quality and is regular, so *posible* gives *posibilidad*. And **-ente** or **-ante** marks *the one doing the verb*, so an unfamiliar word in that shape has a verb inside it worth looking for.

Before you move on

Responsibility? (**La responsabilidad**.) To teach, and to show? (**Enseñar**, for both.) To retire? (**Jubilarse**.)

445.7 (una oferta y una despedida) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *la responsabilidad* and *jubilarse*. The two texts below are about the same desk: one person is leaving it and somebody else is wanted for it.

Your turn

Read both, then answer.

1 — oferta de empleo

Se busca persona **responsable** para el turno de tarde. Se **exige** experiencia previa y se valorará saber **enseñar** a personal nuevo. Contrato fijo. Interesados, enviar currículum antes del día 30.

2 — una nota en el tablón

> Después de treinta y un años, me **jubilo** el viernes. Ha sido un placer. Dejo el turno en buenas manos. Os espero a todos a las seis en el bar de enfrente.

Say these aloud:

- what the job requires, and what it merely prefers
- how long the second person has worked there
- which of the two texts has a person in it

Why it's said this way

The advert separates two things English often blurs. **Se exige** experiencia — it is *required*, and without it you are not eligible. **Se valorará** saber enseñar — it will be *valued*, a point in your favour and nothing more. A reader who treats those as the same sentence either rules themselves out for no reason or applies for something they cannot do.

That distinction is the single most useful thing on the page, and it is carried entirely by the verb.

Notice too that the advert has **no people**: *se busca*, *se exige*, *se valorará*, and even *interesados* is a plural adjective standing in for a noun. The leaving note is the opposite — *me jubilo*, *dejo*, *os espero*, first person throughout. One desk, two registers, and you can now read both.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Five sentences applying for that job: say you are responsible, say you have the experience they require, say you have taught new staff before, ask them to repeat the closing date, and say you are sorry the other person is retiring.

Then check yourself: did you keep **se exige** and **se valorará** apart?

Chapter 446

Mirar Y Moverse

Modes: **voice** (3) **eyes** (4) **Hands-free start:** none of the 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can arrange to go somewhere with somebody and talk about what we watched, keeping ver apart from mirar and mover apart from trasladar.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

446.1 mirar — pointing the eyes on purpose

> Say **mira**, the little word that opens a sentence. Say **ver** and **el ojo**. *Mira* is an order from a verb you have never been given. Name it.

You'll want to know: mirar

mirar — to look, to look at, to watch.

Mírame — look at me. *Estaba mirando por la ventana* — I was looking out of the window. *Mirar la tele* is to watch television, though *ver la tele* is commoner in Spain.

mira and **mire** — the forms you already use to mean *look…*, *listen…* — are this verb told to somebody, nothing more. You have been giving an order for chapters without knowing which verb it came from.

Grammar Lens: ver and mirar are not interchangeable

English has this split too and hides it, because *see* and *look at* feel like one idea. They are not.

verb	what it describes
ver	the eyes **receive** — it happens to you
mirar	the eyes are **aimed** — you do it

Veo el mar desde aquí — I can see the sea from here, whether or not I meant to. *Miro el mar* — I am looking at it, deliberately.
So *ver* belongs with *oír* (to hear) and *mirar* with *escuchar* (to listen). The test is whether you chose: if you could have not done it, the verb is *mirar*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **mīrārī** meant **to wonder at, to be amazed** — not to look at all. The looking came from the wondering: you stare at what astonishes you, and after enough centuries the staring is all that is left. The wonder survives in the relatives:

word	the wonder in it
el milagro	a miracle — a thing wondered at
admirar	to admire — to wonder **at**
mirar	to look

English took the same root for **miracle**, **admire**, **marvel** and **mirage** — a thing that astonishes you and is not there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mirar*
- I can see the sea from here, and I am looking at it
- what *mīrārī* meant before it meant looking

Before you move on

To look at? (**Mirar**.) Which verb is it, when you say *mira*? (**This one, as an order**.) What did the Latin mean? (**To wonder at**.)

446.2 mover — and the phone that is named after it

Say **el móvil** and **trasladar**. Say **mirar**. Your phone is called *móvil* for a reason. Name the verb inside it.

You'll want to know: mover

mover — to move something. **moverse** — to move yourself.

¿Me ayudas a mover la mesa? — will you help me move the table? *No te muevas* — do not move. *El niño no para de moverse* — the child will not sit still.

The stem breaks under stress, like *doler* and *dormir*: **muevo**, **mueves**, **mueve**, but *movemos*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **movēre**, to move. **El móvil** is *mōbilis* — **movable** — from the same verb, so a mobile phone is literally *the movable one*.

word	**the movement in it**
mover	to move it
el móvil	the movable thing
el automóvil	the **self**-moving thing

That last one is the whole of *automobile* explained: *auto-* from Greek *autós*, self, on a Latin stem. A car is a thing that moves without being pulled.

Why it's said this way

Mover and **trasladar** are not the same act, and a notice picks carefully.

Mover is physical and local: shift the table, shift your arm. *Trasladar* is institutional and from-somewhere-to-somewhere: the office was moved, the patient was transferred. You *mueves* a chair across a room;

a company *traslada* its headquarters.
Use *mover* for a thing you could push with your hands, and *trasladar* when an address changes. Getting it backwards is not a grammar mistake — it is a register mistake, and it is the kind a reader notices.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mover*, then *muevo*
- will you help me move the table
- why a phone is called *el móvil*

Before you move on

To move something? (**Mover**.) The *yo* form? (**Muevo**.) What does *móvil* mean literally? (**Movable**.)

446.3 acompañar — going as the one who shares bread

Say **el compañero** and recall what it is made of. Say **mover**. Turn the companion into something you do.

You'll want to know: acompañar

acompañar — to go with somebody, to accompany.

Te acompaño — I will come with you, and also *I am here with you* at a funeral. *¿Me acompañas al médico?* — will you come with me to the doctor? *Acompañado de* — accompanied by, on a form or a menu.

It is the ordinary way to offer to come along, and it is warmer than the English *accompany*, which sounds formal.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

a- plus **compañ-** plus **-ar**, and the middle is the word you already took apart.
el compañero is *com-* together plus *pānis*, bread — **the one you share bread with**. So *acompañar* is **to go along as that person**,

and a Spanish speaker offering *te acompaño* is, at root, offering to share a meal's worth of company.

word	**the bread in it**
el compañero	the one you share it with
acompañar	to be that person for somebody
el pan	the bread itself

That is the third verb in these chapters built the same way — **a-** plus a word you own plus **-ar**, meaning *to make it that*: *acercar* from *cerca*, *acompañar* from *compañero*.

Why it's said this way

The warmth is not decoration; it decides where the word is used. At a Spanish funeral the standard thing to say is **te acompaño en el sentimiento** — *I accompany you in the feeling.* English has no comfortable equivalent and reaches for *I'm sorry for your loss*, which places the speaker outside the grief. The Spanish places them alongside it.

That is worth knowing before you need it, because it is a fixed phrase and improvising in its place is conspicuous.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *acompañar*
- will you come with me to the doctor
- what the bread is doing inside the word

Before you move on

To go with somebody? (**Acompañar**.) Which word is inside it? (***Compañero***.) And what is inside that? (***Pānis***, bread.)

446.4 directo — straight through, and live

Say **recto** and **el tren**. Say **acompañar**. *Recto* is the shape of a line. Name the word for a train that does not stop.

You'll want to know: directo

directo — direct, straight through.

Un tren directo — a through train, no changes. *Un vuelo directo* — a direct flight. *En directo* — **live**, on radio or television, which is the use you will meet most.

Directo also describes a person: *es muy directo* means blunt, and in Spain it is usually a compliment.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

di- apart, thoroughly, plus **-recto**, which you already have.
Recto is Latin **rectus**, straightened, ruled — the participle of *regere*, to rule or guide. To *dirigere* was **to set something straight**, to aim it, and *directo* is the result of that aiming.

word	**the straightening in it**
recto	straight
directo	straightened **towards**
dirigir	to direct, to conduct

English keeps *regere* everywhere once you look: **correct** (straightened *with*), **erect** (straightened *up*), **regular** (by the rule), and **rule** itself.

Why it's said this way

En directo is the one to fix, because it is not obvious from the parts. A broadcast *en directo* is going straight from the event to you with nothing in between — no recording, no editing. English calls that **live**, naming the event; Spanish names the **path**. Once you see that, *en directo* stops needing translation: the line is straight.
The opposite is **grabado**, recorded. A Spanish television corner reading *EN DIRECTO* is telling you that what you are watching is happening now.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *directo*
- a direct train, no changes
- what *en directo* means on a screen

Before you move on

Direct? (**Directo**.) Live, on television? (**En directo**.) Which word you already had is inside it? (***Recto***.)

446.5 el partido — a side split off

Say **la parte**, **jugar** and **el deporte**. Two teams are a whole divided in two. Name what they are about to play.

You'll want to know: el partido

el partido — the match, the game.

El partido del domingo — Sunday's match. *¿Viste el partido?* — did you see the match? *Jugar un partido* — to play a game.

It is also **the political party**: *el partido socialista*. And *sacar partido de algo* is to make the most of something.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

partido is the past participle of **partir**, to divide — and *partir* is **la parte**, which you have.
So *partido* means **divided**, and everything it names is something a whole was split into.

what it names	what was divided
el partido (match)	the players, into two sides
el partido (party)	the electorate, into factions
sacar partido	the advantage, cut out of a situation

One word, no coincidence. A football match and a political party are both *a side that a whole was split into*, and English needs two unrelated words — *match*, from an old sense of *equal*, and *party*, which is the same Latin *pars* arriving through French.

Why it's said this way

Partir has a second life worth having, because it looks like a contradiction.
Partir also means **to leave, to set off** — *el tren parte a las ocho.*

How does *divide* become *depart*?
Because leaving is a division: you separate yourself from the place and the people. English does exactly the same thing and hides it in the Latin — **depart** is *de-* plus the same *partire*, and **a parting** is both a splitting and a goodbye.
So a train that **parte** is cutting itself away from the platform, and a train that is **directo** does not divide the journey at all. The two words in this chapter that describe a train describe opposite things about it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el partido*
- did you see Sunday's match
- why a political party is also *un partido*

Before you move on

The match? (**El partido**.) What does the word mean literally? (**Divided**.) What else does *partir* mean? (**To leave, to set off**.)

446.6 (mirar, mover, acompañar, directo, partido) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *to look at*, *to move*, *to go with*, *direct*, *the match*.

Grammar Lens: you owned four of these already

Not one of these five was learned from nothing.

new word	what you already had
mirar	*mira*, the word that opens a sentence
acompañar	*el compañero*, and the bread inside it
directo	*recto*
el partido	*la parte*

Mirar is the sharpest case. You have been saying **mira** for chapters as a way of starting a sentence, without being told it is an order from a verb. Finding the verb behind a fixed phrase you already use is one of the cheapest kinds of vocabulary there is, and it has happened three times now — *interesante* gave *interesar*, *el concierto* gave *concertar*, and *mira* gives *mirar*.
When a new word looks like something you say already, check before you learn it twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- will you help me move the table
- did you see Sunday's match
- will you come with me

What you've built

You can now arrange to go somewhere with somebody and talk about what you watched. That is most of what a short message between friends is for.
You also have two distinctions a reader notices. **Ver** is the eyes receiving and **mirar** is the eyes aimed. **Mover** is a thing you could push with your hands and **trasladar** is an address changing. Both are register rather than grammar, and getting them backwards is the kind of mistake that is understood and still sounds wrong.

Before you move on

Live, on television? (**En directo**.) To look at, on purpose? (**Mirar**.) A match, and a political party? (**Un partido**, for both.)

446.7 (quedar para el partido) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *el partido* and *directo*. Both are in the message below, and one of them is not about a train.

Your turn

Read both, then answer.

1 — de Nacho

¿Vemos el **partido** en mi casa? Lo dan **en directo** a las nueve. Si quieres **te acompaño** desde la estación, que el bus de noche no pasa.

2 — la respuesta

Vale. Llego sobre las ocho y media. **Miro** los horarios y te digo, pero creo que hay un tren **directo**.

Say these aloud:

- where they are watching, and at what time
- what Nacho offers to do, and why
- what the second person is going to check

Why it's said this way

Directo appears twice and means two different things, and nothing but the noun tells you which.
En directo, about the match: nothing between the event and the screen — live. *Un tren directo*: nothing between the two stations — no changes. Both are the same picture, a straight line with nothing interrupting it, applied once to time and once to distance. Spanish did

not need two words because it named the line rather than the thing. Then look at **vemos** and **miro**. *¿Vemos el partido?* — the match arrives at their eyes, and *ver* is right. *Miro los horarios* — she is aiming her eyes at a timetable on purpose, and *mirar* is right. A Spanish speaker would not swap them, and the pair in one short exchange is the clearest test of the distinction you will get.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Five sentences arranging an evening: say you will watch the match, say it is live, offer to go with somebody, say there is a direct train, and say you will look at the times.
Then check yourself: did you use **ver** for the match and **mirar** for the timetable?

Chapter 447

Juzgar

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can follow a clinic from the door to the results: which door when it is serious, what the doctor ordered, what somebody mentioned about it, and how to apologise for dropping the form.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

447.1 el análisis — loosened apart

> Say **la sangre**, **el médico** and **el examen**. The doctor wants to know what is in your blood. Name what he orders.

You'll want to know: el análisis

el análisis — the analysis, and in a clinic **the test**.

Un análisis de sangre — a blood test. *Me han hecho unos análisis* — they have run some tests on me. *Los resultados del análisis* — the test results.

This is the word on the form, and it is worth having before a waiting room rather than during one.

Grammar Lens: a noun that does not change

el análisis and **los análisis** are spelled identically. Only the article tells you how many.
Spanish does this to every noun ending in unstressed **-is**:

one	more than one
el análisis	**los** análisis
la crisis	**las** crisis
el paréntesis	**los** paréntesis

The reason is a rule you can use elsewhere: a word already ending in **s**, when its stress is *not* on the last syllable, takes no plural ending. The same applies to *el lunes / los lunes* and *el paraguas / los paraguas*. Contrast **el examen**, which does change — *los exámenes* — and gains a written accent when it does, because the stress must stay where it was.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Greek **análysis**: **ana-** up, through, plus **lýein**, **to loosen**.
To analyse something is to **loosen it apart** — to undo the knots and see what the pieces are. That is a physical picture, and it is exactly what a blood test does to blood.
The same *lýein* is in **paralysis**, a loosening of the body's control, and in **catalyst**, which loosens a reaction. Its opposite in Greek was *synthesis*, a putting-together — which is what a Spanish lesson's last section is called.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *el análisis*, then *los análisis*
- the doctor has ordered a blood test
- what the two Greek pieces mean

Before you move on

A blood test? (**Un análisis de sangre**.) What is the plural? (**Los análisis** — unchanged.) What does *lýein* mean? (**To loosen**.)

447.2 comentar — minding it over, together

> Say **pensar**. Say **el análisis**. Thinking is done alone. Name what you do when you think about something out loud, with somebody.

You'll want to know: comentar

comentar — to comment on, and very often no more than **to mention**.

Me comentó que se jubila — he mentioned to me that he is retiring. *¿Lo comentamos mañana?* — shall we talk it over tomorrow? *Sin comentarios* — no comment.

That middle sense is the one to take. In everyday Spanish **comentar** is much closer to *mention* or *talk over* than to the English *comment*, which sounds like a verdict. A Spanish speaker *comenta* things all day without passing judgement on any of them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **com-** together, plus **mens**, **mentem** — the **mind**.
To *comentar* is **to mind something over with somebody**. The mind is sitting inside the word, and it is the same *mentem* behind **la mente**, **mental**, and the ending **-mente** that turns a Spanish adjective into an adverb: *rápidamente* is, at root, *with a rapid mind.*

word	**the mind in it**
comentar	to turn over together
la mente	the mind itself
rápida**mente**	with a rapid mind

That last row is worth keeping. Every Spanish adverb in **-mente** is a fossil of the word for mind, agreeing in the feminine because *mens* was a feminine noun — which is why it is *rápida*mente and never *rápido*mente.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *comentar*
- he mentioned to me that the test results are back

- why every **-mente** adverb takes the feminine adjective

Before you move on

To mention? (**Comentar**.) What is inside the word? (***Mentem***, the mind.) Why *rápidamente* and not *rápidomente*? (***Mens* was feminine**.)

447.3 la urgencia — something pressing on you

Say **la prisa** and **el hospital**. Say **comentar**. Being in a hurry is your own business. Name the kind of hurry a hospital has a door for.

You'll want to know: la urgencia

la urgencia — urgency, an emergency.

Las urgencias, in the plural, is **the emergency department**. The sign over the door of a Spanish hospital says *URGENCIAS*, and *ir a urgencias* is to go to A&E.

The adjective is **urgente**: *es urgente* — it is urgent. On an envelope or an email subject line, *URGENTE* does the same work it does in English.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **urgēre**, **to press, to push hard**. An urgency is something **pressing on you**, and English says the same thing when it calls a matter *pressing*.

And you already have a second Latin word for pressing. **La prisa** is from *premere*, also to press — the root of English *press* itself.

word	**what presses**
la prisa	*premere* — you are pressed for time
la urgencia	*urgēre* — the thing presses on you

The difference is which way the pressure runs. *Tengo prisa* puts it on you: *I* am in a hurry. *Es urgente* puts it on the matter: the thing itself is pushing. You can have *prisa* about something that is not *urgente* at all, and a genuinely *urgente* matter can find you with no *prisa* whatever.

Why it's said this way

The ending is one you have met. **-encia** turns a verb into the state of doing it, the way *experiencia* did in the chapter on paperwork.

verb	**the state**
urgir	la urgencia
existir	la existencia
preferir	la preferencia

So an unfamiliar noun in **-encia** will nearly always be hiding a verb, and the noun names *the condition of that verb happening*. That is two endings now — **-ción** for the act and **-encia** for the state — and between them they cover a large share of the abstract nouns on any Spanish form.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *la urgencia*, then *urgente*
- we had to go to A&E
- the difference between *tengo prisa* and *es urgente*

Before you move on

Urgency? (**La urgencia**.) The sign over the hospital door? (**URGENCIAS**.) What does *urgēre* mean? (**To press**.)

447.4 torpe — from shameful to clumsy

> Say **feo**. Say **la urgencia**. *Feo* judges how a thing looks. Name the word that judges how a person moves.

You'll want to know: torpe

torpe — clumsy, awkward, and of a person's mind, slow.

Soy muy torpe con las manos — I am very clumsy with my hands. *Perdona, qué torpe* — sorry, how clumsy of me, which is what you say after knocking something over.

It does not change for gender: *un niño torpe*, *una niña torpe*. The noun is **la torpeza**, clumsiness — and also a blunder: *fue una torpeza decir eso*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **turpis** meant **ugly, foul, shameful** — a heavy word, used of disgraceful conduct rather than of somebody who drops things. Spanish kept the shape and moved the meaning from **how you look** to **how you act**, and softened it on the way. *Turpis* was an accusation; *torpe* is close to an apology.

the word	what it judges
feo	how a thing **looks**
torpe	how a person **manages**

Both are from Latin words for ugliness — *feo* from *foedus*, *torpe* from *turpis* — and only one of them is still about appearance. English took *turpis* too, in **turpitude**, which kept the original severity and is now used almost nowhere.

Why it's said this way

That softening is the useful part.

Torpe is not an insult in ordinary Spanish. It is what people call themselves after a small mistake, and calling yourself *torpe* is a way of apologising without making the moment larger. Said of somebody else it is mild — closer to *butterfingers* than to any real charge.

A word whose ancestor was severe and whose descendant is gentle is worth noticing, because the direction is not guaranteed. The reverse happens too. If you learn a word from its etymology alone you will pitch it wrong about half the time, so the root tells you where a word **came from** and never how hard it lands today.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *torpe*
- sorry, how clumsy of me
- what *turpis* meant, and how hard *torpe* lands now

Before you move on

Clumsy? (**Torpe**.) What did *turpis* mean? (**Ugly, shameful**.) Is *torpe* an insult? (**No — it is nearly an apology**.)

447.5 (análisis, comentar, urgencia, torpe) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all four: *the test*, *to mention*, *the emergency*, *clumsy*.

Grammar Lens: what a root tells you, and what it does not

Three of these four are physical acts underneath, and knowing that helps.

word	the act
análisis	loosening the knots apart
urgencia	something pressing on you
torpe	— see below

Análisis and *urgencia* behave the way their roots suggest. **Torpe** does not. *Turpis* meant **shameful**, a heavy accusation, and *torpe* is now what you call yourself after knocking a glass over — nearly an apology. That is the limit, and it is worth stating plainly: **a root tells you where a word came from and never how hard it lands today.** Meanings soften, and they harden too. Etymology is a hook for remembering and a guide to shape; it is not a guide to tone.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the doctor ordered a blood test
- he mentioned that it was urgent
- *el análisis* and *los análisis*, and what tells them apart

What you've built

You can now follow a clinic from the door to the results — which door to go to when it is serious, what the doctor has ordered, what somebody mentioned to you about it, and how to apologise for dropping the form.
Two endings close the set you have been collecting. **-encia** names the state of a verb happening, as **-ción** names the act. Between them they cover most of the abstract nouns on a Spanish form, and both have a verb inside worth looking for.
And one plural rule: a noun ending in unstressed **-is** does not change. *El análisis*, *los análisis*; *la crisis*, *las crisis*. Only the article moves.

Before you move on

The emergency department? (**Urgencias**.) A blood test? (**Un análisis de sangre**.) Clumsy? (**Torpe**.)

447.6 (un mensaje desde urgencias) — read it, then do it yourself

Say *urgencias* and *torpe*. One of them is where the writer is, and the other is how she explains getting there.

Your turn

Read both, then answer.

1 — de Lucía

Estoy en **urgencias**, pero no es grave. Me caí bajando del autobús, soy una **torpe**. Me han hecho un **análisis** y una radiografía y estoy esperando.

2 — la respuesta

¿Quieres que me acerque? Me **comentó** tu hermana que hoy librabas, así que no me pilla lejos. Dime algo cuando tengas los resultados.

Say these aloud:

- where Lucía is, and why
- what has been done to her so far
- what the second person offers, and how she knew

Why it's said this way

Two things in that exchange do more work than they look like.
Pero no es grave, in the first line, before any of the detail. A Spanish message from a hospital almost always leads with the reassurance, because the word *urgencias* lands hard and the writer is defusing it immediately. Putting that clause last would read as burying it.
And **me comentó tu hermana**: not *me dijo*, not *me contó*. *Comentar* is the mildest of the three — it says the sister mentioned it in passing, with no weight on it, which is exactly the right temperature for explaining how you happen to know somebody's day off. Choosing *me dijo* would sound like she was told on purpose.
That is the difference between having the words and using them. Both writers pick the softest option available, twice each, and the message reads as calm because of it.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four sentences from a waiting room: say where you are, say it is not serious, say what test they have done, and say somebody mentioned they might come.
Then check yourself: did you put the reassurance **before** the detail?

Chapter 448

La mudanza

Modes: **voice** (6) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 6 of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can hand a flat over and take one on: say when I am moving, call the day hard, and tell somebody which things are out of order and which are actually in pieces.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

448.1 mudarse — changing where you live

Say **la casa** and **el piso**. You are about to leave one of them.

You'll want to know: mudarse

mudarse — to move house.

Me mudo el sábado — I move on Saturday. *Nos mudamos a un piso más grande* — we are moving to a bigger flat. *¿Cuándo te mudas?* — when do you move?

Spanish does not reach for a verb of carrying here. It reaches for a verb of **changing**, and that is the whole idea: you have not transported yourself, you have changed which address is yours.

Grammar Lens: what the -se is doing

There is a plain verb **mudar** underneath, and it means to change something else:

without -se	with -se
la serpiente muda la piel — sheds its skin	*me mudo a Sevilla* — I move
mudar de opinión — change your mind	*se muda de ropa* — changes clothes

On the left the verb reaches out to something: a skin, an opinion. On the right it turns back and lands on the person. Once it lands on you, the thing being changed is understood to be **where you live** — or, in a bedroom, what you are wearing. Context decides between those two, and it decides easily, because nobody packs a lorry to change their shirt.

Note that *mudarse* takes **a** for the destination — *me mudo a Madrid* — the same **a** you already use for going anywhere.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **mutare**, to change. It is a wide family and you can hear it in English: a **mutation** is a change, to **mute** a sound is to alter it, and a bird in **moult** is changing its feathers — the same picture as the snake. Spanish keeps the plain sense in *mudar de opinión* and the specialised one in *mudarse*. A word narrowing from "change anything" to "change address" is ordinary: the commonest thing people announce they are changing is where they sleep.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I am moving on Saturday
- we are moving to a bigger house
- what *mudar* means without the *-se*

Before you move on

To move house? (**Mudarse**.) Which preposition for the destination? (**A** — *me mudo a Bilbao*.) What Latin verb is inside it? (**Mutare**, to change.)

448.2 la mudanza — the day itself

Say **mudarse** and **la caja**. Forty of the second, one of the first.

You'll want to know: la mudanza

la mudanza — the move: not the decision, the day.

Hacer una mudanza — to do a move. *La empresa de mudanzas* — the removal firm. *El camión de mudanzas* — the removal van. *La mudanza es el día quince* — the move is on the fifteenth.

Spanish says **hacer** a move where English says *do* or *make* one, and it never says *tener*. A mudanza is something you carry out, not something you possess.

Grammar Lens: -anza names the doing

Take a verb, cut the ending, add **-anza**, and you have a noun for the act or the state:

verb	noun
mudar	la mud**anza** — the move
esperar	la esper**anza** — hope
enseñar	la enseñ**anza** — teaching
tardar	la tard**anza** — the delay

All four are feminine, and so is every other **-anza** noun you will meet: *la confianza*, *la semejanza*, *la balanza*. Spot the ending and the article comes free.

La esperanza is worth a second look. From *esperar*, to wait — hope, in Spanish, is named after the waiting rather than after the wanting. The ending took an ordinary verb and produced an abstract noun, and that is exactly what it does to *mudar*, except that a mudanza is not abstract at all: it is boxes.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **mutare**, to change, plus the ending. Old Spanish used *mudanza* for any change at all, including a change of heart, and you still meet that sense in older writing and in song lyrics.

The narrowing went the same way as the verb's. When people say *la mudanza* now, boxes are in the room.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the move is on Saturday
- the removal firm is bringing the boxes
- which verb goes with *mudanza*

Before you move on

The move? (**La mudanza**.) The verb? (**Mudarse**.) And the gender that comes with *-anza*? (**Feminine**.)

448.3 duro — hard, and hard going

Say **durante** and **fuerte**. One of them is about how long, the other about how much force.

You'll want to know: duro

duro — hard.

El pan está duro — the bread has gone hard. *Un colchón duro* — a firm mattress. And then, away from things you can press: *un día muy duro* — a hard day. *El trabajo es duro* — the work is heavy going. *No seas tan duro con él* — don't be so hard on him.

A mudanza is the standard example of *un día duro*, and no Spanish speaker would call it *un día fuerte*.

Grammar Lens: duro is not fuerte

The two get confused because English "strong" and "hard" overlap. Spanish keeps them apart by asking a different question about each:

word	the question it answers
fuerte	how much force does it have?
duro	how much does it resist?

Una persona fuerte can lift the boxes. *Una persona dura* will not soften when you ask for a favour. A rock is *duro*; it has no force at all. Wind is *fuerte*; it is not hard in the least.

So when a day is *duro*, the picture is not that the day was powerful. It

is that the day would not give.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **durus**, hard — and from it the verb **durare**, to last.
That derivation repays a moment. What lasts is what resists wearing away, so "hard" and "long-lasting" are one idea seen twice. Spanish kept both halves: *duro* is the resisting, and **durar** — with **durante** inside it — is the lasting. *La mudanza duró todo el día*: the move held out all day.
English took both halves too, from the same place: **durable** and **duration** on one side, **endure** on the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the bread is hard
- the move was a very hard day
- why *durante* and *duro* are relatives

Before you move on

Hard? (**Duro**.) Which word would you pick for a strong wind? (**Fuerte** — force, not resistance.) What links *duro* to *durar*? (**What resists is what lasts**.)

448.4 estropear / estropeado — it no longer works

Say **torpe** and **romper**. Being the first often leads to the second.

You'll want to know: estropear

estropear — to ruin, to wreck, to put out of action.

He estropeado el móvil — I've wrecked my phone. *La lluvia estropeó la fiesta* — the rain ruined the party. With **-se** it happens by itself: *se ha estropeado la lavadora* — the washing machine has broken down.

And the form you meet most is the adjective:
estropeado — out of order, damaged, spoiled.

Ascensor **estropeado**. Usen las escaleras.

That is a real sign, on a real lift, and it is the reason this word earns its place before the polite ones.

Grammar Lens: estropeado is not roto

Both translate as "broken" and they are not interchangeable:

what you mean	the word
it is in pieces	**roto**
it will not work	**estropeado**

A washing machine full of water that does nothing is **estropeada** and not *rota* — nothing came apart. A plate in two halves is **rota** and calling it *estropeada* would sound like an understatement.
Food takes *estropeado* too: *la fruta se ha estropeado* — the fruit has gone off. Again the test holds. The fruit is not in pieces; it no longer does its job.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish took it from Italian **stroppiare**, to cripple or maim, which goes back to Latin **turpis** — shameful, ugly.
So **estropear** and **torpe** are cousins, and the pair is worth holding side by side. The same Latin word for *shameful* came out of Italian as "wreck a thing" and out of Spanish as "clumsy" — an apology you make over a spilled glass. One branch kept the weight and one branch lost nearly all of it.
The **e-** at the front is Spanish's own doing. Spanish will not open a word with *st-*, so it fits a vowel in front: *stroppiare* became *estropear*, the way *stare* became *estar* and *studiare* became *estudiar*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the lift is out of order
- the washing machine has broken down

- which of *roto* and *estropeado* fits a plate in two halves

Before you move on

Out of order? (**Estropeado**.) The verb? (**Estropear**.) Which word already in your head shares its Latin root? (**Torpe** — both from *turpis*.)

448.5 roto — in pieces

Say **romper** and **la caja**. Now say what happened to the box.

You'll want to know: roto

roto — broken, torn, in pieces.

Un vaso roto — a broken glass. *Los pantalones están rotos* — the trousers are torn. *He roto el plato* — I've broken the plate.

It agrees like any adjective: *roto, rota, rotos, rotas.*

Grammar Lens: the participle that lost its middle

A regular *-er* verb would give *romp-ido*. Spanish says **roto**, and it is one of a small group that behave this way:

verb	the participle you expect	the one Spanish uses
romper	*rompido*	**roto**
escribir	*escribido*	**escrito**
abrir	*abrido*	**abierto**

These short forms are the older ones. They came straight down from Latin participles that were already short, and because the verbs are used so constantly, the regular pattern never got a grip on them. The same thing happens in English, where *wrote* survives beside *worked*. One form covers both jobs: *he roto el plato* after *haber*, and *el plato está roto* as a plain description.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **rumpere**, to burst, with participle **ruptus** — and *ruptus* is what became *roto*.

English borrowed the same participle whole: a **rupture**, an **eruption**,

something **abrupt** that breaks off. Spanish let it wear down into a two-syllable everyday word, and kept *ruptura* alongside for the borrowed, formal sense.
Keep the pair from the lesson before this one in view. *Roto* is *ruptus*, bursting. *Estropeado* is *turpis*, shameful. Spanish named the two kinds of failure after two different pictures, and the pictures still sort them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a broken glass, then broken trousers
- I have broken the plate
- whether a dead fridge is *roto* or *estropeado*

Before you move on

Broken, in pieces? (**Roto**.) What would the regular participle have been? (*Rompido*.) Name two more verbs with a short participle. (**Escrito**, **abierto**.)

448.6 (mudarse, la mudanza, duro, estropeado, roto) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *to move house*, *the move*, *hard*, *out of order*, *in pieces*.

Grammar Lens: two words for broken, one question

This is the one distinction in the chapter that will cost you marks if it goes unsorted. Ask: **did anything come apart?**

the situation	**the word**
lift stuck between floors	**estropeado**
window with a hole in it	**roto**
milk that has gone off	**estropeado**
shoelace snapped	**roto**

Notice the milk. Nothing could come apart in a carton, so *roto* is not

available — and that is the test doing its work on a case where English gives you no help at all, since English would say neither "broken milk" nor "out-of-order milk".

Grammar Lens: where the five came from

Four of the five were built out of things you already had.

new word	what it was built on
mudarse	*mudar*, to change
la mudanza	*mudar* plus the *-anza* of *esperanza*
duro	the *dur-* inside *durante*
estropeado	*turpis*, the Latin behind *torpe*

Only **roto** arrived on its own, and even it came with *romper* attached. Five words, one genuinely new root among them. That is what happens once a vocabulary is large enough: new words start arriving as relatives.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- we are moving on the fifteenth
- the move was a hard day
- which preposition follows *mudarse*

Before you move on

All five again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence using two of them at once.

448.7 (el día de la mudanza) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **la mudanza** and **estropeado**. Both are in the note below, and one of them is doing the work of a warning.

Your turn

A note left on the kitchen counter for whoever moves in next. Read it, then answer.

> Hola. Nos **mudamos** hoy y te dejo unas cosas por escrito.
>
> El timbre está **estropeado** desde enero. El portero dice que lo arregla, pero lleva así medio año, así que llama por teléfono.
>
> En el armario hay un cristal **roto**. Lo he tapado con cartón, pero ten cuidado al abrirlo.
>
> La **mudanza** ha sido **dura** y quedan tres cajas en el trastero. Las recojo el domingo.

Say these aloud:

- which two things in the flat are not in working order
- which of the two came apart, and how you know
- what is still in the storage room, and when it goes

Why it's said this way

The note uses both words for broken within four lines, and each one is the only correct choice.
The doorbell is **estropeado**. Nothing about it is in pieces; it has stopped doing its job, and the fault is invisible. The pane of glass is **roto**, which is why it needed covering with cardboard — there is now a hole where glass used to be. Swap the two words and a Spanish reader would picture a smashed doorbell and a window that mysteriously fails to be a window.
Then look at **nos mudamos hoy**. Present tense, for something happening today, exactly as in English. And **dura**, agreeing with *la mudanza*: the day resisted, all day long.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Leave a note of four lines for the next tenant: say you are moving today, name one thing

that is out of order, name one thing that is broken, and say the move has been hard.
Then check yourself: did each of *roto* and *estropeado* go to the right object, and did *duro* agree with what it describes?

Chapter 449

El taller

Modes: **voice** (5) **eyes** (2) **Hands-free start:** first 5 of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can leave a bike at a repair shop and understand the slip that comes back: say which part has failed, ask whether it can be fixed by a given day, and ask somebody to pass me a tool.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

449.1 arreglar — putting it right

Say **reparar** and **estropeado**. One undoes the other.

You'll want to know: arreglar

arreglar — to fix, to mend, to sort out.

¿Me puedes arreglar la bici? — can you fix my bike for me? *Han arreglado el ascensor* — they've fixed the lift. *Ya está arreglado* — it's sorted now.

And beyond machinery: *arreglar los papeles* — sort the paperwork out. *Arreglar una habitación* — tidy a room. *Arreglarse* — get yourself ready to go out.

Grammar Lens: arreglar and reparar

Both mean to fix, and a Spanish speaker reaches for them differently:

word	where it sits
arreglar	everyday speech, and things that are not machines
reparar	the workshop, the invoice, the written notice

He arreglado la silla is what you tell a friend. *Reparación de calzado* is what the shop window says. You can *arreglar* an argument or a haircut; *reparar* neither.

Where the object is a broken machine, the two overlap and either is correct. Take **arreglar** as your default and you will be right far more often.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Break it as **a-rregl-ar**, and the middle is **regla** — a ruler, a rule — from Latin **regula**, the carpenter's straight edge.

So to *arreglar* something is to bring it back to the straight edge: the plank is warped, you true it. You met the same *regula* in **regular**. English took it too, in *regulate*, *rule* and *ruler*, and kept the tool and the law in one word as Spanish does.

The **rr** is where the *a-* meets the *r-* of *regla*. Spanish doubles it and rolls it, and the doubling is the only trace left of the prefix.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- can you fix my bike?
- it's sorted now
- which of the two verbs belongs on a shop sign

Before you move on

To fix? (**Arreglar**.) What tool is hiding inside it? (**La regla**, the straight edge.) What does *arreglarse* mean about a person? (**Getting ready to go out**.)

449.2 el freno — what stops you

Say **la bicicleta** and **arreglar**. Name the part most often needing the second.

You'll want to know: el freno

el freno — the brake.

Los frenos no van — the brakes aren't working. *El freno de mano* — the handbrake. *Frenar* — to brake: *frena antes de la curva*, brake before the bend.

Spanish uses the plural far more than English does. A bicycle has *frenos*, and asking about *el freno* on a bike would sound as though you knew which one was at fault.

Grammar Lens: the noun and the verb in one step

el freno gives **frenar** by adding nothing but *-ar*, and this pair is one instance of a pattern you can lean on:

noun	verb from it
el freno	fren**ar** — to brake
la planta	plant**ar** — to plant
el arreglo	arregl**ar** — to fix

Note the third row runs backwards from the other two: **el arreglo** is the noun built from the verb, not the verb built from the noun. Spanish makes these in both directions and the ending alone will not tell you which came first — a question for a dictionary, not for a rule. What you can rely on is the shape: meeting a noun, try *-ar* on it; meeting an *-ar* verb, try cutting it back to a noun. You will be right often enough to make it worth the guess.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **frenum**, the bit — the metal bar in a horse's mouth that the reins pull on. That is the oldest brake there is, and the word moved onto carts, then bicycles, then cars, without ever changing its job. English has the same word in the medical **frenulum**, the small fold of tissue under your tongue, so called because it holds the tongue back. Spanish keeps the sense alive too: *poner freno a algo* — to put a stop to something.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the brakes aren't working
- can you fix the brakes?
- the verb that goes with *el freno*

Before you move on

The brake? (**El freno**.) On a bike, singular or plural? (**Plural** — *los frenos*.) What was a *frenum* originally? (**The bit in a horse's mouth**.)

449.3 la rueda — the wheel

Say **alrededor** and **la bicicleta**. There is a wheel inside one of those words, and it is not the obvious one.

You'll want to know: la rueda

la rueda — the wheel, and on a car the tyre as well.

La rueda de atrás — the back wheel. *Se me ha pinchado una rueda* — I've got a puncture. *La rueda de repuesto* — the spare.

A bicycle has *dos ruedas*, and Spanish will name a vehicle by counting them: *un vehículo de dos ruedas*.

Grammar Lens: the o that breaks in two

Latin *rota* has an **o**. Spanish has **ue**. That change is everywhere once you look for it, and it happens under one condition — stress:

unstressed o	**stressed, so ue**
r**o**dar — to roll	la r**ue**da
p**o**der — to be able	p**ue**do
v**o**lver — to return	v**ue**lvo

Say *rueda* and *rodar* one after the other and you can hear the same word twice. The vowel splits under the weight of the stress and closes up again when the stress moves off.

This is why so many Spanish verbs look irregular and are not. They

are one vowel obeying one condition.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **rota**, wheel. And here is the payoff on a word you already use daily.
Alrededor is *al* + *rededor*, and *rededor* comes from Latin **retrō**, *backwards* — **pulled sideways by *rota***, the wheel. That is the careful version and it is worth keeping careful: *rota* is not where the word started, it is what bent it on the way. Both ideas ended up inside it, which is why something *alrededor* is behind you as well as in front. The wheel half is generous. A **rotunda** is a round building, a **rotation** turns, Spanish keeps *rotonda* for the roundabout you drive round, and *la rodilla* — the knee — is *rotella*, a little wheel. A knee and the space around you, named by the same rolling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the back wheel and the spare wheel
- the brakes and the wheel need fixing
- what *alrededor* has to do with *rueda*

Before you move on

The wheel? (**La rueda**.) Why *ue* and not *o*? (**The stress falls on it**.) What is the unstressed verb alongside it? (**Rodar**, to roll.)

449.4 el taladro — the drill

Say **la mano** and **la madera**. One holds the tool, the other takes the hole.

You'll want to know: el taladro

el taladro — the drill.

¿Me dejas el taladro? — can you lend me the drill? *Taladrar* — to drill: *hay que taladrar la pared*, we need to drill the wall.

The word covers the machine and, in a workshop, the bit as well. *Un taladro para madera* is a wood bit; *un taladro sin cable* is a cordless drill.

Grammar Lens: lending, in Spanish

Asking to borrow a tool is where two verbs get tangled, because Spanish has no verb for *borrow* at all:

what you want	what Spanish says
lend me the drill	*¿me* ***dejas*** *el taladro?*
can I borrow it?	*¿me lo* ***prestas****?*

Both put the **lender** in the subject position. There is no sentence shaped like *I borrow the drill from you*; you turn it round and ask the other person to do the lending. *Dejar* is the everyday one and *prestar* the slightly more formal.
Hand the tool back with *aquí tienes* and you have the whole exchange.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **taratrum**, a borer — itself taken from Gaulish, the Celtic language spoken in France before Latin arrived. The Romans met a better tool than their own and kept the name with it.
From *taratrum* to *taladro* an **r** turned into an **l**, and notice that *taratrum* has no *l* to begin with. The word had **two r's**, which is awkward, so one of them gave way — a repeated sound in one short word is unstable, and changing one of the pair is the easiest repair.
That is not what happened to *milagro* and *peligro*. Those came from *miraculum* and *periculum*, which **did** have both letters, and the two traded places. Two different habits, worth telling apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- can you lend me the drill?
- we have to drill the wall
- why *milagro* and *taladro* are the same kind of case

Before you move on

The drill? (**El taladro**.) To drill? (**Taladrar**.) How do you ask to borrow something? (**By asking the other person to lend it** — *¿me dejas…?*)

449.5 acercar — pass it here

Say **cerca** and **acercarse**. Now take the *-se* off the second one and see what is left.

You'll want to know: acercar

acercar — to bring something closer, and so, constantly, **to pass**.

¿Me acercas el taladro? — can you pass me the drill? *Acerca la silla* — pull your chair up. *Te acerco a la estación* — I'll run you to the station.

That last one is worth keeping. Offering somebody a lift in Spanish is offering to *acercar* them: you are bringing them nearer to where they are going.

Grammar Lens: one verb, two directions

You already own the *-se* version. Here they are side by side:

form	who moves
acercarse	the subject — *me acerco a la puerta*
acercar	something else — *acerco la silla*

Without the *-se*, the verb needs an object; the thing that comes closer is whatever you name. With the *-se*, the subject is the thing that comes closer. That is the same switch you saw in *mudar* and *mudarse*, and it runs through hundreds of Spanish verbs.

So in a workshop, *acércate* means come over here, and *acércamelo* means send it over here. One syllable apart, and two different people doing the moving.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

a-cerc-ar: the prefix *a-* meaning towards, the *cerca* you already say, and the *-ar* of an ordinary verb. The middle is Latin **circa**, around,

and its ring is still visible in *círculo* and in English *circle* and *circa*. The road from "around" to "near" is short: things arranged around you are the things close to you. Spanish turned the circle into a distance, then built a verb on it, and the verb now does the job of the English *pass*, *pull up* and *give a lift* all at once.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- can you pass me the drill?
- pull your chair up
- I'll run you to the station

Before you move on

Pass me the drill? (**¿Me acercas el taladro?**) Who moves with *acercarse*? (**The subject**.) What does *te acerco a la estación* offer? (**A lift**.)

449.6 (arreglar, el freno, la rueda, el taladro, acercar) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *to fix*, *the brake*, *the wheel*, *the drill*, *to pass*.

Grammar Lens: each noun brought a verb with it

Three of these five came in pairs, and the second half of each pair cost you nothing:

the noun	its verb
el freno	**frenar** — to brake
la rueda	**rodar** — to roll
el taladro	**taladrar** — to drill

Note that *rodar* does not keep the *ue*. The **ue** appears only where the stress lands on it, so the noun has it and the infinitive does not. If you try to say *ruedar* you will be corrected; if you say *rueda* and *rodamos*

you will not.
That one condition — stress — accounts for most of what looks irregular in Spanish verbs, and you now have a noun that shows it standing still.

Grammar Lens: the -se you keep meeting

Three verbs in two chapters have turned on the same small word:

without -se	**with -se**
mudar — change a thing	*mudarse* — move house
acercar — bring it closer	*acercarse* — come closer
arreglar — fix a thing	*arreglarse* — get ready

Read the right-hand column and one thing is constant: the subject is on the receiving end. Read the left and the verb is reaching out to an object. When you meet a new verb in both shapes, that question sorts them before you look anything up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the brakes aren't working and the back wheel is loose
- can you fix it today?
- the verbs belonging to *freno*, *rueda* and *taladro*

Before you move on

All five again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence that puts a tool in somebody's hand.

449.7 (dejar la bici en el taller) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **arreglar** and **el freno**. Both are on the slip below.

Your turn

The slip handed back across the counter. Read it, then answer.

> **Taller de bicicletas — resguardo**
>
> Bicicleta azul, sin cesta. Entra el martes.
>
> Los **frenos** de atrás no van. Se cambian.
>
> La **rueda** delantera está bien; solo hay que apretarla.
>
> Presupuesto: 24 €. Se **arregla** para el jueves.

Say these aloud:

- which part is being replaced and which is only being tightened
- what it will cost and when it will be ready
- what day the bike went in

Why it's said this way

Look at **se cambian** and **se arregla**. Neither says who does the work, and on a repair slip that is the point: the shop is not the subject of a sentence, the job is. Spanish gets there with *se* plus the verb, and the verb agrees with the thing being done — *frenos* is plural so *cambian* is plural, *la bicicleta* is singular so *arregla* is singular.
English reaches for the passive here: *the brakes are being changed*. Spanish reaches for *se*. Once you notice it you will see it on every notice and every menu: *se alquila*, *se vende*, *se ruega*.
And **solo hay que apretarla** does the same job a third way — no subject at all, only a thing that must be done.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines handing a bike over: say what is wrong with the brakes, say the front wheel is fine, ask whether they can fix it by Friday, and ask them to pass you the drill so you can do one part yourself.
Then check yourself: did you use *se* for the work being done, and did the verb agree with the part rather than with the shop?

Chapter 450

El césped y el patio

Modes: **voice** (7) **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a notice pinned to the gate of a sports ground: say where training has moved to, tell a maintained pitch from grass that is merely growing, and warn somebody about stones on a path.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

450.1 el patio — the space in the middle

> Say **el jardín** and **la calle**. A patio is neither, and it sits between them.

You'll want to know: el patio

el patio — the courtyard: an open space with the building around it.

Un piso con patio — a flat with a courtyard. *Los niños están en el patio* — the children are out in the yard. *El patio de butacas* — the stalls of a theatre, the flat part with the seats.

A *jardín* has plants and can be anywhere. A *patio* is defined by what surrounds it, and it may hold nothing but a washing line.

Grammar Lens: the school patio

In a school, *el patio* is the playground, and with it comes a phrase you will hear constantly:

Spanish	what it covers
salir al patio	to go out at break
la hora del patio	break time

The second one names the time by naming the place, and Spanish does this often — *la hora de la calle* for knocking-off time works the same way. When a Spanish phrase seems to be about a location, check whether it is really about a moment in the day.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Here the honest answer is that nobody knows.

The best-supported account brings it from Occitan *pati*, waste ground, and from there back to Latin **pactum**, an agreement — common land held by agreement. A rival account points at Latin *patere*, to lie open, which fits the meaning better and the sound worse. Neither has settled the matter.

That is why this lesson lists no root. An empty list is not an oversight in this material; it is a claim, and the claim is that the origin is genuinely unresolved. Saying so is more useful than picking the prettier story, because the next time you see a root listed you can trust that somebody checked.

What is certain is where the word went. Spanish carried *patio* into English, French and German, and it is now the ordinary word for a paved space behind a house in places that have never used it for anything else.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a flat with a courtyard
- the children are out at break
- the difference between a *patio* and a *jardín*

Before you move on

The courtyard? (**El patio**.) What defines one? (**The building around it**.) What does *la hora del patio* mean? (**Break time**.)

450.2 la hierba — grass, the plant

Say **la planta** and **verde**. Now name the smallest, commonest green plant there is.

You'll want to know: la hierba

la hierba — grass, and more widely any low soft plant: a herb, a weed.

Hay hierba entre las piedras — there is grass growing between the stones. *Las malas hierbas* — the weeds, literally the bad grasses. *Una infusión de hierbas* — a herbal tea.

You will also see it written **yerba**, mostly in the Americas, and *yerba mate* is the usual spelling for the drink. Both are the same word said the same way.

Grammar Lens: the h that is not pronounced and not decorative

Latin *herba* had an h that had already gone silent by Roman times. Spanish kept the letter and added it back where Latin had none:

Latin	Spanish	the h
herba	la **h**ierba	inherited
ovum	el **h**uevo	added
ossum	el **h**ueso	added

Look at what the added ones have in common: they all begin **ue**. Scribes put an *h* in front because a word starting with *u* was read as a *v*, and *uevo* would have been read *vevo*. The *h* is a fence around the vowel.

Hierba begins *ie* rather than *ue*, so it did not need the fence. It kept what Latin had already handed it. The letter is silent in all of them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **herba**, grass or herb. English borrowed the same word twice: once through French as **herb**, and once as the botanical **herbaceous**. Spanish has the learned form too, in *herbicida* and *herbívoro*, where the h sits in front of an unbroken *e* because those words came from books rather than from speech.

That is the tell. *Hierba* has the broken vowel because ordinary speakers wore it down over centuries; *herbívoro* has not, because it was

lifted from Latin whole and handed to a scientist.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- there is grass growing in the courtyard
- the weeds, using the Spanish phrase
- why *huevo* has an h and *hierba* has a different reason

Before you move on

Grass, the plant? (**La hierba**.) Is the h pronounced? (**No** — not on its own, anywhere in Spanish.) What are *las malas hierbas*? (**The weeds**.)

450.3 la piedra — the stone

Say **la madera** and **duro**. Now name the building material that is harder than the first.

You'll want to know: la piedra

la piedra — the stone.

Una casa de piedra — a stone house. *Hay piedras en el camino* — there are stones on the path. *De piedra* also works as a description of a person who has not moved: *me quedé de piedra*, I was stunned.

For the material in the mass — quarried, cut, built with — Spanish stays singular: *un muro de piedra.* For the things you can pick up, plural: *piedras.*

Grammar Lens: the same vowel trick, one row over

You have already watched a stressed **o** break into **ue** in *rueda.* A stressed **e** does the same thing and becomes **ie**:

Latin	Spanish	what broke
petra	la p**ie**dra	e under stress
rota	la r**ue**da	o under stress
herba	la h**ie**rba	e under stress

Three of this chapter's words are the same sound change caught at different moments. Once you hear *ie* and *ue* as stressed vowels that gave way, a large part of Spanish spelling stops looking arbitrary. And the test still works: *petrificar* keeps the plain **e**, because the stress has moved off it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **petra**, taken from Greek **pétra**, a rock.
Latin already had its own word for stone, *lapis*, and it is the one that survived in the learned vocabulary — *lapidario*, and English *dilapidated*. The Greek borrowing won out in ordinary speech instead, which is the reverse of what usually happens.
The name **Pedro** is the same word: Greek *pétros*, a stone, handed out as a nickname and then carried by enough people to become a name in its own right. So *Pedro* and *piedra* are one word twice, and a **petrol** is an oil that comes out of rock.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a stone house
- there is grass between the stones
- what *piedra* and *Pedro* have in common

Before you move on

The stone? (**La piedra**.) Why *ie* rather than *e*? (**The stress fell on it**.) Which language did Latin take *petra* from? (**Greek**.)

450.4 el césped — grass you look after

Say **el campo** and **plantar**. Somebody planted the grass on a football pitch, and that is the whole difference.

You'll want to know: el césped

el césped — the lawn, and on a sports ground the pitch.

Cortar el césped — to mow the lawn. *No pisar el césped* — keep off the grass, the wording on the sign in every park. *El césped está seco* — the pitch is dry.

It has no everyday plural. Where English says *the lawns*, Spanish repeats the singular or names the places instead.

Grammar Lens: césped is not hierba

Both are grass. They answer different questions:

the question	the word
what plant is that?	**la hierba**
what surface is that?	**el césped**

Hierba is the thing growing; *césped* is the maintained expanse of it. So grass coming up between the paving stones is **hierba**, and nobody would call it *césped*. A mown lawn is **césped**, though it is made of *hierba*.

Sports tell the same story. *Jugar en el césped* is to play on the pitch, and a pitch that has stopped being looked after has stopped being *césped*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **caespes**, a cut sod of turf — a slab of earth with grass on top, lifted with a spade for building banks and walls.

That is a good picture to hold, because it explains why *césped* is about the surface rather than the plant. A *caespes* was a thing you could carry.

The written accent is doing real work. A Spanish word ending in a consonant other than *n* or *s* takes its stress on the last syllable by default, so *cesped* without a mark would be read **ces-PED**. The accent overrules the default and pins the stress on **CÉS**-ped.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I have to mow the lawn
- keep off the grass, as the sign puts it

- which word fits grass between the stones

Before you move on

The lawn? (**El césped**.) Why the accent? (**Without it the stress would fall on the last syllable**.) A *caespes* was? (**A cut sod of turf**.)

450.5 el entrenamiento — the session

Say **el tren** and **correr**. One of those two is about to turn up somewhere you would not expect it.

You'll want to know: el entrenamiento

el entrenamiento — training, and a single training session.

Tengo entrenamiento los martes — I have training on Tuesdays. *El entrenamiento es en el césped de atrás* — training is on the back pitch. And the people: **el entrenador**, the coach; **entrenar**, to train; **entrenarse**, to train yourself.

Away from sport it keeps working: *un entrenamiento de dos días* for a course at work.

Grammar Lens: -miento names the process

You have met **-anza** turning a verb into a noun. **-miento** does the same job, and the two split the language between them:

verb	noun
entrenar	el entrena**miento**
mover	el movi**miento**
conocer	el conoci**miento**

Every **-miento** noun is masculine, as every **-anza** noun is feminine, so the ending hands you the article both times.

Which verb takes which is not predictable and has to be met word by word — *esperanza* but *movimiento*, with nothing in the verbs to tell you. What you can rely on is the gender, and that is worth having.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

French **entraîner**, to drag along — and inside it the same *traîner* that gave Spanish **el tren**.
Hold the two together. A **tren** is the set of carriages *dragged* behind the engine. To **entrenar** somebody is to *drag them along* with you until they can keep up. The coach is out in front and the squad is the train.
English took the identical picture from the identical French word, which is why *train* in English means both the thing on rails and what a coach does to a team. Spanish split the two forms — *tren* and *entrenar* — and so kept the relationship visible in a way English hides.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I have training on Tuesdays
- training is on the back pitch
- what a train and a coach are doing that is the same

Before you move on

The training session? (**El entrenamiento**.) The coach? (**El entrenador**.) What gender do *-miento* nouns take? (**Masculine**.)

450.6 (el patio, la hierba, la piedra, el césped, el entrenamiento) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *the courtyard*, *grass*, *the stone*, *the lawn*, *the training session*.

Grammar Lens: three words, one broken vowel

Say these aloud and listen for where the stress sits:

Latin or French	Spanish
herba	la h**ie**rba
petra	la p**ie**dra
entraîner	entren**a**miento

The first two broke their stressed **e** into **ie**. The third did not, because the stress in *entrenamiento* never lands on that **e** at all — it lands three syllables later. Same vowel, same language, different outcome, and the only variable is stress.
This is why *piedra* has a diphthong and *petrificar* does not, and why *rueda* has one and *rodamos* does not. One condition explains all four.

Grammar Lens: two pairs that are not synonyms

the pair	what separates them
patio / jardín	a patio is defined by what surrounds it
hierba / césped	hierba is the plant, césped is the tended surface

Both pairs fail in the same direction for an English speaker: “yard” and “grass” are wide words that cover each pair whole. Spanish is narrower here than English, which is the harder direction, because nothing in your own language warns you that a choice is waiting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- there are stones and grass in the courtyard
- somebody has to mow the lawn
- which of *hierba* and *césped* needs a gardener

Before you move on

All five again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence putting a training session on a pitch.

450.7 (el aviso del polideportivo) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **el césped** and **el entrenamiento**. The notice below moves one of them off the other.

Your turn

A notice on the gate of the sports centre. Read it, then answer.

AVISO

El **césped** del campo grande está en obras hasta el día 20.

Los **entrenamientos** de esta semana se hacen en el **patio** de atrás.

No dejen bolsas sobre la **hierba** del lateral. Se está replantando.

Disculpen las molestias.

Say these aloud:

- where training happens this week, and why
- what you are asked not to do, and where
- when the big pitch will be available again

Why it's said this way

The notice uses **césped** once and **hierba** once, four lines apart, and swapping them would make it unreadable.
The big pitch is **césped**: a maintained playing surface, currently closed for work on it. The strip down the side is **hierba**: grass as a plant, being replanted. A Spanish reader takes *se está replantando* as confirmation — you replant *hierba*, since that is the living thing; *césped* is what you get once the *hierba* has taken and somebody starts mowing it.
Notice also **no dejen** and **disculpen**. Both are the *ustedes* form, which is what public notices use: addressed to everyone, and formal without being cold. A sign saying *no dejes* would read as though it had

been written for one particular person who had already done it once.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines for a gate notice: say the pitch is closed, say where training moves to, ask people to keep off the grass at the side, and say there are stones on the path.
Then check yourself: did *césped* go to the playing surface and *hierba* to the plant, and did you use the *ustedes* form?

Chapter 451

La cola y el carné

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (4) **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can get through a counter: queue, put my name on a list, show the right card, keep the right slip of paper, and follow a notice that says what will be checked and when.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

451.1 la cola — the queue

> Say **esperar** and **la entrada**. Name what forms between the two.

You'll want to know: la cola

la cola — the queue, the line of people.

Hay mucha cola — there's a long queue. *Hacer cola* — to queue: *llevo media hora haciendo cola. Ponte a la cola* — get in line. *El último de la cola* — the last person in the queue.

Spanish says **hacer** cola, never *estar en* cola. You *make* a queue by standing in it, which puts the work where it belongs.

Grammar Lens: two colas, and one of them is glue

There are three separate words spelled **cola** in Spanish, and none of them is related to the others:

the word	where it comes from
la cola — tail, queue	Latin *cauda*
la cola — glue	Greek *kólla*
la cola — the drink	a West African word for the nut

La cola del perro is the dog's tail. *Un bote de cola* is a pot of glue. *Una cola* at a bar is the drink. Nothing but context separates them, and context always does: nobody queues in a tube and nobody glues at the entrance.

Words that collide like this are called homonyms, and Spanish has fewer of them than English because its spelling is so regular that unrelated words rarely arrive at the same shape. When they do, it is worth knowing, because a dictionary will list them as two entries and you might otherwise think you had missed a connection.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **cauda**, tail.

The jump from tail to queue is one picture: a line of people trailing behind something, the way a tail trails behind an animal. French made the same jump with *queue*, which English then borrowed — and *queue* is also from *cauda*. So the English and Spanish words for a line of people are the same Latin word, arrived at independently.

The *au* closing to *o* is regular: *causa* gave *cosa*, *paucum* gave *poco*, *taurum* gave *toro*. The **l** is not. Spanish inherited the word through a spoken form **coda**, and the step from *coda* to *cola* is one nobody has a tidy rule for — which is worth saying, because most of the sound changes in this material do have one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- there's a long queue at the entrance
- I've been queuing for half an hour
- which verb goes with *cola*

Before you move on

The queue? (**La cola**.) To queue? (**Hacer cola**.) What was a *cauda*? (**A tail**.)

451.2 apuntar — put it down

Say **el punto** and **la cola**. The first is inside the verb you are about to meet.

You'll want to know: apuntar

apuntar — to note down, to jot.

Apunta el número — write the number down. *Voy a apuntarlo* — I'll make a note of it.

And with **-se**, the meaning most useful at a counter: **apuntarse**, to put your name down, to sign up.

Me apunto a la excursión — I'm putting my name down for the trip. *¿Te apuntas?* — are you in? That last one is an invitation to anything at all, and it is the phrase you will hear when a group is deciding something.

Grammar Lens: apuntar is not escribir

what you are doing	the verb
producing text	**escribir**
capturing something before it escapes	**apuntar**

You *escribes* a letter, an essay, a message. You *apuntas* a phone number, an address, a time somebody has said aloud. The difference is not length; it is purpose. *Apuntar* is always about not losing the thing. That is why *apuntarse* means signing up: you are getting your name captured onto a list before the places run out.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

a-punt-ar, built straight on **el punto**, and behind that Latin **punctum**, a prick — from **pungere**, to pierce.
So *apuntar* is to put a point on something. All three of its senses are that one action: to note a thing down is to mark a point on paper, to

apuntar a weapon is to aim its point, and to *apuntarse* is to put a point beside your own name.
The family is wide. A **puncture** is a piercing, a **punctual** person hits the point in time, and **puntiagudo** in Spanish is sharp-pointed. Every one of them has a small sharp thing in it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- write the number down
- I'm putting my name down for the trip
- why *apuntar* and *el punto* are the same word

Before you move on

To note down? (**Apuntar**.) To sign up? (**Apuntarse**.) What does *¿te apuntas?* invite? (**Joining in with whatever is being planned**.)

451.3 el carné — the card with your name on it

Say **el documento** and **apuntarse**. You sign up, and then they hand you something.

You'll want to know: el carné

el carné — the card: an official one, with your name on it.

El carné de identidad — the ID card. *El carné de conducir* — the driving licence. *El carné de la biblioteca* — the library card. *El carné joven* — the youth discount card.

Plural **los carnés**. You will also see the French spelling **carnet**, which is common on forms and older signs.

Grammar Lens: carné is not tarjeta

Two Spanish words land on English "card", and they divide the work cleanly:

the card	the word
proves who you are or what you may do	**el carné**
pays, greets, or carries an address	**la tarjeta**

La tarjeta de crédito, *la tarjeta de cumpleaños*, *la tarjeta de visita* — none of those could be a *carné*. And a driving licence could never be a *tarjeta*, however much plastic it is made of.
The test is whether somebody official issued it about **you**. If yes, it is a *carné*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

French **carnet**, a small notebook — from Old French *quernet*, and behind that Latin **quaternum**, a set of four.
Four what? Four sheets of paper folded together, which is how a small notebook was made. The same *quaternum* gave Spanish **el cuaderno**, and the two words are the same object seen at different sizes: a *cuaderno* stayed a notebook, while the French *carnet* shrank to the single card you carry.
Latin **quattuor**, four, is behind both, and behind *cuatro*, *cuarto* and *cuarenta*. A driving licence has four sheets of paper folded inside its history.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the ID card and the driving licence
- I'm signing up, so I need the library card
- which of *carné* and *tarjeta* would pay for something

Before you move on

The ID card? (**El carné de identidad**.) The driving licence? (**El carné de conducir**.) What number is hiding in the word? (**Four** — *quaternum*.)

451.4 mostrar — show it

Say **ver** and **el carné**. Somebody at a desk wants to do the first to the second.

You'll want to know: mostrar

mostrar — to show.

Es obligatorio **mostrar** el carné a la entrada.

Muéstrame la lista — show me the list. *El gráfico muestra tres años* — the chart shows three years.

In speech Spaniards more often say **enseñar** for this — *enséñame el carné*. **Mostrar** is what the sign says and what the form says, so it is a word you read more than you speak. Knowing which register a word belongs to is part of knowing the word.

Grammar Lens: the o that breaks again

You have watched a stressed **o** turn into **ue** in *la rueda*. Here it is inside a verb, doing exactly the same thing:

stress on the stem	stress on the ending
m**ue**stro, m**ue**stras	mostr**a**mos
m**ue**stra, m**ue**stran	mostr**á**is

The infinitive *mostrar* has the plain **o** because the stress is on the *-ar*. Push the stress back onto the stem and the vowel breaks.

So this verb is not irregular in any interesting sense. It is one vowel obeying one condition, and the same condition you used to explain a noun now explains a conjugation.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **monstrare**, to point out — from **monstrum**, and that is where it gets interesting.

A *monstrum* was an omen: something strange that the gods had **shown** you as a warning. The horror came later, from the strangeness of the sign. So **mostrar** and **monstruo** are the same root, one keeping the showing and the other keeping the thing shown.

English has both halves as well, in **demonstrate** and **monster**, and the pair is a clean example of a root splitting into a neutral word and a

frightening one while the idea inside stays the same: something put where you cannot miss it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- you must show your card at the entrance
- show me the list
- which form a friend would use instead

Before you move on

To show? (**Mostrar**.) I show? (**Muestro** — stress on the stem.) What was a *monstrum*? (**An omen, something shown as a warning**.)

451.5 el ticket — the receipt

Say **el billete** and **la entrada**. Neither of them is what the till prints.

You'll want to know: el ticket

el ticket — the receipt, the slip from the till.

¿Quiere el ticket? — would you like the receipt? *Guarde el ticket para cambios* — keep the receipt for exchanges. *El ticket de la compra* — the shopping receipt.

Said **TI-ket**. Spanish also writes it **tique**, and the shorter **el recibo** covers the same ground in more formal use — on an invoice, or where money has changed hands between businesses.

Grammar Lens: three slips of paper, three words

English calls all of these a ticket. Spanish will not:

what it does	the word
carries you somewhere	**el billete**
gets you in	**la entrada**
proves you paid	**el ticket**

A train journey is *un billete*. A concert is *una entrada*. What the supermarket hands you is *un ticket*, and asking for *un billete* at a till would suggest you wanted a banknote, since *billete* covers that too. Sort them by the job rather than by the paper, and all three stay apart.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

This word has been around the houses.
Old French **estiquier** meant to stick — a Frankish word, Germanic in origin, the same family as English *stick*. From it came **estiquet**, a little notice *stuck* onto something: a label.
English borrowed *estiquet* and wore it down to **ticket**, meanwhile narrowing it from any label to a paid-for slip. Spanish then borrowed the English word back, keeping the English spelling.
Spanish also kept the original French form separately, as **la etiqueta** — a label, and by extension the rules of polite behaviour, which were once literally the notices posted at court telling visitors how to behave. One Frankish word for sticking something on a surface, and it has ended up as a supermarket receipt and as the word *etiquette*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- would you like the receipt?
- keep the receipt and show it at the desk
- which of the three words fits a concert

Before you move on

The receipt? (**El ticket**.) The way in? (**La entrada**.) What did *estiquier* mean? (**To stick** — it was a label.)

451.6 revisar — look at it again

Say **ver** and **el aviso**. Both have the same Latin verb inside them, and so does the word coming next.

You'll want to know: revisar

revisar — to check, to go over, to inspect.

Voy a revisar el ticket — I'll check the receipt. *Han revisado el coche* — they've serviced the car. *Revisa las respuestas antes de entregar* — check your answers before handing it in.

Two nouns come with it: **la revisión**, the check-up or the service, and **el revisor**, the inspector who comes down the train.

Grammar Lens: revisar is not mirar

Three verbs of looking, now sorted:

what happens	the verb
it arrives at your eyes	**ver**
you aim your eyes at it	**mirar**
you go over it for faults	**revisar**

Veo el ticket — the receipt is in my field of vision. *Miro el ticket* — I direct my attention at it. *Reviso el ticket* — I am checking whether they charged me twice.

Only the third carries the idea of a verdict at the end. That is why a mechanic *revisa* a car and a passenger merely *mira* the timetable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

re-vis-ar: the prefix *re-*, again, on the stem *vis-* from Latin **videre**, to see, through its participle *visus*.

So *revisar* is to see again — the second look, which is the one where you find what the first look missed.

You have met this root twice already without the seeing being visible. **Ver** is *videre* worn down to two letters. **El aviso** is *a-vis-o*, a bringing to someone's sight. Add *revisar* and you have three words from one Latin verb, each hiding it to a different degree. The English cousins run alongside: **vision**, **advise**, **revise**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I'll check the receipt
- check your answers before handing it in
- what *ver*, *aviso* and *revisar* share

Before you move on

To check over? (**Revisar**.) The inspector on the train? (**El revisor**.) What does the *re-* add? (**Again** — it is the second look.)

451.7 (la cola, apuntar, el carné, mostrar, el ticket, revisar) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all six: *the queue*, *to note down*, *the card*, *to show*, *the receipt*, *to check*.

Grammar Lens: which slip of paper

Four words now cover what English calls a card or a ticket. The sort is by job, not by material:

what it does	the word
says who you are	el carné
carries you somewhere	el billete
gets you in	la entrada
proves you paid	el ticket

Read the left-hand column aloud and the right-hand one answers itself. Try to remember it as four pieces of plastic and paper and it will not, because three of them look identical.

Grammar Lens: two verbs you already half-owned

new verb	what it was built on
apuntar	*el punto*, and behind it *pungere*, to pierce
revisar	*ver* and *el aviso*, and behind them *videre*
mostrar	*monstrum*, an omen — something shown

Revisar is the clearest case in the chapter. You have been saying **ver** since the beginning and **el aviso** for many chapters, without either one looking like Latin *videre*. The third member makes the family visible, and now all three are cheaper to hold than any one of them was alone.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- there's a queue, so put your name down first
- you have to show your card at the entrance
- which verb means going over something for faults

Before you move on

All six again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence that gets you from the back of a queue to a receipt in your hand.

451.8 (en el mostrador) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **el carné** and **el ticket**. The notice below asks for both, at different moments.

Your turn

A notice above the counter at a leisure centre. Read it, then answer.

CAMBIOS Y DEVOLUCIONES

1. Haga **cola** en la ventanilla 2. No se atiende sin turno.
2. **Muestre** el **carné** de socio y el **ticket** de compra.
3. Si no tiene el ticket, **apúntese** en la lista y le llamamos.
4. **Revisamos** cada caso en 48 horas.

Say these aloud:

- the two things you must have with you
- what to do if you have lost the receipt
- how long the decision takes

Why it's said this way

The notice asks for two pieces of plastic and the words are not interchangeable. The **carné de socio** says who you are; the **ticket** says you paid. Lose the first and they cannot identify you; lose the second and they cannot see what you bought. So step three deals only with the missing ticket, and identity is still required.
Then look at the verbs. **Muestre**, **apúntese**, **haga** are all *usted* commands — the register of any counter in Spain. **Apúntese** carries its pronoun on the end and takes a written accent to hold the stress where it was in *apunte*; without the mark you would read *apuntese* with the stress in the wrong place.
Revisamos breaks the pattern deliberately. The first three lines tell you what to do; the fourth says what *we* do. Moving to *nosotros* at the end is how a notice stops giving orders and starts making a promise.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four numbered lines for a counter notice: tell people to queue, to show a card, to keep the receipt, and say that you check each case within two days. Then check yourself: did you use the *usted* command for the instructions and switch to *nosotros* for what the office does?

Chapter 452

El reparto

Modes: **voice** (6) **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can deal with a delivery: read the card left through the door, say where the parcel has gone, quote a tracking number, and ask for a time that suits me.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

452.1 el almacén — where the boxes wait

> Say **la tienda** and **la caja**. The shop sells them; somewhere else keeps them.

You'll want to know: el almacén

el almacén — the warehouse, and in a shop the stockroom out the back.

Está en el almacén — it's in the stockroom. *No queda en almacén* — there's none left in stock. *Los almacenes* — the plural, and note the accent disappears: *almacén* needs it, *almacenes* does not.

Almacenar is the verb, to store. A computer stores the same way: *datos almacenados*.

Grammar Lens: the accent that comes and goes

The stress never moves. The mark does:

singular	**plural**
el almac**é**n	los almac**e**nes
el exam**e**n →	los ex**á**menes

Almacén ends in **n** with the stress on the last syllable, which is not the default, so it needs a mark. Add *-es* and the stress is now on the second-to-last syllable, which **is** the default — so the mark comes off. *Examen* runs the opposite way for the same reason, and having the two side by side is the clearest way to see that the accent is a correction to a rule, not a property of the word.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Arabic **al-makhzan**, the storehouse — from *khazana*, to store up. The **al-** is the Arabic definite article, and Spanish swallowed it whole. That happened to hundreds of words during the centuries of Arabic rule, and once you know the sign you can spot them: *almohada*, *alcalde*, *alfombra*, *algodón*, *azúcar*, *aceite*. Every *al-* at the front of a Spanish word is worth a second look.
So *el almacén* is, strictly, "the the-storehouse". Spanish was not troubled by this and neither is English, which took *magazine* from the same Arabic word by way of French — a store of articles, and then a store of ammunition.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- it's in the stockroom
- the plural, and say whether it keeps the accent
- what the *al-* at the front is

Before you move on

The warehouse? (**El almacén**.) The plural? (**Los almacenes**, no accent.) Which English word is its cousin? (**Magazine**.)

452.2 la ruta — the way through

Say **roto** and **la calle**. One of those two is about to turn up inside a word for a road.

You'll want to know: la ruta

la ruta — the route.

La ruta del reparto — the delivery round. *Cambiar de ruta* — to change route. *La ruta más corta* — the shortest way. *En ruta* — on the way.

It is the word for a **planned** road, which is why a delivery driver, a bus company and a hiking map all use it. The street itself stays *la calle*; the line you trace across several of them is *la ruta*.

Grammar Lens: ruta, camino, calle

Three words an English speaker would cover with "road" or "way":

what it is	the word
the street with the houses on it	**la calle**
the path underfoot	**el camino**
the plan of where to go	**la ruta**

Voy por la calle Mayor — I'm going along a particular street. *El camino está mojado* — the path is wet, something you can stand on. *La ruta pasa por tres pueblos* — the route goes through three villages, which is a fact about the plan and not about any surface.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **via rupta** — a **broken** way.

Rupta is the participle of *rumpere*, to burst or break, and it is the very word you already have in **roto**. A *via rupta* was a road forced through what was in the way: trees felled, rock broken, a line opened where there had been none.

Latin then dropped the *via* and kept the adjective, which is how a word meaning "broken" ended up meaning "route". English took it from French as **route**, and also as **rout** — an army broken open — and **routine**, a way so well worn that you no longer choose it.

So *roto* and *ruta* are one word. A broken plate and a road through a mountain are the same idea applied to two different obstacles.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the delivery route leaves from the warehouse
- we have to change route
- what *roto* and *ruta* have in common

Before you move on

The route? (**La ruta**.) The street? (**La calle**.) What did *via rupta* mean? (**A broken way** — forced through.)

452.3 el seguimiento — where the parcel is

Say **seguir** and **el entrenamiento**. Put the ending of the second onto the first.

You'll want to know: el seguimiento

el seguimiento — tracking, and in a clinic or an office, follow-up.

El número de seguimiento — the tracking number. *Hacer seguimiento de un pedido* — to track an order. *Una consulta de seguimiento* — a follow-up appointment.

Whatever is being followed, the word is the same: a parcel across a country, a patient across six months, a complaint across three departments.

Grammar Lens: you could have built this yourself

Seguir you have had for chapters. **-miento** you met on *entrenamiento*. Put them together and the word comes out with its gender attached:

verb	**noun**
entrenar	el entrena**miento**
seguir	el segui**miento**
sentir	el senti**miento**

Masculine, all of them, as every **-miento** noun is. And note what happened to the stem: *seguir* has an **i** that *sigo* turns into... nothing you need here, because **-miento** attaches to the calm form of the verb, not the shouting one.

This is the point at which Spanish vocabulary starts paying compound interest. A verb plus a known ending is not a new word to learn; it is two things you own, joined.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **sequi**, to follow. It is a root you have been walking past for a long time.
Enseguida — *en seguida*, "in following" — is next-thing-along turned into right-away. And the family in English is enormous: a **sequence** is things following each other, a **consequence** is what follows from something, a **sequel** follows a film, and a **second** is the one that follows the first.
Perseguir is to follow all the way through, and *conseguir* — to get hold of something — is to follow it until you have it. Spanish named succeeding after the chasing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the tracking number
- I'm going to track the order
- which verb is inside *enseguida*

Before you move on

Tracking? (**El seguimiento**.) What gender do *-miento* nouns take? (**Masculine**.) What does Latin *sequi* mean? (**To follow**.)

452.4 cómodo — comfortable, and convenient

Say **el modo** and **duro**. A hard mattress and a comfortable one are about to be the same question.

You'll want to know: cómodo

cómodo — comfortable, and also convenient.

Un sillón muy cómodo — a very comfortable armchair. *¿Estás cómodo?* — are you comfortable? And the other half: *una ruta más cómoda* — an easier route. *A la hora que te sea más cómoda* — whenever suits you best.

So it covers both the cushion and the convenience, where English needs two words. **La comodidad** is the noun, and **incómodo** the opposite, for a chair and for a silence alike.

Grammar Lens: the false friend runs one way only

English **commodious** means roomy, and that is not what *cómodo* means. The trap is worth naming because it is asymmetric:

you want to say	Spanish
a comfortable chair	*una silla c**ó**moda*
a convenient time	*una hora c**ó**moda*
a roomy flat	*un piso **amplio***

Going from Spanish to English, *cómodo* is safe — "comfortable" is nearly always right. Going the other way, "commodious" will not get you there and *amplio* will.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **commodus**: **com-**, with, plus **modus**, a measure — the same *modus* inside **el modo**.

Something *commodus* was "with measure": the right size, fitted to its purpose, neither too much nor too little. From there the road to "comfortable" is short, because a thing that fits is a thing that does not chafe.

The measuring sense survives in English **accommodate**, to make something fit, and in **commodity**, which began as a thing that suited you before it meant a sack of wheat. Spanish keeps the plainest version: a chair that fits you is *cómodo*, and so is a time that fits your day.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a very comfortable armchair
- whenever suits you best
- which Spanish word you would use for a roomy flat

Before you move on

Comfortable? (**Cómodo**.) What is the *modus* inside it? (**A measure** — a thing that fits.) The opposite? (**Incómodo**.)

452.5 (el almacén, la ruta, el seguimiento, cómodo) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all four: *the warehouse*, *the route*, *the tracking*, *comfortable*.

Grammar Lens: three accents, three different jobs

Two of this chapter's words carry a written accent, and they carry it for opposite reasons:

word	why the mark is there
almac**é**n	stress on the last syllable, ending in *n*
c**ó**modo	stress three syllables from the end

Spanish defaults to the second-to-last syllable for a word ending in a vowel, *n* or *s*. *Almacén* breaks that by going later; *cómodo* breaks it by going earlier. Both need a mark to say so, and *ruta* and *seguimiento* need none because both obey the default.

That is why *almacenes* loses the accent while *cómodos* keeps it. The mark is a **correction to a rule**, not a decoration attached to a word, so it appears and disappears as the word changes shape.

Grammar Lens: two of the four were already yours

new word	what it was built on
la ruta	*roto* — Latin *via rupta*, a broken way
el seguimiento	*seguir* plus the *-miento* of *entrenamiento*
cómodo	*el modo*, a measure, with *com-* in front

La ruta is the one to keep. You learned *roto* for a plate in two halves, and the same Latin participle names a road — because a road is what

you get when something in the way has been broken through. Only **el almacén** arrived from outside the family, and it came from Arabic with its article still stuck to the front.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the route starts at the warehouse
- give me the tracking number
- which two of the four keep an accent in the plural

Before you move on

All four again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence that sends a parcel somewhere.

452.6 (el aviso de entrega) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **el seguimiento** and **el almacén**. The card below sends you to one using the other.

Your turn

A card through the letterbox. Read it, then answer.

AVISO DE ENTREGA

Hemos pasado a las 11:40 y no había nadie.

Su paquete vuelve al **almacén** esta tarde.

Consulte el **seguimiento** con el número 4471-XK.

Puede recogerlo mañana o pedir una segunda entrega a la hora que le resulte más **cómoda**.

Say these aloud:

- where the parcel is going now
- the two things you are allowed to do tomorrow
- what the number is for

Why it's said this way

A la hora que le resulte más cómoda is the phrase to take away whole. It is how Spanish says "whenever suits you", and *cómoda* there has nothing to do with comfort — it is the convenience half of the word, agreeing with *la hora*.
Then notice what the card does **not** say. There is no *nosotros* after the first line: *su paquete vuelve*, *puede recogerlo*. Spanish keeps the company out of it and lets the parcel be the subject. The one place the firm appears — *hemos pasado* — is the one fact it is claiming responsibility for.
And **consulte** is the *usted* command again, the register of every counter and every card of this kind.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines for a delivery card: say nobody was in, say the parcel goes back to the warehouse, give a tracking number to check, and offer a time that suits them.
Then check yourself: did *cómoda* agree with *la hora*, and did you use the *usted* command?

Chapter 453

El turno

Modes: **voice** (5) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 4 of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read the rota taped up in a stairwell: say whose week it is, say what is and is not included, and check the sheet before changing anything.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

453.1 la limpieza — the cleaning

> Say **limpio** and **la mudanza**. One is a description, the other names a job of work. You are about to turn the first into the second.

You'll want to know: la limpieza

la limpieza — cleaning, the cleaning.

El turno de limpieza — the cleaning shift. *Productos de limpieza* — cleaning products. *La limpieza del portal es los martes* — the entrance hall is cleaned on Tuesdays.

It names the activity, not the state. For the state you still say *está limpio*. **Limpiar** is the verb: *hay que limpiar la cocina*.

Grammar Lens: four endings, four genders settled

You now have the full set of Spanish's everyday noun-makers:

ending	example	gender
-anza	la mud**anza**	feminine
-miento	el segui**miento**	masculine
-eza	la limpi**eza**	feminine
-ción	la instala**ción**	feminine

Three of the four are feminine, and **-miento** is the one to remember as the exception. Learn the ending and the article stops being a guess. Which ending a given word takes is not predictable — *limpieza* and not *limpiamiento*, *seguimiento* and not *seguianza* — and there is no rule waiting to be found. What is reliable is the gender, and that is most of what you needed.

-eza attaches to adjectives rather than verbs: *limpio* gives *limpieza*, *triste* gives *tristeza*, *pobre* gives *pobreza*. It names the quality, and in this one case also the work of producing it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **limpidus**, clear — as in water you can see through.

English took the same word as **limpid**, and kept it for water and for prose. Spanish let it drift from "clear" to "clean", which is a short walk: a clear stream is a clean one.

There is an older Spanish word for clean, *neto*, from Latin *nitidus*, and it survives in *el peso neto* on a packet. Where Spanish kept two, it usually gave them separate jobs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the cleaning shift
- the kitchen is clean, using the adjective
- which of the four endings is masculine

Before you move on

The cleaning? (**La limpieza**.) The verb? (**Limpiar**.) What did *limpidus* mean? (**Clear** — see-through water.)

453.2 la instalación — the act, and the thing

Say **arreglar** and **la oficina**. Somebody put the heating into that building, and there is one word for both halves of that.

You'll want to know: la instalación

la instalación — the installation, the fitting: and also the thing fitted.

La instalación del aire acondicionado — putting the air conditioning in. *La instalación eléctrica es vieja* — the wiring is old. And in the plural, the premises: *las instalaciones deportivas* — the sports facilities.

Instalar is the verb, for a boiler and for a program alike.

Grammar Lens: -ción names the act and then the result

This double sense is not a quirk of one word. It is what **-ción** does:

word	the act	the result
la instalación	fitting it	the wiring
la construcción	building it	the building
la decoración	decorating	the decor

The noun names the doing, and then drifts onto whatever the doing left behind. When you meet a *-ción* word, expect both readings and let the sentence pick: *durante la instalación* is the act, *revisar la instalación* is the thing.

Every one is feminine, and every one takes an accent in the singular that it loses in the plural — *instalación*, *instalaciones* — for the reason *almacén* did.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Old French **installer**: **in-** plus **stalle**, a stall — a seat in a choir, from a Germanic word for a standing-place.

To *install* somebody was to put them **in their stall**: to seat a canon in his place in the cathedral. The word began as ceremony, moved to furniture, and now means putting a boiler on a wall or software on a machine.

The Germanic *stall* is still around in English for a horse's, in *stall* the market stand, and in **stand** itself. A boiler and a cathedral canon are installed with the same word because both have been put where they belong.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the wiring is old
- the sports facilities are closed for cleaning
- what *-ción* nouns name besides the act

Before you move on

The installation? (**La instalación**.) The plural? (**Las instalaciones**, accent gone.) What was a *stalle*? (**A stall** — a standing-place, a seat.)

453.3 rotativo — it comes round again

Say **la rueda** and **alrededor**. A third word off the same Latin wheel is coming.

You'll want to know: rotativo

rotativo — rotating, done in turns, on a rota.

Un turno rotativo — a rotating shift. *La limpieza es rotativa* — the cleaning goes round the neighbours. *Presidencia rotativa* — a chairmanship that passes from one member to the next.

The idea is always the same: the job does not stay with one person, it comes round. **Rotar** is the verb, and **la rotación** the noun with the ending from the lesson before this one.

Grammar Lens: -ivo describes what a thing does

-ivo makes an adjective meaning "of the kind that does this":

verb	adjective
rotar	rotat**ivo** — that rotates
informar	informat**ivo** — that informs
decorar	decorat**ivo** — that decorates

It is not about being in the act. A *turno rotativo* is not rotating at this moment; it is a shift **of the rotating kind**. The ending names a habit or a capacity, which is why *un cartel informativo* is informative

whether or not anybody is reading it.
English has the identical ending in *rotative*, *informative*, *decorative*, and uses it the same way.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **rota**, wheel — for the third time, and it is worth stopping on.

word	how the wheel got in
la rueda	straight down from *rota*, vowel broken by stress
alrededor	*retrō* bent sideways by *rota*
rotativo	lifted from *rota* whole, by scholars

Three words, three routes out of one Latin noun. *Rueda* is what centuries of speakers did to it. *Rotativo* is what a writer did to it in one step, keeping the **o** intact because it never passed through anybody's mouth on the way.
That difference — worn down by speech, or lifted whole from a book — is the single most useful thing to notice about Spanish vocabulary, and here you can see both outcomes of it side by side.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a rotating shift
- the cleaning goes round the neighbours
- why *rueda* has *ue* and *rotativo* does not

Before you move on

Rotating? (**Rotativo**.) The verb? (**Rotar**.) What does *-ivo* name — an action happening, or a habit? (**A habit or a capacity**.)

453.4 consultar — look it up

Say **revisar** and **el documento**. Both are about paper, and what you do to it differs.

You'll want to know: consultar

consultar — to look up, to check, to consult.

Consulte el horario — check the timetable. *Lo consulto y te digo* — I'll look into it and get back to you. *Consultar con el jefe* — to check with the boss.

Two nouns come with it: **la consulta**, which is both the query and a doctor's surgery, and **el consultorio**, the consulting room.

Grammar Lens: consultar, revisar, mirar

Three verbs that all come out as "check" in English, now separated by what you are after:

what you want	the verb
a fact you do not have	**consultar**
faults in something you do have	**revisar**
to aim your eyes at it	**mirar**

Consulto el horario — I do not know the time and the timetable does. *Reviso el horario* — I am checking the timetable for mistakes, which is a different errand entirely. *Miro el horario* — my eyes are on it, and the sentence has said nothing about why.

Note the preposition: you *consultar* a document directly, but *consultar* ***con*** a person. The **con** marks that the other party can answer back.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **consultare**, the repeated form of **consulere** — to take counsel, to deliberate.

The Roman **consul** is the same root: the officer who takes counsel for the state. And **el consejo** — advice, and a council — came down the spoken road from *consilium*, a close relation.

So *consultar* and *el consejo* are family, and the pair shows the split this chapter keeps meeting: *consejo* is worn smooth by centuries of speech, *consultar* was lifted from Latin by clerks with the **l** and the **t** still in place.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- check the timetable

- I'll check with the boss and tell you
- which preposition goes before a person

Before you move on

To look up? (**Consultar**.) To check for faults? (**Revisar**.) Which Roman officer shares the root? (**The consul** — one who takes counsel.)

453.5 (la limpieza, la instalación, rotativo, consultar) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all four: *the cleaning*, *the installation*, *rotating*, *to look up*.

Grammar Lens: the same Latin word, twice, differently

Two pairs in this chapter show the single most useful fact about Spanish vocabulary: a Latin word can arrive **twice**, once through speech and once through books, and the two arrivals look nothing alike.

worn down by speech	**lifted from the page**
la r**ue**da	r**o**tativo
el cons**ejo**	cons**ultar**

The left-hand column went through hundreds of years of mouths: vowels broke, consonants softened, syllables fell out. The right-hand column was copied out by a clerk who could read Latin, so it kept its shape.

The practical payoff: when a Spanish word looks **more** like its Latin or English cousin, it is usually the later, bookish arrival — and it will belong to writing, forms and notices rather than to the kitchen. That is a register clue you can read straight off the spelling.

Grammar Lens: the four noun-makers, complete

ending	example	gender
-anza	la mudanza	feminine
-miento	el seguimiento	masculine
-eza	la limpieza	feminine
-ción	la instalación	feminine

Three feminine, one masculine. Which ending a word takes has to be met word by word; the gender never does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the cleaning shift is on a rota
- check the timetable and tell me
- which of *rueda* and *rotativo* came through speech

Before you move on

All four again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence putting somebody on a cleaning rota.

453.6 (el cuadro de turnos) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **la limpieza** and **rotativo**. The notice below puts them in the same line.

Your turn

A sheet taped inside the entrance hall. Read it, then answer.

TURNOS DE LIMPIEZA — ESCALERA B

La **limpieza** del portal es **rotativa**, una semana por vivienda.

Esta semana: 3º izquierda. La próxima: 3º derecha.

No se limpia la **instalación** de la caldera. De eso se encarga la empresa.

Para cambiar de semana, **consulten** el cuadro antes de escribir en él.

Say these aloud:

- whose turn it is this week and whose it is next
- the one thing the neighbours do not have to clean
- what you must do before changing your week

Why it's said this way

La instalación de la caldera is the noun in its second sense — not the act of fitting the boiler, which happened years ago, but the pipes and tank it left behind. Nothing in the sentence announces which reading is meant; *no se limpia* settles it, because you cannot clean an act.
Rotativa agrees with *la limpieza*, and it is doing the work of a whole English clause: "goes round the flats in turn". One adjective, because Spanish had a word for the wheel and built on it.
Then **consulten**: *ustedes*, plural and formal, the register of a notice addressed to every household at once. And *se encarga*, once again the *se* that lets a sentence say what happens without naming who.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines for a stairwell notice: say the cleaning is on a rota, say whose week it is, say the boiler installation is not included, and tell people to check the sheet first.
Then check yourself: did *rotativa* agree with *la limpieza*, and did you use the *ustedes* command?

Chapter 454

La vía cortada

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can follow a road or rail closure: read the barrier notice, understand a delay announcement, say what caused it and what is running instead.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

454.1 la obra — the works

> Say **la oficina** and **arreglar**. There is a Latin word for *work* hiding in the first, and it is about to come out on its own.

You'll want to know: la obra

la obra — the works: building work, and the site it happens on.

> Calle cortada por **obras**.

Están de obras — they have the builders in. *La obra empieza en marzo* — work starts in March. *Un obrero* is a manual worker, and *la mano de obra* is labour.

It also means a work of art or a play — *una obra de teatro* — which is the same idea: a thing somebody made.

Grammar Lens: obras in the plural is the roadworks

Singular and plural point at different things here:

Spanish	what it names
la obra	the project, or the artwork
las obras	the works going on, the disruption

Every barrier and diversion sign in Spain says **OBRAS**, plural. A Spaniard saying *hay obras en mi calle* is complaining about noise and dust, not about a sculpture.

Keep *estar de obras* as a phrase: it describes a building in the state of being worked on, and *estar* is right because it is a condition that will pass.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **opera**, works — the plural of **opus**, a work, taken by Spanish as a singular feminine noun.

The same *opus* is inside **la oficina**, which is *opus* plus *facere*: the place where work gets done. So a builder's site and an office are the same Latin word, arriving by different routes and landing far apart.

Opera the music is the identical word again, borrowed through Italian: *the works*. And English **operate**, **operation** and **opus** are all here too. One Latin noun for work, and it has ended up meaning a hole in the road, a room with desks, and a night at the theatre.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- street closed for works
- they have the builders in
- what *la obra* and *la oficina* share

Before you move on

The roadworks? (**Las obras**, plural.) A play? (**Una obra de teatro**.) What did Latin *opus* mean? (**A work**.)

454.2 la vía — the track

Say **el andén** and **todavía**. One of those two has a road inside it, and it is not the one at the station.

You'll want to know: la vía

la vía — the track, the way, the route.

Vía 4. Tren con destino Valencia.

No cruce la vía — do not cross the track. *La vía pública* — the public highway, the wording on every municipal notice. *Por vía aérea* — by air.

The **andén** is where you stand; the **vía** is the rails in front of it. A station announcement gives you both, and mixing them up will put you on the platform edge.

Grammar Lens: the accent that breaks a diphthong

vía is two syllables: **VÍ-a**. Without the accent, *via* would be one syllable, because **i** and **a** together normally fuse.

written	**syllables**
v**ía**	VÍ-a
d**ía**	DÍ-a
fam**ilia**	fa-MI-lia

The mark on the **i** is not about stress position at all here. It is there to say: **this vowel refuses to join the next one**. Spanish has no other way to write that, so the accent does double duty across the language — sometimes marking stress, sometimes prising two vowels apart. *Todavía* has it for the same reason, and you have been reading it correctly for chapters without being told why.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **via**, road — the word on every Roman milestone.
And here is the payoff. **Todavía** is *toda vía*: **all the way**. It meant "by every route, in any case", and from there slid to "still" — the sense of something that has gone the whole distance and is *still* going.
The family is everywhere once you see it: *el viaje*, a journey; *el viaducto*, a way carried over; English **via**, **obvious** (*ob-viam*, lying in the way), **trivial** (*tri-vium*, a place where three roads meet, so

common it is worth nothing), and **voyage**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- track 4, and do not cross the track
- which one is the platform and which the rails
- what *todavía* is made of

Before you move on

The track? (**La vía**.) How many syllables? (**Two** — the accent keeps them apart.) What does *todavía* literally say? (**All the way**.)

454.3 el accidente — what falls on you

Say **la ocasión** and **roto**. A chance and a breakage are about to meet in one Latin verb.

You'll want to know: el accidente

el accidente — the accident.

Ha habido un accidente en la vía — there has been an accident on the track. *Un accidente de tráfico* — a road accident. *Un accidente laboral* — an accident at work, the phrase on every insurance form.

Spanish says *tener un accidente*, and the adverb is **por accidente** — by accident, meaning unintentionally.

Grammar Lens: -cc- is two sounds, not one

accidente has a double **c**, and unlike English the two letters do different jobs:

letters	**sound**
first **c** (before *c*)	**k**
second **c** (before *i*)	**th** in Spain, **s** elsewhere

So the word is **ak-thi-DEN-te**, or **ak-si-DEN-te**. The rule underneath is one you already use: a Spanish **c** is hard before *a*, *o*, *u*

and another consonant, and soft before *e* and *i*.
The same double turns up in *acción*, *dirección* and *lección*. Once you hear the **k** in front of the soft one, these stop being awkward.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **accidere**: **ad-**, towards, plus **cadere**, **to fall**. A thing that falls upon you.
And **la ocasión** is the same *cadere*, with a different prefix — something that falls **to** you. Put the pair side by side and Spanish has a small map of luck:

word	**what falls, and how**
la ocasión	a chance falls your way
el accidente	a misfortune falls upon you

Neither was chosen by anybody. That is the whole idea the root carries, and it is why *accidental* in English still means unplanned rather than harmful.
The same *cadere* is in **caer**, to fall, and in English **cadence**, **decay** and **cascade**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- there has been an accident on the track
- I did it by accident
- how *ocasión* and *accidente* are related

Before you move on

The accident? (**El accidente**.) What does *cadere* mean? (**To fall**.) Which one lands *on* you, and which drops *in front of* you? (**Accidente** on you, **ocasión** in front of you.)

454.4 el servicio — the service

Say **servir** and **arreglar**. Somebody comes out to the accident to do the second, and what they belong to is coming next.

You'll want to know: el servicio

el servicio — the service.

El servicio de grúa — the recovery service, the tow truck. *Los servicios de emergencia* — the emergency services. *Fuera de servicio* — out of service, the sign on a broken lift or a stopped bus.

And the one that catches people out: **el servicio** on a door means **the toilet**. *¿Dónde está el servicio?* is how you ask, and *los servicios* is what the sign in a bar says.

Grammar Lens: fuera de servicio, and its cousins

Fuera de plus a bare noun is a fixed frame, and it turns up on notices constantly:

sign	what it means
fuera de servicio	out of order
fuera de plazo	past the deadline
fuera de temporada	out of season

No article after *de* in any of them. That bare noun is the signal that you are looking at a set phrase rather than a description, and trying to insert *el* will sound wrong to a Spanish ear for the same reason "out of the order" does to an English one.

Set beside **estropeado**, the difference is who is speaking: *fuera de servicio* is the institution's wording, *estropeado* is what a neighbour says.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **servitium**, from **servire**, to serve — and behind that **servus**, a slave.

That is the uncomfortable root of a very ordinary word, and it has not disappeared: *el siervo* is a serf, and English **servile** keeps the sting.

Spanish softened the rest of the family — *servir* is what a waiter does, *el servicio* is what a company sells — while the original sense stayed in the words nobody uses lightly.

English got **serve**, **servant** and **sergeant** from the same place. The last one is *serviens*, "one serving", which rose from servant to soldier to rank.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the emergency services are on the way
- the lift is out of service
- how you would ask for the toilet

Before you move on

Out of service? (**Fuera de servicio**.) The toilet? (**El servicio**.) What was a *servus*? (**A slave**.)

454.5 (la obra, la vía, el accidente, el servicio) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all four: *the works*, *the track*, *the accident*, *the service*.

Grammar Lens: the plural is not always more of the same

Two of these four shift meaning when you add the **s**:

singular	**plural**
la obra — the project	*las obras* — the disruption
el servicio — the service	*los servicios* — the toilets

This is worth holding because the plural is the form you will actually read. Every diversion sign says **OBRAS** and every bar door says **SERVICIOS**, so the singular meanings you learned are the ones you will meet less often.

La vía and *el accidente* behave themselves and mean exactly more of the same thing.

Grammar Lens: every one of the four was already in the corpus

new word	where its root already was
la obra	*la oficina* — *opus* + *facere*
la vía	*todavía* — *toda vía*, all the way
el accidente	*la ocasión* — both from *cadere*, to fall
el servicio	*servir*

Todavía is the sharpest of the four. It is among the commonest words in the language, you have been using it for chapters, and the road was sitting inside it the whole time.
That keeps happening — *mira* gave *mirar*, *sí claro* will give *claro*, *el punto* gave *apuntar*. When a new word looks like a piece of something you already say, check before learning it twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the street is closed for works
- do not cross the track
- which two words change meaning in the plural

Before you move on

All four again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence that closes a road.

454.6 (calle cortada) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **las obras** and **la vía**. Each one closes something below.

Your turn

Two notices on the same morning. Read both, then answer.
1 — on a barrier

Calle cortada por **obras** hasta el día 12. Paso de peatones por la acera de enfrente.

2 — over the loudspeaker

Atención. Por un **accidente** en la **vía**, el tren con destino Valencia saldrá con retraso. El **servicio** de autobús sustituirá al tren hasta las once.

Say these aloud:

- how long the street is shut, and where to walk
- why the train is late
- what is replacing it, and until when

Why it's said this way

Por un accidente en la vía is doing the work of an English clause — "because there has been an accident on the line". *Por* plus a noun is how Spanish gives a cause on a notice, and it is shorter than any sentence you could build with *porque*. The same shape opened the first notice: *cortada por obras*.
Then notice **el servicio de autobús sustituirá al tren**. The announcement names the *service*, not the buses, and the service is what acts. An English announcement would more likely say "buses will replace the train". Spanish prefers the institution as the subject in this register, which is the opposite of what the delivery card did — and the difference is that a card is apologising while an announcement is informing.
Cortada agrees with *la calle*: feminine, because the street is.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines: say the street is closed for works, say until when, say there has been an accident on the track, and say a bus service is replacing the train. Then check yourself: did you use *por* plus a noun to give the reason, and did *cortada* agree with what it describes?

Chapter 455

La habitación

Modes: **voice** (6) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 4 of 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can get a room ready and say so: what I have painted and what colour, what to put where, and what to hang out if the sun comes out.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

455.1 pintar — to paint

> Say **verde** and **arreglar**. One way of fixing a room is to change its colour.

You'll want to know: pintar

pintar — to paint, both walls and pictures.

Voy a pintar la cocina de verde — I'm going to paint the kitchen green. *Recién pintado* — wet paint, the wording on the sign. *¿Quién pintó esto?* — who painted this?

Note the **de** in *pintar de verde*. Spanish marks the resulting colour with *de*, where English puts the adjective straight after the object.

La pintura is both the paint in the tin and the painting on the wall.

Grammar Lens: recién plus a participle

Recién means "newly" or "a moment ago", and it attaches only to participles:

sign	what it means
recién pintado	wet paint
recién llegado	newly arrived
recién casados	newlyweds

In Spain it never stands alone and never modifies a normal adjective — *recién limpio* is not said. Take it as half of a two-word unit whose other half ends in *-ado* or *-ido*.
Much of Latin America is freer with it. *Recién llegué* — I arrived a moment ago — and *recién ayer* are ordinary in the Southern Cone, where *recién* behaves like a plain adverb of time.
The participle agrees: *recién pintada* for *la pared*, *recién pintados* for *los bancos*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **pingere**, to paint — a verb that also meant to **embroider**, and behind both of those an older word for **pricking or cutting a mark** into a surface.
So painting and needlework were one verb in Latin, because both put a design onto cloth. The relatives come off the painting side: English **picture**, **pigment**, **paint** and **pictorial**, and Spanish **pintoresco** — worth-painting — which English borrowed through French as **picturesque**.
The Latin participle *pictus* is where the harder consonants survived: Spanish kept the soft, spoken *pintar* and borrowed the bookish *pictórico* alongside it. Another pair arriving twice, by the two roads.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I'm going to paint the kitchen green
- wet paint, as the sign puts it
- which preposition goes before the colour

Before you move on

To paint? (**Pintar**.) Wet paint? (**Recién pintado**.) What else did *pingere* mean? (**To embroider** — both put a design on cloth.)

455.2 el dormitorio — the bedroom

Say **dormir** and **el piso**. Name the room in the second where you do the first.

You'll want to know: el dormitorio

el dormitorio — the bedroom.

Un piso de dos dormitorios — a two-bedroom flat, the wording in every advert. *El dormitorio da al patio* — the bedroom looks onto the courtyard.

La habitación also covers it in speech — *mi habitación* is what a child says — but a property listing counts *dormitorios*, because *habitación* means any room at all.

Grammar Lens: the vowel that has been breaking all along

You met **duermo** early on, as a verb that changes its stem. It is the same single rule you have now seen in a noun, an adjective and a conjugation:

plain o	stressed, so ue
d**o**rmir, d**o**rmitorio	d**ue**rmo
r**o**dar	la r**ue**da
m**o**strar	m**ue**stro

Dormitorio keeps the plain **o** because the stress lands on the **-to-**, three syllables along. Say *dormitorio* and *duermo* one after the other and you can hear the vowel change as the stress moves.

Nothing here is irregular. One vowel, one condition, and it has been running under the language since the first weeks of it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **dormitorium**, a sleeping place — from **dormire**, to sleep.

-orio names the place where something is done, and once you have it you can read a lot of signs:

word	the place for
el dormit**orio**	sleeping
el laborat**orio**	working
el velat**orio**	keeping watch over the dead

English took *dormitorium* whole as **dormitory**, and shortened it to *dorm*. It also has **dormant**, lying asleep, and the **dormouse**, named for how much of the year it spends doing exactly that.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a two-bedroom flat
- I sleep, then the name of the room
- why *dormitorio* has no *ue*

Before you move on

The bedroom? (**El dormitorio**.) What does *-orio* name? (**The place where something is done**.) Why no *ue*? (**The stress is elsewhere**.)

455.3 claro — light, and clear

Say **sí, claro** and **verde**. You have been saying the first for a very long time. This lesson is about what its second word means.

You'll want to know: claro

claro — light, pale, bright, clear.

Un dormitorio muy claro — a very light bedroom, one that gets the sun. *Verde claro* — light green. *Azul claro* — pale blue. The opposite is **oscuro**, dark.

Beyond colour: *el agua está clara* — the water is clear. *No me queda claro* — I'm not clear about it.

Grammar Lens: the word you have been using without meeting

Sí, claro has been in your mouth since early on, as a way of agreeing — "yes, of course". You were told then that it is Latin *clarus*, bright — but never that you could point it at a wall, because the phrase does not need the colour sense to work.
It is the same word. *Claro* on its own means **it's clear**, and agreeing with somebody by saying "clear!" is how Spanish arrives at "of course".

what you say	what it is doing
sí, claro	of course — the fixed phrase
un cuarto claro	a light room — the adjective
claro que sí	of course — the phrase, emphasised

This is the fourth time a fixed phrase has turned out to have an ordinary word inside it. *Mira* gave you *mirar*, *el punto* gave *apuntar*, *interesante* gave *interesar*, and now *sí, claro* gives *claro*.
Check every new word against the phrases you already say. By this stage of a language, a surprising share of new vocabulary is not new.

Grammar Lens: colour words with claro and oscuro

A colour modified by *claro* or *oscuro* **stops agreeing**:

one thing	more than one
una pared verde	*unas paredes verd**es***
una pared verde claro	*unas paredes verde claro*

Add the shade and the pair freezes. The reason is that *verde claro* is standing in for "of a light green colour" — a description of the shade rather than of the walls — and Spanish leaves such compounds unchanged.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a very light bedroom
- light green walls, plural
- what *claro* is doing inside *sí, claro*

Before you move on

Light, pale? (**Claro**.) The opposite? (**Oscuro**.) Does *verde claro* agree in the plural? (**No** — it freezes.)

455.4 tender — hang it out

Say **la tienda** and **limpio**. A shop is about to turn out to be a stretched thing.

You'll want to know: tender

tender — to hang out, to spread, to stretch out.

Voy a tender la ropa — I'm going to hang the washing out. *El tendedero* — the airer or the washing line. *Tender la mano* — to hold out your hand.

In a flat with no garden this is daily vocabulary, and the sign in a stairwell saying *no tender ropa en la fachada* is asking you not to hang washing on the front of the building.

Grammar Lens: tender is an e-to-ie verb

The same break you have watched all chapter, one vowel over:

stress on the stem	stress on the ending
t**ie**ndo, t**ie**ndes	tend**e**mos
t**ie**nde, t**ie**nden	tend**é**is

And now say **tiendo** and **la tienda** together. They are the same shape, because *la tienda* **is** this verb: a shop was a stretched awning, a cloth tent pulled open over a market stall.

The shop chapter named that cloth when it taught *la tienda*; here is the verb it was named from, so the noun and its verb finally sit together. *Tienda de campaña* — a camping tent — kept the original object entirely.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **tendere**, to stretch.

The family in English is long: **tend**, **tent**, **tension**, **extend**, **intend**, **pretend** — to stretch something out in front of you — **attention**, a stretching towards.

Spanish has the whole set too: *tender*, *la tienda*, *extender*, *pretender*, *la tensión*, *atender*. Every one of them is something being pulled taut, either a cloth or a mind.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I'm going to hang the washing out
- I hang out, using the stem-changing form
- what a *tienda* originally was

Before you move on

To hang the washing out? (**Tender la ropa**.) I hang out? (**Tiendo**.) What does *tendere* mean? (**To stretch**.)

455.5 meter — put it in

Say **el permiso** and **la caja**. There is a Latin verb inside the first, and you are about to use it on the second.

You'll want to know: meter

meter — to put in, to put inside.

Mete la ropa en la caja — put the clothes in the box. *Meter la llave* — put the key in. *Se ha metido en la cama* — he's got into bed.

Meterse also does the social senses: *no te metas* — don't interfere. *Meterse con alguien* — to pick on somebody.

Grammar Lens: meter is not poner

Both come out as "put" and they are not interchangeable:

what you are doing	the verb
putting something **inside** something	**meter**
putting something **somewhere**	**poner**

Pon el libro en la mesa — on the table, a surface. *Mete el libro en la*

caja — into the box, an inside. Swap them and a Spanish speaker will picture you burying a book in a table.
Meter nearly always brings **en** with it, because "in" is the whole idea of the verb. If there is no inside, you want *poner*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **mittere**, to send — and its participle *missus*.
Spanish wore the plain verb down to *meter* and shifted it from sending to inserting, which is a short move: to send a thing into a box is to put it there. The bookish arrivals kept the shape: *admitir*, *permitir*, *emitir*, *transmitir*.
And there it is in a word you already have. **El permiso** is *per-* plus *missus*: something **sent through**. English took the same set as **permit**, **admit**, **mission**, **missile** and **message** — every one of them a sending.
So *meter la ropa en la caja* and *pedir permiso* run on one Latin verb, one worn smooth and one carried in from the page.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- put the clothes in the box
- put the book on the table, choosing the right verb
- what *el permiso* has to do with *meter*

Before you move on

To put inside? (**Meter**.) Which preposition follows it? (**En**.) What does *mittere* mean? (**To send**.)

455.6 (pintar, el dormitorio, claro, tender, meter) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *to paint*, *the bedroom*, *light*, *to hang out*, *to put in*.

Grammar Lens: the fourth phrase to give up a word

what you already said	the word inside it
interesante	**interesar**
mira	**mirar**
el punto	**apuntar**
sí, claro	**claro**

And **la tienda** joins them from the other direction: a shop turned out to be this chapter's verb, a stretched awning.
Claro is the strongest case yet, because *sí, claro* is among the first things anybody learns to say in Spanish and among the commonest things anybody says. You were told back then that it means *bright* — and still never once used it to describe a room, because agreeing with somebody asks nothing of the colour sense.
The habit to keep: when a new word resembles a phrase you already use, look for the connection before learning it twice.

Grammar Lens: two verbs that both mean put

the picture	the verb
into an inside	**meter** — *meter en la caja*
onto or at a place	**poner** — *poner en la mesa*

Meter comes with **en** because "in" is the verb's whole meaning. If nothing encloses the thing, *poner* is what you want.
The same test sorts *pintar de verde*, where **de** marks a resulting colour. Spanish tells you a great deal through its prepositions, and each of these verbs carries one it will not give up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I'm painting the bedroom a light green
- put the clothes in the box
- which verb you use for a surface

Before you move on

All five again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence about getting a room ready.

455.7 (dejar el piso listo) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **pintar** and **claro**. The message below uses them in the same line, and one of them is not about colour.

Your turn

A message between two people sharing a flat. Read it, then answer.

Oye, mañana viene mi hermana.

He **pintado** el **dormitorio** de azul **claro** y huele fuerte, así que deja la ventana abierta.

¿Puedes **meter** las cajas del pasillo en el trastero? No me ha dado tiempo.

Y si sale el sol, **tiende** las toallas antes de irte. Gracias.

Say these aloud:

- what colour the bedroom is now, and what to do about the smell
- the two jobs being asked for
- what has to happen before the towels go out

Why it's said this way

De azul claro carries both of this chapter's small grammar points at once. *De* marks the resulting colour, and *azul claro* does **not** agree with anything — no *azules claros* even if there were several walls, because the pair has frozen into a name for the shade.
Meter las cajas en el trastero is *meter* doing exactly its job: a storeroom is an inside, and *poner* would be wrong. Then **tiende** is the

tú command of a stem-changing verb, so the **ie** is there — *tiende*, never *tende*.
Notice the register throughout. *Oye*, *¿puedes…?*, *deja* — every one is *tú*, because this is a flatmate and not a counter. Set it beside the notices in the chapters before this one and the difference is visible in the verb endings alone.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines to a flatmate: say you have painted the bedroom a light colour, ask them to put the boxes in the storeroom, ask them to hang the washing out, and say why.
Then check yourself: did you use *de* before the colour, *meter* for the inside, and the *tú* forms throughout?

Chapter 456

La cuenta

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (3) **Hands-free start:** none of the 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can order from a set menu and then read the bill: name a first course, tell a price from a charge, query something that was added, and ask whether they take cards.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

456.1 la ensalada — the salted thing

> Say **la sal** and **la verdura**. Put the first on the second and you have named a dish.

You'll want to know: la ensalada

la ensalada — the salad.

Una ensalada mixta — a mixed salad, the standard one on every menu: lettuce, tomato, onion, tuna, olives. *De primero, ensalada* — salad to start.

Ensaladilla is not a small salad. *La ensaladilla rusa* is a cold dish of potato, carrot, tuna and mayonnaise, and it is a fixture in bars.

Grammar Lens: ordering a course

A set menu comes in courses, and Spanish names them with **de**:

Spanish	what it covers
de primero	for a first course
de segundo	for a main
de postre	for pudding

De primero, una ensalada is a complete order. No verb is needed, and adding *quiero* makes it heavier rather than politer — the waiter has asked what you are having for each course, and the phrase answers exactly that.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Ensalada is *en-* plus *sal*: a thing that has been **salted**.
It came from Catalan or Occitan and reached English as **salad** through French, wearing the salt down to nothing on the way. Spanish kept it visible, which is the whole point of stopping here — the dish is named after the dressing, not after the leaves.
The same **sal** is in **la salsa**, a sauce, and in **el salario** — Latin *salārium* is built on *sal*, and that much is solid. The famous story attached to it is not: no Roman source says soldiers were paid in salt, and the salt lesson has already warned you that the tale is an eighteenth-century invention. A salad, a sauce and a salary share a root; they do not share that anecdote.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a mixed salad
- salad to start, using the phrase from the table above
- what *ensalada*, *salsa* and *salario* share

Before you move on

The salad? (**La ensalada**.) For a first course? (**De primero**.)
What is inside the word? (**Sal** — it is the salted thing.)

456.2 el cargo — what has been put on the bill

Say **el carrito** and **la cuenta**. A cart carries a load, and so does a bill.

You'll want to know: el cargo

el cargo — the charge: an amount put onto a bill or an account.

Hay un cargo de doce euros — there's a twelve-euro charge. *Un cargo por servicio* — a service charge. *Sin cargo* — free of charge, the wording on a receipt.

Cargar is the verb — *me han cargado dos veces*, they've charged me twice — and it also means to load, and to charge a phone.

Grammar Lens: cargo is not precio

what you mean	the word
what a thing costs	**el precio**
an amount added to your bill	**el cargo**

El precio de la ensalada is on the menu; *un cargo en la cuenta* is something a business has placed there, and you may be querying it. That is why *cargo* turns up on disputes and *precio* does not: a *precio* is announced in advance, a *cargo* appears afterwards.

El cargo has a third life as a post or office — *el cargo de director* — for the same reason: a job is a load somebody carries.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **carricare**, to load a cart, built on **carrus** — the cart itself, which Spanish kept as *el carro* and shrank into **el carrito**.

So a charge on your bill is a **load put onto a cart**, and the picture holds in every branch of the family: **la carga** is a load, **el cargamento** is cargo, and **descargar** is to unload — or to download, which is unloading onto your machine.

English has the same *carricare* twice, by two different doors: **charge** came through French, and **cargo** was taken straight from Spanish in the seventeenth century. Two English words, one Latin verb, and one of them is this very Spanish noun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- there's a twelve-euro charge on the bill
- free of charge
- which word is on the menu and which on the bill

Before you move on

The charge? (**El cargo**.) Free of charge? (**Sin cargo**.) What was a *carrus*? (**A cart** — the same one inside *el carrito*.)

456.3 aceptar — we take that here

Say **pagar** and **la cuenta**. The question is whether they take the card.

You'll want to know: aceptar

aceptar — to accept.

No se **aceptan** tarjetas.

¿Aceptan tarjeta? — do you take card? *Acepto* — I accept, on a form or a screen. *Aceptar las condiciones* — to accept the terms.

It is the verb of agreeing to something offered: money, terms, an invitation, an apology.

Grammar Lens: aceptar is not admitir

Both come out as "accept" in English and they part company on a bill:

what is happening	the verb
you agree to take what is offered	**aceptar**
you let something in, or own up to it	**admitir**

Aceptan tarjeta — they will take your card. *No se admiten perros* — dogs are not let in. And *admitir un error* is to own up to one, where *aceptar un error* would mean putting up with it.

The test is direction: *aceptar* is about **agreeing**, *admitir* about **letting through**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **accipere**: **ad-**, towards, plus **capere**, **to take**.
So to accept is to take a thing **towards yourself**, and the direction is the whole meaning. Something you did not take towards yourself, you did not accept.
Capere is one of Latin's most productive verbs and you meet it constantly in English: **capture**, **capable**, **captive**, **receive** (*re-capere*, take back), **deceive**, **conceive**, **perceive**. Spanish has *capaz*, *captar*, *recibir* and *percibir* from the same stem.
The **c** before **e** is soft, so *aceptar* is *a-thep-TAR* in Spain and *a-sep-TAR* elsewhere — the same rule that gave you *accidente*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- do you take card?
- cards are not accepted, as the sign puts it
- which verb fits a sign about dogs

Before you move on

To accept? (**Aceptar**.) What does *capere* mean? (**To take**.) Which direction does the *ad-* give it? (**Towards you**.)

456.4 el coste — what it comes to

Say **costar** and **el precio**. The verb has a noun of its own, and it is not *precio*.

You'll want to know: el coste

el coste — the cost.
El coste total — the total cost. *El coste del envío* — the cost of postage. *Sin coste adicional* — at no extra cost.

In Latin America you will more often hear **el costo**; Spain says *coste*. Both are the noun sitting beside *costar*.

Grammar Lens: coste, precio, cargo

Three words now stand between you and a bill you can read:

what it names	the word
what the seller asks	**el precio**
what it works out at for you	**el coste**
an amount added to your account	**el cargo**

El precio is a number on a label. *El coste* is what the thing ends up costing once postage and the rest are in — which is why a business talks about *costes* and a shop window shows *precios*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **constare**: **con-**, together, plus **stare**, **to stand**.
Constare meant to stand firm, to be settled — and from "this is settled" it became "this is what it comes to". The price is the point at which the matter stands still.
English took the same verb twice. Through French it wore down to **cost**; lifted straight from Latin it gave **constant**, a thing that stands firm. *Coste* and *constant* are one word, and you can hear the *n* that Spanish dropped and English kept.
The *stare* underneath is the one inside **estar**, and that is the sense to hold: a cost is a standing, a place the reckoning comes to rest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the total cost, and at no extra cost
- the verb that goes with it
- which of *precio* and *coste* is on a price tag

Before you move on

The cost? (**El coste**.) What does *constare* mean? (**To stand firm**.) Which English word kept the *n*? (**Constant**.)

456.5 la agencia — somebody who acts for you

Say **la agenda** and **la oficina**. One of those two is about to turn out to be a relative.

You'll want to know: la agencia

la agencia — the agency.

Una agencia de viajes — a travel agency. *La agencia inmobiliaria* — the estate agent's. *Lo he reservado por agencia* — I booked it through an agency.

El agente is the person. And the thing an agency charges you for its trouble is **la comisión**, which appears on the bill beside the *coste*.

Grammar Lens: -encia names the doing, again

You have a set of noun-making endings now, and this is another:

ending	example
-anza	la mudanza
-miento	el seguimiento
-encia	la agencia

-encia and its twin **-ancia** come off Latin present participles, which is why they so often name an activity or a quality: *la paciencia*, *la distancia*, *la experiencia*, *la importancia*.

Every **-encia** and **-ancia** noun is feminine. Set beside *-anza*, *-eza* and *-ción*, that is five feminine suffix families against the masculine *-miento*. Keep the claim on the **suffixes**, though, not on abstract nouns in general — *el coste* and *el cargo* from this same chapter are masculine and end in neither. What the endings buy you is an article you no longer have to guess at, one ending at a time.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **agere**, **to do**, **to drive**, **to act**.

An *agencia* is a place that **acts on your behalf**, and an *agente* is the one doing the acting. Now look at **la agenda**, which you already have: it is *agenda*, "the things that must be done" — a Latin plural that Spanish took as a singular noun.

So your diary and a travel agency are the same verb: one lists what must be done, the other does it for you.

English is full of the family too — **agent**, **agenda**, **act**, **agile**, **agitate** — and Spanish keeps *el acto*, *la acción*, *exigente* and *ágil* off the same root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a travel agency
- I booked it through an agency and the cost was higher
- what *la agenda* literally means

Before you move on

The agency? (**La agencia**.) The person? (**El agente**.) What does *agere* mean? (**To do, to act**.)

456.6 (la ensalada, el cargo, aceptar, el coste, la agencia) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all five: *the salad*, *the charge*, *to accept*, *the cost*, *the agency*.

Grammar Lens: three words for money on a page

what it names	the word	where you see it
what the seller asks	el precio	a label
what it comes to for you	el coste	a quote
what has been added	el cargo	a bill

The order is the order of a transaction: you read a *precio*, you work out a *coste*, and afterwards a *cargo* appears. Any of the three translated as "price" will read as slightly wrong to a Spanish speaker in two of the three places.

Grammar Lens: four of the five were relatives

new word	what it was built on
la ensalada	*la sal* — the salted thing
el cargo	*el carrito* — a load on a cart
el coste	*costar*, and *estar* underneath it
la agencia	*la agenda* — things to be done

La agencia is the neat one. Your **agenda** is a Latin plural meaning "the things that must be done", and an **agencia** is a firm that does them for you. Diary and travel agent, one verb.
Even **aceptar** has one, though it takes longer to spot: its *capere*, to take, is the *capere* inside **el principio**, where *princeps* is the one who **takes first place**. Every word in the chapter had a relative waiting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- there's a charge on the bill I didn't expect
- do you take card?
- which of the three money words appears last

Before you move on

All five again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence querying something on a bill.

456.7 (revisar la cuenta) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **el cargo** and **la ensalada**. One of them is on the bill twice.

Your turn

A bill on the table. Read it, then answer.

Mesa 7

2 **ensaladas** mixtas 14,00

1 **ensalada** mixta 7,00

2 cafés 3,60

Cargo por servicio 2,50

No se **aceptan** tarjetas.

Say these aloud:

- what has been counted twice, and what it should say
- what the 2,50 is for
- how you are going to have to pay

Why it's said this way

To query this politely you need the right noun, and it is **cargo** rather than *precio*: the 2,50 was not asked for in advance, it was added. *Hay un cargo que no entiendo* is the sentence, and *hay un precio que no entiendo* would sound as though you were confused by the menu.
No se aceptan tarjetas is the *se* construction again, and it is plural because *tarjetas* is. Spanish agrees the verb with the thing, not with the restaurant, so a single line telling you the same thing about one card would read *no se acepta tarjeta*.
A useful softener for the whole exchange: *perdone, ¿me lo mira?* — literally "will you look at it for me", and far more common than accusing anybody of an error.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines querying a bill: ask them to look at it, say there is a charge you do not understand, say the salad appears twice, and ask whether they take card.
Then check yourself: did you use *cargo* rather than *precio*, and did *se aceptan* agree with the cards?

Chapter 457

La farmacia de guardia

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can get a medicine that is not in stock: ask for it by the word on the box, ask them to order it in, find out when it arrives, and find the chemist that is open tonight.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

457.1 el medicamento — what the doctor ordered

Say **el médico** and **la farmacia**. One writes it down, the other hands it over.

You'll want to know: el medicamento

el medicamento — the medicine, the drug: the formal word, and the one on the packaging.

Un medicamento con receta — a prescription medicine. *Este medicamento no lo tenemos* — we don't have that one in.

In speech people say **la medicina** as readily, and for a single pill **la pastilla**. *Medicamento* is what the box, the leaflet and the pharmacist will use.

Grammar Lens: -mento and -miento are the same ending

You know **-miento** from *el seguimiento*. **-mento** is the same Latin ending arriving by the other road:

worn down by speech	lifted from the page
el segui**miento**	el medica**mento**
el pensa**miento**	el docu**mento**

Both are masculine, so nothing is lost either way. What the spelling tells you is the **register**: a *-miento* noun is usually everyday, a *-mento* noun usually formal or technical. The pattern held for *rueda* and *rotativo*, and it holds here.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **medicus**, a doctor — and behind it **medēri**, to heal, to look after.
So *el médico* and *el medicamento* are one word: the healer, and the thing that does the healing. The family runs wide — *la medicina*, *remedio*, and English **remedy**, **medical**, **meditate**.
That last one is worth a second, and worth handling carefully. An older root does sit behind *medeor*, and **modus**, **moderate** and **meditate** are independent evidence for it. What you should not do is gloss that root as "measure" and then offer a doctor's judgement as the proof — that argues in a circle, as the lesson on *el médico* has already said. The cousins are real; the story about why is not established.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a prescription medicine
- the pharmacy doesn't have that one
- what *médico* and *medicamento* share

Before you move on

The medicine, on the box? (**El medicamento**.) Which ending is the formal one? (**-mento**.) What did *medēri* mean? (**To heal, to look after**.)

457.2 encargar — ask them to get it in

Say **el cargo** and **el pedido**. Put *en-* on the front of the first and you get a verb.

You'll want to know: encargar

encargar — to order something in, to ask for a thing to be got.

¿Me lo puede encargar? — can you order it in for me? *Lo tengo encargado* — it's on order. *Encargar una tarta* — to order a cake.

With **-se de** it means to take charge of something: *yo me encargo de la comida* — I'll see to the food. *De eso se encarga la empresa* — the company handles that.

Grammar Lens: encargar is not pedir

what is happening	the verb
asking for what is there	**pedir**
asking them to **get** what is not	**encargar**

In a restaurant you *pides* a salad, because it is on the menu. At a chemist's you *encargas* a medicine, because it has to be brought in. *Pedir* takes something off a list; *encargar* creates a job for somebody. That is also why *encargarse de* means taking responsibility: the load has been put on you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en- plus **cargar**, and *cargar* is the *carricare* from the lesson on **el cargo** — to load a cart.

So *encargar* is to **load a task onto somebody**, and every sense follows from that one picture. Order a cake: the baker now carries it. Take charge: you are carrying it. *El encargado* — the person in charge — is the one with the load on.

English has the same metaphor in *charge*: you are *in charge*, you *take charge*, somebody is *charged with* a duty. Two languages reached for a cart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- can you order the medicine in for me?
- I'll see to the food
- which verb you use for something on a menu

Before you move on

To order something in? (**Encargar**.) To take charge of it? (**Encargarse de**.) What is being loaded, and onto what? (**A task, onto a person** — the cart again.)

457.3 la guardia — the one that stays open

Say **guardar** and **la farmacia**. Somebody is keeping watch tonight, and it is one chemist in the town.

You'll want to know: la guardia

la guardia — duty, watch: the turn of being the one available.

Farmacia de guardia. Servicio nocturno.

La farmacia de guardia — the duty chemist, the one open when the rest are shut, posted on every pharmacy door. *Estar de guardia* — to be on call. *El médico de guardia* — the doctor on duty.

El guardia with the masculine article is a different thing: a police officer. The article carries the whole distinction.

Grammar Lens: one word, two genders, two meanings

article	what it means
la guardia	the duty, the watch
el guardia	the officer keeping it

Spanish does this with a small set of words, and the rule inside it is consistent: the **feminine** is the abstract thing, the **masculine** is the person who does it. *La guía* is the guidebook, *el guía* is the person showing you round.
So *la farmacia de guardia* is a chemist **on watch**, and *un guardia en la puerta* is a man standing at it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Germanic **wardōn**, to watch over — the same root as **guardar**, which you already have for keeping and putting away.
Spanish took a shelf of Germanic words from the Visigoths and from Frankish, and they are recognisable by the **gu-** where English has plain **w-**:

Spanish	English
guardar	**w**ard
guerra	**w**ar
guante	(glove, from the same Frankish *want*)

English got *guard* back from French, so **guard** and **ward** are the same Germanic word arriving twice — once directly, once round by way of Paris.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the duty chemist
- I'm on call tonight
- which article makes it a police officer

Before you move on

The duty chemist? (**La farmacia de guardia**.) What does *wardōn* mean? (**To watch over**.) What does Spanish **gu-** often answer to in English? (**W-** — *guerra* and *war*.)

457.4 (el medicamento, encargar, la guardia) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all three: *the medicine*, *to order in*, *the duty rota*.

Grammar Lens: the article doing the work

feminine — the thing	**masculine — the person**
la guardia — the watch	el guardia — the officer
la guía — the guidebook	el guía — the guide
la policía — the force	el policía — the officer

One pattern, and it is worth having in advance: the **feminine** names the abstract thing or the body, the **masculine** names a person doing it. A Spanish speaker hears the article and knows which you meant before the noun arrives.
So *la farmacia de guardia* has nothing to do with a man on a door.

Grammar Lens: two of the three were relatives

new word	**what it was built on**
el medicamento	*el médico* — healer and the thing that heals
encargar	*el cargo*, and *el carrito* under that
la guardia	*guardar*, from Germanic *wardōn*

All three, in fact. *Encargar* is the clearest: a cart, then a load, then a charge on a bill, then a task loaded onto somebody. Four lessons apart and one picture throughout.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- can you order the medicine in?
- the duty chemist is open tonight
- what *el guardia* means, with that article

Before you move on

All three again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence getting a medicine that is not in stock.

457.5 (en la farmacia) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **la guardia** and **el medicamento**. The door below tells you where to find one of them after hours.

Your turn

A notice taped inside the glass, and the pharmacist's reply. Read both, then answer.

1 — en la puerta

Horario: 9:00 a 14:00 y 17:00 a 20:30.

Fuera de ese horario, **farmacia de guardia** en la calle Mayor.

2 — en el mostrador

Ese **medicamento** se nos ha terminado. Se lo **encargo** y lo tiene mañana por la tarde, si le parece.

Say these aloud:

- where to go at nine in the evening
- what the pharmacist offers to do
- when the medicine will be there

Why it's said this way

Se lo encargo is the sentence to keep whole. *Encargo* rather than *pido*, because the thing is not there to be asked for — it has to be brought in. And *se lo* is two pronouns stacked: *lo* is the medicine, *se* is you. Spanish puts the person first and the thing second, which is the reverse of English.

Si le parece — "if that suits you" — is how an offer is softened at a counter. It does the same work as the *cómoda* of the delivery card, and both leave the decision with the customer without asking a question.

Notice too that the door says **fuera de ese horario** — the same *fuera de* frame as *fuera de servicio*, but here with a determiner. *Fuera de servicio* is a fixed phrase and takes nothing; *fuera de ese horario* points

back at the hours printed two lines above, and pointing needs *ese*.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines at a chemist's counter: ask for a medicine, hear that it has run out, ask them to order it in, and ask when it will be there. Then say where the duty chemist is.

Then check yourself: did you use *encargar* rather than *pedir*, and did the pronouns come out as *se lo*?

Chapter 458

El plazo

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can deal with a deadline: read the window of dates, hand a form in the right way, and understand that nothing is accepted once the window shuts.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

458.1 el plazo — by when

> Say **el placer** and **la fecha**. One of those two is an odd relative of the word coming next.

You'll want to know: el plazo

el plazo — the period allowed, and so the deadline.

> **Plazo** de presentación: hasta el 30 de abril.

Fuera de plazo — past the deadline. *En el plazo de diez días* — within ten days. *A corto plazo* — in the short term.

A second sense on any purchase: **pagar a plazos** — to pay in instalments, each one a period agreed in advance.

Grammar Lens: plazo is not fecha

what it names	the word
a day on the calendar	**la fecha**
the stretch of time you are allowed	**el plazo**

La fecha límite is the last day; *el plazo* is the whole window that ends there. So *el plazo termina el viernes* and *la fecha límite es el viernes* say the same thing from opposite ends — one names the run, the other the wall at the end of it.
Most official Spanish prefers *plazo*, because a form cares how long you have, not which square on the calendar.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **placitum** — "a thing agreed", the past participle of **placēre**, to please. What pleased both parties was what they had settled on.
That makes *el plazo* a relative of **el placer**, which you already have. Pleasure and a deadline sit oddly together until you see the middle step: *placitum* meant an agreement, then the term of an agreement, then the time you have got.
French took the same *placitum* and made **plaid**, a court hearing, and English has **plea** and **plead** from it — all of them agreements argued over. Spanish kept the calmest branch: a *plazo* is what was agreed, and the paperwork holds you to it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the deadline is the thirtieth of April
- past the deadline
- what *pagar a plazos* means

Before you move on

The deadline? (**El plazo**.) The date? (**La fecha**.) What did *placitum* mean? (**A thing agreed**.)

458.2 entregar — hand it over

Say **el documento** and **el almacén**. Things leave both of them the same way.

You'll want to know: entregar

entregar — to hand in, hand over, deliver.

Entregar los papeles — to hand the paperwork in. *Hay que entregarlo antes del viernes* — it has to be in before Friday. *El paquete se entrega mañana* — the parcel is delivered tomorrow.

La entrega is the noun: *la entrega a domicilio* is home delivery, and *el plazo de entrega* is the delivery time — both of this chapter's first two words in one phrase.

Grammar Lens: entregar is not dar

what is happening	the verb
passing something to somebody	**dar**
handing over what was owed or due	**entregar**

Dame el boli — pass me the pen. *Entrega el boli* would sound as though the pen were evidence.

Entregar carries an obligation with it: homework, a form, a parcel, a set of keys. Something was due, and now it has gone across. That is why a courier *entrega* and a friend *da*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **integrare**, to make whole — from **integer**, **untouched, complete**, which is *in-* plus the root of *tangere*, to touch. An *integer* is a thing nobody has broken into.

So *entregar* is to hand a thing over **entire** — the sense of a delivery that arrives with nothing missing.

The same *integer* gave Spanish **entero**, whole, and **íntegro**, which is the bookish twin and means upright about a person. English took the number sense as **integer** and the character sense as **integrity** — and *integrity* is exactly what *entregar* asks for: the thing handed over undiminished.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- it has to be handed in before Friday
- the delivery time, using both words
- which verb a friend passing you a pen would use

Before you move on

To hand in? (**Entregar**.) The delivery? (**La entrega**.) What did *integer* mean? (**Whole, untouched**.)

458.3 admitir — let it through

Say **meter** and **aceptar**. The word coming next is a cousin of the first and a rival of the second.

You'll want to know: admitir

admitir — to allow in, to accept as valid, and to own up to.

No se **admiten** solicitudes fuera de plazo.

No se admiten perros — no dogs. *Admitir un error* — to admit a mistake. *¿Admiten tarjeta?* — do you take cards, on a sign or a form.

La admisión is the noun, and *admitido* is the word beside your name on a list when you are in.

Grammar Lens: admitir, aceptar, entregar

Three verbs about a thing crossing a line, sorted by who is doing what:

the move	the verb
you agree to take what is offered	**aceptar**
an institution lets it through	**admitir**
you hand over what was due	**entregar**

You *entregas* the form; the office *admite* it or not; a shop *acepta* your card. Notice who is behind *admitir*: nearly every time, an institution. That is why it turns up in the *se* form on notices — *no se admiten* —

with nobody named.
The other sense follows from the same picture: to *admit* a mistake is to let it in rather than keep it outside.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **admittere**: **ad-**, towards, plus **mittere**, **to send**.
You have met *mittere* three times already, and this makes four:

word	**what the prefix does**
meter	the bare verb, worn down: put in
el permiso	*per-*, sent **through**
permitir	the verb of that noun, let through
admitir	*ad-*, sent **towards** — let in

So the family is a set of sendings, and the prefix does all the steering.
English holds the same shelf: **admit**, **permit**, **submit**, **transmit**, **commit**, **mission** — every one a sending in some direction.
Meter is the one that came down through speech, which is why it looks least like the others and is the only one you would use about a box.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- applications are not accepted after the deadline
- I admit I was wrong
- which of the three verbs you do to a form yourself

Before you move on

To let in? (**Admitir**.) What does *mittere* mean? (**To send**.) Which of its relatives would you use about a box? (**Meter**.)

458.4 (el plazo, entregar, admitir) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all three: *the deadline*, *to hand in*, *to let in*.

Grammar Lens: the three of them are one sentence

Put them in the order they happen and you have the whole of official life:

> **Entregue** la solicitud dentro del **plazo**. Fuera de plazo no se **admiten**.

You hand it in, there is a window, and the office decides. Three words, and every form you meet in Spanish will use at least two of them.
Note *dentro del plazo* against *fuera de plazo*: the first takes an article, the second does not, because *fuera de* + bare noun is the fixed frame you met in *fuera de servicio*.

Grammar Lens: mittere, for the third time

word	**the prefix, and what it does**
meter	none — put in
el permiso	*per-*, sent through
admitir	*ad-*, sent towards, let in

One Latin verb, three Spanish words, and the prefix is the whole difference. *Meter* came down through speech and looks least like the others; *permiso* and *admitir* were lifted off the page and kept their shape — the same split you saw in *rueda* against *rotativo*.
And **entregar** hides a different picture: *integrare*, to make whole, so what you hand over should arrive entire.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- hand the form in within the deadline
- late applications are not accepted
- which of the three has a cart nowhere near it

Before you move on

All three again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence about a form that arrived too late.

458.5 (la convocatoria) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **el plazo** and **admitir**. The notice below puts one against the other in a single line.

Your turn

A notice on a noticeboard. Read it, then answer.

CURSOS DE NATACIÓN — INSCRIPCIÓN

Plazo: del 2 al 20 de septiembre.

Entregue la ficha en el mostrador o por correo.

Fuera de plazo no se **admiten** fichas, aunque queden plazas.

Listas de admitidos: el día 25.

Say these aloud:

- the two ways of handing the form in
- what happens if you are a day late
- when you find out

Why it's said this way

Aunque queden plazas is the hard line, and it is where the grammar earns its keep: *aunque* with the subjunctive — *queden*, not *quedan* — says the office is not conceding that there are places. Had it written *aunque quedan plazas* it would have been admitting there are some and refusing anyway, which reads as spite rather than procedure.
So the subjunctive is doing something worth having: it lets a notice state a rule without commenting on the facts.
Then **no se admiten** again, with nobody named. Compare the three verbs in their natural order: *usted entrega*, *la oficina admite*, and you would *aceptar* only what is offered to you. The notice never says who decides, because in official Spanish the decision is a thing that happens rather than a person who acts.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines for a sign-up notice: give the window of dates, say where to hand the form in, say late forms are not accepted, and say when the list goes up. Then check yourself: did you use *entregar* for the handing in and *admitir* for the office, and did *fuera de plazo* go without an article?

Chapter 459

El inventario

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 3 of 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a shop door that is shut for the morning: why it is closed, when it opens, which part stays open, and when the usual hours come back.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

459.1 la sección — a piece cut off

> Say **cortar** and **el almacén**. A big store has been cut into parts, and each one has a name.

You'll want to know: la sección

la sección — the section, the department.

La sección de deportes — the sports department. *¿En qué sección está?* — which part of the shop is it in? *La sección de lácteos* — the dairy aisle.

Beyond shops: a section of a form, of a newspaper, of a report. Anywhere a whole has been divided and the parts labelled.

Plural **secciones**, and the accent comes off, as it does for every *-ción*.

Grammar Lens: sección, parte, departamento

what it names	the word
any piece of a whole	**la parte**
a piece somebody divided off on purpose	**la sección**
a unit of an organisation	**el departamento**

Una parte del libro could be any stretch of it. *Una sección del libro* is one somebody marked out and probably numbered. And a *departamento* has staff.
The middle one is the useful new distinction: *sección* always implies a dividing hand, which is exactly what its root says.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **secare**, **to cut** — the participle *sectus* gave *sectio*, a cutting. So a *sección* is a **cut piece**, and the family is full of cutting: **el insecto** is an animal cut into segments, which is what you can see on an ant.
A word to keep *out* of the family, because it looks as though it belongs: **la sierra** is a saw, and also a mountain range, since a ridge of peaks looks like a saw's teeth. That picture is right, but the word is Latin *serra* and has nothing to do with *secare*. Two words about cutting, unrelated.
English has **section**, **sector**, **dissect**, **segment** and **insect** off the same root — and *insect* is the one worth remembering, because nobody expects a bug to be named after a cut.
Cortar, which you already have, comes from a different Latin word — *curtus*, shortened — so the two are not relatives, and Spanish kept both: the everyday cutting and the bookish dividing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- which section is it in?
- the sports department of the store
- why an insect is called that

Before you move on

The section? (**La sección**.) The plural? (**Las secciones**, no accent.) What does *secare* mean? (**To cut**.)

459.2 el inventario — what we found

Say **venir** and **el almacén**. A very old verb is about to turn up in a very dull word.

You'll want to know: el inventario

el inventario — the inventory, and the stocktake itself.

Cerrado por **inventario**.

Hacer inventario — to do a stocktake. *Está en el inventario* — it's on the list.

That sign goes up on a shop door for a morning once or twice a year, and it is the reason this word is worth having before you need it.

Grammar Lens: cerrado por — the cause on a door

You have met *por* plus a bare noun giving a cause on a notice. Shop doors are where it lives:

sign	why they are shut
cerrado por inventario	stocktaking
cerrado por obras	building work
cerrado por vacaciones	holidays

No article, no verb, no explanation. The frame is *cerrado por* + the reason, and a Spanish reader takes the whole thing in at a glance from across a street — which is what a sign is for.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **invenire**: **in-** plus **venire**, **to come** — so *to come upon*, and from there **to find**.

An *inventario* is therefore a **list of what was found**, which is exactly what a stocktake produces: somebody walks the shelves and writes down what is actually there, as opposed to what the records claim.

The same *invenire* gave **inventar**, to invent — and that is the same idea seen from the other side. To invent something is to *come upon* it. Spanish and English both treat discovery and invention as one act, and the word for a warehouse list is the proof.
Venir is underneath all of it, and you have had it since the early lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- closed for stocktaking
- it's not on the list
- what *invenire* literally means

Before you move on

The stocktake? (**El inventario**.) Closed for it? (**Cerrado por inventario**.) Which verb is inside it? (**Venir** — to come upon, to find.)

459.3 habitual — the way it usually is

Say **he hablado** and **siempre**. The *he* in the first is about to turn up in an adjective.

You'll want to know: habitual

habitual — usual, regular, customary.

El horario habitual — the usual hours. *Nuestro proveedor habitual* — our regular supplier. *Lo habitual es avisar* — the usual thing is to let people know.

Habitualmente is the adverb, and **el cliente habitual** is a regular. The opposite is *poco habitual* — unusual — rather than any single word.

Grammar Lens: habitual, normal, siempre

what you mean	the word
this is the pattern, by habit	**habitual**
this is ordinary, not strange	**normal**
without exception	**siempre**

El horario habitual is the one they usually keep — and this week they may not. *Es normal* means nobody should be surprised. *Siempre abren a las nueve* allows no exceptions at all.
So *habitual* sits between the other two: stronger than "not strange", weaker than "always". A notice using it is telling you what to expect while leaving itself room.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **habēre**, **to have, to hold** — by way of *habitus*, "the way one holds oneself".
You own that verb already: *habēre* is the **haber** of *he hablado*, worn down by centuries of use into an auxiliary so small it barely looks like a word. Set the two side by side and the two roads are visible again:

worn down by speech	lifted from the page
he hablado	**habit**ual

A habit is something you *hold*, which is why English says you **have** a habit rather than doing one. And *el hábito* in Spanish is both a habit and a monk's robe — the clothing you hold yourself in, from the same *habitus*.
The **h** is silent, as it is anywhere in Spanish that it stands on its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the usual hours
- our regular supplier
- which of *habitual* and *siempre* allows an exception

Before you move on

Usual? (**Habitual**.) What does *habēre* mean? (**To have, to hold**.) Which everyday word is it worn down into? (**Haber** — *he hablado*.)

459.4 (la sección, el inventario, habitual) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all three: *the section*, *the stocktake*, *usual*.

Grammar Lens: two everyday verbs, hidden in office words

office word	the everyday verb inside it
el **invent**ario	**venir** — *in-venire*, to come upon
habitual	**haber** — *habēre*, to hold

Both verbs are among the first things anybody learns in Spanish, and both are so worn down that nothing on the surface connects them to these words. An inventory is **a list of what was found**; something habitual is **a thing held on to**.

This is what happens when a language takes the same Latin word twice. The spoken copy shrinks until it is almost nothing — *he*, *vengo* — while the written copy keeps its whole Latin shape.

Grammar Lens: the notice frames, collected

frame	example
cerrado por + bare noun	*cerrado por inventario*
fuera de + bare noun	*fuera de plazo*
por + bare noun, as a cause	*por obras*

No article after any of them. Spanish signs run on these three shapes, and once you can see the frame you can read a notice you have never met by filling in one word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- closed for stocktaking
- the usual hours in the sports section
- which verb is inside *inventario*

Before you move on

All three again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence about a shop that is shut this morning.

459.5 (cerrado por inventario) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **el inventario** and **habitual**. The door below uses one to excuse breaking the other.

Your turn

A sheet taped to a shop door. Read it, then answer.

CERRADO POR INVENTARIO

Solo esta mañana. Abrimos a las 16:00.

El **horario habitual** se recupera mañana.

La **sección** de deportes permanece abierta por la puerta lateral.

Say these aloud:

- how long the shop is shut, and when it opens
- what is open anyway, and how to get in
- when things go back to normal

Why it's said this way

El horario habitual se recupera mañana is the line worth taking apart. *Habitual* rather than *normal*, because the shop is saying *this is the pattern we keep*, not *this is not strange*. And *se recupera* rather

than *recuperamos*: the timetable comes back by itself, nobody is thanked for it.
Permanece abierta agrees with *la sección*, feminine — a small check that catches people out, because *deportes* is masculine and plural and sits right next to the verb. Spanish agrees with the head noun, not with the nearest one.
And the heading is the frame you now know: *cerrado por* plus a bare noun. A reader takes it in from the pavement without reading the rest.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines for a shop door: say you are closed for stocktaking, say when you reopen, say the usual hours come back tomorrow, and say which section stays open.
Then check yourself: did you use the *cerrado por* frame with no article, and did the adjective agree with *la sección* rather than with *deportes*?

Chapter 460

La herramienta

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can borrow a tool from a shared store: read the notice, apply the way the form wants, and understand that there is a waiting list.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

460.1 la herramienta — the tool

> Say **el taladro** and **arreglar**. The drill is one of these; name the category it belongs to.

You'll want to know: la herramienta

la herramienta — the tool.

Una caja de herramientas — a toolbox. *No tengo las herramientas* — I haven't got the tools. *La herramienta adecuada* — the right tool for the job.

It covers the abstract sense as well: *una herramienta muy útil* about an app or a method, exactly as English uses "tool".

Grammar Lens: the h that hides a diphthong

Say it: **e-rra-MIEN-ta**. The **h** is silent, as it is anywhere in Spanish that it stands alone, and underneath it is the **ie** you have met before:

Latin	Spanish
ferramenta	la h**e**rramienta
ferrum	el h**ie**rro

One rule governs both vowels, and it is the one you already have: a stressed **e** breaks, an unstressed one stays flat. In *ferrum* the stress is on the **e**, so it breaks — *h**ie**rro*. In *ferramenta* the stress has moved onto the suffix, so the first **e** stays flat — *h**e**rra-* — and the break happens where the stress went instead: *-m**ie**nta*, the very same *-miento* you have in *el seguimiento*.

The **h** is written because it was once spoken. Latin *f-* weakened to a breathy *h* in Castilian mouths, the breath faded, and the spelling stayed behind. That *f*-to-*h* shift is one of the loudest things Spanish did to Latin.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **ferramenta**, "things made of iron" — the plural of *ferramentum*, from **ferrum**, iron.

So a *herramienta* is an **iron thing**, and the name is older than any of the tools you own. The same *ferrum* is the **Fe** on the periodic table, and it gives Spanish *el hierro*, *el herrero* — the blacksmith — and *la herradura*, a horseshoe.

That **f** to **h** is the signature of Spanish among the Romance languages. Latin *facere* gave *hacer*, *filius* gave *hijo*, *ferrum* gave *hierro* — while Italian kept *ferro* and French kept *fer*. The letter is silent now, but it marks where an *f* used to be.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a toolbox, and the right tool
- the drill is a tool
- which letter *hierro* and *hacer* both used to start with

Before you move on

The tool? (**La herramienta**.) What is *ferrum*? (**Iron**.) What does a silent Spanish **h** often mark? (**Where a Latin f used to be**.)

460.2 solicitar — the word the form uses

Say **la cita** and **entregar**. Both belong to the same morning at a counter.

You'll want to know: solicitar

solicitar — to apply for, to request, formally.

Para **solicitar** una plaza, entregue la ficha antes del día 20.

Solicitar una beca — to apply for a grant. *Solicitar cita previa* — to book an appointment in advance, the phrase on Spanish health-centre and town-hall pages; much of Latin America says *sacar turno* or *agendar una cita* for the same act.

La solicitud is the application itself, and the piece of paper it is written on.

Grammar Lens: solicitar is not pedir

what you are doing	the verb
asking a person for a thing	**pedir**
asking an institution, on a form	**solicitar**

Le pido un café al camarero. Solicito una beca al ministerio. Using *solicitar* with a friend would sound as though you had filled in a form to borrow their drill.
That is the whole difference and it is register, not meaning: *solicitar* is the bookish arrival, worn nowhere down, and it belongs to writing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **sollicitare**: **sollus**, whole, plus **citare**, to set in motion — so to stir something *entirely*, to shake it up.
The oldest sense is agitation, and Spanish keeps that branch too: *estar solícito* is to be attentive, and English **solicitous** means anxiously

caring, while **solicitude** is worry. To apply for something is to set the machinery in motion on your behalf.
That **citare** is the one inside **la cita** — an appointment is a *summoning* — and English **cite**, **excite**, **recite** and **incite** are all the same setting-in-motion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to apply for a place, hand the form in
- book an appointment in advance
- which verb you use with a waiter

Before you move on

To apply for? (**Solicitar**.) The application? (**La solicitud**.) What does *citare* mean? (**To set in motion, to summon**.)

460.3 la espera — the wait

Say **esperar** and **el plazo**. One is the doing, one is the window. The noun between them is next.

You'll want to know: la espera

la espera — the wait.

Sala de espera.

La lista de espera — the waiting list. *Una espera de dos horas* — a two-hour wait. *En espera de su respuesta* — awaiting your reply, the closing line of a formal letter.

The verb you already have; this is the noun that goes on the door.

Grammar Lens: a noun made by cutting, not by adding

You have four noun-making suffixes — three that work on verbs, and *-eza*, which works on adjectives. This is a fifth move, and it is the

opposite of all of them: **take the ending off**.

verb	**noun**
esperar	la esper**a**
entregar	la entreg**a**
comprar	la compr**a**
pagar	el pag**o**

Cut *-ar* and put back a bare **-a** or **-o**. You already have one of these: *la entrega* arrived two chapters ago without being named as a pattern. These are the shortest nouns in the language and among the commonest. What you cannot predict is **which vowel** a given verb will take — *la compra* but *el pago*. Once you have the word, the ordinary *-o*/*-a* rule hands you the article as usual.
Set beside *la solicitud*: one verb swaps its ending for *-ud*, the other drops its ending and puts back a single vowel. Both are ordinary.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **sperare**, from **spes**, hope — though already in Latin it leaned as much on *looking forward to* as on hoping, and a Roman could *sperare* bad news as readily as good.
That middle sense is the hinge. *Esperar* took over the work of Latin *exspectare*, **to expect**, and ended up covering all three English verbs you met when you learned it: *espero el autobús* is waiting, *espero el pan* is expecting, *espero que sí* is hoping. *La espera* names only the first of them.
You met the same root in **la esperanza**, hope, which is *-anza* on this verb. So *la espera* and *la esperanza* are one word twice: the plain wait, and the hope that grew out of it.
The **e-** at the front is Spanish's own, the same one that turned *stare* into *estar* and *stroppiare* into *estropear*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the waiting room and the waiting list
- I'm waiting for the bus, then I hope so
- what *la espera* and *la esperanza* share

Before you move on

The wait? (**La espera**.) The waiting room? (**La sala de espera**.) What else does *esperar* cover? (**Hoping and expecting**.)

460.4 (la herramienta, solicitar, la espera) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all three: *the tool*, *to apply for*, *the wait*.

Grammar Lens: five ways to a noun, now complete

how	example	gender
-anza	la mudanza	feminine
-miento	el seguimiento	masculine
-eza	la limpieza	feminine
-ción	la instalación	feminine
cut the ending	la espera	either

The first four hand you the article. **The fifth does not** — *la espera*, *la compra*, but *el pago* and *el gasto*. The ending is no help in guessing which vowel a given verb takes; once you have the word, the ordinary *-o*/*-a* rule gives you the article as usual.

Note what that costs: these are the shortest and commonest nouns in Spanish, and they are the ones the endings cannot help you with.

Grammar Lens: two of the three were relatives

new word	what it was built on
la herramienta	*ferrum*, iron — and *el hierro*
solicitar	*citare*, inside *la cita*
la espera	*esperar*, and *la esperanza* beside it

La espera is the neat one: **esperar** and **la esperanza** arrived together with the verb itself, long ago, and the moving chapter showed you the *-anza* that builds the second from the first. This is the third member — the plain noun that sits between the verb and the abstract one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the waiting room is that way
- to apply for a place you hand in the form
- which of the five noun-makers leaves the gender open

Before you move on

All three again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence asking for something at a counter.

460.5 (pedir prestada una herramienta) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **la herramienta** and **solicitar**. The notice below uses one for the things and one for the paperwork.

Your turn

A notice in a neighbourhood centre. Read it, then answer.

PRÉSTAMO DE HERRAMIENTAS

Taladros, escaleras y carritos. Dos días por vecino.

Para **solicitar** una **herramienta**, rellene la ficha en conserjería.

Hay **lista de espera** para el taladro grande.

Say these aloud:

- what you can borrow, and for how long
- what you have to do to ask for one
- which item you may not get straight away

Why it's said this way

Solicitar on a noticeboard and **pedir** at the counter are the same act in two registers. The notice says *para solicitar una herramienta* because it is describing a procedure; the neighbour who walks in says *¿me dejas el taladro?* That pair is the whole of Spanish formality in one scene.

Hay lista de espera — bare, with no article at all. The firm rule is what *hay* refuses: never *hay la lista*, because *hay* introduces a thing's existence rather than pointing at one already known. Between *hay lista* and *hay una lista* both are correct, and the bare noun is what a notice board uses.

And **por vecino** — "per neighbour" — is *por* doing distribution, the same *por* that gave a cause on the roadworks sign. One preposition, several jobs, and the noun after it stays bare.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines for a tool library: say what is lent and for how long, say how to apply, say there is a waiting list, and then ask a neighbour informally for the same thing.

Then check yourself: did the notice use *solicitar* and the neighbour *pedir*?

Chapter 461

El donativo

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a collection appeal: what may be donated, what will be turned away and why, and where to hand it in.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

461.1 donar — to give it away

> Say **perdón** and **la sangre**. There is a verb of giving hiding in the first, and the second is the commonest thing it is used about.

You'll want to know: donar

donar — to donate.

Donar sangre — to give blood, the sign outside every mobile clinic. *Donar ropa* — to donate clothes. **La donación** is the donation and **el donante** the donor.

It is not the everyday verb for giving. *Dar* is that. *Donar* is giving to an institution or a cause, and it carries no expectation of return.

Grammar Lens: donar is not regalar

Three verbs of giving, and the difference is who receives:

what is happening	the verb
handing anything to anyone	**dar**
making somebody a present	**regalar**
giving to a cause or a body	**donar**

Te doy el taladro — I'm passing it to you. *Te regalo el taladro* — it is yours, a gift. *Dono el taladro al centro* — the neighbourhood centre has it now.

Use *donar* about a person and it sounds like a charitable act rather than a kindness, which is sometimes exactly the joke a Spanish speaker is making.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **donare**, to give — and here is the payoff on a word you have had since the courtesy chapter, long before you could take it apart. **Perdón** is *per-* plus *donare*: to **give thoroughly**, to give completely away. Forgiving somebody is giving the offence away rather than holding it, and the metaphor is the same in English — *for-give* is built the identical way, *for-* being an intensifier, so *pardon* and *forgive* are the same idea twice.

The family also gives *el don*, a gift or a talent. And off to one side sits **la dosis** — not from *donare* but from Greek's own word for a giving, off the same ancient root: a dose is what is *given* to you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to give blood
- I'm donating the tools to the centre
- what *perdón* is made of

Before you move on

To donate? (**Donar**.) The donor? (**El donante**.) What does *perdón* literally say? (**To give thoroughly** — to give it away.)

461.2 peligroso — dangerous

Say **el taladro** and **el accidente**. One can lead to the other, and the sign warning you sits between them.

You'll want to know: peligroso

peligroso — dangerous.

Peligro. No pasar.

El peligro is the noun and the single word on the sign; **peligroso** is the adjective. *Una zona peligrosa* — a dangerous area. *Es peligroso dejarlo ahí* — it's dangerous to leave it there.

Estar en peligro is to be in danger, and *fuera de peligro* — out of danger — uses the frame you already have from *fuera de servicio*.

Grammar Lens: -oso makes an adjective of a noun

-oso means "full of" or "given to", and it turns nouns into adjectives all over the language:

noun	adjective
el peligro	peligr**oso**
el cuidado	cuidad**oso** — careful
la fama	fam**oso** — famous

English has the same ending in *dangerous*, *famous* and *curious*, from the same Latin *-osus*, so the pair usually translates straight across. It agrees like any adjective — *peligrosa*, *peligrosos* — and the noun keeps its own gender: *el peligro* is masculine, *una zona peligrosa* feminine.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **periculum**, a trial or a risk — from a root meaning **to try**, the one also behind *experiri*, to test by going through.
So a *peligro* is something you have to **try your luck against**, and English **peril** is the same word, kept closer to the Latin. **Experience** and **experiment** are relatives too: all of them are attempts, and only some are survived.
From *periculum* to *peligro* the **r** and the **l** swapped places — the metathesis you met in *milagro* from *miraculum*. Both words came

through speech, and both got their letters shuffled on the way; a word that arrived by book was never shuffled: **periclitar**, to be in danger, keeps *periculum*'s letters in their Latin order, and stands beside the spoken *peligro* as the same word at two speeds.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- danger, do not enter
- the drill is dangerous for a child
- which other word swapped its r and l the same way

Before you move on

Dangerous? (**Peligroso**.) The noun? (**El peligro**.) What did *periculum* mean? (**A trial, a risk** — something you try your luck against.)

461.3 rechazar — to turn it down

Say **aceptar** and **admitir**. The word coming next undoes the first, and it is made of the same Latin.

You'll want to know: rechazar

rechazar — to turn down, to reject, to refuse.

Rechazar una oferta — to turn down an offer. *Han rechazado la solicitud* — the application has been rejected. *El banco rechazó la tarjeta* — the card was declined.

El rechazo is the noun: a refusal, and in medicine the rejection of a transplant.

Grammar Lens: the three verbs of the counter, completed

the move	the verb
you agree to what is offered	**aceptar**
the institution lets it through	**admitir**
it is turned back	**rechazar**

Rechazar is the mirror of **both** of the others, and which one it mirrors depends on who is doing it. A shop *rechaza* your card where it might have *aceptado* it; an office *rechaza* your form where it might have *admitido* it.

Notices usually phrase a refusal by negating the other two — *no se aceptan*, *no se admiten* — but *rechazar* takes the same *se* form when the refusing itself is the point: *se rechazan los rotos*. In the plain active it is a person who does it: *rechacé la oferta*.

Note the spelling: **rechacé**, with a **c**. Spanish spelling prefers **c** before *e*, so a stem *z* turns into a *c* right through the conjugation, which is why *empezar* gives *empecé*. A handful of borrowings keep the *z* — *zen*, *zeta* — but no verb ending does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

re- plus *chazar*, to drive back — a verb Spanish took from Old French *chacier*, and behind that Vulgar Latin **captiare**, to chase, built on **capere**, **to take**. That French leg is why this word has **ch**: Spanish's own inherited form of *captiare* is **cazar**, to hunt.

So *rechazar* and **aceptar** are cousins, and the pair is worth holding: *ad-* plus *capere* is taking a thing **towards** you, and *re-* plus *captiare* is driving it **back**. One Latin verb of taking, pointed two ways by two prefixes.

The same *captiare* gave Spanish **cazar**, to hunt, and French *chasser*, which English borrowed as **chase** — and, through a second borrowing, as **catch**. To reject something is to chase it back the way it came.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- they have rejected the application
- I turned the offer down, in the past

- what *rechazar* and *aceptar* have in common

Before you move on

To turn down? (**Rechazar**.) I turned down? (**Rechacé** — z becomes c before e.) Which verb is its cousin? (**Aceptar** — both from *capere*.)

461.4 (donar, peligroso, rechazar) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all three: *to donate*, *dangerous*, *to turn down*.

Grammar Lens: one verb of taking, pointed two ways

word	the prefix, and where it points
aceptar	*ad-*, **towards** you — you take it
rechazar	*re-*, **back** — you drive it away

Both are Latin *capere*, to take. The prefix does everything, exactly as it did for *meter*, *el permiso*, *permitir* and *admitir* off *mittere*.
That is now two families in four chapters where the prefix carries the whole meaning. When a Spanish verb starts with *a-*, *re-*, *per-*, *ad-* or *des-*, the part after it is usually a word you can already find.

Grammar Lens: two words hiding in your earliest vocabulary

new word	where it was already
donar	*perdón* — *per-donare*, to give thoroughly
peligroso	*el peligro*, and *periculum* behind it

Perdón is the one to keep. You learned it in the courtesy chapter as a thing you say when you bump into somebody, and it turns out to be built on **giving** — forgiveness is handing the offence over rather than keeping it. English does the identical thing in *for-give*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- they turned down the application
- giving blood is not dangerous
- which everyday word has *donar* inside it

Before you move on

All three again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence about something offered and refused.

461.5 (la campaña de donación) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **donar** and **rechazar**. The notice below does the first and warns about the second.

Your turn

A poster in a stairwell. Read it, then answer.

RECOGIDA DE JUGUETES

Puede **donar** juguetes en buen estado hasta el día 30.

Se **rechazan** los que estén rotos o sean **peligrosos** para menores de tres años.

Entréguelos en portería. Gracias por colaborar.

Say these aloud:

- what is being collected, and until when
- the two reasons something would be turned away
- where to hand things in

Why it's said this way

Se rechazan los que estén rotos o sean peligrosos is the sentence to take apart, and the subjunctive is back, doing a cousin of the job it

did on the swimming-course notice. There it withheld agreement that places remained; here it withholds any claim about which toys will actually turn up.
Los que ***estén*** *rotos*, not *están*. The poster is not saying that some of the toys are broken; it is describing a **category that may or may not turn up** — whichever ones happen to be broken. The indicative would point at particular toys the writer had in mind, which on a poster addressed to a whole building would be an odd thing to imply. Note **sean** as well: *ser* for a lasting property, because a toy that is dangerous for a toddler is dangerous by design, not by circumstance. And *estén* for *rotos*, because being broken is a state a thing arrived at. One sentence, both verbs, each right for its own reason.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines for a collection poster: say what can be donated and until when, say what will be turned away and why, and say where to hand it in.
Then check yourself: did you use the subjunctive for the things that might turn up, and *ser* against *estar* for the two reasons?

Chapter 462

La reunión

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can follow a message from a manager about cutting spending, and reply that I am still choosing between two options.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

462.1 reducir — to bring it down

> Say **la ducha** and **el coste**. A shower is about to turn out to be a relative of the verb coming next.

You'll want to know: reducir

reducir — to reduce, to cut back.

Reducir costes — to cut costs, and *reducir costos* wherever you met *el costo*. *Reducir la velocidad* — to slow down, the wording on a road sign. *Han reducido la plantilla* — they've cut the staff.

La reducción is the noun, and *reducido* on a price tag means marked down.

Grammar Lens: the -zc- verbs

The **c** is already in *reducir*. What this group grows is a **z** in front of it:

verb	I ...
reducir	redu**zc**o
conducir	condu**zc**o
conocer	cono**zc**o

It is not only the *yo* form. The whole subjunctive carries the **z** too — *reduzca, reduzcas, reduzcamos* — and that is where you will actually read it, because the polite command is the subjunctive: **Reduzca la velocidad**, the road sign from a moment ago. The rest of the present stays plain: *reduces*, *reduce*, *reducimos*.

Watch the past, though, because the table above hides a split. *Reducir* and *conducir* go *reduje* and *conduje* — not *reducí*. *Conocer* shares the **-zc-** and not that past: it goes *conocí*. Two groups, one spelling.

The **z** has two different stories as well. In *conocer* it is inherited: Latin *cognoscere* had the cluster and the *yo* form kept it. Latin *reducere* never had it, so *reduzco* got its **z** by copying the verbs that did — a pattern that spread rather than a sound that survived. The family it spread through is large, several hundred verbs once the *-ecer* verbs are counted in.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **reducere**: **re-**, back, plus **ducere**, **to lead**. To reduce something is to **lead it back** — to a smaller size, to where it was. *Ducere* is everywhere once you see it. **La ducha** is the same root, and it travelled: Latin *ductia* gave Italian *doccia*, which gave French *douche*, which gave Spanish *ducha* — a pipe that **leads** water. English has **conduct**, **produce**, **educate** (to lead out), **duke** — a leader — and **aqueduct**, which leads water exactly as a shower does.

Spanish keeps *conducir*, to drive, and *el conductor*. A driver leads the car; a shower leads the water; reducing leads the number back down.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- we have to cut costs, in the variety you use
- I reduce, using the first-person form
- what a shower and a duke have in common

Before you move on

To cut back? (**Reducir**.) I reduce? (**Reduzco**.) What does *ducere* mean? (**To lead**.)

462.2 decidirse — to make your mind up

Say **decidir** and **acercar**. You met *decidirse* in passing when you learned *decidir*; now take it properly, with what **-se** did to the second word in front of you.

You'll want to know: decidirse

decidirse — to make up your mind.

No me decido — I can't decide. *Decídete* — make your mind up. *Se decidió por el azul* — she went for the blue one.

The **-se** version takes **por** for the thing chosen: *me decidí por el piso pequeño.*

Grammar Lens: what the -se adds here

You have met the *-se* switch three times, and this is a fourth use of it — not a new meaning, but a new *shade*:

without -se	**with -se**
acercar — bring it closer	*acercarse* — come closer
decidir — settle a matter	*decidirse* — settle **yourself**

He decidido vender el coche states the decision. *Me he decidido a vender el coche* says you struggled and got there. The reflexive adds the **effort**, the sense of having had to bring yourself to it.
That is why *no me decido* is the natural way to say you are dithering, and *no decido* would sound like a job description.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **decidere**: **de-**, off, plus **caedere**, **to cut**. To decide is to **cut off** — the other options, the deliberating, the retreat.
That picture explains the English family exactly. A **decision** cuts things off. Something **decisive** cuts cleanly. And *caedere* is also in **concise** (cut short), **precise** (cut in front, trimmed to the edge), and

— through the same cutting — **homicide** and **suicide**.
Spanish has *decidir*, *la decisión*, *conciso* and *preciso* off the same root. When you make your mind up, a Latin speaker heard you reaching for a blade.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I can't make my mind up
- she went for the blue one
- which preposition follows *decidirse*

Before you move on

To make your mind up? (**Decidirse**.) What does the *-se* add? (**The effort of getting there**.) What does *caedere* mean? (**To cut**.)

462.3 el jefe — the one at the head

Say **la cabeza** and **el trabajo**. Put the first at the top of the second and you have named somebody.

You'll want to know: el jefe

el jefe — the boss, the head of something.

Hablar con el jefe — to speak to the boss. *La jefa de personal* — the head of HR. *El jefe de estación* — the stationmaster.

The feminine is **la jefa**, formed normally, and both are ordinary words at work — not slang and not deferential.

Grammar Lens: the j that used to be something else

Jefe came from French *chef*, and the **ch** became a **j**. Spanish did that to a whole shelf of borrowings:

French	Spanish
chef	el **j**efe
jardin	el **j**ardín
jamais	—

The **j** is the *jota*, the sound at the back of the throat, and it is a latecomer: medieval Spanish did not have it. Words spelled with **j** or with **g** before *e* and *i* all shifted to it at roughly the same time, a few hundred years ago, which is why *jefe*, *mujer* and *gente* now share a sound that none of them started with.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

French **chef** is Latin **caput**, **head** — and *caput* is the same word inside **la cabeza**.

That needs one correction to something you were told earlier. When you learned *la cabeza*, French was described as having dropped *caput* altogether for *testa*, a pot. That is true of the **body part** and only of it: *tête* replaced *caput* for the thing on your shoulders, while *caput* itself stayed on in French as *chef*, a head in the sense of a chief. It is that surviving branch Spanish later borrowed.

So *el jefe* and *la cabeza* are one Latin noun arriving twice: once worn down through Spanish speech into the body part, once borrowed back from French as the person in charge. A boss is literally **a head**, exactly as in English *head of department*.

The family is large: **el capítulo** (a chapter, a little head), **la capital** (the head city), **acabar** — to finish, to bring to a head — and English **captain**, **chief**, **chef**, **capital** and **cape**. A *chef* is the head of a kitchen, and *chief* and *jefe* are the same word in two languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I have to speak to the boss
- the head of HR, using the feminine
- that you cannot make your mind up about asking her
- what *jefe* and *cabeza* have in common

Before you move on

The boss? (**El jefe**.) The feminine? (**La jefa**.) What does *caput* mean? (**Head** — the same one inside *la cabeza*.)

462.4 (reducir, decidirse, el jefe) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all three: *to cut back*, *to make your mind up*, *the boss*.

Grammar Lens: one word, two roads, four hundred years apart

the road	the word
worn down through Spanish speech	**la cabeza**
borrowed from French, much later	**el jefe**

Both are Latin *caput*, head. The first went through centuries of mouths and came out as a body part; the second was picked up whole from a neighbour and came out as a person.

You have watched this several times — *cosa* against *causa*, *razón* against *ración*, *rueda* against *rotativo*, *consejo* against *consultar*. Every one of those came out of Latin twice at two different speeds. This one took a detour through a **third** language, which is why it looks like neither.

Grammar Lens: two verbs, two pictures of cutting and leading

verb	the picture inside it
reducir	*re-ducere*, to **lead back**
decidirse	*de-caedere*, to **cut off**

Deciding cuts the other options away; reducing leads the number back down. Both are physical, and both are still doing the work: *la ducha* leads water, *preciso* is cut to the edge.

And *decidirse* is the fourth *-se* pair you have met, after *mudarse*, *acercarse* and *arreglarse*. Here the *-se* adds effort — *no me decido* is dithering, where *no decido* would be a job description.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the boss wants to cut costs
- I can't make my mind up
- which two Spanish words are both Latin *caput*

Before you move on

All three again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence about a decision somebody is putting off.

462.5 (el correo del jefe) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **el jefe** and **reducir**. The message below is from one about the other.

Your turn

An internal message, and one reply. Read both, then answer.

1 — de la jefa

Buenos días. Tenemos que **reducir** el gasto de material este trimestre.

Antes del viernes, decidme qué se puede dejar de comprar en vuestra sección.

2 — la respuesta

Lo miro hoy. Todavía no **me decido** entre quitar el papel de color o bajar los pedidos de tinta, así que te digo mañana.

Say these aloud:

- what has to be cut, and by when
- the two things the second person is choosing between
- when the answer is coming

Why it's said this way

No me decido entre is the phrase to keep whole. With **entre** you name the options you are stuck between; with **por** you name the one you finally take. *No me decido entre A y B*, then *me decidí por A*.
Decidme is *vosotros*, plural and informal — a boss writing to her own team in Spain. A Latin American writer would say *díganme*, and a formal Spanish notice to the public would too. The verb ending places the writer, the reader and the register in one word.
And **tenemos que reducir**: *nosotros*, although the decision is hers. Spanish management writing does this constantly, and it is doing the same softening as the *se* on a shop notice — spreading the action out so nobody is singled out as its author.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines: as a boss, say spending has to be cut and ask for suggestions by Friday; then as the reply, say you are torn between two options and will answer tomorrow.
Then check yourself: did you use *entre* for the options and *por* for the choice?

Chapter 463

El viaje guiado

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can arrange or join an organised outing: say who is putting it on, that a guide is coming, and ask whether an early start matters to anyone.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

463.1 organizar — to put it together

> Say **la agenda** and **encargar**. Somebody has to put the whole thing together, and that is the verb next.

You'll want to know: organizar

organizar — to organise, to arrange, to put on.

Organizar una excursión — to arrange a trip. *Lo organiza el ayuntamiento* — the town hall is putting it on. *Organízate* — get yourself sorted.

La organización is both the act and the body that does it, the same double sense as *la instalación*.

Grammar Lens: the z that becomes c

You met this with *rechacé*. Here it is as a rule you can apply everywhere:

verb	I did it
organizar	organi**c**é
empezar	empe**c**é
rechazar	recha**c**é

Spanish almost never writes **ze** — outside a short list of oddities like *zeta* and *zigzag* — and in a verb ending it never does. Wherever an ending would put an *e* after the *z*, the *z* becomes a **c**, and the sound does not change at all, because *z* and *c*-before-*e* are the same sound already.
It is a spelling rule and nothing more, which is why every *-zar* verb in the language obeys it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Greek **órganon**, a tool or an instrument — from *érgon*, **work**.
So an *organ* is a **working part**, and to organise is to arrange the working parts so they function together. The body's **órganos** are named the same way: each one is a tool doing a job.
Érgon is worth keeping, because it is in English **energy** (work within), **surgery** — through *kheirourgía*, hand-work — and **ergonomic**. And the musical organ is the same Greek noun: an instrument, a tool for making sound.
Spanish took the word from Greek by way of Latin, which is why it kept its shape rather than wearing down.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the boss is organising a trip
- I organised it, in the past
- what an *órgano* and a tool have in common

Before you move on

To organise? (**Organizar**.) I organised? (**Organicé** — z becomes c.) What does *érgon* mean? (**Work**.)

463.2 el guía / la guía — the person, and the book

Say **la guardia** and **seguir**. The first taught you a rule about articles, and the word coming next obeys it.

You'll want to know: el guía / la guía

el guía — the guide, the person. **la guía** — the guidebook, and also a woman doing the job.

El guía habla inglés — the guide speaks English. *Una guía de Madrid* — a guidebook. *La guía telefónica* — the phone book.

Guiar is the verb: *nos guió por el casco viejo* — she led us round the old town.

Grammar Lens: the pattern you already met

The duty-chemist lesson gave you this: the feminine names the thing, the masculine names a person. Here is the set again, with the new one in place:

feminine	masculine
la guardia — the watch	el guardia — the officer
la guía — the guidebook	el guía — the guide
la policía — the force	el policía — the officer

La guía complicates it, because a female guide is *la guía* as well — so the feminine covers both the object and a woman doing the job, and only context separates them. *La policía* does the same: it is the force, and it is also a policewoman. *Llamé a la guía* is almost certainly a person; *compré la guía* is certainly a book.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

A Germanic word — and nobody can tell you which one. The usual candidate is a reconstructed ***witan**, to watch over, to show the way, which gave Occitan *guidar* and from there *guiar*. The asterisk is the warning you met on *tripaliare*: inferred, never written down. The Academy prefers a different Gothic form again. All the accounts agree on Germanic, and on **watching**.

So not *one who knows*, tempting as English **wit** makes it — that is the neighbouring branch, knowing and watching being two limbs off one

root for *seeing*. The Germanic *w-* does surface as **gu-**, as in *guardar* and *guerra*.
Set it against **seguir**, which is Latin *sequi*, to follow. A *guía* knows the way and a follower *sigue*. Two words for the two ends of the same walk, one Germanic and one Latin — which is the ordinary condition of Spanish vocabulary rather than an oddity.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the guide speaks English
- I bought a guidebook
- which article makes it a person, and why it is not decisive

Before you move on

The guidebook? (**La guía**.) A male guide? (**El guía**.) What is the root of *guía*? (**A Germanic word for watching over** — reconstructed, so it carries an asterisk.)

463.3 importar — to matter

Say **importante** and **interesar**. The first has a verb inside it, and that verb behaves like the second.

You'll want to know: importar

importar — to matter, to be of concern.

No importa — it doesn't matter. *¿Te importa si abro la ventana?* — do you mind if I open the window? *Me importa mucho* — it matters a lot to me.

It also means to import goods, which is the literal sense, but the everyday one is mattering.

Grammar Lens: it works like gustar and interesar

The thing that matters is the **subject**, and the person is an indirect object — the same shape as *interesar*:

Spanish	word for word
me interesa el arte	art interests me
me importa el resultado	the result matters to me
no me importan los horarios	the timetables don't matter to me

The verb agrees with the **thing**, not the person: *importan* for plural timetables. English puts the person first and Spanish puts the thing, which is why *I don't mind* comes out as *no me importa* — literally "it doesn't matter to me".

That makes **¿te importa...?** the standard polite request: you are asking whether a thing would matter to them, not asking permission.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **importare**: **in-**, in, plus **portare**, **to carry**. To carry something **in**.

Importing goods is carrying them in, and that is the whole of what Rome meant by it. **Mattering** is the later half, invented inside the Romance languages long after Latin — you met that split under *importante*, and this is the verb it was cut from. A thing that *imports* brings weight in with it.

Portare is a wide family: **transportar**, **exportar**, English **portable** and the **porter** who carries your bags. Keep it apart from its look-alike *porta*, a **gate** — the word inside *la puerta*, *el puerto* and **el pasaporte**, which carries you through a gate rather than carrying anything itself. You were warned about this pair at *la puerta*, where English's two *porter*s turned out to be two different words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- it doesn't matter
- do you mind if I open the window?
- ask whether the guidebook matters to them
- the timetables don't matter to me, watching the agreement

Before you move on

To matter? (**Importar**.) What does the verb agree with? (**The thing, not the person**.) What does *portare* mean? (**To carry**.)

463.4 (organizar, el guía, importar) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all three: *to organise*, *the guide*, *to matter*.

Grammar Lens: the verbs where the thing is the subject

Spanish	what is the subject
me gusta el libro	the book
me interesa el arte	art
me importa el resultado	the result
me duele la cabeza	the head

Four verbs, one shape, and you now have the four this book has given you. The family is larger — *encantar*, *faltar* and *parecer* all run on the same machine. The person is never the subject; the thing is, and the verb agrees with it. *Me importan los horarios* takes the plural because the timetables are doing the mattering.

The useful consequence: **¿te importa...?** is how Spanish asks a small favour, and it is not asking permission. It asks whether the thing would weigh on them.

Grammar Lens: two spellings the ending forces

verb	I did it
organizar	organi**c**é
rechazar	recha**c**é

Verb endings never put an **e** after a *z*, so every *-zar* verb swaps to **c** before an *e*. The sound is unchanged; only the letter moves.

And **la guía** carries its accent for the reason *la vía* did — to keep the **i** from fusing with the **a**. Two syllables, not one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- they're organising a trip with a guide
- the times don't matter to me
- how you would ask somebody if they mind

Before you move on

All three again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence arranging an outing.

463.5 (la excursión del sábado) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **organizar** and **el guía**. The notice below has one doing the other.

Your turn

A message to a walking group. Read it, then answer.

> Hola a todos. La excursión del sábado la **organiza** el centro cívico.
>
> Viene un **guía** del pueblo, así que no hace falta llevar mapa.
>
> Salimos a las ocho. Si a alguien le **importa** madrugar, hay otro grupo a las once, pero ese no lleva guía.

Say these aloud:

- who is putting the trip on, and who is coming with it
- why you do not need a map
- the difference between the two groups

Why it's said this way

La excursión del sábado la organiza el centro cívico puts the object first and then repeats it as **la**. That doubling is not a mistake and not emphasis for its own sake: Spanish allows the object to lead the sentence, and when it does, a pronoun must hold its place beside the verb. English would say "the Saturday trip is organised by the civic centre" and reach for a passive; Spanish reorders instead.

Si a alguien le importa madrugar is *importar* in its natural habitat. The subject is *madrugar* — getting up early is what does the mattering — and *a alguien le* marks the person it matters to. Word for word: "if getting up early matters to anyone".

Note *le* even though *alguien* is already named. Spanish doubles the indirect object almost always, and leaving the *le* out would sound incomplete.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines to a group: say who is organising the outing, say a guide is coming, give the time, and ask whether an early start matters to anyone.

Then check yourself: did *importar* agree with the thing rather than the person, and did you keep the *le*?

Chapter 464

La cita perdida

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (5) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can handle a missed appointment: read the reminder, apologise for not going, say what let me down, and ask for another.
>
> *Read the message or notice this chapter's words exist for, then say the same thing back.*

464.1 recordar — to remember, and to remind

> Say **el corazón** and **la cita**. The heart is inside the verb that keeps the appointment.

You'll want to know: recordar

recordar — to remember, and also to remind.

No recuerdo su nombre — I don't remember his name. *Recuérdame la cita* — remind me about the appointment. *Te recuerdo que mañana es fiesta* — I remind you that tomorrow is a holiday.

One verb, both jobs. Which it is depends on whether somebody else is being told: *recuerdo* alone is remembering, *te recuerdo* is reminding.

Grammar Lens: recordar is not acordarse

Spanish has a second verb for remembering and the two are near-twins:

Spanish	what it takes
recordar algo	a plain object
acordarse ***de*** *algo*	*de*, always

No recuerdo la dirección and *no me acuerdo de la dirección* mean the same thing. The difference is grammatical, not semantic: *recordar* takes the thing directly, *acordarse* needs its **de**, and dropping it is one of the commonest mistakes learners make.
Both are **o → ue** verbs: *recuerdo*, *me acuerdo*. That is the stressed-vowel break you have had since the stem-change chapter, and you have seen it on this exact root before: *de acuerdo* showed you *cor* opening into *cuerdo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **recordari**: **re-**, back, plus **cor**, **cordis** — **the heart**.
To remember is to **bring back through the heart**, because Latin located memory and thought there rather than in the head. That is the same *cor* inside **el corazón**, which you have had for many chapters.
The family is everywhere once seen: **el acuerdo**, an agreement — hearts brought together — and **recordar**'s English cousin **record**, which is literally a thing committed to memory. **Courage** is *cor* too, by way of French, and so is **concordance**.
So a Spanish speaker asking you to remember something is asking you to run it back past your heart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I don't remember the appointment
- remind me tomorrow
- which preposition *acordarse* needs

Before you move on

To remember? (**Recordar**.) I remember? (**Recuerdo**.) What is *cor*? (**The heart** — the same one in *corazón*.)

464.2 el dentista / la dentista — the dentist

Say **el diente** and **el médico**. Put them together and name the person.

You'll want to know: el dentista

el dentista, **la dentista** — the dentist.

Tengo cita con el dentista — I've got a dentist's appointment. *Voy al dentista* — I'm going to the dentist's.

Note *al dentista* for the place as well as the person: Spanish sends you to the professional, not to the surgery, where English says "to the dentist's".

Grammar Lens: -ista does not change for gender

-ista nouns have one form for both, and only the article moves:

the person	masculine	feminine
dentist	el dentista	la dentista
artist	el artista	la artista
tourist	el turista	la turista

The **-a** ending misleads, because it looks feminine and is not. *El dentista* is correct and *el dentisto* does not exist.

Compare *el médico / la médica*, which does change. The difference is the ending: *-ista* is invariable, *-o* is not. Learn the ending and the article stops being a guess — the same bargain the noun-making suffixes offered.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **dens**, **dentem** — **tooth** — plus the job-ending you met at the very start of this book, when *-ista* first showed you *el artista* and *la artista*. Greek wrote it **-istēs**; Latin took it in as *-ista*, and that Latin *-a* is the one Spanish inherited.

So *dentista* is a Latin body part with a borrowed job-ending welded on, which is how a large family of profession words was built: *el periodista*, *el electricista*, *el taxista*. The ending is still productive, so Spanish goes on making new ones. It is one of several — *-dor* gives *el conductor*, *-ero* gives *el camarero*.

Dentem gives **el diente**, and English **dental**, **dentist** and **indent** — to cut a tooth-shaped notch. A **dandelion** is *dent de lion*, a lion's

tooth, named for its leaves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I've got a dentist's appointment
- a female dentist, with the right article
- why *el dentista* is not a mistake

Before you move on

The dentist? (**El dentista** or **la dentista**.) Does the noun change? (**No** — only the article.) What is *dentem*? (**A tooth**.)

464.3 fallar — to fail somebody

Say **falso** and **estropeado**. One is about truth, one about machines. The verb next covers both.

You'll want to know: fallar

fallar — to fail, to go wrong, to let somebody down.

Me falló el coche — the car let me down. *Ha fallado el sistema* — the system has gone down. *No me falles* — don't let me down.

El fallo is the noun in Spain: a fault, a glitch, and in an exam a wrong answer. Much of Latin America says **la falla** for the same fault.

Grammar Lens: fallar is not estropearse

Both are about things going wrong, and they are not the same:

what happened	the verb
it stopped working, and stayed that way	**estropearse**
it did not do its job at the moment needed	**fallar**

Se ha estropeado el coche — it is broken, in the garage. *Me falló el coche* — it let me down, this morning, when I needed it. A car can

fallar once and be fine afterwards.
That is why *fallar* is the verb for people too. *Me falló* about a friend is a reproach: they were not there when it counted.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **fallere** — the verb that **tripped you up**, as you had it under *falso*. That literal footing is what the rest grows out of: to trip somebody is to put the ground where they did not expect it, and from there to mislead them.
The move from tripping to failing runs through disappointment: something that *fails* you has, in effect, put the ground somewhere other than where it promised. Latin *fallere* carried the deceiving sense alongside the literal one, and Spanish kept the pair — *falso* for the lie, *fallar* for the letting-down.
English took it twice as well: **false** from the participle, and **fail** through French. **Fault**, **fallacy** and **failure** are all here, and so is **default**, which is a failing to act.
A second Spanish branch is **faltar**, to be lacking — *me falta tiempo*, I'm short of time — from the same root by a different road.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the car let me down this morning
- don't let me down
- which verb fits a washing machine that has stopped for good

Before you move on

To let somebody down? (**Fallar**.) The noun? (**El fallo**.) What did *fallere* do to you? (**Tripped you up** — the same verb as *falso*.)

464.4 (recordar, el dentista, fallar) — from cold

Close the lessons before this one. Say all three: *to remember*, *the dentist*, *to let down*.

Grammar Lens: two bodies and a lie

new word	what it was built on
recordar	*cor*, the heart — the one in *el corazón*
el dentista	*dentem*, a tooth — the one in *el diente*
fallar	*fallere*, to deceive — the one in *falso*

Two body parts and a lie, and all three were already in your vocabulary. By this stage that is the ordinary case rather than a happy accident: a corpus of nearly a thousand words contains most of the roots the next hundred will need.

Recordar is the one worth keeping. Latin put memory in the **heart**, not the head, so remembering is running a thing back past it — and English **record** is the same word, a thing committed to memory.

Grammar Lens: endings that fix the article, and one that does not

ending	what it settles
-ista	**nothing changes**; only the article moves
-o / -a	the noun itself changes: *el médico*, *la médica*

El dentista looks feminine and is not. That **-a** rides in on the borrowed job-ending *-ista*, which does not bend for gender at all — so the noun stays put and the article does the work. *El guía* and *la guía*, one chapter back, make the same move without a word of Greek in them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- remind me about the dentist
- the car let me down
- which of the three words has a heart inside it

Before you move on

All three again, in Spanish, without looking. Then one sentence about an appointment you nearly missed.

464.5 (perder la cita) — read it, then do it yourself

Say **recordar** and **fallar**. The first message does one; the second admits the other.

Your turn

Two messages, a day apart. Read both, then answer.

1 — de la clínica

Le **recordamos** su cita con la **dentista** el jueves a las 10:15. Para anular, llame con 24 horas de antelación.

2 — el jueves por la tarde

Buenas tardes. Siento no haber ido esta mañana; me **falló** el despertador y no me acordé hasta las once. ¿Puedo pedir otra cita?

Say these aloud:

- when the appointment was, and who with
- what you must do to cancel, and how far ahead
- the two things that went wrong

Why it's said this way

The apology uses **both** verbs for remembering and they are doing different work. **Me falló el despertador** — the alarm clock is the subject; it let the writer down. Then **no me acordé** — *acordarse*, the reflexive one, for the person's own failure to recall. Spanish separates the thing that failed from the person who forgot, and the apology is more honest for it.

La dentista, feminine, so the clinic is naming a particular woman. And *con la dentista*, not *con el dentista* — had the message said *el*, you would know it was a man, since the noun itself never tells you. **Siento no haber ido** is the standard apology frame: *sentir* plus a perfect infinitive. Not *siento que no fui*, which a learner reaches for and a Spanish speaker does not.

Before you move on

Now your turn, out loud and then in writing. Four lines: as the clinic, remind somebody of a dental appointment and say how to cancel; then as the patient, apologise for missing it, say what let you down, and ask for another.

Then check yourself: did *fallar* go to the thing and *acordarse* to the person, and did *acordarse* keep its *de*?

Chapter 465

El cuaderno de campo

Modes: **voice** (5) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 3 of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can keep a shared written record: read the instructions inside a weather notebook, note down a temperature and a rainfall, and understand why a zero is not the same as a blank.
>
> *Read the instructions taped inside a shared weather notebook, then fill in a day out loud.*

465.1 el cuaderno — the notebook

> Say **el libro**, **el papel** and **el carné**. One is bound, one is loose, and the third already told you which number it counts to.

You'll want to know: el cuaderno

el cuaderno — the notebook, the exercise book.

> Traiga un **cuaderno** y un bolígrafo.

Un cuaderno de espiral — a spiral notebook. *El cuaderno de campo* — the field notebook, the one a person carries to write down what they see outside.

A *libro* is written for you. A *cuaderno* is waiting for you to write in it. That is the difference that matters, and it is why a school hands out *cuadernos* and a library lends *libros*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You have had this number already. *El carné* was Latin **quaternum**, a set of four — four sheets of paper folded together, which is how a small notebook was made — and that lesson named *el cuaderno* while it was there. This is the object the card shrank from.

Latin	Spanish
quaternum	el carné, el cuaderno
quattuor	cuatro, cuarto

So *quaternum* counts **sheets gathered into a fold**, not pages produced by one. Four leaves folded together was the cheapest book anybody could make, and the thing was named after how many went in.

English kept the count plainer still: a **quire** is a gathering of folded sheets, and it is the same *quaternum* worn down through French. The notebook in a bag and the number four are one word, separated by the thing rarely thought about when buying one — how many sheets went into the fold.

Grammar Lens: the ua that does not move

Spanish has taught you to watch stressed vowels, because those are the ones that break. This family shows the other half of that rule.

word	stress falls on
cua-tro	the *ua*
cua-**der**-no	the *-der-*

The *ua* sits still in both. It is not a broken vowel waiting to happen — it came straight from the Latin *qua-* and stayed. The lesson is that the stress test tells you where to *look*, and looking sometimes tells you nothing is happening. Breaking needs two things, not one: the vowel must be stressed **and** must have been a short Latin **e** or **o** (or the *ae* that fell in with short *e*, which is why *quaerere* gave *quiero*). In *cuatro* the *ua* is stressed, so it passes the first test and fails the second. In *cuaderno* it fails both.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- bring a notebook

- the difference between a libro and a cuaderno
- which number is hiding in cuaderno

Before you move on

The notebook? (**El cuaderno**.) Which word did you meet its number under? (***El carné*** — the same *quaternum*, four sheets in one fold.)

465.2 anotar — to write it down

Say **apuntar** and **la nota**. You already have a verb for writing something down. A second one is about to arrive, and the two lean in different directions.

You'll want to know: anotar

anotar — to note down, to record in writing.

Anote la temperatura cada mañana en el cuaderno.

Anotar los datos — to record the figures. *Anotar un gol* — to score a goal, because the scoreboard is a record too.

Grammar Lens: anotar is not apuntar

Both put words on paper, and the difference is what the writing is *for*.

what you are doing	the verb
jotting so you do not forget	**apuntar**
entering it into a record	**anotar**

Apunta mi número is a scrap of paper in a pocket. *Anote su número en el registro* is a line in a book that will be read later by somebody else. The etymologies lean the same way, which is rare enough to be worth noticing. *Apuntar* is **punctum**, the dot a point leaves behind — you had it from *pungere*, to pierce. *Anotar* is **nota**, a mark made so that somebody could read it. Both name marks; the difference is who each mark is for.
So a doctor *apunta* while you talk and *anota* in your file afterwards.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **adnotare**: **ad-**, towards, plus **nota**, the mark you have from *la nota*. The writing is all in the noun.
Latin *nota* was a sign that stood for something — a letter, a brand, a mark in the margin. English took it both ways: a **note** you write, and to **notice**, which marks a thing without writing anything.
You were given **notar** alongside *la nota* — to notice, to catch the mark. That is Spanish having taken the second road. *Anotar* is the first road, with the prefix aiming the mark at something.

Spanish	what it does
notar	to notice it
anotar	to write it down

One root, one prefix, and the prefix is the whole difference between seeing something and keeping it.
Anotado is the participle, and *las anotaciones* are the notes themselves — the *-ción* ending doing the job it has done since you first met it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- note the temperature down in the notebook
- which verb you use for a scrap of paper
- what notar means without the a-

Before you move on

To write it into a record? (**Anotar**.) And to notice, without writing? (**Notar**.) Which Latin word is inside both? (***Nota***.)

465.3 la temperatura — the temperature

Say **el calor** and **el frío**. You have the two ends. Here is the word for the scale that runs between them.

You'll want to know: la temperatura

la temperatura — the temperature.

> Anote la **temperatura** a las ocho de la mañana y a las ocho de la tarde.

Tomar la temperatura — to take somebody's temperature. In Spain, *tener temperatura* is to be running a fever with no number said out loud; *tener fiebre* is the safer phrase everywhere.

Note what *calor* and *frío* cannot do: they tell you which way, never how much. *Hace calor* is a judgement. *La temperatura* is a measurement, and the whole reason a notebook wants one is that a measurement can be compared with yesterday's.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **temperare** did not mean heat at all. It meant **to mix in the right proportion** — to hold two things in balance so that neither wins.

Follow that one idea and a very odd family falls into line:

English	what is being balanced
to **temper** steel	heat against hardness
a **temperate** climate	summer against winter

A person's **temper** is the mix of their humours, and losing it is the mix coming apart. **Tempera** paint is pigment held in the right proportion of egg. And a **temperature** is the point a mixture has reached on the scale between hot and cold.

Spanish keeps the verb as **templar**, to temper or to tune an instrument, and *templado* is the word for weather that is neither one thing nor the other.

Grammar Lens: -ura has two jobs

La factura gave you **-ura** as the thing an action produces, with a verb hiding inside the noun. *Temperatura* is built the same way and on the same instruction: the verb inside it is *temperare*, and what the action produces is a reading.

The ending has a second family, though, and it does not take verbs at all:

base	noun
alto	la alt**ura**
ancho	la anch**ura**

Those sit on adjectives, and they name how much of the quality there is — *altura* is how tall, *anchura* is how wide, and *la verdura* is the one you already own. So when you meet a new **-ura** noun, look for a verb first, as *factura* told you to, and look for an adjective second.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- note down the temperature
- what temperare meant before it meant heat
- how tall, using the -ura noun

Before you move on

The temperature? (**La temperatura**.) What did *temperare* mean? (**To mix in the right proportion**.) What does *-ura* build? (**The thing an action produces** — *factura*, *temperatura* — and on an adjective, **how much of a quality** — *altura*.)

465.4 la lluvia — the rain

Say **llueve** and **el llanto**. Both begin with the sound this word begins with, and both have already told you why.

You'll want to know: la lluvia

la lluvia — the rain.

Lluvia en los últimos tres días: 12 mm.

Lluvia fuerte — heavy rain. *Un día de lluvia* — a rainy day. *La lluvia ácida* — acid rain.

Grammar Lens: the verb and the noun do different work

You already have *llueve*, and it refuses a subject: there is nobody raining. *La lluvia* is what you reach for the moment rain has to be counted, described or put in a column.

what you are saying	the word
it is raining now	**llueve**
how much rain there was	**la lluvia**

Llueve mucho is a report from the window. *Hubo mucha lluvia* is a line in a notebook. A verb with no subject cannot be measured; a noun can, which is why the rainfall column is headed *lluvia* and never *llueve*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

This word's Latin has been passed under your nose several times already, and it is worth saying so.

The rule came to you under *llamar*, back at the beginning: Latin *cl-*, *fl-* and *pl-* arrive as Spanish **ll-** in words that came down by mouth. *Llueve* put it on rain, from *pluere*. And under *el llanto* it was run out over a list — where *la lluvia* was already sitting, as the example beside *lleno* and *llorar*.

Latin	Spanish
pluvia	la lluvia
plenus	lleno

So nothing here is new except the use. Latin **pluvia** is the rain itself, *pluere* is the raining, and both came down by mouth with the cluster shifted.

The shift is not a law, and you have seen it fail. Words lifted later out of writing keep their *pl-* — which is why *planta* still has one, and why Spanish owns **la lluvia** and **pluvial** at the same time, the same word at two speeds. A *pluviómetro* measures exactly what this chapter's notebook is for, and it kept the cluster because it was built by scholars, not worn down by mouths.

That is what the earlier lessons were for. A rule you were given at the start turns up later holding a word you now need, and the word costs you nothing because the rule already paid for it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- heavy rain, and a rainy day
- which one goes in a column, llueve or la lluvia
- what Latin pl- turns into

Before you move on

The rain? (**La lluvia**.) Its Latin form? (***Pluvia***.) And why does it start with *ll*? (**Because Latin *pl-* became Spanish *ll-***.)

465.5 (el cuaderno, anotar, la temperatura, la lluvia) — from cold

Four words, no prompts. The book you write in, the verb for writing into it, the number you write, and the weather you write it about.

You'll want to know: the four, cold

English	Spanish
the notebook	**el cuaderno**
to note down	**anotar**
the temperature	**la temperatura**
the rain	**la lluvia**

Grammar Lens: an impression is not a record

This chapter is about the moment a thing stops being an impression and becomes a record.

impression	record
hace calor	*la temperatura: 24*
llueve	*lluvia: 12 mm*

Hace calor and *llueve* are both true and neither can be compared with yesterday. The nouns can. That is why the chapter's verb is **anotar** rather than **apuntar**: a note you jot is for you, and a note you enter is

for whoever reads the book next.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two of the four hide something that is not about writing or weather at all.

word	what is underneath
el cuaderno	**four** — *quaternum*, four sheets in one fold
la temperatura	**mixing** — *temperare*, to hold in proportion

The other two say what they are. *Anotar* is *nota*, a mark, with a prefix aiming it. And *la lluvia* is *pluvia*, which had been passed under your nose several times — under *llueve*, *el llanto*, *lleno* and *planta* — before you needed it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- note the temperature down in the notebook
- the rain, and then it is raining
- which of the four counts to four

Before you move on

The notebook? (**El cuaderno**.) To enter it in the record? (**Anotar**.) The temperature? (**La temperatura**.) The rain? (**La lluvia**.)

465.6 (el cuaderno de campo) — read it, then fill in a day

Say **el cuaderno** and **anotar**. Somebody else will read what you write in it, which is the whole reason the instructions exist.

Read this

Taped inside the front cover of a shared notebook in a community garden:

> **CUADERNO DE CAMPO — CÓMO USARLO**
>
> **Anote** la temperatura dos veces al día: a las ocho de la mañana y a las ocho de la tarde.
>
> Si ha llovido, **anote** también la lluvia en milímetros. Si no ha llovido, escriba un cero. No deje la casilla en blanco.
>
> Una línea por día. Si olvida un día, déjelo vacío y siga: es peor **anotar** de memoria que no **anotar** nada.

Grammar Lens: a zero is not a blank

Four instructions, and the last one is the interesting one.

the instruction	what it wants
anote la temperatura	twice a day, at fixed hours
escriba un cero	a zero, not an empty box

The notice draws a line between **un cero** and **la casilla en blanco**. A zero says it did not rain. A blank says nobody looked. Those are different facts, and a record that cannot tell them apart is worth less than one that can — which is why the last line would rather you left a gap than filled it in from memory.

Grammar Lens: anote, not anota

Every instruction here is **usted**: *anote*, *escriba*, *deje*, *siga*. A notice usually takes the polite form, because it does not know who will read it — though plenty of Spanish notices use a bare infinitive instead, as in *no fumar*.

to one person you know	on a notice
anota	**anote**

You have had the mechanism since *hable usted*: an *usted* command **is** the subjunctive, because *usted* is a third-person title. Not a borrowing — the same form doing its own job. (The *tú* negative is subjunctive too: *no anotes*.) It is why *reduzca* on the road sign looked the way it

did.

Your turn

Yesterday it rained in the morning and the afternoon was warm. Fill in the line out loud: say the date, the two temperatures, and the rain.

Now say what you would write if it had not rained at all — and say why that is not the same as leaving it blank.

Before you move on

The field notebook? (**El cuaderno de campo**.) The polite command to note something? (**Anote**.) What goes in the box on a dry day? (**Un cero** — never a blank.)

Chapter 466

Una carta del colegio

Modes: **voice** (4) **eyes** (2) **Hands-free start:** none of the 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a formal letter home from a school: understand who signed it, what it reports about behaviour, that the change can be seen, and that being asked to discuss something is an invitation rather than a summons.
>
> *Read a letter home from the head, then say what it actually asks for.*

466.1 el director — the one who signs the letter

> Say **directo** and **el actor**. One gave you the verb and one gave you the ending. Put them together and you have this word already.

You'll want to know: el director

el director, **la directora** — the head, the director.

> Atentamente, la **directora** del centro.

El director del colegio — the head teacher. *La directora de la empresa* — the company director. *El director de cine* — the film director.

Unlike *el guía*, this one **does** change: *director*, *directora* — the ordinary swap, the one *profesor / profesora* already showed you. It is a habit rather than a law, and this very family holds the exception: *actor* takes **actriz**, not *actora*, as you saw.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You have been given both halves already, in two different chapters, and this is where they meet.
When you learned **el actor**, the *-tor* ending was set out as Latin's way of naming the doer: take a verb, add *-tor*, get the one who does it. The table there listed *agere* → *actor*, *docere* → *doctor* — and **dirigere** → **director**. The word was printed in front of you before you needed it. And *dirigere* came earlier still, under **la derecha** and again under **directo**: *dis-*, apart, plus *regere*, to rule — to set something straight, to aim it. So a *director* is the one who **aims the thing**, not the one who shouts.

the verb	**the doer**
dirigere, to aim	el director

Dirigir is the living Spanish verb: *dirigir una empresa*, to run a company. And *dirigirse a alguien* is to address somebody — which is the point *derecha* made about English **address**, to set a letter straight towards a person. Here it is the same verb doing the same job in Spanish, and it is what the letter in this chapter does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the head teacher, then the headmistress
- what dirigere means
- the ending that names the doer

Before you move on

The head? (**El director** — *la directora.*) What does a director do to a thing? (**Aims it** — *dirigere*, to set straight.)

466.2 visible — able to be seen

Say **sociable** and **el aviso**. One gave you the ending, the other gave you the root. This word is the two of them stuck together.

You'll want to know: visible

visible — visible, able to be seen.

> El aviso debe quedar **visible** en el tablón de anuncios.

En un lugar visible — somewhere it can be seen, the phrase notices use about themselves. *Una mejora visible* — a noticeable improvement.

Like *sociable*, it has one form for both genders: *un cartel visible*, *una puerta visible*. The plural still moves — *carteles visibles*.

Grammar Lens: -able and -ible point two ways

They are one ending, Latin **-bilis**, wearing two spellings, and which vowel you get follows the verb's family:

verb family	ending
-ar — *lavar*	lav**able**
-er, **-ir** — *vender*, *ver*	vend**ible**, vis**ible**

Older borrowings can sit outside that, so it is a lean rather than a law — but it predicts the new words, which is what a rule is for.

The direction is steadier than the spelling. *Amable* told you what the ending does: **able to have this done to it**. That is the ordinary reading, and it is the one to reach for first — *lavable*, *visible*, *comestible* all describe a thing something is done **to**.

A small group leans the other way and names a doer or a causer instead: *sociable*, *agradable*, *durable*. Note that *sociable* is not even built on a verb — *socius* is a noun, a companion — which is part of why it behaves oddly. Take the common reading first and learn the handful that do not fit.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **videre**, to see — the root you met under *el aviso*, where *a-vis-o* turned out to be *ad visum*, "to what is seen".

Spanish did not set *videre* aside for the formal words. It kept it as the everyday **ver**, worn short through Old Spanish *veer*, which is what you were told when you learned the verb. What the formal words are built on is the verb's **other stem**, *vis-*: *visible*, *la visión*.

The same root is under a great many English words — **vision**, **visible**, **evident**, **advice**, **view** — most of them arriving through French on their way out of Latin rather than straight from it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- it must stay visible on the board
- which of sociable and visible has it done to them
- the Latin verb underneath

Before you move on

Visible? (**Visible**.) Does it change for a feminine noun? (**No** — but the plural does: *visibles*.) Which way does *-ible* usually point? (**At the thing** — able to have it done to it.)

466.3 el comportamiento — how somebody carries themselves

Say **importar** and **el entrenamiento**. One holds the root of the next word and the other holds its ending.

You'll want to know: el comportamiento

el comportamiento — behaviour, conduct.

Su **comportamiento** en clase ha mejorado.

El comportamiento del grupo — the group's behaviour. In a school letter it is the formal word; a parent at home is more likely to say *se porta bien* or *se porta mal*.

Comportarse is the verb: *compórtate*, behave yourself.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

com-, together, plus **portare**, to carry — the *portare* you had under *importar*, where carrying something **in** turned out to be the whole of what Rome meant by it.
To *comportarse* is to **carry yourself**, and English does the identical thing: *conduct* is *con-* plus *ducere*, to lead — to lead yourself. Two languages, two verbs of motion, the same idea that character is something you are carrying about.

Spanish	English
comportarse, to carry oneself	to conduct oneself

Keep it away from *la puerta*. That is *porta*, a gate — the warning came first at *la puerta*, where English's two *porter*s turned out to be different words, and again at *importar*.

Grammar Lens: -miento on a reflexive verb

You have **-miento** from *el entrenamiento* and *el seguimiento*: it attaches to the calm form of the verb and hands back a masculine noun.
Comportarse is pronominal, and the ending is unbothered by that — it takes the plain stem, *comporta-*, so the *se* never enters the noun at all. You saw the same thing without it being named: *entrenarse* gives *el entrenamiento*.

verb	noun
entrenar(se)	el entrena**miento**
comportar(se)	el comporta**miento**

What the noun buys is register, not anonymity — *su comportamiento* says whose perfectly well. It states conduct as a topic rather than as something a child is doing to you, which is why a school letter reaches for it and a parent says *se porta mal*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- his behaviour in class has improved
- behave yourself
- what com- plus portare means literally

Before you move on

Behaviour? (**El comportamiento**.) The verb? (**Comportarse**.) What are you carrying? (**Yourself**.)

466.4 discutir — to discuss, and to argue

Say **la reunión** and **el director**. A meeting with the head is where this verb usually turns up.

You'll want to know: discutir

discutir — to discuss, and also to argue.

Podemos **discutir** el comportamiento en la reunión.

Discutir un tema — to discuss a topic. *Discutir con alguien* — to argue with somebody. **La discusión** is both the discussion and the row.

Grammar Lens: the preposition decides

One verb covers what English splits between *discuss* and *argue*, and the grammar around it does most of the sorting.

what follows	what it means
a thing — *discutir el precio*	discuss it
con a person — *discutir con él*	argue with him

A thing after the verb is a topic; a person after **con** is an opponent. It is not watertight — *discutir el precio con el jefe* can be either, and tone settles it — but the pattern is reliable enough to lean on, and mistaking the two is how a polite sentence turns rude.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **discutere**: **dis-**, apart, plus **quatere**, to shake.
To *discutere* was to **shake a thing to pieces** — to strike it until it came apart and you could see what was inside. The Romans used it of smashing, and only later of taking an argument apart.
Which makes the two Spanish senses one sense. Discussing a topic and arguing with a person are the same act at two temperatures: something is being shaken until it comes apart. English kept the violent end elsewhere — **concussion** is *con-* plus the same *quatere*, a violent shaking of the head.
Percusión is a third member, a striking right through.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- we can discuss the behaviour at the meeting
- to argue with somebody
- what quatere means

Before you move on

To discuss? (**Discutir**.) And with a person, using *con*? (**To argue**.) What did *quatere* do? (**Shook** — *discutere* shakes a thing apart.)

466.5 (el director, visible, el comportamiento, discutir) — from cold

Four words, no prompts. Who signs the letter, what the notice must stay, what the letter is about, and what the meeting will do with it.

You'll want to know: the four, cold

English	Spanish
the head	**el director**
visible	**visible**
behaviour	**el comportamiento**
to discuss, to argue	**discutir**

Grammar Lens: three endings you already had

One piece of this chapter is new, and it is a spelling: **-ible**, beside the **-able** you already had. The endings themselves are all old news. What is worth holding is which way each one bends.

ending	does it change for a woman?
-tor	yes — *director*, *directora*
-ible	no — *visible* for everyone

El actor gave you *-tor* and printed *director* in its own table — and *la actriz* gave you the exception in the same breath. *Amable* and *sociable* gave you *-able*, and the reading to take first: able to have it done to it. *El entrenamiento* gave you *-miento*. Four words, and almost nothing underneath them you had not been handed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two of the four are about **carrying and shaking**, which is not what a school letter sounds like.

word	**what is underneath**
el comportamiento	*com-* + *portare* — carrying yourself
discutir	*dis-* + *quatere* — shaking a thing apart

El director aims (*dirigere*, to set straight) and *visible* is seen (*videre*). Four abstractions, four physical verbs, and the letter that uses all four is about a child in a classroom.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the headmistress wants to discuss his behaviour
- it must stay visible
- which one of the four changes for a woman, and why the other three cannot

Before you move on

The head? (**El director**.) Visible? (**Visible**.) Behaviour? (**El comportamiento**.) To discuss? (**Discutir**.)

466.6 (una carta del colegio) — read it, then say what it wants

Say **el director** and **el comportamiento**. A letter with both words in it is rarely good news, and rarely as bad as it looks.

Read this

Estimada familia:

Les escribo para informarles de que el **comportamiento**

de su hijo en clase ha mejorado de forma **visible** durante este trimestre.

Me gustaría **discutir** con ustedes cómo mantener esa mejora. Pueden pedir una cita en secretaría.

Atentamente,

La **directora**

Grammar Lens: what the letter is not doing

A reader who knows *discutir* only as *argue* will read this as a summons. It is not one, and two words tell you so.

the word	**what it settles**
ha mejorado	the news is good
discutir **con ustedes**	a conversation, not a row

Discutir con leans towards arguing when nothing else is on the table. Here a topic follows it — *cómo mantener esa mejora* — which is exactly the mixed case you were warned about, and the good news settles it. The preposition leans; the content decides.

Note also **de forma visible**. The letter does not say the child is visible; it says the improvement can be seen. That reading comes from *videre* — seeing is done to a thing — rather than from the ending, which points either way.

Your turn

Say in one sentence what the letter reports and what it asks for.

Now say the same news to a friend, out of the formal register: start with *se porta* instead of *el comportamiento*.

Before you move on

Who wrote it? (**La directora**.) What improved? (**El comportamiento**.) How much? (**De forma visible**.) What does she want? (**Discutir** — to talk it over.)

Chapter 467

El huerto comunitario

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a monthly production sheet on a community garden's door: understand what was produced, who it fed, what the target was, and why a notice writes 'no fue suficiente' where a person would say 'no fue bastante'.
>
> *Read a community garden's monthly figures, then say whether the target was met.*

467.1 producir — to produce

> Say **reducir** and **la ducha**. The verb coming next is their close relative, and it will not make you learn anything twice.

You'll want to know: producir

producir — to produce, to make.

> El huerto **produce** unos cien kilos al mes.

Producir comida — to produce food. *La producción* is the noun, and **el producto** is the thing that comes out.

Grammar Lens: nothing new here, which is the point

Reducir taught you this whole verb, five chapters ago. *Producir* is the same class and takes the same two irregularities:

where	reducir	producir
the **z** before *c*	redu**zc**o	produ**zc**o
the **j** past	redu**j**e	produ**j**e

So the subjunctive is *produzca* — the form on a notice, as *reduzca* was on the road sign — and the past is *produjo*, never *producí*.
That is worth stopping on. Learning *reducir* bought you the whole *-ducir* corner of that class — *producir*, and *traducir* and *introducir* when you meet them — the verbs that take the **j** past as well as the **z**. Not the whole class, though. *Reducir*'s own lesson warned you: *conocer* shares the **-zc-** and not the past, going *conocí*. Two groups, one spelling, and the *-ducir* verbs are the half that also changes its past.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pro-, forward, plus **ducere**, to lead — the *ducere* already under *reducir* and under *la ducha*.
To produce is to **lead something forward**, out where it can be seen. A farmer leads a crop forward out of the ground; a factory leads goods forward out of a door. English keeps the picture in **produce** as a noun, the stuff itself, and in a theatre **producer**, who leads the show out in front of an audience.
Set them side by side and the prefix does all the work: *reducir* leads back, *producir* leads forward, and *conducir* — which *reducir*'s table already showed you — leads along.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the garden produces about a hundred kilos a month
- I produce, using the first-person form
- the past of producir, the one that is not producí

Before you move on

To produce? (**Producir**.) I produce? (**Produzco**.) It produced? (**Produjo**.) Which way does *pro-* lead? (**Forward**.)

467.2 suficiente — enough, and only enough

Say **bastante** and **escaso**. You already own both ends of this. The word coming next overlaps one of them, and the overlap is the lesson.

You'll want to know: suficiente

suficiente — enough, sufficient.

No producimos comida **suficiente** para todos.

Comida suficiente — enough food. *Lo suficiente* — enough of it, as a noun. *Suficientemente* — sufficiently.

Like *bastante*, it has one form for both genders: *un plato suficiente*, *una cantidad suficiente*.

Said of a person it turns unkind — *un tono suficiente* is a smug one.

Grammar Lens: bastante already means this, and that is the problem

Bastante was given to you as the middle of a scale — *poco*, **bastante**, *muy* — and its lesson was firm that it does **not** mean *a lot*. So what is *suficiente* for?

word	what else it does
bastante	*quite*, *fairly* — *bastante caro*
suficiente	names a requirement, not a place on a scale

Bastante has that second, adverbial job: *bastante caro* is **fairly** expensive, a reading on the scale. *Suficiente* has no scale reading at all. It measures a thing against what was needed, and reports whether the need was met.

Both can say there is not enough — *no hay bastante* is the everyday phrasing. A notice reaches for *no hay suficiente* because it names the requirement rather than the quantity, and because it is the formal choice.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **sufficere**: **sub-**, up from under, plus **facere**, to make or do — the *facere* that *la factura* called one of the hardest-working roots in the

language.
To *sufficere* was to put something **under** a thing: supply it from below, prop it, make it stand. Adequacy came out of that, which is why sufficiency is load-bearing rather than abundant — the amount that keeps the thing up.
Suficiente wears the **-ente** of *exigente*; *bastante* wears **-ante**. They are the same ending choosing its vowel by verb family — *-ar* verbs take *-ante*, *-er* and *-ir* verbs take *-ente*.
And the two words are one language at two speeds, the pattern you have from *rueda* against *rotativo*. *Suficiente* is a real Latin present participle, *sufficientem*, lifted off the page. *Bastante* was built inside Spanish on the inherited verb *bastar* — there was never a Latin *bastans*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- we do not produce enough food for everybody
- which of the two can also mean "fairly"
- what sub- plus facere does under a thing

Before you move on

Enough, on a notice? (**Suficiente**.) Which word also means *fairly*? (**Bastante**.) What does *sufficere* do? (**Props a thing from underneath** — adequacy is load-bearing.)

467.3 alimentar — to feed

Say **el medicamento** and **producir**. One lends its ending to this chapter's noun; the other is what has to happen before you can do the verb.

You'll want to know: alimentar

alimentar — to feed, to nourish.

Lo que producimos **alimenta** a unas cuarenta familias.

Alimentar a un niño — to feed a child; the **a** is there because the thing being fed is a person. **El alimento** is the food itself, and **la alimentación** is the feeding, or a person's diet.

Alimentarse de algo is what an animal or a person lives on: *se alimentan de fruta.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **alere** was wider than *to feed.* It meant to nourish, and by that to **rear** — to bring a thing on, to make it bigger. Feeding is the sense that stuck in Spanish; the others are worth having:

English	how the root shows
adult	somebody who has finished growing
alumnus	somebody being brought up

An **alumnus** is literally *one being nourished* — a foster-child, then a pupil, then a graduate. **Coalesce** is *co-* plus *alescere*, to grow together. So *alimentar* is not about hunger. It is about making something bigger, and food is the means.

Grammar Lens: -mento, and the noun it builds here

El medicamento gave you **-mento**, the formal twin of *-miento*, arriving by the other road. Latin *-mentum* often named the **means** of a thing, and both of these are that kind:

noun	the means of
el medica**mento**	healing
el ali**mento**	growing

Watch the cut: it is *ali-* plus *-mento*, exactly as *medica-* plus *-mento.* And the noun is older than the verb — **Latin** built *alimentum* off *alere* first, and *alimentare* came afterwards. Spanish inherited both, which is why the noun is *alimento* and not *alimentamento.*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- what we produce feeds about forty families
- the food itself, then the diet

- what alere meant before it meant feeding

Before you move on

To feed? (**Alimentar**.) The food? (**El alimento**.) What did *alere* cover? (**Nourishing, and rearing** — making a thing bigger.)

467.4 el objetivo — the target

Say **el objeto** and **rotativo**. One is the word underneath the next; the other is its ending.

You'll want to know: el objetivo

el objetivo — the target, the aim, the objective.

Objetivo del mes: alimentar a cincuenta familias.

Cumplir el objetivo — to meet the target. *Nuestro objetivo es…* — our aim is… As an adjective it means **objective**: *un informe objetivo.*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You have the whole of this already. *El objeto* was **ob-**, before or against, plus **iacere**, to throw — a thing *thrown before* you, put in your way. That lesson listed the family: *object*, *project*, *inject*, *eject*, *subject*, all of them throws.
Objetivo is that same thrown thing wearing **-ivo**: *to do with the thing placed in front.* The throw does not turn round — the grammatical object is already what an action is thrown at, as *el objeto*'s own chapter said. What narrowed is **why** the thing is there.

word	**the thing placed before you**
el objeto	whatever is there
el objetivo	the one put there to be reached

English kept both jobs on the same word: an *objective* is an aim, and an **objective lens** is the one that faces the object.

Grammar Lens: -ivo makes an adjective that can stand alone

Rotativo gave you **-ivo**: an ending that names a habit or a capacity — of the kind that does this.
What *objetivo* adds is that such an adjective can harden into a noun and keep both jobs:

use	example
adjective	*un informe objetivo*
noun	*el objetivo del mes*

Spanish does this often and English follows it here, which makes the pair easy to trust: *an objective report*, *the month's objective*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- this month's target: to feed fifty families
- an objective report
- the difference between an objeto and an objetivo

Before you move on

The target? (**El objetivo**.) What is inside it? (***Iacere***, to throw.) What does *-ivo* add? (**Not a new direction** — the sense of a thing placed there to be reached.)

467.5 (producir, suficiente, alimentar, el objetivo) — from cold

Four words, no prompts. What the garden does, whether it is enough, who it keeps going, and the number written at the top of the sheet.

You'll want to know: the four, cold

English	Spanish
to produce	**producir**
enough	**suficiente**
to feed	**alimentar**
the target	**el objetivo**

Grammar Lens: what this chapter actually cost you

Three of the four are assembled out of parts you already held.

word	where the parts came from
producir	*reducir*'s verb class, *ducere*'s prefix trick
objetivo	*el objeto*'s throw, *rotativo*'s *-ivo*

Neither needed a new rule — only a new arrangement of rules you had. *Alimentar* borrowed *-mento* from *el medicamento*. Only *suficiente* asked for something genuinely new, and even that was a distinction rather than a word: you already had *bastante*.

That is what the earlier chapters bought. New words stop being new machinery and start being new arrangements of it, and each one costs less than the last.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two of the four hide a physical action.

word	what is underneath
suficiente	*sub-* + *facere* — **putting enough underneath** to hold it up
alimentar	*alere* — **growing** a thing, with food as the means

Producir leads forward; *objetivo* is the thing placed in front to be reached. Four words off a garden shed, four Latin verbs of handling and growing underneath them — the pattern this book keeps finding.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- we do not produce enough to feed everybody

- the month's target
- which of the four came with its irregular forms already learned

Before you move on

To produce? (**Producir**.) Enough? (**Suficiente**.) To feed? (**Alimentar**.) The target? (**El objetivo**.)

467.6 (el informe mensual del huerto) — read the figures, then judge them

Say **producir** and **el objetivo**. A sheet with both on it is asking one question: did the first reach the second?

Read this

HUERTO COMUNITARIO — MARZO

Objetivo del mes: **alimentar** a 50 familias.

Producido: 380 kg. Familias atendidas: 41.

No fue **suficiente**. En abril vamos a plantar más patata (papa), que **produce** más kilos por metro cuadrado.

Grammar Lens: the sheet answers its own question

Four numbers and one verdict, and the verdict is the word this chapter was for.

what the sheet gives	what it settles
50 against 41	the target was missed
no fue suficiente	and by how the garden judges it

It says *suficiente*, not *bastante*, and that is deliberate — though both would be understood. *No fue bastante* is what you would say out loud. *No fue suficiente* is what a sheet writes, because it names the requirement rather than the quantity, and the 380 kg is being measured against the 50 families.

Note **producido** too: the participle, used as a plain label for the amount. A sheet does not need a whole sentence to report a quantity.

Your turn

Say in one sentence what the target was and whether it was met.

Now say what April is meant to change, and why the potato is the chosen crop.

Before you move on

The month's target? (**Alimentar a 50 familias**.) Was it enough? (**No fue suficiente**.) Why that word on a sheet? (**Because it names the requirement**, where *bastante* names a quantity.)

Chapter 468

Dos grados

Modes: **voice** (5) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can act on a cold-weather reading: take a temperature in degrees off a bus-stop screen, and choose between a jacket, a coat and a scarf on the strength of the number rather than a general impression.
>
> *Read a bus-stop screen and a message from home, then decide what to put on.*

468.1 la chaqueta — the jacket

> Say **el jersey** and **la piel**. Both lessons put the next word in front of you without stopping to teach it.

You'll want to know: la chaqueta

la chaqueta — the jacket.

> Hace frío. Llévate una **chaqueta**.

Una chaqueta de piel — a leather jacket, the phrase *la piel* already gave you. *La chaqueta del traje* — the suit jacket.

Among knitwear the line is clean: a *jersey* goes over your head, a *chaqueta de punto* opens down the front — which is what a cardigan is. Beyond knitwear a *chaqueta* is any short tailored jacket.

where	the everyday word
Spain	**la chaqueta**
much of Latin America	**el saco**, **la campera**, **la chamarra**

Take the regional column seriously here. In Mexico and much of Central America *chaqueta* carries a vulgar second sense, and the neutral word is *saco* or *chamarra*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You were shown this one in passing when you learned *el jersey*, in a table of garments named after somewhere. It sat there as the odd row, because it is not named after a place at all.

French **jaquette** is a small **jaque**, a short tunic — and that much is firm. Where *jaque* came from is not. One account takes it to **Jacques**, the stock name for a French peasant, the way English once said *Jack* for any ordinary man. Another takes it through Spanish *jaco* to an Arabic word for a mail jerkin. Both are live; neither is proved.

You already know Spanish will name a garment after its wearer — *los vaqueros* are the cowherd's trousers. If the Jacques account is right, *la chaqueta* is the same habit, which is why it sat in the wrong column of the *jersey* chapter's table:

garment	named after
el jersey	an island
la chaqueta	a man's name, probably

English took both ends of the pair: **jack**, a medieval padded tunic, straight from *jaque*; and **jacket**, from the little one, *jaquette*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- it's cold, take a jacket
- a leather jacket
- the word to use instead in Mexico

Before you move on

The jacket, in Spain? (**La chaqueta**.) And in Mexico? (**El saco** or **la chamarra**.) Who is it probably named after? (**Jacques** — a peasant's name, on the usual account.)

468.2 el grado — the degree

Say **la temperatura**, then the scale: *poco*, *bastante*, *muy*. The word coming next is what that scale is a scale of, and you have never been given it.

You'll want to know: el grado

el grado — the degree.

Estamos a tres **grados**.

Doce grados — twelve degrees. *Bajo cero* — below zero. The everyday frame with a number is **estar a**: *estamos a tres grados*, we are at three degrees. You will also hear *hace tres grados* and *hay tres grados*; *estar a* is the one to produce.

When you learned *la temperatura* you got the quantity without its unit. This is the unit.

Grammar Lens: the word you already had under another job

Poco, *bastante*, *muy* is a scale of **degree**, and *degree* is **grado**. The review that taught that scale carries this word in its own filename and never once put it in front of you. Here it is.

use	what it counts
tres grados	steps up a thermometer
the *poco / bastante / muy* scale	steps up a quality

Latin **gradus** is a **step** — the one you take walking. From there it went to any step in a series: a step on a staircase, a step of rank, a step of temperature. English keeps the walking sense in **gradual**, one step at a time, and in **grade**, **degree** and **graduate**, who has climbed the steps.

So a *grado* is not only a number. It is a position on a set of stairs, and a thermometer is a staircase somebody agreed the height of.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Gradus also gives Spanish **el grado** for a university degree and for a school year, and **la graduación**, which is both the ceremony and the strength of an alcohol — another scale with steps on it.
De buen grado — willingly, gladly — is a different word, from *gratum*, pleasing. Two *grado*s, and only this one has stairs in it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- we're at three degrees
- twelve degrees, then below zero
- what gradus means

Before you move on

The degree? (**El grado**.) How do you say it is three degrees? (**Estamos a tres grados**.) What is a *gradus*? (**A step**.)

468.3 el abrigo — the coat

Say **el frío** and **la chaqueta**. One is the reason for the next word; the other is not warm enough for it.

You'll want to know: el abrigo

el abrigo — the coat, the overcoat.

A tres grados no salgas sin **abrigo**.

Abrigar is the verb: *abrígate*, wrap up warm. And *una manta que abriga mucho* is a blanket that keeps you very warm — the verb is about the warmth, not the wrapping.

A *chaqueta* is a jacket. An *abrigo* is the long one you put on over everything else when it is properly cold.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

This word is not named for its shape. It is named for what it does. Behind *abrigar* is Latin **apricari**, to **bask in the sun**. *Apricus* was the adjective: open to the sun, warm.

Then Spanish did something quietly odd with it. A word for a place the sun gets **into** became a word for a place the weather cannot, and the coat is named for the second one. *El abrigo* is not "a long coat", it is **a shelter** — *un abrigo rocoso* is a hollow in the rock face out of the weather, and *al abrigo de* is **in the shelter of**.

Spanish	**the shelter**
el abrigo	the one you wear
al abrigo de	the one you stand behind

Watch that second one: what follows *de* is what shelters you, not what you are hiding from.

One warning while *apricus* is in front of you: English **apricot** looks like a relative and is not one. That word came through Arabic and Portuguese from Latin *praecoquum*, the early-ripening fruit, and the resemblance to *apricus* is a coincidence people have been reading meaning into for centuries.

So the garment is named for the sunny corner it replaces.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- at three degrees don't go out without a coat
- wrap up warm
- what apricari meant

Before you move on

The coat? (**El abrigo**.) The verb? (**Abrigar**.) What did *apricari* mean? (**To bask in the sun** — the coat is a shelter you wear.)

468.4 la bufanda — the scarf

Say **el abrigo** and **la chaqueta**. One more goes on top of either, and it is the last piece this chapter needs.

You'll want to know: la bufanda

la bufanda — the scarf, the winter one you wind round your neck.

> Ponte la **bufanda**, que estamos a dos grados.

That **que** is not the joining *que* you have. It is the spoken shorthand for *porque* — *put your scarf on, because it's two degrees* — and Spanish leans on it constantly for reasons.

A *bufanda* is the one you put on because it is cold. **Un fular** is the light draped one worn for how it looks; **un pañuelo** is usually a handkerchief and only sometimes a scarf. A *bufanda* can be silk, so the material is not the test — the reason is.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Every other word in this chapter came with a story. This one comes with a shrug, and you have met that shrug before.

La bufanda has no settled origin. The usual suggestion is French **bouffante**, puffed out, on *bouffer*, to puff — which fits a scarf's bulk around the throat. Another line points at Italian *buffa*, a visor or a covering for the face. The dictionaries hedge, and so does this lesson.

El patio is where this book set the rule out: an origin left open is a claim, not an oversight, and saying so is more useful than picking the prettier story. *El andén*, *tirar* and *el gorro* carry the same mark, and *el gorro* is the nearest neighbour — winter headwear whose origin the Academy also marks uncertain.

La bufanda is the fifth. Read the prose rather than the front matter for this: plenty of lessons leave the root list empty and still tell you the whole story. What is unusual here is that there is no story to tell.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- put your scarf on, because it's two degrees
- which scarf is for warmth and which is for looks
- where la bufanda comes from

Before you move on

The scarf? (**La bufanda**.) Where does it come from? (**Nobody has settled it** — French *bouffante* is the usual guess.) Which earlier word said the same? (***El patio***, or *el gorro*.)

468.5 (la chaqueta, el grado, el abrigo, la bufanda) — from cold

Four words, no prompts. What you put on, what you put on over it, what goes round your neck, and the number that decides.

You'll want to know: the four, cold

English	Spanish
the jacket	**la chaqueta**
the degree	**el grado**
the coat	**el abrigo**
the scarf	**la bufanda**

Grammar Lens: a list that was closed, reopened on purpose

The wardrobe chapter called its list covered end to end. It was — for what that exam asked. *Pantalón*, *falda*, *camisa*, *zapato*, *vaqueros*, *jersey*, *bolso*: enough to say what you are wearing.
What it could not do is answer a question about **weather**.

the old list	this chapter
what you are wearing	what the cold makes you wear

That is the difference between the two exams. The first asks you to describe; the second asks you to decide, and deciding needs a number. *Hace frío* was never going to be enough once somebody writes *estamos a dos grados* on a screen at a bus stop.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two of the four have a settled origin, a third has a guess, and the fourth refuses.

word	underneath
el grado	*gradus*, a **step** — a thermometer is a staircase
el abrigo	*apricari*, to **bask in the sun** — a shelter you wear
la chaqueta	*Jacques*, a peasant's name — probably

La bufanda has no agreed origin at all, and its lesson says so rather than covering over, the way *el patio* and *el gorro* did before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- it's two degrees, put a coat and a scarf on
- which of the four has no known origin
- what a gradus is

Before you move on

The jacket? (**La chaqueta**.) The degree? (**El grado**.) The coat? (**El abrigo**.) The scarf? (**La bufanda**.)

468.6 (el aviso de la parada) — read it, then decide

Say **el grado** and **el abrigo**. The first decides the second, which is the whole task here.

Read this

On the screen at the bus stop:

07:40 — LÍNEA 12 — 6 min

Ahora: **2 grados**. Máxima hoy: 7 grados.

(La máxima is the day's high.)

And a message on your phone:

> Hace mucho frío. Ponte el **abrigo**, no la **chaqueta**. Y llévate la **bufanda**, que estuviste enfermo la semana pasada.

Grammar Lens: what the message is doing that the screen cannot

The screen gives a number. The message gives a decision, and the two are not the same kind of statement.

the screen	the message
2 grados	*ponte el abrigo, no la chaqueta*

Note **no la chaqueta**. With the chosen thing said first, Spanish needs only *no* and the thing ruled out. Turn it round and you are back in the shape *sino* gave you — *no la chaqueta, sino el abrigo.* Same correction, two orders.

And *que estuviste enfermo* gives the reason, with the spoken **que** that stands in for *porque*, which *la bufanda* introduced two lessons ago. A screen rarely explains itself; a person usually does.

Your turn

Say what the temperature is now and what it will reach.

Now answer the message: say what you are putting on and what you are leaving behind, using *no* the way the message does.

Before you move on

How cold is it? (**Estamos a dos grados**.) What goes on? (**El abrigo** and **la bufanda**.) What stays behind? (**La chaqueta**.)

Chapter 469

La impresora de la sala 2

Modes: **voice** (5) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** first 5 of 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can deal with a workplace machine that is not working: read a notice saying a printer is out of service, say what I want to print and what I cannot connect, and offer to make or return a phone call.
>
> *Read a notice taped to a printer and a message from a colleague, then say what you will do.*

469.1 imprimir — to print

> Say **el impreso** and **la prisa**. The first is this verb's participle and the second is its distant cousin.

You'll want to know: imprimir

imprimir — to print.

> Voy a **imprimir** el documento.

Imprimir a doble cara — to print on both sides, where *cara* is the face of the sheet: the same word you learned for a face, lent to paper.

You already have the participle. When you learned **el impreso**, it was given to you as *the irregular past participle of imprimir* — so the verb has been named in this book once, without ever being yours to use. Now it is.

Grammar Lens: the participle you already hold

Most Spanish verbs build a participle by rule. This one does not, and you have had the exception longer than the verb.
The irregular participles gave you *hecho*, *dicho*, *visto* and *puesto*; *cubierto* and *roto* joined the list later. **Impreso** belongs on it too.

verb	**participle**
imprimir	**impreso**
escribir	escrito

He impreso el documento — I have printed the document. You will also meet *imprimido*, which the Academy allows, but *impreso* is what a notice prints and what a printer's menu says.
And *el impreso* as a **noun** — a form to fill in — is that same participle hardened, which is the move *el pedido* taught you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **imprimere**: **in-**, into, plus **premere**, to **press**. To print is to **press something into** a surface, which is exactly what a press does and exactly what the word has always meant.
Premere is the root under *la prisa* — a hurry is a pressing. Follow it outward and English fills up: **press**, **pressure**, **print**, **imprint**, **express** (pressed out), **compress**, **impression** — a mark pressed in, whether into wax or into a person.
So a printer does not "produce" a page. Historically it **presses** one, and the word kept the machine in it long after the machine changed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I am going to print the document
- I have printed the document
- what premere means

Before you move on

To print? (**Imprimir**.) Its participle? (**Impreso**.) What does *premere* mean? (**To press**.)

469.2 la impresora — the printer

Say **la lavadora** and **el impreso**. One lends the ending, the other lends the stem, and together they make the machine.

You'll want to know: la impresora

la impresora — the printer.

La **impresora** de la sala 2 está fuera de servicio.

Una impresora en color — a colour printer.

You could have reached this word before being told, which is what la lavadora promised: a machine is often its verb plus **-dora**.

Grammar Lens: the article says which one you mean

El contador settled one thing already: the ending does not decide the article, since *la lavadora* is feminine and *el contador* masculine off the same **-dor**. Treat that as known.

What this word adds is a case where the article is not merely a fact to memorise but is **carrying the meaning**. *Lavar* has no human washer in ordinary speech, so **-dora** was free to mean the machine and nothing else. *Imprimir* is not like that. Printing was a trade long before it was a box on a desk, and the stem kept both.

Spanish	what it is
el impresor	the person who prints
la impresora	the machine that prints

Say *el impresor* about the box and you have promoted it to a tradesman. With *contador* and *lavadora* the article was something to learn; here it is something to choose.

English will not help you: it calls both of them a **printer** and leaves the sentence to sort it out. Spanish has decided in advance, in one letter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Same *imprimere* as the verb: *in-* plus *premere*, to press into.

Why feminine rather than masculine? *El contador* told you the ending does not decide; this is the mechanism underneath. *Impresora* started life as an adjective leaning on a noun — *la máquina impresora*, the

printing machine. The noun dropped away and left its gender behind. So the article you cannot predict from the ending was fixed by a word that is no longer said.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the printer in room 2 is out of service
- which one is the person and which is the machine
- the verb this machine was built from

Before you move on

The printer? (**La impresora**.) Why feminine? (**Because *la máquina* is** — the noun fell away and left its gender.) And the person? (**El impresor**.)

469.3 conectar — to connect

Say **el ordenador**, then **imprimir**. Nothing gets printed until one more verb has happened.

You'll want to know: conectar

conectar — to connect, to join one thing to another.

No puedo **conectar** la impresora al ordenador.

The noun is **la conexión**, and it is worth a second look: the verb has a **c**, the noun has an **x**. Say *co-ne-XIÓN*, weight on the last syllable.

Grammar Lens: conectar and conectarse

The same verb does two different jobs depending on whether the thing being joined is an object out in front of you or yourself.

what you mean	what you say
join a thing to something	**conectar** la impresora
get yourself online	**conectarse** a internet

So *no me puedo conectar* means *I can't get connected* — you, not the printer. The pronoun is doing the whole of that work, and dropping it turns the sentence into a report about some object you never named.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The Academy's dictionary derives **conectar** from English **to connect** — and English had built that out of Latin **conectere**: **con-**, together, plus **nectere**, to **tie**.
So the Latin is real, and the route is not the one it looks like. The word did not sit in Spanish since Rome waiting for wires. It came in from English in the modern era, carrying Latin parts back to a Latin language.
You have now met that happening three ways in a row:

- **el ordenador** — an old Spanish word that borrowed a new *meaning* from French;
- **internet** — an English word borrowed whole, with only the beat changed;
- **conectar** — an English word borrowed as a shape, its pieces Latin all along.

Nectere is a knot-word. English keeps it in **nexus**, a tying-together, and in **annex**, tied on. A *nexus* is not a vague link — it is the place where the threads are actually knotted.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I can't connect the printer to the computer
- I can't get connected
- what nectere means

Before you move on

To connect? (**Conectar**.) The noun? (**La conexión** — with an x.) What does *nectere* mean? (**To tie**.)

469.4 la llamada — the call

Say **el pedido** and **conectar**. One is a thing made from a verb; the other is what you do before the thing will work.

What to know first

- el pedido — the lesson whose table already showed you today's word.
- perder — you will want its participle in a moment.

You'll want to know: la llamada

la llamada — the call.

You have seen this word once, in the middle of somebody else's lesson. *El pedido* listed it as an example of a participle hardened into a noun, and then moved on. Here it is as yours.

Voy a hacer una **llamada**.

Devolver la llamada — to return the call. *Una llamada perdida* — a missed call, the notice your phone leaves you.

Grammar Lens: the vowel is a rule, the gender is not

Which vowel the participle takes is decided for you, and the participle lesson gave you that rule.

the verb ends	the participle takes
-ar	-ado, -ada
-er, **-ir**	-ido, -ida

Llamar is an *-ar* verb, so *-ada*. *Pedir* is an *-ir* verb, so *-ido*. That much you can work out.

What you cannot work out is the **article**. *El pedido* is masculine. *La llamada* and *la entrada* are feminine. Nothing in *pedir*, *llamar* or *entrar* predicts which way each one went — the gender was settled by

whatever noun the participle used to lean on, and that noun is long gone.
So learn the article with the word, the way you learned *el impreso* and *la impresora*. Working out the ending is free; the gender is not.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Llamada is *llamar* made into a thing, and *llamar* you have had since the very beginning — the lesson where you learned to say your name traced it to Latin **clamare**, to cry out, and showed you the *cl-* that became *ll-*.
What is worth adding is how literal the noun still is. A *llamada* is a **crying-out**, and Spanish has not forgotten it: *una llamada de atención* is a warning — a call for attention, not a phone call at all. The telephone borrowed a word that was already doing the job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I am going to make a call
- I have to return the call
- a missed call

Before you move on

The call? (**La llamada**.) From which verb? (**Llamar**.) Why *-ada* and not *-ida*? (**Because *llamar* is an -ar verb**.)

469.5 (imprimir, la impresora, conectar, la llamada) — from cold

Four words, no prompts. What the machine does, what the machine is, what you do to the machine first, and what you make when it will not work.

You'll want to know: the four, cold

English	Spanish
to print	**imprimir**
the printer	**la impresora**
to connect	**conectar**
the call	**la llamada**

Grammar Lens: two of these you could have guessed

Two of the four were reachable before you were told, and for the same reason: you already held the verb and the ending.

built from	gives you
imprimir + **-dora**	la impresora
llamar + **-ada**	la llamada

La lavadora taught the first ending and *el pedido* the second, and *el contador* already warned you that the ending settles nothing about the article. What this chapter added is a case where the article is not only unpredictable but **meaningful**: *la impresora* is the machine, *el impresor* is the person, and the one letter is the whole difference.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

This chapter put three different routes side by side, and the words look alike on the page whichever route they took.

word	how it got here
imprimir	inherited — Latin *imprimere*, all the way down
conectar	borrowed from English, its parts Latin
la llamada	inherited — Latin *clamare*, through *llamar*

Conectar is the odd one. It is the only word here whose Latin arrived by way of English, which is why it looks as native as the other three and is not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I can't connect the printer, I am going to make a call
- which of the four came in through English
- the machine and the person, in that order

Before you move on

To print? (**Imprimir**.) The printer? (**La impresora**.) To connect? (**Conectar**.) The call? (**La llamada**.)

469.6 (el aviso de la impresora) — read it, then say what you will do

Say **la impresora** and **imprimir**. The notice below is about the first and stops you doing the second.

Read this

Taped to the machine:

> **AVISO**
>
> La **impresora** de la sala 2 está **fuera de servicio**.
>
> La de la tercera planta **funciona**.

And a message from a colleague:

> No me puedo **conectar** a internet desde mi ordenador. ¿Puedes **imprimir** tú el documento? Si no, te **devuelvo** la **llamada** en diez minutos.

Grammar Lens: what each text asks of you

The notice reports a state. The message asks for something and offers a way out if the answer is no. They want different replies.

the notice	the message
está fuera de servicio	*¿puedes imprimir tú el documento?*

Two details in the message repay a second look.

La de la tercera planta. The notice drops *impresora* and leaves *la* standing for it. Spanish does this freely once the noun is on the table, and a notice will do it to save a line.
¿Puedes imprimir tú? The *tú* is not needed for the grammar — the verb already says who. It is there to point: *you*, rather than me, because I cannot. A pronoun that could be dropped and is not is doing work.

Your turn

Say which printer is broken and which one works, using *la* on its own for the second the way the notice does.

Now answer the message: say you will print the document, and say why your colleague could not — the connection, not the machine.

Before you move on

What is wrong with the machine? (**Está fuera de servicio**.) What is wrong for your colleague? (**No se puede conectar**.) What will you do? (**Imprimir el documento**.)

Chapter 470

Un paraguas azul

Modes: **voice** (5) **eyes** (1) **Hands-free start:** none of the 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can deal with something I have lost: read a message describing a mislaid object by colour and by the part you hold, say that I cannot find it anywhere, and ask to be told rather than ask anyone to go looking.
>
> *Read a message to the building group about a mislaid umbrella, then answer it both ways.*

470.1 el paraguas — the umbrella

> Say **la parada** and **el cumpleaños**. One lends this word its first half, the other lends it its shape.

You'll want to know: el paraguas

el paraguas — the umbrella.

> Me he dejado el **paraguas** en el ascensor.

Look at it before you are told anything: **para** plus **aguas**. A verb and a plural noun fused into one word, which is the move *el cumpleaños* taught you — *cumple* plus *años*, a sentence that hardened.

And like *cumpleaños*, it wears a plural **-s** and is singular: **el** paraguas, one umbrella.

Grammar Lens: the plural that does not move

So what is the plural? Nothing changes.

one	more than one
el paraguas	**los** paraguas

This is not a quirk of this word. El análisis gave you the rule: a word already ending in **s**, with its stress somewhere other than the last syllable, takes no plural ending. *El lunes / los lunes* works the same way.

The article is doing all the counting. Drop it and the sentence cannot tell you how many umbrellas there are.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **para-** is the one *la parada* already unpacked: Latin **parare**, to **make ready** — and *parada* reminded you it is not the Greek *para-* of *parallel*. A **parasol** is made ready against the sun, a **parachute** against a fall. A **paraguas** is made ready against the waters.

Which is worth a second look, because English named the same object from the opposite direction:

language	what the word notices
Spanish **paraguas**	the **water** it keeps off
English **umbrella**	the **shade** it makes

Umbrella is Latin *umbra*, a shadow, with a diminutive on it — a little shade, and English took it from Italian. So one language named the object for the shade it casts and the other for the water it turns away, and both are describing the same thing held over the same head.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I have left the umbrella in the lift
- the plural of *el paraguas*
- what *parare* means

Before you move on

The umbrella? (**El paraguas**.) And two of them? (**Los paraguas** — the word does not change.) What is it made ready against? (**The waters**.)

470.2 el mango — the handle

Say **la mano** and **el paraguas**. This word is a relative of the first and a part of the second.

You'll want to know: el mango

el mango — the handle.

Un paraguas azul, con el **mango** de madera.

The handle of a knife, a pan, a door, an umbrella: whatever part of a thing is built for the hand.

Which is what the word says. It is a cousin of **la mano**, and once you hear that, you will not need to store it separately.

Grammar Lens: two mangos, and only one of them grows

There is a second **mango** in Spanish, and it is a completely different word that happens to be spelled the same. This is the situation la cola prepared you for.

the word	where it comes from
el mango — handle	Latin *manus*, the hand
el mango — the fruit	Portuguese *manga*, from Malay

The Academy traces the fruit through Portuguese **manga** to Malay *mangga*; behind that stands a Dravidian word, Tamil *māṅkāy*. It travelled by ship and the handle did not. Nothing connects them but the spelling.

Context settles it every time, so this is not a hazard — it is a reminder that *same letters* and *same word* are different claims.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **manus**, the hand — the root la mano already gave you, along with *manual*, *manufacture* and *maintain*.
A **mango** is the hand-part. Spanish built it on a late Latin form of that root and let the meaning settle on the graspable end of a thing. English does not have this word, so it has nothing to lend you here. What it does have is *manual*, *manuscript*, *manacle* — all of them hands. Put *mango* beside them and it stops looking like a fruit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a blue umbrella with a wooden handle
- the two mangos, and where each comes from
- which Latin word is behind the handle

Before you move on

The handle? (**El mango**.) Which body part is inside it? (**La mano** — Latin *manus*.) And the fruit? (**A different word entirely.**)

470.3 encontrar — to find

> Say **buscar**. You have had the looking for a long time. Say **el mango**. You still have no word for the moment the looking succeeds.

You'll want to know: encontrar

encontrar — to find.

> No lo **encuentro** por ninguna parte.

Buscar and *encontrar* are the two halves of one search, and Spanish keeps them strictly apart:

what you do	what happens
buscar — look for	the effort
encontrar — find	the result

Busco mi paraguas is work in progress. *He encontrado mi paraguas* is over. You can *buscar* all afternoon and never *encontrar*.

Grammar Lens: the o that breaks

You wrote *encuentro* above, not *encontro*. That is mostrar's rule arriving again, unchanged: push the stress back onto the stem and the **o** breaks into **ue**.

stress on the stem	**stress on the ending**
enc**ue**ntro, enc**ue**ntras	encontr**a**mos
enc**ue**ntra, enc**ue**ntran	encontr**á**is

The infinitive keeps its **o** because the stress is on the ending there — *encon-TRAR*. Nothing about the verb is irregular once you know where the weight falls.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en- plus **contra**: to come up **against** something.
That is the whole picture, and it is more honest than the English word. *Find* says nothing about how. *Encontrar* says you went along and the thing was in your way.
English has the same word by a different road: **encounter**, borrowed from French, is *in* plus *contra* exactly. To encounter somebody is to come against them — which is why an encounter can be a meeting or a fight, and *un encuentro* in Spanish is both as well.
So *encontrarse con alguien* is to run into somebody. The *contra* has not gone anywhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- I can't find it anywhere
- I am looking for it, and I have not found it
- what *contra* is doing inside the word

Before you move on

To find? (**Encontrar**.) I find? (**Encuentro** — the stress moved onto the stem.) What is *contra* doing there? (**The thing came up against you**.)

470.4 avisar — to let know

Say **el aviso**. Say **encontrar**. If somebody finds the thing, this is what you want them to do next.

You'll want to know: avisar

avisar — to let know, to notify.

Si lo habéis visto, **avisadme**, por favor.

You have met this verb once already without being given it. El aviso named it in passing — *"behind it is the verb avisar, to notify"* — and then went back to the noun. Here it is as yours.

Avísame — let me know. *Avisar a alguien* — to tell somebody. *Avisar de algo* — to give notice of something.

Grammar Lens: it shows, it does not order

El aviso made a point that the verb inherits whole: an *aviso* is not an instruction but a **making-visible**. Somebody puts a thing where you can see it, and what you do next is yours.
So *avisar* is the weakest of the telling verbs, and that is its use.

you want	you say
somebody to know, no more	**avisar**
somebody to do it	*decir* that they must

Avísame si lo encuentras asks for information and nothing else. It is what you say about a paraguas you left behind: you are not giving an order to a neighbour, you are asking to be shown something.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

El aviso already traced this: Latin **ad vīsum**, toward what has been seen, on **vidēre**, to see. There is nothing to add to the derivation, so

take instead the thing it predicts.
Every relative of *avisar* is about **seeing**, not speaking:

- English **advise** is the same formation — to put something in somebody's view;
- **advice** is what you were shown;
- **evident**, **vision**, **provide**, **survey** are all seeings.

A word for telling, built entirely out of sight. That is why *avisar* feels lighter than it looks: nobody in it is talking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- let me know if you find it
- I left it in the lift; tell me if you have seen it
- which Latin verb is underneath

Before you move on

To let know? (**Avisar**.) Let me know? (**Avísame**.) Is it an order? (**No — it makes something visible**.)

470.5 (el paraguas, el mango, encontrar, avisar) — from cold

Four words, no prompts. The thing you left behind, the part of it you would describe, what you cannot do, and what you want the finder to do.

You'll want to know: the four, cold

English	Spanish
the umbrella	**el paraguas**
the handle	**el mango**
to find	**encontrar**
to let know	**avisar**

Grammar Lens: one English verb, two Spanish ones

English says *look for it and tell me*. Spanish makes you choose twice, and the choices are not the ones you would guess.

the English	what Spanish splits it into
look / find	*buscar* is the effort, **encontrar** the result
tell	**avisar** shows; *decir* says

Avísame si lo encuentras holds both splits in five words: let me know — not order me, not explain to me — if the search actually lands. That sentence is the whole chapter, and you could not have built it a lesson ago.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Three of the four are older than they look, and each keeps a picture inside.

word	the picture
el paraguas	made **ready** against the waters
el mango	the part built for the **hand**
encontrar	to come up **against** a thing

Avisar is the fourth, and its picture is **seeing** rather than telling — which is what made it the gentle verb in the lens above.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a blue umbrella with a wooden handle
- I can't find it anywhere, let me know if you see it

- which of the four is about seeing

Before you move on

The umbrella? (**El paraguas**.) The handle? (**El mango**.) To find? (**Encontrar**.) To let know? (**Avisar**.)

470.6 (el mensaje del vecino) — read it, then answer

Say **el paraguas** and **avisar**. One is lost and the other is what the message is asking for.

Read this

To the building group, this morning:

> Hola, ¿sois vosotros los del piso doce? Me he dejado un **paraguas** azul, con el **mango** de madera, en el ascensor esta mañana y ya no lo **encuentro** por ninguna parte. Si lo habéis visto, **avisadme**, por favor.

Two things to notice before you answer.
Azul, de madera. The colour is the umbrella's and the wood is the handle's. Spanish hangs each description on the noun it belongs to, and *de madera* is how you say what a thing is made of.
Por ninguna parte. The stacking is no … nada's rule, unchanged: *no* in front of the verb and the negative word after it, both required. What is new is only the phrase. *Ninguna parte* joins *nada*, *nadie* and *nunca* as a negative word, and it is two words rather than one.
The trap is the English. *No lo encuentro por ninguna parte* comes out as *I can't find it* ***anywhere***, which looks positive — so the pull is to reach for *en cualquier parte*. Spanish keeps the negative on both halves.

Grammar Lens: what the message is actually asking

Read the last sentence again. It does not ask anyone to look.

what it says	what it does not say
si lo habéis visto	*buscadlo*

The writer is asking to be told about something that may already have

happened, not asking the building to start a search. That is *avisar* doing exactly the work it was built for, and it is the polite shape of this kind of message: you ask for information, not labour.
Answer in the same register.

Your turn

Say what was lost, where, and what it looks like — colour and handle both.

Now answer the message twice. First: you have seen it, and you say where. Then: you have not, and you offer to let them know if it turns up.

Before you move on

What is lost? (**Un paraguas azul con el mango de madera**.) What can the writer not do? (**Encontrarlo**.) What are they asking for? (**Que les avisen** — to be told.)

Chapter 471

El curso de cocina

Modes: **voice** (8) **Hands-free start:** all 8 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can follow somebody explaining that a class did not suit them: hear that the level was too high, that they kept losing the thread, and that they moved to a beginners' group, and say the same about something of my own without criticising anyone.
>
> *Follow two friends on a cooking class that was too advanced, then say the same about something of your own.*

471.1 demasiado — too much

> Say **bastante** and **poco**. You have a scale with a bottom and a middle. Today it gets its top.

You'll want to know: demasiado

demasiado — too much, too many, too.

> El curso era **demasiado** difícil para mí.

Before an adjective it does not change: *demasiado difícil*, *demasiado avanzada*. Before a noun it agrees like any adjective: *demasiada gente*, *demasiados libros*.

Grammar Lens: the word that says it went past the point

Bastante built you a scale of degree. This is the member above the top of it, and the step matters.

the word	**where on the scale**
poco	below what is wanted
bastante	enough — the point itself
demasiado	past the point

Muy difícil is a judgement about the thing. **Demasiado difícil** is a judgement about a **fit**: too hard *for something*, usually for you. That is why it so often arrives with *para* — *demasiado avanzado para mí*. English blurs this, because *too* and *very* sit close together in speech. Spanish does not: say *muy* when you mean intense, and *demasiado* when you mean it has gone past what works.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Underneath is **de más** — *of more*, in excess — which became *demasía*, an excess, and then this adjective. The *más* in it is the *más* you already use, from Latin **magis**, more.
So the word is built out of an admission: there is **more** here than the situation has room for. Not more than exists, more than **fits**.
Keep that and the grammar follows. *Demasiado* always implies a measure it has overrun, even when nobody says what the measure was.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- it was too difficult for me
- the difference between *muy difícil* and *demasiado difícil*
- too many books, with the agreement

Before you move on

Too much? (**Demasiado**.) Which taught word is inside it? (***Más***.) Does it mean *very*? (**No — past the point that fits**.)

471.2 el nivel — the level

Say **el curso** and **demasiado**. A class has one of these, and when it is wrong the second word is how you say so.

You'll want to know: el nivel

el nivel — the level.

El **nivel** era demasiado alto para ella.

Nivel is what a class, a language exam or a game has. *¿Qué nivel tienes?* is the ordinary way to ask how far along somebody is. Note the stress: *ni-VEL*, on the end, and the plural is **los niveles**.

It is also a level in the physical sense — a floor of a building, the surface of water, the tool a builder uses.

Grammar Lens: the phrase the question will use

Two ways of saying the same complaint, and you need to recognise both.

about the class	about its level
el curso era **demasiado avanzado**	el **nivel** era **demasiado alto**

A speaker will usually say the first. Somebody reporting it afterwards — a summary, a question, an exam option — will often reach for the second, because *nivel* lets you talk about the difficulty without naming the class again.

Alto and *bajo* are what *nivel* takes, not *grande* or *mucho*. A level is a **height**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

El litro already told you about Latin **libra**, the balance — hiding in *lb*, in **Libra** the scales in the sky, in **deliberate** and **equilibrium**.

Nivel is the same word, made small. Latin **libella** is a *little libra*, a builder's level: a tiny balance that tells you when a surface is true. It reached Spanish through French, and on the way the first **l** turned into an **n** — *livel* became *nivel* — because two *l* sounds so close together pull apart.

English took *libella* too, without that swap, and got **level**.

So *nivel* and *litro* are cousins, and a level is not a measure of height so much as an instrument for finding **balance**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the level was too high for her
- ask somebody what level they have
- which taught word *nivel* is a cousin of

Before you move on

The level? (**El nivel**.) Plural? (**Los niveles**.) What Latin word is underneath? (***Libra***, the balance — *libella*, a little one.)

471.3 avanzado — advanced

Say **el curso** and **antes**. The second is hiding inside today's word, and you would not guess it from the outside.

You'll want to know: avanzado

avanzado — advanced.

El curso de los lunes era demasiado **avanzado** para mí.

Un nivel avanzado, *un grupo avanzado*: it describes the class, not the person. For the person you say *tiene un nivel avanzado*.

It agrees like any adjective — *avanzada*, *avanzados*, *avanzadas*.

Grammar Lens: a participle doing an adjective's work

Avanzado is the past participle of *avanzar*, to advance, standing in as an adjective. Spanish does this constantly, and you have seen it before:

the participle	what it describes
invitado	the one who was invited
avanzado	the one that has moved ahead

El invitado made the point first — Spanish names a person by what was done to them. Here the same move names a **course** by how far it has got.
So a *curso avanzado* is not a course that is difficult in itself. It is one that has already travelled, and expects you to have travelled with it. That distinction is the whole reason the woman in the recording changed groups.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Avanzar is Latin **ab ante** — *from in front* — which became *abantiare* and then the Spanish verb. The *ante* in it is the same *ante* you already hold in **antes**.
To advance is to put yourself **in front**. Not faster; further along.
One thing worth knowing about the English. **Advance** has a **d** that does not belong to it: the word arrived as *avancer*, and English later added the *d* on the mistaken assumption that the *av-* was a worn-down Latin *ad-*. It was not. Spanish never made that mistake, which is why *avanzar* has no *d* and never did.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the Monday course was too advanced for me
- which taught word is hiding inside *avanzar*
- why English *advance* has a d and Spanish has none

Before you move on

Advanced? (**Avanzado**.) What is it the participle of? (**Avanzar**.) What two Latin words are inside it? (***Ab ante*** — from in front.)

471.4 el principiante — the beginner

Say **el principio**. Say **el estudiante**. One gives today's word its meaning and the other gives it its ending — try it before reading on.

You'll want to know: el principiante

el principiante — the beginner.

> Ahora voy con los **principiantes** y disfruto mucho más.

La principiante for a woman. It is the natural opposite of what you learned a moment ago:

the class	**the person in it**
un curso **avanzado**	un **principiante**

Grammar Lens: you could have built this one

El estudiante gave you the rule outright: **verb plus -ante names the person doing it.** *Estudiar*, cut the *-ar*, add *-ante*.
Here it is again, one step further back. From **el principio**, the beginning, Spanish makes the verb **principiar**, to begin. Take that, cut the *-ar*, add *-ante*:

> princip**iar** → princip**iante**

The one who is beginning. The ending has not changed its job since chapter nine; the only new thing is the verb it is sitting on.
English wore the same ending down to *-ant*, which is why *participant*, *assistant* and *inhabitant* all name the doer too.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

El principio already traced this for you: Latin **principium**, from **princeps**, the one who takes first place — the same first-taking inside English **prince**, **principal** and **principle**.
So a *principiante* is not somebody who is bad at the thing. The word says only that they are at the **start** of it. Spanish has kept that neutral, and so should you when you use it about yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- now I go with the beginners
- build the word from *principiar* out loud

- the opposite of *un curso avanzado*

Before you move on

The beginner? (**El principiante**.) What does *-ante* add? (**The one who does it**.) Does the word say they are bad at it? (**No — only that they are at the start**.)

471.5 sencillo — simple

Say **difícil**. Say **el principiante**. Today's word is what a beginner's class is full of, and it is not the opposite of the first one.

You'll want to know: sencillo

sencillo — simple, plain, straightforward.

Hacemos cosas **sencillas**, pero las hacemos bien.

Una comida sencilla — a plain meal. *Un billete sencillo* — a one-way ticket, where the word means *single* rather than *easy*.

Grammar Lens: sencillo is not fácil

English lets *simple* and *easy* stand in for each other. Spanish keeps them apart, and the line runs between **parts** and **effort**.

the word	**what it measures**
sencillo	how few parts it has
fácil	how little effort it costs

A dish with three ingredients is *sencillo*. A dish you can cook half asleep is *fácil*. They often overlap and they are not the same claim — climbing a staircase is *sencillo* and not remotely *fácil*.
So *hacemos cosas sencillas, pero las hacemos bien* is not modest about the effort. It says the things have few parts, and then insists the execution is good. Hear it as *easy* and you lose the point the speaker is making.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **singulus**, one at a time, single — through a late form *singellus*. English took the same root for **single**, **singular** and **singly**.
That is why *un billete sencillo* means a **single**: the word's oldest sense is *one*, not *easy*. Something *sencillo* is made of one thing, or nearly.
The *-illo* on the end is not doing what it usually does. Elsewhere it makes things small — but here it was already fused into the Latin, and there is no word *senci* underneath for it to shrink.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- we do simple things, but we do them well
- the difference between *sencillo* and *fácil*
- what *un billete sencillo* is

Before you move on

Simple? (**Sencillo**.) Does it mean easy? (**No — few parts, not little effort**.) What Latin word is underneath? (***Singulus*** — one at a time.)

471.6 perderse — to get lost

Say **perder**. Say **equivocarse**. You have had both, and the second one already told you what happens when you put *-se* on the first.

You'll want to know: perderse

perderse — to get lost.

Todos habían hecho cursos antes y yo **me perdía**.

Note what is lost there. Not the way — the **thread**. In a class, in a film, in a conversation, *me pierdo* is *I lose track*, and it is the most useful sense the verb has for you.

Me he perdido — I've got lost, or I've lost the thread. *No te pierdas* — don't get lost, and also don't miss it.

Grammar Lens: the family you were told to notice

Equivocarse named this verb explicitly, in a group worth recalling whole:

plain	**reflexive**
perder — to lose a thing	**perderse** — to get lost
olvidar — to forget a thing	olvidarse — it slips your mind

The reflexive marks something that **befalls you** rather than something you do to an object. *Perder el paraguas* is an act with a victim. *Perderse* has no object at all: the losing happens to you. That is why *me perdía* is not an admission of carelessness. It reports a state she was in, which is exactly why it is the honest thing to say about a class that had moved on without her.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **perdere**: **per-** plus **dare**, to give — to give **away** thoroughly, to hand something over for good.
That *per-* is the thorough one, the same intensifier inside **perfect** (thoroughly made) and **perturb**. So losing, in Latin, is a kind of extreme giving: the thing goes and does not come back.
English **perdition** is the same word, kept for the most complete loss there is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- everyone had done courses before and I kept losing the thread
- the difference between *perder* and *perderse*
- what *per-* adds to *dare*

Before you move on

To get lost? (**Perderse**.) In a class, what do you lose? (**The thread**.) Why the *-se*? (**It happens to you, not to an object**.)

471.7 (demasiado, el nivel, avanzado, el principiante, sencillo, perderse) — from cold

Six words, no prompts. How far past the point it was, what it was too high a one of, what the hard class was, who is in the other one, what they cook there, and what kept happening to you in the first.

You'll want to know: the six, cold

English	Spanish
too much	**demasiado**
the level	**el nivel**
advanced	**avanzado**
the beginner	**el principiante**
simple	**sencillo**
to get lost	**perderse**

Grammar Lens: three endings, all of them already yours

Not one ending in this chapter is new. Each was taught somewhere else and is here doing its ordinary job.

the ending	what it does
-ado	a participle used as an adjective
-ante	the one who does it
-se	it happens to you

El invitado gave the first, *el estudiante* the second, *equivocarse* the third. So three of these six words were readable before you were told, and the chapter's real work was elsewhere: knowing which **sense** each carries, and filling two holes the scale had left.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Four of the six hide a word you already hold.

word	underneath
demasiado	*de más* — the **más** you know
avanzado	*ab ante* — the **antes** you know
principiante	*principium* — the **principio** you know

And **el nivel** is Latin *libella*, a little *libra* — so it is a cousin of **el litro**, which carried that balance for you already.
Sencillo is Latin *singulus*, one at a time — English **single**. And *perderse* is *per-* plus *dare*, to give away thoroughly, which English kept in **perdition**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the Monday class was too advanced and I kept losing the thread
- now I go with the beginners and we do simple things
- which of the six means few parts rather than little effort

Before you move on

Too much? (**Demasiado**.) The level? (**El nivel**.) Advanced? (**Avanzado**.) The beginner? (**El principiante**.) Simple? (**Sencillo**.) To get lost? (**Perderse**.)

471.8 (el curso de cocina) — follow it, then say your own

Say **avanzado** and **perderse**. The first explains the second in everything below.

Read this

— ¿Qué tal el curso de cocina? ¿Sigues yendo? — Sí, pero he cambiado de grupo. El de los lunes era demasiado **avanzado** para mí; todos habían hecho cursos antes y yo me **perdía**. — ¿Y ahora? — Ahora voy los miércoles con

los **principiantes** y disfruto mucho más. Hacemos cosas **sencillas**, pero las hacemos bien.

El de los lunes. The noun *grupo* is dropped and *el* carries it — the same move the printer notice made with *la de la tercera planta*.

Grammar Lens: she never says the class was bad

Every word of the complaint is about **fit**, not quality.

what she says	what she does not say
demasiado avanzado para mí	that the class was bad
yo me perdía	that the teacher was bad

Para mí puts the mismatch between the class and her; *me perdía* reports a state rather than blaming anyone; and *sencillas, pero las hacemos bien* refuses the obvious conclusion.
Now read it the way somebody else would report it:

El **nivel** era **demasiado alto** para ella.

Not a word of that is in what she said, and it is what she meant. She talks about the **class**; a summary talks about its **nivel**. Move between the two, because the person asking what happened will use the second. Spanish gives you a way to leave something that is not working without criticising it, and an exam will ask you to hear the difference between *it did not suit me* and *it was no good*.

Your turn

Say why she changed groups, using *para mí* the way she does.

Now say it about something of your own — a class, a book, a game. Name what was too advanced, say you lost the thread, and say what you do now instead. Keep the blame out of it.

Before you move on

Why did she change? (**Era demasiado avanzado para ella**.) What happened to her in class? (**Se perdía**.) Who is she with now? (**Los principiantes**.) Are the new dishes worse? (**No — sencillas, pero bien hechas**.)

Chapter 472

La biblioteca que presta cosas

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (7) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 7 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can read a report about a service that changed: follow that the idea arose from a survey of its users, that the place is no longer only for reading, and that other places have copied it rather than the other way round.
>
> *Read a report about a library that lends objects, then say where the idea came from and who copied whom.*

472.1 el usuario — the user

> Say **usar** and **la biblioteca**. Today's word is what the second calls the people who do the first.

You'll want to know: el usuario

el usuario — the user.

> Preguntaron a los **usuarios** qué necesitaban.

La usuaria for a woman. This is the word a library, a transport system or a health service uses for the people it serves, and you will meet it on notices far more often than in speech.

Grammar Lens: the word a service reaches for

Spanish picks a different noun depending on what the relationship is, and the choice tells you what kind of place you are in.

the place	what it calls you
a shop	*el cliente* — you pay
a service	**el usuario** — you use

A *biblioteca* has *usuarios*, not *clientes*, because nothing is being sold. A *cliente* implies a transaction; a *usuario* implies **access**.
So when a notice addresses *los usuarios*, it is telling you something beyond the word: this is a thing you are entitled to use, and the notice expects you to behave accordingly.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

usar plus **-ario**, an ending that names the person connected with the thing. Latin **usus**, a use, from **uti**, to use.
The same *usus* is inside English **use**, **usual** — what is used — and **utensil**, a thing for using. And *-ario* is the ending in *el bibliotecario*, the librarian, and *el funcionario*, the official.
So *usuario* is transparent once you see it: **the one who uses**. You could have built it from *usar* the way you built *principiante* from *principio*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- they asked the users what they needed
- why a library has *usuarios* and a shop has *clientes*
- the verb this word was built from

Before you move on

The user? (**El usuario**.) Built from? (**Usar**.) Would a shop use it? (**No — a shop has clientes**.)

472.2 la encuesta — the survey

Say **preguntar** and **el usuario**. Do both at once, to a hundred people, and you have today's word.

You'll want to know: la encuesta

la encuesta — the survey, the poll.

> Hicieron una **encuesta** entre los usuarios.

Hacer una encuesta is the verb it goes with — you **make** a survey, not *do* one. *Según la encuesta* — according to the survey.

Grammar Lens: asking one person and asking a population

You already have *preguntar*. An *encuesta* is not more of it — it is a different act.

what you do	what you get
preguntar	an answer from somebody
una encuesta	a picture of what a group thinks

Preguntar wants one reply and stops. An *encuesta* is built to be counted, which is why Spanish treats it as a thing you **make** rather than something you say. That is also why a notice will report *lo que dice la encuesta* — the survey speaks, not the people in it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **inquisita**, things sought out, from **inquirere**: **in-** plus **quaerere**, to seek.
Now look at what you already hold. **Querer** is that same **quaerere**. The verb that means *to want* in Spanish meant *to seek* in Latin, and *encuesta* is its other child — so **wanting and asking are one word underneath**, which is truer of people than either word admits on its own.
English took the same root repeatedly: an **inquest**, an **inquiry**, a **question**, a **quest**, and **require** — all seekings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- they made a survey among the users
- which taught verb *encuesta* is a cousin of
- the difference between *preguntar* and *una encuesta*

Before you move on

The survey? (**La encuesta**.) Which verb goes with it? (**Hacer**.) Which everyday verb is its cousin? (**Querer** — both are *quaerere*, to seek.)

472.3 surgir — to arise

Say **la encuesta** and **la biblioteca**. An idea came out of the first and changed the second. Today's word is *came out of*.

You'll want to know: surgir

surgir — to arise, to come up, to emerge.

La idea **surgió** de una encuesta.

Ha surgido un problema — a problem has come up. *Surgir de* — to arise *from* something, which is the shape you will meet most.

The **g** is the throaty one before *i*: *sur-JIR*. Before *a* or *o* it is written **j** — *surjo*, I arise — so the sound stays put while the spelling moves.

Grammar Lens: the verb that reports an origin

Surgir says something appeared **without anyone deciding it would**. That is its whole job, and it is why a question about where an idea came from uses it.

what you say	what it implies
la idea **surgió de**	it emerged, nobody planned it
alguien tuvo la idea	a person had it

So *¿de dónde surgió la idea?* is not asking who is responsible. It is asking what the idea **came out of** — a conversation, a complaint, a survey.

Answer it with *de* and a source, the way the question is built.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **surgere**, to rise — itself **sub-** plus **regere**, to direct: to straighten oneself up from below.

The picture is physical and the word has kept it. English took the

same verb for a **surge**, a rising of water, and for **resurgent** and **insurgent**, things that rise again or rise against.
So *surgir* is not *appear*. It is **rise**, and what rises came from somewhere underneath — which is exactly why it wants *de*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the idea arose from a survey
- a problem has come up
- why the word wants *de* after it

Before you move on

To arise? (**Surgir**.) The idea arose from a survey? (**La idea surgió de una encuesta**.) What does *surgere* literally mean? (**To rise**.)

472.4 la lectura — the reading

> Say **leer** and **la factura**. One is this word's verb; the other printed this word in a table and moved on.

You'll want to know: la lectura

la lectura — the reading.

> El servicio ya no es solo de **lectura**.

You have met this word once without being given it. La factura put it in its own table — *leer, to read* / *lectura, a reading* — as an example of the **-ura** ending, then went back to invoices. Here it is as yours.

Un club de lectura — a book club. *La lectura del contador* — the meter reading.

Grammar Lens: three things one word covers

English splits these with different words. Spanish keeps one.

what is meant	English reaches for
the activity	reading
the thing read	a text, a book
the interpretation	a reading of

All three are *la lectura*, and you have already used the third without noticing. When this book asked you for *the two readings of* **como**, it was asking for two **lecturas** — two ways the sentence can be taken. So the word is not only about books. Anything you can take a meaning from has a *lectura*, including a meter and an argument.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Leer is Latin **legere**, and *-ura* is the ending *la factura* gave you: the thing an action produces. A *lectura* is what reading makes.
Legere first meant **to gather**, and the reading sense came later — you gather letters the way you gather grain. That gathering is still visible in English **collect**, **select** and **elect**, all of them picking things out, and in **legible**, able to be gathered, and **lecture**, a reading aloud.
So the ending was predictable and the root was already yours. The only new thing here is permission to use the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the service is no longer only for reading
- a book club, using today's word
- what *legere* first meant

Before you move on

The reading? (**La lectura**.) Which ending built it? (**-ura** — the thing an action produces.) What did *legere* first mean? (**To gather**.)

472.5 copiar — to copy

Say **la lectura** and **la biblioteca**. If one library's idea works, what do the others do?

You'll want to know: copiar

copiar — to copy.

Tres bibliotecas han **copiado** el sistema.

Copiar un documento, *copiar a alguien*. The noun is **la copia**, a copy — and note that it is feminine, where English has no gender to keep track of.

Copiar en un examen is to cheat, so the verb is not always neutral; context does the work.

Grammar Lens: copying a thing and copying a person

The preposition changes what you are claiming.

what you say	what it means
copiar **el sistema**	reproduce the thing
copiar **a** otra biblioteca	imitate the one who did it

Han copiado el sistema is a compliment about a method. *Han copiado a otra biblioteca* puts another institution in the sentence and can sound like a charge of unoriginality.

Three libraries copying a system is a success story. The same three copying *a* somebody is a different report altogether, and a reading question will sometimes turn on which one the text said.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **copia** — **abundance**, plenty. Not *a duplicate*: the word for plenty.

The sense travelled because to copy a manuscript was to make there be **more of it**. A medieval scribe producing a second manuscript was making *copia*, abundance, and the name of the result eventually became the name of the act.

The old meaning is still in English **copious**, meaning plentiful, and in **cornucopia**, the horn of plenty. Set those beside *una copia* and the journey is visible: from having a lot, to having another one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three libraries have copied the system
- the difference *a* makes after this verb
- what *copia* meant in Latin

Before you move on

To copy? (**Copiar**.) The noun? (**La copia** — feminine.) What did *copia* mean first? (**Abundance**.)

472.6 (el usuario, la encuesta, surgir, la lectura, copiar) — from cold

Five words, no prompts. Who the library serves, what it asked them, what came out of it, what the place used to be only for, and what the neighbours did next.

You'll want to know: the five, cold

English	Spanish
the user	**el usuario**
the survey	**la encuesta**
to arise	**surgir**
the reading	**la lectura**
to copy	**copiar**

Grammar Lens: three of the five were already inside words you hold

This chapter minted very little. Most of it was recombination.

word	what it is made of
usuario	**usar** plus *-ario*
lectura	**leer** plus *-ura*
encuesta	the same Latin verb as **querer**

La factura had even printed *lectura* in a table already, as its own example of the *-ura* ending, and moved on. So the work here was less learning words than being handed ones the book had been using in front of you.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The two that were genuinely new both hide a picture.

word	underneath
surgir	*surgere*, to **rise** — so it wants *de*
copiar	*copia*, **abundance** — a copy made there be more

And the one worth keeping: **encuesta** is *inquirere*, **in-** plus *quaerere*, to seek — and *quaerere* is **querer**. Wanting and asking are the same Latin verb, which is a better joke than either language intended.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the idea arose from a survey among the users
- three libraries have copied the system
- which two of the five you could have built yourself

Before you move on

The user? (**El usuario**.) The survey? (**La encuesta**.) To arise? (**Surgir**.) The reading? (**La lectura**.) To copy? (**Copiar**.)

472.7 (la biblioteca que presta cosas) — read it, then answer

Say **la encuesta** and **surgir**. The question below joins those two words, and it is the only question in this chapter you have to answer.

Read this

La biblioteca ya no presta solo libros. Desde hace dos años presta también objetos: herramientas, maletas, máquinas de cocina.

La idea **surgió** de una **encuesta**: preguntaron a los **usuarios** qué necesitaban y qué no querían comprar. El servicio dejó de ser solo de **lectura** y tres bibliotecas de la provincia ya lo han **copiado**.

Grammar Lens: the question is about the source, not the author

An exam will ask **¿de dónde surgió la idea?** and offer three answers. Two of them will be plausible-sounding origins the text does not claim.

what the text says	**what it does not say**
surgió **de una encuesta**	that somebody proposed it
otras bibliotecas **lo han copiado**	that this one copied another

That second row is the trap worth naming. The text says other libraries copied **this** one. A distractor will offer the reverse — *de copiar otra biblioteca* — and it uses the chapter's own word to do it. *Surgir de* points **backwards** to a source. Read the direction as carefully as the words.

Your turn

Say where the idea came from, using *surgir de*.

Now say who copied whom, in that order, and then say it the wrong way round so you can hear the difference.

Before you move on

Where did the idea come from? (**De una encuesta**.) Who was asked? (**Los usuarios**.) Who copied whom? (**Otras bibliotecas copiaron a esta**.)

Chapter 473

El consejo a otras bibliotecas

Modes: **voice** (5) **Hands-free start:** all 5 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can follow advice given to somebody else: hear what a person recommends doing, answer a question that asks the same thing with a different verb, and say that something has to be in good condition.
>
> *Read the librarian's advice to anyone copying the scheme, then answer a question that swaps the verb.*

473.1 aconsejar — to advise

> Say **el consejo** and **la biblioteca**. You have the noun. Today you get the verb that goes with it.

You'll want to know: aconsejar

aconsejar — to advise.

> ¿Qué **aconseja** a otras bibliotecas?

Aconsejar a alguien — to advise somebody. *Aconsejar hacer algo* — to advise doing something. *Te aconsejo esperar* — I advise you to wait.

Grammar Lens: the same machine, a different part fed into it

Acercarse gave you this pattern outright — **a-** plus a word plus **-ar**, *to make it that* — with *acercar* from *cerca*, *alejar* from *lejos*, *aclarar* from *claro*.

Look at what those three have in common. Every one is built on a **preposition or an adjective**. This word is not:

built on	**example**
an adjective or preposition	aclarar, acercar
a **noun**	**aconsejar**, acompañar

Same machine, different raw material. *Acercar* makes something near; *aconsejar* does not make anything *consejo* — it **gives** one. So with a noun the sense shifts from *make it that* to *supply that*, which is worth knowing before you try to build your own.
Note the person goes in with **a**: *aconsejar* ***a*** *otras bibliotecas.* The advice itself follows with no preposition at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

El consejo already traced it: Latin **consilium**, a deliberation — from **con-**, together, and a root about **calling** or taking counsel.
So advising is, underneath, a **sitting together**: the word does not mean telling somebody what to do. English keeps the same sense in **counsel** and **council**, which are the same Latin word split into two spellings, one for the advice and one for the people giving it.
That is a distinction English had to invent twice. Spanish does it with one noun and one verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- what does he advise other libraries
- I advise you to wait
- the noun this verb was built from

Before you move on

To advise? (**Aconsejar**.) Built from? (**El consejo**, with *a-* on the front.) What does *consilium* mean underneath? (**A sitting together**.)

473.2 recomendar — to recommend

Say **aconsejar** and **pensar**. The first gives today's meaning, the second gives today's spelling problem.

You'll want to know: recomendar

recomendar — to recommend.

Les **recomienda** empezar con pocos objetos.

Te recomiendo este — I recommend this one. *¿Qué me recomienda?* — what do you recommend? That last one is what you say to a waiter, and it is the most useful sentence in the lesson.

Grammar Lens: the e that breaks, and the twin it works beside

You said *recomienda*, not *recomenda*. That is pensar's rule: under stress the **e** breaks open into **ie**.

stress on the stem	**stress on the ending**
recom**ie**ndo, recom**ie**ndas	recomend**a**mos
recom**ie**nda, recom**ie**ndan	recomend**á**is

Only the **second** e breaks — the one that carries the stress. The first stays put, which is why the infinitive keeps both.

And the twin. *Aconsejar* and *recomendar* overlap almost completely, with one lean:

verb	**what it leans toward**
aconsejar	what would be wise for you
recomendar	what is good, of its kind

You *recomiendas* a restaurant. You *aconsejas* somebody to rest. Either verb will be understood in either sentence, and a careful speaker picks.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

re- plus **commendare**: **com-**, wholly, plus **mandare**, to **entrust** — to put a thing into somebody's hand.

So recommending is not praising. It is **handing over**: you put the thing in the other person's care and let them judge it.

That *mandare* is busy in English — **command**, **mandate**, **demand**, **commend** — and the hand inside it is *manus*, the same hand you met

in **el mango**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- what do you recommend?
- he recommends starting with few objects
- which of the two verbs you would use about a restaurant

Before you move on

To recommend? (**Recomendar**.) I recommend? (**Recomiendo** — the second e breaks.) What does *mandare* mean? (**To entrust** — to put in the hand.)

473.3 el estado — the condition

Say **estar** and **recomendar**. What somebody recommends often depends on the thing's condition — and the word for that is hiding inside *estar*.

You'll want to know: el estado

el estado — the state, the condition.

Aceptar solo lo que esté en buen **estado**.

En buen estado — in good condition. **En mal estado** — in bad condition, and of food it means gone off. These two phrases are the word's everyday work.

You have read one of them already, on a donation notice: *juguetes en buen estado*.

Grammar Lens: a participle hardened into a noun, again

Estado is also the past participle of *estar* — *he estado aquí* — and that is worth being exact about, because the two are not quite the same story.

word	where the noun came from
el pedido	the participle of *pedir*, hardened
el estado	Latin *status*, borrowed as a noun

El pedido really is its verb's participle put to work. *El estado* arrived as a noun already, from Latin, and only **looks** like the participle because both descend from the same verb. The shape coincides; the route does not.
File it with them anyway — the family is the easiest place to remember it — but do not tell yourself you derived it.
Which is why it is *estar* and never *ser* underneath. A condition is temporary by definition, and the word carries that in its bones.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **status**, from **stare**, to stand — the root *estar* itself came from. English took *status* whole, and took the rest of the family too: **statue**, something made to stand; **station**, a standing-place; **stable**, able to stand; **estate** and **state**, which is the same word arriving twice by different roads.
So *el estado* is a standing — and the political **State** is that word again, meaning the way a country stands. Spanish uses one noun for both, and a capital letter does the separating.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- accept only what is in good condition
- this milk is off, using *estado*
- which verb *estado* is the participle of

Before you move on

The condition? (**El estado**.) In good condition? (**En buen estado**.) Which verb is it the participle of? (**Estar** — Latin *stare*, to stand.)

473.4 (aconsejar, recomendar, el estado) — from cold

Three words, no prompts. What somebody does when asked, what they do about a restaurant, and the thing an object has to be in before anyone will take it.

You'll want to know: the three, cold

English	Spanish
to advise	**aconsejar**
to recommend	**recomendar**
the condition	**el estado**

Grammar Lens: none of the three was really new

Each one is a word you held, put through a machine you had already been shown.

the word you had	what happened to it
el consejo	*a-* on the front, *-ar* on the end
estar	its Latin root borrowed back as a noun

Acercarse gave the first machine. *El estado* is the subtler case: it looks like *estar*'s participle and is not derived from it — both come down from Latin *stare*, and the noun was borrowed from *status* directly. *Recomendar* is the odd one out: its pieces are Latin rather than Spanish, and what you already held was the **rule for its stem** — *pensar*'s e breaking into ie.

So the chapter asked you to recognise three shapes rather than memorise three words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two of the three carry a picture that is still readable.

word	underneath
recomendar	*mandare*, to **entrust** — to put in the hand
el estado	*stare*, to **stand** — how a thing is standing

And *aconsejar* is *consilium*, a **sitting together** — so none of the three is really about giving orders. Advice hands a thing over, or sits down beside you, and neither pushes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- what do you recommend?
- he advises accepting only what is in good condition
- which of the three is a participle turned into a noun

Before you move on

To advise? (**Aconsejar**.) To recommend? (**Recomendar**.) The condition? (**El estado**.)

473.5 (el consejo a otras bibliotecas) — read it, then answer

Say **aconsejar** and **en buen estado**. The question below uses the first and the answer uses the second.

Read this

The library that lends objects, asked what others should do:

> A quien pregunta, le **recomienda** empezar con pocos objetos, aceptar solo lo que esté en buen **estado** y explicar muy bien las normas desde el primer día.

Three pieces of advice, joined by commas and a final **y**. Spanish lists like this without repeating the verb, so *recomienda* governs all three

infinitives: *empezar*, *aceptar*, *explicar*.

Grammar Lens: the question will not use the paragraph's verb

This is the thing to carry away. The text says *recomienda*. The question says:

> ¿Qué **aconseja** a otras bibliotecas?

the text	**the question**
recomienda empezar	¿qué **aconseja**?

Nothing has changed except the verb, and an exam does this on purpose: it checks that you hold the **meaning** rather than the word. If you learned *recomendar* and not *aconsejar*, the question looks like it is about something else.
So treat the two as one idea with two surfaces, and read past the swap.

Your turn

Say all three pieces of advice, keeping one verb and three infinitives the way the text does.

Now answer the question as asked — starting *Les aconseja…* — and notice you are saying the same thing with the other verb.

Before you move on

What does the text's verb say? (**Recomienda**.) What does the question's verb say? (**Aconseja**.) What must the objects be? (**En buen estado**.)

Chapter 474

El curso que paga la empresa

Modes: 🚗 **voice** (6) 🚗 **Hands-free start:** all 6 lessons.

> ***By the end of this chapter:*** I can follow a conversation about who pays for something: hear that an amount is deducted over months rather than taken all at once, and match that to a statement saying the opposite in different words.
>
> *Match a statement about paying the full amount at once against a speaker who says the opposite in different words.*

474.1 invitar — to invite

> Say **el invitado** and **pagar**. Today's verb made the first, and in one very common use it means the second.

You'll want to know: invitar

invitar — to invite.

> Nos **invitaron** a la fiesta.

You have met this verb once without being handed it. El invitado named it in passing — *"from **invitar**, Latin **invitare**, to invite; **invitado** is its participle"* — and then stayed with the guest. Here it is as yours.

Invitar a alguien a algo — the person with **a**, and the thing with **a** as well.

Grammar Lens: in Spanish, inviting can mean paying

This is the use you will meet first in real life, and English has no single word for it.

Spanish	what it means
te invito	**I'm paying**
invito yo	this one's on me

Somebody who says *te invito a un café* is not asking whether you are free. They are telling you they will pay for it. Answering *vale, ¿a qué hora?* when the coffee is in front of you will land oddly.
So *invitar* covers both the asking and the paying, and which one is meant is settled by whether a time is mentioned.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **invitare**, to invite — and the honest answer about what is inside it is that nobody is sure. The older guess tied it to a root about **willingness**, which would make an invitation an appeal to somebody's good will.
English took the whole word twice: **invite**, and the noun **invitation**. There is no native English word for this, which is a small clue that the custom travelled with the Latin.
What Spanish added is the paying. That is not in the Latin and not in the English — it is a courtesy that attached itself to the word here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- they invited us to the party
- this one's on me
- the noun this verb already gave you

Before you move on

To invite? (**Invitar**.) What does *te invito* usually mean? (**I'm paying**.) Which word did you have first? (**El invitado** — its participle.)

474.2 el importe — the amount

Say **importar** and **importante**. Today's noun is the third member of that family, and it is the one that appears on a bill.

You'll want to know: el importe

el importe — the amount, the sum.

Hay que pagar el **importe** completo.

El importe total — the total. *El importe del curso* — the fee for a class. This is a form-and-invoice word: in speech people say *cuánto es*, but anything printed says *importe*.

Grammar Lens: one verb, three jobs

Importar told you two of these. Here is the third, and seeing them together is what makes the word stick.

the sense	example
to matter	*no me importa*
to import goods	*importar café*
to amount to	**el importe**

The thread is Latin **in-** plus **portare**, to **carry in**. Goods carried in are imports. A thing that carries weight *matters*. And what a bill **carries in** for you to pay is its *importe*.
So the noun is not a fourth meaning bolted on. It is the same carrying, applied to money.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Portare is the carrying verb, and once you have it a great many words open at once. Spanish has already given you two of its children without saying so:

- **el deporte** — *dis-* plus *portare*, carrying yourself away from work;
- **el comportamiento** — carrying yourself **with**, which is behaviour.

English carries the same root in **port**, **portable**, **export**, **transport** and **report** — a thing carried back.

And *importante* is literally **carrying-in-ish**: something that brings weight with it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- you have to pay the full amount
- the three jobs of *importar*
- what *portare* means

Before you move on

The amount? (**El importe**.) Which verb is it from? (**Importar** — *in* plus *portare*.) Would you say it out loud in a shop? (**Usually not — it is a printed word**.)

474.3 descontar — to deduct

Say **contar** and **el importe**. Put *des-* on the first and you have what happens to the second.

You'll want to know: descontar

descontar — to deduct, to take off.

Te lo **descuentan** en doce meses.

El descuento is the noun — a discount. *Con descuento* — at a reduced price.

Note the stem: *desc**ue**nto*, *desc**ue**ntan*. The **o** breaks into **ue** under stress, exactly as it does in *contar* itself — *cuento*, *cuentas*.

Grammar Lens: the des- that reverses, and the one that does not

Cubrir set this out plainly: *des-* sometimes undoes the verb and sometimes does nothing of the kind, and only the whole word tells you which.

word	what des- does
descubrir	takes the cover off — it reverses
disfrutar	nothing — the prefix does not reverse
descontar	**takes off the count — it reverses**

This one is in the first camp, and cleanly. *Contar* adds up; *descontar* takes away from the total. If you can count the thing, *des-* will subtract it.
Descansar is the same family — *des-* undoing *cansar*, to tire — and it is where you first met the prefix doing real work.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Contar is Latin **computare**: **com-**, together, plus **putare**, to reckon. So counting is a **reckoning-together**, and *descontar* is a reckoning taken back out.
That *computare* is where English **compute** and **count** both come from — the second worn down through French — so *contar* and *count* are the same word wearing different amounts of Latin.
And *putare* first meant to **prune** a tree. Reckoning, in Latin, began as cutting away what does not belong, which makes *descontar* an oddly exact return to the root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- they deduct it from you over twelve months
- the noun, meaning a discount
- which camp this *des-* is in, and why

Before you move on

To deduct? (**Descontar**.) They deduct? (**Descuentan** — the o breaks.) Does this *des-* reverse? (**Yes — it takes off the count**.)

474.4 el golpe — the blow

Say **descontar** and **pagar**. If the money is not taken off in instalments, it comes in one of today's word.

You'll want to know: el golpe

el golpe — the blow, the knock.

No te lo cobran de **golpe**.

The literal sense is a hit: *un golpe en la puerta*, a knock at the door. But the phrase is what you need: **de golpe** — all at once, suddenly.

Grammar Lens: the phrase a payment plan is defined against

Spanish has two ways to say *all at once*, and a notice about money will use one to rule out the other.

phrase	what it pictures
de golpe	in one blow — suddenly, often unwelcome
de una vez	in a single go — neutral

De golpe carries the impact. *Se me olvidó de golpe* — it went out of my head all at once. *Subió de golpe* — it shot up.
So *no de golpe* about a fee is doing more than saying *in instalments*: it is saying you will not be hit with it. That is why the reassurance lands, and why a question about it may use the calmer *de una vez* instead.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin **colaphus**, a blow with the fist, borrowed from Greek **kólaphos**, a box on the ear.
The road from *colaphus* to *golpe* is worth a look, because two things happened: the **c** softened to **g**, and the middle syllable fell out entirely — *co-la-phus* worn down to *gol-pe*. That is ordinary wear, and it left a word that no longer looks Greek at all.
English has the same blow in **coup**, taken from French rather than Spanish and kept intact: a *coup* is one sharp strike, which is what a *golpe* is. Spanish says **golpe de estado** where English says *coup d'état* — the same two words, twice.
French went further and made a quantity out of it. **Beaucoup** is *beau*

plus *coup*, a **beautiful blow**, and it means *a lot* — so the same punch that gives Spanish its *golpe* gives French its word for plenty.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- they don't charge you for it all at once
- a knock at the door
- which English word is the same blow

Before you move on

The blow? (**El golpe**.) All at once? (**De golpe**.) Which English word is its twin? (**Coup** — both are *colaphus*.)

474.5 (invitar, el importe, descontar, el golpe) — from cold

Four words, no prompts. What somebody does when they are paying, what the bill says, what happens to it over twelve months, and what it would have been if it had all come at once.

You'll want to know: the four, cold

English	Spanish
to invite	**invitar**
the amount	**el importe**
to deduct	**descontar**
the blow	**el golpe**

Grammar Lens: three of the four were already in the room

Only one of these arrived from nowhere.

word	what it came out of
invitar	**el invitado**, its own participle
el importe	**importar**, its third sense
descontar	**contar**, with *des-* reversing

El golpe is the outsider, and even it has a relative you know in English. So the chapter was mostly a matter of being handed things the book had been holding: *invitar* had been named inside *el invitado*, and *importar* had told you two of its three jobs already.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Two roots do most of the work here.

root	what it gave
portare, to carry	**importe**, deporte, comportamiento
computare, to reckon	**descontar**, contar, English *count*

And *golpe* is Latin **colaphus** from Greek **kólaphos**, a box on the ear — the same blow English keeps in **coup**, and the one French built *beaucoup* out of. *Golpe de estado* and *coup d'état* are the same two words said twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- they deduct the amount over twelve months, not all at once
- this one's on me
- which of the four did not come from a word you had

Before you move on

To invite? (**Invitar**.) The amount? (**El importe**.) To deduct? (**Descontar**.) All at once? (**De golpe**.)

474.6 (el curso que paga la empresa) — match it

Say **el importe** and **de golpe**. The exchange below turns on whether the second applies to the first.

Read this

> — El setenta por ciento. El resto lo pones tú, pero te lo **descuentan** en doce meses, no de **golpe**. — Ah, eso no lo sabía.

And the statement you have to match to it:

> Pensaba que había que pagar el **importe** completo de una vez.

Grammar Lens: the match is between two phrases, not two words

This is a matching task, so nothing is quoted back at you. The speaker and the statement describe the same fact in different words, and you have to see it.

the speaker says	**the statement says**
no **de golpe**	**de una vez**
te lo descuentan en doce meses	el importe completo

Neither phrase appears in the other. *De golpe* and *de una vez* are the pair that carries the match, and if you only hold one of them the item is closed to you even though you understood every sentence.
That is worth knowing in general: a matching task rewards **paraphrase**, so the words to learn are the ones that come in pairs.

Your turn

Say what the company pays and what happens to the rest, using *descontar*.

Now say the misunderstanding twice — once with *de golpe* and once with *de una vez* — and hear that they are the same claim.

Before you move on

What happens to the rest? (**Te lo descuentan en doce meses**.) Not how? (**De golpe**.) What did the listener think? (**Que había que pagar el importe completo de una vez**.)

Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

This is a **reference**, not a chapter. You are not meant to read it front to back before starting. Each lesson tells you the one or two sounds you need for *that* word, and links here if you want the fuller picture. Look things up as curiosity strikes; otherwise, keep learning words.

Each entry has an id (e.g. `silent-h`) that lessons cite in their front-matter `sounds:` field, so "Sounds you'll need" notes and this page stay in sync.

Vowels — the five pure sounds

Spanish has exactly five vowel sounds, one per letter, every time. English has a dozen-plus and reuses letters for several; that habit is the thing to unlearn.

- `vowel-a` — **a** as in English *father*. Always. Never *cat*, never *cake*.
- `vowel-e` — **e** as in *bed*. Always. Never the *ee* of *see*.
- `vowel-i` — **i** as the *ee* in *see* (not the English *i* of *sit*). The single most common vowel mistake English speakers make.
- `vowel-o` — **o** as in *note*, but short and clean, with no *w*-glide at the end.
- `vowel-u` — **u** as the *oo* in *food*. Always.

Diphthongs — two vowels run together

- `diphthong-ue` — **ue** as a quick *weh* (Spanish *u* + *e*), e.g. *bueno*, *nueve*.

- `diphthong-ie` — **ie** as a quick *yeh* (Spanish *i* + *e*), e.g. *quiero*, *siete*.
- `diphthong-ei` — **ei** as in English *they*, e.g. *seis*, *treinta*.

Consonants that differ from English

- `silent-h` — **h** is always silent, no exceptions. *hola* is *OH-la*, *hay* is *eye*.
- `soft-c` — **c** before *e* or *i* is a soft sound: *s* in Latin America, a *th* (as in *think*) in most of Spain. *gracias*, *cero*. Before *a/o/u* it's a hard *k* (*casa*).
- `qu-k` — **qu** is a hard *k*, and the **u is silent**: *quiero* is *KYEH-ro*, *qué* is *keh*. (This silent-*u*-after-*q* is inherited straight from Latin.)
- `ll-y` — **ll** sounds like English *y* in *yes* across most of Latin America: *llamo* is *YA-mo*. (Regional variation exists; *y* is the safe default.)
- `n-tilde` — **ñ** is the *ny* of *canyon*: *español* is *es-pa-NYOL*. A different letter from *n*, not a decoration.
- `rr-trill` — **rr** is a rolled/trilled *r*; a single *r* between vowels is a light tap. *pero* (but) vs. *perro* (dog) is a real minimal pair.
- `j-h` — **j** is a throat-*h*, rougher than English *h* (like the *ch* in Scottish *loch*): *jueves*.
- `g-soft` — **g** before *e/i* is the same throat sound as *j* (*gente*); before *a/o/u* it's a hard *g* (*gato*).
- `d-soft` — **d** between vowels softens toward English *th* in *this*: *nada* is closer to *NA-tha*.
- `v-b` — **v** and **b** sound essentially identical in Spanish, both a soft *b*.

Stress & written accents

Three facts cover almost every word:

- `stress-default-vowel-ns` — a word ending in a vowel, *n*, or *s* is stressed on the **second-to-last** syllable: *ca-SA*, *ha-BLAN*, *li-BROS*.

- `stress-default-consonant` — a word ending in any other consonant is stressed on the **last** syllable: *ha-BLAR*, *ciu-DAD*.
- `accent-mark` — a written accent (´) overrides both rules and puts the stress exactly on the marked vowel: *ha-BLÓ*, *DÍ-as*. The mark can also distinguish otherwise-identical words (*qué* "what?" vs. *que* "that", *tú* "you" vs. *tu* "your").
- `accent-i` — a specific case of the above: the accent on *í* in words like *días* keeps the stress on the *i* where the default rule would otherwise misplace it.

Punctuation

- `inverted-marks` — questions and exclamations open with an inverted mark: *¿cómo estás?*, *¡hola!* — so you know the intonation before you reach the end of the sentence.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

abajo
down, below, downstairs — Late Latin bassus, low; English base, bass, abase and debase are the same lowness
Introduced in Chapter 341.

abrir
to open — a regular -ir verb with one irregular part, the participle abierto
Introduced in Chapter 166.

acabar
to finish — from cabo, an end, from Latin caput, a head; English achieve is the same metaphor built again in French
Introduced in Chapter 382.

acaso
perhaps, by chance — a + caso, and Latin casus was a fall; English case, casual, casualty, cadence and accident are all falls too
Introduced in Chapter 324.

aceptar
to accept — to take a thing towards you, and the sign on the till
Introduced in Chapter 456.

acercar
to pass, to bring closer — the same verb as *acercarse* with the -se taken off
Introduced in Chapter 449.

acercarse
to approach — a preposition turned into a verb, and the date that comes closer on its own
Introduced in Chapter 443.

acompañar
to go with somebody — built on the one you share bread with
Introduced in Chapter 446.

aconsejar
to advise — el consejo with a verb built on it, and the verb a question reaches for when it asks what somebody recommends
Introduced in Chapter 473.

además
furthermore, moreover
Introduced in Chapter 273.

adiós
goodbye
Introduced in Chapter 12.

admitir
to let in, to own up to — the *mittere* you already have in *meter*
Introduced in Chapter 458.

adulto, adulta
adult, grown-up
Introduced in Chapter 417.

agosto
August — Latin Augustus, the emperor the month was renamed for, inherited by way of the attested Vulgar Latin agustus; its learned twin augusto keeps the au and the u that agosto lost
Introduced in Chapter 392.

ahí · allí
there, over there — the two places aquí has been missing, and they line up exactly with the three pointing words
Introduced in Chapter 251.

ahora
now — the time word mañana has been waiting for, and a Latin hour in disguise
Introduced in Chapter 252.

ajeno
somebody else's — Latin alienus from alius, other; English alien, alias and alibi all point at somebody who is not you
Introduced in Chapter 350.

al
to the — one of only two places where Spanish forces two words into one, and it does it because the two vowels refuse to sit next to each other
Introduced in Chapter 230.

alegre
cheerful — Latin alacer, lively, through two reconstructed spoken forms; English alacrity and Italian allegro are the same word
Introduced in Chapter 380.

algo
something — Latin aliquod, ali- plus quod, "some other what"; the same ali- is in alias, alien and altruism
Introduced in Chapter 317.

alguien
somebody — Latin aliquem, ali- plus quem, “some other whom”; algo’s exact partner, built for people
Introduced in Chapter 317.

alimentar
to feed — from a Latin verb wider than feeding, which is why the same root is inside adult and alumnus
Introduced in Chapter 467.

alrededor
around, round about — al plus rededor, from Latin retro backwards crossed with rota, a wheel; English rotate, rotund and retro all roll here
Introduced in Chapter 347.

alto
high, tall — Latin altus, which meant high and also deep; altitude, exalt, enhance, haughty and the oboe are all still measuring height
Introduced in Chapter 365.

amable
kind — Latin amabilis, loveable: the person it is easy to be fond of
Introduced in Chapter 283.

amarillo
yellow — from “a little bitter,” not from any Latin word for yellow at all
Introduced in Chapter 151.

ambos
both — Latin ambo, the two together; English ambidextrous, ambiguous and amphitheatre all carry the same both
Introduced in Chapter 351.

ancho
wide — Latin amplus, spacious; ample, amplify and amplitude are the borrowed branch, and Spanish amplio is the same adjective taken fresh from the page
Introduced in Chapter 365.

anoche
last night — Latin ad noctem, toward night, worn into one word; the same noctem gives English nocturnal and equinox
Introduced in Chapter 322.

anotar
to note down — Latin nota on a verb, and the quieter twin of apuntar
Introduced in Chapter 465.

antes
before — Latin ante; English ante-, antique, ancient and ancestor all come off it, and an ancestor is one who went before
Introduced in Chapter 323.

antipático
unpleasant, disagreeable — simpático with the Greek anti- fastened on the front; the two words are a matched pair and neither means what its English lookalike means
Introduced in Chapter 423.

apagar
to turn off or extinguish — from Latin pacare, to calm or pacify
Introduced in Chapter 404.

apenas
barely, hardly, scarcely — a + penas, from Latin poena, a penalty; English pain, penalty, penal and subpoena are the same root
Introduced in Chapter 328.

aprender
to learn — Latin apprehendere, to seize, worn down through apprēndere; the bookish twin aprehender kept the -he- and kept the seizing
Introduced in Chapter 396.

aprobar
to pass an exam — and the surprise is who does the approving, because the Latin has the exam approving you
Introduced in Chapter 429.

apuntar
to note down, to put your name on a list — a verb built on the point of something
Introduced in Chapter 451.

apuntarse
to sign up, to put one's name down
Introduced in Chapter 414.

aquel
that one over there, away from us both — and the second life of the word that became el in your very first chapter
Introduced in Chapter 223.

arreglar
to fix, to sort out — putting a thing back to the straight edge it came off
Introduced in Chapter 449.

arrepentirse
to regret — a verb that looks like it contains sentir, behaves like sentir, and is not related to it
Introduced in Chapter 443.

arriba
up, above, upstairs — Latin ripa, a riverbank; English river, riparian and arrive all come off the same bank
Introduced in Chapter 341.

así
thus, like this, that way — Latin ad sic, to thus; the same sic that Spanish turned into sí and that English still writes inside a quotation
Introduced in Chapter 328.

así que
thus, in that way — and with que after it, "so"; built on the same sīc that gave you sí
Introduced in Chapter 175.

asonancia
assonance — the rhyme Spanish verse actually uses
Introduced in Chapter 276.

aunque
although, even though
Introduced in Chapter 270.

avanzado
advanced — a participle used as an adjective, and a cousin of antes, because to advance is to move to the front
Introduced in Chapter 471.

avisar
to let know — the verb el aviso was named from, handed over now, and it shows rather than orders
Introduced in Chapter 470.

ayer
yesterday
Introduced in Chapter 103.

ayudar
to help — literally the same word as English "aid", arriving by a different road
Introduced in Chapter 161.

azul
blue — an Arabic loan that became the plain everyday word, where French's cousin stayed poetic
Introduced in Chapter 139.

bailar
to dance (bailar — infinitive)
Introduced in Chapter 419.

barato
cheap — from the old verb baratar, to trade or haggle; Corominas calls the ultimate origin uncertain, probably pre-Roman and possibly Celtic, and English barter is very likely the same family
Introduced in Chapter 397.

bastante
enough, quite — an ending you already decode, on a verb meaning to suffice, giving a word that means exactly "sufficing"
Introduced in Chapter 227.

be larga o be corta
the letters with more than one name — which matters because b and v sound identical in Spanish, so the name is how a speaker tells them apart
Introduced in Chapter 425.

beber
to drink (another -er verb — cementing the pattern)
Introduced in Chapter 36.

bien
well / good / fine
Introduced in Chapter 1.

bienvenido
welcome — bien plus venido, well come, two pieces you already own
Introduced in Chapter 282.

billete
ticket
Introduced in Chapter 268.

bonito
pretty — bueno with a real diminutive on it, "nice and good"; and Latin bellus, which gave bello and English beautiful, had already been made the same way out of the same bonus
Introduced in Chapter 399.

borrar
to erase — from borra, coarse wool, the pad that rubbed writing out; English borrow is no relation
Introduced in Chapter 388.

buenas noches
good evening / good night
Introduced in Chapter 2.

buenas tardes
good afternoon
Introduced in Chapter 2.

buenos días
good morning (literally "good days")
Introduced in Chapter 1.

buscar
to look for — of unknown origin; English busker is the one relative anybody can point to
Introduced in Chapter 383.

cada
each, every — Greek kata, down or by, through Latin cata; English catalogue, catastrophe and cathedral all begin with the same kata
Introduced in Chapter 345.

café
coffee / a café — one useful noun before the polite request that follows
Introduced in Chapter 14.

cambiar
to change — Latin cambiāre, itself a word of Gaulish origin, for exchanging one thing for another
Introduced in Chapter 401.

caminar
to walk — built on a Celtic word for a path, beside andar, whose own past is unsettled
Introduced in Chapter 165.

cansado
tired — a state, not a quality, which is why it takes estar and never ser
Introduced in Chapter 59.

caro
expensive — Latin cārus already meant both dear-and-beloved and dear-and-costly, exactly as English dear still does, and charity, cherish and caress all come from it
Introduced in Chapter 397.

casi
almost, nearly — Latin quasi, as if; English borrowed quasi whole and still hyphenates it onto anything that is nearly a thing
Introduced in Chapter 328.

celebrar
to celebrate — and, underneath, to make a crowd; the verb a notice uses for holding an event at all
Introduced in Chapter 440.

cenar
to have dinner — one verb where English needs three words, and the meal a plan usually ends at
Introduced in Chapter 437.

cerca
near, nearby — Latin circa, around; English circa, circle, circuit and circus all turn on the same ring
Introduced in Chapter 340.

cero
zero — Arabic sifr, empty; English took the same word twice, as zero and as cipher
Introduced in Chapter 344.

cerrado
closed — the participle doing an adjective's job, and the sign you read most often
Introduced in Chapter 439.

cerrar
to close — from the bar dropped across a door, not from the Latin verb English inherited
Introduced in Chapter 166.

cien
a hundred — Latin centum, cut short before a noun; English cent, century and percent keep the Latin, and English hundred is the very same ancient word
Introduced in Chapter 351.

cierto
true — Latin certus, sifted: what is left after you separate it out
Introduced in Chapter 284.

claro
light, pale, clear — the adjective behind a word you have been saying for chapters
Introduced in Chapter 455.

cobrar
to charge, to be paid — the other side of pagar, and the verb that decides who owes whom
Introduced in Chapter 431.

cocinar
to cook — built on cocina, the kitchen, from Latin coquīna; English kitchen is that same Latin noun, borrowed early into Germanic
Introduced in Chapter 396.

coincidir
to clash, to coincide — the reason people give for not coming, and a word your English eye can already read
Introduced in Chapter 437.

colgar
to hang — Latin collocare, to place; English couch is the same verb, and the jump from placing to hanging happened only on the Spanish side
Introduced in Chapter 385.

comentar
to comment, to mention — to turn a thing over in the mind, together
Introduced in Chapter 447.

comer
to eat — your first -er verb, and the family whose yo-form you already own
Introduced in Chapter 34.

cometer un error
to make a mistake — with the verb Spanish insists on
Introduced in Chapter 275.

comí
the regular singular -er preterite — comí, comiste, comió
Introduced in Chapter 104.

cómo
how — a whole Latin phrase, quo modo, worn smooth into one word
Introduced in Chapter 6.

cómodo
comfortable, convenient — "with measure", and a false friend in one direction
Introduced in Chapter 452.

comprar
to buy — from Latin's "get ready, procure", and not from the verb behind English compare
Introduced in Chapter 174.

con permiso
excuse me, said when you pass — per plus mittere, to let through
Introduced in Chapter 283.

concentrarse
to concentrate — to gather yourself to a centre, with the Greek word for a goad inside it
Introduced in Chapter 443.

concertar
to arrange an appointment — the same word as a concert, and it began as a fight
Introduced in Chapter 442.

conectar
to connect — the Academy's dictionary records it as taken from English to connect, which had itself been built out of Latin pieces
Introduced in Chapter 469.

conmigo · contigo
with me, with you — two words carrying the same preposition twice, because the first one stopped being audible
Introduced in Chapter 247.

conocer
to meet, to be acquainted with — a verb built out of the moment knowing begins
Introduced in Chapter 171.

conseguir
to get, to obtain — getting as following a thing until you have it
Introduced in Chapter 169.

consultar
to check, to look up, to consult — asking a document rather than a person
Introduced in Chapter 453.

contar
to tell a story — and also to count, because in Spanish, as once in English, a story is something you reckon up
Introduced in Chapter 167.

contento
happy, content — Latin contentus, held together, from continere
Introduced in Chapter 304.

contestar
to answer — a Roman courtroom word that English turned into a fight and Spanish turned into a reply
Introduced in Chapter 174.

copiar
to copy — from Latin copia, abundance, because the first copies were made to have plenty
Introduced in Chapter 472.

correr
to run — a plain -er verb sitting on one of the largest roots English ever borrowed
Introduced in Chapter 165.

cortar
to cut — and on a road sign, to close; the verb behind an adjective you already own
Introduced in Chapter 439.

corto
short — Latin curtus, cut off or docked; curt and curtail descend from it and cortar is its Spanish verb, while English short, shirt and skirt are Germanic and meet it only far back
Introduced in Chapter 365.

costar
to cost — Latin constare, to stand together or be settled
Introduced in Chapter 402.

crecer
to grow — Latin crescere; a crescent is the growing moon, and a recruit is a fresh growth on an army
Introduced in Chapter 386.

creer
to believe, to think — putting your heart somewhere, where pensar weighs it up
Introduced in Chapter 175.

cruzar
to cross — from cruz, Latin crux; English cross reached England by way of Irish and Norse, and crusade stands beside Spanish cruzada
Introduced in Chapter 387.

cual
which, as, of what kind — Latin qualis, of what kind; English quality is qualitas, the what-kind-ness of a thing
Introduced in Chapter 329.

cuando
"when" — the word that puts a scene and an event in one sentence, so the two pasts can be seen doing different jobs
Introduced in Chapter 112.

cubrir
to cover — an irregular participle that joins abierto, and the des- that really does reverse
Introduced in Chapter 444.

de acuerdo
agreed — from cor, the heart: an agreement is two hearts brought together
Introduced in Chapter 284.

de nada
you're welcome (literally "of nothing")
Introduced in Chapter 7.

de repente
suddenly — Latin repente, from repens sudden, which is the present participle of repere to creep; the English reptile is the same creeping
Introduced in Chapter 356.

debajo
underneath; below
Introduced in Chapter 407.

deber
should, ought to — and to owe, because the word is literally "to have something from someone"
Introduced in Chapter 175.

deber de
must — the guess, not the obligation
Introduced in Chapter 275.

débil
weak — Latin debilis; English debilitate and debility are the same word, and the written accent is there because the word ends in -l
Introduced in Chapter 327.

decidir
to decide — to cut a question off, and the verb every notice uses when it stops offering options
Introduced in Chapter 437.

decidirse
to make up your mind — *decidir* with the -se, and a cut underneath
Introduced in Chapter 462.

decir
to say or tell — with the singular present forms digo, dices, and dice
Introduced in Chapter 70.

dejar
to leave — Latin laxare, to loosen, through an older Spanish lejar; the d- is borrowed from dar
Introduced in Chapter 383.

del
of the, from the — the second and last of Spanish's forced contractions, which means once you have these two you have all of them
Introduced in Chapter 231.

delante
in front, ahead — Latin ante, before; English ante, antecedent, anterior, antique and anticipate all come off it
Introduced in Chapter 341.

delgado / flaco
thin — the kind word and the blunt one
Introduced in Chapter 275.

demasiado
too much, too — the top of the degree scale bastante taught, and the member that was missing from it
Introduced in Chapter 471.

dentro
inside, within — Latin de intro, from within, on intra; English interior, internal, entrance and the intro of anything share it
Introduced in Chapter 341.

depende
it depends
Introduced in Chapter 210.

descansar
to rest — named in Spanish as the undoing of tiredness, not as a state
Introduced in Chapter 438.

descontar
to deduct — contar with the des- that really does reverse, and the o breaks to ue
Introduced in Chapter 474.

desde
from, since — three Latin prepositions welded shut, de plus ex plus de; despues is built the same way, out of de plus ex plus post
Introduced in Chapter 356.

despierto
awake — from despertar, and Latin expergisci, to set out from sleep; the e breaks to ie exactly where the stress lands
Introduced in Chapter 327.

después
after — Latin de ex post, three little words run together; the post in it is English postpone, postscript and posterior
Introduced in Chapter 323.

detrás
behind, at the back — Latin trans, across or beyond; English transfer, transit, translate and transparent all carry it
Introduced in Chapter 341.

devolver
to give back — the verb every shop notice and every borrowed object needs, and the one this level asks for most
Introduced in Chapter 431.

día
day (el día — masculine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

dieciséis — diecinueve
16-19 — not words to memorise but a formula, diez y X, with the seam still visible
Introduced in Chapter 149.

difícil
difficult — Latin difficilis, dis- plus facilis, "not doable"; English difficult is odd by comparison, having been cut backwards out of the noun difficulty
Introduced in Chapter 398.

directo
direct, straight through — and on a broadcast, live
Introduced in Chapter 446.

disculpe
excuse me — from culpa, fault: literally, take the fault off me
Introduced in Chapter 283.

discutir
to discuss, and to argue — one verb for both, from a Latin verb about shaking a thing apart
Introduced in Chapter 466.

disfrutar
to enjoy — to take the fruit of something, with a prefix that does not undo
Introduced in Chapter 440.

distinto
a different one — Latin distinctus, pricked apart, from dis and stinguere; English distinct, distinguish and instinct all come off the same pricking
Introduced in Chapter 350.

doble
double, twice as much — Latin duplus, from duo two and -plus fold; English double, duplicate, duplex and duplicity are the same two folds
Introduced in Chapter 344.

doler
to hurt — the verb that makes the pain the subject and you the one it happens to
Introduced in Chapter 443.

donar
to donate — the giving inside *perdón*, said plainly
Introduced in Chapter 461.

dónde
where?
Introduced in Chapter 36.

dormido
asleep — the past participle of dormir, from Latin dormire; English dormitory, dormant and dormouse are all sleeping
Introduced in Chapter 327.

dormir
to sleep — and the other half of the boot, where a stressed o breaks to ue
Introduced in Chapter 165.

dulce
sweet — Latin dulcis; the older Spanish form was duz, and the resemblance to Greek glykys, behind glucose, is a genuine unsolved puzzle
Introduced in Chapter 371.

durante
for, during
Introduced in Chapter 269.

duro
hard — of a thing under your hand, and of a day you would rather not repeat
Introduced in Chapter 448.

e → ie and o → ue
comparing the two vowel changes inside the learned singular forms
Introduced in Chapter 69.

el / la
the (masculine / feminine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

el abecedario
the alphabet — twenty-seven letters, and a name built out of the first four of them
Introduced in Chapter 425.

el abogado
the lawyer — Latin advocatus, one called to your side; English advocate is the same word, and it explains what the job originally was
Introduced in Chapter 427.

el abono
pass, season ticket, subscription — the document or right acquired by someone who subscribes; do not confuse it with the separate abono meaning fertilizer
Introduced in Chapter 400.

el abrazo
a hug — from bracchium, the arm: the word says what the body does
Introduced in Chapter 282.

el abrigo
the coat — named for the shelter it gives rather than the shape it has, and the verb behind it once meant to sit in the sun
Introduced in Chapter 468.

el abuelo
the grandfather — Latin avus, the root inside English avuncular and atavistic
Introduced in Chapter 306.

el accidente
the accident — something that falls upon you, where an *ocasión* falls to you
Introduced in Chapter 454.

el aceite
oil — Andalusi Arabic az-zayt, the oil, borrowed with its article fused on; Latin oleum gave English oil, olive, petroleum and linoleum, and the two words meet in aceite de oliva
Introduced in Chapter 361.

el actor
actor — Latin actor, "one who does", from agere "to drive, to do"; the same verb sits inside agent, agenda and action
Introduced in Chapter 421.

el aeropuerto
airport — Greek aēr, air, set on Latin portus, a harbour; the shape matches English airport but cannot prove a loan, since French built aéroport at home
Introduced in Chapter 392.

el agua
water — a word that barely changed from Latin, and takes el without ever stopping being feminine
Introduced in Chapter 143.

el aire
air — Greek aer into Latin aer into Spanish; aerial, aerobic and aerosol are the family, and malaria is Italian mala aria, bad air, a discarded medical theory frozen inside a word
Introduced in Chapter 362.

el ajo
the garlic — Latin allium, which English kept as the botanical name; aioli is this word and oil, run together
Introduced in Chapter 297.

el almacén
the warehouse, the storeroom — an Arabic word with its article still attached
Introduced in Chapter 452.

el amanecer
the daybreak — Latin mane, in the morning, the same piece that sits inside mañana
Introduced in Chapter 289.

el análisis
the test, the analysis — a loosening-apart, and a noun that never changes for plural
Introduced in Chapter 447.

el andén
the platform — the one station word whose history nobody can recover
Introduced in Chapter 439.

el animal
the animal — Latin for a thing with breath in it, and the superordinate word the corpus never had although it taught a dozen creatures
Introduced in Chapter 428.

el aniversario
the anniversary — Latin annus, year, plus vertere, to turn; the year turning back to the same day, and English annual, versus and reverse share the pieces
Introduced in Chapter 349.

el aparcamiento
parking, car park — aparcar plus -miento; aparcar is built in Spanish from parque, not borrowed from English park
Introduced in Chapter 400.

el apellido
the surname — from appellitare, to call on repeatedly; English appeal sits on the same verb
Introduced in Chapter 305.

el apodo
the nickname — from apodar, Latin putare, to prune and so to reckon; English compute, dispute, amputate
Introduced in Chapter 309.

el árbol
tree — Latin arbor, with one of its two r sounds slid away to l
Introduced in Chapter 278.

el armario
wardrobe, cupboard — Latin armārium from arma, which meant tools and gear rather than weapons; arms, army, armour and alarm are cousins, and French armoire is the very same room-word
Introduced in Chapter 366.

el arroz
the rice — Arabic ar-ruzz, carrying its own article; rice is the same grain by a different road
Introduced in Chapter 290.

el ascensor
elevator, lift — Latin ascēnsor, the one who climbs, from ascendere; the form is ancient but the machine sense is French and dates to 1867
Introduced in Chapter 390.

el asiento
the seat — Latin sedere, to sit; English sedentary, session, reside and assess all sit on it
Introduced in Chapter 311.

el asunto
the matter, the affair — Latin assumptus, taken up, from ad + sumere; English assume, resume, consume and presume are all takings
Introduced in Chapter 331.

el autobús
bus — French autobus, auto(móvil) plus (omni)bus; omnibus is the Latin dative plural of omnis, for all, so bus is a case ending left standing after its own word was thrown away
Introduced in Chapter 363.

el avión
aeroplane — Latin avis bird, but borrowed whole from French avion, coined by Clément Ader in 1875; aviation, aviator, aviary, avian, ostrich and auspices are all avis, and el aviso is not
Introduced in Chapter 363.

el aviso
the notice, the warning — from avisar, and Latin ad visum, to what is seen; English advise, advice, vision, evident and provide share the root videre
Introduced in Chapter 332.

el azúcar
sugar — Arabic as-sukkar back through Persian to Sanskrit śarkarā, grit; the a- on the front is the Arabic article, and English sugar came the same road through French
Introduced in Chapter 367.

el baile
dance — from bailar, borrowed from Occitan balar, from Late Latin ballare; English ball, ballet and ballad are the same word, and ball the round thing is not
Introduced in Chapter 377.

el banco
bank — a Germanic word for a bench; the money-changers of medieval Italy worked at a bench, and a broken bench, banca rotta, is English bankrupt
Introduced in Chapter 353.

el baño
the bathroom — Latin balneum from Greek balaneion; English bath only looks related, and is not
Introduced in Chapter 310.

el barco
ship — Late Latin barca, a small boat attested around 400 AD; barge, bark the sailing ship, embark and disembark are the same word, and the three English barks have three separate origins
Introduced in Chapter 363.

el barrio
the neighbourhood — Andalusi Arabic barri, of the outside, from barr, the open land beyond the walls; English borrowed barrio whole
Introduced in Chapter 325.

el bebé
the baby — French bebe, echoic babble, the same kind of word as English baby and babble
Introduced in Chapter 309.

el beso
kiss — Latin basium, which the Academy's dictionary says Latin itself took from Celtic; French baiser and Italian bacio are the same word
Introduced in Chapter 375.

el boleto
the ticket — a little bulla, a Latin seal; the same seal gives English bulletin and the papal bull
Introduced in Chapter 313.

el bolso
the handbag — one letter away from la bolsa, which is a different thing, and the vowel is the whole difference
Introduced in Chapter 430.

el bombero
the firefighter — named from la bomba, the pump, so Spanish calls them the pump-person while English calls them the fire-person
Introduced in Chapter 427.

el bosque
the wood — a Germanic word, not a Latin one; bush, bosky and ambush are its English cousins
Introduced in Chapter 291.

el botón
button — Old French boton, a thing that pushes out, from bouter, to thrust, taken from Germanic botan, to strike; button, buttress, rebut, abut and the butting of a goat all still push, and beat is the inherited cousin
Introduced in Chapter 360.

el brazo
the arm — Greek brakhion, "the shorter one", taken into Latin as bracchium; an embrace and a bracelet are both built on it
Introduced in Chapter 314.

el burro
the donkey — Latin burricus, a little reddish horse, from burrus, red; English borrowed the whole word back, and the burrito with it
Introduced in Chapter 296.

el caballo
the horse — Latin caballus, the working nag, which beat the noble equus and left cavalry and chivalry behind it
Introduced in Chapter 296.

el calendario
the calendar — Latin calendarium, an account book, from calendae the first of the month when debts fell due; English calendar and intercalate share it
Introduced in Chapter 343.

el calor
heat — Latin calor from calere, to be warm; English calorie, cauldron, scald, chowder and nonchalant are all built on it
Introduced in Chapter 334.

el camarero
waiter — Greek kamára, a vault, into Latin camera and Vulgar Latin camara, giving Spanish cámara, a room; whether camarero was built inside Spanish or borrowed from Medieval Latin camarārius cannot be told apart
Introduced in Chapter 391.

el cambio
the change — Latin cambiare, borrowed from Gaulish; English change and exchange are the same word, and so is the coin you get back
Introduced in Chapter 313.

el camino
the road, the way — Late Latin camminus, borrowed from Gaulish; one of the few Celtic words Spanish kept, and the source of French chemin
Introduced in Chapter 330.

el campo
the field, the countryside — Latin campus, flat open ground; camp, campus, campaign and champion are all fought or pitched on it
Introduced in Chapter 299.

el cargador
the charger — the doer-ending a fourth time, on a verb worth having in its own right
Introduced in Chapter 434.

el cargo
the charge on a bill — a load, from the same cart as *el carrito*
Introduced in Chapter 456.

el carné
the card, the licence — four folded sheets that turned into a piece of plastic
Introduced in Chapter 451.

el carrito
the trolley — a little cart, and the ending Spanish uses more than almost any other
Introduced in Chapter 444.

el centro
centre, downtown — Latin centrum from Greek kentron, the spike a compass turns on; English centre, central, concentrate and eccentric all turn on it
Introduced in Chapter 347.

el cepillo
brush — a diminutive of cepo, from Latin cippus, a post or block of wood; the brush is named for its back, not its bristles
Introduced in Chapter 374.

el cerdo
pig — most likely from cerda, a bristle, so the bristly one; Spanish also kept puerco from Latin porcus, which English has as pork and as the older farrow
Introduced in Chapter 368.

el césped
the lawn, the pitch — grass as a surface somebody looks after
Introduced in Chapter 450.

el chico
the boy, the lad — Latin ciccum, a worthless trifle; a word that means small first and boy second
Introduced in Chapter 308.

el chocolate
chocolate — Nahuatl, but the Academy marks the etymology disputed; the famous xocolātl is unattested, and chicolātl, named for the whisking stick, is the live proposal
Introduced in Chapter 376.

el cielo
the sky — Latin caelum, which is also the ceiling over a room and the cerulean of a paint box
Introduced in Chapter 289.

el cine
cinema — short for cinematografo, Greek kinema movement plus graphein to write, a movement-writer; the same kinein is in English kinetic
Introduced in Chapter 354.

el circo
circus — Latin circus “ring”, from Greek kirkos; the ring is the oldest part of the idea and the only part still round
Introduced in Chapter 420.

el cliente, la cliente
client; customer — the person who buys or uses a service
Introduced in Chapter 406.

el coche
car — Hungarian kocsi, a cart from the town of Kocs, by way of German Kutsche and French coche; English coach is the same word, and the coach on the touchline began as a tutor who carried a student through
Introduced in Chapter 363.

el cocinero
the cook — coquere, to cook; the kitchen, the biscuit and a precocious child are all in it
Introduced in Chapter 285.

el color
colour — Latin color, from celare to hide, because a colour is what covers a thing; conceal, cell, occult and even hell are the same hiding
Introduced in Chapter 358.

el compañero
the colleague — the word whose story you were told when you learned bread, finally given to you as a word
Introduced in Chapter 436.

el comportamiento
behaviour — carrying yourself, with the same portare that carries goods in and out
Introduced in Chapter 466.

el comprador
the buyer — the other half of a sale, built from comprar with the same ending, so the pair costs one rule rather than two words
Introduced in Chapter 427.

el concierto
concert
Introduced in Chapter 413.

el conjunto
the set, the whole group — Latin coniunctus, yoked together, from com and iungere; English junction, join and even yoga come off the same yoking
Introduced in Chapter 352.

el consejo
advice, and also a council — Latin consilium; English counsel and council are the same word that stopped being one
Introduced in Chapter 321.

el contador
the meter — the same doer-ending a second time, on the verb for counting, and the word on every notice about the water
Introduced in Chapter 432.

el contrato
the contract — two parties drawn together, and the verb that still does the drawing
Introduced in Chapter 441.

el corazón
heart — Latin cor, cordis with a Spanish augmentative ending; cordial, courage, accord and discord are all hearts, and record is literally to bring a thing back to the heart
Introduced in Chapter 364.

el correo electrónico
email — correo is not built on correr but comes through Catalan correu from Old French corlieu, a messenger; electrónico goes back to Greek ēlektron, amber, and the pair renders English electronic mail
Introduced in Chapter 393.

el coste
the cost — the noun that belongs to *costar*, and what it stands on
Introduced in Chapter 456.

el cuaderno
the notebook — a counting word underneath, because the oldest notebook was four sheets folded once
Introduced in Chapter 465.

el cuarto
the quarter, a fourth — Latin quartus, fourth, on quattuor four; English quarter, quart, quartet and quarantine all count to four
Introduced in Chapter 342.

el cuchillo
the knife — Latin cultellus, a little culter; cutlery, cutlass and the plough's coulter are the same blade
Introduced in Chapter 294.

el cuello
the neck — Latin collum, which is also the collar round it and the accolade thrown round it
Introduced in Chapter 293.

el cuidado
care, caution — Latin cogitatum, a thing thought about, from cogitare to think; English cogitate and Descartes' cogito are the same verb
Introduced in Chapter 333.

el cumpleaños
the birthday — the same day as an aniversario, named by the opposite metaphor
Introduced in Chapter 440.

el currículum
the CV — a Latin word that kept its Latin ending, and the first thing a job advert asks you to send
Introduced in Chapter 435.

el curso
course, class
Introduced in Chapter 417.

el dato
piece of information; datum
Introduced in Chapter 406.

el dedo
finger, and equally toe — Latin digitus; digit became a numeral because people count on fingers, and digital reached the computer through the numerals rather than through the hand
Introduced in Chapter 364.

el dentista / la dentista
the dentist — an -ista noun, where only the article changes
Introduced in Chapter 464.

el deporte
sport
Introduced in Chapter 412.

el desayuno
breakfast — des- undoing ayuno, a fast; English breakfast says the same thing in Germanic words, and dinner is the borrowed Romance version of it
Introduced in Chapter 367.

el descanso
the rest — des- undoes cansar, to tire; rest in Spanish is defined as the reversal of being worn down
Introduced in Chapter 315.

el destino
destination, fate, and a job posting — from destinar, a learned borrowing of Latin dēstinā̄re, to make firm or fix in place, on the stā̄re that also stands behind estar
Introduced in Chapter 392.

el diente
the tooth — Latin dentem, with the e broken to ie; a dandelion is a dent de lion, a lion's tooth
Introduced in Chapter 314.

el dinero
money — the name of a Roman coin, still doing service two thousand years later
Introduced in Chapter 280.

el director / la directora
the head, the director — the -tor noun you were shown in a table, now the person who signs the letter
Introduced in Chapter 466.

el doctor / la doctora
doctor
Introduced in Chapter 408.

el documento
document — a written record or proof
Introduced in Chapter 406.

el dolor
the pain — Latin dolor; condolence hurts with you, and indolent once felt no pain at all
Introduced in Chapter 286.

el dormitorio
the bedroom — built on a verb you learned in the first weeks
Introduced in Chapter 455.

el edificio
building — Latin aedificium, from aedes, temple or house, plus facere, to make; English edifice and edify are the same word
Introduced in Chapter 378.

el entrenamiento
the training session — and the train you already know, hiding inside it
Introduced in Chapter 450.

el envío
the shipment — what enviar leaves behind, and a road hidden inside the verb
Introduced in Chapter 442.

el esposo
the husband — Latin spondere, to pledge solemnly; English spouse, sponsor, respond, despondent
Introduced in Chapter 306.

el estado
the state, the condition — Latin status, which only looks like estar's participle, and the phrase a donation notice already used on you
Introduced in Chapter 473.

el euro
the currency — the Academy derives it as a clipping of europeo, and files the Greek wind eurus as a separate, unrelated entry under the same spelling
Introduced in Chapter 391.

el examen
exam, examination
Introduced in Chapter 410.

el extranjero
abroad, a foreign country; a foreign person
Introduced in Chapter 415.

el faro
the lighthouse — named after Pharos, the island at Alexandria that held the first one; a place name that became the word for the thing
Introduced in Chapter 302.

el favor
a favour, a good turn — Latin favere, to be well disposed toward somebody; English favour, favourite and favourable are all the same word
Introduced in Chapter 320.

el fin
the end — Latin finis, a boundary stone between fields; English final, finish, finite, define and confine all mark the same edge
Introduced in Chapter 348.

el fin de semana
the weekend
Introduced in Chapter 409.

el fondo
the bottom, the back of a room — Latin fundus, the bottom of a thing; English found, foundation, fund and profound all sit on it, and Spanish hondo is the same word with f turned to h
Introduced in Chapter 355.

el freno
the brake — named after the bit in a horse's mouth, and still doing that job
Introduced in Chapter 449.

el frío
cold — Latin frigidus; English frigid, refrigerate and refrigerator are the same word, and hace frio has been carrying this noun all along
Introduced in Chapter 334.

el fuego
fire — Latin focus, which meant the hearth and not the fire at all; focus, focal, curfew and fuel all come down from that hearth, while the Latin word for fire itself lost the fight across Romance
Introduced in Chapter 362.

el ganado
the livestock — from ganar, to gain: cattle are simply "what has been gained", the way English cattle and chattel are what you own
Introduced in Chapter 299.

el garaje
the garage — a French word wearing a Spanish spelling, and the floor of the building most notices are about
Introduced in Chapter 433.

el gimnasio
gym, gymnasium
Introduced in Chapter 412.

el golpe
the blow — and de golpe, all at once, which is the phrase a payment plan is defined against
Introduced in Chapter 474.

el gorro
brimless cap — a round or close-fitting head covering, of uncertain origin
Introduced in Chapter 402.

el grado
the degree — the unit la temperatura was missing, and the word the degree scale was named after without ever being shown to you
Introduced in Chapter 468.

el gramo
a gram — Greek gramma, a written thing and also a small weight, from graphein to scratch; grammar, program, diagram and telegram are the same gramma
Introduced in Chapter 359.

el grupo
the group — a short plain word that came in whole, and the unit a course or a trip is organised into
Introduced in Chapter 436.

el guante
glove — Germanic rather than Latin, probably through Catalan from Frankish want, a mitten, arriving already wearing the gu- Romance gives Germanic w-
Introduced in Chapter 374.

el guía / la guía
the guide and the guidebook — the article decides which
Introduced in Chapter 463.

el guion
the hyphen — shorter than la raya and with a different job, and a word whose own spelling the Academy changed
Introduced in Chapter 424.

el guion bajo
the underscore — the low hyphen, named by position rather than by shape, and the last piece an address can contain
Introduced in Chapter 428.

el hambre
hunger — Latin famen from fames; a feminine noun that takes el before its stressed a-, and one of the f-to-h words like hacer, hijo and hierro
Introduced in Chapter 334.

el helado
ice cream; frozen
Introduced in Chapter 411.

el hermano, la hermana
brother and sister — NOT from frater/soror, but from an adjective meaning “of the same seed”
Introduced in Chapter 140.

el hielo
ice — Latin gelu; English gelatin, jelly, congeal and gelid are the same word, and the h- here is a spelling habit, not the f- that hides in humo
Introduced in Chapter 370.

el hijo
the son — Latin filius, cousin to English filial and affiliate; the f- that became a silent h-
Introduced in Chapter 306.

el hilo
the thread — Latin filum with its f worn down to a silent h; filament, filigree and a file of soldiers are all threads
Introduced in Chapter 301.

el hombro
the shoulder — Latin umerus, which doctors still call the humerus; the h is silent and came late
Introduced in Chapter 293.

el horario
the timetable, the opening hours — Latin horarium, on hora an hour; English hour, horoscope and horology come off the same root, and the -ario ending is English -ary
Introduced in Chapter 342.

el horno
the oven — Latin furnus, wearing the silent h that marks where an f used to stand; furnace is the same fire
Introduced in Chapter 297.

el hospital
hospital — Latin hospitale, a house kept for guests, from hospes, which meant the host and the guest at once; English host, hotel, hostel and hospitality all come off it
Introduced in Chapter 353.

el hotel
hotel — French hotel, from Old French hostel, from the same Latin hospitale as hospital; the little hat on the French o is a headstone for a lost s
Introduced in Chapter 354.

el huevo
egg — Latin ovum, wearing an h that exists only to help your eyes
Introduced in Chapter 280.

el humo
smoke — Latin fumus, a clean example of Latin f- turning into Spanish h-; English has fume, perfume and fumigate from the same word
Introduced in Chapter 369.

el humor
mood, and humour — one word for both, because your temperament was once a fluid
Introduced in Chapter 440.

el idioma
language — Greek idioma, a peculiarity of style, from idios, one's own; idiom, idiosyncrasy and idiot are all from the same idios
Introduced in Chapter 377.

el importe
the amount — the third sense of importar, and the one a bill uses
Introduced in Chapter 474.

el impreso
printed form — a sheet with spaces to fill in
Introduced in Chapter 406.

el instante
the instant — Latin instans, standing upon you, from in plus stare; English instant, instance and constant all stand on the same verb
Introduced in Chapter 348.

el instituto
the secondary school — the false friend that sends English speakers to the wrong building, because an English institute is a research body and a Spanish one is where you go at twelve
Introduced in Chapter 429.

el inventario
the stocktake — a list of what was found, from *venir*
Introduced in Chapter 459.

el invitado
a guest — the invited one; Spanish names the person by what was done to him
Introduced in Chapter 282.

el jabón
soap — Latin sapo, which Latin had itself borrowed from its northern neighbours
Introduced in Chapter 287.

el jardín
garden — Frankish gardo, an enclosure, the same Germanic word English kept as yard and borrowed back from French as garden; kindergarten is a children's enclosure
Introduced in Chapter 354.

el jefe
the boss — a head, and the same head as *la cabeza*
Introduced in Chapter 462.

el jersey
the jumper — an English word for an island, borrowed whole, and then made to follow Spanish accent rules in the plural
Introduced in Chapter 430.

el kilo
a kilo — Greek khilioi, a thousand; it is not Latin mille, so kilo and the mil of mil gracias are two unrelated thousands
Introduced in Chapter 359.

el labio
lip — Latin labium, the same word as English labial; English lip is Germanic, and the old Indo-European link between them is now doubted
Introduced in Chapter 375.

el lado
side
Introduced in Chapter 407.

el lago
the lake — Latin lacus; lake, lagoon and lacuna are all the same standing water
Introduced in Chapter 292.

el lápiz
pencil — Latin lapis, a stone, with no diminutive in it; lapis opens lapis lazuli, and Spanish azul comes from the other half
Introduced in Chapter 374.

el libro
book — named after the part of a tree people wrote on before paper
Introduced in Chapter 57.

el litro
a litre — Greek litra, a Sicilian unit, the same word Latin took as libra, the pound; a pound is still abbreviated lb, and Libra is the scales in the sky
Introduced in Chapter 359.

el llanto
the weeping — Latin planctus, a beating; Roman mourners struck their own chest, and pl- became ll- on the way into Spanish
Introduced in Chapter 316.

el lobo
wolf — Latin lupus, which is irregular for the ancient word it should be and probably reached Rome from a neighbouring Italian dialect; English wolf is the inherited cousin
Introduced in Chapter 368.

el lugar
the place, the spot — Latin locus through localis; the same locus is already inside hasta luego and en primer lugar
Introduced in Chapter 325.

el maestro
the teacher — magister, from magis, more; and minister, from minus, less
Introduced in Chapter 285.

el maíz
maize — Taíno mahis, one of the first American words to reach Europe, and the word Spanish handed on to English as maize
Introduced in Chapter 376.

el mango
the handle — a cousin of la mano, and a homonym of the fruit in the way la cola taught
Introduced in Chapter 470.

el mapa
the map — Latin mappa, a cloth; the world was drawn on a napkin, and napkin is the same word
Introduced in Chapter 312.

el mar
sea — Latin mare; marine, maritime, marina and ultramarine are borrowed from it, while the mer- of mermaid and the words marsh and moor are inherited English cousins of the same ancient root
Introduced in Chapter 362.

el medicamento
the medicine — the word on the box, built on the doctor you already know
Introduced in Chapter 457.

el médico
doctor — Latin medicus, a physician, from medeor, to heal; a word taken off the page, still carrying whole the three beats that Catalan metge wore away
Introduced in Chapter 394.

el menú
the set meal, and the card it is printed on — French menu, small and detailed, from Latin minūtus, made small; menudo and minuto are that same Latin word by two other roads
Introduced in Chapter 391.

el mercado
market — Latin mercatus from merx, goods; English market, merchant, commerce and even mercy grow out of the same trade
Introduced in Chapter 346.

el metro
a metre — Greek metron, a measure, as in diameter and geometry; the underground metro is a different word, short for metropolitano, from meter a mother plus polis a city
Introduced in Chapter 359.

el miedo
the fear — Latin metus, with the e broken to ie; meticulous once meant full of fear
Introduced in Chapter 315.

el minuto
the minute — Latin minutus, made small, from minuere to lessen; English minute, minor, minus, diminish and minuscule are the same smallness
Introduced in Chapter 342.

el modo
the way, the mode — Latin modus, a measure; English mode, model, modern, modest and moderate are measurings, and Spanish como is quomodo, in what measure
Introduced in Chapter 331.

el momento
a moment — Latin momentum, the smallest movement that tips a balance
Introduced in Chapter 303.

el móvil
mobile phone — literally the movable one, from Latin mobilis
Introduced in Chapter 404.

el mundo
the world — Latin mundus, meaning clean and orderly; English mundane is the same word, and Greek kosmos made the identical jump from order to world
Introduced in Chapter 330.

el museo
museum — Greek mouseion, a seat of the Muses; the Mouseion at Alexandria was a place scholars lived and worked, and the same Muses are inside English music
Introduced in Chapter 353.

el niño
the boy, the child — a nursery word with no Latin pedigree, and the one English borrowed whole as El Niño
Introduced in Chapter 308.

el nivel
the level — a cousin of el litro through Latin libra, the balance, because a level is a little pair of scales
Introduced in Chapter 471.

el nombre
the name — Latin nomen, cousin to English name and root of noun and nominate
Introduced in Chapter 305.

el norte
north — Germanic northa through Old French nord; this is literally the English word north, borrowed back into a Romance language
Introduced in Chapter 347.

el nudo
knot — Latin nodus by way of an irregular Vulgar Latin form; desnudo, naked, is a different Latin word, and Corominas denies the two ever merged
Introduced in Chapter 374.

el número
the number — Latin numerus; English number, numeral, numerous, enumerate and numb all come off it
Introduced in Chapter 344.

el objetivo
the target, the objective — el objeto wearing -ivo, narrowed to the thing placed in front to be reached
Introduced in Chapter 467.

el objeto
the object, the thing — Latin objectum, thrown before, from ob and iacere to throw; English object, project, inject, eject and subject are all throws
Introduced in Chapter 345.

el oeste
west — Germanic westaz through Old French ouest; the same word as English west, and behind it the old root for evening that also gives vespers
Introduced in Chapter 347.

el oído
the hearing, the inner ear — the past participle of oír made into a noun; Latin audire is under audio, audience and obedient
Introduced in Chapter 314.

el ojo
the eye — Latin oculus; English eye is its distant cousin, not a translation of it
Introduced in Chapter 286.

el ordenador
computer, in Spain — Latin ōrdinātor, the one who puts things in order; the word is old and Spanish, but the computing sense was taken from French ordinateur in the mid-1950s
Introduced in Chapter 393.

el oro
gold — Latin aurum, from an ancient root for shining and dawning; aurora is the same root, and so, far back, is the English word east
Introduced in Chapter 373.

el padre, la madre
father and mother — among the oldest reconstructible words in the whole family
Introduced in Chapter 140.

el país
the country — Late Latin pagensis, of the country district, from pagus a village; English pagan and peasant are both country-dwellers
Introduced in Chapter 325.

el pan
bread — and the compañero who shares it with you
Introduced in Chapter 143.

el pantalón
trousers — French pantalon, from Pantalone, the Venetian comic stock character and his long tight legwear; English pantaloons, clipped to pants, is the very same word
Introduced in Chapter 360.

el papel
the paper — from papyrus, the reed the Egyptians wrote on; it also means the part an actor plays, because the part was written on one
Introduced in Chapter 301.

el paquete
package, parcel
Introduced in Chapter 415.

el paraguas
the umbrella — the para- of la parada, fused to a plural noun the way cumpleaños was, and invariable for the reason el análisis gave
Introduced in Chapter 470.

el pariente
the relative — Latin parere, to give birth; English parent and postpartum, and a false friend worth knowing
Introduced in Chapter 309.

el parque
park — Frankish parrik, an enclosure, through Medieval Latin parricus; a park was a fence before it was grass, and the English dialect word paddock is the same fence
Introduced in Chapter 354.

el partido
the match, and the political party — both of them a side split off
Introduced in Chapter 446.

el pasajero
passenger, and passing or fleeting — pasaje plus -ero, on pasar from Vulgar Latin passāre, from passus, a step; an adjective first, and without the intruding n of English passenger
Introduced in Chapter 392.

el pasaporte
the passport — pass plus port; the paper that lets you through the gate, from Latin passus and porta
Introduced in Chapter 313.

el pastor
the shepherd — from pascere, to graze; the pasture, the pastor of a church and a repast are all feeding
Introduced in Chapter 299.

el patio
the courtyard — a word Spanish gave the world, and cannot account for itself
Introduced in Chapter 450.

el pecho
the chest — Latin pectus, whose ct became ch on the same road that took noctem to noche; English keeps the Latin in pectoral
Introduced in Chapter 315.

el pedido
the order — the thing you have asked a shop to send, named from the verb for asking
Introduced in Chapter 431.

el peine
comb — Latin pecten; the same Latin family may reach the words for money, since pecuniary and peculiar are built on the word for livestock
Introduced in Chapter 373.

el permiso
permission, leave — Latin permissus from permittere, per + mittere, to let go through; English permit, mission, transmit, submit and promise are all sendings
Introduced in Chapter 332.

el pescado
fish as food — Latin piscātus, the catch, from piscārī to fish, on piscis; Pisces and piscine are borrowed, English fish is the inherited cousin, and pecado sin is a different word entirely
Introduced in Chapter 361.

el peso
weight — Latin pensum, a thing weighed out, from pendere to weigh and to hang; pension, spend, expensive, pendant and ponder are all still weighing something
Introduced in Chapter 359.

el pie
the foot — Latin pedem, from a root so old that Hindi pair, Persian pa and English foot are all the same word
Introduced in Chapter 314.

el pimiento
pepper — from pimienta, Latin pigmenta, which passed from colouring matter through drug and ingredient to condiment; the American pepper took the Old World name
Introduced in Chapter 376.

el piso
floor, storey, flat — from pisar, to tread, from Late Latin pinsare to pound; English pestle and piston are the same pounding, and in Spain un piso is a flat
Introduced in Chapter 355.

el placer
pleasure — Latin placere, to please; English please, placid, plea and placebo are all the same verb
Introduced in Chapter 321.

el plato
a plate — Greek platys, flat: the same flatness in a plaza and in a platypus
Introduced in Chapter 287.

el plazo
the deadline, the instalment — a term that was agreed, from the same root as *el placer*
Introduced in Chapter 458.

el policía
the police officer — Greek polis, the city, so the word names the person by the thing they keep in order; and the article changes what it means
Introduced in Chapter 427.

el polideportivo
the sports centre — one building, many sports, and the word says so
Introduced in Chapter 438.

el pollo
chicken — the food word to keep distinct from polvo, dust
Introduced in Chapter 403.

el polvo
dust — Latin pulvis; English took the same word twice, powder through French with a d that was never in it, and pulverize straight off the Latin
Introduced in Chapter 369.

el portal
the entrance hall — the door made big, and the part of a Spanish building that has no tidy English name
Introduced in Chapter 433.

el postre
dessert — the Latin family of post, after, with posterus and postrēmus behind it; Corominas makes postre a back-formation out of the phrase a la postre, the dessert sense documented in 1561
Introduced in Chapter 391.

el prado
meadow — Latin pratum; English prairie is the same word through French, and Madrid's museum is named for the meadow it stands on
Introduced in Chapter 378.

el precio
the price — Latin pretium, worth; English price, precious, appreciate and praise all come off it
Introduced in Chapter 311.

el préstamo
the loan — the noun the lending cycle was missing, and the word for a borrowed word
Introduced in Chapter 441.

el primo
the cousin — Latin primus, first; the same root as primero, and as English prime and primary
Introduced in Chapter 307.

el principiante
the beginner — el principio plus the -ante ending el estudiante already taught you to build with
Introduced in Chapter 471.

el principio
the beginning — Latin principium from princeps, the one who takes first place; English prince, principal and principle are the same first taking
Introduced in Chapter 348.

el proveedor
the supplier — the third party a shop blames when your order is late, and the reason this word turns up in complaints
Introduced in Chapter 431.

el pueblo
the village, and also the people — Latin populus, which gave popular, population and public
Introduced in Chapter 292.

el puente
the bridge — Latin pontem; a pontoon floats one and a pontiff is, underneath, a bridge-builder
Introduced in Chapter 295.

el puerto
the harbour — Latin portus, the twin of the porta you already have; import, export and opportunity are all ships coming in
Introduced in Chapter 302.

el pulgar
thumb — Latin pollicaris, which meant an inch long, from pollex; the same word gives Spanish pulgada, an inch
Introduced in Chapter 375.

el punto
the full stop — one mark with three jobs, and the job it is doing is decided by what comes after it rather than by the mark itself
Introduced in Chapter 424.

el punto
the point, the dot — Latin punctum, a prick, from pungere to prick; English point, puncture, punctual, punctuation and pungent share the needle
Introduced in Chapter 342.

el queso
cheese — Latin caseus, the very same word as English cheese by another road
Introduced in Chapter 280.

el rato
a while, a short time — Latin raptus, a snatching, from rapere to seize; English rapid, rapt, rapture and ravish are all seizures
Introduced in Chapter 331.

el regalo
a present — from regalar, French regaler, on Old French gale, merry-making; English gala and to regale a guest are the same fun, and it has nothing to do with king or regal
Introduced in Chapter 357.

el reloj
the clock — Greek horologium, the hour-teller; the same hora sits in English hour and horoscope
Introduced in Chapter 312.

el remedio
the remedy — re- and mederi, to heal again; medicine, medical and a medic are all the same healing
Introduced in Chapter 300.

el respeto
respect — Latin respicere, to look back at somebody; the same specere gives English spectacle, inspect and suspect
Introduced in Chapter 321.

el restaurante
restaurant — French restaurant, a thing that restores, from Latin restaurare; the first restaurant was a broth sold to people who felt weak, and the room took the name of the soup
Introduced in Chapter 354.

el resto
the rest, what is left — Latin restare, to stand back, from re and stare; English rest and arrest stand on the same verb
Introduced in Chapter 352.

el retraso
the delay — the word a station announcement, a courier and an apology all reach for
Introduced in Chapter 431.

el rincón
the inside corner of a room — Arabic rukn, a corner or a supporting pillar; the street corner, la esquina, is Latin, so Spanish gets its two corners from two languages
Introduced in Chapter 355.

el río
river — Latin rivus, a stream, which gave rival and derive; English river is not this word at all but comes from ripa, a bank, the same word behind arrive
Introduced in Chapter 369.

el ruido
the noise — Latin rugitus, a roaring, from rugire to roar; the same root gave English rut, the roaring season of deer
Introduced in Chapter 333.

el saludo
a greeting — from salutem, health: to greet was to wish someone their health
Introduced in Chapter 282.

el seguimiento
tracking, follow-up — the -miento ending on a verb you have had for chapters
Introduced in Chapter 452.

el sendero
the path — Latin semita, a by-way, with semi- meaning half: a path is a half-road
Introduced in Chapter 295.

el servicio
the service — and, on a door, the toilet
Introduced in Chapter 454.

el siglo
the century, the age — Latin saeculum, a generation or a lifetime; English secular is the same word, meaning of this age rather than of eternity
Introduced in Chapter 343.

el silencio
the silence — Latin silentium from silere, to be still; English silence, silent and the silent film all come off it unchanged
Introduced in Chapter 333.

el sobrino
nephew — Latin sobrinus, a cousin on the mother's side, built on soror, sister; English cousin is the prefixed consobrinus
Introduced in Chapter 375.

el sofá
the sofa — the one word in this chapter you could not have built, and the stress that keeps its accent
Introduced in Chapter 432.

el sueño
the sleep, and the dream — Latin somnus with the o broken to ue; insomnia and somnolent keep the o intact
Introduced in Chapter 300.

el supermercado
supermarket — a calque of English supermarket, American and dated 1933, built on mercado, which Spanish inherited from Latin mercātus, from mercārī, to trade, from merx, wares
Introduced in Chapter 391.

el sur
south — Germanic sunthaz through Old French sud; the same word as English south, and probably built on the word for sun
Introduced in Chapter 347.

el taladro
the drill — the loudest thing a neighbour owns, and a word worth knowing before they use it
Introduced in Chapter 449.

el taller
the workshop — where a thing goes to be mended, and also the name of a short course
Introduced in Chapter 434.

el tamaño
size — Latin tam magnum, so big, welded shut; the tam is the tan inside tambien and tampoco, and magnus is the magn- of magnify and magnitude
Introduced in Chapter 358.

el teatro
theatre — Greek theatron, a place for viewing, from theaomai "to behold"; the same root sits inside the English word theory
Introduced in Chapter 420.

el techo
roof, ceiling — Latin tectum, the covered part, from tegere to cover; to protect is to cover in front, to detect is to take the cover off, and a Roman toga was a covering
Introduced in Chapter 355.

el teléfono
the telephone — Greek tele far plus phone voice; a far-voice, and both halves are everywhere in English
Introduced in Chapter 312.

el tenedor
the fork — built on tener, to hold: it is "the holder", the same shape as any Spanish word ending in -dor
Introduced in Chapter 297.

el ticket
the receipt — a word that went to England, changed jobs, and came back
Introduced in Chapter 451.

el tiempo
the one noun that covers both "time" and "weather" — because Latin tempus already did
Introduced in Chapter 148.

el tío
the uncle — Greek theios, borrowed into Late Latin; the word English did not take, because English took avunculus instead
Introduced in Chapter 307.

el tipo
the kind, the sort — Greek typos, a blow and the dent a blow leaves; English type, typical, typography and prototype all take the same impression
Introduced in Chapter 350.

el tobillo
the ankle — from Latin tuber, a swelling; a tuber in the ground and a protuberance are the same lump
Introduced in Chapter 293.

el tomate
the tomato — Nahuatl tomatl, one of the words Spanish carried back across the Atlantic
Introduced in Chapter 290.

el toro
bull — Latin taurus, most likely taken from a language spoken before Latin; English Taurus and toreador come from it, and steer may or may not belong with it
Introduced in Chapter 368.

el trabajo
work, a job — a reconstructed Vulgar Latin *tripaliāre, to torture, on Late Latin tripalium, an instrument of torture attested in a church canon of 578; English travail is the same word*
Introduced in Chapter 394.

el tren
train — borrowed from French train, a thing drawn along, from traîner to drag; keep it sharply apart from tres, three
Introduced in Chapter 400.

el trigo
the wheat — Latin triticum, the rubbed grain, from terere, to rub; trite is worn down the same way
Introduced in Chapter 290.

el triple
triple, three times as much — Latin triplus, three plus the -plus that means fold; English triple, treble and triplicate are all three folds
Introduced in Chapter 351.

el tronco
the trunk — Latin truncus, meaning lopped or maimed; to truncate is to do it on purpose
Introduced in Chapter 291.

el trueno
thunder — from a Latin word for a thunderclap, with an r that wandered in; English thunder is the inherited cousin, and tornado is a mangled Spanish tronada
Introduced in Chapter 370.

el turno
the turn, your slot — Greek tornos, a lathe, through Latin tornus; English turn, tour, tournament, contour and tornado all spin off it
Introduced in Chapter 348.

el usuario
the user — usar plus the -ario ending, and the word a service uses for the people it serves
Introduced in Chapter 472.

el valle
the valley — Latin vallis; valley, vale and avalanche all come down the same slope
Introduced in Chapter 292.

el vaso
a glass — Latin vas, a vessel: named for what it does, not for what it is made of
Introduced in Chapter 287.

el vecino
the neighbour — from vicus, a village street: the person off your own block
Introduced in Chapter 285.

el vendedor
the seller — vender plus the same -dor ending that turned trabajar into trabajador, which is how Spanish makes a person out of an action
Introduced in Chapter 427.

el vestido
dress — Latin vestire, to clothe, its past participle standing alone as a noun; vest, invest, divest and travesty are all still clothing something, and wear is the inherited cousin
Introduced in Chapter 360.

el viaje
the journey — Latin viaticum, the provisions you packed for the road
Introduced in Chapter 288.

el viento
wind — Latin ventus, and the English word that is its cousin rather than its borrowing
Introduced in Chapter 278.

el vino
wine — one Latin root that reached English by three separate roads, plus one English built at home
Introduced in Chapter 143.

el volcán
volcano — through Portuguese volcão from Latin Vulcanus, the Roman god of fire and the forge
Introduced in Chapter 378.

el vuelo
flight — the noun built from volar, to fly; for travel, the route an aeroplane covers from origin to destination
Introduced in Chapter 400.

el wifi
Wi-Fi — a brand name coined to echo Hi-Fi, with Wireless Fidelity attached later as marketing
Introduced in Chapter 404.

el zapato
shoe — origin genuinely unknown; Portuguese sapato, Catalan sabata, French savate, Italian ciabatta and Arabic sabbat all share it, and the famous sabotage story attached to it is false
Introduced in Chapter 360.

empezar
to begin — from pieza, a piece; English begin is a different word built on the same idea
Introduced in Chapter 382.

empujar
to push — probably late Latin impulsare, though both dictionaries hedge; English push is a cousin, not the same word
Introduced in Chapter 388.

en efecto
indeed — from ex and facere, carried out; it confirms what somebody has just said, and does not mean "in effect"
Introduced in Chapter 298.

en medio
in the middle
Introduced in Chapter 407.

en mi opinión
in my opinion
Introduced in Chapter 270.

en primer lugar
in the first place, firstly
Introduced in Chapter 273.

en resumen
in short — and the last thing this book asks of you
Introduced in Chapter 277.

encantado
delighted to meet you — Latin incantare, to sing a spell into; English enchanted
Introduced in Chapter 305.

encargar
to order in, to put somebody in charge — the cart again, with a prefix
Introduced in Chapter 457.

encontrar
to find — literally to come up against, and the o that breaks into ue exactly as mostrar's does
Introduced in Chapter 470.

enfermo
ill — Latin infirmus, not firm; the same word as English infirm
Introduced in Chapter 304.

enfrente
opposite, across from, facing — Latin frontem, the forehead; English front, frontier, affront, confront and effrontery all come off the same brow
Introduced in Chapter 340.

enseguida
right away — en seguida, "in what follows," from Latin sequi, to follow; English sequence, sequel and pursue come off the same verb
Introduced in Chapter 322.

enseñar
to teach, and to show — to put a sign into somebody, which is one act in Spanish
Introduced in Chapter 445.

entender
to understand — literally "to stretch toward"; the second e→ie stem-changer
Introduced in Chapter 154.

entero
whole, entire — Latin integer, untouched, from in not plus tangere to touch; English integer, integrity and intact are the same untouched thing
Introduced in Chapter 352.

entonces
then — Latin in tunc, "at that time"; tunc and English then both grow out of the old pointing word that also gives the, that and there
Introduced in Chapter 323.

entrar
to go in — Latin intrāre, from intrā, within; the short i dropped to e in words carried by mouth, while the prefix intra- kept its i, and English enter, entrance and interior are the same root
Introduced in Chapter 395.

entregar
to hand in, to deliver — to give a thing over whole
Introduced in Chapter 458.

enviar
to send — Latin inviare, to put on the road, from via; not related to envy
Introduced in Chapter 384.

equivocarse
to get it wrong — two Latin pieces meaning "equal voice", and the verb a shop uses to admit a mistake
Introduced in Chapter 437.

es decir
that is to say — the same idea in your own words
Introduced in Chapter 277.

es que...
it's just that…
Introduced in Chapter 272.

escaso
scarce, in short supply — Vulgar Latin excarpsus, picked over, from ex and carpere to pluck; English scarce, excerpt and carpet are the same plucking
Introduced in Chapter 352.

escribir
to write — from a Latin verb meaning "to scratch", and the reason Spanish puts an e- in front
Introduced in Chapter 156.

ese
that one, by you — the slot Latin's iste left empty when Spanish moved it, filled by a word that used to mean self
Introduced in Chapter 222.

español
"Spanish" — the language, the people, and the Roman name for the peninsula underneath it
Introduced in Chapter 22.

esperar
to wait — and to hope, and to expect, all in one verb
Introduced in Chapter 174.

espero viajar
I hope to travel
Introduced in Chapter 269.

está en...
is in or at… — locate someone with estar and the already-known en
Introduced in Chapter 48.

estar
to be — but the *standing* kind, straight from Latin stāre
Introduced in Chapter 8.

estar en paro
to be out of work — el paro is a stoppage, and Spain names unemployment after the halt rather than after the missing job
Introduced in Chapter 430.

estás / está
what estar is for — a current state or location — and the only two forms you need this chapter
Introduced in Chapter 8.

este
this one, here, next to me — the first of three words for pointing, and the reason Spanish never needs to say "the this book"
Introduced in Chapter 221.

estropear / estropeado
to ruin, to break — and the adjective on the sign when the machine will not work
Introduced in Chapter 448.

estudiante
student — a word you can build yourself, out of a verb you already have
Introduced in Chapter 52.

estudiar
to study (a third -ar verb — the pattern is automatic now)
Introduced in Chapter 21.

exacto
exactly — from exigere, to drive out, and then to weigh out precisely
Introduced in Chapter 284.

exigente
demanding — a word that drives things out of you, from the verb behind agenda and actor
Introduced in Chapter 445.

explicar
to explain — literally to unfold, and the verb that names what this whole chapter has been building
Introduced in Chapter 175.

fácil
easy — Latin facilis, built on facere, "to do", so what it says is do-able rather than light; hacer is the same verb worn down by mouth, while fácil was lifted off the page and kept its c
Introduced in Chapter 398.

fallar
to fail, to let somebody down — the deceiving inside *falso*
Introduced in Chapter 464.

falso
false, fake — Latin falsus, the past participle of fallere, to trip somebody up; English fail, fault, fallacy and false all come off it
Introduced in Chapter 324.

favorito
favourite — from favor, Latin favēre, "to be well disposed toward"; the -ito on the end is an Italian past participle, not the Spanish little-word ending it looks exactly like
Introduced in Chapter 398.

feliz
happy
Introduced in Chapter 269.

feo
ugly — Latin foedus, foul; a different Latin foedus meaning treaty gave English federal, and the two never had anything to do with each other
Introduced in Chapter 380.

fijo
fixed, permanent — a past participle so old that nobody feels it as one
Introduced in Chapter 441.

firmar
to sign — literally to make firm, which is what a signature was for
Introduced in Chapter 441.

francés / francesa
French; French person
Introduced in Chapter 410.

fresco
fresh, cool — a Germanic frisk, new and lively, that spread through Romance; the painting technique is the Italian form, for paint laid on wet plaster
Introduced in Chapter 379.

fuera
outside
Introduced in Chapter 407.

fuerte
strong, loud — Latin fortis, the same root already spent on la fuerza; English fort, force, effort, comfort and fortify all come off it
Introduced in Chapter 327.

fui
the shared singular preterite of ser and ir — fui, fuiste, fue
Introduced in Chapter 103.

funcionar
to work, said of a machine — built on función, Latin fūnctiō from fungī, to discharge a duty; the untouched Latin cluster shows it came off the page
Introduced in Chapter 396.

gastar
to spend — Latin vastare, to lay waste; devastate is the clean cousin, and the w in English waste is a Germanic fingerprint
Introduced in Chapter 386.

gato
cat — a word that travelled out of Africa with the animal, pushing Latin's own fēlēs aside
Introduced in Chapter 150.

girar
to turn — Latin gyrare, from Greek gyros, a circle; a late arrival taken from books rather than inherited from speech
Introduced in Chapter 387.

gordo
fat — Latin gurdus, dull or blunt, which Quintilian says he heard came into Latin from Spain; French gourd, numb, is the survivor, and English gourd is a false friend
Introduced in Chapter 371.

gracias
thank you
Introduced in Chapter 7.

grande
big — the first word in this book for what something is like, and it does not change for gender
Introduced in Chapter 58.

gratis
free of charge — a whole Latin word swallowed unchanged, grātīs contracted from grātiīs, "for thanks", which is why it never grows an -o or an -a
Introduced in Chapter 397.

gris
grey — a Germanic word borrowed into Spanish through its Romance neighbours; English grey is a cousin from a different Germanic stem, not the same word
Introduced in Chapter 372.

gritar
to shout — Latin quiritare, to cry out; English cry is the same word, and only English moved it from shouting to weeping
Introduced in Chapter 388.

grueso
thick — Late Latin grossus, coarse; English gross is the same word, and so is grocer, a dealer who sold in bulk
Introduced in Chapter 379.

guapo
good-looking — the Academy derives it from Latin vappa, flat wine and so a good-for-nothing, but Corominas argues against that route, so this is a word whose origin the two standard authorities do not agree on
Introduced in Chapter 399.

guardar
to keep — Germanic wardon, to watch over; the w- became gu- in Spanish, which is why ward and guard are the same word twice
Introduced in Chapter 383.

gustar
to please — the verb English calls "to like", built the other way round
Introduced in Chapter 163.

habitación
room
Introduced in Chapter 268.

habitual
usual, regular — what you hold on to, from the *haber* you already have
Introduced in Chapter 459.

hablar
to speak / to talk — at root, "to tell stories"
Introduced in Chapter 16.

hablaré
I will speak
Introduced in Chapter 49.

Hablo español
your first sentence built from parts — and the rule that languages take no article
Introduced in Chapter 22.

hace calor, hace frío, hace sol
the three weather words Spanish reports with hacer — "it makes heat," "it makes cold," "it makes sun"
Introduced in Chapter 148.

hacer
to do or make — with the singular present forms hago, haces, and hace
Introduced in Chapter 70.

hasta
until / up to
Introduced in Chapter 12.

hasta luego
see you later (literally "until later")
Introduced in Chapter 13.

hasta mañana
see you tomorrow (literally "until tomorrow")
Introduced in Chapter 13.

hasta pronto
see you soon (literally "until soon")
Introduced in Chapter 13.

hay
"there is" and "there are" — one word for both, which no other Spanish verb form manages
Introduced in Chapter 191.

hola
hello / hi
Introduced in Chapter 1.

hoy
today — a whole Latin phrase worn down to three letters, and the tense it prefers
Introduced in Chapter 252.

igual
the same, equal — Latin aequalis from aequus, level; English equal, equator and adequate are all about a surface with no tilt in it
Introduced in Chapter 350.

importante
important — built on importar, from Latin importāre, "to carry in"; classical Latin never used it to mean "to matter", and English import still carries both jobs
Introduced in Chapter 398.

importar
to matter — the verb behind *importante*, and it works like *gustar*
Introduced in Chapter 463.

imprimir
to print — the verb el impreso was the participle of, handed back with its own lesson
Introduced in Chapter 469.

incluir
to include
Introduced in Chapter 409.

incluso
even, including — Latin inclusus from includere, in + claudere, to shut in; English include, enclose, recluse, seclude and conclude are all shuttings
Introduced in Chapter 328.

inteligente
intelligent — Latin intellegere, inter "between" plus legere "to pick out"; intelligence is literally the act of choosing between things
Introduced in Chapter 423.

interesante
interesting — from Latin interesse, inter + esse, "to be between"; the same phrase gave banking the word interest, because what a lender lost was id quod interest, the difference between
Introduced in Chapter 398.

interesar
to interest — the verb behind an adjective you own, running on the same machine as doler
Introduced in Chapter 443.

internet
the internet — English Internet, itself Latin inter, between, bolted onto Germanic net; taken into Spanish unchanged except for the beat, which moves to the last syllable
Introduced in Chapter 393.

invitar
to invite — the verb el invitado was named from, handed over now, and in Spanish it also means paying
Introduced in Chapter 474.

ir
to go — with the three singular present forms voy, vas, and va
Introduced in Chapter 49.

jamás
never, ever — Latin iam magis, already more; the magis half is the same word that became más, and French jamais took the identical road
Introduced in Chapter 328.

joven
young — Latin iuvenis; English young is the inherited cousin, juvenile and junior are the borrowed ones, and June comes in only through Juno
Introduced in Chapter 371.

jubilado
retired — a participle used as a noun, the same move that made el pedido, and a surprisingly cheerful root
Introduced in Chapter 435.

jubilarse
to retire — the verb behind a word you were given, and it names a shout of joy
Introduced in Chapter 445.

jugar
to play — from Latin's word for joking, and the only verb in the language that breaks u to ue
Introduced in Chapter 170.

junto
together, next to — one short word doing two jobs, and the preposition that decides which
Introduced in Chapter 433.

la
"it" for something feminine — the one word in this pair that never had to change
Introduced in Chapter 84.

la abeja
bee — Latin apicula, the little apis; Spanish kept the small form and let the big one die, the same way oveja and oreja did
Introduced in Chapter 368.

la abuela
the grandmother — the avus root swung feminine, the same -o/-a switch as hijo and hija
Introduced in Chapter 306.

la academia
academy, language school
Introduced in Chapter 410.

la actividad
activity — Medieval Latin āctīvitās, a Scholastic coinage on āctīvus, from agere, to drive or to do; the -ct- still sitting intact inside activ- is the sign the word came off the page
Introduced in Chapter 394.

la actriz
actress — Latin actrix, the feminine of actor; the -triz ending is a museum piece that survives in only a handful of Spanish words
Introduced in Chapter 421.

la administración
the administration — built on the word for the LESSER one, which is what a servant was
Introduced in Chapter 442.

la agencia
the agency — a place that acts for you, and the *agenda* is its cousin
Introduced in Chapter 456.

la agenda
the diary, the schedule — Latin agenda, the things that must be done, from agere to drive; English agent, agile and act come off the same verb
Introduced in Chapter 349.

la aguja
the needle — a little acus, a sharp; the same sharp that names the acute accent, and the one in acupuncture
Introduced in Chapter 301.

la alfombra
rug, carpet — Andalusi Arabic al-ḥánbal, a kind of tapestry; the al- is the Arabic article, and a once-popular red-carpet story turned out to be a different word
Introduced in Chapter 373.

la almohada
pillow — Andalusi Arabic al-mukhadda, the cheek-instrument, with the Arabic article fused on; this word has no English relative at all
Introduced in Chapter 366.

la amiga
a friend, of a woman — Latin amica, from the same amare as amable
Introduced in Chapter 285.

la arena
sand — Latin harena, whose origin nobody has settled; English arena is the same word, the sand spread on an amphitheatre floor to soak up what was spilled on it
Introduced in Chapter 369.

la arroba
the at sign — an Arabic unit of weight that became a merchant's shorthand and then an e-mail address, which is why Spanish has a real word where English says at
Introduced in Chapter 428.

la avenida
avenue — a broad street, from avenir, whose older senses include things that come or arrive
Introduced in Chapter 401.

la ayuda
help — Latin adiutare, to bring strength toward someone; the same root gives English aid
Introduced in Chapter 303.

la barra
the slash — the mark that offers a choice, abbreviates a street, and sits inside every speed limit sign
Introduced in Chapter 424.

la batería
the battery — a word that looks built and is not, at least not in this language
Introduced in Chapter 434.

la biblioteca
library — Greek biblion, a book, plus theke, a chest, so a book-chest; the same theke gave Spanish bodega and botica, French boutique and English apothecary
Introduced in Chapter 353.

la bicicleta
bicycle — French bicyclette, Latin bi- two on Greek kyklos circle, wheel; cycle, tricycle, cyclops and the 1848 coinage cyclone are the same root, English wheel is its inherited cousin, and encyclopedia comes from a misread Greek phrase
Introduced in Chapter 363.

la boca
the mouth — Latin bucca was the cheek, and the cheek pushed the mouth out of the job
Introduced in Chapter 286.

la boda
the wedding — a Latin plural that hardened into a Spanish singular, and the pieces are invisible
Introduced in Chapter 440.

la bolsa
the bag — Latin bursa from Greek byrsa, a hide; English purse, bursar and reimburse are all the same leather
Introduced in Chapter 311.

la botella
bottle — from French bouteille, on a late Latin buttis, a cask; a butler is the bottle-keeper, and the older Spanish form of the same word is bota
Introduced in Chapter 373.

la bufanda
the scarf — one of a handful of words this book has had to leave open, and the fifth to say so out loud
Introduced in Chapter 468.

la cabeza
the head — Spanish KEPT Latin's real word, unlike French, which replaced it with slang for "pot"
Introduced in Chapter 141.

la caja
box — Latin capsa, the case a Roman kept scrolls in, probably reaching Castilian through Catalan or Occitan; case, capsule and chassis are cousins, and English cash first meant the box itself
Introduced in Chapter 366.

la calefacción
the heating — heat-making, built from two words you already own
Introduced in Chapter 444.

la calificación
the grade, as printed on a document — the formal partner of nota, and a word that says out loud what a grade is for
Introduced in Chapter 429.

la calle
the street — Latin callis, the narrow track worn through rough ground by driven animals; the town's word began in the hills
Introduced in Chapter 302.

la calma
the calm — Late Latin cauma from Greek kauma, burning heat; the windless noon at sea gave sailors a word for stillness
Introduced in Chapter 333.

la cama
bed — one of the commonest Spanish words, and nobody has settled where it came from
Introduced in Chapter 279.

la camisa
shirt — Late Latin camisia, a garment worn close to the body
Introduced in Chapter 402.

la camiseta
T-shirt — camisa plus the diminutive suffix -eta
Introduced in Chapter 402.

la cantidad
the quantity, the amount — Latin quantitas from quantus, how much; English quantity, quantum and quantify all ask the same question
Introduced in Chapter 351.

la cara
face — Late Latin cara, generally traced to Greek kara head though the trail is not clean; the identical cara meaning expensive is a separate root, carus, which gave English charity, caress and cherish
Introduced in Chapter 364.

la carne
meat, flesh — Latin carō, stem carn-; carnal, incarnate and carnage are the direct cousins, and carnival is carnelevare, the removing of meat
Introduced in Chapter 361.

la carta
the letter, and the menu — Latin charta from Greek khartes, a papyrus sheet; English chart, charter, card and cartoon are all it
Introduced in Chapter 312.

la casa
house, home — and a word French wore down so far it stopped looking like a noun
Introduced in Chapter 56.

la cebolla
the onion — Latin caepulla, a little caepa; the chive in English is the same root, undiminished
Introduced in Chapter 290.

la ceniza
ash — from Latin cinis; English incinerate is the same word, but English cinder is a Germanic impostor that only borrowed the Latin spelling
Introduced in Chapter 369.

la cesta
the basket — Latin cista from Greek kiste, a box; English chest and cistern are the same container by two different doors
Introduced in Chapter 301.

la chaqueta
the jacket — a word you have already been shown twice without being given it, and probably named after a peasant rather than a place
Introduced in Chapter 468.

la chica
the girl — the same ciccum root, and the one word here that English borrowed from Spanish rather than the reverse
Introduced in Chapter 308.

la cita
an appointment, a date — from citar, Latin citare to summon, from ciere to set in motion; English cite, recite, incite and excite are all the same summons
Introduced in Chapter 356.

la ciudad
the city — Latin civitatem from civis, a citizen; English city, civic, civil, civilian and citizen are the same word
Introduced in Chapter 325.

la clase
a class, a kind, a lesson — Latin classis, one of the six bands Rome sorted its citizens into by wealth; a writer of the top band was classicus, which is where classic comes from
Introduced in Chapter 358.

la cola
the queue — named after a tail, and not to be confused with its own homonym
Introduced in Chapter 451.

la colina
the hill — Latin collis, from a root meaning to rise; excel and culminate rise from the same place
Introduced in Chapter 292.

la coma
the comma — and the list rule where Spanish and English disagree, because Spanish puts no comma in front of the final y
Introduced in Chapter 424.

la comida
food, a meal — a noun you can build yourself out of a verb you already own
Introduced in Chapter 77.

la cosa
the thing — Latin causa, a cause or legal case, which drifted to mean thing; English cause, because, accuse and excuse keep the original sense
Introduced in Chapter 331.

la cosecha
the harvest — from collecta, the gathered-up, which is the colligere you already took apart once
Introduced in Chapter 299.

la costa
coast — Latin costa, a rib, so the coast is the country's side; English coast, intercostal, accost and cutlet are all the same rib
Introduced in Chapter 370.

la cuchara
a spoon — Latin cochlear, from cochlea, a snail shell you dug the snail out with
Introduced in Chapter 287.

la cuenta
the bill — Latin computare, to reckon together; English compute, count and account are the same word at three distances
Introduced in Chapter 311.

la cuerda
the rope — Greek khorde by way of Latin chorda, a gut string; cord, chord and cordon are the same string, and the o breaks to ue again
Introduced in Chapter 301.

la cueva
cave — from a Latin variant of cavus, hollow; cavity, excavate and cage are relatives, but English cove is a Germanic look-alike that is not
Introduced in Chapter 370.

la culpa
fault, blame — Latin culpa; English culprit and culpable are the same word, and mea culpa was never translated at all
Introduced in Chapter 320.

la cumbre
summit — Latin culmen, which meant the ridge of a roof before it meant a mountaintop; culmen is a squeezed-down columen, with columna a cousin rather than a twin
Introduced in Chapter 378.

la década
the decade — Greek deka, ten, through Latin decas; English decade, decimal, December and dean all count in tens
Introduced in Chapter 349.

la demora
the delay — Latin mora, a lingering, through demorari; English demur and moratorium are the same hanging back
Introduced in Chapter 348.

la derecha
the right, the right-hand side — Latin directus, straightened, from dirigere to set straight; English direct, direction, erect and address share it
Introduced in Chapter 340.

la despedida
the farewell — from despedir, Latin expetere, to ask out: a leave-taking was a request
Introduced in Chapter 288.

la dirección
address — Latin dīrēctiō, dīrēctiōnem, lifted from the written language rather than handed down, as derecho beside directo and razón beside ración show; on a form it is where you live
Introduced in Chapter 393.

la disculpa
the apology — dis- undoing culpa, blame, from Latin culpa; English culpable, culprit, exculpate and mea culpa keep the blame in place
Introduced in Chapter 332.

la docena
the dozen — Latin duodecim, two-ten, from duo and decem; English dozen and duodecimal are the same twelve
Introduced in Chapter 344.

la documentación
the paperwork — a fourth ending, and the one that turns an action into a thing
Introduced in Chapter 435.

la ducha
the shower — Latin ducere, to lead; the same root leads water through an aqueduct and gives English duct, conduct and duke
Introduced in Chapter 310.

la edad
age — Latin aetatem from aetas and aevum, a lifetime; the -dad ending you know from verdad and ciudad, and English age, eternal, medieval and longevity share the root
Introduced in Chapter 334.

la empresa
the company — literally a thing taken on, from the same root as English enterprise, which Spanish uses for the firm itself rather than only for the venture
Introduced in Chapter 427.

la encuesta
the survey — a cousin of querer, because asking and wanting are one Latin verb
Introduced in Chapter 472.

la enfermera
the nurse — from infirmus, not firm: named after the patient, not the work
Introduced in Chapter 285.

la ensalada
the salad — a salted thing, and the salt is still in the word
Introduced in Chapter 456.

la entrada
the entrance, and the admission ticket — Latin intrare from intra, within; English enter, entrance and interior are all inside it
Introduced in Chapter 313.

la época
the age, the era, the season — Greek epokhe, a stopping point, from epekhein to hold back; English epoch is the same word
Introduced in Chapter 343.

la escalera
stairs, ladder — Latin scālāria from scāla, a ladder; scale, ascend, descend and echelon are cousins, while escalate arrived by way of a 1900 trademark
Introduced in Chapter 366.

la escoba
the broom — Latin scopa, a bundle of twigs, wearing the Spanish e- step for the third time
Introduced in Chapter 294.

la escuela
school — Latin schola from Greek skholē, spare time; English school, scholar and scholastic keep the leisure that turned into study
Introduced in Chapter 346.

la espalda
the back — Latin spatula, a broad blade; the same blade is a spatula, a spade and an epaulette
Introduced in Chapter 293.

la espera
the wait — the noun of *esperar*, and the sign above the chairs
Introduced in Chapter 460.

la esposa
the wife — the same spondere pledge, feminine; and the reason handcuffs are called esposas
Introduced in Chapter 307.

la esquina
the corner — from a Germanic word for a shinbone; English shin is the same bone, and a corner is an edge as sharp as one
Introduced in Chapter 302.

la estación
station — Latin statio from stare, to stand; a station is a standing-place, and English station, stationary, statue and stable stand on the same verb
Introduced in Chapter 346.

la estantería
the shelving unit — a second ending that builds nouns, and the thing every flat-pack instruction is about
Introduced in Chapter 432.

la estrella
the star — Latin stella, wearing the e- that Spanish puts in front of an s and a consonant
Introduced in Chapter 289.

la etapa
a stage, a leg of a journey — French etape, once a storehouse where an army drew supplies, from Middle Dutch stapel a heap; English staple is the same pile
Introduced in Chapter 356.

la experiencia
experience — what an advert asks for, and a word that reads itself if you let it
Introduced in Chapter 435.

la exposición
exhibition — Latin ex- "out" plus ponere "to place", a putting-out; the same ponere is inside compose, deposit and position
Introduced in Chapter 420.

la factura
the invoice — "a making", by the same ending that gives escritura and lectura
Introduced in Chapter 441.

la falda
skirt — a Germanic word for a fold, so a skirt is the folded thing; English fold is the inherited cousin, and falso is a look-alike from a different family
Introduced in Chapter 373.

la familia
the family — Latin familia, the whole household including its servants; English family and familiar
Introduced in Chapter 309.

la farmacia
pharmacy, chemist's — Greek pharmakon, a drug that could cure or kill; the Greek word never chose between the remedy and the poison, and English pharmacy keeps it whole
Introduced in Chapter 353.

la fecha
the date — Latin facta, done or made, from facere; English fact, feat, factory, affect and perfect all come off the same making
Introduced in Chapter 343.

la fiebre
the fever — Latin febris, which English borrowed early as fever and late as febrile
Introduced in Chapter 286.

la fiesta
the holiday, the party — Latin festa, the feast days; English feast, festival and festive are the same word, and English borrowed fiesta itself
Introduced in Chapter 349.

la flor
flower — Latin flos, and the reason English flour is spelled so oddly
Introduced in Chapter 278.

la forma
shape — Latin forma, which came into Spanish twice; the borrowed half is la forma, and the inherited half is hermoso, beautiful, from formosus, well shaped
Introduced in Chapter 358.

la foto
photo — the everyday shortening of fotografía, still feminine
Introduced in Chapter 405.

la fotografía
photograph or photography — literally light-writing through Greek roots
Introduced in Chapter 405.

la frase
phrase, sentence — Greek phrasis, a way of speaking, through Latin; English phrase and paraphrase are the same word
Introduced in Chapter 377.

la fruta
fruit — Latin fructus from frui, to enjoy, so a fruit is what a plant gives back; English fruit and frugal both arrived through French, and the old verb brook is the inherited cousin
Introduced in Chapter 367.

la fuerza
the strength — Latin fortia from fortis, with the o broken to ue; force, fort, effort and comfort are all built on it
Introduced in Chapter 315.

la gallina
the hen — Latin gallina, the female of gallus; and in both languages the bird is also what you call a coward
Introduced in Chapter 296.

la garganta
the throat — a word made out of the noise itself, as gargle and gurgle are
Introduced in Chapter 286.

la gente
people — Latin gens, the clan; the root of English gentle, genteel, Gentile and general
Introduced in Chapter 308.

la granja
the farm — from granum, the grain: a farm is named after the one thing it was built to store
Introduced in Chapter 299.

la guardia
the duty rota — the chemist that is open tonight, and a Germanic word for watching
Introduced in Chapter 457.

la guitarra
guitar — Ancient Greek kithára, a stringed instrument; the Greek source is certain and the road into Spanish is genuinely disputed, with three standard references giving three different answers
Introduced in Chapter 394.

la harina
flour — Latin farina, from far, husked wheat; the f became h by the Castilian change behind hacer and hijo, which spared frente and fuego
Introduced in Chapter 376.

la herramienta
the tool — a thing of iron, with the iron still in the word
Introduced in Chapter 460.

la hierba
grass, the plant — with a silent h that Spanish added on purpose
Introduced in Chapter 450.

la hija
the daughter — the same filius root, swung to -a; English filial covers both
Introduced in Chapter 306.

la historia
story, history — Greek historia, knowledge got by inquiry; English history and story are the same word, story having come through Anglo-French
Introduced in Chapter 377.

la hora
hour / o'clock — telling the time, and a word Spanish inherited almost unchanged from Latin
Introduced in Chapter 147.

la huella
the footprint — from hollar, to tread, and behind that fullare, to trample cloth; a fuller was the man who did it with his feet
Introduced in Chapter 302.

la iglesia
church — Latin ecclesia from Greek ekklesia, the people called out to assemble; English ecclesiastical is the same gathering
Introduced in Chapter 346.

la impresora
the printer — the machine-ending you met on la lavadora, now on a stem that also yields a person, so the article is what tells the two apart
Introduced in Chapter 469.

la instalación
the facility, the installation — a noun that means both the act and the thing
Introduced in Chapter 453.

la isla
the island — Latin insula; insular, isolate, peninsula and insulin all come off the same rock
Introduced in Chapter 295.

la izquierda
the left, the left-hand side — Basque ezkerra, one of the few pre-Roman words in Spanish; it drove out Latin sinistra, which English kept as sinister
Introduced in Chapter 340.

la jornada
the day's stretch, a working day — Latin diurnus, of the day, through Occitan; English journey, journal and adjourn are the same day
Introduced in Chapter 349.

la lámpara
lamp — Greek lampas, a torch, from lampein, to shine; lamp and lantern are cousins, and Spanish relámpago, lightning, comes free with it
Introduced in Chapter 366.

la lavadora
the washing machine — the doer-ending from the last chapter, put on a verb you have had since the household words
Introduced in Chapter 432.

la leche
milk — Latin lac, stem lact-; lactose and lactate are learned coinages and Italian latte is the same word, while lettuce is lactūca, named for the milky sap of a cut stem
Introduced in Chapter 361.

la lectura
the reading — the word la factura already printed in its own table, handed over now, and a thing you have been doing since chapter sixty-six
Introduced in Chapter 472.

la letra
letter of the alphabet — Latin littera, which also gives English letter, literal and literature; where Latin got it is still unsettled
Introduced in Chapter 377.

la limpieza
cleaning — the fourth way Spanish turns a word into the name of a doing
Introduced in Chapter 453.

la llamada
the call — the word el pedido's table already showed you, handed over now with the part that table left out: the gender is not predictable
Introduced in Chapter 469.

la llave
the key — Latin clavis, the little key; the same root gives English clavicle, clef and conclave
Introduced in Chapter 310.

la llegada
the arrival — from llegar, Latin plicare, to fold: a ship folded its sails and had arrived
Introduced in Chapter 288.

la lluvia
the rain — the noun to a verb you have had since the weather chapter, and a word you were once shown as somebody else's example
Introduced in Chapter 465.

la luna
moon — Latin luna, worn down from an earlier louksna, the shiny one, from the same ancient root as la luz; light is the inherited English cousin, lucid and luminous the borrowed ones, and leukemia the one that came through Greek
Introduced in Chapter 362.

la luz
the light — Latin lux, lucem; English keeps it in lucid, translucent and elucidate
Introduced in Chapter 310.

la madera
wood — Latin's word for matter, which meant timber first, and reached Spanish twice
Introduced in Chapter 444.

la madrugada
the small hours, daybreak — Latin maturus, ripe or early, through madurgar; English mature and premature are the same ripeness
Introduced in Chapter 342.

la maleta
the suitcase — a little mala, the Gaulish word for a bag; English mail, the post, is named after the same bag
Introduced in Chapter 312.

la manera
the way, the manner — from Latin manuarius, of the hand, and manus a hand; English manner, manual, manufacture and manage are all handlings
Introduced in Chapter 331.

la mano
the hand — feminine despite ending in -o, Spanish's most famous gender exception
Introduced in Chapter 141.

la manta
the blanket — Latin mantum, a cloak; the mantle, the mantelpiece and the manta ray are all cloaks
Introduced in Chapter 294.

la manzana
apple — named after a Roman gardener whose variety outlived him
Introduced in Chapter 280.

la máquina
the machine — the general word under all the particular ones you already hold
Introduced in Chapter 434.

la marca
a mark, a brand — Germanic marka, a boundary; the border lands were marches, their lords marquises, and Latin margo, an edge, is the cousin that gives margin
Introduced in Chapter 358.

la mayoría
most of them, the majority — Latin maior, greater, from magnus; English major, mayor and magnitude are all the same greatness
Introduced in Chapter 352.

la mesa
the table — Latin mensa, the measured board; English borrowed mesa whole for the flat-topped hill
Introduced in Chapter 310.

la miel
the honey — Latin mel, which sweetens mellifluous, molasses and marmalade
Introduced in Chapter 290.

la minúscula inicial
the initial lower-case letter — whether a small word inside a surname takes a capital depends on whether the forename is standing in front of it
Introduced in Chapter 426.

la mitad
the half — Latin medietatem, the middle-ness, from medius middle; English medium, median, mediate and moiety come off it, and the -dad ending is the one you know
Introduced in Chapter 344.

la molestia
trouble, bother — Latin molestia from moles, a heavy mass; English molecule is the same mass made small
Introduced in Chapter 320.

la moneda
the coin — Latin moneta, a title of the goddess Juno in whose temple Rome struck its coins; English money and mint are both her
Introduced in Chapter 313.

la montaña
the mountain — Latin mons; paramount is above the hill and an amount is what it comes to
Introduced in Chapter 292.

la mosca
fly — Latin musca; English borrowed the Spanish diminutive whole as mosquito, and the same little fly became the sparrowhawk and then the musket
Introduced in Chapter 368.

la mudanza
the move, the removal — and the ending that turns a verb into the event
Introduced in Chapter 448.

la mujer
woman, and also wife — Latin mulier, whose own origin is unexplained; English took almost nothing from it beyond the rare muliebrity, while Latin homo gave human, homage and homicide
Introduced in Chapter 364.

la música
music
Introduced in Chapter 413.

la nacionalidad
nationality — built inside Spanish from nacional plus -idad; its base nación is the borrowing, Latin nātiō, nātiōnem, birth and then a people, which Corominas dates to the fifteenth century
Introduced in Chapter 393.

la naranja
orange — Arabic naranj from Persian narang, traceable back to Sanskrit; Spanish kept the n that English lost when a norange was reheard as an orange
Introduced in Chapter 367.

la nariz
nose — Latin nāris, which meant nostril and usually came in the plural nārēs; English nose is the inherited cousin, nasal the borrowed one, and meter las narices keeps the Latin plural alive
Introduced in Chapter 364.

la natación
swimming as a discipline — the Latin twin of nadar, borrowed back whole
Introduced in Chapter 438.

la Navidad
Christmas — Latin nativitatem, a birth, from nasci to be born; Spanish nada and nadie are the same verb, a born thing and born people
Introduced in Chapter 357.

la niebla
the mist — Latin nebula, the word set aside earlier as the near-cousin of nubes; nebulous is the same mist
Introduced in Chapter 295.

la nieve
snow — Latin nivem, and the s- that Latin dropped and English kept
Introduced in Chapter 278.

la niña
the girl — the counterpart of El Niño, and the reason the pupil of the eye is a little girl in both languages
Introduced in Chapter 308.

la noche
night / evening (la noche — feminine)
Introduced in Chapter 2.

la norma
the rule — the heading above every list a building, a library or a pool puts on its wall
Introduced in Chapter 433.

la nota
the mark — the same word the corpus already taught for a written note, and the older of its two senses is this one
Introduced in Chapter 429.

la nube
the cloud — Latin nubes, and the ancestor of nuance, which began as a shade of cloud
Introduced in Chapter 289.

la obra
the works, the building site — and the same Latin word as *la oficina*
Introduced in Chapter 454.

la ocasión
an occasion, a chance — Latin occasio, a falling-down, from ob and cadere to fall; accident, cadence, case, chance and cascade are all that same falling
Introduced in Chapter 356.

la oficina
office — Latin officina, a workshop, squeezed out of opificina from opus work and facere to make; English office, officer and opus are the same making
Introduced in Chapter 346.

la olla
the pot — Latin olla, unchanged in two thousand years; potpourri is a French translation of olla podrida
Introduced in Chapter 294.

la orilla
the shore — Latin ora, an edge or border, with the small ending: the little edge of anything
Introduced in Chapter 295.

la oveja
the sheep — Latin ovicula, a little ovis; Spanish kept the small one and dropped the full-sized word entirely
Introduced in Chapter 296.

la paciencia
patience — Latin pati, to undergo; the same root gives English patient, passion and compassion
Introduced in Chapter 321.

la paella
paella — the Valencian rice dish named from the pan
Introduced in Chapter 403.

la página web
web page — Latin pagina, a column of writing fastened to a frame, plus English web; the oldest word for a written surface carrying the newest one
Introduced in Chapter 422.

la palabra
the word — Latin parabola from Greek parabole, a throwing beside; the same Greek word gave English parable, parabola, parley and parliament
Introduced in Chapter 332.

la pantalla
the screen — a lampshade before it was a monitor, and a history nobody can settle
Introduced in Chapter 442.

la parada
the stop — from parar, to stop, and Latin parare, to make ready; English prepare, repair, apparatus, parade and parasol are all the same root
Introduced in Chapter 330.

la pared
the wall of a room — Latin paries, the wall of a house rather than of a town; the town wall was murus, which is Spanish muro and English mural, and paries survives in English only as the parietal bone
Introduced in Chapter 355.

la pareja
the couple, the partner — Latin par, equal; English pair, par, peer, parity and umpire
Introduced in Chapter 309.

la parte
the part, the share — Latin partem from pars; English part, party, partial, particle, partner and portion all come off it
Introduced in Chapter 345.

la Pascua
Easter — Latin pascha, from Greek paskha, from Hebrew pesach, the Passover; English kept a spring goddess's name for the feast but the Latin one for paschal
Introduced in Chapter 357.

la pastilla
pill or tablet
Introduced in Chapter 408.

la patata
potato — read as a crossing of Taíno batata, the sweet potato, with Quechua papa, this one; English potato is the Spanish word, and it named the sweet one first
Introduced in Chapter 367.

la película
film or movie — Latin pellicula, a tiny skin or thin layer
Introduced in Chapter 404.

la pena
sorrow, a shame — Latin poena, a penalty; English pain, penalty and subpoena all come off it
Introduced in Chapter 320.

la persona
the person — Latin persona, an actor's mask; English person, personality, persona and impersonate all still wear it
Introduced in Chapter 345.

la piedra
the stone — and a Greek word that came to Spanish by way of a nickname
Introduced in Chapter 450.

la piel
the skin — Latin pellis, a hide, with the e broken to ie; a pelt is the same hide, and a surplice is a shirt worn over one
Introduced in Chapter 300.

la pierna
the leg — Latin perna, a ham; Spanish named the living leg after the butcher's cut
Introduced in Chapter 314.

la pieza
the part — what is missing when a thing does not work, and what a repair replaces
Introduced in Chapter 434.

la piscina
swimming pool — Latin piscīna, from piscis, fish, plus -īna; a word taken from writing, standing beside the inherited pez from the same root
Introduced in Chapter 390.

la planta
floor, storey — Latin planta, both the sole of the foot and a cutting set in the ground; its pl- shows it was taken from writing, since the mouth-worn twin is llanta
Introduced in Chapter 390.

la playa
beach — Late Latin plagia, a flat stretch of shore; keep it apart from plaza by hearing y against z or s
Introduced in Chapter 400.

la plaza
the square — Latin platea from Greek plateia, a broad way; English place, plate, plateau and platypus all mean broad
Introduced in Chapter 325.

la portera
the concierge — the person who belongs to the portal, and a job with no close English equivalent
Introduced in Chapter 433.

la prima
the cousin, feminine — the primus root you can already see in prima donna and prima facie
Introduced in Chapter 307.

la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno
the four seasons — three straightforward, and one whose MEANING quietly shifted from "spring" to "summer"
Introduced in Chapter 142.

la prisa
the hurry, the rush — Latin pressa, from premere to press; English press, pressure, express, impress, oppress and print are all pressings
Introduced in Chapter 333.

la puerta
door — Latin porta, a gate, and the o that opened into ue
Introduced in Chapter 279.

la raíz
the root — Latin radix, which is also the radish, the radical and the thing you eradicate
Introduced in Chapter 291.

la rama
the branch — Latin ramus; when an argument ramifies, it is growing these
Introduced in Chapter 291.

la raya
the dash that marks a turn of speech — the mark this book has used in every printed dialogue without ever naming it
Introduced in Chapter 424.

la razón
reason — Latin ratio, rationem, a reckoning; English ratio, ration and rational are the same word arriving whole
Introduced in Chapter 321.

la recepción
reception, the reception desk
Introduced in Chapter 414.

la responsabilidad
responsibility — being answerable, from the same promise that makes a spouse
Introduced in Chapter 445.

la reunión
the meeting — making one again, out of the plainest number there is
Introduced in Chapter 442.

la risa
the laughter — Latin risus from ridere, to laugh; English took the root only in unkind forms — ridicule, deride, risible
Introduced in Chapter 315.

la rodilla
the knee — Latin rotella, a little wheel, from rota; rotate, rotary and roulette are the same wheel
Introduced in Chapter 293.

la ropa
clothes — Germanic raupa, plunder, beside raupjan, to pluck or strip; rob, reave and bereave still take, and robe made the same slide from spoils to garment on its own
Introduced in Chapter 360.

la rueda
the wheel — and the word you have been saying inside *alrededor* all along
Introduced in Chapter 449.

la ruta
the route — a road broken through, and a cousin of *roto*
Introduced in Chapter 452.

la sal
salt — Latin sal, salis; salad, salsa, sauce, sausage and salary are the real family, while salud, saludo and salvo belong together to a whole-and-safe root, and salir to a leaping one
Introduced in Chapter 361.

la sala
living room, hall — Proto-Germanic salaz, a one-room building, not Latin at all; English salon and saloon are the same word by way of French
Introduced in Chapter 390.

la salida
the way out — from salir, and Latin salire, to jump: a Roman jumped out of a room
Introduced in Chapter 288.

la salud
health — Latin salus, salutem, health and safety and a greeting all at once; English salute, salutary and salubrious keep it, and Spanish saludo is a wish for it
Introduced in Chapter 334.

la sangre
the blood — Latin sanguinem; sanguine once meant ruddy and cheerful because of it, and consanguinity is shared blood
Introduced in Chapter 300.

la sartén
the frying pan — Latin sartago; its written accent is a receipt for where the stress went, and the plural hands it back
Introduced in Chapter 297.

la sección
the section — a thing cut, and the cut is still in the word
Introduced in Chapter 459.

la sed
the thirst — Latin sitis; Spanish does not say you are thirsty, it says you have thirst, and the difference is the point
Introduced in Chapter 300.

la selva
jungle, forest — Latin silva, a wood; English sylvan and savage are the same word, and Pennsylvania means Penn's woods
Introduced in Chapter 378.

la semana
week — Latin septimana, the set of seven; the same septem gives English September and, down the Germanic road, seven
Introduced in Chapter 322.

la semilla
the seed — Latin seminalia, the things for sowing; a seminar is a seed-bed and disseminate is scattering
Introduced in Chapter 291.

la sílaba
the syllable — what may be split at the end of a line and what may never be, plus the words Spanish accepts two spellings for
Introduced in Chapter 425.

la silla
chair — Latin sella, a seat, from the verb to sit
Introduced in Chapter 279.

la sombra
the shade — Latin sub umbra, under the shadow; an umbrella is a little one of these
Introduced in Chapter 289.

la sonrisa
a smile — subridere, to laugh slightly: a laugh with the volume turned down
Introduced in Chapter 282.

la sopa
the soup — Germanic suppa, a piece of bread soaked in broth; the bread came first and soup, sop and supper are all it
Introduced in Chapter 297.

la suerte
luck — Latin sors, sortem, a token drawn from a jar; English sort, sorcery and consort are all lots being drawn
Introduced in Chapter 320.

la talla
size, especially clothing size — from tallar, to cut or shape
Introduced in Chapter 402.

la tarde
afternoon (la tarde — feminine; also: late)
Introduced in Chapter 2.

la tarjeta
a card — a little targe, from French targe, a small shield, from Frankish targa; English target is the same little shield, and it meant a shield for centuries before anyone shot at it
Introduced in Chapter 357.

la taza
the cup — Arabic tassa, from Persian; French tasse and the English demitasse are the same vessel
Introduced in Chapter 294.

la temperatura
the temperature — from a verb meaning to mix in the right proportion, which is also why steel is tempered and a person has a temper
Introduced in Chapter 465.

la terraza
terrace, café tables outside — Latin terra, earth, through a Vulgar Latin terrācea meaning earthen; English terrace is the same word, though how it entered Spanish is unsettled
Introduced in Chapter 390.

la tía
the aunt — the same Greek root feminine; English aunt comes from a wholly different Latin word, amita
Introduced in Chapter 307.

la tienda
the shop — Latin tendere, to stretch; a shop began as a stretched awning, which is why English tent, extend and tendon are relatives
Introduced in Chapter 311.

la tierra
earth, ground, land — Latin terra, the dry part of the world as against the water; terrain, terrace, subterranean, terrestrial, terra cotta and Mediterranean are the family, and terror is not
Introduced in Chapter 362.

la toalla
a towel — a Frankish word that went into French and came out in two languages
Introduced in Chapter 287.

la tormenta
storm — Latin tormenta, from torquere, to twist; torment, torture, torque and contort are the same Latin verb, and a storm is weather that wrings the sky
Introduced in Chapter 370.

la tubería
the pipework — the same collecting ending again, and the word behind every notice that the water is going off
Introduced in Chapter 432.

la uña
fingernail — Latin ungula, a diminutive of unguis, nail or claw; English ungulate, a hoofed animal, is the same word
Introduced in Chapter 375.

la universidad
university — Latin ūniversitās, a corporation or guild of people, from ūniversus, turned into one; the first Spanish use, in 1490, means totality, and the school sense arrives in 1505
Introduced in Chapter 394.

la urgencia
urgency — a pressing, and in the plural the sign over the hospital door
Introduced in Chapter 447.

la uva
grape — Latin uva, a grape or a bunch of them; English uvula is its diminutive, the little grape at the back of the throat
Introduced in Chapter 376.

la vaca
the cow — Latin vacca, unchanged in six letters; vaccine is named after her, because the first one came from a cow
Introduced in Chapter 296.

la vela
candle — from velar, Latin vigilare, to keep watch; the identically spelled vela meaning sail is a different word entirely, from velum, cloth
Introduced in Chapter 374.

la ventana
window — a wind-hole, built on the same Latin ventus as viento
Introduced in Chapter 279.

la verdad
the truth — Latin veritas from verus, true; English keeps it in verity, verify and verdict, and in the older sense of very
Introduced in Chapter 324.

la verdura
vegetables or greens — from verde, with a marked secondary sense outside this food use
Introduced in Chapter 403.

la vez
a time, an occasion, a turn — Latin vicem, a turn or change; English vice-president, vicar and vicarious are all standing in someone's place
Introduced in Chapter 330.

la vía
the track, the way — the word you have been saying inside *todavía*
Introduced in Chapter 454.

la vida
life — Latin vita; English vital, vitamin, revive, survive and viable are all built on it, and the vitamin was named by a chemist who thought it was an amine
Introduced in Chapter 330.

la víspera
the eve, the day before — Latin vespera, evening; English vespers is the evening prayer, Greek hesperos is the evening star, and English west is a cousin of both
Introduced in Chapter 357.

la voz
the voice — Latin vox, vocem; English voice, vocal, vowel, vocation, advocate, evoke and provoke all come off it
Introduced in Chapter 332.

la vuelta
the return — from volver, Latin volvere, to roll: a return is a turning back
Introduced in Chapter 288.

lanzar
to throw — late Latin lanceare, to wield a lance; English launch is the same verb, and the boat called a launch is not
Introduced in Chapter 388.

largo
long — Latin largus, abundant and generous; English large is the very same word gone one way, largesse keeps the older sense, and Spanish took it the other way, to long
Introduced in Chapter 365.

las abreviaturas
abbreviations — the shortened forms of address a letter and a form print, and the point that must not be left off
Introduced in Chapter 426.

las cinco vocales
the five vowel letters — a closed set that never grew, and the two marks one of them can carry
Introduced in Chapter 425.

las comillas
quotation marks — Spanish has three shapes in a stated order of preference, and the one it prefers is the one an English reader has never used
Introduced in Chapter 424.

las letras voladitas
the raised letters — the little o and a that sit above the line in an ordinal or an abbreviation, and which one to use for a woman
Introduced in Chapter 426.

las mayúsculas
capital letters — and the four things Spanish pointedly does not capitalise, every one of which English does
Introduced in Chapter 426.

las siglas
initialisms and acronyms — written without points, and pluralised by doubling the letters rather than by adding an s
Introduced in Chapter 426.

las vacaciones
the holidays — Latin vacātiō, exemption, from vacāre, to be empty or free of duty; a learned borrowing, twin of English vacation and vacant, and no relation to vaca, the cow
Introduced in Chapter 392.

lavar
to wash — Latin lavare, which English kept in lavatory, launder and lavish
Introduced in Chapter 381.

le
"to him, to her, to you" — a Latin case Spanish kept and English threw away
Introduced in Chapter 93.

leer
to read — from a Latin verb meaning "to gather, to pick out"
Introduced in Chapter 155.

lejos
far, far away — Latin laxius, more loosely, from laxus loose; English lax, relax, release and leash come off the same slack rope
Introduced in Chapter 340.

lento
slow — Latin lentus, pliant then slow; taken off the page rather than inherited, and the inherited form came out as liento, damp. English relent is the same word
Introduced in Chapter 371.

levantarse
to get up, to stand up — "to raise oneself", built from a participle exactly as sentarse was
Introduced in Chapter 166.

libre
free — Latin liber meaning unowned, which is a different Latin word from the liber that gave libro; English liberty, liberal and deliver come off this one
Introduced in Chapter 326.

limpio
clean — from limpidus, clear, the word English kept for water and Spanish moved to laundry
Introduced in Chapter 281.

listo
clever with ser, ready with estar — one word whose meaning is decided by the verb in front of it; the RAE traces it to Gothic lists, cunning
Introduced in Chapter 326.

llamo
I call (from llamar, to call)
Introduced in Chapter 4.

llegar
to arrive — Latin plicāre per Corominas, whose sense he routes through the nautical idiom applicāre nāvem, to bring a ship to shore; initial pl- gave Spanish ll- and Portuguese ch-, which is why Portuguese says chegar
Introduced in Chapter 395.

lleno
full — Latin plēnus; plenty, plenary, replenish and complete are the borrowed cousins, full is the inherited one, and comply belongs with filling rather than with folding
Introduced in Chapter 365.

llovía / llovió
the same rain in two tenses — how a story uses the imperfect for the scene and the preterite for the events
Introduced in Chapter 167.

llueve
rain refuses the hacer pattern and brings its own verb — and its ll- is the sound change you already met in llamar
Introduced in Chapter 148.

lo
"it" — a word you have been saying since your fourth chapter, in a job you have not met yet
Introduced in Chapter 83.

lo cual
which — pointing back at a whole clause
Introduced in Chapter 273.

lo siento
I'm sorry — literally "I feel it," a naming of the feeling rather than a claim about yourself
Introduced in Chapter 137.

los dígrafos
the two-letter combinations that spell one sound — and two of them used to be letters in their own right until 1994
Introduced in Chapter 425.

los dos puntos
the colon — plural in Spanish because there are two of them, and the mark that opens a Spanish letter where English uses a comma
Introduced in Chapter 424.

los meses
the months — Roman gods and emperors, marching almost unchanged from Latin
Introduced in Chapter 145.

los paréntesis
parentheses — Greek for a putting-in-beside, which is exactly what the mark does to a sentence
Introduced in Chapter 424.

los símbolos
symbols — currency, the compass and the units, none of which take a point, because a symbol is not an abbreviation
Introduced in Chapter 426.

los vaqueros
jeans — literally cowboy trousers, and one of the few garments Spanish names after the person who wore them first
Introduced in Chapter 430.

luego
then, next — a word you already own from hasta luego, now doing a second job: joining two events in order
Introduced in Chapter 167.

lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes
the weekdays (Monday–Friday) — worn-down planet-god names
Introduced in Chapter 138.

mal
badly — the partner bien has been waiting for since the opening pages, in a long form and a short one
Introduced in Chapter 228.

mas
but — the literary one, without the accent
Introduced in Chapter 276.

más despacio
"more slowly" — the request that makes the last sentence solvable
Introduced in Chapter 15.

más que
more than
Introduced in Chapter 269.

más vale pájaro en mano
a bird in the hand — the proverb, and what a proverb is
Introduced in Chapter 274.

mayo
May
Introduced in Chapter 416.

mayor
bigger, older — Latin maior, the comparative of magnus, "great"; English took the same word twice, as major and as the mayor of a town, though Spanish calls that official something else entirely
Introduced in Chapter 397.

me
me / myself
Introduced in Chapter 4.

me llamo
my name is (literally "I call myself")
Introduced in Chapter 4.

mediodía, medianoche
noon and midnight — both halves still fully alive as ordinary Spanish words, unlike French's worn-down midi/minuit
Introduced in Chapter 146.

menor
smaller, younger — Latin minor, the partner of minus; Latin built minister out of minus to stand opposite magister, so mayor and menor give you master and minister as a matched pair
Introduced in Chapter 397.

menos
less, fewer, except — Latin minus, the twin of magis; English minus, minor, minimum, minister and diminish are all the small end of it
Introduced in Chapter 324.

meter
to put in — the plainest verb of putting, and the *mittere* inside *el permiso*
Introduced in Chapter 455.

mezclar
to mix — spoken Latin misculare, from miscere; English meddle and medley are its true siblings, and a medley was once a fight
Introduced in Chapter 385.

mi, tu, su
my, your informal, and your formal or his or her — before a singular noun
Introduced in Chapter 49.

mientras
while — Latin dum interim, "for the time between"; the inter in it is English interim, interval and international
Introduced in Chapter 323.

mil gracias
a thousand thanks — mille, the same thousand that measures a mile
Introduced in Chapter 283.

mira
look — and the tone shifts
Introduced in Chapter 272.

mirar
to look at — the verb behind the mira you already use, and it began as wonder
Introduced in Chapter 446.

mismo
same, very, self — Vulgar Latin metipsimus, a piled-up superlative of ipse self; English ipso facto and solipsism keep the ipse
Introduced in Chapter 345.

mojado
wet — from mojar, Vulgar Latin molliare, to soften, from mollis, soft; English mollify and emollient come from the same mollis
Introduced in Chapter 379.

morir
to die — Latin mori; English mortal and mortgage are the same root, and murder is a cousin by another road
Introduced in Chapter 384.

mostrar
to show — the verb on the sign, with a monster somewhere in its family
Introduced in Chapter 451.

mover
to move something — the verb your phone is named after
Introduced in Chapter 446.

mucho
much / a lot
Introduced in Chapter 6.

mucho gusto
pleased to meet you (literally "much pleasure")
Introduced in Chapter 6.

mudarse
to move house — a verb about changing, with the change aimed back at yourself
Introduced in Chapter 448.

muy
very — not a new word at all, but mucho with its ending bitten off, and the shape tells you what is coming next
Introduced in Chapter 226.

nada
nothing — Latin res nata, “a thing born”; the res fell away and the born thing came to mean no thing at all
Introduced in Chapter 316.

nadar
to swim
Introduced in Chapter 417.

nadie
nobody — Latin nati, “born ones”, from homines nati, “people born”; the exact twin of nada, which was a thing born
Introduced in Chapter 317.

necesario
necessary — Latin necessarius, from necesse, unavoidable; English necessary is the same Latin word, borrowed rather than inherited
Introduced in Chapter 380.

necesitar
to need — Medieval Latin necessitō, borrowed late and attested in Spanish by the seventeenth century; inside necesse the ne- is secure and the rest has resisted definitive analysis, whatever the confident dictionaries print
Introduced in Chapter 395.

negro, blanco
black and white — the two words, and the straight-line Latin history of the first one
Introduced in Chapter 139.

nervioso
nervous — Latin nervosus from nervus, a sinew; English nerve, nervous and neuron are the same fibre, and -oso is the -ous you already know
Introduced in Chapter 326.

ni
nor, not even — the joining word for two things that are both absent, and the one place Spanish stacks negatives on purpose
Introduced in Chapter 234.

ni hablar
out of the question — “not even to speak of it”, two pieces you already own, and the flattest refusal on the dial
Introduced in Chapter 298.

no
no / not
Introduced in Chapter 7.

no + verb
putting *no* in front of the verb — the whole of Spanish negation
Introduced in Chapter 267.

no ... nada
the double negative — where Spanish stacks what English forbids
Introduced in Chapter 267.

no entiendo
"I don't understand" — the most useful sentence a beginner owns
Introduced in Chapter 15.

no hay de qué
not at all — the reply to thanks, assembled entirely from words you already have
Introduced in Chapter 283.

no sé
I do not know — saber is Latin sapere, to taste; knowing began as tasting
Introduced in Chapter 303.

nos
"us" — the object pronoun that speaks for more than one person
Introduced in Chapter 88.

nuestro, nuestra
our — matching a known masculine or feminine singular noun
Introduced in Chapter 69.

nuevo
new — Latin novus, and English new, which is the cousin rather than the loan
Introduced in Chapter 281.

nunca
never — Latin numquam, ne plus umquam, "not ever"; English never is ne plus ever, the identical compound built out of Germanic parts
Introduced in Chapter 316.

o
or — one letter, and one rule about what happens when the next word starts with the same sound
Introduced in Chapter 233.

ocupado
busy — Latin occupare, to seize; to be busy is to be seized
Introduced in Chapter 304.

ofrecer
to offer — to carry something toward somebody, and the verb a shop reaches for when it cannot give you what you asked
Introduced in Chapter 436.

oír
to hear — the half of listening you do not choose, and a verb that sprouts a y
Introduced in Chapter 165.

olvidar
to forget — Latin oblitare, from oblivisci; English oblivion is the same word, and the trail stops there
Introduced in Chapter 384.

once — quince
11-15 — five single opaque words, each one a Latin compound worn down until the seam disappeared
Introduced in Chapter 149.

organizar
to organise — to fit the working parts together, from a Greek tool
Introduced in Chapter 463.

os
"you all" as the object — the shortest word in the set, and the one that stops at a border
Introduced in Chapter 90.

oscuro
dark — Latin obscurus, ob- plus a word for dark; English obscure is the same word, and which ancient root the second half belongs to is still argued over
Introduced in Chapter 372.

otra vez
again — literally another turn; vez is Latin vicem, a turn taken in rotation
Introduced in Chapter 303.

otro
another, other — Latin alter, which meant the other of a pair rather than any other at all
Introduced in Chapter 317.

pagar
to pay — Latin pacare, to pacify, from pax, peace; paying somebody was settling with them
Introduced in Chapter 382.

pálido
pale — Latin pallidus; English pale came through French and pallid straight from the Latin, so they are the same word twice, and fallow is the inherited cousin
Introduced in Chapter 372.

para
"for" pointing forward — at a destination, a purpose, a deadline, a person meant to receive something
Introduced in Chapter 176.

pasar a mejor vida
to pass on — and why the language turns away
Introduced in Chapter 274.

peligroso
dangerous — a trial you might not survive, with its letters swapped
Introduced in Chapter 461.

pensar
to think — at root "to weigh", and a stem-changer that breaks e→ie
Introduced in Chapter 153.

pequeño
small — no Latin ancestor anybody can name; the dictionary of record calls it an expressive word shared across the Romance languages, and piccolo and petit are the same kind of word
Introduced in Chapter 371.

perder
to lose — Latin perdere, to destroy or lose, inherited whole; per- is clear but the second element is disputed, either dare, to give, or a separate element meaning to put, and English perdition is the clean cognate
Introduced in Chapter 395.

perderse
to get lost — the reflexive equivocarse already grouped it with, and in a class it is the thread you lose, not the way
Introduced in Chapter 471.

perdón
the other sorry — "give completely" — for fault and for getting past people, where lo siento is for regret
Introduced in Chapter 137.

permitir
to permit or allow — from Latin permittere, to let through
Introduced in Chapter 405.

pero
but — the first word you need to hold two true things against each other, and the first word of any argument
Introduced in Chapter 218.

perro
dog — a genuinely unsolved etymology, and the Latin word it pushed out
Introduced in Chapter 150.

pintar
to paint — and a Latin verb that once meant to embroider
Introduced in Chapter 455.

plantar
to plant — to press in with the sole of the foot, which is what planta meant
Introduced in Chapter 444.

poco
little, few — Latin paucus; English paucity is the noun and few is the same root through Germanic, and you already carry it inside tampoco
Introduced in Chapter 317.

poder
to be able or can — with the singular present forms puedo, puedes, and puede
Introduced in Chapter 69.

poner
to put or place — with the singular present forms pongo, pones, and pone
Introduced in Chapter 71.

por
"for" pointing back or through — at a cause, a route, an exchange; and you have been saying it since your first page
Introduced in Chapter 177.

por ejemplo
for example
Introduced in Chapter 270.

por favor
please (literally "for [a] favour")
Introduced in Chapter 14.

por lo tanto
therefore
Introduced in Chapter 273.

por supuesto
of course — supponere, to place under: it was already under the conversation
Introduced in Chapter 284.

por un lado... por otro
on one hand… on the other — holding two sources at once
Introduced in Chapter 277.

porque
because — two tiny words fused into one, and the reason a sequence becomes a story
Introduced in Chapter 167.

preferir
to prefer — Latin praeferre, to carry in front; ferre left Spanish no inherited verb at all, so every -ferir word came off the page
Introduced in Chapter 396.

preguntar
to ask (a question) — and the reason English's one "ask" becomes two Spanish verbs
Introduced in Chapter 160.

preparar
to prepare
Introduced in Chapter 409.

prestar
to lend — the other half of devolver, and the verb that decides which way the object is moving
Introduced in Chapter 436.

previo
previous, prior — the adjective that completes the phrase every advert uses
Introduced in Chapter 435.

primero · segundo · tercero
first, second, third — the counting words for order rather than amount, and the story inside the second one
Introduced in Chapter 262.

problema
problem
Introduced in Chapter 268.

producir
to produce — the second -ducir verb, and it conjugates exactly like the one you already have
Introduced in Chapter 467.

profesor
teacher — and the one place Spanish drops the "a" that English insists on
Introduced in Chapter 51.

propio
one's own — Latin proprius, belonging to the individual; English proper, property and appropriate all began as words about owning
Introduced in Chapter 350.

próximo
next, nearest — Latin proximus, nearest, the superlative of prope near; English proximity, approximate, approach and reproach come off it
Introduced in Chapter 343.

puede ser
could be — two words you already own, standing side by side and meaning less together than either does alone
Introduced in Chapter 298.

pues
well, then, since — Latin post, after; the same post is inside despues, and English keeps it raw in post-, posterior and postpone
Introduced in Chapter 329.

qué
what? (a new question word for verbs you already know)
Introduced in Chapter 36.

quedar
to stay — Latin quietare, to make still, from quies, rest; English quiet, quit and coy are the same root
Introduced in Chapter 382.

quedarse
to stay, to remain
Introduced in Chapter 416.

quemar
to burn — the Academy says Latin cremare; Corominas says the sounds forbid it, and the argument is still open
Introduced in Chapter 387.

querer
to want — with the singular present forms quiero, quieres, and quiere
Introduced in Chapter 69.

quién
who — the asking word Spanish keeps for people, and the reason qué has never had to do that job
Introduced in Chapter 232.

quién
who? — one tiny people-question before the writing marks are explained
Introduced in Chapter 5.

quizás
maybe, perhaps
Introduced in Chapter 271.

rechazar
to turn down — the opposite of *aceptar*, and its cousin
Introduced in Chapter 461.

recoger
to collect, to pick up — the single most demanded verb in the A2 papers, and one word for four English ones
Introduced in Chapter 436.

recomendar
to recommend — aconsejar's near twin, an e that breaks to ie like pensar's, and a root about entrusting
Introduced in Chapter 473.

recordar
to remember, to remind — to pass a thing back through the heart
Introduced in Chapter 464.

recto
straight — Latin rectus; in directions, continue straight, not resto, the rest or remainder
Introduced in Chapter 401.

reducir
to cut back — to lead a thing back, and a shower is its cousin
Introduced in Chapter 462.

regular
so-so / not great (also "más o menos")
Introduced in Chapter 9.

reír
to laugh — a word that wears a prefix it never had, and an accent that marks a missing consonant
Introduced in Chapter 438.

rellenar
to fill in; to fill out — especially a form or document
Introduced in Chapter 406.

reparar
to repair — Latin reparāre, re- plus parāre, to make ready; whether it came down by mouth or off the page cannot be settled, and the reason is the lesson
Introduced in Chapter 396.

repetir
to repeat — to seek again, from the same petere that sits under el pedido
Introduced in Chapter 445.

reservar
to reserve, to book
Introduced in Chapter 409.

revisar
to check over — looking at something a second time, on purpose
Introduced in Chapter 451.

rojo
red — a cousin of French rouge and English red, but by a different branch of the same very old family
Introduced in Chapter 139.

romper
to break — Latin rumpere, and the reason a road is called a route
Introduced in Chapter 381.

rosa
pink, and the rose — Latin rosa, itself a loanword from the east; rosemary is not rose and Mary but ros marinus, sea dew
Introduced in Chapter 372.

rotativo
rotating, on a rota — the third word in the track built on a wheel
Introduced in Chapter 453.

roto
broken, in pieces — an irregular participle that dropped two letters and kept them
Introduced in Chapter 448.

sábado, domingo
the weekend (Saturday, Sunday) — where religion overwrote astronomy
Introduced in Chapter 138.

saber
to know how — before an infinitive it names a skill you learned, where poder names a chance you happen to have
Introduced in Chapter 389.

sacar
to take out — origin unsettled; not from saco meaning bag, though a Latin saccus meaning filter may be behind both
Introduced in Chapter 383.

salir
to leave or go out — with the singular present forms salgo, sales, and sale
Introduced in Chapter 72.

saltar
to jump — Latin saltare, and the somersault is a jump over the top
Introduced in Chapter 381.

salvo
except, safe — Latin salvus, unharmed; English salvage, salvation, salvo, salve and safe itself all come off it
Introduced in Chapter 329.

sano
healthy — Latin sanus, sound in body and mind; English sane, sanity, insane, sanitary and sanatorium are the same word
Introduced in Chapter 327.

se llama
he/she calls himself; you (formal) call yourself
Introduced in Chapter 6.

seco
dry — Latin siccus; English desiccate is the same word, and so is the sec on a French wine label
Introduced in Chapter 379.

seguir
to follow or continue — from Vulgar Latin sequīre, built from Latin sequī with the ending of īre, to go
Introduced in Chapter 401.

según
according to — marking whose claim it is
Introduced in Chapter 277.

seguro
sure — se- without plus cura, care: free from care, and so reliable
Introduced in Chapter 284.

seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez
the numbers 6–10 and the old counting hidden in month names
Introduced in Chapter 47.

sencillo
simple, plain — few parts rather than little effort, which is what separates it from fácil
Introduced in Chapter 471.

señor
sir, Mr — Latin senior, older; respect built out of age
Introduced in Chapter 305.

señora
madam, Mrs — the feminine of senor, on the same Latin senior
Introduced in Chapter 305.

sentarse
to sit down — literally "to seat oneself", the reflexive that lands the action back on you
Introduced in Chapter 166.

ser
to be — the verb used here to identify someone or say what someone is
Introduced in Chapter 48.

ser un quijote
to be a Quixote — an allusion working as a word
Introduced in Chapter 274.

ser vs estar
identify with ser; describe a current state or location with estar
Introduced in Chapter 48.

serio
serious, earnest — Latin serius, weighty; the metaphor of heaviness for gravity of manner is so old that Latin had already forgotten it was a metaphor
Introduced in Chapter 423.

servir
to serve — Latin servire, from servus, a slave; dessert is the clearing of the table, and sergeant is servant said a second time
Introduced in Chapter 386.

sí
yes
Introduced in Chapter 7.

sí que
the emphatic yes — contradicting something unsaid
Introduced in Chapter 275.

sí, claro
yeah, right
Introduced in Chapter 272.

siempre
always — Latin semper, kept almost whole; sempiternal is semper plus aeternus, everlasting said twice
Introduced in Chapter 316.

simpático
likeable, nice — Spanish's own adjective from simpatía, Latin sympathia from Greek sympatheia; it does not mean sympathetic
Introduced in Chapter 380.

sin duda
no doubt — duda is dubitare, and behind that duo, two: to doubt is to be caught between a pair of answers
Introduced in Chapter 298.

sin embargo
however, nevertheless
Introduced in Chapter 270.

sino
but rather — si plus no, if not; the negative that corrects a negative, and both halves are words you already have
Introduced in Chapter 329.

siquiera
even, at least — two words you already have, si and quiera, welded into one; ni siquiera is not even
Introduced in Chapter 324.

sociable
sociable, outgoing — Latin socius, a companion or ally, plus -able; the same socius is inside society, associate and the word soccer
Introduced in Chapter 423.

solicitar
to apply for, to request — the formal verb on the form
Introduced in Chapter 460.

solo
alone, and also only — Latin solus; the accent that once separated the two meanings was abolished in 2010, so five letters now do both jobs
Introduced in Chapter 326.

soñar
to dream — Latin somniare, and the reason sleeplessness is called insomnia
Introduced in Chapter 381.

soy de...
I am from… — use ser with de to state origin
Introduced in Chapter 48.

suave
smooth, soft — Latin suavis; English sweet is the inherited cousin of the same root, and to persuade is to make a thing sweet to somebody
Introduced in Chapter 372.

subir
to go up — Latin subire, which was built on sub, meaning under; English sudden is the same sub-
Introduced in Chapter 384.

sucio
dirty — from sucidus, greasy with its own juice, said first of unwashed wool
Introduced in Chapter 281.

suficiente
enough — the formal partner of bastante, naming a requirement where bastante names a place on a scale
Introduced in Chapter 467.

supongo que
I suppose that
Introduced in Chapter 271.

surgir
to arise, to come up — Latin surgere, to rise, and the verb a question reaches for when it asks where an idea came from
Introduced in Chapter 472.

suspender
to fail an exam — Latin for to leave hanging, which is exactly what a resit does to your year
Introduced in Chapter 429.

tal
such, such a — Latin talis, of that kind; English keeps it in retaliate, to give back the like, and in the lawyers' lex talionis
Introduced in Chapter 329.

tal vez
maybe — literally "such a turn", from vicem, a turn or a change; vice versa is the turn turned round
Introduced in Chapter 298.

también
also — and you have been holding half of it since the first chapter of this book
Introduced in Chapter 219.

tampoco
neither — the same tan, a different second half, and the word that lets you agree with a no
Introduced in Chapter 220.

tardar
to take time — the verb the delay chapter promised and did not give you
Introduced in Chapter 437.

te quiero
"you" as the object — and the sentence it makes, which is the one people actually need
Introduced in Chapter 85.

temprano
early — Latin temporanus, in good time, built on tempus; English temporary, tempo and contemporary share the root, and so does el tiempo
Introduced in Chapter 322.

tender
to hang out the washing — to stretch something, and the verb inside *la tienda*
Introduced in Chapter 455.

tener
to have — a common verb with two visible changes
Introduced in Chapter 47.

tener gracia
to be funny — and a word that does not translate
Introduced in Chapter 274.

tengo · hago · digo
comparing the three learned yo forms that end in -go
Introduced in Chapter 70.

terminar
to finish, to end
Introduced in Chapter 409.

tibio
lukewarm — Latin tepidus, the same word English borrowed later as tepid, one worn down by speech and the other kept in a book
Introduced in Chapter 379.

tímido
shy, timid — Latin timidus from timere "to fear"; the same verb is inside intimidate, which is the act of putting that fear into someone
Introduced in Chapter 423.

tirar
to throw away, and on a door, to pull — one verb pointing two opposite ways
Introduced in Chapter 439.

tocar
to touch — Romance toccare, which meant to knock or strike; English touch is the same word, and a toccata shows off the player's touch
Introduced in Chapter 385.

todavía
still, yet — literally toda vía, "all the road"; the via in it is English via, viaduct, deviate and obvious
Introduced in Chapter 322.

todo
all, everything — Latin totus; English total is the same word, and Portuguese tudo is its sibling down a parallel road
Introduced in Chapter 316.

tomar
to take (and, across Latin America, to drink) — an everyday word with no settled origin
Introduced in Chapter 159.

tomar el pelo
to pull someone's leg (lit. to take the hair)
Introduced in Chapter 272.

torcerse
to twist something of your own — the injury verb, and a stem that breaks under stress
Introduced in Chapter 438.

torpe
clumsy — a word that meant shameful, and moved from how you look to what you can do
Introduced in Chapter 447.

trabajador
hard-working — trabajar plus the agent ending -dor, the Spanish descendant of the Latin -tor that made actor; the same ending makes both a noun and an adjective
Introduced in Chapter 423.

trabajar
to work (a second -ar verb — same pattern)
Introduced in Chapter 20.

traer
to bring — Latin's word for dragging, and a verb with a direction built into it
Introduced in Chapter 168.

tranquilo
calm — Latin tranquillus, the word for a sea with no wind on it
Introduced in Chapter 304.

trasladar
to move something across — built from a prefix and a participle that belongs to a different verb
Introduced in Chapter 439.

triste
sad — Latin tristis, which also meant harsh and grim before it softened
Introduced in Chapter 304.

tú / usted
two of the three words Spanish uses to one person — and the one English quietly retired
Introduced in Chapter 5.

tú o usted
the choice English lost — and the surprise that usted takes he/she verb forms
Introduced in Chapter 5.

último
last — Latin ultimus, a superlative to a stem meaning beyond; English ultimate, ultimatum and ultra are all in that family
Introduced in Chapter 380.

uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco
the numbers 1–5
Introduced in Chapter 47.

usar
to use — a reconstructed spoken-Latin usare built on uti; English use is the same word, and usury, utensil and abuse are built on it
Introduced in Chapter 385.

valiente
brave — the old present participle of valer, from Latin valere, to be strong or be worth; English valiant, valour, value and valid are the same root
Introduced in Chapter 326.

varios
several — Latin varius, speckled, of mixed colours; English various, variety and variegated all start from a spotted hide
Introduced in Chapter 351.

veinte
twenty — the ceiling of the teens, and a word that was worn but never fused
Introduced in Chapter 149.

vender
to sell — Latin vendere, squeezed out of venum dare, to give for sale; there is a give hidden inside the word for selling
Introduced in Chapter 386.

venir
to come — with the singular present forms vengo, vienes, and viene
Introduced in Chapter 73.

ver
to see — veo, ves, ve
Introduced in Chapter 108.

verde
green — from a verb meaning "to flourish," and a cousin of verdant but not of English green
Introduced in Chapter 151.

viejo
old — from vetulus, "little old one", the affectionate form rather than the plain one
Introduced in Chapter 281.

visible
visible — the -able ending you know, spelled the other way, and pointing the other way too
Introduced in Chapter 466.

viví
the regular singular -ir preterite — viví, viviste, vivió
Introduced in Chapter 104.

vivir
to live — your first -ir verb, and a family that asks you to learn nothing new
Introduced in Chapter 35.

volar
to fly — Latin volare; a volley is a flight of arrows, and volatile is Latin for winged
Introduced in Chapter 387.

volver
to return — Latin volvere, to roll, on an old root meaning to turn; the stressed o breaks into ue in vuelvo, Old Spanish wrote bolver, and English revolve, involve and volume are the borrowed cousins
Introduced in Chapter 395.

vos
"you" across a large part of the Spanish-speaking world — to recognise, not to say
Introduced in Chapter 5.

voy a + infinitive
I am going to… — the near future with ir, a, and a known infinitive
Introduced in Chapter 49.

y / ¿y tú?
and / and you? — a tiny connector that hands the conversation back
Introduced in Chapter 9.

ya
already, now — Latin iam; English borrowed it without knowing, in the déjà of déjà vu
Introduced in Chapter 323.

¡Felicidades!
congratulations — a plural noun used as an exclamation, and the one Spanish reaches for on a birthday where English would not
Introduced in Chapter 428.

¡Salud!
cheers, and bless you — the noun you already have, used as an act rather than as a description, and it does two jobs
Introduced in Chapter 428.

¿cómo está usted?
how are you? — assemble the formal question from cómo, estar, and usted
Introduced in Chapter 8.

¿cómo se dice?
the single most useful sentence a learner owns — and it is this chapter's grammar, doing exactly what the chapter said
Introduced in Chapter 183.

¿cómo se llama usted?
what's your name? (formal)
Introduced in Chapter 6.

¿Cuántos años tienes?
how old are you? — literally, how many years do you have?
Introduced in Chapter 47.

¿dónde está?
where is it?
Introduced in Chapter 268.

¿Hablas español?
the yes-or-no question — and why Spanish barely has to do anything
Introduced in Chapter 267.

¿qué significa?
what does it mean — significar is Latin significare, to make a sign
Introduced in Chapter 303.

¿verdad?
the tag question — asking someone to agree
Introduced in Chapter 267.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 hola — *let your eye and your hand meet the word*
How many letters are written in hola, and which one makes no sound?

1.2 hola — *one supported copy*
Copy the visible word hola once, then report how many letters you wrote.

1.3 hola — *look, hide, write, compare*
After hiding the model for five seconds, write the greeting and then compare it.

1.4 *One heard greeting — write what you know*
From the heard cue OH-la alone, write the known greeting.

1.5 *Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind* el *and* la
How many grammatical noun classes does Spanish keep?

Chapter 2

2.1 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*
Why does bueno become buenos in buenos dias?

2.2 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*
And why buenas in buenas tardes?

Chapter 3

3.1 *un — "a," and the number hiding in it*
Say a day in Spanish.

3.2 *un — "a," and the number hiding in it*
Which one points at a day we both already know about: el dia or un dia?

3.3 *un — "a," and the number hiding in it*
What number is hiding inside un, and inside English a?

3.4 *una — the feminine one*
Say an afternoon.

3.5 *una — the feminine one*
Un or una before dia?

3.6 *una — the feminine one*
Which of the two lost a syllable on the way from Latin?

3.7 *Review — the four little words*
The day.

3.8 *Review — the four little words*
An afternoon.

3.9 *Review — the four little words*
Where does an article get its gender from?

Chapter 11

11.1 *Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span*
In 'Roberto, ¿cómo estás?', is Roberto inside the question?

Chapter 16

16.1 *hablo — "I speak"*
Turn hablar into I speak.

16.2 *hablo — "I speak"*
Which single letter is doing the work of the word I?

16.3 *hablo — one word, one whole sentence*
How many words does Spanish need to say I speak?

16.4 *hablo — one word, one whole sentence*
Why must English say the word I, when Spanish need not?

Chapter 17

17.1 *hablas — "you speak," to someone you know*
Turn hablar into you speak, to a friend.

17.2 *hablas — "you speak," to someone you know*
Which one means I speak: hablo or hablas?

Chapter 18

18.1 *habla — "he speaks," and the polite "you speak"*
Turn hablar into he speaks.

18.2 *habla — "he speaks," and the polite "you speak"*
Which form goes with usted: hablas or habla?

Chapter 19

19.1 *Review — the three forms, side by side*
I speak.

19.2 *Review — the three forms, side by side*
She speaks.

19.3 *Review — the three forms, side by side*
You speak, to a friend.

Chapter 23

23.1 *-ción — about two thousand words, at once*
Turn the English word information into Spanish.

23.2 *-ción — about two thousand words, at once*
What gender is every -cion word?

23.3 *-ción — about two thousand words, at once*
Why is this a rule rather than a coincidence?

Chapter 24

24.1 *-dad — twelve hundred more*
Turn the English word university into Spanish.
24.2 *-dad — twelve hundred more*
You see the word realidad and have never met it. What does it mean?
24.3 *-dad — twelve hundred more*
Why does -dad look less like -ty than -cion looks like -tion?

Chapter 25

25.1 *-mente — with no upper limit*
Make an adverb from rapido.
25.2 *-mente — with no upper limit*
Why does the adjective go feminine before -mente?
25.3 *-mente — with no upper limit*
What does rapidamente literally say?

Chapter 26

26.1 *Review — three endings*
Give the three Spanish endings and their English partners.
26.2 *Review — three endings*
Which of the three endings tell you the gender for free?
26.3 *Review — three endings*
Which ending is a machine rather than a decoder, and why?

Chapter 27

27.1 *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught*
What does La universidad tiene una reputacion internacional mean?
27.2 *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught*
How many words in that sentence had you never been taught?
27.3 *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught*
Why can a rule be worth more than a word?
27.4 *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught*
Are these endings perfectly reliable?

Chapter 28

28.1 *f → h — why the h says nothing*
Why is the Spanish h silent?

28.2 *f → h — why the h says nothing*
Which English word is hablar's friend, once you put the f back?

28.3 *f → h — why the h says nothing*
You meet hierro and have never seen it. Decode it.

28.4 *f → h — why the h says nothing*
Is every Spanish h a dead f?

Chapter 29

29.1 *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-*
Which English words are llamar's cousins?

29.2 *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-*
Which three Latin clusters all became ll-?

29.3 *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-*
You meet llave and have never seen it. Try the three clusters and decode it.

29.4 *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-*
What do all three sound laws have in common?

Chapter 31

31.1 *Synthesis — the decoder*
Decode hoja.

31.2 *Synthesis — the decoder*
Decode lleno.

31.3 *Synthesis — the decoder*
Decode la conservacion de la ciudad.

31.4 *Synthesis — the decoder*
A word resists every rule you have. What does that suggest?

Chapter 32

32.1 *Synthesis — the same conversation, twice*
You are talking to someone your own age. Which form: hablas or habla?

32.2 *Synthesis — the same conversation, twice*
You are speaking to someone you want to show respect to. Which form?

32.3 *Synthesis — the same conversation, twice*
In BOTH conversations, how do you say I speak?

Chapter 34

34.1 *comer — "to eat," and the second verb family*
Which ending makes comer a different family from hablar?

34.2 *como — "I eat," and you already knew how*
Turn comer into I eat.

34.3 *como — "I eat," and you already knew how*
Which ending is identical in the -ar and -er families?

34.4 *comes — "you eat," and the first real difference*
Turn comer into you eat, to a friend.

34.5 *comes — "you eat," and the first real difference*
What does a final -s on a Spanish verb always tell you?

34.6 *come — "he eats," and the polite "you eat"*
Turn comer into he eats.

34.7 *come — "he eats," and the polite "you eat"*
Which form goes with usted: comes or come?

34.8 *Review — the -er family, all three*
I eat.

34.9 *Review — the -er family, all three*
You eat, to a friend.

34.10 *Review — the -er family, all three*
Which of the three slots is identical between the -ar and -er families?

Chapter 35

35.1 *vivir — "to live," and the third family (that's barely new)*
Give the three singular forms of vivir in order: I, tú, usted.

Chapter 36

36.1 *beber — "to drink," and the pattern is yours*
Say 'I drink coffee' in Spanish.

36.2 *qué — "what", a new question word*
Ask one friend 'What do you drink?' in Spanish.

36.3 *dónde — "where?"*
Say 'I live in Madrid' in Spanish.

36.4 *Practice — asking real questions*
Give the yo forms of comer, vivir, and beber, in that order.

36.5 *Practice — asking real questions*
Ask one friend 'What do you drink?' in Spanish.

36.6 *Practice — asking real questions*
Answer 'Where do you live?' with Madrid.

Chapter 37

37.1 *Synthesis — asking, and answering*
Ask a friend what they eat.

37.2 *Synthesis — asking, and answering*
Ask a friend where they live.

37.3 *Synthesis — asking, and answering*
How many verb families do you now hold in the singular?

Chapter 38

38.1 *hablamos — "we speak"*
Turn hablar into we speak.

38.2 *hablamos — "we speak"*
What was the Latin ending that became -mos?

Chapter 39

39.1 *hablan — "they speak," and "you all speak"*
Turn hablar into they speak.

39.2 *hablan — "they speak," and "you all speak"*
Which form goes with ustedes?

39.3 *hablan — "they speak," and "you all speak"*
What phrase is ustedes worn down from?

Chapter 40

40.1 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*
Which form goes with vosotros?

40.2 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*
You are addressing a group of friends in Argentina. Vosotros or ustedes?

40.3 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*
What two words is vosotros built from?

Chapter 41

41.1 *Review — the whole thing, at last*
We speak.

41.2 *Review — the whole thing, at last*
They speak.

41.3 *Review — the whole thing, at last*
How many forms does the present tense of a regular -ar verb have?

Chapter 42

42.1 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*
In Madrid, to a group of friends: which verb form?

42.2 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*
The same friends, in Bogota: which form?

42.3 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*
Which of the two is the correct one?

Chapter 43

43.1 *comemos — "we eat"*
Turn comer into we eat.
43.2 *comemos — "we eat"*
Which part of the ending is the same in hablamos and comemos?
43.3 *vivimos — where the two families part*
Turn vivir into we live.
43.4 *vivimos — where the two families part*
What is the only difference between comemos and vivimos?

Chapter 44

44.1 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*
Vosotros, from comer.
44.2 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*
Vosotros, from vivir.
44.3 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*
In how many of the six slots do -er and -ir actually differ?

Chapter 45

45.1 *comen and viven — agreeing again*
They eat.
45.2 *comen and viven — agreeing again*
They live.
45.3 *comen and viven — agreeing again*
In which two slots do -er and -ir differ?

Chapter 46

46.1 *Review — the present tense, whole*
Which row is identical across all three families?
46.2 *Review — the present tense, whole*
In which two rows do -er and -ir differ?
46.3 *Review — the present tense, whole*
We live.

Chapter 47

47.1 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five*
Write the Spanish numbers 1 through 5 in order.

47.2 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five*
Say 'one coffee' in Spanish.

47.3 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count*
Write the Spanish numbers 6 through 10 in order.

47.4 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count*
Were July and August inserted into the Roman calendar or were older months renamed?

47.5 *tener — "to have," with two visible changes*
Give the yo, tú, and él/ella forms of tener, in that order.

47.6 *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age*
Ask one friend 'How old are you?' in Spanish.

47.7 *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age*
Answer 'I am eight years old' using the Spanish age frame.

47.8 *Practice — counting, having, and age*
Write the Spanish numbers 1 through 10 in order.

47.9 *Practice — counting, having, and age*
Give the three learned singular forms of tener: yo, tú, then él/ella.

47.10 *Practice — counting, having, and age*
Answer ¿Cuántos años tienes? with nine years.

Chapter 48

48.1 *ser — another way to say "to be"*
Give the three learned singular forms of ser: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

48.2 *ser — another way to say "to be"*
Complete the identification for formal you: Usted _____ Ana.

48.3 *ser vs estar — identity or current state?*
Choose es or está: ¿_____ usted Ana?

48.4 *ser vs estar — identity or current state?*
Choose es or está: ¿_____ usted bien?

48.5 *soy de… — saying where you are from*
Ask one friend 'Where are you from?' in Spanish.

48.6 *soy de… — saying where you are from*
Answer 'I am from Madrid' in Spanish.

48.7 *está en… — saying where someone is*
Ask formal you 'Where are you?' in Spanish.

48.8 *está en… — saying where someone is*
Say 'Ana is in Madrid' in Spanish.

48.9 *Practice — identity, origin, state, and location*
Complete with es or está: ¿____ usted Ana?

48.10 *Practice — identity, origin, state, and location*
Say 'I am from Madrid' in Spanish.

48.11 *Practice — identity, origin, state, and location*
Say 'Ana is in Madrid' in Spanish.

48.12 *Practice — identity, origin, state, and location*
Complete with es or está: ¿____ usted bien?

Chapter 49

49.1 *ir — "to go," from more than one historical stem*
Give the three learned singular present forms of ir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

49.2 *ir — "to go," from more than one historical stem*
Complete the formal question: ¿Dónde ____ usted?

49.3 *voy a + infinitive — moving toward the near future*
Say 'I am going to speak' in Spanish.

49.4 *voy a + infinitive — moving toward the near future*
Say 'You are going to eat' to one friend in Spanish.

49.5 *mi, tu, su — whose café?*
Say 'my coffee' in Spanish.

49.6 *mi, tu, su — whose café?*
Addressing usted, say 'your coffee' in Spanish.

49.7 *Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership*
Give the learned singular forms of ir: yo, tú, then usted.

49.8 *Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership*
Ask formal you 'Where are you going?' in Spanish.

49.9 *Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership*
Say 'I am going to speak' in Spanish.

49.10 *Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership*
Addressing usted, say 'your coffee' in Spanish.

Chapter 50

50.1 *somos — "we are"*
Say we are.
50.2 *somos — "we are"*
Why do ser's forms look so unlike each other?
50.3 *son — "they are"*
Say they are.
50.4 *son — "they are"*
What Latin form is son worn down from?
50.5 *sois — the last of the six*
Vosotros, from ser.
50.6 *sois — the last of the six*
The same thing in Peru: which form?
50.7 *Review — all of ser*
We are.
50.8 *Review — all of ser*
They are.
50.9 *Review — all of ser*
Which of the six does not begin with s, and why?

Chapter 51

51.1 *profesor*
Say: I am a teacher.
51.2 *profesor*
Say: she is a teacher.
51.3 *profesor*
What did Latin profiteri mean?

Chapter 52

52.1 *estudiante*
Build the word for the one who studies, from estudiar.
52.2 *estudiante*
Say: we are students.
52.3 *estudiante*
Decode importante.

Chapter 53

53.1 *-ista*
Decode dentista.
53.2 *-ista*
Say: she is an artist.
53.3 *-ista*
Periodista is built on periodico. What is a periodico?

Chapter 54

54.1 *Synthesis — saying what people do*
Say: we are students.
54.2 *Synthesis — saying what people do*
You have never seen violinista. What is it?
54.3 *Synthesis — saying what people do*
Say what you are, then turn the question around.

Chapter 55

55.1 *estamos — the other "we are"*
Say we are, using estar.
55.2 *estamos — the other "we are"*
Why is estar regular here when ser is not?
55.3 *están — "they are"*
Say they are, using estar.
55.4 *están — "they are"*
Why does estan carry an accent when hablan does not?
55.5 *estáis — and nothing surprises you*
Vosotros, from estar.
55.6 *estáis — and nothing surprises you*
The same thing in Chile: which form?
55.7 *Review — both verbs for "to be"*
We are, with estar.
55.8 *Review — both verbs for "to be"*
They are, with estar.
55.9 *Review — both verbs for "to be"*
Which of the two has a regular plural, and why?

Chapter 56

56.1 *la casa — "house," and "home"*
Say the house in Spanish.

56.2 *la casa — "house," and "home"*
Say I have a house.

56.3 *la casa — "house," and "home"*
Which French word is casa worn all the way down?

Chapter 57

57.1 *el libro — "book"*
Say the book in Spanish.

57.2 *el libro — "book"*
Say I have a book.

57.3 *el libro — "book"*
What did Latin liber originally mean?

Chapter 58

58.1 *grande*
Say: a big house.

58.2 *grande*
Does grande change for la casa?

58.3 *grande*
What did Latin grandis mean?

Chapter 59

59.1 *cansado*
Say: I am tired.

59.2 *cansado*
Why estoy and not soy?

59.3 *cansado*
Your decoder finds no English cousin for cansado. What does that mean?

Chapter 60

60.1 *Synthesis — describing things*
Say: the house is big, but I am tired.

60.2 *Synthesis — describing things*
A woman says she is tired. Which word changes?

60.3 *Synthesis — describing things*
Put the words in Spanish order: grande / casa / una.

Chapter 61

61.1 *-oso*
You have never seen misterioso. What is it?

61.2 *-oso*
Say: a famous teacher, about a woman.

61.3 *-oso*
Ser or estar for nervioso, and why?

Chapter 62

62.1 *-ncia*
You have never seen preferencia. What is it?

62.2 *-ncia*
Which article goes with distancia, el or la?

62.3 *-ncia*
Say: a big difference.

Chapter 63

63.1 *-ario*
You have never seen imaginario. What is it?

63.2 *-ario*
Why does diccionario mean dictionary rather than word-ish?

63.3 *-ario*
Necesario, said of a feminine noun. What changes?

Chapter 64

64.1 *Review — the eight endings*
Which of -ista and -oso names a person?

64.2 *Review — the eight endings*
An -ncia word you have never seen. What gender?

64.3 *Review — the eight endings*
Decode la posibilidad.

Chapter 65

65.1 *Synthesis — reading a paragraph*
Decode: la comunidad tiene una tradicion.

65.2 *Synthesis — reading a paragraph*
Decode: su estructura es voluntaria, evidentemente.

65.3 *Synthesis — reading a paragraph*
A word you have never seen: especialista. What is it?

Chapter 66

66.1 *falsos amigos*
Exito is not exit. What does it mean, and why?

66.2 *falsos amigos*
Actualmente decodes to actually. What does it really mean?

66.3 *falsos amigos*
An ending gives you a word that makes the sentence strange. What do you do?

Chapter 67

67.1 *tenemos — and the stem change disappears*
Say we have.

67.2 *tenemos — and the stem change disappears*
Why does tienes break its stem but tenemos does not?

67.3 *tienen — the break comes back*
Say they have.

67.4 *tienen — the break comes back*
In any stem-changing verb, which two forms never break?

67.5 *tienen — the break comes back*
What actually decides whether the stem breaks?

Chapter 68

68.1 *vamos — from a verb that is not* ir
Say we go.

68.2 *vamos — from a verb that is not* ir
Why does the present of ir begin with v when the infinitive has none?

68.3 *vamos — from a verb that is not* ir
Name the English pair that works the same way.

68.4 *van — and the four are done*
Say they go.

68.5 *van — and the four are done*
They are (permanently), and they are (right now): which two forms?

68.6 *van — and the four are done*
What usually explains a Spanish verb that looks chaotic?

Chapter 69

69.1 *querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change*
Give the learned singular present forms of querer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

69.2 *querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change*
Say 'I want to speak' in Spanish.

69.3 *poder — ability with the o → ue change*
Give the learned singular present forms of poder: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

69.4 *poder — ability with the o → ue change*
Say 'You can eat' to one friend in Spanish.

69.5 *e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms*
Give the learned yo forms of querer and poder, in that order.

69.6 *e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms*
Give the learned tú forms of tener, querer, and poder, in that order.

69.7 *nuestro, nuestra — "our" with singular gender agreement*
Say 'our day' in Spanish.

69.8 *nuestro, nuestra — "our" with singular gender agreement*
Say 'our night' in Spanish.

69.9 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*
Give the learned singular forms of querer: yo, tú, then usted.

69.10 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*
Give the learned singular forms of poder: yo, tú, then usted.

69.11 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*
Say 'I want to speak' in Spanish.

69.12 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*
Say 'You can eat' to one friend in Spanish.

69.13 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*
Say 'our night' in Spanish.

Chapter 70

70.1 *hacer — doing or making with three singular forms*
Give the learned singular present forms of hacer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

70.2 *hacer — doing or making with three singular forms*
Say 'I make coffee' in Spanish.

70.3 *decir — saying with the same small person frame*
Give the learned singular present forms of decir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

70.4 *decir — saying with the same small person frame*
Say 'I say hello' in Spanish.

70.5 *decir — saying with the same small person frame*
Ask one friend 'How do you say hello?' in Spanish.

70.6 *tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know*
Give the learned yo forms of tener, hacer, and decir, in that order.

70.7 *tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know*
Which learned yo form means 'I do' or 'I make'?

70.8 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*
Give the learned singular forms of hacer: yo, tú, then usted.

70.9 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*
Give the learned singular forms of decir: yo, tú, then usted.

70.10 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*
Give the learned yo forms of tener, hacer, and decir, in that order.

70.11 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*
Say 'I make coffee' in Spanish.

70.12 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*
Ask one friend 'How do you say hello?' in Spanish.

Chapter 71

71.1 *poner — putting or placing with three singular forms*
Give the learned singular present forms of poner: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

71.2 *poner — putting or placing with three singular forms*
What two English verbs does poner cover?

Chapter 72

72.1 *salir — leaving with three singular forms*
Give the learned singular present forms of salir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

72.2 *salir — leaving with three singular forms*
Say 'I leave Madrid' in Spanish.

Chapter 73

73.1 *venir — coming with three singular forms*
Give the learned singular present forms of venir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

73.2 *venir — coming with three singular forms*
Say 'I come from Madrid' in Spanish.

73.3 *venir — coming with three singular forms*
Give the tú forms of venir and tener, in that order.

Chapter 74

74.1 *Review — six verbs, one ending*
How many verbs are in the -go set?

74.2 *Review — six verbs, one ending*
Which slot does the -go appear in?

74.3 *Review — six verbs, one ending*
Are these six related to each other?

74.4 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Give the learned singular forms of poner: yo, tú, then usted.

74.5 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Give the learned singular forms of salir: yo, tú, then usted.

74.6 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Give the learned singular forms of venir: yo, tú, then usted.

74.7 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Say 'I leave Madrid; I come from Madrid' in Spanish.

74.8 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Give the learned yo forms of tener, hacer, decir, poner, salir, and venir, in that order.

74.9 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Match each Spanish verb to one English cousin: poner, salir, venir.

Chapter 75

75.1 *Synthesis — you, and somebody else*
Say I am leaving, in one word.

75.2 *Synthesis — you, and somebody else*
Now say she is leaving. Is it irregular?

75.3 *Synthesis — you, and somebody else*
In these six verbs, which slot is the only irregular one?

Chapter 76

76.1 *queremos, quieren — work them out first*
We want.

76.2 *queremos, quieren — work them out first*
They can.

76.3 *queremos, quieren — work them out first*
Poder changes o to ue. What is we can?

76.4 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*
We do or make.

76.5 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*
They leave.

76.6 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*
Decir stem-changes. What are we say and they say?

76.7 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*
Salir is a -go verb. What is we leave?

76.8 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*
And they leave?

76.9 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*
How many rules generate the whole present tense?

Chapter 77

77.1 *la comida — "food," built from a verb you have*
Build the noun for food from the verb comer.

77.2 *la comida — "food," built from a verb you have*
Say I make the meal.

77.3 *la comida — "food," built from a verb you have*
What gender is any noun built with -ida?

Chapter 78

78.1 *las casas — "the houses"*
Say the houses.

78.2 *las casas — "the houses"*
Say the meals.

78.3 *las casas — "the houses"*
How many new rules did this lesson add?

Chapter 79

79.1 *los libros — "the books"*
Say the books.

79.2 *los libros — "the books"*
Why is it los and not els?

79.3 *los libros — "the books"*
Give all four forms of the Spanish word for the.

Chapter 80

80.1 *-es — the plural your first chapter owed you*
Make espanol plural.

80.2 *-es — the plural your first chapter owed you*
Which word have you been using this rule on since long before this chapter?

80.3 *-es — the plural your first chapter owed you*
Why -es rather than plain -s after a consonant?

Chapter 81

81.1 *Review — all four words for "the"*
Give the four Spanish words for the, in the order masculine singular, feminine singular, masculine plural, feminine plural.

81.2 *Review — all four words for "the"*
Say the books and then the houses.

81.3 *Review — all four words for "the"*
State the plural rule in one sentence, including what happens after a consonant.

81.4 *Review — the half of* ir *you never say out loud*
We go, then they go.

81.5 *Review — the half of* ir *you never say out loud*
Say you all go.

81.6 *Review — the half of* ir *you never say out loud*
Comer gives you la comida. What does the same ending give you from ir?

Chapter 82

82.1 *Synthesis — more than one*
Say I have books.

82.2 *Synthesis — more than one*
Now say I have the books.

82.3 *Synthesis — more than one*
Say I make meals, meaning meals in general.

82.4 *Synthesis — more than one*
What is the difference in meaning between casas and las casas?

Chapter 83

83.1 *lo — "it"*
Say I have it, replacing el libro.

83.2 *lo — "it"*
Does the pronoun go before or after the conjugated verb?

83.3 *lo — "it"*
Which everyday Spanish word comes from the same Latin word as lo?

Chapter 84

84.1 *la — "it," for a feminine noun*
Say I make it, about la comida.

84.2 *la — "it," for a feminine noun*
What decides whether you say lo or la?

84.3 *la — "it," for a feminine noun*
Why does the feminine article match its pronoun exactly, when the masculine pair does not?

Chapter 85

85.1 *me quieres — "you love me"*
Say you love me.

85.2 *me quieres — "you love me"*
In me llamo the me points back at the speaker. What is it doing in me quieres?

85.3 *me quieres — "you love me"*
How many new word forms did this lesson ask you to learn?

85.4 *te quiero — "I love you"*
Say I love you.

85.5 *te quiero — "I love you"*
Quiero un libro means I want a book. Why does te quiero not mean I want you?

85.6 *te quiero — "I love you"*
Which of tu and te is the one doing, and which is the one it lands on?

85.7 *te — the pair English used to have*
Which old English pair is the same inherited pair as tu and te?

85.8 *te — the pair English used to have*
Thee lines up with which Spanish word — tu or te?

Chapter 86

86.1 *Review — four pronouns, one slot*
Name the four object pronouns you now hold.

86.2 *Review — four pronouns, one slot*
What single question chooses between all four?

86.3 *Review — four pronouns, one slot*
Which two of the four depend on knowing a noun's gender?

Chapter 87

87.1 *Synthesis — saying it once*
Answer yes to Tienes el libro, without repeating the noun.

87.2 *Synthesis — saying it once*
Answer yes to Haces la comida, without repeating the noun.

87.3 *Synthesis — saying it once*
Somebody says Te quiero. Say the answering half.

87.4 *Synthesis — saying it once*
Version one of the dialogue was grammatically correct. What was wrong with it?

Chapter 88

88.1 *nos — "us"*
Say they love us.

88.2 *nos — "us"*
Me quieren and nos quieren differ in one thing. What?

88.3 *nos — "us"*
Where does nos stand in nos quieren?

88.4 *nosotros — the word inside -mos*
Which verb ending is the same ancient word as nos?

88.5 *nosotros — the word inside -mos*
What are the two pieces inside nosotros, and what do they mean together?

88.6 *nosotros — the word inside -mos*
Nosotros hablamos carries the same ancient word in two places. Name them.

Chapter 89

89.1 *los and las — "them"*
Say I have them, about los libros.

89.2 *los and las — "them"*
Say I make them, about las comidas.

89.3 *los and las — "them"*
The article el had to change shape for its plural. Why did the pronoun lo not?

Chapter 90

90.1 *os — "you all," in Spain*
Say I love you all, as a speaker in Spain would.

90.2 *os — "you all," in Spain*
Say the same thing the way most of the Spanish-speaking world would.

90.3 *os — "you all," in Spain*
Which older word is os worn down from, and where is it still said whole?

Chapter 91

91.1 *Review — all eight*
Give all eight direct object pronouns.

91.2 *Review — all eight*
Which four of the eight need you to know a noun's gender?

91.3 *Review — all eight*
Which two of the eight did you never have to be taught?

Chapter 92

92.1 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*
Answer yes to Tienes los libros, without the noun.

92.2 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*
Answer the question about las comidas, saying you make them.

92.3 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*
Say they love us.

92.4 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*
You have been talking about meals and you say los tengo. What goes wrong for your listener?

Chapter 93

93.1 *le — "to him," "to her," "to you"*
Say I tell him.

93.2 *le — "to him," "to her," "to you"*
How many genders does le have?

93.3 *le — "to him," "to her," "to you"*
Lo comes from Latin illum. Which Latin form does le come from, and what was it for?

Chapter 94

94.1 *les — "to them," and what this system really costs*
Say I tell them.

94.2 *les — "to them," and what this system really costs*
How many genuinely new words does the indirect set add?

94.3 *les — "to them," and what this system really costs*
Which four pronouns are identical in both sets?

Chapter 95

95.1 *Which one is the verb asking for?*
State the one-question test in your own words.

95.2 *Which one is the verb asking for?*
Say I speak to her.

95.3 *Which one is the verb asking for?*
Say I have it, about the book, and say which set that is.

95.4 *Which one is the verb asking for?*
Somebody in Madrid says le veo for I see him. Has a rule been broken?

Chapter 96

96.1 *Review — two systems, two new words*
Give the six indirect object pronouns.

96.2 *Review — two systems, two new words*
Which row is the only one where the two sets differ in shape, and how?

96.3 *Review — two systems, two new words*
Across both tables, how many distinct word shapes are there in total?

Chapter 97

97.1 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*
Answer yes to Tienes el libro, without the noun.

97.2 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*
Say I tell her today.

97.3 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*
Say I speak to them.

97.4 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*
Two pronouns in the same slot, both two letters, both from one Latin word. What is the only thing that tells them apart?

Chapter 98

98.1 *me lo — both at once*
Say I tell it to you.

98.2 *me lo — both at once*
Which comes first, the person or the thing?

98.3 *me lo — both at once*
Say you make it for me, about la comida.

Chapter 99

99.1 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*
Say I tell it to him.

99.2 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*
In front of which four words do le and les become se?

99.3 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*
How many different people can se lo digo be about?

Chapter 100

100.1 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*
What did Old Spanish say instead of se lo?

100.2 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*
Is the se of se lo digo the same word as the se of se llama?

100.3 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*
Which two Latin pronouns were squeezed together to make gelo?

Chapter 101

101.1 *Review — the pairs*
State the two facts that generate the whole table.

101.2 *Review — the pairs*
Give the pair meaning it to us.

101.3 *Review — the pairs*
How many new pronoun forms did this arc introduce?

Chapter 102

102.1 *Synthesis — two at a time*
Say shall I tell it to you.

102.2 *Synthesis — two at a time*
Say I make it for her, about la comida.

102.3 *Synthesis — two at a time*
In se la hago, how many of the three words name anything?

102.4 *Synthesis — two at a time*
You lose track of which thing se la points at. Does the sentence become wrong?

Chapter 103

103.1 *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir*
Give the shared singular preterite forms of ser and ir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

103.2 *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir*
Say 'I went to Madrid' in Spanish.

103.3 *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir*
In 'Fue Roberto', which verb does fue express?

103.4 *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb*
Give the singular completed-past forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

103.5 *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb*
Say 'I spoke Spanish' in Spanish.

103.6 *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb*
Which form means 'I spoke' as a completed event: hablo or hablé?

103.7 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*
Give the three learned forms shared by ser and ir.

103.8 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*
Give the three learned completed-past forms of hablar.

103.9 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*
Which sentence uses the shared form as ir, 'to go': Fui a Madrid or Fue Roberto?

103.10 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*
Give 'I speak Spanish' and then 'I spoke Spanish.'

103.11 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*
Which two of hablé, hablaste, habló carry written accents?

Chapter 104

104.1 *comí — one regular -er singular past*
Give the singular completed-past forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

104.2 *comí — one regular -er singular past*
Which form means 'I ate' as a completed event: como or comí?

104.3 *comí — one regular -er singular past*
Did Spanish -í, -iste, -ió arise by simple letter-dropping alone, or by sound change plus analogy?

104.4 *viví — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb*
Give the singular completed-past forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

104.5 *viví — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb*
Say 'I lived in Madrid' in Spanish.

104.6 *viví — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb*
Which three singular past endings do comer and vivir share?

Chapter 105

105.1 *tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress*
Give the singular completed-past forms of tener: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

105.2 *tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress*
Say 'I had coffee' in Spanish.

105.3 *tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress*
Which phrase best describes tuve: a letter-for-letter copy of tenuī, or a historically reshaped strong form?

105.4 *hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve*
Give the singular completed-past forms of hacer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

105.5 *hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve*
Say 'I made coffee' in Spanish.

105.6 *hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve*
Which Latin strong-perfect form lies behind the historical development of hice?

105.7 *estuve — a third known verb joins the strong pattern*
Give the singular completed-past forms of estar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

105.8 *estuve — a third known verb joins the strong pattern*
Say 'I was well' as a completed past statement in Spanish.

105.9 *estuve — a third known verb joins the strong pattern*
Which known strong form helped shape the family resemblance in estuve: tuve or hice?

Chapter 106

106.1 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Give the learned yo past forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

106.2 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Give the learned yo past forms of tener, hacer, and estar, in that order.

106.3 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Say 'I made coffee' in Spanish.

106.4 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Say 'I lived in Madrid' in Spanish.

106.5 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Say 'I was well' as a completed event in Spanish.

106.6 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Which pair carries written accents: comí/comió or tuve/tuvo?

106.7 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Which learned form is especially described as analogically remodeled beside tuve: comí, hice, or estuve?

106.8 *Synthesis — you can hear which past it is*
A preterite with no written accent. Where is the stress, and which kind is it?

106.9 *Synthesis — you can hear which past it is*
Why does comi carry an accent when tuve does not?

106.10 *Synthesis — you can hear which past it is*
In the regular preterite, do -er and -ir take the same endings?

Chapter 107

107.1 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*
Give the learned singular imperfect forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

107.2 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*
Which form leaves 'I spoke' open or habitual: hablé or hablaba?

107.3 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*
Which consonant links Latin -ābam with Spanish -aba?

107.4 *comía — hear both vowels*
Give the learned singular imperfect forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

107.5 *comía — hear both vowels*
Which form means 'I was eating': comí or comía?

107.6 *comía — hear both vowels*
Write comía with syllable breaks.

107.7 *vivía — reuse the complete -er row*
Give the learned singular imperfect forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

107.8 *vivía — reuse the complete -er row*
Which two infinitive classes share the learned imperfect endings -ía, -ías, -ía?

107.9 *vivía — reuse the complete -er row*
Say 'I was living in Madrid' in Spanish.

Chapter 108

108.1 *ver — learn the verb before its past*
What does Spanish ver mean?

108.2 *ver — learn the verb before its past*
Give the learned present forms of ver: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

108.3 *ver — learn the verb before its past*
Which Latin verb stands behind Spanish ver: vidēre or īre?

Chapter 109

109.1 *era — an old root in an open past*
Give the learned singular imperfect forms of ser: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

109.2 *era — an old root in an open past*
Which ser form presents a background past: era or fue?

109.3 *era — an old root in an open past*
Which Latin form stands directly behind Spanish era: eram or ībam?

109.4 *iba — ir returns to its inherited past*
Give the learned singular imperfect forms of ir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

109.5 *iba — ir returns to its inherited past*
Say 'I was going to Madrid' in Spanish.

109.6 *iba — ir returns to its inherited past*
Which inherited Latin verb stands behind iba: īre or vidēre?

109.7 *veía — keep the extra e you already met*
Give the learned singular imperfect forms of ver: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

109.8 *veía — keep the extra e you already met*
Which sentence means 'I was seeing coffee': Veo café or Veía café?

109.9 *veía — keep the extra e you already met*
Which earlier Spanish form makes the extra e of veía easier to see: veer or ir?

Chapter 110

110.1 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Give the imperfect yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

110.2 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Give the imperfect yo forms of ser, ir, and ver, in that order.

110.3 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Say 'I was speaking Spanish' in Spanish.

110.4 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Say 'I was living in Madrid' in Spanish.

110.5 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Say 'I was going to Madrid' in Spanish.

110.6 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Choose the open past: comí or comía.

110.7 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Match the three forms to their historical bridges: era, iba, veía — eram, ībam, veer.

110.8 *Synthesis — three exceptions, and no others*
How many irregular verbs does the imperfect have in the whole language?

110.9 *Synthesis — three exceptions, and no others*
Name them.

110.10 *Synthesis — three exceptions, and no others*
Why are those three the irregular ones?

Chapter 111

111.1 *hablaba and habló — two ways of looking*
Do the two past tenses differ in when something happened?

111.2 *hablaba and habló — two ways of looking*
Which form looks at the event from outside, finished?

111.3 *hablaba and habló — two ways of looking*
Say I was studying, putting the listener inside it.

Chapter 112

112.1 *cuando — putting both pasts in one sentence*
Say I was studying when Ana spoke.

112.2 *cuando — putting both pasts in one sentence*
Which tense sets the room, and which one walks into it?

112.3 *cuando — putting both pasts in one sentence*
Which other Spanish question words share the front of cuando?

Chapter 113

113.1 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*
Say I had a house, meaning it was simply so.

113.2 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*
What does tuve una casa actually mean?

113.3 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*
You meet a new verb that names a state. What will its preterite mean?

Chapter 114

114.1 *Review — one question, three answers*
State the one question that chooses the tense.

114.2 *Review — one question, three answers*
In estudiaba cuando hablo Ana, which verb is the scene?

114.3 *Review — one question, three answers*
Which two rows of the table are NOT the same event seen twice?

Chapter 115

115.1 *Synthesis — a small story*
In the story, which two verbs are the background?

115.2 *Synthesis — a small story*
Why is tuve un libro in the foreground when tenia un libro was not?

115.3 *Synthesis — a small story*
Say I was studying when I spoke with Ana.

115.4 *Synthesis — a small story*
Why did this take three chapters when neither tense was new?

Chapter 116

116.1 *hablado, comido, vivido — the participle*
Give the participle of hablar.

116.2 *hablado, comido, vivido — the participle*
Give the participles of comer and vivir.

116.3 *hablado, comido, vivido — the participle*
Does the participle change for who is speaking?

Chapter 117

117.1 *he hablado — "I have spoken"*
Say I have spoken Spanish.

117.2 *he hablado — "I have spoken"*
What does haber mean in he hablado?

117.3 *he hablado — "I have spoken"*
Which English verb was hollowed out the same way?

Chapter 118

118.1 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*
Give all six forms of haber, in order.

118.2 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*
Say they have eaten.

118.3 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*
Why is haber shorter than an ordinary verb?

118.4 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*
How many forms does comido take across all six rows?

Chapter 119

119.1 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*
Give the participles of hacer, decir, ver and poner.

119.2 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*
Which everyday English noun is the same word as hecho?

119.3 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*
Why are these four irregular rather than some other four?

119.4 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*
Say we have seen it, using the participle of ver.

Chapter 120

120.1 *Review — a tense you build*
What are the two pieces of this tense, and which carries the person?

120.2 *Review — a tense you build*
Say we have lived.

120.3 *Review — a tense you build*
Say you have said it, using the participle of decir.

120.4 *Review — a tense you build*
Why did this tense cost less than the present or the preterite?

Chapter 121

121.1 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*
Say I have eaten, meaning you are not hungry now.

121.2 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*
For something that happened today, which tense would a speaker in Madrid pick, and one in Mexico City?

121.3 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*
Two speakers correct you in opposite directions. Which of them is right?

121.4 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*
Say we have spoken Spanish.

Chapter 122

122.1 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*
Give the learned singular future forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

122.2 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*
Say 'I will speak Spanish' in Spanish.

122.3 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*
Which Latin verb meaning 'to have' contributed material to the Romance future endings?

122.4 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*
Give the learned singular future forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

122.5 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*
Use the learned -er future pattern to say 'I will drink coffee' in Spanish.

122.6 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*
Which endings do hablaré and comeré share across the learned singular row?

122.7 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*
Give the learned singular future forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

122.8 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*
Say 'I will live in Madrid' in Spanish.

122.9 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*
Give the future yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

Chapter 123

123.1 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*
Give the learned singular conditional forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

123.2 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*
Say 'I would speak Spanish' in Spanish.

123.3 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*
Write hablaría with the final three syllables separated.

123.4 *comería — keep -er before "would"*
Give the learned singular conditional forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

123.5 *comería — keep -er before "would"*
Give the yo pair 'I will eat; I would eat' in Spanish.

123.6 *comería — keep -er before "would"*
Which endings do hablaría and comería share across the learned singular row?

123.7 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*
Give the learned singular conditional forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

123.8 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*
Say 'I would live in Madrid' in Spanish.

123.9 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*
Give the conditional yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

Chapter 124

124.1 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*
Give the pair 'I will make coffee; I would make coffee' in Spanish.

124.2 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*
Give the future and conditional yo forms of tener, in that order.

124.3 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*
Give the pair 'I will be able to speak Spanish; I could speak Spanish' in Spanish.

124.4 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Give the future yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

124.5 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Give the conditional yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

124.6 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Say 'I will speak Spanish' in Spanish.

124.7 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Say 'I would live in Madrid' in Spanish.

124.8 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Give the pair 'I will make coffee; I would make coffee' in Spanish.

124.9 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Give the learned stems for hacer, tener, and poder, in that order.

124.10 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Which Latin 'have' verb contributed material to both Romance constructions?

Chapter 125

125.1 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*
You are committing to it. I will speak: which form?

125.2 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*
Now you are only supposing. I would speak: which form?

125.3 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*
What single word is glued onto the infinitive in BOTH tenses?

Chapter 126

126.1 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*
Which form asserts that one friend speaks: hablas or hables?

126.2 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*
Say 'I want to speak Spanish' in Spanish.

126.3 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*
Say 'I want you to speak Spanish' to one friend.

Chapter 127

127.1 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*
Give the learned singular present-subjunctive forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

127.2 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*
Which present form gives the stem for regular hable: hablo or habla?

127.3 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*
What joining idea sits inside the Latin source of subjuntivo?

127.4 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*
Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

127.5 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*
Which form belongs after quiero que for one friend: comes or comas?

127.6 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*
Say 'I want you to eat' to one friend.

127.7 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*
Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

127.8 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*
Which two regular verb families share -a, -as, -a here?

127.9 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*
Say 'I want you to live in Madrid' to one friend.

Chapter 128

128.1 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*
Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of querer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

128.2 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*
Which known present yo form gives the stem quier-?

128.3 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*
Complete 'Quiero que _____ hablar español' for one friend.

128.4 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*
Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of poder: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

128.5 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*
Which known present yo form gives the stem pued-?

128.6 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*
Say 'I want you to be able to speak Spanish' to one friend.

128.7 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*
Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of hacer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

128.8 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*
Which known present yo form gives the stem hag-?

128.9 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*
Say 'I want you to make coffee' to one friend.

Chapter 129

129.1 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*
Say 'I hope you speak Spanish' to one friend using ojalá.

129.2 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*
Does the learned ojalá frame require que before hables? Answer yes or no.

129.3 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*
Through which historical language variety did Spanish receive ojalá?

129.4 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Choose the wanted-event form: hablas or hables.

129.5 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Give the pair 'I want to speak Spanish; I want you to speak Spanish.'

129.6 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Give the tú subjunctive forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

129.7 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Which present-person form supplies the stem in this chapter's recipe?

129.8 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Give the learned singular subjunctive row of querer.

129.9 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Say 'I want you to be able to speak Spanish' to one friend.

129.10 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Say 'I want you to make coffee' to one friend.

129.11 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Say 'I hope you live in Madrid' to one friend using ojalá.

129.12 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
What does the Latin source subiūnctīvus help you picture?

129.13 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Name the historical language variety through which ojalá entered Spanish.

129.14 *Review — you never learned a new stem*
You say puedo. Do the move: drop the -o, add -a.

129.15 *Review — you never learned a new stem*
Same move on hago.

129.16 *Review — you never learned a new stem*
And on vivo — an -ir verb this time.

Chapter 130

130.1 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*
You are stating a fact about a friend: you speak Spanish. Hablas or hables?

130.2 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*
Now you only wish it were so. Which form follows ojala?

130.3 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*
What did ojala originally mean, and in which language?

Chapter 131

131.1 *habla — telling somebody to do something*
Tell somebody you call tu to eat.

131.2 *habla — telling somebody to do something*
Which form do you use to give a tu command?

131.3 *habla — telling somebody to do something*
Which two English words share a root with imperative?

Chapter 132

132.1 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*
Give the eight irregular tu commands.

132.2 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*
Tell somebody to come.

132.3 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*
Why are these eight so much shorter than every other verb form?

Chapter 133

133.1 *no hables — telling somebody not to*
Tell somebody not to speak.

133.2 *no hables — telling somebody not to*
Tell somebody not to eat.

133.3 *no hables — telling somebody not to*
Why does a negative command take the subjunctive?

Chapter 134

134.1 *hable usted — the polite command*
Politely ask somebody you address as usted to speak.

134.2 *hable usted — the polite command*
Of the four command boxes, how many use the subjunctive?

134.3 *hable usted — the polite command*
Why is the usted command the polite one?

Chapter 135

135.1 *Review — four boxes*
Give all four command forms of comer: tu do it, tu don't, usted do it, usted don't.

135.2 *Review — four boxes*
What was the only genuinely new material in this whole rung?

135.3 *Review — four boxes*
Why is the informal positive command the one box that keeps old irregular forms?

Chapter 136

136.1 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*
Tell a friend to come.

136.2 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*
Ask a stranger to eat, politely.

136.3 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*
In Spanish, where does the politeness of a command mostly live?

136.4 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*
You use usted commands with an old friend. What have you done?

Chapter 144

144.1 *la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth*
Say I drink it, about el agua.

144.2 *la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth*
Why can the pronoun show a gender the article hides?

144.3 *la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth*
You meet a new noun and cannot tell its gender from its article. What can you listen for?

Chapter 152

152.1 *Synthesis — saying something about your own life*
Say I have a black dog.

152.2 *Synthesis — saying something about your own life*
You are mentioning your cat for the first time. Un gato or el gato?

152.3 *Synthesis — saying something about your own life*
Say it is cold.

152.4 *Review — the same question, asked of eleven words*
Red, blue, green, yellow.

152.5 *Review — the same question, asked of eleven words*
Say it is two twenty.

152.6 *Review — the same question, asked of eleven words*
Say it is raining at noon.

152.7 *Review — the same question, asked of eleven words*
Which colour word started life meaning a little bitter?

152.8 *Review — one Saturday, from morning to midnight*
Say it is nine twenty.

152.9 *Review — one Saturday, from morning to midnight*
Say at midnight it is still raining.

152.10 *Review — one Saturday, from morning to midnight*
Octubre carries which number, and which month is it really?

152.11 *Review — one Saturday, from morning to midnight*
Which season is octubre in, north of the equator?

Chapter 157

157.1 *Review — four verbs of the mind*
Which of the four verbs originally meant to weigh?

157.2 *Review — four verbs of the mind*
Which one meant to gather or pick out?

157.3 *Review — four verbs of the mind*
And which one meant to scratch?

Chapter 158

158.1 *Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't*
What does no entiendo literally say, given intendere?

158.2 *Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't*
How do you say I understand now, once it slows down?

Chapter 162

162.1 *Review — three verbs that behave*
Which of the three is the same word as English aid?

162.2 *Review — three verbs that behave*
Which of the three has no agreed etymology at all?

162.3 *Review — three verbs that behave*
In all three verbs, who is the sentence about — the one doing it, or the thing done?

Chapter 164

164.1 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*
In me gusta el cafe, what is the subject?

164.2 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*
What did gustar originally mean?

164.3 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*
Which phrase you learned long ago is built from this same word?

Chapter 166

166.1 *Review — down, up, and away*
You have got up. How do you say you are standing?

166.2 *Review — down, up, and away*
Name the two everyday verbs for walking.

166.3 *Review — down, up, and away*
Is the origin of andar settled?

Chapter 167

167.1 *Review — the accent is doing the work*
Which of the three asks for a reason?

167.2 *Review — the accent is doing the work*
Say: I get up because I run.

167.3 *Review — the accent is doing the work*
What makes el porque a thing rather than a connector?

Chapter 172

172.1 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*
How many stem-change patterns does Spanish have in total?

172.2 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*
Which pattern belongs to exactly one verb, and which verb?

172.3 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*
Which change does conseguir make?

Chapter 173

173.1 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*
You want to say you know a person. Conocer or saber?

173.2 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*
Someone asks you to move something toward where they are. Traer or llevar?

173.3 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*
You want to ask for a coffee, not ask a question. Preguntar or pedir?

Chapter 176

176.1 *para — "for," pointing forward*
Say it is for you.

176.2 *para — "for," pointing forward*
Say by tomorrow.

176.3 *para — "for," pointing forward*
Which Latin piece inside para means toward, and which English words carry it?

Chapter 177

177.1 *por — and you already know three of these*
Say thanks for the meal.

177.2 *por — and you already know three of these*
What does por favor literally say?

177.3 *por — and you already know three of these*
Which everyday English word is the per inside por, still meaning through?

Chapter 178

178.1 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*
Say I am doing it for you, meaning you will receive it.

178.2 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*
Now say it meaning you are the reason.

178.3 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*
State the test in one sentence.

178.4 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*
Why is the arrow test not just a mnemonic?

Chapter 179

179.1 *Review — one arrow*
Give the two directions in one line.

179.2 *Review — one arrow*
Name three phrases you already knew that turn out to contain por.

179.3 *Review — one arrow*
A sentence takes either por or para. What should you conclude?

Chapter 180

180.1 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*
Tell somebody you are making the meal as a gift to them.

180.2 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*
Now say it meaning they are the reason you are doing it at all.

180.3 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*
Thank somebody for the meal.

180.4 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*
You pick the wrong one of the two. What have you produced?

Chapter 181

181.1 *se habla español — nobody in particular*
Write the sign that says Spanish is spoken here.

181.2 *se habla español — nobody in particular*
Who speaks Spanish, according to that sentence?

181.3 *se habla español — nobody in particular*
Say one eats well here.

Chapter 182

182.1 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*
Say books are bought.

182.2 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*
What is the verb agreeing with in se compran libros?

182.3 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*
Read se compran libros as if se still meant themselves. What does it say?

Chapter 183

183.1 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*
Ask how something is said.

183.2 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*
Ask how something is said in Spanish, politely.

183.3 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*
Why is it se dice rather than a form aimed at the person you are asking?

Chapter 184

184.1 *Review — the three se's*
Of the three se's, which two are really one word?

184.2 *Review — the three se's*
What single thing right after se tells you it is the impostor?

184.3 *Review — the three se's*
Which se is in como se dice?

Chapter 185

185.1 *Synthesis — reading the window*
What does the sign SE COMPRAN LIBROS tell you?

185.2 *Synthesis — reading the window*
A sign has a word you do not know. Ask somebody, politely.

185.3 *Synthesis — reading the window*
Say the food is good here, the way a sign would.

185.4 *Synthesis — reading the window*
Why does leaving the person out give a sign its authority?

Chapter 186

186.1 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*
Join Tengo el libro and Compro el libro into one sentence.

186.2 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*
What happens to the repeated noun when que joins two sentences?

186.3 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*
Which question words share que's root?

Chapter 187

187.1 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
Say the book I bought.

187.2 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
Say the house I have.

187.3 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
What English pattern always means a que is needed in Spanish?

187.4 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
Why can English afford to drop it when Spanish cannot?

Chapter 188

188.1 *lo que — "what," out of two old words*
Say what I say, meaning the thing that I say.

188.2 *lo que — "what," out of two old words*
What is the difference between lo digo and lo que digo?

188.3 *lo que — "what," out of two old words*
How many new words did this chapter introduce?

Chapter 189

189.1 *Review — three jobs, no new words*
How many new words did this rung introduce?

189.2 *Review — three jobs, no new words*
Say the house I have, and name the trap.

189.3 *Review — three jobs, no new words*
When there is no noun to join to, what supplies one?

Chapter 190

190.1 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*
Ask whether somebody has the book you bought.

190.2 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*
Say the thing I do not have.

190.3 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*
Say what I do not have is the meal you make.

190.4 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*
Why is a long sentence not harder than the short ones it is made of?

Chapter 191

191.1 *hay — "there is," "there are," same word*
Say there is a house.

191.2 *hay — "there is," "there are," same word*
Say there are books.

191.3 *hay — "there is," "there are," same word*
What does hay agree with?

Chapter 192

192.1 *ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word*
What two pieces make up hay?

192.2 *ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word*
Where else in modern Spanish does that y meaning there appear?

192.3 *ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word*
Which French phrase is the same three pieces, kept separate?

Chapter 193

193.1 *hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular*
Say you have to speak Spanish, without naming anybody.

193.2 *hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular*
What form of the verb follows hay que?

193.3 *hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular*
Name the other Spanish construction that leaves the person out.

Chapter 194

194.1 *Review — three letters*
Say there is a house, there are books, and one must eat.

194.2 *Review — three letters*
Name the two things hay never does.

194.3 *Review — three letters*
Why did a three-letter word need four chapters when comida needed one?

Chapter 195

195.1 *Synthesis — describing where you are*
Ask what there is here.
195.2 *Synthesis — describing where you are*
Say there are books, the ones I bought.
195.3 *Synthesis — describing where you are*
Say what there is, one must eat.
195.4 *Synthesis — describing where you are*
What is left to learn now that the machinery is assembled?

Chapter 196

196.1 *si*
Say: if I have time, I speak Spanish.
196.2 *si*
Which one means yes, si or si with an accent?
196.3 *si*
What is the Latin word for yes built out of?

Chapter 197

197.1 *si + futuro*
Say: if I have time, I will speak Spanish.
197.2 *si + futuro*
Is si tendre tiempo correct?
197.3 *si + futuro*
Why does only the second half get the future?

Chapter 198

198.1 *Synthesis — real conditions*
Say it as a habit: if I have time, I speak Spanish.
198.2 *Synthesis — real conditions*
Now say it as a plan for today.
198.3 *Synthesis — real conditions*
Si and si with an accent: which is which?

Chapter 199

199.1 *hablaron*
Say: they spoke Spanish.

199.2 *hablaron*
Why does hablo carry an accent but hablaron does not?

199.3 *hablaron*
Build the same form from trabajar.

Chapter 200

200.1 *hablamos*
Say: we spoke Spanish.

200.2 *hablamos*
How does a listener know which tense hablamos is?

200.3 *hablamos*
Give the we form and the they form, both past, for trabajar.

Chapter 201

201.1 *comieron*
Say: they ate.

201.2 *comieron*
Now the same form from vivir.

201.3 *comieron*
Which of hablamos, comimos and vivimos is a past form ONLY?

Chapter 202

202.1 *tuvieron*
Say: they had.

202.2 *tuvieron*
Build the same form from hacer.

202.3 *tuvieron*
Which strong forms hold the stress on the stem?

Chapter 203

203.1 *fueron*
Say: they were.

203.2 *fueron*
How many meanings does fueron have?

203.3 *fueron*
Where did Spanish get the past of to be?

Chapter 204

204.1 *Review — the whole preterite*
Which two we-forms are present AND past?

204.2 *Review — the whole preterite*
Name the four stems that had to be memorised.

204.3 *Review — the whole preterite*
Which plural refuses both -aron and -ieron?

Chapter 205

205.1 *Synthesis — telling what happened*
Say: they spoke Spanish and they had time.

205.2 *Synthesis — telling what happened*
Say: we ate at home.

205.3 *Synthesis — telling what happened*
Swap the -ron on tuvieron for -ra. What do you get?

Chapter 206

206.1 *hablara*
Build the supposing form of comer.

206.2 *hablara*
Why does this form have no irregular verbs?

206.3 *hablara*
What did this -ra ending mean in Latin?

Chapter 207

207.1 *tuviera*
Build the supposing form of tener.

207.2 *tuviera*
How many verbs does fuera serve?

207.3 *tuviera*
How many new stems did this chapter ask you to learn?

Chapter 208

208.1 *si tuviera*
Say: if I had time, I would speak Spanish.

208.2 *si tuviera*
What does the unreal version tell a listener that the real one does not?

208.3 *si tuviera*
Is si tenga tiempo possible?

Chapter 209

209.1 *Review — the two conditions*
Turn si tengo tiempo, hablo espanol into the unreal version.

209.2 *Review — the two conditions*
Name the two forms that never follow si.

209.3 *Review — the two conditions*
What does si itself contribute to the difference between the three sentences?

Chapter 210

210.1 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*
Say: if I were a teacher, I would speak Spanish.

210.2 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*
Say one true-for-you unreal condition about today.

210.3 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*
Which earlier gap had to be filled before this sentence was possible?

Chapter 211

211.1 *dice que*
Report it: he says he is tired.

211.2 *dice que*
Can you leave que out, the way English leaves out that?

211.3 *dice que*
Which word did you change to report your own words instead of his?

Chapter 212

212.1 *dijo*
He said.

212.2 *dijo*
They said. Careful — the ending is not the one you learned for tuvieron.

212.3 *dijo*
Which Latin letter is the j of dijo descended from?

Chapter 213

213.1 *dijo que*
Move it back: Dice que esta cansado.

213.2 *dijo que*
Move it back: Dice que trabaja.

213.3 *dijo que*
Why the imperfect rather than the preterite?

Chapter 214

214.1 *preguntó si*
Report it: Trabaja? (he asked)

214.2 *preguntó si*
Does the reported version keep its question marks?

214.3 *preguntó si*
Where have you met this si before?

Chapter 215

215.1 *preguntó dónde*
Report it: Donde trabaja? (he asked)

215.2 *preguntó dónde*
Does donde keep its accent in the reported version?

215.3 *preguntó dónde*
Do you need que or si in front of donde here?

Chapter 216

216.1 *(review)*
Which joint reports a statement?

216.2 *(review)*
Which joint reports a yes-or-no question?

216.3 *(review)*
And when the question already starts with donde?

Chapter 217

217.1 *(synthesis)*
Report the first line of the conversation.

217.2 *(synthesis)*
Report the second line.

217.3 *(synthesis)*
Report the third line.

Chapter 218

218.1 *pero — the word that lets two true things stand together*
Say: I am tired, but I study.

218.2 *pero — the word that lets two true things stand together*
Does pero cancel the first half of the sentence?

218.3 *pero — the word that lets two true things stand together*
How many Latin words is pero, originally?

Chapter 219

219.1 *también — a word with your very first word inside it*
Somebody says Estoy cansado. Agree, in two words.

219.2 *también — a word with your very first word inside it*
What two words is tambien made of?

219.3 *también — a word with your very first word inside it*
What does tan mean on its own?

Chapter 220

220.1 *tampoco — the same frame, the other half*
Somebody says No estoy cansado. Agree, in two words.

220.2 *tampoco — the same frame, the other half*
What two words is tampoco made of?

220.3 *tampoco — the same frame, the other half*
Which word tells you to answer tampoco rather than tambien?

Chapter 221

221.1 *este — pointing at what is in your hand*
Say: this book.

221.2 *este — pointing at what is in your hand*
Now: this house.

221.3 *este — pointing at what is in your hand*
Is el este libro possible?

Chapter 222

222.1 *ese — pointing at what is by you*
The book is next to the person you are talking to. Say: that book.

222.2 *ese — pointing at what is by you*
What decides between este and ese – distance, or something else?

222.3 *ese — pointing at what is by you*
What did the Latin word behind ese originally mean?

Chapter 223

223.1 *aquel — the far one, and an old friend in disguise*
The house is across the street, near neither of you. Say: that house.

223.2 *aquel — the far one, and an old friend in disguise*
Name the three, in order: by me, by you, by neither.

223.3 *aquel — the far one, and an old friend in disguise*
Which word from chapter one is hiding inside aquel?

Chapter 224

224.1 *esto · eso · aquello — pointing at what has no name yet*
You are holding something and have no idea what it is. Ask what it is.

224.2 *esto · eso · aquello — pointing at what has no name yet*
Is esto masculine or feminine?

Chapter 225

225.1 *(review)*
A book is an arm's length away, right next to the person you are speaking to. Este or ese?

225.2 *(review)*
Which question do you ask first, before choosing a form?

225.3 *(review)*
What does the pointing word push out of the sentence?

Chapter 226

226.1 *muy — the same word, bitten short*
Say: I am very tired.

226.2 *muy — the same word, bitten short*
Which form goes in front of a noun – muy or mucho?

226.3 *muy — the same word, bitten short*
Can muy stand on its own as an answer?

Chapter 227

227.1 *bastante — an ending you can already read*
Say: I am quite tired.

227.2 *bastante — an ending you can already read*
Put them in order, least to most: muy, poco, bastante.

227.3 *bastante — an ending you can already read*
What does bastante literally mean, taken apart?

Chapter 228

228.1 *mal — bien finally gets its opposite*
Somebody asks how you are, and you are not well. Answer.

228.2 *mal — bien finally gets its opposite*
Which form is the plain adjective, bad – mal or malo?

228.3 *mal — bien finally gets its opposite*
Give the opposite of bien, and the opposite of bueno.

228.4 *a word in a hurry — the short form and the long one*
What do mucho/muy and malo/mal have in common?

228.5 *a word in a hurry — the short form and the long one*
Which of each pair stands on its own – mucho or muy, malo or mal?

228.6 *a word in a hurry — the short form and the long one*
When a Spanish word loses its ending, what is it about to do?

Chapter 229

229.1 *(review)*
Which of the three means enough rather than a lot?

229.2 *(review)*
When does a Spanish word lose its ending?

229.3 *(review)*
Which ending inside bastante had you already learned to read?

Chapter 230

230.1 *al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*
Say: I'm going to the cafe.

230.2 *al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*
Is a el cafe a more careful way of saying it?

230.3 *al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*
Why does Voy a El Salvador keep the two words apart?

Chapter 231

231.1 *del — and then the list stops*
Say: the teacher's book.

231.2 *del — and then the list stops*
How many obligatory contractions does Spanish have?

231.3 *del — and then the list stops*
Does de la contract?

Chapter 232

232.1 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*
Somebody knocks. Ask who it is.

232.2 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*
You want the name of a person. Que or quien?

232.3 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*
Which Latin form did quien come from – the subject one or the object one?

Chapter 233

233.1 *o — one letter, one catch*
Offer a choice: coffee or water?

233.2 *o — one letter, one catch*
Say: seven or eight.

233.3 *o — one letter, one catch*
Is the o-to-u swap about spelling or about sound?

Chapter 234

234.1 *ni — joining two absences*
Say: I don't want coffee or water.

234.2 *ni — joining two absences*
How many negative words are in that sentence, and is it correct?

234.3 *ni — joining two absences*
Does ni mean or, or and not?

Chapter 235

235.1 *(review)*
How many obligatory contractions must you learn in Spanish?

235.2 *(review)*
The answer you expect is a person's name. Which asking word?

235.3 *(review)*
Why does siete o ocho become siete u ocho?

Chapter 236

236.1 *hablando — an action caught in the middle*
Make the -ando form of trabajar.

236.2 *hablando — an action caught in the middle*
How many forms of hablando are there, for all the different people?

236.3 *hablando — an action caught in the middle*
Does hablando mean to speak, I speak, or speaking?

Chapter 237

237.1 *comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending*
Make the gerund of comer.

237.2 *comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending*
And of vivir?

237.3 *comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending*
How many gerund endings are there for three verb families?

Chapter 238

238.1 *estoy hablando — the payoff*
Say: I am eating.

238.2 *estoy hablando — the payoff*
Which of the two words changes for different people?

238.3 *estoy hablando — the payoff*
Can estoy comiendo mean I'm eating with her tomorrow?

Chapter 239

239.1 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*
Say: I see Maria.

239.2 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*
Now: I see the house.

239.3 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*
What job is the little a doing that Latin did with an ending?

Chapter 240

240.1 *(review)*
Say: we are studying.

240.2 *(review)*
Which of these takes the little a – seeing a house, or seeing a person?

240.3 *(review)*
How do you say you are eating with somebody tomorrow?

Chapter 241

241.1 *hablasteis — the form you were promised*
You all spoke.

241.2 *hablasteis — the form you were promised*
Which form is hidden inside hablasteis?

241.3 *hablasteis — the form you were promised*
How many forms of the -ar preterite do you now hold?

Chapter 242

242.1 *comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes*
You all ate.

242.2 *comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes*
You all had. (tener)

242.3 *comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes*
Is any part of the preterite still owed to you?

Chapter 243

243.1 *hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural*
We used to speak.

243.2 *hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural*
They used to work.

243.3 *hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural*
Why does only hablabamos need a written accent?

Chapter 244

244.1 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*
We used to eat.

244.2 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*
We were. (ser)

244.3 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*
How many irregular verbs does the imperfect have?

Chapter 245

245.1 *(review)*
Which single form of the -aba imperfect carries a written accent?

245.2 *(review)*
Name the three irregular imperfects.

245.3 *(review)*
Is anything still owed to you in either past tense?

Chapter 246

246.1 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*
Say: the coffee is for me.

246.2 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*
Which persons actually change shape after a preposition?

246.3 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*
Why does mi take an accent but ti does not?

Chapter 247

247.1 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says "with" twice*
Ask: are you coming with me?

247.2 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says "with" twice*
How many times does the word with appear inside conmigo?

247.3 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says "with" twice*
And with him?

Chapter 248

248.1 *¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming*
Somebody shows you something enormous. React, in two words.

248.2 *¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming*
Say the Spanish for great! or nice!

248.3 *¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming*
What has that accent always marked – questions, or something else?

Chapter 249

249.1 *María, ven — naming who you are talking to*
Tell Maria to come, naming her first.

249.2 *María, ven — naming who you are talking to*
What marks the person being addressed?

249.3 *María, ven — naming who you are talking to*
Does the person you address take the personal a?

Chapter 250

250.1 *(review)*
With me?

250.2 *(review)*
For you. (informal)

250.3 *(review)*
What replaced Latin's case for addressing somebody?

Chapter 251

251.1 *ahí · allí — the other two places*
The book is next to the person you are speaking to. Which place word?

251.2 *ahí · allí — the other two places*
And across the room, near neither of you?

251.3 *ahí · allí — the other two places*
Which pointing word goes with ahi?

Chapter 252

252.1 *ahora — now*
Say: right now I am eating.

252.2 *ahora — now*
Which word you already knew is hiding inside ahora?

252.3 *ahora — now*
Which of ahora and manana is the one you are inside of?

252.4 *hoy — today*
The word for today?

252.5 *hoy — today*
Which Latin word wore down into hoy, and what did it mean?

252.6 *hoy — today*
Say: today I am going to eat with her.

Chapter 253

253.1 *unos · unas — the plural of "one"*
Say: some books.

253.2 *unos · unas — the plural of "one"*
And some houses?

253.3 *unos · unas — the plural of "one"*
Which one talks about books in general – compro libros, or compro unos libros?

Chapter 254

254.1 *vuestro — the last possessive*
Say: your house, speaking to several friends.

254.2 *vuestro — the last possessive*
Which two possessives change for gender?

254.3 *vuestro — the last possessive*
How many possessives are there in the set now?

Chapter 255

255.1 *vi — the shortest past in the language*
I saw.

255.2 *vi — the shortest past in the language*
He saw.

255.3 *vi — the shortest past in the language*
Why does vi take no accent when comi does?

255.4 *di — the verb that changed families in the past*
He gave.

255.5 *di — the verb that changed families in the past*
Dar is an -ar verb. Which endings does it take in the past?

255.6 *di — the verb that changed families in the past*
Which two preterite forms of dar carry no written accent, and why?

Chapter 256

256.1 *(review)*
Which says books in general – compro libros, or compro unos libros?

256.2 *(review)*
What is hiding inside ahora?

256.3 *(review)*
Which set of past endings does dar take?

256.4 *Review — two pasts, both finished*
You all ate, then you all had.

256.5 *Review — two pasts, both finished*
Why does comiamos need its accent?

256.6 *Review — two pasts, both finished*
Dar is an -ar verb. Say I gave.

256.7 *Review — two pasts, both finished*
We were, and we used to go.

256.8 *Review — the column that belongs to* vosotros
You all go.

256.9 *Review — the column that belongs to* vosotros
You all ate, and you all had.

256.10 *Review — the column that belongs to* vosotros
Nosotros gives nuestro. What does vosotros give?

Chapter 257

257.1 *hablo — one form, two readings*
Give the two English readings of Como.

257.2 *hablo — one form, two readings*
Somebody asks what you are doing. Which is the ordinary answer – como, or estoy comiendo?

257.3 *hablo — one form, two readings*
So what is estoy comiendo actually for?

Chapter 258

258.1 *hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who*
What decides the ending on a Spanish verb?

258.2 *hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who*
Why can Spanish leave out yo?

258.3 *hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who*
When does the pronoun come back?

Chapter 259

259.1 *mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees*
Say: a lot of water.

259.2 *mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees*
Say: she works a lot.

259.3 *mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees*
What single question decides whether it agrees?

Chapter 260

260.1 *María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article*
Say: I see Maria.

260.2 *María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article*
Why does a name take no article?

260.3 *María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article*
You are speaking TO Professor Garcia. Article or no article?

Chapter 261

261.1 *(review)*
Is estoy comiendo required to say you are eating right now?

261.2 *(review)*
Ella trabaja mucho, or ella trabaja mucha?

261.3 *(review)*
Dropping yo – quirk, or consequence?

Chapter 262

262.1 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*
Uno, dos, tres tells how many. Give the three words that tell which one in the line.

262.2 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*
Say: the second house.

262.3 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*
What did the Latin word behind segundo actually mean?

262.4 *el primer libro — where an ordinal stands*
Say: the first book.

262.5 *el primer libro — where an ordinal stands*
And the first house?

262.6 *el primer libro — where an ordinal stands*
Which side of the noun does an ordinal take, and which habit does primer share with muy and mal?

Chapter 263

263.1 *uno… otro — splitting a pair*
Two books. Say: one is big, the other is good.

263.2 *uno… otro — splitting a pair*
Is un otro libro correct?

263.3 *uno… otro — splitting a pair*
Did Latin alter mean any other, or the other of two?

263.4 *Review — picking one, pairing two, refusing both*
The three place words, nearest to furthest.

263.5 *Review — picking one, pairing two, refusing both*
Split a pair across a sentence: one is red, the _____ is not.

263.6 *Review — picking one, pairing two, refusing both*
Turn both of them down: neither one nor the other.

263.7 *Review — picking one, pairing two, refusing both*
Ask for the one over there, away from you both.

Chapter 264

264.1 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*
Say: eating is good.

264.2 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*
Is comiendo es bueno correct?

264.3 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*
Say: speaking Spanish is good.

264.4 *Review — what happens where two words touch*
One book, then the first book.

264.5 *Review — what happens where two words touch*
Give both of Spanish's obligatory contractions.

264.6 *Review — what happens where two words touch*
Say seven or eight.

264.7 *Review — what happens where two words touch*
Which word in your Spanish says with twice?

264.8 *Review — what happens where two words touch*
Put the middle word into the scale: poco, _____, muy.

Chapter 265

265.1 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*
How many places can hoy go in Como en casa?

265.2 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*
What does putting hoy at the front do?

265.3 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*
Why can Spanish move these pieces safely?

265.4 *Review — what the ending carries, and what happens when it carries nothing*
Say you all go, with no pronoun. Then say what tells the listener who.

265.5 *Review — what the ending carries, and what happens when it carries nothing*
Give the two English readings of hablo.

265.6 *Review — what the ending carries, and what happens when it carries nothing*
Say eating is good.

265.7 *Review — what the ending carries, and what happens when it carries nothing*
Turn comer into a noun with an article.

Chapter 266

266.1 *(review)*
Eating is good – comer es bueno, or comiendo es bueno?

266.2 *(review)*
How many times have you now seen a word drop its ending before another word?

266.3 *(review)*
Does otro take an article?

266.4 *Review — one name, four different jobs*
I see Maria, then Maria, come.

266.5 *Review — one name, four different jobs*
Talk about Mrs Garcia in the third person, with her title.

266.6 *Review — one name, four different jobs*
A lot of water, then he eats a lot.

266.7 *Review — one name, four different jobs*
Say today I eat at home, putting the emphasis on today.

266.8 *Review — one name, four different jobs*
Say how big!

266.9 *(reading) — the first paragraph*
Who does Maria live with?

266.10 *(reading) — the first paragraph*
Why is she not working today?

266.11 *(reading) — the first paragraph*
Two things are said about the book. What are they?

266.12 *(reading) — the second paragraph*
Who is at home with the dog?

266.13 *(reading) — the second paragraph*
Why does he go out?

266.14 *(reading) — the third paragraph*
Whose house do they go to on Saturday?

266.15 *(reading) — the third paragraph*
What does the mother do?

Chapter 268

268.1 *Review — three phrases, in the order you need them*
Say the three in the order a journey needs them: find it, buy it, sleep.

268.2 *Review — three phrases, in the order you need them*
Habitar means to live in. What does the -cion ending add?

268.3 *Review — three phrases, in the order you need them*
Ask for a room, politely.

268.4 *Review — when the ending tells the truth, and when it lies*
Put the right article on each: habitacion, problema.

268.5 *Review — when the ending tells the truth, and when it lies*
Which language did the -ma of problema come through?

268.6 *Review — when the ending tells the truth, and when it lies*
A new word ends in -cion. Which article does it take?

Chapter 318

318.1 *Review — hasta pronto, and the word inside it*
Say see you soon in Spanish.

318.2 *Review — hasta pronto, and the word inside it*
What Latin word is pronto from, and what did it mean?

318.3 *Review — two sorries, and how to tell them apart*
You need to get past somebody in a narrow corridor. Which word?

318.4 *Review — two sorries, and how to tell them apart*
What does lo siento mean word for word?

318.5 *Review — two sorries, and how to tell them apart*
What are the two Latin pieces inside perdonar?

318.6 *Review — four nouns, easiest gender to hardest*
Say the hand in Spanish, with its article.

318.7 *Review — four nouns, easiest gender to hardest*
An article looks like it is hiding a noun's gender. What can you listen for instead?

318.8 *Review — four nouns, easiest gender to hardest*
Give the article and noun for the wine, then for the head.

318.9 *Review — two marks that were added, and when*
Who made the opening question mark official, and in what year?

318.10 *Review — two marks that were added, and when*
Was the h in hermano ever pronounced?

Chapter 319

319.1 *Review — what the surface does not tell you*
Which of the two sorries asks the other person for something?

319.2 *Review — what the surface does not tell you*
El agua takes el. Which pronoun replaces it, and what does that prove?

319.3 *Review — what the surface does not tell you*
Hijo and hermano both start with a silent h. Which one was once spoken aloud?

319.4 *Review — the five words of a leaving*
Name the five words of the leaving, in order from the street outwards.

319.5 *Review — the five words of a leaving*
Which body part is hiding inside esquina?

319.6 *Review — the five words of a leaving*
El faro was a place before it was a thing. Which place?

319.7 *Review — the harbour, the light, and see you soon*
Name the harbour and the lighthouse in Spanish, in that order.

319.8 *Review — the harbour, the light, and see you soon*
Say see you soon, and give the two words it is made of.

319.9 *Review — an introduction, start to finish*
Which Spanish word is the family name?

319.10 *Review — an introduction, start to finish*
Give both forms of address, and the one Latin word behind them.

319.11 *Review — an introduction, start to finish*
A woman is answering an introduction. What does she say?

319.12 *Review — two ways to answer an introduction*
Which of the two answers literally says you have been put under a spell?

319.13 *Review — two ways to answer an introduction*
What did the gusto of mucho gusto mean first?

319.14 *Review — five answering words, and where they came from*
Which of algo and alguien is for people?

319.15 *Review — five answering words, and where they came from*
What did the Latin behind nadie literally mean?

319.16 *Review — five answering words, and where they came from*
Latin alter, behind otro, meant the other of how many?

319.17 *Review — five answering words, and where they came from*
Which word you already had has poco hiding inside it?

319.18 *Review — the two that agree, and the p that becomes an f*
Which two of the five answering words change their ending?

319.19 *Review — the two that agree, and the p that becomes an f*
Poco and few are the same root. What happened to the p?

Chapter 335

335.1 *Review — six words that arrived last*
One Spanish noun names both a doorway and the ticket that gets you through it. Which?

335.2 *Review — six words that arrived last*
You have paid, and you are owed coins back. Name what you are owed.

Chapter 336

336.1 *Review — the same six, inside something you would say*
Two Spanish sentences use el calor: one about the weather, one about you. Give the one about you.

336.2 *Review — the same six, inside something you would say*
Ask somebody their age using the noun rather than the years.

Chapter 337

337.1 *Your own line — the first writing with no model*
Four in the afternoon, meeting someone new. Write your greeting and your name, using only the five given words.

337.2 *Your own line — the first writing with no model*
Same task, but it is nine in the morning. Write only the greeting.

337.3 *Your own line — the first writing with no model*
And at ten at night?

Chapter 338

338.1 *Four lines about you*
Write the line that gives your age. Use the frame, with a blank where the number goes.

338.2 *Four lines about you*
Which frame answers where you are FROM, and which answers where you live NOW?

338.3 *Four lines about you*
Write the line that says where you live, then the word that closes the form.

Chapter 339

339.1 *The same four lines, with a clock*
How long does the DELE A1 writing paper run, and how many tasks does it hold?

339.2 *The same four lines, with a clock*
The personal-information task asks for how many words?

339.3 *The same four lines, with a clock*
Under the clock, write the four lines and the close.

Chapter 345

345.1 *Review — the mask, the share, and the thing thrown down*
Which of the three words was a mask in Latin?

345.2 *Review — the mask, the share, and the thing thrown down*
Name a thing, and name a share of it.

345.3 *Review — three plain words, none of them one piece*
Say each object.

345.4 *Review — three plain words, none of them one piece*
Say the same object.

345.5 *Review — three plain words, none of them one piece*
Objeto is ob plus iacere. What does iacere mean?

Chapter 388

388.1 *Review — four verbs, four kinds of "related"*
Which of the four has no relation at all to its English lookalike?

388.2 *Review — four verbs, four kinds of "related"*
Why is push only a cousin of empujar?

388.3 *Review — four verbs, four kinds of "related"*
Cry and gritar are the same word. Which language moved the meaning?

Chapter 389

389.1 *Review — the verbs that will not sit behind* sé
Say you know how to throw.

389.2 *Review — the verbs that will not sit behind* sé
Why does se gritar sound odd?

389.3 *Review — the verbs that will not sit behind* sé
What did Latin sapere mean before it meant to know?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 hola — *let your eye and your hand meet the word*
Answer: four letters; the h
Also accepted: 4; four; h; the h; four, h

1.2 hola — *one supported copy*
Answer: hola — four letters
Also accepted: hola; 4; four

1.3 hola — *look, hide, write, compare*
Answer: hola

1.4 *One heard greeting — write what you know*
Answer: hola

1.5 *Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind* el *and* la
Answer: two
Also accepted: 2

Chapter 2

2.1 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*
Answer: it agrees with masculine plural dias
Also accepted: agreement with masculine plural dias; dias is masculine plural; because dias is masculine and plural

2.2 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*
Answer: tardes is feminine plural
Also accepted: because tardes is feminine; feminine plural; tardes is feminine and plural

Chapter 3

3.1 *un — "a," and the number hiding in it*
Answer: un dia
Also accepted: un día

3.2 *un — "a," and the number hiding in it*
Answer: el dia
Also accepted: el día; the first

3.3 *un — "a," and the number hiding in it*
Answer: one
Also accepted: 1; uno; the number one

3.4 *una — the feminine one*
Answer: una tarde
Also accepted: una tarde.

3.5 *una — the feminine one*
Answer: un
Also accepted: un dia; un, dia is masculine

3.6 *una — the feminine one*
Answer: un
Also accepted: un, from unus; the masculine one

3.7 *Review — the four little words*
Answer: el dia
Also accepted: el día

3.8 *Review — the four little words*
Answer: una tarde
Also accepted: una tarde.

3.9 *Review — the four little words*
Answer: from the noun beside it
Also accepted: the noun; from the noun; it copies the noun

Chapter 11

11.1 *Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no it is not; it is not

Chapter 16

16.1 *hablo — "I speak"*
Answer: hablo
Also accepted: yo hablo

16.2 *hablo — "I speak"*
Answer: o
Also accepted: -o; the o

16.3 *hablo — one word, one whole sentence*
Answer: one
Also accepted: 1; just one; uno

16.4 *hablo — one word, one whole sentence*
Answer: English endings wore down so they no longer show who is speaking
Also accepted: english endings wore down; english lost its endings; english endings dont show the person; because speak never changes

Chapter 17

17.1 *hablas — "you speak," to someone you know*
Answer: hablas
Also accepted: tu hablas

17.2 *hablas — "you speak," to someone you know*
Answer: hablo
Also accepted: the first; hablo means i speak

Chapter 18

18.1 *habla — "he speaks," and the polite "you speak"*
Answer: habla
Also accepted: el habla

18.2 *habla — "he speaks," and the polite "you speak"*
Answer: habla
Also accepted: usted habla

Chapter 19

19.1 *Review — the three forms, side by side*
Answer: hablo
Also accepted: yo hablo

19.2 *Review — the three forms, side by side*
Answer: habla
Also accepted: ella habla

19.3 *Review — the three forms, side by side*
Answer: hablas
Also accepted: tu hablas

Chapter 23

23.1 *-ción — about two thousand words, at once*
Answer: informacion
Also accepted: información; la información

23.2 *-ción — about two thousand words, at once*
Answer: feminine
Also accepted: always feminine; la

23.3 *-ción — about two thousand words, at once*
Answer: both come from the same latin ending
Also accepted: spanish inherited it and english borrowed it; they are the same word

Chapter 24

24.1 *-dad — twelve hundred more*
Answer: universidad
Also accepted: la universidad

24.2 *-dad — twelve hundred more*
Answer: reality
Also accepted: reality, the quality of being real

24.3 *-dad — twelve hundred more*
Answer: english wore that ending down further
Also accepted: english took it through french and it eroded more

Chapter 25

25.1 *-mente — with no upper limit*
Answer: rapidamente
Also accepted: rápidamente

25.2 *-mente — with no upper limit*
Answer: because mente is a feminine noun
Also accepted: it used to agree with the noun mente

25.3 *-mente — with no upper limit*
Answer: with a rapid mind
Also accepted: with a quick mind

Chapter 26

26.1 *Review — three endings*
Answer: -cion is -tion, -dad is -ty, -mente is -ly
Also accepted: -ción/-tion, -dad/-ty, -mente/-ly

26.2 *Review — three endings*
Answer: -cion and -dad, both feminine
Also accepted: -ción and -dad; the two noun endings

26.3 *Review — three endings*
Answer: -mente, because you can build new words with it
Also accepted: -mente — it makes an adverb from any adjective

Chapter 27

27.1 *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught*
Answer: the university has an international reputation
Also accepted: the university has international reputation

27.2 *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught*
Answer: four
Also accepted: 4

27.3 *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught*
Answer: a rule reaches words you were never taught
Also accepted: it applies to thousands of words at once

27.4 *Synthesis — reading what you were never taught*
Answer: no, a few have drifted
Also accepted: mostly, but there are false friends

Chapter 28

28.1 *$f \to h$ — why the h says nothing*
Answer: it marks where an f used to be
Also accepted: the f weakened to h and then to nothing; it is a leftover spelling

28.2 *$f \to h$ — why the h says nothing*
Answer: fable
Also accepted: fable, fabulous

28.3 *$f \to h$ — why the h says nothing*
Answer: ferrum, iron, as in ferrous
Also accepted: iron; ferrous

28.4 *$f \to h$ — why the h says nothing*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, some were always silent; no — hola and hasta are not

Chapter 29

29.1 *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-*
Answer: claim and clamour
Also accepted: claim; clamour, exclaim, proclaim

29.2 *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-*
Answer: cl-, pl-, fl-
Also accepted: cl pl fl

29.3 *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-*
Answer: clavem, key, as in clavicle
Also accepted: key; clavicle, clef

29.4 *cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-*
Answer: spanish wore the word down and english borrowed it closer to latin
Also accepted: spanish inherited and eroded it; english borrowed it later

Chapter 31

31.1 *Synthesis — the decoder*
Answer: folia, leaf, as in foliage
Also accepted: leaf; foliage, portfolio

31.2 *Synthesis — the decoder*
Answer: plenum, full, as in plenty
Also accepted: full; plenty, plenary

31.3 *Synthesis — the decoder*
Answer: the conservation of the city
Also accepted: conservation of the city

31.4 *Synthesis — the decoder*
Answer: it is probably not from latin
Also accepted: it may be arabic, basque or from the americas

Chapter 32

32.1 *Synthesis — the same conversation, twice*
Answer: hablas
Also accepted: tu hablas

32.2 *Synthesis — the same conversation, twice*
Answer: habla
Also accepted: habla usted

32.3 *Synthesis — the same conversation, twice*
Answer: hablo
Also accepted: the same, hablo; hablo both times

Chapter 34

34.1 *comer — "to eat," and the second verb family*
Answer: -er
Also accepted: er; the -er ending

34.2 *como — "I eat," and you already knew how*
Answer: como
Also accepted: yo como

34.3 *como — "I eat," and you already knew how*
Answer: the yo ending -o
Also accepted: -o; o; the yo ending

34.4 *comes — "you eat," and the first real difference*
Answer: comes
Also accepted: tu comes

34.5 *comes — "you eat," and the first real difference*
Answer: it is talking to tu
Also accepted: you, informal; it means tu; the subject is tu

34.6 *come — "he eats," and the polite "you eat"*
Answer: come
Also accepted: el come

34.7 *come — "he eats," and the polite "you eat"*
Answer: come
Also accepted: usted come

34.8 *Review — the -er family, all three*
Answer: como
Also accepted: yo como

34.9 *Review — the -er family, all three*
Answer: comes
Also accepted: tu comes

34.10 *Review — the -er family, all three*
Answer: the yo slot
Also accepted: yo; the I form; -o

Chapter 35

35.1 *vivir — "to live," and the third family (that's barely new)*
Answer: vivo, vives, vive
Also accepted: vivo vives vive; vivo / vives / vive

Chapter 36

36.1 *beber — "to drink," and the pattern is yours*
Answer: Bebo café.
Also accepted: Bebo café; bebo cafe; bebo cafe.

36.2 *qué — "what", a new question word*
Answer: ¿Qué bebes?
Also accepted: Qué bebes?; ¿Qué bebes; Qué bebes

36.3 *dónde — "where?"*
Answer: Vivo en Madrid.
Also accepted: Vivo en Madrid; Yo vivo en Madrid.; Yo vivo en Madrid

36.4 *Practice — asking real questions*
Answer: como, vivo, bebo
Also accepted: como vivo bebo; como / vivo / bebo

36.5 *Practice — asking real questions*
Answer: ¿Qué bebes?
Also accepted: Qué bebes?; ¿Qué bebes; Qué bebes

36.6 *Practice — asking real questions*
Answer: Vivo en Madrid.
Also accepted: Vivo en Madrid; Yo vivo en Madrid.; Yo vivo en Madrid

Chapter 37

37.1 *Synthesis — asking, and answering*
Answer: que comes
Also accepted: ¿que comes?; qué comes; que comes tu

37.2 *Synthesis — asking, and answering*
Answer: donde vives
Also accepted: ¿donde vives?; dónde vives

37.3 *Synthesis — asking, and answering*
Answer: three
Also accepted: 3; all three

Chapter 38

38.1 *hablamos — "we speak"*
Answer: hablamos
Also accepted: nosotros hablamos

38.2 *hablamos — "we speak"*
Answer: -mus
Also accepted: mus; amamus

Chapter 39

39.1 *hablan — "they speak," and "you all speak"*
Answer: hablan
Also accepted: ellos hablan

39.2 *hablan — "they speak," and "you all speak"*
Answer: hablan
Also accepted: ustedes hablan

39.3 *hablan — "they speak," and "you all speak"*
Answer: vuestras mercedes
Also accepted: your graces; vuestra merced plural

Chapter 40

40.1 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*
Answer: hablais
Also accepted: habláis; vosotros hablais

40.2 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*
Answer: ustedes
Also accepted: ustedes hablan

40.3 *habláis — the form Spain keeps*
Answer: vos and otros
Also accepted: vos otros; you others

Chapter 41

41.1 *Review — the whole thing, at last*
Answer: hablamos
Also accepted: nosotros hablamos

41.2 *Review — the whole thing, at last*
Answer: hablan
Also accepted: ellos hablan

41.3 *Review — the whole thing, at last*
Answer: six
Also accepted: 6

Chapter 42

42.1 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*
Answer: hablais
Also accepted: habláis; vosotros hablais

42.2 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*
Answer: hablan
Also accepted: ustedes hablan

42.3 *Synthesis — the same sentence, two continents*
Answer: neither, they are regional
Also accepted: neither; both are correct; it depends where you are

Chapter 43

43.1 *comemos — "we eat"*
Answer: comemos
Also accepted: nosotros comemos

43.2 *comemos — "we eat"*
Answer: -mos
Also accepted: mos; the mos

43.3 *vivimos — where the two families part*
Answer: vivimos
Also accepted: nosotros vivimos

43.4 *vivimos — where the two families part*
Answer: one vowel
Also accepted: the vowel; e versus i; one letter

Chapter 44

44.1 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*
Answer: comeis
Also accepted: coméis; vosotros comeis

44.2 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*
Answer: vivis
Also accepted: vivís; vosotros vivis

44.3 *coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last*
Answer: two
Also accepted: 2; nosotros and vosotros

Chapter 45

45.1 *comen and viven — agreeing again*
Answer: comen
Also accepted: ellos comen; ustedes comen

45.2 *comen and viven — agreeing again*
Answer: viven
Also accepted: ellos viven; ustedes viven

45.3 *comen and viven — agreeing again*
Answer: nosotros and vosotros
Also accepted: nosotros, vosotros; we and you all

Chapter 46

46.1 *Review — the present tense, whole*
Answer: yo
Also accepted: the yo row; the I form; -o

46.2 *Review — the present tense, whole*
Answer: nosotros and vosotros
Also accepted: nosotros, vosotros; we and you all

46.3 *Review — the present tense, whole*
Answer: vivimos
Also accepted: nosotros vivimos

Chapter 47

47.1 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five*
Answer: uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco
Also accepted: uno dos tres cuatro cinco

47.2 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five*
Answer: un café
Also accepted: un cafe

47.3 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count*
Answer: seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez
Also accepted: seis siete ocho nueve diez

47.4 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count*
Answer: older months were renamed
Also accepted: renamed; they were renamed; the older months were renamed

47.5 *tener — "to have," with two visible changes*
Answer: tengo, tienes, tiene
Also accepted: tengo tienes tiene; tengo / tienes / tiene

47.6 *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age*
Answer: ¿Cuántos años tienes?
Also accepted: Cuántos años tienes?; ¿Cuántos años tienes; Cuantos anos tienes?

47.7 *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age*
Answer: Tengo ocho años.
Also accepted: Tengo ocho años; tengo ocho anos; tengo ocho anos.

47.8 *Practice — counting, having, and age*
Answer: uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco, seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez
Also accepted: uno dos tres cuatro cinco seis siete ocho nueve diez

47.9 *Practice — counting, having, and age*
Answer: tengo, tienes, tiene
Also accepted: tengo tienes tiene; tengo / tienes / tiene

47.10 *Practice — counting, having, and age*
Answer: Tengo nueve años.
Also accepted: Tengo nueve años; tengo nueve anos; tengo nueve anos.

Chapter 48

48.1 *ser — another way to say "to be"*
Answer: soy, eres, es
Also accepted: soy eres es; soy / eres / es

48.2 *ser — another way to say "to be"*
Answer: es
Also accepted: Usted es Ana.; usted es ana

48.3 *ser vs estar — identity or current state?*
Answer: es
Also accepted: ¿Es usted Ana?; Es usted Ana?

48.4 *ser vs estar — identity or current state?*
Answer: está
Also accepted: ¿Está usted bien?; Esta usted bien?; esta

48.5 *soy de… — saying where you are from*
Answer: ¿De dónde eres?
Also accepted: De dónde eres?; ¿De dónde eres; De donde eres?

48.6 *soy de… — saying where you are from*
Answer: Soy de Madrid.
Also accepted: Soy de Madrid

48.7 *está en… — saying where someone is*
Answer: ¿Dónde está usted?
Also accepted: Dónde está usted?; ¿Dónde está usted; Donde esta usted?

48.8 *está en… — saying where someone is*
Answer: Ana está en Madrid.
Also accepted: Ana está en Madrid; ana esta en madrid; ana esta en madrid.

48.9 *Practice — identity, origin, state, and location*
Answer: es
Also accepted: ¿Es usted Ana?; Es usted Ana?

48.10 *Practice — identity, origin, state, and location*
Answer: Soy de Madrid.
Also accepted: Soy de Madrid

48.11 *Practice — identity, origin, state, and location*
Answer: Ana está en Madrid.
Also accepted: Ana está en Madrid; ana esta en madrid; ana esta en madrid.

48.12 *Practice — identity, origin, state, and location*
Answer: está
Also accepted: ¿Está usted bien?; Esta usted bien?; esta

Chapter 49

49.1 *ir — "to go," from more than one historical stem*
Answer: voy, vas, va
Also accepted: voy vas va; voy / vas / va

49.2 *ir — "to go," from more than one historical stem*
Answer: va
Also accepted: ¿Dónde va usted?; Donde va usted?

49.3 *voy a + infinitive — moving toward the near future*
Answer: Voy a hablar.
Also accepted: Voy a hablar

49.4 *voy a + infinitive — moving toward the near future*
Answer: Vas a comer.
Also accepted: Vas a comer

49.5 *mi, tu, su — whose café?*
Answer: mi café
Also accepted: mi cafe

49.6 *mi, tu, su — whose café?*
Answer: su café
Also accepted: su cafe

49.7 *Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership*
Answer: voy, vas, va
Also accepted: voy vas va; voy / vas / va

49.8 *Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership*
Answer: ¿Dónde va usted?
Also accepted: Dónde va usted?; Donde va usted?; ¿Donde va usted?

49.9 *Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership*
Answer: Voy a hablar.
Also accepted: Voy a hablar

49.10 *Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership*
Answer: su café
Also accepted: su cafe

Chapter 50

50.1 *somos — "we are"*
Answer: somos
Also accepted: nosotros somos

50.2 *somos — "we are"*
Answer: it is two Latin verbs fused
Also accepted: two verbs; esse and sedere; it comes from two verbs

50.3 *son — "they are"*
Answer: son
Also accepted: ellos son; ustedes son

50.4 *son — "they are"*
Answer: sunt
Also accepted: sunt, minus the t

50.5 *sois — the last of the six*
Answer: sois
Also accepted: vosotros sois

50.6 *sois — the last of the six*
Answer: son
Also accepted: ustedes son

50.7 *Review — all of ser*
Answer: somos
Also accepted: nosotros somos

50.8 *Review — all of ser*
Answer: son
Also accepted: ellos son

50.9 *Review — all of ser*
Answer: eres, it came from a different Latin form
Also accepted: eres; eres - different origin; eres, from eris

Chapter 51

51.1 *profesor*
Answer: soy profesor
Also accepted: soy profesora

51.2 *profesor*
Answer: es profesora
Also accepted: ella es profesora

51.3 *profesor*
Answer: to declare publicly
Also accepted: to declare something publicly; declare

Chapter 52

52.1 *estudiante*
Answer: estudiante
Also accepted: el estudiante

52.2 *estudiante*
Answer: somos estudiantes
Also accepted: nosotros somos estudiantes

52.3 *estudiante*
Answer: important
Also accepted: importantly

Chapter 53

53.1 *-ista*
Answer: dentist
Also accepted: a dentist

53.2 *-ista*
Answer: es artista
Also accepted: ella es artista

53.3 *-ista*
Answer: a newspaper
Also accepted: newspaper; a periodical

Chapter 54

54.1 *Synthesis — saying what people do*
Answer: somos estudiantes
Also accepted: nosotros somos estudiantes

54.2 *Synthesis — saying what people do*
Answer: a violinist
Also accepted: violin player

54.3 *Synthesis — saying what people do*
Answer: soy ... y tu
Also accepted: soy estudiante y tu; soy profesor y tu

Chapter 55

55.1 *estamos — the other "we are"*
Answer: estamos
Also accepted: nosotros estamos

55.2 *estamos — the other "we are"*
Answer: estar is one Latin verb, ser is two fused
Also accepted: estar is one verb; ser is two verbs, estar is one; because estar has one ancestor

55.3 *están — "they are"*
Answer: estan
Also accepted: están; ellos estan; ustedes estan

55.4 *están — "they are"*
Answer: the stress is on the ending
Also accepted: because estar stresses the ending; stress on the last syllable

55.5 *estáis — and nothing surprises you*
Answer: estais
Also accepted: estáis; vosotros estais

55.6 *estáis — and nothing surprises you*
Answer: estan
Also accepted: están; ustedes estan

55.7 *Review — both verbs for "to be"*
Answer: estamos
Also accepted: nosotros estamos

55.8 *Review — both verbs for "to be"*
Answer: estan
Also accepted: están; ellos estan

55.9 *Review — both verbs for "to be"*
Answer: estar, because it is one Latin verb
Also accepted: estar; estar - one verb; estar, it has one ancestor

Chapter 56

56.1 *la casa — "house," and "home"*
Answer: la casa
Also accepted: casa

56.2 *la casa — "house," and "home"*
Answer: tengo una casa
Also accepted: yo tengo una casa

56.3 *la casa — "house," and "home"*
Answer: chez
Also accepted: chez, as in chez moi

Chapter 57

57.1 *el libro — "book"*
Answer: el libro
Also accepted: libro

57.2 *el libro — "book"*
Answer: tengo un libro
Also accepted: yo tengo un libro

57.3 *el libro — "book"*
Answer: the inner bark of a tree
Also accepted: tree bark; bark

Chapter 58

58.1 *grande*
Answer: una casa grande
Also accepted: casa grande

58.2 *grande*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no it stays grande

58.3 *grande*
Answer: full-grown
Also accepted: fully grown; grown up

Chapter 59

59.1 *cansado*
Answer: estoy cansado
Also accepted: estoy cansada

59.2 *cansado*
Answer: it is a state not a quality
Also accepted: because being tired is temporary

59.3 *cansado*
Answer: nothing is wrong the rules are a lead not a guarantee
Also accepted: some words simply give nothing back

Chapter 60

60.1 *Synthesis — describing things*
Answer: la casa es grande pero estoy cansado
Also accepted: la casa es grande pero estoy cansada

60.2 *Synthesis — describing things*
Answer: cansada
Also accepted: cansado becomes cansada

60.3 *Synthesis — describing things*
Answer: una casa grande
Also accepted: casa grande

Chapter 61

61.1 *-oso*
Answer: mysterious
Also accepted: it means mysterious

61.2 *-oso*
Answer: una profesora famosa
Also accepted: profesora famosa

61.3 *-oso*
Answer: estar because it is a state
Also accepted: estar it is how you are right now

Chapter 62

62.1 *-ncia*
Answer: preference
Also accepted: a preference

62.2 *-ncia*
Answer: la
Also accepted: la distancia

62.3 *-ncia*
Answer: una diferencia grande
Also accepted: diferencia grande

Chapter 63

63.1 *-ario*
Answer: imaginary
Also accepted: it means imaginary

63.2 *-ario*
Answer: because -ario names the place a thing is kept
Also accepted: it is the place the words are kept

63.3 *-ario*
Answer: necesaria
Also accepted: it becomes necesaria

Chapter 64

64.1 *Review — the eight endings*
Answer: -ista
Also accepted: ista

64.2 *Review — the eight endings*
Answer: feminine
Also accepted: la

64.3 *Review — the eight endings*
Answer: the possibility
Also accepted: possibility

Chapter 65

65.1 *Synthesis — reading a paragraph*
Answer: the community has a tradition
Also accepted: the community has a custom

65.2 *Synthesis — reading a paragraph*
Answer: its structure is voluntary evidently
Also accepted: the structure is voluntary, obviously

65.3 *Synthesis — reading a paragraph*
Answer: a specialist
Also accepted: specialist

Chapter 66

66.1 *falsos amigos*
Answer: success because exitus was the way a thing came out
Also accepted: success — spanish kept the outcome, english kept the door

66.2 *falsos amigos*
Answer: currently
Also accepted: at the moment; right now

66.3 *falsos amigos*
Answer: trust the sentence over the ending
Also accepted: suspect a false friend and check the context

Chapter 67

67.1 *tenemos — and the stem change disappears*
Answer: tenemos
Also accepted: nosotros tenemos

67.2 *tenemos — and the stem change disappears*
Answer: the stress is on the stem in tienes and on the ending in tenemos
Also accepted: stress; because of where the stress falls; tenemos stresses the ending

67.3 *tienen — the break comes back*
Answer: tienen
Also accepted: ellos tienen; ustedes tienen

67.4 *tienen — the break comes back*
Answer: nosotros and vosotros
Also accepted: nosotros, vosotros; we and you all

67.5 *tienen — the break comes back*
Answer: whether the stem is stressed
Also accepted: stress; where the stress falls

Chapter 68

68.1 *vamos — from a verb that is not* ir
Answer: vamos
Also accepted: nosotros vamos

68.2 *vamos — from a verb that is not* ir
Answer: the present comes from a different verb, vadere
Also accepted: it is a different verb; from vadere; ir is two verbs

68.3 *vamos — from a verb that is not* ir
Answer: go and went
Also accepted: go, went; went is from wend

68.4 *van — and the four are done*
Answer: van
Also accepted: ellos van; ustedes van

68.5 *van — and the four are done*
Answer: son and estan
Also accepted: son, están; son y estan

68.6 *van — and the four are done*
Answer: it is more than one verb
Also accepted: two verbs fused; it is several words; suppletion

Chapter 69

69.1 *querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change*
Answer: quiero, quieres, quiere
Also accepted: quiero quieres quiere; quiero / quieres / quiere

69.2 *querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change*
Answer: Quiero hablar.
Also accepted: Quiero hablar

69.3 *poder — ability with the o → ue change*
Answer: puedo, puedes, puede
Also accepted: puedo puedes puede; puedo / puedes / puede

69.4 *poder — ability with the o → ue change*
Answer: Puedes comer.
Also accepted: Puedes comer

69.5 *e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms*
Answer: quiero, puedo
Also accepted: quiero puedo; quiero / puedo

69.6 *e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms*
Answer: tienes, quieres, puedes
Also accepted: tienes quieres puedes; tienes / quieres / puedes

69.7 *nuestro, nuestra — "our" with singular gender agreement*
Answer: nuestro día
Also accepted: nuestro dia

69.8 *nuestro, nuestra — "our" with singular gender agreement*
Answer: nuestra noche
Also accepted: nuestra noche.

69.9 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*
Answer: quiero, quieres, quiere
Also accepted: quiero quieres quiere; quiero / quieres / quiere

69.10 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*
Answer: puedo, puedes, puede
Also accepted: puedo puedes puede; puedo / puedes / puede

69.11 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*
Answer: Quiero hablar.
Also accepted: Quiero hablar

69.12 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*
Answer: Puedes comer.
Also accepted: Puedes comer

69.13 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*
Answer: nuestra noche
Also accepted: nuestra noche.

Chapter 70

70.1 *hacer — doing or making with three singular forms*
Answer: hago, haces, hace
Also accepted: hago haces hace; hago / haces / hace

70.2 *hacer — doing or making with three singular forms*
Answer: Hago café.
Also accepted: Hago café; Hago cafe; Hago cafe.

70.3 *decir — saying with the same small person frame*
Answer: digo, dices, dice
Also accepted: digo dices dice; digo / dices / dice

70.4 *decir — saying with the same small person frame*
Answer: Digo hola.
Also accepted: Digo hola

70.5 *decir — saying with the same small person frame*
Answer: ¿Cómo dices ‘hola’?
Also accepted: ¿Cómo dices hola?; Cómo dices hola?; Como dices hola?; ¿Como dices hola?

70.6 *tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know*
Answer: tengo, hago, digo
Also accepted: tengo hago digo; tengo / hago / digo

70.7 *tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know*
Answer: hago
Also accepted: yo hago

70.8 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*
Answer: hago, haces, hace
Also accepted: hago haces hace; hago / haces / hace

70.9 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*
Answer: digo, dices, dice
Also accepted: digo dices dice; digo / dices / dice

70.10 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*
Answer: tengo, hago, digo
Also accepted: tengo hago digo; tengo / hago / digo

70.11 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*
Answer: Hago café.
Also accepted: Hago café; Hago cafe; Hago cafe.

70.12 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*
Answer: ¿Cómo dices ‘hola’?
Also accepted: ¿Cómo dices hola?; Cómo dices hola?; Como dices hola?; ¿Como dices hola?

Chapter 71

71.1 *poner — putting or placing with three singular forms*
Answer: pongo, pones, pone
Also accepted: pongo pones pone; pongo / pones / pone

71.2 *poner — putting or placing with three singular forms*
Answer: to put or to place
Also accepted: put or place; to put and to place; put and place

Chapter 72

72.1 *salir — leaving with three singular forms*
Answer: salgo, sales, sale
Also accepted: salgo sales sale; salgo / sales / sale

72.2 *salir — leaving with three singular forms*
Answer: Salgo de Madrid.
Also accepted: Salgo de Madrid

Chapter 73

73.1 *venir — coming with three singular forms*
Answer: vengo, vienes, viene
Also accepted: vengo vienes viene; vengo / vienes / viene

73.2 *venir — coming with three singular forms*
Answer: Vengo de Madrid.
Also accepted: Vengo de Madrid

73.3 *venir — coming with three singular forms*
Answer: vienes, tienes
Also accepted: vienes tienes; vienes / tienes

Chapter 74

74.1 *Review — six verbs, one ending*
Answer: six
Also accepted: 6; seis

74.2 *Review — six verbs, one ending*
Answer: the yo slot
Also accepted: yo; the I form; first person

74.3 *Review — six verbs, one ending*
Answer: no, they converged by accident
Also accepted: no; they are not a family; they arrived by different routes

74.4 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Answer: pongo, pones, pone
Also accepted: pongo pones pone; pongo / pones / pone

74.5 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Answer: salgo, sales, sale
Also accepted: salgo sales sale; salgo / sales / sale

74.6 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Answer: vengo, vienes, viene
Also accepted: vengo vienes viene; vengo / vienes / viene

74.7 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Answer: Salgo de Madrid; vengo de Madrid.
Also accepted: Salgo de Madrid. Vengo de Madrid.; Salgo de Madrid, vengo de Madrid; Salgo de Madrid y vengo de Madrid

74.8 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Answer: tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo
Also accepted: tengo hago digo pongo salgo vengo; tengo / hago / digo / pongo / salgo / vengo

74.9 *Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular*
Answer: poner—position; salir—salient; venir—convene
Also accepted: poner position salir salient venir convene; poner: position; salir: salient; venir: convene; position salient convene

Chapter 75

75.1 *Synthesis — you, and somebody else*
Answer: salgo
Also accepted: yo salgo

75.2 *Synthesis — you, and somebody else*
Answer: sale, and no
Also accepted: sale; sale - regular; no, sale

75.3 *Synthesis — you, and somebody else*
Answer: the yo slot
Also accepted: yo; the I form; first person

Chapter 76

76.1 *queremos, quieren — work them out first*
Answer: queremos
Also accepted: nosotros queremos

76.2 *queremos, quieren — work them out first*
Answer: pueden
Also accepted: ellos pueden; ustedes pueden

76.3 *queremos, quieren — work them out first*
Answer: podemos
Also accepted: nosotros podemos

76.4 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*
Answer: hacemos
Also accepted: nosotros hacemos

76.5 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*
Answer: salen
Also accepted: ellos salen; ustedes salen

76.6 *hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all*
Answer: decimos and dicen
Also accepted: decimos, dicen

76.7 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*
Answer: salimos
Also accepted: nosotros salimos

76.8 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*
Answer: salen
Also accepted: ellos salen

76.9 *Synthesis — a verb you have never met*
Answer: three
Also accepted: 3; tres

Chapter 77

77.1 *la comida — "food," built from a verb you have*
Answer: comida
Also accepted: la comida

77.2 *la comida — "food," built from a verb you have*
Answer: hago la comida
Also accepted: yo hago la comida

77.3 *la comida — "food," built from a verb you have*
Answer: feminine
Also accepted: always feminine

Chapter 78

78.1 *las casas — "the houses"*
Answer: las casas
Also accepted: las casa s

78.2 *las casas — "the houses"*
Answer: las comidas
Also accepted: comidas

78.3 *las casas — "the houses"*
Answer: none
Also accepted: zero; 0

Chapter 79

79.1 *los libros — "the books"*
Answer: los libros
Also accepted: libros

79.2 *los libros — "the books"*
Answer: the plural kept the vowel the singular lost
Also accepted: el is a worn-down elo; they wore down differently

79.3 *los libros — "the books"*
Answer: el, la, los, las
Also accepted: el la los las; el / la / los / las

Chapter 80

80.1 *-es — the plural your first chapter owed you*
Answer: espanoles
Also accepted: los espanoles

80.2 *-es — the plural your first chapter owed you*
Answer: ustedes
Also accepted: usted becomes ustedes; usted

80.3 *-es — the plural your first chapter owed you*
Answer: the bare s would be unsayable
Also accepted: you cannot pronounce it; spanish needs a vowel to get the s out

Chapter 81

81.1 *Review — all four words for "the"*
Answer: el, la, los, las
Also accepted: el la los las; el / la / los / las

81.2 *Review — all four words for "the"*
Answer: los libros, las casas
Also accepted: los libros las casas

81.3 *Review — all four words for "the"*
Answer: add -s, or -es when the bare s would be unsayable
Also accepted: -s after a vowel and -es after a consonant

81.4 *Review — the half of* ir *you never say out loud*
Answer: vamos, van
Also accepted: vamos y van; nosotros vamos, ellos van

81.5 *Review — the half of* ir *you never say out loud*
Answer: vais
Also accepted: vosotros vais

81.6 *Review — the half of* ir *you never say out loud*
Answer: la ida
Also accepted: ida

Chapter 82

82.1 *Synthesis — more than one*
Answer: tengo libros
Also accepted: yo tengo libros

82.2 *Synthesis — more than one*
Answer: tengo los libros
Also accepted: yo tengo los libros

82.3 *Synthesis — more than one*
Answer: hago comidas
Also accepted: yo hago comidas

82.4 *Synthesis — more than one*
Answer: houses in general versus particular known ones
Also accepted: one is indefinite and one is definite; las casas means the houses

Chapter 83

83.1 *lo — "it"*
Answer: lo tengo
Also accepted: yo lo tengo

83.2 *lo — "it"*
Answer: before
Also accepted: in front of it; before the verb

83.3 *lo — "it"*
Answer: el
Also accepted: the article el; el, the article

Chapter 84

84.1 *la — "it," for a feminine noun*
Answer: la hago
Also accepted: yo la hago

84.2 *la — "it," for a feminine noun*
Answer: the gender of the noun it replaces
Also accepted: the noun's gender; whether the noun is masculine or feminine

84.3 *la — "it," for a feminine noun*
Answer: the masculine lost a vowel and the feminine had none to lose
Also accepted: only the masculine wore down; the sound change only hit the masculine

Chapter 85

85.1 *me quieres — "you love me"*
Answer: me quieres
Also accepted: tu me quieres

85.2 *me quieres — "you love me"*
Answer: it is the person the verb lands on
Also accepted: it is the object; it is who is being loved

85.3 *me quieres — "you love me"*
Answer: none
Also accepted: zero; 0

85.4 *te quiero — "I love you"*
Answer: te quiero
Also accepted: yo te quiero

85.5 *te quiero — "I love you"*
Answer: querer aimed at a person means to love
Also accepted: because the object is a person; with people it means love

85.6 *te quiero — "I love you"*
Answer: tu does, te receives
Also accepted: tu is the doer, te is the object; tu doer te object

85.7 *te — the pair English used to have*
Answer: thou and thee
Also accepted: thou thee; thee and thou

85.8 *te — the pair English used to have*
Answer: te
Also accepted: te, the object form

Chapter 86

86.1 *Review — four pronouns, one slot*
Answer: me, te, lo, la
Also accepted: me te lo la; me / te / lo / la

86.2 *Review — four pronouns, one slot*
Answer: who or what the verb lands on
Also accepted: who is receiving the action; what the object is

86.3 *Review — four pronouns, one slot*
Answer: lo and la
Also accepted: lo, la; la and lo

Chapter 87

87.1 *Synthesis — saying it once*
Answer: si, lo tengo
Also accepted: lo tengo; si lo tengo

87.2 *Synthesis — saying it once*
Answer: si, la hago
Also accepted: la hago; si la hago

87.3 *Synthesis — saying it once*
Answer: me quieres
Also accepted: y yo te quiero; te quiero

87.4 *Synthesis — saying it once*
Answer: it named the same thing twice
Also accepted: it repeated the noun; nobody talks like that

Chapter 88

88.1 *nos — "us"*
Answer: nos quieren
Also accepted: ellos nos quieren

88.2 *nos — "us"*
Answer: how many people are on the receiving end
Also accepted: one person versus more than one; me is one, nos is more

88.3 *nos — "us"*
Answer: in front of the verb
Also accepted: before the verb; the same slot as me and te

88.4 *nosotros — the word inside -mos*
Answer: -mos
Also accepted: the -mos ending; mos

88.5 *nosotros — the word inside -mos*
Answer: nos and otros, we others
Also accepted: nos + otros; we others

88.6 *nosotros — the word inside -mos*
Answer: nosotros and the -mos ending
Also accepted: nos in nosotros and mos in hablamos; the pronoun and the ending

Chapter 89

89.1 *los and las — "them"*
Answer: los tengo
Also accepted: yo los tengo

89.2 *los and las — "them"*
Answer: las hago
Also accepted: yo las hago

89.3 *los and las — "them"*
Answer: lo never lost the vowel el lost
Also accepted: it kept its vowel; there was nothing to repair

Chapter 90

90.1 *os — "you all," in Spain*
Answer: os quiero
Also accepted: yo os quiero

90.2 *os — "you all," in Spain*
Answer: los quiero
Also accepted: las quiero; los quiero a ustedes

90.3 *os — "you all," in Spain*
Answer: vos, in Argentina
Also accepted: vos; vos, in the river plate region

Chapter 91

91.1 *Review — all eight*
Answer: me, te, lo, la, nos, os, los, las
Also accepted: me te lo la nos os los las

91.2 *Review — all eight*
Answer: lo, la, los, las
Also accepted: lo la los las; the bottom two rows

91.3 *Review — all eight*
Answer: los and las
Also accepted: los, las

Chapter 92

92.1 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*
Answer: si, los tengo
Also accepted: los tengo; si los tengo

92.2 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*
Answer: las hago
Also accepted: si, las hago; las hago hoy

92.3 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*
Answer: nos quieren
Also accepted: ellos nos quieren

92.4 *Synthesis — the conversation without them*
Answer: they look for a masculine thing and there is not one
Also accepted: the pronoun points at nothing; the gender does not match what was said

Chapter 93

93.1 *le — "to him," "to her," "to you"*
Answer: le digo
Also accepted: yo le digo

93.2 *le — "to him," "to her," "to you"*
Answer: none
Also accepted: one form for all; it does not mark gender

93.3 *le — "to him," "to her," "to you"*
Answer: illi, for the one the action is aimed at
Also accepted: illi, the dative; illi

Chapter 94

94.1 *les — "to them," and what this system really costs*
Answer: les digo
Also accepted: yo les digo

94.2 *les — "to them," and what this system really costs*
Answer: two
Also accepted: 2; le and les

94.3 *les — "to them," and what this system really costs*
Answer: me, te, nos, os
Also accepted: me te nos os

Chapter 95

95.1 *Which one is the verb asking for?*
Answer: does the verb act on it or aim at it
Also accepted: can you put to in front of it in english; to whom versus what

95.2 *Which one is the verb asking for?*
Answer: le hablo
Also accepted: yo le hablo

95.3 *Which one is the verb asking for?*
Answer: lo tengo, direct
Also accepted: lo tengo

95.4 *Which one is the verb asking for?*
Answer: no, it is leismo and it is accepted
Also accepted: no; no, that is normal in spain

Chapter 96

96.1 *Review — two systems, two new words*
Answer: me, te, le, nos, os, les
Also accepted: me te le nos os les

96.2 *Review — two systems, two new words*
Answer: the him/her row: lo and la versus le
Also accepted: the third row; lo la versus le

96.3 *Review — two systems, two new words*
Answer: nine
Also accepted: 9; me te lo la le nos os los las les

Chapter 97

97.1 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*
Answer: si, lo tengo
Also accepted: lo tengo

97.2 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*
Answer: le digo hoy
Also accepted: le digo

97.3 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*
Answer: les hablo
Also accepted: yo les hablo

97.4 *Synthesis — the thing and the person, in one sentence*
Answer: what you mean
Also accepted: the meaning; whether the verb acts on it or aims at it

Chapter 98

98.1 *me lo — both at once*
Answer: te lo digo
Also accepted: yo te lo digo

98.2 *me lo — both at once*
Answer: the person
Also accepted: indirect first; the indirect one

98.3 *me lo — both at once*
Answer: me la haces
Also accepted: tu me la haces

Chapter 99

99.1 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*
Answer: se lo digo
Also accepted: yo se lo digo

99.2 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*
Answer: lo, la, los, las
Also accepted: lo la los las; the direct object pronouns for things

99.3 *se lo — the pair that does not exist*
Answer: five: him, her, you, them, you all
Also accepted: five; him her you them or you all

Chapter 100

100.1 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*
Answer: gelo
Also accepted: ge lo

100.2 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, they are unrelated; no, they only sound alike

100.3 *Why se? — and why it is not the se you know*
Answer: illi and illum
Also accepted: illi, illum; the dative and the accusative

Chapter 101

101.1 *Review — the pairs*
Answer: person first, and le becomes se before the thing
Also accepted: indirect first; le and les become se

101.2 *Review — the pairs*
Answer: nos lo
Also accepted: nos la; nos lo or nos la

101.3 *Review — the pairs*
Answer: none
Also accepted: zero; 0

Chapter 102

102.1 *Synthesis — two at a time*
Answer: te lo digo
Also accepted: ¿te lo digo?; te lo digo?

102.2 *Synthesis — two at a time*
Answer: se la hago
Also accepted: yo se la hago

102.3 *Synthesis — two at a time*
Answer: none
Also accepted: zero; 0

102.4 *Synthesis — two at a time*
Answer: no, it becomes about something else
Also accepted: no; it stays grammatical but means something else

Chapter 103

103.1 *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir*
Answer: fui, fuiste, fue
Also accepted: fui fuiste fue; fui / fuiste / fue

103.2 *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir*
Answer: Fui a Madrid.
Also accepted: Fui a Madrid

103.3 *fui — one past set shared by ser and ir*
Answer: ser

103.4 *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb*
Answer: hablé, hablaste, habló
Also accepted: hablé hablaste habló; hablé / hablaste / habló

103.5 *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb*
Answer: Hablé español.
Also accepted: Hablé español

103.6 *hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb*
Answer: hablé

103.7 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*
Answer: fui, fuiste, fue
Also accepted: fui fuiste fue; fui / fuiste / fue

103.8 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*
Answer: hablé, hablaste, habló
Also accepted: hablé hablaste habló; hablé / hablaste / habló

103.9 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*
Answer: Fui a Madrid.
Also accepted: Fui a Madrid

103.10 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*
Answer: Hablo español. Hablé español.
Also accepted: Hablo español; hablé español; Hablo español. Hablé español; hablo español hablé español

103.11 *Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past*
Answer: hablé and habló
Also accepted: hablé habló; hablé y habló; hablé / habló

Chapter 104

104.1 *comí — one regular -er singular past*
Answer: comí, comiste, comió
Also accepted: comí comiste comió; comí / comiste / comió

104.2 *comí — one regular -er singular past*
Answer: comí

104.3 *comí — one regular -er singular past*
Answer: sound change plus analogy
Also accepted: sound change and analogy; sound change, plus analogy

104.4 *viví — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb*
Answer: viví, viviste, vivió
Also accepted: viví viviste vivió; viví / viviste / vivió

104.5 *viví — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb*
Answer: Viví en Madrid.
Also accepted: Viví en Madrid

104.6 *viví — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb*
Answer: -í, -iste, -ió
Also accepted: í iste ió; -í -iste -ió; -í / -iste / -ió

Chapter 105

105.1 *tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress*
Answer: tuve, tuviste, tuvo
Also accepted: tuve tuviste tuvo; tuve / tuviste / tuvo

105.2 *tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress*
Answer: Tuve café.
Also accepted: Tuve café

105.3 *tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress*
Answer: a historically reshaped strong form
Also accepted: historically reshaped strong form; a reshaped strong form

105.4 *hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve*
Answer: hice, hiciste, hizo
Also accepted: hice hiciste hizo; hice / hiciste / hizo

105.5 *hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve*
Answer: Hice café.
Also accepted: Hice café

105.6 *hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve*
Answer: fēcī
Also accepted: feci

105.7 *estuve — a third known verb joins the strong pattern*
Answer: estuve, estuviste, estuvo
Also accepted: estuve estuviste estuvo; estuve / estuviste / estuvo

105.8 *estuve — a third known verb joins the strong pattern*
Answer: Estuve bien.
Also accepted: Estuve bien

105.9 *estuve — a third known verb joins the strong pattern*
Answer: tuve

Chapter 106

106.1 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Answer: hablé, comí, viví
Also accepted: hablé comí viví; hablé / comí / viví

106.2 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Answer: tuve, hice, estuve
Also accepted: tuve hice estuve; tuve / hice / estuve

106.3 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Answer: Hice café.
Also accepted: Hice café

106.4 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Answer: Viví en Madrid.
Also accepted: Viví en Madrid

106.5 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Answer: Estuve bien.
Also accepted: Estuve bien

106.6 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Answer: comí and comió
Also accepted: comí comió; comí/comió; comí y comió

106.7 *Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*
Answer: estuve

106.8 *Synthesis — you can hear which past it is*
Answer: on the stem, a strong preterite
Also accepted: stem, strong; on the stem; strong preterite

106.9 *Synthesis — you can hear which past it is*
Answer: the stress is on its final vowel
Also accepted: because the stress is on the ending; stressed final vowel; the ending is stressed

106.10 *Synthesis — you can hear which past it is*
Answer: yes
Also accepted: yes, the same; they agree; identical

Chapter 107

107.1 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*
Answer: hablaba, hablabas, hablaba
Also accepted: hablaba hablabas hablaba; hablaba / hablabas / hablaba

107.2 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*
Answer: hablaba

107.3 *hablaba — let a past action stay open*
Answer: b
Also accepted: the b; b sound

107.4 *comía — hear both vowels*
Answer: comía, comías, comía
Also accepted: comía comías comía; comía / comías / comía

107.5 *comía — hear both vowels*
Answer: comía
107.6 *comía — hear both vowels*
Answer: co-mí-a
107.7 *vivía — reuse the complete -er row*
Answer: vivía, vivías, vivía
Also accepted: vivía vivías vivía; vivía / vivías / vivía
107.8 *vivía — reuse the complete -er row*
Answer: -er and -ir
Also accepted: er and ir; -er / -ir; er ir
107.9 *vivía — reuse the complete -er row*
Answer: Vivía en Madrid.
Also accepted: Vivía en Madrid

Chapter 108

108.1 *ver — learn the verb before its past*
Answer: to see
Also accepted: see
108.2 *ver — learn the verb before its past*
Answer: veo, ves, ve
Also accepted: veo ves ve; veo / ves / ve
108.3 *ver — learn the verb before its past*
Answer: vidēre
Also accepted: videre

Chapter 109

109.1 *era — an old root in an open past*
Answer: era, eras, era
Also accepted: era eras era; era / eras / era
109.2 *era — an old root in an open past*
Answer: era
109.3 *era — an old root in an open past*
Answer: eram
109.4 *iba — ir returns to its inherited past*
Answer: iba, ibas, iba
Also accepted: iba ibas iba; iba / ibas / iba
109.5 *iba — ir returns to its inherited past*
Answer: Iba a Madrid.
Also accepted: Iba a Madrid

109.6 *iba — ir returns to its inherited past*
Answer: īre
Also accepted: ire

109.7 *veía — keep the extra e you already met*
Answer: veía, veías, veía
Also accepted: veía veías veía; veía / veías / veía

109.8 *veía — keep the extra e you already met*
Answer: Veía café.

109.9 *veía — keep the extra e you already met*
Answer: veer

Chapter 110

110.1 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Answer: hablaba, comía, vivía
Also accepted: hablaba comía vivía; hablaba / comía / vivía

110.2 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Answer: era, iba, veía
Also accepted: era iba veía; era / iba / veía

110.3 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Answer: Hablaba español.
Also accepted: Hablaba español

110.4 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Answer: Vivía en Madrid.
Also accepted: Vivía en Madrid

110.5 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Answer: Iba a Madrid.
Also accepted: Iba a Madrid

110.6 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Answer: comía

110.7 *Practice — keep the past open or close it*
Answer: era—eram; iba—ībam; veía—veer
Also accepted: era eram iba ībam veía veer; era-eram, iba-ībam, veía-veer

110.8 *Synthesis — three exceptions, and no others*
Answer: three
Also accepted: 3; tres; only three

110.9 *Synthesis — three exceptions, and no others*
Answer: ser, ir, ver
Also accepted: era, iba, veia; ser ir ver; to be, to go, to see

110.10 *Synthesis — three exceptions, and no others*
Answer: they are the most used verbs, so they were never regularised
Also accepted: because they are used constantly; most common verbs; they were never tidied up

Chapter 111

111.1 *hablaba and habló — two ways of looking*
Answer: no, in how you look at it
Also accepted: no; they differ in viewpoint

111.2 *hablaba and habló — two ways of looking*
Answer: hable
Also accepted: hablé; the preterite

111.3 *hablaba and habló — two ways of looking*
Answer: estudiaba
Also accepted: yo estudiaba

Chapter 112

112.1 *cuando — putting both pasts in one sentence*
Answer: estudiaba cuando hablo Ana
Also accepted: estudiaba cuando habló ana

112.2 *cuando — putting both pasts in one sentence*
Answer: the imperfect sets the room, the preterite walks in
Also accepted: imperfect is the scene, preterite is the event

112.3 *cuando — putting both pasts in one sentence*
Answer: que, quien, como
Also accepted: qué, quién, cómo; que and quien

Chapter 113

113.1 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*
Answer: tenia una casa
Also accepted: tenía una casa; yo tenia una casa

113.2 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*
Answer: i got a house
Also accepted: i received a house; the moment i came to have one

113.3 *tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning*
Answer: the moment the state began
Also accepted: when it started; the start of the state

Chapter 114

114.1 *Review — one question, three answers*
Answer: am i saying what happened or what things were like
Also accepted: what happened versus what things were like; does it have edges

114.2 *Review — one question, three answers*
Answer: estudiaba
Also accepted: the imperfect one; estudiaba, the imperfect

114.3 *Review — one question, three answers*
Answer: the state rows, tenia and tuve
Also accepted: rows three and four; tenia and tuve

Chapter 115

115.1 *Synthesis — a small story*
Answer: estudiaba and tenia
Also accepted: estudiaba, tenía; the imperfects

115.2 *Synthesis — a small story*
Answer: tuve is the moment of getting it
Also accepted: because it is an event, not a state; getting has edges

115.3 *Synthesis — a small story*
Answer: estudiaba cuando hable con Ana
Also accepted: estudiaba cuando hablé con ana

115.4 *Synthesis — a small story*
Answer: because the choice is the difficulty, not the forms
Also accepted: english lets you leave the question unanswered; the forms were never the hard part

Chapter 116

116.1 *hablado, comido, vivido — the participle*
Answer: hablado
Also accepted: habl-ado

116.2 *hablado, comido, vivido — the participle*
Answer: comido, vivido
Also accepted: comido vivido

116.3 *hablado, comido, vivido — the participle*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, it stays the same

Chapter 117

117.1 *he hablado — "I have spoken"*
Answer: he hablado espanol
Also accepted: he hablado español; yo he hablado espanol

117.2 *he hablado — "I have spoken"*
Answer: nothing on its own
Also accepted: nothing; it has no meaning here, only a job

117.3 *he hablado — "I have spoken"*
Answer: have
Also accepted: to have; have, as in I have eaten

Chapter 118

118.1 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*
Answer: he, has, ha, hemos, habeis, han
Also accepted: he has ha hemos habéis han

118.2 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*
Answer: han comido
Also accepted: ellos han comido; ustedes han comido

118.3 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*
Answer: because it is said more often
Also accepted: frequency wears words down; it is used in every perfect sentence

118.4 *has, ha, hemos, habéis, han*
Answer: one
Also accepted: 1; it never changes

Chapter 119

119.1 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*
Answer: hecho, dicho, visto, puesto
Also accepted: hecho dicho visto puesto

119.2 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*
Answer: fact
Also accepted: fact, from factum

119.3 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*
Answer: they are the most used
Also accepted: because they are the commonest verbs; frequency

119.4 *hecho, dicho, visto, puesto*
Answer: lo hemos visto
Also accepted: hemos visto

Chapter 120

120.1 *Review — a tense you build*
Answer: haber and the participle; haber carries the person
Also accepted: a form of haber plus a participle

120.2 *Review — a tense you build*
Answer: hemos vivido
Also accepted: nosotros hemos vivido

120.3 *Review — a tense you build*
Answer: lo has dicho
Also accepted: has dicho

120.4 *Review — a tense you build*
Answer: it is built from two pieces rather than conjugated per verb
Also accepted: six words once, not endings on every verb

Chapter 121

121.1 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*
Answer: he comido
Also accepted: yo he comido

121.2 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*
Answer: madrid the perfect, mexico the preterite
Also accepted: he hablado in spain, hable in latin america

121.3 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*
Answer: both, for their own variety
Also accepted: both; neither is wrong

121.4 *Synthesis — two shores, two answers*
Answer: hemos hablado espanol
Also accepted: hemos hablado español

Chapter 122

122.1 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*
Answer: hablaré, hablarás, hablará
Also accepted: hablaré hablarás hablará; hablaré / hablarás / hablará

122.2 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*
Answer: Hablaré español.
Also accepted: Hablaré español

122.3 *hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future*
Answer: habēre
Also accepted: habere; haber

122.4 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*
Answer: comeré, comerás, comerá
Also accepted: comeré comerás comerá; comeré / comerás / comerá

122.5 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*
Answer: Beberé café.
Also accepted: Beberé café; Bebere cafe; Bebere cafe.

122.6 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*
Answer: -é, -ás, -á
Also accepted: é ás á; -é -ás -á

122.7 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*
Answer: viviré, vivirás, vivirá
Also accepted: viviré vivirás vivirá; viviré / vivirás / vivirá

122.8 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*
Answer: Viviré en Madrid.
Also accepted: Viviré en Madrid

122.9 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*
Answer: hablaré, comeré, viviré
Also accepted: hablaré comeré viviré; hablaré / comeré / viviré

Chapter 123

123.1 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*
Answer: hablaría, hablarías, hablaría
Also accepted: hablaría hablarías hablaría; hablaría / hablarías / hablaría

123.2 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*
Answer: Hablaría español.
Also accepted: Hablaría español

123.3 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*
Answer: ha-bla-rí-a
Also accepted: habla-rí-a; rí-a

123.4 *comería — keep -er before "would"*
Answer: comería, comerías, comería
Also accepted: comería comerías comería; comería / comerías / comería

123.5 *comería — keep -er before "would"*
Answer: Comeré; comería.
Also accepted: Comeré comería; comeré / comería

123.6 *comería — keep -er before "would"*
Answer: -ía, -ías, -ía
Also accepted: ía ías ía; -ía -ías -ía

123.7 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*
Answer: viviría, vivirías, viviría
Also accepted: viviría vivirías viviría; viviría / vivirías / viviría

123.8 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*
Answer: Viviría en Madrid.
Also accepted: Viviría en Madrid

123.9 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*
Answer: hablaría, comería, viviría
Also accepted: hablaría comería viviría; hablaría / comería / viviría

Chapter 124

124.1 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*
Answer: Haré café; haría café.
Also accepted: Haré café Haría café; haré café / haría café

124.2 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*
Answer: tendré, tendría
Also accepted: tendré tendría; tendré / tendría

124.3 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*
Answer: Podré hablar español; podría hablar español.
Also accepted: Podré hablar español Podría hablar español; podré hablar español / podría hablar español

124.4 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Answer: hablaré, comeré, viviré
Also accepted: hablaré comeré viviré; hablaré / comeré / viviré

124.5 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Answer: hablaría, comería, viviría
Also accepted: hablaría comería viviría; hablaría / comería / viviría

124.6 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Answer: Hablaré español.
Also accepted: Hablaré español

124.7 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Answer: Viviría en Madrid.
Also accepted: Viviría en Madrid

124.8 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Answer: Haré café; haría café.
Also accepted: Haré café Haría café; haré café / haría café

124.9 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Answer: har-, tendr-, podr-
Also accepted: har tendr podr; har- / tendr- / podr-

124.10 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*
Answer: habēre
Also accepted: habere; haber

Chapter 125

125.1 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*
Answer: hablare
Also accepted: hablaré; yo hablare

125.2 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*
Answer: hablaria
Also accepted: hablaría; yo hablaria

125.3 *Synthesis — promising, and supposing*
Answer: haber
Also accepted: habere; the verb to have; have

Chapter 126

126.1 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*
Answer: hablas

126.2 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*
Answer: Quiero hablar español.
Also accepted: Quiero hablar español

126.3 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*
Answer: Quiero que hables español.
Also accepted: Quiero que hables español

Chapter 127

127.1 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*
Answer: hable, hables, hable
Also accepted: hable hables hable; hable / hables / hable

127.2 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*
Answer: hablo

127.3 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*
Answer: subjoined or joined under
Also accepted: subjoined; joined under

127.4 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*
Answer: coma, comas, coma
Also accepted: coma comas coma; coma / comas / coma

127.5 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*
Answer: comas

127.6 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*
Answer: Quiero que comas.
Also accepted: Quiero que comas

127.7 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*
Answer: viva, vivas, viva
Also accepted: viva vivas viva; viva / vivas / viva

127.8 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*
Answer: -er and -ir
Also accepted: er and ir; -er / -ir

127.9 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*
Answer: Quiero que vivas en Madrid.
Also accepted: Quiero que vivas en Madrid

Chapter 128

128.1 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*
Answer: quiera, quieras, quiera
Also accepted: quiera quieras quiera; quiera / quieras / quiera

128.2 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*
Answer: quiero

128.3 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*
Answer: quieras

128.4 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*
Answer: pueda, puedas, pueda
Also accepted: pueda puedas pueda; pueda / puedas / pueda

128.5 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*
Answer: puedo

128.6 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*
Answer: Quiero que puedas hablar español.
Also accepted: Quiero que puedas hablar español

128.7 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*
Answer: haga, hagas, haga
Also accepted: haga hagas haga; haga / hagas / haga

128.8 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*
Answer: hago

128.9 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*
Answer: Quiero que hagas café.
Also accepted: Quiero que hagas café; Quiero que hagas cafe

Chapter 129

129.1 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*
Answer: Ojalá hables español.
Also accepted: Ojalá hables español; Ojala hables espanol

129.2 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*
Answer: no

129.3 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*
Answer: Hispanic Arabic
Also accepted: Arabic; Andalusi Arabic; Hispano-Arabic

129.4 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Answer: hables

129.5 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Answer: Quiero hablar español; quiero que hables español.
Also accepted: Quiero hablar español Quiero que hables español; Quiero hablar español / quiero que hables español

129.6 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Answer: hables, comas, vivas
Also accepted: hables comas vivas; hables / comas / vivas

129.7 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Answer: the yo form
Also accepted: yo; present yo form

129.8 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Answer: quiera, quieras, quiera
Also accepted: quiera quieras quiera; quiera / quieras / quiera

129.9 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Answer: Quiero que puedas hablar español.
Also accepted: Quiero que puedas hablar español

129.10 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Answer: Quiero que hagas café.
Also accepted: Quiero que hagas café; Quiero que hagas cafe

129.11 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Answer: Ojalá vivas en Madrid.
Also accepted: Ojalá vivas en Madrid; Ojala vivas en Madrid

129.12 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Answer: a clause subjoined or joined under another
Also accepted: subjoined; joined under

129.13 *Practice — assert the event or want it*
Answer: Hispanic Arabic
Also accepted: Arabic; Andalusi Arabic; Hispano-Arabic

129.14 *Review — you never learned a new stem*
Answer: pueda
Also accepted: que pueda

129.15 *Review — you never learned a new stem*
Answer: haga
Also accepted: que haga

129.16 *Review — you never learned a new stem*
Answer: viva
Also accepted: que viva

Chapter 130

130.1 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*
Answer: hablas
Also accepted: hablas - indicative

130.2 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*
Answer: hables
Also accepted: hables - subjunctive; ojala hables

130.3 *Synthesis — claiming, and not claiming*
Answer: may God will it, in Arabic
Also accepted: arabic, may god will it; and may god will it; wa sha allah

Chapter 131

131.1 *habla — telling somebody to do something*
Answer: come
Also accepted: ¡come!; come!

131.2 *habla — telling somebody to do something*
Answer: the he/she present form
Also accepted: the third person singular; the el form

131.3 *habla — telling somebody to do something*
Answer: emperor and empire
Also accepted: emperor, empire

Chapter 132

132.1 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*
Answer: di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, se, ven
Also accepted: di haz ve pon ten sal sé ven

132.2 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*
Answer: ven
Also accepted: ¡ven!

132.3 *di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven*
Answer: commands are shouted and hurried, so they wore down most
Also accepted: because they are the most used and most shouted; frequency and hurry

Chapter 133

133.1 *no hables — telling somebody not to*
Answer: no hables
Also accepted: ¡no hables!

133.2 *no hables — telling somebody not to*
Answer: no comas
Also accepted: ¡no comas!

133.3 *no hables — telling somebody not to*
Answer: because nothing is being asserted
Also accepted: there is no speaking to describe; the subjunctive is the non-asserting form

Chapter 134

134.1 *hable usted — the polite command*
Answer: hable, por favor
Also accepted: hable por favor; hable usted por favor

134.2 *hable usted — the polite command*
Answer: three
Also accepted: 3; all but the informal positive

134.3 *hable usted — the polite command*
Answer: it is aimed at a title, not at the person
Also accepted: usted is third person, so the order is indirect; because it is not pointed straight at them

Chapter 135

135.1 *Review — four boxes*
Answer: come, no comas, coma, no coma
Also accepted: come no comas coma no coma

135.2 *Review — four boxes*
Answer: the eight irregular tu commands
Also accepted: eight one-syllable words; di haz ve pon ten sal se ven

135.3 *Review — four boxes*
Answer: it is said the most
Also accepted: because it is the most used; heavy use keeps old forms alive

Chapter 136

136.1 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*
Answer: ven
Also accepted: ¡ven!

136.2 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*
Answer: coma, por favor
Also accepted: coma por favor

136.3 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*
Answer: in the choice of tu or usted
Also accepted: in which person you chose; in the pronoun

136.4 *Synthesis — asking without sounding rude*
Answer: put distance between you
Also accepted: sounded stiff; been cold rather than polite

Chapter 144

144.1 *la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth*
Answer: la bebo
Also accepted: yo la bebo

144.2 *la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth*
Answer: nothing collides in front of the pronoun
Also accepted: the article changes for sound, the pronoun does not; there are no two a sounds meeting

144.3 *la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth*
Answer: which object pronoun a speaker uses for it
Also accepted: whether they say lo or la; the pronoun

Chapter 152

152.1 *Synthesis — saying something about your own life*
Answer: tengo un perro negro
Also accepted: yo tengo un perro negro

152.2 *Synthesis — saying something about your own life*
Answer: un gato
Also accepted: un; un gato blanco

152.3 *Synthesis — saying something about your own life*
Answer: hace frio
Also accepted: hace frío

152.4 *Review — the same question, asked of eleven words*
Answer: rojo, azul, verde, amarillo
Also accepted: rojo azul verde amarillo

152.5 *Review — the same question, asked of eleven words*
Answer: son las dos y veinte
Also accepted: las dos y veinte

152.6 *Review — the same question, asked of eleven words*
Answer: llueve al mediodia
Also accepted: llueve a mediodia

152.7 *Review — the same question, asked of eleven words*
Answer: amarillo
Also accepted: yellow; amarillo, yellow

152.8 *Review — one Saturday, from morning to midnight*
Answer: son las nueve y veinte
Also accepted: las nueve y veinte

152.9 *Review — one Saturday, from morning to midnight*
Answer: a medianoche todavia llueve
Also accepted: a medianoche llueve

152.10 *Review — one Saturday, from morning to midnight*
Answer: ocho, and it is the tenth
Also accepted: eight, tenth; ocho, el decimo

152.11 *Review — one Saturday, from morning to midnight*
Answer: el otono
Also accepted: otono; el otoño

Chapter 157

157.1 *Review — four verbs of the mind*
Answer: pensar
Also accepted: pensar (to think); think

157.2 *Review — four verbs of the mind*
Answer: leer
Also accepted: leer (to read); read

157.3 *Review — four verbs of the mind*
Answer: escribir
Also accepted: escribir (to write); write

Chapter 158

158.1 *Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't*
Answer: I am not stretching that far
Also accepted: i am not reaching that far; not stretching toward it; i cannot stretch that far

158.2 *Synthesis — what you understand, and what you don't*
Answer: ahora entiendo
Also accepted: entiendo; entiendo ahora

Chapter 162

162.1 *Review — three verbs that behave*
Answer: ayudar
Also accepted: ayudar (to help); help

162.2 *Review — three verbs that behave*
Answer: tomar
Also accepted: tomar (to take); take

162.3 *Review — three verbs that behave*
Answer: the one doing it
Also accepted: the doer; the person doing it; the subject does it

Chapter 164

164.1 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*
Answer: el cafe
Also accepted: the coffee; cafe; el café

164.2 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*
Answer: to taste
Also accepted: taste; tasting

164.3 *Synthesis — what you like, and who is doing the liking*
Answer: mucho gusto
Also accepted: gusto; much pleasure

Chapter 166

166.1 *Review — down, up, and away*
Answer: de pie
Also accepted: estoy de pie

166.2 *Review — down, up, and away*
Answer: caminar, andar
Also accepted: caminar y andar; andar, caminar

166.3 *Review — down, up, and away*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, es discutido; disputed

Chapter 167

167.1 *Review — the accent is doing the work*
Answer: por que
Also accepted: por qué; ¿por qué?

167.2 *Review — the accent is doing the work*
Answer: me levanto porque corro
Also accepted: porque corro

167.3 *Review — the accent is doing the work*
Answer: el
Also accepted: the article; el porqué; putting el in front

Chapter 172

172.1 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*
Answer: four
Also accepted: 4; cuatro

172.2 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*
Answer: u to ue, jugar
Also accepted: u-ue, jugar; jugar, u to ue; jugar

172.3 *Review — the four stem changes, all of them*
Answer: e to i
Also accepted: e-i; e becomes i; consigo

Chapter 173

173.1 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*
Answer: conocer
Also accepted: conocer (acquaintance); conozco

173.2 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*
Answer: traer
Also accepted: traer (toward); bring

173.3 *Synthesis — the choices English never makes you make*
Answer: pedir
Also accepted: pedir (request); pedir un cafe

Chapter 176

176.1 *para — "for," pointing forward*
Answer: es para ti
Also accepted: para ti

176.2 *para — "for," pointing forward*
Answer: para manana
Also accepted: para mañana

176.3 *para — "for," pointing forward*
Answer: ad, as in advance and admit
Also accepted: ad; ad — advance, admit, adhere

Chapter 177

177.1 *por — and you already know three of these*
Answer: gracias por la comida
Also accepted: gracias por la comida.

177.2 *por — and you already know three of these*
Answer: by way of a favour
Also accepted: through a favour; by means of a favour

177.3 *por — and you already know three of these*
Answer: per, as in per hour
Also accepted: per; per hour, per cent

Chapter 178

178.1 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*
Answer: lo hago para ti
Also accepted: para ti

178.2 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*
Answer: lo hago por ti
Also accepted: por ti

178.3 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*
Answer: does the arrow point at it or come from it
Also accepted: at the thing is para, from the thing is por

178.4 *Which way is the arrow pointing?*
Answer: the directions are inside the words, ad and per
Also accepted: para contains ad, toward; por contains per, through

Chapter 179

179.1 *Review — one arrow*
Answer: para points at it, por comes from it
Also accepted: para toward, por through or because

179.2 *Review — one arrow*
Answer: por favor, por que, gracias por
Also accepted: por favor, porque, gracias por

179.3 *Review — one arrow*
Answer: that it means two different things
Also accepted: both are correct and the choice is the meaning; neither is wrong

Chapter 180

180.1 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*
Answer: hago la comida para ti
Also accepted: la hago para ti

180.2 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*
Answer: hago la comida por ti
Also accepted: la hago por ti

180.3 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*
Answer: gracias por la comida
Also accepted: gracias por la comida.

180.4 *Synthesis — the gift and the motive*
Answer: a true sentence about a different situation
Also accepted: something correct that means something else; not nonsense, just the wrong meaning

Chapter 181

181.1 *se habla español — nobody in particular*
Answer: se habla espanol
Also accepted: se habla español

181.2 *se habla español — nobody in particular*
Answer: nobody in particular
Also accepted: it does not say; no one is named

181.3 *se habla español — nobody in particular*
Answer: se come bien
Also accepted: aqui se come bien

Chapter 182

182.1 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*
Answer: se compran libros
Also accepted: se compran los libros

182.2 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*
Answer: the books
Also accepted: the thing being bought; libros

182.3 *se compran libros — the verb tells on itself*
Answer: books buy themselves
Also accepted: the books buy themselves

Chapter 183

183.1 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*
Answer: como se dice
Also accepted: ¿cómo se dice?; ¿como se dice?

183.2 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*
Answer: como se dice en espanol, por favor
Also accepted: ¿cómo se dice en español, por favor?

183.3 *¿cómo se dice? — the sentence that unlocks the rest*
Answer: you are asking about the language, not about them
Also accepted: it is impersonal; nobody is being named

Chapter 184

184.1 *Review — the three se's*
Answer: the reflexive and the impersonal
Also accepted: se llama and se habla; reflexive and impersonal

184.2 *Review — the three se's*
Answer: lo, la, los or las
Also accepted: a direct object pronoun; lo or la

184.3 *Review — the three se's*
Answer: the impersonal
Also accepted: impersonal — nobody is named

Chapter 185

185.1 *Synthesis — reading the window*
Answer: books are bought here
Also accepted: they buy books; we buy books

185.2 *Synthesis — reading the window*
Answer: como se dice, por favor
Also accepted: ¿cómo se dice, por favor?

185.3 *Synthesis — reading the window*
Answer: aqui se come bien
Also accepted: se come bien

185.4 *Synthesis — reading the window*
Answer: nobody is claiming it, so there is nobody to argue with
Also accepted: there is no person to disagree with; it sounds like a fact rather than an opinion

Chapter 186

186.1 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*
Answer: tengo el libro que compro
Also accepted: el libro que compro

186.2 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*
Answer: it disappears
Also accepted: you only say it once; it is not repeated

186.3 *el libro que compro — one sentence out of two*
Answer: que, quien, como, cuando
Also accepted: qué, quién, cómo, cuándo; the qu- family

Chapter 187

187.1 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
Answer: el libro que compre
Also accepted: el libro que compré

187.2 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
Answer: la casa que tengo
Also accepted: la casa que yo tengo

187.3 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
Answer: a noun followed straight by a new subject and verb
Also accepted: a noun then a subject and verb with no that

187.4 *el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out*
Answer: english word order is rigid, spanish is looser
Also accepted: spanish moves its pieces around, so it needs the joint

Chapter 188

188.1 *lo que — "what," out of two old words*
Answer: lo que digo
Also accepted: lo que yo digo

188.2 *lo que — "what," out of two old words*
Answer: lo digo points at a known thing, lo que digo points at no thing
Also accepted: one is I say it, the other is what I say

188.3 *lo que — "what," out of two old words*
Answer: none
Also accepted: zero; 0

Chapter 189

189.1 *Review — three jobs, no new words*
Answer: none
Also accepted: zero; 0

189.2 *Review — three jobs, no new words*
Answer: la casa que tengo; english drops the that
Also accepted: la casa que tengo

189.3 *Review — three jobs, no new words*
Answer: lo
Also accepted: lo, as in lo que

Chapter 190

190.1 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*
Answer: tienes el libro que compre
Also accepted: ¿tienes el libro que compré?

190.2 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*
Answer: lo que no tengo
Also accepted: lo que no tengo.

190.3 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*
Answer: lo que no tengo es la comida que haces
Also accepted: lo que no tengo es la comida que haces.

190.4 *Synthesis — sentences worth saying*
Answer: the clause only adds a slot, not new grammar
Also accepted: it is the same spanish arranged inside itself

Chapter 191

191.1 *hay — "there is," "there are," same word*
Answer: hay una casa
Also accepted: hay una casa.

191.2 *hay — "there is," "there are," same word*
Answer: hay libros
Also accepted: hay libros.

191.3 *hay — "there is," "there are," same word*
Answer: nothing
Also accepted: nothing at all; it never changes

Chapter 192

192.1 *ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word*
Answer: ha and y
Also accepted: ha plus y; ha + y

192.2 *ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word*
Answer: nowhere
Also accepted: nowhere else; only in hay

192.3 *ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word*
Answer: il y a
Also accepted: il y a — it there has

Chapter 193

193.1 *hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular*
Answer: hay que hablar espanol
Also accepted: hay que hablar español

193.2 *hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular*
Answer: the infinitive
Also accepted: the dictionary form; the plain infinitive

193.3 *hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular*
Answer: the impersonal se
Also accepted: se habla espanol; the se of se habla

Chapter 194

194.1 *Review — three letters*
Answer: hay una casa, hay libros, hay que comer
Also accepted: hay una casa; hay libros; hay que comer

194.2 *Review — three letters*
Answer: agree, and name anybody
Also accepted: it never agrees and never names a person

194.3 *Review — three letters*
Answer: short words are worn down by constant use
Also accepted: the smallest words need the most explaining; heavy use turns them into fossils

Chapter 195

195.1 *Synthesis — describing where you are*
Answer: que hay aqui
Also accepted: ¿qué hay aquí?

195.2 *Synthesis — describing where you are*
Answer: hay libros, los que compre
Also accepted: hay libros — los que compré

195.3 *Synthesis — describing where you are*
Answer: lo que hay, hay que comerlo
Also accepted: lo que hay hay que comer

195.4 *Synthesis — describing where you are*
Answer: words, and familiar structures in new places
Also accepted: vocabulary and practice; nothing structural

Chapter 196

196.1 *si*
Answer: si tengo tiempo hablo espanol
Also accepted: hablo espanol si tengo tiempo

196.2 *si*
Answer: the one with the accent
Also accepted: si with the accent means yes

196.3 *si*
Answer: si plus a pointing particle
Also accepted: sic is si plus -ce

Chapter 197

197.1 *si + futuro*
Answer: si tengo tiempo hablare espanol
Also accepted: hablare espanol si tengo tiempo

197.2 *si + futuro*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no spanish keeps the present after si

197.3 *si + futuro*
Answer: only the result makes a claim about the future
Also accepted: the si half is a supposition not a prediction

Chapter 198

198.1 *Synthesis — real conditions*
Answer: si tengo tiempo hablo espanol
Also accepted: hablo espanol si tengo tiempo

198.2 *Synthesis — real conditions*
Answer: si tengo tiempo hablare espanol
Also accepted: hablare espanol si tengo tiempo

198.3 *Synthesis — real conditions*
Answer: si is if and si with the accent is yes
Also accepted: unaccented if accented yes

Chapter 199

199.1 *hablaron*
Answer: hablaron espanol
Also accepted: ellos hablaron espanol

199.2 *hablaron*
Answer: hablaron ends in n so the default stress is already right
Also accepted: a word ending in n is stressed on the second to last syllable

199.3 *hablaron*
Answer: trabajaron
Also accepted: ellos trabajaron

Chapter 200

200.1 *hablamos*
Answer: hablamos espanol
Also accepted: nosotros hablamos espanol

200.2 *hablamos*
Answer: from the context
Also accepted: from the rest of the sentence

200.3 *hablamos*
Answer: trabajamos trabajaron
Also accepted: trabajamos y trabajaron

Chapter 201

201.1 *comieron*
Answer: comieron
Also accepted: ellos comieron

201.2 *comieron*
Answer: vivieron
Also accepted: ellos vivieron

201.3 *comieron*
Answer: comimos
Also accepted: comimos only

Chapter 202

202.1 *tuvieron*
Answer: tuvieron
Also accepted: ellos tuvieron

202.2 *tuvieron*
Answer: hicieron
Also accepted: ellos hicieron

202.3 *tuvieron*
Answer: tuve and tuvo
Also accepted: only the yo and el forms

Chapter 203

203.1 *fueron*
Answer: fueron
Also accepted: ellos fueron

203.2 *fueron*
Answer: two they were and they went
Also accepted: it serves ser and ir

203.3 *fueron*
Answer: from a different verb meaning to grow or become
Also accepted: from another root, as english did with was

Chapter 204

204.1 *Review — the whole preterite*
Answer: hablamos and vivimos
Also accepted: the -ar one and the -ir one

204.2 *Review — the whole preterite*
Answer: tuv hic estuv fue
Also accepted: tuve hice estuve fui

204.3 *Review — the whole preterite*
Answer: fueron
Also accepted: fueron, from ser and ir

Chapter 205

205.1 *Synthesis — telling what happened*
Answer: hablaron espanol y tuvieron tiempo
Also accepted: hablaron espanol, tuvieron tiempo

205.2 *Synthesis — telling what happened*
Answer: comimos en casa
Also accepted: nosotros comimos en casa

205.3 *Synthesis — telling what happened*
Answer: tuviera
Also accepted: it becomes tuviera

Chapter 206

206.1 *hablara*
Answer: comiera
Also accepted: comiera, from comieron

206.2 *hablara*
Answer: because it is built from the preterite which already absorbed them
Also accepted: it inherits the irregularity instead of inventing new ones

206.3 *hablara*
Answer: i had done something
Also accepted: it marked a plain past, not a supposition

Chapter 207

207.1 *tuviera*
Answer: tuviera
Also accepted: tuviera, from tuvieron

207.2 *tuviera*
Answer: two ser and ir
Also accepted: both ser and ir

207.3 *tuviera*
Answer: none
Also accepted: zero, they were already known

Chapter 208

208.1 *si tuviera*
Answer: si tuviera tiempo hablaria espanol
Also accepted: hablaria espanol si tuviera tiempo

208.2 *si tuviera*
Answer: that it is not true
Also accepted: that the speaker does not have the time

208.3 *si tuviera*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, si never takes the present subjunctive

Chapter 209

209.1 *Review — the two conditions*
Answer: si tuviera tiempo hablaria espanol
Also accepted: si tuviera tiempo, hablaria espanol

209.2 *Review — the two conditions*
Answer: the future and the present subjunctive
Also accepted: si tendre and si tenga are both impossible

209.3 *Review — the two conditions*
Answer: nothing
Also accepted: nothing, the verbs carry it

Chapter 210

210.1 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*
Answer: si fuera profesor hablaria espanol
Also accepted: si fuera profesora, hablaria espanol

210.2 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*
Answer: si tuviera tiempo comeria en casa
Also accepted: any si + -ra form followed by a -ria form

210.3 *Synthesis — supposing out loud*
Answer: the preterite plural
Also accepted: the they-past, which the supposing form is built from

Chapter 211

211.1 *dice que*
Answer: dice que esta cansado
Also accepted: el dice que esta cansado

211.2 *dice que*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, que is required

211.3 *dice que*
Answer: digo
Also accepted: dice becomes digo

Chapter 212

212.1 *dijo*
Answer: dijo
Also accepted: el dijo

212.2 *dijo*
Answer: dijeron
Also accepted: ellos dijeron

212.3 *dijo*
Answer: x
Also accepted: the x of dixit

Chapter 213

213.1 *dijo que*
Answer: dijo que estaba cansado
Also accepted: el dijo que estaba cansado

213.2 *dijo que*
Answer: dijo que trabajaba
Also accepted: el dijo que trabajaba

213.3 *dijo que*
Answer: because it was going on at the time
Also accepted: it was true when he spoke, not a finished event

Chapter 214

214.1 *preguntó si*
Answer: pregunto si trabajaba
Also accepted: el pregunto si trabajaba

214.2 *preguntó si*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, it is a statement now

214.3 *preguntó si*
Answer: in conditions
Also accepted: si tengo tiempo; the if of conditions

Chapter 215

215.1 *preguntó dónde*
Answer: pregunto donde trabajaba
Also accepted: el pregunto donde trabajaba

215.2 *preguntó dónde*
Answer: yes
Also accepted: yes, it is still an asking word

215.3 *preguntó dónde*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, donde is the joint

Chapter 216

216.1 *(review)*
Answer: que
Also accepted: que, and it cannot be dropped

216.2 *(review)*
Answer: si
Also accepted: si, the same one as in conditions

216.3 *(review)*
Answer: donde is the joint
Also accepted: no que and no si, donde does it

Chapter 217

217.1 *(synthesis)*
Answer: pregunto donde trabajaba
Also accepted: el pregunto donde trabajaba

217.2 *(synthesis)*
Answer: dijo que trabajaba en casa
Also accepted: dijo que trabajaba

217.3 *(synthesis)*
Answer: pregunto si estaba cansado
Also accepted: el pregunto si estaba cansado

Chapter 218

218.1 *pero — the word that lets two true things stand together*
Answer: estoy cansado pero estudio
Also accepted: estoy cansada pero estudio

218.2 *pero — the word that lets two true things stand together*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, both halves stay true

218.3 *pero — the word that lets two true things stand together*
Answer: two
Also accepted: two: per hoc

Chapter 219

219.1 *también — a word with your very first word inside it*
Answer: yo tambien
Also accepted: yo tambien!

219.2 *también — a word with your very first word inside it*
Answer: tan and bien
Also accepted: tan bien, so well

219.3 *también — a word with your very first word inside it*
Answer: so
Also accepted: so, as; as

Chapter 220

220.1 *tampoco — the same frame, the other half*
Answer: yo tampoco
Also accepted: yo tampoco!

220.2 *tampoco — the same frame, the other half*
Answer: tan and poco
Also accepted: tan poco, so little

220.3 *tampoco — the same frame, the other half*
Answer: no
Also accepted: the no in their sentence

Chapter 221

221.1 *este — pointing at what is in your hand*
Answer: este libro
Also accepted: este libro.

221.2 *este — pointing at what is in your hand*
Answer: esta casa
Also accepted: esta casa.

221.3 *este — pointing at what is in your hand*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, este replaces the article

Chapter 222

222.1 *ese — pointing at what is by you*
Answer: ese libro
Also accepted: ese libro.

222.2 *ese — pointing at what is by you*
Answer: whose side it is on
Also accepted: which of us it is near; not distance

222.3 *ese — pointing at what is by you*
Answer: self
Also accepted: self, as in ipso facto; ipse, self

Chapter 223

223.1 *aquel — the far one, and an old friend in disguise*
Answer: aquella casa
Also accepted: aquella casa.

223.2 *aquel — the far one, and an old friend in disguise*
Answer: este ese aquel
Also accepted: este, ese, aquel

223.3 *aquel — the far one, and an old friend in disguise*
Answer: el
Also accepted: el, from Latin ille

Chapter 224

224.1 *esto · eso · aquello — pointing at what has no name yet*
Answer: que es esto
Also accepted: ¿que es esto?

224.2 *esto · eso · aquello — pointing at what has no name yet*
Answer: neither
Also accepted: neither, it is the leftover neuter

Chapter 225

225.1 *(review)*
Answer: ese
Also accepted: ese, it is on their side

225.2 *(review)*
Answer: do i have a noun
Also accepted: whether there is a noun at all

225.3 *(review)*
Answer: the article
Also accepted: el, la – the article

Chapter 226

226.1 *muy — the same word, bitten short*
Answer: estoy muy cansado
Also accepted: estoy muy cansada

226.2 *muy — the same word, bitten short*
Answer: mucho
Also accepted: mucho, the long form

226.3 *muy — the same word, bitten short*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, it needs something to lean on

Chapter 227

227.1 *bastante — an ending you can already read*
Answer: estoy bastante cansado
Also accepted: estoy bastante cansada

227.2 *bastante — an ending you can already read*
Answer: poco bastante muy
Also accepted: poco, bastante, muy

227.3 *bastante — an ending you can already read*
Answer: sufficing
Also accepted: the one that suffices; bastar plus -ante

Chapter 228

228.1 *mal — bien finally gets its opposite*
Answer: estoy mal
Also accepted: mal; estoy mal.

228.2 *mal — bien finally gets its opposite*
Answer: malo
Also accepted: malo, the long form

228.3 *mal — bien finally gets its opposite*
Answer: mal and malo
Also accepted: mal, malo; mal / malo

228.4 *a word in a hurry — the short form and the long one*
Answer: the ending is bitten off when it leans on another word
Also accepted: a long form and a short form; apocope

228.5 *a word in a hurry — the short form and the long one*
Answer: mucho and malo
Also accepted: mucho, malo; the long forms

228.6 *a word in a hurry — the short form and the long one*
Answer: lean on the word after it
Also accepted: hurry to the next word; attach to the following word

Chapter 229

229.1 *(review)*
Answer: bastante
Also accepted: bastante, the middle one

229.2 *(review)*
Answer: when it leans on the next word
Also accepted: when another word follows it

229.3 *(review)*
Answer: -ante
Also accepted: ante, as in estudiante

Chapter 230

230.1 *al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*
Answer: voy al cafe
Also accepted: voy al cafe.

230.2 *al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, it is simply wrong

230.3 *al — two words Spanish will not let you keep apart*
Answer: el is part of the name
Also accepted: because El is part of a name

Chapter 231

231.1 *del — and then the list stops*
Answer: el libro del profesor
Also accepted: el libro del profesor.

231.2 *del — and then the list stops*
Answer: two
Also accepted: two: al and del

231.3 *del — and then the list stops*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, only de el does

Chapter 232

232.1 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*
Answer: quien es
Also accepted: ¿quien es?

232.2 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*
Answer: quien
Also accepted: quien, because the answer is a person

232.3 *quién — the asking word reserved for people*
Answer: the object one
Also accepted: quem, the object form

Chapter 233

233.1 *o — one letter, one catch*
Answer: cafe o agua
Also accepted: ¿cafe o agua?

233.2 *o — one letter, one catch*
Answer: siete u ocho
Also accepted: siete u ocho.

233.3 *o — one letter, one catch*
Answer: sound
Also accepted: sound, so a silent h counts too

Chapter 234

234.1 *ni — joining two absences*
Answer: no quiero cafe ni agua
Also accepted: no quiero cafe ni agua.

234.2 *ni — joining two absences*
Answer: two and yes
Also accepted: two, and it is correct

234.3 *ni — joining two absences*
Answer: and not
Also accepted: and not – the no is inside it

Chapter 235

235.1 *(review)*
Answer: two
Also accepted: two, al and del

235.2 *(review)*
Answer: quien
Also accepted: quienes, if you expect several

235.3 *(review)*
Answer: the o would be swallowed
Also accepted: because the next word starts with the o sound

Chapter 236

236.1 *hablando — an action caught in the middle*
Answer: trabajando
Also accepted: trabajando.

236.2 *hablando — an action caught in the middle*
Answer: one
Also accepted: one, it never changes

236.3 *hablando — an action caught in the middle*
Answer: speaking
Also accepted: speaking, the action underway

Chapter 237

237.1 *comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending*
Answer: comiendo
Also accepted: comiendo.

237.2 *comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending*
Answer: viviendo
Also accepted: viviendo.

237.3 *comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending*
Answer: two
Also accepted: two: -ando and -iendo

Chapter 238

238.1 *estoy hablando — the payoff*
Answer: estoy comiendo
Also accepted: estoy comiendo.

238.2 *estoy hablando — the payoff*
Answer: estar
Also accepted: estar, the gerund never changes

238.3 *estoy hablando — the payoff*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, it only means right now

Chapter 239

239.1 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*
Answer: veo a maria
Also accepted: veo a maria.

239.2 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*
Answer: veo la casa
Also accepted: veo la casa.

239.3 *veo a María — the little a that guards people*
Answer: marking who is on the receiving end
Also accepted: marking the object

Chapter 240

240.1 *(review)*
Answer: estamos estudiando
Also accepted: estamos estudiando.

240.2 *(review)*
Answer: a person
Also accepted: seeing a person

240.3 *(review)*
Answer: voy a comer
Also accepted: with voy a comer, not estoy comiendo

Chapter 241

241.1 *hablasteis — the form you were promised*
Answer: hablasteis
Also accepted: vosotros hablasteis

241.2 *hablasteis — the form you were promised*
Answer: hablaste
Also accepted: hablaste, the tu form

241.3 *hablasteis — the form you were promised*
Answer: six
Also accepted: six, all of them

Chapter 242

242.1 *comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes*
Answer: comisteis
Also accepted: vosotros comisteis

242.2 *comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes*
Answer: tuvisteis
Also accepted: vosotros tuvisteis

242.3 *comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, it is complete

Chapter 243

243.1 *hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural*
Answer: hablabamos
Also accepted: nosotros hablabamos

243.2 *hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural*
Answer: trabajaban
Also accepted: ellos trabajaban

243.3 *hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural*
Answer: the stress is not where the default puts it
Also accepted: because the default stress would land a syllable later

Chapter 244

244.1 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*
Answer: comiamos
Also accepted: nosotros comiamos

244.2 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*
Answer: eramos
Also accepted: nosotros eramos

244.3 *comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent*
Answer: three
Also accepted: three: ser, ir, ver

Chapter 245

245.1 *(review)*
Answer: hablabamos
Also accepted: the nosotros form

245.2 *(review)*
Answer: ser ir ver
Also accepted: ser, ir, ver

245.3 *(review)*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, both are complete

Chapter 246

246.1 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*
Answer: el cafe es para mi
Also accepted: el cafe es para mi.

246.2 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*
Answer: the first two
Also accepted: only mi and ti

246.3 *para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own*
Answer: there is no other ti to confuse it with
Also accepted: mi already means my; ti has no twin

Chapter 247

247.1 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says "with" twice*
Answer: vienes conmigo
Also accepted: ¿vienes conmigo?

247.2 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says "with" twice*
Answer: twice
Also accepted: two: con at the front and cum at the back

247.3 *conmigo · contigo — the word that says "with" twice*
Answer: con el
Also accepted: con el.

Chapter 248

248.1 *¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming*
Answer: que grande
Also accepted: ¡que grande!

248.2 *¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming*
Answer: que bien
Also accepted: ¡que bien!

248.3 *¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming*
Answer: the word carrying the force
Also accepted: not questions; the word doing the work

Chapter 249

249.1 *María, ven — naming who you are talking to*
Answer: maria ven
Also accepted: maria, ven

249.2 *María, ven — naming who you are talking to*
Answer: a comma
Also accepted: the comma

249.3 *María, ven — naming who you are talking to*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, she is not on the receiving end

Chapter 250

250.1 *(review)*
Answer: conmigo
Also accepted: ¿conmigo?

250.2 *(review)*
Answer: para ti
Also accepted: para ti.

250.3 *(review)*
Answer: a comma
Also accepted: the comma

Chapter 251

251.1 *ahí · allí — the other two places*
Answer: ahi
Also accepted: ahi, by you

251.2 *ahí · allí — the other two places*
Answer: alli
Also accepted: alli, away from both

251.3 *ahí · allí — the other two places*
Answer: ese
Also accepted: ese, by you

Chapter 252

252.1 *ahora — now*
Answer: ahora estoy comiendo
Also accepted: ahora estoy comiendo.

252.2 *ahora — now*
Answer: hora
Also accepted: hora, the hour

252.3 *ahora — now*
Answer: ahora
Also accepted: ahora, now

252.4 *hoy — today*
Answer: hoy
Also accepted: hoy, from hodie

252.5 *hoy — today*
Answer: hodie, this day
Also accepted: hodie; hoc die, this day

252.6 *hoy — today*
Answer: hoy voy a comer con ella
Also accepted: hoy voy a comer con ella.

Chapter 253

253.1 *unos · unas — the plural of "one"*
Answer: unos libros
Also accepted: unos libros.

253.2 *unos · unas — the plural of "one"*
Answer: unas casas
Also accepted: unas casas.

253.3 *unos · unas — the plural of "one"*
Answer: compro libros
Also accepted: the bare one

Chapter 254

254.1 *vuestro — the last possessive*
Answer: vuestra casa
Also accepted: vuestra casa.

254.2 *vuestro — the last possessive*
Answer: nuestro and vuestro
Also accepted: nuestro, vuestro

254.3 *vuestro — the last possessive*
Answer: six
Also accepted: six, all of them

Chapter 255

255.1 *vi — the shortest past in the language*
Answer: vi
Also accepted: yo vi

255.2 *vi — the shortest past in the language*
Answer: vio
Also accepted: el vio

255.3 *vi — the shortest past in the language*
Answer: it has only one syllable
Also accepted: one syllable, so the beat cannot fall elsewhere

255.4 *di — the verb that changed families in the past*
Answer: dio
Also accepted: el dio

255.5 *di — the verb that changed families in the past*
Answer: the -er endings
Also accepted: -er endings; those of comer

255.6 *di — the verb that changed families in the past*
Answer: di and dio, because they are one syllable
Also accepted: di and dio; di, dio – one syllable each

Chapter 256

256.1 *(review)*
Answer: compro libros
Also accepted: the bare plural

256.2 *(review)*
Answer: hora
Also accepted: hora, the hour

256.3 *(review)*
Answer: the -er ones
Also accepted: -er endings, though it is an -ar verb

256.4 *Review — two pasts, both finished*
Answer: comisteis, tuvisteis
Also accepted: comisteis y tuvisteis

256.5 *Review — two pasts, both finished*
Answer: to keep the i and the a in separate syllables
Also accepted: otherwise they run together; to split the vowels

256.6 *Review — two pasts, both finished*
Answer: di
Also accepted: yo di

256.7 *Review — two pasts, both finished*
Answer: eramos, ibamos
Also accepted: éramos, íbamos

256.8 *Review — the column that belongs to* vosotros
Answer: vais
Also accepted: vosotros vais

256.9 *Review — the column that belongs to* vosotros
Answer: comisteis, tuvisteis
Also accepted: comisteis y tuvisteis

256.10 *Review — the column that belongs to* vosotros
Answer: vuestro
Also accepted: vuestro, vuestra

Chapter 257

257.1 *hablo — one form, two readings*
Answer: i eat and i am eating
Also accepted: I eat; I am eating

257.2 *hablo — one form, two readings*
Answer: como
Also accepted: como, the plain present

257.3 *hablo — one form, two readings*
Answer: insisting that it is happening now
Also accepted: emphasis on right now

Chapter 258

258.1 *hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who*
Answer: the subject
Also accepted: who is doing it

258.2 *hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who*
Answer: the ending already says it
Also accepted: because the -o carries the subject

258.3 *hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who*
Answer: when the ending is ambiguous
Also accepted: when habla could be he, she or usted

Chapter 259

259.1 *mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees*
Answer: mucha agua
Also accepted: mucha agua.

259.2 *mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees*
Answer: ella trabaja mucho
Also accepted: ella trabaja mucho.

259.3 *mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees*
Answer: is it leaning on a noun or a verb
Also accepted: whether a noun follows

Chapter 260

260.1 *María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article*
Answer: veo a maria
Also accepted: veo a maria.

260.2 *María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article*
Answer: it already points at one thing
Also accepted: there is nothing left to narrow down

260.3 *María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article*
Answer: no article
Also accepted: none, it is a vocative

Chapter 261

261.1 *(review)*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, como covers it

261.2 *(review)*
Answer: mucho
Also accepted: mucho, it describes the working

261.3 *(review)*
Answer: consequence
Also accepted: a consequence of agreement

Chapter 262

262.1 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*
Answer: primero, segundo, tercero
Also accepted: primero segundo tercero

262.2 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*
Answer: la segunda casa
Also accepted: la segunda casa.

262.3 *primero · segundo · tercero — counting in order*
Answer: following
Also accepted: following, from sequi

262.4 *el primer libro — where an ordinal stands*
Answer: el primer libro
Also accepted: el primer libro.

262.5 *el primer libro — where an ordinal stands*
Answer: la primera casa
Also accepted: la primera casa.

262.6 *el primer libro — where an ordinal stands*
Answer: in front, and the ending is bitten off when it leans on the noun
Also accepted: before the noun; the same shortening; in front; apocope

Chapter 263

263.1 *uno… otro — splitting a pair*
Answer: uno es grande otro es bueno
Also accepted: uno es grande, otro es bueno

263.2 *uno… otro — splitting a pair*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, otro takes no article

263.3 *uno… otro — splitting a pair*
Answer: the other of two
Also accepted: the second of a pair

263.4 *Review — picking one, pairing two, refusing both*
Answer: aqui, ahi, alli
Also accepted: aquí, ahí, allí

263.5 *Review — picking one, pairing two, refusing both*
Answer: otro
Also accepted: el otro

263.6 *Review — picking one, pairing two, refusing both*
Answer: ni uno ni otro
Also accepted: no quiero ni uno ni otro

263.7 *Review — picking one, pairing two, refusing both*
Answer: quiero aquel de alli
Also accepted: aquel de alli; aquel de allí

Chapter 264

264.1 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*
Answer: comer es bueno
Also accepted: comer es bueno.

264.2 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, the gerund cannot be a subject

264.3 *comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject*
Answer: hablar espanol es bueno
Also accepted: hablar espanol es bueno.

264.4 *Review — what happens where two words touch*
Answer: un libro, el primer libro
Also accepted: un libro y el primer libro

264.5 *Review — what happens where two words touch*
Answer: al y del
Also accepted: al, del; a el gives al, de el gives del

264.6 *Review — what happens where two words touch*
Answer: siete u ocho
Also accepted: siete u ocho.

264.7 *Review — what happens where two words touch*
Answer: conmigo
Also accepted: conmigo, contigo

264.8 *Review — what happens where two words touch*
Answer: bastante
Also accepted: bastante.

Chapter 265

265.1 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*
Answer: three
Also accepted: three: front, middle, end

265.2 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*
Answer: emphasises it
Also accepted: stresses today as against another day

265.3 *hoy como en casa — the pieces that move*
Answer: the endings already say who does what
Also accepted: because agreement and the personal a keep the roles clear

265.4 *Review — what the ending carries, and what happens when it carries nothing*
Answer: vais; the ending
Also accepted: vais, the ending does; vais - the ending

265.5 *Review — what the ending carries, and what happens when it carries nothing*
Answer: I speak, and I am speaking
Also accepted: I speak / I am speaking

265.6 *Review — what the ending carries, and what happens when it carries nothing*
Answer: comer es bueno
Also accepted: comer es bueno.

265.7 *Review — what the ending carries, and what happens when it carries nothing*
Answer: la comida
Also accepted: comida

Chapter 266

266.1 *(review)*
Answer: comer es bueno
Also accepted: comer es bueno, the infinitive

266.2 *(review)*
Answer: three
Also accepted: three: muy, mal, primer

266.3 *(review)*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, never

266.4 *Review — one name, four different jobs*
Answer: veo a maria; maria, ven
Also accepted: veo a maria, maria ven

266.5 *Review — one name, four different jobs*
Answer: la senora garcia
Also accepted: la señora garcia

266.6 *Review — one name, four different jobs*
Answer: mucha agua; come mucho
Also accepted: mucha agua, come mucho

266.7 *Review — one name, four different jobs*
Answer: hoy como en casa
Also accepted: hoy, como en casa

266.8 *Review — one name, four different jobs*
Answer: que grande
Also accepted: ¡qué grande!; qué grande

266.9 *(reading) — the first paragraph*
Answer: her brother
Also accepted: su hermano; with her brother

266.10 *(reading) — the first paragraph*
Answer: because it is sunday
Also accepted: porque es domingo; it is sunday

266.11 *(reading) — the first paragraph*
Answer: it is good but big
Also accepted: muy bueno pero bastante grande; good and quite large

266.12 *(reading) — the second paragraph*
Answer: her brother
Also accepted: su hermano; the brother

266.13 *(reading) — the second paragraph*
Answer: because he wants to see his father
Also accepted: porque quiere ver a su padre; to see his father

266.14 *(reading) — the third paragraph*
Answer: their mother's
Also accepted: su madre; the mother; casa de su madre

266.15 *(reading) — the third paragraph*
Answer: she is a teacher
Also accepted: es profesora; teacher; she teaches

Chapter 268

268.1 *Review — three phrases, in the order you need them*
Answer: donde esta, billete, habitacion
Also accepted: ¿dónde está?, un billete, una habitación; dónde está, billete, habitación

268.2 *Review — three phrases, in the order you need them*
Answer: the noun for its result
Also accepted: turns it into a noun; a place lived in; the result

268.3 *Review — three phrases, in the order you need them*
Answer: una habitacion, por favor
Also accepted: una habitación por favor; una habitación, por favor

268.4 *Review — when the ending tells the truth, and when it lies*
Answer: la habitacion, el problema
Also accepted: la habitación, el problema; la habitación el problema

268.5 *Review — when the ending tells the truth, and when it lies*
Answer: greek
Also accepted: griego; from Greek

268.6 *Review — when the ending tells the truth, and when it lies*
Answer: la
Also accepted: la — feminine; feminine

Chapter 318

318.1 *Review — hasta pronto, and the word inside it*
Answer: hasta pronto
Also accepted: ¡hasta pronto!; hasta pronto.

318.2 *Review — hasta pronto, and the word inside it*
Answer: promptus, brought forth or ready at hand
Also accepted: promptus, ready; promptus

318.3 *Review — two sorries, and how to tell them apart*
Answer: perdon
Also accepted: perdón; perdon, it asks for something back

318.4 *Review — two sorries, and how to tell them apart*
Answer: i feel it
Also accepted: I feel it, from sentire; i feel this

318.5 *Review — two sorries, and how to tell them apart*
Answer: per- thoroughly and donare to give
Also accepted: per and donare; per, thoroughly, plus donare, to give

318.6 *Review — four nouns, easiest gender to hardest*
Answer: la mano
Also accepted: la mano, feminine despite the -o

318.7 *Review — four nouns, easiest gender to hardest*
Answer: the object pronoun
Also accepted: whether they say lo or la; the pronoun, lo or la

318.8 *Review — four nouns, easiest gender to hardest*
Answer: el vino, la cabeza
Also accepted: el vino and la cabeza

318.9 *Review — two marks that were added, and when*
Answer: the spanish royal academy in 1754
Also accepted: the royal academy, 1754; 1754, the spanish royal academy

318.10 *Review — two marks that were added, and when*
Answer: no
Also accepted: no, it was added in spelling only; never

Chapter 319

319.1 *Review — what the surface does not tell you*
Answer: perdon
Also accepted: perdón; perdon, a pardon is granted

319.2 *Review — what the surface does not tell you*
Answer: la, and that agua is feminine
Also accepted: la, agua is feminine underneath; la

319.3 *Review — what the surface does not tell you*
Answer: hijo
Also accepted: hijo, where the h stands for a latin f; hijo and hacer

319.4 *Review — the five words of a leaving*
Answer: la calle, la esquina, la huella, el puerto, el faro
Also accepted: calle, esquina, huella, puerto, faro

319.5 *Review — the five words of a leaving*
Answer: the shin
Also accepted: the shinbone; shin, from skina

319.6 *Review — the five words of a leaving*
Answer: pharos
Also accepted: pharos, the island off alexandria; the island of pharos

319.7 *Review — the harbour, the light, and see you soon*
Answer: el puerto, el faro
Also accepted: el puerto and el faro

319.8 *Review — the harbour, the light, and see you soon*
Answer: hasta pronto: hasta, until, and pronto, soon
Also accepted: hasta pronto, until and soon

319.9 *Review — an introduction, start to finish*
Answer: el apellido
Also accepted: apellido

319.10 *Review — an introduction, start to finish*
Answer: senor and senora, from senior
Also accepted: señor, señora — senior; senor senora senior

319.11 *Review — an introduction, start to finish*
Answer: encantada
Also accepted: encantada, with an a

319.12 *Review — two ways to answer an introduction*
Answer: encantado
Also accepted: encantado or encantada; encantada

319.13 *Review — two ways to answer an introduction*
Answer: a taste
Also accepted: taste, from gustus; a tasting

319.14 *Review — five answering words, and where they came from*
Answer: alguien
Also accepted: alguien, from aliquem

319.15 *Review — five answering words, and where they came from*
Answer: born ones
Also accepted: people born; nati, born ones

319.16 *Review — five answering words, and where they came from*
Answer: two
Also accepted: two, a pair; the other of a pair

319.17 *Review — five answering words, and where they came from*
Answer: tampoco
Also accepted: tampoco, tan plus poco

319.18 *Review — the two that agree, and the p that becomes an f*
Answer: otro and poco
Also accepted: otro, poco; otro and poco, because they measure a thing

319.19 *Review — the two that agree, and the p that becomes an f*
Answer: it turned into an f
Also accepted: p became f down the germanic road; p to f

Chapter 335

335.1 *Review — six words that arrived last*
Answer: la entrada
Also accepted: entrada; la entrada, the way in and the ticket

335.2 *Review — six words that arrived last*
Answer: el cambio
Also accepted: cambio; el cambio, the change

Chapter 336

336.1 *Review — the same six, inside something you would say*
Answer: tengo calor
Also accepted: tengo calor, I have heat; tengo calor (hace calor is the weather)

336.2 *Review — the same six, inside something you would say*
Answer: que edad tienes
Also accepted: ¿qué edad tienes?; qué edad tienes; que edad tiene usted

Chapter 337

337.1 *Your own line — the first writing with no model*
Answer: buenas tardes. me llamo
Also accepted: buenas tardes me llamo; Buenas tardes. Me llamo.

337.2 *Your own line — the first writing with no model*
Answer: buenos días
Also accepted: buenos dias; Buenos días.

337.3 *Your own line — the first writing with no model*
Answer: buenas noches
Also accepted: Buenas noches.

Chapter 338

338.1 *Four lines about you*
Answer: tengo _____ años
Also accepted: tengo anos; Tengo _____ anos.

338.2 *Four lines about you*
Answer: soy de for from, vivo en for now
Also accepted: soy de / vivo en; soy de is origin, vivo en is where you live

338.3 *Four lines about you*
Answer: vivo en _____. gracias
Also accepted: vivo en, gracias; Vivo en _____. Gracias.

Chapter 339

339.1 *The same four lines, with a clock*
Answer: 25 minutes, two tasks
Also accepted: 25 minutes and two tasks; twenty-five minutes, 2 tasks

339.2 *The same four lines, with a clock*
Answer: 15 to 25
Also accepted: fifteen to twenty-five; 15-25 words

339.3 *The same four lines, with a clock*
Answer: me llamo _____. tengo _____ años. soy de _____. vivo en _____. gracias
Also accepted: me llamo, tengo anos, soy de, vivo en, gracias; Me llamo _____. Tengo _____ anos. Soy de _____. Vivo en _____. Gracias.

Chapter 345

345.1 *Review — the mask, the share, and the thing thrown down*
Answer: persona
Also accepted: la persona

345.2 *Review — the mask, the share, and the thing thrown down*
Answer: el objeto, la parte
Also accepted: el objeto and la parte

345.3 *Review — three plain words, none of them one piece*
Answer: cada objeto
Also accepted: cada objeto.

345.4 *Review — three plain words, none of them one piece*
Answer: el mismo objeto
Also accepted: mismo objeto

345.5 *Review — three plain words, none of them one piece*
Answer: to throw
Also accepted: throw

Chapter 388

388.1 *Review — four verbs, four kinds of "related"*
Answer: borrar
Also accepted: borrar / borrow; borrar (borrow)

388.2 *Review — four verbs, four kinds of "related"*
Answer: it lacks the in-
Also accepted: English took the plain pulsare; no in- on the front; it comes from plain pulsare

388.3 *Review — four verbs, four kinds of "related"*
Answer: english
Also accepted: el ingles; inglés

Chapter 389

389.1 *Review — the verbs that will not sit behind* sé
Answer: se lanzar
Also accepted: sé lanzar; yo sé lanzar

389.2 *Review — the verbs that will not sit behind* sé
Answer: shouting is not a learned skill
Also accepted: nobody is taught to shout; it is not learned; saber claims a skill

389.3 *Review — the verbs that will not sit behind* sé
Answer: to taste
Also accepted: taste; saborear

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

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11-15 — five single opaque words, each one a Latin compound worn down until the seam disappeared *once — quince*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 149, p. 511
16-19 — not words to memorise but a formula, diez y X, with the seam still visible *dieciséis — diecinueve*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 149, p. 511

A

a bird in the hand — the proverb, and what a proverb is *más vale pájaro en mano*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 274, p. 887
a card — a little targe, from French targe, a small shield, from Frankish targa; English target is the same little shield, and it meant a shield for centuries before anyone shot at it *la tarjeta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 357, p. 1511
a class, a kind, a lesson — Latin classis, one of the six bands Rome sorted its citizens into by wealth; a writer of the top band was classicus, which is where classic comes from *la clase*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 358, p. 1519
A Coffee, Please
chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 99

a different one — Latin distinctus, pricked apart, from dis and stinguere; English distinct, distinguish and instinct all come off the same pricking *distinto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 350, p. 1455
á é í ó ú — the acute accent, and the two jobs it does
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 10, p. 73
a favour, a good turn — Latin favere, to be well disposed toward somebody; English favour, favourite and favourable are all the same word *el favor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 320, p. 1241
a friend, of a woman — Latin amica, from the same amare as amable *la amiga*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 285, p. 973
a glass — Latin vas, a vessel: named for what it does, not for what it is made of *el vaso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 287, p. 989
a gram — Greek gramma, a written thing and also a small weight, from graphein to scratch; grammar, program, diagram and telegram are the same gramma *el gramo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 359, p. 1527
a greeting — from salutem, health: to greet was to wish someone their health *el saludo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 282, p. 949
a guest — the invited one; Spanish names the person by what was done to him *el invitado*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 282, p. 949
a hug — from bracchium, the arm: the word says what the body does *el abrazo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 282, p. 949
a hundred — Latin centum, cut short before a noun; English cent, century and percent keep the Latin, and English hundred is the very same ancient word *cien*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 351, p. 1463
a kilo — Greek khilioi, a thousand; it is not Latin mille, so kilo and the mil of mil gracias are two unrelated thousands *el kilo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 359, p. 1527
a litre — Greek litra, a Sicilian unit, the same word Latin took as libra, the pound; a pound is still abbreviated lb, and Libra is the scales in the sky *el litro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 359, p. 1527

a mark, a brand — Germanic marka, a boundary; the border lands were marches, their lords marquises, and Latin margo, an edge, is the cousin that gives margin *la marca*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 358, p. 1519
a metre — Greek metron, a measure, as in diameter and geometry; the underground metro is a different word, short for metropolitano, from meter a mother plus polis a city *el metro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 359, p. 1527
A Moment, And Its Two Edges
chapter topic; Chapter 348, p. 1439
a moment — Latin momentum, the smallest movement that tips a balance *el momento*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 303, p. 1117
A Package Abroad
chapter topic; Chapter 415, p. 1969
a plate — Greek platys, flat: the same flatness in a plaza and in a platypus *el plato*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 287, p. 989
a present — from regalar, French regaler, on Old French gale, merry-making; English gala and to regale a guest are the same fun, and it has nothing to do with king or regal *el regalo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 357, p. 1511
a smile — subridere, to laugh slightly: a laugh with the volume turned down *la sonrisa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 282, p. 949
a spoon — Latin cochlear, from cochlea, a snail shell you dug the snail out with *la cuchara*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 287, p. 989
a stage, a leg of a journey — French etape, once a storehouse where an army drew supplies, from Middle Dutch stapel a heap; English staple is the same pile *la etapa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 356, p. 1503
a thousand thanks — mille, the same thousand that measures a mile *mil gracias*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 283, p. 957
a time, an occasion, a turn — Latin vicem, a turn or change; English vice-president, vicar and vicarious are all standing in someone's place *la vez*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 330, p. 1321
a towel — a Frankish word that went into French and came out in two languages *la toalla*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 287, p. 989

a while, a short time — Latin raptus, a snatching, from rapere to seize; English rapid, rapt, rapture and ravish are all seizures *el rato*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 331, p. 1329
A While, a Way, a Thing
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a word in a hurry — the short form and the long one
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abroad, a foreign country; a foreign person *el extranjero*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 415, p. 1969
Academy, French, Student and Exam
chapter topic; Chapter 410, p. 1947
academy, language school *la academia*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 410, p. 1947
according to — marking whose claim it is *según*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 277, p. 909
activity — Medieval Latin āctīvitās, a Scholastic coinage on āctīvus, from agere, to drive or to do; the -ct- still sitting intact inside activ- is the sign the word came off the page *la actividad*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 394, p. 1833
actor — Latin actor, "one who does", from agere "to drive, to do"; the same verb sits inside agent, agenda and action *el actor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 421, p. 1995
actress — Latin actrix, the feminine of actor; the -triz ending is a museum piece that survives in only a handful of Spanish words *la actriz*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 421, p. 1995
address — Latin dīrēctiō, dīrēctiōnem, lifted from the written language rather than handed down, as derecho beside directo and razón beside ración show; on a form it is where you live *la dirección*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 393, p. 1823
adult, grown-up *adulto, adulta*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 417, p. 1977
advanced — a participle used as an adjective, and a cousin of antes, because to advance is to move to the front *avanzado*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 471, p. 2497

advice, and also a council — Latin consilium; English counsel and council are the same word that stopped being one *el consejo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 321, p. 1249
aeroplane — Latin avis bird, but borrowed whole from French avion, coined by Clément Ader in 1875; aviation, aviator, aviary, avian, ostrich and auspices are all avis, and el aviso is not *el avión*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 363, p. 1565
after — Latin de ex post, three little words run together; the post in it is English postpone, postscript and posterior *después*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 323, p. 1265
afternoon (la tarde — feminine; also: late) *la tarde*
explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 2, p. 15
again — literally another turn; vez is Latin vicem, a turn taken in rotation *otra vez*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 303, p. 1117
age — Latin aetatem from aetas and aevum, a lifetime; the -dad ending you know from verdad and ciudad, and English age, eternal, medieval and longevity share the root *la edad*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 334, p. 1353
agreed — from cor, the heart: an agreement is two hearts brought together *de acuerdo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 284, p. 965
Ahí, Allí — The Other Two Places
chapter topic; Chapter 251, p. 787
Ahora, Hoy — Now and Today
chapter topic; Chapter 252, p. 789
air — Greek aer into Latin aer into Spanish; aerial, aerobic and aerosol are the family, and malaria is Italian mala aria, bad air, a discarded medical theory frozen inside a word *el aire*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 362, p. 1555
airport — Greek aēr, air, set on Latin portus, a harbour; the shape matches English airport but cannot prove a loan, since French built aéroport at home *el aeropuerto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 392, p. 1813
Al — Two Words Spanish Will Not Keep Apart
chapter topic; Chapter 230, p. 745
all, everything — Latin totus; English total is the same word, and Portuguese tudo is its sibling down a parallel road *todo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 316, p. 1211
almost, nearly — Latin quasi, as if; English borrowed quasi whole and still hyphenates it onto anything that is nearly a thing *casi*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 328, p. 1305

alone, and also only — Latin solus; the accent that once separated the two meanings was abolished in 2010, so five letters now do both jobs *solo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 326, p. 1289
already, now — Latin iam; English borrowed it without knowing, in the déjà of déjà vu *ya*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 323, p. 1265
also — and you have been holding half of it since the first chapter of this book *también*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 219, p. 721
although, even though *aunque*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 270, p. 861
always — Latin semper, kept almost whole; sempiternal is semper plus aeternus, everlasting said twice *siempre*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 316, p. 1211
An Adult Swimming Course
chapter topic; Chapter 417, p. 1977
an appointment, a date — from citar, Latin citare to summon, from ciere to set in motion; English cite, recite, incite and excite are all the same summons *la cita*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 356, p. 1503
an occasion, a chance — Latin occasio, a falling-down, from ob and cadere to fall; accident, cadence, case, chance and cascade are all that same falling *la ocasión*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 356, p. 1503
and / and you? — a tiny connector that hands the conversation back *y / ¿y tú?*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 67
Andenes Y Cierres
chapter topic; Chapter 439, p. 2177
Animals About the House — Horse, Cow, Sheep, Hen, Donkey
chapter topic; Chapter 296, p. 1061
another, other — Latin alter, which meant the other of a pair rather than any other at all *otro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 317, p. 1219
Answering, and Handing It Back
chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 67
apple — named after a Roman gardener whose variety outlived him *la manzana*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 280, p. 933
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-ario
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 63, p. 251

-ario — the Eighth and Last Ending
chapter topic; Chapter 63, p. 251
around, round about — al plus rededor, from Latin retro backwards crossed with rota, a wheel; English rotate, rotund and retro all roll here *alrededor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 347, p. 1431
Around The Room
chapter topic; Chapter 366, p. 1595
ash — from Latin cinis; English incinerate is the same word, but English cinder is a Germanic impostor that only borrowed the Latin spelling *la ceniza*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 369, p. 1625
Asking Someone's Name
chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 41
asleep — the past participle of dormir, from Latin dormire; English dormitory, dormant and dormouse are all sleeping *dormido*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 327, p. 1297
assonance — the rhyme Spanish verse actually uses *asonancia*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 276, p. 903
August — Latin Augustus, the emperor the month was renamed for, inherited by way of the attested Vulgar Latin agustus; its learned twin augusto keeps the au and the u that agosto lost *agosto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 392, p. 1813
avenue — a broad street, from avenir, whose older senses include things that come or arrive *la avenida*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 401, p. 1895
Awake, Asleep, Strong, Weak
chapter topic; Chapter 327, p. 1297
awake — from despertar, and Latin expergisci, to set out from sleep; the e breaks to ie exactly where the stress lands *despierto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 327, p. 1297
Ayudar — the Same Word as Aid
chapter topic; Chapter 161, p. 557

B

badly — the partner bien has been waiting for since the opening pages, in a long form and a short one *mal*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 228, p. 739

bank — a Germanic word for a bench; the money-changers of medieval Italy worked at a bench, and a broken bench, banca rotta, is English bankrupt *el banco*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 353, p. 1479
barely, hardly, scarcely — a + penas, from Latin poena, a penalty; English pain, penalty, penal and subpoena are the same root *apenas*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 328, p. 1305
Bastante — An Ending You Can Already Read
chapter topic; Chapter 227, p. 737
beach — Late Latin plagia, a flat stretch of shore; keep it apart from plaza by hearing y against z or s *la playa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 400, p. 1887
Beber, and Two Ways to Ask
chapter topic; Chapter 36, p. 161
because — two tiny words fused into one, and the reason a sequence becomes a story *porque*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 167, p. 587
bed — one of the commonest Spanish words, and nobody has settled where it came from *la cama*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 279, p. 925
bee — Latin apicula, the little apis; Spanish kept the small form and let the big one die, the same way oveja and oreja did *la abeja*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 368, p. 1615
Before, After, and While
chapter topic; Chapter 323, p. 1265
before — Latin ante; English ante-, antique, ancient and ancestor all come off it, and an ancestor is one who went before *antes*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 323, p. 1265
behaviour — carrying yourself, with the same portare that carries goods in and out *el comportamiento*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 466, p. 2447
behind, at the back — Latin trans, across or beyond; English transfer, transit, translate and transparent all carry it *detrás*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 341, p. 1381
bicycle — French bicyclette, Latin bi- two on Greek kyklos circle, wheel; cycle, tricycle, cyclops and the 1848 coinage cyclone are the same root, English wheel is its inherited cousin, and encyclopedia comes from a misread Greek phrase *la bicicleta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 363, p. 1565
big — the first word in this book for what something is like, and it does not change for gender *grande*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 58, p. 237

bigger, older — Latin maior, the comparative of magnus, "great"; English took the same word twice, as major and as the mayor of a town, though Spanish calls that official something else entirely *mayor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 397, p. 1863
black and white — the two words, and the straight-line Latin history of the first one *negro, blanco*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 139, p. 469
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blanco — the colour Spanish did not inherit
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 139, p. 469
Blood and Household — Son, Daughter, Grandfather, Grandmother, Husband
chapter topic; Chapter 306, p. 1135
blue — an Arabic loan that became the plain everyday word, where French's cousin stayed poetic *azul*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 139, p. 469
book — named after the part of a tree people wrote on before paper *el libro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 57, p. 235
both — Latin ambo, the two together; English ambidextrous, ambiguous and amphitheatre all carry the same both *ambos*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 351, p. 1463
bottle — from French bouteille, on a late Latin buttis, a cask; a butler is the bottle-keeper, and the older Spanish form of the same word is bota *la botella*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 373, p. 1661
box — Latin capsa, the case a Roman kept scrolls in, probably reaching Castilian through Catalan or Occitan; case, capsule and chassis are cousins, and English cash first meant the box itself *la caja*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 366, p. 1595
brave — the old present participle of valer, from Latin valere, to be strong or be worth; English valiant, valour, value and valid are the same root *valiente*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 326, p. 1289
bread — and the compañero who shares it with you *el pan*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 143, p. 487
breakfast — des- undoing ayuno, a fast; English breakfast says the same thing in Germanic words, and dinner is the borrowed Romance version of it *el desayuno*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 367, p. 1605

Breakfast, Fruit And Something Sweet
chapter topic; Chapter 367, p. 1605
brimless cap — a round or close-fitting head covering, of uncertain origin *el gorro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 402, p. 1903
broken, in pieces — an irregular participle that dropped two letters and kept them *roto*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 448, p. 2273
brother and sister — NOT from frater/soror, but from an adjective meaning "of the same seed" *el hermano, la hermana*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 140, p. 475
brush — a diminutive of cepo, from Latin cippus, a post or block of wood; the brush is named for its back, not its bristles *el cepillo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 374, p. 1669
buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 15
Building a Paragraph — Plan, Add, Join, Refer Back
chapter topic; Chapter 273, p. 879
building — Latin aedificium, from aedes, temple or house, plus facere, to make; English edifice and edify are the same word *el edificio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 378, p. 1701
bull — Latin taurus, most likely taken from a language spoken before Latin; English Taurus and toreador come from it, and steer may or may not belong with it *el toro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 368, p. 1615
bus — French autobus, auto(móvil) plus (omni)bus; omnibus is the Latin dative plural of omnis, for all, so bus is a case ending left standing after its own word was thrown away *el autobús*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 363, p. 1565
busy — Latin occupare, to seize; to be busy is to be seized *ocupado*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 304, p. 1123
but rather — si plus no, if not; the negative that corrects a negative, and both halves are words you already have *sino*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 329, p. 1313
but — the first word you need to hold two true things against each other, and the first word of any argument *pero*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 218, p. 719
but — the literary one, without the accent *mas*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 276, p. 903

button — Old French boton, a thing that pushes out, from bouter, to thrust, taken from Germanic botan, to strike; button, buttress, rebut, abut and the butting of a goat all still push, and beat is the inherited cousin *el botón*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 360, p. 1535

C

calm — Latin tranquillus, the word for a sea with no wind on it *tranquilo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 304, p. 1123
candle — from velar, Latin vigilare, to keep watch; the identically spelled vela meaning sail is a different word entirely, from velum, cloth *la vela*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 374, p. 1669
Cansado — a State, Not a Quality
chapter topic; Chapter 59, p. 239
capital letters — and the four things Spanish pointedly does not capitalise, every one of which English does *las mayúsculas*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 426, p. 2049
Capitals, Short Forms And Symbols
chapter topic; Chapter 426, p. 2049
car — Hungarian kocsi, a cart from the town of Kocs, by way of German Kutsche and French coche; English coach is the same word, and the coach on the touchline began as a tutor who carried a student through *el coche*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 363, p. 1565
care, caution — Latin cogitatum, a thing thought about, from cogitare to think; English cogitate and Descartes' cogito are the same verb *el cuidado*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 333, p. 1345
cat — a word that travelled out of Africa with the animal, pushing Latin's own fēlēs aside *gato*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 150, p. 517
cave — from a Latin variant of cavus, hollow; cavity, excavate and cage are relatives, but English cove is a Germanic look-alike that is not *la cueva*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 370, p. 1635
centre, downtown — Latin centrum from Greek kentron, the spike a compass turns on; English centre, central, concentrate and eccentric all turn on it *el centro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 347, p. 1431

chair — Latin sella, a seat, from the verb to sit *la silla*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 279, p. 925
Character, Not Mood
chapter topic; Chapter 423, p. 2009
cheap — from the old verb baratar, to trade or haggle; Corominas calls the ultimate origin uncertain, probably pre-Roman and possibly Celtic, and English barter is very likely the same family *barato*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 397, p. 1863
cheerful — Latin alacer, lively, through two reconstructed spoken forms; English alacrity and Italian allegro are the same word *alegre*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 380, p. 1717
cheers, and bless you — the noun you already have, used as an act rather than as a description, and it does two jobs *¡Salud!*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 428, p. 2073
cheese — Latin caseus, the very same word as English cheese by another road *el queso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 280, p. 933
chicken — the food word to keep distinct from polvo, dust *el pollo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 403, p. 1909
Chicken, Vegetables and Paella
chapter topic; Chapter 403, p. 1909
Children and Everybody — Boy, Girl, Lad, Lass, People
chapter topic; Chapter 308, p. 1147
chocolate — Nahuatl, but the Academy marks the etymology disputed; the famous xocolātl is unattested, and chicolātl, named for the whisking stick, is the live proposal *el chocolate*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 376, p. 1685
Christmas — Latin nativitatem, a birth, from nasci to be born; Spanish nada and nadie are the same verb, a born thing and born people *la Navidad*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 357, p. 1511
church — Latin ecclesia from Greek ekklesia, the people called out to assemble; English ecclesiastical is the same gathering *la iglesia*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 346, p. 1423
cinema — short for cinematografo, Greek kinema movement plus graphein to write, a movement-writer; the same kinein is in English kinetic *el cine*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 354, p. 1487
-cion — About Two Thousand Words, At Once
chapter topic; Chapter 23, p. 127

-ción — about two thousand words, at once
grammar topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 23, p. 127
circus — Latin circus "ring", from Greek kirkos; the ring is the oldest part of the idea and the only part still round *el circo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 420, p. 1987
cl-, pl-, fl- → ll-
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 29, p. 139
Cl-, Pl-, Fl- to Ll-
chapter topic; Chapter 29, p. 139
clean — from limpidus, clear, the word English kept for water and Spanish moved to laundry *limpio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 281, p. 941
cleaning — the fourth way Spanish turns a word into the name of a doing *la limpieza*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 453, p. 2329
clever with ser, ready with estar — one word whose meaning is decided by the verb in front of it; the RAE traces it to Gothic lists, cunning *listo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 326, p. 1289
client; customer — the person who buys or uses a service *el cliente, la cliente*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 406, p. 1923
Clients, Documents and Data
chapter topic; Chapter 406, p. 1923
closed — the participle doing an adjective's job, and the sign you read most often *cerrado*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 439, p. 2177
clothes — Germanic raupa, plunder, beside raupjan, to pluck or strip; rob, reave and bereave still take, and robe made the same slide from spoils to garment on its own *la ropa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 360, p. 1535
clumsy — a word that meant shameful, and moved from how you look to what you can do *torpe*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 447, p. 2263
coast — Latin costa, a rib, so the coast is the country's side; English coast, intercostal, accost and cutlet are all the same rib *la costa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 370, p. 1635
coffee / a café — one useful noun before the polite request that follows *café*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 99

cold — Latin frigidus; English frigid, refrigerate and refrigerator are the same word, and hace frio has been carrying this noun all along *el frío*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 334, p. 1353
colour — Latin color, from celare to hide, because a colour is what covers a thing; conceal, cell, occult and even hell are the same hiding *el color*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 358, p. 1519
coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 127, p. 433
comb — Latin pecten; the same Latin family may reach the words for money, since pecuniary and peculiar are built on the word for livestock *el peine*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 373, p. 1661
come — "he eats," and the polite "you eat"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 153
Comeis and Vivis
chapter topic; Chapter 44, p. 183
coméis and vivís — the second difference, and the last
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 44, p. 183
comemos — "we eat"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 43, p. 179
Comen and Viven — Agreeing Again
chapter topic; Chapter 45, p. 185
comen and viven — agreeing again
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 45, p. 185
Comer Es Bueno — The Infinitive as Subject
chapter topic; Chapter 264, p. 823
comer es bueno — the infinitive as the subject
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 264, p. 823
Comer — the Second Verb Family, One Slot at a Time
chapter topic; Chapter 34, p. 153
comeré — the same endings keep -er
productive pattern; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 122, p. 417
comería — keep -er before "would"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 123, p. 421
comes — "you eat," and the first real difference
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 153
comfortable, convenient — "with measure", and a false friend in one direction *cómodo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 452, p. 2319
comía — hear both vowels
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 107, p. 379

Comíamos, Éramos, Íbamos — Every One With an Accent
chapter topic; Chapter 244, p. 773
comíamos · éramos · íbamos — every one with an accent
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 244, p. 773
Comiendo, Viviendo — Two Families, One Ending
chapter topic; Chapter 237, p. 759
comiendo · viviendo — two families, one ending
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 237, p. 759
comieron
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 201, p. 683
Comieron — One Ending, Two Families
chapter topic; Chapter 201, p. 683
Comisteis, Tuvisteis — The Last Gap Closes
chapter topic; Chapter 242, p. 769
comisteis · tuvisteis — the last gap closes
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 242, p. 769
¿cómo está usted? / ¿cómo estás? — choose the register
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 9, p. 67
como — "I eat," and you already knew how
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 153
Como Se Dice — The Sentence That Unlocks the Rest
chapter topic; Chapter 183, p. 647
¿cómo? — the two marks that say "this is a question"
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 6, p. 41
comparing the three learned yo forms that end in -go *tengo · hago · digo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 70, p. 277
comparing the two vowel changes inside the learned singular forms *e → ie and o → ue*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 69, p. 269
computer, in Spain — Latin ōrdinātor, the one who puts things in order; the word is old and Spanish, but the computing sense was taken from French ordinateur in the mid-1950s *el ordenador*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 393, p. 1823
concert *el concierto*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 413, p. 1961
congratulations — a plural noun used as an exclamation, and the one Spanish reaches for on a birthday where English would not *¡Felicidades!*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 428, p. 2073
Conmigo, Contigo — The Word That Says With Twice
chapter topic; Chapter 247, p. 779
Conocer — Coming to Know
chapter topic; Chapter 171, p. 607

Conseguir — Getting Is Following Until You Have It
chapter topic; Chapter 169, p. 601
could be — two words you already own, standing side by side and meaning less together than either does alone *puede ser*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 298, p. 1077
Counting Past Your Fingers
chapter topic; Chapter 351, p. 1463
Country, City, Neighbourhood
chapter topic; Chapter 325, p. 1281
course, class *el curso*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 417, p. 1977
Courtesy Past Thank You — Excuse Me, With Permission, Kind, A Thousand Thanks
chapter topic; Chapter 283, p. 957
Cuando — Both Pasts in One Sentence
chapter topic; Chapter 112, p. 395

D

-dad — Twelve Hundred More
chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 129
-dad — twelve hundred more
grammar topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 24, p. 129
dance — from bailar, borrowed from Occitan balar, from Late Latin ballare; English ball, ballet and ballad are the same word, and ball the round thing is not *el baile*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 377, p. 1693
Dancing, and the Article You Drop
chapter topic; Chapter 419, p. 1983
dangerous — a trial you might not survive, with its letters swapped *peligroso*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 461, p. 2403
dark — Latin obscurus, ob- plus a word for dark; English obscure is the same word, and which ancient root the second half belongs to is still argued over *oscuro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 372, p. 1653
day (el día — masculine) *día*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1
Days of the Week
chapter topic; Chapter 138, p. 463
Decidir, Coincidir, Equivocarse
chapter topic; Chapter 437, p. 2159

Del — And Then the List Stops
chapter topic; Chapter 231, p. 747
delighted to meet you — Latin incantare, to sing a spell into; English enchanted *encantado*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 305, p. 1129
demanding — a word that drives things out of you, from the verb behind agenda and actor *exigente*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 445, p. 2241
Deriving the Rest
chapter topic; Chapter 76, p. 295
Describing an Experience — How It Felt, How Long, How It Compared
chapter topic; Chapter 269, p. 855
dessert — the Latin family of post, after, with posterus and postrēmus behind it; Corominas makes postre a back-formation out of the phrase a la postre, the dessert sense documented in 1561 *el postre*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 391, p. 1803
destination, fate, and a job posting — from destinar, a learned borrowing of Latin dēstināre, to make firm or fix in place, on the stāre that also stands behind estar *el destino*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 392, p. 1813
Di, Haz, Ve, Pon, Ten, Sal, Se, Ven
chapter topic; Chapter 132, p. 449
di, haz, ve, pon, ten, sal, sé, ven
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 132, p. 449
di — the verb that changed families in the past
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 255, p. 797
dice que
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 211, p. 705
Dice Que — Someone Else's Sentence, Inside Yours
chapter topic; Chapter 211, p. 705
difficult — Latin difficilis, dis- plus facilis, "not doable"; English difficult is odd by comparison, having been cut backwards out of the noun difficulty *difícil*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 398, p. 1873
dijo
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 212, p. 707
dijo que
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 213, p. 709
Dijo Que — Both Verbs Step Back
chapter topic; Chapter 213, p. 709
Dijo — The Stem That Breaks Its Own Rule
chapter topic; Chapter 212, p. 707

direct, straight through — and on a broadcast, live *directo*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 446, p. 2251
dirty — from sucidus, greasy with its own juice, said first of unwashed wool *sucio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 281, p. 941
doctor *el doctor / la doctora*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 408, p. 1937
doctor — Latin medicus, a physician, from medeor, to heal; a word taken off the page, still carrying whole the three beats that Catalan metge wore away *el médico*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 394, p. 1833
Doctor, Pills and Tiredness
chapter topic; Chapter 408, p. 1937
document — a written record or proof *el documento*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 406, p. 1923
dog — a genuinely unsolved etymology, and the Latin word it pushed out *perro*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 150, p. 517
Dog and Cat
chapter topic; Chapter 150, p. 517
door — Latin porta, a gate, and the o that opened into ue *la puerta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 279, p. 925
Dos grados
chapter topic; Chapter 468, p. 2467
double, twice as much — Latin duplus, from duo two and -plus fold; English double, duplicate, duplex and duplicity are the same two folds *doble*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 344, p. 1405
down, below, downstairs — Late Latin bassus, low; English base, bass, abase and debase are the same lowness *abajo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 341, p. 1381
dress — Latin vestire, to clothe, its past participle standing alone as a noun; vest, invest, divest and travesty are all still clothing something, and wear is the inherited cousin *el vestido*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 360, p. 1535
dry — Latin siccus; English desiccate is the same word, and so is the sec on a French wine label *seco*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 379, p. 1709
duodēvīgintī — the quirk Spanish threw away
etymology topic; explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 149, p. 511

dust — Latin pulvis; English took the same word twice, powder through French with a d that was never in it, and pulverize straight off the Latin *el polvo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 369, p. 1625

E

each, every — Greek kata, down or by, through Latin cata; English catalogue, catastrophe and cathedral all begin with the same kata *cada*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 345, p. 1413
early — Latin temporanus, in good time, built on tempus; English temporary, tempo and contemporary share the root, and so does el tiempo *temprano*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 322, p. 1257
earth, ground, land — Latin terra, the dry part of the world as against the water; terrain, terrace, subterranean, terrestrial, terra cotta and Mediterranean are the family, and terror is not *la tierra*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 362, p. 1555
Earth, Sea And Sky
chapter topic; Chapter 362, p. 1555
Easter — Latin pascha, from Greek paskha, from Hebrew pesach, the Passover; English kept a spring goddess's name for the feast but the Latin one for paschal *la Pascua*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 357, p. 1511
easy — Latin facilis, built on facere, "to do", so what it says is do-able rather than light; hacer is the same verb worn down by mouth, while fácil was lifted off the page and kept its c *fácil*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 398, p. 1873
egg — Latin ovum, wearing an h that exists only to help your eyes *el huevo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 280, p. 933
El Animo
chapter topic; Chapter 443, p. 2217
El césped y el patio
chapter topic; Chapter 450, p. 2295
El consejo a otras bibliotecas
chapter topic; Chapter 473, p. 2519
El Contrato
chapter topic; Chapter 441, p. 2197
El cuaderno de campo
chapter topic; Chapter 465, p. 2435

El Cuarto Y La Mesa — Key, Shower, Table, Light, Bathroom
chapter topic; Chapter 310, p. 1163
El Cuerpo Y El Descanso
chapter topic; Chapter 438, p. 2167
El curso de cocina
chapter topic; Chapter 471, p. 2497
El curso que paga la empresa
chapter topic; Chapter 474, p. 2527
El donativo
chapter topic; Chapter 461, p. 2403
El Edificio Y Sus Normas
chapter topic; Chapter 433, p. 2123
El huerto comunitario
chapter topic; Chapter 467, p. 2457
El inventario
chapter topic; Chapter 459, p. 2387
El Libro — And a Word Made of Tree Bark
chapter topic; Chapter 57, p. 235
El Libro Que Compre — The Word You Cannot Leave Out
chapter topic; Chapter 187, p. 655
el libro que compré — the word you cannot leave out
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 187, p. 655
El Libro Que Compro — One Sentence Out of Two
chapter topic; Chapter 186, p. 653
el libro que compro — one sentence out of two
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 186, p. 653
El Mostrador — Ticket, Coin, Passport, Entrance, Change
chapter topic; Chapter 313, p. 1187
el or él? — the accent as a meaning label
script and writing topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 10, p. 73
El Pedido Y La Devolución
chapter topic; Chapter 431, p. 2105
El plazo
chapter topic; Chapter 458, p. 2379
el primer libro — where an ordinal stands
grammar topic; explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 262, p. 815
El Puesto
chapter topic; Chapter 445, p. 2241
El reparto
chapter topic; Chapter 452, p. 2319
El taller
chapter topic; Chapter 449, p. 2285
El Taller Y La Máquina
chapter topic; Chapter 434, p. 2131

El turno
chapter topic; Chapter 453, p. 2329
El viaje guiado
chapter topic; Chapter 463, p. 2419
elevator, lift — Latin ascēnsor, the one who climbs, from ascendere; the form is ancient but the machine sense is French and dates to 1867 *el ascensor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 390, p. 1793
email — correo is not built on correr but comes through Catalan correu from Old French corlieu, a messenger; electrónico goes back to Greek ēlektron, amber, and the pair renders English electronic mail *el correo electrónico*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 393, p. 1823
enough, quite — an ending you already decode, on a verb meaning to suffice, giving a word that means exactly "sufficing" *bastante*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 227, p. 737
enough — the formal partner of bastante, naming a requirement where bastante names a place on a scale *suficiente*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 467, p. 2457
Entender — Understanding Is Stretching Toward
chapter topic; Chapter 154, p. 535
Enye and the Upside-Down Marks
chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 77
era — an old root in an open past
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 109, p. 385
es- + consonant
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 30, p. 143
-es — The Plural Chapter One Promised
chapter topic; Chapter 80, p. 305
-es — the plural your first chapter owed you
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 80, p. 305
Es- — the Vowel Spanish Put in Front
chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 143
Escribir — Writing Is Scratching
chapter topic; Chapter 156, p. 543
Ese — Pointing at What Is by You
chapter topic; Chapter 222, p. 727
Espanol, and Your First Built Sentence
chapter topic; Chapter 22, p. 123
estáis — and nothing surprises you
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 55, p. 227
estamos — the other "we are"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 55, p. 227

están — "they are"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 55, p. 227
Estar in the Plural
chapter topic; Chapter 55, p. 227
Este — Pointing at What Is in Your Hand
chapter topic; Chapter 221, p. 725
Esto, Eso, Aquello — Pointing at What Has No Name
chapter topic; Chapter 224, p. 731
esto · eso · aquello — pointing at what has no name yet
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 224, p. 731
Estoy Hablando — The Payoff
chapter topic; Chapter 238, p. 761
estoy hablando — the payoff
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 238, p. 761
Estudiante — a Word You Can Build
chapter topic; Chapter 52, p. 221
Estudiar — Studying Is Being Eager
chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 121
estuve — a third known verb joins the strong pattern
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 105, p. 369
even, at least — two words you already have, si and quiera, welded into one; ni siquiera is not even *siquiera*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 324, p. 1273
even, including — Latin inclusus from includere, in + claudere, to shut in; English include, enclose, recluse, seclude and conclude are all shuttings *incluso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 328, p. 1305
exactly — from exigere, to drive out, and then to weigh out precisely *exacto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 284, p. 965
exam, examination *el examen*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 410, p. 1947
except, safe — Latin salvus, unharmed; English salvage, salvation, salvo, salve and safe itself all come off it *salvo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 329, p. 1313
excuse me — from culpa, fault: literally, take the fault off me *disculpe*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 283, p. 957
excuse me, said when you pass — per plus mittere, to let through *con permiso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 283, p. 957
exhibition — Latin ex- "out" plus ponere "to place", a putting-out; the same ponere is inside compose, deposit and position *la exposición*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 420, p. 1987

expensive — Latin cārus already meant both dear-and-beloved and dear-and-costly, exactly as English dear still does, and charity, cherish and caress all come from it *caro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 397, p. 1863
experience — what an advert asks for, and a word that reads itself if you let it *la experiencia*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 435, p. 2139

F

f → h — why the h says nothing
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 28, p. 137
F to H — Why the H Says Nothing
chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 137
face — Late Latin cara, generally traced to Greek kara head though the trail is not clean; the identical cara meaning expensive is a separate root, carus, which gave English charity, caress and cherish *la cara*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 364, p. 1575
false, fake — Latin falsus, the past participle of fallere, to trip somebody up; English fail, fault, fallacy and false all come off it *falso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 324, p. 1273
falsos amigos
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 66, p. 257
Falsos Amigos — the Words That Obey and Lie
chapter topic; Chapter 66, p. 257
far, far away — Latin laxius, more loosely, from laxus loose; English lax, relax, release and leash come off the same slack rope *lejos*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 340, p. 1373
fat — Latin gurdus, dull or blunt, which Quintilian says he heard came into Latin from Spain; French gourd, numb, is the survivor, and English gourd is a false friend *gordo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 371, p. 1645
father and mother — among the oldest reconstructible words in the whole family *el padre, la madre*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 140, p. 475
fault, blame — Latin culpa; English culprit and culpable are the same word, and mea culpa was never translated at all *la culpa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 320, p. 1241

favourite — from favor, Latin favēre, "to be well disposed toward"; the -ito on the end is an Italian past participle, not the Spanish little-word ending it looks exactly like *favorito*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 398, p. 1873
film or movie — Latin pellicula, a tiny skin or thin layer *la película*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 404, p. 1913
Fine Shades — Four Differences a Translation Loses
chapter topic; Chapter 275, p. 895
finger, and equally toe — Latin digitus; digit became a numeral because people count on fingers, and digital reached the computer through the numerals rather than through the hand *el dedo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 364, p. 1575
fingernail — Latin ungula, a diminutive of unguis, nail or claw; English ungulate, a hoofed animal, is the same word *la uña*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 375, p. 1677
Finish, Prepare and Plan the Weekend
chapter topic; Chapter 409, p. 1941
Fire, Crossings, and Things That Turn
chapter topic; Chapter 387, p. 1771
fire — Latin focus, which meant the hearth and not the fire at all; focus, focal, curfew and fuel all come down from that hearth, while the Latin word for fire itself lost the fight across Romance *el fuego*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 362, p. 1555
first, second, third — the counting words for order rather than amount, and the story inside the second one *primero · segundo · tercero*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 262, p. 815
fish as food — Latin piscātus, the catch, from piscārī to fish, on piscis; Pisces and piscine are borrowed, English fish is the inherited cousin, and pecado sin is a different word entirely *el pescado*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 361, p. 1545
Five Animals, Two Of Them Small
chapter topic; Chapter 368, p. 1615
Five Buildings You May Have To Find
chapter topic; Chapter 353, p. 1479
Five Everyday Actions
chapter topic; Chapter 395, p. 1843
Five Last Pieces
chapter topic; Chapter 428, p. 2073

Five More Everyday Actions
chapter topic; Chapter 396, p. 1853
Five More Short Answers — Maybe, Could Be, Indeed, No Doubt, Out of the Question
chapter topic; Chapter 298, p. 1077
Five More Things You Ask For — Knife, Cup, Pot, Blanket, Broom
chapter topic; Chapter 294, p. 1045
Five More Things You Ask For — Rope, Needle, Thread, Basket, Paper
chapter topic; Chapter 301, p. 1101
Five Parts of a Building
chapter topic; Chapter 390, p. 1793
Five Places A Town Has
chapter topic; Chapter 346, p. 1423
Five Places and Things in a Week
chapter topic; Chapter 394, p. 1833
Five Places You Can Ask About
chapter topic; Chapter 378, p. 1701
Five Short Answers — Agreed, Sure, True, Exactly, Of Course
chapter topic; Chapter 284, p. 965
Five Sizes of When
chapter topic; Chapter 322, p. 1257
Five Things a Form Asks For
chapter topic; Chapter 393, p. 1823
Five Things a Person Has
chapter topic; Chapter 375, p. 1677
Five Things on a Plate
chapter topic; Chapter 376, p. 1685
Five Things You Ask For — Soap, Towel, Glass, Spoon, Plate
chapter topic; Chapter 287, p. 989
Five Things You Can Learn
chapter topic; Chapter 377, p. 1693
Five Things You Can Pick Up
chapter topic; Chapter 373, p. 1661
Five Things You Hold
chapter topic; Chapter 374, p. 1669
Five Ways to Be
chapter topic; Chapter 326, p. 1289
Five Words for a Journey
chapter topic; Chapter 392, p. 1813
Five Words for Eating Out
chapter topic; Chapter 391, p. 1803
Five Words for How Something Feels
chapter topic; Chapter 379, p. 1709

Five Words for Making a Journey
chapter topic; Chapter 400, p. 1887
Five Words for Weighing One Thing Against Another
chapter topic; Chapter 397, p. 1863
Five Words for What a Thing Is Worth
chapter topic; Chapter 398, p. 1873
Five Words for What Something Is Like
chapter topic; Chapter 380, p. 1717
Five Words in a Clothes Shop
chapter topic; Chapter 402, p. 1903
fixed, permanent — a past participle so old that nobody feels it as one *fijo*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 441, p. 2197
flight — the noun built from volar, to fly; for travel, the route an aeroplane covers from origin to destination *el vuelo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 400, p. 1887
floor, storey, flat — from pisar, to tread, from Late Latin pinsare to pound; English pestle and piston are the same pounding, and in Spain un piso is a flat *el piso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 355, p. 1495
floor, storey — Latin planta, both the sole of the foot and a cutting set in the ground; its pl- shows it was taken from writing, since the mouth-worn twin is llanta *la planta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 390, p. 1793
flour — Latin farina, from far, husked wheat; the f became h by the Castilian change behind hacer and hijo, which spared frente and fuego *la harina*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 376, p. 1685
flower — Latin flos, and the reason English flour is spelled so oddly *la flor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 278, p. 917
fly — Latin musca; English borrowed the Spanish diminutive whole as mosquito, and the same little fly became the sparrowhawk and then the musket *la mosca*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 368, p. 1615
food, a meal — a noun you can build yourself out of a verb you already own *la comida*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 77, p. 299
for, during *durante*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 269, p. 855
for example *por ejemplo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 270, p. 861

"for" pointing back or through — at a cause, a route, an exchange; and you have been saying it since your first page *por*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 177, p. 633
"for" pointing forward — at a destination, a purpose, a deadline, a person meant to receive something *para*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 176, p. 631
Four Everyday Actions English Kept
chapter topic; Chapter 381, p. 1725
Four lines to one person — where the second needs the first
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 418, p. 1981
Four Ordinary Adjectives — New, Old, Clean, Dirty
chapter topic; Chapter 281, p. 941
Four Roads, and Where the Trail Stops
chapter topic; Chapter 384, p. 1747
Four Things in a Room — Door, Window, Chair, Bed
chapter topic; Chapter 279, p. 925
Four Things Outdoors — Wind, Snow, Tree, Flower
chapter topic; Chapter 278, p. 917
Four Things the Hands Do
chapter topic; Chapter 385, p. 1755
Four Things You Buy — Cheese, Egg, Apple, Money
chapter topic; Chapter 280, p. 933
Four Verbs Two Languages Built Twice
chapter topic; Chapter 382, p. 1731
Four Words for Following Directions
chapter topic; Chapter 401, p. 1895
free — Latin liber meaning unowned, which is a different Latin word from the liber that gave libro; English liberty, liberal and deliver come off this one *libre*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 326, p. 1289
free of charge — a whole Latin word swallowed unchanged, grātīs contracted from grātiīs, "for thanks", which is why it never grows an -o or an -a *gratis*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 397, p. 1863
French; French person *francés / francesa*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 410, p. 1947
fresh, cool — a Germanic frisk, new and lively, that spread through Romance; the painting technique is the Italian form, for paint laid on wet plaster *fresco*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 379, p. 1709
from, since — three Latin prepositions welded shut, de plus ex plus de; despues is built the same way, out of de plus ex plus post *desde*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 356, p. 1503

From the Seed Up — Seed, Root, Trunk, Branch, Wood
chapter topic; Chapter 291, p. 1021
From When, For How Long, And All At Once
chapter topic; Chapter 356, p. 1503
fruit — Latin fructus from frui, to enjoy, so a fruit is what a plant gives back; English fruit and frugal both arrived through French, and the old verb brook is the inherited cousin *la fruta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 367, p. 1605
fueron
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 203, p. 687
Fueron — They Were, and They Went
chapter topic; Chapter 203, p. 687
full — Latin plēnus; plenty, plenary, replenish and complete are the borrowed cousins, full is the inherited one, and comply belongs with filling rather than with folding *lleno*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 365, p. 1585
Further Down — Neck, Shoulder, Back, Knee, Ankle
chapter topic; Chapter 293, p. 1037
furthermore, moreover *además*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 273, p. 879

G

garden — Frankish gardo, an enclosure, the same Germanic word English kept as yard and borrowed back from French as garden; kindergarten is a children's enclosure *el jardín*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 354, p. 1487
Gente Y Trato
chapter topic; Chapter 436, p. 2149
glove — Germanic rather than Latin, probably through Catalan from Frankish want, a mitten, arriving already wearing the gu- Romance gives Germanic w- *el guante*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 374, p. 1669
Going, and the Future You Can Already Say
chapter topic; Chapter 49, p. 205
gold — Latin aurum, from an ancient root for shining and dawning; aurora is the same root, and so, far back, is the English word east *el oro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 373, p. 1661
good afternoon *buenas tardes*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 2, p. 15
good evening / good night *buenas noches*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 2, p. 15

good-looking — the Academy derives it from Latin vappa, flat wine and so a good-for-nothing, but Corominas argues against that route, so this is a word whose origin the two standard authorities do not agree on *guapo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 399, p. 1883
good morning (literally "good days") *buenos días*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1
goodbye *adiós*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 85
Goodbye
chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 85
Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind *el* and *la*
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1
Grande — the First Word for What a Thing Is Like
chapter topic; Chapter 58, p. 237
grape — Latin uva, a grape or a bunch of them; English uvula is its diminutive, the little grape at the back of the throat *la uva*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 376, p. 1685
grass, the plant — with a silent h that Spanish added on purpose *la hierba*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 450, p. 2295
Green and Yellow
chapter topic; Chapter 151, p. 521
green — from a verb meaning "to flourish," and a cousin of verdant but not of English green *verde*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 151, p. 521
grey — a Germanic word borrowed into Spanish through its Romance neighbours; English grey is a cousin from a different Germanic stem, not the same word *gris*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 372, p. 1653
Grey, Pink And Dark
chapter topic; Chapter 372, p. 1653
guitar — Ancient Greek kithára, a stringed instrument; the Greek source is certain and the road into Spanish is genuinely disputed, with three standard references giving three different answers *la guitarra*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 394, p. 1833
Gustar — the Verb Built the Other Way Round
chapter topic; Chapter 163, p. 563
Gym and Sport
chapter topic; Chapter 412, p. 1957
gym, gymnasium *el gimnasio*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 412, p. 1957

H

Ha + Y — The Fossil in a Three-Letter Word
chapter topic; Chapter 192, p. 665
ha + y — the fossil in a three-letter word
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 192, p. 665
habla — "he speaks," and the polite "you speak"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 18, p. 113
Habla — Telling Somebody To Do Something
chapter topic; Chapter 131, p. 447
habla — telling somebody to do something
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 131, p. 447
Hablaba and Hablo — Two Ways of Looking
chapter topic; Chapter 111, p. 393
hablaba and habló — two ways of looking
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 111, p. 393
hablaba — let a past action stay open
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 107, p. 379
Hablábamos — The Imperfect Gets Its Plural
chapter topic; Chapter 243, p. 771
hablábamos — the imperfect gets its plural
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 243, p. 771
Hablado, Comido, Vivido — The Participle
chapter topic; Chapter 116, p. 405
hablado, comido, vivido — the participle
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 116, p. 405
Hablais — the Form Spain Keeps
chapter topic; Chapter 40, p. 173
habláis — the form Spain keeps
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 40, p. 173
hablamos
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 200, p. 681
Hablamos — the First Form That Is Not About One Person
chapter topic; Chapter 38, p. 169
hablamos — "we speak"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 169
Hablamos — We Speak, and We Spoke
chapter topic; Chapter 200, p. 681
Hablan — They, and Ustedes
chapter topic; Chapter 39, p. 171
hablan — "they speak," and "you all speak"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 39, p. 171
Hablando — An Action Caught in the Middle
chapter topic; Chapter 236, p. 757

hablando — an action caught in the middle
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 236, p. 757
hablara
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 206, p. 693
Hablara — the Form for Supposing
chapter topic; Chapter 206, p. 693
hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 122, p. 417
hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 123, p. 421
hablaron
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 199, p. 679
Hablaron — They Spoke
chapter topic; Chapter 199, p. 679
Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 126, p. 431
hablas — "you speak," to someone you know
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 17, p. 111
Hablasteis — The Form You Were Promised
chapter topic; Chapter 241, p. 767
hablasteis — the form you were promised
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 241, p. 767
hablé — a regular singular past from a known verb
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 103, p. 357
hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 127, p. 433
Hable Usted — The Polite Command
chapter topic; Chapter 134, p. 453
hable usted — the polite command
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 134, p. 453
Hablo, Hablas, Habla — The Ending Says Who
chapter topic; Chapter 258, p. 807
hablo · hablas · habla — the ending says who
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 258, p. 807
hablo — "I speak"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 16, p. 107
Hablo — One Form, Two Readings
chapter topic; Chapter 257, p. 805
hablo — one form, two readings
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 257, p. 805
hablo — one word, one whole sentence
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 16, p. 107
hacemos, hacen — and the club has no plural at all
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 76, p. 295

Hacer, Decir, and the -go Verb Club
chapter topic; Chapter 70, p. 277
haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 128, p. 437
happy *feliz*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 269, p. 855
happy, content — Latin contentus, held together, from continere *contento*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 304, p. 1123
hard — of a thing under your hand, and of a day you would rather not repeat *duro*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 448, p. 2273
hard-working — trabajar plus the agent ending -dor, the Spanish descendant of the Latin -tor that made actor; the same ending makes both a noun and an adjective *trabajador*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 423, p. 2009
haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 124, p. 425
Has, Ha, Hemos, Habeis, Han
chapter topic; Chapter 118, p. 409
has, ha, hemos, habéis, han
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 118, p. 409
hasta aquí / hasta la noche — point to the limit
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 12, p. 85
Hay Que — Somebody Has To, and Nobody in Particular
chapter topic; Chapter 193, p. 667
hay que — somebody has to, and nobody in particular
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 193, p. 667
Hay — There Is, There Are, Same Word
chapter topic; Chapter 191, p. 663
He Hablado — A Verb With No Meaning Left
chapter topic; Chapter 117, p. 407
he hablado — "I have spoken"
grammar topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 117, p. 407
He, She, and the Polite You
chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 113
he/she calls himself; you (formal) call yourself *se llama*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 41
Head and Hand
chapter topic; Chapter 141, p. 481
Health, Hunger, Cold and Heat
chapter topic; Chapter 334, p. 1353

health — Latin salus, salutem, health and safety and a greeting all at once; English salute, salutary and salubrious keep it, and Spanish saludo is a wish for it *la salud*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 334, p. 1353
healthy — Latin sanus, sound in body and mind; English sane, sanity, insane, sanitary and sanatorium are the same word *sano*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 327, p. 1297
Hearing, Sleeping, Walking, Running
chapter topic; Chapter 165, p. 569
heart — Latin cor, cordis with a Spanish augmentative ending; cordial, courage, accord and discord are all hearts, and record is literally to bring a thing back to the heart *el corazón*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 364, p. 1575
heat — Latin calor from calere, to be warm; English calorie, cauldron, scald, chowder and nonchalant are all built on it *el calor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 334, p. 1353
Hecho, Dicho, Visto, Puesto
chapter topic; Chapter 119, p. 411
hecho, dicho, visto, puesto
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 119, p. 411
hello / hi *hola*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1
help — Latin adiutare, to bring strength toward someone; the same root gives English aid *la ayuda*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 303, p. 1117
hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 105, p. 369
high, tall — Latin altus, which meant high and also deep; altitude, exalt, enhance, haughty and the oboe are all still measuring height *alto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 365, p. 1585
Hola and Buenos Días
chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1
***hola* — let your eye and your hand meet the word**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
***hola* — look, hide, write, compare**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
***hola* — one supported copy**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
hospital — Latin hospitale, a house kept for guests, from hospes, which meant the host and the guest at once; English host, hotel, hostel and hospitality all come off it *el hospital*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 353, p. 1479

hotel — French hotel, from Old French hostel, from the same Latin hospitale as hospital; the little hat on the French o is a headstone for a lost s *el hotel*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 354, p. 1487
hour / o'clock — telling the time, and a word Spanish inherited almost unchanged from Latin *la hora*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 147, p. 503
house, home — and a word French wore down so far it stopped looking like a noun *la casa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 56, p. 233
how — a whole Latin phrase, quo modo, worn smooth into one word *cómo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 41
How Are You
chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 61
how are you? — assemble the formal question from cómo, estar, and usted *¿cómo está usted?*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 8, p. 61
how old are you? — literally, how many years do you have? *¿Cuántos años tienes?*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 47, p. 189
How Tall, How Long, How Full
chapter topic; Chapter 365, p. 1585
How You Get There
chapter topic; Chapter 363, p. 1565
however, nevertheless *sin embargo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 270, p. 861
Hoy Como en Casa — The Pieces That Move
chapter topic; Chapter 265, p. 827
hoy como en casa — the pieces that move
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 265, p. 827
hunger — Latin famen from fames; a feminine noun that takes el before its stressed a-, and one of the f-to-h words like hacer, hijo and hierro *el hambre*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 334, p. 1353

I

I am from... — use ser with de to state origin *soy de…*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 48, p. 197
I am going to... — the near future with ir, a, and a known infinitive *voy a + infinitive*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 49, p. 205

I call (from llamar, to call) *llamo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 27
I do not know — saber is Latin sapere, to taste; knowing began as tasting *no sé*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 303, p. 1117
"I don't understand" — the most useful sentence a beginner owns *no entiendo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 103
I hope to travel *espero viajar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 269, p. 855
I'm sorry — literally "I feel it," a naming of the feeling rather than a claim about yourself *lo siento*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 137, p. 459
I suppose that *supongo que*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 271, p. 867
I will speak *hablaré*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 49, p. 205
iba — ir returns to its inherited past
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 109, p. 385
Ice Cream
chapter topic; Chapter 411, p. 1953
ice cream; frozen *el helado*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 411, p. 1953
ice — Latin gelu; English gelatin, jelly, congeal and gelid are the same word, and the h- here is a spelling habit, not the f- that hides in humo *el hielo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 370, p. 1635
identify with ser; describe a current state or location with estar *ser vs estar*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 48, p. 197
ill — Latin infirmus, not firm; the same word as English infirm *enfermo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 304, p. 1123
important — built on importar, from Latin importāre, "to carry in"; classical Latin never used it to mean "to matter", and English import still carries both jobs *importante*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 398, p. 1873
in front, ahead — Latin ante, before; English ante, antecedent, anterior, antique and anticipate all come off it *delante*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 341, p. 1381
in my opinion *en mi opinión*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 270, p. 861
in short — and the last thing this book asks of you *en resumen*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 277, p. 909

in the first place, firstly *en primer lugar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 273, p. 879
in the middle *en medio*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 407, p. 1931
indeed — from ex and facere, carried out; it confirms what somebody has just said, and does not mean "in effect" *en efecto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 298, p. 1077
initialisms and acronyms — written without points, and pluralised by doubling the letters rather than by adding an s *las siglas*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 426, p. 2049
Inside The Building, Not Outside It
chapter topic; Chapter 355, p. 1495
inside, within — Latin de intro, from within, on intra; English interior, internal, entrance and the intro of anything share it *dentro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 341, p. 1381
intelligent — Latin intellegere, inter "between" plus legere "to pick out"; intelligence is literally the act of choosing between things *inteligente*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 423, p. 2009
interesting — from Latin interesse, inter + esse, "to be between"; the same phrase gave banking the word interest, because what a lender lost was id quod interest, the difference between *interesante*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 398, p. 1873
Ir in the Plural — a Verb That Is Not Ir
chapter topic; Chapter 68, p. 265
is in or at... — locate someone with estar and the already-known en *está en…*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 48, p. 197
-ista
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 53, p. 223
-ista — Jobs You Can Already Read
chapter topic; Chapter 53, p. 223
"it" — a word you have been saying since your fourth chapter, in a job you have not met yet *lo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 83, p. 313
it depends *depende*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 210, p. 701
"it" for something feminine — the one word in this pair that never had to change *la*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 84, p. 315

it's just that... *es que…*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 272, p. 871

J

jeans — literally cowboy trousers, and one of the few garments Spanish names after the person who wore them first *los vaqueros*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 430, p. 2095
Jugar — Playing Was Joking
chapter topic; Chapter 170, p. 603
jungle, forest — Latin silva, a wood; English sylvan and savage are the same word, and Pennsylvania means Penn's woods *la selva*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 378, p. 1701
Juzgar
chapter topic; Chapter 447, p. 2263

K

kind — Latin amabilis, loveable: the person it is easy to be fond of *amable*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 283, p. 957
kiss — Latin basium, which the Academy's dictionary says Latin itself took from Celtic; French baiser and Italian bacio are the same word *el beso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 375, p. 1677
knot — Latin nodus by way of an irregular Vulgar Latin form; desnudo, naked, is a different Latin word, and Corominas denies the two ever merged *el nudo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 374, p. 1669
Knowing How — the Verb That Once Meant Taste
chapter topic; Chapter 389, p. 1789

L

La Bebo — The Pronoun Tells the Truth
chapter topic; Chapter 144, p. 493
la bebo — the pronoun tells the truth
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 144, p. 493
La biblioteca que presta cosas
chapter topic; Chapter 472, p. 2509
La Casa Por Dentro
chapter topic; Chapter 432, p. 2113

La Casa Por Fuera
chapter topic; Chapter 444, p. 2229
La Casa — Your First Everyday Noun
chapter topic; Chapter 56, p. 233
La cita perdida
chapter topic; Chapter 464, p. 2427
La cola y el carné
chapter topic; Chapter 451, p. 2307
La Comida — A Noun You Can Build
chapter topic; Chapter 77, p. 299
La cuenta
chapter topic; Chapter 456, p. 2361
La farmacia de guardia
chapter topic; Chapter 457, p. 2371
La Fiesta Y El Año
chapter topic; Chapter 440, p. 2187
La Gestion
chapter topic; Chapter 442, p. 2207
La habitación
chapter topic; Chapter 455, p. 2349
La herramienta
chapter topic; Chapter 460, p. 2395
La impresora de la sala 2
chapter topic; Chapter 469, p. 2477
La mudanza
chapter topic; Chapter 448, p. 2273
La reunión
chapter topic; Chapter 462, p. 2411
La — The Pronoun Carries What Left
chapter topic; Chapter 84, p. 315
La Tienda Y La Cuenta — Shop, Bill, Price, Bag, Seat
chapter topic; Chapter 311, p. 1171
La vía cortada
chapter topic; Chapter 454, p. 2339
lamp — Greek lampas, a torch, from lampein, to shine; lamp and lantern are cousins, and Spanish relámpago, lightning, comes free with it *la lámpara*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 366, p. 1595
language — Greek idioma, a peculiarity of style, from idios, one's own; idiom, idiosyncrasy and idiot are all from the same idios *el idioma*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 377, p. 1693
las casas — "the houses"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 78, p. 301

Las — The Plural Article That Behaves
chapter topic; Chapter 78, p. 301
last — Latin ultimus, a superlative to a stem meaning beyond; English ultimate, ultimatum and ultra are all in that family *último*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 380, p. 1717
last night — Latin ad noctem, toward night, worn into one word; the same noctem gives English nocturnal and equinox *anoche*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 322, p. 1257
Le — To Him, To Her, To You
chapter topic; Chapter 93, p. 337
Leer — Reading Is Gathering
chapter topic; Chapter 155, p. 539
Les — And What the Second System Costs
chapter topic; Chapter 94, p. 339
les — "to them," and what this system really costs
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 94, p. 339
less, fewer, except — Latin minus, the twin of magis; English minus, minor, minimum, minister and diminish are all the small end of it *menos*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 324, p. 1273
letter of the alphabet — Latin littera, which also gives English letter, literal and literature; where Latin got it is still unsettled *la letra*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 377, p. 1693
library — Greek biblion, a book, plus theke, a chest, so a book-chest; the same theke gave Spanish bodega and botica, French boutique and English apothecary *la biblioteca*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 353, p. 1479
life — Latin vita; English vital, vitamin, revive, survive and viable are all built on it, and the vitamin was named by a chemist who thought it was an amine *la vida*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 330, p. 1321
light, pale, clear — the adjective behind a word you have been saying for chapters *claro*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 455, p. 2349
likeable, nice — Spanish's own adjective from simpatía, Latin sympathia from Greek sympatheia; it does not mean sympathetic *simpático*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 380, p. 1717
lip — Latin labium, the same word as English labial; English lip is Germanic, and the old Indo-European link between them is now doubted *el labio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 375, p. 1677

little, few — Latin paucus; English paucity is the noun and few is the same root through Germanic, and you already carry it inside tampoco *poco*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 317, p. 1219
living room, hall — Proto-Germanic salaz, a one-room building, not Latin at all; English salon and saloon are the same word by way of French *la sala*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 390, p. 1793
Lo Que Llevas — Clock, Phone, Suitcase, Map, Letter
chapter topic; Chapter 312, p. 1179
Lo Que — What, Out of Two Old Words
chapter topic; Chapter 188, p. 657
lo que — "what," out of two old words
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 188, p. 657
Lo — Saying It Without Naming It
chapter topic; Chapter 83, p. 313
Lo Siento
chapter topic; Chapter 137, p. 459
long — Latin largus, abundant and generous; English large is the very same word gone one way, largesse keeps the older sense, and Spanish took it the other way, to long *largo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 365, p. 1585
look — and the tone shifts *mira*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 272, p. 871
los and las — "them"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 89, p. 329
Los and Las — Them, Derived
chapter topic; Chapter 89, p. 329
los libros — "the books"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 79, p. 303
Los Papeles Del Trabajo
chapter topic; Chapter 435, p. 2139
Los — The One That Does Not Add -s
chapter topic; Chapter 79, p. 303
luck — Latin sors, sortem, a token drawn from a jar; English sort, sorcery and consort are all lots being drawn *la suerte*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 320, p. 1241
lukewarm — Latin tepidus, the same word English borrowed later as tepid, one worn down by speech and the other kept in a book *tibio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 379, p. 1709

M

madam, Mrs — the feminine of senor, on the same Latin senior *señora*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 305, p. 1129
maize — Taíno mahis, one of the first American words to reach Europe, and the word Spanish handed on to English as maize *el maíz*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 376, p. 1685
Making a Case — Claim, Example, However, Although
chapter topic; Chapter 270, p. 861
Mal — Bien Finally Gets Its Opposite
chapter topic; Chapter 228, p. 739
mañana, español — the ñ in the words you are about to need
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 11, p. 77
María · España · profesor — the nouns that need no article
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 260, p. 811
María, España — The Nouns That Need No Article
chapter topic; Chapter 260, p. 811
María, Ven — Naming Who You Are Talking To
chapter topic; Chapter 249, p. 783
María, ven — naming who you are talking to
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 249, p. 783
market — Latin mercatus from merx, goods; English market, merchant, commerce and even mercy grow out of the same trade *el mercado*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 346, p. 1423
May *mayo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 416, p. 1973
maybe — literally "such a turn", from vicem, a turn or a change; vice versa is the turn turned round *tal vez*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 298, p. 1077
maybe, perhaps *quizás*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 271, p. 867
Me and Te — The Two People Talking
chapter topic; Chapter 85, p. 317
Me Lo — Both at Once
chapter topic; Chapter 98, p. 347
me lo — both at once
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 98, p. 347
me / myself *me*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 27
me quieres — "you love me"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 85, p. 317

meadow — Latin pratum; English prairie is the same word through French, and Madrid's museum is named for the meadow it stands on *el prado*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 378, p. 1701
meat, flesh — Latin carō, stem carn-; carnal, incarnate and carnage are the direct cousins, and carnival is carnelevare, the removing of meat *la carne*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 361, p. 1545
Meeting Someone — Welcome, Greeting, Hug, Smile, Guest
chapter topic; Chapter 282, p. 949
-mente — With No Upper Limit
chapter topic; Chapter 25, p. 131
-mente — with no upper limit
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 25, p. 131
Middle, Below, Outside and Beside
chapter topic; Chapter 407, p. 1931
milk — Latin lac, stem lact-; lactose and lactate are learned coinages and Italian latte is the same word, while lettuce is lactūca, named for the milky sap of a cut stem *la leche*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 361, p. 1545
Mine, Somebody Else's, And Which Kind
chapter topic; Chapter 350, p. 1455
Mirar Y Moverse
chapter topic; Chapter 446, p. 2251
mobile phone — literally the movable one, from Latin mobilis *el móvil*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 404, p. 1913
money — the name of a Roman coin, still doing service two thousand years later *el dinero*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 280, p. 933
mood, and humour — one word for both, because your temperament was once a fluid *el humor*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 440, p. 2187
moon — Latin luna, worn down from an earlier louksna, the shiny one, from the same ancient root as la luz; light is the inherited English cousin, lucid and luminous the borrowed ones, and leukemia the one that came through Greek *la luna*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 362, p. 1555
More of the Kitchen — Pan, Oven, Fork, Garlic, Soup
chapter topic; Chapter 297, p. 1069
"more slowly" — the request that makes the last sentence solvable *más despacio*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 103

more than *más que*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 269, p. 855
most of them, the majority — Latin maior, greater, from magnus; English major, mayor and magnitude are all the same greatness *la mayoría*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 352, p. 1471
much / a lot *mucho*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 41
mucha agua · pocos libros — when the quantity word agrees
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 259, p. 809
Mucha Agua — When the Quantity Word Agrees
chapter topic; Chapter 259, p. 809
museum — Greek mouseion, a seat of the Muses; the Mouseion at Alexandria was a place scholars lived and worked, and the same Muses are inside English music *el museo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 353, p. 1479
music *la música*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 413, p. 1961
Music and Concert
chapter topic; Chapter 413, p. 1961
must — the guess, not the obligation *deber de*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 275, p. 895
Muy — The Same Word, Bitten Short
chapter topic; Chapter 226, p. 735
my name is (literally "I call myself") *me llamo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 4, p. 27
my, your informal, and your formal or his or her — before a singular noun *mi, tu, su*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 49, p. 205

N

ñ — the letter that remembers a doubled n
script and writing topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, script, usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 77
Naming a Date, and the Stretches Around It
chapter topic; Chapter 343, p. 1397
Naming, Properly — Name, Surname, Sir, Madam, Delighted
chapter topic; Chapter 305, p. 1129
Naming the Land — Village, Hill, Valley, Lake, Mountain
chapter topic; Chapter 292, p. 1029
Naming the Whole — Family, Nickname, Relative, Partner, Baby
chapter topic; Chapter 309, p. 1155

nationality — built inside Spanish from nacional plus -idad; its base nación is the borrowing, Latin nātiō, nātiōnem, birth and then a people, which Corominas dates to the fifteenth century *la nacionalidad*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 393, p. 1823
-ncia
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 62, p. 247
-ncia — Turning a Quality into a Thing
chapter topic; Chapter 62, p. 247
Near, Far, and Which Side
chapter topic; Chapter 340, p. 1373
near, nearby — Latin circa, around; English circa, circle, circuit and circus all turn on the same ring *cerca*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 340, p. 1373
necessary — Latin necessarius, from necesse, unavoidable; English necessary is the same Latin word, borrowed rather than inherited *necesario*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 380, p. 1717
neither — the same tan, a different second half, and the word that lets you agree with a no *tampoco*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 220, p. 723
nephew — Latin sobrinus, a cousin on the mother's side, built on soror, sister; English cousin is the prefixed consobrinus *el sobrino*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 375, p. 1677
nervous — Latin nervosus from nervus, a sinew; English nerve, nervous and neuron are the same fibre, and -oso is the -ous you already know *nervioso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 326, p. 1289
Never, Always, All, Nothing
chapter topic; Chapter 316, p. 1211
Never, Barely, Almost, Even
chapter topic; Chapter 328, p. 1305
never, ever — Latin iam magis, already more; the magis half is the same word that became más, and French jamais took the identical road *jamás*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 328, p. 1305
never — Latin numquam, ne plus umquam, "not ever"; English never is ne plus ever, the identical compound built out of Germanic parts *nunca*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 316, p. 1211
new — Latin novus, and English new, which is the cousin rather than the loan *nuevo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 281, p. 941

next, nearest — Latin proximus, nearest, the superlative of prope near; English proximity, approximate, approach and reproach come off it *próximo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 343, p. 1397
Ni — Joining Two Absences
chapter topic; Chapter 234, p. 753
night / evening (la noche — feminine) *la noche*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 15
no doubt — duda is dubitare, and behind that duo, two: to doubt is to be caught between a pair of answers *sin duda*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 298, p. 1077
No Hables — Telling Somebody Not To
chapter topic; Chapter 133, p. 451
no hables — telling somebody not to
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 133, p. 451
no / not *no*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 7, p. 53
nobody — Latin nati, "born ones", from homines nati, "people born"; the exact twin of nada, which was a thing born *nadie*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 317, p. 1219
Noise, Silence, Calm and Hurry
chapter topic; Chapter 333, p. 1345
Noon and Midnight
chapter topic; Chapter 146, p. 499
noon and midnight — both halves still fully alive as ordinary Spanish words, unlike French's worn-down midi/minuit *mediodía, medianoche*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 146, p. 499
nor, not even — the joining word for two things that are both absent, and the one place Spanish stacks negatives on purpose *ni*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 234, p. 753
north — Germanic northa through Old French nord; this is literally the English word north, borrowed back into a Romance language *el norte*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 347, p. 1431
Nos — Us, and the Word Inside -mos
chapter topic; Chapter 88, p. 325
nose — Latin nāris, which meant nostril and usually came in the plural nārēs; English nose is the inherited cousin, nasal the borrowed one, and meter las narices keeps the Latin plural alive *la nariz*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 364, p. 1575
nosotros — the word inside -mos
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 88, p. 325

not at all — the reply to thanks, assembled entirely from words you already have *no hay de qué*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 283, p. 957
nothing — Latin res nata, "a thing born"; the res fell away and the born thing came to mean no thing at all *nada*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 316, p. 1211
now — the time word mañana has been waiting for, and a Latin hour in disguise *ahora*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 252, p. 789
Numbers, and How Old You Are
chapter topic; Chapter 47, p. 189
Numbers Eleven to Twenty
chapter topic; Chapter 149, p. 511

O

O — One Letter, One Catch
chapter topic; Chapter 233, p. 751
of course — supponere, to place under: it was already under the conversation *por supuesto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 284, p. 965
of the, from the — the second and last of Spanish's forced contractions, which means once you have these two you have all of them *del*
explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 231, p. 747
office — Latin officina, a workshop, squeezed out of opificina from opus work and facere to make; English office, officer and opus are the same making *la oficina*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 346, p. 1423
oil — Andalusi Arabic az-zayt, the oil, borrowed with its article fused on; Latin oleum gave English oil, olive, petroleum and linoleum, and the two words meet in aceite de oliva *el aceite*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 361, p. 1545
Ojala — a Prayer That Outlived Its Religion
chapter topic; Chapter 129, p. 441
ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 129, p. 441
old — from vetulus, "little old one", the affectionate form rather than the plain one *viejo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 281, p. 941
on one hand... on the other — holding two sources at once *por un lado… por otro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 277, p. 909

One heard greeting — write what you know
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
one's own — Latin proprius, belonging to the individual; English proper, property and appropriate all began as words about owning *propio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 350, p. 1455
One Stem, Two Tenses
chapter topic; Chapter 124, p. 425
Opening, Closing, Sitting Down, Standing Up
chapter topic; Chapter 166, p. 577
opposite, across from, facing — Latin frontem, the forehead; English front, frontier, affront, confront and effrontery all come off the same brow *enfrente*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 340, p. 1373
or — one letter, and one rule about what happens when the next word starts with the same sound *o*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 233, p. 751
orange — Arabic naranj from Persian narang, traceable back to Sanskrit; Spanish kept the n that English lost when a norange was reheard as an orange *la naranja*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 367, p. 1605
Os — You All, in Spain
chapter topic; Chapter 90, p. 331
-oso
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 61, p. 243
-oso — a Shelf of Words You Were Never Taught
chapter topic; Chapter 61, p. 243
our — matching a known masculine or feminine singular noun *nuestro, nuestra*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 69, p. 269
Out and Away — Street, Corner, Footprint, Harbour, Lighthouse
chapter topic; Chapter 302, p. 1109
out of the question — "not even to speak of it", two pieces you already own, and the flattest refusal on the dial *ni hablar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 298, p. 1077
outside *fuera*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 407, p. 1931
Overhead — Daybreak, Sky, Cloud, Star, Shade
chapter topic; Chapter 289, p. 1005

P

package, parcel *el paquete*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 415, p. 1969

paella — the Valencian rice dish named from the pan *la paella*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 403, p. 1909
pale — Latin pallidus; English pale came through French and pallid straight from the Latin, so they are the same word twice, and fallow is the inherited cousin *pálido*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 372, p. 1653
Para — For, Pointing Forward
chapter topic; Chapter 176, p. 631
Para Mí — The Pronouns That Stand on Their Own
chapter topic; Chapter 246, p. 777
para mí — the pronouns that stand on their own
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 246, p. 777
parentheses — Greek for a putting-in-beside, which is exactly what the mark does to a sentence *los paréntesis*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 424, p. 2023
Parents and Siblings
chapter topic; Chapter 140, p. 475
park — Frankish parrik, an enclosure, through Medieval Latin parricus; a park was a fence before it was grass, and the English dialect word paddock is the same fence *el parque*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 354, p. 1487
parking, car park — aparcar plus -miento; aparcar is built in Spanish from parque, not borrowed from English park *el aparcamiento*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 400, p. 1887
pass, season ticket, subscription — the document or right acquired by someone who subscribes; do not confuse it with the separate abono meaning fertilizer *el abono*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 400, p. 1887
passenger, and passing or fleeting — pasaje plus -ero, on pasar from Vulgar Latin passāre, from passus, a step; an adjective first, and without the intruding n of English passenger *el pasajero*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 392, p. 1813
patience — Latin pati, to undergo; the same root gives English patient, passion and compassion *la paciencia*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 321, p. 1249
pencil — Latin lapis, a stone, with no diminutive in it; lapis opens lapis lazuli, and Spanish azul comes from the other half *el lápiz*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 374, p. 1669
Pensar — Thinking Is Weighing
chapter topic; Chapter 153, p. 531

people — Latin gens, the clan; the root of English gentle, genteel, Gentile and general *la gente*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 308, p. 1147
People Named By What They Do
chapter topic; Chapter 427, p. 2061
pepper — from pimienta, Latin pigmenta, which passed from colouring matter through drug and ingredient to condiment; the American pepper took the Old World name *el pimiento*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 376, p. 1685
perhaps, by chance — a + caso, and Latin casus was a fall; English case, casual, casualty, cadence and accident are all falls too *acaso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 324, p. 1273
permission, leave — Latin permissus from permittere, per + mittere, to let go through; English permit, mission, transmit, submit and promise are all sendings *el permiso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 332, p. 1337
Permission, Notice, and the Word
chapter topic; Chapter 332, p. 1337
Pero — Two True Things at Once
chapter topic; Chapter 218, p. 719
pharmacy, chemist's — Greek pharmakon, a drug that could cure or kill; the Greek word never chose between the remedy and the poison, and English pharmacy keeps it whole *la farmacia*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 353, p. 1479
photo — the everyday shortening of fotografía, still feminine *la foto*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 405, p. 1919
photograph or photography — literally light-writing through Greek roots *la fotografía*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 405, p. 1919
Photography, Photos and Permission
chapter topic; Chapter 405, p. 1919
phrase, sentence — Greek phrasis, a way of speaking, through Latin; English phrase and paraphrase are the same word *la frase*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 377, p. 1693
piece of information; datum *el dato*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 406, p. 1923
pig — most likely from cerda, a bristle, so the bristly one; Spanish also kept puerco from Latin porcus, which English has as pork and as the older farrow *el cerdo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 368, p. 1615

pill or tablet *la pastilla*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 408, p. 1937
pillow — Andalusi Arabic al-mukhadda, the cheek-instrument, with the Arabic article fused on; this word has no English relative at all *la almohada*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 366, p. 1595
pink, and the rose — Latin rosa, itself a loanword from the east; rosemary is not rose and Mary but ros marinus, sea dew *rosa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 372, p. 1653
Pinning Down Which One
chapter topic; Chapter 345, p. 1413
please (literally "for [a] favour") *por favor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 99
pleased to meet you (literally "much pleasure") *mucho gusto*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 6, p. 41
pleasure — Latin placere, to please; English please, placid, plea and placebo are all the same verb *el placer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 321, p. 1249
Pleasure, Reason, Respect
chapter topic; Chapter 321, p. 1249
Poner — Putting, and the Root Under Position
chapter topic; Chapter 71, p. 283
Por — And Three Phrases You Already Owned
chapter topic; Chapter 177, p. 633
potato — read as a crossing of Taíno batata, the sweet potato, with Quechua papa, this one; English potato is the Spanish word, and it named the sweet one first *la patata*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 367, p. 1605
Preguntar — Asking, and Sounding a Depth
chapter topic; Chapter 160, p. 553
preguntó dónde
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 215, p. 713
Preguntó Dónde — What the Accent Was Always For
chapter topic; Chapter 215, p. 713
preguntó si
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 214, p. 711
Preguntó Si — A Question That Stops Being One
chapter topic; Chapter 214, p. 711
pretty — bueno with a real diminutive on it, "nice and good"; and Latin bellus, which gave bello and English beautiful, had already been made the same way out of the same bonus *bonito*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 399, p. 1883

previous, prior — the adjective that completes the phrase every advert uses *previo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 435, p. 2139
Primero, Segundo, Tercero — Counting in Order
chapter topic; Chapter 262, p. 815
printed form — a sheet with spaces to fill in *el impreso*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 406, p. 1923
problem *problema*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 268, p. 845
Profesor — and the Article Spanish Leaves Out
chapter topic; Chapter 51, p. 219
pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 128, p. 437
Push, Throw, Rub Out, Shout
chapter topic; Chapter 388, p. 1779
putting *no* in front of the verb — the whole of Spanish negation *no + verb*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 267, p. 839
Putting the -ar Verbs to Work
chapter topic; Chapter 33, p. 151

Q

¡Qué Grande! — The Same Word, Exclaiming
chapter topic; Chapter 248, p. 781
¡Qué grande! — the same word, exclaiming
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 248, p. 781
queremos, quieren — work them out first
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 76, p. 295
Quién — The Asking Word for People
chapter topic; Chapter 232, p. 749
quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 128, p. 437
quotation marks — Spanish has three shapes in a stated order of preference, and the one it prefers is the one an English reader has never used *las comillas*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 424, p. 2023

R

rain refuses the hacer pattern and brings its own verb — and its ll- is the sound change you already met in llamar *llueve*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 148, p. 507

Reading Between the Lines — Imply, Invert, Look It Up, Re-tune
chapter topic; Chapter 272, p. 871
Reading Older Spanish — Register, Date, and Form
chapter topic; Chapter 276, p. 903
reason — Latin ratio, rationem, a reckoning; English ratio, ration and rational are the same word arriving whole *la razón*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 321, p. 1249
reception, the reception desk *la recepción*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 414, p. 1965
red — a cousin of French rouge and English red, but by a different branch of the same very old family *rojo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 139, p. 469
respect — Latin respicere, to look back at somebody; the same specere gives English spectacle, inspect and suspect *el respeto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 321, p. 1249
responsibility — being answerable, from the same promise that makes a spouse *la responsabilidad*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 445, p. 2241
restaurant — French restaurant, a thing that restores, from Latin restaurare; the first restaurant was a broth sold to people who felt weak, and the room took the name of the soup *el restaurante*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 354, p. 1487
retired — a participle used as a noun, the same move that made el pedido, and a surprisingly cheerful root *jubilado*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 435, p. 2139
Review — A Tense You Build
chapter topic; Chapter 120, p. 413
Review — All Eight
chapter topic; Chapter 91, p. 333
Review — All Four Stem Changes
chapter topic; Chapter 172, p. 611
Review — All Four Words for The
chapter topic; Chapter 81, p. 307
Review — Five Sets, Finished
chapter topic; Chapter 256, p. 801
Review — Four Boxes
chapter topic; Chapter 135, p. 455
Review — Four Last Pieces, and the Thread
chapter topic; Chapter 266, p. 831
Review — Four Pronouns, One Slot
chapter topic; Chapter 86, p. 321
Review — Four Rules You Already Obeyed
chapter topic; Chapter 261, p. 813

Review — Four Small Things
chapter topic; Chapter 250, p. 785
Review — Four Small Words, One Instinct
chapter topic; Chapter 235, p. 755
Review — Four Things Worth Saying Twice
chapter topic; Chapter 318, p. 1227
Review — Four Verbs of the Mind
chapter topic; Chapter 157, p. 547
Review — One Arrow
chapter topic; Chapter 179, p. 637
Review — One Question, Three Answers
chapter topic; Chapter 114, p. 401
Review — One Scale, One Habit
chapter topic; Chapter 229, p. 743
Review — Second Looks
chapter topic; Chapter 319, p. 1233
Review — Six Verbs, One Ending
chapter topic; Chapter 74, p. 289
Review — Six Words That Arrived Last
chapter topic; Chapter 335, p. 1363
Review — the Eight Endings
chapter topic; Chapter 64, p. 253
Review — The Pairs
chapter topic; Chapter 101, p. 353
Review — the Present Tense, Whole
chapter topic; Chapter 46, p. 187
Review — The Same Six, In Use
chapter topic; Chapter 336, p. 1365
Review — The Three Forms Side by Side
chapter topic; Chapter 19, p. 115
Review — The Three Se's
chapter topic; Chapter 184, p. 649
Review — the Two Conditions
chapter topic; Chapter 209, p. 699
Review — the Whole Present Tense
chapter topic; Chapter 41, p. 175
Review — the Whole Preterite
chapter topic; Chapter 204, p. 689
Review — Three Endings
chapter topic; Chapter 26, p. 133
Review — Three Jobs, No New Words
chapter topic; Chapter 189, p. 659
Review — Three Joints, Two Constants
chapter topic; Chapter 216, p. 715

Review — Three Letters
chapter topic; Chapter 194, p. 669
Review — Three Places, One Question
chapter topic; Chapter 225, p. 733
Review — Three Verbs That Behave
chapter topic; Chapter 162, p. 561
Review — Two Endings and One Little A
chapter topic; Chapter 240, p. 765
Review — Two Systems, Two New Words
chapter topic; Chapter 96, p. 343
Review — Two Tenses Finished
chapter topic; Chapter 245, p. 775
right away — en seguida, "in what follows," from Latin sequi, to follow; English sequence, sequel and pursue come off the same verb *enseguida*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 322, p. 1257
river — Latin rivus, a stream, which gave rival and derive; English river is not this word at all but comes from ripa, a bank, the same word behind arrive *el río*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 369, p. 1625
roof, ceiling — Latin tectum, the covered part, from tegere to cover; to protect is to cover in front, to detect is to take the cover off, and a Roman toga was a covering *el techo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 355, p. 1495
room *habitación*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 268, p. 845
rotating, on a rota — the third word in the track built on a wheel *rotativo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 453, p. 2329
rug, carpet — Andalusi Arabic al-ḥánbal, a kind of tapestry; the al- is the Arabic article, and a once-popular red-carpet story turned out to be a different word *la alfombra*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 373, p. 1661

S

sad — Latin tristis, which also meant harsh and grim before it softened *triste*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 304, p. 1123
Salir — Leaving
chapter topic; Chapter 72, p. 285

salt — Latin sal, salis; salad, salsa, sauce, sausage and salary are the real family, while salud, saludo and salvo belong together to a whole-and-safe root, and salir to a leaping one *la sal*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 361, p. 1545
same, very, self — Vulgar Latin metipsimus, a piled-up superlative of ipse self; English ipso facto and solipsism keep the ipse *mismo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 345, p. 1413
sand — Latin harena, whose origin nobody has settled; English arena is the same word, the sand spread on an amphitheatre floor to soak up what was spilled on it *la arena*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 369, p. 1625
Saying No, and Asking
chapter topic; Chapter 267, p. 839
Saying Why
chapter topic; Chapter 175, p. 623
Saying Your Name
chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 27
scarce, in short supply — Vulgar Latin excarpsus, picked over, from ex and carpere to pluck; English scarce, excerpt and carpet are the same plucking *escaso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 352, p. 1471
school — Latin schola from Greek skholē, spare time; English school, scholar and scholastic keep the leisure that turned into study *la escuela*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 346, p. 1423
Se Compran Libros — The Verb Tells On Itself
chapter topic; Chapter 182, p. 645
se compran libros — the verb tells on itself
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 182, p. 645
Se Habla Espanol — Nobody in Particular
chapter topic; Chapter 181, p. 643
se habla español — nobody in particular
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 181, p. 643
Se Lo — The Pair That Does Not Exist
chapter topic; Chapter 99, p. 349
se lo — the pair that does not exist
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 99, p. 349
sea — Latin mare; marine, maritime, marina and ultramarine are borrowed from it, while the mer- of mermaid and the words marsh and moor are inherited English cousins of the same ancient root *el mar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 362, p. 1555

see you later (literally "until later") *hasta luego*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 91
see you soon (literally "until soon") *hasta pronto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 91
see you tomorrow (literally "until tomorrow") *hasta mañana*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 91
Selling, Serving, Spending, Growing
chapter topic; Chapter 386, p. 1763
Ser and Estar — Two Ways to Be
chapter topic; Chapter 48, p. 197
Ser in the Plural
chapter topic; Chapter 50, p. 213
serious, earnest — Latin serius, weighty; the metaphor of heaviness for gravity of manner is so old that Latin had already forgotten it was a metaphor *serio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 423, p. 2009
Setting Off — The Way Out, the Journey, the Return, the Arrival, the Farewell
chapter topic; Chapter 288, p. 997
several — Latin varius, speckled, of mixed colours; English various, variety and variegated all start from a spotted hide *varios*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 351, p. 1463
shape — Latin forma, which came into Spanish twice; the borrowed half is la forma, and the inherited half is hermoso, beautiful, from formosus, well shaped *la forma*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 358, p. 1519
ship — Late Latin barca, a small boat attested around 400 AD; barge, bark the sailing ship, embark and disembark are the same word, and the three English barks have three separate origins *el barco*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 363, p. 1565
shirt — Late Latin camisia, a garment worn close to the body *la camisa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 402, p. 1903
shoe — origin genuinely unknown; Portuguese sapato, Catalan sabata, French savate, Italian ciabatta and Arabic sabbat all share it, and the famous sabotage story attached to it is false *el zapato*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 360, p. 1535

short — Latin curtus, cut off or docked; curt and curtail descend from it and cortar is its Spanish verb, while English short, shirt and skirt are Germanic and meet it only far back *corto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 365, p. 1585
should, ought to — and to owe, because the word is literally "to have something from someone" *deber*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 175, p. 623
shy, timid — Latin timidus from timere "to fear"; the same verb is inside intimidate, which is the act of putting that fear into someone *tímido*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 423, p. 2009
si
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 196, p. 673
si + futuro
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 197, p. 675
Si + Futuro — What Will Happen If
chapter topic; Chapter 197, p. 675
Si — If, and the Word Yes Is Made Of
chapter topic; Chapter 196, p. 673
si tuviera
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 208, p. 697
Si Tuviera — Supposing What Is Not So
chapter topic; Chapter 208, p. 697
side *el lado*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 407, p. 1931
Sign Up at Reception
chapter topic; Chapter 414, p. 1965
simple, plain — few parts rather than little effort, which is what separates it from fácil *sencillo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 471, p. 2497
sir, Mr — Latin senior, older; respect built out of age *señor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 305, p. 1129
size, especially clothing size — from tallar, to cut or shape *la talla*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 402, p. 1903
size — Latin tam magnum, so big, welded shut; the tam is the tan inside tambien and tampoco, and magnus is the magn- of magnify and magnitude *el tamaño*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 358, p. 1519
skirt — a Germanic word for a fold, so a skirt is the folded thing; English fold is the inherited cousin, and falso is a look-alike from a different family *la falda*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 373, p. 1661

slow — Latin lentus, pliant then slow; taken off the page rather than inherited, and the inherited form came out as liento, damp. English relent is the same word *lento*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 371, p. 1645
Small, Fat, Young, Slow, Sweet
chapter topic; Chapter 371, p. 1645
small — no Latin ancestor anybody can name; the dictionary of record calls it an expressive word shared across the Romance languages, and piccolo and petit are the same kind of word *pequeño*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 371, p. 1645
smaller, younger — Latin minor, the partner of minus; Latin built minister out of minus to stand opposite magister, so mayor and menor give you master and minister as a matched pair *menor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 397, p. 1863
smoke — Latin fumus, a clean example of Latin f- turning into Spanish h-; English has fume, perfume and fumigate from the same word *el humo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 369, p. 1625
smooth, soft — Latin suavis; English sweet is the inherited cousin of the same root, and to persuade is to make a thing sweet to somebody *suave*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 372, p. 1653
snow — Latin nivem, and the s- that Latin dropped and English kept *la nieve*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 278, p. 917
so-so / not great (also "más o menos") *regular*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 67
soap — Latin sapo, which Latin had itself borrowed from its northern neighbours *el jabón*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 287, p. 989
sociable, outgoing — Latin socius, a companion or ally, plus -able; the same socius is inside society, associate and the word soccer *sociable*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 423, p. 2009
sois — the last of the six
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 50, p. 213
somebody else's — Latin alienus from alius, other; English alien, alias and alibi all point at somebody who is not you *ajeno*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 350, p. 1455
somebody — Latin aliquem, ali- plus quem, "some other whom"; algo's exact partner, built for people *alguien*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 317, p. 1219

something — Latin aliquod, ali- plus quod, "some other what"; the same ali- is in alias, alien and altruism *algo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 317, p. 1219
Something, Somebody, Nobody
chapter topic; Chapter 317, p. 1219
somos — "we are"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 50, p. 213
son — "they are"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 50, p. 213
sorrow, a shame — Latin poena, a penalty; English pain, penalty and subpoena all come off it *la pena*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 320, p. 1241
south — Germanic sunthaz through Old French sud; the same word as English south, and probably built on the word for sun *el sur*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 347, p. 1431
"Spanish" — the language, the people, and the Roman name for the peninsula underneath it *español*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 22, p. 123
sport *el deporte*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 412, p. 1957
stairs, ladder — Latin scālāria from scāla, a ladder; scale, ascend, descend and echelon are cousins, while escalate arrived by way of a 1900 trademark *la escalera*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 366, p. 1595
station — Latin statio from stare, to stand; a station is a standing-place, and English station, stationary, statue and stable stand on the same verb *la estación*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 346, p. 1423
Stay in May
chapter topic; Chapter 416, p. 1973
still, yet — literally toda vía, "all the road"; the via in it is English via, viaduct, deviate and obvious *todavía*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 322, p. 1257
storm — Latin tormenta, from torquere, to twist; torment, torture, torque and contort are the same Latin verb, and a storm is weather that wrings the sky *la tormenta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 370, p. 1635
Storm, Thunder And Ice
chapter topic; Chapter 370, p. 1635
story, history — Greek historia, knowledge got by inquiry; English history and story are the same word, story having come through Anglo-French *la historia*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 377, p. 1693

straight — Latin rectus; in directions, continue straight, not resto, the rest or remainder *recto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 401, p. 1895
strong, loud — Latin fortis, the same root already spent on la fuerza; English fort, force, effort, comfort and fortify all come off it *fuerte*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 327, p. 1297
student — a word you can build yourself, out of a verb you already have *estudiante*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 52, p. 221
such, such a — Latin talis, of that kind; English keeps it in retaliate, to give back the like, and in the lawyers' lex talionis *tal*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 329, p. 1313
Such, Which, Then, But Rather
chapter topic; Chapter 329, p. 1313
suddenly — Latin repente, from repens sudden, which is the present participle of repere to creep; the English reptile is the same creeping *de repente*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 356, p. 1503
sugar — Arabic as-sukkar back through Persian to Sanskrit śarkarā, grit; the a- on the front is the Arabic article, and English sugar came the same road through French *el azúcar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 367, p. 1605
summit — Latin culmen, which meant the ridge of a roof before it meant a mountaintop; culmen is a squeezed-down columen, with columna a cousin rather than a twin *la cumbre*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 378, p. 1701
supermarket — a calque of English supermarket, American and dated 1933, built on mercado, which Spanish inherited from Latin mercātus, from mercārī, to trade, from merx, wares *el supermercado*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 391, p. 1803
sure — se- without plus cura, care: free from care, and so reliable *seguro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 284, p. 965
sweet — Latin dulcis; the older Spanish form was duz, and the resemblance to Greek glykys, behind glucose, is a genuine unsolved puzzle *dulce*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 371, p. 1645
swimming as a discipline — the Latin twin of nadar, borrowed back whole *la natación*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 438, p. 2167

swimming pool — Latin piscīna, from piscis, fish, plus -īna; a word taken from writing, standing beside the inherited pez from the same root *la piscina*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 390, p. 1793
symbols — currency, the compass and the units, none of which take a point, because a symbol is not an abbreviation *los símbolos*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 426, p. 2049
Synthesis — A Small Story
chapter topic; Chapter 115, p. 403
Synthesis — Asking, and Answering
chapter topic; Chapter 37, p. 167
Synthesis — Asking Without Sounding Rude
chapter topic; Chapter 136, p. 457
Synthesis — Carrying a Conversation
chapter topic; Chapter 217, p. 717
Synthesis — Claiming, and Not Claiming
chapter topic; Chapter 130, p. 445
Synthesis — Describing Things
chapter topic; Chapter 60, p. 241
Synthesis — Describing Where You Are
chapter topic; Chapter 195, p. 671
Synthesis — More Than One
chapter topic; Chapter 82, p. 311
Synthesis — Promising, and Supposing
chapter topic; Chapter 125, p. 429
Synthesis — Reading a Paragraph
chapter topic; Chapter 65, p. 255
Synthesis — Reading the Window
chapter topic; Chapter 185, p. 651
Synthesis — Reading What You Were Never Taught
chapter topic; Chapter 27, p. 135
Synthesis — Real Conditions
chapter topic; Chapter 198, p. 677
Synthesis — Saying It Once
chapter topic; Chapter 87, p. 323
Synthesis — Saying Something About Your Own Life
chapter topic; Chapter 152, p. 525
Synthesis — Saying What People Do
chapter topic; Chapter 54, p. 225
Synthesis — Sentences Worth Saying
chapter topic; Chapter 190, p. 661
Synthesis — Supposing Out Loud
chapter topic; Chapter 210, p. 701
Synthesis — Telling What Happened
chapter topic; Chapter 205, p. 691

Synthesis — The Choices English Never Makes You Make
chapter topic; Chapter 173, p. 613
Synthesis — The Conversation Without Them
chapter topic; Chapter 92, p. 335
Synthesis — The Decoder
chapter topic; Chapter 31, p. 147
Synthesis — The Gift and the Motive
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Synthesis — The Same Conversation, Twice
chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 149
Synthesis — the Same Sentence, Two Continents
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Synthesis — The Thing and the Person
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Synthesis — Three Exceptions, and No Others
chapter topic; Chapter 110, p. 389
Synthesis — Two at a Time
chapter topic; Chapter 102, p. 355
Synthesis — Two Shores, Two Answers
chapter topic; Chapter 121, p. 415
Synthesis — What You Like, and Who Does the Liking
chapter topic; Chapter 164, p. 567
Synthesis — What You Understand, and What You Don't
chapter topic; Chapter 158, p. 549
Synthesis — You, and Somebody Else
chapter topic; Chapter 75, p. 293
Synthesis — You Can Hear Which Past It Is
chapter topic; Chapter 106, p. 375

T

T-shirt — camisa plus the diminutive suffix -eta *la camiseta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 402, p. 1903
Talking About Ideas — Hedging From Doubt, and From Inference
chapter topic; Chapter 271, p. 867
Talking to a Friend
chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 111
También — Your First Word, Hidden Inside
chapter topic; Chapter 219, p. 721
Tampoco — The Same Frame, the Other Half
chapter topic; Chapter 220, p. 723
te — the pair English used to have
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 85, p. 317

teacher — and the one place Spanish drops the "a" that English insists on *profesor*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 51, p. 219
Telling Time
chapter topic; Chapter 147, p. 503
Telling What Happened
chapter topic; Chapter 167, p. 587
tenemos — and the stem change disappears
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 67, p. 261
Tener in the Plural, and the Stem-Change Rule
chapter topic; Chapter 67, p. 261
Tenia and Tuve — When the Tense Changes the Meaning
chapter topic; Chapter 113, p. 399
tenía and tuve — when the tense changes the meaning
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 113, p. 399
terrace, café tables outside — Latin terra, earth, through a Vulgar Latin terrācea meaning earthen; English terrace is the same word, though how it entered Spanish is unsettled *la terraza*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 390, p. 1793
thank you *gracias*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 53
Thank You, Yes, and No
chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 53
that is to say — the same idea in your own words *es decir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 277, p. 909
that one, by you — the slot Latin's iste left empty when Spanish moved it, filled by a word that used to mean self *ese*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 222, p. 727
that one over there, away from us both — and the second life of the word that became el in your very first chapter *aquel*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 223, p. 729
the accident — something that falls upon you, where an *ocasión* falls to you *el accidente*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 454, p. 2339
The Actor and the Actress
chapter topic; Chapter 421, p. 1995
the administration — built on the word for the LESSER one, which is what a servant was *la administración*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 442, p. 2207
the age, the era, the season — Greek epokhe, a stopping point, from epekhein to hold back; English epoch is the same word *la época*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 343, p. 1397

the agency — a place that acts for you, and the *agenda* is its cousin *la agencia*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 456, p. 2361
the alphabet — twenty-seven letters, and a name built out of the first four of them *el abecedario*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 425, p. 2037
the amount — the third sense of importar, and the one a bill uses *el importe*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 474, p. 2527
the animal — Latin for a thing with breath in it, and the superordinate word the corpus never had although it taught a dozen creatures *el animal*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 428, p. 2073
the ankle — from Latin tuber, a swelling; a tuber in the ground and a protuberance are the same lump *el tobillo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 293, p. 1037
the anniversary — Latin annus, year, plus vertere, to turn; the year turning back to the same day, and English annual, versus and reverse share the pieces *el aniversario*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 349, p. 1447
the apology — dis- undoing culpa, blame, from Latin culpa; English culpable, culprit, exculpate and mea culpa keep the blame in place *la disculpa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 332, p. 1337
the arm — Greek brakhion, "the shorter one", taken into Latin as bracchium; an embrace and a bracelet are both built on it *el brazo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 314, p. 1195
the arrival — from llegar, Latin plicare, to fold: a ship folded its sails and had arrived *la llegada*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 288, p. 997
the at sign — an Arabic unit of weight that became a merchant's shorthand and then an e-mail address, which is why Spanish has a real word where English says at *la arroba*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 428, p. 2073
the aunt — the same Greek root feminine; English aunt comes from a wholly different Latin word, amita *la tía*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 307, p. 1141
the baby — French bebe, echoic babble, the same kind of word as English baby and babble *el bebé*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 309, p. 1155

the back — Latin spatula, a broad blade; the same blade is a spatula, a spade and an epaulette *la espalda*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 293, p. 1037
the bag — Latin bursa from Greek byrsa, a hide; English purse, bursar and reimburse are all the same leather *la bolsa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 311, p. 1171
the basket — Latin cista from Greek kiste, a box; English chest and cistern are the same container by two different doors *la cesta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 301, p. 1101
the bathroom — Latin balneum from Greek balaneion; English bath only looks related, and is not *el baño*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 310, p. 1163
the battery — a word that looks built and is not, at least not in this language *la batería*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 434, p. 2131
the bedroom — built on a verb you learned in the first weeks *el dormitorio*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 455, p. 2349
the beginner — el principio plus the -ante ending el estudiante already taught you to build with *el principiante*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 471, p. 2497
the beginning — Latin principium from princeps, the one who takes first place; English prince, principal and principle are the same first taking *el principio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 348, p. 1439
the bill — Latin computare, to reckon together; English compute, count and account are the same word at three distances *la cuenta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 311, p. 1171
the birthday — the same day as an aniversario, named by the opposite metaphor *el cumpleaños*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 440, p. 2187
the blanket — Latin mantum, a cloak; the mantle, the mantelpiece and the manta ray are all cloaks *la manta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 294, p. 1045
the blood — Latin sanguinem; sanguine once meant ruddy and cheerful because of it, and consanguinity is shared blood *la sangre*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 300, p. 1093
the blow — and de golpe, all at once, which is the phrase a payment plan is defined against *el golpe*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 474, p. 2527
The Body, Further Down — Arm, Leg, Foot, Tooth, Ear
chapter topic; Chapter 314, p. 1195

the boss — a head, and the same head as *la cabeza* *el jefe*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 462, p. 2411
the bottom, the back of a room — Latin fundus, the bottom of a thing; English found, foundation, fund and profound all sit on it, and Spanish hondo is the same word with f turned to h *el fondo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 355, p. 1495
the boy, the child — a nursery word with no Latin pedigree, and the one English borrowed whole as El Niño *el niño*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 308, p. 1147
the boy, the lad — Latin ciccum, a worthless trifle; a word that means small first and boy second *el chico*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 308, p. 1147
the brake — named after the bit in a horse's mouth, and still doing that job *el freno*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 449, p. 2285
the branch — Latin ramus; when an argument ramifies, it is growing these *la rama*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 291, p. 1021
the bridge — Latin pontem; a pontoon floats one and a pontiff is, underneath, a bridge-builder *el puente*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 295, p. 1053
the broom — Latin scopa, a bundle of twigs, wearing the Spanish e- step for the third time *la escoba*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 294, p. 1045
the buyer — the other half of a sale, built from comprar with the same ending, so the pair costs one rule rather than two words *el comprador*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 427, p. 2061
the calendar — Latin calendarium, an account book, from calendae the first of the month when debts fell due; English calendar and intercalate share it *el calendario*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 343, p. 1397
the call — the word el pedido's table already showed you, handed over now with the part that table left out: the gender is not predictable *la llamada*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 469, p. 2477
the calm — Late Latin cauma from Greek kauma, burning heat; the windless noon at sea gave sailors a word for stillness *la calma*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 333, p. 1345
the card, the licence — four folded sheets that turned into a piece of plastic *el carné*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 451, p. 2307

the century, the age — Latin saeculum, a generation or a lifetime; English secular is the same word, meaning of this age rather than of eternity *el siglo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 343, p. 1397
the change — Latin cambiare, borrowed from Gaulish; English change and exchange are the same word, and so is the coin you get back *el cambio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 313, p. 1187
the charge on a bill — a load, from the same cart as *el carrito* *el cargo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 456, p. 2361
the charger — the doer-ending a fourth time, on a verb worth having in its own right *el cargador*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 434, p. 2131
the chest — Latin pectus, whose ct became ch on the same road that took noctem to noche; English keeps the Latin in pectoral *el pecho*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 315, p. 1203
the choice English lost — and the surprise that usted takes he/she verb forms *tú o usted*
explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 5, p. 33
the city — Latin civitatem from civis, a citizen; English city, civic, civil, civilian and citizen are the same word *la ciudad*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 325, p. 1281
the clock — Greek horologium, the hour-teller; the same hora sits in English hour and horoscope *el reloj*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 312, p. 1179
The Clock, Taken Apart
chapter topic; Chapter 342, p. 1389
the cloud — Latin nubes, and the ancestor of nuance, which began as a shade of cloud *la nube*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 289, p. 1005
the coat — named for the shelter it gives rather than the shape it has, and the verb behind it once meant to sit in the sun *el abrigo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 468, p. 2467
the coin — Latin moneta, a title of the goddess Juno in whose temple Rome struck its coins; English money and mint are both her *la moneda*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 313, p. 1187
the colleague — the word whose story you were told when you learned bread, finally given to you as a word *el compañero*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 436, p. 2149

the colon — plural in Spanish because there are two of them, and the mark that opens a Spanish letter where English uses a comma *los dos puntos*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 424, p. 2023
the comma — and the list rule where Spanish and English disagree, because Spanish puts no comma in front of the final y *la coma*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 424, p. 2023
the company — literally a thing taken on, from the same root as English enterprise, which Spanish uses for the firm itself rather than only for the venture *la empresa*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 427, p. 2061
the concierge — the person who belongs to the portal, and a job with no close English equivalent *la portera*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 433, p. 2123
The Conditional — Saying What Would Happen
chapter topic; Chapter 123, p. 421
the contract — two parties drawn together, and the verb that still does the drawing *el contrato*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 441, p. 2197
the cook — coquere, to cook; the kitchen, the biscuit and a precocious child are all in it *el cocinero*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 285, p. 973
the corner — from a Germanic word for a shinbone; English shin is the same bone, and a corner is an edge as sharp as one *la esquina*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 302, p. 1109
the cost — the noun that belongs to *costar*, and what it stands on *el coste*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 456, p. 2361
the country — Late Latin pagensis, of the country district, from pagus a village; English pagan and peasant are both country-dwellers *el país*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 325, p. 1281
the couple, the partner — Latin par, equal; English pair, par, peer, parity and umpire *la pareja*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 309, p. 1155
the courtyard — a word Spanish gave the world, and cannot account for itself *el patio*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 450, p. 2295
the cousin, feminine — the primus root you can already see in prima donna and prima facie *la prima*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 307, p. 1141

the cousin — Latin primus, first; the same root as primero, and as English prime and primary *el primo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 307, p. 1141
the cow — Latin vacca, unchanged in six letters; vaccine is named after her, because the first one came from a cow *la vaca*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 296, p. 1061
the cup — Arabic tassa, from Persian; French tasse and the English demitasse are the same vessel *la taza*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 294, p. 1045
the currency — the Academy derives it as a clipping of europeo, and files the Greek wind eurus as a separate, unrelated entry under the same spelling *el euro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 391, p. 1803
the CV — a Latin word that kept its Latin ending, and the first thing a job advert asks you to send *el currículum*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 435, p. 2139
the dash that marks a turn of speech — the mark this book has used in every printed dialogue without ever naming it *la raya*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 424, p. 2023
the date — Latin facta, done or made, from facere; English fact, feat, factory, affect and perfect all come off the same making *la fecha*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 343, p. 1397
the daughter — the same filius root, swung to -a; English filial covers both *la hija*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 306, p. 1135
the day's stretch, a working day — Latin diurnus, of the day, through Occitan; English journey, journal and adjourn are the same day *la jornada*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 349, p. 1447
the daybreak — Latin mane, in the morning, the same piece that sits inside mañana *el amanecer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 289, p. 1005
The Days A Calendar Circles
chapter topic; Chapter 357, p. 1511
the deadline, the instalment — a term that was agreed, from the same root as *el placer* *el plazo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 458, p. 2379
the decade — Greek deka, ten, through Latin decas; English decade, decimal, December and dean all count in tens *la década*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 349, p. 1447

the degree — the unit la temperatura was missing, and the word the degree scale was named after without ever being shown to you *el grado*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 468, p. 2467
the delay — Latin mora, a lingering, through demorari; English demur and moratorium are the same hanging back *la demora*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 348, p. 1439
the delay — the word a station announcement, a courier and an apology all reach for *el retraso*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 431, p. 2105
the dentist — an -ista noun, where only the article changes *el dentista / la dentista*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 464, p. 2427
the diary, the schedule — Latin agenda, the things that must be done, from agere to drive; English agent, agile and act come off the same verb *la agenda*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 349, p. 1447
the donkey — Latin burricus, a little reddish horse, from burrus, red; English borrowed the whole word back, and the burrito with it *el burro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 296, p. 1061
the double negative — where Spanish stacks what English forbids *no … nada*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 267, p. 839
the dozen — Latin duodecim, two-ten, from duo and decem; English dozen and duodecimal are the same twelve *la docena*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 344, p. 1405
the drill — the loudest thing a neighbour owns, and a word worth knowing before they use it *el taladro*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 449, p. 2285
the duty rota — the chemist that is open tonight, and a Germanic word for watching *la guardia*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 457, p. 2371
the emphatic yes — contradicting something unsaid *sí que*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 275, p. 895
the end — Latin finis, a boundary stone between fields; English final, finish, finite, define and confine all mark the same edge *el fin*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 348, p. 1439
the entrance, and the admission ticket — Latin intrare from intra, within; English enter, entrance and interior are all inside it *la entrada*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 313, p. 1187

the entrance hall — the door made big, and the part of a Spanish building that has no tidy English name *el portal*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 433, p. 2123
the eve, the day before — Latin vespera, evening; English vespers is the evening prayer, Greek hesperos is the evening star, and English west is a cousin of both *la víspera*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 357, p. 1511
the eye — Latin oculus; English eye is its distant cousin, not a translation of it *el ojo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 286, p. 981
the facility, the installation — a noun that means both the act and the thing *la instalación*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 453, p. 2329
the family — Latin familia, the whole household including its servants; English family and familiar *la familia*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 309, p. 1155
the farewell — from despedir, Latin expetere, to ask out: a leave-taking was a request *la despedida*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 288, p. 997
the farm — from granum, the grain: a farm is named after the one thing it was built to store *la granja*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 299, p. 1085
the fear — Latin metus, with the e broken to ie; meticulous once meant full of fear *el miedo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 315, p. 1203
the fever — Latin febris, which English borrowed early as fever and late as febrile *la fiebre*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 286, p. 981
The Field and the Farm — Field, Farm, Livestock, Harvest, Shepherd
chapter topic; Chapter 299, p. 1085
the field, the countryside — Latin campus, flat open ground; camp, campus, campaign and champion are all fought or pitched on it *el campo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 299, p. 1085
the firefighter — named from la bomba, the pump, so Spanish calls them the pump-person while English calls them the fire-person *el bombero*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 427, p. 2061
the five vowel letters — a closed set that never grew, and the two marks one of them can carry *las cinco vocales*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 425, p. 2037

the foot — Latin pedem, from a root so old that Hindi pair, Persian pa and English foot are all the same word *el pie*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 314, p. 1195
the footprint — from hollar, to tread, and behind that fullare, to trample cloth; a fuller was the man who did it with his feet *la huella*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 302, p. 1109
the fork — built on tener, to hold: it is "the holder", the same shape as any Spanish word ending in -dor *el tenedor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 297, p. 1069
the four seasons — three straightforward, and one whose MEANING quietly shifted from "spring" to "summer" *la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 142, p. 485
the frying pan — Latin sartago; its written accent is a receipt for where the stress went, and the plural hands it back *la sartén*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 297, p. 1069
the full stop — one mark with three jobs, and the job it is doing is decided by what comes after it rather than by the mark itself *el punto*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 424, p. 2023
The Future — Saying What Will Happen
chapter topic; Chapter 122, p. 417
the garage — a French word wearing a Spanish spelling, and the floor of the building most notices are about *el garaje*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 433, p. 2123
the garlic — Latin allium, which English kept as the botanical name; aioli is this word and oil, run together *el ajo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 297, p. 1069
the girl — the counterpart of El Niño, and the reason the pupil of the eye is a little girl in both languages *la niña*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 308, p. 1147
the girl — the same ciccum root, and the one word here that English borrowed from Spanish rather than the reverse *la chica*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 308, p. 1147
the grade, as printed on a document — the formal partner of nota, and a word that says out loud what a grade is for *la calificación*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 429, p. 2083
the grandfather — Latin avus, the root inside English avuncular and atavistic *el abuelo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 306, p. 1135

the grandmother — the avus root swung feminine, the same -o/-a switch as hijo and hija *la abuela*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 306, p. 1135
the group — a short plain word that came in whole, and the unit a course or a trip is organised into *el grupo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 436, p. 2149
the guide and the guidebook — the article decides which *el guía / la guía*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 463, p. 2419
the *h* in hermano — a letter that was never spoken
etymology topic; explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 140, p. 475
the half — Latin medietatem, the middle-ness, from medius middle; English medium, median, mediate and moiety come off it, and the -dad ending is the one you know *la mitad*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 344, p. 1405
the hand — feminine despite ending in -o, Spanish's most famous gender exception *la mano*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 141, p. 481
the handbag — one letter away from la bolsa, which is a different thing, and the vowel is the whole difference *el bolso*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 430, p. 2095
the handle — a cousin of la mano, and a homonym of the fruit in the way la cola taught *el mango*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 470, p. 2487
the harbour — Latin portus, the twin of the porta you already have; import, export and opportunity are all ships coming in *el puerto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 302, p. 1109
the harvest — from collecta, the gathered-up, which is the colligere you already took apart once *la cosecha*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 299, p. 1085
the head — Spanish KEPT Latin's real word, unlike French, which replaced it with slang for "pot" *la cabeza*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 141, p. 481
the head, the director — the -tor noun you were shown in a table, now the person who signs the letter *el director / la directora*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 466, p. 2447
the hearing, the inner ear — the past participle of oír made into a noun; Latin audire is under audio, audience and obedient *el oído*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 314, p. 1195
the heating — heat-making, built from two words you already own *la calefacción*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 444, p. 2229

the hen — Latin gallina, the female of gallus; and in both languages the bird is also what you call a coward *la gallina*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 296, p. 1061
the hill — Latin collis, from a root meaning to rise; excel and culminate rise from the same place *la colina*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 292, p. 1029
the holiday, the party — Latin festa, the feast days; English feast, festival and festive are the same word, and English borrowed fiesta itself *la fiesta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 349, p. 1447
the holidays — Latin vacātiō, exemption, from vacāre, to be empty or free of duty; a learned borrowing, twin of English vacation and vacant, and no relation to vaca, the cow *las vacaciones*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 392, p. 1813
the honey — Latin mel, which sweetens mellifluous, molasses and marmalade *la miel*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 290, p. 1013
the horse — Latin caballus, the working nag, which beat the noble equus and left cavalry and chivalry behind it *el caballo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 296, p. 1061
the hurry, the rush — Latin pressa, from premere to press; English press, pressure, express, impress, oppress and print are all pressings *la prisa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 333, p. 1345
the husband — Latin spondere, to pledge solemnly; English spouse, sponsor, respond, despondent *el esposo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 306, p. 1135
the hyphen — shorter than la raya and with a different job, and a word whose own spelling the Academy changed *el guion*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 424, p. 2023
The Imperfect — What Used to Happen
chapter topic; Chapter 107, p. 379
the initial lower-case letter — whether a small word inside a surname takes a capital depends on whether the forename is standing in front of it *la minúscula inicial*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 426, p. 2049
the inside corner of a room — Arabic rukn, a corner or a supporting pillar; the street corner, la esquina, is Latin, so Spanish gets its two corners from two languages *el rincón*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 355, p. 1495

the instant — Latin instans, standing upon you, from in plus stare; English instant, instance and constant all stand on the same verb *el instante*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 348, p. 1439
The Instituto, And What A Mark Is Called
chapter topic; Chapter 429, p. 2083
the internet — English Internet, itself Latin inter, between, bolted onto Germanic net; taken into Spanish unchanged except for the beat, which moves to the last syllable *internet*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 393, p. 1823
the invoice — "a making", by the same ending that gives escritura and lectura *la factura*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 441, p. 2197
the island — Latin insula; insular, isolate, peninsula and insulin all come off the same rock *la isla*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 295, p. 1053
the jacket — a word you have already been shown twice without being given it, and probably named after a peasant rather than a place *la chaqueta*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 468, p. 2467
the journey — Latin viaticum, the provisions you packed for the road *el viaje*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 288, p. 997
the jumper — an English word for an island, borrowed whole, and then made to follow Spanish accent rules in the plural *el jersey*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 430, p. 2095
the key — Latin clavis, the little key; the same root gives English clavicle, clef and conclave *la llave*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 310, p. 1163
the kind, the sort — Greek typos, a blow and the dent a blow leaves; English type, typical, typography and prototype all take the same impression *el tipo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 350, p. 1455
the knee — Latin rotella, a little wheel, from rota; rotate, rotary and roulette are the same wheel *la rodilla*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 293, p. 1037
the knife — Latin cultellus, a little culter; cutlery, cutlass and the plough's coulter are the same blade *el cuchillo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 294, p. 1045
the lake — Latin lacus; lake, lagoon and lacuna are all the same standing water *el lago*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 292, p. 1029

the laughter — Latin risus from ridere, to laugh; English took the root only in unkind forms — ridicule, deride, risible *la risa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 315, p. 1203
the lawn, the pitch — grass as a surface somebody looks after *el césped*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 450, p. 2295
the lawyer — Latin advocatus, one called to your side; English advocate is the same word, and it explains what the job originally was *el abogado*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 427, p. 2061
the left, the left-hand side — Basque ezkerra, one of the few pre-Roman words in Spanish; it drove out Latin sinistra, which English kept as sinister *la izquierda*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 340, p. 1373
the leg — Latin perna, a ham; Spanish named the living leg after the butcher's cut *la pierna*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 314, p. 1195
the letter, and the menu — Latin charta from Greek khartes, a papyrus sheet; English chart, charter, card and cartoon are all it *la carta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 312, p. 1179
The Letters Themselves
chapter topic; Chapter 425, p. 2037
the letters with more than one name — which matters because b and v sound identical in Spanish, so the name is how a speaker tells them apart *be larga o be corta*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 425, p. 2037
the level — a cousin of el litro through Latin libra, the balance, because a level is a little pair of scales *el nivel*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 471, p. 2497
the light — Latin lux, lucem; English keeps it in lucid, translucent and elucidate *la luz*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 310, p. 1163
the lighthouse — named after Pharos, the island at Alexandria that held the first one; a place name that became the word for the thing *el faro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 302, p. 1109
the livestock — from ganar, to gain: cattle are simply "what has been gained", the way English cattle and chattel are what you own *el ganado*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 299, p. 1085

the loan — the noun the lending cycle was missing, and the word for a borrowed word *el préstamo*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 441, p. 2197
the machine — the general word under all the particular ones you already hold *la máquina*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 434, p. 2131
the map — Latin mappa, a cloth; the world was drawn on a napkin, and napkin is the same word *el mapa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 312, p. 1179
the mark — the same word the corpus already taught for a written note, and the older of its two senses is this one *la nota*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 429, p. 2083
¿ ¡ — the marks that open a question
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 77
The Marks Themselves
chapter topic; Chapter 424, p. 2023
the (masculine / feminine) *el / la*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1
the match, and the political party — both of them a side split off *el partido*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 446, p. 2251
the matter, the affair — Latin assumptus, taken up, from ad + sumere; English assume, resume, consume and presume are all takings *el asunto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 331, p. 1329
the medicine — the word on the box, built on the doctor you already know *el medicamento*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 457, p. 2371
the meeting — making one again, out of the plainest number there is *la reunión*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 442, p. 2207
the meter — the same doer-ending a second time, on the verb for counting, and the word on every notice about the water *el contador*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 432, p. 2113
the minute — Latin minutus, made small, from minuere to lessen; English minute, minor, minus, diminish and minuscule are the same smallness *el minuto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 342, p. 1389
the mist — Latin nebula, the word set aside earlier as the near-cousin of nubes; nebulous is the same mist *la niebla*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 295, p. 1053

The Months
chapter topic; Chapter 145, p. 495
the months — Roman gods and emperors, marching almost unchanged from Latin *los meses*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 145, p. 495
the mountain — Latin mons; paramount is above the hill and an amount is what it comes to *la montaña*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 292, p. 1029
the mouth — Latin bucca was the cheek, and the cheek pushed the mouth out of the job *la boca*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 286, p. 981
the move, the removal — and the ending that turns a verb into the event *la mudanza*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 448, p. 2273
the name — Latin nomen, cousin to English name and root of noun and nominate *el nombre*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 305, p. 1129
the neck — Latin collum, which is also the collar round it and the accolade thrown round it *el cuello*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 293, p. 1037
the needle — a little acus, a sharp; the same sharp that names the acute accent, and the one in acupuncture *la aguja*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 301, p. 1101
the neighbour — from vicus, a village street: the person off your own block *el vecino*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 285, p. 973
the neighbourhood — Andalusi Arabic barri, of the outside, from barr, the open land beyond the walls; English borrowed barrio whole *el barrio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 325, p. 1281
the nickname — from apodar, Latin putare, to prune and so to reckon; English compute, dispute, amputate *el apodo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 309, p. 1155
the noise — Latin rugitus, a roaring, from rugire to roar; the same root gave English rut, the roaring season of deer *el ruido*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 333, p. 1345
the notebook — a counting word underneath, because the oldest notebook was four sheets folded once *el cuaderno*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 465, p. 2435
the notice, the warning — from avisar, and Latin ad visum, to what is seen; English advise, advice, vision, evident and provide share the root videre *el aviso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 332, p. 1337

the number — Latin numerus; English number, numeral, numerous, enumerate and numb all come off it *el número*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 344, p. 1405
the numbers 1–5 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 47, p. 189
the numbers 6–10 and the old counting hidden in month names *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 47, p. 189
the nurse — from infirmus, not firm: named after the patient, not the work *la enfermera*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 285, p. 973
the object, the thing — Latin objectum, thrown before, from ob and iacere to throw; English object, project, inject, eject and subject are all throws *el objeto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 345, p. 1413
the one noun that covers both "time" and "weather" — because Latin tempus already did *el tiempo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 148, p. 507
the onion — Latin caepulla, a little caepa; the chive in English is the same root, undiminished *la cebolla*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 290, p. 1013
The Only Three Irregulars
chapter topic; Chapter 109, p. 385
the order — the thing you have asked a shop to send, named from the verb for asking *el pedido*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 431, p. 2105
the other sorry — "give completely" — for fault and for getting past people, where lo siento is for regret *perdón*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 137, p. 459
the oven — Latin furnus, wearing the silent h that marks where an f used to stand; furnace is the same fire *el horno*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 297, p. 1069
the pain — Latin dolor; condolence hurts with you, and indolent once felt no pain at all *el dolor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 286, p. 981
the paper — from papyrus, the reed the Egyptians wrote on; it also means the part an actor plays, because the part was written on one *el papel*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 301, p. 1101
the paperwork — a fourth ending, and the one that turns an action into a thing *la documentación*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 435, p. 2139

the part, the share — Latin partem from pars; English part, party, partial, particle, partner and portion all come off it *la parte*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 345, p. 1413
the part — what is missing when a thing does not work, and what a repair replaces *la pieza*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 434, p. 2131
the passport — pass plus port; the paper that lets you through the gate, from Latin passus and porta *el pasaporte*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 313, p. 1187
the path — Latin semita, a by-way, with semi- meaning half: a path is a half-road *el sendero*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 295, p. 1053
The Person, Head To Hand
chapter topic; Chapter 364, p. 1575
the person — Latin persona, an actor's mask; English person, personality, persona and impersonate all still wear it *la persona*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 345, p. 1413
the pipework — the same collecting ending again, and the word behind every notice that the water is going off *la tubería*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 432, p. 2113
the place, the spot — Latin locus through localis; the same locus is already inside hasta luego and en primer lugar *el lugar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 325, p. 1281
the platform — the one station word whose history nobody can recover *el andén*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 439, p. 2177
the point, the dot — Latin punctum, a prick, from pungere to prick; English point, puncture, punctual, punctuation and pungent share the needle *el punto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 342, p. 1389
the police officer — Greek polis, the city, so the word names the person by the thing they keep in order; and the article changes what it means *el policía*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 427, p. 2061
the pot — Latin olla, unchanged in two thousand years; potpourri is a French translation of olla podrida *la olla*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 294, p. 1045
The Preterite — Your First Past Tense
chapter topic; Chapter 103, p. 357
the price — Latin pretium, worth; English price, precious, appreciate and praise all come off it *el precio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 311, p. 1171

the printer — the machine-ending you met on la lavadora, now on a stem that also yields a person, so the article is what tells the two apart *la impresora*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 469, p. 2477
The *qu-* question family — one ancient pattern, many clues
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 41
the quantity, the amount — Latin quantitas from quantus, how much; English quantity, quantum and quantify all ask the same question *la cantidad*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 351, p. 1463
the quarter, a fourth — Latin quartus, fourth, on quattuor four; English quarter, quart, quartet and quarantine all count to four *el cuarto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 342, p. 1389
the queue — named after a tail, and not to be confused with its own homonym *la cola*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 451, p. 2307
the rain — the noun to a verb you have had since the weather chapter, and a word you were once shown as somebody else's example *la lluvia*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 465, p. 2435
the raised letters — the little o and a that sit above the line in an ordinal or an abbreviation, and which one to use for a woman *las letras voladitas*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 426, p. 2049
the reading — the word la factura already printed in its own table, handed over now, and a thing you have been doing since chapter sixty-six *la lectura*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 472, p. 2509
the receipt — a word that went to England, changed jobs, and came back *el ticket*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 451, p. 2307
The Regular Preterite
chapter topic; Chapter 104, p. 365
the regular singular -er preterite — comí, comiste, comió *comí*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 104, p. 365
the regular singular -ir preterite — viví, viviste, vivió *viví*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 104, p. 365
the relative — Latin parere, to give birth; English parent and postpartum, and a false friend worth knowing *el pariente*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 309, p. 1155
the remedy — re- and mederi, to heal again; medicine, medical and a medic are all the same healing *el remedio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 300, p. 1093

the rest — des- undoes cansar, to tire; rest in Spanish is defined as the reversal of being worn down *el descanso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 315, p. 1203
The Rest of the Greetings
chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 15
the rest, what is left — Latin restare, to stand back, from re and stare; English rest and arrest stand on the same verb *el resto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 352, p. 1471
the return — from volver, Latin volvere, to roll: a return is a turning back *la vuelta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 288, p. 997
the rice — Arabic ar-ruzz, carrying its own article; rice is the same grain by a different road *el arroz*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 290, p. 1013
the right, the right-hand side — Latin directus, straightened, from dirigere to set straight; English direct, direction, erect and address share it *la derecha*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 340, p. 1373
The River, The Sand And The Ash
chapter topic; Chapter 369, p. 1625
The Road and the World
chapter topic; Chapter 330, p. 1321
the road, the way — Late Latin camminus, borrowed from Gaulish; one of the few Celtic words Spanish kept, and the source of French chemin *el camino*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 330, p. 1321
the root — Latin radix, which is also the radish, the radical and the thing you eradicate *la raíz*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 291, p. 1021
the rope — Greek khorde by way of Latin chorda, a gut string; cord, chord and cordon are the same string, and the o breaks to ue again *la cuerda*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 301, p. 1101
the route — a road broken through, and a cousin of *roto* *la ruta*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 452, p. 2319
the rule — the heading above every list a building, a library or a pool puts on its wall *la norma*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 433, p. 2123
the salad — a salted thing, and the salt is still in the word *la ensalada*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 456, p. 2361

the same, equal — Latin aequalis from aequus, level; English equal, equator and adequate are all about a surface with no tilt in it *igual*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 350, p. 1455
the same rain in two tenses — how a story uses the imperfect for the scene and the preterite for the events *llovía / llovió*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 167, p. 587
the scarf — one of a handful of words this book has had to leave open, and the fifth to say so out loud *la bufanda*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 468, p. 2467
the screen — a lampshade before it was a monitor, and a history nobody can settle *la pantalla*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 442, p. 2207
The Seasons
chapter topic; Chapter 142, p. 485
the seat — Latin sedere, to sit; English sedentary, session, reside and assess all sit on it *el asiento*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 311, p. 1171
the secondary school — the false friend that sends English speakers to the wrong building, because an English institute is a research body and a Spanish one is where you go at twelve *el instituto*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 429, p. 2083
the section — a thing cut, and the cut is still in the word *la sección*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 459, p. 2387
the seed — Latin seminalia, the things for sowing; a seminar is a seed-bed and disseminate is scattering *la semilla*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 291, p. 1021
the seller — vender plus the same -dor ending that turned trabajar into trabajador, which is how Spanish makes a person out of an action *el vendedor*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 427, p. 2061
the service — and, on a door, the toilet *el servicio*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 454, p. 2339
the set meal, and the card it is printed on — French menu, small and detailed, from Latin minūtus, made small; menudo and minuto are that same Latin word by two other roads *el menú*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 391, p. 1803
the set, the whole group — Latin coniunctus, yoked together, from com and iungere; English junction, join and even yoga come off the same yoking *el conjunto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 352, p. 1471

the shade — Latin sub umbra, under the shadow; an umbrella is a little one of these *la sombra*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 289, p. 1005
the shared singular preterite of ser and ir — fui, fuiste, fue *fui*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 103, p. 357
the sheep — Latin ovicula, a little ovis; Spanish kept the small one and dropped the full-sized word entirely *la oveja*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 296, p. 1061
the shelving unit — a second ending that builds nouns, and the thing every flat-pack instruction is about *la estantería*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 432, p. 2113
the shepherd — from pascere, to graze; the pasture, the pastor of a church and a repast are all feeding *el pastor*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 299, p. 1085
the shipment — what enviar leaves behind, and a road hidden inside the verb *el envío*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 442, p. 2207
the shop — Latin tendere, to stretch; a shop began as a stretched awning, which is why English tent, extend and tendon are relatives *la tienda*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 311, p. 1171
the shore — Latin ora, an edge or border, with the small ending: the little edge of anything *la orilla*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 295, p. 1053
the shoulder — Latin umerus, which doctors still call the humerus; the h is silent and came late *el hombro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 293, p. 1037
the shower — Latin ducere, to lead; the same root leads water through an aqueduct and gives English duct, conduct and duke *la ducha*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 310, p. 1163
the silence — Latin silentium from silere, to be still; English silence, silent and the silent film all come off it unchanged *el silencio*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 333, p. 1345
the single most useful sentence a learner owns — and it is this chapter's grammar, doing exactly what the chapter said *¿cómo se dice?*
Chapter 183, p. 647
the skin — Latin pellis, a hide, with the e broken to ie; a pelt is the same hide, and a surplice is a shirt worn over one *la piel*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 300, p. 1093

the sky — Latin caelum, which is also the ceiling over a room and the cerulean of a paint box *el cielo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 289, p. 1005
the slash — the mark that offers a choice, abbreviates a street, and sits inside every speed limit sign *la barra*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 424, p. 2023
the sleep, and the dream — Latin somnus with the o broken to ue; insomnia and somnolent keep the o intact *el sueño*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 300, p. 1093
the small hours, daybreak — Latin maturus, ripe or early, through madurgar; English mature and premature are the same ripeness *la madrugada*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 342, p. 1389
the sofa — the one word in this chapter you could not have built, and the stress that keeps its accent *el sofá*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 432, p. 2113
the son — Latin filius, cousin to English filial and affiliate; the f- that became a silent h- *el hijo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 306, p. 1135
the soup — Germanic suppa, a piece of bread soaked in broth; the bread came first and soup, sop and supper are all it *la sopa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 297, p. 1069
the sports centre — one building, many sports, and the word says so *el polideportivo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 438, p. 2167
the square — Latin platea from Greek plateia, a broad way; English place, plate, plateau and platypus all mean broad *la plaza*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 325, p. 1281
the star — Latin stella, wearing the e- that Spanish puts in front of an s and a consonant *la estrella*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 289, p. 1005
the state, the condition — Latin status, which only looks like estar's participle, and the phrase a donation notice already used on you *el estado*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 473, p. 2519
the stocktake — a list of what was found, from *venir* *el inventario*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 459, p. 2387
the stone — and a Greek word that came to Spanish by way of a nickname *la piedra*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 450, p. 2295

the stop — from parar, to stop, and Latin parare, to make ready; English prepare, repair, apparatus, parade and parasol are all the same root *la parada*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 330, p. 1321
the street — Latin callis, the narrow track worn through rough ground by driven animals; the town's word began in the hills *la calle*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 302, p. 1109
the strength — Latin fortia from fortis, with the o broken to ue; force, fort, effort and comfort are all built on it *la fuerza*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 315, p. 1203
The Stretches A Calendar Marks
chapter topic; Chapter 349, p. 1447
The Strong Preterites
chapter topic; Chapter 105, p. 369
The Subjunctive Built From the Yo Form
chapter topic; Chapter 128, p. 437
The Subjunctive, Regular
chapter topic; Chapter 127, p. 433
the suitcase — a little mala, the Gaulish word for a bag; English mail, the post, is named after the same bag *la maleta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 312, p. 1179
the supplier — the third party a shop blames when your order is late, and the reason this word turns up in complaints *el proveedor*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 431, p. 2105
the surname — from appellitare, to call on repeatedly; English appeal sits on the same verb *el apellido*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 305, p. 1129
the survey — a cousin of querer, because asking and wanting are one Latin verb *la encuesta*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 472, p. 2509
the syllable — what may be split at the end of a line and what may never be, plus the words Spanish accepts two spellings for *la sílaba*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 425, p. 2037
the table — Latin mensa, the measured board; English borrowed mesa whole for the flat-topped hill *la mesa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 310, p. 1163
the tag question — asking someone to agree *¿verdad?*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 267, p. 839
the target, the objective — el objeto wearing -ivo, narrowed to the thing placed in front to be reached *el objetivo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 467, p. 2457

the teacher — magister, from magis, more; and minister, from minus, less *el maestro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 285, p. 973
the telephone — Greek tele far plus phone voice; a far-voice, and both halves are everywhere in English *el teléfono*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 312, p. 1179
the temperature — from a verb meaning to mix in the right proportion, which is also why steel is tempered and a person has a temper *la temperatura*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 465, p. 2435
the test, the analysis — a loosening-apart, and a noun that never changes for plural *el análisis*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 447, p. 2263
the thing — Latin causa, a cause or legal case, which drifted to mean thing; English cause, because, accuse and excuse keep the original sense *la cosa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 331, p. 1329
the thirst — Latin sitis; Spanish does not say you are thirsty, it says you have thirst, and the difference is the point *la sed*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 300, p. 1093
the thread — Latin filum with its f worn down to a silent h; filament, filigree and a file of soldiers are all threads *el hilo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 301, p. 1101
the three weather words Spanish reports with hacer — "it makes heat," "it makes cold," "it makes sun" *hace calor, hace frío, hace sol*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 148, p. 507
The Three Words for You
chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 33
the throat — a word made out of the noise itself, as gargle and gurgle are *la garganta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 286, p. 981
the ticket — a little bulla, a Latin seal; the same seal gives English bulletin and the papal bull *el boleto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 313, p. 1187
the timetable, the opening hours — Latin horarium, on hora an hour; English hour, horoscope and horology come off the same root, and the -ario ending is English -ary *el horario*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 342, p. 1389
the tomato — Nahuatl tomatl, one of the words Spanish carried back across the Atlantic *el tomate*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 290, p. 1013
the tool — a thing of iron, with the iron still in the word *la herramienta*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 460, p. 2395

the tooth — Latin dentem, with the e broken to ie; a dandelion is a dent de lion, a lion's tooth *el diente*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 314, p. 1195
the track, the way — the word you have been saying inside *todavía* *la vía*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 454, p. 2339
the training session — and the train you already know, hiding inside it *el entrenamiento*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 450, p. 2295
the trolley — a little cart, and the ending Spanish uses more than almost any other *el carrito*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 444, p. 2229
the trunk — Latin truncus, meaning lopped or maimed; to truncate is to do it on purpose *el tronco*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 291, p. 1021
the truth — Latin veritas from verus, true; English keeps it in verity, verify and verdict, and in the older sense of very *la verdad*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 324, p. 1273
the turn, your slot — Greek tornos, a lathe, through Latin tornus; English turn, tour, tournament, contour and tornado all spin off it *el turno*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 348, p. 1439
the two-letter combinations that spell one sound — and two of them used to be letters in their own right until 1994 *los dígrafos*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 425, p. 2037
the umbrella — the para- of la parada, fused to a plural noun the way cumpleaños was, and invariable for the reason el análisis gave *el paraguas*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 470, p. 2487
the uncle — Greek theios, borrowed into Late Latin; the word English did not take, because English took avunculus instead *el tío*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 307, p. 1141
the underscore — the low hyphen, named by position rather than by shape, and the last piece an address can contain *el guion bajo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 428, p. 2073
the user — usar plus the -ario ending, and the word a service uses for the people it serves *el usuario*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 472, p. 2509
the valley — Latin vallis; valley, vale and avalanche all come down the same slope *el valle*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 292, p. 1029

the village, and also the people — Latin populus, which gave popular, population and public *el pueblo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 292, p. 1029
the voice — Latin vox, vocem; English voice, vocal, vowel, vocation, advocate, evoke and provoke all come off it *la voz*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 332, p. 1337
the wait — the noun of *esperar*, and the sign above the chairs *la espera*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 460, p. 2395
the wall of a room — Latin paries, the wall of a house rather than of a town; the town wall was murus, which is Spanish muro and English mural, and paries survives in English only as the parietal bone *la pared*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 355, p. 1495
The Wardrobe, And The Word For Having No Work
chapter topic; Chapter 430, p. 2095
the warehouse, the storeroom — an Arabic word with its article still attached *el almacén*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 452, p. 2319
the washing machine — the doer-ending from the last chapter, put on a verb you have had since the household words *la lavadora*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 432, p. 2113
the way out — from salir, and Latin salire, to jump: a Roman jumped out of a room *la salida*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 288, p. 997
The Way Out — Path, Bridge, Shore, Island, Mist
chapter topic; Chapter 295, p. 1053
the way, the manner — from Latin manuarius, of the hand, and manus a hand; English manner, manual, manufacture and manage are all handlings *la manera*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 331, p. 1329
the way, the mode — Latin modus, a measure; English mode, model, modern, modest and moderate are measurings, and Spanish como is quomodo, in what measure *el modo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 331, p. 1329
The Weather
chapter topic; Chapter 148, p. 507
The Web Page
chapter topic; Chapter 422, p. 2003
the wedding — a Latin plural that hardened into a Spanish singular, and the pieces are invisible *la boda*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 440, p. 2187

the weekdays (Monday–Friday) — worn-down planet-god names *lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 138, p. 463
the weekend *el fin de semana*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 409, p. 1941
the weekend (Saturday, Sunday) — where religion overwrote astronomy *sábado, domingo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 138, p. 463
the weeping — Latin planctus, a beating; Roman mourners struck their own chest, and pl- became ll- on the way into Spanish *el llanto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 316, p. 1211
the wheat — Latin triticum, the rubbed grain, from terere, to rub; trite is worn down the same way *el trigo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 290, p. 1013
the wheel — and the word you have been saying inside *alrededor* all along *la rueda*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 449, p. 2285
The Whole Set, And How Much Of It
chapter topic; Chapter 352, p. 1471
The Wider Circle — Wife, Uncle, Aunt, Cousin
chapter topic; Chapter 307, p. 1141
the wife — the same spondere pledge, feminine; and the reason handcuffs are called esposas *la esposa*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 307, p. 1141
the wood — a Germanic word, not a Latin one; bush, bosky and ambush are its English cousins *el bosque*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 291, p. 1021
the word — Latin parabola from Greek parabole, a throwing beside; the same Greek word gave English parable, parabola, parley and parliament *la palabra*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 332, p. 1337
The Words Behind Please and Sorry
chapter topic; Chapter 320, p. 1241
the works, the building site — and the same Latin word as *la oficina* *la obra*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 454, p. 2339
the workshop — where a thing goes to be mended, and also the name of a short course *el taller*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 434, p. 2131
the world — Latin mundus, meaning clean and orderly; English mundane is the same word, and Greek kosmos made the identical jump from order to world *el mundo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 330, p. 1321

The Written Accent
chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 73
the yes-or-no question — and why Spanish barely has to do anything *¿Hablas español?*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 267, p. 839
Theatre, Exhibition, Circus
chapter topic; Chapter 420, p. 1987
theatre — Greek theatron, a place for viewing, from theaomai "to behold"; the same root sits inside the English word theory *el teatro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 420, p. 1987
then — Latin in tunc, "at that time"; tunc and English then both grow out of the old pointing word that also gives the, that and there *entonces*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 323, p. 1265
then, next — a word you already own from hasta luego, now doing a second job: joining two events in order *luego*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 167, p. 587
"there is" and "there are" — one word for both, which no other Spanish verb form manages *hay*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar; Chapter 191, p. 663
there, over there — the two places aquí has been missing, and they line up exactly with the three pointing words *ahí · allí*
explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 251, p. 787
therefore *por lo tanto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 273, p. 879
thick — Late Latin grossus, coarse; English gross is the same word, and so is grocer, a dealer who sold in bulk *grueso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 379, p. 1709
thin — the kind word and the blunt one *delgado / flaco*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 275, p. 895
this one, here, next to me — the first of three words for pointing, and the reason Spanish never needs to say "the this book" *este*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 221, p. 725
thumb — Latin pollicaris, which meant an inch long, from pollex; the same word gives Spanish pulgada, an inch *el pulgar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 375, p. 1677
thunder — from a Latin word for a thunderclap, with an r that wandered in; English thunder is the inherited cousin, and tornado is a mangled Spanish tronada *el trueno*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 370, p. 1635
thus, in that way — and with que after it, "so"; built on the same sīc that gave you sí *así que*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 175, p. 623

thus, like this, that way — Latin ad sic, to thus; the same sic that Spanish turned into sí and that English still writes inside a quotation *así*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 328, p. 1305
ticket *billete*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 268, p. 845
tienen — the break comes back
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 67, p. 261
tired — a state, not a quality, which is why it takes estar and never ser *cansado*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 59, p. 239
to accept — to take a thing towards you, and the sign on the till *aceptar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 456, p. 2361
to advise — el consejo with a verb built on it, and the verb a question reaches for when it asks what somebody recommends *aconsejar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 473, p. 2519
to answer — a Roman courtroom word that English turned into a fight and Spanish turned into a reply *contestar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 174, p. 617
to apply for, to request — the formal verb on the form *solicitar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 460, p. 2395
to approach — a preposition turned into a verb, and the date that comes closer on its own *acercarse*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 443, p. 2217
to arise, to come up — Latin surgere, to rise, and the verb a question reaches for when it asks where an idea came from *surgir*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 472, p. 2509
to arrange an appointment — the same word as a concert, and it began as a fight *concertar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 442, p. 2207
to arrive — Latin plicāre per Corominas, whose sense he routes through the nautical idiom applicāre nāvem, to bring a ship to shore; initial pl- gave Spanish ll- and Portuguese ch-, which is why Portuguese says chegar *llegar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 395, p. 1843
to ask (a question) — and the reason English's one "ask" becomes two Spanish verbs *preguntar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 160, p. 553
to be a Quixote — an allusion working as a word *ser un quijote*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 274, p. 887

to be able or can — with the singular present forms puedo, puedes, and puede *poder*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 69, p. 269
to be — but the *standing* kind, straight from Latin stāre *estar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 61
to be funny — and a word that does not translate *tener gracia*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 274, p. 887
to be out of work — el paro is a stoppage, and Spain names unemployment after the halt rather than after the missing job *estar en paro*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 430, p. 2095
to be — the verb used here to identify someone or say what someone is *ser*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 48, p. 197
to begin — from pieza, a piece; English begin is a different word built on the same idea *empezar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 382, p. 1731
to believe, to think — putting your heart somewhere, where pensar weighs it up *creer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 175, p. 623
to break — Latin rumpere, and the reason a road is called a route *romper*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 381, p. 1725
to bring — Latin's word for dragging, and a verb with a direction built into it *traer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 168, p. 597
to burn — the Academy says Latin cremare; Corominas says the sounds forbid it, and the argument is still open *quemar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 387, p. 1771
to buy — from Latin's "get ready, procure", and not from the verb behind English compare *comprar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 174, p. 617
to celebrate — and, underneath, to make a crowd; the verb a notice uses for holding an event at all *celebrar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 440, p. 2187
to change — Latin cambiāre, itself a word of Gaulish origin, for exchanging one thing for another *cambiar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 401, p. 1895
to charge, to be paid — the other side of pagar, and the verb that decides who owes whom *cobrar*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 431, p. 2105

to check over — looking at something a second time, on purpose *revisar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 451, p. 2307
to check, to look up, to consult — asking a document rather than a person *consultar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 453, p. 2329
to clash, to coincide — the reason people give for not coming, and a word your English eye can already read *coincidir*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 437, p. 2159
to close — from the bar dropped across a door, not from the Latin verb English inherited *cerrar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 166, p. 577
to collect, to pick up — the single most demanded verb in the A2 papers, and one word for four English ones *recoger*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 436, p. 2149
to come — with the singular present forms vengo, vienes, and viene *venir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 73, p. 287
to comment, to mention — to turn a thing over in the mind, together *comentar*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 447, p. 2263
to concentrate — to gather yourself to a centre, with the Greek word for a goad inside it *concentrarse*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 443, p. 2217
to connect — the Academy's dictionary records it as taken from English to connect, which had itself been built out of Latin pieces *conectar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 469, p. 2477
to cook — built on cocina, the kitchen, from Latin coquīna; English kitchen is that same Latin noun, borrowed early into Germanic *cocinar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 396, p. 1853
to copy — from Latin copia, abundance, because the first copies were made to have plenty *copiar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 472, p. 2509
to cost — Latin constare, to stand together or be settled *costar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 402, p. 1903
to cover — an irregular participle that joins abierto, and the des- that really does reverse *cubrir*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 444, p. 2229

to cross — from cruz, Latin crux; English cross reached England by way of Irish and Norse, and crusade stands beside Spanish cruzada *cruzar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 387, p. 1771
to cut — and on a road sign, to close; the verb behind an adjective you already own *cortar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 439, p. 2177
to cut back — to lead a thing back, and a shower is its cousin *reducir*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 462, p. 2411
to dance (bailar — infinitive) *bailar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 419, p. 1983
to decide — to cut a question off, and the verb every notice uses when it stops offering options *decidir*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 437, p. 2159
to deduct — contar with the des- that really does reverse, and the o breaks to ue *descontar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 474, p. 2527
to die — Latin mori; English mortal and mortgage are the same root, and murder is a cousin by another road *morir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 384, p. 1747
to discuss, and to argue — one verb for both, from a Latin verb about shaking a thing apart *discutir*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 466, p. 2447
to do or make — with the singular present forms hago, haces, and hace *hacer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 70, p. 277
to donate — the giving inside *perdón*, said plainly *donar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 461, p. 2403
to dream — Latin somniare, and the reason sleeplessness is called insomnia *soñar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 381, p. 1725
to drink (another -er verb — cementing the pattern) *beber*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 161
to eat — your first -er verb, and the family whose yo-form you already own *comer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 153
to enjoy — to take the fruit of something, with a prefix that does not undo *disfrutar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 440, p. 2187
to erase — from borra, coarse wool, the pad that rubbed writing out; English borrow is no relation *borrar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 388, p. 1779

to explain — literally to unfold, and the verb that names what this whole chapter has been building *explicar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 175, p. 623
to fail an exam — Latin for to leave hanging, which is exactly what a resit does to your year *suspender*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 429, p. 2083
to fail, to let somebody down — the deceiving inside *falso* *fallar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 464, p. 2427
to feed — from a Latin verb wider than feeding, which is why the same root is inside adult and alumnus *alimentar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 467, p. 2457
to fill in; to fill out — especially a form or document *rellenar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 406, p. 1923
to find — literally to come up against, and the o that breaks into ue exactly as mostrar's does *encontrar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 470, p. 2487
to finish — from cabo, an end, from Latin caput, a head; English achieve is the same metaphor built again in French *acabar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 382, p. 1731
to finish, to end *terminar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 409, p. 1941
to fix, to sort out — putting a thing back to the straight edge it came off *arreglar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 449, p. 2285
to fly — Latin volare; a volley is a flight of arrows, and volatile is Latin for winged *volar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 387, p. 1771
to follow or continue — from Vulgar Latin sequīre, built from Latin sequī with the ending of īre, to go *seguir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 401, p. 1895
to forget — Latin oblitare, from oblivisci; English oblivion is the same word, and the trail stops there *olvidar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 384, p. 1747
to get it wrong — two Latin pieces meaning "equal voice", and the verb a shop uses to admit a mistake *equivocarse*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 437, p. 2159
to get lost — the reflexive equivocarse already grouped it with, and in a class it is the thread you lose, not the way *perderse*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 471, p. 2497
to get, to obtain — getting as following a thing until you have it *conseguir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 169, p. 601

to get up, to stand up — "to raise oneself", built from a participle exactly as sentarse was *levantarse*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 166, p. 577
to give back — the verb every shop notice and every borrowed object needs, and the one this level asks for most *devolver*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 431, p. 2105
to go in — Latin intrāre, from intrā, within; the short i dropped to e in words carried by mouth, while the prefix intra- kept its i, and English enter, entrance and interior are the same root *entrar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 395, p. 1843
to go up — Latin subire, which was built on sub, meaning under; English sudden is the same sub- *subir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 384, p. 1747
to go with somebody — built on the one you share bread with *acompañar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 446, p. 2251
to go — with the three singular present forms voy, vas, and va *ir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 49, p. 205
to grow — Latin crescere; a crescent is the growing moon, and a recruit is a fresh growth on an army *crecer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 386, p. 1763
to hand in, to deliver — to give a thing over whole *entregar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 458, p. 2379
to hang — Latin collocare, to place; English couch is the same verb, and the jump from placing to hanging happened only on the Spanish side *colgar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 385, p. 1755
to hang out the washing — to stretch something, and the verb inside *la tienda* *tender*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 455, p. 2349
to have — a common verb with two visible changes *tener*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 47, p. 189
to have dinner — one verb where English needs three words, and the meal a plan usually ends at *cenar*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 437, p. 2159
to hear — the half of listening you do not choose, and a verb that sprouts a y *oír*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 165, p. 569
to help — literally the same word as English "aid", arriving by a different road *ayudar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 161, p. 557

"to him, to her, to you" — a Latin case Spanish kept and English threw away *le*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 93, p. 337
to hurt — the verb that makes the pain the subject and you the one it happens to *doler*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 443, p. 2217
to include *incluir*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 409, p. 1941
to interest — the verb behind an adjective you own, running on the same machine as doler *interesar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 443, p. 2217
to invite — the verb el invitado was named from, handed over now, and in Spanish it also means paying *invitar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 474, p. 2527
to jump — Latin saltare, and the somersault is a jump over the top *saltar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 381, p. 1725
to keep — Germanic wardon, to watch over; the w- became gu- in Spanish, which is why ward and guard are the same word twice *guardar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 383, p. 1739
to know how — before an infinitive it names a skill you learned, where poder names a chance you happen to have *saber*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 389, p. 1789
to laugh — a word that wears a prefix it never had, and an accent that marks a missing consonant *reír*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 438, p. 2167
to learn — Latin apprehendere, to seize, worn down through apprēndere; the bookish twin aprehender kept the -he- and kept the seizing *aprender*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 396, p. 1853
to leave — Latin laxare, to loosen, through an older Spanish lejar; the d- is borrowed from dar *dejar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 383, p. 1739
to leave or go out — with the singular present forms salgo, sales, and sale *salir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 72, p. 285
to lend — the other half of devolver, and the verb that decides which way the object is moving *prestar*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 436, p. 2149
to let in, to own up to — the *mittere* you already have in *meter* *admitir*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 458, p. 2379

to let know — the verb el aviso was named from, handed over now, and it shows rather than orders *avisar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 470, p. 2487
to live — your first -ir verb, and a family that asks you to learn nothing new *vivir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 159
to look at — the verb behind the mira you already use, and it began as wonder *mirar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 446, p. 2251
to look for — of unknown origin; English busker is the one relative anybody can point to *buscar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 383, p. 1739
to lose — Latin perdere, to destroy or lose, inherited whole; per- is clear but the second element is disputed, either dare, to give, or a separate element meaning to put, and English perdition is the clean cognate *perder*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 395, p. 1843
to make a mistake — with the verb Spanish insists on *cometer un error*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 275, p. 895
to make up your mind — *decidir* with the -se, and a cut underneath *decidirse*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 462, p. 2411
to matter — the verb behind *importante*, and it works like *gustar* *importar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 463, p. 2419
to meet, to be acquainted with — a verb built out of the moment knowing begins *conocer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 171, p. 607
to mix — spoken Latin misculare, from miscere; English meddle and medley are its true siblings, and a medley was once a fight *mezclar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 385, p. 1755
to move house — a verb about changing, with the change aimed back at yourself *mudarse*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 448, p. 2273
to move something across — built from a prefix and a participle that belongs to a different verb *trasladar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 439, p. 2177
to move something — the verb your phone is named after *mover*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 446, p. 2251

to need — Medieval Latin necessitō, borrowed late and attested in Spanish by the seventeenth century; inside necesse the ne- is secure and the rest has resisted definitive analysis, whatever the confident dictionaries print *necesitar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 395, p. 1843
to note down — Latin nota on a verb, and the quieter twin of apuntar *anotar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 465, p. 2435
to note down, to put your name on a list — a verb built on the point of something *apuntar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 451, p. 2307
to offer — to carry something toward somebody, and the verb a shop reaches for when it cannot give you what you asked *ofrecer*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 436, p. 2149
to open — a regular -ir verb with one irregular part, the participle abierto *abrir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 166, p. 577
to order in, to put somebody in charge — the cart again, with a prefix *encargar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 457, p. 2371
to organise — to fit the working parts together, from a Greek tool *organizar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 463, p. 2419
to paint — and a Latin verb that once meant to embroider *pintar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 455, p. 2349
to pass an exam — and the surprise is who does the approving, because the Latin has the exam approving you *aprobar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 429, p. 2083
to pass on — and why the language turns away *pasar a mejor vida*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 274, p. 887
to pass, to bring closer — the same verb as *acercarse* with the -se taken off *acercar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 449, p. 2285
to pay — Latin pacare, to pacify, from pax, peace; paying somebody was settling with them *pagar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 382, p. 1731
to permit or allow — from Latin permittere, to let through *permitir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 405, p. 1919
to plant — to press in with the sole of the foot, which is what planta meant *plantar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 444, p. 2229

to play — from Latin's word for joking, and the only verb in the language that breaks u to ue *jugar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 170, p. 603
to please — the verb English calls "to like", built the other way round *gustar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 163, p. 563
to prefer — Latin praeferre, to carry in front; ferre left Spanish no inherited verb at all, so every -ferir word came off the page *preferir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 396, p. 1853
to prepare *preparar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 409, p. 1941
to print — the verb el impreso was the participle of, handed back with its own lesson *imprimir*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 469, p. 2477
to produce — the second -ducir verb, and it conjugates exactly like the one you already have *producir*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 467, p. 2457
to pull someone's leg (lit. to take the hair) *tomar el pelo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 272, p. 871
to push — probably late Latin impulsare, though both dictionaries hedge; English push is a cousin, not the same word *empujar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 388, p. 1779
to put in — the plainest verb of putting, and the *mittere* inside *el permiso* *meter*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 455, p. 2349
to put or place — with the singular present forms pongo, pones, and pone *poner*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 71, p. 283
to read — from a Latin verb meaning "to gather, to pick out" *leer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 155, p. 539
to recommend — aconsejar's near twin, an e that breaks to ie like pensar's, and a root about entrusting *recomendar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 473, p. 2519
to regret — a verb that looks like it contains sentir, behaves like sentir, and is not related to it *arrepentirse*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 443, p. 2217
to remember, to remind — to pass a thing back through the heart *recordar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 464, p. 2427

to repair — Latin reparāre, re- plus parāre, to make ready; whether it came down by mouth or off the page cannot be settled, and the reason is the lesson *reparar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 396, p. 1853
to repeat — to seek again, from the same petere that sits under el pedido *repetir*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 445, p. 2241
to reserve, to book *reservar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 409, p. 1941
to rest — named in Spanish as the undoing of tiredness, not as a state *descansar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 438, p. 2167
to retire — the verb behind a word you were given, and it names a shout of joy *jubilarse*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 445, p. 2241
to return — Latin volvere, to roll, on an old root meaning to turn; the stressed o breaks into ue in vuelvo, Old Spanish wrote bolver, and English revolve, involve and volume are the borrowed cousins *volver*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 395, p. 1843
to ruin, to break — and the adjective on the sign when the machine will not work *estropear / estropeado*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 448, p. 2273
to run — a plain -er verb sitting on one of the largest roots English ever borrowed *correr*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 165, p. 569
to say or tell — with the singular present forms digo, dices, and dice *decir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 70, p. 277
to see — veo, ves, ve *ver*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 108, p. 383
to sell — Latin vendere, squeezed out of venum dare, to give for sale; there is a give hidden inside the word for selling *vender*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 386, p. 1763
to send — Latin inviare, to put on the road, from via; not related to envy *enviar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 384, p. 1747
to serve — Latin servire, from servus, a slave; dessert is the clearing of the table, and sergeant is servant said a second time *servir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 386, p. 1763
to shout — Latin quiritare, to cry out; English cry is the same word, and only English moved it from shouting to weeping *gritar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 388, p. 1779

to show — the verb on the sign, with a monster somewhere in its family *mostrar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 451, p. 2307
to sign — literally to make firm, which is what a signature was for *firmar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 441, p. 2197
to sign up, to put one's name down *apuntarse*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 414, p. 1965
to sit down — literally "to seat oneself", the reflexive that lands the action back on you *sentarse*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 166, p. 577
to sleep — and the other half of the boot, where a stressed o breaks to ue *dormir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 165, p. 569
to speak / to talk — at root, "to tell stories" *hablar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 16, p. 107
to spend — Latin vastare, to lay waste; devastate is the clean cousin, and the w in English waste is a Germanic fingerprint *gastar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 386, p. 1763
to stay — Latin quietare, to make still, from quies, rest; English quiet, quit and coy are the same root *quedar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 382, p. 1731
to stay, to remain *quedarse*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 416, p. 1973
to study (a third -ar verb — the pattern is automatic now) *estudiar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 21, p. 121
to swim *nadar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 417, p. 1977
to take (and, across Latin America, to drink) — an everyday word with no settled origin *tomar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 159, p. 551
to take out — origin unsettled; not from saco meaning bag, though a Latin saccus meaning filter may be behind both *sacar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 383, p. 1739
to take time — the verb the delay chapter promised and did not give you *tardar*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 437, p. 2159
to teach, and to show — to put a sign into somebody, which is one act in Spanish *enseñar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 445, p. 2241

to tell a story — and also to count, because in Spanish, as once in English, a story is something you reckon up *contar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 167, p. 587
to the — one of only two places where Spanish forces two words into one, and it does it because the two vowels refuse to sit next to each other *al*
explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 230, p. 745
to think — at root "to weigh", and a stem-changer that breaks e→ie *pensar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 153, p. 531
to throw away, and on a door, to pull — one verb pointing two opposite ways *tirar*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 439, p. 2177
to throw — late Latin lanceare, to wield a lance; English launch is the same verb, and the boat called a launch is not *lanzar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 388, p. 1779
to touch — Romance toccare, which meant to knock or strike; English touch is the same word, and a toccata shows off the player's touch *tocar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 385, p. 1755
to turn down — the opposite of *aceptar*, and its cousin *rechazar*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 461, p. 2403
to turn — Latin gyrare, from Greek gyros, a circle; a late arrival taken from books rather than inherited from speech *girar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 387, p. 1771
to turn off or extinguish — from Latin pacare, to calm or pacify *apagar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 404, p. 1913
to twist something of your own — the injury verb, and a stem that breaks under stress *torcerse*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 438, p. 2167
to understand — literally "to stretch toward"; the second e→ie stem-changer *entender*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 154, p. 535
to use — a reconstructed spoken-Latin usare built on uti; English use is the same word, and usury, utensil and abuse are built on it *usar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 385, p. 1755
to wait — and to hope, and to expect, all in one verb *esperar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 174, p. 617
to walk — built on a Celtic word for a path, beside andar, whose own past is unsettled *caminar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 165, p. 569

to want — with the singular present forms quiero, quieres, and quiere *querer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 69, p. 269
to wash — Latin lavare, which English kept in lavatory, launder and lavish *lavar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 381, p. 1725
to work (a second -ar verb — same pattern) *trabajar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 20, p. 117
to work, said of a machine — built on función, Latin fūnctiō from fungī, to discharge a duty; the untouched Latin cluster shows it came off the page *funcionar*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 396, p. 1853
to write — from a Latin verb meaning "to scratch", and the reason Spanish puts an e- in front *escribir*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 156, p. 543
today — a whole Latin phrase worn down to three letters, and the tense it prefers *hoy*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 252, p. 789
together, next to — one short word doing two jobs, and the preposition that decides which *junto*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 433, p. 2123
Tomar — Taking, and a Word With No Past
chapter topic; Chapter 159, p. 551
too much, too — the top of the degree scale bastante taught, and the member that was missing from it *demasiado*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 471, p. 2497
Trabajar — Work, and the Torture Device Behind It
chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 117
tracking, follow-up — the -miento ending on a verb you have had for chapters *el seguimiento*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 452, p. 2319
Traer — Bringing, and Latin for Dragging
chapter topic; Chapter 168, p. 597
train — borrowed from French train, a thing drawn along, from traîner to drag; keep it sharply apart from tres, three *el tren*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 400, p. 1887
Travelling — Asking, Boarding, Staying, and When It Goes Wrong
chapter topic; Chapter 268, p. 845
tree — Latin arbor, with one of its two r sounds slid away to l *el árbol*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 278, p. 917

triple, three times as much — Latin triplus, three plus the -plus that means fold; English triple, treble and triplicate are all three folds *el triple*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 351, p. 1463
trouble, bother — Latin molestia from moles, a heavy mass; English molecule is the same mass made small *la molestia*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 320, p. 1241
trousers — French pantalon, from Pantalone, the Venetian comic stock character and his long tight legwear; English pantaloons, clipped to pants, is the very same word *el pantalón*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 360, p. 1535
True, False, and Not Even
chapter topic; Chapter 324, p. 1273
true — Latin certus, sifted: what is left after you separate it out *cierto*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 284, p. 965
tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 105, p. 369
tuviera
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 207, p. 695
Tuviera — the Hard Stems, Collected Free
chapter topic; Chapter 207, p. 695
tuvieron
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 202, p. 685
Tuvieron — the Strong Stems, Made Plural
chapter topic; Chapter 202, p. 685
twenty — the ceiling of the teens, and a word that was worn but never fused *veinte*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 149, p. 511
two of the three words Spanish uses to one person — and the one English quietly retired *tú / usted*
Chapter 5, p. 33
Two Words for How Something Looks
chapter topic; Chapter 399, p. 1883
Two Words From Outside, and Two Nobody Can Place
chapter topic; Chapter 383, p. 1739

U

ugly — Latin foedus, foul; a different Latin foedus meaning treaty gave English federal, and the two never had anything to do with each other *feo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 380, p. 1717

un — "a," and the number hiding in it
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 23
Un and Una — the Other Article
chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 23
Un paraguas azul
chapter topic; Chapter 470, p. 2487
Una carta del colegio
chapter topic; Chapter 466, p. 2447
una — the feminine one
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 23
underneath; below *debajo*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 407, p. 1931
university — Latin ūniversitās, a corporation or guild of people, from ūniversus, turned into one; the first Spanish use, in 1490, means totality, and the school sense arrives in 1505 *la universidad*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 394, p. 1833
Uno... Otro — Splitting a Pair
chapter topic; Chapter 263, p. 819
uno... otro — splitting a pair
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 263, p. 819
Unos, Unas — The Plural of One
chapter topic; Chapter 253, p. 793
unos · unas — the plural of "one"
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 253, p. 793
unpleasant, disagreeable — simpático with the Greek anti- fastened on the front; the two words are a matched pair and neither means what its English lookalike means *antipático*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 423, p. 2009
until / up to *hasta*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 85
Until When
chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 91
up, above, upstairs — Latin ripa, a riverbank; English river, riparian and arrive all come off the same bank *arriba*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 341, p. 1381
urgency — a pressing, and in the plural the sign over the hospital door *la urgencia*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 447, p. 2263
"us" — the object pronoun that speaks for more than one person *nos*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 88, p. 325
usual, regular — what you hold on to, from the *haber* you already have *habitual*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 459, p. 2387

V

vamos — from a verb that is not *ir*
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 68, p. 265
van — and the four are done
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 68, p. 265
vegetables or greens — from verde, with a marked secondary sense outside this food use *la verdura*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 403, p. 1909
veía — keep the extra e you already met
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 109, p. 385
Venir — Coming
chapter topic; Chapter 73, p. 287
Veo a María — The Little A That Guards People
chapter topic; Chapter 239, p. 763
veo a María — the little a that guards people
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 239, p. 763
Ver — Seeing
chapter topic; Chapter 108, p. 383
Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers
chapter topic; Chapter 69, p. 269
very — not a new word at all, but mucho with its ending bitten off, and the shape tells you what is coming next *muy*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 226, p. 735
Vi, Di — The Shortest Pasts
chapter topic; Chapter 255, p. 797
vi — the shortest past in the language
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 255, p. 797
visible — the -able ending you know, spelled the other way, and pointing the other way too *visible*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 466, p. 2447
viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 127, p. 433
vivía — reuse the complete -er row
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 107, p. 379
vivimos — where the two families part
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 43, p. 179
Vivir — the Family That Costs Nothing
chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 159
viviré — one future row for three verb families
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 122, p. 417
viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 123, p. 421

volcano — through Portuguese volcão from Latin Vulcanus, the Roman god of fire and the forge *el volcán*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 378, p. 1701
***vuestra merced* → *usted* — respect compressed into one word**
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 5, p. 33
Vuestro — The Last Possessive
chapter topic; Chapter 254, p. 795
vuestro — the last possessive
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 254, p. 795

W

waiter — Greek kamára, a vault, into Latin camera and Vulgar Latin camara, giving Spanish cámara, a room; whether camarero was built inside Spanish or borrowed from Medieval Latin camarārius cannot be told apart *el camarero*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 391, p. 1803
Waiting, Answering, Buying
chapter topic; Chapter 174, p. 617
Wanting, Not Asserting
chapter topic; Chapter 126, p. 431
wardrobe, cupboard — Latin armārium from arma, which meant tools and gear rather than weapons; arms, army, armour and alarm are cousins, and French armoire is the very same room-word *el armario*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 366, p. 1595
water — a word that barely changed from Latin, and takes el without ever stopping being feminine *el agua*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 143, p. 487
Water, Wine, and Bread
chapter topic; Chapter 143, p. 487
weak — Latin debilis; English debilitate and debility are the same word, and the written accent is there because the word ends in -l *débil*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 327, p. 1297
web page — Latin pagina, a column of writing fastened to a frame, plus English web; the oldest word for a written surface carrying the newest one *la página web*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 422, p. 2003
week — Latin septimana, the set of seven; the same septem gives English September and, down the Germanic road, seven *la semana*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 322, p. 1257

weight — Latin pensum, a thing weighed out, from pendere to weigh and to hang; pension, spend, expensive, pendant and ponder are all still weighing something *el peso*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 359, p. 1527
welcome — bien plus venido, well come, two pieces you already own *bienvenido*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 282, p. 949
well / good / fine *bien*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1
well, then, since — Latin post, after; the same post is inside despues, and English keeps it raw in post-, posterior and postpone *pues*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 329, p. 1313
west — Germanic westaz through Old French ouest; the same word as English west, and behind it the old root for evening that also gives vespers *el oeste*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 347, p. 1431
wet — from mojar, Vulgar Latin molliare, to soften, from mollis, soft; English mollify and emollient come from the same mollis *mojado*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 379, p. 1709
what? (a new question word for verbs you already know) *qué*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 161
What a Phrase Carries — Authority, a Story, a Silence, a Sense of Charm
chapter topic; Chapter 274, p. 887
what does it mean — significar is Latin significare, to make a sign *¿qué significa?*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 303, p. 1117
what estar is for — a current state or location — and the only two forms you need this chapter *estás / está*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 8, p. 61
What Is Eaten — Wheat, Rice, Onion, Tomato, Honey
chapter topic; Chapter 290, p. 1013
What Is On The Table
chapter topic; Chapter 361, p. 1545
What It Weighs, And How Much There Is
chapter topic; Chapter 359, p. 1527
what's your name? (formal) *¿cómo se llama usted?*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 41
What the Body Feels — Chest, Strength, Rest, Fear, Laughter
chapter topic; Chapter 315, p. 1203

What the Body Says — Thirst, Sleep, Skin, Blood, Remedy
chapter topic; Chapter 300, p. 1093
What You Put On
chapter topic; Chapter 360, p. 1535
When Bien Is Not True — Calm, Ill, Content, Busy, Sad
chapter topic; Chapter 304, p. 1123
"when" — the word that puts a scene and an event in one sentence, so the two pasts can be seen doing different jobs *cuando*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 112, p. 395
When the Words Run Out — Help, a Moment, Again, I Don't Know, What Does It Mean
chapter topic; Chapter 303, p. 1117
When You Don't Understand
chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 103
where? *dónde*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 161
Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 11, p. 77
Where -er and -ir Part Company
chapter topic; Chapter 43, p. 179
where is it? *¿dónde está?*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 268, p. 845
Where It Hurts — Eye, Mouth, Throat, Pain, Fever
chapter topic; Chapter 286, p. 981
Where The Town Goes When The Work Stops
chapter topic; Chapter 354, p. 1487
which, as, of what kind — Latin qualis, of what kind; English quality is qualitas, the what-kind-ness of a thing *cual*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 329, p. 1313
Which One: By Colour, Size And Shape
chapter topic; Chapter 358, p. 1519
Which One Is the Verb Asking For?
chapter topic; Chapter 95, p. 341
Which one is the verb asking for?
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 95, p. 341
which — pointing back at a whole clause *lo cual*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 273, p. 879
Which Way, And What Is Around You
chapter topic; Chapter 347, p. 1431
Which Way Is the Arrow Pointing?
chapter topic; Chapter 178, p. 635
Which way is the arrow pointing?
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 178, p. 635

while — Latin dum interim, “for the time between”; the inter in it is English interim, interval and international *mientras*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 323, p. 1265
who? — one tiny people-question before the writing marks are explained *quién*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 5, p. 33
Who Someone Is — Neighbour, Friend, Teacher, Nurse, Cook
chapter topic; Chapter 285, p. 973
who — the asking word Spanish keeps for people, and the reason qué has never had to do that job *quién*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 232, p. 749
whole, entire — Latin integer, untouched, from in not plus tangere to touch; English integer, integrity and intact are the same untouched thing *entero*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 352, p. 1471
Why se? — and why it is not the se you know
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 100, p. 351
Why Se? — Gelo, and a Collision
chapter topic; Chapter 100, p. 351
Wi-Fi — a brand name coined to echo Hi-Fi, with Wireless Fidelity attached later as marketing *el wifi*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 404, p. 1913
Wi-Fi, Mobile Phones and Films
chapter topic; Chapter 404, p. 1913
wide — Latin amplus, spacious; ample, amplify and amplitude are the borrowed branch, and Spanish amplio is the same adjective taken fresh from the page *ancho*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 365, p. 1585
wind — Latin ventus, and the English word that is its cousin rather than its borrowing *el viento*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 278, p. 917
window — a wind-hole, built on the same Latin ventus as viento *la ventana*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 279, p. 925
wine — one Latin root that reached English by three separate roads, plus one English built at home *el vino*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 143, p. 487
with me, with you — two words carrying the same preposition twice, because the first one stopped being audible *conmigo* · *contigo*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 247, p. 779

wolf — Latin lupus, which is irregular for the ancient word it should be and probably reached Rome from a neighbouring Italian dialect; English wolf is the inherited cousin *el lobo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 368, p. 1615
woman, and also wife — Latin mulier, whose own origin is unexplained; English took almost nothing from it beyond the rare muliebrity, while Latin homo gave human, homage and homicide *la mujer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 364, p. 1575
wood — Latin's word for matter, which meant timber first, and reached Spanish twice *la madera*
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 444, p. 2229
work, a job — a reconstructed Vulgar Latin *tripaliāre, to torture, on Late Latin tripalium, an instrument of torture attested in a church canon of 578; English travail is the same word* *el trabajo*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 394, p. 1833
Working From Sources — Credit It, Restate It, Hold Both, Compress
chapter topic; Chapter 277, p. 909
Writing — Four Lines About You
chapter topic; Chapter 338, p. 1369
Writing — Four Lines That Hold Together
chapter topic; Chapter 418, p. 1981
Writing — With A Clock
chapter topic; Chapter 339, p. 1371
Writing — Your Own Line
chapter topic; Chapter 337, p. 1367

Y

yeah, right *sí, claro*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 272, p. 871
yellow — from "a little bitter," not from any Latin word for yellow at all *amarillo*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 151, p. 521
yes *sí*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 53
yesterday *ayer*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 103, p. 357
"you" across a large part of the Spanish-speaking world — to recognise, not to say *vos*
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 5, p. 33

"you all" as the object — the shortest word in the set, and the one that stops at a border *os*
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 90, p. 331
"you" as the object — and the sentence it makes, which is the one people actually need *te quiero*
explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 85, p. 317
you're welcome (literally "of nothing") *de nada*
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 53
young — Latin iuvenis; English young is the inherited cousin, juvenile and junior are the borrowed ones, and June comes in only through Juno *joven*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 371, p. 1645
your first sentence built from parts — and the rule that languages take no article *Hablo español*
explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 22, p. 123
Your First Verb, and the Form That Means I
chapter topic; Chapter 16, p. 107
Your own line — the first writing with no model
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 337, p. 1367

Z

zero — Arabic sifr, empty; English took the same word twice, as zero and as cipher *cero*
explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 344, p. 1405
Zero, Halves and Dozens
chapter topic; Chapter 344, p. 1405